# World Eater

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30130209.

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Mature

**Archive Warning:**
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F, F/M, Gen, Multi, Other

**Fandom:**
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

**Relationships:**
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Minor Bow/Glimmer - Relationship

**Characters:**
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

**Additional Tags:**
Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Post-Season/Series 04, Space Opera, Slow Burn, Hurt/Comfort, Angst with a Happy Ending, Alternate Universe, Angst, Slow Build, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, world building, plot heavy, tons of foreshadowing, big battle set piece, Movie Poster Art, no one gets a good night's sleep in this somehow, Family of Choice, Conspiracy Theories, Adora has performance anxiety, Glimmer has survivor's guilt, Catra has self worth issues (what else is new)

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by TelenNarre

Summary

With Horde Prime defeated, the Best Friend Squad journeyed into space to bring magic back to the galaxy. At least, that was the best outcome among many that fate could have taken them to.

In this reality, when Adora smashes the Sword of Protection, Etheria is instead pulled into a universe with problems far larger than a sadistic Galactic Emperor—a universe where the Hero, the Fallen Friend, and the Once-Queen have no choice but to confront a crisis threatening the very foundations of reality itself.

Etheria is no longer alone in Despondos, and the galaxy is a far more dangerous place than they could have ever imagined.

(Post-Season 4 AU. Large word count but told in 5 manageable parts)

- Translation into Español available: Devorador de Mundos (Traducción) by catradoramelio

# Part I: The Devil and the Deep Blue Sea, Chapter 1: Hostages




Art commission done by SzethK. Linktree: Here

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## Chapter One: Hostages

Glimmer paced the length of her cell and rehearsed for the thousandth time in her head what she would say to the officers that would come with their morning meal.

At least a week had passed since Catra convinced Horde Prime to spare her life. At least a week since both were captured aboard his citadel and thrown in a cell together. No new information about her friends back on Etheria had come, despite her every effort to get any of Prime's officers to drop so much as a hint. It didn't matter if they were clone or alien, or even vaguely Etherian looking themselves—no one had said a word.

*Maybe if I physically get between them and the door when they come in*, she thought.

Horde Prime had spared them for a reason. He wouldn't let his prisoners—or 'guests' as he liked to call them—be harmed, would he? Glimmer hoped it was the slender looking officers that came today. If it was them, then maybe she'd stand a chance intimidating them; if it were those giant hulking walls of muscle, however? Or worse, if it were Prime's clones themselves this time around…?

"Do you really have to keep pacing like that?" Catra lay in the bottom bunk of their cell, staring at her as her tail twitched. She was dehydrated, if the vague molasses lilt of her voice gave any indication.

Glimmer tried to ignore her, and instead stared out the large window at the back of their cell.  A smattering of stars and nebulae stood as a backdrop with Etheria's curve taking up most of the remaining real-estate. She frowned. The planet seemed to somehow mock her. A whole week, gone. And for all Glimmer knew, her friends could already be dead. Where were Bow and Adora and the other princesses? Fighting on the surface no doubt but were they okay? Were they safe?

“Whatever it is you’re thinking, it’s not going to work,” Catra said. “Horde Prime may have spared our lives, but that doesn’t mean his officers won’t retaliate if you do something to them.”

Glimmer clenched her jaw. “I’m not going to do anything to them,” she said.

“Liar. I can tell you’re planning something stupid this time because you’re pacing harder than normal.”

Glimmer rounded on her and snarled, pushing magic to her fists. But no magic came, and the stark reminder she was too far away from Etheria’s surface to use any of it slapped her in the face. Catra leveled her with a placid, unfazed expression atop the bed, and Glimmer deflated.

Catra had saved her life not once, but twice since they had gotten stuck up on Horde Prime’s citadel. She couldn’t remember much of what happened, just that, one day, she woke in the infirmary instead of the cell. The nurses, fragile, spindly looking aliens all of them, filled her in: Her body had gone into shock, likely as an aftereffect of her activating the Heart and it shoving a great amount of magic through her all at once. Her body wasn’t prepared to handle it, and if it weren’t for Catra, dozens of towels, and bowls of cold water from their shared bathroom keeping her from overheating, she likely would have died.

“She wouldn’t stop whining at the camera in there,” one of the nurses had said, faint disdain on its blunted features. “It was so incessant and annoying that someone was sent to check and they brought you to us.”

Glimmer took a deep breath and centered herself. Catra cocked an eyebrow at her and Glimmer tried for the hundredth time to picture her dragging her into the bathroom and taking care of her. Catra barely looked functional herself, like she’d immediately collapse under her own weight from weakness the moment she stood up. Imagining this person taking care of her wasn’t just an

inability to believe a former enemy had actually helped her, it was a logistical problem too.

"Can you at least stop pacing?" Catra asked. "It's driving me insane. Really."

Glimmer massaged her face until her scowl loosened up, pulled out one of the chairs pushed under their shared table in the center of the room, and sat. As much as she wanted to squeeze the life out of Catra's body with her own two hands for being so dang *annoying*, she fought to give her the benefit of the doubt. If sitting rather than pacing helped ease Catra's frustration, well then Glimmer would oblige. They were enemies, but she was indebted and wanted to dig herself out from under that debt as soon as possible.

"Thank you," Catra said.

The doors to their cell slid open just as Glimmer grunted out a response, and she immediately stood and whirled around to face whoever had come. She had rehearsed this moment in her head time and time again. Now it was time to act. Except, her willingness to do so seeped out of her as soon as she saw who had come: four clones stepped in, two holding a tray of food each and two flanking them as extra security.

It had always been actual aliens, Horde Officers of various races and genders, that had brought their food and done their wellness checks. But never the clones. In fact, she had only ever seen them the one time in the throne room when they first arrived. To say she was surprised to see not one, but four of them step into their room with their afternoon rations was an understatement. Even Catra, finally sitting up in the bunk with her hair all matted, seemed surprised.

"Lord Prime will come for you soon," the first clone said, stepping forward. He made a show of craning his neck and glancing behind Glimmer at Catra. "Your friend has not eaten since arriving. She must be presentable when Lord Prime comes for you. He would

not like the idea that our honored guests are in such a disheveled state. It would reflect poorly on him as host."

"If he doesn't want to be seen as a poor host, then maybe he shouldn't lock his 'honored guests' in a cell aboard his ship." Glimmer stood as straight as she could and put her best approximation of a 'Queenly demeanor' in her voice.

The clone, three heads taller than her and staring nearly straight down, blinked once with a vacant expression on its face. It slid around her and placed the tray on the table. "If she will not eat, then we will make her. It will not be pleasant."

The clone carrying the second tray of food followed suit. All four of them then swept out of the room before Glimmer could decide whether to chance her original plan, and the door hissed shut behind them.

Glimmer stared at the trays in front of them. Everything there looked foreign to her with no native Etherian dishes—not that she expected there to be any. Fortunately, Glimmer could at least mentally categorize each of them based off their taste and texture: some kind of meat, a vegetable medley, and a type of sweet dessert. Thankfully all the food they had eaten thus far had sat well with their stomachs too.

Well, her stomach at least. She finally looked over to Catra and found her exactly how she expected her to be: curled up on the bed now the clones had left, shivering under the covers, facing the wall with her back toward her. Glimmer hadn't seen Catra move from that position since she had returned from the med bay, and despite her inability to tell exact time aboard the ship, she knew at least a day or two had passed since then.

Glimmer sighed and prepared herself for an uphill battle. "Food is here Catra, come over and eat." When Catra didn't stir, she rolled her eyes. "You can't groan and whine about listening to me walk around the cell and then immediately after pretend not to hear me talking to you."

Catra snorted and turned around. Her face was sunken and pale, her eyes bloodshot and sagging, and her fur stuck up in every which odd direction. “You weren’t walking, Sparkles, you were pacing. There’s a difference.”

Glimmer felt on the verge of bursting a vein. She picked up one of the trays to give her hands something to grasp aside from Catra’s scrawny neck and shuffled over to her. Catra eyed her as she did, fur puffing out in warning as she got closer.

“Come on, it’s time to eat,” Glimmer said, speaking through clenched teeth.

“Not hungry.”

“I didn’t ask if you were hungry, I said it’s time to eat.” Glimmer plonked the tray down on the nearby nightstand and dragged the whole thing over next to Catra on the bed. It screeched as if it were a live animal being dunked in scalding water, and the sound made Catra hiss with her ears pinned back flat against her head.

Glimmer didn’t try very hard to suppress her amusement at that. “Now, let’s eat. Okay?”

Catra narrowed her eyes at her and Glimmer swore she saw the moment the other girl decided to continue fighting her. Catra had her ‘shit-stirring persona’ down to a science. “What are you going to do if I say no? Force me?”

“Did you not hear what those clones just said? If they come back and see you still haven’t touched your food, they aren’t just going to take it away like before. They’re going to tie you down and force it down your gullet.”

“That’s kinda kinky,” Catra said, laughing, and Glimmer felt her hands inch toward the other girl’s neck. She only stopped when Catra’s gaze turned morose. “If I had to choose between you or the clones,” she said. “I would choose you.”

Glimmer blinked. “Excuse me?”

"Forcing me to eat. If it were between you or the clones, you'd probably be gentler, at least."

Glimmer narrowed her eyes at her. Was she making another crude joke or trying to be sincere about how Glimmer wouldn't hurt her? It was hard to tell with the way she jumped from one extreme to the other, and she almost asked before she saw the little smirk flit across Catra's lips.

How the hell could she be making jokes at a time like this? She felt a perverse sense of glee overcome her as she realized something else: two could play that game.

"Are you sure about that?" she asked. "Bow has told me on numerous occasions that I roughhouse like his brothers. I *like* him and I'm not all that gentle—just imagine what it'd be like for you." A thought came to her. "How the heck are you still even alive? I don't think I've seen you touch any food at all, and I'm pretty sure it's been at least a week we've been here."

Catra shrugged and spoke in a casual tone. "I have an efficient metabolism. Never ate much, even when we got double rations in the Horde."

Glimmer chuckled at that and Catra joined her. She couldn't believe it; they were bonding over being brats to each other. It was almost a nice feeling, until she suddenly remembered she was standing across from the person that essentially took her mother from her. She could sense the moment her features turned dark because Catra immediately stopped laughing and averted her eyes.

In an effort to distract herself, Glimmer reached over and speared some 'meat' and 'vegetables' with the fork on the tray holding it out for her. She fully intended to get into a shouting match if needed. Catra would eat, even if she came away with scars up and down her arms and a black eye. It wasn't until Glimmer actually looked at Catra—really looked at her—that she saw how Catra had recoiled from her. Fear and terror danced in her eyes.

“Touch me and I swear I’ll claw your eyes out,” Catra said.

Adora had looked at Shadow Weaver that same way shortly after healing her with She Ra’s power. Her surprise visit to Bright Moon had shaken her, and Glimmer would never forget how her heart ached seeing her friend look so much like a cornered animal. Seeing that same look now directed at her calmed the anger threatening to boil over in Glimmer’s chest.

She placed the fork back on the tray and turned it so it was instead pointing handle-first in Catra’s direction. “If you won’t eat, then I won’t either,” she said as she made her way back to the table and sat, leaving Catra’s food within arm’s reach of the bunk.

“What?” The tip of Catra’s tail twitched and betrayed her unease.

“You heard me. If you won’t eat, neither will I.”

Catra groaned and ran her hands through her hair. “I told you I’m not hungry.”

“And I told you that I didn’t ask if you were hungry. You need to eat or else we’re both going to have something unpleasant done to us. Do you want those clones to come in here and force you to eat after all? Because I sure don’t.”

Glimmer wasn’t certain if Catra was about to attack or start crying by the way she looked at her until, finally, Catra turned her attention to her tray, picked up the fork with a shaky hand, and ate what Glimmer had speared for her in the first place.

“S’good,” Catra said. Her eyes darted down to the tray, as if noticing it for the first time. She dropped the fork with a clatter and instead started shoveling everything she could into her mouth as fast as possible. Glimmer couldn’t tell if she even took the time to chew before swallowing, only to make room for the next handful of food she had ready to cram into her face. A moment later and Catra’s entire platter was empty. Her eyes shot toward Glimmer’s tray, still sitting untouched in front of her on the table.

Glimmer didn't miss how ravenous she looked. Catra must have caught the look of astonishment she was giving her because she immediately looked away, embarrassed, then covered that embarrassment with the darkest scowl Glimmer had seen her make yet. Despite herself, she found it almost endearing.

"Not hungry, huh?" She made sure to really push the teasing lilt in her voice, if only to unbalance Catra even further. "You know, someone else I know from the Horde had that exact same reaction the first time they ate real food."

Catra's scowl deepened. She hugged her knees close to her chest, like she thought it possible to disappear from view entirely if she made her body small enough. It wasn't the reaction Glimmer was hoping for, and she immediately realized why what she said seemed to make Catra descend into self loathing rather than embarrassment: she was talking about Adora, but Adora was probably the last person Catra wanted to think about in that moment.

"Uhh…it was Scorpia!" Glimmer said. She didn't know why she was suddenly trying to spare Catra's feelings. "She came to us and the first time she tried strawberries I swear it was like she didn't know something like that could exist in the first place. Frosta told me later that she didn't know food came in sizes and textures other than 'ration bar.'"

Catra softened at hearing that and Glimmer breathed a sigh of relief.  "Scorpia's with you?" she asked after a moment.

Glimmer weighed the many responses that flitted through her head before settling on one she thought was the best. "Yes, she is."

"How is she?" Catra asked, curling tighter again. "Is she…happy?"

Glimmer softened, suddenly feeling…something—what, exactly, she wasn't sure. "Yeah, I think she's happy."

Catra stayed silent, and Glimmer thought that was the end of their longest and deepest conversation yet, until…

"Good," Catra said, voice quavering with her hands. "That's good. I'm glad. She deserves that, to be happy… she deserves to be happy."

Glimmer studied Catra. Was this the same person that only weeks ago they were kicking and punching and biting each other inside an exploding military base? Was this the same person she was ready to end on the ruined floors of the Fright Zone? She sighed and approached Catra once more, this time carrying her own tray of food. Catra eyed her with barely disguised apprehension until Glimmer tipped her tray toward Catra's empty one and scraped half her meal onto it.

Catra's eyes blew wide. "That's your food." She sounded as if she didn't trust herself to speak at all.

"Nothing gets past you, does it?" Glimmer suppressed the urge to snort at the look of confusion on Catra's face. "You need it more than me. Efficient metabolism or no, you haven't eaten in far too long. I'd feel better if you made up for it by eating some of mine."

"And you think that I want to do anything to help you feel better because why?"

Glimmer shrugged and said nothing. She went over to place her tray with its remaining food on a second nightstand, picked it up so it wouldn't scrape across the ground, and waddled over and placed it opposite Catra's own tray and nightstand. Then she grabbed the chair she was using earlier and sat down across from her at their makeshift table.

"You didn't have to call for doctors when I was sick," Glimmer said. She noticed how Catra immediately refused to look her in the eye when she spoke. "But you did it anyways. And even when no one came at first, you kept calling until they had no choice but to come." She gestured to their trays and Catra followed her

hands. “I don’t have to give you my food either, but I’m doing it for the same reason you helped me.”

“And what reason is that?” Catra had finally glanced up and locked eyes with her.

Glimmer wasn’t about to say it out loud, but Catra seemed to get that she didn’t need to in order to understand what that reason was.

“Stop being difficult and just eat it already,” Glimmer said. “Please.”

Another long moment hung in the air. Catra averted her eyes again and took a deep, sniveling breath. She brought her arm up and rubbed it back and forth across her face like she was trying to strip her skin raw. Then, in one quick motion, scooted forward, picked up the fork this time, and began spearing and slowly eating the extra food Glimmer had given her.

Opting to provide her at least a small chance to save face, Glimmer busied herself with her own food. Out of the corner of her eye she watched Catra alternate between eating and rubbing at her face. The occasional sniffle accompanied the sound of their utensils clacking on the tin.

She thought of her mother again. For the first time since being stuck in the same room as her, Glimmer didn’t feel the familiar tug of anger or resentment.

A smile spread across her face as another thought came to her, and she glanced at Etheria out the window: whatever her friends were doing down there, she hoped they were making the same kind of progress against the Emperor’s forces that she and Catra were making together up here with each other. If that were true, then it would only be a matter of time before they beat him. She had faith.

Prime stood no chance.

# Ultimatums

Chapter Notes

> One week later and this story is on like, the 13th page or so from the front. I love how active this fandom is! You all are awesome.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Dread gripped Adora's heart as she stood atop one of the great spires at Bright Moon castle and looked out at the castle town below. Prime clones and Horde warbots combed the empty streets, stepping over rubble and through flaming debris in their search for hostages. Thankfully, the Rebellion had managed to move everyone inside the walls of the castle proper before any civilians were taken. Plumes of smoke rose in the lands beyond the town, likely from the scorched earth and scarred fields of the many villages and settlements in the distance Prime's forces had already annihilated.

A sound built up overhead, like roaring thunder, and Adora looked up at a massive warship orbiting above. It was the source of all this destruction and chaos to begin with. Light from a cannon on its underside pulsed and illuminated the smooth surface of its hull. The cannon flashed, blinding bright, and a beam as large as one of the castle's own turret towers shot from the belly of the ship and streaked toward them. It smashed into a massive magic shield separating them from the attacking enemy, and the cannon-fire dissipated across the dome, lighting up an intricate pattern of geodesic lines and kaleidoscope swirls that spanned the shield's surface.

The ground shook with the impact of the blast and Adora grimaced. That warship was the sole reason their entire resistance had fallen, mere hours after returning with Bow. After defying Light Hope and breaking the Sword of Protection to stop the Heart of Etheria from firing, they both sped back to Bright Moon atop

Swift Wind. That warship descended upon them almost immediately thereafter, spitting fire and beaming clone troops and killer bots to the surface to demolish and occupy everything in sight. It was a miracle the princesses and Elite Bright Moon guard had jumped into action as quickly and efficiently as they had. She didn't even want to think about what would have happened if Micah and Shadow Weaver hadn't worked together to erect that shield so quickly. It was probably the only thing successfully keeping the enemy forces at bay.

Another burst of fire from the ship and another rumble in the earth sent Adora clutching at her ribs in pain.

"Adora, you should really get that looked at," King Micah said, standing next to her. "Please."

"I can't do that, sir," Adora said.

A clone or warbot—she wasn't sure which—had grazed her with blaster fire earlier, when she couldn't get out of the way fast enough. She counted herself lucky to get away with what was likely just a bruise, since the final push to get civilians inside the castle walls had been a brutal fight. Her armor was ruined and she could no longer wear it, but at least she was alive.

"The next wave could come at any minute," she said. "I have to be ready for it."

"*We* have to be ready," Micah said, "not just you. You should be able to take a break or go and get yourself examined if need be. The rest of us are here protecting the castle, too."

Adora didn't say anything. She really didn't want to get into this right now and hoped Micah would let it go if she didn't engage.

"The sword is broken and She Ra is gone for now," he said. "You made the choice you thought was right in the moment and I don't blame you for it in the slightest. But there's no use in dwelling on that any longer." He swept his hands at the wreckage and enemy soldiers on the other side of the barrier. "This is a fight we'll have

to win without her. I'll need you in top shape if we're to stand any chance."

Adora opened her mouth to respond when Entrapta's voice blared through the transceiver at Micah's belt.

"We have a signal and we're being hailed! It's coming—oh gosh, it's coming directly from Horde Prime's citadel in orbit. It's coming now! Hurry!"

Adora and Micah spared each other knowing glances before they both took off at a dead sprint down the spire's stairs. Adora did what she could to keep her mind from spiraling. They raced down the hallway, passing huddles of refugees from the surrounding area and pockets of battered Bright Moon soldiers. Everyone looked so exhausted, and Adora had a feeling she wasn't faring much better in their eyes either.

When they finally skidded around a sharp turn and burst through the high double doors into the castle's war room, the princesses and Shadow Weaver were already there, huddled around a frantic Bow and manic Entrapta. The two of them worked furiously at a briefcase-sized device on the table. It was undoubtedly one of Entrapta's creations, judging by its haphazard, jury-rigged appearance.

"Hurry!" Entrapta said to Bow. "You need to amplify the capture signal or we're going to lose it!"

"Get the transmission up," Micah said, striding in with a confidence that betrayed nothing of the fact he and Adora were sprinting like mad moments earlier.

Bow yanked at a handful of dials and knobs on the device and dashed over to a hole in the floor. Massive cables snaked from the box through the hole into the foundations of the castle underneath, and the sound of Bow exerting himself echoed out the moment he jumped inside. Entrapta keyed a few commands into the tablet she held in her left hand, furrowed her brow at the

box when it apparently didn't do what she was expecting it to, and pounded the top of the device once with a closed fist.

A life-sized hologram of Horde Prime flickered into existence next to them and bathed the room in a green light.

"Greetings, Etherians," he said with his hands folded behind his back and a cool expression on his face. "I have come to negotiate terms of your surrender, for Prime is merciful, and the newest addition to our Galactic Empire should not suffer such bloodshed and destruction needlessly. Who among you has the authority to treat with an Emperor?"

A murmur of uncertainty spread through the group as the princesses looked at each other. Adora felt their eyes linger on her, then turn away. They didn't mean anything by it. She knew they were just uncertain whether they should place such a burden on someone who had just lost She Ra at their most desperate hour, but that didn't stop the pang of guilt that shot through her in response.

"I can speak with you," Micah said, stepping forward. "I am Micah, King of Brightmoon. What terms of surrender do you propose?"

Horde Prime turned and regarded Micah with a genteel expression. The earlier murmur of uncertainty from the princesses turned into alarm, and Adora looked at Micah as if to say *what the heck are you doing*? He was talking to her of winning the battle without She Ra not even moments earlier. Why all of a sudden did he seem to jump at the chance to talk of surrender?

Except, the look Micah returned to her suggested something else was at play. Prime spoke then of unconditional surrender and an immediate vacating of the castle. He wanted them to march out beyond the magic shield with arms behind their heads. Micah instead countered with questions about guaranteeing their safety. It wasn't long before Adora realized what he was doing: he was stalling. Purposefully.

Adora didn't think, she just moved. They had to capitalize on Micah's distraction—come up with a plan of some sort.

"Entrapta," she said, shuffling around Prime toward her and gritting her teeth, trying to eke out the syllables without moving her lips. "Can you get the transmission's coordinates?"

Entrapta looked up at her with a confused expression. "It's coming from Horde Prime's citadel? You know, since that's where he is?"

"No that's not what I—" Adora sighed and suppressed the urge to turn on Entrapta and shake her right then and there. "We need to know where on that station he's broadcasting from. Can you work your magic and get us the *exact* coordinates of the transmission?"

Realization dawned on Entrapta's face. "Ohhhh, yeah I can get that. It will take a moment so make sure you keep him talking."

Adora was about to point out that's exactly what Micah was already doing, but Entrapta had already turned and was busy tapping commands into her data-pad and adjusting the knobs and dials on the projector. Adora and the princesses exchanged wide-eyed looks of horror as she worked. Prime only had to turn around, and he would see they were up to something.

Fortunately, Micah was doing a wonderful job irritating the Emperor with increasingly ludicrous questions about their surrender.

"All I'm asking is who is going to pay for repairs to the castle town and surrounding countryside?" he said. "My people have no homes, and their livelihoods have been erased because of the consequences of the invasion."

Micah gestured with strong, sweeping motions of his arms as he spoke. Adora couldn't help but feel impressed at how convincingly he led Horde Prime around by the nose with his tangents. For someone who had been stuck for years on Beast Island and proclaimed to not be used to speaking, he was doing a damn good job of it right when they needed him.

*The same can't be said for you and She Ra, though.* The thought came uninvited to her head, and she pushed it out. She had to focus.

"Not to mention the cost of rebuilding the other kingdoms," Micah said. "If the level of destruction in Bright Moon is indicative of how the other domains are faring, then it is safe to say we as a planet cannot fund our own rebuilding effort. Not fully, anyway, and not without significant stagnation in our global economy. Our ability to thrive as a subject under your rule would be severely hampered."

One of the extra eyes on Horde Prime's face twitched, and his lips tugged upward in a snarl. "You will leave those details to me. The Empire will decide how best to help you rebuild and integrate. All you and your band of holdouts need concern yourselves with is vacating your castle and letting my forces take custody of it and of you."

"Yes, but what if—"

"Enough!" Horde Prime seemed to grow even taller in his fury. He balled his fists at his side and the tendrils on his head coiled like dancing snakes. "You are beaten, King of Bright Moon. Do you not realize this? You and your castle are the last resistance still standing on your planet. You will surrender peacefully or you will all die, but you will not be standing come morning."

The room stilled and Prime relaxed, uncurling his fists and combing his fingers through his tendril-hairs with a deep breath through the nose. "I have grown to appreciate the benefits of negotiating peace as opposed to long conquests and their brutality. I had hoped to extend the same offer for peaceful surrender to your people, but that seems to have unintentionally emboldened you. Maybe this will help you understand." Prime gestured and an image fizzled to life in the space next to him. When they recognized what the image was, everyone in the room gasped.

It was surveillance video of a single, sanitary-white room. One bunk bed was shoved into the wall, and a table with chairs sat in the center. The camera was placed high in the corner, judging by the perspective. Catra was standing underneath, looking directly up at them, eyes wide with fear and hair sticking out every which direction. She looked skinnier and was yelling something repeatedly at the camera, although Adora couldn't tell what, since there was no sound. Glimmer lay on the bottom bunk, clearly not doing well. Was she dead? Is that why Catra looked so panicked?

An icy feeling seized Adora by the gut and she forced herself to look away. Instead, she glanced at her friends. The princesses all looked shocked, and Bow had stepped forward with a murderous glint in his eyes. King Micah, on the other hand, held his hand out like he had tried to reach through the image to pull his daughter through to him. He looked absolutely devastated. Heartbroken.

Entrapta flagged Adora down with exaggerated movements of her hair and, somehow, Prime still hadn't caught on. *I have the coordinates*, she mouthed soundlessly to her. Adora nodded. A fire felt like it had suddenly lit itself inside her.

"Ah, it seems that did indeed get your attention," Prime said to Micah. "You have no power to negotiate in this exchange. You will surrender to my forces outside your castle immediately."

"No, we will not," Adora said.

Everyone turned to her in surprise. Prime blinked once, twice. He looked like he didn't quite trust what he heard.

"Say that again?" he asked.

Adora took a step forward and pushed her chin out at him. Prime was several heads taller than her, but that didn't mean she couldn't make him feel like *she* was the one looking down on him. "I said no. We will not be surrendering. You will return Glimmer and Catra to us immediately or there will be hell to pay."

“Oh? And who are you? Your King must truly be daring if he allows his subjects to make such demands in his stead.”

“I am Adora, Princess of Power. If you do not return Queen Glimmer and Catra to us at once, then we will come for them ourselves. I’m warning you, Horde Prime…if you’ve done anything to them, anything at all, then I will make you pay. On this I swear as a citizen of Bright Moon, and as She Ra of Etheria.”

Horde Prime crossed his arms and narrowed his eyes at her. “Hm.” His holographic figure stuttered, then disappeared entirely, leaving them alone in the war room.

“He cut the signal,” Entrapta said.

Adora immediately went to Micah who was shaking with wide eyes.

“I’m sorry,” he said, forcing himself to calm down. “I saw her there in the back and I just…I just froze.”

‘It’s okay, sir,” Adora said. She beckoned to the others who hurried over to comfort him. “We were all shocked to see that too, but you haven’t seen Glimmer in years. I can’t imagine trying to keep a clear head if I were in your shoes. I could barely keep it together as is.”

Micah flashed her a grateful look.

“This does beg the question though,” said a voice off to the side. Shadow Weaver, who up to that point had remained quiet in the corner, glided toward them. “What do we do, now that you have taken any chance of negotiation unequivocally off the table?”

Adora felt another piece in her plan fall into place and smiled. “You’ve teleported before, haven’t you? Twice, each over long distances if I remember correctly. The first when you came to Bright Moon from the Fright Zone, and the second when you, Bow, and Glimmer all came to rescue me.”

Shadow Weaver gave her a skeptical look. “Indeed, I did use a teleportation spell for each of those instances, and for others. I feel I must warn you—whatever it is you are thinking in your head of doing, teleporting is not easy nor straightforward. It’s incredibly difficult.”

Adora nodded, “I understand that, but it’s going to be difficult regardless if we intend to do anything other than give up. Entrapta pulled the coordinates from Prime’s broadcast. The exact coordinates.”

Entrapta’s eyes lit up. She seemed to suddenly piece together what Adora was getting at. “Those coordinates should not only just tell us where on the ship he is, but where exactly in space he is. XYZ coordinates. If we combine that with a teleportation spell, then—“

“Then we can teleport right in front of him and take him out.” Micah said, finishing her sentence with a nod. “It would be incredibly difficult, and we’d have to get it exactly right, but…” he glanced at Shadow Weaver, who looked like she very much didn’t want to go ahead with that plan but couldn’t find a good reason to refuse. “We should be able to do it.”

“Good,” Adora said and all eyes turned back to her. “Entrapta, you work with King Micah and Shadow Weaver on getting us there, by any means necessary. As soon as you give us the green light we’ll go.”

“This sounds awfully like a suicide mission to me,” Mermista said, looking at the other princesses, likely to gauge how many of them felt the same as her. “If we screw this up at all, even slightly, we’re done. No more Princess Alliance, no more princesses. Possibly no more Etheria.”

“That’s already going to happen if we don’t do anything at all,” Adora said. “I understand the hesitation, but think about if this works. We’ll be able to get right in front of Prime without him even expecting it and grab him, either for ransom or something

else. We should probably decide what to do with him before we go, but either way: if this works, we can turn this invasion on its head with one swift stroke."

There was another low murmur through the group, but Adora didn't hear any consensus around rejecting her plan.

"Uhh, guys?" Bow said. He had made his way to the war room's general controls during their discussion, and was looking at the reading on the console with a nervous expression. "You should take a look at this." He punched a few commands into the console and a large screen in the room blinked to life.

Multiple surveillance videos splayed across the monitor showed fresh clones pushing through the barrier like they were wading through molasses, regrouping in ordered formations on the inside. Other video feeds showed additional troops, and now tanks and armored vehicles, materializing on the outside of the barrier, beamed in from the warship overhead. They too pushed through the barrier and formed up with their fellows on the other side.

"Battle stations everyone," Adora said. "We've got another assault!"

The rest of the princesses sprinted out the war room and to their respective posts. Bow punched another command into the system and a siren blared in the distance, warning the guards to gear up and join them outside.

"Entrapta, Shadow Weaver, Micah, you three know what to do," Adora said. "Let us know as soon as you're ready. And please, hurry!" The three of them nodded, and Adora rushed off to join the others in battle.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you everyone for your comments and feedback last chapter. See you all next Thursday!

# Skin the Cat

Chapter Notes

Hello to everyone reading! I hope you are enjoying the story so far, and thank you for all your comments and feedback. I swear this chapter title isn't an April Fool's joke...I didn't even plan for it to land on this particular day either xD

Fair warning to those of you clicking into this chapter, though: This is where the storyline truly earns its 'M' rating in my eyes. While there's nothing particularly egregious (to my taste and sensibilities, at least), please know that this story doesn't shy away from the mature and dark themes it tries to explore.

Horde Prime is a despot. He acts as you'd expect a despot would.

Content warnings—not necessarily all in this chapter but for future chapters too—include: graphic violence, blood, occasional use of alcohol, references to drugs, suggestive themes, and language (mostly because of Catra, honestly...)

Edit: The original content warning here mentioned 'sexual themes' instead of 'suggestive themes', and one very thoughtful anon asked if this story would deal with anything rape or sexual assault related. The answer is no. World Eater will deal with complex emotions, reactions to those emotions, and how there are many different ways that trauma can pervade someone's lived experience and color how they cope with trauma (honestly, in the spirit of the show itself), but it will not at all even edge close to rape or sexual assault-related themes.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Although the clones had warned her Horde Prime would come for them soon, it still took Glimmer by surprise when he did. The door

to their cell hissed open a few hours after they finished eating and he stepped through, flanked by a half dozen clone guards.

"Greetings, Queen Glimmer." He smiled at her and bowed deep with a flourish. Something about him didn't seem right, but Glimmer couldn't figure out what. "I am glad to see you are doing better than when we first brought you aboard. My apologies it took so long for us to check up on you."

Glimmer shifted to give Catra, who had peeled herself off the bed and shuffled over to them, room to stand next to her. "That is quite alright," she said. "I understand conquering a planet can get complicated enough that other things"—she made a dismissive gesture with her hands—"just slip through the cracks."

Prime didn't miss the sarcasm in her voice. His smile widened and Glimmer finally realized what was bugging her the moment she saw him: he smiled as if doing so came naturally, but the impression he gave when she focused on only his eyes was that of a man one step away from reaching out and strangling her. Catra visibly shivered nearby.

"Your kingdom is feisty," he said. "The soldiers of Bright Moon are the only fighters that have managed to mount a successful defense against my forces. I recently contacted them to discuss a peaceful surrender, however your king proved to be…less than cooperative."

"Wait," Glimmer said, "what do you mean you spoke to the king of Bright Moon?" Her sense of unease from earlier threatened to boil over. There was no king of Bright Moon. Not unless…no, that couldn't be it. That was impossible.

Prime held up a small, circular emitter in the palm of his hand. It whirred to life and a still holographic image of Micah appeared.

Glimmer gasped and covered her hands with her mouth. "Dad?"

He looked much older than when she last remembered seeing him, but that was without a doubt her father. He was alive! She

had no idea how, but he was, and she wanted nothing more than for him to be real and standing physically in front of her so she could run into his arms. Then she saw the look on Prime's face, and reality reasserted itself, as did the sudden urge to cry.

"Ah, so he's your *father*," Prime said. "That explains the reaction."

Glimmer balled her hands into fists. "What did you do to him?" Just looking at Prime's face, she wasn't sure she wanted the answer.

Prime placed a hand to his chest and feigned hurt. "Me? I did nothing at all." Then he dropped the act and his grin returned. "Nothing yet, at least. As I said, I reached out to discuss terms for a peaceful surrender and he felt it a better use of his time to waste mine. I showed him a recording from your first night as my guest and, instead of realizing he was in no position to make demands of me, he froze." Prime's smiled devolved into a vaguely irritated expression. "Then one of your other subjects—she called herself the Princess of Power—swore that she would personally come rescue the both of you."

Something reinvigorated Glimmer her at the mention of Adora's title. Even Catra seemed to perk up next to her.

"Oh, you're in trouble now," Glimmer said. "If my dad and Adora are coming, then it's only a matter of time before you'll be begging us for peaceful terms of surrender for yourself."

Prime laughed. "Yes, well, I have decided to just conquer the stronghold the old-fashioned way. Bright Moon shall fall by the time the morning sun rises on your kingdom, then Etheria will join a long list of worlds that have been subjugated and annexed into my empire."

He stepped forward and stroked her cheek with the back of his hand. Glimmer shuddered and resisted the urge to bite his fingers.

“What I need from you now, though,” he said, “is information on the weapon. You will come with me and tell me everything you know about the Heart of Etheria. I need to know exactly who among the princesses I capture need to be kept alive to operate it. Everyone else will be made a severe example of.”

Glimmer scoffed. “I’m not telling you anything.” To her surprise, that only seemed to make Prime more excited.

“That’s quite alright,” he said. The tendrils atop his head started to unfurl. “You don’t need to speak at all if you don’t want to. I intend to get the information I desire by other means.” The tips of those tendrils peeled back, revealing six needles on the ends, each of them poised like serpents about to strike.

If him stepping so close and violating her personal space hadn’t done enough to deter her, the tendrils made up the difference. As soon as she saw them point at her, she realized what he intended to do, and the fiery, defiant feeling that had spurred her forward suddenly snuffed out. All of a sudden, it seemed a very good idea to run as far and fast away from him as she could.

Prime gestured to his clone guards and they surged forward. Two of them grabbed her under the arms and lifted her so her feet came off the ground. Glimmer struggled, shouting and kicking and yelling and screaming for them to put her down. Prime merely turned and began to stalk out the room while the clones followed suit, dragging her along with them.

“Wait!”

Glimmer craned her neck around and saw Catra standing there, one hand outstretched as if to physically grab hold of her, pupils constricted into pinprick slits, ears pinned and tail low and subdued under her body. Prime turned and cocked an eyebrow at her. He didn’t speak.

Catra swallowed. “Take me instead,” she said, smoothing her mane down. “I’m a safer bet for interrogation than she is, at least

to start."

"Oh?" Prime turned fully and snapped his fingers. The clones lowered Glimmer to the ground and she jerked out of their grasp. "And why is that?"

"B-because you don't know how probing her mind with those will go," Catra said, indicating his tendrils. "It might be fine and you'd have the information you want, or it might go horribly and you might kill one of the pieces you definitely need to work the Heart. It will be safer to start with me. If I die, then you still have another chance with her. Besides, I already have experience…." Catra shuddered and looked away as if remembering something horrible. When she next spoke, her voice was low and sounded like she felt disgusted with herself. "I already have experience having my mind probed anyway."

Prime seemed to think on her words for a moment. Finally, he nodded. "You Etherians are all so defiant. Normally I'd just crush you and be done with it for speaking out of turn, but it is especially vexing given the recent state of the Empire. At least you are the first I've come across to argue with some sense." He gestured again to his clones. "Take them both."

Half the clones moved to surround Catra too. She shrugged them off and pushed them away when they moved to grab her, much like Glimmer had. "There's no need for that," she said, ducking away from the grasp of another clone. "I'll come willingly."

One of the clones grabbed Catra by the shoulder, violently torqued his body, and slammed a fist deep into her gut. The muscles in his arm and shoulder rippled with the impact, and Glimmer gasped. Catra yelped, then fell to the floor and threw up the only food she had eaten in days. Prime sneered at the sight, then turned and stalked out of the cell without looking back.

Catra continued to wretch even as the clones grabbed her by the armpits and dragged her limp body through her sick and out the door behind Prime. Glimmer didn't put up any further fight when

her own escorting clones lifted her and followed the rest of them at the back.

They continued on down a long hall and piled in to an elevate at the end. Glimmer stole glances in Catra's direction as she felt the elevator pull them up. Her head lolled to the side, and Glimmer didn't think she'd have been able to stand if the clones let go of her. She pleaded in her head for Catra not to give them any further reason to hurt her. Enemy or not, she didn't want that for her.

When the lift doors opened, they exited out into a perfectly circular room. Massive windows to the stars outside stretched from floor to ceiling along the room's perimeter in lieu of bulkheads, and because this unbroken panorama showed far more of their surroundings than the window of their holding cell, Glimmer also saw something she hadn't before: a titanic fleet of warships, stretching endlessly in the distance all around them, parading in neat rows and columns like a never-ending field of crops orbiting Etheria's curve. It was an observation deck situated at the top of Prime's citadel. Suddenly, the long elevator ride made sense.

"Beautiful, isn't it?" Prime said. "Only the most elite and distinguished soldiers and officers comprise my Vanguard. They do not typically leave the Heartlands, but I take a fraction of them along when I travel." He frowned. "Unfortunately, conflict among the border has necessitated that many of them be redeployed to the front lines."

Glimmer barely registered what he said out of her concern for Catra. She seemed to have recovered somewhat. Her head no longer lolled to the side, and she no longer hung completely limp between her escort, but there was no telling what Prime had planned for the both of them or how they would fare through it.

The clones dragged them to the center of the room where a group of figures wearing white robes with deep hoods stood in a tight ring. They admitted them into the circle when they

approached, where Glimmer saw two examination chairs inside, angled facing each other with restraining belts hanging off their frames. A set of consoles stood nearby, and the two clones that weren't supporting her or Catra moved to man them.

Another man, wearing the same robes as the others except gilded in green, stood next to the first chair and glanced over at them. Gaunt features and sunken eyes stared out at them from inside the hood. Then he lowered it and revealed a prominent widow's peak, and greying hair worn slicked back. A beak-shaped nose accented his profile and gave Glimmer the firm impression of a malnourished bird of prey masquerading as a man.

"This is Salas," Prime said. He snapped his fingers and the clones let them down to stand on their own two feet. Catra wobbled, but they supported her. "Salas is my advisor and an Imperial Battlemage of the Enclave. I believe the closest analogy to your planet's institutions would be the Mages Association at Mystacor."

Glimmer blanched. Powerful spells shrouded Mystacor to render it invisible and keep it safe. If Prime knew of it and of the Mages Association, did that also mean he had already conquered it? What did that mean for her Aunt? She wouldn't have let it fall… not without a fight…

Prime leered at her and Glimmer couldn't finish the thought.

The man—Salas was what Prime said his name was? It was hard to remember with everything happening—she couldn't read his expression. Instead of giving Prime the satisfaction of seeing her panic over Mystacor, she swallowed the lump growing in her throat, turned to face Salas, and said, "Nice to meet you." Her voice didn't come out nearly as confident as she'd hoped it'd be.

She heard a thunk and a yell as one of the clones shoved Catra onto one of the chairs and began strapping her in. Catra, dazed, started to struggle against them and another clone rammed its fist into her gut once again before Glimmer could react.

“Don’t hurt her!” she said, lunging toward them, determined to get them to stop.

The other clones held her back, but otherwise didn’t harm her. She hated how gentle they were with her. Why couldn’t they do the same with Catra?

Catra doubled over, coughing and hacking and spitting up on the floor. The clones shoved her upright into the back of the chair and finished strapping her in without any further protest. Catra groaned, her breathing coming out in ragged, wheezing gasps. Glimmer looked away and tried to drown out the sound of her suffering.

“Hurry and finish your preparations,” Prime said to Salas. “I want as much information as possible before the Seraph arrives and makes things difficult, since your order was so adamant about sending her.”

Salas nodded and gestured to the other chair. “Queen Glimmer, please take your seat so we may begin.” His voice was surprisingly sturdy, despite his appearance.

Glimmer hesitated, and Horde Prime extended a clawed finger and caught Catra underneath the chin. “Salas is ever a polite man,” he said to her. “But contrary to his tone, that was not a request. You will take your seat and cooperate or Catra will suffer the consequences for your insolence.” Catra whimpered and stuck her chin high in the air to avoid Prime’s claw, but he followed her movement and didn’t let up. A thin line of blood ran from under her chin, down Prime’s finger.

“Fine, fine, fine,” Glimmer said, darting in to the chair. “Just don’t hurt her any more. Let’s just talk, okay? Whatever information you need, just ask us and we’ll cooperate. There’s no need to do whatever you’re about to do. This doesn’t need to be an interrogation.”

Prime laughed and slid around behind Catra's chair. She panicked and her eyes darted as she twisted in her restraints trying to watch what he was doing. Prime reached up over the head rest, palmed her entire head in his hand, and pulled it back so it was flush against the chair. Glimmer got the sense he was doing this on purpose to drive a point home.

"Shhhh, it's okay, shhh," Prime bent over low and whispered into Catra's ear as her panic deepened. When she screwed her eyes shut and stilled as if tensing for another beating, Prime turned and looked Glimmer in the eyes and unfurled his tendrils. "A thousand apologies, Queen Glimmer," he said, not sounding sorry at all. "We unfortunately do not have the luxury of time on our side. This is simply the most efficient way—it's nothing personal. When I have thoroughly sucked every usable tidbit of information from this creature's mind"—he jerked Catra's head side to side like it was a joystick—"I will turn my attention to you. I have a feeling you will offer scant resistance after watching what happens to your friend." He cracked a wicked grin and nodded at Salas.

"Whatever you do," said a voice startlingly close to her. "Do not get out of this chair no matter how agonizing it is to stay. Your friend will thank you for it." Salas had taken up a position near her, and had spoken in a low enough voice that Horde Prime hadn't seemed to hear. Glimmer stared up at him and swallowed.

Salas looked around at the hooded figures in the circle and gestured. Suddenly, every member of the circle tilted their heads down, extended their arms out in front of them, and splayed their fingers. A low chanting filled the air and washed out the ambient beeping and whirring of the station's life support. A hush then descended upon them, covering them like a blanket. A chill ran down Glimmer's spine, and goosebumps sprang up along her flesh.

Patterns began to etch themselves into the metal of the floor. Glimmer watched them weave and curl like serpents performing an intricate dance. Within moments, the lines began to connect,

and soon a whole circular design underneath them was there, flourished and strangely beautiful.

*It's a magic rune*, Glimmer realized with a start. She had learned many of them during her short time as Shadow Weaver's student, but none of them nearly as intricate or large as this.

She tried to pinpoint what each area of the rune did—*that part is a feedback loop for the magic energy, that area over there is a smoothing agent*—but quickly pulled her attention away; just looking at it seemed to pull a fog over her mind. Instead, she glanced up at Salas and tried to see if watching him would hint at their plans.

Salas made a quick gesture with one hand and Glimmer felt magic ripple out from where he stood. Another pattern formed in the floor, this one with an even more intense light emanating from his design as it burned itself into the ground. The new pattern directly intersected and, at times, complimented what the other mages had made. A pressure built in Glimmer's head the more he drew.

"How does it feel, Salas?" Prime asked, when the man was done. "Is Etheria everything that wretched girl said it would be?"

Salas seemed surprised Horde Prime had asked him that question. "If anything, my lord, I think Evelyn underestimated this place. We are high up enough the magic should be only a fraction of its real strength on the surface, but what I feel is staggering, even here."

Prime frowned. "I had her wiped from the histories for a reason, and you would do well to remember that. Never say her name again."

"I apologize," Salas said with a shallow nod. "It shall not happen again. Our preparations are complete. Please begin at your leisure."

Prime's eyes lit up and he once again stooped over behind Catra's chair so he was roughly equal-height with her. Two of his uncoiled

tendrils reared back, then shot one after the other into either side of Catra's head at the temples. The pressure at the back of Glimmer's head from earlier exploded. Abject terror ripped into her. It blew out every other sense and instinct she had.

*Insolent child. You have never been anything but a disappointment to me.*

Voices in her head. There were voices in her head. Glimmer slammed her eyes shut and tried to shake the voices free, tried to drown them out.

Shadow Weaver wasn't there…she just wasn't. It was a trick of her mind. It was whatever spell Salas and his men had tangled her in, making her hear things.

Something came from that pressure, threatening to smash her head like a grapefruit—a command to keep her eyes open. She obeyed.

Catra screamed and struggled in the chair across from her, straining the belts hard enough to show muscles and veins popping and rippling under her skin. Her nails dug into the arm rests and her eyes rolled into the back of her head.

*Rise, Force Captain Catra.* Pride burned within Glimmer's chest at the words and she realized with a chill that the rune underneath them had *linked* her mind with Catra's. Whatever emotions and images Horde Prime was dragging from her memories were also on full display for her as well

The scene shifted in her head and sorrow took her. Glimmer felt as if a young Adora stood before her, sensed it happening without seeing it with her own eyes. She could almost imagine Adora's giant, friendly, blue eyes and hesitant smile as she looked at her—at *them*.

*It doesn't matter what they do to us, y'know? You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other.*

“Adora!” Catra spoke aloud. Screamed. She twisted against her restraints. “Adora, help me!”

Prime held her head still for the tendrils. Lines of blood slid down her face where his claws pricked her trying to hold tight, and two larger rivers of red streaked down from where his tendrils intersected her temples.

Something about the magic around them abated somewhat. Glimmer realized she could once more feel her own sensations and emotions when the urge to lunge forward and physically wrestle Prime away from Catra grew overpowering.

*Don’t get out of that chair*.

Salas’ words came to her as if he spoke directly into her head. Glimmer looked to him and, surprisingly, saw him looking back.

*Your friend needs you to hold onto*, he said. *If you break the connection, then she will be lost at sea. She will never recover. Stay in the chair and stop fighting me.*

Glimmer grit her teeth in frustration and indecision. She had no way of knowing if Salas was telling the truth, but he spoke of Catra recovering and that was enough for her. The pinprick of hope was there and she chose to cling to it. She forced herself to relax, and her vision misted over the moment she did. Salas, Prime, Catra, the mages, and the whole observation deck disappeared as if a heavy fog descended upon them.

Shapes and angles appeared in the fog like shadows, and Glimmer recognized the new setting as it pulled into focus. She was in some sort of lab deep in the Fright Zone. Boxes lay stacked nearby in the corner and a terminal whirred in front of her. ‘DANGER!’ flashed red on the giant screen above. A voice echoed from somewhere Glimmer couldn’t pinpoint.

“This time, I am going to win. I don’t care what it takes, we are opening that portal, now!”

Glimmer looked around for Catra. It was her voice, no doubt about that, but she didn't see anyone there with her. She swung back around and nearly fell backward in fright when it was Entrapta standing there instead of Catra, looking up at her with fear in her eyes.

"No!" Entrapta said. "I won't! I need to tell Hordak. He'll understa—"

Glimmer's body wasn't her own. She realized that as she lunged forward and rammed a stun baton she hadn't noticed she was carrying into Entrapta's back when she turned to run. Entrapta fell to the ground unconscious, and Glimmer dropped the baton. Her hands flew to cover her mouth.

*What have I done?* she thought. *What did I do to Entrapta?*

Glimmer turned to run away, only to see a brand-new sight before and around her. She was no longer in the lab with Entrapta, but a new area of the Fright Zone—one that lay in ruins. Broken machinery lay strewn about. Pipes all around leaked oil and steam, and fires burned everywhere she turned, emanating smoke that burned her throat and made her eye's water.

This time, Glimmer saw Catra. She was standing in the distance, one arm crossed over to hold the elbow of the other, terrified.

"Catra?" Glimmer ran toward her, stepping over debris and shards of broken glass. "Catra, something's going on. I don't know what's happening, but something is *wrong.* I can feel it." What happened to Horde Prime's ship? What happened to all the clones? They needed to get out of there. They needed to—

A second Catra stepped toward the first—one that Glimmer hadn't seen until she rounded a pile of burning equipment and the full scene beyond came into view. Glimmer skidded to a halt and tried to figure out what the hell was happening.

"You try so hard to play the big, bad villain," said the second Catra, invading the first's personal space and rubbing up against

her. “But your heart’s never been in it, has it?”

First Catra panicked. “What? What are you...? No, stop. Stop it!” She lunged. Second Catra dodged and grabbed her by the wrist.

“People have hurt you, haven’t they?” she said as she transformed into Shadow Weaver. “They didn’t believe in you.” Shadow Weaver transformed into Hordak, “They didn’t trust you.” Hordak transformed into Adora. “Didn’t need you. Left you.”

Catra yelped and scrabbled backward, falling to the floor. Adora transformed into Double Trouble, who stepped forward and continued to press her.

“But did you ever stop to think maybe they’re not the problem?” they said. They transformed again and a moment later it was Scorpia who towered above Catra. “It’s you. You drive them away, Wildcat.”

Catra stared up at Scorpia in anguish. “Why are you doing this?”

Glimmer reached out to Catra and the scene began to melt back into the fog from before. The ruins of the Fright Zone turned back into shapes and shadows in mist as Glimmer called out Catra’s name. Nothing kept the scene from continuing to devolve, no matter how many times she shouted and no matter how loud. She was powerless to stop whatever it was, pulling her out. A chorus of new voices chased her back to oblivion.

*…It’s for your own good, darling. We both know this isn’t what you really wanted…*

*…Never been anything but a disappointment to me…*

*…Because you left me! Don’t you see, Adora…?*

Reality reasserted itself so abruptly Glimmer almost fell out of her chair. Her heart pounded like war drums in her ears, drowning out anything she might have been able to focus on around her. She realized she was back in the interrogation chair as she blinked the

blur out of her vision. The rune on the floor was still there, as was Salas and his circle of robed mages. Prime's two clones monitoring the consoles off to the side exchanged confused glances with one another. Catra still screamed and flailed in the chair opposite her.

It was only Horde Prime that looked any different. Whereas before he had worn a face filled with glee, now he seemed annoyed.

"Why can't I see anything more relevant?" he asked, glancing up at Salas and narrowing his eyes. "Why can't I see anything about the weapon?"

"Memories are complicated my lord," Salas said. "She is not one of your clones, so it will require time, alongside my skill and finesse."

"W-why are you doing this?" Catra's voice came out in hoarse croaks and she screwed her eyes shut in pain. "I t-told you already, I don't know anything else about the w-weapon. I'm sor-…I'm sorry, just…just please. Please don't. No more. Please."

"You're lying," Prime said, his sing-song voice making it clear how much he enjoyed hurting her. "And if I find out you really *do* know nothing, that you lied about having information in the first place to spare the Queen, then I will make sure you come back as nothing more intelligent than a vegetable."

"Uh, sir?" one of the clones at the terminal said. "Lord Prime, we are being pinged. It's a priority one message sir, and the identification code is confirmed. It's from the *Constable*, transmitting in hyperspace."

Prime cursed. "You *stall* her, damn it. You tell her I am busy, that it is an emergency—I don't care. Just keep her away."

The clone looked up with a distressed expression. "I can't reject the request, sir. My access has been overridden. It's connecting on its own."

A section of the nearby panorama window turned opaque and a young woman appeared on screen. "Lord Prime," she said. "Hello."

Her projection onto the massive windows made her appear several times larger than life. Glimmer could only see the top half of her, but judging from the officer's cap atop her head and the medals decorating the standing collar and breast of her jacket, it was obvious this new person was someone important.

The woman studied him for a long moment, her eyes never leaving his. "In the middle of something, I see? Sorry for interrupting. I only wished to inform you that I have been dispatched to oversee the Etheria project and will arrive soon."

Horde Prime grimaced and stood up straight, disconnecting his tendrils from Catra's head but still keeping his hand firm on her head. "Taline," he said. "What a surprise. Who would have guessed the Enclave would send you to handle their affairs in this matter."

Catra moaned and her eyes fluttered open. Glimmer felt another urge to rush to her side and stamped it down when she remembered Salas' words from earlier. She needed to be in the chair, to be the rock Catra held onto through this ordeal.

Taline frowned, looking down at the both of them in the chairs. "My lord, I feel compelled to remind you that you explicitly promised the Enclave full operational authority over Etheria once it reappeared. Why are you torturing its subjects and invading the planet? This is a direct violation of our agreement."

Prime smiled and made a conciliatory gesture. "I'm securing both the planet and necessary information on the weapon before you arrive. Think of it like me giving you a running start on what is no doubt going to become a long assignment."

Taline's frown deepened and she didn't respond for several moments. When she again spoke, it was clear she had taken the time to consider her words carefully.

"You and I both know this mission concerns more than just your rule. It's entirely safe to say that if we fail then the entire galaxy is

at risk, not just the Empire. I need them in one piece when I arrive. All of them. I can't do my job if their subjects are broken and everything has already been thrown into chaos."

Prime's smile tightened. "I understand. Rest assured that I will not hinder you in your mission. The planet is under my control save for a small rebel group at the kingdom of Bright Moon." He gestured to Glimmer and sneered. "I have their Queen, and they will do nothing while she is in danger. I will guarantee their safety until you arrive. Is this sufficient for you?"

"It is, lord Prime. Thank you. I shall arrive within a day and will hail you again once I do."

She glanced for the briefest of moments in Salas' direction and nodded. Then she turned back to Prime, gave a sharp salute, and disappeared from the viewscreen as it turned transparent. Etheria, the stars, and the warships of Prime's armada appeared there once more.

The smile on Prime's face morphed into a look of barely concealed rage. "Get the Queen back to her cell," he said. The clones nearest her grabbed Glimmer under the arms and hauled her off the chair.

"My lord, what of the cat girl?" Salas asked.

"I promised your colleague that no further harm would come to Bright Moon or its citizens and I intend to keep that promise," he said, squeezing Catra's head in his claws and forcing another whimper from her mouth. "But this one is one of my defective brother's underlings—a citizen of 'The Fright Zone,' as it were. She is not included, and I will finish my interrogation with your assistance."

Glimmer panicked. She was supposed to stay in the chair…she *had* to stay. She fought the clones as they dragged her back out the circle and toward the elevator, hating the fact they didn't punch

her into submission like they did Catra. She couldn't leave. She had to stay and help.

Salas locked eyes with her a moment, and Glimmer saw in his look that he hadn't expected this to happen. The thought should have given her hope that maybe he really was trying to help them, but it only served to make her panic more the further she was dragged away. Salas glanced from her back toward Catra and set his lips in a thin line, as if a renewed sense of resolve invaded him.

Glimmer turned her attention back to Catra and didn't take her eyes off her until the mages reformed their circle and blocked her view. As soon as the clones pulled her far enough away that she came off the magic rune, she felt her connection to Catra break. All the horror and rage and despair that she felt earlier vanished, leaving a cavernous void inside where emotion and memory once roiled. She gasped, feeling very much like ice water had been thrown over her.

The clones had gotten her inside the elevator. The last thing Glimmer heard as the doors sealed shut in front of her was Catra's unbridled, full-throated wail for the one person she hoped beyond hope would save her.

"*Adora!*"

Chapter End Notes

> My beta after reading this chapter: "Wow okay, so that's definitely earned the 'hurt' part of your 'hurt/comfort' tag… does that mean we get the 'comfort' part next?
>
> Poor Catra...girl can't catch a break. Maybe Glimmer will be a little more understanding the next time they see each other? What do you think?

# Unlikely Allies

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer wasn't sure how many hours she had passed pacing around the table in the cell after her return, all she knew was Catra had been gone too long. So long in fact, she had started to fear Horde Prime really had killed her in that chair back on the observation tower.

Finally, at long last, the doors slid open and two Prime clones dumped her body inside the threshold like a sack of bricks. They left without a second glance back, and Glimmer rushed to kneel at her side.

"Catra? Catra wake up. It's me, Glimmer."

For a second time, Glimmer feared she was dead—feared Prime had decided to play a cruel joke on her by dumping her cell-mate's dead body back in there with her instead of disposing of it. Catra was already malnourished and dehydrated to begin with. Adding the dried blood caked into her face and the sweat and grime matting the rest of her fur, she was near indiscernible from a corpse. Glimmer watched her carefully, searching for the rise and fall of her chest.

Finally, Catra moaned and Glimmer breathed a sigh of relief. Catra's eyes peeled open and she looked up at her. Her inner eyelids refused to pull back all the way. Glimmer could see her pupils trying to focus, see Catra's mind begin to piece together where she was and what was going on.

"Get away from me!" Catra unsheathed claws and swiped at her, forcing Glimmer back. "I told you I don't know anything. Get out of my head! No more hallucinations. I'm sorry! I don't know anything, just…no more. Please. Haven't you taken enough?"

Catra scurried to a corner of the room, wincing with every movement as if her whole body itself was an open sore, and Glimmer felt her heart break. Even with all the adrenaline coursing through her veins, Catra could still feel the pain. This wasn't the Horde Commander that nearly destroyed Bright Moon all those years ago, wasn't the Horde Commander that Adora obsessed over being outsmarted by, and definitely wasn't the same Horde Commander that opened a portal in the Fright Zone that took her mother from her. This was a broken shell of a person, pressing herself into the corner like she thought it was the only way to survive.

"Catra, I'm not a hallucination," Glimmer said, inching forward on her knees and holding an open palm to her. "It's me, Glimmer—the real Glimmer. You're back in our cell, and Horde Prime isn't here. He can't hurt you anymore, okay? It's just you and me."

Catra pushed further into the wall as Glimmer approached. Her pupils narrowed to hairline slits and she hissed, although she stopped short of lashing out again. Glimmer continued to close the distance inch by inch, until she was finally close enough to touch her. Catra flinched and hissed again when Glimmer lay the back of her hand gently against her forehead, but from there seemed to calm.

"My god, you are burning up," Glimmer said.

Hearing her voice in conjunction with the touch seemed to do the trick. The tension in Catra's shoulders relaxed and she stopped baring fangs at her. Glimmer adjusted herself so their knees touched, and move to stroke Catra's cheek instead of her forehead. Catra's tail thrashed less with each caress, and some form of recognition seemed to return to the look in her eyes.

"It's…really cold," Catra said, voice dipping low into a rasp. A shiver ran down her body and, nodding, Glimmer took her hand away and slowly scooted backward.

Catra tracked her as she crossed the cell to their bunk bed and yanked a pillow and sheets from the bottom bunk. She came back around and, after taking a second look at her, thought of something else.

"I'm going to grab some stuff from the bathroom and try and clean you up a bit, okay?" Glimmer chose to lean down and placed the bedding on the floor next to Catra rather than tossing it, in case the sudden movement startled her. When she glimpsed the uncertain look in Catra's eyes, she said, "I'm not leaving. I'll be just behind that door over there for like, two seconds and I'll be right back."

She pointed to their bathroom and edged toward it. Catra gave a jerky nod as she pulled the blankets closer to her.

Glimmer slipped into the bathroom as quickly as she could. Even if Catra watched her walk in here, she didn't want to risk her lapsing into another paranoid episode being left alone outside. So, she did the only thing she could do, and talked to her in the other room.

"I'm surprised we have such a nice bathroom," she said, throwing open the linen cabinet and scooping as many towels as she could into her arms. "Horde Prime is such a bastard, but at least there's stuff in here we can use." She grabbed a wash basin and shoved it under the sink, turning the faucet on full blast. A first aid kit sat in the medicine cabinet when she opened it and she nabbed that as well. "It's kind of like the 'cell' we have at Bright Moon, except our place is nice. We don't like treating people badly, even if they're an enemy, so our 'prison' just seems like any other room in the castle." Glimmer had a feeling Prime only gave his prisoners nice things to instill a false sense of security.

She hurried out of the bathroom, balancing the linens in one hand and the full wash basin in the other. Catra had propped her pillow behind her in the corner where Glimmer had left her, and had pulled her blankets up half-heartedly over her lap. She likely didn't have the strength to do much more than that, now that the adrenaline had left her.

Glimmer knelt back down in front of her. “I’m going to try and get as much of the blood off you as I can, okay?” She held up the rag to show Catra she wasn’t planning on doing anything threatening. “You’ll feel better once I get you cleaned up a bit.”

Catra eyed her and the washcloth, but didn’t refuse. Taking that as permission to proceed, Glimmer dipped the first towel in the water and dabbed at Catra’s temple, where the freshest and nastiest wound lay. Catra flinched, hissing and baring her teeth once again. Glimmer paused but didn’t move away, and when Catra stilled, she resumed dabbing at the wound.

The rag came away almost immediately soaked through in blood, and Glimmer wasn’t sure whether or not she was just making it worse. She dipped the cloth back in the basin and watched as her hand underneath the water disappeared into a sea of red. Fortunately, this time when she resumed cleaning, the blood seemed to clear up some. By the time she felt she had done as much as she could on the first wound and moved on to the second at her other temple, Catra had calmed enough to lie in a fetal position, sideways with her head resting on Glimmer’s lap.

“They went on for a while after they took you away,” Catra said in a low voice. “I have no idea how long. It felt like forever.”

Glimmer looked away out of guilt and paused her dabbing. “I’m sorry I couldn’t be there. They grabbed me and I just…I fought, but I couldn’t get away.”

Catra shrugged. “It’s not like you could have done anything even if you had. Those clones are strong—I’m pretty sure I have a bruised rib or two from where they slugged me.” She paused, and when Glimmer glanced back at her, she saw Catra looking up at her out the corner of her eye. “Thanks for trying though.”

“Why did you volunteer to take my place?” Glimmer hated how resigned to it all Catra sounded. She exchanged the rag for a fresh one and worked at the grime and blood elsewhere on Catra’s face. The injuries at her temples looked as clean as she

thought she were going to get them, and now it was time to move on to the rest of her.

"What do you mean? I was strapped down to a chair, so it's not like I really had a choice."

"That's not what I meant," Glimmer said. "Horde Prime was going to take just me at first. You were the one that jumped in and convinced him to start with you. Why?"

Catra cracked a smile. "Can't a girl just do something nice for once? You're welcome."

"You and I have very different ideas of 'nice,' " Glimmer said, making a face. "Volunteering for torture in lieu of someone else is called 'masochistic' in my book."

"Ain't that the truth." Catra closed her eyes and chuckled when her face suddenly contorted in pain. She curled into herself on Glimmer's lap as deep, hacking coughs wracked her body.

"Hey, come on now." Glimmer dropped the rag, tilted Catra further forward to gain better access to her back, and rubbed at the knots there with firm, smoothing gestures. "I know for you it's probably impossible to resist, but don't go making smart-ass comments if you're just going to end up hurting yourself."

Catra made several high-pitched gasps for air between coughs, but steadily relaxed against Glimmer's movements. Her breathing evened out until, finally, the tension in her body released. She gave another shiver under the blankets, and Glimmer pulled them up to better insulate her.

"You're hopeless," Glimmer said. Without even thinking about it, she moved her hands from Catra's back and began running her fingers through her mane instead.

"Mmm shut up." A purr rumbled out from her. "You sound like Adora."

Glimmer froze, her fingers halfway down the length of Catra's hair. Under normal circumstances, she wouldn't have thought twice if someone compared her to Adora—it was a compliment. But these were far from normal circumstances, and Catra's relationship both to her and to Adora was complicated at best. Had Catra meant that in a positive way? Even if she hadn't, did it really matter? Glimmer shrugged and decided it really didn't, and resumed combing her fingers through Catra's hair.

"I have a little more experience with mind probes than I'm guessing you do," Catra said, looking at her again after a long moment of silence.

"After what happened up there with Prime and those mages? No doubt about it." Glimmer was surprised to hear Catra speak at all. She thought she had fallen asleep in her lap.

"I'm answering your question, stupid." Catra and averted her eyes. "I wasn't lying when I told Prime earlier that I already had prior experience. I figured, out of the two of us, I'd break less easily and…well…I didn't want to take the chance things wouldn't go well for you. So, I stepped up."

Glimmer fought to keep the anger out of her voice when she next spoke. "When were you mind probed before?" Catra squeezed her eyes shut and tensed her shoulders, and Glimmer gave voice to the guess that had first popped into her head. "Shadow Weaver did that to you? Why?"

"I've been trying to figure that one out for as long as I can remember," Catra said, her voice small. "I just figured that, since I already know what it's like, I might do better going first. Prime would be less likely to push your limits if he already pushed mine."

"Did you really just asked him to *test drive* you first?" Glimmer asked. "So he'd be less likely to break me on accident the second time around?" She pulled her hands out of Catra's hair before she started inadvertently fisting it in anger. "That's it? *That* was your genius idea?"

“I just didn’t expect it to hurt as much…or go on as long.”

Catra spoke as if admitting the words to herself. As if everything she said were merely an afterthought and not a confession of pure martyrdom to Glimmer’s ears.

“I thought you had some sort of plan, Catra.” All the fight had left Glimmer in a rush, like someone had exorcised it from her, leaving behind only the sadness she felt for the body curled against her. “You always had plans when we fought. Why is it now that we’re just trying to survive together that you throw yourself forward like some kind of sacrifice?”

“I did have a plan” Catra said, opening her eyes and glaring up at her again. Some of the fight that had abandoned Glimmer seemed to have seeped into her instead. “Wanting to keep you from getting hurt was the main reason, but I didn’t just throw myself forward at him.”

“Alright, and what was this grand plan of yours then?”

Catra huffed again. “Shadow Weaver never told me about this—it definitely wasn’t something she wanted me to know. But if you were probed enough times, you’d eventually pick up on the fact those probes are a two-way street. Prime went digging in my head for answers about the Heart, but I was also able to feel about a little in his head as well.”

Glimmer’s eyebrows shot up in surprise. “You were? What did you find?” Separately, she wondered in the back of her mind how many probes Catra had been subjected to for her to have learned that little trick, and resolved to revisit Shadow Weaver’s license to freely roam Bright Moon if she ever made it home.

“That woman,” Catra said. “The one that contacted him right before you were taken away—I think Prime called her Taline…he’s afraid of her.” Catra swallowed, as if telling of Prime’s thoughts forced her to revisit the torture session anew. “He’s afraid of her,

and he's afraid of her order—the Enclave. He bottles it up so it doesn't show outwardly, but it's there."

Glimmer furrowed her brow. "Afraid as in like, she's the true power behind the throne or…?"

Catra shook her head. "I can't tell for sure, but I don't think so. That's not what it felt like.  He doesn't fear *her* necessarily, he hates her. But he fears what her coming here means…fears what she represents." She growled, as if frustrated she couldn't find the right words. "I don't know how to describe it better than that."

"It's okay," Glimmer said. She wrung the water out of yet another rag and resumed dabbing at Catra's forehead with it. Sometime during their conversation, she remembered how nasty of a fever Catra had, and Glimmer wanted to do what she could to bring it down quickly. "Whoever this Taline person is—and whatever it is she's coming to do—we'll get through it together. I don't care if those clones dislocate my arm trying to hold me back or cart me off somewhere, I'm not getting separated from you again."

Catra hummed at that and closed her eyes while Glimmer worked on her. Within moments she fell into a deep sleep.

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Glimmer woke at some point, not having realized she had closed her eyes at all to begin with.

Her back ached sitting against the wall, even with the pillow propped behind her. Catra was pulling out of her lap, and Glimmer quickly shook the grogginess from her mind to get up and help her stand. She half expected Catra to shy away from her touch and argue with her, and when she didn't, Glimmer helped support her to the bathroom, leaving her be after handing over one of the unused towels from earlier and a fresh set of clothes from the storage bin under their bunk.

The clones brought food while she was sat next to the closed bathroom doorway, ready in case Catra needed help and actually

called for it. They came in and left the trays on the table like they always had, never speaking a word. Today was a big bowl of soup for each of them.

Before long, Catra stepped out of the bathroom with a cloud of steam and heat billowing out behind her. The clean clothes Glimmer had given her hung off her bones, already soaked almost all the way through as she stood there and dripped bath water on the floor: she hadn't had the strength or energy to fully dry herself off, and instead merely draped the towel around her neck and over her shoulders.

She bared her teeth at Glimmer when she stood up to help her. "Don't touch me," Catra said, pulling away from her and clung to the wall as she skirted the perimeter of the cell toward the bunk. She lost her balance and would have fallen to the floor if Glimmer hadn't darted in and held her up.

Catra grumbled but didn't fight her as she guided them the rest of the way and eased her into a sitting position on the bed. When Glimmer took the towel from her shoulders and moved to dry her off, Catra hissed and said, "I can do it myself!"

Glimmer huffed and dropped the towel in her lap. She had no idea why Catra was suddenly so prickly. Did the humidity from her shower make her forget that Glimmer had cleaned her wounds, practically petted her to sleep, and then helped her into the bathroom in the first place? She slogged back to the table and sat, gritting her teeth as she watched Catra's pitiful attempt to dry off without her help. She eventually shoved the towel to the floor with a snarl after giving up, and Glimmer picked up one of the trays of soup to bring over to her, refusing to utter a single word.

"I'm not hungry," Catra said, glaring at her approach.

"We aren't doing this again." Glimmer scowled at her. "Stop being stubborn and just eat."

Catra scoffed and Glimmer slammed the tray down hard onto her lap. Soup sloshed out and scalded her knees and thighs, and she bit back another hiss with her eyes screwed shut. Glimmer didn't even try to hide how satisfied shutting Catra up made her feel as she spooned a bit of soup and held it in front of her face for her to sip on.

"Okay, okay, I get it," Catra said, leaning away from the spoon. "I was wrong. Maybe you wouldn't be gentler than the clones. Let me at least feed myself?"

Glimmer shrugged and dropped the spoon back into the bowl, splashing more soup and sending Catra into another hissing fit. She was far past the point of caring. If Catra wanted to go back to being a stubborn pain in the ass, then she'd respond in kind. It made no difference to her.

Catra fished spoon out of the bowl with shaky fingers and, when she realized she couldn't grip them strong enough, resorted to palming the handle between the heels of both her hands. The spoon rattled against the bowl and shook violently as she slowly tried to bring it to her mouth. She grew increasingly frustrated the longer she tried. Even Glimmer winced watching her struggle.

She ultimately stopped her, shooting out an arm to grab both Catra's wrists before she made an even larger mess all over the bed. She suppressed the urge to smack Catra upside the head when she gave her another glare and, instead, pulled the chair around in front of her to sit on, scooped up a healthier portion of soup, and held it up a second time with steady hands for her to eat from.

"Well?" Glimmer said after watching Catra's gaze dart between her and the spoon. When Catra inched forward and took a bite, Glimmer smirked. "See? That wasn't so hard now, was it?" Catra refused to look her in the eyes, but continued to dutifully eat every spoonful Glimmer presented her with.

"Why are you doing this?" Catra asked after a while.

"You think someone else is going to step up and make sure you get food in you if you can't do it yourself? Last I checked, it's just us two in here."

"That's not what I meant," Catra said, taking another bite. Again, she sounded small rather than combative, and Glimmer wondered when this roller coaster of hot and cold between them would level out. "I meant…why are you helping me at all? Why go to all this trouble when I've been such an asshole to you and all your precious princess friends?"

"Isn't that just the question of the century?"

Glimmer gave a derisive laugh, only to let it die out after seeing the stony look Catra returned her. She was being serious, but Glimmer had no idea how to respond. It was a lot to unpack—what the heck was she *supposed* to say?

"I don't know," she said at last. "I'm just doing what I can to help. Not really thinking about the 'why' behind anything right now."

"I opened the portal."

Glimmer grit her teeth. "I know." This was where she wanted to go with this?

"It nearly destroyed the entire planet." Catra didn't break eye contact with Glimmer, as if to say 'yeah, we're having this conversation and we're having it now.' Her tail thrashed about behind her. "It allowed Hordak to send a message to Horde Prime. He's here because of me."

"I *know*." Glimmer felt the metal from the spoon handle cut into her fingers because she gripped it so tight.

"You're not a princess anymore, you're a queen. That happened right after the portal closed and your mom didn't come back. I'm not stupid, I know what happened." Catra hugged herself and shivered. She seemed to physically buckle under the weight of her words. "Hordak mentioned she's not dead so much as she's just

floating out there in the nothingness. But unless Entrapta's figured out some way to access the space between realities, then she's as good as gone, right? I killed her, Sparkles. I killed your mom."

Glimmer saw red and she swore she'd already have magic at her fingertips ready to strike were they back on Etheria. She thought her mom had well and truly died. Finding out she was instead likely just lost in a pocket dimension—dead for all intents and purposes rather than actually killed—had taken her by surprise as much as it had rekindled her anger and plunged her back into grief.

"What's your point?" she asked, not bothering to mask the acid in her voice.

"You shouldn't be helping me. You should be mad. You should be murderous."

"And do you seriously think that this"—she balled her free hand into a fist and raised it as if she were about to pummel Catra in the face—"doesn't look like I'm not on the verge of literally drowning you in your soup?"

Catra didn't flinch away. "You could do it, you know," she said, breaking eye contact only to look purposefully at Glimmer's hands. "I'm too weak to put up much of a fight. None of your friends would have to find out. We both know I'd deserve it…"

Something in the way Catra looked at her fist and spoke as if she were *hoping* Glimmer would make good on her threats jolted her, and her brain pump the breaks, hard. All the tension flushed from her body. She placed the spoon back in the bowl and moved the whole tray to the table behind her. All her movements were purposeful and robotic, as if she were controlling someone else's hands instead of her own.

It wasn't until she went to clasp Catra's hands in her own that she finally flinched—as if that gesture above all others was the one that would harm her. Glimmer held firm and didn't let her go when

she tried to pull away. Instead, she guided her hands forward, closer to her.

"I know all that," she said. "Well, not the part about my mom being stuck instead of dead, but I have a feeling that doesn't matter very much in the end." She waited, and when Catra only let out a strangled sound instead of a real response, she said, "You and I beat each other pretty bad at that secret outpost back in the Whispering Woods. If it were that Catra stuck with me in this cell, then maybe I'd have it in me to really do something to you."

Catra gulped and looked away. "It *is* the same person. I'm right in front of you."

"But you're not though." Glimmer ran her thumbs along Catra's knuckles and kept the pressure on when Catra gave another scoff. "I'm serious, Catra. As cheesy as it sounds, you aren't the same crazy idiot that wanted to destroy the world not all that long ago. Am I supposed to believe that's the same person who let themselves get strapped to a chair and mind probed in my place?"

"What do you even know?" Catra said, muttering under her.

"More than you give me credit for, that's for sure," Glimmer said. "Why did you volunteer in my place?"

Catra paused and looked at her as if she had gone crazy. "We've already had this conversation, stupid. Or did Prime come grab you and scramble your brains while I was passed out on top of you?"

"You hoped going first would make it easier for me to survive going second, and you made some joke about being 'nice' for once. But that's the thing—why even do that in the first place?"

Catra's expression faltered, as if she realized she was slowly being cornered into a trap, and she redoubled her efforts to pull away. "I don't need a reason. And even if I did have one, I'm not required to tell."

Glimmer held tighter to Catra's hands and refused to let her escape. "Horde Prime very nearly killed me the moment he teleported me onto this citadel. It was because you stepped in that he didn't. And then I almost died *again* a few days later in this cell until you cried loud enough and long enough at that"—she gestured to the camera mounted at the ceiling corner opposite them—"until they took me to the medical bay."

Now Catra really struggled, panic evident on her face as she tried to yank out of Glimmer's iron grip. "No, I'm not…I didn't—"

"Look at me and tell me you did all those things for selfish reasons, Catra." Glimmer pulled hard enough that Catra had no choice but to face her. "Look at me and tell me that it's all some secret ulterior plan you've dreamt up I just haven't figured out yet. Look me in the eyes and swear to me that it *isn't* because you're trying to change and do the right thing for once. Swear it on every happy memory you've ever had growing up with Adora in the Horde."

Catra froze and stared at her with giant, glassy eyes. Glimmer knew from what Adora had shared with her that her memories with Catra were one of the few things she considered 'happy' growing up in the Fright Zone, and judging by Catra's reaction, the same was true for her. Glimmer's gamble invoking Adora's name had paid off.

"I….I…" Catra started twice before cutting off and taking in choked breaths. "I've hurt too many people. It's all I do…all I'm good at. I can't bring your mom back to you…I can't make up for all the mistakes I made."

"No," Glimmer said. "No, you can't. But that's not really the point, is it?"

Catra swallowed, and her voice was thick with emotion when she spoke again. "I can't make up for it, but I want to do everything I can."

Glimmer sighed and finally let Catra's hands go. She pulled them back, sluggish and despondent.

"I'm not completely blameless either, to be honest with you," Glimmer said. "I said some…pretty horrible things to Adora and to Bow before I got picked up by Prime. I almost finished what you started after activating the Heart, despite literally everyone warning me not to. I got so blinded by winning, by beating you and the rest of the Horde, that I hurt my friends and nearly killed everyone."

Catra watched her through watery eyes, and Glimmer gripped the fabric of her pants to try and steady herself. She still wasn't sure she had the courage to say what was coming next.

"I can't express how sorry I am to them, and I'm even more terrified they're going to turn me away when I try and apologize, but the point is that I understand. It doesn't make the things you did right, but I understand where they came from. Shadow Weaver abused you growing up, Adora leaving the Horde probably felt like the biggest betrayal from someone you never imagined getting that from. Heck, even Double Trouble screwed you. So, I get it—life sucked for you, just like it sucked for me when my mom disappeared. You wanted to stand on top of the world and be able to tell it that you had beaten it, even for a moment."

Glimmer realized she had gone off on a tangent when she noticed Catra's gaze turn from fearful to curious, and she coughed, suddenly embarrassed. "That last part could apply to either of us, by the way. In any case, the point I was trying to make is that even if you can't fix all your mistakes, the fact you're trying to be better is all the proof I need that the Catra who opened the portal and the Catra sitting across from me right now, barely choking down alien soup are different people. You may have burned a heck of a lot of bridges, but you haven't completely burned away your bridge with me. Not yet."

Catra stared at her, unblinking, for a long moment. "Are you sure Horde Prime didn't steal you away while I was sleeping and turn

you into someone too forgiving for your own good?" She sounded like she privately couldn't believe what she heard, but happy about it nonetheless, and Glimmer smiled in response.

"How can I face Bow and Adora and hope they'll forgive me if I can't even do that for you?" Glimmer paused and frowned as she hit upon a realization. "You uh…don't have a secret ulterior plan I haven't figured out yet, right? You never did answer my question earlier."

Catra shook her head so hard Glimmer thought she'd give herself a concussion. "No secret plan, no hidden agenda, I swear. I know I can't make up for everything, but if I can do something—anything—to help make it better, I want to try."

Glimmer nodded and pulled Catra's bowl of soup back into her lap. "Good. First order of business is somehow getting off this station. And you can't do that or help fix anything afterward if you die from starvation. So, let's focus on staying alive, yeah?"

She spooned more soup and held it up. Catra nodded and took a bite, then waited for Glimmer to scoop another with an eager gleam in her eyes.

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Hours later, and Glimmer listened to the tiny snores Catra let out while she was fast asleep, splayed out on the bottom bunk with a full belly.  Glimmer was sat at the table, spooning her portion of now cold soup into her mouth while she thought on her conversation with Catra from earlier.

A starship blinked into existence outside their viewport and she turned to look. Several dozen more followed the first, cascaded into existence outside. Each had a single insignia stamped onto the side of their hulls—one which was different from Prime's Imperial Horde motif. Glimmer didn't recognize the pattern, but she knew what it represented.

Taline had arrived.

Chapter End Notes

Glimmer, Adora, and Catra are the main three characters of this story, even though Catra hasn't had an official pov chapter (yet). Any side characters—or even original characters—present will never usurp the main three. Some may have a sizeable role to play and may even have their own mini-arcs playing out within the larger context of the story, but they will never overshadow the main characters nor will we ever switch into their povs. This is the story of the Hero, the Fallen Friend, and the Once-Queen, after all. (Can you guess who is who? The answer may surprise you).

That being said, what kind of character do you think Taline will end up being? I'm curious to hear your thoughts, so please leave a comment if you're open to sharing!

I also made a tumblr! Come hang out, say hi, ask me questions, give me constructive feedback, recommend fics to read (even your own, I'll review them haha), and also any other She Ra centric blogs you think I should follow. Anonymous asks are on too :)

https://telennarre.tumblr.com/

See you all next Thursday, and thank you for reading!

# Sister Departed

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra was having a nightmare. It was the usual one, the one she almost always had whenever she managed to win a few precious hours of sleep after first throwing that switch to the portal in the Fright Zone.

*"Why did you do it?"*

Adora stared at her from in front of the portal, her eyes every bit a storm as the vortex at her back. It didn't matter that Catra always anticipated this scene, and it didn't matter that she always tried to run away—knowing she was in the middle of a nightmare never seemed to make it feel less scary, and nothing she did ever changed the outcome of what inevitably happened next.

She fell.

This time, rather than fight it, Catra closed her eyes and let herself go, felt herself get swept off her feet and sucked backward into the portal behind Adora. She was eager to wake up and calm her heart she knew was hammering in her chest.

Except, the nightmare didn't end when she opened her eyes again. Instead, she found herself in a grand throne room—Horde Prime's throne room. And she was the one sitting on the throne.

"What of the program?" she heard herself ask. "That AI? The one that helped her to decipher the ancient writings."

A woman was kneeling before her, head down, wearing a military cap with a visor that obscured her face. "We didn't find anything on her," she said. "No data chips on her body, and nothing out of the ordinary with the rest of her implants—all standard issue, science-grade."

“And what of her remains?”

“C-cremated, my lord.” The woman said, fists trembling at her sides. “Since she was denied military honors or a marked grave, I decided to take her with me, instead.”

Anger leaked from the woman’s voice and Catra felt herself grin. “It doesn’t matter that her actions ended the war,” Catra said. “Had she obeyed my commands from the beginning, had she furthered the research she brought to me in the first place, then many more trillions of lives would have been saved. As it stands, all she’s bought us is more time. And at what cost? Outing the remainder of the Daiamid and driving them to extinction?” Catra scoffed. “Traitors don’t become martyrs, they become nameless. Your sister shall be forgotten by history, and any who dare utter her name shall share her fate. You’re lucky I’m not punishing *you* for helping her, Taline.”

Taline looked up at her, and Catra finally saw her face. Rage flared in her eyes, tears streamed down her face, and Catra felt a perverse sense of glee ripple in her chest at the sight. She wanted Taline to act on that anger and give Catra the excuse she needed to put her down and humiliate her further. Retaliating now after what happened would make Catra look weak in front of her subjects, but if Taline attacked her? That would be good enough reason to pay her back a hundred times over for the humiliation she had subjected her to in the earlier battle.

Taline relaxed and looked away. “Thank you for your discretion, sir.” Even though it sounded as if speaking the words made her sick, Catra couldn’t help but feel disappointed she’d chosen to deescalate.

Catra gave a dismissive wave of her hand. “If that program wasn’t on her person, then I’m certain a copy of it is stored on her private research servers. Who from your team is in charge of tearing apart that lab the Daiamid gave her?”

“I have Diallo en route to the planet as we speak, my lord,” she said, standing.

Diallo? Now there was a man with aspirations far larger than his abilities. Catra wondered what strange force had possessed Taline to put him in charge. Thanks to her near-perfect memory recall—helped in part by the implants that allowed her full access to her clones’ experiences—Catra knew almost every important subject of her empire by name. But Diallo was so unremarkable, he threatened to shake himself loose and fall between the gaps in her memory.

“Good,” Catra said, preferring not to read too deeply into it. “I want a fully itemized list of his findings within a week, and I want everything in that lab brought to my personal storage facilities on Acheron Prime.” She raised a finger in warning. “And don’t think I won’t know if something is missing, Taline. Prime knows all.” Taline gave a muted ‘Yes sir,’ and Catra made another dismissive gesture at her. “Now get out of my sight.”

Catra’s mind wandered as Taline turned and headed for the exit at the far end of the throne room. In her thousands of years alive, hopping through clone bodies as they aged beyond use in a never-ending mission to conquer both death and the galaxy, her fate had always been her own to make. Now her empire tottered on the brink of collapse, and the only way to ensure its survival was to wait for the appearance of a magic planet, lost in the space between dimensions, before the barrier holding back that hell-spawn creature burst through and put an end to them for good.

That same empire had thrived for many hundreds of thousands of years because they not only had the technology to make her essentially immortal, but also had the means to shove great fleets into the void and pluck them out on the other side of the galaxy faster than the speed of light. Yet despite this, they could not locate a single, massive planet stuck within that same void and pull it through to their own reality? Why was Catra forced to wait for it to show up on its own terms instead of on hers?

She took a deep breath and smoothed the worry lines she felt cropping up on her face. The scientists had said it would be easier to locate a single person and return them from the void than it would be to locate a whole planet and do the same—something about their inability to read the energy signature of a thing that massive because of the sensitivity of their instruments. The specifics never made sense to her, but that was why she had her advisors in the first place: to deal with the specifics. In any case, although she had damned her to anonymity, Taline's blasted sister had never once been wrong about her predictions once they started coming to her, and she likely wouldn't be wrong about this one. Etheria would show, and the Enclave—Taline especially—would be on constant lookout for it.

That didn't stop Catra from feeling powerless over the fact all this was out of her hands, however. She hated that feeling. She needed to do something to return that sense of control.

"Taline?" Catra called, her voice echoing in the great sanctum and stopping her just shy of the exit. "Aren't you forgetting something?"

Taline stiffened, and Catra thought she might ignore her and walk straight through the doors. Then, she did a quick about-face, clicked her heels together, and thrust an open hand to her visor in an aggressive salute. "Hail the Horde Empire! Hail Horde Prime!"

Anguish flared anew on her face. She didn't break eye contact with Catra as she held the salute for a long five seconds. Then she stowed her salute, and marched out of the throne room. Catra listened to sound of Taline's boots echo down the hall outside, growing quieter the farther away she got. Before long, her vision faded to black…

…And she finally woke, back aboard Prime's citadel.

Her heart hammered in her chest, like she expected it to back when she first fell into the portal at the beginning of the nightmare. Her head hurt. It felt like someone took an axe to her

head. Even still, Catra never thought she'd ever feel relieved to see the stars outside their window, or the halogen strip lights on the ceiling of their cell. They bathed the room in light harsh enough to make her nauseous, but at least she was herself again.

The pain in her head grew suddenly worse, and her vision blurred out. The room began to spin. It wasn't until a dull pain radiated from her knees and hands up to her hips and elbows that she realized she had fallen off the bottom bunk and caught herself on the floor.

Someone kneeled in front of her and held her by the shoulders. Catra tried to focus on their face but it was impossible to get her eyes to focus or the room to stop spinning. All she could make out through the pain was the vague pink tones of their hair.

"Glimmer?" she asked, before chastising herself in her head. Of *course* it was Glimmer. Who the hell else would it be? Glimmer was the only other person in this cell with her.

Catra shivered, remembering their conversation from earlier. She didn't deserve Glimmer's kindness, and part of her wish she'd withhold it and spare Catra the shame. Her vision focused enough to make out Glimmer's features, only to immediately realize that this person in front of her wasn't actually Glimmer at all.

"You don't look so good," Angella said, supporting the back of Catra's head with one hand as she swayed.

"This is another dream," Catra said, feeling panic well up inside her again. "It has to be. You aren't here. You….you can't be here."

Angella frowned at her. "Your mind can't keep up with what happened to it. Go to sleep now. Things will be better when you wake up, I promise." Angella pressed her thumb and index finger to Catra's forehead, and she fell back into unconsciousness.

This time, there were no nightmares.

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Glimmer hadn't slept. The warships outside had reminded her that someone powerful enough to make Horde Prime change course was coming for them, and that unnerved her. Catra's sudden tossing and turning and moaning in bed hadn't helped either, and Glimmer had been moments away from going to check on her when she heard loud voices and footsteps approaching from outside the cell.

The doors slid open a moment later and a woman stepped through, straight-backed, wearing a crisp military uniform. She doffed her cap, stowed it under one arm, and swept the room with a gaze of ice. Two soldiers encased head to toe in body armor joined her. A stylized faceplate covered their faces and prevented Glimmer from reading their expressions or intentions.

A thud sounded off to the side before Glimmer could properly react, and all attention turned to Catra. She had fallen off the bed and lay there spasming on her hands and knees. Glimmer yelped and rushed forward when both guards intercepted her. One of them grabbed her arm to hold her back while the other barred her path forward.

Panicking, Glimmer swung with her free hand at the one in front. Pain radiated up her arm when flesh met armor, and she cursed, yanking out of the other soldier's hold to nurse her throbbing hand.

"Please don't punch my Sentinels," the woman said. Glimmer looked over and found her cradling a now unconscious Catra in her arms, one hand supporting the back of her head while the other pressed her thumb and index finger to Catra's forehead. "I'm terrible with healing runes and, frankly, I don't have the time to send you to the medical bays either. It would be terribly inconvenient if you had to go and break your hand, not to mention painful and unnecessary."

"You're Taline," Glimmer said, leering at the Sentinels while trying to keep an eye on her. "I recognize you from when you interrupted Prime's fun with us."

"You're welcome for that, although I did find out later that he didn't stop torturing this one." Taline stood with a grimace on her face, lifting Catra bridal style between her arms. She motioned to the Sentinel closest to her—the one blocking Glimmer's path—and deposited Catra in their arms, murmuring a quick order to bring her to the infirmary.

"Don't worry," Taline said after seeing the look Glimmer gave them carrying Catra out the door. "Your friend will be ok. I just helped calm her mind somewhat. It's still processing what it went through with the Emperor. He gets…impatient when he probes a mind that isn't cloned from his own, and although Salas is proficient enough to keep him from damaging them beyond saving, there's still an adjustment period afterward, shall we say."

Glimmer narrowed her eyes at her, not entirely sure what to make of her words. "Is that your armada out there?" she asked, gesturing to the window.

"Armada?" Taline seemed confused as she looked out the window too.  Then gave a soft laugh. "I'd hardly call *that* an armada, but yes. Those are my ships."

"And what, pray tell, are you planning on doing to us? Horde Prime didn't get anything out of Catra about the Heart because she doesn't actually know anything, and neither do I. Not really."

Glimmer shut her mouth when fear started to make her voice quaver. She obviously didn't want to be the subject of another torture session, not at Horde Prime's hands nor any other. But she couldn't think of any good reason for why someone like Taline would be there in the first place if it wasn't to extract more information.

"I'm not here to do anything to you," Taline said. "I'm here because I need your help."

Glimmer blinked as if she hadn't heard her correctly. Even if she didn't trust Taline further than she could throw her, hearing *that*

come out of her mouth was unexpected. “What exactly is it you need my help with?”

“I need you to help me convince the Emperor to leave this planet the hell alone.”

Chapter End Notes

This was an interesting chapter for me, looking at it from a 'craft' perspective. We hop into our final POV character (Catra), and her deteriorated mental state is used to:

1. introduce some background worldbuilding and conflict from the memories of someone already familiar with the world in question (Horde Prime), and...

2. introduce a third, brand new character we've only seen a glimpse of before (Taline)

Lots of heavy lifting in a relatively short chapter, but it does a lot. Hope you all enjoyed, and see you next Thursday!

# To Stand Defiant

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer flew down the hallway and struggled to keep pace with the rapid clip Taline had set—wherever she was leading her, it was in a hurry. The other guard (Sentinel?), the one that hadn't taken Catra from the cell, didn't seem to struggle nearly as much as her despite the rifle strapped to their chest piece and the giant knife strapped to their leg over the armor. While this was the second time in a short period Glimmer traveled down this exact hallway, the context felt different. This time, she wasn't being manhandled in Horde Prime's wake on the way to a torture chamber, but was instead coming along to…help?

That's what Taline had told her, at least, and that's what Glimmer chose to focus on instead of her uncertainty over Catra's whereabouts. They piled into the elevator at the end of the hall, and no sooner had Taline selected the floor they needed to travel to did the sound of radio chatter echo out from the armor of the Sentinel next to her.

"TF 12 is reporting back, Ma'am," the Sentinel said, pressing a gloved hand to the side of their helmet. Despite the modulation, Glimmer could tell it was a woman underneath all that protection. "Still no return signal from the holdouts. Shall I order them to continue attempting contact?"

"No, I'll take care of it," Taline said. The elevator dropped them down and she tapped a few commands into a holographic screen built into a bracer on her arm before letting loose a sigh. "Didn't I tell you this was going to happen, Miri? Didn't I call it years ago that the Emperor was going to do this exact thing once Etheria finally showed up?"

"You did say so," Miri said. She and Taline must have had this conversation many times in the past, judging by her tone of voice. "I've never disagreed with you on it either. I'm just glad we got here before he decided on an orbital bombardment."

"Yeah well, even with that luck it might still be too late. The only people he *hasn't* conquered yet are refusing to even—yes, hello? Alan?" Taline shook the device on her wrist with an annoyed expression and brought it closer to her face, muttering about 'shitty connection.' "Hi, yes, it's Taline. No, it's okay, you don't need to keep pinging them, it's obvious they're ignoring us on purpose. Try and get a visual of what they're doing inside that castle of theirs—they've been holed up inside for hours since Prime's last wave."

Glimmer tried to make sense of what she overheard, and wished she could make out more of the person's response on the other line than just muffled comms chatter. This was the most information she had about her friends back on the surface since being beamed into the citadel in the first place, and it was frustrating how little she could glean from it.

"Yes, I realize there's likely plenty of wounded inside," Taline said. "But I won't risk sending down a landing party if they're just going to think it's another invasion force. I'm going to see the Emperor right now and ask about taking over the hologram emitters he's placed planet-side already. If they won't take our hails, we'll just project a message to them they can't turn off."

The sound of the other person's response murmured out against the whirring of the elevator as they shot through Prime's citadel. After a last brief exchange of words, Taline cut the line, and leaned against the far wall with arms crossed and a heavy sigh. Glimmer got the sense she was seeing a rarely-displayed side of her, looking so frustrated as she did, although that realization garnered no sympathy from her: overhearing that conversation put a new worry at the front of her mind.

“Did I just hear you say there are wounded?” Glimmer asked. “What’s been going on down there?”

Taline regarded her out the corner of her eye. “Bright Moon is still holding out after the Emperor’s latest attacks. The rest of the planet fell fast, but there’s a group down there that’s fought off two invasion forces of his now. Your people, I’m assuming?”

“*All* of Etheria but Bright Moon is conquered? But I can’t have been away for much longer than a week at most.” Glimmer remembered hearing something about final holdouts when Prime first talked to Taline during the interrogation, but she hadn’t been paying attention on account of everything else going on. She gave a self-satisfied laugh and said, “Bright Moon is my kingdom. I’ll take it as a point of pride that Adora and the others are still standing.”

“Yes, well, capitulating fast is a *good* thing, if curbing casualties is of any concern to you. The longer they resist, the angrier the Emperor grows and the more people die. We’ll have a hard enough time as it is convincing him to disengage after they thwarted him twice.”

“And so that’s where I come in? I’m to just ‘stand there and look vaguely pathetic while you do the talking’, was it? You didn’t exactly mince words back at the cell.” The idea of Glimmer’s friends ultimately prevailing over Prime had never been brought up. Maybe that was fair, considering they were the only ones left after so little time at war.

“There’s more, obviously,” Taline said. “But let’s focus on the first step to start, okay? As much as I’m sure you hope your friends can succeed against him, I’m sorry to say they won’t. The goal is to deescalate both sides.”

“He started it!” Righteous anger boiled over in Glimmer’s mind, and she rounded on Taline with wide, aggressive gestures. “He kidnapped Catra and I, then laid waste to the rest of the planet.

People are dead—my *friends* are dead—because he just showed up and started killing!”

“And more will die if we don’t work together, me with the Emperor and you with your friends on the surface. Horde Prime is a prideful son of a bitch. Need proof? Just look at how he promised me he’d keep everyone safe before I arrived and then continued torturing your friend. Being rebuffed twice will only make him push harder and kill more. But he gets distracted by displays of weakness. If you stand there looking scared and slightly out of your element, he’ll take that as a sign of victory and I’ll be able to more effectively massage him into doing what we need.”

“Coming to the table for a ceasefire?”

“Now you’re catching on. The problem is, your friends down below are justifiably pissed off and ignoring any attempt my team makes at contacting them. Horde Prime agreeing to hold off won’t matter at all if we send a peaceful landing party down and the people of Bright Moon attack out of an assumption it’s a hostile force. The Emperor will just push a third assault. One more ruthless than the others because he’d take that as them spitting on his hand when trying to show mercy.”

“I can help,” Glimmer said. “You mentioned getting some hologram emitters? If we can project a message to them, I can record it. They’d be more likely to listen if it’s me telling them to come out and talk.”

“Good.” Some of the tension in Taline’s stance smoothed away. She almost looked relieved. “That’s exactly what I had in mind.”

“I want something in return though,” Glimmer said, refusing to back down when both Taline’s eyebrows shot up in surprise. “I want a guarantee no one else gets hurt. If I help you with this, my friends remain safe, and everyone who needs it gets immediate medical attention.”

“Done.”

Glimmer blinked in surprise, somewhat confused. “Done? That’s it? That easy?”

“That easy.” Taline nodded. “This invasion wasn’t supposed to happen in the first place. The Emperor wasn’t supposed to come anywhere near your planet when it finally emerged.” The irritated creases in Taline’s brow returned, deeper this time. “I was supposed to make first contact with your world. *Peaceful* first contact. Maybe I haven’t been clear about this so far, and if that’s the case then I’m sorry. But I want as much death and destruction in this as you do. None. We’re both on the same side here.”

Glimmer wasn’t sure she’d go that far, but she’d take what she could get. If Taline wanted her help to bring hostilities to an end, especially in a fight where her side was so horridly outmatched, then she’d do what she could to help. Even if that meant keeping her mouth shut and pretending to look beaten.

A perverse sense of amusement washed over her then as she realized there had been more similarity between her and Catra than she initially acknowledged. Prime wouldn’t have come if she hadn’t activated the Heart and pulled Etheria out of Despondos in the first place. They both were ‘doing what they could’ to right their wrongs, in a sense. Glimmer’s mind wandered to Catra, and she hoped she was doing better in the infirmary.

The elevator pulled to a halt and the doors swished. She, Taline, and the Sentinel Miri stepped out into Horde Prime’s massive throne room where the second Sentinel, the one who had taken Catra away, was already there waiting for them. Did he really bring Catra to the infirmary that quickly? Together, the four of them approached the Emperor, surrounded by intelligence screens and lounging on his throne at the far end of the chamber.

“Lord Prime,” Taline said, taking a knee when they reached the first step of the dais. She nudged Glimmer, who hurried to follow her example. “Have you considered my request? I would like to use the projectors you installed on the planet’s surface.”

Prime inspected his nails, leaning back with one leg crossed over the other on his throne. Two clone guards holding staves stood on either side, and Salas stood inside on Prime's left with his hands held behind his back. He looked strangely clammy and worn out, more so than when she last saw him up in the interrogation room. It was almost as if someone had stretched him too thin, too quickly.

One of Prime's extra eyes turned to look at them. "I have considered," he said. "And I don't feel sufficiently convinced I should give them to you. I'm not about to hand over my equipment when you have the resources to install your own projectors. You were adamant about this world being under your jurisdiction, Taline. A good commander solves their own problems."

Glimmer couldn't believe how petty the Emperor had become compared to the almost nightmarish figure from their prior meeting. It almost made her feel bad for Taline, having to navigate the situation. She redoubled her efforts to look sufficiently cowed in his presence.

"My lord, that would take time we simply do not have," Taline said. "The rebels in the castle refuse to answer my hails. I fear they are planning something while I am trying to call an end to the hostilities."

"Planning something, you say?" The Emperor's eyes lit up with glee. "A counterattack perhaps?"

"It's possible, but I can't be certain as of yet." Taline stood, and Glimmer followed her, hugging one arm close to her body with the other. "My men are working on getting us eyes inside their stronghold as we speak."

"That may be amusing to see play out," Prime said. "Nothing about their technology indicates they would pose a threat to me all the way up here. Now I'm especially tempted to withhold the projectors from you, if only to see what they come up with."

“My lord, I implore you to remember why we are here on Etheria in the first place.” Taline took the first step up the dais to the throne. The clone guards on either side strode forward, pointing their staves at her. She didn’t so much as look at them. “There is no time for detours and no time to play games like this. Our analysts’ projections are generous, but we still have no idea the level of complexity we are about to encounter researching the Heart.

“Ignominite took three months to discover, and Imperial R&D continues to make advancements with it to this day. The Barrier and its algorithm took three *years* to implement, and no progress whatsoever has been made trying to perfect it despite eight years of trying. We may have plenty of time or barely enough at all, but if the Barrier fails before we have the weapon then everything is lost. We cannot afford distractions, no matter how tempting.”

Horde Prime narrowed his eyes at them and sat forward, uncrossing his legs. If he looked disinterested and bored earlier, he looked downright furious now. Glimmer had no idea what Taline was talking about, but she could tell whatever point she made had struck a nerve with Prime. She half expected him to refuse to help out of spite. This was her cue.

“Lord Prime, please,” Glimmer said, taking a tentative step forward. When all eyes turned on her, she swallowed and bowed low. “I may be a young Queen, but I am no fool. I recognize that we are thoroughly beaten.” She chanced a glance up. Taline and even Salas seemed surprised she spoke up at all, but Prime looked pleased.

“You have already conquered Etheria,” she said. “Even if my own subjects haven’t yet caught on to that fact. And if it’s indeed Adora that you talked to when you first reached out, then there’s no doubt in my mind she is planning a counter attack. As queen it’s my responsibility to look out for the safety of my people, and I know there will be nothing left of them if they go down that path. Please sir. Let Taline use your projectors. Let them see that I am safe and let us negotiate a ceasefire, I beg you.”

Horde Prime studied her through narrowed eyes. Glimmer could practically see him turning her words over in his head, and despite the look of drunk satisfaction on his face, she feared she hadn't done enough—that he'd still refuse, even after she groveled. It was Salas that, after stepping up to whisper something in his ear, made him nod.

"Very well," he said. "I am not a cruel ruler. I see potential when an opponent recognizes they are beaten and asks for mercy, and I too wish to avoid unnecessary bloodshed where possible. I will grant you access to the projectors, Taline. Record your message on the communications bridge, and I will inform my Relay Master that he is to transmit whatever you give him."

"Thank you, my lord," Taline said with another quick bow. "Hail the Horde. Hail Horde Prime." She grabbed Glimmer by the arm and the four of retreated back toward the elevators. "That was perfect," she said when they arrived, mashing the 'call' button on the elevator panel. "What you just did there? That was exactly what we needed."

"I helped you, just like you asked," Glimmer said, frowning. "You'd better hold up your end of the deal. What do we do now?"

"Now we get to the communications bridge like he said. You'll record a message telling everyone that you are safe and that they are to come out of the castle and surrender. We'll be able to land safely, make their surrender official, and begin our research right away."

"Hold on a minute," Glimmer said, crossing her arms and taking a step back. "Surrender? That's not what we agreed on."

"We agreed on safety for your friends and medical attention to those who needed it. How do you think we're going to keep anyone safe if they don't surrender?"

"I thought we were going to negotiate a ceasefire. Surrender is too much."

The elevator dinged and the doors opened, but no one stepped inside. Taline shot Glimmer a withering glare.

"Do you seriously expect the Emperor to sit there on his throne and not execute every single one of your people in front of your eyes if they refuse to submit to him? What did you think was going to happen? That we'd stop the fighting and you could negotiate him into leaving you alone? He came here and conquered your planet in a week, you said so yourself."

"This isn't what we agreed to," Glimmer said, taking another step back. "I don't know what it is you need our planet for so badly, but you went straight from wanting to end hostilities and keep people safe to jumping right into your little research project the minute you got what you wanted."

"Glimmer, we don't have time to—"

"No, *you* don't have time to waste," Glimmer said. She didn't care that she was probably causing a scene near enough for the Emperor to notice. "How do I even know I can trust you? How do I know you aren't going to just throw us back to the wolves as soon as you have what you want? Did you even bring Catra to the infirmary like you said, or did this guy"—she jerked her thumb toward the larger of the two Sentinels still with them—"just dump her body out an airlock or something?"

The elevator doors closed without them aboard, the quiet hissing sound amplified against the silence Glimmer let hang over them after she finished speaking. Taline looked disgusted with her, and a small voice at the back of the head suggested to Glimmer that maybe she shouldn't be pushing the buttons of the only person that seemed to be on their side and giving her answers. Still, she refused to trust blindly, and there was at least one thing she believed could be reasonably used as leverage.

"You need to get the Heart working, right?" Glimmer asked. "You need it to fight whatever war is threatening your precious empire?

Well, let me cut to the chase and let you in on a little secret. The Heart is defective."

Taline's look of disgust mellowed out into one of irritation and interest. "Go on," she said.

"The only way you can activate it is if you have all the princesses, my friends, channel their power into it at once. And even if you somehow managed to get them to cooperate with you, the planet blows up. It's unstable. I'm changing the terms of our agreement, since it's clear the Heart is the only thing you care about. You need to take me back down to the planet personally to talk to everyone. Either that, or you show me some other kind of proof you're going to keep your word and make sure my friends are safe if we surrender."

"And if I don't?"

"Then I don't lift a finger to help you any further than I already have."

Taline's eyes hardened and she squared her shoulders. A surge of adrenaline pumped through Glimmer's veins upon seeing that, and she responded in kind, ready for a fight.

"Fine," Taline said after a tense moment. "Have it your way. We don't have time to make a trip to the surface, so I'll go get your cellmate from the infirmary and prove to you she's better and that I didn't have her done away with. Is that enough for you?"

Glimmer was surprised and grateful things didn't escalate into violence, especially since she was certain she wouldn't come out the victor when Taline had two armored Sentinels at her side. She considered Taline's proposal, and ultimately decided that it would be proof enough. If she had actually taken care of Catra when she could have just as easily killed her and lied about it to secure Glimmer's cooperation, then that was probably enough to say she wouldn't abandon her friends once they disarmed themselves.

“Good,” Taline said when Glimmer nodded at her. “You’re going to head to the communications center like we originally planned, and I’ll be along shortly thereafter with your friend.” She turned to the Sentinels at her side and said, “Guard her. The clones and especially other officers may give her a hard time if I’m not there and we can’t risk that. I don’t care who you have to step between, make sure no harm comes to the queen for any reason. Do I make myself clear?”

“Crystal clear, ma’am.” Both Sentinels spoke and snapped off sharp salutes at the same time, and Taline turned back to address Glimmer.

“Follow their lead. This citadel is a monstrosity, but they’ll know how to get you to communications. No detours.”

“No detours,” Glimmer agreed, nodding.

Taline stared at her a moment longer, as if looking for any sign of subterfuge. Seemingly finding none, she turned and took off at a quick march toward a set of doors farther away. Glimmer watched her exit after the guards posted there scrambled to get out of her way, then she turned to look at the Sentinels left behind to guard her. She still hadn’t seen their faces, completely covered in body armor as they were.

“Shall we get going?” the taller of the two asked. “We’ll take the elevator up and escort you to communications.”

Glimmer thought back to the orders Taline gave them—thought about how oddly specific it was that Taline told them she didn’t care who they needed to step between in order to keep her safe. An idea sprung to her in her quest to feel better in control over her predicament.

“You’re Miri,” she said, pointing to the smaller of the two, before gesturing to the larger. “But what’s your name?”

“I am called Narre, Queen Glimmer,” the other said.

“Well, Miri and Narre…Taline did give you a set of pretty specific orders. But I have something I want to try first.”

The Sentinels glanced at each other. Glimmer took one look at the elevator the two of them were clearly hoping she would get aboard, pointedly turned away, and marched instead back toward the Emperor on his throne.

Chapter End Notes

Chapter 7 will be out early: next Wednesday evening, PST instead of Thursday like normal. I won't be around a computer to post on Thursday, but I'm not letting that keep me from my schedule. I'd rather get the chapter out to you guys early than late :)

We're reaching the top of that early roller coaster climb...Not quite there yet, but soon. Can you feel it?

# Threading a Needle

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora sat on the floor in the hallway right outside the castle war room and leaned against the wall, letting the white onyx touch as much of her back as she could to cool her down. The battle had been rough. They had just barely pushed the enemy forces into retreat once the ship above finally stopped spitting out reinforcements. If it hadn't been for Entrapta and the cadre of fighting war bots she had been stockpiling for exactly that kind of desperate moment, they might not have made it.

Many of the foot soldiers who hadn't died were in critical condition, and even the majority of the princesses were in no shape to fight, although they hadn't lost any of them permanently, thank god. In fact, when Adora went through her mental catalogue of the injuries, she and Scorpia were the only two not in the infirmary.

Pain flared at her abdomen. Adora screwed her eyes shut and grit her teeth. Maybe Scorpia was the only one who had come out in one piece after all. Adora really should have joined the others in the infirmary, but they were stretched too thin as it was and she couldn't afford to let Catra and Glimmer down by sitting out the upcoming assault on Horde Prime's citadel. If anyone saw her in pain, they'd bench her, so she did her best to power through it.

"You don't look so good," a voice directly in front of her said.

Adora snapped her eyes open and looked up. Lonnie stood there looking down at her, covered in bruises and lacerations. One eye had nearly swollen shut on her, and Rogelio stood at her left, missing an arm.

"Neither do the two of you," Adora said, forcing a laugh.

“I was the luckiest of the three of us,” she said. “Gonna be sore and in pain for months, probably, but at least nothing’s broken. Rogelio’s got a few cracked ribs but they’ll heal quick, and that arm of his will grow back too.”

“What about Kyle?”

“Kyle…wasn’t so lucky.”

“Did…did he not make it?” The mood between them grew dark. Rogelio dipped his head and Lonnie rubbed his back.

“No, he’s not dead,” Lonnie said, sighing. “He’ll be fine, thank god. He just…won’t regrow the leg. They propped him up on a chair in the infirmary as many of the beds as possible need to be free for people who actually need them. He’s really pissed at me for making him stay behind for the assault, though.”

“It’s the right decision,” Adora said, breathing a sigh of relief and flinching with another jolt of pain through her ribs. “Normally I’d suggest Rogelio stay behind too, but at least you can still move and somewhat fight without an arm. Kyle without a leg though? Different story.”

Rogelio gave a grunt in affirmation and, when Lonnie cracked a smile at her, Adora couldn’t help smiling back. When Horde Prime first arrived, she had worried she’d hold back the other princesses without her powers, but Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio had shown up at Bright Moon before the first wave and immediately jumped to aid their defense. Adora had fallen in with them sometime during the fighting, and the result was staggering.

Fighting techniques and homegrown squad tactics Adora hadn’t practiced since leaving the Horde came back to her amidst a tidal wave of nostalgia, and the four of them had taken down more enemies together than Adora thought possible without She Ra. For the first time since breaking the sword, she felt like an asset rather than a liability. To say she felt grateful the three of them had appeared when they did was a grave understatement.

“You on the other hand,” Lonnie said, her tone and expression turning serious. “You sure you’re okay to fight? I watched you take that blaster hit directly to the armor back in that first wave, and you weren’t exactly all there this time around either. I was worried about you, moving around without that breastplate of yours.”

“I’m fine, I promise.” Adora made her point by moving to stand, and the muscles in her side started to seize. Rogelio helped her get the rest of the way upright, and the disapproving look on Lonnie’s face deepened.

“You look like you’re literally about to pass out,” Lonnie said. “Maybe you should sit this one out too.”

“I can’t.” Adora turned away from them when she heard her voice grow thick with emotion. She wasn’t going to lose it in front of them—they’d really make her stay behind if she did. “I can’t, Lonnie.” She took a shuddering breath, ground her teeth against yet another spike of pain as she did so, and forced herself to look Lonnie in the eyes. She just wished the tears in her own had gone away before she did. “Catra and Glimmer are up there. I’m not staying here while everyone else goes to save them.”

Lonnie studied her for a moment before letting out a long breath. “Alright,” she said, shaking her head. “Glimmer’s a tough one, and Catra’s no pushover either. I’m sure they’re alright. We’ll zap in there together, all of us will kick Horde Prime’s alien ass, and get everyone home. And that includes you too, so you’d better have your shit together up there, Adora.” She jabbed Adora in the shoulder hard enough to make her take a step back.

Adora grinned back at her, smug. “No one gets it together better than me. I’m really glad I’m fighting next to the both of you again. Thank you for coming to help us.”

Lonnie and Rogelio nodded. As cohorts growing up together, nothing else needed to be said.

The doors to the war room opened and the smiles on their collective faces disappeared when Shadow Weaver stepped out into the hall.

"We're almost ready," she said, giving them a once-over. "Entrapta, Micah and I will test some final adjustments, but I think it's time we all have a plan for when we are finally aboard."

Adora, Lonnie, and Rogelio exchanged looks, then they followed Shadow Weaver inside. The war room looked completely different compared to how it was before the last wave.

Micah stood at the center of the room with one hand drumming his fingers on his chin while he stared down at an impossibly complex magic rune drawn into the floor. Entrapta darted around him, yammering with expansive gestures about calculations and probabilities and statistics while occasionally tapping furious commands into an oversized tablet she wore strapped to a forearm. The large boardroom table that had previously been the centerpiece of the room had been pushed off to the side. Scorpia sat alone at one end of it, glassy eyes staring right through everything.

Lonnie and Rogelio shuffled over to her after bidding Adora farewell and Scorpia perked up, imploring them to pull up a chair and sit with her after noticing them. Shadow Weaver strode toward Entrapta and Micah, and Adora followed.

"Adora, there you are," Micah said, interrupting Entrapta mid-sentence as they approached. "I was afraid something may have happened to you after finding out how many people we lost in that last wave."

Adora shook her head. "I'm okay, sir, I got luckier than most. Sorry for making you worry. How are we doing with the teleportation spell?"

"I think we have it," Micah said, gesturing to the designs on the floor. "It's not perfect, but I think it's as close as we're going to

get it." He turned to Entrapta, who had busied herself with the tablet on her arm.

"I've run the calculations over and over again a thousand times," she said. "While Emily was assisting Bow, I also had her run several hundred thousand variations on her unused CPU threads, and we're 99.98% certain that the coordinate parameters we've used in conjunction with this rune should teleport you right into the heart of the citadel's throne room. Any adjustments, however slight, yield a less accurate arrival percentage."

"What happens in that two hundredths of a percent situation?" Adora asked.

Entrapta gave her a sheepish look. "You'll uh…end up in the vacuum of space most likely. It's not just the calculations. If the spell misfires or one of you puts too much or too little energy into it, then you may even teleport halfway inside one of the citadel's bulkheads or between decks. Maybe even inside one of the warships around it instead of the citadel itself."

"There's also the chance we may not reappear at all," Shadow Weaver said. "Entering the void between dimensions to teleport is easy enough, but coming back? We may get stuck with no way to return, much like a certain other queen I won't mention by name."

"It's like threading a needle," Micah said. If he had caught Shadow Weaver's jab at Angella, he didn't show it. "Sadly, this is the only option we have of getting up there. We either do this, or we hope the Emperor doesn't hold Adora's words against us when we agree to surrender after all."

Thinking of surrendering made Adora grimace. The ache from earlier flared, and she clutched at her side in pain before she could stop herself.

"Are you alright?" Micah asked, stepping closer to her. "I told you fighting in your condition was no good even before the second wave. You're pushing yourself too hard, Adora."

Adora was about to protest when Shadow Weaver interrupted.

"She has several bruised ribs on her side and still can't get in touch with her powers," she said. "But with how few fighters we have left, I'm not sure we can spare her."

Adora couldn't help her open-mouthed surprise at hearing Shadow Weaver vouching for her to keep fighting. Even as a child, she encouraged her to rest when needed, although Adora was certain it was out of a desire to keep her performing perfectly rather than any actual love the woman had for her. Hearing her advocate to keep pushing when even she could admit privately to herself that she wasn't at her best was unexpected. She shut her mouth and averted her eyes the moment she saw Shadow Weaver notice her reaction.

"I feel like I shouldn't be putting this on you seeing as I am both the King and old enough to be your father," Micah said. "But Shadow Weaver is right—we don't have the luxury to lose more people. I will go along with whatever you decide, but I want you to be certain of your decision. Are you well enough to fight and are we really going to go up there to take the fight to Horde Prime directly? There will be no one here to defend the injured if Horde Prime sends a third wave while we are up there."

Adora balked and looked around the room. She hadn't considered they fact the castle would be defenseless when they left. There weren't even enough Bright Moon guards to man the front gates. Would it even make a difference what she did? There were only eight of them in total including her. Seven if you took out Entrapta, since she was staying behind after handing over all of her fighting bots that still functioned.

Scorpia and her were the only princesses. Then there were the two badly injured Ex-Horde soldiers, King Micah, Shadow Weaver, and Bow when he got back from the armory. No She Ra. Were they really going to assault Horde Prime's citadel with just that? Could she really order everyone to go with such dismal odds?

A clamor sounded off behind them, and Bow hurried through the double doors into the room. He clutched a golden breastplate tight to his chest, and Emily followed close behind, pushing a purple hover cart laden with gadgets and weapons. Bow stopped to look around as soon as he got inside, and marched over to Adora as when he spotted her.

"I did it," he said to her, out of breath. "I fixed it up as best I could." He turned the breastplate to display for her and Adora felt her mouth drop when she looked.

She had raided Bright Moon's armory before the first wave, reasoning that if she couldn't transform into She Ra, then she'd have to make do with a normal-sized set of armor, different from the one she had worn when Catra first assaulted the castle years prior. That armor had let her walk away with her bruised ribs instead of a gaping, cauterized hole in her chest where the blaster fire had hit her, but it had left nearly the entire left hemisphere of the breastplate shattered beyond recognition. Adora had given it to Bow hours earlier, pretty much having written off ever wearing it again. What he had done to fix it was nothing short of a miracle.

"Bow, this is incredible," she said, tracing her fingers along its near-pristine surface.

"I managed to get it pretty much back in fighting shape," he said, turning the breastplate slightly so she could get a clear look at its curves and angles. "You can still see where it was originally damaged, but it should protect you almost as good as if that break didn't happen in the first place."

Adora took it from him to inspect closer. Sure enough, there was a thin indent down the side where the laser had hit, but she'd be kidding herself if she thought that would cause any problems. "I really didn't think you'd be able to fix it," she said. "It was a mess when I first handed it over."

Bow gave her a bright smile that clashed with the bags under his eyes. “I couldn’t let you go out there without it. It saved your life the first time, and that meant I needed to get it ready just in case it needed to do so a second time.”

Adora pulled him into a hug and squeezed tight. “Thank you Bow.”

Bow hesitated, seemingly taken aback, before hugging her back. Happiness radiated from him for a moment when they pulled away, before the melancholy that had followed him around like a shadow since learning of Glimmer’s abduction returned. He looked away from her, and Adora felt her own mood plummet in response. Lonnie, Rogelio, and Scorpia were crowding the purple cart Emily had wheeled in, examining the weapons and equipment and planning out who would use what and how.

“We’re going,” Adora said, turning back around to face Micah and Shadow Weaver with a renewed sense of determination. “We’ve already seen how ruthless Horde Prime is in conquering this planet. Surrender is not an option for us, and although I’d much rather have way more than just the seven of us going, I know that we’ll succeed. We’ll rescue Glimmer, we’ll rescue Catra, we’ll take Horde Prime as our prisoner if we can, or we’ll end his life if we have no other choice. But one way or the other, we’re putting an end to this invasion once and for all.”

Lonnie and Scorpia gave an excited whoop as they smacked hand to claw, and Micah’s eyes twinkled with inspiration.

“That’s the spirit,” he said. He nodded to Entrapta who tapped a command into her tablet, and a holographic schematic of what Adora guessed was Horde Prime’s throne room appeared. Micah stepped close and peered at it. “Entrapta went to a lot of trouble to give us these layouts. They’re only estimations from her scans into space, but they’re the best we have."

A smile spread across Adora’s face when she saw the layouts. “This is more than enough. Alright. We come up with a solid plan of attack, and go. There’s no more time to waste.”

Chapter End Notes

You heard her, no more delays!

I know some of you were probably hoping we'd stick with Glimmer and see what kind of predicament she'd get herself into with the Emperor and I promise we'll get there. But we really needed to see Adora take stock of the Rebellion's situation on the surface, see what they were up against and what they were working with, and still make the decision to go anyways. It's important, I promise.

Next chapter will be big, and it will come at it's originally scheduled time: next Thursday evening, PST. See you then!

# Overtures Across Time and Space

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra woke when a sharp feeling pinched her arm. She blinked the sleep out her eyes and looked down. A thin alien, dressed in white and wearing a surgical mask, sat on a rolling stool and pushed a needle into her forearm.

"Get away from me!" She yanked away and hissed, causing the doctor to scramble backward in the stool with a yelp. The syringe dropped to the floor and shattered, dashing the liquid inside across the linoleum and sending the needle skittering off somewhere under the bed.

"Miss, you are not well," the doctor said, putting his hands up for her to see and inching forward once more. "Please, if you will just let me—"

"Don't come any closer!" Catra leapt up into a crouch atop the bed with every hair on her body standing on edge. "Where am I? Where's Glimmer?"

When the doctor hesitated, a door in the corner of the room slid open and a woman in a sharp military uniform walked through.

"You're in one of the private medical wards in the Emperor's citadel," she said, taking off her cap and stowing it under her arm. "The same one Glimmer went to when she got sick."

Catra studied the woman's face. "I remember you from the observation deck," she said, although she couldn't remember the name Prime had called her by at the time.

"Well at least you aren't hallucinating anymore. That's a good sign." The woman turned to the doctor, who looked to be at a

complete loss for what to do next. “That will be all. I can take it from here.”

The doctor nodded and hurried out of the room, relief plain on his face. The woman approached and Catra gave another hiss in warning. The room then lurched and spun, and all of Catra’s efforts suddenly went into keeping her from falling off the bed and faceplanting into the floor.

“Relax,” the woman said, pulling up the stool to sit on and digging through a wire rack of drawers next to the bed. “My name is Taline. Not that this will make any sense to you right now, but I’m a Battlemage of the Enclave, a protectorate within the Galactic Horde. I’ve been sent to assimilate your world into the empire and lead a research team in studying the Heart of Etheria.”

She pulled another syringe and a second small vial filled with liquid from the drawers. Catra’s mind screamed danger at her as she watched Taline stick the syringe through the top of the vial and draw out its contents, but the room now spun so fast she couldn’t do anything about it.

“This is a sedative,” Taline said, turning to face her. “A mild one to help with the vertigo and the nausea. Your brain is still sorting itself out after the Emperor’s little romp through it.” Without waiting for her go ahead, Taline grabbed Catra by the arm, swabbed her with an antiseptic pad she hadn’t even seen her pull out, and plunged the needle in while Catra reeled from the smell of alcohol that overpowered her nose.

Catra tried to pull away and hiss again, but Taline’s grip was too strong. She panicked, thinking she for sure was either going to die or fall unconscious and wake up strapped to another interrogation chair. But by the time Taline emptied the syringe’s contents into her, the room had stopped spinning, and Catra already felt better.

“Huh,” she said, flexing her fingers in front of her and tilting her head to test her equilibrium. “That works so fast.”

“Glimmer will be at the communications bridge,” Taline said, pulling away and disposing of the syringe. “You should be in good enough condition to walk after a few minutes. We’ll head over there and meet up with her when you are.”

“Communications bridge?” Catra asked. “You let her wander around outside *alone*? What the hell were you thinking?” She always had the nagging feeling in the back of her mind the cell was as much for their protection on the citadel as it was for Horde Prime to keep them in one place. It was why she never fought against being locked up in the first place.

“She’ll be fine, since both my Sentinels are watching over her,” Taline said.

“Both your what?” Catra shook her head. “Never mind, just…as long as she’s safe. Whatever. Why is she not in our cell anymore?”

Taline brought Catra up to speed on what had happened, although speaking with a tone of voice that implied her patience was running empty. “Your queen helped me persuade the Emperor to let us use some of the holographic projectors he’s already set up on the surface,” she said as she wrapped up. “My men are escorting her to communications so we could record a message for everyone still resisting on the planet’s surface.”

“She’s not my queen,” Catra said, her tail twitching in irritation.

“No? She seemed to care a great deal about you. And that wasn’t just out of skepticism for me, although I don’t blame her for that in the slightest. She agreed to cooperate if I brought you to her and proved you were okay. I guess she thought I might have done away with you as soon as was convenient for me.”

Catra didn’t know what to think of that. Glimmer wanted to know she was safe? They had been acting almost like allies during their captivity so far, sure, but she had chalked that up to both of them leaning on one another for survival and nothing more. Catra didn’t actually matter, so why did Glimmer care if she was safe or not?

“She convinced the Emperor to help, huh?” Catra asked, trying to distract herself from thinking any further about it. “Forgive me if I find anything you say hard to believe. Horde Prime just laid waste to all of Etheria and practically conquered the planet, according to you. I’ve seen the army of ships he has orbiting the planet. Why the hell would he listen to anything you or anyone else has to say?”

A look spread across Taline’s face—one that Catra recognized the meaning behind immediately. She had made the same face before: once, months ago, when she had been trying to finalize battle plans for an upcoming assault and Scorpia tumbled through, trying to balance two teacups on the ends of her pincers before dropping them. She had also made that face on the multiple occasions she had tried to keep Entrapta’s focus on an important project, only to find her thoroughly distracted by some piece of scrap or new tech off in a corner.

It was the look of someone far and away overwhelmed with what they felt was a flood of inane roadblocks, while doing everything they can to keep from falling apart. Yes, Catra had been there many times before, but seeing it on another person’s face was a new experience.

“Horde Prime is a sadistic pain in the ass,” Taline said. “I’ve said as much to Glimmer. And you’re right to think he’d normally ignore anyone’s opinion but his own. But he’s not suicidal. In fact, his instinct for survival is strong enough to override even his pride. Once Glimmer helped soothe his ego, and I reminded him we don’t have the luxury of getting distracted conquering planets, he came around and remembered why he agreed to let us lead Etheria’s assimilation in the first place.”

Taline looked at her as if that explained everything, and didn’t instead fill Catra with more questions than answers.

“Okay?” Catra said. “I don’t understand how that makes anything clearer for me.”

Taline sighed and rubbed at the crease in her brow. “I came in with twenty-three warships maybe four hours ago. The Emperor has over a thousand hovering above this planet alone. And yet, he’s agreed to defer to my authority here despite how irritated he feels about it. What in the world do you think would cause him to do so?”

“Oh, I don’t know,” Catra said exaggerating the sarcasm in her voice. “How about nothing? There’s nothing that would get him to do that, and you’re just manipulating me. Is there a prize for guessing the right answer?”

“Stop thinking with your fear and start thinking with your brain,” Taline said. “You’re a smart girl. You’re intelligent enough to already have asked some good questions, so don’t stop because you’re getting frustrated. Why would Horde Prime back off?”

Catra paused. Had she just complimented her? No one had ever called Catra smart before, even in the obscurely condescending way Taline had put it. Catra pressed her lips into a thin line and considered what they had talked about, rolling the words ‘instinct for survival’ and the image of Horde Prime’s massive fleet around in her head.

“There’s a threat,” she said at last. “One big enough he’d rather have your cooperation than lose it going against you.”

“There you go,” Taline said. “What else?”

Catra looked away before Taline saw how her encouragement affected her. It was pathetic, really, how the words of a stranger—especially one who had drugged her moments earlier—affected her. But what could she say? Aside from Adora, she hadn’t gotten an ounce of positive reinforcement growing up. She was starved.

“I don’t understand how you’re expected to help if you’ve brought even less firepower than Horde Prime already has,” Catra said. “And why would he need help in the first place if he has such a

strong military? Something that can threaten a force that size has to be…unprecedented."

"'Unprecedented' is putting it lightly," Taline said with a grimace. She pointed to the badge on the front of her officer's jacket. "You see this insignia?"

Catra nodded. She had noticed the instant Taline walked in. Everyone aboard this damned citadel wore the Horde insignia—upturned wings flanking a diamond in the center. This new insignia, however, was the opposite: a smooth, stylized chevron with wings that pointed down instead of up, and a teardrop shape in the center instead of a diamond. Unlike the stark red of Hordak's forces or the dull grey of Horde Prime's, Taline's shone bright silver and cut a sharp contrast when placed against the black of her uniform.

"This is the crest of my order, the Enclave Protectorate. And this"—she angled herself to the side and pointed to another insignia there: a truncated pentagram within a circle, also embroidered in silver—"marks me as a battlemage within that order. It's one of the highest military ranks you can attain. My peers refer to me as the Seraph of Archanas."

"Congratulations," Catra said, trying to mask her interest by forcing her voice to go flat. "That supposed to mean something to me?"

"I'm not telling you this to flatter myself," Taline said. "All of this should be telling you *why* Horde Prime is willing to disengage despite being, you know, Emperor of the known galaxy."

More memories, senses, and emotions that had been swirling in the fog at the back of Catra's mind came to the forefront, almost as if Taline's words helped massage them free. "I met your colleague," Catra said. "Salas. Prime introduced him as his advisor, right before he helped him with the mind probe. You Enclave aren't just extra military….Prime relies on you for your expertise. But in what? Magic?"

“You catch on quick,” Taline said. “We’re a protectorate, which means we retain full autonomy as a vassal state. In exchange the Emperor consults with us when magic beyond his understanding comes into play. It’s a good system, as long as he doesn’t ever feel like his ‘divine omnipotence’ is threatened by our presence.”

“So this threat that has him putting you in charge is what? A *magic* army?”

Taline laughed and shook her head. “If only it were that simple. You’ll find out soon enough, but we’ve spent enough time sitting. You should be fine to walk now and we need to go. The sooner we get Glimmer’s message out the—“

A buzz at Taline’s wrist interrupted her, and she extended her arm to expose a thin bracer of electronics underneath her sleeve. When she tapped at it, a holographic screen sprang up in front of her, and she cursed under her breath.

“What is it?” Catra asked.

“Do all you Etherians have some sort of death wish?” Taline asked. “First everyone in that castle seemed to think it was a better idea to bunker up and fight off a thousand orbiting ships instead of surrender, and now this.” She tapped at the screen and what had once been a blank white panel—ostensibly to keep whoever was sitting opposite her from looking at its contents—turned transparent. “My tactical officer got a visual of the inside of the castle.”

Catra perked up at the still image: a blurry photo of eight people standing around an enormous design painted on the floor. It looked not unlike the one she saw beneath her during her interrogation. She squinted and leaned in closer, trying to identify everyone. Lonnie and Rogelio were there with Scorpia, checking out a cart of tech. Adora stood nearby with Arrow Boy—wasn’t his name Bow?—and they were both embracing each other. Someone she didn’t recognize, likely Glimmer’s dad, stood there too next to Entrapta, tapping at a comically large tablet strapped to her arm.

Then Catra saw Shadow Weaver and that nauseous, nervous feeling that had followed her constantly since childhood returned. She backed away from the image and felt the room begin to tilt again.

"Do you recognize that rune?" Taline asked.

Catra shook her head and immediately regretted it when that threatened to fling her off the bed. She gripped the mattress harder to steady herself.

"That's a teleportation spell," Taline said. "Judging by how complicated it is, they're going to try and do a recall without a mark to anchor their exit."

"I don't understand what that means," Catra said through gritted teeth.

"It means they're going to teleport without a concrete beacon to help them reappear where they need to be. It's extremely dangerous, like trying to land a cargo-liner on an ocean platform with zero visibility or instrumental guidance." She zoomed the picture to focus on the rune and pursed her lips. "This is ridiculous. It looks like they're going to try and come out right here in the station."

Catra forced a laugh. "That sounds about right for that group of idiots. They're always doing crazy shit without thinking it through."

"That's not all," Taline said, her frown deepening. "Glimmer is still in the throne room, mouthing off to the Emperor."

Those words struck Catra hard enough to almost make her forget her vertigo. "She's what!?"

"My men sent me a note about it. I told her to head to the communications bridge and meet us there, but she's gone and done something stupid instead."

Catra struggled to breathe. Images of Prime combing through her mind atop in the interrogation chamber flashed through her head, and a sudden, unshakeable fear that Glimmer would push him too far grabbed hold of her. She knew exactly how unbalanced the Emperor was from seeing into his head. Glimmer had no idea what she was poking at.

"She's going to get herself killed," Catra said, kicking her legs out the side of the bed. "We should go. Now."

"She'll be fine," Taline said, sounding more irritated than worried. "Unless she says something particularly egregious, he won't risk an incident with my Sentinels there." Taline gave her a look. "Hey, are you okay? I might have misjudged…you don't look steady enough to—"

Catra pushed off to stand and felt her legs turn to jelly the moment her feet touched the floor. Taline snapped forward faster than Catra thought her capable of moving, sending the stool clattering backward and catching her under the arms before she fully collapsed to the floor.

"Alright, I'm fully convinced. All of you are crazy and do indeed have a death wish. Nothing you say can convince me otherwise." Taline manhandled Catra back onto the bed.

Catra's mind raced. She couldn't keep up with the thoughts, the feelings, the emotions. She was herself one moment, then was Horde Prime the next—she was here, in the infirmary during one beat of her heart, then somewhere else in time and space before she could get her bearings. Images flickered before her eyes one after the other, each throwing her off balance and thrusting her into a deepening spiral of decay. She was drowning.

*Adora was reaching for her…begging Catra to follow her to the Rebellion.*

*Catra was on some distant planet, leading a siege against an alien fortress, commanding her clones. She'd slaughtered millions*

*already on this world, and would slaughter millions more before the campaign was done.*

*Shadow Weaver was standing over her, terrorizing her for staring at the Black Garnet again. She should have known better than to let herself get caught.*

*She was at the head of a military tribunal, screaming at the defendants: a young man and a young woman—Taline's sister. Taline sat to Catra's right, one of the seven justices in the court proceedings. She looked…conflicted.*

*Glimmer and her were fighting. She had found Catra in her secret base and was coming for her. Catra had to escape, before everything burned down around her.*

*She was outside, on the steps of the Enclave's massive judiciary. Soldiers and other battlemages were fighting to keep the insurrectionists from escaping, and she watched Taline let loose a blinding fork of magic lightning at the man who was standing on the defendant dais only moments earlier. She probably wouldn't win the fight—not when Catra knew who the man was—but she hoped, nonetheless.*

*Catra was hiding behind a pile of rubble on Horde Prime's citadel. She watched him approach Glimmer, watched him lay a palm against her cheek. It was a lie…Catra had to stop him before he killed her.*

A hand cupped the side of her face just as she watched Horde Prime do the same to Glimmer, and the visions dispersed. She was back in the medical bay, looking up at Taline, who's own expression bored into her with concern. Catra yelped and tried to jump away but Taline shot her hand forward, gripped her behind the head, and held her in place.

Catra swung at her with extended claws. Taline threw her other arm up and blocked, twisting the moment their bodies made contact to grip at Catra's wrist like a vice. Catra yelled, ready to

scratch with her other hand, to ram her forehead into Taline's face, to kick and bite and scream to get away.

In one smooth motion, Taline let go of her wrist and pushed a palm gently against Catra's forehead. A light appeared there, and Catra felt a cool sensation cascade down her body, calming her. Finally, the room stopped spinning, and she stopped fighting.

"Why didn't you tell me you were spiraling again?" Taline asked. "I could have helped stabilize you before all that happened."

Catra pulled away and Taline let her go. "I don't need your help," she said.

"Clearly. You do a good job hiding yourself, pretending everything is okay. I really didn't catch on until you almost dumped yourself to the floor."

"I have plenty of practice pretending things are fine when they're not," Catra said. Another image of Shadow Weaver flashed by and she suppressed a shudder. "Kind of had to."

"I know."

Catra looked over and saw her staring back with a hard expression: Taline must have glimpsed the same visions Catra was having. Those eyes of concern from earlier were gone, replaced with a look of barely concealed anger. Not at her, but at what she had experienced. Catra didn't know why she suddenly felt ashamed. Why should she care what Taline thought of her after seeing glimpses of her pathetic life?

"Come on," Taline said, urging her to stand once more. "It's only a small spell, but it should brace your mind and prevent more flare ups in the short term. We should get to the throne room now, before Glimmer finds something more stupid to do."

"They're not going to go for it," Catra said as Taline headed for the door. She stopped and turned with a confused expression on her face.

"What are you talking about?"

"I'm talking about the Rebellion. They're not going to go for surrender, even if you get Glimmer up on a giant projection asking them to." Taline's frown deepened and Catra pressed on.

"It's just like you said. Everyone on Etheria is crazy. Them especially. I would know, since I've been fighting them for a while. The Rebellion has never surrendered. Even when I had them up against impossible odds, they've always come out on top, and it's given them a hugely inflated sense of invulnerability. I think they'd sooner try and teleport up here to attack Horde Prime directly than surrender to you, even if you do parade Glimmer out there as bait."

"They're all going to die," Taline said, fully turned around to face Catra again. "What can I do to get them to stand down?"

"Who's to say they aren't going to die anyways if they do surrender?"

"I do," Taline said, her voice devoid of any humor. "I'll promise you like I promised Glimmer—no harm will come to them if they lay down their arms."

Despite how foggy much of her still felt, Catra furrowed her brow and thought. She didn't trust Taline—that would be stupid, after all. Especially after seeing that she had a few suspicious appearances in Horde Prime's memories as well. But, surprisingly, Catra found that she didn't *distrust* her.

And she was right: if the Rebellion didn't stand down, they would die. She had seen the Emperor kill countless without blinking, after all. She hated the Rebellion. They took everything from her, including Adora, but that didn't mean she wanted to see them and everyone on the planet slaughtered. What could they do to get them to stop fighting?

Strangely, she found when she wracked her brain there were… more memories than just the ones she saw flash before her

earlier. More memories of an irate Emperor, sitting on his throne, contemplating his empire. They had the technology to shove great fleets into the void and pluck them out on the other side of the galaxy faster than even light could travel. It had frustrated him they couldn't locate Etheria in Despondos before it emerged on its own.

*The scientists had said it would be easier to locate a single person and return them from the void than to do that for something as large as a planet.*

Catra gasped, pulling herself out of the memories. She had let guilt get the better of her one day, and Hordak surprised her by answering her question for once: Queen Angella wasn't technically dead, just…lost beyond where anyone could reach. She was gone for good.

But that was then, and this was now. The Horde Empire—the true Galactic Horde Empire—could obviously do a lot more than Hordak could in his dinky lab she had trashed to bits when they fought.

"You've thought of something," Taline said, still looking her in the eyes. "We have some time. Crazy as your friends are, if they know magic well enough to craft that rune, then they'll spend several hours testing it before they do anything. Talk to me."

Catra bit her lip. Was this crazy to suggest? Would it really work? "If, hypothetically, someone got stuck in one of those portals, like they tried cast that teleportation spell and couldn't come out the other side…would you be able reach in and grab them?"

Taline cocked an eyebrow and pulled the stool around to sit on it again, clearly intrigued by her line of reasoning. "It's not easy."

"But not impossible, right?" Catra sighed and decided there was no going back. "They won't just listen to Glimmer, since they'll think she's just being forced into saying whatever. But if you were to start talking about what you could do for someone they lost?

Someone they'd do anything to get back? Well, that'd be a different story, wouldn't it?"

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"And if my mom were here, she'd kick your ass too," Glimmer said, enjoying the thoroughly annoyed expression on Horde Prime's face as he stared at the intel on the screens around his throne instead of her. "But that's okay, because She Ra is more than enough to take you, all by herself even."

Glimmer didn't know why she was doing this. Intentionally trying to get a rise out of the Emperor was probably the dumbest thing she could have chosen to do. She should have listened to Taline and gone to the communications bridge; she should have just gotten in the elevator like the Sentinels had urged her to, but something about being left to her own devices with an armed guard demolished her better judgement. She was just surprised Narre and Miri hadn't picked her up and carted her away by force. Instead, they had followed her back to the throne.

Prime finally turned away from the screens and looked at her. "Was all that groveling and cowering you did moments earlier just a ruse? You would have made a good actress, were you born into my empire rather than a queen on a backwater planet."

The muscles in his jaw tightened with each word he spoke, and Glimmer felt a tinge of adrenaline shoot through on noticing. She was getting to him.

"You've never met She Ra, have you?" she asked, ignoring his dig at her entirely. "You don't know who she is."

"Should I have?" Prime asked, his voice, clipped. "It doesn't really make a difference who she is. I've conquered more worlds than you can imagine. Each of them had their own champions they put forward, confident they'd put a stop to me. All of them failed."

Glimmer smirked and pushed her tone to be as smug and condescending as possible. "I'm sure you have, but I bet none of

them could hold a candle to She Ra. She's eight feet tall and all muscle and magic. You wouldn't like her. Like I said, if it were you and her in a fight, she'd beat you to a pulp."

Salas, who this entire time had been standing next to Horde Prime amidst his clone guards, sighed and looked off in the distance. He looked paler and clammier than before up in the interrogation room, like at any moment he'd keel over from anemia. He also looked like he'd rather slit his own throat if it meant he didn't have to stand there listening to her bicker with his emperor.

Glimmer felt strangely proud of that. She had no idea what he had meant back on the observation deck telling her to stay in the chair. It sounded like he was trying to help, but she couldn't look past the fact he essentially facilitated Catra's torture, and it felt to Glimmer like she had turned the tables on him somewhat, subjecting him to this argument.

Horde Prime rolled his four eyes. "Little girl, I've lived for thousands of years and conquered tens of thousands of planets in my life, like I said. By contrast, your entire lived experience thus far is but a flicker before my eyes. Do you think your words scare me? I've known many, many people—proud people who have thought like you and lashed out irrationally in some vain attempt to wrest back a semblance of control despite their circumstances. All of them are dead now, and their worlds are under my rule. Or did you miss that part when I said they failed to stop me?"

Glimmer flinched. Prime had seen through her even when she herself couldn't figure out what had come over her. Everything clicked into place all of a sudden. She had felt so helpless up here for days, unable to escape, unable to use her powers, unable to even help Catra in her time of need. The need to feel in control of at least something amid that sea of helplessness had overwhelmed her, and now she was 'lashing out', as he had put it. And that realization did nothing to tamp down her frustration.

"I may only have been alive for so long," she said. "But even I know when someone is too proud to admit they're scared. Too

weak to admit it."

Prime narrowed his eyes to slits. "What was that?"

"Isn't it obvious?" Glimmer asked, drawing on what Catra had shared with her about him in the cell after being probed. "An all-powerful Emperor, absolute ruler of tens of thousands of worlds, torturing a helpless girl strapped to a chair for hours on end? Normally I'd just peg you as a sadist and leave it at that, but then someone comes aboard to take over your invasion, and you just let her?" Glimmer gave a harsh laugh. "I don't know what it is, but you're afraid of something. Afraid enough to let Taline come here and order you around."

Horde Prime tightened his hands around the arms of his throne hard enough the metal crimped. Salas' eyes darted to the same place, and he took a tentative step forward.

"She is not ordering me around," Prime said, voice low enough to be a growl.

"No? She comes here saying she doesn't have time to conquer the planet and neither do you. She tells you to stand down and manipulates you into giving her access to your projectors so she can call a ceasefire. Who's subordinate to who here?" She scoffed and gave a flip of her hair, hoping it looked as obnoxious as it felt to do. "It's probably better for you in the long run she wants to negotiate. If my friends refuse then you'd end up meeting She Ra on the battlefield, and then you'd know I was right about her being able to kick your ass."

Prime jumped to his feet, eyes flaring and tendrils uncoiling from around his head. Glimmer stepped back in spite of herself. For all her swagger, Horde Prime was a truly ferocious sight, and this was the first time she had seen him fully lose his composure. His clone guards looked to each other, startled, and the Sentinels, who until this point had stood quietly behind her, put themselves physically between her and Prime, unhooking the rifles they wore strapped to the front of their breastplates.

"My Lord," Salas said, taking a confident step toward the Emperor and resting a hand on his shoulder. "It is like you said. She is naïve and brash, and she is lashing out for control. Control that you will be giving her if you respond to her provocations."

Glimmer looked to the Sentinels as if noticing they were there for the first time. How was it she  was acknowledging the stupidity of her original idea only after it had already worked? Taline had told them to protect her against any threat, and while Glimmer hadn't really believed that applied to the Emperor himself, the fact it *had* was nothing short of awe inspiring to her. Glimmer had no idea how the command structure in the Enclave worked, but if Taline's people followed her orders to the letter like this, then maybe she was mistaken to have doubted her in the first place.

Feeling strangely emboldened, Glimmer laughed again. "What did I say? Now even your own advisor is giving you orders? Be a good evil conqueror and do as he says, won't you?"

Horde Prime snarled and took a step toward her. The Sentinels snapped their rifles up, aiming them straight at his chest. The clone guards moved to stand in the line of fire, their staves held high and poised to throw.

"Lord Prime!" Salas' voice cracked in the air like a whip. The tension in the air was so palpable Glimmer didn't dare move or breath. "We cannot risk an incident. Not with the Enclave, not now. Please, employ some of the restraint that got us through the last crisis. We need it now more than ever."

Horde Prime tensed further and Glimmer was certain he'd ignore Salas' words. Then he relaxed and sat back down in his chair.

"I believe you were told to be on the communications bridge," he said, voice eerily calm once more. "I suggest you find your way there while you still have two functioning legs."

Glimmer bristled but knew she had lost. Unable to get a rise out of the Emperor, she instead glared at Salas for interfering. Salas

merely regarded her with a weary look before shaking his head at her. Glimmer then turned on her heel and marched toward the elevator at the back. She heard the Sentinels fall in behind her, but otherwise paid them no attention. Her mind was elsewhere, trying to recover even a sliver of the dignity and control she had felt earlier before Salas had ripped it away.

She stopped midstride. Something didn't feel right. She glanced around, trying to figure out why she suddenly heard static and felt goosebumps form on her skin. Judging by their body language when Glimmer checked behind her, the Sentinels had picked up on it as well.

Miri suddenly lunged toward her, while Narre jumped and rolled away. Light exploded right next to her, just as Miri grabbed her and threw her in the air away from the blast. She yelped and sailed through the air before crashing into the floor at Narre's feet.

Dazed and blinded, she let Narre help her up. Several people were yelling in the distance, sounding as if they were at the other end of a long tunnel. When Glimmer focused enough to look up, Miri was nowhere to be seen. Standing in her place, inside a smoldering circular scorch mark in the floor, were reinforcements.

Adora, Lonnie, Rogelio, Bow, and Scorpia were crouched low in a tight formation inside the circle. Standing at the circle's edges, were Shadow Weaver and her father, King Micah of Bright Moon.

Footsteps thundered past her as dozens of clone soldiers surged forward to confront them. Even more purple spider bots crawled out from where Glimmer's friends and family now stood, fanning out to meet them headlong in battle. Purple and black magic flared at her father's and Shadow Weaver's respective fingers. Adora gripped the staff she held in both hands, and the rest readied themselves with determination glinting in their eyes.

"Now!" Adora shouted. The throne room descended into madness as Rebellion clashed against Imperial Horde.

Chapter End Notes

Al-RIGHT, who's ready for the big battle set piece?

Taline was referred to as the "Seraph" exactly once before, but anyone want to take a guess at what (an/the) Archanas is? Or take bets on how well the Rebellion does?

To the Anon who left their appreciation on my Tumblr yesterday--made my whole day, so if you see this: Thank you :)

Hope you enjoyed this chapter, and see you all next Thursday!

# Gambit

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I thought you said we had at least a few more hours!" Catra said, sprinting down the hallway after Taline. An explosion in the distance rumbled the ground and she struggled to maintain her footing. Just as she had wrapped up talking about Angella, an alarm had blared alongside a call to arms: the throne room had been invaded.

"I seem to have underestimated just how bullheaded your friends on the surface are," Taline said, pushing past a group of clone and alien technicians plugging up the hallway and sending them sprawling. "It's a miracle what they did worked. Any sane person would have put that spell through more testing before sending anyone through it."

"Yeah well, what did I tell you?" Catra vaulted over the bodies Taline left in her wake, amazed at how light she felt now that the world wasn't threatening to pull itself out from underneath her. That sedative she had given her and whatever spell she cast on her head worked wonders. "They're crazy people, all of them, and they don't ever plan. They just jump headfirst into everything and figure it out as they go. Honestly, it's worked for them so far."

"Maybe so, but this is the end of the line for them. They've attacked the Emperor in his own throne room."

Anxiety seized her at hearing those words. They rounded the corner and Catra pumped her legs to run alongside Taline instead of behind her. "Is there any hope for a ceasefire still if we can get them to stand down?"

"I don't know," Taline said. "Prime is not the type to forgive this, but a lot has changed in the past eight years."

"You'll need all the princesses to make the Heart work," Catra said. "If they die, you may as well kiss your precious weapon goodbye." They got to the door that emptied out into the throne room and Catra could hear the sounds of blaster fire and violent magic on the other side.

"You don't know that," Taline said, giving her a sidelong glance. "Terrible as it was for you, the Emperor expressed his… frustrations with finding nothing of use in your head. You don't know anything. You just said what you had to in order to keep yourself and Glimmer alive." Catra jutted her chin out, about to bite back with some clever retort when Taline shook her head and cut her off. "Still," she said. "I'd like to prevent more deaths if I can."

Taline palmed the scanner to the door to open it. The scene that unfolded in front of them was worse than Catra imagined. The throne room was enormous—far larger than Catra had remembered it being when she was first beamed aboard. Many of the metal panels making up the floor had been ripped from their installations, bent upwards to form dozens of makeshift barriers the clone soldiers used as cover against the attackers. Purple fighting spider bots Catra assumed could only have come from Entrapta's handiwork crawled along the floor and walls and ceiling, blasting and slashing and biting at the clones.

A large purple dome of pure energy blazed in the center of the room, far enough away from the throne that the clones concentrating their fire there could employ full squad tactics in the space between. Shadow Weaver and a bearded man Catra didn't recognize maintained the shield while immolating clones with well-aimed magic bolts. She could also clearly see Scorpia and Lonnie and Rogelio inside, sheltering against the attacks. Suddenly, they fanned out, darting behind the metal barriers and pressing their backs against them with laser rifles hugged close to their chests.

Bow was there too, sheltering behind a different metal panel, sniping clones that left themselves open with his arrows. He shifted to look out from behind cover, and that's when Catra saw

Adora there next to him. Sweat sheened her skin and plastered her hair flat to her forehead. She gripped a staff in both hands and breathed hard as if she were winded. A golden breastplate covered her chest.

*Why isn't she transforming?* Catra thought as she searched Adora for any sign of the sword. *Adora wouldn't come here and not use She Ra. Not unless…*

"That one right there," Catra said, pointing her out to Taline. "That's Adora. She's one of the leaders. Usually she can…well, transform. Into this huge glowing warrior princess, but I think she might be holding back to turn the battle when it gets tight. She's the one we need to convince."

"There's also Glimmer's father," Taline said, pointing to the bearded man. "The Emperor talked to him a few days ago. He thought he might have gotten through to him until Adora stepped in, but he's technically the king. We might be able to convince him, too." She paused and looked Catra in the eye. "Stay close to me."

Catra cast an uncertain glance at her.

"You're still recovering," Taline said. "And you aren't equipped for a fight in the first place."

She had a point. Catra still had the same loose clothes she had changed into after her shower back in the cell and, despite feeling much better, she was still unsteady on her feet and generally weak from a lack of eating.

"I'll try and force an opening for us," Taline said. "The Emperor's clones are the only soldiers allowed in here, and they won't hesitate against his will. If we want to keep your friends alive, we need to get them to surrender. If they don't, Prime will crush them without mercy and kill them all, guaranteed. He won't take prisoners. Not after this."

Catra nodded and sprinted after Taline as they both entered the fray.

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It took several seconds for Glimmer to notice the shimmer in the corner of her eye. Salas had blanketed nearly the entire throne room in small runes after Adora and her dad arrived, and he had used those runes to pull up the metal paneling in the floors to provide cover for Prime's soldiers. Narre had already dragged her almost all the way back to the throne and behind one of those panels before she regained her sense of direction. Everything had moved so fast; it was that glinting in her peripheral vision that she first noticed as soon as she caught her breath. When she looked, she saw an ornate dagger laying there, gleaming amid the rubble.

It was Miri's knife. Glimmer had seen it strapped to the armor of her leg when they first met, although she didn't think anything of it until that moment. It must have been all that was left of her after getting caught in her dad's teleportation spell. The mere fact she could find nothing else of the Sentinel except her blade that had been flung halfway across the throne room was a testament to just how powerful of a spell they had needed to use to get up here. Glimmer suppressed a shudder at the thought—Miri had saved her life, preventing her friends and her dad from inadvertently killing her in their attempt at a rescue.

A thunderous clap rang out, and Glimmer looked up to see Shadow Weaver cast a spell. A black tendril of energy raced out from her hands past the energy shield her father had put up to guard them. It streaked toward the Emperor like a python moving in for a kill.

Salas stepped in front of the Emperor and gestured with his hands. An intricate rune appeared and twisted in the air in front of him. A shield far larger than her dad's appeared with the rune, blanketing the throne and a good third of the remaining room, including Glimmer and Narre. Shadow Weaver's magic slammed into the shield. Salas slid back across the floor a number of

inches, straining from the impact, but the shield held and the magic tendril dissipated.

“Form up!” Salas said. Two person-sized portals opened up on either side of him and the hooded mages from earlier on the interrogation deck poured through, flowing like water and arranging themselves like a choir at his back. In one motion, they moved and chanted in a harsh voice. The rune Salas maintained grew larger and more complex. Salas clapped his hands together and the rune dissipated, sending a shockwave across the battlefield.

Glimmer felt herself pull away from the floor, weightless. She made a split-second decision and leapt for the knife, grabbing and hugging it tight to her with one hand as she flailed about, trying to grab hold of anything that’d keep her attached to the ground before she pulled too far away. Strong arms grabbed her around the waist and she turned to see Narre, holding her tight with one arm while the other cradled his unholstered rifle. He oriented himself so his feet pointed back to the ground and slammed his heels together. The floor came rushing back until he stood upon it again like normal. Glimmer was still in danger of floating away without special boots of her own, so he continued to hold tight to her.

“Miri is dead,” he said, voice coming through the face plate heavily synthesized. “But my orders are still to keep you safe.”

“Bring me to my friends,” Glimmer said. “I need to get to them. Please”

Narre shook his head. “My orders are to keep you safe,” he said, repeating himself as if he hadn’t said it the first time. “That isn’t safe. Those are dead men and women walking.”

“No!” Glimmer kicked and struggled to get out of his grasp. His hold on her never weakened, but neither did it tighten. He was like an immovable force of nature, refusing to listen or let her loose, but refusing to hurt her in his attempt to keep her, either.

Glimmer screamed, hating the feeling of hopelessness that grew steadily stronger inside her.

She fought to look for her friends, for her dad, and found some of them still firmly planted on the ground behind the shield. All of the clone soldiers must have had special boots like Narre's, since none of them floated in the air with Salas' spell either, but several of Entrapta's purple bots had come loose from their stations and floated aimlessly in the air, kicking about and tumbling. When she looked up, Glimmer saw Scorpia, Lonnie, and Rogelio floating out in the open as well. They must have left the safety of her dad's shield at some point, and had been caught up in Salas' magic.

A half dozen Horde clones aimed for them and fired. The three of them jolted when hit and stilled in the air, heavy burn marks visible in their armor. Glimmer screamed and redoubled her efforts to escape Narre's grip.

A second shockwave emanated from her dad's shield and washed over them. Glimmer felt gravity impose itself upon them once more and her feet slammed to the ground; either her father or Shadow Weaver had negated the spell. She saw Scorpia, Lonnie, and Rogelio drop from the sky like bricks and rushed toward them as soon as Narre released her, only for him catch her by the arm and stop her once again.

"Let me go!" Glimmer said.

"You cannot save them." Narre yanked her closer. "You will die if you go to them."

"I don't care, let me go!" Glimmer yanked again and still couldn't get free. "They're not dead yet. I have to help!"

"There's nothing you can do. Live on and honor their memory."

The emotion that tinged his voice was apparent even against the modulation from the armor, and it forced Glimmer to pause. Those were words from the heart—she could almost imagine the sadness in his eyes despite the helmet covering his face. Aside from Miri, it

made her stop and wonder what else he had gone through serving under Taline.  Narre's grip loosened and she jerked away from him, refusing to meet his gaze again.

Another explosion sounded off nearby. Salas and his team had deflected another bolt of Shadow Weaver's dark magic, and were responding with a wall of fresh runes that spit fire and lighting back. Horde Prime stood just behind. Simmering rage played across his features as he called for reinforcements.

A spark of inspiration struck Glimmer at seeing that. Honor her friends' memories, Narre had said? She didn't have to wait until they died to start doing that. In fact, if she acted now, she might just prevent that whole 'dying' bit from happening altogether.

Glimmer gripped the knife still in her hand and vowed instead to honor Miri, someone already gone, having given her life to protect Glimmer's. She evaded Narre when he reached for her once again, and took off at a dead sprint toward Horde Prime.

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"Adora, come on! Stop fighting us and listen for a second, will you?" Catra danced around their zone of engagement, trying to keep as close as possible to Taline as she dodged Adora's staff and Bow's arrows.

Taline had protected the both of them when Salas' antigravity spell hit, and Catra had watched Adora and Bow cling both to each other and the paneling they had taken cover behind to keep from floating away themselves. When Shadow Weaver and Micah —as Catra had come to learn his name was—dispelled it, they had both caught her and Taline's approach when crashing back to the floor. It hadn't taken more than a few seconds after that for them to engage.

"You saw Scorpia and Rogelio and Lonnie go down just a second ago," Catra said to Adora, leaving Taline's side to catch Bow in the middle of drawing an arrow back. He released just as she knocked his aim off, sending the arrow flying high over Taline's head

instead of at her chest. “Do you really think you’re going to win this? Your only hope out is to surrender.”

Adora grimaced, and Catra could tell she was getting through to her, even if she didn’t respond. Something about the way her attacks grew sloppier with their aggression and the way her eyes took on a wild look as she fought clued her in.

Bow dashed to the side and slid forward on his knees, another arrow already nocked and aimed. He let loose, and the arrow whistled straight at the back of Taline’s head. Catra already knew she wouldn’t get to it quick enough to intercept it.

Taline dodged the arrow, leaving Adora in front of her wide open to take the blow. Catra and Bow gasped and Adora’s eyes went wide seeing the arrowhead screaming straight for her face. Taline snatched it out of the air centimeters from impact.

“Arrow Boy, you stupid son of a—"

“I’m sorry! Adora! Oh my god.”

Catra turned and gave Bow her full attention, firing off punches and swipes with her claws, trying to sweep his leg, throwing blow after blow in rapid succession, anything to put him on the defensive and keep him from readying another arrow.

“You guys must be really desperate if you're going for headshots like this,” Catra said amidst another flurry of attacks. “Where’s She Ra? Why isn’t Adora transforming?”

Bow grunted, trying to put enough space between the two of them to get another arrow nocked. Catra was faster. She pushed closer and threw another series of punches, the last of which Bow wasn’t fast enough to fully step out from.

“She can’t transform, can she?” Catra asked as the blow grazed his shoulder. “Something’s wrong, isn’t it? That’s why you all are fighting so sloppy. You don’t have She Ra anymore. You’re all desperate.”

Bow didn’t respond, but the grim expression on his face told Catra all she needed to know. He took a step backward to dodge another swipe and lost his balance when his feet tangled. Catra pressed the advantage and threw a haymaker. It connected with the side of his head and Catra swore she felt his consciousness leave his body. Bow crumpled boneless to the floor, and she turned around to look for Adora and Taline.

Catra was already worried about everyone surviving the fight, but if Adora couldn’t even use She Ra any longer, then the Rebellion was at an even bigger disadvantage than she originally thought. She found Taline and Adora trading blows not far from where she left them, and rushed to rejoin.

“This is insane, Adora,” she said, coming up on Taline’s left and giving the both of them a wide berth to continue dancing. “Are you trying to get yourself killed? Taline’s been trying to call a ceasefire ever since she got here. She’s taken over from Horde Prime and she isn’t here to conquer Etheria, so just surrender already so no one else has to get hurt!”

A flaming Entrapta bot flew over her head, chased by a flurry of blaster fire. Catra cursed and threw herself behind one of the metal barriers, then peeked out the edge to continue watching them.

Taline fought Adora as if she were waiting for her to transform at any moment. She kept her distance, goading Adora with false openings that she’d then take, only to inadvertently leave herself wide open to a counterattack. Except Taline wouldn’t press it. Instead, she’d retreat, leading Adora around in a wide circle that edged them closer to Micah and Shadow Weaver.

Adora glanced behind her and seemed to realize what Taline was trying to do. She roared and charged at her, fighting with a reckless abandon that Catra hadn’t ever seen her stoop to since they were barely-trained cadets.

Taline dodged and blocked each attack. Adora thrust her staff forward in a particularly sloppy jab, and Taline caught it between her arm and her side. She then torqued her lower body and shoved an open palm against its side. The staff broke in two at the impact point, and Taline quickly looked over her shoulder at Catra still ducking behind cover.

"I leave her to you!" she said. "I'm going to see what I can do with the king."

Adora stepped in and threw a punch. Without looking, Taline gave a quick gesture of her hand and a rune appeared in her palm, as did small circlets of magic at Adora's wrists and ankles. Taline gave another gesture and Adora flew up and over, landing in a heap right next to Catra, then she turned and ran off toward the Rebellion's magic shield in the distance.

Magic crackled and roared in the distance, as did the sound of blaster fire, the scurrying of bots, and the shouting of clone soldiers as they coordinated, trying to flank the bots. Adora groaned nearby, dazed from impacting the ground, and Catra didn't waste the opportunity to climb on top and restrain her before she came to her senses.

"What the hell, Catra?" Adora said, struggling to break free. Catra tightened her hands around her wrists and squeezed her thighs tighter around her abdomen, flexing the armor there. Adora bit back a cry of pain when she did, but Catra refused to let up.

"Come off it, Adora," she said. "I know about She Ra. I know you can't use her."

Adora shot her a glare. "So what? You think I'm just going to give up and let Glimmer die up here without trying to rescue her?" Tears welled up in her eyes, and venom seeped into her voice. "I was coming for you too, despite everything that happened. But it looks like you've chosen a different side. Again. How can you *help* them, Catra?"

“That’s not it,” Catra said with a growl. “I’m on your side this time, I really am. Horde Prime is going to kill all of you. I can’t stand by and just let that happen.”

“It sure seems to me that’s exactly what you’re trying to help him do.”

“I told you earlier!” Catra said, jostling Adora in her frustration. “Taline isn’t here to conquer the planet, she’s here to help. There’s some sort of…enemy the Empire is fighting against and Prime needs her help fighting it. Etheria, the Heart…they need it. Taline’s here trying to keep more people from dying so they can research it.”

“Is that what she told you?” Adora asked, both eyebrows shooting up in genuine disbelief. “Tell me you didn’t fall for that.”

Catra furrowed her brow, not expecting that reaction. “What do you mean?” She expected Adora to listen to her, or at least listen to reason. They were so far outmatched, but the way Adora responded to her just now sounded almost like she thought it was —

“That sounds like a straight up lie!” Adora said, tone so biting it made Catra flinch. “You’re smarter than this, Catra. ‘Some sort of enemy’ they’re fighting? *That’s* what got you to believe she was trying to help?”

Catra faltered. “I don’t…no. No, that’s not what—“

“Horde Prime conquered the entire planet except Bright Moon in three days. He would have finished us off too if it weren’t for Micah and Shadow Weaver and all the princesses and the entire Royal Guard coming together. We just barely turned their advance into a prolonged siege. And that was from one warship he sent down to us—he’s got thousands up here! Horde Prime doesn’t need help with some made up enemy, that woman is just using you to try and get us to surrender.”

A fresh onslaught of emotions attacked her. Lied to? Used? Again? How could she let this happen? How could she not see it coming? Why did everyone do this to her? Shadow Weaver had done it so many times, shown just a bit of compassion or tossed a morsel of approval here to get her to bend, and then…

Catra released Adora and slid off her, eyes staring through everything. Adora sat up and rubbed at her wrists, sending a pitying look in Catra's direction. Catra turned away, embarrassed.

"I'm sorry," Adora said. "I shouldn't have made it sound like you were stupid for believing it. I have no idea what you and Glimmer went through up here, and that may have…" she glanced over at her and Catra could feel her staring at the wounds at her temples where Horde Prime had probed.

"Lonnie, Rogelio, and Scorpia aren't dead, but they're down and out," Adora said. "But Entrapta's bots are still tying up Prime's forces. Shadow Weaver and Micah are slowly whittling down their mage. He's a lot more powerful than we expected, but they're getting through him. And once they are, we're taking the Emperor out and ending this." Adora stood and extended a hand down to her. "Come on. I can't let whoever 'Taline' is go and distract them. Help me. Please?"

Catra looked up and saw the guarded, hopeful look Adora was giving her. She bit back the urge to put herself down for being so naïve, and took Adora's hand, reveling in the look of relief and happiness that passed across her face when she did.

Except something didn't feel right.

Catra followed, this time hot on Adora's heel instead of Taline's, and tried to keep her head low to avoid stray blaster fire as they went. It was as she looked around that it gradually dawned on Catra just how disadvantaged the Rebellion was without She Ra. Lonnie, Rogelio, and Scorpia were tied together and unconscious off in a corner. Entrapta's purple bots numbered only a handful now, and the clones were on the verge of wiping them out

entirely. Once that happened, they'd have an unimpeded path to Shadow Weaver and Micah, and the battle would end the moment their protective shield went down.

The screaming and crunching and thundering of battlefield magic grew louder the closer Adora and Catra drew to Micah's shield. Shivers ran down Catra's spine with the rumbling that pulsed through the floor and up her body. She could feel Shadow Weaver's magic there, and even though it mixed with Micah's less toxic emanations, it took everything in her body to not shy away.

They came away from cover and in full sight of the battle. Shadow Weaver faced away from them, throwing black fireball after black fireball toward Salas and his chorus of mages. Micah held one hand high in the air where a rune twisted, maintaining the protective shield that insulated him and Shadow Weaver from Salas' counter attacks. He held his other hand outstretched in front of him, a continuous beam of energy shooting forth from the rune in that palm and out at his opponent.

Taline stood six feet away, back toward them, feet planted wide, clothes and hair flapping ruthlessly in the blowback from Micah's attack. She held both hands thrust in front of her where a massive rune of her own design twisted and gyrated, splitting Micah's beam and sending it careening off in six different directions away from her. The sheer power emanating from the both of them physically buffeted Catra like a gust of wind, and her jaw hinged open in awe.

Adora crouched low and pull a knife from her boot, straining with every step forward, fighting for every inch of progress she made against the buffeting winds toward Taline. It was clear she intended to ambush her while distracted. Catra followed close behind, that gnawing feeling of something not being right growing stronger with every step.

"Micah, their sorcerer is running on empty, I can feel it," Shadow Weaver said all of a sudden. Another thick black tendril of energy

shot toward the throne from her extended palms. “How are you holding up back there?”

“Just fine!” Micah said, grimacing and clearly exerting himself trying to keep the shield up and take down Taline at the same time. “She’s got a strong defense, but I can handle it. I leave the Emperor to you!”

Catra stopped. Micah’s words made her remember what Taline had said only moments earlier.

*I leave Adora to you.*

Clarity dawned on her. She suddenly understood what that ‘wrong’ feeling was: if Taline was faring this well against Micah, then she must have had the upper hand the entire fight with Adora. Every feint she used to goad her into using She Ra had left Adora vulnerable to counterattack, and Taline hadn’t exploited a single opening. Taline could have ended Adora in an instant, but instead, had tossed her over to Catra so she could try and convince her to stand down instead.

Catra still wouldn’t go as far as to say she trusted Taline, but it was obvious she was doing everything she could to not kill them, and that was all Catra needed. She wasn’t about to gamble Adora’s life on the Rebellion’s half-brained plan, especially when it was going as poorly as it was.

*If we want to keep them alive, we need to get them to surrender. It’s their only chance.*

Adora stood and charged, knife poised in the air to strike. An image of Horde Prime conquering planets and slaughtering millions came at Catra. It was the same image she had glimpsed back in the infirmary. This time, all the faces of the victims had turned into Glimmer and Scorpia. Some were of Lonnie and Rogelio, too. One of them had Adora’s face, and that was when she made her decision.

“Stop!” Catra said, yelling as hard as she could. “Adora, stop!”

Adora didn't hesitate, but Taline glanced behind her at Catra's outburst and caught Adora in another magical hold before she could strike. Adora gasped and dropped the knife when Taline made a squeezing motion with her hand. The blade clattered to the ground and, for a terrible moment, Catra feared she had made the wrong choice…feared that Taline would squeeze the life out of her right then and there.

Instead, Taline made another gesture and Adora fell unconscious and limp in the air before dropping to the ground in a heap. Catra came up on Taline's left, pushing against the shockwaves of magic that still buffeted her from Taline and Micah's duel.

Micah bristled and reached out an arm in Adora's direction. A tendril of purple energy sprang forth and grabbed her, pulling her to safety behind the shield before Taline could do anything further. The shield flickered a moment as Micah concentrated on getting Adora to safety, and Catra shot Taline a look, watching to see how she'd react to this sudden weakness. Taline instead turned to her.

"We're out of options," she said, shouting to be heard over the crackling of magic. She shunted power into her rune, and another shield large enough to cover the both of them sprung up to intercept a sudden attack from Micah that would have hit Catra were it not for Taline's quick thinking. "Unless you can think of something else and quick, everything is about to come to an abrupt end. And not in your friends' favor, I'm afraid."

Catra's thoughts went to the plan she had been brewing in the back of her mind the moment she surveyed the battle. "Do you know where Glimmer is?" she asked, feeling sick for what she was about to do. "Can you get me to her?"

Another explosion rocked the floor and Shadow Weaver cackled. "The mage is almost down!" she said. "I can feel him draining! Keep protecting us, Micah. We're almost there!"

Taline grabbed Catra by the shoulders. "I can take you," she said. "But you have to be quick. If this isn't solved within the next few

minutes then I'm putting an end to it, personally."

She pulled her close and wrapped her in a tight hug. Catra felt as if something had hooked under her breastbone to pull, and everything faded to black.

Chapter End Notes

> What's Catra got up her sleeve this time? Is it going to be something smart? Something dumb? Y'all know she's capable of either, and sometimes both at the same time.
>
> If you want to check out one of World Eater's influences, go look up a one-shot titled "Looks like we're both alone now" by alettapegasus. Something about how they wrote Catra and Glimmer working through being locked together in a cell after the Season 4 finale resonated enough to drag me out of my fanfic writing retirement.
>
> World Eater is well and truly its own independent thing, but I like to think you'd be able to see the homage I've paid to it in my initial Catra & Glimmer-centric chapters. Them arguing about food, talking about Scorpia, Catra volunteering herself for interrogation about the Heart, those all started as seeds planted because of that one-shot. I'm still surprised I took it to the extremes and watered that seed into this ridiculous story.
>
> There are other inspirations too, of course, and I'll share them as we continue, but I wanted to start with this one. Credit where credit is due :) I doubt the author will read this, but if you do: thanks for inspiring me to start writing again.
>
> See you all next Thursday!

# Queen's Blade

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer screamed as she ran at Horde Prime, blade gripped tight in her hands. A thrill shot through her chest as she did—a mix of adrenaline and fear. The Emperor hadn't noticed her yet. He seemed preoccupied, observing the battle and commanding his forces from safety behind Salas' shield.

She leapt into the air, poised to strike, when Horde Prime turned and plucked her out of the air by the throat like an afterthought.

"You thought you could sneak up on me?" he asked, voice wild with rage. "I have three eyes on the right side of my head, girl. Three!"

He squeezed and Glimmer pounded against his forearm with her free hand for him to let go, coughing and hacking and choking for breath. Lessons Shadow Weaver had drilled into her over their short time together kicked into gear all on their own, and Glimmer pushed for calm in her mind amidst her panic. She had only seconds at most before Prime cut off enough blood to her head that she'd fall unconscious, and she spent those precious seconds trying to ground herself and feel the knife still held high in her other hand. She aimed the point toward the space where Prime's shoulder met his neck, and plunged down.

Prime caught her by the forearm with his other hand, and all attempts at concentrating fled her. She was going to die.

Her senses dulled like she was slipping into a peaceful sleep, but it was the pain jolting up her limb that kept her awake. Prime was squeezing the forearm he caught, *hard,* the glint in his eyes turning wilder still. Glimmer heard a snap. She cried out, her voice barely a raspy whisper straining against his hold on her throat. She dropped the knife the when her broken arm could no longer

make her hand grasp it. It clattered to the ground, a distant noise against the fog in her brain.

Glimmer forced her eyes to focus despite her tunnel vision growing tighter. Her arm bent in the center at an unnatural angle in Prime's grip, and looking at it sent a fresh jolt of pain shooting through it to her shoulder. She clawed at the arm holding her throat with her other hand, desperate to breathe, and when she finally looked Prime in the eye, it was as if she finally acknowledged who Prime was: a warlord who conquered a galaxy, slaughtering all in his path.

She realized then, finally, that she should never have attacked him. She should have just gone with Taline immediately to push for a surrender, and now everyone would die because she hadn't. Prime squeezed her throat harder still, and Glimmer wondered whether or not her neck would snap before she'd fall unconscious. Her grip on his hand weakened, her legs stopped kicking. It began to feel as if she were staring up at his cold eyes from the bottom of a very deep well.

And then she fell to the floor, coughing and hacking once more, clutching at her throat as she gasped deep raspy breaths. All her senses felt blown out, like they were compensating for having been muted earlier. When she glanced up, Prime was using his arms to shield himself from blaster fire. For a terrifying moment, Glimmer thought him invincible, since none of the blasts left any wounds or marks. But as he continued to take steps back to get away, she saw small markings appear about him like fireflies, intercepting the blaster bolts before they hit—he was wearing a personal shield, on top of what Salas was providing.

Narre came into view, taking confident steps forward as he assaulted the Emperor with bursts of fire from his rifle. The clone soldiers nearby turned to engage him and he pivoted, firing again and putting two, three, four, then five of them down on the ground with smoking holes in their chests. He whirled around to train his sights back on the Emperor, but he had taken advantage of Narre's momentary distraction to close the distance between

them. He knocked the rifle away with such force that it flew out of his grip and skittered along the ground.

Narre spun with the momentum and aimed a backhand at the Emperor's head. Horde Prime blocked, and Narre stepped forward and head-butted him. The Sentinel's helmet thudded against the Emperor's skull, but he didn't flinch and it was Narre instead who recoiled in pain. Prime surged forward and grabbed him by the shoulders, crimping his armor and lifting his feet off the ground as if he weighed almost nothing.

Narre gripped Horde Prime by the wrists and strained to force his hands apart. When that didn't seem to work, he head-butted him again, sending cracks rippling through his helmet and faceplate.

"You dare?" Prime seemed unfazed in his wrath. His tendrils uncoiled and hovered at the sides of Narre's helmet. "You dare join these…these lowlifes fighting in my own throne room? I will enjoy making an example out of all of you." The tendrils pierced through the armor, and Narre went rigid in Prime's grasp.

Glimmer screamed again. Miri's knife she had dropped earlier laid nearby and glinted at her again. It was as if it were calling out to her. She crawled toward it, careful to guard her broken arm against further injury, when a massive spike of black energy impaled Salas' shield around them. Hairline fractures snaked along the surface from the blow, and Glimmer watched several of Salas' mages fly backward with the blowback from the blast. Their bodies disintegrated inside their cloaks, fabric floating gently back to the ground. Salas himself stayed alive, but fell to his knees amid the strain of holding back Shadow Weaver's attacks.

Glimmer shook herself back to her senses and grabbed the knife. Narre continued to convulse nearby in Prime's grip. They were right there in front of her, and Prime looked even more distracted than before. She could get up close and thrust the knife into his leg, slash at his heels, drive it deep into the space between his legs, *something*. The clones weren't dragging her away like they

did when Prime tortured Catra, and she wasn't powerless in this situation any longer. She could help. She had to help.

"I can feel your thoughts," Prime said, a rictus grin spreading across his face as he spoke to Narre. "Miri is dead and the only thing you can think of is joining her and the rest of your squad. Let me do you a favor and send you to them!" He leaned in close and whispered at the side of the Sentinel's head. "And especially give my warm regards to Evelyn and Corynth."

Prime cackled and Narre released his grip on the Emperor. He threw his right arm out to the side and a serrated blade extended from his bracer. Narre slashed up and caught Prime's tendrils still latched to his head, severing them. Green liquid sprayed as the tendrils flailed about and Prime reeled, screaming. He made a fist in his agony and rammed it through Narre's stomach. That fist burst out the other side of the Sentinel, covered in blood, and Glimmer and Prime both screamed again, one in horror and the other in feral rage.

Narre stilled, and Prime turned to fix all four eyes on Glimmer, pulling his bloody hand from the man's body and dropping him to the floor with a thump. He advanced on her and she froze, her mind too caught up in fear to react.

Yet another explosion rocked the ground, and the cracks in Salas' shield deepened, before it shattered completely and disappeared in a burst of mist. Salas and a handful of his remaining mages flew backward and landed in an unconscious heap near the throne. Horde Prime stopped and glanced over at them in surprise, then up at the Rebellion across the room. Another beam of Shadow Weaver's magic streaked forth, flying over the small army of clones still sparring with Entrapta's bots. It beelined straight for him, now near defenseless without his mage advisor's magic shield.

A portal flashed into existence in front of him and disappeared almost as quickly as it had come. Taline stood in its place, steam dissipating off her body. She opened her arms to reveal Catra,

who she had carried through the portal with her. She pushed Catra out of harm's way with one hand, then thrust the other one forward in front of her.

Bright spider webs of energy erupted across Taline's body like lines on a circuit board. Shadow Weaver's beam of dark energy struck her bare palm instead of the Emperor and, unlike Salas, she stood firm with her feet planted in the ground, moving not even an inch backward as her uniform flailed behind her in the blowback. Taline then took a step forward *into* the magic and physically pushed against it. The beam reflected off her back toward the Rebellion, and it slammed into Micah's shield hard enough the floor rumbled again, forcing everyone on the battlefield aside from Taline to brace themselves once more to retain their footing.

Shadow Weaver's spell dissipated, and Taline took another step forward. She curled her outstretched hand into a fist and held it tight to her chest. Twelve orbs of blue energy crackled into in an upright circle before her, and bolts of lightning shot out from each of them, arcing and buffeting the Rebellion's shield in a continuous attack. Somewhere in the back of Glimmer's mind she realized Taline had done all this without relying on any of the magic runes she had seen Salas and even her father employ thus far.

"Go!" Taline said without looking away. "You have until I break their shield to figure something out."

Glimmer wasn't certain to whom she was speaking, but Catra—who had stood nearby and stared at Taline's display of power in awe much like Glimmer had—startled and hurried over to her.

"Come on Sparkles, on your feet," she said as she wrapped her arm around Glimmer and helped her stand.

Glimmer didn't fight her. Together the two of them stumbled away from the Emperor and, to Glimmer's relief, toward the Rebellion—toward her friends. Toward her father. Catra looked at her with

concern as they limped together, obviously trying to assess her. Her eyes darted from Glimmer's broken arm to her other hand, the one that still held Miri's knife in a white-knuckled grip.

"I couldn't do anything," Glimmer said, trying to keep the images of blood and death from overwhelming her. "I was right there, and Prime was distracted. If I had just moved…if I had just done something, maybe he wouldn't have…"

Her throat constricted with emotion and she couldn't finish her sentence. Catra's eyes narrowed at her, as if she had made a decision or came to a realization about something. She pulled Glimmer quickly off to the side and behind one of the metal barriers.

"We don't have much time to save everyone," Catra said, speaking rapidly and cutting Glimmer off before she could ask what she was doing. "I know this is going to sound crazy, but I need your help getting everyone to surrender."

"It's too late for that." Glimmer said. "They've attacked him in his throne room. He said he was going to make an example of everyone, Catra. They're all going to die because I couldn't—"

"Would you just shut up for two seconds and let me finish?" Catra said, shaking her. "You heard Taline. We don't have much time and if we're going to do something, it has to be now before your dad's spell breaks. Did you see how she just threw Shadow Weaver's attack back at them? He's not going to last long."

Glimmer hyperventilated. Everyone was going to die. Everyone was going to die *and it was all her fault*. If she had just moved, if she had just attacked Prime while he was distracted, then they could have ended all this.

"Glimmer, listen to me." Catra clapped her gently on the side of her head, squishing her cheeks together between her palms and forcing her to focus. "She can bring your mom back!"

That brought everything in Glimmer's head to a screeching halt. "What did you just say?" she asked, focused at last. Catra had never called her by her real name before, and seeing the look of determination in her eyes reminded her that Catra had once been a proud and determined Horde Commander.

"We can get Angella back," Catra said. "She's not dead. Taline can bring her back, but none of that is going to matter if she kills everybody before they surrender. We can't hash this all out right now, but I already have a plan and I need your help."

"I…I don't—"

"Catra squeezed her harder and shook her head. "Look, I know this is probably too much to ask given our history, but we literally don't have any more time. I need you to trust me. Please?"

Glimmer narrowed her eyes at her. Trust Catra? It was true that their relationship had…evolved since getting captured, but to go so far as to blindly trust her and Taline? But what choice did she have? It was either put her trust in Catra, or everyone was going to die. And if they could bring her mom back too…?

Glimmer pushed all reasoning out her head and focused on Catra's eyes. "What do you need me to do?" she asked, praying she wasn't going to regret her choice.

Catra smiled, relief plain on her face. "Hand me that knife, and follow my lead."

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Adora groaned and pushed up into a kneeling position, making sure to pick up the dagger laying nearby as she went. When had she dropped it? Her head pounded and everything looked blurry, but soon enough she got back on her feet. When had she fallen unconscious? What happened?

"Adora, you're okay," Micah said, breathing a sigh of relief through the strain in his voice as he shunted more magic power into the

shield covering them. Shadow Weaver didn't speak, likely preoccupied trying to bust through the other Horde mage's shield.

"Alive, but far from okay I think," Adora said, dusting off her legs and shoulders and breastplate.

"I'll take it," Micah said. "That sorceress with Catra, she disappeared and took over for the other mage as soon as Shadow Weaver brought him down."

Adora looked and really studied Shadow Weaver now—watched her straining to push her magic against Taline in the distance while Micah defended against the forks of lightning she sent back.

"If she's now over there," Adora said, scanning the room and trying to piece together what had happened, "then did you see where Catra went? She was just behind me, so she couldn't have gotten far." Adora remembered Catra calling out to her, likely trying to warn her before Taline turned on her and…did whatever she did to her.

Micah frowned, sweat running down his face in beads. "I think Catra tipped her off that you were coming."

Adora shook her head, fighting the chill that crept into her mind when she heard that. "N-no, no that can't be it. I got through to her…she was going to help me. I could have sworn she was trying to warn me about something."

"She called out to you and that woman turned around and caught you before you could attack. I only just barely pulled you to safety when you fell unconscious, then she grabbed Catra and they both teleported away." Micah gave her a sympathetic look despite the tension in his face. "I'm sorry, Adora. I don't think she was trying to help."

"She's too strong," Shadow Weaver said, straining. "She redirected my attack at us and is now tearing the shield apart. There's nothing I can do to get through—her defense is maddening."

Adora looked around at the battlefield again, both to assess the situation and to see if maybe she could spot Catra among the chaos. The scattered parts of Entrapta's purple bots littered the field, and the clone forces still between them and the throne stood idle, all of them content to watch, none of them taking cover. It was as if they thought they had already won the fight.

It wasn't until she thought about it that Adora realized they were conserving ammunition, likely until Micah's shield went down. Their predicament all of a sudden felt much more dire. They couldn't actually be *losing*, could they?

Micah's shield started to crack, and she moved to support him from behind when he started to slide backward.

"I can handle it!" he said between grit teeth. Then he repeated himself, a little softer and with more confidence. "I can handle it. This plan we came up with is dead in the water. We'll have to go with the backup. Shadow Weaver and I will continue to distract the sorceress while you take your shot. Do you still have that sidearm?"

"I've still got it," Adora said, pulling a small blaster out from where she had stashed it inside her breastplate and checking to make sure it was still charged.

"I know you really didn't want to have to use it," Micah said, "but we're really out of options here. Taking Horde Prime alive was always a best-case scenario. I just hope your aim is sharp—you'll likely only get one shot."

"Adora hefted the blaster in her hand to test the weight after moving her knife into her off hand. "One between the eyes, right? I think I can manage that."

Micah nodded, then extended an arm in Taline's direction. "You ready, Shadow Weaver?" At her acknowledgement, he formed another rune in his palm while still maintaining the shield. Taline's lightning cracked and arced around it, sending deeper cracks into

its surface. Adora was frankly impressed at how powerful he was, able to maintain such a strong defense while coordinating an attack with a second person.

A beam of purple energy shot forth from Micah's hand, catching and disintegrating several dozen clones before they scrambled back behind cover. That beam intertwined with a fresh beam of dark magic from Shadow Weaver, and the combined attack slammed against a defensive rune Taline threw up at the last minute, before dissipating.

"That did something," Shadow Weaver said. "We'll do it again, but stronger. Blast her with everything we have, and you take the shot at Horde Prime immediately after, Adora. If we monopolize her defense, even for a moment, that will give you the opening you need. Just make sure you're ready to—"

"Wait!" Adora said, heart leaping into her throat at what she glimpsed in the distance.

Micah, face creased and red from exertion, glanced about. "What? What is it?"

Shadow Weaver must have picked up on what Adora had noticed, because she touched his knee, pointed a shaking finger down range, and said, "look over there."

Glimmer and Catra were supporting each other, limping toward them as quickly as they could between cover at the perimeter of the room. Glimmer held one, oddly bent arm close to her body, while Catra looked unsteady on her feet and ready to throw up.

Micah called out to them, and Shadow Weaver sent and a small amount of her black energy to him through her touch. The tension in his face lessened, and several of the cracks in their shield around them sealed up. She was helping support him with her own magic. Glimmer limped toward them faster at hearing Micah's voice, and Catra did her best to keep up.

Adora's heart swelled at seeing them, especially Catra. She just knew Catra wasn't against them. Whatever happened up here on the citadel had shaken her enough that Adora was able to get through to her for once. Who knew it'd only take the threat of impending doom from an extraterrestrial conqueror to get them on the same side again? Whatever. She'd take it. Just as long as she could have her friend back—both her friends back.

"Okay, new plan," Adora said. "Those two get in here safely, and then we do this. We'll have to grab Bow and the others in the fallout, and it'll be easier if Glimmer and Catra are inside the shield while we do. Don't want to corral more people than absolutely necessary when all this goes down."

Micah nodded. "Good idea. That one's powerful" he said, referring to Taline still raining magic electricity down upon them, "but I think we can hold her a little longer. Right, Shadow Weaver?"

"Do I really have a say in the matter?" she asked.

Adora almost laughed at the irony in Shadow Weaver's voice when she saw Catra, not even a half dozen steps away, push Glimmer in front of a wall of upturned metal and press a knife against her throat.

"Surrender Adora!" she said. "Surrender or Sparkles here dies!"

"What?" Adora's jaw hinged open in disbelief. She couldn't believe what she was seeing.

"I swear to god Adora, surrender now!" Catra pressed the knife harder against Glimmer's throat, and a thin line of blood started to trickle down and stain her shirt. Glimmer pulled back to edge away from the blade and whimpered.

"I don't—" Adora's mind raced. What the hell was Catra doing? Was she really…she couldn't really be…

The shield flickered. Adora glanced to her left and saw Micah, eyes wide in shock, reaching toward Glimmer like he had back at

Bright Moon: as if he were trying to physically grab her and pull her out of harm's way.

The shield flickered again.

*No.*

"Micah," Shadow Weaver said, a warning clear in her voice.

*No. This couldn't be happening.*

"Surrender now Adora! Do it!"

*This wasn't happening. They were about to lose everything because of her.*

She heard Catra sob. "God damn it Adora, please!"

"Micah!" Shadow Weaver squeezed the King's knee. "Micah, you have to concentrate. If you don't—"

The shield broke. A deluge of clones poured out from behind cover and pointed their rifles at their now defenseless group.

"They surrender!" Catra said, dropping her knife and grabbing her hair by the fistful. "Oh my fucking god, they surrender."

A high-pitched whine, the sound of hundreds of beam rifles powering up to fire, careened around the room, and Adora saw her life flash before her eyes.

Taline blinked into existence inches in front of her, eyes glowing neon blue. She thrust one hand behind her and caught Micah and Shadow Weaver in some sort of stasis spell. Adora took a step back and raised her blaster, only for it to immediately get ripped out of her hands and tossed aside. She tried to raise the knife next, and Taline stepped closer into her space, snatching Adora's wrist like a viper.

"Drop the knife," she said, voice low.

"I—"

"Don't make your friends watch me kill you." For some reason, her voice sounded desperate rather than dangerous. "You've lost, Adora. Drop the knife and surrender. Please."

Adora swallowed and glanced over at the terrified look on Glimmer's face and was surprised to see it mirrored on Catra's expression as well. Why did *she* look concerned now of all times? After what she did?

Adora dropped the knife, defeated, and heard it clatter to the ground.

"Lower your weapons!" Taline said, shouting over her shoulder. 'They've surrendered."

The clones complied, then a group splintered off and surged forward to grab them. They weren't gentle with any of them, least of all Adora. They kicked her to her knees and forced her hands behind her back to shackle her wrists together.

"Don't cuff her!" she heard Catra yell in the distance. "Don't! Her arm, it's—"

Glimmer screamed and Adora seethed, fighting against the clones restraining her. One punched her in the face and she saw stars.

Taline gave them all a pitying look as the clones rounded up the rest of them. Soon, Bow, Lonnie, Rogelio, and Scorpia, all unconscious but thankfully alive despite their injuries, lay with them. Glimmer, shaking and pale with her busted arm bent at an even worse angle than before to fit into the cuffs, sat with her back to Catra, who had turned a sickening shade of pale green.

When the clones finished rounding them all up, they parted and Horde Prime stepped through. Two thick, truncated tentacles hung limp from his head, staining his shoulders green. He looked them over with eyes of steel.

“Execute them all,” he said.

The clones again aimed their blasters at them, and Taline physically stepped between them as a shield.

“My Lord, they are contained,” she said. “There is no reason to kill them.”

Horde Prime cocked an eyebrow and took a step toward her, every twitch of his body broadcasting danger. “No reason to kill them? They attacked me in my throne room.”

“They have surrendered, sir. We need them to research the Heart.”

“They have attacked me, Taline. *In my throne room*.”

“Lord Prime, please. I beg you once more to listen to reas—“

Horde Prime backhanded her across the face hard enough a deafening *crack* resounded off the walls. Taline stumbled several steps to the side, and Adora saw blood streak the floor.

“You do not speak to me of reason after what these rebels have done.” Prime said, voice shrill with hysteria. “To say nothing of your Sentinel who mutilated me.” He spat at the ground, “Traitorous blood runs in your veins, Taline. No, you do not speak to me of anything.” He turned and roared at the clones. “Kill them all! Kill them now!”

Another whine of hundreds of rifles powering up. Adora squeezed her eyes shut, but not before seeing Taline, four bloody gashes marring the side of her face, reach into her jacket and yank out a red crystal. She squeezed until it shattered in her hand.

Everything went white.

Chapter End Notes

Okay, so maybe this is the third cliffhanger in a row I've left you guys on, but the battle sequence would have been like 15k words otherwise and I really needed to split. Adora's gamble in space with the Emperor will resolve with the next chapter, and then we get to move forward into even *more* fun things :D

Not much else to say other than I hope you enjoyed! See you next Thursday

# A Deal with the Devil

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora woke standing atop a hill. A breeze caressed her cheek, ran through her hair, and made the leaves and branches in the far away trees rustle and dance. Large, four-legged animals with spotted hides lumbered in the distance, occasionally dipping wide heads levered by thick necks to graze at the grass underfoot.

"Hello?" she asked, speaking aloud what she assumed would come out as only a thought in her mind. "Anyone there?"

Someone chuckled behind her and she turned. A tall woman garbed in white and gold stood before her, shoulders shaking with laughter.

"Hello Adora," She Ra said. "Do you recognize me?"

Adora blinked. "She Ra? Of course I recognize you. How could I not?" She frowned. "Am I dead?"

She Ra's eyes shaded with sadness. "No. No, you aren't dead. I'm protecting you from a memory right now, actually."

Adora frowned. "You're protecting me…from a memory?"

"Yes. It's quite an unpleasant one, really. Even with death, there are much better ways to have gone than what this person experienced. Unfortunately, while I can protect you from the memory itself, I can't protect you from what killed her. Not fully, and not for much longer anyways."

"I…I don't understand."

She Ra narrowed her eyes at Adora, and her entire demeanor shifted. "Well, I guess that puts us on an even playing field then,

doesn't it?" she asked. "Because I don't understand either. Why did you choose to forsake myself and the sword, Adora? Why did you destroy it?"

Adora felt like she had been slapped. "Fors—…I didn't forsake anything. The Heart was going to destroy the entire planet. Light Hope was going to force me, I had no choice but to—"

"No choice but to what?" She Ra asked. "Someone else was going to force you to use your sword? Your power? And you decided the best course of action was to break the sword turn your back on that power altogether?"

"Yes…no, wait. That's not fair. That's…" Adora frowned, suddenly unsure. She huffed, feeling attacked. "I didn't just turn my back on it. What would you have had me do instead? Let the planet explode?"

"I would have had you control the power," She Ra said, emphasizing her words. "I would have had you think to your friends and those you love. I would have had you dig deep and refuse to let it be used without your consent, not turn your back on it altogether because it overwhelmed you. You have forsaken me, Adora. You are not the person I thought you were."

"I wasn't about to be some pawn in the First One's schemes! You think I turned my back on you, fine. We can agree to disagree on that." Adora crossed her arms. "I refuse to power the Heart of Etheria. I refuse to be their weapon, and if that means I've 'forsaken' you and my powers, then so be it."

"Do you even know what that weapon is destined for?"

"It doesn't matter what it's destined for," Adora said, jutting her chin out. "If it's powerful enough to destroy Etheria then it's powerful enough to destroy other planets, kill trillions. I don't want anything to do with it. I will not be responsible for genocide."

“Foolish girl, it does not matter what the weapon can do, it only matters what you choose to do with it! I am far older than the First Ones, and so is the enemy that I—that we—are destined to face.” She took a step toward Adora. “Mara, in her ignorance, nearly cost us everything stranding the planet. And now you, when confronted with the notion that there is more to the Heart than you are aware of, wish to push your head further into the sand and stand behind a flimsy moral argument you made up with less than half the facts to begin with?”

She Ra seemed to have grown taller in her rage, and Adora flinched at how sudden it had come. Thunder rumbled in the distance and the landscape grew dark as black clouds rolled across the sky. Adora cleared her throat and tried to keep calm. This wasn’t how she thought this conversation would play out, not that she thought it would have come at all in the first place.

“Enemy?” she asked. “You’re not talking about the Horde, are you?” Those words made even less sense when she spoke them than they did in her head, and she couldn’t escape the feeling she was just grasping at straws to say anything back.

“The Horde is part of the reason there is still a galaxy left to save at all,” She Ra said. Some of the tension left her face, until she looked more sad than angry. “I only hope there is enough time.”

“I don’t understand,” Adora said, shaking her head. “Enough time for what? What enemy? Please, tell me what’s going on.”

A heavy presence blanketed the area, like something sinister was trying to smother them. She Ra’s face turned frantic. She took another step forward. “It’s found us. My magic can last only so long without your cooperation. It was only a matter of time.”

She took another step forward, reaching, and instinct forced Adora a step back.

“Tell me what’s going on.” Adora said. None of this felt right.

“Be brave. Remember, your friends believe in you and so do I, even after everything.” A mental image of Bow, Glimmer, Angella, Micah, the princesses—everyone, flashed in front of her eyes as She Ra took another faltering step forward. “I will still be with you.”

She disappeared, and Adora finally realized how dark it had become. The clouds had been letting up when she last paid attention, but now it was practically pitch black.

“She Ra?” Adora said, looking around. “Where did you go? Where am I?” Fear nearly paralyzed her when she reached out with both hands to feel about and couldn’t see them. How could it have gotten so dark she couldn’t see her own hands, groping about in front of her face?

“Hey Adora,” said a voice behind her.

Adora whirled and saw two eyes, one blue and one yellow, staring back at her. “Catra?”

“Who else would it be?” Catra asked.

Adora frowned. Her voice didn’t sound quite right. “What are you doing here? And where is ‘here’, exactly?” She looked around once more and still couldn’t make anything out except Catra’s eyes.

“You don’t know?” Catra asked. “You should have listened.”

“Should have listened to what?” She blinked, hoping that would help her eyes adjust. “Of course I don’t know where we are. I can’t see anything.”

Lightning struck high in the sky and illuminated their surroundings. Adora gasped, finally realizing what about Catra’s voice just seemed off: a dark void had swallowed the right half of her face and body. She looked as she had when she first chased Adora through the portal world.

"You should have listened when Light Hope told you to forget about me," Catra said. "You should have listened when she told you to let go."

Adora took a step back. "Catra, what are you—"

"You should have *listened,* Adora. I'm a distraction. I throw you off, make you second guess yourself." Another crack of lightning spouted overhead and illuminated her in time for Adora to see her snap forward and grab her wrist.

"Why are you saying these things?" Adora tried to pull away, but Catra held firm. Somewhere in the back of her mind, she felt she was forgetting something important. It hit her the next moment, and she successfully yanked her arm away with a snarl. "You threatened Glimmer. We were going to take the Emperor down, but were waiting for the both of you."

"There we go," Catra said. Another flash of lightning illuminated the grin spread across her face.

"You forced our hand….we had to surrender. What the hell happened, Catra? You still went ahead and chose to help the Emperor after he kept you hostage up on the citadel? I saw what you looked like in that cell, you looked miserable." Tears stung Adora's eyes and she blinked them away. "What did he tell you to get you on his side? I thought we finally found common ground. I thought…I thought…"

"You thought what? That we'd be on the same side and fight together again? After you berated me and called me stupid?"

Adora opened her mouth just to close it without saying a word, her response already dead before it left her lips. She recalled Catra's words from their argument in the throne room, and they gave new meaning to She Ra's warning from earlier.

*Taline isn't here to conquer the planet, she's here to help. There's some sort of…enemy the Empire is fighting against and Prime needs her help fighting it. Etheria, the Heart…they need it.*

The enemy Taline had mentioned to Catra…the one Adora so brazenly mocked her for believing…could that be…?

"It doesn't matter," Catra said, pulling Adora out of her thoughts. "Like I said, I'm a distraction. I make you second guess yourself. I hurt you."

Adora shook her head. "Catra, no. I shouldn't have dismissed you like that back in the throne room, I just—"

"How much more control over your powers would you have had if you didn't spend half your time in the Rebellion trying to hedge against me?"

Adora gaped at her. "I…I don't—"

"Do you think you would have had enough control to stop the Heart from firing prematurely instead of having to shatter the sword?"

"I don't know," Adora said, finally confident in at least one answer.

Another flash of lighting. This time it hung in the air as if frozen in time, illuminating their surroundings in harsh white light. Adora glanced about and couldn't help the second gasp that tore free when she finally saw what was around them.

The surrounding greenery and trees and grazing animals had gone. In their place, lay a wasteland: dead, dry grass dotted the landscape, scattered among piles of bones as tall as people. A ruined playground lay at the bottom of the hill, rust and mold eating away at the fixtures. A city skyline loomed in the distance, the holes and chunks missing from dilapidated skyscraper husks telling her that everyone in that once gleaming, sprawling metropolis was long dead.

"What is this?" Adora clapped her hand to her mouth and felt tears trickle down her face.

"This is you, Adora," Catra said. "This is what happens when you say 'I don't know' to the things you should know, just like you should have known to listen to Light Hope when she told you to let me go. You would have seen this coming you know? If you weren't so fixated on me."

Adora turned to Catra. "This can't be right. This isn't real. There are no cities like this on Etheria, this hasn't happened yet."

Catra gave a small, sad smile and glanced away. "Always the optimist, aren't you? Did you already forget we aren't in Despondos anymore? We're in the wider galaxy now, Adora. Well…*a* galaxy. One of many. This has already happened, on a world very far away. You were too late to stop it."

Adora felt like she battled for every breath with the way her chest constricted. "How do you know all of this? This isn't you."

Catra looked back at her and quirked her eyebrow, as if confused by the question. "Look to the stars and you'll see it too. You'll see exactly what I see."

Adora looked up. The lightning bolt still hung frozen in the sky. "I can't see anything. It's too bright, and the clouds are in the way."

"Not those stars, idiot. *Look at me*."

Adora looked back at Catra, not at all sure what she was trying to get at, when she saw small pinpricks of light emanating from the void-kissed parts of her body. "Is that…are those stars?" she asked, leaning in closer to get a better look.

And then she fell.

Fell through the void into the vastness of space, spinning and twirling, feeling like a log thrashed about and carried downstream in a whitewater torrent. She screwed her eyes shut, casting silent prayers in her mind for everything to just, for once, start making sense again. The vertigo pulling her in seemingly ten directions at once finally subsided, and she opened her eyes, this time looking

at a beautiful, rotating universe that stretched out infinitely in front of her.

Adora saw everything. It was as if the atoms of creation itself were her eyes and ears. She saw the lumbering beasts from earlier, grazing atop the surface of the planet before its demise. She saw that planet hugging its central star in a tight orbit as part of a larger solar system, and saw that solar system following trillions of other systems as they rocketed a roughly elliptical orbit around the greater turn of one of the galaxy's arms. And from there, she saw trillions upon trillions of other galaxies, just like that one, expanding ever outward. Some collided with one another in a majestic cosmic dance, while others at the outer fringes of reality were growing dim, then finally snuffing out like a candle at the end of its wax.

She saw countless people, dead. Bodies piled higher than castle parapets, children without their parents and parents missing their children. The balance of life in this reality had tipped. It overwhelmed her for a moment, witnessing all these things, before a strange peace blanketed her. She realized then that she had already felt and seen this all before, every time she transformed into She Ra. Only, she had always experienced it as a filtered, concentrated force back then. This felt raw and unfiltered. Amazing.

A small cluster of stars in the center of one of the galaxies flickered and went dark. That darkness spread, rapidly, until the galaxy itself ceased to exist, and Adora frowned.

*That isn't supposed to happen yet*, a thought told her. *Not for a world so young.*

Scattered pockets of light in another nearby galaxy flickered and dimmed. Those pockets grew and collided with one another until, like a cancer, nothingness engulfed more than a third of that galaxy's stars.

Adora felt a chill at seeing that, and she peered closer.

All the stars surrounding her blinked out of existence at once like she had suddenly fallen head first into a black hole. Her unease from earlier grew into unrestrained terror. She couldn't tell up from down or left from right. There were no stars, no nebulae, nothing to orient her. She couldn't tell if she was spinning and hurtling through space or if she had stagnated and stilled in the void.

And then she felt it: a presence, a distinct entity, separate from the vast nothingness, full of malice and anger and hostility. A great face appeared in the darkness and fixed its eyes on her. And when it spoke, it was as if the cosmic background radiation of reality itself had been given voice, projecting a stream of blown out white-noise directly into her head.

*HELLO ADORA.*

She gasped, and ragged sobs tore from her throat when she fell, again. Her palms were chained together, and they hit something cold and hard—a floor. She wasn't in the void anymore. She was back in ruins of Horde Prime's throne room, although when she had come back and for how long she had been away, she couldn't tell.

Her friends were still there with her too, including Catra, who no longer seemed to be consumed by the blackness as she had been earlier. All of them sat nearby with hands still bound together. It seemed no time at all had passed, but the image of that…thing still burned in her mind and its voice continued to echo in her ears, a reminder that what she had seen hadn't at all been just a dream.

Taline stood off to the side, trembling. Blood poured out of the gashes in her cheek, staining her uniform and dripping to the floor. Horde Prime approached her with a somber expression, and Taline immediately dropped to both knees in front of him.

"What have you done?" Prime asked. "Did you just…" his voice trailed off. Adora couldn't shake how strange it felt seeing

someone like the Emperor at such a loss for words.

“No, my Lord,” Taline said, shaking her head and keeping her eyes trained to a spot next to Prime’s feet. “It was only a memory.”

“Whose memory?”

Taline didn’t immediately answer, and he repeated himself with more force. She still did not speak, but her shoulders began to shake and Prime must have inferred the answer, because he grew enraged.

“I ordered her forgotten,” he said. “The mere mention of her name is forbidden. You dare defy me by subjecting my court and I to the memories of a damned woman?”

“She gave her life with the rest of them at Corynth’s command.” Taline’s voice was hoarse with emotion. “She helped stem the tide for as long as possible, but the Barrier is failing and the Beast is coming through once more. We need the weapon, and if it is indeed true that we need all the princesses alive for it to work, then we cannot risk killing them.”

Taline finally looked up, and she raised a shaky fist toward the Emperor as if presenting an offering. Slowly, she uncurled her fingers, revealing a dull red crystal, cracks and fissures running across its facets.

“She is gone, Lord Prime. Those memories were the last thing of hers that existed in this world, siphoned from her body before it was burned. Even still, the mere memory of the Beast is strong enough to transcend time and space and speak to us as if it were really there. Can we really afford to carelessly throw away lives if this is what we are to fight?”

Horde Prime reached out and plucked the crystal from Taline’s hand. He looked down at it as if it were an egg about to hatch a creature that would attack him.

“Please, my Lord,” Taline said. “I know it won’t be enough to pay for their transgressions, but punish me in their place. I will relinquish my claim on this planet when a suitable replacement is agreed upon, and I will openly accept whatever punishment you deem necessary in their stead. Just please…spare them so we may research the weapon. I beg you.”

Adora saw movement off to the side and looked. Catra sat there next to a pale and unconscious Glimmer, mouth open and eyes wide in unblinking surprise. She looked on the verge of saying something.

Anger welled in Adora’s chest, then. She wanted to yell at her and taunt her for having such a brazen reaction about someone who, moments ago, threatened to kill them all if she didn’t surrender. Instead, she kept quiet and simmered in her fury. Catra closed her mouth and averted her eyes in…was that shame?

*You are so overwhelmed with emotion you can’t even speak?* Adora thought. *That’s never stopped you before. Where’re the smart quips now? The incessant, smug comments about everything and anything? Where’d they go, Catra?*

Adora stopped herself and looked away, suddenly feeling shameful. She had never felt this angry before—not about anything and especially not toward Catra, even after the portal incident. The rage and pent-up hurt scared her almost as much as that creature in the void had.

Prime laughed, still standing over Taline. “Even after all these years you are still mocking me,” he said, speaking to the crystal as he studied it. He squeezed it in his hand until it shattered into a fine dust, then turned his palm to the side and let the pieces tumble to the floor. “Take them to their cells,” he said to his clones before turning to look Taline in the eye. “I believe you and I have some negotiating to do.”

The clones started grabbing people and dragging them off. No one struggled. They came for Adora last, and when she turned to look

at Taline, still on both knees as the clones dragged her past, she saw how utterly broken the other woman looked. Tears mixed with the blood on the floor, and Taline gathered as many broken pieces of crystal as she could in her trembling hands, all while Prime looked on.

Chapter End Notes

11 chapters and ~44k words in and we finally get a glimpse of what the major opposing force is. Horde Prime, as menacing and cool as he may be, is the level one antagonist. That "slow build" tag is there for a reason!

Also, canon Season 5 Adora had the patience and forgiveness of a saint. My take on Adora in this story will have her find her line and set her boundaries a little higher and sooner. But again, the relationship tags (both Catra/Adora and Bow/Glimmer) and "slow burn" tag are also there for a reason ;) They are some of the only tags that will not change as the story progresses.

Anyone catch the Terry Pratchett reference in this chapter?

# Ties that Bind

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer stared out a window of one of Bright Moon's guest rooms and watched Enclave and Etherian laborers work in the sun. Four days had passed since the Rebellion had returned to the planet's surface, and a whole two weeks since the citadel had been invaded. Horde Prime had taken his armada and abandoned Etheria altogether after a lengthy stint of negotiation. Glimmer hadn't been present for it, but the result was acceptable nonetheless: Horde Prime had left only one member of his retinue behind.

She found him walking among the workers, occasionally referencing a large tablet held in his left hand, occasionally speaking with Adora and Micah who walked with him as they inspected the work. Salas had taken over organizing and leading the Enclave's efforts to help Etheria rebuild.

"It's still weird to see him walking around helping like that," Catra said, standing to her left and looking out at the same view. "He was defending Horde Prime and fighting Shadow Weaver and your dad not all that long ago."

Glimmer caught the hesitation in Catra's words at her mention of Shadow Weaver. No one had seen her since the clones dragged them off to individual cells, and they had only recently found out Prime had taken her with him when he left.

"Taline told you its thanks to him you aren't brain damaged, right?" Glimmer asked. "Apparently he linked our minds to give you something to hold onto when the Emperor probed you, and then used himself as an anchor after I was taken away."

"She told me," Catra said with a grimace and a nod. "He's also the one who apparently pushed the medical team to come check on

us when you first got sick, after he saw me screaming at the surveillance cameras. And I guess he's the one who urged Taline herself to come check on me as soon as she arrived."

"Taline had one of her Sentinels bring you to the infirmary, yeah," Glimmer said. "But I didn't know it was Salas who had her go to us first thing." Her dad broke out in laughter down below at something Salas had whispered to him and Glimmer frowned. "He's certainly more on our side than I expected. I'm surprised Taline got Horde Prime to back off as much as he did, leaving just him behind."

"Me too," Catra said.

Her father's laughter grew stronger and he started nudging Adora with his elbow. When her shoulders visibly relaxed, Catra's tighten as if in direct response.

"Even Adora is playing nice with him," Catra said, putting her hands on the windowsill and gripping them hard enough her nails scratched the stone there.

"Have you talked to her yet?"

Catra tensed and Glimmer feared she had pushed their newfound comfortability around each other too far. "Not yet," she said after a pause. "Every time I work up the courage to go to her, she gets dragged off to help with some other thing. It's like she always has to be doing something. Can't sit still for a second, and the universe conspires to help her with that at my expense."

Glimmer "hmm'd"

"That's Adora for you," Catra said, after giving a wry laugh. "Always running off to play the hero. Always—" she cut off, holding the tension in her shoulders for a beat before releasing it with an exhale and speaking in a more subdued tone. "No. I haven't gotten the chance to talk to her yet."

Glimmer nodded, content to let those words just hang between them. Catra had grown less skittish with time, opening up about things Glimmer didn't think her open to discussing in the first place. It surprised her, and that surprise compounded when she realized she was open to reciprocating.

"I haven't gotten the chance to speak with her either yet," Glimmer said. "Or Bow. Not really."

"Seriously?" Catra turned to her with an open expression of shock. "So many people have come to see you, all squealing in happiness that you're back, but not Arrow Boy or Adora?"

Glimmer gave a rueful laugh and pulled her broken arm closer against her body in its sling. It was true that everyone from Frosta to Scorpia and even Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio—who had all miraculously made it out alive after taking blaster fire directly to their armor—had come to express absolute joy that she was back safe and sound. Salas and the rest of the princesses practically had to pull her dad away from her to help with the relief efforts because he didn't want to leave her side. But Bow and Adora?

"Not Adora, but I have talked to Bow," Glimmer said.

Both Catra's eyebrows shot up when she heard the uncertainty in Glimmer's voice. "And?"

"But we didn't *talk* talk…if you get what I mean." Glimmer sighed. "He's just as busy as Adora with the reconstruction. Our 'talk', if you could even call it that, was…frostier than I hoped it'd be. I tried to apologize…he didn't want to hear it."

A long silence curled around them. Catra's expression cycled out the corner of Glimmer's eye—poor girl was trying to wrack her mind for words to say.

"Maybe once things settle down, he'll be more open," she said at last. "Probably just needs to process still, y'know?"

“Yeah. Maybe.” Glimmer’s lips tugged up into a smirk despite the mood; she’d never imagined Catra of all people would try to comfort her, let alone that it might actually work. She swallowed and let the thought pass. “How do you like it in Bright Moon so far?” she asked.

Catra shrugged. ”S’fine, I guess.”

Glimmer scoffed and rolled her eyes. “Just fine? You do realize you’re not a prisoner here, right? Neither of us are on the citadel any more. You can wander and go find all the hidden spots in the castle I haven’t come across even after living here for twenty years. Do the kitchens not beckon to you with promises of food you never got to eat in the Horde? If all you can say is ‘it’s fine’ then you, Ma’am, haven’t taken advantage of all your freedoms here yet.”

Catra had the decency to at least smile at her attempt at levity. “Honestly? I don’t really feel welcome here after everything I’ve done,” Catra said, not taking her eye away from the window. “It’s got nothing to do with you…it’s just me. Aside from Taline, who’s been locked up in the war room with Entrapta since we got here, I’m not really getting my hopes up for any visitors.”

“Catra…”

“I’m doing okay so far,” she said. “Really. Not good, not bad. Just okay, which is a hell of a lot better than either of us have been in a while.”

Glimmer couldn’t argue with that, although she did freeze at the mention of Taline and Entrapta working together. Catra hadn’t been joking when she said they could bring her mother back. It was the first thing Taline dragged Entrapta off to work on when Horde Prime finally left them alone. Catra had probably glossed over that topic on purpose, maybe to afford her the same respectful distance Glimmer had granted her by not delving into Shadow Weaver when she was brought up. But Glimmer decided it was worth delving into if it meant another opportunity for them

to bond a little more. What could she say? Her time aboard the Citadel had endeared Catra to her, and she wasn't too proud to push for a deeper friendship.

"I went down there myself a few hours ago," Glimmer said. "They've really been working non-stop since they arrived. Thank god for the windows because the smell alone tells me they haven't left once, not even to shower."

Catra laughed. "Did they say when they might be ready?"

"Tomorrow, actually," Glimmer said. "If everything keeps going smoothly. Entrapta was strangely excited about it because Taline apparently has something planned for her afterward. You don't happen to know what that is, do you?"

"No idea whatsoever," Catra said, her tone implying the exact opposite. She was the only one to have attended Taline's negotiations with Prime and, although she refused to disclose exactly what had happened, the rumor was that Catra had played an important part in winning some key concessions from the Emperor.

"Fine," Glimmer said with a laugh and a roll of her eyes. "Keep your secrets. If it's half as amazing as bringing my mom back, then I'm sure it's something special."

A comfortable silence extended between them for a few moments. Adora, Micah, and Salas had long since disappeared from view, but they continued to watch the day's reconstruction work until Glimmer spoke again.

"You said you weren't expecting any visitors other than maybe Taline." She knew she was easing into a touchy subject. "Why is that?"

"I dunno."

Glimmer cocked an eyebrow and chose to wait her out. Catra had a lot more to say and just didn't know how to say it, she knew

that much.

Catra gripped the stone windowsill again like she'd float away if she weren't careful. "I guess…I guess it felt nice?" she said. "She wasn't exactly gentle or cautious when she came to see me in the infirmary. She kinda just walked up and stuck a needle in my arm while I was having a panic attack. That sounds bad now that I say it out loud, but…I don't know." She huffed. "She was so calm when she explained everything to me, said everything she was going to do and everything that was going to happen. It was like, even though she wasn't giving me a choice in things, I could trust that she was going to take care of me. It felt…well…"

"Safe?"

Catra nodded. "Yeah, safe. And then she complimented me when I was figuring out why she was even there taking over for the Emperor in the first place." She frowned, her hold on the windowsill growing stronger. "I'm so used to people looking down on me I just…don't know what to think when they don't. Is that weird?"

Glimmer shook her head. "I don't think that's weird at all. Maybe she sees something in you."

Catra scoffed. "Yeah right."

"I'm serious. She didn't call anyone else aside from you out of their cell to help her with negotiations, did she? Judging by the lack of Horde Prime presence and the fact we're all still alive, I'd say they went well."

Catra turned her head away from her so she couldn't see her face and gave a wildly exaggerated shrug. She definitely said something that affected her, and Glimmer hoped it had been in a positive way.

"I don't know about that," Catra said. Another silence grew between them, one that Glimmer wasn't sure Catra was going to dig herself out of as the seconds ticked by.

“Are you worried about her?” Glimmer asked. “She offered herself up in our place, and Horde Prime fully intended on killing us. Do you think…when she leaves…?”

Catra cringed, and Glimmer feared she had just made everything worse.

“No, he’s not going to kill her,” Catra said, relaxing after a moment. “I was only there for negotiations on Etheria’s behalf. Everything else was behind closed doors, but she did say she avoided an execution when I asked.”

“That’s a relief,” Glimmer said, not taking her eyes off Catra.

“He’s not going to kill her, but she’s still uneasy—I could just tell. Whatever he did decide on, it’s still terrible. And from what little I saw in the few memories of his I experienced, it makes sense. Killing her would have been too clean and easy an end. He wanted to put her down and humiliate her…watch her suffer.”

“Like, put her in a prison or torture chamber for the rest of her life?”

“I can’t be sure, but I don’t think that’s going to happen either. The way she phrased it, she’s too important to both the Enclave and the Empire for something like that.”

“If he’s not going to kill her and not going to lock her away in a torture chamber forever, then what the heck is he going to do?”

“Good question,” Catra said. She narrowed her eyes, still looking out the window, and sighed. “Now that I think about it, as much as I’d like it, I guess I don’t actually expect her to stop by and visit me either. She’s got a lot of other things to worry about. It’s just…you have so many visitors, but for me she’s the only one I can realistically see having any reason to come by. It’s not like Adora is going to come see me any time soon,  but I’m kind of hoping at least Taline does. I don’t know, it’s stupid.”

"It's not stupid." Glimmer reached over and placed a hand atop Catra's on the windowsill. "And even if she doesn't come, you'll still have at least one visitor."

Catra didn't pull her hand away like Glimmer expected. Instead, she looked at her with a bewildered expression. "Who?"

"Me," Glimmer said, teasing her with a grin. "I'm your visitor. And despite what you think, it's not because I'm itching to relive our wonderful experience together in that cell."

Catra laughed and Glimmer felt the air around them ease up.

"You know," Glimmer said, feeling brave enough to push her luck with the touchy subjects. "I haven't been able to sleep well since we got back. The nightmares have been keeping me up. I know you have them too."

Catra's hand tensed underneath hers and Glimmer gave a reassuring squeeze to bring her back down. They hadn't talked about it. Up until that very moment, it had never felt like an appropriate time to address it. Strangely, only Adora, Catra, and herself seemed affected by them, if they glassy listless gaze constantly on their faces were any indication. The others on the citadel, her dad included, seemed unaffected. Whatever happened when Taline had broken that crystal seemed to have also broken something in their dreams as well.

*Better nightmares than experiencing the actual memory*, Taline had said to them, not long after they admitted to her what they had been suffering from. *Adora at least had She Ra's protection to shield her from them…I was relieved it left an imprint on so few people, and that your minds seemed to have stepped in anyways to protect you, on some level.*

Still, as relieved as Taline sounded about them not seeing the actual memory inside the crystal, Glimmer couldn't shake the visions she saw of Narre and Miri's real deaths alongside her

friends' hypothetical ones in her head, no matter what she did to relax before drifting off most nights.

"I'm worried they'll never go away," Catra said in a tiny voice. "Every day I see…"

She faltered and Glimmer squeezed her hand harder. "I'm sure they'll go away at some point. Or at least affect us less."

Catra nodded. She turned her hand palm-up and gave Glimmer a squeeze back. "Thank you for visiting me."

Glimmer laughed and nudged her with her elbow. "Come on now, I know you missed our bonding sessions back up in space. I figured, why deprive you of them when I could just come bother you for fun?" She watched Catra try and fail to hide the smile breaking out on her face.

"You are so full of it, you know that?" Catra said, shoving her back, careful not to catch her injured arm. "I'll never know how I survived all that time together with you without ripping my hair out."

"You're one to talk," Glimmer said with a smirk. "Worst cellmate ever."

Catra lunged for her and Glimmer screamed, teleporting around the bed nearby while Catra darted left and right trying to catch her. Laughter pealed around the room as they continued, until Glimmer heard a knock. They both froze and turned to see a familiar face standing at the open door, holding an ice pack against the side of his head.

"Bow!" Glimmer said, smoothing out her outfit and fixing her hair. "H-how long have you been standing there?"

"Not too long," Bow said. He cleared his throat. "Can we talk please?"

Glimmer chewed at the inside of her lip. He had a hard look in his eyes that set her even further on edge. “Sure, give me a second?”

Bow nodded. “I’ll wait in your room. Whenever you’re ready.” He turned to head back into the hall, but paused before turning back around. “Catra?” he said.

Catra gave a strangled noise before schooling her voice into a poor approximation of calm. “Yeah?

“I don’t know where I got it in my head you can't hit very hard because you’re small and stringy, but you pack one hell of a punch.” He pulled the ice pack away from his face, revealing a lump at the side of his head large enough to make Glimmer cringe. “It’s taken a while, but the swelling has finally started going down. Anyway, I wanted to say thank you for watching over Glimmer up there. I really appreciate it.”

“Y-yeah, don’t mention it,” Catra said. She seemed almost in disbelief that Bow had something nice to say to her at all.

Bow finally slipped out the door, and the unease Glimmer had felt earlier grew to full-blown panic. He was finally ready to talk, but what would he say? What was going to happen to them? A hand squeezed her shoulder, and she looked over to see Catra giving her an intense look, tail swishing behind her.

“It’ll be fine, Sparkles,” she said. “Just be chill.”

Glimmer bit her lip. “What if he doesn’t want to listen to me? What if I apologize and he still hates me?”

“I don’t know,” she said with a shrug. “But even if that did happen…it’ll still be okay.”

“It will *not* be okay if that happens,” Glimmer said, making a face. She didn’t want to let her mind even wander down that road.

“It will,” Catra said, squeezing her harder. “Stop thinking with your fear and start thinking with your brain. I hated you for years after

Adora left me to join your little rebellion. And you know what? In the span of a month…well, I don't hate you anymore. Bow's supposed to be your best friend, right? If I couldn't keep hating you then what chance does he have? And if he really does say he's done, then it *will still be okay.*"

The look in Catra's eyes seemed to say *"I lost it all and more, but here I am,"* and Glimmer calmed. Yeah, things would be okay. She'd absolutely hate life for a long while if they didn't make up, but she would be okay, one way or the other.

Glimmer pulled her into a hug. "You're the best, Catra. Thank you."

She pulled away before Catra could respond, caught the dumbstruck look on her face, and rushed to chase after Bow only to nearly barrel straight into Scorpia on her way out.

"Oh, uh hey Glimmer!" Scorpia said, careful not to slosh the two cups of tea she held in her claws while she braced against the door. "I was looking for Catra's room and thought this was it. Oh geeze, did I get the wrong room?"

"You got the right place," Glimmer said. She held the door open wider for Scorpia to peek inside. "She's in there. I'm sure she'll be really happy to see you."

Scorpia's eyes lit up and Glimmer felt a stab of elation for Catra upon seeing it; unlike Bow's glare from earlier, Scorpia was actually looking forward to this meeting—looking forward to a heartfelt reconciliation. Glimmer shooed her inside and shut the door behind her to give them privacy. Catra's cry of surprise echoed out from the other side moments later, and Glimmer couldn't suppress the smile that broke out across her face.

Now if only she and Bow could get some of that. Maybe then that knot she had felt in her chest ever since returning to Etheria could begin to loosen.

*Stop thinking with your fear and start thinking with your brain*, she chanted to herself as she walked down the hall back to her own room. *Whatever happens, it will be okay. It will.*

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They brought Queen Angella back the next day. Glimmer thought she'd cried all the tears her body could produce after Bow admitted with a morose face that he still didn't feel right about things between them, but nothing compared to the reaction she experienced seeing Taline pull her mother through the giant portal they had set up in the war room.

Her mom was fine, if a bit surprised to see the sheer number of people surrounding her and openly weeping for joy. She seemed even more surprised to learn how much time had passed since her disappearance—to her, it had felt like only a few minutes since she parted from Adora. The Princesses, Bright Moon's citizens, Royal Guards, Micah, all of them celebrated at Angella's side until she suddenly grew disoriented and Salas motioned to the medical team on standby to pull her away.

"She'll be okay," Taline had said to her and her father, the ones least cooperative in letting her go. "Salas' specialty is stabilizing minds. It's why he excelled as Prime's assistant. Angella is perfectly healthy, she just needs rest and time to ease back into this reality."

Glimmer finally stopped protesting after she promised they could see her again soon, and she folded herself into her dad's arms to cry even harder as the crowd dispersed. Frosta had actually brought her a glass of water shortly after in fear Glimmer would dehydrate herself crying so much, and when she moved to accept the glass, she also glimpsed Catra approaching Adora in the far corner of the room.

She rooted for her, until Adora turned on her heel and march away the moment she noticed Catra approaching. As quickly as it had come, the overwhelming happiness Glimmer experienced seeing her mom come back to them all at once colored with

sorrow, and her tears suddenly felt bittersweet seeing the look of panicked dejection on Catra's face.

Days passed, and that feeling unfortunately never went away. Despite the hours she spent at her mom's bedside and despite the hours she spent with her dad helping rebuild Bright Moon alongside Salas and the Enclave, Glimmer only grew more uncomfortable the longer she spent time with…other people. The awkward, guarded words and unsteady, unreadable body language she got from Bow every time they spoke didn't help, either.

No matter what she tried, she couldn't figure out how to shake the sense she no longer belonged there either, same as Catra had said. It wasn't the nightmares, which had finally subsided for the both of them. Taline had chalked it up to post traumatic stress when she finally spoke of it to her. For a time, that seemed an adequate explanation.

But then Glimmer and Adora made up—truly made up—and she witnessed first-hand how Adora seemed determined to train and spar herself into an early grave. The Enclave had helped her reforge the Sword of Protection, but she still hadn't been able to transform into She Ra.

"It's just a matter of time," she'd hear Adora mutter to herself under her breath. "I just need to be stronger. Need to be faster. She'll come back."

Glimmer had a sneaking suspicion Adora's nightmares hadn't let up, and the more she witnessed her obsess over training, the stronger that "out of place" feeling hit. Soon enough, 'stress' no longer seemed a sufficient explanation.

"Whatever you do, don't let it drive you to open a portal and destroy the world," Catra said during one of their unofficial 'meals together, just the two of them' appointments. "And if you do, I wouldn't bank on a second intergalactic empire swooping in and

helping fix things. Seems like a once-a-campaign kind of thing, y'know?"

Her tone had been light, but they ended up speaking long into the night about how that "out of place-ness" was a daily constant for Catra like she had said in the beginning. It only solidified Glimmer's inkling that her own issue went far deeper than she initially realized, and likely wouldn't go away on its own.

It wasn't until she almost interrupted her parents during a private moment that she finally understood what had happened to her. Micah sounded distraught, and Glimmer peeked through a crack in the doorway to find him openly weeping in Angella's arms. He lamented having lost so many happy years together with her, openly expressed his sorrow at having missed out on seeing his own daughter grow up into a "fine young woman", and spoke of his terror at having come home only to learn he might have lost them both forever.

And when, in the face of all this turmoil, Glimmer looked to her mom and saw her equally anguished expression—saw her also at a complete loss for what to say back—Glimmer finally realized that the "out of place" feeling she had been haunted by for weeks was only her picking up on how much everything and everyone around her had changed. Bright Moon was no longer the same. Glimmer herself was no longer the same. Her relationships were no longer the same.

She turned that very instant and raced down the hall as fast as she could with tears stinging her eyes, only to just make it to Taline's temporary quarters before finally falling apart.

Taline, bless her heart, merely set Narre's cracked helmet she had been cradling alone off to the side, got up to close the door behind Glimmer to give them privacy, and guided her to take a seat on the bed.

"What's going on?" she asked, taking a seat next to her. "It's visitation hours, isn't it? Shouldn't you be spending time with your

mom and your dad? Why are you crying?”

It took Glimmer several false starts before she got any words out. Taline stayed quiet, rubbing her back until she finally could.

“You’re supposed to be leaving soon, right?” Glimmer asked between hiccups. “Within the next week or two?”

Taline frowned, and Glimmer tried to not let her gaze linger on the thick gauze still covering her cheek. Prime had apparently done some permanent damage if she still had to wear that thing after so much time. “Who told you when I was supposed to go?”

Everyone knew Taline would leave at some point; it was part of the deal she had struck with Prime to get him to leave first. But no one had an exact timeframe, and Taline’s reaction told Glimmer her guess wasn’t far off.

“Catra and I thought it would be soon,” she said. “Reconstruction is in full swing and research on the Heart will begin soon, right? I know it’s supposed to be a secret and I promise I won’t say anything until you announce it, but I just…I need to know.”

Taline thought for a long moment before nodding with a sigh. “Unless something drastic happens, my last day will be at the end of the week, two weeks from today.”

Glimmer sniffled and looked at Narre’s helmet, propped on the desk across from her. “I know I wasn’t exactly cooperative when we first met, but can I ask you for a favor before you go?”

Taline angled her head, the question plain on her face. Glimmer took a deep breath. She still had no idea what Taline was going to be doing after leaving, but if she had any authority left after Horde Prime was through with her, she had to take the chance.

The words came slow and halting at first, but she forced herself through them—forced herself to speak with Taline about what had been tossing around in her head ever since the “out of place” feeling first bothered her.

Chapter End Notes

Horde Prime is gone? Everything's chill now then, right?

Nope. We're just getting started :)

# All Cards on the Table

Chapter Notes

> There's a lot of information dropped here, as the chapter title implies. It's okay if not all of it makes complete sense still yet—just getting the gist is enough to keep you firmly grounded in the story moving forward.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora drummed her fingers on the war room's conference table and tried to focus. The princesses all sat around the table, interspersed between the many heads of magic, engineering, and military affairs from the Enclave. Except for Micah and Angella who sat near the head of the table and Taline who sat opposite them, everyone was deep in animated conversation, and Adora was on the verge of snapping. She couldn't string two coherent thoughts together in her head it was so loud.

After nearly a month of nonstop work streamlining Etheria's rebuilding efforts, the "Alliance"—as they had named themselves the week prior, expanding on the old Princess Alliance to now include their Enclave allies—finally reached the point where the princesses could soon return home. They were to oversee the remainder of their respective kingdoms' reconstructions while training under Enclave mentors in advanced forms of magic. King Micah had supposedly been tapped to help as well.

Entrapta, who practically hadn't emerged from her lab since Angella's return, had worked with the Enclave to reforge the Sword of Protection. Adora might have felt happy about that too, if it weren't for the fact she still couldn't connect with She Ra. The sword had reverted to a gauntlet the moment Entrapta pieced it together, and everything Adora tried made neither it nor her transform. She had redoubled her efforts in Bright Moon's gym to help deal with her anxiety, but even coming straight from an

intense workout session and shower wasn't enough to soothe her in this particular moment.

Salas and Taline were finally going to brief them on the 'threat'—whatever it was she had seen in her vision aboard the citadel. Whatever that voice she heard and face she saw speaking and looking at her almost every time she closed her eyes to sleep.

Glimmer had mentioned seeing similar nightmares, although she hadn't gone into detail and Adora hadn't pushed for them. Adora could see the bags under her eyes despite how far away she sat, and judging by how far Bow sat from *her*, it was obvious Glimmer hadn't gotten much sleep and he hadn't forgiven her enough yet to help with that. Bow had always been someone with sound judgement in Adora's mind, but that whole situation convinced her he had a blind spot.

She caught sight of Catra, leaning with crossed arms and legs against a pillar in the far corner, and wanted to scream. Salas was late, seeing Catra just made her feel all the more conflicted, and Adora was doing everything she could to keep from flipping the whole table over in irritation. Could he just *get there* already and start? She needed everyone to quiet down so she could hear herself think, and she needed to know what this great enemy was they were all apparently conscripted into fighting.

At last, she saw the white and green of Salas' robes as he hurried through the doors to them.

"Sorry I'm late, everyone," he said, finally sweeping into the room with a harried expression. "There was a mix-up with the latest personnel arrivals and I had to sort it out first. Let's begin." He took up a position at the head of the table, nodding to Taline and Micah on either side of him, and keyed up a holographic presentation deck in the center of the table.

Most of what he walked them through initially, the princesses already knew from just existing alongside their Enclave counterparts for some time now: The Enclave was an autonomous

Protectorate inside the Empire, blah blah blah. They were generally left alone to do their own thing in exchange for serving that Empire when it came to all things magic, yadda yadda yadda. It wasn't until Salas dove into the next section that a hush descended upon the room.

"I understand many of you have been wondering for some time now why we've taken great pains to help rebuild your world, especially after it was our own Emperor that nearly destroyed it," Salas said, as he flipped through images of ruined civilization after ruined civilization on the slide deck. "This is the reason why."

One of the stills was an image of the hill upon which Adora stood in her vision aboard the citadel, complete with grazing aliens in the distance. She gasped and looked around at her friends, many of who had asked her previously why she had turned so readily from fighting the Enclave one moment, to wholeheartedly advocating they work together. She had only been able to shake her head at the time, unsure of how to explain the vision she saw in Horde Prime's citadel, but the fact the very same world from that vision had showed up on Salas' presentation only solidified her belief she had done the right thing. They didn't have time to fight each other. Not with what was coming.

Thankfully, no one seemed to notice her freezing up in the middle of the room, and Salas quickly moved on with another half dozen images of other worlds.

"Contrary to what some of you I'm sure are thinking," he said, "this is not the work of the Emperor conquering other planets. This is the work of an enemy we desperately need your help in defeating."

The image shifted, and they watched a video of a black, amorphous blob writhe inside a clear box.

"It may not look intimidating in there," Salas said. "But that's just a sample one of our research teams captured back in the early days. If it actually gets free on a planet or in the vacuum of

space, it will eat stars and worlds until there's nothing left. Almost did, on multiple occasions in the past. Many ancient civilizations we've come across throughout the centuries reference the creature as well, and even your own ancestors, the Eternians, wrote extensively on a near-mythical phenomenon they named the World Eater."

More images, this time of various ancient texts, paintings, and archaeological digs across barren planets flashed before them. By this point, some in the room had picked up hushed, worried conversations. The princesses looked to one another in confusion while Adora thought back to some of the last words She Ra had spoken to her: about how her power was destined to oppose something far older than the First Ones civilization itself.

"The Eternians were close to finding a way to stop its eventual return," Salas said, "though they unfortunately didn't finish by the time the Emperor conquered them several thousand years ago. We didn't learn of their preparations until the thing suddenly appeared in our galaxy and started eating literal star system outright. By then, we had already given it a different name. The Beast."

Salas flipped ahead, and the next several slides showed the Beast in various stages of agitation inside the containment box.

"Those images of destruction you saw earlier?" he said. "Those were taken before it even arrived on planet. Those were the result of unrest and sheer panic from the populace as they scrambled to evacuate. This"—he tapped at his console and the slide jumped forward—"is what those planets looked like from orbit once the Beast actually reached them."

All conversation in the room died as the princesses gasped and their Enclave counterparts shot each other uncomfortable looks. Even Entrapta, who had sat with rapt attention between Scorpia and Perfuma, now held an uncertain look on her face. Adora felt an icy cold snake through her chest and squeeze her heart.

The writhing mass of black flesh from earlier covered the entire planet. Salas tapped the console again and the view zoomed out, revealing seven other black planets orbiting a black star. He tapped a third time and the image gradually pulled out to reveal a third of the galaxy in a similar state—as if some god had taken a bite out of it. Adora realized with a start that this was, again, the exact view she had seen in her vision right before the creature spoke to her.

"This was eight years ago," Salas said, "at the end of a long campaign trying to stop its advance through our reality. The creature spread exponentially the more ground it covered. It grew smarter and bolder with each planet—with each person—it took. By this point, unless we did something to stop it immediately in its tracks, it would have grown too fast and too smart to stop at all. So, we mustered the entirety of the Imperial fleet and staged an assault. One final, massive stand to save our galaxy."

Another slide popped up showing what must have been tens of thousands of warships against a backdrop of stars, battling a literal wave of darkness raging toward them.

"Even the Emperor, who until that point had stayed away from direct conflict out of fear the enemy would corrupt him, led personally on the battlefront." Salas sighed, fatigue tingeing his voice. "Our victory, if you could even call it that, was pyrrhic at best, and temporary. If it weren't for a breakthrough from one of our science teams, we wouldn't have even had that. You all would have returned to a galaxy devoid of any life at all except for the Beast."

Someone in the room—Adora wasn't sure who, although she guessed Mermista—let out a long and low curse under their breath. It was quiet enough no one would have heard were it not for the complete, near suffocating silence in the war room. Salas ignored it.

"That team had researched much of what the Eternians left behind for us," he said. "They had apparently been working on an

ancient interdimensional prison named the Barrier before they fell. Much of the work had already been done long ago, as it already spanned a majority of the galaxy's mid-rim systems. With the power of thousands of 'nodes' powered by stars, the Barrier had the potential to lock the Beast away in between dimensions forever.

"Unfortunately, Horde Prime wasn't convinced that the Barrier was the answer we needed. You see, that same science team had also discovered a different technology earlier in the war. A mineral named Ignominite that could harm the Beast if imbued into munitions, or pacify it within crystals if caught.

"As the war took a particularly desperate turn, a few years before the final battle, they came to the Emperor in the Heartlands to petition him for the resources necessary to finish their research on unlocking and booting the Barrier system the Eternians had left behind. He instead ordered them to abandon the project altogether and focus on further advances with Ignominite. The head of the science team, someone I am forbidden from naming out loud, defied him."

Salas' eyes flicked to Taline, who sat there, stock still, eyes forward, and knuckles white from squeezing her hands into fists underneath the table. None of the other princesses seemed to notice, since, aside from her hands, Taline's face looked like the epitome of calm. But Adora *did* notice how the other members of the Enclave reacted; some exchanged meaningful looks with one another while others glanced at Taline only out of the corner of their eyes. Each of them, for some reason, seemed invested in how she in particular reacted to Salas' words.

"That would have been the end of it," Salas said, jolting Adora out of her observations. "The Emperor ordered her death, and would have had it if her head of security, a young man named Corynth, hadn't risen to defend her and her team. He, as it turned out, was a member of the Daiamid, a group that, up until the very moment he revealed himself, many had believed existed only in rumor and hearsay—in stories parents told their children to scare them into

behaving for them. They were the Emperor's supposed secret police. An ancient cabal of elite mages and assassins that did his bidding from the shadows.

"Corynth rallied the rest of his people and they followed, appearing in the spotlight to defy the very person they had served in secret. They chastised the Emperor for getting in the way of research that was supposedly key to saving our reality, and delivered a humiliating defeat to him at the capital before fleeing deep into the uncharted recesses of space."

The slide skipped forward and displayed two enormous fleets, one of Horde white and green and another, the red and black of the Beast, clashing above a sea of fire and brimstone. It took Adora a moment to realize that sea was actually a view of the surface of an enormous planet, covered in the Beast and marred with massive oceans and rivers of lava along its surface.

"We fought the Beast not long after," Salas said. "Our final stand, as I said. Despite our best efforts, it had taken a major hub world in the mid-rim earlier in the war. A planet named Archanas. It became too smart after that, and even steadfast optimists couldn't bring themselves to still hope after it started outmaneuvering even our most brilliant tacticians. It was there, as we tried to take that world back, that the Daiamid returned."

Another slide appeared, this one of a handful of ships in an impossibly tight formation shooting through the wave of black Beast vessels like an arrowhead through an air current.

"Our fleet above Archanas punched a hole in the Beast's defenses large enough for Corynth, the rest of his Daiamid Shapers, and the lead scientist to slip through and carry a payload directly into the maw of the enemy. Their research on the Barrier had paid off, and with one decisive blow, they sealed the Beast away at the cost of their own lives."

Salas shut off the presentation. "Which brings us to the present moment," he said. "The Barrier and its interlocking algorithm of

keys is imperfect. What software the science team had used in that final payload to activate the Barrier was not what the Eternians had originally developed, but only the best approximation of it that could be put together in the intervening years since fleeing the Emperor. Just as you have returned from being lost in a pocket dimension, so too has the Beast begun to seep back into our reality from its prison.

"Your world, your Heart of Etheria, is another Eternian construct. It is repeatedly mentioned in their surviving documents, and just like the Barrier was designed to be the one cage capable of trapping the creature away forever, the Heart was to be the one weapon guaranteed to kill it outright. It is our last hope for survival, and now that you are here, our number one priority is to get it functioning as intended. We must destroy the Beast before it has the chance to fully escape and finish us off for good. Are there any questions?"

He swept the room with steel in his eyes before Mermista broke the silence.

"Are you seriously not kidding me with all this?" she asked. "That's what we're up against? Something that literally eats entire planets and stars like they're lunch? How the hell are we supposed to beat that?"

All eyes shot to her, and Adora was relieved to see many of the princesses and even some younger members of the Enclave seeming to agree with her. Everything Salas said had terrified her. She had no idea how they were supposed to fight. The planet still couldn't even fire the Heart.

"I understand this may be a lot for you all to absorb," Taline said, rising in her chair and speaking for the first time since the meeting convened. "Every senior member of the Enclave here, including Salas and myself, lived through what you just saw. Lived through that war. To us, it wasn't just a presentation, it was another reminder that we lost more than we care to dwell on. But I must stress to you that we are extremely optimistic about this.

Our research team has been churning behind the scenes while everyone else has been busy rebuilding, and the preliminary analysis is very positive.

"Engineering fully believes they can get the Heart operationally sound within a handful of years. That includes doing the work necessary to make sure the planet doesn't explode, too. In the meantime, the Imperial Armada is more than equipped to stem the tide of what does slip through the barrier while we work. If everyone keeps their heads down and focused on the goal, we will come out of this alive. Then the galaxy at large, including Horde Prime, will welcome you with open arms as saviors."

The tension around the room lessened with each word she spoke. All seemed to take solace in her words, except for Adora, who only grew more anxious to reconnect with She Ra. Taline was an inspiring figure, and despite their clashing aboard the citadel, Adora held no hard feelings for her. But, functioning or not, the Heart depended on her as She ra to wield. She refused to let herself feel calm or confident until she made certain her connection to the Princess of Power remained unbroken.

Salas prompted further questions, and no one spoke up.

"Very well," he said. "Unfortunately, due to the nature of the mission and the current state of the Empire, Etheria will remain hidden and not all of you will be permitted to venture off planet. Until our work together is done, only certain members of Etheria's homegrown Horde will be allowed to conscript into the wider military and leave, by special invitation. We will break shortly to give everyone time to process what that means, and then reconvene to discuss specifics. But before we do, I think it prudent to mention—next week will be Taline's last here with us."

A low murmur of disappointment rumbled through the group. Everyone knew this was coming but didn't want to face it. The princesses had all grown to like her, and it was obvious both young and experienced Enclave members alike all held some sort

of muted reverence for her. Even Adora found herself feeling upset about the thought of her leaving.

"I just want to say it's been an honor working with you all," Taline said, looking them over. "I know some of us got off to a rough start together, but I want you all to know that I am grateful for the hospitality you've shown, and the trust you've chosen to give. Salas, as I'm sure you've all witnessed first-hand, is a fantastic choice to lead the research into the Heart. I'm thankful the Emperor agreed to let him take charge in my stead, and you are all in good hands with him."

A quiet round of agreement rippled through the group, and Adora saw Micah and Angella glance at each other. Then, the room grew quiet as Micah got to his feet.

"I must admit, I knew of this shortly before the announcement," Micah said, rubbing the back of his head with a sheepish expression as he looked at Taline. "Angie and I talked it out and we both agreed. Bright Moon will throw a grand feast, both to celebrate a great new partnership with the Enclave, and to thank you for vouching for us to Horde Prime."

Taline blinked, true surprise flashing across her features for the first time in Adora's recollection. "You don't have to do that," she said.

"But we will," Angella said, giving her a smile. "We want to. Everyone here understands that without you personally stepping forward and defending us, then Bright Moon would likely not have lived through Horde Prime's wrath. Please, accept this celebration as another expression of our gratitude to you."

Taline, still reeling, agreed and thanked the two of them for the gesture. Micah returned to his chair and Salas adjourned for a small recess.

As the princesses and Enclave higher-ups turned to strike up conversations or shuffle out of the war room, Adora saw Glimmer

get up from her chair and wander over to Taline with a determined expression. Angella and Micah, also watching her, exchanged glances with one another, and Adora wondered why they suddenly looked so sad.

Catra somehow caught Adora's attention immediately after, although she wasn't sure how since she was still leaning against the far pillar, tail swishing low behind her. Then she noticed the look in Catra's eyes, at her with an unspoken question reflected there.

*Can we talk?*

Adora stood fast enough her chair made an obnoxious squeal as it scraped along the ground and she fled. She knew exactly what Catra wanted to talk about and had to avoid that confrontation at all costs. She made it past the doors and a half dozen steps down the hall when—

"Adora!"

She paused and fought with herself. If she just kept walking, she could pretend she hadn't heard. Maybe it was the fact she felt guilty about the first time she did that, back when Angella first returned, but Adora couldn't bring herself to move. Catra's footsteps hurried after her; she was running.

"Adora, wait. Can we just—"

Adora took off. Whatever had kept her rooted to the spot her in the first place suddenly spurred her forward, twice as panicked as she was moments earlier. She hated herself for it, but she ran away—ran away from someone whose friendship used to mean the world to her growing up, and still meant just as much, if not more so, in the present.

"Adora, please!"

Catra's voice bled with anguish. It echoed down the hall and chased her like a specter. Adora slammed her eyes shut and grit

her teeth as her feet pounded the floor. She couldn’t face her. She couldn’t get distracted, not with so much on the line.

Chapter End Notes

> You’ll be able to read between the lines and catch some of the subtler stuff later on the more dots you can connect from this chapter, but I don’t punish readers for not fully grasping backstory.
>
> Whereas this chapter was heavy backstory and worldbuilding, next chapter is all character-focused. Adora can only run away from Catra for so long ;)

# Burdens and Responsibilities

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra didn't know how she had let Glimmer talk her into wearing the suit. It didn't fit nearly as well as it did years ago. Despite the abundance of delicious food now available to her, she had lost weight, and the red and black suit which she once wore proudly to Princess Prom now hung off her frame and pooled in odd places. She frowned as she looked herself over in the mirror and let her mind wander.

Adora had blatantly rejected her the last time she tried to approach her. The first time could have been an honest mistake, when they brought Angella back, but that second time after the briefing? Despite her knack for self-deception, Catra couldn't deny that Adora was deliberately avoiding her.

It hurt. So much so, she had thrown herself into assisting whatever reconstruction or research-infrastructure-building-whatever project she could get her hands on in the ensuing days. Even with the majority of major projects already well underway and fully-staffed, there was still plenty of work to be done. The only problem was that many of the ex-Horde employed on them didn't want to work with her. Many Bright Moon citizens avoided her too, afraid of the once-Horde Commander that nearly conquered them before Prime did. Even the Enclave didn't know what to do with her.

"You're not a scientist," they'd tell her. "I'm not sure I should let you handle any of this equipment."

"Just give me something heavy and hard to break and tell me where you need it installed," she'd say, hands already gripping whatever needed to be moved. She'd ignored everyone who gave her sidelong glances or snide remarks, and needled and pressured

everyone else until they finally capitulated and gave her something to do.

She'd worked herself so far to the bone slaving through the hurt that, when Taline's big going-away celebration finally came and all work ceased for everyone to partake, every inch of Catra's body ached like all hell, and she had nothing to do except sit in her room with her sour, depressing, dark thoughts. Maybe that was why, when she barged into her room the day of and learned Catra hadn't planned on attending, Glimmer had an easier time persuading her to go. After all, who'd have wanted to spend time alone with only their thoughts for company? Certainly not Catra.

Giving up on trying to feel better about her appearance, she pointedly turned away from the mirror and headed out to the grand hall. There was a feast she had been asked to attend, and she was determined to find some enjoyment out of the night even if it killed her.

A train of people wearing formalwear snaked down the main hallway to the entrance, and Catra followed. Angella and Micah were standing near the doorway greeting guests as they filed in, and Catra hung back to look for a group large enough for her to blend into and slip past without either of them noticing her. Catra hadn't had much interaction with either the king or queen since returning to Etheria, and she preferred it that way; despite now being on the same side and despite Catra being partially responsible for Angella's return, the thought of speaking face to face alone with either of them threatened to send her into a panic. There was just too much bad history between them.

A particularly large group of what Catra guessed were minor princesses and their dates filed past and she trailed them close behind. To any looking close, she'd stick out, since most of them wore frilly princess dresses. But Catra figured with a crowd that size, Angella and Micah would be too busy greeting them all and making small talk to notice her quickly slip past and inside.

She'd almost made it too, until Angella called out to her specifically.

"Excuse me, please enjoy the party," Angella said, extricating herself from both the group and her husband when Catra froze.

"H-hey, Queen Angella," Catra said, forcing a smile she had the sneaking suspicion looked more like a grimace than anything else. "Nice party!"

*Smooth*, she thought. *Are you just going to stand there and pretend like you hadn't hurt these people for years?*

Angella thanked her, and Catra rushed to speak her next words before the conversation could get away from her.

"Uhm, listen…about everything that happened," she said. "I wanted to say I'm really sorry about— "

Angella wrapped her in a tight hug and she immediately cut off, practically choking on her words. Getting pulled into a hug with the Queen was the last thing she expected to happen. Reluctantly, as if unsure this were really happening, she returned it and patted her on the back.

"There's no need for you to apologize," Angella said, pulling back. "Not to me. Sorry, by the way."

"Sorry? What are you apologizing for?"

"Glimmer mentioned you don't like people touching you unexpectedly, but I didn't know what else to do in the moment to tell you I'm not angry. I might have panicked just a little."

The sheer bluntness of her words caught Catra off guard and she snorted with laughter. "It's okay," she said, suppressing the urge to bust up a second time. She frowned, suddenly feeling unsure. "Why aren't you angry with me though? I was part of the Horde for years. I destroyed towns and villages trying to conquer you

guys. I….I killed you and almost destroyed the world. How can you not be angry?”

“You kept our family together,” Micah said, walking over to join them. He slotted himself beside Angella and put a hand around her waist.

“I what?” Catra asked. She leaned back onto her heels as she remembered the look Micah gave her when she had threatened Glimmer aboard the citadel. Seeing the hope drain out of his eyes when she pressed that knife up against his daughter’s throat had been painful, even if her and Glimmer were both in on it together.

“Listen, Catra,” Angella said, taking Micah’s hand from her hip and adjusting so she could thread her fingers through his. “You may be ex-Horde, but so are a lot of other people, many of whom are helping diligently with the reconstruction effort just like you.”

“Ah.” Catra didn’t have the heart to say she was mostly doing that to keep her mind from wandering to Adora, but she figured Angella’s point still stood despite that.

“I’ve seen you out there slaving away, helping clear the rubble and put up new structures,” Micah said. “Don’t think I’m too busy to not have noticed you.”

“And yes, you did do a lot of damage in the past,” Angella said. “There are still plenty of hurt feelings and simmering tensions, none of which will magically go away overnight. But the fact you are helping tells me enough. As for nearly killing me?” A smile crept onto Angella’s face and Catra gulped. “Let’s just say I’m not holding it against you. You aren’t a murderer. I know you didn’t intend to kill me and I also know you are part of the reason why I’m back.”

“Taline told you?” Catra asked, taken aback.

“Of course she did,” Angella said, nodding. “She said it was you who asked in the first place if it were possible at all.”

"Glimmer also told us what really happened on the citadel," Micah said. "She told us your plan to get us to surrender and that she went along with it. She also said she probably wouldn't have survived past the first few days if you weren't there for her." He gripped Angella's hand tighter as she ran her fingers across his knuckles. "In any case, others may be slower to forgive what happened in the past, but we both wanted you to know there is no bad blood between us." He stuck out his free hand for Catra to shake and she stared at it. "You are always welcome here in Bright Moon."

Emotions she wasn't prepared to handle bubbled up in her chest when she took his hand and squeezed. "T-thank you," she said, swallowing past the lump in her throat.

"No, thank *you*," Micah said, shaking his head. "I thought I'd lost my whole family the moment I got back to Bright Moon and Horde Prime invaded. We're back together again thanks in large part to you, and we will never forget it. Well…back together for a short while at least."

Angella and Micah exchanged a sad look, and Catra thought they were on the verge of saying more. They didn't, and instead merely asked that she enjoy the party before excusing themselves back to the entrance. More guests continued to filter in and Catra wandered with a blank mind toward one of the still mostly vacant long tables.

Catra's heart soared with such happiness she thought it would burst. Angella and Micah's words made the thoughts in her head lighten up for the first time since Adora had first left the Horde. And, for some reason she could only assume was pride, she fought to steady her breath and keep the tears from flowing—she didn't want anyone to see her cry.

"Holy shit,' she said under her breath, glad that she had picked a table and a chair with no one near enough to pay attention to her yet.

The smell of food wafted, overpowered her other impulses when she calmed, and soon she shucked her suit jacket to drape behind her chair, claiming it from others before she hurried over to the buffet table pushed against the far wall. Despite the dizzying variety of meats, fruits, vegetables, and sweets on offer, Catra came away with barely a half-full plate sampled from only a handful of dishes. She knew if she ate too much too quickly, she'd likely just waste it being sick in the nearest wastebin not long after.

Strangely disappointed in herself about it, her mind defaulted to searching for Adora. She couldn't find her. The seat at the head table next to the king and queen, reserved for special guests of honor like Salas and Taline, remained empty. She did, however, find Bow talking with animated gestures to Entrapta, who looked like she was only half listening. Suddenly, Entrapta bid Bow a clipped good bye and darted off with two whole plates piled high with food, much to Bow's confusion. Catra had a hunch she knew where Entrapta was going off to, and she hoped Bow would take her sudden departure as an opportunity to spend time with Glimmer and hopefully make up with her, although she doubted it.

As she made her way back to her seat, Catra found something large and red sitting in the chair next to hers.

"Scorpia?" She placed her meager pickings on the table and reclaimed her spot.

"Hey, Wildcat," Scorpia said through a mouthful of food. "Saw your jacket and figured I'd claim the seat next to yours before anyone else does. I, uh…hope that's okay?"

"Y-yeah, it's fine," Catra said, wondering why Scorpia needed to even ask. An uncomfortable silence hovered over the both of them when she didn't know what to say next. Desperate for it to go away, she said the first thing that came to mind. "Thanks for grabbing this suit for me from the Fri—er, Scorpion Kingdom," she said, picking at the suit draping off her body. "Didn't think I'd ever

need it again to be honest, but then Sparkles somehow convinced me to come to this party."

"No problem," Scorpia said, swallowing another bite of food. "I've made several trips helping clean up what I could there, you know. Saw that outfit and figured I'd bring it back for you just in case." Her eyes slid over to Catra's plate and she frowned. "Don't take this the wrong way Wildcat, but…is everything okay with you? I thought you might have looked a little thin when we talked in your room. I swore I was just imagining things, but that suit definitely doesn't fit the same way it once did. I'm worried about you."

Catra face burned she looked away, embarrassed. "I'm fine, Scorpia. Really." Why was she being so nice to her and worrying so much? Her and Entrapta. She had made up with the both of them already, but still felt like it was more than she deserved, even after how hard they had worked to convince her that wasn't the case.

"Why are you even going out of your way to sit with me?" she asked, trying to push the attention off of her and how poorly she cleaned up, only to cringe when she heard the sound of her own words, at how aggressive she sounded without meaning to.

Scorpia, thankfully, took it in stride. "Never feels like going out of my way to spend a little time with you," she said with a shrug.

"I meant why aren't you sitting at the head table with the rest of the princesses? They didn't forget to include you, did they? They couldn't have."

"Nah, I've got a spot next to Frosta and Perfuma," Scorpia said. "But the party's gonna go all night and we haven't gotten to catch up much except for the one time."

"Ah," Catra said, words escaping her after realizing that trying to avoid being put in the spotlight only resulted in her receiving even more unfiltered personal attention. Not knowing what else to say, and feeling even more out of her element the longer the silence

stretched between them, she purposefully speared a vegetable with her fork and popped it in her mouth. Concentrating on the taste ended up being just as difficult as fighting off the voice in her head urging her to make better conversation.

"So what are you planning on doing now?" Scorpia asked.

*Holy fuck you're not making it easy on me at all are you Scorpia*, Catra thought, shocked at how she had pushed the conversation into an even harsher identity crisis for her. *Please. Have mercy on a poor soul.* "What do you mean?" she asked, trying to buy time to think of a good response.

"I mean Horde Prime is gone, and now we'll be helping the Enclave perfect the Heart and fight the Beast. All us princesses will continue rebuilding our kingdoms and honing our magic so when the time comes, the Heart will work. What are you going to do now that there's no more Horde? No more need to conquer the planet?"

"I really don't know," Catra said. "I haven't really thought about it."

"You could come and work with me." When Catra only looked to her with skepticism, Scorpia clacked her claws together. "I'm serious! Turns out the old Fright Zone is in pretty bad shape compared to the other Kingdoms, and I've had my connection to the Black Garnet only a fraction of the time the others have had their connections. I have extra reconstruction to help with and extra training to get up to speed magic-wise. The Enclave is supposed to assign me someone to help with organizing most of the rebuilding, but you're Catra. You nearly conquered the entire world. I think you would do an amazing job helping put the old place back together."

Scorpia grew more excited and animated with each word she spoke. Catra couldn't help the emotion that tugged at her the longer she watched. Even after everything she had done, Scorpia

still saw a good person in her. Vouched for her, *to* her. How did she ever make a friend like her?

"Ohh! And Entrapta will be there a lot too," Scorpia said. "The Enclave apparently really likes what she's done, what with bringing Angella back and helping integrate their tech with ours and everything. She's going to be spending a lot of time at my new Kingdom, and I know she'd be super happy if you were there too. After all, you did convince Horde Prime to give back Ho—"

Catra hissed and surged forward, clapping a hand over Scorpia's mouth and scanning the room to see if anyone heard what she was about to say. When she looked back at Scorpia and saw the surprise and confusion on her face, she pulled her hand back, and her ears drooped.

"Sorry," she said. "I didn't mean to overreact I just…"

"Was I not supposed to know?" Scorpia asked. "Oh gosh, I'm so sorry. It's just, she was so excited and happy she couldn't keep it to herself and told me a few weeks ago and—"

"It's fine," Catra said, waving her hands to shut her up quick so no one overheard. "I should have expected something like that to happen, I just…can you make sure it doesn't get out past the two of you? I told her to give it at least six months before she let anyone else know. Let him work on tech and whatever, and then tell people about it after he's already done plenty to help. If they found out now so soon after everything is starting to calm down they'll just freak."

"I understand," Scorpia said, nodding solemnly. "Totally get it, one hundred percent, yep." She made a "lips sealed" gesture with her claws.

"Thanks," Catra said. "And thank you for offering me a spot at the Scorpion Kingdom too, I just…I don't know."

"You don't want to come?"

“It’s not that I don’t want to help you,” Catra said. “It’s just…” she sighed. “I think the Fright Zone just harbors too many bad memories for me. And I know it’s not the Fright Zone anymore and it’s your kingdom and everything, but I really think if I went back the only thing I would think about is what I suffered through there. As much as I want to help you, I just think being reminded about all the fucked up shit Shadow Weaver did to me, or how Adora and I would talk about running the place when we got older only to…” she trailed off as the mention of Adora brought fresher, more painful memories and she shook her head. “I just don’t think it’d be healthy for me. I’m sorry Scorpia, I hope that makes sense.”

Scorpia shook her head as if she were the one that had said something wrong and was scrambling to make up for it. “No! No, no that makes total sense to me, I should’ve realized that before I asked.” She made an exaggerated motion thunking herself on the forehead with her claw. “I get it. Once I get the place fixed up I don’t think it will look very much like the old Fright Zone, to be perfectly honest. And I hope you won’t let old memories stop you from coming to visit from time to time. You’d always be welcome.”

“Of course I’ll come visit,” Catra said, feeling more confusing emotions at hearing Scorpia say the same thing the king and queen had told her only moments earlier. “And I mean what I said before, I have no idea what I’m going to do now. All I know is that I really want to make things right with Adora again. Everything else I’ll figure out after.”

Something pricked at the corners of her awareness and she turned her head. Adora stood there, off in a shadowy corner of the banquet hall with her back facing her, gesturing with wide, angry movements at a stone-faced Glimmer.

“Mother of Etheria, do I have some sort of fucking sixth sense when it comes to her or something?” Catra said, more to herself than anything. She caught Scorpia following her line of sight and said, “don’t answer that. It was rhetorical.”

“You should go talk to her,” Scorpia said, reaching over to spear some of Catra’s vegetables off her plate.

“I’ve tried already. Twice! She keeps running away from me.”

Scorpia frowned and her eyes turned sad. “Adora’s been having a hard time. It’s not just me that’s noticed it, either. All the princesses talk about how she doesn’t seem to sleep and is way more irritable lately. I mean, just look at her with poor Glimmer over there.”

Catra didn’t respond and just chewed the inside of her cheek as she watched.

Scorpia nudged her gently with her elbow. “Go talk to her,” she said. “If she’s really having as hard a time as it looks then maybe what she needs most right now is a friend—one who really will go out of their way to show her she doesn’t have to bear this whole ‘save-the-galaxy’ stuff on her own.”

“What if she just runs away again?”

“I don’t think Glimmer will let her get away that easily if you ask me,” Scorpia said. “Besides, you guys grew up together. She’ll come around, just have to keep trying. True friends don’t give up that easily on each other, am I right?”

Scorpia nudged her again, this time with a wink. A whole new nuance to Scorpia’s sudden appearance at her table dawned on Catra upon seeing it.

“Thanks Scorpia,” she said, a genuine appreciation welling up inside her. “For everything. Thank you.”

She stood and headed over to Adora and Glimmer as fast as she could, fearing that if she delayed even a little she might lose the sudden confidence she felt with Scorpia’s blessing. As she got closer, she caught the tail end of their conversation.

"—don't know what else to say to you Adora. I was hoping you would be supportive about this. Hell, even my parents said they understood. We just barely got our family back together so of course they're sad as shit too, but you don't see them trying to change my mind."

"Yeah? Have you thought about how we're going to activate the Heart once it's stabilized? We need someone connected to every runestone to get it to work. How the heck did she okay this?"

"No, I haven't forgotten," Glimmer said. "Have you forgotten that my mom has a connection too? And has had it for far longer? She'll need to undergo less training than anyone else, and seeing as how she's the most experienced out of everyone at actually running a kingdom, she'll also be better suited than I am for leading the rest of the princesses."

Adora frowned. "Just because Bow is being weird doesn't mean you have to—"

"It's not about Bow," she said, interrupting her with a steel to her voice Catra hadn't expected. When Adora didn't respond, Glimmer said, "you know I'm right. Look, I know and there's a lot of pressure on you and I sympathize with that, but that doesn't change anything. It's not Bow, it's not you….I promise. The decision is made."

"You mean *you've* made the decision. Don't make it sound like it's out of your hands when you're the one that did it." Adora stiffened as if realizing her and Glimmer weren't alone. Then she turned and looked at Catra.

"Hey Adora." Catra played with her fingers behind her back, not sure what else to do with them, and her tail flicked low to the ground in unease.

Adora's eyes went wide and she turned to march away from the both of them. "It's fine, Glimmer. Do what you want. I'll see you —"

Glimmer teleported in front of her and spread her arms wide. “Adora, you can’t run away from this.”

“Get out of my way,” Adora said, gritting her teeth.

“You aren’t seriously trying to run away from this after telling *me* not to run away from my problems, are you?” Glimmer asked, arching an eyebrow.

“Glimmer—“

“No, Adora. Just no.” She let her arms down and crossed them over her chest, then jutted out her chin as if daring Adora to force her way through. “You keep talking about how you need to save the galaxy and how much is at stake but you can’t even turn around and talk to her. You’re the one that needs to stop running away from your problems. Not me.”

“Glimmer, please,” Adora voice had gone low and desperate, all of her cutting, judgmental tone from earlier having disappeared. Catra shifted on her feet and bit her lip. Maybe she shouldn’t have come over in the first place after all if Adora was that uncomfortable with her.

“I care about you,” Glimmer said, still speaking to Adora, her own voice growing soft. “I was terrified you would hate me for what I said and for what I did before Horde Prime arrived because I value your friendship so much. And no matter what happens to us, I will always be your friend. But that’s why, as your friend, I’m telling you to turn around and have this conversation. Don’t run away from this anymore.”

Adora stood there with her hands balled into shaking fists. She didn’t say anything for so long Catra almost gave up right then and there. Then Adora’s shoulders relaxed, she let out a shaky breath, and Glimmer nodded, satisfied. With lips pressed into a thin line, she walked past Adora and clapped Catra on the shoulder with one hand as she passed her.

“Come see me after you two finish talking please,” she whispered into Catra’s ear as she went. Then the two of them were finally alone, standing in the corner of the banquet room with the sounds of drunken celebration reverberating in the background.

Catra traced a crack in the marble flooring with her eyes, suddenly shy and uncomfortable in her own skin now that she was reasonably certain Adora wouldn’t run away. She opened her mouth to say something when Adora turned and pulled her by the wrist.

“Come on,” Adora said.

Catra let herself be dragged into the hallway connecting to the main room, the hairs all over her body threatening to stand on end. They stopped with enough distance put between them and the open doorway to give them privacy against anyone walking by, and Adora suddenly let go of Catra’s wrist and turned.

Catra rushed to get her words out first. “I know you’re still mad at me about—”

“I’m not mad at you,” Adora said, setting her jaw.

Catra scowled. “You’ve been running away from me every time I’ve approached you. It’s taken Sparkles giving you a tongue lashing just for us to get this far, how can you stand there and say you aren’t mad?” Anger flashed across Adora’s eyes before she schooled her expression into calm.

“Ok, we’ll talk,” Adora said. The calm in her voice set Catra further on edge. “We’ll talk, but I want to go first. I want to say everything that’s been running nonstop in my head for the past month. And as much as you are going to get the urge to interrupt, don’t. Let me get everything out first without you knocking me off track and twisting my words in ways that I don’t mean them, and then I’ll listen to everything you have to say without interrupting. Deal?”

Catra felt the immediate urge to challenge the accusation she twists Adora's words before violently telling herself not to even start. By her own admission, she just got Adora to turn around and acknowledge her. Catra wasn't about to violate the one requirement she put in place for this conversation before it even got off the ground. She swallowed the lump in her throat and nodded. "Sure. Go ahead."

"I loved you."

Catra thought her heart might stop. "W-what?"

Adora's nostrils flared as she spoke, and she blinked so often Catra suspected she was trying to hold back tears, but Adora didn't take her eyes off her as she battled for her words.

"We grew up together. Pulled each other through some of the darkest times in our childhoods. How could I not? You think I'm mad at you, but that's not it Catra. I wanted to spend the rest of my life with you…I loved you. I still love you, and that's why I'm so terrified of having this conversation."

Adora only looked at her after throwing that between them, daring her to say something. Catra, suppressing every instinct to press her for more, somehow managed to stay quiet.

"I'm not mad *now,* but I was…before," Adora sounded as if she was sure her words would blow up in her face like a landmine with each syllable. "I didn't understand why you wouldn't come with me to the Rebellion, I didn't understand why you'd turned so vicious in the Crystal Castle after I thought we were finally getting through to each other, or why you pulled the lever and opened the portal even after I begged you not to. I…didn't understand why everything I said seemed to only make things worse and make you angrier with me."

A single tear broke free and ran down Adora's face. She took a sharp breath in and looked away. Catra couldn't tell if she was hissing in anger or from sadness, but took a step forward, intent

on comforting her. Adora took a step back as quickly as if she had burned her foot. She held up a hand to clearly tell Catra to keep her distance and, unsure of what to do, she complied. What else could she do?

"I'm not mad anymore," Adora said." I finally understood what it felt like to be you…to be so determined not to lose that you throw everything else out the window just to win. What you felt throwing the switch to that portal? I felt that ordering all of us to teleport onto the citadel—to fight even when I knew how likely the chances were that we'd die. I'm not mad about all the stuff you did anymore, Catra, because now I understand why you did it. How it felt."

She gave a bitter, barking laugh and more tears welled up in her eyes. "And now I finally understand what it feels like to be abandoned. I always thought you were making a bigger deal out of it than it really was because I never felt like I was leaving you behind. It just felt like I was doing the right thing and you would have understood, especially if I invited you to the Rebellion with me. I had no idea it'd *hurt* this much, even when I understand why it's happening. Glimmer's right—it's the best thing for her, but that doesn't make me feel any better about it. If I had known this is what it felt like for you when I left…maybe I would have done things differently. I'm so sorry, Catra."

Adora dragged a sleeve across her eyes and took a shuddering breath. More tears had spilled down her face as she had spoken, and Catra couldn't keep herself restrained any longer. She took another step toward her.

"Adora, I—"

"Stop." Adora said, voice so harsh it actually made Catra freeze mid-step. "You're only going to make it harder for me to finish. You promised I could say everything first. You *promised*."

On one hand, Catra wanted nothing more than to go and do whatever she could to comfort her, pride be damned. On the

other, seeing the pleading look Adora gave her when she took that first step told her that, if she went any further, she'd yet again be betraying the very person she was trying to make amends with: her Adora. The war inside Catra's mind had never raged so furiously before, and in the end, she decided to stay exactly where she was and pray that Adora didn't sink herself before she gave permission for Catra to finally go to her.

"I can't do this," Adora said, running her other sleeve across her eyes and sniffling.

"What can't you do?" Catra asked after Adora didn't explain further. "You can't keep having this conversation right now or…?"

"I can't go through this with you." Adora wouldn't stop rubbing her eyes, one sleeve replacing the other over and over again. "Ever since I found that…*god's forsaken* sword in the woods I've done nothing but second guess myself over you. I've spent more time agonizing over how to repair our friendship or how to prevent you from outsmarting the Rebellion than I spent trying to control my powers and accept responsibility over them."

A sinking feeling in Catra's stomach made itself known with each word Adora struggled to get out between hiccups and sniffles and shaky breaths. "What are you saying?" she asked. "What do you mean you can't go through this with me?"

"When we fought in the Crystal Castle, I tried and hoped and wished with everything that you would come with me. And when you attacked Bright Moon, I hadn't tried to embrace She Ra until it was almost too late. I kept thinking you would come to your senses and stop at some point. When you opened the portal, I spent more time trying to convince you to come with me and escape than I did trying to work out how to use She Ra and stop it. We lost Queen Angella because of it."

"Adora, that's not on you. That's on—"

"And even though everything worked out in the end, I panicked when I saw you hold that knife against Glimmer's throat up on the citadel. King Micah tried to tell me that you weren't on our side, but I didn't believe him. I wanted you to be on our side so badly I literally froze at the worst possible time because I refused to believe you had turned on us. Again."

"I didn't turn on you," Catra said. "I didn't! I know it looked like it at the time, but I was helping you. Horde Prime was going to kill you all if you didn't surrender. I had to…I had to do *something*." Catra felt the conversation getting away from her—felt the path Adora had gotten herself on with and where they ended. It terrified her.

"And what if Taline hadn't been able to convince him?" Adora asked. "I saw your reaction when she offered herself to him in our stead for punishment. That surprised you. You weren't expecting it."

Adora was right, but Catra had to get her off this train of thought before it was too late. "I know but—"

"What if our only chance at living had been if I focused on my responsibilities in the first place?" Adora asked. "What if our only chance was if I had taken out Prime like we originally planned, without getting distracted? I've been lucky…things have worked out so far, but it's not always going to be like that. It would be naïve and irresponsible for me to think that with so many lives at stake. The Beast is coming, we need to prepare, and I need to fulfill my destiny as She Ra or else trillions will die. Trillions have already died. There's no getting around it this time. No more lucky breaks."

Adora stopped rubbing her eyes and looked Catra head on. Only then did it dawn on her that Adora hadn't been merely on the verge of tears and trying to hide it; she was already all out sobbing. Tears flowed nonstop and free down her face, and it broke Catra's heart. She hadn't seen Adora cry that hard since

they were children. That realization took the creeping, uneasy, sinking feeling from earlier and pushed her into a near panic.

"So what are you saying?" Catra asked in a low voice.

"I can't risk it," Adora said. "I choked three times now because I was so focused on you…focused on *us*. If I do that again…" She shook her head. "You heard Salas. This weapon is the Galaxy's last hope. It has to work."

"Say what it is you're trying to say, Adora. Just spit it out already." Tears of Catra's own prick the corners of her eyes, and she fought them back, shoveling venom into her voice instead.

"I can't be second guessing myself because of how strong my feelings for you are. I can't risk even just the possibly of it happening again, even if the both of us swear to be on the same side and work on our relationship. I can't afford to be irresponsible. Naïve." A sob escaped her. "When this banquet is over—"

Panic got the better of Catra. She suddenly didn't want Adora to finish her sentence. "Adora, wait—"

"—and when I get the sword back…when we all start training in earnest to use the Heart—"

"Just wait, don't finish what you're—"

"—I don't want to see or hear from you again, Catra."

That last phrase hung in the air between them and echoed down the hall. Catra had heard the phrase "waiting for the other shoe to drop" before, but now that it had finally happened, she realized it felt more like a cinderblock dropping through to the pit of her stomach than any shoe she knew.

"There," Adora said, sniffling. "I've said everything. Your turn. Sorry to make you wait."

"You don't mean that," Catra said, half begging and half asserting.

"I do mean it. That's why I've been running away from this conversation for a month. I didn't want to have it."

"You can't mean that, Adora…you can't really mean that…"

"Please don't make this harder than it already is." Adora's voice broke again. It was infuriating. What right did Adora have to beg *her* to not make things difficult after what she said? "I've fought myself for weeks over whether or not this is the right thing to do, and it *is* the right thing to do. I can't let myself get distracted, not when so much is at stake. If you were ever in danger again, I would come do everything I could to help you without a second thought, but otherwise I don't want to see you while I'm trying to figure this out…not until we defeat the Beast at the very least."

Somewhere in Catra's rattled mind she realized it was now finally her turn to speak freely, to tell Adora all the things she had been wanting to say. But just the thought of trying to come up with coherent words or thoughts sent her spiraling into even further swells of anxiety and despair.

*She doesn't want you anymore. You pushed everything too far. You've ruined it. She doesn't want you. Adora doesn't want you. You hurt her.*

Catra's thoughts ripped her to shreds, tearing into her without end. The hallway started closing in around her, trying to suffocate her. She couldn't breathe. She couldn't see. Everything had gone blurry with the tears in her eyes. Her heart beat so fast Catra was convinced it'd stop at any moment. Somewhere, she heard Adora's muffled voice prompt her again, but all she could think to do was escape.

Catra turned and ran down the hall, nearly bowling over a blur of pink and purple on her way to the castle doors. Someone called out to her from behind her. She ignored them and ran for all she was worth.

Chapter End Notes

How we all doing? Everyone make it?

Before anyone gets their pitchforks and torches out, the relationship tags are still valid. Even if Catra and Adora just went backwards into "not on speaking terms." Even if it takes a long time for them to get back on speaking terms.

We're almost through the first arc of the story. I have some exciting information to share with y'all when we get there (no hiatuses).

See you next Thursday!

# Evelyn

Chapter Notes

> Same deal as with chapter 13--grabbing the gist will keep you firmly rooted in the story moving forward, and the more detail you retain, the more nuance you'll catch.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was still dark outside when Catra finally regained enough of her senses to take stock of her surroundings. She was sitting up on a grassy knoll. The edge of the Whispering Woods began just in front of her and Bright Moon castle lay behind, with the lights and music from the feast still going strong. Despite losing all sense of time, she must not have been fighting her panic attack long enough for the party to die down. One of Taline's Enclave star cruisers, the *Constable*, hovered high above, leaving a sharp, triangular patch of darkness amid the stars in the sky.

A breeze picked up, ruffling the grass and making the tree branches creak. Catra shivered and hugged her knees for warmth; she'd always been susceptible to the cold despite being covered in fine fur. Her jacket was still in the banquet hall, she realized, having forgotten about it completely in her rush to escape from the castle closing in on her. She considered returning for it before deciding it wasn't worth it. What if she ran into Adora again? And even if she didn't, being around people was the last thing she wanted at the moment.

Something rustled in the grass behind her and it didn't sound like the breeze. She whipped around with ears perked, landing on all fours with fur bristled, teeth bared, and claws extended.

Taline stood before her holding a covered platter of what Catra assumed was food with both hands.

"Sorry," Catra said, retracting her claws and forcing her fur to settle down. She had never enjoyed snapping at people before,

but neither had she cared much when she had. Now, for some reason, baring her fangs at Taline even when she didn't know it was her to begin with suddenly made her feel guilty. "Sorry," she said again, looking to the side, embarrassed that she couldn't even grasp at an excuse to give.

"It's fine," Taline said, shrugging. "I thought you'd have heard me coming a lot sooner. Too in your head tonight?"

"You could say that."

"Mind if I join you?"

"Why?" Catra cringed when Taline merely quirked an eyebrow at her and reached for something to smooth over how combative that had sounded. "You leave tomorrow. Don't you want to, I don't know, enjoy the party they're all throwing for you before you have to go?"

"I wouldn't be out here if that's what I wanted to do," Taline said. "Now can I join you or not? My arms are getting tired holding this thing." She hefted the platter in her hands.

*You were the one who hoped she'd come visit you,* Catra thought, slamming her head against a wall in her mind. *Why are you coming up with reasons for her to leave now that she's finally here?*

"S-sure," Catra said. "Sorry."

Taline came up and sat next to her on the hill, facing away from the castle and toward the woods. Catra mirrored her, and Taline placed the tray on the grass before sliding it over in front of her.

"Glimmer came and found me," Taline said. "She was worried about you after you stormed out of the castle. I actually had to pull up the *Constable's* sensor scanner and show her you were just hanging out at the edge of the woods before she'd let it go."

Catra thought back to the blur in the hallway she saw as she was running away. “I think I almost ran her over trying to escape,” she said with a chuckle, hugging her knees again rather than reach for the food. Catra startled, suddenly remembering something. “Oh shit. She wanted me to come talk to her after I finished with Adora. I totally forgot.”

“It’s fine,” Taline said, laughing through her nose. “I told her to let you cool off on your own out here for a while and she agreed. She’s a bullheaded and impulsive person, so if it were really that important, she’d have come found you on her own.”

The endearing tone with which Taline spoke had Catra laughing in spite of herself. Glimmer had told her how she went to antagonize Horde Prime instead of follow Taline’s orders, and Catra had told her how vexed Taline had looked when she found out about it. It seemed Taline didn’t hold onto any hard feelings from it, and Catra was glad for it.

“How are you?” Taline asked. Catra almost responded with one of her well-practiced deflections until she saw the way Taline looked at her. Instead, she deflated.

“Not good,” Catra said. “I shouldn’t be surprised Adora reacted the way she did after everything, but something in me still wished that bridge wasn’t already burnt beyond repair.” She had no idea how much Taline knew of what transpired earlier, but she guessed she was filled in enough already.

“You were hoping you could fix things?”

“Well, yeah of course. We’ve just been through so much growing up together, a part of me thought…well, hoped is a better word I guess—hoped that no matter how bad things got, we’d be able to get back to one another somehow.” Catra’s chest constricted, warning of another impending panic attack the more she talked. She hugged her knees closer and pricked her claws into her shins.

“I don’t think there’s such a thing as unconditional love, much as we all want to believe in it,” Taline said. “At least…as far as I’ve experienced. Closest I’ve ever seen is a parent’s love for their child, and you already know that’s not always the case.”

Catra didn’t move a muscle on her body except to dig her claws deeper. She had the sneaking suspicion Taline had long already knew of Shadow Weaver and who she was to Catra. Taline bringing her up in this way all but confirmed it. She laughed and shrugged, as if physically trying to shirk the conversation topic away.

Taline looked at her with an unreadable expression. “That said, I do think you and Adora have something special. I’ve seen the way she looks at you, even with all your…history. Maybe there’s a chance you two will reconcile in the future, learn how to lean on each other like you did as kids once more.”

“You think so?”

Taline shrugged. “Or maybe you won’t, who knows? I’m not an oracle. I wasn’t the member of my family blessed with that particular curse.”

Catra frowned, not exactly sure what Taline was referring to. She still felt so unsatisfied and frustrated about everything, despite Taline obviously trying to cheer her up in her own awkward way. “I just…I don’t know what to do now,” Catra said. She sighed, and after another moment of silence, she looked up at Taline, prompting her for a response.

Taline startled. “Oh, you wanted me to give you an answer?” She blinked, clearly in thought. “I’m not sure if I have one, honestly. You may have grown up knowing only a primitive version of the Horde and the few relationships it entailed, but it doesn’t have to be that way anymore. That whole situation with Adora? Ball’s not in your court any longer, I’d say. You’ll be miserable if that’s the only thing you focus on, because you don’t have any influence over its outcome .”

“That’s…depressing to think about.”

Taline nodded. “It can be, if you choose to look at it that way. Or you can choose to see it as an opportunity to discover yourself, now that the relationships and foundations that have underpinned your entire life are now dissolved. You can choose to work on yourself—grow as a person in a direction you want.”

Catra narrowed her eyes, at a complete loss for words. Grow as a person in the direction she wanted? What the hell did that even mean?

Taline threw her head back and laughed so hard she snorted. “Too preachy?” she asked, wiping a tear from her eye. “Sorry, I’ve never seen that caught-in-the-headlights look from you before. It threw me.”

“Hell yeah it threw you, it threw me too!” Catra said. “Where did that come from? Here I thought you were just someone that throws magic lightning from her hands strong enough to blast Shadow Weaver on her ass. If I knew you gave sage advice I might have just gone and sought you out first.”

Taline smiled, before her demeanor turned somber and she sighed. “I’ve done a lot I’ve had to reflect on over the years. That ‘sage advice’ has been won at great personal cost.”

Catra nodded and swallowed, riding the wave of tension between them. She had a question she wanted to ask, and needed to ride her emotions until they brought her somewhere she could speak without her voice wavering or cracking.

“What was it like for you when you lost your sister?”

Taline narrowed her eyes and Catra feared she had overstepped. “You saw through his memories when the Emperor probed you, didn’t you?” she asked. “I had a feeling that’s what had happened. How else would you know she was my sister when no one dares even say her name, let alone admit she exists?” She looked away and set her lips in a thin line. “What did you see?”

“I was him for a moment in the throne room,” Catra said, picking her words carefully. “It was after a battle, I think. He was angry. You were there, and he asked what happened to the body.”

Taline didn’t say anything at first. Then…

“That was maybe a week after the final battle above Archanas ended,” she said. “Salas didn’t mention it in the meeting, but I was the one leading our naval forces above the planet. Prime was not happy to learn I defied his order to retreat and made an opening for the Daiamid ships to get through instead, when they returned.”

“Is that how you earned your moniker?” Catra asked. “Is that where ‘Seraph of Archanas’ came from?”

Taline shook her head, a sudden sullenness coming to her expression. “It’s not. That came from something else entirely, but it doesn’t stop everybody in the empire thinking that’s where it came from—me defying the Emperor in the final battle.”

Catra gave her a confused look and Taline glanced away from her. “It’s…complicated. As much as people have good intentions when they invoke my title, it’s not exactly a pleasant memory for me to relive…how I actually got it. Maybe one of these days I’ll tell you, but for right now…?”

“No, no it’s fine,” Catra said, shaking her head. The last thing she wanted to do was push Taline away the moment they had an opportunity to talk. Is this what people felt like trying to get her to open up? Walking on eggshells? “Sorry I brought it up.”

Etheria’s nighttime wildlife chirped and crooned in the background with the rustling of leaves in the breeze. Catra stayed silent, praying she hadn’t alienated Taline already.

“After the battle,” Taline said, continuing off from their previous topic as if they hadn’t diverted in the first place. “I took a landing party down to the surface, where we found my sister’s body. There wasn’t anything worth taking off her corpse, so instead, the

Emperor wanted me to get everything from the hidden lab she and her team had set up with the Daiamid after fleeing the Heartlands." She leaned back, propping herself up with both hands behind her on the grass and stared up at the stars. "God, that was eight years ago now. I probably wasn't much older than you are now."

Those words didn't initially jolt Catra. But, as she processed what Taline had said and the implications behind them, horror and anger built within her like a wave picking up speed the closer it sped toward the shore, threatening to crash her into rocks on the cliffside. Before long, just imagining herself in Taline's shoes made Catra flinch. Shadow Weaver and the Horde had damaged her and, somewhere deep inside, she feared that damage was irreparable. But she couldn't imagine losing someone in a battle and then having to scour the last of their belongings only to hand it over to Prime.

Not only that, but apparently nobody could even acknowledge she had existed. What was it Prime had said to her? Catra wracked her brain trying to remember specifics about that nightmare back on the citadel. She shuddered when it came to her.

*Your sister shall be forgotten by history, and any who dare utter her name shall share her fate.*

Something akin to empathy knotted itself in Catra's chest, and she sat there in silence for a moment, watching the stars in the sky twinkle down at them.

"Tell me about her," Catra asked. "Please?"

Taline studied her as if searching for any sign of Catra second guessing herself. Finally, she nodded and pulled at the sleeve of her uniform to expose the hardware sitting underneath. She tapped a few commands into the device on her forearm until a holographic interface appeared above her wrist.

“Captain,” Taline said. “I need you to shut off the passive trackers you have for me and the Etherian girl I’m with,” A moment passed as, Catra assumed, whoever was on the other line responded. “Yes, full privacy please,” Taline said. “No logs recorded, no timestamps. Nothing.” Another moment, then she killed the communicator and leaned back on her hands again with a sigh.

“Her name was Evelyn,” she said. “That’s the name Horde Prime has tried so hard to prevent anyone from speaking. We didn’t get along—not at first. I hated her when we were young, and it took a long while for me to come around.”

Catra had the decency to not hide the surprise she felt hearing that. The few times Catra imagined Taline’s nameless, near-faceless sister before then, she imagined them having a good relationship—imagined Taline being a model sister. Still, she rolled the name ‘Evelyn’ around in her mind, and prompted Taline to continue by not saying anything at all. Part of her feared by saying anything, whatever invisible spell had compelled Taline to open up to her would break.

“I was an orphan too, you know,” Taline said. “Just like you.”

“Really?” Catra stared at her, surprising even herself at just how quickly she gave up on keeping quiet.

Taline smiled and nodded. “Yes, really. My parents thought they couldn’t conceive, so they took me in. Things were good for a while, until they found out they actually could have a child of their own after all. That’s when Evelyn came—four years after me.”

“Did they treat you badly after she came?” Catra already felt a lump growing in her throat just asking the question. “Is that why you two didn’t get along?”

“Wouldn’t that be a convenient excuse if they had?” Taline asked, laughing to herself and shaking her head. “No, they loved both of us and were fantastic parents. I think that only made it harder for me though.”

“What do you mean?”

“I mean that it was *me*,” Taline said. “I was the reason we didn’t get along. Not my parents. Not Evelyn.” She plucked grass from the dirt and sighed. “Just me. I was the one with the book smarts out of the two of us, and I pushed myself to use them. I studied for hours outside of school for perfect grades, and used them to get into a top university in the Heartlands. Evelyn struggled to maintain even a passing average, and that was with my tutoring. But no matter how much more I accomplished than her, no matter how much more I achieved, I could never be their biological child —that was always going to be Evelyn.”

Catra held her breath. She empathized with Taline even more now than moments before. It was a strange thing, being able to see both her and Adora’s struggle in Taline’s story; the urge to keep fighting and achieving, but forever feeling second rate. Forever feeling like someone undeserving of love and praise, despite it all.

“I only wish I realized how stupid I was being before it was too late,” Taline said. “Our parents were proud of her too, of course. She was just beginning her undergraduate at a minor vocational science school at around the same time I left to train with the Enclave. If I could go back in time and shake my past self, tell her I didn’t have to kill myself overachieving because the three of them already loved me, I would. But I wouldn’t learn that lesson until after our parents had died. Not until Evelyn and I had only each other left.”

“That sounds…I think I might understand some of that.” Catra couldn’t count how many times since returning to Etheria she wanted to grab her past self and shake her, too. Convince past Catra to be less…stupid.

Taline turned to look at her, startling her with how sudden the movement was. “Then you’ll probably understand when I say the answer to your question is it felt horrible, losing her. I lost my parents only to finally learn to appreciate Evelyn, and then I lost

her because I didn't know her well enough to realize she needed help. Seeing her body lying there in the ruins on Archanas…"

Taline trailed off, averting her eyes. To Catra, she looked strong—somehow seeming confident in a moment of weakness. What a strange juxtaposition.

"What do you mean you didn't realize what was really going on with her?" Catra asked.

Taline chuckled again, nostalgia making her eyes shimmer as she reminisced. "Evelyn had no magic potential to speak of. In fact, she barely kept up with her studies while I was away. War had broken out with the Beast by the time she graduated, and I assumed she'd pick something nondescript as a job. Simple. Maybe an associate position at a minor lab in the Heartlands. I didn't at all expect she'd sign onto a black site."

Catra frowned and Taline must have picked up on her confusion, because she said, "they used hidden space stations to research the Beast—still do, to this day. Evelyn had accepted a position at one to help with the war effort and didn't tell me. This was before she discovered ignominite…back when the two-year survival rate serving on one of those teams was damn near zero. When I found out, I nearly blew a gasket."

"How did you find out, exactly?" Catra asked. "If the stations are supposed to be secret, how would you have known she joined one?"

"I didn't know," Taline said with a frown. "Not until it was almost too late. Her station had lost control of the Beast sample it was working with and exploded. All hands lost, except for two. I was serving on the front lines at the time and intercepted the distress signal. The captain of the ship I was on wasn't very happy when I commandeered his carrier and forced it to respond, but what are you going to do? Say no to an Enclave Battlemage?" She laughed. "We got there, and it was only her and Corynth out of a team of seventy that survived."

“That’s it?” Catra asked, astounded. “Two out of seventy?”

“The fact anyone survived at all was newsworthy in and of itself, Catra,” Taline said. “There had never been survivors before, ever. I should have known something was wrong right then and there, especially after Corynth told me he was a Battlemage too. I was supposed to be an exceedingly rare case, earning my own commission at the age I did. He couldn’t have been more than a few months older than me at the time.”

“He was there with her even back then?” Catra asked. “Corynth.”

“There from the very start.” Taline said with a nod. “He was only masquerading as a Battlemage, of course, but I wouldn’t have known that. The Daiamid were still just rumors and whispers at that point. There was no way I could have known he already had his claws in Evelyn at the time, manipulating her. I was just so happy to see her still alive…and what she told me once I finally got her alone surprised me so much I didn’t even think to look if anything was wrong in the first place.”

“What’d she say to you?” They weren’t talking about coping with loss any longer, but Catra couldn’t stop herself from asking. She was already far too invested in the story.

“She said her team finally found a promising trail of research on the Beast shortly before everything went to hell. Time was of the essence, and, as the only surviving member of her group, she was apparently the only person who could see it through to fruition. She begged me to help her get the resources she needed to finish her assignment.”

“You believed her?”

Taline grimaced. “How could I not? Like I said, I was so happy to see her alive, I didn’t think about looking into things deeper. She was the first ever recorded survivor of a black-site meltdown, and I was ready to believe anything that came out of her mouth.

"I pulled some strings. Got her a research station of her own. Within three months she discovered ignominite and changed the landscape of the war. Now, instead of containing the Beast in clear boxes, they shoved it into crystals made of the stuff, and Beast-related research deaths dropped to near zero overnight. When the military incorporated it into our munitions, suddenly we could now more effectively harm the thing…push it back. Treat it almost like a terrestrial enemy. Ignominite is such an important commodity, it makes up a significant chunk of the empire-wide GDP to this day."

"That's what Prime gambled on instead of the Barrier" Catra said, remembering what Salas mentioned at the briefing. "Ignominite."

"You've been paying attention." Taline smiled at her and Catra flushed. She was still so bad with compliments and authority figures.

"What is it?" she asked, after a moment. "I mean, I know why it's important but…what *is it*, exactly?"

Taline made a face. "A bio-metallic alloy derived from the dead remains of the Beast itself. Lots of innate properties, most important of which is rendering the Beast docile. It's extremely expensive to make. *What* it is isn't as important as what it could do, and we still couldn't win the war with it, even after we started using it wholesale. The creature had just grown too large to be stopped by conventional forces. Prime believed if we made a few more breakthroughs with it then we'd be able to turn the tide, but Evie was convinced he was wrong.

"She discovered the ruins of the First Ones…deciphered their notes on the Barrier. Then she outright refused to do anything other than pursue researching it, even with the threat of death looming upon her. I tried to convince her, but…" she shrugged, suddenly looking angry. "When the Emperor called for her head, Corynth and the rest of his people revealed themselves as members of the Daiamid. They took her and her team away to finish their research in secret."

“Prime didn’t just let her walk out the door,” Catra said. “From the way Salas talked, it sounded as if—”

“As if there were a fight,” Taline said, nodding. “There was. It was vicious.” She sighed, taking a long moment before speaking once again. “I was one of the justices at her trial. I tried to convince her to admit guilt, privately. Prime promised me he wouldn’t kill her if she submitted. She refused, and he called for her head anyways, even after I voted to acquit.

“The Daiamid stepped in to defend her. They were…incredible sorcerers, far more powerful than the army of battlemages there that day for Evelyn’s trial. I didn’t want her executed, obviously, but I didn’t trust what they were going to do if they abducted her, either. I…tried my best to stop them. I thought that if I kept their insurrection from succeeding then I might have been able to sway Prime—convince him to still spare her life anyways. But…they got away, and Prime still hasn’t lived it down, as you can tell.”

Another image came to Catra—one she had seen in passing while her mind still flip-flopped in the citadel’s medical ward, before Taline stabilized her. She was there too, standing on the steps of the Enclave Judiciary, the setting sun casting a dramatic background while soldiers and Battlemages fought the insurgents. She had witnessed Taline let loose a blinding fork of magic at someone in a deep cloak, a black mask covering his face in Prime’s memories. Catra remembered the rage she felt—his rage—when she had watched him deflect Taline’s spell with nothing but a gloved hand, much like Taline had done to Shadow Weaver.

“I think…I think I might have seen glimpses of that as well,” Catra said, blinking away the memory to return to Etheria. How did Evelyn discover all this stuff? The Barrier, ignominite…she couldn’t have just stumbled upon it, right?

Taline sighed, suddenly looking exhausted and aged. “Some people have special reactions when they come into contact with the Beast, if they live through the experience. Normally you’d die when it comes into contact with you and overwhelms your mind.

It would then use your body as a thrall, or worse, an Abomination. But in Evie's case…"

"She had an incredibly powerful member of the Daiamid to protect that mind of hers?"

Taline nodded. "Corynth manipulated her. Just like Salas stabilized your mind against Prime's influence, Corynth did so with Evelyn's against the Beast, just on a grander scale. Instead of dying when she touched consciousnesses with the thing, she saw through time."

"She what now?" Catra wasn't sure she heard her right. Saw through time?

"I'm not kidding," Taline said, turning to look at her. "It showed her glimpses of its previous conflicts with other civilizations. Memories and events from eons ago. She saw how one civilization nearly discovered ignominite before her, saw the First Ones and their Barrier…. she saw the Heart, which is how she knew of Etheria's coming. She warned us to prepare for you."

"And despite all of that, Horde Prime still decided to interfere and nearly screw everything up?"

"He was furious when she defied him," Taline said, shrugging. "The public had already seen Corynth and his Shapers in action at the final battle. It would have been impossible to discredit them, so he exalted them instead and proclaimed them the true heroes of the war. Then he had Evie's name wiped from existence to claw back any semblance of control he could."

"And the Enclave just accepted that?" Catra asked, growing angry both at the injustice of it all and how seemingly resigned to it Taline looked. "You have all this clout to convince him not to conquer our planet and enough bargaining power to get him to leave us alone, but they just went along with erasing someone who saved all their asses because Prime was pissed off about it?"

Taline sighed. “It sparked days of debate in our political chambers, but they ultimately accepted without challenge.”

“Why the hell would they do that? Don’t you think that’s kind of a betrayal to you and your sister?”

“Yes.” Taline looked at her with hard eyes and steel in her voice, and Catra finally saw the rage and anguish she had expected to see from the start, simmering there under the surface. “Of course it’s a betrayal. I hated going along with it too, but the galaxy needed help picking itself back up after what happened. I’ve never forgiven myself for not seeing what was really happening to her…for seeing through Corynth and how he was manipulating her. For not stopping it before it was too late.”

Catra understood the feeling. For all that Adora tried to reach out to her after she left the Horde, she never understood exactly *why* Catra never went along with her. She never saw underneath the surface at what really was going on with her despite every effort to do so. If this was the end result of a path like that, then…

“I don’t know what to say,” Catra said at last. “That’s just…It’s…” she growled, feeling frustrated at not being able to find the words. “I’m sorry.”

Taline shook her head. “It was eight years ago. Not a day goes by that I don’t think about it, but you learn to cope with the new normal. I told you about this because I want you to understand something. It’s okay to feel broken up about what happened between you and Adora. It’s okay if it takes you a long time to focus on something in your life other than her. But at some point, you have to move forward. If you don’t, you’ll end up like me.”

“That honestly doesn’t seem like a terrible thing, truth be told,” Catra said, earning a laugh.

“You’ll end up like me eight years ago, Catra, not like me right now. I had let my bitterness and envy control my every interaction with Evie until it was too late. I wasted my chance to know her

like a true sister, and in the end, it cost her life when I couldn't see how she was being used. At least with Adora, both of you are still alive, and there's the opportunity for your paths to cross again in the future."

Catra sighed and considered that. "I don't want to keep going through life trying to get back at her for leaving me," she said. "Even if she had a good reason to. I just don't know what to do now. The entire planet is going to be completely focused on the Heart. I'd like to help—heck, Scorpia even extended an invitation to come be an advisor in her new kingdom. But I feel like anything I do on this planet short of secluding myself deep in the woods or out in the Crimson Wastes is just going to remind me of her."

"It would be pretty hard to get away from that considering how central to the Enclaves plans Adora is."

Catra cursed under her breath and leaned back on her hands to stare up at the stars, matching Taline's posture. "I'd leave if I could," she said, thinking aloud. "See the galaxy, find a new place where I'd fit. But like Salas said at the briefing, only ex-Horde who are extended an invitation can go, and they'd be locked into a five-year term of service as front-line soldiers in the military. I'm not opposed to serving, I've been in Hordak's version of the Horde my whole life, but I didn't get an invitation to leave."

She shifted, suddenly feeling exposed. She had burned even more bridges with her old squad mates and the Etherian Horde in general long before Horde Prime's arrival. Her leadership under Hordak hadn't been well-received—not by Lonnie or Rogelio or the others, and she had a feeling her lack of an invitation to come along stemmed in part from that.

When she had heard Salas make the announcement after reconvening their briefing, and when she found out she hadn't been invited to serve like literally every other member of Hordak's old group had, it nearly broke her. Just thinking about it now still

made her uncomfortably sad, even though she wouldn't admit it to anyone but herself.

"About that," Taline said, a playful tone dancing at the edge of her words. "Why not come with me?"

One of Catra's ears quirked. "I'm sorry, can you say that again? I'm not sure I heard you correctly."

"Glimmer's coming too."

"What!?"

Taline laughed. "Just so we're clear, she approached *me* about it, I didn't go to her. In fact, I was initially against it until she gave me a few good reasons to consider."

"She just got both her parents back, why would she want to leave Etheria and come with you? No offense, but I don't understand that."

"It's not my place to share," Taline said. "If she wants to tell you then she will, and I won't say anything more about it than that. But I'm offering you the same opportunity because of the same reasons I agreed to bring her along. The only difference is she asked me to take her and I'm offering to take you, if you want."

"And what reasons do you have for bringing us?"

"You're both smart, resourceful—"

Catra scoffed and tried to wave her off.

"—you're talented," Taline said, leaning in and forcing her voice past Catra's attempts to brush them away. "I mean it Catra. The both of you could use some distance from this place to grow, and the galaxy just so happens to be in a place where they could use your talents. Everything we've done on Etheria for the past month helping to rebuild we've also been doing throughout the whole galaxy for the past eight years. And now that the Beast is slowly

returning, people are on edge. Our society is more fragile than ever."

Catra narrowed her eyes in thought. Sparkles was leaving? She had just started to become comfortable with her after everything, and one of the few silver linings Catra held close to her heart was, if she had to stay on Etheria, at least she'd be on good terms with Glimmer. Maybe even get a job she didn't hate and didn't force her to interact with Adora every day. But now? Now that Sparkles too was leaving? Was that what she wanted to talk to her about earlier? Was that why she had asked Catra to find her after finishing with Adora?

Taline pulled out a thin, saucer-shaped object from her jacket's breast pocket. She held it aloft between the two of them, and a holographic representation of what looked like a massive space station appeared above, rotating on its center axis.

"This is Phoenix Station," Taline said. "My new assignment for the foreseeable future, possibly until retirement."

"You agreed to accept whatever punishment Prime gave you in our place and he gave you command of a station?" Catra asked, incredulous.

"It's more complicated than that, but essentially yes. He wanted me expelled from the Enclave and thrown in prison, but whereas the Enclave didn't feel able to put their foot down with Evie, they stuck their necks out for me. I'm no longer a member of any of the Enclave's legislative councils or any of its steering committees. I have no more sentinels, and I no longer have a strong military following. I just have Phoenix Station and my job keeping peace in the sector of space it administrates."

She clicked a button and the spinning image transitioned into a visual of their spiral galaxy. A section of space in the middle rim highlighted in yellow.

“The station sits in this area of the mid-rim. You aren’t familiar with the Empire’s astrography so I’ll spare you the details, but it’s in an area that is decidedly tame. There’s little unrest, it’s not as crowded as the Heartlands and not as chaotic as the outer rim. It’s slow and boring and that’s part of the reason Prime put me there.

“None of this is a free ride, mind you. I’ll be training Glimmer in magic and putting her up for consideration with the Enclave since it’s the natural choice. You, on the other hand, have a few more options than she does, and still many more than your ex-Horde colleagues. You can’t do magic, but there are plenty of spots that can use your skills and attitude. You’ll have one year of probationary service under my sponsorship before you’re given official citizenship with the Empire. Normally it takes five years, but a sponsor from a member of the Enclave holds special weight.”

Catra ran scenarios through her mind so fast she was afraid she’d get whiplash. She could leave and start over! But then she’d be leaving the only home she’s known, ever. Sparkles would be there too! But what if it was worse for her out there than here? But she’d have a clean slate and this time, and the benefit of Taline’s guidance, rather than Shadow Weaver and the damned Fright Zone Horde.

“You don’t have to make a decision right away,” Taline said, resting a hand on Catra’s knee. “And you wouldn’t be saying goodbye to Etheria forever, either. The planet will make its debut on the galactic stage at some point in the future, whether in two years or five. I’ll see what I can do to get limited, periodic contact for the both of you in the meantime, but even if I can’t do that, it’s not like you’re saying goodbye forever.”

Another breeze swelled up around them causing Catra to shiver.

Taline stood. “We’re leaving tomorrow at 0900 sharp. A transport will land in the castle grounds to take us.” She stripped off her jacket and placed it around Catra’s shoulders. “Take the evening

to think it over, and find me in the morning, if not to come with me then to at least say goodbye and to return my jacket."

She winked at her and without another word, turned to stalk down the knoll they were sitting on and head back toward the castle. Catra watched her go, struck dumb at what had just happened. Another breeze picked up and she pulled the jacket tighter around her for more warmth.

"Oh, and remember," Taline said, shouting over her shoulder as she went. "Not a word about Evelyn. Not. A. Word."

Catra clicked her jaw shut and nodded vigorously, even though Taline wasn't looking at her. She watched her go until she was a speck in the distance before she turned back around toward the Whispering Woods. The platter Taline brought from earlier caught her eye, and her stomach gave a mighty growl; she was starved and her body wasn't going to let her get away with ignoring its needs any longer. Catra lifted the cover and a flurry of delicious smells assaulted her. Her mouth watered, immediately.

A swell of emotion nearly brought her to tears at the sheer display of kindness she had experienced that day. Despite the train wreck that happened with Adora, Sparkles' parents both welcomed her with open arms, as did Scorpia. Taline's kindness was the metaphorical boulder that broke the dam—it was almost too much to handle. Catra ate in silence and savored every bite, taking extra care to not accidentally spill anything on Taline's jacket.

After a time, she craned her neck to get a look at the patches sewn into the fabric. The jacket felt comfortable, but looked even better. The Enclave and Battlemage insignias stood out crisp against the black material, and looking at them sent a strange feeling of pride through her similar to how she felt looking at the Force Captain badges for the first time.

"Phoenix Station, huh?" She said, staring up at the stars. Catra took another bite of food and thought of her future, her mind running wild with imagination.

Chapter End Notes

Catra actually did glimpse pieces of Evelyn's story in Horde Prime's memories. All those context-less flashbacks from earlier chapters? That was it.

I made a cool little graphic for anyone curious--its a link to a png on a google drive: here

This is a non-spoiler timeline of the events discussed prior to the start of the story, along with the actual text and chapters from Catra's vision and where it lines up in the history. This is by no means required reading, just supplemental for anyone who's interested in this stuff. I'd suggest turning your device to the side and zooming if you're on mobile, and zooming still anyways if you're on a computer.

If anyone is familiar with the terms "Gardeners vs Architects" or "Pantser vs Plotter" when it comes to writing, I'm sure it's beyond obvious now that I fall firmly into the Architect/Plotter side of things :)

# An Unexpected Gift

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer anticipated the morning so much she hadn't slept at all through the previous night. After the festivities ended and she had finished speaking to everyone else, she and her parents had stayed up, enjoying the last moments they would have together for the foreseeable future. Even Bow came. This time, with no tension in his voice or body, Glimmer had been able to pretend everything between them was as it had once been. At least for the night.

When it finally came time for her to meet Taline in the courtyard, she slung the small bag of possessions she had packed over her shoulder and opened the door to her room to find an unexpected visitor standing there in the hallway, poised to knock.

"Hey," Adora said. Uncertainty flashed across her face; they had fought again after Catra nearly planted Glimmer into the floor in her haste to get away at the feast, and it was clear Adora wasn't sure she'd be welcome.

"Adora?" Glimmer adjusted the pack to sit more comfortably on her shoulder and glanced back at Bow and her parents still in the room. Her mom flashed her an encouraging smile, while Bow was too engrossed in conversation with her dad to have noticed them. "I'm surprised you came to say goodbye after what happened last night."

"I know, and I'm really sorry," Adora said. "You're right, I was afraid and overwhelmed hearing that you were leaving, and instead of being a good friend I got confrontational and hypocritical. But I'm sorry. Really, really sorry, and I really don't want us to leave off on a bad note like that. Your friendship means a lot to me too. I don't want to lose it."

Glimmer smiled and opened her arms wide for a hug. “Thank you for saying that.”

Adora shuffled into her arms and they pulled each other into a strong embrace. Truth be told, Glimmer was just as relieved as Adora looked. She had worried about their relationship all night after that second fight—she didn’t want to lose the friendship either.

“So where exactly is she taking you?” Adora asked, keeping pace with Glimmer after she beckoned to everyone still in her room and their group of five began trekking down the hall.

“Phoenix Station. It’s apparently an administrative hub somewhere in one of the more quiet, mid-rim Empire systems.” Glimmer heard Bow and her parents chatting quietly from behind as they followed. She felt grateful that they were conscientious enough to give her and Adora some time to catch up alone. “It’s supposed to take a few days to get there, even with the FTL drives on the *Constable*. Space is a lot bigger than I’d ever imagined.”

“Well, I hope you get some sleep on the trip,” Adora said. “Seriously, you look ready to keel over any minute now.”

“You’re one to talk,” Glimmer said, laughing. “You look half dead. Did you not sleep last night either?”

“I didn’t. I was too worried about what happened between us to sleep, and just as I was starting to drift off, Salas pulled me into a very early meeting with Entrapta and some of the engineering team to talk about She Ra and the sword.” Adora made a comically pained expression. “They would have gone longer but I cut it short so I could come see you off.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes with a smirk on her face and Adora, watching her reaction, laughed. Then, realizing that they had arrived at the castle’s front entrance, both of them stopped and the mood between them dampened.

“Hey,” Glimmer said turning and taking Adora’s hands into her own and running her thumb along her calloused knuckles. “Promise me you won’t put too much pressure on yourself? I know your powers haven’t come back to you yet, but you can’t keep pushing yourself like this. Nonstop training sessions, meetings booked every moment you aren’t conditioning yourself… it’s not healthy. Promise me you’ll cut yourself some slack.”

Adora looked anywhere but her. “Would you believe me if I said I will?”

“No, but I want you to tell me you’re going to at least try. I know you have an important part to play in this, but don’t go placing the entire survival of the galaxy on your shoulders, okay? The Heart will fail all the same if it’s you being unable to activate it or Frosta being unable to control her runestone as precisely as possible or Entrapta and the Enclave being unable to stabilize the planet’s energy signature. And if you kill yourself from stress then there’s nothing any of us can do from there. Promise me.”

Adora sighed and finally looked at her. “I’ll do my best, I promise.”

Glimmer eyed her, not entirely convinced, when Bow came up from behind.

“I’ll be sure to keep an eye out for her,” he said, smirking at Adora when she glared at him.

“We *all* will,” her dad said, earning a nod from her mom.

Satisfied, Glimmer let Adora’s hands drop and turned to glance out the open door to the castle grounds. The transport that was supposed to ferry them up to the *Constable* idled no more than a hundred steps away.

“Catra is supposed to meet us,” Glimmer said. “Either she’s going to come along or decide to stay here, but she’s supposed to at least talk to Taline in person. Do you want to come talk to her too?”

Adora's eyes lingered on the waiting transport. Glimmer expected to see anguish or at least surprise appear on her face learning Catra might be leaving too, but the look of conflict that sprung up suggested she had already anticipated this happening and was just struggling with how to respond to it.

Finally, Adora took a step back, hugging herself, still with an uncertain look on her face. "I'm not sure I should. After what I said last night…"

"You were emotional," Glimmer said. "I also kind of forced you into it, which I don't regret by the way, but if things came out wrong in the moment, now might be your last chance to iron things out before it's too late."

Adora bit her lip and thought. "No, I can't do that," she said after a moment, shaking her head. "You were right, I can't keep running away from my problems and, at some point, I have to draw a line in the sand and stand behind it. It didn't come out the way I wanted last night, but I meant everything that I said. I'm not going to be able to stick to anything at all if I tell her to give me space only to go back on that less than a day later."

Glimmer thought Adora was making a mistake. She had caught the end of their conversation and had a sinking feeling the both of them got on separate pages despite having had the same conversation. But Adora had a point, and if she really wanted to focus on the Heart and her powers, who was Glimmer to force her to talk to Catra again? The first time had already been a disaster.

"Okay," Glimmer said, after deciding it would only further damage her already fragile and recently made-up relationship with Adora to push the issue. "If you think that's what's best, then I understand."

Adora nodded and everyone pulled together for a group hug.

"Be safe out there," Adora said. "And as soon as you get some way to contact us, you'd better do it. I'm not going to feel better

about anything until I hear that you're doing okay."

Glimmer grunted her affirmation into Adora's shoulder and let her shirt soak up her tears.

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Catra scrambled.

*Shit shit shit I'm late*.

She had woken up when the rays of the morning sun, peeking through the branches of the tree she had fallen asleep under, stabbed her in the eyes. One moment she had laid there boneless, Taline's jacket draped over the front of her like a blanket, and the next she was a ball of speed and adrenaline, sprinting to the castle, hoping she hadn't slept through Taline's departure. It wasn't until she saw the transport still idling on the castle grounds that she allowed herself to catch her breath.

She moved quickly then, heading back to her room and shoving the few belongings she had into a sack. She almost knocked on Scorpia's and Entrapta's doors as she passed their rooms in the castle's guest quarter, but she chickened out and used the lack of time as an excuse to justify heading straight back to the transport. Taline, wearing a long coat that reached halfway down her booted calves, was halfway up the ramp into the belly of the craft as Catra rounded the corner out the side exit back onto the grounds.

"I've decided to come," Catra said, handing Taline back her jacket after taking extra time to fold it as neatly as she could. "Phoenix Station sounds interesting. I'm curious to see what's out there."

"There's still about ten minutes before we leave," Taline said. "Take your time and say your goodbyes, the pilots still need to get through their pre-flight checklist."

*Well crap*, Catra thought, looking around the grounds anxiously. She had made such a rush to get to the transport it felt like some of the wind had been taken out of her sails having to just wait.

She looked back toward the castle entrance and saw Sparkles, flanked by Arrow Boy and her parents, making their way toward them on foot. They all waved to her and Catra gave an awkward wave back. A thought hit her, and she looked around for Adora, fearing she'd tag along. Catra didn't want to put up with the awkwardness trying to figure out how to act in front of her after what happened the previous night. Thankfully, Adora didn't show, and Catra settled into a half-alert sense of security.

"Sooo," Glimmer said, sidling up to Catra with Bow while her parents went to talk with Taline. "What did you decide?"

"I'm coming," Catra said. "It just makes sense, I guess. And Etheria isn't gone forever. I think being away for a bit might be good for me. I have to say though, I'm surprised you're leaving too."

"Yeah, part of me is still surprised myself, believe it or not. I'll tell you why on the way."

"Watch out for her while you two are out there, okay?" Bow said, looking Catra in the eyes. He seemed to refused to look in Glimmer's direction.

"I will," Catra said, not wanting to chance ruining the moment with some ill-timed deflection. Glimmer had told her Bow's reaction to her apology, that they were not okay, and she was certain Glimmer was just as surprised hearing him say those words as Catra was surprised at hearing them asked of her.

Movement out the corner of her eye drew her attention, and Catra turned. Two people she didn't at all expect to see were running toward her from the castle and waving their hands as if to flag down her attention.

"Scorpia? Entrapta?" she said, taking halting steps around Bow and toward them, not entirely sure she was seeing things correctly.

"Catra!" they both yelled at the same time.

Scorpia waved with even more energy when she realized Catra had seen them, while Entrapta was holding some sort of wrapped box in her hands. Catra glanced behind her to question Bow and Glimmer with a look, but they had both turned and headed back toward the King and Queen, conversing with Taline by the ramp.

"What are you guys doing here?" Catra asked, turning back to the two of them as they pulled up in front of her.

"What do you mean?" Scorpia asked, panting. "We heard you might be leaving, so of course we weren't going to let you leave without at least seeing you off."

"I can't believe you were going to go and not say goodbye!" Entrapta said, her hair flying about. "After everything we've been through."

Catra winced. "Actually, that's uh…well part of the reason why I wasn't sure if I shoul—"

Entrapta's hair suddenly covered her mouth and cut her off. "Oh hush," she said, a mad scientist's grin plastered on her face. "You and I already had our talk and I've forgiven you. I'm just giving you a hard time, unless you have something else you wanted to talk about?" Catra quickly shook her head and Entrapta took her hair away before pushing the box she was holding into Catra's hands. "Here. Scorpia and I wanted to give this to you."

Catra looked down and stared at the box. A present?

She undid the latch and opened it at Scorpia's and Entrapta's excited prodding. Inside, propped up on the velvet-pillowed interior, sat what looked like a large screen attached to red straps.

"It's a PDA!" Entrapta said, practically bouncing on her heels as she took the contraption out of the box. "Hold out your left arm. Wait, you're left-handed if I remember correctly, right? Give me the right one instead. It has to go on your non-dominant arm."

Catra, feeling the effects of years growing up with Shadow Weaver trying to train her out of using her dominant hand, stowed the box under her left arm and reluctantly raised her right.

"I've been working on this baby essentially since I finished helping bring Angella back," Entrapta said, strapping the device to her. "The Enclave has some craaaaazy tech, and their wrist PDAs were just too cool for me to not try and replicate. I couldn't think of anything to give you as a thank you for bringing you-know-who back, and then it hit me. I'll give you my prototype!"

"You don't have to do that," Catra said, feeling awkward about Entrapta's gratitude she didn't think she deserved. Scorpia only watched with glee on her face and her claws pressed to her cheeks.

"I want to," Entrapta said. "Actually, I gave you the second prototype. Mine is the first, just to test out a lot of the features." Catra caught a glimpse of a second, far chunkier looking device under Entrapta's own sleeve.

"I made the straps!" Scorpia said. "Genuine leather, with my own two claws." She clicked them in front of her face and grinned.

"There," Entrapta said, pulling the last buckle tight and turning Catra's limb to expose the screen on the underside of her forearm. She tapped at it and a streamlined interface popped up on the LCD. "I didn't have time to put in the holographic display so it's not as cutting edge as I'd like it to be, but functionally everything is there."

She started flitting through the icons while Catra looked on, overwhelmed both by her friends' enthusiasm and from the fact she had friends like this at all after everything she had done.

"You've got your basic tools," Entrapta said. "Calculator, scheduler, rudimentary speech recognition, picture and video capabilities. Oh! I like this one."

She tapped one of the icons and a light at the front end of the device turned on.

"It's a flashlight! But not just any flashlight." A control widget had popped up when she selected the program and Entrapta slid it all the way to its most powerful setting. Despite it being morning and the daylight being in full effect, Catra had to shield her eyes as the light shooting from her wrist nearly blinded her.

"It's suuuuuper powerful," Entrapta said. "Be careful not to burn anyone's eyes out with it."

"This is…wow this is a lot," Catra said after Entrapta turned off the light.

"Not really," Entrapta said. "I just included the basics and rooted it as much as possible on the Enclave's software infrastructure. I'm not sure what kind of tech and systems they have out there since I haven't ever been to space, but it will theoretically talk to their computers. You should be able to upgrade it and add more software as you need."

"Oh, oh, oh and there are little videos from us!" Scorpia came over and pressed one of the icons, bringing up a recorded video of her and Entrapta sitting in their guest room in the castle. Lamps lit the room and Catra could see stars in the sky out the window behind them. They must have recorded it the previous night.

"Hi Catra!" the both of them said, the excitement in their voices coming through the PDA's speakers. "So, we're kind of recording a lot of this one last minute since apparently you may be lea—"

Scorpia quickly cut off the recording and ran a claw along the back of her head with a sheepish expression. "May want to save that and watch it when you're alone," she said. "I got a little teared up in it, so…"

Catra just stared at the device strapped to her arm, then startled when Entrapta suddenly asked in a small voice if she didn't like it.

“No! I mean…I mean, yes! It’s amazing, it’s just…wow. You did all this for me?”

Entrapta and Scorpia both nodded at the same time.

“I love it,” Catra said, the biggest grin spreading across her face.

Scorpia pulled the both of them into a fierce bear hug, and Catra felt the air squeeze out of her as her legs dangled. Then, giving in to the happiness filling her to near bursting, she wrapped her arms around the both of them before her brain had the chance to put the brakes on.”

“Super Pal Trio,” Scorpia said, setting the both of them on the ground. “Never forget.”

Entrapta and Catra both nodded with big smiles on their faces. “Super Pal Trio,” they both said.

The transport’s engines surged behind them, kicking up a gust of wind that buffeted the trees and threatened to bowl them all over.

“All aboard!” Taline said, standing tall at the threshold between the ramp and the interior, her long coat flapping furiously against the swell of the jet engines. “Always wanted to say that.”

Catra pulled her friends into one last quick hug, waved to Bow and Micah and Angella as Glimmer said her final goodbyes to them, and boarded. Glimmer followed soon after, and the both of them turned and stood on the inside precipice of the vessel, waving to their respective groups of friends as the ramp pulled up.

“I’m with the pilots in the cockpit,” Taline said after the ramp fully closed and sealed them in. “You and Glimmer just strap into one of the seats and enjoy the view.”

Row after row of austere seats lined the inside of the craft. Catra picked a forward-facing one near a bulkhead window and strapped herself into the full body harness. Glimmer, rubbing her eyes with her sleeve and looking like she was trying as hard as

she could not to cry, threw herself into the backward facing chair directly across from her.

The g-forces picked up as the craft lifted off and Catra looked out the window. Everyone was still waving and continued to do so as the ground fell further and further away from them. Catra waved back even though she was certain they couldn't see her, and she pushed away the mounting wave of bittersweet emotions growing inside. She glanced toward the castle's main entrance and swore she saw a red jacket framing a patch of blonde hair, standing half hidden behind the open main entrance. But, when she squinted to take a closer look, they had already pushed high enough into the air she couldn't make out any details.

Clouds blanketed the window for a moment and Catra leaned back into the chair to relax, feeling the vibrations of the ship as it shot through the atmosphere. Her jaw nearly dropped when they came out of the cloud covering and she saw Etheria's curve and the sunrise in the distance. Stars twinkled above the horizon, growing clearer as the sky grew blacker.

"We're really leaving, aren't we?" Catra asked, staring up into space with awe.

She glanced over at Glimmer when she didn't hear a response. Glimmer had her face smooshed against her own window, fast asleep, snoring softly with a bit of drool threatening to spool loose from her mouth. Catra cracked a smile, unable to keep from laughing. Glimmer looked terrible with the bags hanging under her eyes. It was good she was finally getting some sleep.

Unable to calm her own giddiness, Catra turned to the PDA strapped to her arm. She marveled at the gift and thought back on her friends as she flicked through the menus and got accustomed to the device. She finally figured out how to work the camera, and snapped a picture of Glimmer conked out in the chair.

The craft burned through the atmosphere and into space. It made slow, steady progress toward the cruiser idling in orbit, waiting to take them someplace new.

## End of Part One

Chapter End Notes

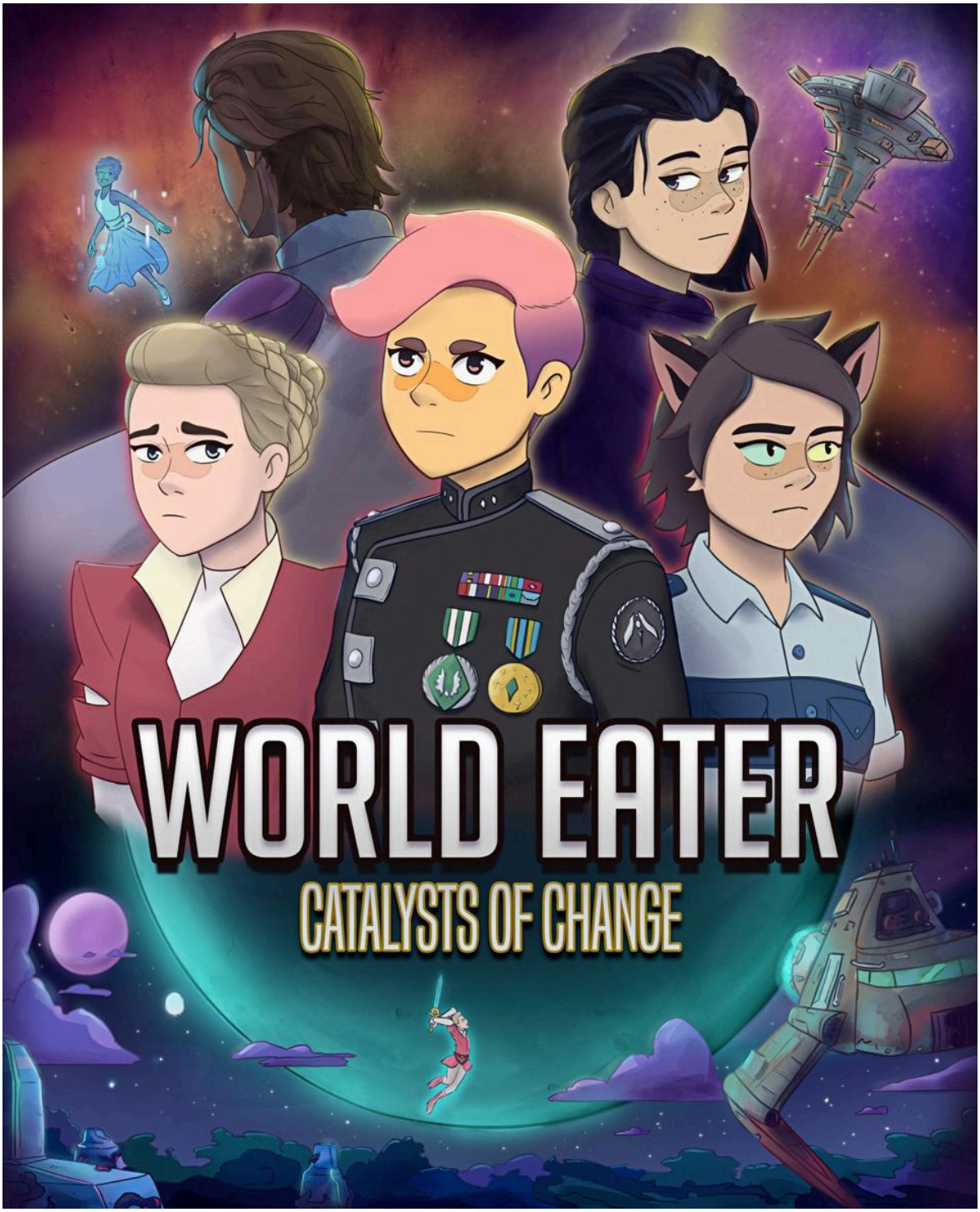
> And that's a wrap for part 1! Thank you everyone who's been reading and commenting so far--the story is far from over. If you've been following along from the beginning and didn't go back to peek at chapter 1 like the before-chapter note said, I'd highly suggest looking now. I had some fantastic poster art commissioned for this story, and the artist did an amazing job with it. Best of all, it's just the first piece of several I get to show you!
>
> If you've enjoyed what you've read so far, then I'm happy to say the story continues (obviously), and really dives into and expands upon the threads I've introduced. What's Adora's deal? Does she get She Ra back at some point? What about Catra and her whole thing now that she's left and is no longer anchored (physically) by Etheria and Adora? What's Glimmer going to get up to? Do they defeat the Beast? Does Etheria and the Enclave get the Heart up and working in time? Corynth and Evelyn and Taline?
>
> Each of our big three (Catra, Adora, Glimmer) will have their own arcs. These arcs tie into the larger conflict (the Beast). We see more of the galaxy as we follow these characters in their struggles, so for those of you that liked the world building I've done so far, there's more! And it's not just window dressing, it's used. In fact, some things have already been foreshadowed and hinted at in part 1 :)

# Part II: Catalysts of Change, Chapter 17: A New Normal

Chapter Notes

> The response for part 1 has been amazing. Thank you to everyone who's reading, and an even bigger thank you to those who take the time to leave a kudo or comment. It really means a lot :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes




Art commission done by SzethK. Linktree: [Here]

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**Chapter Seventeen: A New Normal**

Glimmer sat forward in her chair with her elbows on the desk, rubbing at her temples to soothe the headache brewing there

while she stared at Adora's hopeful face through the ansible. It had been three years since they last saw each other in person, but to her eyes, god…Adora might as well have aged almost a decade.

"I haven't been able to find any new information on the Daiamid," Glimmer said. "It doesn't look like the Enclave has any special records other than what's already available to the general public."

All the hope in Adora's eyes vanished, as was expected, and Glimmer felt the wave of guilt she had prepared for hit her like a bus. She had been traveling for days in hyperspace aboard an Enclave cruiser, having just come off another deployment that taxed her more than she'd care to admit. Kicking Adora while she was down was exactly what she didn't need right then and there.

"How is that possible?" Adora asked, brow creasing in thought. "How can they stop an apocalyptic event dead in its tracks but there's literally almost no information about them?"

"I'm sorry," Glimmer said. If only she could just reach through the stupid ansible and hug her, but communicating in real time across hundreds of light years of distance as they were was miracle enough, she supposed.

Adora shook her head. "It's not your fault, I'm sorry for getting upset. It's just, you'd think there would be *something* to go off of. There isn't even a mention of where they came from."

"They're all dead and gone, Adora, and they were the Emperor's personal assassins. He's controlling the narrative, like he's always done. I thought maybe there'd be something in the Enclave's personal archives, but he must have had everything about them scrubbed even from there a long time ago."

Adora blinked at her. "You've been doing that for a while now."

"Doing what?"

"Calling him the Emperor."

Glimmer sighed and slumped down a little further in the chair. "That's because he *is* the Emperor, Adora. No one out here calls him Horde Prime."

It really wasn't as big a deal as Adora was making it out to be. One of the first things Glimmer had learned about the empire was, while Horde Prime was about as bad as they came, everyone else were just regular people like her or Catra or her parents, trying to live their lives. The Emperor was a despot, sure, but his empire was actually a stable place for most. Glimmer had come to understand Taline's reluctance to fight for her sister's name after learning how much doing so might have jeopardized the stability of all of society after the end of the war.

Still, even though Adora knew that about the empire, she wouldn't understand it, and she was still sensitive to all the changes that had happened over the years since they parted. Glimmer couldn't really blame her for being so constantly wound tight; even seeing her with her hair styled short with an undercut for the first time had knocked Adora off balance, and Glimmer was convinced it would only stun her again if she ever decided to grow it out to its original length she had as queen.

Adora sat forward toward the ansible and brought both hands up to fret at the braid tucked high at the back of her head. "It's fine, I get it, just…what am I supposed to do now?"

"Have you asked Salas about it?" The look Adora gave her said everything she needed to know and Glimmer grew impatient. "Salas would know more than me in the first place, Adora. He's been around longer, likely has access to more sensitive information than a rookie would have—"

"A genius rookie," Adora said, interrupting her

Glimmer waved her off. "Whatever, you know what I mean. If there's a single person who could point you in the right direction with the Daiamid, it'd be Salas. Why haven't you asked him about it?"

Adora fidgeted and spoke in a quiet, almost shy voice. "I don't want to bother him."

"Are you for real right now?" Glimmer asked. One second, she wanted to hug her through the ansible and the next she wanted to reach through and wring her neck.

"What? He's got a million and one other things on his mind he has to keep track of. I don't want to get in the way of that just to ask him about some wild goose chase of a theory I have."

"And why is it that you've come to this 'wild goose chase' of a theory in the first place? Oh yeah. Because despite everything you've tried for the past three straight years, you still haven't been able to reconnect with She Ra. You're desperate."

Adora froze and her lip trembled and Glimmer immediately felt guilty. "I'm sorry." she said with a sigh. "I didn't mean to sound so angry about it. I'm coming off three deployments back-to-back and I can sense how stressed out you are. And that's making me more stressed…like a feedback loop."

Adora shrugged. "It's okay."

"It makes sense what you're doing and I get why you want to look into it," Glimmer said. "Especially since you've tried literally everything else. Extreme training sessions with Mermista and Scorpia? Beating the crap out of hundreds of Entrapta's bots for hours with Frosta when she needs to blow off just as much steam as you? Endless magic training sessions with my parents?" Glimmer held up fingers as she counted off the crazy stories Adora had shared with her over the years, all in attempt after attempt to reconnect with her powers. "Remember when you tried those hallucinogenic leaves and went on a six-day meditation binge with Perfuma?"

Adora groaned and threw her head back in her chair, all trace of hurt replaced with embarrassment. "Don't remind me," she said. "I couldn't tell up from down and those six days felt like six years."

"You made out with one of those pretty royals from her court as well," Glimmer said, a grin spreading across her face.

"Who told you about that!?" Adora covered her face with her hands. "Did Perfuma tell you?"

"You bet your ass she did! Oh my god, she said you made that poor noble walk around in a daze for a week because of that." Glimmer snorted and almost fell off her chair with laughter.

Adora pulled her hands away from her face, revealing mortified eyes and a tomato-red complexion. "I needed to soak in the tub for hours just to feel clean again after that. And I still wasn't any closer to getting She Ra back!"

"Yeah, but that's probably the most relaxed I'd ever seen you since we took that trip to Mystacor and did the hot springs. You've tried everything except taking a vacation, Adora. The planning and political meetings will go on without you for a week or two, why don't you just take some time off for the sake of your own sanity?"

Adora hemmed and hawed, talking about not being able to relax even if she took time off.

"If you're not going to think about taking a break, then will you at least agree to talk to Salas?" Glimmer asked. "I mean it when I say your line of thinking makes sense. The Daiamid were powerful enough to rebuff Battlemages like Taline and shove the Beast on its ass. She Ra is just as powerful, if not more so. There has to be *something* you can learn from them if we can just get our hands on the information."

"Salas has started pulling me from meetings," Adora said, voice turning small again.

"He's what?"

"You mentioned that planning and political meetings will go on without me, like that's a good reason for me to take a break from

them. But they've already been going on without me for a few weeks now. I haven't been able to join the last few sessions. There's a list you have to be on to be let in, and I've been removed. He's the only one I can think of that would do that."

Glimmer furrowed her brow. That didn't seem right. "And let me guess, you haven't gone and asked him about that either?"

Adora shook her head. "I think he's starting to lose faith in me. Why else would he take me off? I know this sounds stupid, but I'm afraid to go and talk to him about it only to see him look back at me and tell me how I'm disappointing everyone…that I'm a failure for still not getting this."

Glimmer nodded. "That's not a stupid thing to be afraid of, Adora, especially since there's a lot riding on your shoulders. But I don't think you're being excluded because he's losing faith in you. You're She Ra, they need you. My guess is he's trying to forcefully give you more time for yourself rather than stress you out with more meetings."

"I don't know…" Adora said, rubbing her shoulders and looking away.

"You're driving yourself insane trying to get back in touch with your powers. You're right that it's a matter of galactic concern that you haven't been able to yet, but I also don't think anyone has any room to judge. I would be clawing my eyes out if that was still happening to me after three years. Screw Salas and his busy schedule. Put yourself in front of him and tell him you need his help. I guarantee you he isn't shutting you out, Adora. Your issues are worth being addressed."

Glimmer had spoken to Salas more than a few times through the ansible since her departure; he was her main point of contact for updates on Etheria and the Heart project. That, coupled with what Taline had said about him during their time together, only cemented the idea in her head he was a strong and true ally despite their initial introductions.

Adora brightened, and she even gave Glimmer a small smile, although it didn't reach to her eyes. "Okay," she said. "I'll think about it. I'm still invited to the Induction Ceremony in a few days, so I should have the perfect opportunity to get some one-on-one time with him."

Glimmer grimaced. Adora's mention of the ceremony made her think of Narre and Miri's deaths aboard the Emperor's citadel. Adora must have caught on because her smile disappeared.

"Are you okay?" Adora asked, leaning closer to the ansible to get a better look at her.

"Yeah, fine." Glimmer rubbed harder at her temples. "How have the nightmares been for you recently?"

"They've started picking up again," Adora said, looking troubled. "It's always on the anniversary and it's always of the same thing. I'm guessing it's the same with you?"

Glimmer nodded. They didn't say anything for a while after that. They didn't need to. While the nightmares of the Beast subsided with time, they always returned for a bit around the anniversary of the Emperor's invasion of Etheria—when Taline had first stepped between them and the Emperor back on the citadel.

"How is Catra doing?" Adora asked, breaking the silence.

A number of responses filtered through Glimmer's brain with the surprise at hearing Adora ask that question. She chose to lead with the safest possible response. "I haven't heard anything out of the ordinary, but that's usually how it goes with her. I won't hear about how it's affecting her this year until I see her again in a few days."

"You're going back to Phoenix?"

Glimmer nodded. "I've been on too many deployments one after the other. You know better than most how hard the Enclave pushes their Battlemages, but even they know to give us time to

recharge. I have two weeks of shore leave approved as soon as I arrive." Glimmer had vented more than once to Adora when Taline's training regiments pushed her too hard, so she understood just how unforgiving the Enclave could be.

"Now you're just trying to guilt me into a vacation," Adora said, keeping her voice light.

"Even if I am, I'm not apologizing for it," she said, matching her tone. "You need a break, Adora. Even Catra would say so if she were here right now."

Glimmer watched Adora's expression change, watched her pull up her walls and hide behind them. Every other time she had brought either Catra up to Adora or Adora up to Catra it hadn't ended well, so she chose her words carefully as she navigated the same minefield for the hundredth time.

"You know, a lot has changed since we left," Glimmer said. "You aren't the only one learning to let yourself lean on people a little bit again, asking me to look into the Daiamid for you."

"What do you mean?" Adora asked.

"Catra asked me to look into something for her as well. I didn't find much, but what little I did helped."

"*Catra* asked you for help?" Adora looked at a complete loss for words.

"Yep," Glimmer said, nodding. "That should clue you in to how much she's changed. It's been a long time, Adora…maybe you should reach out to her? I can pass along a message from you if you don't want to do something live though an ansible. Who knows, maybe having her rip you a new one and tell you to take a vacation will be the kick in the ass you need to actually do it."

The corner of Adora's lips tug up in a smirk and Glimmer nearly leapt off her chair and did a dance right then and there. That was the best reaction she'd seen Adora have toward Catra since ever.

A clamor echoed through the ansible and Adora turned to look somewhere off screen. Her expression turned irritated as the commotion grew louder, now mixing with the muffled sounds of people arguing nearby.

"Can you guys wait until I'm done in here before you start putting things down?" Adora asked, clearly trying to remain professional. "I'm in the middle of a call right now. It's expensive." A muffled, response came through. "No! No just, ugh…just put it down and get out please. I'm almost done."

Another muffled reply, and then the sound of a door hissing shut, cutting the voices off.

"Sorry," Adora said, turning to look back at her. "I'm at the Scorpion Kingdom and Entrapta has had delivery after delivery of all new tech into her lab. None of the delivery people know where to put the new machinery and they've just been stacking them wherever there's space."

Glimmer bit back an amused expression, fully understanding the kind of chaos that could swirl around Entrapta without her even trying. "I'm surprised you didn't try and convince me you were already taking a vacation by going to the Scorpion Kingdom."

Adora laughed. "Trust me, I thought about it. Bright Moon was getting a little too claustrophobic for me, so I agreed to come here and help Entrapta with whatever. She's been going on about a pattern in the security breaches we've had and has been hyper focused on nailing it down."

"Are you actually able to help with that stuff?"

"No, but she tells me it helps when she has someone to bounce ideas off of like a sounding board. Although I'm not sure why she still asked me to come when Hordak is down here with her as well."

"Hordak is away from the fleet?" Glimmer asked, incredulous. Finding out Catra had pushed Taline to bring him back had thrown

the princesses for a collective loop about a month after they left, but things had smoothed over considerably over the years. Salas had put him in charge of the Orbital Defense Fleet over the Etheria, and that was that.

"He's uh…apparently on shore leave as well," Adora said, shifting uncomfortably in her seat and refusing to look at her.

A beat passed between them before Glimmer laughed outright. "All this talk about vacations and even Hordak the notorious workaholic has you beat? Wow."

Adora grumbled. "Yeah, I know, okay. I get it." She sighed and leaned forward, resting her head on the table in front of the ansible. "I still can't believe Salas managed to convince us to let him stick around and help, let alone give him command over parts of our fleet."

"Hey, this is the same guy that managed to convince the Enclave High Council to give me communications clearance with Etheria. If he can do that, plus keep the Emperor off your backs while working on the Heart, anything else he manages to accomplish I'm not all that surprised by."

"That's true," Adora said, picking her head up off the table and smoothing her hair.

"Go talk to him, Adora. I'm honestly surprised you came to me first, although I am flattered."

"I will," she said. "I already said I would, didn't I?" She thought for a moment, scrunching her face in thought and reminding Glimmer of simpler times with the lack of conflict in her expression. "Yeah, I definitely said I'd go talk to him. Thanks for the pep talk, Glimmer."

"Any time. How is everyone else doing?"

Adora shrugged. "Nothing much has changed since last month. Sea Hawk and Swift Wind are driving your Aunt nuts in Mystacor,

Bow is here tinkering with incorporating more tech into his arrows, and Frosta is visiting as well. Entrapta and the Enclave are still pulling their hair out trying to figure out Light Hope."

"Still?" Glimmer asked, concern dawning on her features. She ignored the fact Adora had slipped Bow's name in there and chose to focus on the larger issue. "It's been months and they haven't made a single step forward?"

Adora shook her head. "No, they haven't, unfortunately. That's part of the reason she's had so many deliveries. She hit a slump, then like a thousand new ideas hit her and she mass ordered a bunch of stuff to try it all."

Glimmer laughed. "That sounds like Entrapta, all right." A notification blipped on the top corner of the screen and she sighed. "My time is almost up. I have to go."

Adora nodded, a sad expression coming across her face. "I know. Sorry for hogging the entire session this time. Especially since Bow didn't…y'know."

"No! No, it's okay," Glimmer said. Maybe it was a bit naïve for her to think Adora wouldn't keep pushing when she didn't react to Bow's name the first time. He hadn't passed a message through Salas for her this month, and with Adora taking up the whole hour on the ansible they had, it meant she wouldn't hear from him until the following month at the earliest. Still, she refused to feel bad for helping her friend when she so clearly needed it.

Adora's eyes narrowed in scrutinizing concern. "Glimmer…"

"I'm happy to help," Glimmer said. "Really. Whatever you need, I'm here. I'm sure he'll make it up to me next month." She put on a smile for Adora's sake and didn't let it fade until it was obvious Adora wouldn't push further. "Think about what I said with Catra," she said. "Even if it's just a recorded message, I'll pass it along for you."

"I'll think about it," Adora said. "Be safe out there."

Glimmer hit the kill switch and the screen connecting her and Adora across lightyears of space flickered off. She sighed and leaned back in the chair. To her great relief, the melancholy that had been threatening to bubble up from under the surface didn't return. There was still an exhaustion she felt in her bones, but that was something she knew how to handle. Deployments always deprived her of much needed sleep, and the nightmares would likely continue for a few days more. She knew what to expect.

Hopefully Taline wouldn't be there to greet her when she disembarked on Phoenix Station in a few days, though. To the untrained eye Glimmer's uniform looked pristine—Enclave patches and Battlemage pin undoubtedly level and immaculate. But the effects of her sleep deprived state bled through into its appearance in subtle ways Taline would no doubt pick up on. Despite having ridden her raw for over a year in training—thus helping her perform under pressure on her deployments and rocketing her to minor infamy within the Enclave, despite technically still being a rookie—her mentor wouldn't take pity on her for nightmares.

Glimmer stretched further still, her joints letting loose a cascade of pops and cracks that felt as amazing as they'd have been off-putting to anyone who might have been sitting there with her. She tapped a few commands into the ansible's control panel, connected it to her list of contacts stored on her wrist PDA, and navigated to Catra's name. She typed a quick message and sent it off before heaving her body off the chair and padding out of the communications chamber, intent on finding something to eat and more caffeine to keep the dreams at bay.

Chapter End Notes

> Me first plotting out Catra and Adora's arcs: "Yeah, a *little* distance and time away from each other would be good for them"
>
> Me when writing the first chapter of part two: "So three years go by..."

"Ansibles" are my homage to Ursula K. Leguin :)

# In Plain Sight

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"For the honor of Grayskull!"

Adora cracked open an eye and looked up at the wooden training sword she held aloft. It hadn't transformed like it was supposed to, and the runestone embedded in the gauntlet clasped to her forearm twinkled as if mocking her.  The purple hue of Entrapta's lab within the Scorpion Kingdom did little to calm her nerves and Adora groaned, lowering the sword to her side.

"Still nothing, huh?" Bow said. Surrounded by crates piled high with Entrapta's new experiment equipment, he knocked another arrow and sent it down the makeshift shooting range—the only part of the lab not currently crowded beyond use. It slammed into the center chest piece of a bot, powered off and tied to a post. "Did it feel any different that time?"

"No different than the other hundred-thousand times I've tried," she said, tossing the sword to the ground with a clatter. "It's there, I can feel it under the surface, it just…won't come to me. I'm getting desperate here. How does holding a practice sword to bring the real one out even make sense?"

"Hey!" a nearby voice said. Frosta stared her down with an irate expression as she kicked her legs against the particularly tall stack of crates she sat upon.

"I mean, it's true!" Adora said, leaning against another nearby crate.

"You thought it was a good enough idea when I suggested you give it a try," Frosta said. She had traveled from her kingdom for the Induction Ceremony in Bright Moon, but a special attachment she had grown in the intervening years since the Enclave's first

appearance necessitated a detour to the old Fright Zone first. The doors leading into the lab hissed open and she turned a pointed look to the person who stepped through. “You thought it was a good idea too, right?”

Hordak didn’t even lift his eyes from the tablet he plucked at when he responded. “Did I think what was a good idea?” He made his way through the maze of crates to Entrapta, sitting hunched at her desk in the back, whispering rapidly to herself as she worked. She had spiraled into a funk trying and failing for so long to make any sort of progress on Light Hope that he had suggested she lock herself in the lab for a few days and work on something else.

He glanced up when no one responded, his eyes flicking to the wooden sword on the ground, then to Adora’s frustrated expression, then to Frosta’s expectant one before he seemed to realize what they were asking him. “You’re really getting desperate, aren’t you?” he asked Adora.

Adora threw her arms up in the air, nearly ready to tear her hair out. She felt agitated and sweaty all of a sudden, and reached up behind her head to feel at the braid tucked high and tight there. She had started tying it in that fashion to keep it out of the way while she trained, and found putting it up in that complicated style helped calm her in and of itself, almost like a meditative ritual. The only problem was her having made a habit of constantly checking to make sure it was still perfect; likely her body trying to find any excuse to undo and then redo it to pacify her mind.

“I don’t suppose *you* have any ideas of your own, do you?” she said to Hordak. “Might as well ask you since I’ve been making the rounds again, talking to anyone I can grab hold of to see what they think I could try next.”

“I don’t have anything new to suggest, no.” He turned his eyes back to his tablet, already unplugging from the conversation. Adora wasn’t ready to let him go.

“You pulled me from that portal as a baby,” she said, stepping up to him. “The first one you opened to try and reach Prime years ago. You brought me back to the Fright Zone, gave me to Shadow Weaver to raise me. Are you saying you had no idea about She Ra or my connection to the sword when you found me?” Adora set her jaw when she saw how Bow and Frosta reacted to her bringing up Shadow Weaver. They hadn’t seen or heard from her after she left with the Emperor, and everyone knew Adora never brought her up unless she was really spiraling. “Nothing comes to mind that you knew back then that might help me now?”

“Nothing,” Hordak said, shaking his head. “I saw an infant swaddled in a blanket with no one there to care for her, and decided it better to bring you with me than let you succumb to the elements. It was Shadow Weaver who insisted on raising you herself when I suggested we put you with the rest of the young orphans, and I allowed it if it meant she’d let me return to my experiments in peace.” He sighed and gave her a rarely-seen sympathetic look. “The other princesses, Frosta included, have been training diligently with Micah and the Enclave Mentors for years now. Have you tried them?”

“If you bothered to pay attention to anything other than the fleet up in orbit then you would have known I’ve done more training with them over the past three years than all the rest of the princesses combined,” Adora said. She ignored the way Frosta beamed at Hordak for referencing her. It was stupid, and she knew it, but even that small exchange only seemed to sour her mood further. At least Frosta was making measurable progress with them.

“Then I’m afraid I don’t have much to offer when it comes to fixing your…problem,” Hordak said. “I’m sorry.”

Adora deflated and sank back onto one of the crates again. Despite what she had expressed to Glimmer, Hordak had turned into a valuable asset and an unlikely ally since his reappearance. Even Frosta warmed up to him, to the extent she would purposefully seek out opportunities to spend time with him when

he came down for leave on the surface; she had gravitated toward him like an unlikely father figure, which undoubtedly helped endear him to the last of the Etherians that still looked at him sideways.

Adora had learned to live with it, especially since he also made Entrapta happy, but she never fully acclimated to it. His presence was a permanent reminder to her that, while even their old enemies were contributing to the war preparations in unexpected ways, she still couldn't manage the one thing that was expected of her: summon She Ra.

A hand rested on her shoulder and she turned. Bow was there, flashing her a reassuring look.

"It will be okay," he said.

"Thanks." Adora reached up to grab his hand with her own. "By the way," she said, dipping her voice low and looking around to make sure the others weren't listening in. "Glimmer."

Bow's face hardened. "I don't—" He moved to pull his arm away, but Adora held it firm.

"She tried really hard to not let it show, but I *know* she was upset you didn't write to her." Adora leaned further into his space. "We only get to exchange messages once a month. The ansible gets used even less, and I took all the reservation this time. I know you're still coming around, but why didn't you at least send *something*?"

"I don't want to talk about this right now," he said. "Please, Adora."

His eyes didn't waver from hers for several long moments. When he moved to pull away a second time, she let him go with a sigh, knowing very well that he could flip the argument on its head and needle her about never having once reached out to Catra. Still, having to sit there and watch the sadness flit across Glimmer's face through the ansible…having to sit there and watch her shove

it far enough inside her she could fake a smile back…it had hurt. Knowing full well all that was just because Bow was being both stubborn and stuck made her want to wrestle him into coming around.

"Just…you never know when you might not have the opportunity to speak to her again, you know?" she said. "She's on the front lines, after all."

Bow sucked in a harsh breath. He averted his eyes, swallowed, and Adora felt a small amount of satisfaction seeing how her words had affected him.

*Good¸* she thought. *Maybe that will knock a little bit of sense into him.*

"It was good of her to give you the whole meeting," he said, still not meeting her eyes. "Did you learn anything?"

Adora sighed. "Not a thing. There's literally nothing on the Daiamid she could find that we didn't already know."

Bow cursed under his breath and narrowed his eyes. "I wasn't about to give up hope when neither of my dads turned anything up—what would two history nerds on Etheria be able to get their hands on anyways, right? But to think there was nothing even in the Enclave's protected archives?"

"I just don't get what else we're supposed to try," Adora said. "Where else are we supposed to look?"

"I don't know," Bow said. "I don't know what the big secret is all about, but we'll keep poking around and find something. Maybe it's time to start digging in a different direction entirely."

Adora closed her eyes and nodded, exhaling a breath she hadn't realized she had been holding. She had no idea what "different direction" he had in mind, but the fact he was already thinking of their next step was reassuring. She let herself relax with the

knowledge that, even if she felt like giving up, Bow wouldn't let her.

"Speaking of surprises," Entrapta said, making Adora jump with how abruptly it cut through the calm she had been settling back into. "I've found an interesting pattern with the security breaches. Come take a look at this."

Everyone stood and shuffled over to Entrapta, still hunched over a terminal atop her tornado-wreck of a desk she had shoved into a corner of the lab. She tapped a few commands on the keyboard and a massive auxiliary screen nearby sprang to life. It showed a map of Etheria and its many kingdoms. A dizzying number of multicolored dots, icons, and flags dotted the landscape.

"This is a log of every "malfunction" in the Enclave's security logging system since platform inception," she said. "Don't ask me how I got access to this, it's a secret so shhhh. And also, don't be alarmed by how many icons there are. This logs everything from power outages to someone accidentally oversleeping past the start of their shift."

She tapped at the console and a large chunk of the icons disappeared. Adora could actually see the landmasses and kingdom names now.

"Take out all the missed shifts and other one-off errors and you get something easier to deal with," Entrapta said. "When I went through the data here, I found something."

A window popped up, showing a last-minute shift switch between one Enclave security guard and another.

"This doesn't look like anything out of the ordinary," Bow said, stroking his chin and reading the change manifest through narrow eyes. "It looks like someone just subbed out for someone else last minute."

"It wouldn't be abnormal, especially since these kind of shift changes happen all the time," Entrapta said. "Except, when you

isolate for this specific employee ID—the one that replaces the other—and display only their recorded events, you get this." The screen changed, showing only several dozen flags instead of several hundred.

"These are spread all across the continent," Adora said, furrowing her brow.

"Is that not supposed to happen?" Frosta asked.

Adora shook her head. "Enclave standard operating procedure here is to assign people to one major location, *maybe* two. But all kingdoms within three years? That doesn't seem right."

"Not all kingdoms," Entrapta said. "Whoever they are, they've hit everywhere except Bright Moon and the Fright Zo—er, Scorpion Kingdom. This data is a few months old though, so it's entirely possible they've already gotten to one of those places. It gets even weirder when you apply a time series to the data."

A scrolling date bar appeared above the map and all but a small handful of icons centered around Salineas disappeared. Entrapta slowly dragged the selector across the widget. As she did so, icons appeared and disappeared in rapid succession, all of them at first centering on Salineas before moving wholesale to Plumeria. As Entrapta continued to drag the cursor along the bar, so too did the icons popcorn from Plumeria to Dryl, the Kingdom of Snows, and finally Mystacor.

"This is troubling indeed," Hordak said. "I wouldn't say this alone would constitute a full red alert, but it's certainly worth a deeper look."

"I thought the same thing," Entrapta said, "which is why I already did more digging." She pulled up another window on the monitor and security footage of an ancient ruin somewhere Adora didn't immediately recognize played. The timestamp showed a date three years in the past, when the Enclave was still in the midst of setting up.

“This is a First Ones’ dig site in Salineas,” Entrapta said, “before the Enclave could help us repair the damage Horde Prime did there. Watch carefully.”

The feed suddenly cut to static, although the videos’ scrub bar continued to crawl forward and the timestamp continued to count up. “The video cuts out for two hours,” Entrapta said, skipping forward to the point where the feed comes back online. Nothing looked out of the ordinary once it did.

“That’s odd, but not unheard of,” Hordak said. “The Enclave’s energy grid was far from reliable back then. It wouldn’t be out of the ordinary for a camera or two to fail every now and then.”

“No, it wouldn’t,” Entrapta said. “But if a piece of tech fails, it’s usually just the one, and they had backup generators installed for this very thing even back then. This was deliberate.” She tapped a command and the feed played over from the beginning, except this time splitting into six separate feeds, each showing the same dig site but from a different angle. At the exact moment the first feed cut off, so too did the other five.

“Now that’s decidedly not normal,” Bow said. “Especially for the Enclave. Their tech hygiene is too good, even for something thrown up overnight.”

“This was taken maybe a week after that person’s first shift change,” Entrapta said. “And the pattern continues across all instances of them showing up. They appear, roughly a week or two goes by, then a major site’s security footage goes down for a time. Sometimes it’s only for a few minutes, sometimes it’s for a few hours, but every camera goes down at the same time without the backup generators kicking in. Then they all mysteriously start back up again at the same exact time. This is consistent across all kingdoms and all records of them subbing out for someone else, even up to six months ago when they appeared in Mystacor.”

“Let me guess, no one has reported anything out of the ordinary?” Frosta asked.

"Nothing, nada, zippo," Entrapta said, spinning around in her chair with a manic laugh and a wide grin. "The only reason I found this in the first place is my database scrapers flagged this one ID as abnormal, and it took three years of data to finally assess the abnormality with a ninety five percent confidence rate. I have a pretty high standard for personally turning my attention to something my bots pick up, but once I did it was easy to isolate the data and find the correlation with the closed-circuit footage."

"Can you pull up any information on that person?" Adora asked, thinking Entrapta was far too happy for finding the anomaly in the first place. One security breach was no joke, let alone years of them.

"I can't, unfortunately," she said, using her hair to stop the chair from spinning any further and adopting a vaguely irritated expression. "All the personnel files are in a different database on a different server, and I haven't been able to crack the security on that one no matter what I've tried.  It's not nearly as complicated as Light Hope's neural networks, but it's still got a nasty firewall I can't get past. As far as I know, only the Enclave department heads on-planet have access to that information."

"Better get this over to Salas as soon as possible so he can look into it then," Bow said, echoing Adora's worried expression. "He'd definitely have access to that data too, and I don't like the look of this at all."

"Already have," Entrapta said. "I sent him all the files and my full write up before I turned around and showed all of you. He responded almost immediately saying that he's already looking into it."

Adora grimaced. Whatever was going on here made her skin crawl. Bow was right, the Enclave was far too good for this to happen. Both him and Entrapta would wax for ages talking about how airtight their systems were, and despite Adora having the tech savvy of a rock, even she understood someone manipulating their system like this should be unheard of. The fact they got

away with it for so long without anyone noticing was only more alarming.

The door to Entrapta's personal lab opened and a group of Enclave workers team lifting even more crates shimmied in. The first one through the door looked around at the mass of boxes already inside and Adora saw him wilt.

"Where do you want these?" he asked.

"Oh, just anywhere you can find room," Entrapta said, giving an emphatic shrug with her hair. "As long as you don't pile any of them in Bow's shooting range. I think he needs the space."

She didn't seem to comprehend there wasn't much space at all for anything. The worker in question continued to look about for where he and his partner could drop off their crate, and grew more conflicted when it seemed the only space left was directly where Adora and the rest of them were already standing.

"Watch out, coming through," said a gravelly voice from the back.

The laborers made as much room as they could and one of their own made his way to the front. His hair was disheveled and he walked with a resigned gait. He looked about the room like his colleague immediately before and, without missing a beat, headed straight for Entrapta's desk and thunked the crate down right next to where Adora stood.

Adora saw him glance at the data on Entrapta's screen and watched an expression she couldn't decipher flit across his sunken eyes. They locked gazes for the briefest moment, and that was enough for Adora to confirm something was off about him. He turned to leave and she almost reached out to stop him before Entrapta shouted.

"Hey! What are you two doing in here?"

Everyone turned and saw two Prime clones idling at the doorway, glancing about the room like tourists at an exhibit.

"Ah, we transported your new hardware on our ship," one of them said. "Since we came all this way to deliver from off world, we thought we'd come to the surface and see what kind—"

"Not allowed!" Entrapta said, bringing her hair tendrils up in front of her and making an "X" shape with them. "Prime clones are not allowed in here. This room is strictly off limits."

Despite Salas' repeated mentions that Prime could only see through the eyes of his clones if they were within a certain distance of him, no one trusted them to roam freely and everyone eyed them suspiciously as moles waiting to report back to Prime. Was it fair? Probably not. But, then again, neither was how Prime nearly destroyed their world to begin with.

"It's all right, Entrapta," Hordak said, the red of his eyes and blue of his hair setting him distinctly apart from the others. "I'll take care of this. I suggest you give some concrete direction to these delivery people, or you might find yourself unable to use your lab when they're done with their drop offs."

He swept past all of them, squeezing through the rest of the laborers to reach the clones.

"Brothers," Adora heard him say as he put on a cordial face and clapped them on the shoulders. "Please accept my apologies. The Etherians are still touchy about what happened with their world."

He spun them around and guided them out the door with a gentle hand at both their backs. The laborers stepped forward, stacking crate after crate in two-man teams according to Entrapta's direction. She apologized to Bow as she ordered them to stack a few of the crates in the firing range after all. Soon enough, Adora, Bow and Frosta had to clamber up onto the crates themselves to stay out of the way.

Adora tried to find the first worker who came in, the one looking on the verge of exhaustion, but despite scanning everyone's faces multiple times, she couldn't locate him. When the last team placed

their crate down and left, something struck her that she hadn’t realized earlier: He was the only one to carry in his load alone. The rest of them had all worked two to a crate.

Chapter End Notes

> This chapter was particularly difficult to enter into from a writing perspective.
>
> Glimmer's Part 1 intro in chapter 1 is her pacing around a cell alone with Catra, lost in her thoughts. Her part 2 intro is a singular conversation across a screen in some nondescript room aboard a cruiser. Adora's part 1 intro was her surveying a Bright Moon castle town under siege standing next to Micah. This scene is 5 people (Adora, Bow, Frosta, Entrapta, and Hordak) each doing something different in a room with a particular setup (crates everywhere) after a 3 year timeskip.
>
> Trying to juggle catching readers up with Adora's mindset, her current situation, what she's physically doing in relation to 4 other characters, what they're physically doing, and what's changed between and among them over the years, while writing an engaging scene that keeps you grounded is way more difficult than it sounds (and it sounds difficult!) First few paragraphs of this went through several more revisions than most of the other chapters.
>
> Catra's got the lengthiest post-timeskip scene, and it has its own set of challenges I'll talk about next week. See you then!

# A Red-Carpet Arrival

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra stared at the bottle of sleeping pills sitting in her locker at the precinct. It was nearly ten at night station time, and she had slept maybe eight hours total over the past three days. A battle raged in her head over what to do with the pills when she ran shaky hands through her hair and her heart started to race: there was much less hair for her to comb her fingers through than she anticipated.

Then she remembered.

She had cut it one of the first days she arrived on station three years ago and maintained it religiously since then—a shaggy, layered bob cut terminating at her jaw line. The nightmares starting up again recently had brought her mentally and emotionally back to a time when her life was falling apart at the seams, and forgetting how she had purposefully changed her appearance to mark the start of a new life proved how disassociating an effect the lack of sleep was having on her.

She grabbed the bottle of pills and eyed the trash can sitting in the far corner. Heart beating like a war drum, she overhanded it across half the locker room, sinking it into the receptacle with a definitive tinny gong just as the door next to it opened and her Section Chief walked in.

"Are you celebrating getting clean or declaring a start to it?" Dax asked, glancing into the can.

"Neither," Catra said, pulling her security uniform from her locker and tossing it onto the bench behind her. "I pass all the drug screenings every time, even the random ones, so don't bust my balls."

Dax rolled his eyes with a smile and Catra couldn't help cracking one of her own. He was technically her supervisor, but they got along well. Some of the new recruits—the ones hailing from more conservative worlds—had apparently balked at the idea of locker and shower rooms mixing genders and races, but that had been the norm in Etheria's Horde as far as Catra was concerned. She figured the fact she gave him no lip service about it when she first came on had instantly elevated her in his eyes and made her a favorite.

"I ain't busting nothin'." He pulled open his own locker at the end of the hall and began stowing his belongings. "Those are basic over the counters anyway, and you look like shit. Why are you throwing perfectly fine sleeping pills away when it's obvious you haven't been getting any sleep?"

"Maybe I've been busy entertaining guests all night," Catra said, tone brimming with innuendo as she pulled her casual wear off and shoved it into her locker. "What's it to you what I do on my time off?"

"I'm just doing my job and making sure everyone under my command is in solid shape," he said. "Also, I don't buy that for a second. Glimmer's been gone for months, there's no way. Who the hell else would you be 'entertaining'?"

Catra sputtered, her head caught in the neck of one of the clean undershirts she always kept neatly folded in the locker. "Glimmer? Why the hell would…no! Glimmer and I do not have that type of relationship." Her face burned even though she spoke the truth and she focused on threading her arms through her dress shirt and buttoning it up.

Dax only shrugged as he started to button his service shirt. "Could have fooled me. Hell, I'd love to be close with someone who looks as good as her, let alone a Battlemage…" His eyes took on a faraway look and Catra swore she could see the gears of his imagination turning. "Hey," he said, shaking himself back to reality and looking at her. "You wanna introduce us?"

Catra snorted, tugging on her uniform slacks and tucking the shirt in. “Not a chance in hell.”

Dax pouted. “Why not? If you aren’t with her, then…”

“We’ve known each other for how long now, Dax? Almost three years? You’d think if I wanted to do that it’d already have happened. Besides, you aren’t her type.”

“Not her type?” Dax spoke with a certain annoying lilt in his voice and Catra groaned. She’d never had an annoying older brother figure drive her to the brink of insanity from secondhand embarrassment, but Dax was coming close. “What is her type then?”

“Darker-skinned and more wear-your-heart-on-your-sleeve than you are.” She turned to look him up and down in his half-dressed state, purposefully exaggerating the way her eyes roved over his body. “You need abs too. That’s important. Being unable to rock a crop top is a deal breaker for her, unfortunately.”

He furrowed his brow. “A crop top?”

“Don’t worry about it,” Catra said. She felt a little bad talking about Glimmer and Bow like that—especially since they still hadn’t made up on account of Bow’s stupidity—but Catra didn’t want to give Dax any sense of hope about it either; Glimmer wasn’t taking her eyes off that man any time soon, regardless of the fact Bow seemed determined to keep a wall between them.

“All kidding aside,” Dax said. “Are you sure you’re okay for this assignment?”

Catra pulled on her utility belt, checking to make sure her stun gun and electric baton were both fully charged before ramming them home into their holsters. “I’ll be fine, Dax. I threw the pills away because I don’t think I need them, not because I was afraid of abusing them.” She grabbed her cap and placed it on her head and shut the locker.

"Okay, but are you sure?"

"For the love of—yes, I'm sure!" She rolled her eyes before glaring at him, although she wasn't actually mad. The fact he worried that much was more endearing than annoying. "They're OTC like you said. I just don't want to give my body any excuse to start needing stronger stuff. Best to just get rid of it now before it tempts me again." In fact, that was the exact reason she had moved them from her small flat to her work locker in the first place.

"This isn't some regular shift I put you on, Catra, this is Diallo and Moriarty we're talking about—a System Governor and the Regional Admin himself. Security needs to be airtight."

"I know, I know." She walked over to him and punched his shoulder. "I'll be fine dude, and I'll be alert. I promise. Besides, I need the money. Graveyard shift pays well, and the assignment is a step up than the usual stuff."

"You say that like you aren't the one who's been rejecting all the good shit I try and throw your way in the first place. I still don't understand why you've turned down the promotions I've put you up for, either." He stopped when something akin to an epiphany flashed across his face. "Does the fact you took this assignment mean anything about how you'll take my recommendations at your next performance review?"

Catra frowned. How did she not see this line of questioning coming from a mile away? For all the idiocy and buffoonery Dax liked to shroud himself with to seem less threatening to his subordinates, he had a razor-sharp mind she had somehow forgotten about and had now gotten trapped by. Thankfully, a subtle rumble at her wrist came and she pushed back the sleeve of her uniform. The PDA Entrapta and Scorpia gifted her before she left Etheria chirped at her: Glimmer had sent her a message.

*Hey you. I should be on Phoenix Station by the time you get this —time displacement and all that, you know how weird things get*

*using an ansible in hyperspace. Let me know when you can meet up?*

Catra couldn't help the smirk tugging at her lips and the small swell of anticipation that welled up from inside.

"That thing is like an antique, I can't believe you're still using it," Dax said, craning his neck to the side to try and read the screen. "Who's that, one of your nighttime guests?"

Catra pulled her arm away and spun on her heel to head to the exit. "None of your business," she said, sticking her tongue out at him over her shoulder as she went. "I'll meet you at the staging area."

"Hey, you still haven't answered my question," he said, calling after her. "I don't want to recommend you for another promotion if you're just going to shut me down again. Reviews are in a few weeks!"

"Hurry up or you'll be late!" she said without slowing or turning to look back at him. "Tardiness is my shtick. Get your own." She heard him groan behind her and she smiled as she exited the locker room. When the doors slid shut behind her, she brought up her PDA and opened a blank draft to respond to Glimmer.

*Last minute graveyard shift tonight. I won't get off until like two in the morning. Go ahead and get some sleep, we can meet up in the afternoon.*

She sent the message off and was just about to head out when Glimmer, completely unlike herself, responded almost immediately. She had definitely already arrived.

*You should have something from the Enclave today or tomorrow if they haven't reached out already. I still have that bottle we bought. Been saving it.  Let's open it whenever you hear from them, good or bad. You'll tell me either way, right?*

Catra's stomach churned. She knew what Glimmer was talking about but had hoped to forget about it at least for the night. Especially since she knew the anticipating and the waiting would drive her crazy.

She started to type out a response, trying to stamp down the nerves. When the words didn't come, she deleted the draft altogether and pulled her sleeve back over the device. She took a deep breath, then adjusted the cap on her head and the 'Station Security' badge pinned over her heart before starting off toward the station's main hangar bays.

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Hours later and finally Catra could anticipate completing the last (and arguably easiest) portion of the assignment. Sweeping the entire hangar for security vulnerabilities had taken an agonizingly long time, but she wasn't complaining; the extra pay was well worth the hours of work, and the prestige wasn't something to scoff at either. Other officers would have killed for the chance to join one of these high-level security assignments. All that was left was greeting the arrival party and escorting them to the executive levels.

She fidgeted, standing as one uniformed station security officer among several hundred, arranged in a formation of two sets of neat rows and columns facing one another. The idea was to have the VIPs walk down the center with them on either side, like a parade. Dax stood to Moriarty's left in the center aisle. He had somehow beaten her to the staging area despite Catra having left first, and the teasing looks from earlier in the locker room were gone. Instead, he wore a serious expression and stood straight-backed, his demeanor reflecting the gravity of their assignment.

She was right there with him. A sense of unease had permeated every member of the security detail too during their previous sweep, not just because of who they were protecting but because of who they were working with: Moriarty, the monstrously obese Regional Administrator, had a platoon of white and green-armored Imperial Vanguard soldiers plucked straight from the front lines as

his personal guard. Everyone wondered what the *hell* the Emperor's own, elite soldiers were doing on a quiet mid-rim station, and Dax, as supervisor, was the only one standing with Moriarty who was not Vanguard.

*At least they aren't clones*, was all Catra could tell herself to keep from side-eyeing them the entire time.

Every head turned at once toward the energy barrier separating the hangar from the vacuum of space outside. A luxury transport, transit-foils folding up against its polished body, taxied across the barrier flanked on either side by escort fighters. The craft's repulsor engines buffeted them, whipping everyone's clothing violently around them in the air. Catra placed her hand atop her cap to keep it from flying away. The standby capture crew sprang into action, moving to guide the three craft to a safe landing before strapping them to the hangar floor.

The ships powered off as the crew plugged refueling hoses into them and ran diagnostics. The belly of the transport opened with a hiss. A ramp extended to the hangar floor.

"Company—Present Arms!"

The commanding Vanguard officer standing at Moriarty's right, a soldier who had likely lived through more life-threatening battles than Catra had fingers with which to count, gave the command. Catra snapped to attention and gave a crisp salute toward the craft in time with every other standing member of the security force in attendance.

A middle-aged man who looked like he spent most of his time hunched over books descended the ramp. He pushed a pair of oval glasses up the bridge of his nose and looked around, clearly taken aback at seeing everyone gathered around. No one else descended the ramp after him.

"T-this is a bit much, don't you think?" he said, ambling up to Moriarty and reaching out for a handshake. "The transport, the

escort, all these guards. You d-didn't do this any of my other visits."

"I wasn't up for reelection any of the previous years, Diallo," Moriarty said, lunging forward with a speed that looked off-putting given how fat the man was. He gripped Diallo's arm in a meaty, glove-covered hand that practically engulfed the entire limb and shook with such vigor that Catra swore Diallo's feet left the ground.

"Yes, well t-there's nothing I can say to argue against that," Diallo said, rubbing his arm with a frown after Moriarty released it. It was the stutter that completed the package, Catra decided. Diallo seemed so frail it was a wonder Moriarty hadn't broken his arm clean in two with that handshake. She caught a glimpse of Dax saluting just beyond, struggling to keep from laughing at the humor of the whole situation.

"Company—Order Arms!"

Catra stowed her salute in time with everyone else. The ripple of movement and sound across the hangar made Diallo startle and elicited a bark of a laugh from Moriarty.

"Come!" Moriarty said, sweeping his arms wide and thumping Diallo on the back hard enough he had to readjust his glasses. "The Beast may not be spreading as quickly as it had during the last war, but if anyone even gets the thought it might seep into a system soon, mass panic and evacuations ensue. You and the other System Governors play an important part in maintaining peace and order in my region. We have much to discuss."

From there, the congregation broke out into squads and posts. Some quickly found their team and raced ahead to cover their assigned locations along the convoy's pre-planned route, others stayed behind to look after the ships. Catra, along with two other officers she had served alongside in the past, had been assigned to a relatively important position: following the procession from the back to provide cover from behind.

“Hey rookie,” Keren said, nudging her in the side with her elbow. She was a purple alien twice Catra’s height and easily four times her weight, so the ‘slight nudge’ still put Catra back on her heels. “How’d a greenhorn like you get an assignment like this?”

“I’ve been on the force for nearly three years now,” Catra said, putting considerable force into a shove of her own that barely jostled her back. “That’s, what, one year less than you? I can pull these assignments no problem.”

Keren snorted and ruffled Catra’s hair, earning a squeak of protest. She had been one of Catra’s first friends when she started her new job, and by the end of the first week they had bonded over pancakes and orange juice at a diner adjacent to the precinct headquarters.

“Technically you are still a rookie, despite the tenure,” said the second person on their three-man assignment. Trayn was similarly built to Keren, tall and stocky and strong enough to punch holes into ship bulkheads. But where Keren was softer and squishier on the outside, Trayn was all bony protrusions and armor plating. He was the only one Catra got to unsheathe her claws on during sparring matches, and many of their fellow officers often joked that he didn’t even need the body armor or protective vests handed out to all officers when they went on patrol.

“Do *not* ask me why I keep turning down the promotions,” Catra said. She stepped quickly behind Moriarty and his entourage as they headed out the hangar bay, forcing the two of them to fall into formation on either side of her. “I don’t want to hear how I’m ‘technically a rookie’ because I’m still on the lowest rung,” she said, making air quotes as they walked. “That’s some quality bullshit right there.”

“No honey, what’s bullshit is you’re still on a cadet’s paygrade despite three years on the force,” Keren said, earning a sharp look from Catra. “Is it true even Taline herself recommended you get bumped up? Like, at least four levels?”

They had reached the massive industrial elevators at the end of the hangar compound and everyone shuffled in. Catra had a choice number of things she wanted to say back to Keren, but chose to keep her mouth shut to avoid an incident. Thankfully, she didn't push her and neither did Trayn. Despite the elevators accommodating the whole group with room to spare, Catra didn't want to start an argument where their voices would echo. It seemed her friends had the same idea, since they didn't speak up either. The Regional Administrator, a System Governor, and a whole squad of Vanguard soldiers would bear witness to their arguing otherwise, and Dax would definitely think twice before ever giving any of them an assignment like this again.

The elevators deposited them onto one of the major rapid transit stations on Phoenix, and by the time the they rode the tram through the station's guts and exited out onto the Atrium, the opportunity for sharp rebuttals had long passed; Keren and Trayn had already moved on to new topics of conversation.

"I can count on one hand how many times I've been up here," Keren said once they disembarked, gazing up at the fountains and sculptures and sprawling levels of office space and luxury apartments towering all around them. Massive flags multiple stories tall hung from balconies and pillars, projecting the green and white of the Horde Imperial insignia for all to see. The Atrium was the pinnacle luxury ward aboard Phoenix Station.

"Dax tried assigning me up here once and I just couldn't hack it," Trayn said.

"Why not?" Catra asked. The procession continued forward and she kept her two-steps-to-their-one pace as they followed VIPs from a distance.

Trayn motioned vaguely at their surroundings, as if that were answer enough. Catra furrowed her brows and looked around. It took her a moment to realize he was indicating the people living in the Atrium district itself. They milled about, hanging out on their balconies high above or bustling to their destinations with eyes on

their PDAs, generally just living their lives. None paid any attention to the massive clump of soldiers and officers protecting Diallo and Moriarty as they made their way through the walkways and gardens.

"They're so in their bubble they don't even bat an eye at any of this," Trayn said. "Pompous assholes who are so used to their importance they don't even register what's going on around them. I wonder if they even realize everyone on the other levels are getting squeezed by poverty. The refugees aren't making it easier either, but everyone up here is completely oblivious."

"I lasted a month when Dax sent me up here the last time," Keren said. "The most dangerous thing I think I helped address during that time was someone who claimed their wallet had been stolen. Trayn gets annoyed at seeing everyone live in luxury up here, but I just get bored. It's too safe."

Trayn snorted. "Did you catch whoever did it? Stole that precious planetary governess' or whoever's wallet?"

Keren shook her head, barely concealing her laughter. "No one stole shit. The *man*," she said, emphasizing how Trayn's assumptions about the victim had been wrong right down to the gender, "was a scion of one of the minor sects of the Vestamid. Apparently he had been shopping in one of the department stores and accidentally put his third credit card in his second wallet instead of the first one, like he normally did. He couldn't find it and automatically assumed it was stolen. The expression on his face when he took a second look and found it was really something."

"That sounds…annoying," Catra said. She ignored the irony of someone from that fanatic religion having three credit cards and two wallets, and instead tried to picture how she'd have reacted in a similar situation.

"Yeah," Keren said. "And remember, that was the most interesting thing that happened to me. It's so boring and inane up here that I

asked Dax to transfer me back to the lower wards as soon as possible. Can't stand it up here. The place just makes me feel useless. Like some sort of glorified errand girl."

"And look, still not even a refugee in sight,' Trayn said, not bothering to mask his disgust. "When are they going to open up the Atrium for them? There's way more room than in any of the other levels."

Catra didn't need to take a second look to know Trayn was right. With the Beast crisis snowballing, more worlds were evacuating in anticipation, flooding their neighboring systems and planets and stations with countless refugees. The lower wards and especially the bowels of the stations were practically overflowing with people. Hell, she could hardly get to her own modest apartment without stepping over hundreds of them. But up here? She saw a carefully curated and maintained veneer of perfection; a false utopia.

Conversation turned to less important topics for the remainder of the mission. When Moriarty, Diallo, and the Vanguard entered a gilded elevator at the end of a particularly lavish pavilion, Dax radioed the teams under his command and officially relieved them of their duties. Catra politely declined Keren and Trayn's invitations to happy hour.

"Glimmer just got in," she said, angling her body away from them, "and I have to take care of some stuff and get some sleep before I see her tomorrow." They oooh'd and awe'd and made kissy faces at her, and she flipped them her middle finger as she stalked away. Soon, they had disappeared from sight, and Catra was somewhere else in the Atrium, alone.

There was a reason she hadn't contributed as much to the conversation as she normally would have when on the same shift with Trayn and Keren: she had spent more time on the Atrium than she wanted them to know about. Truthfully, she preferred the lower levels with their bustle of activity and crazy amalgamations of various cultures, but Glimmer spent almost all

her time in the nicer areas of Phoenix when on-station, and Taline was practically unreachable when she wasn't up here anyways. And so, here Catra would come whenever she had to meet one or both of them. Even though she'd spent less time here recently than in the past, it still wasn't something she was racing to confess.

Her many visits also never seemed to prevent her from getting lost the next time she came, though.

*Motherfuck*, she thought, looking around. *For the love of…where am I?*

She tried to make sense of her surroundings, maybe find a landmark. A large sculpture loomed in the distance next to a bench, framed by the petals of an even larger cherry blossom tree, and Catra made a beeline for it. The one thing she never forgot about the Atrium levels was the statues. Most of them were of Horde Prime, a few of them were of other famous historical figures in the Empire's history; all of them served as a kind of marker for where one could also find a station directory.

She came up on the statue from behind. Sure enough, as soon as she ambled around it, a large touchscreen taller than she was came into view. Advertisements flashed and scrolled their garish fonts and colors at her, and she was about to reach out to tap the screen when she made the mistake of looking up at the statue first, instead.

A towering figure, wrought in obsidian with flowing robes and a deep hood stood before her. It posed with one hand thrust high in the air and the other balled into a fist at its side. Whoever had completed the sculpture wanted to make it look as powerful and dynamic and imposing as possible. At its base lay a plaque.

*Corynth—Last Shaper of the Daiamid. Savior of the Empire. Beast Slayer*

Catra abandoned the directory and creeped closer to the statue, stepping as a timid but curious animal might. She stared up and squinted at the space inside the hood, where…

"Of course," she said, giving a rueful laugh. "Never seen *you* before, but you're always depicted the same no matter where on the station they put you, right?"

Catra had watched the documentaries and saw the paraphernalia everywhere: figurines, movies, books, artistic interpretations—she even managed to get her hands on a few seconds of legitimate, first hand footage of his last known sighting before the end of the war. Every depiction showed him wearing a mask, even the larger-than-life sculpture standing triumphant in front of her.

"You saved trillions upon trillions of people," Catra said, speaking to it. "I know you didn't do it alone, but everyone alive today is alive partially thanks to you. And yet no one, not a single person, knows your face. Knows what you really look like under there."

She stared into the black holes in the mask where the eyes would have peeked through had it been a real person, letting the moment drag her into a rare contemplative mood.

"If someone were to ask Shadow Weaver about me, she'd probably go on and on about how terrible I was. She'd probably talk their ear off about how I was nothing but a nuisance and a failure. If someone were to ask Sparkles about me, they'd probably think I was some sort of superhuman genius." She laughed, finding a kind of ironic humor from her words. Glimmer apparently always hyped Catra up to her circle whenever she came up in conversation.

"And you know what? There's a little bit of truth to both, I want to say. Glimmer can get a bit carried away and would somehow make even my bad qualities sound good. I fucking hate Shadow Weaver but, as much as I hate to admit it, she probably knows me better than most. I can't exactly bring myself to say she's *wrong* when she says I'm a disappointment. How can someone

who raised me and watched me almost my whole life be wrong about something like that?"

Catra still couldn't point to one specific reason why she obsessed over Corynth ever since learning about him. Part of her thought that Taline's hatred for him clashed so brilliantly with everyone else's adoration, the juxtaposition alone made her curious. Another, simpler part of her couldn't deny the similarities between Shadow Weaver wearing a mask and Corynth doing the same—simplistic as it was, it was enough for her to consider the possibility seriously. Regardless of where her fixation on him originated, it always seemed to bring her to moments like these: spilling some deep seated and closely held secrets to a statue, alone.

"If someone were to ask Taline about me? Well…" she trailed off, and frustrated tears pricked at her eyes when she realized she had no idea what she was trying to say. Instead, she gave another rueful, self-deprecating laugh. "Look at me, talking to a statue like a fucking crazy person.

"Taline hates your fucking guts and blames you for everything that happened, while everyone else thinks you're some kind of legendary hero. I may be stupid and useless just like Shadow Weaver says, but even I know that the truth about you is probably somewhere in between." She lowered her voice and, speaking more to herself, said, "just like I'm somewhere in between."

She took another step toward the statue. She knew she looked ridiculous talking to it, should anyone have walked by at that moment. She was just projecting onto it, after all.

"Gotta admit that I'm at least a bit curious," she said. "There was a real person behind that mask of yours and I'd love to know… who were you really, underneath it all?"

Something went *ping!* beside her the moment she finished her sentence, and she barely started rolling her eyes out of exasperation before the voice came.

“Hello there!” said a translucent, green hologram of a young woman with long, flowing hair standing next to her. “I am Hilda, virtual directory assistant aboard Phoenix Station. You are currently in the Atrium, first level.”

“How did I not realize that’d trigger you?” Catra asked in a deadpan. She turned and looked at the AI, and it tilted its head like a confused puppy, blinking at her.

“I’m sorry, I don’t understand your query. Reverting to last understood question.” Hilda gestured to the statue. “This is a rendition of Corynth, last Shaper of the Diamid, Savior of the Galaxy, Be—“

“Yeah, yeah, yeah I know all that already,” Catra said, waving a hand through Hilda’s avatar and glitching out the projection. “Never mind him, can you help me find something here?”

The hologram paused again, churning her question through its answer matrix.

“Query understood. What would you like me to help you find?”

“A friend of mine is visiting. Should be here for a week or two and I want to spend some time with her up here. Do you know of any restaurants or stores or whatever that I can take her to and we can have a good time?” She tapped her foot, suddenly embarrassed. “It uh…needs to be within a certain price range.”

She cursed herself for getting shy at the end there. She shouldn’t be shy. Things up on the Atrium were ridiculously expensive, but she had saved money for this. Plus, the money from the shift she just finished would help, even though she wouldn’t get her hands on the funds until the next payday. She could afford to splurge a bit. No reason to be shy about that.

The hologram blinked and tilted its head again. “What price range would you like me to constrain my search to?”

Not long after and Catra had navigated her way through clump after clump of refugees and alley thugs in the station's lower wards before pushing into her tiny flat and locking the door behind her.

She took everything back: there had been plenty of reason to feel shy, even though in hindsight it seemed dumb to feel that way in front of a damn software program. She knew the Atrium was pricey, but how the hell was she supposed to know it was *that* pricey? It wasn't nearly that bad the last time she had looked at prices in the past, although that was years ago now. The stupid AI had just stood there 'computing' and blinking and tilting its head at her until she gave up on her own.

She hadn't even gone back to the precinct to change before coming home she was so embarrassed. She stripped her uniform off and ran the bath, intent on just warming up some leftovers and throwing herself in front of the television until she passed out. It was when she came out of the bathroom to fish around her fridge that she saw it.

A small envelope lay on the floor next to her discarded uniform, and Catra already knew what it was before she picked it up. Despite how technologically advanced the Empire was, she got plenty of physical mail still: lots of paper bills that kept piling up, tons of junk mail she'd recycle, and countless catalogues she'd comb through for coupons. But the envelope? It was made of expensive cardstock and addressed to her in a flowy, handwritten calligraphy. She flipped it over and the wax seal there was stamped with the Enclave's teardrop wing insignia.

Her breath hitched and her heart raced. With the bath and leftovers completely forgotten, Catra broke the seal and pulled the letter out with shaky fingers.

Chapter End Notes

> This chapter was kind of like the inverse of the info-heavy chapters in part 1.

Brand new location, and lots of new characters and concepts shown but not explained (not really, at least). There's a *little* explanation, sure. Like what the deal with the statues and directories is, but it's all told through this sort of veneer of Catra's pov--someone who has already lived three years in this new place by the time we catch up to her. I ended up editing many of the explanations in later drafts to be less "pause and introduce" and be more "catch the reader up just enough they aren't fully lost, and now lets keep the pace pushing forward," which was an interesting challenge.

Diallo and the Vanguard were already introduced and name dropped as far back as early part one. Super kudos to the readers following week by week who remember or can find those name drops. They read like blink-and-you'll-miss-it throwaway lines, but are actually the first mention of some important stuff. :D

# A Call to Hope

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora stood with Angella on a stage at the far end of Bright Moon castle's lawn. The night moons hung high in the sky, and several hundred people had gathered around them, each holding candles that illuminated their faces and rows upon rows of tombstones all around. Frosta, Mermista, Scorpia, and Perfuma stood together in a group near the back, all of them except Frosta having arrived only a few hours earlier. The annual Induction Ceremony was in full swing, and near everybody important on Etheria was in attendance.

She angled her head to look at the queen, taking a moment to admire her. Angella had near single-handedly shepherded Bright Moon through a new age. Her being the one to run the kingdom and smooth over the growing pains and interpersonal arguments that came with accepting the Enclave had freed Micah to dedicate his time to the other kingdoms, training the Princess Alliance alongside the other Enclave mentors. Adora knew the responsibility hung heavy on Angella's shoulders, but she still looked radiant and young and strong against the moonlight. She wondered how she did it, and if any of that radiance might rub off on her if she were to stick around her long enough.

"You know, to all these people here you are doing a magnificent job looking morose and in a contemplative mood," Angella said. "But I've known you for too long to not notice."

"What are you talking about?" A gust of wind blew through, and Adora jolted herself out of her daze, quickly covering the candle she held in her own hands to protect the flame from going out.

"Something is bothering you," Angella said. "More so than usual." Decorum insisted they maintain an appropriately somber

expression and refrain from talking, so Angella didn't take her eyes from the crowd and barely moved her lips as she spoke.

Adora only wished she could be as subtle. "I'm okay," she said.

"That crease in your forehead hasn't gone away once since this morning."

Adora's eyes went wide and she took her hand away from guarding the candle to cover her forehead. When she did, the gust extinguished the flame, and Adora groaned in pitiful frustration. Angella laughed under her breath and that only made it worse.

"Here," Angella said. She reached over and snapped her fingers over the candle. A new flame sparked to life and danced on the end of the wick.

"Thanks." Adora made sure to guard it from the elements properly this time. She thought Mermista might have locked eyes with her and grinned from the earlier display, but she couldn't be sure. That still didn't stop her from flushing with embarrassment.

Technically, reigniting the candle with magic should have been no problem for her to do herself. But, still unable to channel She Ra's power, Adora was back to being her plain, magicless self. Re-forging the sword hadn't changed anything and, although she knew her friends didn't think less of her for it, she couldn't stop feeling somehow broken and isolated. Like something was wrong with her. Having to finally opt out of magic training with Micah and the Enclave after years of trying had been heartbreaking, but she knew it was the right choice. Even when her friends insisted that she keep on, Adora had refused; she hadn't felt right taking up time that could be better spent on them.

She tried to keep the admittedly small and inconsequential candle hiccup from getting her down as more people filled out the crowd. Except, the more she tried not to think about it the more she couldn't help doing so. Adora, supposed She Ra and destined

savior of the galaxy, couldn't even relight a stupid candle with magic after so many years of trying to reconnect with her powers.

Everyone quieted as the ground beneath them suddenly rumbled. It wasn't enough to shake anyone's balance—in fact, it was barely enough to feel it if one didn't know what to look out for. A kaleidoscope of colors shot up and engulfed the sky, as if some great God drew shut a curtain of ions around the heavens. Adora shut her eyes as lights flashed bright and whited everything else out. When the light died down and it was again night on Etheria, she opened her eyes and gazed at a new constellation pattern in the sky: Etheria had successfully traversed another portal and emerged in a new sector of space.

"Where's Salas?" Adora asked, knowing that the ceremony was to soon conclude.

"Not coming."

"I thought he's supposed to lead the ceremony with you," Adora said with a frown. "He did it the last two years, what's going on?"

"He got some alarming data from Entrapta about security breaches in the kingdoms and he's prioritized that over today's ceremony. He didn't mention anything to you?"

A pang of anxiety shot through Adora. He was losing faith in her… pushing her out. "No, he didn't," she said, her eyes beginning to mist over. If she hadn't been literally standing there when Entrapta made the discovery, would no one have thought to tell her?

"He's scatterbrained, Adora, not forgetting about you."

"So...you're doing the honors alone this time?" Adora tried to keep the uncertainty she felt from seeping into her voice.

"I have you here with me."

Adora hadn’t expected to hear that. Decorum be damned, she couldn’t help it. She turned her head and looked at Angella, only to see her already looking back out the corner of her eye, wearing an expression with so much emotional nuance it was staggering. Only an immortal fairy ruler and beloved mother—someone with several lifetimes’ worth of exposure to the idiosyncrasies and emotions of others—could have pulled off that look. It both teased and grounded her, all with one sidelong glance.

“Me? I-I wouldn’t know what to say. I don’t have anything prepared, I—“

Angella laughed and Adora realized, her face burning, that she had overreacted. Again.

“Leave the talking to me then,” Angella said. “You just stand there and look like you’re comfortable having the weight of the universe on your shoulders. Just until we get off this platform, mind you. Also, hold my hand.”

Adora blinked. “What?”

Angella turned her attention back to the crowd and, without looking at her, subtly took one hand from her candle and extended it in Adora’s direction. Not entirely sure what she was getting herself into, Adora reached out and took it.

“My fellow Etherians and esteemed members of the Enclave,” Angella said, projecting her voice all the way to the back of the group. Adora had no doubt even the guards patrolling the inside of the castle in the distance could hear her speak. “Today marks the third anniversary of Etheria’s reemergence into the wider galaxy, the third anniversary of the start to our sacred partnership, and thus we hold our third annual Induction Ceremony to commemorate. Thank you all for being here.”

Her voice echoed in the night. Nothing but the breeze pushing its way through leaves and grass answered her.

"As many of you are already aware, the Beast continues its slow advance across the outer rim systems, just as our research—our efforts at reawakening the great weapon at the core of this world—continue its slow advance. And despite how it may seem to many of us, standing in the midst of this titanic effort and unable to see the forest from among the trees, we are winning the battle."

Adora watched everyone's faces reflected in the light of their candles. Shadows played across their faces as the flames danced and weaved. Hope and genuine admiration emanated from each of them. Even Adora herself couldn't stop from feeling somewhat uplifted.

"A friend of mine recently reached out to me asking for help," Angella said. "They didn't come to me privately to express the sense of unease that had been growing like a cancer for some time in their heart. They didn't pull me aside and use words to convey how hopeless they had been feeling. In fact, I suspect they said nothing and spoke to no one because they feared those feelings inside were contagious and would spread like the very enemy we are hoping to defeat. No, this friend cried out in other ways. And after noticing it, I couldn't help but ask myself…how had I not seen this sooner?

"How had I not seen the way they no longer walked with shoulders back in a confident stride? How had I not noticed they no longer smiled when they spoke with their friends and loved ones? How had I missed the way their eyes no longer sparkled full of life and excitement?"

Adora gasped and almost dropped her candle outright. Was Angella speaking about her? There was no way she wasn't, who else would it be? She moved to pull away, but Angella only gripped her tighter with a strength completely at odds with her delicate appearance.

"When I finally did notice, I took a step back and realized I had inadvertently left them behind. I had grown too focused on the

task at hand. I had lost sight of what was truly important. Look before you! Look at the tombstones standing here. Each represents a life given in sacrifice to bring us together so we may better fight the enemy. And for every single name engraved upon these slabs of granite and marble, ten more have died either escaping the newest incursion of the Beast or fighting on the front lines to slow its advance.

"Make no mistake that what we are striving for here will indeed decide whether our descendants thousands of generations in the future will have the privilege of traveling the stars and feeling the kiss of the sun against their skin. But regardless of our success—and believe me, we will emerge successful if Salas and Entrapta and your unwavering hard work have anything to say about it—all of us will pass on, only to be remembered by those who stare at our name on a tombstone and think upon our legacy.

"We have come a long way, all of us together, and there is still a long way for us to go. We have finally achieved stabilization for the weapon so our planet doesn't break apart at the seams when it activates—a great achievement, thanks to your efforts. But despite this, progress on Light hope, the artificial intelligence that will mediate between the princesses, the massive store of energy in the core, and She Ra…it is elusive. We estimated that another two years of diligent research are required to solve this last hurdle, and chances are high that many of us will grow silently disillusioned with our progress now that it has slowed considerably.

"I ask that you recognize these moments of disillusionment for what they truly are: a call from within to take a step back, to look around, and to understand the importance of living in the present moment. Appreciate the fact you are all alive, here, now, today, regardless of how the state of the galaxy and our struggle evolves. I ask that you honor those who have died by lifting up and being there for those around you who still live—your fellow brothers and sisters in arms, toiling silently beside you."

Angella paused. She held the crowd at the end of a string pulled taught with emotional tension and impact. Every person in the crowd gave her their full, undivided, rapt attention. Adora squeezed Angella's hand so hard she feared she'd hurt her, but it was all she could do to keep from breaking down completely on stage.

"We now move into our fourth year of cooperation," Angella said. "I will do all in my power to keep us pushing strong." She held her candle high in the air. "To the fallen, this I swear."

Adora raised her own candle along with everyone else in attendance. They all chanted the same phrase back in a muted chorus, and that murmur from the crowd masked the choked sob that escaped from Adora when she tried to say the phrase too. She quickly blew out her own candle and, unable to take it any longer, pulled her hand out of Angella's grasp and retreated behind the blocked off prep area backstage.

A stool lay tucked away in the corner and she sat on it, putting her head between her knees and interlocking her fingers behind her neck. She breathed—quick, shallow breaths at first but gradually slowing them down until she could think straight.

"Adora?" Angella said, her footsteps *tap tap tapping* lightly on the floor as she came closer. "Adora are you okay? I'm sorry for what happened out there, I didn't mean for my words to catch you off guard or overwhelm you."

"I'm okay," Adora said, her voice coming out hoarse. She fought the urge to redo her braid, and instead looked up. Angella was kneeling in front of her with a concerned expression. The room was nearly pitch black, the only light coming from the small crack between the curtains leading back to the vigil outside.

"Aren't you supposed to be out there guiding the ceremony?" she asked. They were supposed to place their candle in front of one of the tombstones and whisper a message to the departed.

“I’m more worried about you,” Angella said, shaking her head. “I had hoped to get through to you and let you know you didn’t have to shoulder whatever was bothering you alone. I didn’t expect you to nearly have a panic attack and escape.”

“Sorry,” Adora said, taking another shaky breath. “I really liked what you said. I think I needed to hear it, just”—another her shaky breath. “I just...have too many thoughts right now. Too many emotions...I didn’t know what to do. I didn’t want to embarrass you up there so I just came back here.”

“Adora, it breaks my heart you think having an emotional breakthrough would be embarrassing for me.” She inched forward and placed a hand on Adora’s knee. “What’s on your mind?”

Adora frowned and kept her eye on the sliver of the outside she could see from where she sat, afraid that looking Angella in the eyes would get her too emotional again. “I feel like I’ve been slowly going crazy ever since I broke the sword,” she said, watching the people outside move about and place candles in front of tombstones. “Not a moment goes by that I don’t think about reconnecting with She Ra and feel frustrated that I still can’t do it.”

“She isn’t gone, though,” Angella said. “You can still feel her, right?”

Adora nodded. “She’s there under the surface. I just can’t get her to come to me when I reach. I’ve tried everything and I’ve listened to everyone’s advice—your advice, King Micah’s advice. I think I’ve gone to every Enclave magic trainer and mentor to listen to their advice too, but none of it has worked. Meanwhile everyone is chugging along at full speed, all the other princesses are getting stronger day by day, Glimmer is out there evacuating entire cities full of people to keep them alive, and Catra…” She trailed off, the courage she had been riding like a wave having disappeared.

Angella nodded but kept silent. It encouraged her and she took a moment to ground herself before continuing.

"I've had nightmares ever since that day aboard Horde Prime's citadel. They get bad around the anniversary…really bad."

Angella reached up and took Adora's hands into her own. She hadn't realized they had been shaking. "Glimmer mentioned something about them to me in the past. What kind of nightmares do you have?"

Adora swallowed. She had never spoken about them before to anyone. Sure, Glimmer knew she had them, but she didn't know what they were about. "I saw it, Angella. I saw the Beast. It spoke to me."

Angella raised both brows in surprise. Somehow, seeing her reaction felt validating, and the floodgates opened.

"I know Catra gets them too, but I'm not sure what she sees either. As far as I know, I'm the only one that saw it directly. When Taline released the memory…when she broke that crystal to keep the Emperor from killing us…it showed me everyone the Beast had eaten. It showed me all the worlds it had taken, all the suns it had devoured. There were so many of them…so many dead people I couldn't save just…just looking at me!"

Angella pulled her into an embrace, holding the back of Adora's head and pressing her face flush against her as she gripped Angela in a vice and sobbed. "Shhhh, it's okay" she said, stroking Adora's hair. "It's okay. You're here, I'm here with you. Just breathe."

Adora rode out the waves and crashes of her breakdown as best she could. When she finally calmed enough, she pulled away and rubbed her eyes dry.

"Why didn't you say anything about this earlier?" Angella asked. "We all knew you were struggling, Adora, but we had no idea about it being this bad."

Adora sniffled and shrugged. “I don’t know. It didn’t even cross my mind to talk about it. I knew this sounds stupid, but it felt like it wasn’t something anyone else would be able to understand.” Being held and being heard…already she felt better. Was it really that simple to begin healing? To start to feel whole again?

“That’s not all,” Adora said. “I saw She Ra. And Catra too, before the Beast showed up.”

“Oh?” Angella said, reaching up and wiping away a tear that escaped down Adora’s cheek with one of her thumbs. “What did they say?”

“She Ra was disappointed I broke the sword, even though it really was the best option I could think of at the time. She said she wished I spent more time learning to hone my powers and control them instead of focus on Catra. And when Catra showed up, she said the same thing—that I’d have been able to resist firing the Heart against my will if I had spent more time training than obsessing over her. Then I wouldn’t have had to break the sword and my connection to She Ra in the first place.”

“Is that why you ended things with her back then?” Angella asked.

Adora closed her eyes and nodded. More tears leaked out and ran down her face. “It’s just so hard trying every day to get back in touch with my powers and failing. It’s not just because I gave up Catra for it…it’s knowing that everyone in the universe will also die if I don’t figure it out.”

“You have to stop thinking about it that way,” Angella said, wiping more tears away for her again.

“What?” she asked, furrowing her brow. “That *is* what will happen, isn’t it? If I don’t get back in touch with She Ra, the Beast will win.”

“That may happen, yes, but you’re forgetting that even if you awaken She Ra right this instant, we still can’t use the Heart. Entrapta and the Enclave have to figure out how to get Light Hope

back online, and then everyone needs to come together and test the weapon before we can even think about using it. There's still time, Adora. Putting this much pressure on yourself all the time until you're literally falling apart in the back area of our little stage will only make things harder, not easier."

Adora took another deep breath, feeling strangely light. "Okay," she said. "I get it. I feel a lot better now too, thank you for listening."

Angella cupped both her cheeks in her hands and looked her straight in the eyes. "I will always listen to you, and I'm sorry I didn't catch on sooner. I would have dragged this out of you way earlier if I was paying better attention."

"So, you're saying I've gotten better at not being so obvious?" Adora said, making a play for levity. It worked, since Angella smiled.

"More like I got too focused on the day to day to notice, but nice try. You're still an open book, like always." Her face turned serious. "I want you to go talk with Salas about your nightmares."

Anxiety started to crawl its way back into Adora's chest. "What?"

"And I want you to talk to him about you being unable to channel She Ra."

"Why?" More anxiety. She returned her attention to the outside. Someone was standing absolutely still over a grave, holding their candle between both hands. They must have been whispering a long message since most everyone else was starting to peter out

"Those nightmares are concerning," Angella said, leaning to the side to capture Adora's attention once more. "Especially since they've been affecting your ability to function."

She held up a finger to keep Adora from speaking when she opened her mouth to protest. "And no, I don't care that they only spike once a year. To me, that's enough. Salas is the leader of the

Enclave here, not to mention a genius when it comes to working literal magic on the mind. He's got more first-hand experience with the Beast threat than probably anyone on the planet and, aside from my husband, he's the only other person I've come to rely on for moral support when I start to feel the pressures of my own job. He stabilized and reoriented me after I came back through the portal. Do I need to keep going?"

"No, but—"

"No buts, Adora. I'm not going to take no for an answer on this one. Why is it you are so reluctant to go speak with him?"

Angella had gone from calming and holding her sobbing body one moment, to cornering her with no avenue for escape the next. She could be truly terrifying when she set her sights on something, and Adora came to regret forgetting that.

"I don't know!" Adora said, letting her panic show brazenly on her face and through her gestures, despite knowing full well how irrational it was. "Maybe because he's 'the leader of the Enclave' and a literal genius when it comes to magic? Maybe because he was able to actually hold his own for a time against both Micah and Shadow Weaver up on the citadel? Maybe because he spent decades as Horde Prime's second in command and somehow managed to thrive despite advising a literal psychopath for longer than I've been alive? Or heck, maybe it's because he really is the type of person even you've come to rely on as well? I don't know."

"He intimidates you," Angella said. It was a statement, not a question.

Adora sighed. "I have a part to play in all this—an important part, even though you and everyone else tell me not to tie myself into knots over having difficulties with it. But it seems like I'm the only one that can't deliver on my part." Again, she looked past Angella and back out to the vigil-goers, lowering her voice and speaking the next part rapidly. "And yeah, maybe it's a little intimidating to go up to someone you think is starting to grow impatient with you

because they've removed you from all the meeting itineraries and just, I don't know, have a normal conversation like I'm not at all massively letting him down."

Angella laughed, driving higher the embarrassment she felt. She had to admit, her worries did sound a lot more serious in her head.

"He isn't disappointed in you," Angella said. "And he removed you from the itineraries because he worried they were only stressing you out. He wanted to give you more time to rest from your own training, since everyone could tell you were starting to pull back into yourself."

"Wait, are you serious? That's exactly what Glimmer said."

"He was supposed to tell you, but I'm guessing that slipped his mind as well?"

Adora nodded and Angella deflated. "That man just has too much going on. Maybe we should invest in finding him another assistant. Either way, he's not disappointed in you, just worried. He has a lot of wisdom to offer, and staying away from him because he's a little intense just isn't a smart idea."

"I'll go talk to him, I promise," Adora said, feeling intensely relieved. She paused a moment before pulling Angella in for another hug. "Thank you for everything. I feel so much better now."

"Of course," Angella said, patting her on the back. "Anything for you."

Adora grinned back, and then immediately dropped the smile when something outside caught her eye. The same person she saw who had been standing there earlier, staring at a tombstone and holding a candle, *still* stood there in the same spot despite the rest of the crowd having already thinned considerably.

She squinted her eyes and focused on their face, and something struck her as odd: whereas all the other vigil-goers had looked appropriately somber-faced, this man looked positively furious, with bloodshot eyes that suggested he had shed a large number of tears. The Induction Ceremony was a time for respect and quiet introspection, but she had never seen anyone genuinely anguished in the past.

“Have you ever seen that guy before?” Adora asked.

“Sorry?” Angella pulled back from the hug and gave Adora a quizzical look.

“Over there,” she said, pointing out the small crack in the curtains to the crowd outside. The man was no longer there. “Hold on,” she said, rocketing off the stool and throwing the curtains open to run back out onto the stage.

“Who were you trying to point out?” Angella said, joining her at her left. “I see a few people I recognize still in the crowd.”

Adora looked among every face as they went about, placing candles in front of tombstones and continuing to whisper their messages to the deceased. The princesses were all gone already, as was the man she had tried to point out earlier. He had stood in the same spot for far longer than the rest, and it just didn’t make sense. She swore he looked familiar too, on top of it all.

She made her way to the place she last saw him standing and looked down. There was a single gravestone with one candle in front of it, flickering peacefully in its holder. The names of Taline’s two Sentinels, killed in action protecting Glimmer aboard Horde Prime’s citadel three years prior, were engraved upon its surface.

*To Narre and Miri, beloved friends, saviors, and loyal to the end.*

Chapter End Notes

Couldn't bring Angella back and have her sit around doing nothing, now could I?

So far there's been lots of set-up, device-placement, and slow snowballing and build-up. Not unlike the first 8 chapters of part 1. And if you liked how things came together there, then I'm sure you'll be happy to know I've been expanding the scope, raising the stakes, and giving us another ramp up in part 2 completely on purpose :D

Shameless plug: I started releasing a new story! It's very different from World Eater, but for those of you who want another flavor of "Modern AU meet-cute," take a look at "The New Girl" on my profile :) That story will update every Monday evening PST, and World Eater will continue its Thursday evening updates.

See you all soon, and thank you for reading!

# Sanctuary

Chapter Notes

> I've added a "final" chapter count to this story. You might be wondering, "how the heck are you going to tie everything up in 6 more chapters?" and that would be a totally legitimate question. The answer is: I'm not.
>
> Chapter 28 is the last chapter of part 2, but there will be more parts after. Similar to how television shows have seasons made up of episodes, World Eater will have 5 parts made up of a certain number of varying chapters in each part. I'm hoping that by providing the chapter counts, all of you following along as the story is posted can have a sort of "goal-post" to look forward to for when we get through a significant arc of the story. You remember that action scene shot of Adora leaping through the air with her sword in the part 2 poster?
>
> Let me know if you like the chapter counts being up or if you'd prefer the part lengths to be a mystery. I'll base my decision to include chapter counts for the next parts based on how you guys feel about it. Either way, you can continue to look forward to regular weekly updates.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra stood in the middle of a lavish hallway, thirty floors up and deep in one of the Atrium's hotel complexes, for what felt like hours before she gathered the courage to knock on the door. Then, she thunked her head forward against the doorframe in total defeat and waited. An intercom installed nearby chimed at her.

"Who is it?" Glimmer asked through the device. "Whoever you are, you'll need to take your head off my door so I can see your face. I'm not opening up for strangers at three in the morning."

Catra pulled away from the door and looked at the small camera on top of the intercom. Her head felt heavy, like someone had tied a cinderblock to her face.

"Catra? Is that you?"

"Hey Sparkles," she said, her voice coming through as a despondent rasp. The door opened and Glimmer, wearing wrinkled, half-tucked-in pajamas, appeared.

"My god you look terrible," she said, stifling a yawn and rubbing sleep from her eyes.

"Speak for yourself," Catra said, staring at the dark circles under her eyes and the unkempt tuft of hair on her head.

"Believe me, I know. I've refused to look at myself in a mirror since I got here." She glanced down at the letter Catra held crimped in her hand and, without another word, pulled the door open wider in a clear invitation for her to come in.

"They always put you up in nice spots," Catra said, glancing around the room as she entered. Glimmer hadn't turned any lights on, but Catra's night vision let her see once again just how extravagant living in the Atrium was. It was like this every other time she visited Glimmer as well, she had to stop being so surprised by it.

"Only the best for their esteemed Battlemages is what I'm always told," Glimmer said with a strong hint of sarcastic irony. She shut the door behind her and locked it. "Although I keep telling them all this this is just unnecessary. I can't tell you how many times I've asked for something smaller, maybe in the lower wards. I'm starting to think they don't even have connections to accommodations anywhere but up here."

Catra snorted. "I don't think you'd like it in the lower wards," she said, pulling out a stool at the bar separating the living room from the kitchen and jumping up to sit on it.

"Why not? I prefer cozy over spacious, believe it or not. It was cool the first time they put me up here, but now it just feels…I don't know, artificial and cold? Not lived in?"

"Lower wards are the farthest thing from 'cozy' you can get right now," she said, watching Glimmer feel around the kitchen for a light switch. She shielded her eyes when she finally found one and flipped it on. "Place outside my flat feels more "backside of a dumpster in an alleyway" nowadays than it does "lived in." Besides, with all the refugees I don't think there'd even be a cardboard slate and a street corner you could find to lay on right now."

Catra placed the letter, crumpled from squeezing it so hard on the way over, on the bar top face down, then slid it far enough away she couldn't inadvertently see it out of the corner of her eye. When she looked back up, Glimmer was standing on her toes on a step stool, reaching for an amber bottle sitting on a top shelf of an overhead cupboard. Catra knew Glimmer had an imposing reputation among her circle in the Enclave, and watching the 5'2" ex-murder-queen reach for all her worth for a bottle of alcohol was almost too amusing not to laugh at.

Almost.

"Don't bring that out," Catra said instead, not even a smile coming out of her. "That's supposed to be for celebrating."

"We *are* celebrating," Glimmer said, tottering off the stepstool cradling the bottle like an infant.

Catra sighed. Leave it to Glimmer to be stubborn. "Dax asked about you by the way," she said, raising an eyebrow when Glimmer shot her a confused look. "You know, my Statsec captain? He apparently was under the impression that this"—she gestured between them—"was a thing, and then asked if I could introduce you two when I told him we weren't."

Glimmer snorted and turned back to the lower cabinets to fish out two glasses. "What'd you tell him? Is he cute?"

"Okay, first of all, I'm the last person that should be commenting on his looks—"

"Because of what's between his legs?"

"Because he's my *boss*," Catra said. "And second of all, I told him a certain someone back home had your attention so he was shit out of luck." Glimmer was off the stool and halfway back to the bar when she froze and Catra caught the play of emotions that flickered across her face.

"I'm not…I mean, that's not really—" Glimmer cut her sentence off and bit her lip. Averted her eyes.

"I mean, I can make the introduction if you want." Catra shrugged and hoped it was convincing enough to mask how cautious she was really being with the whole conversation. "He's at least a solid eight. That's if, you know, I close my eyes and pretend I like dudes."

She had hoped the joke would lighten the mood, but Glimmer only worried harder at her bottom lip. "I think I'm okay," she said at last, shaking her head. "Thanks, but no thanks."

"You sure?" Catra suppressed a frustrated growl. She really thought she had gotten her this time. "Bow's spent the last three years like his only goal with the two of you is to keep you at arm's length. 'Hello' and a coffee with someone new isn't gonna kill you."

"Catra can we *please* not do this now?"

"Do what? I'm just sayin'..."

Glimmer groaned and hammered the bottle and glasses onto the bar-top. "Look. We're about to get plastered on some expensive

swill. Can we just focus on that?" She turned the bottle so Catra could see the label. She ignored it.

"I still don't know why we're celebrating in the first place," she said. "I'm not exactly jumping up and down with excitement here, in case you haven't noticed."

"Exactly." Glimmer uncorked the bottle with a *pop* that echoed around the room. "You're obviously upset about whatever's on that letter you death-gripped on your way over here, and I'm supposed to be your emotional support while we both get shitfaced. If we don't drop it now, then we're both going to be drunk and sad. See the problem?"

Catra sighed again and felt the urge to fight fade from her. Maybe it was a good idea to not push the 'Bow' issue right then and there. "They rejected me," she said. "The Enclave turned me down from the Sentinel program."

Glimmer studied her a moment, then gestured toward the letter with a tilt of her head. "Can I?"

Catra shrugged and Glimmer reached for it. She smoothed out the paper and held it up with one hand, her eyes darting back and forth across the page as she read.

"You don't care what happens to this, do you?" she asked when she finished.

"Not particularly, no. Why do you—hey!"

Glimmer ripped the page in half, then folded the halves and ripped those in two. She continued for several repetitions, purposefully ignoring Catra and her gaping jaw, until nothing more than shreds of the letter remained. Then she ambled out of the kitchen and threw the scraps into a waste bin sitting near the stools.

"Why the hell did you do that?" Catra asked, unsure whether she felt more shocked or angry at how Glimmer reacted.

“It’s done, Catra,” she said, turning to face her. “You gave it your best shot, they took your application seriously, and decided against moving forward. Now you can move on to better things.”

“You’re happy I didn’t get in, aren’t you?” Catra asked, emotion making her voice start to come out wet.

“What makes you say that?”

When Glimmer raised both eyebrows, Catra already knew she had uncovered a mine. It was too late to back out now. “I know how Taline’s Sentinels affected you,” she said.

“Catra, *I’m* the one who dug for information on how to apply in the first place since there’s literally no public knowledge about it. I wrote your letter of recommendation too!”

“I know that,” Catra said, trying to keep her voice level. “But Narre and Miri are part of your nightmares for crying out loud. It’s close to the anniversary…I know they’re flaring up for you too.”

“I’m not relieved about it,” she said, still on the offensive.

“You sure as hell don’t sound all that upset.”

“What do you want me to do, go curl up in a corner and sob because they didn’t take you? Will that make you feel better?”

Catra stopped short of saying the first response that came to mind. Despite how good it might have felt in the moment, she wouldn’t let the conversation devolve into a shouting match. The last thing she wanted was to fight with Glimmer on top of everything else. “Maybe you weren’t consciously thinking it, but I want to hear you at least admit that part of you is relieved I was turned down,” she said.

Glimmer looked away, conflict warring on her face. She sighed, visibly calmed, and sat on the stool next to Catra’s.

"I'm not relieved," she said, turning and looking Catra in the eyes. "If you got in, Taline would likely have taken you directly under her wing. And with a Sentinel at her back again, she'd be able to finally come out of retirement. She's a dang war hero and the emperor has just kept her chained behind a desk for the past three years. It would let her get back to the front lines with you in tow, and god knows we need all the help we can get out there."

Catra stared at her with a placid face and Glimmer sighed. She leaned against one elbow propped up on the bar table and rubbed at her temple.

"I'll admit that I was worried," she said. "Even though I'm just part of the evacuation crew, what little I've seen first-hand is not pretty and I *did* worry about you being out there in that. But I'm not relieved they decided to pass on you. I know how hard you worked for this and how much you wanted it. I'm not relieved at all."

Tears welled in Catra's eyes and she blinked them down. "Sorry," she said, looking away. Glimmer reached out, cupping both Catra's cheeks and turning her so they faced one another again.

"It's okay," she said. "I get it. I just need you to know that I fully supported you in this. There isn't any part of me that's secretly happy it didn't work out. Okay?"

Catra nodded dumbly and Glimmer let her face go.

"Good," she said. "You're amazing Catra, and I know that you don't believe that, but it doesn't change the fact that you are. You worked so damn hard, and I know they took you seriously, especially after they dug into your service history."

"You think so?"

"I know so. Why else would they put you through the ringer for six whole months evaluating everything they could get their hands on? The Enclave doesn't fuck around. If they knew from the start they couldn't take you they would have said so. The fact you

made it through all the way to the end is worth celebrating in and of itself. That's why I brought the bottle out."

Catra finally glanced at it sitting on the countertop and remembered when they had first bought it. It had sat on one of the merchandiser shelves in an Atrium artisan boutique long ago. She had reeled from sticker shock after seeing the price, the two of them having taken the day to explore the station, nearly six months into her cadet training and Glimmer's Battlemage tutelage respectively. Glimmer had merely grabbed it off the shelf and paid for it without a second thought, talking about keeping it 'for a special celebration' while Catra gawked at her.

"So?" Glimmer asked, prompting her with the look in her eyes. "What do you say?"

"On second thought, I like the way you think, Sparkles. This whole 'find the silver lining' thing sounds like a good idea."

"Oh thank god," she said, visibly relaxing. "I was running out of inspiring things I could say to convince you."

"We could keep going if you want to practice," Catra said, teasing.

"Nope. No, that's totally okay with me," Glimmer leaned forward and reached for the bottle along with the two tumbler glasses. She froze mid-reach when Catra's stomach gave a sudden and completely unprovoked rumble, ratcheting her head around to give her a shit eating grin. "Someone's hungry."

"Maybe we should eat something first before we tackle that bottle," Catra said, covering her stomach with her arms. She really should have taken the time to at least eat the leftovers now sitting forgotten in her fridge before coming over.

Glimmer laughed and Catra felt her face go hot. Then she pushed Glimmer off the stool to get even with her for being so smug.

---

An hour later and the both of them sat in the dining room, the circular table in front of them stacked with boxes upon boxes of take out and a half-empty bottle of expensive drink.

"Oh my god," Catra said, leaning back into the chair and undoing the button on her pants. "I can't believe you actually ordered all of this."

"I can't believe you ate so much of it," Glimmer said, a hiccup breaking up the laugh that escaped her as she reached across the table to pour more alcohol into Catra's glass.

"Hey, it was good, okay? Don't judge me for indulging if you order a bunch of food and place it in front of me." She gestured to the remaining boxes. Despite both of them having eaten so much, more than half the haul still remained. "What are we going to do with all of this?"

"We'll keep them in the fridge," Glimmer said, shot-gunning her fourth glass (holy shit) and slamming it back down on the table. Alcohol made Glimmer quicker to express emotions other than excitability or aggression, and thus she tended to lean in whenever given the chance to indulge in it. "Plenty to snack on through the night if either of us wake up hungry, and whatever we don't finish, you can take home and keep as leftovers."

"Wait, are you for real?" Catra asked, sitting forward and appraising the piles with fresh enthusiasm.

Glimmer nodded. "I don't ever want to see your fridge as empty as it was the last time I went over to your place. I was so sad for you."

Catra grunted and decided not to argue, remembering the day Glimmer caught a glimpse of the inside of her fridge, only to promptly drag her to the nearest supermarket to stock her up. "So, what's new with you?" she asked instead, watching in mild disbelief as Glimmer filled up her glass again. "Three deployments back-to-back and the Enclave finally said you can take some time

off. How'd it feel being thrown around from planet to planet for eight months?"

"Do you see how many drinks I'm pouring myself here?" Glimmer asked, turning the bottle and shaking it to gauge how much was left. "It's hard, exhausting work, both physically, mentally, and especially emotionally. I thought Taline's training was grueling, but she was just preparing me for what it'd be like out there on the front lines."

"I remember how much you'd complain about those training sessions," Catra said, sipping her glass. After a moment, she shrugged and downed the rest of it in one go, indicating to Glimmer to fill her up again. Normally she'd be a little more reserved, but Glimmer was here again for the first time in a long while, the alcohol gave her a nice burn, it felt good, and she didn't have work the next day. Hence, plenty of excuse to indulge.

"I think they're going to try and push me into a command role soon," Glimmer said, staring off into the distance.

"That's good!" Catra said. "Promotions are good."

Glimmer shook her head. "No, they aren't. Not when I can't even think about leading people without having a full-blown panic attack about it."

"It's different when you're in the thick of things." Catra paused and considered if she really wanted to dive into this conversation or not. She knew what Glimmer saw in her nightmares, just as Glimmer knew of hers, but they hadn't actually *talked* about their wider implications. She eventually decided it was now or never.

"Look, I know you keep seeing what happened on the citadel, and I know a lot of things trigger those memories for you. I'm not going to sit here and pretend I have some sort of answer to solve all of it, but I do know that when you're out there in a life-or-death situation, you don't have time to start thinking about what happened and you don't have time to panic. You fall back on your

training and just act. You already know this. You're training is second to none. Just look at what happened on Rinne."

Glimmer's glare turned to acid at the mention of that name and Catra, flinched, berating herself in her head for being so careless. She likely just derailed one touchy conversation and got them onto something worse.

Thankfully, Glimmer just rolled her eyes and scoffed, downing her glass in three, four, five consecutive swallows. "You're probably the fifth person I've heard that from. Even Taline's tried talking me through it, but I just don't see it. How can I justify accepting command over other soldiers, people whose lives depend on me being functional, when I can't even fathom doing so without hyperventilating?"

"Maybe a leap of faith?"

Glimmer furrowed her brow. "Leap of what?"

"A leap of faith," Catra repeated. "You aren't going to figure out if you can handle an 'official' command of your own by sitting back and thinking about it. You're fucking awesome, Glimmer. You're the famous Angel of Archanas!"

Glimmer buried her head in her hands. "Nope. No, no, no we're not talking about that story."

Catra snickered, satisfied at having dodged one minefield by purposefully sending Glimmer down a spiral she knew was safe. Rinne might be a nuclear topic, but quoting the nickname she got from that nightmare campaign never sent her into dark, depressive moods so much as it just comically irritated the hell out of her.

"Fine, I'll spare you this time," Catra said. "But—"

"I haven't even been to Archanas! Why couldn't they just call me something else? Sure, Taline did some crazy shit there that helped end the war, but what does that have to do with me*?*"

Catra fought to keep her snicker from escalating into a full-blown belly laugh. They'd had this conversation about her now-famous moniker she inherited from Taline countless times in the past, but never with this much alcohol in their systems. Glimmer usually just scoffed and changed topics, so seeing her get legitimately pissed off about it was a refreshing change.

"Because you were her student," Catra said, leaning in to emphasize her point. "And at the end of the day it doesn't matter what you did to originally grab their attention. What *does* matter is that you reminded everyone that they can act decisively, even in the face of overwhelming odds. It reminded them of that 'crazy shit' Taline did, herself. You and I both know it wasn't her fielding the fleet over that planet that earned her that 'Seraph' title, but that didn't stop every living person in the galaxy from thinking that's where it came from. If Taline isn't exempt from that sort of thing, I don't think you should feel too bad when it happens to you either."

There. Rinne was off limits, but that was about the closest Catra could get to speaking tangentially about it without everything blowing up in her face.

"I think it just means everyone is dense," Glimmer said. "I hate it."

Catra barked out a laugh and decided to concede the point.

"But seriously, you made Battlemage in what?" she asked. "A year? You're top rookie on the front lines six months after? There's a reason they're stretching you thin on so many assignments, dude. It's because you're doing an awesome job and impressing all the right people. And you're forgetting that you've already led people in the 'official' way back on Etheria. You damn near singlehandedly kicked my ass overtaking my hidden base. I say just take baby steps."

Glimmer laughed. "Tell me, what would 'baby steps' mean in this situation, then?"

“Accept the promotion and the command when they offer it, start with a small team on minor forward advances, maybe a few covering assignments to get people back to the evac stations. Stuff like that. You’ll find out pretty quickly if you start choking under pressure or not.”

“You’re telling me to accept a promotion when you’ve turned yours down how many times now?”

Catra stiffened, suddenly feeling an animosity emanating from Glimmer she hadn’t noticed before. Glimmer wasn’t actually mad, just defensive, and the alcohol exaggerated it. Still, even though Catra knew that, it was jarring to hear her tone of voice shift so suddenly.

“It makes sense,” Catra said, becoming acutely aware of how the room tilted, how fuzzy her head seemed, and how thick her tongue felt. She hoped she hadn’t slurred any of her words when she was trying to convey a serious thought.

“How is it you tell them four freaking times that you don’t want to get promoted and its fine, but everyone and their mother seems hell bent on getting me to command a squad? This is just like that time Adora got angry at me after I told her I was leaving and said I needed to stop running away from my problems.”

Catra’s ears drooped despite trying her hardest to not let it happen—they had a mind of their own. With horror, she finally realized the effect the alcohol was having on her. It was more than she anticipated, and she probably hadn’t caught on sooner because she was sitting stationary in a chair rather than trying to balance on two feet. But that was beside the point.

Normally she’d bite back with a scathing remark, throw her walls up, and metaphorically scratch and kick and verbally spar with Glimmer until, spent and thoroughly vented, they made amends (usually by crying-hugging it out). Now all she did was sulk. Alcohol tended to have that effect on her, depressing her moods.

It was the reason she out of the two of them was the one who tended to nurse only one or two drinks the whole night.

Glimmer looked like she suddenly realized what she had said and her eyes misted over. ”Oh shit, I’m so sorry Catra. I didn’t mean for it to come out like that.”

Catra shook her head. “It’s okay,” she said, pushing the emotions deeper down and swallowing the lump that had been forming in her throat. “I know you didn’t. It’s okay.”

“I just…I can’t risk taking responsibility over peoples’ lives like that. Not when even the chance of me fucking up means they’ll die. I already choked aboard Horde Prime’s citadel, Catra. He had Narre in his grip and was distracted. I had the knife, I could have just—“ she gestured vaguely to finish her point. “But I didn’t do anything. I sat there frozen in fear, and he died because I couldn’t help. And Rinne? Well…we won’t even talk about that.” She sighed. “I can’t chance that happening again with other people. I won’t chance it. No matter what.”

Catra nodded, swallowing again. “Hey, I get it, trust me. We both have our things we’re struggling with. I shouldn’t have made those suggestions so casually. I know it’s not that easy.”

Glimmer quickly poured another glass for herself and, when hovering the bottle over Catra’s glass, she nodded and let her pour one for her as well. It would have been better had they both stopped, but Catra wanted to give some sort of indication she had accepted the apology.

“How is Adora?” Catra asked quietly, putting a false casualness into her tone as she picked up her glass and pretended to absentmindedly study its contents.

“You’re asking me about Adora?” Glimmer sounded like she couldn’t believe her ears.

Catra shrugged. “I guess I am.”

"She's…well, stressing. She still hasn't been able to get back in touch with her powers. It's causing a bit of a crisis for her, I'm pretty sure."

Catra gave a snort of laughter that sounded more forced and derisive than she intended it to be. "Yeah, that absolutely would throw her for a loop. Adora can't stand letting people down, and that probably goes double if she's somehow gone sterile."

"I suppose it's out of the question for me to suggest you reach out to her, is it?"

Catra arched a brow. "Why would that even be a question in the first place?"

"Well, I mean…she's struggling, and… come on. We both know how much you struggled too at some point."

"*Still* struggling," Catra said, correcting her with a ruthless deadpan. "Just struggling in space instead of on Etheria, thank you. Remember my fridge?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Fine, but you've got experience actually learning to open up to people and ask for help when you need it. I mean, you came and knocked on my door at three in the morning rather than wait. That's light years of improvement compared to old Catra."

Catra stared at her drink and tried to figure out if Glimmer was complimenting her or not.

"Adora used to know how to go to people too," Glimmer said. "But I've been hearing from my parents and the other princesses for a while now how worried they all are about her. It sounds like she's just kind of…retreated into herself? Does that make sense? She asked me to look into the Daiamid and I swear she was going to crumble into dust from sheer disappointment when I couldn't find anything for her."

"And you think I should reach out to her and help her realize the power of friendship blah blah blah all over again?" Catra asked.

"I wouldn't put it quite like that," Glimmer said, pouting. "But yeah. A lot has changed since we left. Neither of you are the same person from when you last spoke. I think she could use your help."

Catra considered that. Since leaving Etheria, Adora had never been far from her mind. The first few months were the worst, with her repeatedly catching herself ruminating on their last conversation, over and over and over again. More recently, however, she'd manage to go even longer without thinking of her once. It was only when something like this happened—her getting brought up unexpectedly—that everything would come rushing back in a storm of dull pain and anguish from old wounds reopening.

She downed the entire contents of her glass in one go and gestured for a refill. "I don't think that's a good idea, Glimmer," she said, seeing the reaction on her friend's face when she addressed her by her actual name. "Maybe Adora would be open to hearing from me again, but she's the one that said she wanted to focus on saving the world. She's the one who asked me not to speak to her again."

"I was there when she said that," Glimmer said, tipping the bottle. "I caught the tail end of that conversation. I don't think the two of you were on the same page about what that meant."

"Yeah, but we all *heard* the same thing, didn't we?" Catra said, leaning forward as she pushed authority into her voice. "It's not my responsibility to overanalyze what Adora was *trying* to say, all I can speak for is what she *did* say, what I heard, and what I think that means. The ball is in her court, she can reach out if she wants. I plan on honoring her last request, even if it means I never see her again. I've made my peace with that." It was a lie, but one she had managed to convince herself of on most

occasions. She tipped her glass back and downed its contents again in one go.

Glimmer sighed and Catra could see the moment she decided to let the argument go. “Fair enough,” she said. “But I think you should go talk to Taline about your Sentinel application at least.”

Catra blinked. “What? Sparkles, that’s even more out of the question than talking to Adora again. Why in the world would you think that was a good idea?”

“I can’t put my finger on it, but I think something was weird with the application.”

“You just got done telling me they were seriously considering me because I made it through the whole process. Now you’re telling me the application might have been wrong?”

“I don’t know whether it was wrong or not, Catra, but that’s exactly why I’m saying you should talk to her about it. People had this sort of…weird look they gave me when I researched more into how the whole process worked. And when I actually showed up to give my recommendation and submit all your paperwork, all the people at the intake office kind of looked at each other and spoke with a weird tone. It was like they weren’t quite sure what to do with everything.”

“And you think that’s a good reason for why I should go confess to Taline that I tried to do this and also ended up failing miserably at it?”

“You didn’t fail miserably, Catra, don’t be dramatic.”

“Look, there was a reason I didn’t want her to know, okay? There was a reason I made you swear not to ask her about how any of it worked, even if it meant you wouldn’t find anything. That reason hasn’t changed. In fact, now that they rejected me, I especially don’t want her to know.”

"Yeah, but you have no idea *why* they didn't take you, do you? They didn't say so in the letter, and unless there's another document you got that I didn't see, then you have no idea what made them decide to ultimately pass."

"Oh, that's an easy one," Catra said, falling back on her tried-and-true defenses. "I'm a failure and useless, just like Shadow Weaver always said. No surprises there. They rejected me since everyone else does too."

Glimmer rolled her eyes, clearly growing impatient. "Catra, I mean it. Stop talking like that, you're only hurting yourself."

Catra took a deep breath and centered herself. Glimmer was right, and she was letting her emotions run out of control. A lifetime of abuse meant a lifetime of learning to be kind to oneself, and it'd be irresponsible of her to take the lazy way out and bring herself down all on her own. "Sorry," she said.

"It's fine, it happens. I know you came close, and I know the very last thing Taline would do is make you feel worse about it. I get it's a touchy subject so I won't pry about why you don't want to tell her, but I really think, if anyone is going to have any answers for you at this point, it's her. So just…think about it, okay?"

Catra nodded. "I'll think about it."

Satisfied, Glimmer leaned forward and reached for the bottle again. She looked and saw how it was practically almost gone, and then shrugged.

"Enough talk about work and depressing things," she said, pouring Catra another glass before she could protest and then moving on to empty the rest of the bottle into her own glass. "I have two weeks of shore leave and I'm so excited to spend it doing nothing but stuffing my face and hanging out. Oh! And I have messages for you from Entrapta and Scorpia as well. They're always super good about making sure their transmissions get included in my monthly download. Hand me your PDA and I'll transfer the files."

Catra laughed. She downed her glass before unstrapping the device from her arm and handing it over to a woozy Glimmer.

For several more hours they passed the time, just enjoying each other's company and exchanging stories. It wasn't until the light of the artificial sun on the station blared through the open window that Catra cracked an eye open. Sometime during the night, she and Glimmer ended up snuggled tight against each other on top of the pull-out couch in the center of the living room.

She had meant what she had said to Dax: she and Glimmer had a solid friendship, but nothing beyond that. In fact, that was plenty already. She hadn't imagined ever being comfortable enough around another person to seek comfort in sleep next to them, especially after what had happened with Adora.

Maybe Glimmer was right. Maybe she *had* truly improved her life leaps and bounds beyond where she had been back on Etheria. And it wasn't just her friendship with Glimmer either. It was Dax and her colleagues, Trayn and Keren as well. And of course, Taline too, although there was more to unpack there than she felt comfortable thinking about, even after three years.

She turned and studied Glimmer's face. She looked so peaceful, like she was finally getting the deep sleep she had been missing out on for so long. Catra realized then that she hadn't woken up in a cold sweat either, and the nightmares she had grown to anticipate during this time of the year hadn't chased her to wakefulness. In fact, she was reasonably certain she hadn't had any nightmare at all this time.

With a content sigh, she snuggled in closer, eliciting a half-awake groan from Glimmer as they adjusted and better molded their bodies against each other. Catra slowly drifted back to sleep, feeling Glimmer's heart beat thump against her ear as she melted into her warmth.

Her last conscious thought was that maybe, just maybe, it might be a good idea to go and talk to Taline after all. If vulnerability

with Glimmer felt this encouraging, what would it be like with her?

Chapter End Notes

Someone mentioned in a comment about Catra and Glimmer coming across as "understanding each other but still butting heads," and I thought that evaluation is spot on, especially as I was doing my final proofread pass of this chapter. (Final proofread is ironic because I still find typos or grammatical problems even after the fact, but I do my best T.T)

Special shout out to withredhair. I appreciate each and every comment I get, but this person has literally commented on every single thing I've put out since I started posting in March, and I wanted to let you know I appreciate it more than I can adequately convey. Thank you!

# A Long Overdue Conversation

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A few days had passed since the Induction Ceremony. The other princesses had gone home to their respective kingdoms, and Adora finally had an audience with Salas. She felt on the verge of hyperventilating right outside his office, deep in Bright Moon castle. Strong hands pulled hers away from her braid when she moved to redo it, and Adora turned to see Bow giving her a knowing look.

"How many times have you messed with that in the past half hour?" he asked, releasing her wrists when she didn't fight him and gripping her by the shoulders instead. "The braid is perfect, like always. Just focus on me instead. Breathe."

"Okay." She nodded and leaned into him as she closed her eyes and took deep breaths. The urge to fix her hair subsided. "I'm calm now," she said after several moments. "Thanks, Bow."

He flashed her a grin when she opened her eyes again. "If it gets a bit much in there, just remember that he doesn't hate you," he said. "He's just scatterbrained with everything that's going on. Angella said so herself, and if anyone has information that can help you it will be him. This is a *good* thing, you going to talk to him."

"I don't know what I would do without you," Adora said. The relief that flooded her as she soaked in his words was hard to describe. "Are you going to be here when I get out?"

"Probably not," he said, releasing her. "I promised Swift Wind I would fly with him right after this, and I wouldn't feel right canceling last minute."

"Ah." Adora fought to keep her guilt from showing on her face. Bow had couched things in impressively non-confrontational language, but it still reminded Adora she hadn't ridden Swift Wind in nearly two years. It wasn't his fault things had deteriorated between them; it was hers. She had expected too much from him, thinking she could reconnect with She Ra through their bond. "Yeah, no problem. That's…that's probably a good idea."

"Hey," Bow said, shaking her loose from her thoughts. "It's fine. Really. Him and I are overdue for some guy time is all."

Adora wanted to argue—how could it be okay? But the look in his eyes and the expression on his face convinced her and, for the hundredth time that week, she wondered if she would have remained sane even a fraction as long as she had so far without him.

He promised they'd meet up the next day so she could share whatever she got from Salas, and Adora watched him recede down the hall and turn the corner, out of sight. She waited a little longer after he disappeared, just in case he came back, then quickly undid her braid and fixed it for the fourth time that afternoon. She took another steadying breath when she finished, and turned finally to face the door to Salas' office.

*You can do this,* she thought. She raised a fist to the wood and knocked.

"Come in," came his voice from inside.

Adora pushed inside, only to be assaulted with the sight of the messiest, most cluttered room she had ever seen in the castle. Salas stood behind an ebony desk, piled high with papers and books and other esoteric paraphernalia, holding up a document and squinting at it as he read.

"Hello Adora," he said, glancing over his paper at her as she made slow, tentative steps inside. "Please, have a seat."

She looked to the single chair in front of the desk. Piled atop the cushion sat another stack of books and papers. She almost said something, and then Salas gestured. A tiny ripple of magic billowed out from him, and a small spinning rune appeared over the stack, picking it up, floating it off the seat, and placing it gently somewhere to the side and out of the way.

"Thanks," Adora said, taking the seat.

The stacks of books and papers on the desk itself obscured almost all of Salas standing behind it, and she wouldn't have been able to look him in the eyes had he been sitting down. Salas made another gesture and several more runes appeared over each pile, moving them one after the other out of the way until the desk too was spotless. Once the spell finished, he took a seat on the other side and gave her his full attention.

"Angella mentioned a few days ago you'd be reaching out to me," he said. "She also properly admonished me for not warning you about changing the meeting itineraries. I'm sorry about that, my mind has been all over the place keeping track of things. And now that Entrapta has sent me this log of security breaches to review"—he waved the document he still held in his hand—"I barely have time to sleep or eat, let alone remember the little details." He put the paper down on the desk and slid it off to the side. "To what do I owe the pleasure?"

Adora fidgeted in the chair. Admittedly this wasn't nearly as intimidating or stressful as she had imagined it beforehand to be. She knew better, had *seen* enough first-hand to know this wasn't the case, but Salas looked positively harmless amidst a room full of books. That, and spoke in such a way it was hard to not feel welcome in his presence. Her unease, she realized with a small amount of surprise, wasn't that *he* scared her, it was that she had no idea exactly what to say to him. How did she jumpstart that conversation about her fears and troubles, the Daiamid, and She Ra?

She took a deep breath and dove right in, starting with the nightmares. The entire time, he merely listened, sometimes asking clarifying questions and other times only nodding or leaning forward to show his investment in her words. Before she knew it, she had walked him through the entire vision that had plagued her for three years since that day aboard Prime's citadel.

"This is a common phenomenon when coming into contact with the Beast I'm afraid," Salas said, frowning slightly and giving her a sympathetic look.

"Is there anything I can do to make them stop? Or make them, I don't know…less?"

"It's not a perfect cure, but you could try to stop your obsessing over the Beast. Once you stop thinking about it day in and day out, the nightmares will gradually lose their potency."

Adora frowned. "I don't think about the Beast every day like that," she said.

"You don't?"

"No."

"And your constant, almost pathological physical training near daily for the past three years has nothing to do with the Beast? The hours upon hours you spend meditating in front of your runestone? The weeks at a time you'd lock yourself deep in the castle library or George and Lance's collection, poring over old tomes and deciphering ancient writings?"

Adora frowned. He recalled a lot about her behavior for someone so busy they couldn't be bothered to warn her about barring her from meetings. "All of that is so I can try and get back in touch with She Ra."

"And then you can fire the Heart and defeat the Beast when it comes time. When that's done, you've succeeded in saving trillions of lives. Then you can rest?" Salas let the words hang

between them for several moments and something clicked in Adora's head.

"Oh. Okay, I think I see what you're trying to get at." She narrowed her eyes. "So, your advice is to just stop worrying? 'Hey Adora, have you tried solving your problem by, I don't know…not having a problem?' There's a universe eating threat out there and I have the responsibility to stop it, Salas. I can't force myself to just not care about it."

Salas sighed. "You're missing my point, so let me try a different approach. During the first conflict, you were considered extraordinarily lucky if you lived at all after exposure to the Beast in person. A small amount and you might have gotten out relatively unscathed, a tiny bit more and you'd lose your sanity if you were lucky enough to emerge at all. Any more than that and the Beast claimed you entirely and took you as a thrall. In fact, there are only a handful of people that we know for certain ever lived through a lethal exposure, one of them being Corynth and another being someone I explicitly am forbidden from discussing. I'm sure you know who I'm talking about."

"Evelyn."

Salas shut his eyes and hissed with tense shoulders. Adora let silence linger between them, until he relaxed and opened his eyes.

"How many times do I have to tell you it's dangerous to utter that name?"

"We're on a planet-sized black-site research station," Adora said. "One that Horde Prime explicitly agreed not to spy on while we worked. You yourself *told* me about Taline's sister not long after she left. If the Emperor was going to bring the hammer down on us for saying that name here, it would have happened already."

"Yes, but I'm concerned about what happens later," Salas said. "Etheria will enter the public sphere at some point, and when it

does it will be the center of a great deal of attention and scrutiny. Just because you may be safe to utter that name now does not mean that will always be the case. If you were to slip up in a place where the emperor could pay attention—"

"Okay, okay I get it," Adora said, deflating. "Sorry. I won't let it happen again. Can we just get back to the part where you help me? Please?" She felt a little bad cutting him off like that, but another of his endless lectures was not something she was prepared to handle graciously. Not with her nerves as frayed as they were—she already felt the urge to fix her braid again.

Salas eyed her with exasperated eyes before he continued. "What you were exposed to aboard the citadel was merely this person's last memories before they passed. The Beast wasn't actually there, but seeing through her eyes as the thing consumed her must have been enough to influence your brain chemistry anyways."

"I don't actually remember seeing anything of her memories," Adora said. "She Ra said she protected me from them. I just saw a vision of my own."

"Even so, that mind of yours is ruminating," Salas said. "It's doing everything it can to re-analyze the threat it experienced that day, over and over again, turning it relentlessly to inspect every angle so it might know how to fight properly should it stumble across the Beast again. The only problem is, there isn't really a threat. Not an immediate one, at least, because you aren't in any immediate danger—you're sitting here, in my study, with me. Do you understand what I'm saying?"

"I think so," Adora said, nodding. "I know the difference between training to fight this thing and actually being in the middle of a fight with it but…my brain doesn't?"

"You are exactly right. If you can learn to step away and stay away, to separate your anxiety from yourself after a night terror, your mind will eventually pick up on the fact that you are safe,

even if you don't feel that way in the moment. Repeat that enough times, and eventually the nightmares will cease to have as strong an effect. Cognitive behavioral therapy in a nutshell."

"Will the nightmares ever go away altogether, do you think?"

"Not fully," Salas said. "I'm afraid they will likely be with you to some extent even far into the future, but they will lose their potency. They may spike in frequency or severity especially around anniversaries like now, but in time they will lessen to something more akin to an uncomfortable memory instead of a debilitating nightmare."

Adora considered that.

"I also want to add that you aren't the only one struggling with this sort of thing right now," Salas said.

"What do you mean?" Adora asked. "Someone else is having nightmares too?" As far as she knew, only Glimmer and possibly Catra had them. Everyone else aboard the citadel when Taline exposed them—Scorpia, Micah, Bow, even Lonnie and Rogelio before they left—hadn't experienced side effects.

Salas laughed. "Sometimes I forget how literal a person you are Adora. It's endearing. I see why Angella speaks so fondly of you."

Adora flushed and, thankfully, Salas continued without making a bigger deal of it.

"Morale is beginning to dip. The Light Hope roadblock is proving to be a real struggle for our scientists and engineers. Their frustrations are beginning to seep into the support structure around them, which is exactly why Angella gave the type of speech she did at the ceremony."

"She didn't say those things just to get through to me," Adora said, replaying in her mind what Angella had said that night. It was explicitly worded for everyone to hear, but Adora had been so focused on her own problems and her own struggles she only saw

it as Angella speaking directly to her in the moment. She forgot the queen had only used her as an example to inspire, even if her words were genuine.

"I've learned once Entrapta starts to feel the stress, then the others have likely been feeling it much worse for far longer," Salas said. "Why do you think I approved Hordak's shore leave early? Entrapta needed a break…Hordak needed a break. Everyone needs a break." He smiled at her. "You especially."

"I don't know how I can do that though," Adora said. She felt like they were finally getting to the root of the problem, the thing she hadn't been able to voice out loud. "Even if I take time off and get away, I don't think I'd be able to relax. I could be sitting in one of Mystacor's spa pools and still be worrying about the Beast and my connection to She Ra. It's like I'm missing a part of myself, Salas. You don't just stop thinking about it because you decided to take a vacation."

"That's a fair point," Salas said, sitting back in his chair and combing his hands through his hair. "Did you find anything helpful from Glimmer about the Daiamid?"

Adora did a double take. "How do you know about that?" she asked. The ansible communications were supposed to be private.

"I know everything that happens here," he said, speaking as if that were common knowledge. "Why do you think my mind can't tell up from down anymore? Too much to juggle for one old man."

"Well apparently you didn't know about all the security breaches," Adora said, then immediately cringed when she heard how bad that sounded. She shot him a sheepish look when he glared at her. "Sorry."

"Yes…well…" Salas adjusted his clothing and sat straighter in the chair. "I must admit I'm impressed she found those breaches in the first place. The crew schedules are supposed to be top secret."

"How is someone able to manipulate the system like that for three years without anyone catching on?" Adora asked.

"They aren't," Salas said, narrowing his eyes and glancing toward the paper from earlier again. "Someone is helping them game the system."

"We have a mole?"

"We have a mole," Salas said nodding. "Although now that Entrapta has brought it to my attention, the charade is up. It's only a matter of time before the intruder is found, and their inside man as well. The funny thing," he said, grabbing the paper again and scanning it, "is their personnel file is only three years old. Same as the length of the breaches."

"That's…bad. That *is* bad, right?"

"Every person working here on the Heart has an extensive, recorded history either with the Enclave or the Empire, and their entire record should be available for me to see. It's only the members of the standing navy in orbit that are more inexperienced, since we need as many veterans as possible slowing the Beast down on the front lines. But even they have service histories stretching back past three years. To find someone in the system that has no history before the Enclave took responsibility over Etheria in the first place is an anomaly."

Salas flipped the paper over for her and Adora saw how little information was printed on it. A small photo of the person in question stared at her in the upper corner.

"That's the guy I saw in Entrapta's lab!" she said, pointing at the picture. "He was at the Induction Ceremony too, just standing there in front of Narre and Miri's grave."

"The name we have on file for him is Kalanthe, although I wouldn't be too certain that's his actual name." Salas sighed and studied the paper again through narrow eyes. Having an inside man to move you around and get through security is one thing,

but having a doctored Imperial service record is another. And when I looked into the Eternian dig sites this 'Kalanthe' character visited, none of them showed any signs of tampering at all."

"What do you mean?"

"Those sites are incredibly complex for our team to work through. So much so, that we're still breaking into them to this day. Eternian technology is several orders of magnitude more advanced than the current cutting edge of the Empire. But, once we inevitably do get in, there are no signs of someone else having been there in thousands of years. Whoever this person is, they've been doing something with the ruins, getting in and out over the course of a few hours, sometimes as little as thirty minutes, and leaving without a trace. It usually takes our best people weeks just to get the darn things open."

"That sounds really serious," Adora said.

"Believe me, the fact he is able to do something with the ruins in that short amount of time is more concerning to me than the fact he's been skulking about undetected for so long," Salas drummed his fingers on the desk, a nervous tic. "If you see him again, do not engage him. I want you to call for back up and wait for it to arrive, okay?"

Adora agreed and Salas seemed to relax. "Now, I believe we were originally talking about the Daiamid?" he said. "I know you asked Glimmer to look into it, but I haven't had the time yet to find out on my own what she told you."

Adora wilted. "She couldn't find anything. There's nothing on them other than what everyone already knows. I don't even know what a 'Shaper' is. Is there like, a special type of member they call a 'Shaper of the Daiamid' or…?"

"That's just the official title someone in their ranks had," Salas said. "They 'shape' their magic rather than relying on runes. Thus, 'Shaper.'"

Adora gave him a look that said she didn't find that at all helpful and Salas laughed.

"I'm not surprised you didn't find anything, just to be clear," he said. "The emperor is obsessive about controlling the narrative and flow of information surrounding the first Beast war. Corynth and the other Shapers are a large part of that."

"I had hoped there might be something in the Enclave's records that would tell me more about them," Adora said. "I'm really scraping the bottom of the barrel here, but I thought learning about them might help me reconnect with She Ra."

Salas smoothed his hair back with his hands again and sighed. "You aren't scraping the bottom of the barrel. The truth is they likely would have had a lot to teach you had they still been alive. They knew how to manipulate magic in the same way as you princesses, only without runestones of their own."

"Glimmer mentioned you might have first-hand knowledge about them," Adora said. "The fact they were considered myths before showing up wasn't even in the public documents—I only knew that because you mentioned it before."

"Of course I have first-hand knowledge," Salas said. "I know more about the Daiamid than you'd ever learn looking for recordings in some archive, Enclave or no. I just can't actually teach you what they would have when it came to your powers. Taline would have been better suited to that, if she were still here."

Adora frowned. "Why would Taline be able to teach me what the Daiamid would have?"

"She would have been *one of them* if she hadn't so brazenly planted her flag against them at her sister's trial," Salas said.

"Wait," Adora said, heartrate picking up. "Wait, wait, wait…you're saying she was going to join them? Then turned them down purposefully to oppose them? Why would she do that? Weren't

they trying to help her sister escape after Prime ordered her executed?"

"I don't know," Salas said. "She's never told me, although not for lack of me asking, mind you. Taline was one of the jurors at the trial. I don't think it ever even crossed her mind that her sister might have been acting out of a genuine belief she was right, but Taline was convinced the Daiamid were manipulating her sister into defying the emperor for their own purposes. She became one of the few people to fight them and live."

"Taline *fought* the Daiamid?"

"Not just the Daiamid," Salas said. His eyes glazed over in a look that told Adora he was reliving something vivid from his memories. "She fought Corynth himself. On the steps of the Imperial Judiciary, deep in the Heartlands. I'll never forget that duel for as long as I live. I was there when Prime made the accusation of sedition…I was there when Corynth and every other Shaper present revealed their real identities and protected the scientists while they made their escape. I was there when Taline rebuffed Corynth's offer for her to join them."

"She must have had a good reason to do that. She *had* to." Adora couldn't imagine someone like Taline making decisions lightly, not after the way she looked her in the eye up on the citadel and commanded her to surrender.

"She must have," Salas said, agreeing. "Although, again, she never told me what that reason was no matter how many times I asked. Never explained why she thought the Daiamid were manipulating rather than helping. All I know is she wasn't faking it. The ferocity with which she fought that day…the look in her eyes as she did so...that was someone who truly thought she'd lose her sister forever if she didn't turn Corynth into a red smear across the pavement."

He laughed and, to Adora, it sounded sad. "Looking back on it now, that's exactly what happened, actually. Still, powerful as she

was even back then, Taline was no match for him. If Narre and Miri hadn't stepped in when they did to pull her back…"

He trailed off and Adora's imagination ran wild. She knew what kind of figure Corynth was—had seen some of the documentaries, watched some of the movies, read some of the biopics. That battle must have been unimaginable to witness and she wanted to ask Salas more, wanted to get him to tell her of it in greater detail. But, upon seeing the look of sadness and regret on his face, her tongue stilled. Instead, she refocused on why the topic had been brought up to begin with.

"Even if Taline was powerful enough to fight their leader, she never actually became one of them," Adora said. "How would she be able to teach me what they would have about my powers?"

"It's not just because she fought them," Salas said. "It's because she understands magic at a level even higher than myself. If Battlemages are the Enclave elite, then the Daiamid could justifiably be considered the Battlemage elite. They have a connection to the underlying chaos of the world unlike any other, and that allows them to 'shape' that chaos, and thus the world, as they see fit. Within reason, of course.

"What Taline did on Archanas to earn her 'Seraph' title…the fact she can cast magic without relying so heavily on runes…and just look at what she did with Glimmer. It takes five years on average for a top-class mage to earn a full Battlemage commission from the Enclave. Your friend is an incredibly talented person, but earning the Battlemage designation in little over a year is in large part thanks to Taline's mentorship."

Adora blinked at him. "Okay, she's very talented. Maybe even a genius, sure. But you and the other mentors are no slouches, and Micah is considered a prodigy too. I don't understand how she'd help me when they couldn't. Glimmer is able to do runic magic even with her connection to the Moonstone being severed because she's so far away. I couldn't even light my candle for the Induction Ceremony when it went out."

Salas rubbed his hands together and grumbled.

"I'm starting to believe you are purposefully looking for reasons to fail rather than for solutions. I mentioned runes, didn't I? As mages, we concentrate on the study and application of runes as a medium for channeling magic. If you have the gift, understand the formulas, and can draw good, clean runes, you can cast powerful spells quite reliably. This is different from how you and the other princesses tap into magic through your runestones. The connection, at least in that instance, is more visceral. More… instinctual, you could say.

"Thankfully, since the majority of the princesses have had connections to their runestones for quite some time, the issue with training them is less about how to foster the connection, and more about how to hone it, develop it, and exercise even greater control over it. All of which are aspects that the Enclave and its philosophy around magic excel at."

"But when it comes to me," Adora said. "Someone who didn't have a connection or even formal training for the majority of my life…"

"It's a different hurdle entirely," Salas said, nodding. "One in which we sadly have very little experience in. For us, you either have the gift and can connect or you cannot. We have no pedagogy for training someone to foster a connection in the first place. The Daiamid on the other hand? Taline? People who are skilled enough to cast reliably without relying on runes? They are in tune enough with magic to do so only because they've somehow fostered a connection far stronger than the average mage. Average Battlemage, even."

Adora groaned and sat back in her chair. "But Taline is gone, and she's expressly forbidden from participating in the Heart project in any way. She can't help me. And I can't just not ever connect to She Ra again. There's so much riding on this and I'm literally driving myself insane. What am I supposed to do? I feel like a failure."

“Adora, the one thing I can say is that you will learn to channel She Ra again one day.”

“You don’t know that.”

“I *do* know that. I have absolutely no doubt in my mind.”

“Well, I have enough doubt for the both of us then, and I’m the one that needs to perform here. How can you be so confident?”

“Because this isn’t an issue about whether or not you have a connection in the first place,” Salas said with a smile. “If you felt nothing when you reached for your power then I’d be more concerned, but this is about fostering your existing connection and learning to tap into it again, not learning how to reconnect something that was severed. If that were the case, not even Taline nor the Daiamid would have been able to help.”

Adora frowned and considered that. Was that supposed to make her feel better? She wasn’t cut off from her powers entirely, but practically speaking, was there any difference?

“You are afraid, Adora,” Salas said, bringing her out of her thoughts. “And I completely understand that feeling, especially with the weight you put on yourself. But you are not ready. You will be one day, but not right now, and that’s perfectly okay. Don’t rush it.”

Adora let out a big breath, finally understanding for the first time what everyone had been trying to tell her for so long. It was okay to not be ready. Lots of other things weren’t ready either, like Light Hope. They had time. She flashed Salas a small smile, then faltered a bit when she realized how foreign doing so had felt. It must have been some time since she had smiled last.

“The Heart project will continue,” Salas said. “And Entrapta has also floated some ideas for trying to activate and channel the Heart without relying on She Ra. You’d still be the first choice of course, but if she comes up with that breakthrough then the fate of the galaxy won’t rest on your ability to perform any longer.”

That made Adora feel even more at ease. Being able to fire the weapon without She Ra would be a huge boost, and it honestly would take away almost all the pressure she felt. She'd be able to reconnect with her powers at her own pace, without worrying about trillions dying if she failed. If it could be done at all, she knew full well Entrapta would be the one to figure out how.

"I think I'd like to take some time off," Adora said, relief flooding through her as she finally said the words.

Salas didn't miss a beat. "Done," he said. "Next two weeks are yours to do with what you will. Just take your PDA with you and check in from time to time."

Adora smiled wider, the sudden urge to collapse into a bed and sleep for a week straight hitting her hard. She stood, thanking Salas out loud for his time and thanking Angella and Glimmer in her head for pushing her to do this. As she made her way to the exit, she realized the overwhelming pressure that had been in her chest for so long had disappeared.

For the first time in a long while, she felt free.

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Adora woke from a nap, hours later and long after the sun had set. The moons, framed by the alien constellations and nebulae of their new sector in space, shined through the tall window of her room and bathed her in their light. The triangular silhouettes of a half-dozen Orbital Defense carriers holding a parade formation loomed high overhead, standing stark against the night sky. She stood and stretched, feeling well rested for the first time in ages. To her surprise, the first thing her unburdened mind wandered to was Catra.

Her thoughts had edged toward her old friend every now and then in the past, typically in moments of quiet, and each time it had done so she'd been diligent about pushing them down in order to refocus on her training. But now, after a blissful sleep

and with nothing on her plate for the next two weeks, she found that she didn't actually want to push the thoughts away anymore.

How was Catra doing? What was it that she had asked Glimmer to look into for her? How was Phoenix Station? Did she miss her? Or had she made new friends and moved on already?

The last question in particular sent a stone of anxiousness plummeting through her stomach, and she wandered over to her PDA on her desk, hoping she'd find a distraction on its screen. Instead, seemingly without thought, she turned the device's record feature on and started taping a message to Catra. She got all of two words in before she suddenly didn't know what to say and quickly deleted the footage.

Now she didn't want to think anything about Catra at all. She slipped the PDA onto one arm, clasped the gauntlet with her still-cracked runestone in it onto her other arm, and grabbed her fighting staff. When the (practically second-nature) urge to do her hair up in its tucked-in braid came, she ignored it and headed out the door, hair down for the first time in years, after slipping her shoes on. She had the sudden urge to make a trip to the Crystal Castle, and decided that a solo walk through the cool night air under the stars would do her well.

Feeling playful for the first time in ages, she made a game out of sneaking past the guards patrolling the hallways. They wouldn't have stopped her had they seen her, but it gave her something to focus on, and kept her mind from inadvertently turning back toward Catra again out of idleness.

Soon, she made it out the castle and to the grounds. Dozens of new fortifications, barricades, and turrets littered the area, all of it set up during the Enclave's previous three years. It was as clear and frightening a sign as any that they were preparing for war. She rounded a particularly tall guard tower when a voice called out to her from behind.

"Adora? Is that you?"

She turned around and saw Swift Wind not more than a dozen paces away, standing near one of the stables, giving her a confused look.

“Your hair is down,” he said. “Wow, it’s been ages since I’ve seen you like that.”

“Hey Swifty…” she said, trying to keep the apprehension she felt from seeping into her voice. Judging by how the hesitancy on his face only deepened, she probably didn’t do a good job of it. “What are you doing out here so late?”

Swift Wind blinked at her and turned to look at the stable behind him. “I live out here?”

*Shit, way to go Adora,* she thought. *Way to not make things even more awkward.*

“Oh yeah!” she said, forcing a laugh. “Silly me. Uhm…Bow told me you guys were going to hang out. How did that go?”

“Fine. Bow’s always a good time.” Swift Wind narrowed his eyes at her and took a tentative step forward. “Are you going somewhere?”

“Just going out for a bit. Need to clear my head.” Adora took a step back, angling her body away. She hoped he’d take the hint.

“Why don’t I come with you?” he said, perking up. “Feels like we haven’t talked in ages. Would be good to catch up.”

“Sorry I just”—Adora cringed when she saw hurt flash across his face—"I just really need to be alone right now. But yes! We do need to catch up. Soon, I promise. Okay?”

Swift Wind nodded, taking a step back. “Sure,” he said. “Soon.”

Adora grit her teeth and waited for him to turn away. When he didn’t break eye contact first, she did, and swore her heart broke a little because of it. She turned fully around and walked as

quickly as she could away from him and away from the castle grounds. By the time she felt brave enough to look over her shoulder, he was long gone.

A good hour and a half later and she was deep in the Whispering Woods. Etheria always had a nasty chill at night, and she hugged her jacket closer to her as a breeze pushed past. The woods used to confuse her and easily get her turned around, but years escaping from Bright Moon and traversing its many trees eventually gave her an innate sense of direction. Soon, the spires of her castle peeked through the branches and leaves around her, and she power walked to the entrance.

Something felt off about the place the longer she looked at it, and it wasn't until she got closer that she realized why: There were no guards at the front, and the door was already wide open. One of the first things the Enclave did was set up a rotation of guards for all the castles, hers included, and no one except her and a select few others had the credentials to open the door.

"Hello? Is anyone there?" she whispered, as she poked around.

Something glinted in the moonlight off in the distance and she ran toward it. Two guards lay with their backs against the trunk of a large tree, placed in a way that no one would see them walking up from the front. Not unless they specifically came from off the beaten path.

"Hey, wake up," she said, squatting down in front of them and snapping her fingers near their faces. They didn't stir and, for a terrible moment, she thought they were dead. Then she pressed two fingers against each of their necks and felt a pulse.

Breathing a sigh of relief, she tapped at her PDA. Salas had told her not to engage and to call for backup if she ever encountered the intruder, and she had a strong inkling that was exactly who she'd find if she went inside. This "Kalanthe" apparently hadn't visited the Scorpion Kingdom or Bright Moon yet when Entrapta had given her analysis, and Adora had seen him in both places

since. If he was hitting First One’s locations and ruins, then the Crystal Castle would be a natural target.

She typed out a quick message to Bow, urging him to get backup, and pursed her lips when it kicked back an error. She pressed the call button next to his avatar and uttered a frantic curse under her breath when it didn’t even attempt to put her through: the stupid thing couldn’t pick up a signal.

She glanced at the door to the castle, to the unconscious guards against the tree, and back to her PDA, weighing her options. She could run back to the castle to get help, sit here and wait for a signal, or go in and confront whoever was in there herself.

The lack of connectivity wasn’t just a coincidence, she was sure of it. Blocking any and all communications in or out of an infiltration zone seemed like child’s play given the intruder could apparently hack into First Ones ruins in a matter of hours. Not to mention downing all of the surrounding surveillance cameras.

Running back to Bright Moon castle to physically bring reinforcements was out of the question as well, she decided. In that time, Kalanthe could escape, or worse, could come back and finish off these guards.

She made up her mind. Adora took a deep breath and, gripping her combat staff tight, she stood and ran into the castle.

Chapter End Notes

> Someone wrote a fic (in another fandom) where they split the main thrust of the story against two POVs in separate locations. They mentioned it being tough writing (and subsequently posting) a story that needed two setups and essentially double the length to ramp up. Let me tell you, I've been hard-pressed to find something I've resonated with more this week than that. Except this story is 3 ramp ups...after a psuedo reset 70,000 words in because of a time skip lmao.

This is the tipping point for Adora's arc--the inciting incident.

# An Unexpected Reunion

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer didn't get her shore leave. Not even a little.

Instead, she was deep in space, sat inside one of the private observation booths aboard the Horde Interstellar Vessel *Omen-Kador*, watching concentric Dyson rings rotate around the star they were orbiting. An emergency communication had come through early in the morning: she had been tapped for a last-minute deployment, non-negotiable, and had needed to scramble just to make it to the ship on time. She hadn't even had time to wake Catra for a proper goodbye, only able to leave a hastily scrawled note behind instead.

The view screen had a powerful dampener activated, making the light from the star come through in a warm orange color, and the rings cast moving shadows inside the booth as the arms eclipsed that star at alternating intervals. She took a deep breath, letting the pattern of shadow dancing with orange almost entrance her.

"Gorgeous, isn't it?" Taline said, speaking from the PDA Glimmer held up in front of her. "That's oddly one of the things I miss about traveling the galaxy. Refueling at one of the Barrier nodes and watching it from your ship is a strangely meditative experience."

"I remember the first time I saw one," Glimmer said. "I didn't want us to jump away after we finished resupplying." She laughed. "I still can't believe the thing keeping the Beast from overwhelming us relies on neutron stars and an AI to power it."

"Algorithm," Taline said. "Not an AI, an algorithm."

"Yeah, that."

Taline sighed across the connection. “No, not ‘that’,” she said, “You do know the difference, right? I spent hours drilling this into your head, Glimmer.”

“Yes, I know the difference,” Glimmer said, sidestepping Taline’s henpecking with faux indifference.

“Enlighten me.”

Glimmer pursed her lips and spoke in a deliberately indifferent tone, as if reading from a teleprompter. “The Barrier keeps the Beast at bay with an incredibly complicated ‘pattern’ anchored and powered by several hundred neutron stars,” she said. “An algorithm changes the ‘bars’ and ‘locks’ on the Barrier several thousand times a second in a near perfect oscillating pattern. But because the current algorithm is only nearly-perfect, it’s degrading, and slowly letting the Beast back into our reality. Hence the second wave of infections spreading across the Outer Realms.”

“If I didn’t know any better, I would have guessed you had no idea what it is you just said.” Taline sounded exasperated through the feed.

“Yes, well, I have yet to find a single person who doesn’t understand all that about the Barrier,” Glimmer said, satisfied at having irked her mentor. “It’s practically hammered into everyone’s heads as part of any compulsory education. I understand having adults who want to matriculate into the Empire take it as part of a citizenship test, but this is included in the curriculum for primary-age schoolkids, Taline. Do you realize how nuts that is?”

Taline laughed and agreed with her, before turning serious. “I’m sorry they cut your shore leave off so quickly by the way,” she said. “How are you feeling about the mission?”

“Nervous,” Glimmer wrung her hands. “They wouldn’t have pulled me out like that for another deployment unless it was serious.”

"No, they wouldn't have," Taline said. "I was going to call bullshit if you said you were fine, because I'm nervous for you. Have they given you any details about what's going on?"

Glimmer shook her head. "Only that we're resupplying here before jumping somewhere along the Kaloshi border."

Both of Taline's eyebrows shot up. "The Kaloshi border? That's… that's way closer to the mid rim than any of the previous incursions have been."

"I know," Glimmer said, grimacing. The Barrier was supposed to be stronger the closer to the galactic core one got, alongside the increase in population density. "You haven't heard anything on your end, have you?"

"I'm a disgraced Battlemage, stripped of my prestige and forced to act as a desk jockey on a quiet station," she said with levity in her voice. "The Enclave didn't expel me because they like me, but they're not going to go feeding me classified operational information any time soon."

"I figured as much."

"That didn't stop me from doing my own bit of digging, though," Taline said, a mischievous twinkle sparkling in her eye.

"Why am I not surprised?" Glimmer said, smiling. "And? What did you find?"

"Nothing good," Taline said, the levity from earlier disappearing from her voice. "I got my hands on the operation's deployment plan. The number of ships they've pulled together for this is staggering. In fact, the *Omen-Kador* is slated to be one of the last vessels to arrive. Check your PDA."

A notification from Taline appeared next to her face in the video stream, and Glimmer tapped it. A list of ships appeared, and she scrolled down as she scanned the names. And scrolled and scrolled and scrolled.

“My god, there must be dozens here.”

“Six dozen, to be exact,” Taline said. “Ninety-six carriers, cruisers, and dreadnoughts all deployed to one world. It has to be one of the major populations on the border, that’s the only reason I could think for them to mobilize like this. I already knew it would be bad just seeing the transit manifest, but I had no idea it was as close as Kaloshi.”

“I don’t like how this bodes for the war effort,” Glimmer said, scanning through the list again. “If the Beast is able to break into an area like that, it may force the analysts to reassess their projections.”

“Trust me, no one is happy thinking the Beast might be slipping through faster than anticipated. I’m sure it’s the number one thing on all their minds right now.” Taline sighed and Glimmer felt a familiar dread build at seeing her mentor’s change of tone. “They may tap you for command sooner, too,” she said. “Especially if things indeed are moving faster.”

“No,” Glimmer said.

“Glimmer, we’ve talked about this. You can’t just—“

“We’ve talked about this a lot, yes,” Glimmer said, cutting her off. “The answer is still no.”

Taline let out a long breath and pinched the bridge of her nose. A long beat of silence passed between them. “Do you remember what I said to you back on Etheria?” she said. “Back when you first asked me to take you with me off planet?”

Glimmer hadn’t expected the question. “Yes,” she said, before she recounted to Taline what she remembered of their conversation in the past—how she felt her home had changed too much. How Miri and Narre’s deaths, along with her own friends’ close calls had affected her. How she wanted to learn how to move past the trauma of that night.

“I said I wanted to learn how to be strong again,” she said, nearing the end of her recounting. “And I didn’t think I could learn to do that if I stayed behind.”

“That wasn’t what you told me at first,” Taline said. “You told me at first you just wanted to get away without any concrete reason, and I said—“

“That I needed to have a better reason to go than to just run away from my problems, yes I remember,” Glimmer said, hoping to rush them past an exchange she found embarrassing and preferred not to revisit.

“You were a model student, Glimmer,” Taline said. “You learned everything I had to teach you, and in such a short amount of time, too. You did a magnificent job.”

Glimmer blinked. Taline’s praise came rarely, and always made an impact when it did. “T-thank you,” she said.

“Even if you are not my student any longer, I still hope you’d to abide by what we agreed upon. You are running away from your problems again instead of facing them. The only difference is that I cannot be there and teach you how to overcome whatever is holding you back from confidently leading a team. You have to figure that out on your own, and until you do you will not have the kind of strength you told me you wanted to have when we first left your home.”

Glimmer tried to interject, but she couldn’t get out from underneath Taline’s words fast enough to lessen their impact. By the time she had finished speaking, Glimmer couldn’t even pretend to deny that Taline had a very good point.

“You’re right,” Glimmer said, deflating. “I just don’t know how to take that step.”

“You’ll be ready one day,” Taline said. “Maybe not today, but you will be soon. Just don’t try and stop it when it you see it coming.”

Glimmer scoffed. “When did you turn into a poet philosopher, Taline?”

“Hey, I just took something I heard Salas say once and put my own spin on it,” Taline said. A noise suddenly came through the connection—someone speaking—and she looked somewhere offscreen, likely at whoever had interrupted them. “I might have to go soon,” she said. “Diallo is on station for one of his quarterly visits and he’s going to monopolize a significant chunk of one of my days here pretty soon.”

“Again?” Glimmer asked, incredulous.

“Yes, unfortunately. And I can’t turn him away either, since I’m technically the reason he has his position in the first place.” She stiffened. “He’s going to try and get me to buy into another wild goose chase again, you know how it goes. I need to get some work done in advance before he comes or else I’ll fall behind.”

“You know, hearing you talk about your desk job like that sometimes makes me seriously question whether paperwork or evacuating planets from the Beast is worse.”

Taline laughed at that. “I wonder that too, sometimes.”

“Before I forget…” Glimmer said, catching an inquisitive look from Taline when she hesitated to speak further. “Catra may or may not come visit you.”

“Oh?” Taline looked genuinely surprised. “She’s never visited me before. What’s going on?”

“She’s visited plenty of times,” Glimmer said. “Just…you know, never in your office. I’ll let her explain it to you, just promise me you’ll see her if she does stop by? Don’t send her away and reschedule if you’re in the middle of something. You know how hard it is to get her to come out of her shell sometimes.”

“I do, just as I know she has no qualms about using that shell of hers to bulldoze her way around and make a mess, rather than

just come out of it." There was a fondness to Taline's voice that made Glimmer smile. "I'll be sure to see her, even if she has to walk in on Diallo in the middle of one of his ravings again."

"Thank you," Glimmer said. "And let's hope so. I'd love to hear her reaction when she tells me what happened later. She always has a very colorful way of telling stories." Another sound echoed behind Taline. "I'll let you go," she said. "Don't want to keep you from the paperwork."

"Aren't you forgetting something?"

Glimmer blinked, wracking her brain and trying to think of something she may have missed. "No?" she said after coming up short.

"You're supposed to show me your progress on the teleportation spell you've been working at."

Glimmer groaned. Oh yeah, how could she have forgotten?

"Don't give me that," Taline said, making a face. "You asked me to help you dial it in."

"Yeah, but that was back when I thought I'd have two weeks on Phoenix to relax and have you there to help focus me in person."

"No time like the present. You have my undivided attention for the next sixty seconds—show me what you got."

Glimmer sighed and tapped her PDA, opaquing a portion of the observation booth's view screen and casting the video feed to it. With her hands free and Taline now having a full-body view of her, Glimmer stood, stretched her arms far enough that her joints popped, and started to draw a rune in the air in front of her.

"Slow down," Taline said as Glimmer got about a third of the way through the design. "Speed is important on the battlefield, sure, but so is drawing smooth, accurate ley lines. Teleporting only half your squad—and by that, I mean half of each member of your

squad and not half the number of them—is just as undesirable as not teleporting out of a sticky situation in time at all."

Taline had deliberately made that example one of Glimmer leading a team to purposely vex her, she just knew it. Still, she redoubled her efforts to slow down and concentrate. Before long, she completed the circuit and a shining, intricate teleportation rune shimmered in front of her.

"Not bad," Taline said. "Your diacritics invite room for interpretation so it may be a rocky transit, but I think you'd be able to get at least yourself through that if you activated it. Good job."

Glimmer breathed a sigh of relief and wiped the rune. She didn't understand why she took so quickly to all the other spells Taline had taught her only to run into hurdle after hurdle getting the teleportation spell correct. It was almost as if being so far away from Etheria and cut off from the Moonstone had made it that much harder for her to do it the 'other' way, rather than just poofing like she had all the other times in her life.

"Get in touch with me as soon as you arrive at your destination," Taline said. "I want to hear you're safe, as often as you can pull away to let me know. The time lag will be nasty even at the Kaloshi border, but please don't forget."

"I won't," Glimmer said. "I promise. Give my best to Catra when you see her, will you? I had to go in a hurry and could only leave a note. I feel bad."

Taline promised she would and they exchanged quick salutes. The feed cut, and Glimmer collapsed onto the couch behind her to stare blankly out at the Barrier node once more.

*So much for shore leave*, she thought, unable to fully erase the tinge of bitterness that came with it.

She let her thoughts wander while the rings oscillating around the star lulled her into a second daze. Against her better judgement,

she pulled up Bow's contact on her PDA and drafted a letter to him. Halfway through the second sentence she bit at her lip in annoyance and deleted what she had written, only to start over fresh. She did the same for a third attempt. Then a fourth.

"Well, I'll be damned," a voice from behind said.

Glimmer swore and spun around on the couch, her heart pounding in her chest. A familiar face standing in the open doorway looked back at her. "Lonnie?" she said, standing. "My god it *is* you. How did I not even hear you open the door?"

"Hey Glim," she said, cracking a smile. "You look pretty good for someone heading into their fourth straight deployment without a break. That's edging close to Vanguard numbers. Isn't it dangerous for you Battlemage types to go so long without a pause?"

Glimmer gaped at her, still not trusting what she saw. She hadn't seen Lonnie since leaving Etheria, obviously, and seeing her standing there almost convinced Glimmer she had actually fallen asleep and started dreaming in the observation room altogether. Lonnie was dressed in the grey and green service uniform of the Horde standing navy, looking virtually unchanged from when Glimmer last saw her save for a thin line running from her scalp, past her eye, and disappearing under her chin. She must have had some sort of sub-dermal implant installed, but otherwise…

"Holy hell, you look fantastic!" Glimmer said, going in for a hug that was warmly received and enthusiastically returned. "How the heck did you get here? Were you just hanging out as part of an extra garrison or something?"

Lonnie shook her head. "Nope, transferred from my last assignment to yours. Old girl was a beater." She made her way into the private booth and toward the view screen. "In fact," she said, leaning forward and squinting at something in the distance. "If you look really hard, you can see her from here."

Glimmer followed Lonnie's finger where she pointed and squinted too. There, idling in the distance just past one of the rotating arms of the Barrier node, floated a modest-sized carrier.

"She looks like she's seen better days," Glimmer said, noting the blast marks and battle scars across its hull.

"Yeah, she's emptying most of her personnel and traveling to a nearby shipyard on a skeleton crew. Needs heavy repairs and a retrofit."

"Good. It honestly doesn't look like it'd last another assignment." Glimmer glanced at her out of the corner of her eye. "Did I hear you correctly? Did you say something about the Vanguard?"

Lonnie turned to the side and showed off one of the patches on the arm of her service uniform: a stylized crest with the Horde wing motif, combined with the spear and shield graphic made famous by the emperor's personal elite force.

Glimmer whistled. "I shouldn't be surprised, really, considering it's you. But Vanguard is still impressive wherever you see them."

"You're not the only one out here making a name for yourself," Lonnie said, waggling her eyebrows at her. "Angel of Archanas."

Glimmer flushed. "Please, I've heard the story a million times, spare me the spotlight."

Lonnie laughed and thumped Glimmer on the back of the shoulder. "Space has changed you, princess. The old you would have beamed and jumped at the chance to retell the time you saved all those people on Rinne by sprouting—"

"Yes, yes," Glimmer said, waving to cut Lonnie off and beckoning her to take a seat on the couch before joining her. "I thought it was awesome too until I couldn't go three steps anywhere without everyone turning around and whispering about me all excited. I didn't sign on to the Enclave to be a celebrity." She forced a laugh.

“Enough about me, what about you? How did you get in with the Vanguard of all things? I didn’t even know you had left home.”

“Well, speaking of home…you know how after everything got settled and the Enclave made that announcement? How they let every member of Hordak’s old group sign up for service with the actual Imperial Horde if they wanted to?”

Glimmer nodded.

“Kyle, Rogelio, and I all signed on. None of us wanted to stay after what happened, and space just seemed so full of opportunities. It was rough at first, but we all promised to stay together as a team no matter what happened. Even turned down assignments if it meant us getting split up.”

“You guys always were such good friends.” Glimmer said.

“Yeah, and I guess we make a pretty damn good squad too, because we beat all the survival odds together. Nine deployments later, more successful missions than anyone has any right to, a lot of money lost for the people who bet against us, and we officially got scouted by the Vanguard. That was over a year ago.”

“Nine deployments?” Glimmer said. “Nine? In three years? Are you serious?”

“Nine in a year and a half, actually,” Lonnie said. “They got shorter but more numerous once we actually joined up with the emperor’s finest. This is my twenty-second deployment now. Thirteenth in the Vanguard.”

When Glimmer’s eyes threatened to bulge out of her head, Lonnie laughed. “It’s not like your Enclave assignments,” she said. “We don’t stay behind and help stabilize the worlds once the incursion is taken care of, and we don’t help relocate evacuees. For us, as soon as the Beast is pushed back and dealt with, we’re off. High impact missions only, then straight on to the next one as soon as the first is done.”

"That's insane. I don't know how you haven't gone crazy from the stress yet," Glimmer said. "And did I hear you correctly that it's you and Kyle and Rogelio still together? If you're in the Vanguard then does that mean…?"

Lonnie nodded. "Yep. We're all in the same squad, after all."

"*Kyle* is a member of the Vanguard?" Glimmer didn't know how many more world-shattering revelations she could take.

"You wouldn't recognize him," Lonnie said, laughing. "He's a hell of a pilot. Nerves of steel, and he's gotten us and hundreds of others out of situations I didn't think we'd make it through."

"I believe you it's just…wow. So much has changed." A thought came to her and Glimmer furrowed her brow. "Hey, Vanguard got its name partially because you guys are almost always the first in on the battlefield, right? But the *Omen-Kador* is supposed to be one of the last ships arriving to assist. Was there like a mix-up with the transit manifests or something?"

Lonnie shot her a quizzical look. "You mean, you didn't see the orders?"

"I haven't seen anything," Glimmer said, shaking her head. "I got pulled from shore leave last minute as an emergency and barely got myself to my staging zone on time."

Lonnie reached into the breast pocket of her service jacket and handed Glimmer a small silicone chip. Glimmer felt her blood freeze over as she took it, already anticipating what was on the card without having to run it through a reader.

"I've been assigned to you as a section commander," Lonnie said. She stood, clicked her heels together and snapped off a sharp salute. Then she broke decorum by shooting Glimmer a wide smile. "As soon as I found out who I'd be serving under, I couldn't wait to get aboard and find you. I look forward to being a member of your first command, Ma'am."

Glimmer felt like she was about to be sick. The only thing that ran through her mind as she tried to keep from hyperventilating on the spot was one thought:

*Oh no.*

Chapter End Notes

Glimmer's 'catalyst of change'. Surprise! I bet Glimmer getting forcibly assigned a squad wasn't too huge of a surprise, considering that's what she confessed to Catra during their last chapter together. But getting Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio back I'm sure surprised some people.

There's literally only 1 story with a Glimmer & Lonnie tag, it's so rare, but it's a treasure trove of opportunity. Lonnie and Catra are similarly hot-headed and stubborn, but whereas Catra has that history and mutual respect for Glimmer, Lonnie does not. In fact, by this point in the story, all Lonnie has is the pedestal she obviously has put Glimmer up on, which is in stark contrast to the mutual respect Catra and Glimmer have with one another. A solid example of this already is how Catra and Lonnie both tackled the "Angel of Archanas" and "Rinne" subjects. Catra brought it up strategically to distract Glimmer from spiraling, Lonnie put it forward as an attempt at reconnecting through mutual war stories.

Lonnie has her heart in the right place, obviously, but its only going to make things harder on top of the fact Glimmer's worst nightmare about leading a team is apparently coming true. If you think things are not going to go remotely smooth then you, dear reader, are spot on :D

I'm still undecided on adding the new relationship tag. I might add it in next week, or just leave it out entirely to preserve the surprise.

# The Secret in the Embassy

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The elevator was crowded. So crowded in fact, that Catra might have decided to turn around and go home had she not already been operating on complete autopilot. Instead, she headed inside, selected one of the highest floors on the control panel, and slotted herself between a chubby, pink fellow faintly reminiscent of a bipedal piglet and a slender alien with six arms.

The nightmares had returned fiercer than they had ever been in the past, and she had woken in a cold sweat earlier in the day, alone on Glimmer's couch. With her gone, Catra feared she was still in the midst of the nightmare still—one that had undergone a strange mutation, showing her a different reality in which, once again, her closest friend in this new life of hers had left her abandoned. It wasn't until Catra managed to peel herself from the tangled mass of sheets and find the note written in Glimmer's flourished princess-scrawl that she realized, no, she had already woken up. Glimmer had indeed gone, although she hadn't abandoned her.

*Pulled away on a last-minute assignment,* the note had read. *Sorry I can't say bye properly, it's an emergency. I'll get in touch again as soon as I make landfall.*

The elevator continued to rise, and Catra watched the ground floor of the Atrium get farther and farther away, continued to watch the people bustling among the trees and pathways and in and out of department stores and restaurants shrink smaller and smaller.

The elevator would stop with a pleasant ding. The doors would open and everyone inside would shift to let a subset of

passengers off. No one got on. Catra remained lost in her thoughts.

What kind of emergency would pull Glimmer away from shore leave on such short notice she barely had time to scrawl a note to her? What did it mean that the nightmares got even worse after she left? Was she going backwards now? Losing the progress she had made since leaving home?

The elevator dinged again, bringing Catra out of her thoughts. Everyone else had gotten off already leaving her alone and on the highest level of the Atrium; only the Executive levels immediately above were any higher.

She stepped out into the Enclave Embassy and its spacious front lobby. Hand-carved columns of marble lined the sides and reached high to support a tall ceiling. The polished flooring made every clack of a heel or syllable of a conversation echo, giving the chamber a bustling atmosphere despite Catra only seeing a handful of people around. Two tall statues, one of Horde Prime and the other being yet another rendition of the Shaper Corynth, flanked another cherry blossom tree—the centerpiece of the room. Catra approached it, rubbing her shoulders and glancing about at everyone else as if she were afraid they might approach her. She didn't belong here.

Catra had only ever visited the Embassy one time. It was when she first came to the station and started her citizenship paperwork with Glimmer at Taline's behest. And regardless of the fact she'd get lost in the Atrium every time she went, Catra somehow always knew how to find her way back to the Embassies, despite never having gone a second time.

"H-hey, Hilda? You there?" Catra said, when she reached the statues. The holographic guide flickered into existence to Catra's left and shot her a cheery smile.

"Hello Catra," she said, tilting her head. "How may I be of assistance?"

"I'm looking for Taline's office. I've never actually been…can you point me in the right direction?"

Hilda bowed her head in assent and gave directions, and Catra declined when she offered to walk her there personally. Paintings of the Embassy Consuls prior to Taline lined hallway after hallway alongside other pieces of fine art and sculpture. Catra made a game of trying to make as little sound as possible as she traipsed along.

She rounded a corner and into the waiting room of Taline's embassy corner office. Several chairs lined the walls, each seat filled with someone either reading one of the magazines from the large center coffee table or playing on their PDA. One woman bounced an infant on her knee, trying to keep it quiet while entertaining a second toddler. More than a few people of various alien races and colors stood due to lack of seating.

The door to Taline's office proper was shut, and a small fountain hung from the wall behind the front desk, immersing the room in the sound of falling water. Catra approached, and the receptionist, sitting before a computer and amidst several high stacks of papers piled high on the desk, typed rapidly at the keyboard. She seemed to be copying information from the surrounding documents, because as soon as she finished a spurt of typing, she'd move the top page from the nearest stack to another one, only to start the process over again. Catra thought *she* had it bad with paperwork back at the precinct.

"Hi, sorry," she said, trying to get the receptionist to notice her.

"Consular Taline is busy with an important visitor at the moment," the receptionist said, not even taking her eyes off the computer. "All appointments have been postponed until further notice. You're free to take a seat if you'd prefer to see her as soon as she's available and in the order of your appointment, or we can set a new time and date for you to come back."

Catra turned and looked at the filled room. All these people wanted to wait for god knows how long just to see her? She knew Taline was popular on the station; she was the only member of administration who insisted on having her office somewhere other than up in the executive floors, and she was also the only member of the administration to hold open office hours. But Catra had no idea people would sit around waiting with no definite appointment time just to talk to her.

"Uhm, I don't have an appointment, but can I make one?"

The woman put another page on the finished pile, grabbed the whole thing and dropped it with a thump onto the ground next to six other equally tall stacks that Catra hadn't noticed before. Then she grabbed a third, unprocessed stack of papers and started working on those. Somewhere in that series of practiced movements, she had placed a palm scanner up on the desk platform for Catra to access.

"Hand on the reader, please. Bookings are filled for the next two months, but I can get you put in and on a waiting list. If someone cancels, we might bump you up. Just need your ID."

Catra placed her hand on the scanner. It flashed as it read her prints and biometrics, and the woman behind the desk suddenly paused and looked up at her.

"Catra?" she asked.

"Yeah, that's me. Is something wrong?"

The woman shook her head. "Nothing wrong, I just…" She didn't finish her sentence, and instead picked up the handset on her desk and put it to her ear. "Hello, Taline?"

Catra could hear the muffled sound of a man speaking frantically on the other side of the line. Then she heard Taline's voice, still muffled but louder and closer to the handset on her end, although she still couldn't make out the words.

“Yes, I understand you’re still with him,” the receptionist said, “but I thought it best to let you know that Catra is standing out here. She’s asking to make an appointment to see you.”

Taline’s voice came through again, and Catra grew nervous. What was she saying?

“You want me to”—a pause, and a nod—“…yes, I understand. Okay.” The receptionist hung up the phone and looked back at Catra. “She asked that I just send you in now.”

Catra’s ears flicked sideways and she took a step back. “Now? You just told me she was with someone.”

“I know.” She pressed a button on her desk and Catra heard the door to Taline’s office click as the lock disengaged. “I have a feeling she’d much rather visit with you than with who’s in there now though, so go right in. Also, it’s nice to finally meet you.”

“Uhh, nice to meet you too,” Catra said, unsure if that was the right thing to respond with or not. Catra ignored the looks she got from everyone else in the lobby and walked over to the door. Laying a hand on the lever, she took a deep breath and pushed inside.

The voice of someone in the middle of a passionate argument assaulted her, and she scrambled to get inside and click the door shut behind her before it caused a commotion out in the waiting room. A man sat in a chair on the other side of Taline’s desk. Catra recognized him—it was Diallo, the VIP she helped escort the previous day. His back was toward her and he gesticulated wildly as he spoke.

“No one just c-cuts budgets like that, Taline. Not that drastically. I’m telling you t-t-there’s something fishy going on with him. I don’t know if it has something to do with paranoia around his reelection, but I’m already at my l-limit as it is trying to keep my system in order.”

“I understand,” Taline said, sitting straight-backed and stone-faced in her chair. Instead of the black and silver Battlemage uniform Catra had seen her in when they first met, she wore simple Consular’s robes. “But I’m not sure what you expect me to do about it. Moriarty is the Regional Administrator of our section of the mid-rim. He has thousands of planets, hundreds of systems, and thus hundreds of System Governors like yourself to make decisions for. He may use my station as his base of operations, but he reports directly to the Emperor. There is nothing I can do for you.”

Diallo hadn’t noticed Catra come in, and although Taline faced in her direction, she made no indication to him she was there. Catra pushed herself up against the far wall and tried to be as small and unobtrusive as possible.

“You are a Battlemage of t-the Enclave, Taline,” Diallo said. “Moriarty doesn’t answer to you, but he m-must take your counsel into consideration. I cannot protect the planets under my jurisdiction with such heavy cuts into my budget.” He sat forward in his chair and put his palms together. “I became System Governor in the first place off y-your recommendation. I implore you to speak with him.”

Taline sighed. “You know I am no longer a Battlemage. I am simply Consular Taline now and have been for the past three years. No matter how many times you come visit me and ask for my help, it will not change the fact my job right now is ensuring the safety and wellbeing of this station and of its people. That’s it.”

“And what of the d-drive?” Diallo asked, holding up a thin electronic device Catra hadn’t noticed before.

Taline narrowed her eyes at him and lowered her voice. “That’s an incredibly dangerous thing you have there,” she said. “I have no idea how you got your hands on it, but if you want my suggestion, I would destroy it immediately and never mention it again.”

“This is concrete proof of what I’ve b-been telling you for years,” he said, practically hissing. “Every time you even caught a whiff of something like this on interstellar channels in the p-past you’d climb straight into a starship and leave me to manage your affairs until you came back. Why do you suddenly not even want to look at this now that I finally b-brought proof?”

“The Vestamid make up too large a portion of the GDP of the Empire, Diallo. Ignominite supply would be irreparably harmed if something were to happen to their production lines. I don’t understand why you are pushing so hard for me to look into this. Do you want a galaxy-wide incident to occur? With everything else going on?”

“I don’t remember when Taline, the Seraph of Archanas herself, would t-turn her nose up at an opportunity to investigate one of these ph-phantom algorithms.”

Taline flinched and her eyes hardened. “My student has taken up that name. It no longer means anything to me, and you have no idea how that drive is encrypted. No idea at all.”

“That’s exactly my p-point,” Diallo said. “The encryption is uncrackable. The best software I’ve run it through d-doesn’t even know where to begin with it. The old you wouldn’t have flinched and g-gone straight to investigate, but now you’re p-protecting some militant sect of fanatics instead? Why are you suddenly refusing to even look?”

Taline pursed her lips. “Like I’ve said, my priority is this station. Nothing else. And believe it or not, if something happens to that ignominite supply your constituents provide, then the safety of everyone on this station, not to mention your own system itself, would be put at risk. I’m not getting into any more wild goose chases, Diallo. Corynth is dead, and for the sake of my own mental health I want to leave it at that.”

Catra felt a tickle at her nose and, despite trying everything she could to resist, she sneezed. Taline glanced up at her with a smirk

and Diallo contorted his body around his chair to look at her.

“I d-didn’t realize I had someone secretly sitting in on a private conversation,” Diallo said, irritated.

“This is Catra,” Taline said, nodding in her direction. “She’s the second person I sponsored into the Empire after Glimmer. You two have already met, believe it or not.”

Diallo raised an eyebrow at her and Catra stepped forward, feeling exposed. “I’m a member of station security, under section chief Dax,” she said. “I was there when you arrived yesterday, as a member of the security detachment.”

“Oh?” Diallo looked surprised. “D-Dax is a good man. I like him.”

Catra only nodded, not sure what else to say. Diallo stood from his chair and turned back to Taline. “Well, it seems I’m once again t-taking up time you would otherwise be using to sit with those who actually have appointments w-with you. I’m glad you’ve kept up that tradition, by the way. Keeps you well c-connected to the common person under your care.” He held up the drive one more time before purposefully placing it on Taline’s desk. “I’ll leave this here. You can decide if you’d truly prefer it destroyed or if you want t-to see for yourself that I’ve finally brought your proof.”

With that, Diallo headed for the exit. He nodded to Catra as he went, his eyes lingering on her a moment longer than she thought necessary. Then the door clicked shut behind him and Catra and Taline were alone.

Taline slumped forward and held her head in both her hands with her elbows on the table. Catra took tentative steps toward her until she was at the chair Diallo just vacated.

“Thank you for coming,” Taline said, not lifting her head from her hands. “He’s been here for an hour and it’s felt like five. I don’t know how much longer I would have lasted if you hadn’t come along.”

“I didn’t do anything except stand there,” Catra said, lowering herself onto the chair.

“He didn’t want to talk in front of someone else, so you just standing there was enough to get him to leave.” She combed her fingers through her hair. “Diallo is a good man. Would have joined the Enclave himself if he had just a little more aptitude for magic. He was a great help categorizing and accounting for all the things we found in my sister’s second lab, but he’s always had an eccentric side. It’s almost strong enough sometimes to overshadow how meek and unassuming he seems.”

She lifted her head off the desk and frowned, accentuating the three silver scars running across her cheek from when the Emperor backhanded her aboard the citadel. “Actually, I’m fairly certain that eccentricity has only grown worse the longer I’ve known him. At times it’s merely off-putting, and at other times I feel like I barely recognize him.”

“You’re able to...” Catra trailed off, looked around, and lowered her voice. “You’re able to talk freely about your sister in here?”

Taline nodded. “It’s one of the few truly safe places to do so. No bugs, no hidden devices, completely sound insulated against the outside listening in. It’s one of the reasons Diallo felt comfortable talking about this particular thing so freely in here.” She gestured to the portable drive sitting untouched between them.

Catra nodded, remembering how loudly Diallo had spoken when she entered, and how she hadn’t heard even a murmur of it standing right outside the door. Taline looked like she was waiting for her to say something, so she started to panic. Silences were always uncomfortable around Taline, though through no fault of her own. Catra just felt bare and vulnerable, like Taline could see right through her. She always tried to avoid letting pauses linger during their conversations as much as possible.

“Thank you for seeing me,” Catra said, reaching for the first thing that popped into her mind. “You had a bunch of people out there

waiting, but the receptionist just sent me in."

"Of course," Taline said. "I think this is the first time you've ever come all the way to my office, so it must be important for you to make the trip. What did you want to talk to me about?"

Catra cringed. Taline hadn't meant to guilt her with that comment, but she felt guilty about it all the same. They visited with each other plenty of times! What did she have to feel bad about?

"I uh…well." Catra deflated in the chair. "Glimmer left. And I was looking forward to hanging out with her. Dax turned me away when I tried to clock in for work because he already cleared me for PTO. Also, I guess I looked too hungover for him to feel comfortable letting me patrol."

"You do look like you had a bit too much to drink last night," Taline said nodding.

"Glimmer said I should come talk to you too since, well…y'know. The nightmares and everything."

"Have they been getting worse?"

"No. Well…yes, but not really?" Taline gave her a confused look, and Catra wondered why she felt so sweaty all of a sudden. Why was it always so difficult for her to just talk like a normal person?

"You're going to have to be a little more specific than that," Taline said. "I tried reaching out. I hadn't heard much from you since Glimmer was last on the station eight months ago. I was starting to worry…if the nightmares are getting worse and you've just been reticent to tell me, I promise I'm not going to judge."

Another stab of guilt. Catra realized that the 'plenty of times' she and Taline had visited together had only been when Glimmer came along too, since Catra always felt too exposed and in the hot seat if it were just her and Taline. With Glimmer gone on so many consecutive deployments, it really had been the better part of a year since Catra last saw Taline in person.

“I don’t think they’re getting *worse* worse,” Catra said. “Maybe I just freaked out waking up and seeing Glimmer gone is all. I think it's fine.”

“You wouldn’t have come all the way up here if everything were fine though,” Taline said. “Is this about your Sentinel application?”

“You know about that!?” Catra shot up from the chair. Her tail thrashed behind her and her ears pinned to her head. “How did you find out? Did Glimmer tell you? I told her not to say anything!”

Taline gave her an exasperated look. It only got Catra’s hackles up further that she didn’t look the least bit surprised at her outburst. “Glimmer didn’t say a word to me. I found out from my other colleagues.”

Catra forced herself to calm down before she collapsed back into the chair with a sigh. There it was, the exact thing Glimmer had urged Catra to come and talk to her about. Taline had taken a sledgehammer up to her walls and, within minutes, knew exactly how and where to strike to make them crumble fast. No wonder Catra hesitated to spend time with her—Shadow Weaver knew how to do the same thing. And while she didn’t think Taline would ever use her weaknesses against her, she still hated how easily she unraveled. That wasn’t all, but this whole meeting was still a mistake.

“Why would they tell you about that?” Catra asked, folding her arms. She was angry, both with herself that she hadn’t built up the courage to broach the topic herself, and at Taline for not giving her the time to do so.

“Despite everything I told Diallo, I’m still well connected among my peers, Catra. This station may be my sole concern now, but the Enclave didn’t excommunicate me like the Emperor asked because the other members of the High Council didn’t want to do so. Seeing an application come in from you? One of the people I explicitly sponsored into the Empire? There’s no way they wouldn’t

have told me about it. The very fact an application was sent in at all was news in and of itself."

"What do you mean?" Catra asked, brows furrowed and tail flicking. That last sentence alone threatened to upend any sense of calm she had won back for herself.

"How did you know how to submit an application in the first place?"

"I…I don't know. Glimmer looked into it for me."

Taline leaned back in her chair, mild surprise on her face. "Glimmer helped you? That's interesting. Is that why you didn't want her to tell me anything?"

"No…I mean, that's not why." Catra's heart raced. She couldn't slow it down. There was no doubt about it; something about Taline's tone and line of questioning had tipped her off. She had done something wrong with the application. "What's interesting? Why would you say it's interesting? Why would you say that it makes sense?"

Taline narrowed her eyes at her. "Are you okay? You seem—"

"I'm fine." No she wasn't. She couldn't get her breathing under control. "Just tell me. Tell me what's interesting."

Taline spoke as if she were coaxing a startled animal from its hiding place. "No one has sent in a physical application like you did for hundreds of years, Catra. It's an archaic practice."

*Oh shit.*

"Archaic practice!? What the hell does that mean?" She was spiraling. "How do you guys get new Sentinels if no one sends applications?"

"It's okay, Catra. It's not a huge deal."

It wasn't okay. It was a big deal. Massive. What was she going on about?

"Everyone kind of got a good laugh at it," Taline said. "It actually made them look at you more seriously because of it."

"You're saying everyone laughed at me? Laughed at the months of hard work they put me through, jumping through all those hurdles and all that red tape for them? That's what was going on?"

"No, that's not…" Taline trailed off, blinking rapidly in her surprise. "What's going on? Why are you getting so upset?"

"I'm not upset."

"You very clearly are. Just take a deep breath. It's not as bad as you think."

"I'm *calm*." Catra tapped her foot on the ground and her tail thumped hard against the chair.

"Why are you so worked up right now?"

"Because I'm not like Evelyn!" Catra screamed the words, tearing at her hair.

Taline flinched. She looked like she had just been slapped. Everything crawled to a halt, and ice flooded Catra's veins. She went instantly from not being able to get enough air no matter how quickly she breathed to holding her breath altogether, afraid of burning yet another bridge if she so much as opened her mouth to sip at the air.

"What does any of this have to do with Evelyn?" Taline asked, voice low.

Catra breathed out slow through her nose and counted heartbeats. "I'm not like Evelyn," she said. "I can't…I'm not…" She gritted her teeth. Why could she never find the right words? A

thought occurred to her then: if she flipped the frustration on its head and asked a question instead, maybe then she could get a foothold into what she was trying to convey. “Did you only invite me off planet because I reminded you of her?”

Taline blinked, now looking taken aback. “No. Why would you think I did?”

Catra breathed a sigh of relief. She expected a different answer, but this helped put her mind at ease at least. “I just can’t figure out why you invited me off Etheria. You didn’t even invite Glimmer, she had to ask you to take her along. But you came and asked me, not just to come off planet with you, but also to advise you when you were negotiating with the Emperor. You came to me outside the castle that day I lost Adora. You brought food… encouraging words…you gave me your jacket. You encouraged me to turn my life around.”

“And you thought I only did those things because you reminded me of Evie?” Taline asked? “Is that really what you thought?”

“I couldn’t think of any other reason why! Why would you want to help someone like me?” Tears pricked her eyes and Catra strained to keep them at bay. She wouldn’t cry. She refused to cry. “Why would you bring me here and walk me through all the paperwork to get citizenship? Why would you set me up with a freaking job on the station? Even when you were busy training Glimmer to be a Battlemage on top of all your other responsibilities, you always went out of your way to check in with me and make sure I had everything I needed. Why would you do that for someone like me? The only thing I could think of was…well…”

“That I did so only because I saw you as a stand in for my sister,” Taline said, finishing what Catra couldn’t bring herself to say. “Because you don’t think you deserve any of it otherwise.”

Catra swallowed. She couldn’t deny it, even though she wanted so badly to.

"Is this why you turned down all of my help?" Taline asked. "Why you avoid me unless Glimmer is there with you?" She paused, suddenly looking horrified. "I've written glowing character references for every one of your performance reviews. Tell me that doesn't have anything to do with you rejecting all your promotions at work."

Catra hung her head.

"Dax came to me last week and asked me not to submit anything on your behalf this time," Taline said. "I didn't understand why at the time but…now I do."

Catra hated herself. She could hear the hurt in Taline's voice, could hear how hard she fought to keep it from showing. "I love my police job," she said, hands twisting in her lap. She didn't trust herself to look Taline in the eyes. "But a small part of me always felt like I was only given that because of you. I didn't want to take the promotions because I didn't feel I earned them if you were just giving them to me as well."

"Catra…"

"I asked Glimmer to look into the Sentinels," she said, not wanting to give Taline the chance to interrupt. She needed to get this all out before she lost her nerve entirely. "You ordered Narre and Miri to protect Glimmer's life, and then they did so against the freaking Emperor for crying out loud. I'm not stupid, I recognize how much you must have trusted them to give that kind of an order. I thought that, I don't know…maybe if I applied and got accepted without you or anyone else even knowing, and I got in, then that would be something I earned on my own."

She sniffled and dragged her sleeve across her face. "Then I could stand next to you and help you, not because you gave me a position but because I earned it—because I'm competent and worthy enough to hold it."

Taline gave a great sigh, and the sound of her chair squeaking filled the silence in the room as she sat back in thought. “Look at me, Catra,” she said after a long pause.

Slowly, reluctantly, Catra edged her eyes up to meet Taline’s. She looked so heartbroken and sad that Catra immediately knew her entire thought process for all this held no weight.

“It’s true that in some ways you remind me of Evie,” Taline said, weary. “But that goes just the same for Glimmer. Even Adora, for the short amount of time I knew her, reminded me a little bit of her. I absolutely did not choose to help you—any of you—because of that. You are Catra. I don’t see you as anyone else. I chose to help you because of who you are and who I want to be, not because I’m trying to use you to replicate a relationship I can no longer have with Evie. Do you understand?”

Catra nodded and drug her sleeve across her eyes again. She had cried even though she promised herself she wouldn’t.

“Good.” Taline leaned forward and pressed a button on the phone on her desk. The receptionist outside greeted her on the other side of the line.

“Lyra,” Taline said. “Please tell everyone waiting out there that I’m extremely sorry, but we’ll have to reschedule their appointments for a different day.”

“Is everything okay?” Lyra asked.

“Don’t cancel all those peoples’ appointments just for me,” Catra said, mumbling. She was too emotionally drained to protest any harder, even though she did just inadvertently ruin everyone’s day outside.

Taline only held up an open palm to tell her to wait. “Everything is fine, just…something came up I won’t push off. Tell them that I will visit them at their homes for their rescheduled appointments as an apology for all the inconvenience.”

“Alright, I’ll get it done,” Lyra said. “You’ll let me know if you need anything else?”

“Of course I will.” Taline thanked her, then cut the connection and ran her hands through her hair again.

“Why did you do that?” Catra asked, hoarse.

“I have something I want to show you,” Taline said. She tapped a few commands into the computer at her desk before standing up and heading to a floor-to-ceiling display shelf behind her. Catra stood and approached to her left.

Taline pressed a section of the wall next to the shelves. It depressed, and then flipped around to reveal another palm scanner. She pressed her hand to it, waited for the scan to finish, and then stepped back. The entire shelving case and the section of wall it was fixed to suddenly jolted and slowly swung backward, revealing a pitch-black room hidden beyond.

“Aside from me, there is only one other person alive today who knows about this,” Taline said, stepping through the doorway and into the shadows.

“Who’s that?” Catra asked, following her in.

“You.”

Catra couldn’t see anything, despite her night vision. Taline flipped a switch to her right and Catra threw up one arm to shield her eyes against the sudden brightness. When she adjusted and looked around, a new room stretched out before her, completely at odds with the office behind them because of its sparse concrete design.

Wire-rack shelves stood in neat rows all the way to the back, filled with reams of papers, beakers, test-tubes, computers, and various dusty lab equipment. Wires, aluminum HVAC ducts, exposed piping and colorful industrial electric cords snaked through nearly every exposed surface. It felt like she had stepped into a room

that belonged adjacent to the maintenance corridors of the station's lower wards, rather than up in the embassies.

"What is this place?" Catra asked, eyes darting everywhere.

"Do you remember how I once told you of the research black-sites during the last war? How the Empire and Enclave used them to run experiments on the Beast?

Catra nodded.

"And do you remember how I mentioned Evelyn had demanded I give her a lab of her own shortly after we rescued her and Corynth?

Catra nodded again. "You said she told you she needed to finish the breakthrough they came across before everyone else on her team died." Her jaw hinged open when she started to piece things together, and she looked open-mouthed at Taline, a silent question in her eyes.

"Phoenix Station's original purpose was to serve as one of those secret research stations," Taline said. "This is where she and Corynth first experimented with the Beast together. This is where they touched minds with it until she finally discovered ignominite. This is where the beginning of the end started."

Chapter End Notes

> This chapter and the next encompass one of the first scenes I envisioned when the idea for this fic first took hold. It wasn't anything other than "Catra hears something she needs to hear from a nicer authority figure than Shadow Weaver" at the time, but after watching season 4, that's all I could think of until I started plotting this in earnest T.T

# Hidden Treasure

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I can't believe this is here," Catra said, stalking through the corridors of wire-rack shelves, each filled with research equipment. Evelyn's old lab was a marvel. "How did you manage to keep all of this hidden?"

"It wasn't easy," Taline said, walking with her. "The Enclave gutted this place shortly after Evie and the rest of her team first rebelled against the emperor. They closed it off and repurposed the station…built it out to be an administration hub like you see today. What they didn't know was that Evie programmed back-door access for me. She left a recorded message saying as much among her things in the new lab she had occupied with the Daiamid."

"So, all this stuff is from the second lab," Catra asked, playing with the antennae of a piece of robotic equipment that looked like a bug. "Not the first?"

Taline nodded. "After she died, that second site was to be ransacked just like this one. The emperor wanted everything catalogued and transported to his personal storage facilities in the Heartlands. Diallo was actually in charge of the team that did the cataloguing and shipping—I met him shortly before and recommended him for the job when it turned out we worked well together."

"If the emperor wanted everything stored in his personal vaults, how did all this stuff end up here?"

A sly smile spread across Taline's face. "Diallo has no real love for the emperor either. Not really. He helped me secret a portion of the equipment away here. We managed to smuggle almost everything I wanted, everything of real or sentimental value.

There was just one thing we couldn't find no matter how hard we looked."

"What was that?"

"The original sample of the Beast Evie researched. It wasn't among her things in the second lab. I'm pretty sure either she destroyed it, or had Corynth do it for her before they left for Archanas." Taline had grown somber and, as if suddenly realizing it herself, she shook her head and snapped out of it. "Anyways, almost no one knows this first lab even existed to begin with. Anyone who does, believes it is both empty and permanently sealed. Only I, and now you, know that it's here and know what's inside."

"Wouldn't Diallo know as well since he helped you?" Catra asked, leaning in closer to a shelf and trying not to get distracted at something sparkling up at her.

"He only knows this equipment was never sent to the emperor's storage facilities," Taline said. "He doesn't know where I sent them to, and he doesn't know this place exists. To him, they just disappeared into thin air after I got done going through them. Probably thinks I destroyed them just so the emperor couldn't have them."

"Entrapta would love all this stuff," Catra said, studying at each piece of tech individually as she went. "Now I understand why you insisted on having your office here in the embassy instead of up in the executive level. And here I thought it was just because you found everyone up there to be too snobbish." Catra wrinkled her nose and Taline chuckled.

"I do think they're snobbish too though," she said with a smile. "My office right outside here used to just be extra storage space. It wasn't until after Etheria, when I was assigned here permanently, that I turned it into my lobby and office."

“The emperor thought it’d be a kind of cruel, practical joke to assign you to your sister’s old station, didn’t he?” Catra asked, frowning as the reasoning came together in her head. “He might not know about all this equipment, but he would be one of the few people to know of the station’s history.”

“Yes, I guess he thought, if he couldn’t get me executed or expelled, the next best thing would be to chain me here and force me to relive her memory every day without ever being able to say a word of it to anyone else.” Taline gave a rueful laugh. “The joke’s on him though. Didn’t need his help to do that to myself almost every day on my own.”

“What do you mean?”

Catra gave her a questioning look, and Taline beckoned for her to follow. They threaded through the shelves until they opened up into a small, open, central area. An intricate rune twice as large across as a person was burned into the floor.

“Recognize this?” Taline asked, pointing to it.

“A mark rune?” Catra traced over the incalculable number of flourishes and diacritics inside the circle with her eyes. She had no ability to cast magic herself, but Glimmer had practiced these enough she knew what one generally looked like. It was just that this one looked so dense…

“You got it. It’s more complicated than most others, though, because it accounts for a vastly increased range of efficacy.”

“How far can you go and still teleport back here from?”

“Anywhere in the galaxy.”

Catra nearly choked. “A-anywhere in the…?” She took another look at it. The outright majesty of its design suddenly hit her after understanding exactly what it was capable of.

“It took me six months of work to put this together, burning it into the floor on my hands and knees with fire and lightning spells. Anywhere I go in the galaxy—whether to the core worlds in the Heartlands or to the very far reaches of the outer arms—if I concentrate, I can feel this mark and pull myself back here to this very spot.”

“Why in Mara’s name would you need something like this here?”

Taline smirked at her. That was Glimmer language. “Because I was convinced that a ghost would turn up here one day,” she said. “And I didn’t want to miss it when it happened.”

Catra turned and looked at her. Taline’s expression shifted. Was that anger in her eyes as she stared at the markings in the floor? No, there was regret and guilt mixed in there as well.

“You thought a ghost would show up here? I don’t understand what that means.”

Taline sighed and walked over to a nearby storage cabinet. “I get my own set of nightmares too, you know. They didn’t start during the war. Only after.” She pressed her hand against a scanner on the locker, and the door popped open.

“Do they spike around a particular time, too?” Catra asked. She was curious about the contents of those nightmares but knew better than to ask. “Glimmer and I have different ones, but they spike around the same time. Now.”

Taline nodded. “Mine come every year around the anniversary of Evie’s death.” she pulled the door open wider to reveal stacks of shoe-box sized containers filling the inside of the locker. “I always get a second spike shortly after Diallo’s visits too, but I haven’t had the heart to tell him. We spent so much time together after she died, I think my brain just associated him with her.”

“That seems like a difficult way to keep a friendship,” Catra said, watching as Taline pulled a number of boxes out and set them on the floor, only to dive back in and reach further to the back for

whatever was crammed back there. “I don’t know if I’d be able to accept visits from someone if they triggered night terrors and a week of sleep deprivation.”

“It’s not really his fault,” Taline said, leaning forward to grab something at the very back. “It’s actually much more manageable now that he’s a System Governor. He used to work on this station as a staffer in the executive levels above, and would always make it a point to come see me every time I visited. It was part of the reason I got him the Governor job in the first place, aside from him being a truly competent pick for it.”

“With him off station, you didn’t have to see him every time you came,” Catra said. “Smart.”

“Doubly smart now after I got assigned here,” Taline said, pulling a large box twice the size of the others out of the back of the locker. “I might have gone crazy if I didn’t push him to take the job, and then have had to see him every day.”

“I don’t understand what that has to do with ghosts and this rune though,” Catra said, eyeing the box. “What’s in there?”

Taline opened it. Inside, was a mask—the same mask Catra had seen time and time again, on dramatizations, media, busts, paintings. In fact, she had just seen that same mask rendered on the statue in the embassy lobby on her way there.

“Is that…that can’t be Corynth’s actual mask, can it?”

Taline nodded. “Our team found two things when we touched down onto Archanas after the final battle. Corynth and his Daiamid had delivered Evelyn’s payload to the Beast and sealed it away. Among the ruins and calcified Beast remains on the surface were her body and this.” She hefted the box.

“What happened to the bodies of the other Shapers?” Catra asked, marveling at the mask.

"Well, we counted over two hundred scorch marks roughly in the shape of humanoid bodies," she said. "All the Shapers wore masks like these. Why Evelyn's body and Corynth's mask were the only things left in-tact, no one knows. And for years—*years* after that day, I obsessed over finding him. I thought him still alive. I saw not just my sister in my nightmares, but Corynth as well. Any whiff of something out of the ordinary coming through on interstellar channels and I'd already convinced myself it was him."

Catra saw the madness she had been cured of a scant three years ago reflected briefly in Taline's eyes as she spoke. She had nearly destroyed a planet trying to grab at Adora, after all. Taline's words to her back on Etheria echoed in her head.

*It's okay if it takes you a long time to focus on something in your life other than her. But at some point, you have to move forward. If you don't, you'll end up like me.*

"Maybe it was someone breaking in where they shouldn't have been only to escape without a trace," Taline said in the present, jolting Catra out of the memory. "Maybe it was an encrypted message sent between the stars that couldn't be decoded. Whatever it was, if it was a mystery people found difficult to solve, I immediately left to investigate. I thought I'd wander into a room one day and see him just standing there, waiting for me."

Diallo had mentioned her habit of once dropping everything and leaving in a starship to pursue leads. "You never found anything, did you?" Catra asked.

"Never once," Taline said, shaking her head. "This rune is here because I always thought, if I didn't find him first, then he'd eventually make his way here. The only other person who'd even know of this lab's existence would be him, so if the alarm ever tripped, I would know the lab had been breached and who had breached it. I put this here so, if that were to ever happen, wherever I was in the galaxy and whatever I was doing, I could come back here and face him."

“What would you have done if you ever found him?” Catra had a feeling she already knew the answer.

“I’d kill him.” Taline said it with the same gravity as someone talking about what they ate for lunch that day. “He’s the one who dragged my sister into the war. He decided to prey on someone fresh off their vocational education. Someone wide-eyed and naïve, working their first real job, in a black-site military research center of all places because they truly thought they’d be able to change the world.”

Taline’s posture turned wistful, and Catra was certain she wouldn’t have heard the next words out of her mouth if she didn’t have the hearing she did. “He preyed on us both.”

“They saved everyone, Taline,” Catra said, swallowing down hard the feeling she was staring at a mirror image of herself from years ago, pining after Adora. “You admitted it yourself…none of us would be here if it wasn’t for what they did.”

“Yeah.” Taline grimaced and spoke in a low voice, all trace of wistfulness gone. “They did. But that doesn’t change the fact he took my sister from me when he could have picked anyone else. I don’t care if he’s a war hero, her blood is on his hands just as it is mine. If I had seen him again, I would have killed him myself. I’m almost upset the enemy got to him before I did.”

“I thought the effects of being touched by the Beast were random?” Catra said. She didn’t want to stoke the fires of Taline’s passions any harder, but this was a rare conversation for them. She felt close to Taline in the moment. She wanted more. “Back on Etheria, when you first told me she could see through time….it sounded like that just happened to be the side effect she experienced when she came into contact with the thing. Are you saying that’s actually something Corynth used her for specifically? Planned for?”

“I can’t say for certain,” Taline said. “I can’t prove it. But it’s the only thing that makes sense. Evelyn didn’t have powers to begin

with, remember? She couldn't draw a rune to save her life let alone make it work. But Corynth? I fought that man when he first revealed himself. The things he was capable of doing…how the words he spoke could worm their way into a person and change them forever…I had never experienced or seen anything like it before in my life. It makes more sense to me that her future vision was a product of his manipulation than something natural or random."

Catra frowned and considered that. All this magic stuff flew way over her head, and even though she got the gist of what Taline was saying, she also got the distinct feeling Taline wasn't being one hundred percent honest with her.

"Glimmer has mentioned in passing you've taken an interest," Taline said. "Do you linger on the statues too? Wonder what's behind the mask? Stare at the eyes and wish they weren't just stone sometimes?"

Catra's first instinct was to deny, but then she caught sight of the way Taline looked at her and knew she could see right through her. She was paralyzed, unable to do anything except swallow and nod and then hang onto every ticking second afterward, waiting to hear what Taline would say next.

"If a statue of him holds that much sway," Taline said, each of her syllables spooling out almost like a confession of guilt, "then imagine what seeing him face to face, looking him in the eyes might have been like."

Catra caught it then, in that same laser-focused look Taline kept leveled at her: she wasn't just seeing right through her, but telling her more, almost like she hoped Catra could understand what she was trying to convey just like she could glimpse the emperor's memories when he went digging around in hers. It was all just out of reach for her—she couldn't read it. Catra and Glimmer knew how to communicate with looks, hold whole conversations almost. But her and Taline?

Catra hadn’t visited enough for that.

“That was the old me,” Taline said with a sigh, sounding exhausted, jolting Catra out of yet another trance. She set the mask aside on a nearby table, rather than putting it with the rest of the boxes on the floor near the locker. “The more crazy witch hunts I went on, the less confident I was that he was actually still alive. I think I was just giving myself something to do other than face my guilt over letting Evelyn be manipulated like that—giving myself any excuse to not grieve.

“The nightmares have stopped affecting me as much. The paranoia, intrusive thoughts, all of it I’ve learned to move forward with. Evie and the Daiamid…they let themselves be collectively consumed by the Beast. They stalled it long enough for the Barrier to activate and trap it in the next dimension. No one could have survived that much infection, it’s just not possible. After I was assigned to this station, I made the conscious decision to go on no more wild goose chases. No more scanning broadcasts, no more combing through hours of news reels. I refused to go looking for things that didn’t exist.”

Catra looked at the mask still in the box on the desk and traced its outline with her eyes. She glanced down at the rune at her feet. Then she looked around at all the equipment in the room, all the shelves stacked with tech behind them.

“Glimmer doesn’t know any of this, does she?” Catra asked. “You said I was the only person aside from you who knows of this place now. Why tell me all of this?”

“I offered to take you with me off Etheria because I saw something in you, Catra. Not just because you reminded me in part of someone I had lost. I can repeat that to you over and over again until I’m blue in the face, but if you don’t believe me by now, then it doesn’t matter how else I put it or how often I say it.” Taline turned back to the open locker and pulled another box out from a lower shelf. “The fact you went to so much trouble trying

to become a Sentinel, and the fact you did it for the reasons you did, tells me that this is the right thing to do."

Taline opened the box and revealed a crystal and a vial inside. The crystal glowed a faint red against the cushion, while a fine sparkly powder filled the inside of the vial up to its cork stopper.

"Recognize this?" Taline asked, placing the box next to the mask and holding the crystal up between them.

Catra shook her head.

"This is an apeiron," Taline said. "It's an incredibly rare and expensive crystal, made almost entirely of ignominite. It's similar to the runestones on your home world, except on a smaller scale and with a few more varied uses. It can hold a physical fragment of the Beast, if you want. That's what all the research stations switched too as soon as Evie discovered the mineral—it's what cut fatalities down to almost nothing. Or, in this case, it can be used to store information and memories. You've already been exposed to one in the past."

"That crystal you destroyed on the emperor's citadel," Catra said. "That was an apeiron too?"

Taline nodded. "I gathered as much of what was left of it and put it in that vial. That one held a strong imprint of the Beast, since it was Evie's last memories alive before she was consumed. This one holds my memories, instead." She turned the crystal in front of both of them and Catra watched the light reflect off its facets. "Every painful memory of us fighting, every thought I've ever had or emotion I've ever felt grieving her loss, it's all recorded in this."

Catra's mouth went dry hearing that. If the first apeiron she had been exposed to had subjected her to life-altering nightmares, she wondered what damage this one was capable of.

"I'd come every month after the war for years to sit with this," Taline said. "And after being assigned as Consul on this station, I've come every day for the past three years. I've spent hours

upon hours meditating on those thoughts, both to pay penance and to honor Evie's memory. There are no pictures of her, no mention of her in any texts or recorded histories. No one speaks her name…all that remains of her now are the memories and emotions and thoughts of an older sister who didn't deserve her, distilled and recorded in this." Taline extended the crystal to Catra. "And now I think it's time that I let her go. I want you to have it."

Catra's eyes threatened to bug out of her head and she took a step backward in shock.

"I can't…Taline, no," she said, looking anywhere but at the crystal. "I can't take that. I just…I can't." Her thoughts and emotions spiraled. She didn't know whether she felt flattered or overwhelmed or sad for Taline or confused. It was likely a combination of all of the above, although that realization did nothing to help calm her in the moment.

"She's not truly gone, Catra. Not yet at least. As long as I'm alive, there will be at least one person who remembers her. Me wanting to give this to you is more than just a symbolic gesture."

"What do you mean?" Catra still didn't trust herself to look directly at the thing.

"I've spent so much time with it and imbued it with such strong memories over so many long years that it's intrinsically tied to me. It's like a portable mark-rune. Just like the rune on the floor, I can feel the presence of this crystal should I concentrate on it. And were it to break, I'd be able to lock onto its position in an instant, and pull myself through time and space to appear right next to it in a moment's notice. If you are to become my Sentinel, I want you to have this. Not just because I want to give you my sister's legacy, but because I want to know at all times that I can come to your aid should you ever need it."

Catra blinked and let Taline's words sink into her. Slowly she turned to look up at her.

“I don’t understand,” she said. “The Enclave rejected me from the program. I’m not going to be a Sentinel.”

Taline smirked and shook her head, amused. “Catra, there is no program.”

“What?” Now she was well and truly lost. “What do you mean there’s no program? What did I apply for?”

“You applied to be a Sentinel, but they didn’t reject you because you were unfit for some type of academy or training program or boot camp or anything of the sort. In fact, according to their assessments, you did remarkably. Your combat skills are sharp, your reflexes are sharp, your service record is stellar except for the fact you are habitually late to everything. You were a stellar candidate.”

“Why then? Why did they turn me away, and what exactly did I get turned away from?”

“You were rejected because you had no one to officially take you on.”

Catra furrowed her brow. “I still don’t understand.”

“Applications used to be commonplace back in the ancient days of the Enclave,” Taline said. “That’s why everyone had such a strange reaction to seeing one again. No one had actually applied in centuries. Modern Sentinels share a much more personal connection to their Battlemages than in the past—all of them are handpicked not just for their combat skills and experience, but because of the bond they have with the one they agree to watch over.”

“I was turned down because no one wanted me?”

Taline made a face. “You somehow always turn things into that. The answer is yes and no. People were interested, but there’s decorum to these things. I not only trained Glimmer, one of the most promising rookies in the Enclave to come around in

generations, but did you forget that I sponsored you into the Empire as well? People were interested, Catra, but no one would reach over me and take you on. Even when I told them I had no intention of signing you, many feared straining their relationship with me and decided to hold off."

Catra felt both relieved and saddened by those words. Relieved that people wanted her, but sad that Taline had explicitly said she didn't. "Why wouldn't you sign me when you saw my name come up?" Again, she felt small and hated herself for it, hated feeling things she had no right to. Taline had already done so much.

"Why would I have any reason to believe that's what you'd want from me?" Taline said, sounding irritated for once. "You rejected any promotion or pay raise or commendation if my endorsement came alongside it. I'd get excuse after excuse any time I'd send you an invitation to lunch or coffee if Glimmer wasn't to be there too. This is the first time in three years you've come to me on your own volition, and a very large part of me believes that's only because Glimmer strong armed you into doing even that."

Catra winced and shrank further into herself with every word Taline spoke. It's not that she said it in a way that guilted her. In fact, she seemed intent on presenting everything as neutrally as possible, even if she did sound a little annoyed. But Catra well and truly felt guilty now that she saw first-hand how her treatment had made Taline feel.

"You asked Glimmer to look into this for you," Taline said, "but explicitly asked her not to say anything at all to me, since you would have found out how archaic a practice your application was had you asked. What am I supposed to think after all that? I considered signing you for all of three seconds before I decided that was a terrible idea." She sighed and deflated. "If my help is really that abhorrent to you then…well, it is what it is, I guess. But I don't understand why you'd turn right around and get upset after I finally get the hint."

Never in a million years had Catra thought she'd ever make another person feel unwanted, the same way Shadow Weaver had made her feel. Yet here she was. She took a step forward and shook her head vigorously, wringing her hands raw with remorse.

"That's not it at all," she said. "I just…I wanted to get in and surprise you, like I said. I wanted to be able to say 'look at what I can accomplish' and then planned to ask if I could serve as your Sentinel after the Enclave qualified me." She hung her head and spoke in a small, embarrassed voice. "I'm an idiot. I didn't know it was the other way around. I'm sorry."

Taline didn't say anything for a long moment and Catra looked back up at her, half afraid of what she'd see. She saw her standing there, face tense in thought and mired in confusion. Another beat passed, and all the tension evaporated from her face, replaced with unabashed relief and mirth. Her shoulders shook with quiet laughter.

"Well, that's a relief," she said. "I was half afraid you'd actually grown to hate me."

Again, Catra shook her head. She'd have spoken, too, but the sting of fresh tears threatened to fall from her eyes, and she didn't want to risk crying again.

"You aren't an idiot either," Taline said. "I understand why believing I only thought of you as a substitute for Evie made things hard. But we've cleared that up now, and can move past it. I will gladly accept you as my Sentinel, if that is what you still want."

Catra couldn't nod her head fast enough. She was going to pull a muscle with all the shaking and nodding she was doing. "Yes. Yes, I want that. Is it really that simple?"

"Sure," Taline said with a smile. "Battlemages are entitled to handpick their Sentinels. There is one condition, however."

"Anything. Whatever it is, I'll do it."

“You have to promise to kill me should I ever become corrupted by the Beast.”

Catra faltered. The conversation had taken a decidedly dark turn she was wholly unprepared for.

“You know what happens to someone the Beast touches right?” Taline asked, after seeing the shocked look on Catra’s face. “I’m not just talking about the dying part.”

Catra swallowed and nodded. “Glimmer might have mentioned something, but she didn’t go into too much detail. Said it gave her the creeps. It’s not the same for you as it is for regular people, right?”

Taline nodded. “The Beast makes thralls of people it consumes. It doesn’t matter if you are a soldier or a politician, royalty or a beggar on the streets. If it grabs hold of you, it consumes you. It takes your mind and adds it to its growing, collective intelligence, then uses your husk of a body as a thrall. That’s part of the reason why the emperor didn’t commit any of his clones on the battlefield until he was forced to. He was afraid if the Beast took one of them, then it would spread through his interconnected mental web and get to him.

“But if someone like Glimmer or I were to fall victim to the Beast? We still don’t understand why, but when the creature comes across someone with magical talent, it doesn’t subsume their consciousness into itself. Instead, it imbues a perfect copy of itself into that magic wielder much like a cell undergoing mitosis. It turns that mage into an Abomination—an entirely new, separate infectious center point with its own destructive intelligence.”

“Are…are only mages converted to Abominations? Is that how that works?”

“Almost all,” Taline said. “There were a few recorded cases of Abominations stemming from people without the talent, but it’s almost always a mage.”

“That’s how it was able to spread so quickly, isn’t it?” Catra asked, several more pieces of information she had picked up over the years clicking into place. “That’s why you’re technically not allowed to be deployed to the front lines, aside from the emperor explicitly forbidding it as punishment. You have no more Sentinels to watch over you.”

Taline nodded again. “That’s exactly it. Sentinels aren’t just there to watch over their Battlemages. With the advent of the Beast war, they evolved the additional responsibility of looking out for the wellbeing of the planets and systems their Battlemages were deployed to. An Abomination suddenly appearing on the field of battle, to this day, is the difference between a strike force being able to fend off a Beast attack to save a city at heavy cost, and having to abandon the entire planet and bombard it to hell from orbit.”

“Holy shit,” Catra said. Her fingers shook from the mental imagery of hundreds of ships nuking the surface of a planet with orbital cannons from space.

“That’s part of the reason why the number of new Sentinels has decreased so rapidly since the first war. It was one thing to serve with honor alongside someone you considered a friend. It’s something else entirely to kill that friend should they be corrupted. Most refuse to do so, which is why a lot of the responsibilities an Enclave Sentinel used to possess have gradually shifted to Imperial Vanguard soldiers assigned to Battlemages out in the field.”

Catra knit her brow, deep in thought over the implications of what becoming a Sentinel truly meant. It was wildly different from the image she had in her head going while drafting her application, but did that mean she no longer wanted it?

“Like I said before,” Taline said. “Nothing would make me happier than to take you on if that is what you want. But I don’t want to sugarcoat anything for you either—if I am ever corrupted, for the

sake of everyone else around, you must kill me. Are you prepared to do something like that?”

Catra studied her shaking fingers and ran through her thought process one last time before she made up her mind. She squeezed her fingers into a fist to stop them from shaking, looked up and at Taline in the eyes, and nodded. “Yes. I’m prepared, if it ever comes to that.”

Taline smiled wider than Catra had seen ever before, and once again held out the crystal to her. “Then take this and let’s not speak of these depressing things again.”

Catra reached out, took the crystal from her, and stared at it in her hand. After burning an image of it into her brain trying to immortalize the moment forever in her memories, she put it in her pants pocket and patted it. “I’ll find a cord or something so I can wear it.”

“Just as long as you have it on you always,” Taline said. “There’s one last thing I want to give you.”

Catra thought she’d just about explode from all the emotions she’d already churned through. What else could there be?

Taline turned to a large box looming next to the storage locker. Catra thought it looked like a massive black refrigerator, except the number of cords and tubes connected to the back of it told her it likely wasn’t that. Taline keyed in a quick code on a number pad attached to it before scanning her palm again. A small drawer slid out, revealing a vaguely handgun-shaped object inside. She gripped its handle and pulled it out. It came free with a hiss, like it had been hooked up to pressurized air, and Catra recognized it as an injection gun.

“Hold out your arm, palm up please,” Taline said.

Catra held out her right arm, then quickly pulled it back and held out her left instead. She still had Entrapta’s PDA attached to the right like always.

Just the fact she did as Taline asked without hesitating spoke volumes. What would have caused her anxiety to spike not even three years ago, she didn't think twice about now. In fact, she remembered a great deal of panic the first time Taline had injected her with something. How far she had come.

"This was a big project Evie worked on before her death," Taline said, pressing the device to Catra's exposed skin and pulling the trigger. Catra felt a pinch and took a sharp breath at the sensation.

"The emperor explicitly wanted it and was so mad when Diallo and I told him we couldn't find it. It's missing a lot of its functionality. I'm not sure if it was corrupted somehow or if she just never finished, but it's incredibly useful despite me not being able to get any information about her out of it."

"What is it?" Catra asked, rubbing her arm when Taline pulled the injector away and stowed it.

"I won't ruin the surprise," she said, shutting the drawer and turning to head out of the lab with Catra not far behind. "It will take a few days to calibrate to you, but you will know when it's ready to go. I think you'll like it."

They exited, and Taline shut the door behind them. Catra felt buoyant, like she was floating above the clouds in pure bliss. So much had happened, she wasn't sure how she'd process it all. But one thing she was certain of was that she was happy.

"Here," Taline said, tossing something to her as Catra turned. She caught it mid-air and opened her palm to look: it was the storage drive Diallo had left on her desk. "Take that to our System Governor friend, will you please?"

"You don't want to destroy it yourself?" Catra asked, turning the device around in her palm.

"Nope." Taline pressed a button on the underside of her desk and the lock on her door disengaged. Catra hadn't realized she had

locked it in the first place. “Let him figure out what he wants to do with it. Like I said, I’m done chasing ghosts and going on wild goose chases. I have the station and its people I have to look out for. And now, I have you to officially mentor too.”

“This is really happening, isn’t it?” Catra asked. “I really get to have this?” She wasn’t talking about the drive.

“Of course you do,” Taline said. “The paperwork will take time. Lyra is already swamped as it is so I might do it myself, but Moriarty has a campaign speech I’m expected to be in attendance for in a few days. As soon as that’s done, I’ll come get you and we can hash out a concrete training plan. Once we get your skills honed a bit more, I should be allowed to at least leave the station on a few diplomatic missions. It will be a good chance for you to get out and see more of the galaxy too, instead of just this station.”

Catra nodded and bid her an excited farewell. She was all smiles as she waved goodbye to a bewildered Lyra, still trapped behind a prison of stacked paperwork on her desk, and she walked with a bounce in her step all the way back toward the embassy lobby. Diallo wouldn’t be too thrilled at having his drive returned to him uninvestigated, but Catra couldn’t find it in her to worry about that in the slightest.

She couldn’t remember the last time she felt so happy, either.

Chapter End Notes

Catra can have nice things! Sometimes! :D

We catch up with Adora next chapter. Thank you as always for reading!

# A Thief in the Night

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora crept along the main hallway high up inside the Crystal Castle and tried to make as little noise as possible.

She had already climbed dozens of stories' worth of stairs, bypassing practically every room in the castle in lieu of the one place she knew to look first. If an intruder looking for First One's tech were to infiltrate her stronghold, the first place they'd be most likely to look was Light Hope's central command room near the top.

She rounded a corner and heard a voice echo down the hallway. Heart hammering in her chest, she dashed behind a pillar and pressed her back against it.

"—done getting through the firewall," said a female voice. "The security around the safe should be straightforward enough to expose it, but I'll need to get the castle's avatar booted up again if we're to open it."

"How close did Salas and the rest of them get to bringing it back online?" a second, male voice asked.

"Ehhh, it's debatable. That girl with the purple hair appendages had a pretty good whack at it. I don't think they'd have made the progress they already have without her, but it's still a way's off."

"Good thing I have you then."

Adora came out from behind the pillar and followed the voices to Light Hope's main sanctum, gripping her combat staff tight in one hand. Gear from the Enclave's work and Entrapta's experiments littered the area. A man, dressed in the robes and armor of the Bright Moon castle guard, stood with his back toward her and

tapped away at Light Hope's command terminal in the center of the room. His helmet lay upright on a section of the curved console desk to his right, next to a bulky containment box and several more pieces of Enclave tech. A translucent hologram of a young woman with a pixie cut floated to his left like a specter.

"Funny seeing you in a Bright Moon guard uniform," Adora said, circling behind them. "It's Kalanthe, isn't it? I thought you were supposed to be part of the Enclave's security detail. Or was it supposed to be the science staff? That was you unloading Entrapta's deliveries in the Scorpion Kingdom, wasn't it?"

"Adora," Kalanthe said, continuing to work at the console without turning around. "I'm surprised to see you here. Thought you'd be off obsessively training, if not asleep, right now." He reached over to the containment box to his right, undid the clasps, and opened the lid.

"I got two weeks off," she said, keeping up the banter for as long as possible to gauge her plan of attack. "Thought I'd take a walk and clear my head." She hefted the staff in her arms, testing its weight and balance. "Who's your little floaty friend over there?"

The translucent girl with the pixie cut turned to her. Her face lit up and she pointed to herself as if to ask 'are you talking to me?' Then she blinked out of existence and appeared again the next instant, floating right in front of Adora.

"Hi! My name's Pip." She grinned wide and Adora stumbled back, gripping her staff with both hands. "I'd shake your hand but I can't actually physically do that. You understand, right?"

Adora looked her up and down. She could see clear through her, and saw Kalanthe pull a pair of glowing crystals out of the storage box and put them into a circular device up on the console dash. Adora glanced to the side and saw how this 'Pip' made herself corporeal: through the half a dozen holographic projectors littering the room, the ones Entrapta and the Enclave frequently used for various three-dimensional displays.

“I’m so glad those are there,” Pip said, following Adora’s trail of sight and positively beaming. She flew around the room, twirling and making loops, different projectors activating depending on where in the room she flew next. “Normally I’m not able to manifest like this, but with these projectors here I can go practically anywhere!”

“Can you focus please?” Kalanthe said, slotting a sixth crystal into the machine. He pressed a button and the cylinder holding the crystals rotated up and started to spin. Pip shot Adora an apologetic look before disappearing and reappearing right next to him.

“I can multitask you know,” she said to him, pouting. “That’s what I was designed to do, remember? The system has recognized the crystals, but I’m still working on getting everything else up and running. You’ll know when everything is ready.”

“Those guards you left outside behind that tree…” Adora said, inching toward them. “Did you kill them?”

“They aren’t dead, they’ll be fine,” Kalanthe said, returning to the console. He still hadn’t turned around. “I suggest you leave. What I’m doing here doesn’t concern you. It’d be better for you if you didn’t get involved.”

Adora laughed and got closer. “You’ve been sneaking around Etheria for three years. I see you in Entrapta’s lab, I see you at the Induction Ceremony, and now I see you in my own sanctuary castle? I have no idea what you’re doing, but I think it concerns me very much. Turn around.”

“Walk away, Adora,” Kalanthe said. He still hadn’t turned, but he stood eerily still, not touching the electronics or the computer, as if he were tensing for a fight. “We wouldn’t want them finding you in the morning next to the guards outside.”

“Out of the two of us, it’s going to be you they find out there,” Adora said. Then she paused, since that really didn’t make any

sense. Why would she leave him outside unconscious for hours until morning? "Or…or dragged! Out of the two of us, it's going to be you that's going to get dragged, by me, to the Enclave. To answer for...sneaking about and…"

She trailed off and groaned, shaking her head. Moment ruined.

Hoping to at least catch him off guard, she snapped forward with the staff, thrusting one end up toward the back of his head. Kalanthe leaned to the side, letting the staff zoom past his ear. He spun low and aimed an open palm at her solar plexus.

Adora turned her body to the side and caught him between her abdomen and upper arm. He followed through, stepping into her space to deliver another blow. She met him halfway and rammed her skull into his head before he could strike first.

Stars danced in her vision, but pushing aggressively had taken the initiative away from him. She had the upper hand. Kalanthe stumbled backward, dazed, and Adora pressed the advantage. She stabbed left, then right with the staff, first high at the shoulder before angling it down for a strike at the legs, her hair whipping about with her movements, reminding her she had forgotten to tie it up since leaving Bright Moon.

She let the staff do most of the work, putting the forward momentum from another thrust into a lateral swipe aimed for his chest. She did everything she could to keep the attacks coming as quickly and aggressively as she could. Salas said he was dangerous. She had to keep him off balance.

He surprised her, taking a blow to the side against the plate armor there. Adora thought she had gotten him for a moment, until she realized it was a calculated move on his part.

Kalanthe stepped forward the moment his armor stopped the staff, grabbed it in one hand, and tried to pull it out of her grasp.

Adora let herself be yanked forward, faking being thrown off-balance only to put her forward momentum into a punch she

aimed squarely for his head. Her fist collided with his face. She both felt and heard his nose snap under the blow.

Kalanthe cried out, letting go of Adora's staff and stumbling backward holding his face.

"Ready to give up?" Adora said with a smirk, Adrenaline coursed through her. This felt *good*. She might not be able to draw upon She Ra still, but that didn't mean she couldn't fight. In fact, with the obsessive training she put herself through trying to get in touch with her powers again through sheer peak conditioning alone, she was an even better fighter as Adora than she'd ever been.

Kalanthe glared at her over the top of his hand which he held to his face. He pinched the bridge of his nose and set it. The sound of bone and cartilage sliding across each other sent a wet sound echoing around the room. Adora cringed, but Kalanthe didn't take his eyes off her. He didn't even flinch.

"I have to say," Pip said, floating in a relaxed posture nearby on her back. "I'm somewhat disappointed. Have you gotten slower?"

Kalanthe gave her a look but didn't respond. Turning his attention back to Adora, he pulled a set of pins under the shoulder plates of the palace guard armor and the robes fell to the floor. Then he undid the clasp at the neck and the rest of the ensemble went tumbling to the ground in a clatter. He stood there in nothing but a lightweight shirt and pants, and the pair of muddy boots he had on from the start.

He dashed forward, and the speed with which he did so was such a shock, Adora almost didn't get out of the way in time to avoid his next strike.

*So fast*, she thought, barely able to keep up with the flurry of blows. *Way too fast*.

Adora parried a blow and set her feet. Kalanthe had dashed in a small arc in front of her, probably gearing up for a kick, so she

aimed a thrust with her staff where she expected him to be. Except he wasn't there, and her staff swished through the air to strike nothing. It shouldn't have been possible. Not even Catra was able to cancel out her inertia like that.

Her leg gave out from behind and her knee slammed to the ground. Kalanthe had struck her there and forced her to kneel, only to reappear once again before her, poised for another strike. Panicking, Adora swung at him with a fist.

Kalanthe plucked her hand out of the air like he caught a ball someone had thrown him and clapped something onto her wrist. She looked up in surprise and saw a manacle attached to her. She twisted her body and moved to strike at him with the staff in her other hand, but he blocked, kneed her in the stomach, kicked the staff out of her grip when she tried to suck in a breath of air, and shackled her other wrist to the first.

Adora yelped and tried to torque out of his hold, but Kalanthe held the small strip of chain linking the manacles together with an iron grip. She couldn't break free. She tried to stand again but he circled behind her and kicked the back of her leg once again to keep her down. He then yanked her arms over back and behind her head.

Adora glared up at him, and he stared back, down the bridge of his nose with an almost imperious gaze. He had stopped attacking her, for some reason choosing to hold her there in this trapped position rather than end the fight for good. Adora decided to take the opportunity to calm down, come up with a quick plan, and capitalize on it once she had lured him into a false sense of security.

Kalanthe stepped away from her, showing that he no longer held her arms back. Surprised and thrown entirely off guard, Adora tugged again and found she still couldn't pull her arms free. She twisted, still kneeling on the ground, and saw a person-sized spider robot directly behind her, gripping the chain linking her handcuffs in its mandibles. It trilled at her and Adora screamed

and yanked away from it again with more urgency. The bot held fast, all eight red eyes swiveling to look at her as it refused to let her go. Then six more bots came out of the shadows and joined their brother, surrounding her. These were Entrapta's own security bots! Why were they going against her?

"That's more like it," Pip said, floating next to Kalanthe as he walked to the center of the room.

"Wouldn't have needed to do that if you had cracked the system faster," he said, rolling his shoulder as if it were stiff. "In fact, I wouldn't have even had to deal with her at all if you remembered to shut the door behind us in the first place."

"I'm sorry!" Pip said, throwing her hands up and sounding not sorry at all. "Old Eternian systems are so cumbersome, it just takes a while, okay? You have no idea how many threads I'm devoting to just waking up their administrator protocols right now. Forgetting to close a door here or there is a given, so cut me some slack."

"Fine, fine," he said, waving her off. He didn't even sound winded, just mildly inconvenienced, and that realization infuriated Adora to no end. "How are we coming along on that?"

"Hey!" Adora tried again to yank away from the spider with no luck. At least they weren't attacking her either. "What the hell? Let me out of here."

"You, zip it," Kalanthe said, turning and making a motion across his lips with a hand. "I told you to leave and you didn't. Now just sit there and please shut up."

Adora opened her mouth to protest and one of the spiders in front of her bayed, startling her she clicked her jaw shut instead and flinched.

"Still working on it, Boss," Pip said, when Kalanthe gave her another look. "Maybe another few minutes and I'll have it." He

sighed in response and walked back over to Adora. The spider that bayed at Adora scurried out of the way when he approached.

"Why don't you go ahead and reach for She Ra?" he asked, kneeling in front of her so they were eye level with each other. "Should have no problem busting out of those cuffs and trashing these security bots if you can."

Adora scowled at him through the threads of her hair hanging in front of her face. She found it odd that her enemy was not only suggesting ways she could beat him, but also giving her time to actually try it. Part of her wanted to refuse and bust out on her own without She Ra's help purely out of spite, but she tried yanking the chains a third time and decided against it when they still didn't give. It was like she was tied to a concrete post. So, she reached for the power, not expecting to be able to do much of anything with it.

The power wasn't there.

*Oh no.*

Adora reached inside again, her heart racing, and confirmed her worst fear. Before, she could at least *feel* She Ra bubbling under the surface despite not being able to do anything with her. But now? When she reached for the power now, she felt nothing. The sound of despair that escaped on its own volition from her lips might have embarrassed her had she not been so swept up in her panic.

"Nothing, huh?" Kalanthe said, shooting her a bored look. "That's a shame. Well, since you aren't getting out of there and you aren't going to call on She Ra any time soon, will you do me a huge favor and just sit here quietly for a few minutes? Thanks."

Adora gaped at him, but was too shocked to respond. Where was She Ra? Why couldn't she feel her at all now? She could sense her just minutes ago while she was wandering through the woods. What happened?

“I’m in,” Pip said.

Kalanthe stood and Light Hope materialized next to him.

“Administrator detected,” she said. “Hello, Kalanthe.”

“Are you kidding me right now?” Adora pulled so hard on the manacles that the spiders yanked her back fully onto her ass, all of them trilling a warning in unison this time.

“What did I just say about sitting quietly?” Kalanthe said.

How did he get Light Hope to work? Entrapta had worked so hard to make any sort of progress with this—it had taken months just to connect her bots to the system to act as security! And he just came along and reactivated her in the amount of time it took for them to fight? Not only that, why did Light Hope recognize him as an Administrator?

“Light Hope!” Adora said, yanking on the chain again. “It’s me, Adora. You remember me, right? She Ra?”

Light Hope looked at her then turned a shade of red. “Intruder detected. Beginning emergency interception protocol.”

The bugs trilled a third time, and it sounded even more menacing.

“It’s okay, Hope,” Kalanthe said, placing a hand on Adora’s shoulder as he spoke. It took everything in her to not jerk away from him. “Adora is a guest. Please don’t harm her.” He turned and spoke to her. “I won’t ask for your cooperation again. Say something else and I’ll have the bots gag you.” Two more spiders scurried about in front of her and rattled their abdomens at her as if to accentuate his point.

“I maaaaay have accidentally reset her memory banks when I turned her on,” Pip said with a sheepish look.

“Your companion informs me that you wish to access the vault,” Light Hope said, speaking once again to Kalanthe after returning

to her usual shade of blue. Pip gave a thumbs up, floating off to the side.

"Yes please," Kalanthe said. "I know we just met and it's rude to talk business so suddenly, but this is urgent. You'll see I've already provided the keys you need."

"Yes. Six keys from six kingdoms," Light Hope said, nodding. "All is as it should be, although I imagine it was difficult to convince the rulers of those kingdoms to part with their keys. I do not see them here with you."

"No, it wasn't easy," he said, shooting a glare at Adora when she scoffed. "Three years and a lot of effort went into getting them for you. Some of those dig sites were challenging."

Light Hope nodded. "I can only imagine. I will open the vault for you."

Adora squirmed. "Don't! Light Hope, I don't know who this person is or what he's trying to do, but he's not an Administrator. He's trying—"

One of the spider bots turned around and shot webbing at her mouth. It hardened instantly, preventing Adora from speaking.

"I told you what would happen," Kalanthe said, looking down at her with tired eyes. "Why does no one ever listen?"

A portion of the flooring nearby opened up a pedestal emerged up out of it, turning like a screw as it rose. A large, partially cut amethyst the size of a person's fist lay atop the pedestal, magnificent veins of red and black twisting and curling through the purple. Kalanthe approached it, and the pedestal stopped rising when it reached roughly chest-height.

"The Eye of Shukra is the shining masterpiece of Eternian crystal-work," Light Hope said. "It contains the foundations of our mathematics and new theories of physics that have underpinned our efforts to shape Etheria into what it is today. The work of

entire generations of scholars and engineers over millennia is now in the palm of your hand."

Adora tried to yell, but her words only came out as muffled cries. Kalanthe ignored her.

"Can you access this as is or do you need me to hook more tech up for you?" he asked Pip, shooting her a quick look before stooping down and inspecting the crystal from the side. Pip hovered next to him, staring wide-eyed at it.

"Should be fine as is," she said. "It's really pretty."

"It's likely the most advanced of its kind we've ever come across," he said, straightening, "so it will probably feel just as interesting as it looks when you go poking around in there. Have at it."

"Yesser, Boss sir," Pip said, slapping her hand to her head in a cartoonish salute and giggling. She floated closer and plunged both hands into the crystal. Her eyes glossed over, turning an opaque white. Several moments passed, before: "Oh wow. Kal, if only you could see what I see as I go through this thing….it's amazing."

"Don't get distracted," Kalanthe said. "You can tell me all about it later, but the sooner we finish this the better, for everyone."

Pip continued to work in silence, her face taking on all manner of expression—from surprise, to excitement, to wonder as her hands danced around the crystal. Suddenly, her brows knit together and she grunted.

"Uh, Kal?"

"What is it? Did you find it?"

"No I think…there's something." Pip's avatar flickered and stuttered.

"Are you okay?" Kal asked. "What's going on?"

“There’s something he—..there’s…ca—t…se—se—see—"

Pip disappeared and the lights in the control room shut off with a clang. Light Hope and the eyes of the bug robots continued to glow, the only source of illumination in the room.

“What the hell is going on?” Kalanthe said, his eyes casting about. “Pip? Where’d you go? I swear if this is another one of your practical jokes, I’m going to delete you. I’m serious, I don’t care how big you make your eyes this time when you apologize.”

Emergency lights came on, bathing them in a sea of red hues. Light Hope turned a matching shade of crimson.

“Intruder alert!” she said.

“Hope, it’s me, Administrator Kalanthe. Stand down.”

“Intruder detected! Intruder detected!” Hope blared like a siren. “Activating defensive measures.”

The spiderbot’s eyes glowed brighter and they rattled their frames hard enough Adora thought they’d break.

“Shit,” Kalanthe said. He grabbed Adora’s staff and destroyed each of them in short order before they could react. Then he ripped the sticky material from her mouth and unlocked her shackles, taking the handcuffs back and stowing them in his shirt.

Countless more red eyes lit up around them, in the shadowy crevices of the ceiling and walls and corners of the room. Light Hope continued to scream.

“Run!” Kalanthe said to her, before grabbing the crystal from the pedestal and making a break for the far exit.

The eyes in the dark multiplied, and the raucous chorus of hundreds of spider bots rattling their abdomens in warning created a thunderous white noise that filled the room, like a furious hailstorm beating down on a tin roof. All of the eyes

suddenly surged down the walls like a sea of death coming to inundate them.

Adora didn’t think twice. She jumped to her feet and ran after him.

Chapter End Notes

Finally posting a chapter with Kal and Pip feels almost cathartic--they're like the last major pieces I had yet to introduce and there they finally are :D

2 more chapters in part two and then we jump right into part 3. The new poster art is already looking pretty nice too :)

# An Awakening

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora sprinted down hallways and around hairpin turns in the Crystal Castle. The flood of spider bots chasing just behind roared like a tsunami.

*I can't believe my own castle is attacking me*, she thought. Her feet slid along the floor when she took a corner too hard and she almost slammed sideways into a wall. *Why is my own castle attacking me!?*

She saw Kalanthe ahead, her staff under his arm and the crystal he stole in the other hand as he sprinted. The speed with which he moved earlier during their fight wasn't just a figment of her imagination—he truly was fast. Despite his head start, she wasn't able to gain on him despite the years she spent on her grueling training regimen. In fact, he might have been putting even more distance between them. She'd see him disappear around one corner or fly up a flight of stairs, and when she'd round the same corner or clear the same staircase, he'd be back in her vision but even smaller and farther away.

The halls of the castle were dark, the emergency alarm lights casting everything in a low, ominous red. But despite the low visibility, Adora could readily and easily see Kalanthe against the backdrop. If she didn't know any better, she would have said he was glowing. It was subtle, but she swore she could see it, outlining him clearly against the darkness.

The hallway opened up to the outside. Dozens of carriers and dreadnoughts orbited in formation high above. Stars and the moonlight from Etheria's twelve satellites bathed Adora in a soft light when she blasted full tilt out onto the terrace near the top of the castle.

That light filtered through a pergola overhead, supported on either side by stone pillars lined up like an honor guard. It cast eerie, dancing shadows on her skin as she ran. The deluge of spider bots nipping at her heels continued, although the sound changed tone. It somehow sounded more overbearing, despite that sound no longer bouncing around the enclosed space of the hallway.

A flash of red high and to the right caught her attention and Adora looked up. There, balancing on tripod legs atop the roof of the terrace's central turret tower, stood a particularly massive sentry bot. Its middle eye glowed with energy and tracked Kalanthe from high above as he ran ahead of her.

"Hey!" Adora said, waving her arms and hoping her voice carried far enough for him to hear. "Watch out! I think that thing is going to blast you!"

Kalanthe gave no indication he heard her and Adora grit her teeth. When she looked back up, the sentry was no longer tracking him. It was aiming for her.

Her vision saturated as a tight beam of energy shot out of the sentry's eye, flashing everything red for a split second. Adora couldn't see its trajectory, but she ducked her head low out of instinct and felt it just miss the top of her head. A pillar to her left exploded from the impact and wobbled. The pergola creaked and bent, before snapping altogether. Adora zig-zagged her course forward as giant planks of splintered wood careened down and struck the stone underfoot, like hail slamming to the earth. One caught her shoulder and Adora yelped in pain.

That broken pillar turned into a domino that crashed into its neighbor just ahead of her. A crack raced from the base of that second pillar to the top. It too started to fall just as Adora zagged in its direction. A jolt of adrenaline shot through her the moment she realized why its shadow grew suddenly and alarmingly larger and darker around her.

Her feet tangled. She fell forward, sliding to a stop just under the pillar as it toppled to the floor. She watched it get closer with wide eyes, then squeezed them shut and crossed her arms in front of her face. Any second and it'd slam into her, squashing her like a bug. Killing her.

Death never came.

Adora cracked an eye open and saw the pillar hovering above her as if held by invisible hands. She blinked in awe for all of two seconds before the storm of spider bots chasing from behind surged in to overwhelm her. The pillar shot forward, scraping along the ground, breaking into separate boulders and crushing several dozen bots caught in its wake.

It wasn't enough. Dozens more of them still spilled around and over the now ruined chunks of rock and granite, gunning for her like a river. With another yelp of surprise, Adora picked herself up off the floor and started forward at another dead sprint. Her ankle didn't support her when she put weight on it. She cried out in pain and nosedived to the floor once again just as the first bot reached her.

Its icepick legs dug into her skin as it crawled onto her back. Adora screamed, although the pain she felt dig into her like a scorching needle somehow killed her ability to hear. She reached around behind her to yank it off and throw it forward. She got one, two, three limping steps before a half-dozen bots converged on her anew.

"Get off, get off, get off!"

She twisted and rammed her fist into the side of one of them, not caring that the metal of its body bruised and cut her knuckles, only that it tumbled off her and died. She twisted again, punching and hurling away as many as she could get her hands on, scrambling backwards and away from them. It was no use. When she got rid of one, three more came to take its place. They nipped and bit and scratched and peeled away at her, and no matter how

vigorously she struggled to get away, they kept coming. Adora thought she'd go mad from the pain.

One got up and sat right on her chest, pinning her flat to the ground. Adora got her scratched and bloody arms up and gripped the insides of its pincer-mouth as it lunged for her throat, snapping over and over again. She struggled, straining and pushing to keep it away from her neck as it death rattled at her.

Her staff came flying from out of sight and impaled the bot clean through its center. It seized a moment, its pincers baying and snapping uncontrolled, and then it slumped down on top of her. Adora whined from the effort as she half-pushed, half-slid it off her, and she breathed deep when the weight finally abated from her chest.

Something didn't feel right. In another moment, Adora realized what: the sound of the bots rushing her had abated entirely, and she was no longer set upon by an avalanche of them trying to kill her. She pulled her head up off the floor and looked downrange. Hundreds of bots floated above the terrace floor, kicking uselessly about with their legs in the air like they were trying to swim.

*Kalanthe is a mage*, Adora thought with a sudden burst of inspiration. This and the pillar from earlier suddenly made sense. And if he had been using his magic to subtly speed his movements, that explained the fighting skill too—how he could move in ways that weren't readable. She looked the floating mass of bugs over.

*Runes,* she thought. *There were always runes, so where were they now?*

When she squinted and still found nothing on the bots, she angled her head up-range instead and found the answer.

Kalanthe glowed with brilliant light. Ley lines stretched and pulsed across his skin much like the way the princesses glowed when the Heart first powered on. His eyes were like pits of starlight. Adora

thought she might get sucked through into another reality if she looked at them for any longer than a moment.

*He himself is the rune*, she thought, amazed at how different magic could manifest from person to person.

The sentry bot from earlier powered its beam eye once more and recoiled when it fired again, this time at Kalanthe. The beam impacted a barrier he had somehow erected around him without even moving. It deflected at an angle, and sliced through a sizeable swathe of the spiderbots still swimming fruitlessly above Adora. They all exploded in turn, one after the other, and showered her with gears and springs and splatters of oil.

She heard another roar in the distance and worried their fighting had awakened something fearsome deep within the castle. Then, a ship rose over the far edge of the terrace, casting floodlights down on them and making Adora squint against the brightness. Kalanthe had been reduced to a silhouette against the light.

A missile sprouted from the ship. It pigtailed through the air before slamming into the sentry bot atop the tower. A dozen more missiles fired loose, screaming through the air before making short work of the remaining bots that hadn't already been destroyed. Two more missiles shot past and slammed into the exit they came through, barricading the only hallway leading into or out of the terrace. Kalanthe seemed intent on preventing any more bots from following them, just in case.

Adora laid her head back down on the ground and sighed. She was safe. No more impending death from her own castle trying to murder her because it forgot who she was. Out of the top corner of her vision, she saw the ship rotate mid-air and touch down. With the light no longer shining on them, she saw Kalanthe, no longer glowing, head for a ramp leading into the hold of the ship that had just opened up.

"Wait," Adora said, trying to call out to him. Her voice came out as a strained croak. "Wait, don't go."

She rolled onto her stomach and pushed into a kneeling position. Her adrenaline was already waning, and the weight of her injuries piled on top now that she could fully feel them.

"You can't leave!"

Kalanthe locked eyes with her, and then he turned and disappeared inside the ship. The ramp rose slowly, as if daring her to do something about it. She heard the engines begin to build once again.

"No…stop!"

Her body didn't want to cooperate, but she forced it. She forced herself to her feet. Forced herself to take one staggering step after another. Forced herself to begin to jog, then sprint. She pumped her legs faster and harder despite her ankle screaming at her that it couldn't take any more abuse.

The engines spooled quicker, kicking up a small dust storm around the ship. The flaps on the wings extended and retracted, like a bird prepping for flight.

Her ankle twisted again and she crashed to the floor.

*Move, Adora*, she thought to herself. *Get up. You have to get up!*

Something buzzed at her wrist and she glanced down. Her PDA, scratched and busted almost beyond recognition, had come to life. Whatever phenomenon blocking any signal from reaching her when she first tried to use it had gone, and all the messages she had missed in the interim pinged over and over again. Messages from Bow. Several missed calls.

*I got your text*, he wrote. *Where are you?*

Another message: *Angella checked your room. Your PDA and gauntlet and staff are gone and you aren't there. Please tell me you aren't at the castle already??*

Yet another: *Adora?? Pick up! Entrapta told me the castle just exploded. Are you alright?*

The ship pulled away from the ground.

*Get up now!* Her mind screamed at her.

The PDA continued to buzz on her arm as more messages come in. New texts from Angella and Entrapta now, and even more messages from Bow. They were minutes away, but wouldn't get there in time to help her stop the intruder from leaving. They were too late.

She fought with her body that refused to move, and her mind turned to her friends as she watched the craft slowly rise—watched the doors of her failure continue to close.

Thoughts of Bow came, images of him training relentlessly day after day to perfect his archery, tinkering with new tech that would allow him to be a fearsome foe on the battlefield; he had sworn to never go down again as quickly as he had when he last fought Catra. He still had faith in her. Adora felt like she was failing him somehow, unable to have that same faith in herself.

There was Glimmer, off in the galaxy on some alien planet, fighting on the front lines against the Beast to evacuate and save as many people from populated cities as possible. All the stories she had shared with Adora over the years…how terrifying it could be out there. What was Adora still doing on Etheria except stagnating?

She thought of Entrapta, working tirelessly to so that they'd be one step closer to stopping the Beast's relentless advance. This Kalanthe person had managed to do what she struggled to achieve and activate Light Hope again in a matter of minutes. And he was escaping. Not just with the knowledge of how to do what they could not, but also with a mysterious crystal she never knew existed in her castle to begin with. Whatever it was, it was important and she was letting him get away with it. Letting him

slip through their fingers like sand because she was too much of a failure for her own castle to acknowledge her as She Ra.

The ship pulled higher into the air. If she took a running jump at it now, she might have just be able to touch the underside. But her body still wouldn't move! If she lost him, if she let him get away, all of her friends' hard work would be lost. What if they couldn't get the Heart to work again no matter what they tried? What if stopping Kalanthe and getting that crystal was the only way to succeed?

Another image she hadn't expected flashed in front of her. It was of the day she looked Catra in the eyes and told her they were done—told her she didn't want to hear from her any longer until they defeated the Beast.

She had wanted—no, *needed*—she had needed to focus on She Ra, damn it. But even after three years she was no closer than before. She had given up Catra for this! If she didn't stop this person…if she didn't succeed here, now, then even that sacrifice would have been meaningless.

Catra wasn't meaningless. She wasn't!

Rage and loathing boiled inside her at the thought of it. And as soon as she admitted that to herself, that she didn't want giving up Catra to have been meaningless, she felt a power surge through her.

It wasn't the same power she knew from when she still had She Ra (or maybe it was and it had just been so long she forgot what that felt like), but something other than more adrenaline coursed through her veins and made her feel lighter. Her ankle didn't throb as hard when she stood, and the pain from the lacerations that seared across her knuckles and all around her body burned less. She looked down and confirmed the injuries hadn't actually healed. She didn't look any different.

Except, now she held a sword.

The gauntlet she had been so used to seeing for so long now was gone, and in her right hand she held the Sword of Protection. It was thinner and sleeker than the sword of old, and glowed with a healthy brilliance she hadn't seen the old sword have.

Adora looked up at the ship, a full four stories off the ground, angling its nose to the stars to take off. She crouched low, concentrated every bit of energy she could muster into her legs, and with a banshee's scream, she leapt. As high as she could. She soared through the sky, racing to meet the ship. At the zenith of her arc, she slammed the sword into the top of its fuselage, and it took off.

The ship raced through the clouds and jetted to the stars. Adora held on for dear life. The wind blew through her loose hair and screamed into her ears so loud she couldn't hear anything else. She looked behind, surprised at how quickly the Crystal Castle and surrounding landscape grew smaller. The air got colder, and it got harder to breathe the more apparent Etheria's curve on the horizon came to be. As quick and sudden as it had come to her, She Ra's power began to fade.

*No*, she thought. *No, no, no. Not right now. I have to get inside!*

The last dregs of her power and energy disappeared, and her vision blurred. She tried to blink it back into focus, but somewhere around the third or fourth blink she realized the ship was suddenly getting smaller: she had let go without realizing, and was now free falling toward the planet's surface.

Her body flipped around mid-air and she faced down. Etheria's curve flattened gradually with the wind still whipping her hair and her face. The ground underneath came up to meet her much slower than she had initially left it. Somewhere in her head, alarm bells rang. Death loomed once more, but she was too exhausted to pay any attention to it. It was almost like an old friend by now.

Soon, individual trees among the forest below came into focus. In her daze, Adora felt as if she could just reach out and pluck them

straight from the ground. Everything went black then, and she fainted.

Chapter End Notes

Bit of a shorter chapter this time around, but very important (of course). I have a feeling some readers were thinking Adora would make some progress if she just chilled and were a bit kinder to herself, but what finally did it was her actually getting *more* upset. Makes you wonder what's going to happen with Catra and Glimmer...I did get some comments about them finally getting validation (Catra) and a team to lead (Glimmer) as positive developments :)

Speaking of Catra and Glimmer...I combined two chapters into one for next week's update since I thought it flowed better--both Catra and Glimmer pov scenes :)

As always, thank you for reading!

# To Mute the Drums of Fate

Chapter Notes

> It's been a bit since we last saw Glimmer. She was pulled away on an emergency assignment at the beginning of her shore leave, and found out she's supposed to lead Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio as a squad.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Aratoth!”

Glimmer pounded on the bulkhead door to the Battlemage Commander’s private quarters. The HISV *Omen-Kador* was still an hour away from emerging out of hyperspace. She finally knew where they were going, but Glimmer needed to speak with him before they rendezvoused with the rest of the fleet in orbit above Scavria. She pounded harder on the door.

“Commander Aratoth, I know you can hear me. Please sir, I have to speak with you. Urgently!”

The door slid open and a harried man stood before her, only half changed into his service uniform and in the middle of brushing his teeth.

“Glimmer?” he said, words muffled by the toothbrush still in his mouth. He welcomed her inside before padding back to the bathroom only six paces away. “Why the sudden visit?” he asked, spitting into the sink. “I saw your messages. I’m sorry I didn’t have time to see you earlier.”

“I can’t lead the squad you assigned me,” Glimmer said, dancing on her toes and eschewing all decorum.

“I’m sorry?” Aratoth gave her a look that said he already didn’t like where the conversation was going.

Glimmer held up the data chip Lonnie had given her several days earlier. “I can’t take on this assignment, sir. I can’t lead people. Not on a mission like this. Not yet.” Glimmer had done her best to pretend like everything was fine after she and Lonnie spoke, but it had been obvious Lonnie sensed something was wrong, and Glimmer had spent the next few days avoiding her supposed new subordinates while she pushed as hard as possible for a meeting with the commander.

“I don’t remember asking about your opinion on your assignments, soldier,” Aratoth said, putting his toothbrush away and cleaning up. “These are good troops, three of them Vanguard. It’s a solid team.”

“Sir, I don’t think you understand—“

“Are you referring to your panic attacks and night terrors?” Aratoth said. He finished washing up and dried his hands, then walked back out to the main room.

“Yes, sir.” Glimmer scrambled out of the way when it was clear he was heading for the standing dresser directly behind her. Despite being of high enough rank that he had his own private quarters, space was still limited on the super carrier, and there were other commanders and people of importance to house too.

“We’re fighting the Beast,” he said, pulling open the dresser and revealing the rest of his uniform hanging neat inside, its black and silver motif looking stately as ever. “Everyone and their mothers experience varying levels of PTSD on and after these assignments. Hell, even just landing on an infected planet puts some people in the crazy wards. But last I checked, the general consensus from the doctors on your last three deployments is that you are cleared for service.”

“That’s true, but this is a different matter entirely, sir. Have you spoken with Consular Taline about the nature of my…attacks?”

"No," Aratoth said with a bored tone. "I wasn't under the impression I had to consult with the Seraph—who might I add is retired from active service despite her accomplishments—over actual medical doctors. Not when it comes to your ability to perform." He gave her a look over his shoulder. "You aren't suggesting you require her blessing to do your job, are you?"

"No sir!" Glimmer said, never having shaken her head 'no' so quickly before in her life. "I've just… never lead a squad before and I just think it's a bit premature to be—"

"If you read those command orders," he said, his eyes flicking to the data chip she still held, "and I know you have, then you'll clearly see that you are to be leading only a small team of twelve soldiers. Two Vanguard riflemen, your pilot, and nine regular infantry is hardly a tall order for your first command. This especially since you will be reporting directly under me and learning from my example leading my own men. Compared to Rinne, this should be no problem."

Glimmer flinched, not having expected him to bring up the last time she was put in charge of anything more important than a refugee processing station. Aratoth seemed not to notice. He began putting on the rest of his ensemble, threading his arms through sleeves and adjusting himself in the mirror on the inside of one of the wardrobe doors.

"Those marching orders were designed specifically with your lack of experience in mind," he said. "I'm sure you've noticed the Beast is spreading faster than originally projected—the fact it's cropped up on Scavria of all places is just more proof of that. Between that and those loonies from the Vestamid gumming up the political machine, arguing the futility of fighting their God now that it's returned, we need more talented people who can lead, and we need them fast. You are at the top of that list of talent to cultivate."

Glimmer balked. "Sir, I understand the situation, and believe me, I am the last person who wants to be on the sidelines and not pull

her weight, but I wouldn't approach you like this if it weren't serious."

"Are you trying to tell me that we need to bench you, soldier?" Aratoth said, looking Glimmer in the eyes through the mirror while he adjusted the buttons on his service shirt. "Is that the extent of these nightmares?"

"No sir! I can still serve," Glimmer said, trying to keep her mind from racing. "I can still fight. Please, put me on my original assignment. Put me with the evac center so I can still help. If the forward stations get overwhelmed, I can still defend the refugees. I'm not a liability I just…I can't lead the team you've given me."

"If you are in good enough condition to fight and stable enough to function in the evac center, then you are perfectly fit and able to serve on the front lines, under me, with a team. Am I wrong?"

Glimmer was about to lose it. Every instinct in her body urged her to fight harder to prevent this, but her previous experience out in the field had already thoroughly broken any lofty and idealistic notions her younger self might have had about that approach working. If Aratoth still didn't get what the problem was, even after bringing both Rinne and her nightmares up, then Glimmer wasn't in a position to truly educate him. That would skirt dangerously close to revealing information about Etheria and the Emperor's invasion of it, which was still classified above top secret even amongst colleagues in the Enclave. It was part of the reason Scorpia and Entrapta could only send their messages to Catra through Glimmer once a month, with Salas' permission.

Oh, if only he had spoken to Taline! Even though she had warned her about this, Glimmer had no doubt in her mind she would have helped if she found out they wanted her in charge of something *now*. Hard as she might have been during Glimmer's apprenticeship, Taline understood the trauma seeing Narre and Miri die on the citadel…understood the trauma of all of Glimmer's friends nearly meeting the same fate. Understood how that trauma only compounded after Rinne…

“Speak candidly, Battlemage,” Aratoth said.

“Sir, I can’t explain *why* this is a bad idea, but I need to stress how strongly I believe that it is,” she said, trying to convey the frantic feeling knocking about inside her head threatening to make her scream without breaking decorum. “I had hoped by coming here and quite literally banging on your door while you were getting dressed and making my case would have shown that. If I lead this squad, people will die.”

Aratoth narrowed his eyes at her through the mirror and finished putting on the rest of his uniform. “You are an exemplary soldier and an incredibly promising Battlemage,” he said, shutting the dresser and turning to look at her properly. “People assigning you Taline’s moniker wasn’t just a fluke. You would have likely been given a different nickname, one that wasn’t so lofty, should the public have judged you unfit to carry her legacy. Which is why I hope you understand what I’m trying to get across when I say that the Enclave and especially the High Council have exceptionally high expectations from you. Turning to them and saying I cannot put you in command of a squad like they ordered because you have nightmares is simply not an option.”

Glimmer feared the conversation had shut and he had overridden her protests with finality. Then, when she thought on the strange way he emphasized the “because you have nightmares” and leaned into the nuance with his posture, it hit her. He wasn’t overriding her concerns, he was pointing her to an exit. An option where neither of them would lose face when inevitably forced to explain why they decided to supersede the High Councils orders. Her mind kicked into high gear. He *had* understood what she was trying to tell him between the lines; she just needed to find words that he could officially accept and use.

“Sir, I was about three hours into my first good night’s rest in almost a year when I was pulled on this emergency assignment,” Glimmer said, remembering with no small amount of frustration the disappointment she had felt at having to leave Catra and her vacation behind. “This is my fourth deployment without rest. I am

mentally, emotionally, and physically exhausted. And while I agree with the High Council's assessment that we sorely need a strong pipeline of Battlemages with command experience, I wish to make the case that putting an inexperienced person running on fumes in charge of a squad for the very first time—in the middle of the largest Beast engagement in almost twelve years, by the way—is a recipe for disaster. Not to mention the fact that three of my assigned subordinates are personal friends I haven't seen in years. The emotional connection on top of everything else will only serve to complicate an already handicapped attempt to expose me to a first command."

Aratoth regarded her with cool eyes as he adjusted his sleeve cuffs. Glimmer wanted to go up to him, shake him, and yell at him to take her off the command. The thought of leading Lonnie and Kyle and Rogelio would sooner immobilize her in anxiety and fear than prove useful on the battlefield.

"For the record, I disagree with your sentiment," he said. "Everyone has issues and we all need to pull our weight, especially in a war like this." He sighed and ran a hand through his hair. "But I also trust that you wouldn't be coming to me making excuses if it weren't serious. Lucky for us, despite being such a heavily populated planet, the Beast on Scavria is confined only to the capital city of Tir. Our forces there are already making steady progress pushing the creature back, and we may not end up needing the number of personnel we originally forecasted."

"That's fantastic news," Glimmer said, bouncing again on her toes with a hopeful expression.

Aratoth studied her. "Out of respect for you and for your mentor, I will agree to change your assignment for this deployment. You will be relegated back to the evacuation center and resume normal duties. Your first command will have to wait until your next deployment, after you've taken your already well-earned shore leave. But make no mistake—should things turn south and more leaders are needed, I will reverse my decision and expect to see you on the front lines with your squad. Is that clear?"

“Crystal clear, sir. Thank you.”

Aratoth nodded. “We exit hyperspace in an hour and make landfall in two. I want you on the first lander planet-side. You are dismissed.”

Glimmer snapped off a sharp salute, barely registering the lackadaisical one Aratoth returned, before she beat a hasty retreat. She hurried down the hall, passing staffers and enlisted corpsmen walking and chatting as they headed from duty post to the mess hall, or from whatever recreation time they had come off of to their duty posts. A shift change was coming soon, and the hallways were more crowded than usual.

She pushed past a pair of ensigns whispering to each other. One of them called out to her in anger when she bumped him. She ignored him and trudged on without looking back, then ignored how his buddy shushed him and started whispering into his ear about who the pink-haired girl that just jostled him really was. Whispers of ‘Archanas’ and ‘Rinne’ followed her. She rounded a corner and found the door to her own room, punching her access code into the console next to the door and rushing inside when it slid open.

As Battlemage, Glimmer was afforded her own room as well, albeit an even smaller one than the one Commander Aratoth enjoyed. Heart pounding, head spinning, and thoughts racing, Glimmer headed straight to the bathroom attached to her room. She threw the door to the tiny shower open, barely large enough for her, stepped in, and yanked the ‘cold’ lever all the way to max power.

Cold showers were the worst. In fact, Glimmer had never touched the cold lever in her life, often waiting until she couldn’t see her hand in front of her face from the steam building in the room before letting the water touch her. This time, Glimmer barely registered the cold when it soaked her, uniform and all.

She breathed deep, quick breaths, nearly hyperventilating in her attempt to override her anxiety attack and just ground herself in reality. Finally, she sunk to the ground on her knees and pulled at her hair. And screamed. She screamed over and over and over again, trying to drown out the images of Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio surrounding her, dead on the field of battle because of her failure to lead.

When the *Omen-Kador* emerged from hyperspace an hour later and the landers in the hangar were loading up the first batch of people to take down, no one asked Glimmer to her face why she was sopping wet standing there in line with the rest of them. They did, however, whisper among themselves and shoot her concerned glances.

She ignored them all, and instead counted water droplets as they fell from her mussed hair to the floor. A puddle of shower water grew ever larger at her booted feet with each drip.

She didn't come out of her stupor until stepping foot on Scavria's surface—until the scent of death in the air gave her more important things to worry about.

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Catra hummed and practically skipped along the pathways of the Atrium on her way to meet Diallo. She had asked Hilda where the System Governor had gone when she reached the embassy's lobby, and she had sent him a message on her behalf asking to meet.

She took her time, however, because as she passed little shops and department stores and delicatessens, Catra couldn't help but marvel at the items on display. What used to make her roll her eyes at the luxury of it all now made her want to stop and appreciate them in a new light, all on account of her being in a better mood than she had ever been in since her and Adora had their first secret sleepover as kids.

*I still saved money to spend here with Sparkles,* she thought as she looked through the window of a toy store, at the diorama of small dolls and trains on display. *If it's just me buying something celebratory, it won't be nearly as expensive as a two-week extravaganza with her.*

She remembered passing by a tiny specialty butcher not too long ago, thought about how good it smelled. She could have something from there, right? Maybe an expensive cut of jerky or something she could snack on. Boxes of leftovers still sat in Glimmer's fridge, and Catra had been dying to get to them, but the thought of buying something expensive and savory as a present to herself was enticing all the same.

She shook her head. *Diallo first,* she thought. *Give him the drive, buy jerky. In that order, Catra, damn you.*

She had no issues finding their meeting spot on the Atrium, primarily because it was in a place she had already been to recently. Diallo sat alone on a bench, and adjusted the spectacles on his face. A great cherry blossom stood nearby, shading the statue of Corynth Catra had first mulled over a few days ago.

"Governor Diallo," Catra said, striding up to him and extending her hand for a confident handshake. "It's me again. Catra. From Taline's office."

"Yes, I remember," Diallo said, pushing his glasses up the bridge of his nose before reaching for her hand. He took it and, despite obviously putting energy behind the handshake, his grip was weak. "I got your message from the d-directory assistant and figured I'd w-wait for you. I hope you don't m-mind meeting here on the ground floor. They've set me up with a temporary office up on the Executive l-level, but the food d-down on the Atrium has always b-been more agreeable with my stomach."

"I don't mind at all," Catra said. She couldn't fathom how someone like Diallo had worked with Taline during the height of the Beast wars, and then ended up in a relatively high-up position

like a System Governorship. He was too…frail looking? Frail sounding? She couldn't quite place it, but he gave impression he'd crumble to dust under the slightest bit of stress or pressure. Did his stutter make it hard for him to work with his staffers?

Then Catra considered maybe the fact he lived through the previous war, had helped catalogue Evelyn's Beast research for Taline, and thus was likely exposed to a large amount of the Beast during his life might have contributed to his frailty and she felt bad.

"I hope they don't work you too hard while you're visiting," she said, clearing her throat to hide her embarrassment.

"Not as much p-paperwork compared to being among my constituents, many more skull-numbing meetings that feel like they g-go nowhere," he said, waving a hand dismissively. "What is it you wanted to see m-me for, officer?"

Catra pulled the portable drive out of her pocket and held it out to him. "Taline asked that I return this to you. She apologized, but said she was firm in her decision to return it, and thought it best not to get involved." Catra admitted to herself she had embellished the message to make it land softer. Diallo didn't look like the kind of person whose buttons she'd enjoy pushing. It'd probably feel more cruel than entertaining, if she were honest.

Diallo raised both eyebrows but made no move to collect the drive. "Interesting," he said. He looked from the drive to Catra and seemed to study her.

"Uh…Governor Diallo? Your drive?" She held it a little closer for him, just in case reaching for it from the bench was uncomfortable.

"What were her w-words exactly when she asked you to bring it to me?"

"She said to let you decide what to do with it and that she was done chasing ghosts. Said she had the people on the station to

look after and…uhm….” Catra trailed off, unsure if she was allowed to mention the fact Taline had taken her or not.

“V-very interesting,” Diallo said.

“What’s interesting?” Catra asked, bristling. She wished he’d just take the damn thing already.

“You can k-keep the drive, Catra,” Diallo said, shaking his head. “I believe I understand what Taline is trying to s-say. You are going to help me instead of her.”

“What? No. No, no, no, that’s not at all what she said.”

“You w-would understand why the Consul cannot just speak freely about how to handle that device if you knew w-what it contained,” he said. “Taline would not send a s-simple errand girl to return it to me, and she certainly w-wouldn’t have gotten a member of station security of all people involved unless it w-was specifically to help me in her stead.”

“No, that doesn’t sound right,” Catra said, although she suddenly felt uncertain given how confidently Diallo spoke. How could someone both stutter their words and sound so sure of themselves? “Why would she do that?”

“Because she’s taken you on, h-hasn’t she? Taline sponsored you into the Empire, and n-now she’s taken you on as a Sentinel.”

“I…No, she hasn’t,” Catra said, although she didn’t sound as full of conviction as she had hoped. If no one was supposed to find out about this yet, then she was in deep shit. “Look, sir, I’m just here to give back the drive. Please take it.”

Diallo grinned wider and Catra whined in frustration. She recognized the look of someone who just hit upon an epiphany.

“T-tell me,” Diallo said, suddenly sitting forward with an excitement in his voice. “What exactly did she tell you was to

happen n-next after she took you on? Did she talk to you about training, or perhaps a f-first assignment?"

Catra wilted and spoke in a small voice, once again feeling exposed. "She said she'd get a training plan together after she got the paperwork done. She's got a weird sense of humor, and it felt oddly like she was implying this was my 'first assignment,' returning your property. And I'm one hundred percent serious when I say she didn't actually tell me that, and I'm pretty sure it would have been a joke even if she were implying it."

Diallo sat back and slapped his knee in a laugh. "W-wonderful! Absolutely wonderful. Let me guess, she mentioned n-none of the training would likely h-happen until after Moriarty's campaign speech to the station?"

Catra nodded but didn't say anything. She had gone from feeling on top of the world to feeling suddenly entirely out of the loop. She hated it. Diallo seemed to sense her discomfort and instead of getting even more excited, he calmed and patted a space next to the bench. Catra eyed it warily for a moment, then stalked over and lowered herself down onto the bench next to him.

"I take back everything I s-said back in her office," Diallo said, keeping his eyes forward instead of looking at her as he spoke. "With her new responsibilities and the Emperor keeping a c-closer eye on her than before, she doesn't have the freedom to m-move about that she used to."

"Diallo, sir, I'm not sure what you are talking about right now."

"Just Diallo, p-please," he said. "Sir isn't n-necessary. Tell me, Catra, were you ever acquainted with Taline's previous Sentinels? Narre and Miri?"

"Very briefly," Catra said, nodding. "I never spoke or interacted with them, but I saw them once."

Diallo nodded. "Very sad, what h-happened to them. Taline was vague on the details but I understood enough—it's unfortunately

just p-part of the job sometimes. Working with a Battlemage is not without its risks. I'm assuming she t-told you what the actual duty of a Sentinel is?"

Catra nodded. "Protect her, both from outside threats and from being corrupted. I'm to kill her before she becomes an Abomination if the Beast were to ever get to her." Diallo didn't respond when she finished, as if he were waiting for her to continue. "W-was there more? She didn't mention any more."

"No, she likely wouldn't have. A Sentinel is not j-just a bodyguard, Catra. I'm assuming she told you how they're handpicked by the Battlemages that f-field them?"

"How do you know about that?" Catra asked, her tail swishing and brushing the floor in agitation. "I couldn't find that out no matter where I looked." She decided to leave Glimmer's name out of it for the time being.

Diallo chuckled. "It's an open secret, r-really. Not written down anywhere but f-freely shared if you only ask a Battlemage or a Sentinel you are on personal terms with. In the past, I worked extensively b-both with Narre and Miri when Taline herself couldn't meet with me. She also frequently sent one of them off to represent her if she were busy and unable to go herself."

"They act in her stead for her?" Catra asked.

"Sometimes," Diallo said, nodding. "Why do you think a Sentinel traditionally shares such a tight b-bond with their Battlemages before being chosen? If a competent b-bodyguard was all they needed, hiring mercenaries or partnering with the Imperial Vanguard was always an option. A Sentinel is given far more trust and r-responsibility in the affairs of their Battlemage than any common bodyguard."

Catra's pride swelled. Even after her heart to heart with Taline, she still woefully underestimated what it meant to inherit the title

she just recently earned. Thinking back on it, she felt incredibly foolish for having thought she could just apply and get in.

"That d-drive in your hand," Diallo said, still not look at her. "It c-contains what I believe to be a phantom algorithm. Are you familiar with the term?"

Catra shook her head.

"They're encryption algorithms that are uncrackable by any deciphering s-software we currently possess. They're named so because, to this d-day, no one has come across one. This, despite many purporting to have created one or f-found one of their own when intercepting encrypted messages. Hence the 'phantom' in the n-name."

Catra laughed. "Uncrackable, huh? I'd like to see how it stands up to my precinct's deciphering AI. Nothing we've fed it has ever been able to stump it."

"I guarantee you t-this will be the first to do so. Phantom algorithms are like f-folk tales or urban legends to cryptologists, many of whom just indulge in the fantasy because it p-passes the time and is novel. But to people like Taline and m-myself, we know they exist. And up until Taline got s-stationed here permanently, we'd both hunted obsessively to find one, l-leaping into action at the merest sign one had appeared."

"How are you so certain they exist?"

"There's one already hiding in plain sight, p-protecting us all."

Catra furrowed her brow. "Are you talking about…the Barrier?"

Diallo grinned. "That exactly," he said. "You s-see, despite the Barrier itself being different from an encryption, it is still powered by an algorithm. An imperfect one to be sure, but one that that no current s-system has been able to crack. No one knows how it w-works."

“And you think what’s on this drive is encrypted using a similar thing to the Barrier?”

“Not a s-similar thing, the exact same one. There is only one ‘phantom algorithm’, and if the tests I’ve ran it through m-mean anything, then yes—a variant of the Barrier n-node algorithm is indeed keeping the contents of that disk under h-heavy encrypted lock and key.”

“Why are the both of you so worried about whether or not someone’s figured out that algorithm in the first place? Isn’t that a good thing? Doesn’t that mean someone could improve it and maybe shore up the imperfections letting the Beast slip through?”

“Th-think about it like this,” Diallo said. “The greatest scientific minds in the galaxy have been working nonstop f-for over eight years since the Daiamid started up the Barrier, trying to understand h-how it works, and they have made n-no progress on it. Its design is completely alien in n-nature, and the processing power needed to execute it, l-let alone analyze it, requires literally hundreds of Dyson spheres s-spread across the galaxy. There’s only one plausible answer to wh-who can employ this technology.”

Catra tilted her head in thought. “Who?”

“Corynth.”

Catra shook her head. “Corynth is dead. Long dead.” She glanced over to the statue of him looming over them.

“That’s what everyone th-thinks,” Diallo said. “That’s what Taline wants to th-think too. But if this indeed is the Barrier algorithm, then it’s indisputable proof he is s-still alive. He is the only one who would have access to it. Think about it—all the scientists that worked on the project with the Daiamid are either in th-the emperor’s employ or dead, and all the Shapers are long gone. No one except Corynth, were he to still be alive, would have ever h-had direct access to the algorithm when it was first developed.”

He took his glasses off and cleaned them with a cloth he pulled out from a pocket. Catra waited for him to finish, not sure what to say. When he finally slotted the frames back onto his face, he said, "you tell me what m-makes more sense—that some nobody scientist discovered the answer and is using it to h-help his underworld buddies conceal their messages, or that Corynth actually survived the last battle and he's using it to hide his secret dealings. Why do you think his mask and not the remains of his charred body was f-found on Archanas?"

Catra bit her lip in thought. What Diallo said made sense, but she still didn't want to buy into it so readily. It felt foolish.

"If that w-wasn't enough to get the gears of conspiracy turning in your head," Diallo said, then you should know I intercepted th-this from a messenger meant to deliver the drive personally. It's supposed to go to Moriarty, and it comes f-from the Vestamid."

Catra finally looked at Diallo when he mentioned the two names, and he was looking directly back at her.

"The Vestamid? You can't be serious." Their name had dropped back in Taline's office, but she hadn't thought twice about it at the time. "If this tripped any alarms, they'd have the entire Imperial Armada shoved down their throats in an audit. They're too big a threat to Prime and the Empire to risk drawing this kind of attention."

"Another way to look at it is that's exactly the narrative the emperor w-wants everyone to see," Diallo said. "No one's mind n-needs to wander into colorful territory regarding their relationship if everyone thinks the empire's largest s-supplier of ignominite is chafing the emperor's sense of absolute control."

"You mean they're just pretending to be capitalist religious zealots to hide the fact they're secretly state-sponsored?"

Diallo shrugged. "Again, w-we're talking about phantom algorithms and conspiracies. I know just as much as the average

Imperial citizen, despite being p-placed pretty high in the political hierarchy myself."

"And Moriarty?"

"He's been cutting f-funding from dozens of systems for months now with explanations that barely h-hold water. On top of that, he helped f-fast track approval for one of the Vestamid's energy storage p-projects about two years ago. Now they're sending him encrypted messages on a ph-physical drive during a heavily contested election year? I have no idea what the correlation is, but if we were to just p-prove without a doubt that a correlation does indeed exist, Taline would blow this th-thing wide open."

"And this is where I come in?" Catra asked, starting to grow uncomfortable with where the conversation was heading.

"Th-this is where you come in," Diallo said, nodding. "The computer in Moriarty's office should be primed to unlock th-the encoded messages, since they're addressed to him in the first place. I n-need you to sneak into that office and pull those m-messages so we can see what the Vestamid is having him do. Then I need you to get a copy of the pattern used to decrypt the message from the same computer. With that pattern, we should be able to m-map the algorithm used t-to scramble the message in the first place, and determine if it is r-really is based off the Barrier algorithm or not."

Catra balked. "I…I don't know about that," she said. "That really doesn't seem like something Taline would ask me to do."

"It's not," Diallo said. "Just like it's not s-something she would have outright asked Narre or Miri to do either, had they s-still been alive. But remember, you are able to act as an extra p-pair of arms and legs and eyes and ears to do and see and go where sh-she cannot. It's plausible deniability, Catra. Should you get caught, she can tell the truth and s-say she never ordered you to do anything."

That set Catra on edge. "I…I'm still not sure. Let me think about it? Maybe I'll reach out to her and see if that's really what she intended. I don't like the idea of going behind her back to do something like this, especially against such a powerful political elite like Moriarty. I don't want to be the thing that makes an enemy out of him for her."

Diallo nodded. "We h-have time, since Moriarty's speech isn't for a few days. But you're unlikely to get ahold of h-her with everything she has to do to get ready. And even if you were to get a chance to speak with her, she w-would deny everything. For an espionage job like this, she's not going to outright sp-spell it out for you."

He sighed. "Listen, Catra. You and I just met and this is the f-first real conversation we've had, but I've worked with Taline long enough n-now that I know she wouldn't have chosen you if you weren't smart and couldn't read between the lines. She's relying on you to l-look into this, just like I'm relying on you f-for your help. You want to impress her and do a good job on your first assignment, r-right?"

Catra frowned and nodded, slowly.

"Good. Keep the drive, th-think about what I've said. Try and get ahold of her if you want, but I'm telling you, nothing will come of it. Destroy the drive or agree to h-help me, but come find me and tell me your decision before the day of Moriarty's s-speech. Our window to act on th-this will close by then." With that, Diallo pushed off the bench and hobbled over to the far elevator, bidding her a cheery goodbye and saying he needed to return to his work.

Catra's stomach churned. She looked up again at the statue of Corynth looming nearby.

"You're not still alive, are you?" she asked, murmuring as if speaking to herself. "You're dead. You have to be dead."

She sat on that bench and contemplated for a long while. Her good mood never did return. In the end, she made her way back

to the leftovers in Glimmer’s fridge, all thought of stopping by a shop to buy a gift for herself long forgotten.

**End of Part Two**

Chapter End Notes

Aaaand part 2 is done! For those of you who don't want to read a massive deep dive into my thoughts with this author's note, let me just say:

Thank you as always for reading, I hope you enjoyed part 2, and part 3 begins next Thursdy at it's usual time. There is still no hiatus. Also, the super awesome poster art for part 3 will show up in the next chapter too :)

If you're interested in me rambling about the story for a bit, then keep reading.

I'd say at this point the story has hit it's main stride. Part 1 was long and cool, but much of that was to set up the pieces to tell the real story I had built up when first writing World Eater. In fact, the working title for my first draft of part 1 was "Prologue" lol. All 16 chapters and ~70k words of it.

From the start I hammered out a story about the heros coping with their traumas as best they could and making choices that don't work out for them the way the hoped.

Adora is enslaved to her sense of duty--its why she left the Horde in the first episode of season 1, and its why she pushed Catra away near the end of part 1. She struggled to find her identity as She Ra and figure out her powers during the canon show. She doesn't even see "Adora" as seperate from "She Ra" until Mara gives her a talk in Season 5. In this story? She goes three years after sacrificing her relationship with Catra and still doesn't make any progress with her powers, and the weight on her shoulders is more dire than just Horde Prime. She Ra may have "come back" somewhat

at the end of the last chapter, but that's really just the start of it all.

Glimmer dealt with issues being her own person and escaping from under the thumb of her mom and her responsibilities during the canon show. In World Eater, she "ran away" in a sense to train with Taline after seeing real actual death before her eyes, and she blames herself for those deaths because she froze when confronted with an actual bodily threat (Horde Prime). Sure, she's come a long way learning to be powerful again, but completely breaks down and runs in the opposite direction when given the opportunity to lead. Lonnie very clearly idolizes her--you can see that from their one interaction in the last Glimmer chapter. And Glimmer, right now, is someone who begged her superior to take her off that leadership assignment so she could work behind the front lines in the evacuation center. Any guesses on how well that's going to play out? How Lonnie would take it, being rejected from an authority figure of her own she looks up to?

And finally Catra. She's been treated the kindest so far, with Taline, a strong and "good" authority figure going out of her way to nurture her. But even after removing herself from Etheria and spending three years living her new life, Catra isn't able to break away from her low self worth, complete lack of self esteem, and her need to seek validation from her authority figures. That's why her and Taline had such a tumultuous relationship when they met back up. That's why Catra stares at those statues of Corynth, who is like a galaxy-wide idol and authority figure. And now, she's caught between a rock and a hard place. Right after Taline breaks through to her and gives her an important position she is finally able to accept, Catra runs into Diallo, yet another authority figure with a close and long-term relationship to Taline, and needs to decide between trusting what he says and acting secretively to help him, or rejecting him and risking being wrong about her role as a Sentinel.

Part 3 is the longest of the 5 parts, because it progresses each of the three main characters' conflicts to the next phase, so to speak. This, and it interweaves with the overall conflict that sits atop each of the three character arcs: The Beast, the Daiamid Shapers, and now the Vestamid, all of which are concepts I've hinted at throughout the three POV character chapters in part 2 :) The Vestamid in particular are interesting. Except for the final scene with Diallo where they are talked about a little deeper, each reference to the Vestamid in previous chapters read more as throwaway lines. If you're like me and go hunting for details, you can probalby piece together a solid picture of who the heck they are and what role they play in the background if you go back and look at each time they're mentioned.

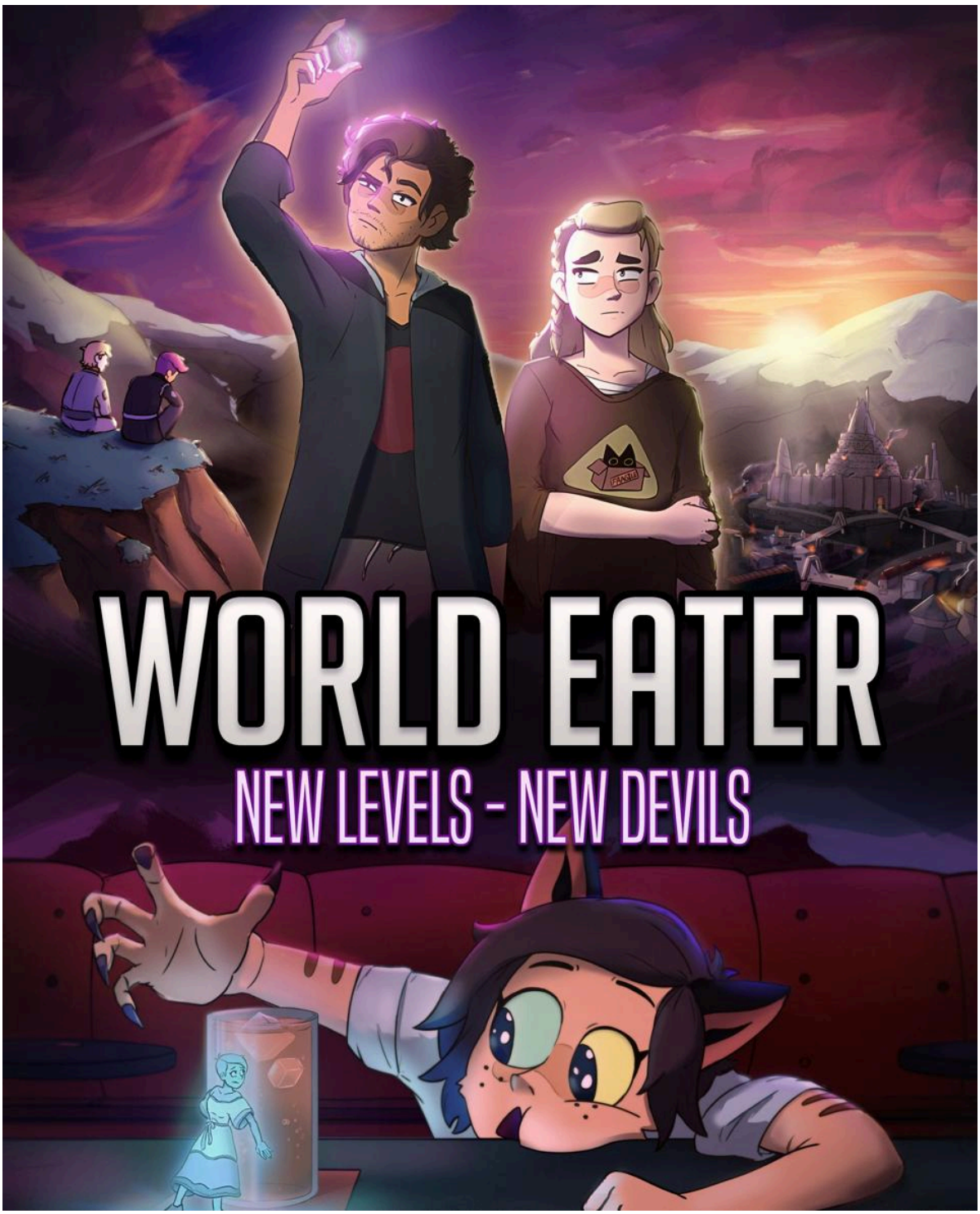
Also, I have barely a rudimentary idea of how encryption, hashing, digests, and the like work for cryptology...I took what little I did understand, dumbed it down even more, and used it as a major plot point/device. I hope it's enough for your suspension if disbelief. If you happen to read this and are an expert on the subject, please don't make fun of me for all the wild liberties I took. xD

If you've read this whole thing to the end then I commend you. Thanks so much for following along as always, and I will see you next week!

# Part III: New Levels - New Devils, Chapter 29: Hinterlands of Fate

## Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes



Art commission done by SzethK. Linktree: Here

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## Chapter Twenty-Nine: Hinterlands of Fate

Adora opened her eyes and groaned. A metal bulkhead ceiling and a pair of halogen lights hanging overhead came into focus. She tried to sit up and immediately gave up on it when the throbbing in her head only got worse. Her body ached. Somewhere off in the distance she heard a voice.

"—knew this was going to happen, didn't you?" A muffled response she couldn't make out, and then: "Well I couldn't just let her fall to her death now, could I?"

Adora pushed into a sitting position, forcing herself through the pain shooting through her body. The room lurched sideways and she tumbled off the bed, falling to the ground with a thud.

"She's awake," the voice said. "I just heard her fall off the bed."

A note of panic poked at the back of her mind, and she heard the voice say goodbye to whomever it was speaking to. There was an annoying pinching feeling at her arm. Something was screeching at her—had been since she fell—but she couldn't orient herself enough to understand anything beyond that. Getting the room to stop spinning was the only thing her brain could focus on.

The far door slid open and someone stepped through. Adora pulled her head up and focused long enough to see who it was.

"Kalanthe," she said. "If that's even your real name." She tried to sound threatening, but only succeeding in slurring her words. Even to her vertigo-addled mind, she could hear how off balance she sounded.

"Just Kal will do," he said, looking down at her with an impassive face and speaking with a deadpan. "And it's just as real as any other name, I suppose. You know, I considered strapping you down to the bed so this wouldn't happen, but it'd probably have

freaked you out to wake up like that. Welcome to the *Dzivia*." He stepped forward to help her up and she scooted back, bumping into the bed still behind her.

"Get away from me," she said, weak. "Don't touch me."

Kal frowned and stepped off to the side. Adora tracked him as he walked along the perimeter of the room until he reached a monitor at the back. It was flashing an 'ERROR' signal at him, until he reached behind and flipped a switch there to turn it off. The incessant screeching from earlier ceased.

Adora reached for the bed to try and pull herself up, and saw that a catheter had been inserted into her forearm, dangling free there. Blood seeped out from under the adhesive tape; she had almost ripped the needle out of her arm when she fell.

"What did you do to me?" she said, trying to weather another lurch of the room that spiked with her adrenaline. "Did you…did you drug me?"

"Not unless you consider a saline drip to be a drug."

Adora frowned and, giving up on the bed for the time being, looked herself over as best she could sprawled out on the floor. Kal had taped sensors to her body, and most of them had come undone when she fell as well. Suddenly it made sense why the monitor in the corner was blaring; he was watching her vitals.

Much of her clothing was ripped—her pants had been reduced to shorts that cut off mid-thigh, and the arms had been ripped off her top along with the entire midsection. More skin than she ever would have been comfortable showing voluntarily might have been out on display, except for the fact that nearly every inch of her that would have exposed had instead been wrapped in thick gauze and adhesive bandages. When she traced the bandages around her stomach and felt just how high up her chest they reached, she turned a murderous glare in Kal's direction.

“I didn’t do anything to you,” he said, annoyance now coming through in his voice. “I left as much clothing on you as I could, but I had to dress your wounds. You would have either bled out or gotten an infection if I hadn’t. You’re welcome.”

That did make sense, if she remembered correctly how the spiderbots at her castle nearly ripped her limb from limb. And at least she was still wearing what was left of her original clothes instead of something new entirely. Still, she didn’t like it.

“Now, can I help you get back on the bed or are you going to keep glaring at me?” Kal asked, moving back to stand in front of her. “You’ll feel better once you’re elevated a bit.”

He squatted down in front of her, but Adora didn’t answer him. Kal rolled his eyes and hooked his arms under her to help her stand. She didn’t fight him. Despite how gaunt and emaciated he looked, he had no trouble supporting her weight. The cords of his muscles rippled underneath his baggy clothes as he helped maneuver her back into a sitting position on top of the examination bed. This was the same guy who carried a whole crate by himself into Entrapta’s lab, while everyone else worked in twos. He looked harmless almost, and Adora knew even through the fog in her head that was a lie.

“Take me back to Etheria,” she said as soon as he let her go. “My friends will come for me and make you regret it if you don’t.”

The room had stopped spinning, but all she could feel was annoyed. Annoyed that he was helping her, annoyed that he was right about getting elevated. Annoyed that should couldn’t stop him from escaping and now was depending on him.

“I’m afraid it’s too late for that,” he said, skirting around the bed and fishing through an overhead cabinet nearby. A moment later, he came away with a large rag. “Besides, they would have caught me already if they were ever going to. We’ve been traveling through hyperspace for three days now.”

“I’ve been asleep for *three days*?” Adora choked the words out. A wave of dread crashed into her, nearly overpowering her nausea. “Where are you taking me?”

“I’m not taking you anywhere,” Kal said, coming over and reaching for Adora’s arm. He frowned when she pulled it away from him. “You’re the one that tried to stow away.” He pointed to her arm. “Can I have that please? I’m trying to help.”

“I wasn’t trying to stow away,” Adora said, although she didn’t fight when Kal reached across and pulled her arm closer to him.

“Then what the hell were you trying to do?” he asked, dabbing at the blood coming out from under the IV, already drying on her skin.

“You were getting away.” Adora grimaced when the room tilted to the side again. “I was trying to stop you.”

“Yeah, that worked out wonderfully,” he said, giving a dry laugh as he worked. “Looks like someone forgot that the air gets too thin to breathe if you go high enough. You fell unconscious, and I had to turn around and catch you with a tractor beam before you hit the ground. Then I had to stop and spend hours fixing the hole you put in my ship with your sword.”

More of what happened came back to her, and Adora remembered the power she felt as she watched him start flying away; she had somehow awoken She Ra again, although she had no idea how. Quietly, she reached for the power. When she felt it there, bubbling under the surface as it always had, relief flooded her. At least the power wasn’t missing entirely, as it had when she fought him. That nearly gave her a heart attack. It wasn’t until Kal finished cleaning up the blood on her arm the she realized her bracer and runestone were missing.

“Relax,” Kal said, pulling her from her thoughts. Adora glanced up and saw him looking straight into her eyes. “Your stuff is over there.” He inclined his head toward a table at the far end of the

room. Her bracer and busted PDA lay next to piles of tech, a surgical kit, and a bowl full of bloody rags.

Adora tried to slide off the bed to go get it, but Kal put his hand on her shoulder to keep her from moving.

"Let go of me," she said, shooting him another dangerous look.

"Didn't we just go through this? I'm not helping you again if you dump yourself onto the floor a second time."

"I said, let me go." She grabbed onto his arm and tried to pry his hand off her. Despite her straining, she couldn't get him to let go.

"I don't understand the hostility," he said. "I'm trying to help you, Adora. I'm not your enemy."

"If you think that just because you saved my life I—"

"Three times."

Adora blinked, confused and thrown off balance. "What?"

"I saved your life three times," he said, face and voice impassive. "First was that pillar that almost squashed you, second was when all those spiderbots nearly minced you, and third was the falling to Etheria."

"It doesn't matter if you saved me a hundred times," Adora said, "If you think I'm going to trust you after seeing you steal something from my castle, then you have another thing coming."

"You don't even know what that thing is, do you?" He asked. "Otherwise, you wouldn't call it a 'thing.'"

"I know it must be important if it was locked away. I know that no one except you even knew it was there, and I also know that you somehow made Light Hope think you're an administrator when you aren't so you could take it and escape with it. That's enough for me to know you can't be trusted."

“That apeiron, which is the actual name for one of those things by the way, is what’s going to put a stop to the Beast invading the galaxy once and for all.”

Adora frowned. “That…what? No it isn’t, that’s what the Heart of Etheria is for. The Enclave has spent the past three years researching a way to get it to work again.” Her frown deepened as she remembered something, and she rounded on him, more hostile than before. “You’ve *been* around the whole time! You know about all that, what am I doing saying it as if you don’t know?”

Kal shook his head. “The Enclave couldn’t even figure out how to turn Light Hope on. I watched them try. What makes you think they know how to stop the Beast? They had no idea that crystal exists or what it does.” He laughed. “Hell, *you* didn’t know it existed until I pulled it out of that vault right in front of you.”

“How the hell was I supposed to know it was there?”

“It’s your castle. You didn’t ever once think, ‘gee I wonder why it’s called the Crystal fucking Castle?’”

Adora could only gape at him. Who was this guy? She was about to give him another piece of her mind when he shook his head again and squeezed her shoulder.

“You don’t trust me, even after I saved your life?” he said. “That’s fine, but that doesn’t make me your enemy. And as much as it’d make my life easier, I’m not about to throw you out of an airlock because you annoy me. Unless you volunteer to do it yourself, then we’re stuck with one another. Trust or no trust, we can at least be civil. I’m sorry for yelling.”

Adora narrowed her eyes at him. “And what exactly is your idea of ‘being civil’?”

“We’ll make it to our destination soon, and despite the fact you’ve healed up quite nicely and regained consciousness, you still can’t stand on your own two feet.” He gestured around at the room

then at himself. “There’s nowhere for you to go and you’ve already seen that I’m not going to hurt you, so why don’t you lay back down and focus on regaining your strength? I’d prefer to take you along with me when we arrive, rather than lock you in here because you’re too weak to move.”

Adora narrowed her eyes at him even further, scrutinizing him. He didn’t back down.

“Fine,” she said, letting him guide her head back down to the pillow underneath. “But this conversation isn’t over. I still don’t trust you, and I have a lot of questions.”

“I’m sure you do,” he said, voice devoid of emotion. “Rest now.”

Adora wanted to say something back just to have the last word. This whole situation aggravated her, even more so than the wounds on her body. She thought about being petty—staying awake and pestering him with some of the many questions she had churning in her head—but as soon as her head hit the pillow, all thought of rebelling disappeared. Sleep beckoned, and within moments, she drifted off despite her every attempt to keep awake.

Chapter End Notes

> Kal during part 2: Some mysterious interloper that can evade everyone on Etheria, hack tech faster than Entrapta, beat Adora in a melee fight, defend against her entire castle, and successfully escape unscathed.
>
> Kal at the start of part 3: beleaguered homeless man taking care of a stubborn injured person.
>
> Like Taline, Kal also doesn't have any POV scenes. Closest you're going to get into his head is through Adora's interactions with him, these author notes, and maybe comment replies lol

Shorter chapter this time around, but it's okay because the new poster art is here! One person commented privately to me that everyone in the first two posters looked somber (for good reason). The artist and I decided to run with that and go in a more lighthearted direction with poster 3 (especially Catra). There *are* some lighthearted moments in this story! Some already in part 2 if you squint, and definitely moments in part 3 that I think are heartwarming. I wanted the art to reflect some of that. I don't think I could get away with doing that in the part 4 or 5 posters.

Let me know your guys' thoughts!

# Stirrings of Change

Chapter Notes

> Quick refresher for those following along weekly: Trayn and Keren are Catra's coworker friends, and Dax is her boss.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra sat at her desk in the precinct, staring at her computer screen and unable to keep her hands from shaking as she reached for her cup of coffee.

"Holy hell," Keren said from her desk next to her. "Catra, how many cups of coffee are you planning on drinking today? That has to be your third already."

"Fourth actually," Catra said after downing the mug. She stood from her chair. "Time for number five."

"It's not even been an hour since you clocked in, dude. Are you okay?"

"'M'fine." Catra ignored the look Keren gave her as she walked past, mug in hand, and headed for the break room.

The nightmares had only gotten worse since Glimmer left. Normally, they would have subsided by now. Instead, she woke most mornings in a cold sweat, usually after staring at Adora's grief-stricken face in her dreams, or sometimes Shadow Weaver's, or even an evil copy of herself. It had gotten so bad that Catra started seeing them while still awake, sometimes looking back at her from poorly lit areas of the station or in the moments she'd lay down with her eyes closed before sleep claimed her. It was distressing, to say the least. Last night had been particularly rough after the position Diallo had put her in.

*More coffee*, was the only thought she could focus on.

Catra threaded through the crowd of officers rushing around the office. The precinct was more crowded than she had ever seen it before on account of the influx of refugees and the spike in unrest on the station. The Beast crisis was starting to spiral out of control, and she had a first-hand view of its consequences. When she finally made it to the break room in the back corner, she was surprised, though not ungrateful, to find it empty. Her mind wandered as she placed her cup under the coffee machine's spout and selected the option with the most caffeine.

Glimmer hadn't checked in, even though she promised she would after reaching her assignment. Catra had tried reaching out, but none of her messages would send. That meant Glimmer was either still in transit, or all inbound and outbound communications had been blocked for her deployment. Catra hoped it was the first reason and not the latter; if a moratorium had been placed on all nonessential communications…well, she preferred not to dwell on it.

Her thoughts started to drift toward Adora instead and Catra grabbed her mug and sped out of the breakroom. That was one topic she refused to think about, especially now. She was so fixated on what was in her head that, when something large rushed at her and her body dashed to the side seemingly all on its own, she didn't realize what had happened until after the yelling already started.

"Hey, get back here!"

It was Trayn's voice, and every head in the precinct snapped up and swiveled to look at her. Catra blinked, and then realized a moment later that they weren't staring *at* her, but staring *past* her. She spun around saw a massive alien, two pairs of handcuffs chaining four beefy wrists together, standing behind her, baying like an animal about to charge.

Her mind rewound the past few seconds. That alien was a suspect on its way to being booked. He—or she? It? Catra couldn't tell—had yanked out of Trayn's grasp, bum rushed forward, and had

almost knocked Catra flat on her ass. If it weren't for the fact she had moved out of the way without even realizing it, she might have become paste on the linoleum.

Four-arms must have realized it was heading further into the precinct rather than out because it had pivoted—faster than anything its size had any right to move—and now stood opposite Catra, locking eyes with her. A spike of alarm shot through her when Four-arms sniffed and pawed at the ground, challenging her. With the exit behind her, Catra was a direct obstacle in its path to freedom.

It charged. Once again without thinking, Catra spun to the side, carrying her inertia into a roundhouse kick that connected with Four-arms' face. She felt the shock from the blow travel up her leg and rattle her pelvis, heard a crack emanate from the suspect's head. Its legs gave out from underneath and it crashed to the floor, unconscious, with a thump that rocked the nearby desks.

A half-dozen officers pushed through the mob surrounding them, yelling. Each held stun batons poised to strike, only to look from the heap muscle in front of them to each other, blinking in surprise.

"Where did that come from?" Trayn asked, looking at Catra. The words came out with breathless surprise. "One second I'm trying to book that guy and the next he's already out on the ground before I even realize he's escaped. Don't tell me you've been holding back during our sparring sessions."

"Uhhh." Catra balked at the expectant look he gave her and he pointed to her side.

"You didn't even spill your coffee."

Catra looked down at the mug in her hand. Trayn was right: she hadn't spilled even a drop.

"Lucky blow," Catra said. "I was keeping my eye on him since he looked like he was about to try something."

Trayn raised an eyebrow then shrugged. “Well, thanks I guess,” he said, seeming to buy it. “He’ll be easier to book like this, at least.”

The commotion died down soon after, and the other officers went back to their average-if-hectic day to day. It should have been concerning that someone had almost escaped the middle of the precinct, but the fact no one seemed to find it in themselves to react to it spoke volumes about the amount of stress and overwork all her fellow officers were under. Had been under for some time now. The refugee problem was starting to break the system.

Catra watched Four-arms get dragged off by five of her colleagues working together and frowned. Even though she said she had kept on eye on him to pacify Trayn, the truth was even now she was barely even aware of her surroundings. Her body had reacted on its own, almost as if being controlled by another person. She looked down at her free hand and flexed her fingers open and closed, as if expecting her body to, again, do something surprising. When nothing happened, she frowned deeper and made her way back toward the main floor.

When had she even clocked in to work that morning? Everything was a blur. She rounded the corner and found Dax leaning against her desk. Keren was still sat nearby as she always had, except she was shooting Catra a surreptitious, worried look while Dax wasn’t paying attention.

“Catra, with me,” Dax said as she approached. Catra’s heart sank. He didn’t sound angry or upset. Just apprehensive, but that didn’t do much to help.

“Hey Dax,” she said after following him to his office and clicking the door shut behind her.

“I just got a message from Taline, and the paperwork to begin transferring you directly underneath her,” he said, taking his seat behind his desk and offering a chair on the other side to her.

Catra stood behind the chair and rested her hands on the back, but didn't take a seat. "I swear I was going to tell you," she said, tail swishing low to the ground. "It hasn't even been a whole day yet. I didn't think you'd have gotten the orders already."

"I'm not mad," Dax said. "Just…wow. Didn't expect it, is all. I'm guessing you turning down all your promotions was more about not wanting to wade too deep into this job?"

"It's complicated," Catra said. "I don't really know what else to say about it other than that. I like this job, Dax. Really like it, and I couldn't imagine doing anything else after working with people like you and Keren and Trayn. It's just…" she shrugged. "This came up."

"You don't have to explain anything to me," he said. "Really, I get it. Working with Taline, and as her Sentinel for crying out loud…I can't imagine anyone willingly passing that up. Congratulations."

He gave her a reassuring smile, but all Catra could focus on was how tired he looked. Did she look just as worn out in his eyes?

Dax propped his elbows up on the table and leaned forward to rest his head in his hands. "I'm a little sad to see you go, honestly. But I feel like that about most everyone that works under me. I'm just glad you have something else to jump to."

Catra's tail stilled. The way he phrased that…something didn't feel right. "What's going on?"

"Our budget is getting slashed," Dax said. "I have to let almost half the precinct go because we don't have the funds any more after this fiscal quarter is up."

"What?" Catra had, at best, only rudimentary budgeting skills. She had learned them as part and parcel of becoming independent after leaving Etheria. But even she knew that cutting half the precinct wasn't just the department shedding some excess weight.

"I just got the news from Moriarty's aides this morning," Dax said. "Apparently cutting costs and funneling as much capital as possible to Imperial R&D is a huge part of his reelection campaign. A lot of it he's going to announce during his rally in a few days."

Catra threw her arm out and gestured with open palms and exaggerated movements at the chaos outside Dax's floor-to-ceiling office windows. "How the hell does Moriarty expect you or any of the other Section Chiefs to control all this with half the staff?"

"I had the same question…"

"We're barely keeping the unrest from spilling over with the influx of refugees as it is. And more will come."

"Catra, I know…"

"I mean, he's not even elected in the first place. It's all just political posturing bullshit. All that matters is that the emperor wants him as governor, he doesn't actually give two shits what the people want from their—"

"Catra!" Dax spoke loud enough to get through to her. Then he lowered his voice and spoke easier. "I know. I tried making all the same points, but the decision is made. Like I said, you're lucky you're getting pulled into something new. Can't imagine you'd have to worry about job security as a Sentinel."

"No, but I *do* have to worry extra hard about 'life security' in exchange." She sighed. "Have you told anyone else yet?"

Dax shook his head. "Just you, since you're going to be on your way out soon. I'm dreading making the announcement, to be honest. It's going to get ugly out there."

"It's going to get even uglier when there are tens of thousands of refugees on the station and only half the security around to help keep the peace, not to mention everyone being out of work. It's

not like there's a surplus of jobs to be had with everything else going on."

"Trust me Catra, I know," Dax said, letting loose a groan and slumping further into his desk. "You're preaching to the choir on this one. It's Moriarty calling the shots, but I can't retain people if I don't have a budget. Apparently, he's making cuts all across the board. It's not just us."

Catra pursed her lips as she remembered pieces of Diallo's conversation with Taline. "I overheard Diallo complaining about having his resources gutted too," she said.

"Diallo?" Dax said, picking his head up off the desk.

"The System Governor," Catra said, trying to jog his memory. "You know, the one we escorted a few days ago with Moriarty?"

"I know who he is, Catra, but how did you know he's"—Dax cut off, like he suddenly remembered why he had called Catra into his office to begin with. "Oh. Are you already getting higher level briefings, or…?"

Catra shook her head. "I was serious when I said I wasn't expecting the paperwork to come in as soon as it had. Taline and I talked just yesterday, and I came in at the tail end of her conversation with Diallo. She hasn't briefed me on anything, yet."

Dax nodded. "Got it. Yeah, that makes sense." Then he frowned in thought. "I'm not surprised he's getting his own resources cut too, though. Moriarty seems to be sacrificing everything to R&D this election cycle. I have no idea what they've cooked up now that requires starving the rest of the empire's infrastructure, but rumor is it's somehow related to that project Moriarty greenlit a while ago. You remember that thing with the Vestamid?"

Nothing immediately came to mind and Catra wracked her brain for something relevant. It wasn't like she was ignorant of the goings on of the empire, but she didn't go out of her way to pay attention to it either. To her, the Vestamid were a bunch of crazy

religious nuts that bothered her on her way home from the precinct, not a major economic force in the known galaxy. That's how little they had affected her day to day.

Finally, she remembered something she had heard playing over the news reels not too long ago: a story about a paradigm-shift in energy storage the Vestamid were pioneering on one of their major mining facilities. It had apparently caused a lot of controversy with how quickly the approvals had been rammed through for it. Catra remembered that Diallo had also alluded to it when they spoke at the Atrium, and she asked if that's what Dax was referring to.

"That's the one," he said, nodding.

"So, something fishy was going on with that after all?" Catra asked, all monotone. "What a surprise."

Dax nodded, and then deflated again. "I just wish there were something I could do, but Moriarty is practically untouchable. Once he's made up his mind, that's it. The only way he'd ever even think about maybe not stripping all of us bare is if the emperor himself came down from the Heartlands and commanded it so."

Diallo's storage drive lay in one of Catra's pockets along with the apeiron crystal Taline had given her, and Catra felt at both. Taline had lamented Moriarty's influence and his politics during their meeting, but had made it clear that she couldn't get involved. That was only moments before she brought Catra on as her Sentinel, and with such enthusiasm that…

*I've worked with Taline long enough now that I know she wouldn't have chosen you if you weren't smart and couldn't read between the lines.* Diallo's words to her came back all on their own. *She's relying on you to look into this, just like I'm relying on you for your help.*

Catra turned and glanced out Dax's office windows at the precinct floor. She watched Keren and Trayn and everyone else she had worked with over the past three years, and imagined how they might fare once Dax had let them go. Under Moriarty's policies, they'd only suffer.

"I'm sure things will work out," she said, distracted. "They always do." It felt odd, her being the one to offer reassuring words this time. "Hey, out of curiosity, how sophisticated is our encryption cracking software?"

Dax arched an eyebrow at her and, for a moment, Catra feared he would press her on the sudden conversation shift. Then he shrugged, as if to visibly say that it wasn't news for Catra to come to him with odd questions.

"It's the best you can get," he said.

"Better than, say, what a System Governor would be able to get their hands on?"

"Better or just as good as," Dax said, voice growing more suspicious. "Depends on which governor. Those in the Heartlands with the Emperor would likely have something cutting edge like ours, but someone running only a few planets out in the middle of nowhere wouldn't have the resources to get ahold of what we have. Why?"

"Just curious," Catra said.

"Well, whatever is drawing your curiosity, if you need to make use of our system, I suggest you do it sooner rather than later. I don't doubt you'd still have access to it when your Sentinel paperwork goes through, but who knows how long we'll be able to maintain it with three quarters of our budget disappearing overnight."

Catra agreed and gave Dax another round of what she hoped were reassuring words. She shut the door behind her on her way out and the windows of his office turned opaque the moment she

did; he probably wanted some privacy while he figured out exactly how to break the news to everyone else.

Then, heart racing and mind burdened with too many cycling thoughts, Catra made her way past the other officers, visitors, and suspects being booked, and toward the record room at the back of the precinct instead of her desk. She palmed the scanner next to the door and pushed inside after it unlocked, then quickly turned and shut herself inside. She took several deep breaths to steady herself, not really sure why she was so worked up to begin with.

The records room was cold. There were no papers or locked file cabinets maintaining physical documents. Instead, the room was filled with rows upon rows of computer servers, each twice as tall as Catra. She stalked along until she came to what she was looking for: an open space in the center of the server configuration where a waist-height donut-shaped access console stood.

Catra vaulted over the console so she stood in the middle of it, preferring to lean on her athletics to get the blood flowing rather than just open the hinged bar-flap door like a normal person would. The 'Mother Brain', as she liked to call it, woke from idle when her feet touched the central platform, and a holographic screen appeared that extended around her in a perfect 360-degree panorama.

*Hello, Catra.*

The greeting appeared in front of her all on its own, and the text caret blinked at her after the last letter in her name; the thing already knew who was interfacing with it. Normally, as a greenhorn cadet still at the first rung of the advancement ladder despite her years on the force, her access was limited. But, since Dax already received the paperwork to get her transfer started, she wondered…

*Query current access credentials*

She typed the question into the interface and the answer popped up nearly as soon as she hit the return key.

*Access level: Black*

Catra was glad the record room had a strict no drink policy, because if she had taken her coffee in with her, she would have spat it out all over the electronics.

How in the hell did she already have top-level security clearance? That alone opened up so many possibilities. Practically every level of the station except private offices, residences, and the very top Executive floor above the Atrium were open to her. So many ideas for mischief flooded her mind, and she pushed them aside to focus.

She pulled out the storage drive from her uniform's pants pocket and laid it on top of a flat section of the console to her right. The console lit up, indicating Mother Brain had detected the hardware and was interfacing with it. An icon blipped into existed high up on the interface, and Catra reached up on tiptoes to tap it with three fingers. She felt a rumble against her fingertips when she did so, the subtle tactile feedback indicating she had successfully 'double-clicked' on the device—whatever that meant. She wasn't good with electronics.

A window opened up and there was nothing inside. Catra frowned, and typed out another query ordering it more explicitly to display the contents of the drive.

*No contents to display.*

"That can't be right," she said to herself, chewing her bottom lip. When she ordered the system to display information on the drive itself, rather than the contents inside it, an overwhelming amount of information cascaded down and across the screen. There was more data than she'd expect to see in even a multi-year detective's case file, and splayed across the entire panorama around her, taking up the entire 360 degrees of real-estate. She

spun slowly as her eyes darted across everything, trying to make as much sense of it as she could.

"How the hell can you have this much information about what's inside the drive, but not be able to show any of it?" she asked, more to herself than anything.

*Drive is encrypted*, she typed into the console. *Decrypt contents and display.*

For a production-level interface, Mother Brain thankfully had state of the art natural language processing. For someone as technologically illiterate as Catra, that meant she didn't have to write programming calls or understand code libraries to use its more advanced functions. Still, giving commands how one talked to another flesh and blood person or alien took considerable processing power, even for a system as complex as this.

Catra watched the circular wheel animation as Mother Brain processed her command.

*No encryption detected,* it said after a while. *All contents are currently displayed.*

The window supposedly holding the contents of the drive still showed nothing, and Catra threw her head back and groaned.

"What the fuck?" Her frustration spiked, but this time, she felt something new come along too. It was like an instinct—one she couldn't fight as her hands came up to the interface once more and started hammering at breakneck speed at the keys.

Her fingers danced, seemingly on their own volition, sending a blazing inferno of tactile lights and bleeps and bloops flying about with every keystroke. Entrapta had sent over a long video one month a while back that walked her through basic electrical jury rigging for the PDA currently still strapped to her forearm, and she had also learned a thing or two about messing with its code to keep everything running smooth, but Catra still hadn't considered herself tech-savvy by any means. What she watched her body do

right in front of her eyes was nothing short of extraordinary. It was like she was communicating with the Mother Brain on a visceral level.

After a rapid succession of what she could only assume were low-level system calls and forced overrides, Catra sent a new command off to the computer and stepped back as if to admire her handiwork, and the computer got to work processing.

A string of errors cascaded down the screen not long after, while she was still trying to figure out what had just happened. The screen itself flickered before shutting down entirely.

*Uh oh.*

Catra stepped forward and started tapping at the keys, trying to get a response from the system. It had frozen, and she started to panic. Had she just crashed the central mainframe for Phoenix Station's entire security force? She didn't even know how to explain what had just happened to her body, let alone what she had done to Mother Brain. If some auditor or forensics team got involved about this, she'd have no idea what to say.

Thankfully, everything seemed to reset after a moment, and the display came back just as responsive as before. Catra breathed a deep sigh of relief before she noticed one small difference: Mother Brain no longer recognized the drive sitting right next to her. No matter what she tried, it absolutely refused to acknowledge the drive's presence. It seemed almost like it had been forced through a traumatic experience and refused to acknowledge its presence again, let alone interface with it.

Brow furrowed and mind racing with even more thoughts than before, Catra slipped the drive back into her pocket and left. She walked straight past Trayn, struggling to guide yet another massive suspect he was trying to book into the precinct. She also walked straight past Keren, still typing away at her computer. She neither looked at nor acknowledged either of them when they

tried to flag her down, because there was only one thing on her mind: Diallo had been right.

She believed Dax when he said their system was cutting edge. Nothing had been able to stump it in the past, despite all the crazy cyphers and encryptions they had fed it over the years. Catra had scoffed when Diallo suggested it wouldn't be able to read the drive, yet here she was, freaking out because that's exactly what had just happened. And if Diallo had been right about the drive, then what else could he be right about?

Was he right about Taline hoping she'd read between the lines and act where she could not? Was he right in saying that Catra was supposed to help him in Taline's stead? She found she had no proof to the contrary, and so, made her decision. She walked straight out of the precinct without looking back, intent on finding Diallo. He and Taline needed a tool to stop to Moriarty from gutting the region and leaving everyone unprotected.

She would be that tool.

Chapter End Notes

> I work with computers and data and code for my day job, and even though I've also taken wild liberties with computer stuff in this chapter, it was still one of the easier and faster chapters I finished.
>
> Next is another Adora chapter, and then we get to Glimmer after. (Glimmer's was challenging to write T.T)
>
> Thank you all so much for reading and commenting as always! More people than usual had something to say last chapter and it was really nice to hear from all of you :)

# Misconceptions on the Dzivia

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora opened her eyes and groaned, again. Everything still hurt and she had no idea how long she had been out for, but this time, when she pushed up into a sitting position, the room didn't spin and she didn't fall off the bed. She swung her legs around and dangled them off the side, taking careful stock of her equilibrium. Trusting her strength maybe a little too much, she pushed off and her legs thankfully held her weight.

She took shaky, excited steps to the far wall, where she grabbed her runestone bracer and PDA and slid them onto each arm. A fresh set of clothes lay folded neatly nearby and she changed into them. They were loose but comfortable—definitely Kal's clothes, but Adora didn't know how to reconcile her impression of the man with the ridiculous design on the front of the shirt.

She Ra's power bubbled under the surface once more, just like it always had. Adora still hadn't figured out what exactly happened back at the castle that had caused her to lose touch, and she briefly considered going all the way to try to bring her out again. She had done it once, kind of, so she should be able to again, right?

Ultimately, she decided against it after attempting to experimentally 'nudge' She Ra from deep inside and not feeling the reaction she had hoped for. There was none of that 'warming, energizing' feeling she had gotten back when she had summoned the sword. Being able to stand on her own two feet, move about, and feel her power once again was heartening enough already; she didn't want to push her luck.

The entirety of the ship around her hummed, and she heard Kal's voice somewhere in the distance. He sounded frustrated.

Feeling whole once more with her runestone and PDA returned to her, Adora stretched as much as her body would let her from its injuries, and left the tiny infirmary. She tottered along the narrow hallway outside, exposed wires and pipes threading through exposures in the bulkhead. Each footstep rang out, since the floor was actually a patterned metal grate that covered even more wires and tubes.

Kal's voice echoed out again. He definitely was mad about something, and Adora followed his words, growing louder the farther she went, until she came to a closed door in a bend in the hallway. She palmed the reader next to the door and was mildly surprised when it actually slid open for her.

Beyond lay the cockpit. Gauges and levers and touch screens embedded in consoles encircled a pilot and co-pilot seat at the front, framing an expansive forward viewscreen. Through it, Adora could see they were hurtling down a multicolored tunnel. The kaleidoscope colors of hyperspace reminded Adora of that 'trip' she took the one time she agreed to a meditation binge with Perfuma, and that reminder was all that was needed for her stomach churn. She looked away and tried not to be sick.

Kal stood in the open space between the pilot chairs and the doorway, hunched over a makeshift workbench built into the side wall. Adora saw the giant sapphire crystal—the "apeiron" he had called it, although she decided right then and there she was never going to call it that—floating and tumbling gently in an antigravity well the circular device underneath it was emitting. That device was hooked into another machine, displaying flashing diagnostics and data streams to a holographic display spanning floor to ceiling between them.

"You're awake," he said, his voice tight with irritation. "How do you feel?"

"Fine I guess," Adora said, watching him as he turned to face her. Instead of giving her his full attention, he focused on the holographic display and swiped impatiently at the information

displaying between them. Adora stood there and waited for him to say something else. The longer he went without doing so, the more idiotic she felt, until at last she opened her mouth to say something and he cut her off.

"Was there something you—fucking hell, what is that supposed to mean?" He pinched the screen and zoomed into what looked like a birds-nest mass of clustered data points and lines. A significant portion of the center was completely devoid of any data, leaving what amounted to a giant hole in the web. "Where did all of this go? This is such a mess."

Adora couldn't tell if he was talking to her or to himself. When she didn't answer and he didn't repeat the question, she said, "I'm hungry." Her stomach growled, as if her body conspired to drive her point home without her consent, and she tried to stifle the sound with her arms, embarrassed.

Kal seemed to forget about her entirely. He turned back to the workbench and, with more aggressive and irritated movements than before, tweaked more dials and knobs on the panel overhead, muttering dark words to himself.

"You were the one that said let's be civil to one another," Adora said, growing impatient when her stomach complained a second time. "Last I checked, feeding someone in your care is part of being civil."

Kal started smacking the side of the overhead panel, repeatedly calling it a "piece of shit." Adora was about ready to strangle him.

"Fine!" She threw up her arms. "I'll find the food myself. Just don't come complaining to me if I push a wrong button and the entire ship depressurizes or something." With that, she stomped off, not caring to even look back to see if Kal finally paid any attention.

Her irritation only grew as wandered back down the hallway she came and she opened door after door on her way. She stuck her

head into each room, only to come away disappointed; nothing she saw even remotely resembled a kitchen or dining area.

*Food means a table, right?* She thought, as she opened another room and found it completely empty. All of the spacefaring vessels she had toured back on Etheria, starting with Mara's desolate ship out in the Crimson Wastes and ending with the Enclave cruisers and carriers orbiting the planet, had a dining area. Even the tiny corvettes she saw had at least a cupboard for the tandem crew to store nonperishables and a small nook to sit and eat at.

Finally, she came across a room with a modest table anchored in the center. A bench sat on either of the long ends, and the cupboards and countertops lining the far wall seemed to call out to her with the implicit promise of food. Her stomach complained again, and she hurried inside to look for something—*anything at all*—to eat. Kal said they had been in hyperspace for at least three days, so that meant it had been at least that long since she last ate something.

She threw open the first cupboard above the countertop she saw, and yanked out a dull grey box made of thick plastic. It was heavier than she anticipated. As soon as she got most of it out, she lost control and it fell out of the cupboard, smacking into the countertop with a loud noise and dumping several dozen brown pouches onto the floor.

Adora yelped and stood stock still as her heart pounded in her chest. Her eyes darted to the door she came through. She listened for the inevitable sound of Kal storming down the hall, angry at her for making a mess. Then, almost as if remembering how to breath again, she caught how stupid that sentiment was. Being on a strange ship with someone she barely knew, let alone trusted, must have awoken something primal in her; that part of her that wanted to never make a mistake, never leave a bad first impression, and never break something out of fear of being reprimanded. Adora frowned, shook away what Shadow Weaver had conditioned into her as a child, and reached down to pick up one of the pouches that had dumped out onto the floor.

“Acheron stuffed chicken,” she said, reading the script on the pouch out loud. She wasn’t sure if she was reading an alien language with She Ra’s help (she hoped that was the case) or if the pouches were actually labeled in standard Etherian (less likely). She furrowed her brow and turned the pouch over; there were no other labels. She shrugged, ripped open the top of the package, and scooped out a handful of the brownish-white powder from inside.

“Seems fine,” she said, bringing her face closer and inspecting the powder with careful eyes. She gave a tentative sniff and, sensing nothing was amiss, licked some of it off her hands.

It tasted like sand.

Adora spat, hacking and coughing after accidentally dropping the pouch and sending the “chicken-sand” concoction scattering and spreading all across the floor.

“How can anyone eat that?” Adora said after a moment, sputtering.

The taste lingered, and she scraped at her tongue out of desperation to get it to leave. When she could do no more, she eventually turned her attention to the other cupboards. Panic ensued with the thought that all the other cupboards were also filled with the same stuff. That couldn’t be all the food on this ship, could it? That stuff was inedible. What was she going to do?

Adora was spiraling with no way out when the far door slid open and Kal walked through, holding the crystal suspended in its antigravity well in one hand, and a small holo-projector puck in the other.

“What are you doing?” he asked, his eyes drifting from Adora, still covered in dust, to the pouches and powder and open case dumped out on the floor.

“I don’t know!” Adora said, suddenly afraid of getting a Shadow Weaver-level scolding for making a mess. “I told you something

like this might happen. I have no idea where anything is on this ship, and *why* does all your food look and taste like sand?"

"That's because you haven't made any of it yet." He looked like he was trying to decide between making fun of her, helping, or turning around and walking right back out the way he came. "Did you seriously just eat the raw powder?"

"I. Don't. Know. What. Any. Of. This. Stuff. Is." Adora scooped up armfuls of still-sealed pouches and dumped them back into the case with every punctuated word. She stopped and glared at Kal when she heard him laugh. He had moved further into the room to stand next to the table, placing the crystal and the puck atop it. He was smiling, and that seemed to erase ten years from his face. He still looked older than her, but no longer seemed within the same age range as Shadow Weaver or Micah.

"We can't both be this neurotic at the same time," he said, shaking his head. "We'll end up at each other's throats before we get to Eden. I'll tell you what—let's trade. I'll make the food, and you come take a look at this. Maybe you'll be able to figure something out that I haven't been able to yet.

"Look, I'm going to be honest because, again, you mentioned the 'being civil' thing and I'm trying since, you know, you didn't let me fall to my death…but I have no idea what that is or what I'm supposed to do that you haven't already tried."

"Come here and just touch the crystal," Kal said, leaning down and pulling out a pouch from the case still open on the floor. "You're a magical being. Even if your connection to your magic is spotty, you should be able to pick up something from the apeiron if you reach. Would probably do better than me, actually."

Adora scowled but decided to do as he asked. "You know, no one is supposed to know about me and She Ra," she said, heading for the table.

“You’re joking, right? Everyone knows that you’re She Ra, even the random townspeople outside the kingdoms. If that was supposed to be a secret then it’s a shit secret.”

“No, I meant the fact I’ve been having a bit of trouble getting in touch with her.”

Kal snorted. “’A bit of trouble’ is putting it lightly.” Adora almost said something back, then he turned to her and held up a pouch in either hand. “You want the chicken or lasagna?”

Adora tilted her head. “What’s a luh-zahn-yuh?”

“Chicken it is, then.” He tossed one of the pouches back into the crate. Adora watched him grab a bowl from one of the cabinets under the countertop, dump the contents of the pouch inside and swirl some water from the far sink into the mix.

“Soooo,” she said, staring at the puck. She tapped it and a holographic screen popped up, displaying the web of data points and lines Kal had been staring at back in the cockpit. “What’s a member of the Enclave doing hiding from their own people for three years on Etheria? You not get assigned to the planet and decide to sneak onsite anyways?”

“I’m not with the Enclave,” he said.

“You’re not?” Adora said, narrowing her eyes at him through the holographics. “But you can do magic.”

“And you think everyone who can do magic is automatically a member of the Enclave?”

“Well, what else would you be?” Adora asked, watching him shove the bowl of water and powder inside a machine, close the door, and press a few buttons. It powered on and started to hum. “It’s not like you’re part of the Daiamid.”

“Three years on that planet and I forget all you Etherians are essentially hermits,” he said. “Just because I can do magic doesn’t

mean I'm a member of the Enclave."

"Fine, so you're freely admitting to being a rogue mage then?"

Kal sighed. He was in the middle of preparing a second pouch. "By the very strict and narrow definition you have no doubt been fed, yes. I am a rogue mage."

"Are rogue mages supposed to be trained enough to wield magic as well as you though? I was under the impression someone would need a whole team of assistants to do what you did back at the castle." Adora was doing her best to bluff. Salas had needed a team, and so did many of the other Enclave mentors teaching the princesses. Aside from the princesses, who were supposed to be a special case entirely, only Taline had been able to single-handedly do extraordinary feats the one time she had seen her in action. It wasn't supposed to be common, the level of magic Adora had witnessed atop her castle.

"I don't see how this line of questioning is going to help either of us get along better," he said. "Have you figured anything out about the aperion?" He glanced over in her direction in the middle of stirring the second bowl with a wooden spoon. "You haven't even touched it yet, have you?"

Adora gave him a face, then grudgingly reached into the antigravity well to pull the crystal tumbling inside out. As soon as it came free from the threshold, Adora felt the full weight of the thing in her hand and she almost dropped it.

It was heavy.

She turned the thing in her hands, watching how the light glinted off the thousands of facets across the surface, making intricate shapes that seemed like they could easily mesmerize anyone who dared look at it for too long. It was much like the hyperspace tunnel she saw earlier, but strangely more entrancing, if that were possible. All that majesty and wonder, condensed into something so small in the palm of her hand

Then she felt something inside, much like how she often felt She Ra slumbering under the surface when she went reaching. So she reached again, except this time into the crystal. There was that strange sensation again, almost like something was slumbering deep inside. It was fainter, much fainter then even her lowest, most out of touch moment trying to reach out to She Ra, but it was undoubtedly there.

She was about to say as much to Kal when her eyes caught on the holographic web between them first. She looked at this time—really looked—and it finally clicked into place just what exactly that thing was. She had seen this type of data stream before, time and time again when Entrapta had left her screens open—the patterns back then had just been much less complicated.

"This AI," she said, pointing to the screen. "The one with the giant holes missing from it…is this that girl from the castle that helped you turn on Light Hope?"

Kal turned to her with such excitement that all trace of the haggard, sleep-deprived grouch of a person she had seen slinking around Etheria and had fought with in the Crystal Castle disappeared. "Yes," he said. "You recognize it? Don't tell me you got something from the apeiron that showed you what happened to her?"

Adora shook her head. "I saw Entrapta poring over fragments of Light Hope's code for hours on end, you'd think I'd recognize AI neural networks after they're in front of my face for long enough." She gestured to the screen once more when the excitement drained from Kal's face. "Something this complex I fully believe can hack into Light Hope's systems and wake her up. What I don't understand is how you, a rogue mage hiding from the Enclave, has it. Our best scientists, Entrapta included, haven't cracked open Light Hope yet. If you have the expertise to make something like this, why keep it hidden from the Enclave in the first place? Why not help them?"

“She’s not an ‘it’, her name is Pip,” Kal said. “And I didn’t make her. Not smart enough for that.”

“Then who gave you this…Pip?”

“She was a gift.”

“From who?”

Kal narrowed his eyes at her. “Not anyone that you would know, and not anyone that could help us now. Now, have you figured out anything from the apeiron or not? Stop changing the subject. I make food, you tell me what you feel from it. Let’s start there.”

Adora hefted the crystal in both her hands. She hadn’t figured out anything useful about it, but she Kal had looked so hopeful thinking she might have gleaned information from it he couldn’t. Because of her connection to She Ra? Like how she could read alien languages without ever having studied it before? She wanted to know more about the crystal too, since it was clear he was keeping thing from her. Judging by how he reacted when she asked about Pip, though, she didn’t think she’d get a straight answer if she just asked.

Two could play the subterfuge game, however.

“Yes, I’ve actually gotten a lot from it while we’ve been talking,” she said. “But I want some of my questions answered.” Already her hands felt slick with sweat, and she feared he’d catch onto her immediately just from the way her hands and her voice trembled in anticipation.

Kal, however, hadn’t seemed to notice. He gave her a sideways glance, as if to say “go on?”

“What is this thing?” she asked, hefting it in her hands again.

“I’ve already told you—it’s an apeiron. It holds information, memories, things. If it holds what I hope it does, then we’ve got the Beast dead to rights. We won’t need She Ra to defeat it.”

“It’s a crystal, I’m not calling it…whatever you called it.” Adora huffed. “And let me guess, you aren’t going to tell me what you hope is inside?”

“No use getting your hopes up with speculation. I’d rather say one way or the other once I know for certain what’s in there.” He gestured to the screen. “Pip was supposed to analyze it, but half her code got corrupted when she started scanning into it, as you can see. I have no idea how to fix her.”

“This isn’t doing very much for me when it comes to building trust between us, you know,” Adora said, grumbling more to herself than anything.

“I am literally about to feed you right now,” Kal said. “Are you usually this difficult with people trying to do you a favor?”

“Who was it you were talking to earlier?” Adora asked. She couldn’t lose control of the conversation. She had to press him and keep him off balance, just like she did back at the castle. “I heard you talking to someone on the other side of the door when I first woke up.”

“You mean right before you fell and ate shit?”

“Who were you talking to?” she asked again, choosing to ignore the swipe.

“My contact on Etheria,” he said. “They helped me get around.”

“They’re the one who got you past all the security?” Adora asked. “Salas mentioned there was a mole. This is the same person who gave you fake credentials and everything?”

“That’s the person, yep,” Kal said, nodding.

“So, who are they? Why are you being so defensive about this?”

Kal laughed outright in her face, and even Adora had to admit she felt a little foolish with that last question. They clearly weren’t

allies, so why was she acting surprised about his dishonesty?

"Ok," Kal said, after he had calmed down. "First of all, I'm not about to out one of my allies just because you asked nicely. And second of all, even if I did tell you, what the hell are you going to do about it? You're stuck on this ship with me. You have no way to communicate with anyone on Etheria, and even if you did, the entire planet is locked down tighter than Prime's prison planet on Theranis IV—no one can send transmissions or data to them." Despite the nature of his words, Kal didn't sound angry, just amused. As if he were trying to explain a drunk friend's irrational behavior to them after they had sobered.

"They're going to look for me," Adora said. "As soon as they realize I'm missing they're going to come looking for me."

"No one is going to come looking for you," he said. "At least, not the way you expect them to. Like I said before, it's been days since you've been gone. If they were able to catch us in the first place, they would have done so already. No one is going to start a galaxy-wide manhunt for you.

"And what makes you so sure of that?"

"The planet portals around the galaxy every year just to keep people from finding its location on accident, Adora. You think they're going to file a missing person report for you? For all intents and purposes, Etheria doesn't exist. The entire planet itself is a black-site."

"It's funny," Adora said, giving a rueful laugh. "I've only ever heard that term used in only one context. Horde Empire." That was a lie, of course. She had used the term herself when she spoke to Salas, but Kal had derailed her completely, and she wasn't handling it well.

"This should be good," Kal said. The machine on the countertop with her food beeped, and he turned his back to her to get it. The two bowls he pulled out steamed, inundating the room in

fragrances that would have made Adora's mouth water were she not already hell-bent on having her say.

"You know what I think really is going on?" Adora pushed the holographic projector to the side to get an unobstructed view of him. Catra had always told her, both when they were growing up and when they were fighting on opposite sides, that Adora was too trusting a person. That it would her into trouble. Well, Adora liked to think she had finally grown out of that.

"Tell me," Kal said. "I'm dying to know."

"I think your 'mole' on Etheria isn't really on Etheria to begin with," she said. "I think it's Horde Prime, and I think he's using you to sneak around the planet, gather information for him, and sabotage our work. You even said yourself—there's no way for us to contact anyone on the planet anymore, so why were you be able to talk to your contact earlier if they were still there?

"Horde Prime obviously hated the fact he agreed to leave so easily after what we did in his throne room. I think he sent you to spy, and that's exactly what you were doing there for the past three years. Why else would you be in all the kingdoms? All those shift changes and sneaking around? That was for you to gather information, wasn't it?"

"Interesting theory," Kal said, preparing a third pouch of food in another bowl. "Let's say you're right and I'm a spy for the emperor. How would you explain what happened in the Crystal Castle? The whole empire is relying on the Enclave and your people to get Light Hope and the weapon working. But I—someone spying for that same empire—get in carrying an AI advanced enough to solve all the problems Entrapta and the Enclave have had with Light Hope in a just a few minutes. I don't think I would be doing a very good job 'sabotaging' anything if that were the case, don't you think?"

"I haven't figured out how that part fits in yet," Adora said. "But it makes a lot more sense to me that the Empire is capable of far

more than a vassal state is. If you can turn Light Hope on as easily as you did, then you probably could sabotage Entrapta's work just as easily without anyone knowing. That's what happened at those ruined dig sites, isn't it? It took you minutes to get in and get those keys, and no one after you had any idea you were in there because they didn't find any traces of tampering."

"I mean, you aren't wrong," Kal said. "I could have done a lot more than what I did without anyone knowing. But why would Horde Prime want to sabotage anything at all if his survival is just as dependent on Etheria as anyone else's?"

"I don't know yet," Adora said. He had poked enough gaping holes in her thought process to make her pause, but something just didn't feel right about him and she wasn't about to cave because she didn't have all the information. "I *know* you're a spy, I just can't prove it. My guess is whatever this thing is"—she gestured to the crystal—"it's important enough for you to change your mission. No more spying and sabotaging, you've found something valuable and worthwhile no one else knew about. I'm guessing we're on our way to meet up with Prime right now so you can hand it over to him, and you're trying to get me to tell you more about it so you have impressive things to say to your boss."

"Anything else?" Kal asked as he loaded up a platter with the three separate bowls he had been working on.

"That about sums it up," she said, crossing her arms with a stony expression. She couldn't tell what he was thinking, and refused to let the uncertainty she felt show on her face. Admittedly, Adora had reached pretty far at the end there, but she must have taken a page out of Catra's book because she refused to reconsider her own stance. "What are you planning on getting for all this information? Were you going to ask for a System Governorship? Maybe ask to be appointed a Regional Administrator instead? Prime rewards people who perform for him, I'm sure."

"Let me give you some advice," Kal said, stalking over and placing the tray of food off to the side of the table. Adora refused to look

at it, despite the smells wafting to her and despite her stomach begging her to just eat already. "Never make life or death decisions off of your hunches. Everything you just said was so wrong, I'd laugh in your face if it weren't so insulting.

"First, I wasn't moving around the kingdoms trying to spy for Horde Prime. When you saw me at the Induction Ceremony? I didn't use that as ruse to get into Bright Moon. Regardless of my thoughts on the Enclave, on Taline, and on her Sentinels, I've made the trip to Narre and Miri's graves every year to pay my respects. To have you even think otherwise is insulting to the people who saved your friend from certain death at Horde Prime's hands."

Adora flinched. She wasn't expecting to hear the kind of emotion coming through in his voice, wasn't expecting to see the anger in his eyes as he held her gaze. She had indeed struck a nerve after all, but it wasn't panning out how she had hoped.

"Second," Kal said. "I travelled across the kingdoms for three years of my life specifically to get the keys needed to retrieve this"—he pointed to the crystal—"from your castle. I didn't trick anyone to get in. If I was playing the part of a guard, I guarded. That day you first recognized me? I was assigned to help deliver Entrapta's things, and deliver her things I did. That's it. I didn't take those assignments because I needed a cover to get into the ruins—I could have done that anyways, any time I wanted. I took those assignments because you guys needed help, and I tried to do what I could while I was in the area."

Adora shrank into herself with every word he spoke. Despite the fact he wasn't yelling, she felt just as bad, maybe even worse, than when Shadow Weaver chewed her out when she was younger. Every word was telling her how disappointed he was in her without ever outright saying it, and the fact she felt affected by that was even more aggravating. She hoped he didn't have a third topic to speak toward.

"And third—"

*Oh no, there was a third*.

"—I am not a Horde spy. Prime is too self-centered and proud to use something like spies in that way. After what happened last time, I doubt he'd try it again."

"Wait," Adora said, trying to cut in and shift the conversation before she imploded from feeling bad. "What did Prime do before with—"

"That crystal, apeiron, thing…whatever you want to call it," Kal said, ignoring the fact she was trying to get a word in. "It's exactly what I said earlier. If we can fix Pip and get her to read it, and if it contains what I hope it does, then you won't have to worry about whether or not you can get in touch with She Ra again to save the universe. It will already have been taken care of."

Kal took a step around the table and closer to her, leaned down to put his face closer to hers, and Adora actually shrank away from him. He met her eyes didn't blink or flinch as he spoke, his next words each coming out in a measured, focused, intense way, like he was speaking to an unruly child and ensuring they understood him.

"Who gifted me Pip, who my contact on Etheria is, what my hopes are for what's inside the apeiron? I'd only tell those things to someone I trust, and regardless of how you tried to go about it, trust isn't something I give to people because they asked for it. Accusing someone of being a spy is far from 'being civil.' You're back on your feet and have the strength to move around, but I want to leave you on the ship when we arrived more than ever right now."

He grabbed the crystal from Adora's hands, turned off the holographic display full of Pip's code and grabbed that too. His hands shook as he reached for each, then he turned and headed for the exit. "Enjoy your meal," he said, just before the door shut behind him.

Adora turned her attention to the platter and three bowls of food Kal had brought her. She almost couldn't believe her eyes. In one bowl sat an entire roast chicken, steam rising from its crispy skin. Another bowl held some sort of rice in a creamy broth. The third bowl overflowed with vegetables. All of it looked delicious, and when Adora took her first bite, an uncomfortable mix of emotions flooded her.

Kal's actions so far contradicted everything she had believed about him. He fought her and stole from her, but had given her the option to walk away first, and then saved her life when she didn't. Then he asked for her help, and fed her when all she gave in return were accusations. Accusations she didn't even feel fully confident in to begin with. Sure, he was definitely hiding things and she most assuredly didn't trust him, but…but what, exactly?

In the midst of all of this, her mind wandered to Catra. She thought of how her old friend had acted to save her life and the lives of everyone aboard Horde Prime's citadel in the months leading up to their separation. She thought of their last conversation.

"So much for being too trusting," she said to herself at some point midway through the meal. "Three years, millions of light years away, and you're still getting my head all sorts of mixed up, aren't you?"

Chapter End Notes

> Adora, most of the time: earnest soldier, fearsome warrior goddess in waiting, steadfast paragon of righteousness with a tragic, fallible, rigid sense of duty.
>
> Adora, after eating sand: "There is no food at all and I am going to /starve/ to death on this ship!" *proceeds to metaphorically bite the hand that is literally feeding her.
>
> You, the audience: Where the heck is the author going with this?

Me, the author: Hehe, I told them there would be light moments in part 3.

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The food scene pays homage to a very similar scene in "The Fifth Element," where Milla Jovovich's character pulls an entire roast chicken out of a microwave after shaking what looks like just a bottle of herbs onto a plate lmao. I thought about having Adora echo her "chicken good" line at the end too, but decided I wanted to close the scene out a little more somber, dwelling on Catra lol.

# Ground Zero

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The enormous spires and steeples of Scavria's capital city of Tir loomed in the distance.

Plumes of smoke rose from the skyline, which stood proud in front of the expansive, snow-capped mountain range—also called Tir—from which the city derived its name. A great, rocky steppe, littered with pockets of tall grass and piles of stones, spanned the twenty-mile distance between the city and the evacuation compound Glimmer was stationed at. The staging area before her was packed. A small army of junior soldiers worked as gently as possible to corral the throng of refugees there, guiding them into roughly twenty ordered lines that fed into the processing stations lining the fenced-off entrance to the compound proper.

A shiver and a chill shot down Glimmer's spine, and she wasn't sure from where it had come—either from seeing the sheer number of living bodies she and the team still had to process after days already working nonstop, or from the actual, physical chill of the cold morning air that whistled over the mountains and in from the city. It was probably both, if she were honest; this cohort of people were even larger than the first that came three days ago, and the wind sounded vaguely like a thousand voices moaning low in agony all at once as it blew. None of this was pleasant.

Every evacuation she had been part of before had been similar: them setting up on the outskirts of a once thriving community that had been reduced to essentially a mass grave, scrambling to process in the fraction of the population that survived the initial Beast wave and shove them into titanic megaliths—ships ready to take off at a moment's notice should the effort to retake whatever city had been hit fell through. A strange coldness had always permeated the air, smelling vaguely of death and despair. One

could almost sense the life and color and potential for growth that had once been there, all but drained dry.

Maybe this time, it was the fact Tir was once a population of several hundred million before disaster struck, or maybe it was because this infection had started so close to the mid-rim, but for some reason, the feeling of destruction and hopelessness pervaded far deeper than any of her previous assignments. This, despite the fact they actually stood a decent chance at saving the city this time, unlike others.

Glimmer finished processing in a family, gestured for them to continue past her station to the gates beyond, and a new pair—a young man and woman, both Scavrian like the rest—shuffled up to her. They looked up and over her roofed stall, toward the megaliths oriented behind her in the compound, beyond the fencing.

"Hi there," she to them, putting on the most inviting smile she could muster. It wasn't much, considering she was halfway through a double shift without much sleep the previous night.

They didn't respond, both still staring beyond her, wide-eyed and a little overwhelmed. Glimmer had seen this reaction more than once; on top of all the chaos these people were going through trying to evacuate in the middle of a Beast incursion, the megaliths themselves were a colossal sight to behold. Each were multiple stories in height, taller than even some skyscrapers over in their capital city, and as spacious as several stadiums put together. Usually there was only one, maybe two. The fact there were six of them this time, arranged in a circular pattern around a hastily erected courtyard in the compound, likely only made things feel more dire. It certainly did for Glimmer.

She cleared her throat, finally garnering their attention. "If you'll please provide some kind of identifying information, I'll get you through the intake as quickly as possible so you can get settled aboard a ship."

The male, likely in his late teens or early twenties, hardened his expression. “We don’t have any documents,” he said. “We evacuated so quickly there wasn’t any time to grab our belongings. All we have are the clothes on our backs.”

“That’s not a problem,” Glimmer said, keeping her tone light. Tir in particular had been a rushed operation, since the task force believed they could save the city if they moved fast enough; people coming through without even a spare change of clothes let alone their official documents were the rule rather than the exception. She pulled out a portable palm scanner from her station’s equipment drawer and held it over the countertop for them. “We’ll can do a basic biometric read and that should be more than sufficient for intake.”

His expression hardened further, and he traded a quick glance with the girl at his side. Except for their vaguely elfin features, and for a pair of second eyelids that displayed only under extreme stress or illness, the Scavrians didn’t look all that different from Etherians, or any other humanoid races of the empire for that matter. That only made it easier for Glimmer to realize they were obviously terrified about something above and beyond just evacuating. That in and of itself wouldn’t have been an issue—she had seen a lot of second eyelids since landing planet-side—but this felt different. They looked they were afraid of *her* more than anything else.

“It’s a routine scan,” she said. “It’s really about accounting for missing persons instead of anything else. If the worst happens and we have to evacuate, any of your loved ones you might have gotten separated from can search the intake logs and see which megalith you’re stationed on. And even if we don’t have to take off, many people still rely on the manifest to make sure whoever they’re looking for is safe.” She left out the part about how anyone not on the official intake list were marked officially dead or missing after a time.

“Please don’t split us up, ma’am,” said the girl. She couldn’t be older than fourteen.

Glimmer was taken aback, and was about to ask why that'd even be an issue when a high-pitched screech roared overhead.

She looked up and caught sight of a large personnel transport on approach. By habit, she glanced down at her PDA and checked the air-traffic logs she had bookmarked. That was a transport, not a warbird, so it definitely wasn't Kyle flying. Him and Lonnie and Rogelio were likely still clearing out the Beast from one of the last infected sectors of the city. But still, she had to check, and she didn't let it go until she confirmed that vessel was just carrying a fresh batch of refugees in from Tir.

Her relief was palpable. Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio had found out Glimmer had rejected her command before they even touched down on Scavria's surface. Glimmer had no idea who leaked the decision to them before she could tell them personally, but she had a bulleted list of things she'd do to that person if she ever found out who they were. Lonnie's reaction was the only one she had seen, and she had been livid. So livid, in fact, Glimmer was worried about running into them again, afraid of seeing the same anger and disappointment on Kyle and Rogelio's faces too. Weren't reunions supposed to be happy?

The entire operation had been placed on a communications lockdown too, meaning Glimmer could neither check in with Catra or Taline, nor could she vent to them about what had happened. She was stuck out here alone, and had never felt lonelier.

"Is everything okay here?" said a voice off to the side.

An Imperial soldier, clad in the white munitions armor of the enlisted forces, had wandered over from his nearby post. He likely had seen Glimmer taking much longer than usual with the two Scavrians in front of her and had come to investigate.

"Everything is fine," Glimmer said, careful to keep her tone neutral. "There's just so many we need to process, bottlenecks with the system are bound to happen. Return to your post, please."

The soldier nodded and ambled off. The two refugees watched him with barely concealed panic. Glimmer was happy she had successfully monopolized the soldier's attention; if he saw how they looked at him, or if she were a little too quick to answer him, he might have sensed something going on and asked more questions. Glimmer studied them, and when they realized her attention was back on them, they balked and shuffled their feet under her gaze.

"We can pay you," the older one said. "We have some money. How much to let us through without scanning us?"

Glimmer laughed. She had gotten that question more times than she cared to remember, but this was the first time it had come from someone who looked genuinely harmless. Everyone else seemed like they belonged on some unsavory blacklist.

"Look," she said, leaning in and lowering her voice so no one else could hear. "We're sworn to take in anybody as long as they aren't terrorists or escaped convicts. The prisons have their own way of evacuating inmates. I don't care who you are, but I do have to know you aren't a danger to the rescue effort or other refugees." She held out the bio scanner to them. "I'll do only a basic outstanding arrest warrant check," she said. "If you're caught up on some petty theft charges or something then I won't make a fuss about it, but you can't get in until I issue you a certificate. If I promise not to dig further than the major police reports, will you agree to be scanned?"

The two exchanged looks once again, blinking their second eyelids at each other in rapid succession. Glimmer had a feeling a there was far more conversation exchanging between them than she was privy to. Finally, the male turned to her and gave a curt nod before extending a four-fingered hand and placing it on the scanner.

The readings came back empty, and they looked to each other in confusion when she told them so.

“I don’t know what it is that you both are so afraid of, but you are clean,” she said as she worked at the terminal for a moment. When she pressed a button on the console inside her booth, two plastic cards dispensed from a machine behind her and dropped into a tin catch with a clang.

“These are your boarding passes,” she said, handing them over. “They’re not new identities—not really, but they’ll get you around the megalith without anyone asking you too many questions. You can transfer whatever money you were going to bribe me with onto it and use it like a debit card for purchases.”

They took the cards from her and stared wide-eyed at them in their hands. “Are you certain you haven’t saved our information anywhere?” the girl asked, more skeptical now than scared.

Glimmer sighed. “Look around you,” she said, careful to not seem exasperated. “We’re optimistic about saving the city, but we still have thousands of your fellow citizens to process into the compound just in case the ships need to take off. What I did would cost me my job if anyone found out about it, but my priority is to help as many people as I can. If you aren’t on the list of the empire’s most wanted or aren’t an escaped serial killer, then it doesn’t really matter to me who you are or who you may have pissed off.” She shrugged. “All of us are the same in front of the Beast. We’re food. I’m not going to get any of you in trouble, since you don’t even show up on the warrant scans. I didn’t even check your names. Just don’t mention that I did this to anyone, okay?”

They nodded their heads, looking equal parts relieved and grateful. Glimmer made a ‘get going’ gesture with her head and they shuffled past to the compound beyond. One of the guards at the gate scanned their new ID cards and ushered them through. Another set of refugees had already approached her station, but Glimmer didn’t turn her attention to them until those two were fully through.

Several hours later and the work still hadn't let up. The train of people she processed was endless, and soon, even the words of comfort she spoke to those walking scared past her station—the one part of the job she actually enjoyed—grew stale and meaningless in her mouth. She wasn't even sure those words were coherent anymore, although the Scavrians on the receiving end seemed to relax and grow hopeful at hearing them.

That pair from earlier hadn't been far from her mind as she worked, and every opportunity she could, Glimmer checked her PDA for Kyle's flight log as well; even though everyone was no doubt still furious with her for turning them down, now that she knew they were on this deployment with her, she couldn't stop checking in on them—checking that they were safe.

Scavria's orange star flew high in the sky. It was almost lunchtime, and she was excited to go on break. Everything else notwithstanding, she had been thinking hard about how she might reconnect with Bow after he didn't send her a message with her monthly download from Etheria, and she thought she might have finally figured out something. Her lunch break would be the perfect time to draft it up, and from there, once she got it queued for Salas, it was only a matter of waiting for the communication lines to open up for that message to go through.

Unfortunately, she made the mistake of looking over at the crowds again before clocking out. They seemed to have doubled since the morning, and she slumped against the back wall of her station, all excitement having fled from her. Then she noticed something: a young boy, no older than six, eyes wide in panic and cheeks streaked with tears, darting in and out of the refugees lined up before them. She watched him shuffle forward with the group he had fallen in with, then retreat further back into the crowd once he got to the front. He'd then poke around there for a while until inevitably finding his way into a different line, beginning the process all over again.

*Poor boy must be lost*, she thought. She left her station before another refugee group could monopolize her and marched out

toward him.

“C-can you help me find my p-p-parents?” the boy asked her between hiccups and sobs the moment she crouched down in front of him.

“I sure can,” Glimmer said. “What’s your name, big man?”

“Newton,” he said, rubbing his eyes. “Newton Durange.”

Glimmer nodded, offering her hand to him and guiding him past all the lines back to her booth, asking him questions along the way about why he had been wandering around alone.

He had gotten separated from his family, it turned out, when they were evacuated from deep inside the city. Newt—the nickname he asked her to call him by because “all my friends call me Newt”—couldn’t tell her much else. But, judging by how shaken up he sounded, Glimmer got the impression he was evacuated directly by one of the Battlemage and Vanguard combo squads combing the city streets. That was the only way she could make sense of how frantic his rendition of events seemed; he likely had been pulled directly from an active hotspot, rather than somewhere further away from an epicenter. The fact his parents still hadn’t turned up didn’t bode well either.

She propped Newt up on the desk in her booth, ignoring the way the other Imperial soldiers and even some of the refugees looked at her for cutting him to the front. His feet swung free, high off the ground, as she turned around to access the computer. Nothing popped up on when she put his last name through the system.

“Looks like your parents haven’t been put in the system yet either,” she said to him with a frown.

“What does that mean?” He had calmed considerably and no longer cried, likely because someone was finally paying attention to him.

"It just means that you got here before they did," she said, purposefully leaving out the fact there was a good chance they might just never show up.

"Will they get here soon?" he asked, another hiccup trailing after his last word.

"I'm sure they will." She smiled. "Tell you what, I'm about to get off for lunch. Why don't we go get something to eat? And then I'll take you somewhere you can meet a lot of new friends until your parents come."

Newt nodded and Glimmer quickly processed him through. She grabbed his card when the machine spit it out and offered her hand to him again after he hopped off the desk. Someone took over her stall the moment she vacated it, and together, they walked through the security checkpoint, past the gates, and toward the compound in the distance.

The closer they got to the main square and the six surrounding megaliths, the more uneasy Glimmer felt. Newt toddled along next to her—two steps for every one of hers—seemingly oblivious to whatever was getting her hackles up. When they finally reached the center pavilion, Glimmer realized what was happening: a larger than expected mob of people were crowded there among the popup shops, field hospital, and administration offices, kicking up a scene with complaints and shouts and jeers. Glimmer found an off-duty clerk she had worked with previously and approached her with Newt in tow.

"What's going on?" she asked the woman.

"Typical unrest," she said, shrugging her shoulders. "Nothing out of the ordinary, except there's more people here than ever before."

It was true. With six megaliths to evacuate people and over ninety ships in orbit for Tir alone, not to mention the resources stationed at other parts of Scavria, this was by far the most infrastructure

that had been deployed to one world since the first war—the most refugees they'd have to handle at once, too.

"It looks like the guards are having a hard time keeping things from spilling out of control this time," Glimmer said.

"Doesn't help that ninety-percent of the muscle is out in the city pushing back the infection," the clerk said, looking over the crowd. She gave Glimmer a pointed look. "Ninety-nine percent, actually. You're the only 'muscle' over here instead of out fighting. Who's the kid?"

Glimmer grimaced but decided not to make a big deal about the comment. She wasn't being irritating on purpose. "Little guy is waiting for his parents to catch up to him," she said. "I was going to bring him to the Crechemaster's office so they could watch over him after lunch."

"Mmm, they're overflowing with other kids whose parents haven't shown up either, though. I don't know if they'll be able to take another."

Glimmer looked down at Newt, thankful that he didn't seem to register their conversation. "That's not going to work. They have to take him, they can't just turn him away because they're running out of space."

"Have you gone to see what it looks like there? If you had, you'd know trying to shove him in there is a bad idea."

It couldn't be *that* bad, could it? Glimmer was about to ask what she meant when a harsh crack resounded out from the crowd; someone had thrown a bottle and shattered it, and the crowd grew rowdier in response. A number of soldiers, who up until that point had been standing on raised platforms trying to shout and calm people down, started to finger at the rifles strapped to their chests and the handguns at their hips.

"Are you planning on doing anything about that?" the clerk asked.

Glimmer set her lips into a thin line and said, “Yeah,” dreading what she knew would come next. “It looks like it will get ugly if someone doesn’t step in soon. And who better to get their attention than me, the muscle, right?”

She kneeled in front of Newt, and he fixed his giant eyes on her. “Hey big man,” she said. “I’m going to go talk to that crowd and get them to be a little nicer to one another. Would you do me a huge favor and stay here with my friend where it’s safer?”

Newt, who had been nothing but docile and compliant so far, squeezed her hand tighter and shook his head. “No, I want to stay with you.”

“It’s dangerous, and I don’t want you to get hurt. Please stay here.”

“No!” Newt shook his head and hugged Glimmer’s hand with his whole body.

Glimmer sighed. She wouldn’t be able to pull apart without hurting him, and the mob was quickly growing louder. They were building to a fever pitch, and unless she stepped in soon then someone on either side of the refugee-guard conflict might do something drastic. There was something she could try if Newt refused let go. It wasn’t her first choice but, on second thought, it might actually help calm everyone down faster.

“Alright,” she said. “You can stay with me, but I need you to not let go of my hand no matter what, okay? Even if things get scary, you can’t let go. Can you promise me?”

Newt nodded. “I promise.”

Glimmer rose and, together, they approached the mob, stopping only a few feet from the back of the outermost layer of refugees in the pavilion. The megaliths stood tall around them like six monstrous, looming guardians. Bits and pieces of coherency came through the noise.

“Where is my son? Where is my daughter? Where is my wife?”

“Will we be evacuated from the planet? Where will we go?”

“Why can I not get any answers about anything going on here?”

“How did the Empire let this happen in the first place?”

“Who’s in charge? No, not you, I want to speak to whoever really is in charge of this evacuation.”

“Why do I have to stay in the compound? My family lives in the next city over and I need to get to them. I thought this was an evacuation center, not a prison.”

Glimmer had heard all this time and time again on her other deployments. None of it was new, but it *was* exhausting to repeatedly address. After checking that Newt was as close to her as he could get, she gave a quick gesture in the air with her other hand.

A purple rune, wreathed in neon, etched itself under their feet. Newt stared at it in wide-eyed wonder, and Glimmer breathed a sigh of relief. She was afraid that might have startled him.

She completed the rune so that its circumference reached about an arm’s breadth from the center of their bodies—enough room for her to feel safe they wouldn’t fall off, but not so large she had to concentrate in order to maintain it. She gave another gesture, and the rune lifted them off the ground like a platform and floated them over the heads of the crowd toward the center.

The noise died down as more people saw Glimmer flying over them. By the time they hovered over the center of the mob, everyone had stopped shouting, and the few who weren’t staring up at her with open mouths were whispering to their neighbors in excitement and interest instead.

“It’s the Seraph,” she heard one person say. “The Seraph of Archanas is here.”

A person nearby nudged them and said, “No you idiot, the Seraph doesn’t have pink hair. That’s the other one, the Angel.”

“If she’s here then we must be safe, right?” the first asked.

“I don’t know. If they sent her, it might mean we need extra help. Do you see how many ships are up there in orbit?”

Glimmer struggled not to roll her eyes. It wasn’t that she didn’t appreciate the impact she had on the lives of Imperial citizens, but the way many of them practically idolized her next to Taline and even Corynth bordered on creepy sometimes.

She cleared her throat instead, and said, “Excuse me.”

The whispering didn’t die down, so she cleared her throat a second time and projected her voice louder, all the way to the back. “Okay everyone, please calm down.”

Finally, the whispering ceased and she had the crowd’s full attention, including the soldiers still stationed nearby.

“I’m sure some of you are already aware of who I am,” she said. “For those unfamiliar, my name is Glimmer. I am the only Enclave Battlemage currently assigned to the evacuation site here.” She paused, waiting for an interruption she was sure would come. Someone in the back coughed, and the guards continued to fidget with their weapons, nervous.

“I understand your apprehension,” she said. “This infection was sudden and violent. Many of you have been ripped from your homes only to come here and receive no answers. I want you to understand that your questions and your concerns and your frustrations are nothing new. As cold as that might sound, please try to take that as a good thing—you are not alone. In my experience, everyone who has made it to one of these evacuation centers and the megaliths in the past has made it out of the infection alive. You have nothing to worry about.”

The whispering picked up, and Glimmer knew if she left it at that, it would only frustrate the crowd more.

"I also understand that's not nearly enough information to make anyone satisfied," she said, pushing her voice so it still carried over the noise. "It certainly wouldn't satisfy me.  So, I will share what I can with you about the state of Scavria's fight against the Beast."

That seemed to calm people enough she didn't have to fight as hard to be heard.

"I've been part of many evacuations since joining the Enclave," she said. "To put concrete numbers on it, this is my fourth deployment and ninth city evacuation effort. My mentor, your 'Seraph of Archanas,'  has also taken part in hundreds of planet-side battles and their ensuing evacuations during the first war."

More whispers traveled around the crowd at her mention of Taline, and Glimmer suppressed the urge to shy away. This was to boost their morale, nothing more. It was fine. She was fine. No reason to panic, although she already felt the beginnings of an attack clawing at the edges of her psyche.

"So far the infection has only hit the capital city," she said. "No other city on Scavria is currently fighting a Beast infection, and we have megaliths and fleets stationed nearby for them in any case. For those of you worried about friends and family in other places, please rest easy.

"Further, this is the largest fleet ever to respond to an infection before, and this was largely because this is the largest settlement the Beast has hit since the first war. We planned for a worst-case scenario and instead received something far less dire. Preliminary reports have come in, and Fleet Command is confident we can retake the city. Our mission will be a success, and it will be a success very soon."

Excitement thrummed through the crowd. Glimmer wasn't certain she was at liberty to share what she had. In fact, she'd surely broken several layers of classified intel security already, but it was far better than letting a mob devolve into violence.

"Be aware, everything will *not* go back to normal as soon as the city is retaken," she said. "Rebuilding efforts will be strenuous, cataloguing and paying respects to lost loved ones will take its toll. But if we are successful, then you will not have to evacuate the planet. That is my sincere hope, and the sincerest hope of every officer here trying to keep the peace, and every Battlemage and Vanguard soldier out there fighting to retake the city. Please, cooperate with us a while longer. Help us help you retake your planet. We can't let even one more civilization fall to the enemy."

The crowd grew rowdy again, but this time in their agreement with her. Glimmer could already feel how morale soared. She smiled and looked down at Newt, saw him staring out at the crowd with vacant eyes. He seemed to not even notice that they were floating a dozen feet in the air.

"Is there a Crechemaster in this crowd by any chance?" Glimmer said, scanning the faces around for anyone familiar. "This child here is looking for his parents."

The refugees checked with one another, briefly, before one spoke up and said there wasn't anyone there to help, unfortunately. Glimmer figured as much, and she lowered the both of them to the ground when the crowd began to disperse.

"Well, that went better than I thought it would," she said to Newt. Her panic was still there, but it wasn't overpowering as it normally was after doing something like this. "It's lunchtime. How about you and I go find something to eat, and then we can figure out what to do about—"

Newt suddenly jumped up and down on his toes, full of excitement. Glimmer followed his line of sight and saw the pair of refugees from earlier—the ones she had provided temporary cards

to after they tried to bribe her—pushing their way through the crowd toward them.

“Ennis!” Newt said, pulling out of Glimmer’s hold to run toward the man. Newt jumped into his arms and Ennis spun him around with a smile on his face as his companion looked on.

Glimmer watched this as she approached, intrigued but still a little apprehensive. Both Scavrians looked happy to see him.

Ennis put Newt down and kneeled down eye-level with him. “Go play with Marcie, okay? I’ll be there in a minute.” Newt nodded, and the girl, Marcie, took him by the hand and lead him off a ways to give them privacy.

“You know each other?” Glimmer asked Ennis when they got far enough away to speak without being overheard.

“We do,” Ennis said. “Very well, actually. You said his parents haven’t shown up?”

“Nope,” Glimmer said, rubbing the back of her neck with her hand and watching Newt and Marcie play nearby. “Poor guy was wandering the crowds outside the compound looking for them. I was going to take him to the Crechemaster’s office after we got something to eat.”

“What are the chances they’ll turn up, you think?”

Glimmer almost asked him why he was so interested, but stopped short after seeing the sincerity on his face. “Not very likely,” she said in a low voice. “Once families get separated, it’s rare they find each other again, even with the intake logs. There’s just too much chaos going around.”

Ennis frowned. “We’ll take him in then.”

Glimmer raised a brow. "I don’t think that’s a good idea.”

“Marcie and I were servants to his parents,” Ennis said. “Had been for years. They took us off the streets, paid us a decent wage, gave us a roof over our heads, beds to sleep in, three meals a day…too much to recount. If he’s suddenly orphaned, then it’s the least we could do to take care of him.”

Glimmer narrowed her eyes at him. “Letting you in without a full scan and no questions asked is one thing, but I’m not about to let some lost kid go with you that easily. You tried to bribe me just a few hours ago.”

Ennis sighed and his shoulders slumped. “I understand that.” He seemed to fight with himself a moment before making a decision. “Marcie and I left their villa about a week ago when the infection first hit. His parents were convinced staying inside the walls of their compound would be safer than trying to leave. They wanted us to stay too, but we grew up on the streets as orphans. Our gut told us that staying was a bad idea, and it was our got that gut that helped us survive the streets in the first place, so we followed it.”

He cringed then before continuing. “We…we stole a bunch of their valuables on the way out. Fenced them for some money so that, wherever we ended up after evacuating, we wouldn’t be trying to start over penniless like before.”

Glimmer raised both her eyebrows this time. She knew there was something they were afraid of when they first spoke and she hadn’t pried, but hearing this was still unexpected.

“We were surprised they didn’t file police reports on us,” Ennis said. “Even with all the chaos going around, Tir’s infrastructure hadn’t crumbled yet and we figured…well.” He huffed, frustrated. “I guess maybe they died before they could report us. Or maybe they didn’t have it in their hearts to do it, even though we certainly would have deserved it. Either way, if Newt’s parents don’t come for him, then we want to be there for him. It wouldn’t sit right with either of us if we didn’t use some of the money we

stole from his parents in the first place to help him, now that he's likely on his own."

Glimmer studied him. More than a few duplicitous people had crossed paths with her in her life, Shadow Weaver not even topping the list, so she had gotten good at identifying liars and cheats. Ennis had none of the 'tells' she had grown accustomed to detecting, but that still didn't mean she was going to let it go that easily.

She pushed up the sleeve of her Enclave uniform to expose her own PDA on her wrist. A notification had pinged her sometime since she last checked the screen: Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio were off duty, likely either heading back to or already up at the *Omen-Kador* in orbit. She cleared the alert and navigated to the portable bio-scanner software included on the device.

"Let me run a full scan on you," she said, holding out her arm for him. "We already know you don't have warrants. I want to see that your story checks out before I make any decisions."

Ennis glanced at the PDA, then at her, then back again. Finally, he reached out and placed a fingertip on the scanner.

Everything came back exactly as he said. He was a servant for House Durange, and had been for a long time. Newt's parents *had* gone to the authorities before everything collapsed, but not to file a police report for theft; they had filed a missing person report instead. Both for him and for Marcie. Newt's parents didn't want them found for theft, they wanted them found out of a concern for their safety.

"The Crechemaster's office is overflowing," Ennis said. "They couldn't take him, and even if they did, there's a high chance he'd be neglected since they just don't have the resources to watch over all those kids. Trust me, Marcie and I looked." He put his palms together, not even bothering to hide how he was literally pleading with her. "Let us take care of him. You already see he's comfortable with us, and having the three of us together, with

cash, to watch out for one another will be much better than trying to stick him in an overcrowded humanitarian office."

Glimmer looked over. Newt and Marcie were still playing nearby. They both looked so carefree and happy, and Ennis had such a sincere look on his face Glimmer couldn't help but feel for him.

"Alright," she said at last. "I'm going to be keeping an eye on you though. And if his parents show up, you have to bring him right away, stolen goods or no."

"Of course," Ennis said. "There's no question about that."

"You're nice for offering to do this, you know," Glimmer said. "I know what living on the streets and fending for yourself is like. Not first hand, but a good friend of mine grew up that way. Two good friends, actually. Most people just…think about themselves and that's it."

"It does teach you to make hard decisions," Ennis said, nodding his agreement. "I do have that mindset sometimes and work hard to not let it take over me. I wish I didn't, truthfully. I still feel bad about fencing their stuff, but I know Marcie and I wouldn't be alive if we hadn't. The streets…well, let's just say that surviving them teaches you how to make decisions, even in the face of fear and death. Especially in the face of fear and death, maybe."

Glimmer gave him a surprised look, her heart suddenly pounding in her chest like it wanted to break free. That's exactly what Catra had tried to convey to her the last time they saw each other, just not in as few words. It's exactly what she struggled to do herself, aboard the emperor's citadel…on Rinne. Her mood plummeted, and she couldn't shake the feeling that even this lone refugee would do a better job leading a team then she might. Ennis at least wouldn't choke under pressure.

"Sorry," Ennis said, shooting her a sheepish look as he yanked Glimmer out of her thoughts. "I didn't mean to get that dark. Your speech was nice. I think having a Battlemage here will help calm

peoples’ nerves a lot.” He turned away from her and gave a halfhearted wave. “Anyways, I’ll see you around. You mentioned lunch and I think it best the three of us grab something to eat sooner rather than later.”

Glimmer watched him go, waving at Newt when Ennis reached him and Marcie.

Ennis’ words were forcing her down another spiral. Thoughts and emotions she had been working for years to overcome surfaced with a relentless energy. This was worse than the panic attacks she’d feel coming on the other times she’s had to talk down unruly groups during prior evacuations. She wouldn’t be able to stop this one.

First a shore leave cut short, then having to turn down and disappoint Lonnie and the others, and now this. It wouldn’t be good for anyone if she had a breakdown in the middle of the square. Just as she felt herself start to hyperventilate anew, she turned and marched off. There was one secluded spot in the compound she knew of, and that’s where she needed to be.

Chapter End Notes

> "Ground Zero" is another name for the World Trade Center site. That should be plenty of implication for what's to come...
>
> Fun fact about this chapter and Glimmer's arc overall: When I was first drafting this story over a year ago, I had no idea what Glimmer's arc was going to entail. Originally I hadn't intended on writing a full Glimmer arc at all. My original plan was to make her a key character in part one, have her be "off screen" doing "important battlemage things for the galaxy" until an important moment right before the climax of the story, and then fold her back into the narrative in-person.
>
> It wasn't until I finished Catra and Adora's part 2-4 scenes that I finally realized what piece of the puzzle I was missing--the other two deal with things periphery to the main Beast

conflict and, except for one very specific instance I'm not going to spoil, the Beast as an on-scene entity and concrete antagonist wasn't going to make an appearance until much later in the story. That's when I got the idea for what to do with Glimmer--showing what the actual front lines look like, evacuating entire cities, etc.--and the main story beats for her arc pretty much came to me wholesale in that instant. It was surreal, like one moment I had no idea what to do with her and was just going to do nothing, and the next I spent the next 4 hours furiously jotting down the main beats of her story arc in a notebook.

And THIS chapter is literally where I had the most trouble actually getting into the scene. Sure, it *sounds* straightforward and cool to write "Glimmer is helping evacuate an entire city, meets an orphan, channels her mom with that speech to uplift peoples' spirits, and has an existential crisis because of something a refugee says to her," but actually getting into the scene and writing it took many tries, failed experiments with tone and pacing, and I wanted to rip my hair out by the time I had a draft one of this scene complete. Not to mention the number of rewrites I did to get it to this point.

All in all, Glimmer's whole arc stretched me as a writer, and I'm very happy with how the end result came out. We've really gone pretty far left of field with this chapter, actually showing logistically what this sort of mass-evacuation might look like, but if you're this far deep in the story then I feel like you're already sold on the premise and how "far out" this story can go :)

Thanks for indulging in my ravings, and as always, thank you for reading!

# Eden

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Opened packets littered the floor and a fine sheen of food-prep dust blanketed the countertops of the *Dzivia's* tiny kitchen by the time Adora finally succeeded in preparing a second meal. The feast Kal had put in front of her normally would have sufficed, but something about waking up still injured after three days unconscious had made her ravenous. That, and she had grasped onto any excuse she could to stall having to see him again on account of how guilty she felt for their previous interaction.

Finally, with a second full-course meal in her stomach, Adora could prolong things no further—she had to go find Kal. She found him in the same place from the first time, in the cockpit, except this time he lounged in the pilot's chair with his feet up on the forward console, seat reclined all the way back, staring blank-faced out the view screen at the warp tunnel.

He didn't say anything to her. Didn't even turn around when she came in, even though she knew he had heard her. The doors slid shut. She chewed her lip and shifted her weight from one foot to the other, unsure what to say.

"Just tell me one thing, Kal," she said, when the silence between them grew too much for her to stand.

He didn't immediately respond, and Adora swallowed the lump growing in her throat. He leaned back further, enough to look at her upside down in the chair, over the top of his raised brow and through the wispy strands of his hair.

"Are you here to help?"

"I told you I'm not you're enemy," he said. "I'm not lying about that. I'm trying to help."

Adora looked him in the eyes when he said it. She imagined he were Catra telling her three years ago that they were on the same side. She tried to walk herself through the motions of denying his words, tried to convince herself that he was lying to her and she was only being quick to trust as was in her nature. Despite her best efforts, she couldn't bring herself to believe that; not only did everything since their skirmish in the castle indicate he wasn't trying to hurt her, even her own gut instinct urged to not see him as an enemy, although she couldn't for the life of her understand why.

"I'm sorry for earlier," she said, rubbing her shoulders even though there was no chill in the cockpit. "I…I think this is all starting to get too much for me. She Ra was gone entirely in the castle when we fought…I couldn't…" she stopped and grabbed a breath, her train of thought already slipping away. "Then she all of a sudden comes back and I leap four stories onto your ship to stop you? It's just…" She huffed. "That crystal of yours? That apeiron? I couldn't feel anything more than a tiny hint of something in there when I reached…I lied when I said I gleaned a lot of information from it."

He looked surprised at her words, and Adora didn't want to give him the time to interject out of fear she'd lose it entirely if she was even slightly derailed.

"I'm on some mysterious ship with a mysterious person who, up until a few weeks ago, was sneaking around Etheria and breaking into First One's vaults without anyone knowing. I just feel so far out of my element, I…you said you wanted to leave me behind. Please don't leave me behind on the ship when we get to…well, wherever we're going."

Her words hung between them for a beat, then two, before Kal gestured toward the co-pilot seat. Adora shuffled forward, stretching a leg out to awkwardly straddle-hover over the center console, and tried not to wince too pitifully as she lowered herself into the chair. Her muscles and injuries screamed murder at her, but it was a small price to pay considering the alternative was falling to her death back on Etheria.

Dials and levers and sleek diagnostic readouts were built into the control panel before and around her. They seemed to vie for her attention, each one of them, and the hyperspace tunnel encompassing everything else on top of it nearly gave Adora sensory overload. She thought she might have to shut her eyes to keep from going insane, and there was a feeling she was moments away from being sucked out of the cockpit entirely and into the void beyond.

"You'll get used to it," Kal said, watching her adjust. "Hyperspace is something that takes the brain some time to acclimate to. Now that I think about it, it's probably a good metaphor for everything else you'll encounter soon, out in the wider galaxy."

"Does the 'getting used to it' part of that metaphor apply to the 'everything out in the galaxy' too?" she asked. "Or just to this tunnel?"

Kal laughed, and it struck Adora that this was the first time she had ever heard him do so. It was light and casual and entirely at odds, again, with the image she had in her head of this interloper.

"I sure hope you acclimate to the rest of the galaxy too," he said. "I'm guessing there was a time when you weren't used to She Ra either, back when you could use her a little more readily. You got used to her after a time too, didn't you?"

"My powers are…a larger issue," she said, tamping down on the urge to already lash out at him for bringing it up. "I've always been able to feel her, even when I couldn't draw her out. She was always there, under the surface." A deep breath. "But, when we fought in the castle and you told me to bring her out, she was… she was…"

"Gone?"

Adora whirled in the chair to face him, barely able to keep from yelling and asking him how he knew. Kal must have read her question from her expression, because he reached up to the

overhead controls and grabbed something dangling there she hadn't noticed earlier. It was the circular manacles he had cuffed her with back when they fought.

"Don't worry," he said, a smile flickering across his face. He held them out for her and she shied away from them. "I'm not going to put them on you. Just…take them and try and reach for your power."

Adora did so. Holding both cuffs, one in each hand, she reached for She Ra and felt…nothing. Frowning, she pushed harder and still felt no answer. There was no wall pushing back against her or blocking her from reaching for it, either. It was as if her powers weren't there and had never been there at all to begin with. She placed the manacles up on the console off to her left and reached again, now that she wasn't holding them. She Ra bubbled there under the surface like she had never left. Adora tried it again, just to be sure.

"You're taking it better than most," Kal said, watching her expression as she experimented. "Most magically-inclined have a complete meltdown the first time something like that happens to them."

"Full disclosure, I did have a meltdown the first time it happened," she said. "I almost freaked out on you just now, right when you brought it up." She held up the cuffs by one manacle, letting the second one dangle and swing freely off the chain connecting it to the first. "What is this thing?"

"Ignominite cuffs. Extremely expensive. Slap one of those on someone and even a Battlemage like Taline wouldn't be able to so much as light one of the candles at your Induction Ceremonies with her magic."

"I thought ignominite was only imbued into crystals to trap the Beast," Adora said, handing the manacles back to Kal and watching him hook them up on the overhead console again. "Like an apeiron, no?"

“That and forging them into bullets are the most common uses, yes,” he said. “They’re also used to restrain rogue mages, since physically touching the stuff blocks any use of magic. You didn’t lose your connection to She Ra back in the castle, I cut you off.”

“You egged me on,” Adora said, remembering what happened. “You told me to reach for She Ra after slapping those on me, knowing what would happen. You played me.”

“Yep,” he said, grinning. “At the time, I just wanted to bring your attention to the fact she was gone, rather than you trying to reach on your own and finding something wrong. Figured you’d freak out worse and make it harder for me to work if it were the latter. Sorry about that. It was mean.”

“It *was* mean,” Adora said, agreeing. To her surprise, relief flooded through instead of anger. Nothing was wrong with her connection, at least not any more wrong than it had been in the past. Kal still had that grin on his face as if the whole thing were a practical joke and, to her even greater surprise, she found it kind of funny too.

“My god,” she said, unable to keep a smile of her own from forming. “You damn near gave me a heart attack. You are such a *jerk*, I thought I lost her for good!” She felt so happy she almost reached over and slugged him in the arm, hard enough to bruise.

“Yeah, very jerk-like of me, I fully admit it,” he said. “Although I did pay for that bit of fun, in the end.”

“What do you mean?”

“There’s nothing wrong with your powers. If anything, you seem to be coming back into them, slowly. When you managed to call on some of it and catch me, you put a giant hole in my ship that I spent forever repairing.”

“Serves you right,” she said with a smirk.

Adora didn't tell him she was still worried, though. There were many times since waking up where she had quietly tried to transform, where she had tried thinking of her friends while reaching for her powers since that's what had worked back at the castle. But despite her best efforts, she *still* couldn't wield her powers at will. In fact, if Kal hadn't just confirmed what had happened, she might have started to think that multi-story jump, sword in hand, was just a fever dream.

"I'm sorry too, by the way," Kal said, shaking her from her thoughts.

'You're…sorry? I'm the one that accused you of being a spy."

"You did, but I wasn't exactly being very understanding either. I can't imagine how strange it would have felt to be in your shoes, waking up on some random person's ship bound for who knows where after fighting them for stealing something out of your castle? And I *did* steal from you—I won't deny that." He sighed. "Not the best introduction, I'll admit."

"Not really, no," Adora said. It felt strange hearing him so openly acknowledge this. It almost made her want to drop her guard, although she knew better than that. Naïve Adora was a thing of the past.

"I *was* a member of the Enclave once," he said. "That was the first thing you asked, and I said that I wasn't, though I didn't give you the full context."

Adora considered that. "Why did you leave?"

Kal shrugged and turned back to stare at the warp tunnel, his grin long since faded into a stony expression. "I served for a handful of years during the first Beast war as a Battlemage. Saw too many of my friends and squad mates die, as is the case in war. I decided I was done with it all after the Daiamid emerged and I saw what a clusterfuck that caused."

Adora barely kept her surprise from showing on her face. She had half expected Kal to admit to being kicked out of the order, her having asked why he left having been a loaded question. This, however, was a far more interesting development.

"Were you there in person when it happened?" she asked, "The trial where they revealed themselves? Or were you talking, like, more in a general sense? I was told news of the fighting that day reached all corners of the empire, pretty much."

"I was there in person, just like Salas was," Kal said. "In fact, I remember seeing him. And Prime. I watched the emperor put his ego ahead of the safety of his people and I watched the Enclave go along with it. About the only admirable thing I saw was watching Taline's Sentinels jump literally into the heat of battle and pull her out—save her life before she lost it fighting against the Daiamid when they escaped. Although that wasn't enough to stop me from leaving the Enclave as a whole after." He glanced sidelong at her. "Hearing you accuse me of being a spy for the emperor after what he started…I didn't react to it well."

That made sense, but suddenly there were a million other things in her head that didn't. He knew Salas? What did it say that Salas hadn't seemed to recognize him when his face showed up tied to all the security breaches? Did Kal know of Salas but Salas didn't know of Kal? And why was Kal avoiding the Enclave if their goals aligned? Everyone on Etheria, including the Enclave, were trying to find a way to stop the Beast. Was there something stopping them from working together, even if Kal was no longer one of them?

It was hard enough keeping the food she had eaten still inside her while sitting so close to the viewscreen. Deciding which question to ask next was another matter entirely, and it made her even more nauseous with anxiety. To keep from agonizing over it any longer, she picked the most straightforward thing she could ask.

"Is that what you were doing at the Induction Ceremony?" She remembered seeing him standing there before their graves with

anguish on his face while she had a breakdown in Angella's arms. "Paying respects to Narre and Miri because you admired what they did for Taline that day?"

"I visited all three times and did the same thing," he said, voice light. "Honestly, I was surprised you didn't notice until the last one."

"I've been kind of unable to focus on anything at all except She Ra ever since Prime invaded," Adora said. She cringed—that sounded so much more concerning out loud than it did in her head. "You seem to know a lot, so I'm sure you're already well aware of how…single-minded I've been while you were wandering around the kingdoms."

Kal's silence was answer enough. Suddenly, she no longer wanted to ask any of the burning questions knocking about in her head. She felt too ashamed thinking back on how she had spent the past few years, and feared getting her questions answered might only exacerbate that for some reason.

There was a good reason for her wanting to get back in touch with She Ra, of course. No one could dispute that. But, still…three whole years doing nothing but training and agonizing over powers that never came to her? Her relationship with everyone but Bow and Glimmer had deteriorated, and as embarrassing as it was to admit, she only had herself to blame. Angella's speech at the ceremony couldn't have come sooner.

Kal took his feet off the dash and leaned forward. "We're here," he said.

He released a lock somewhere, and the throttle on the center console between them jumped back to a neutral position. The hyperspace tunnel fell away and a massive, yellow star filled the viewscreen, bathing them in a near-unbearable blinding light. Adora pushed herself into the back of the chair trying to get away from its brilliance, shielding her eyes with her hands.

“Should have put this up first,” Kal said, pressing another button. “Sorry about that.” The view screen polarized, muting the light of the star into a calming yellow glow.

Adora lowered her hands and her jaw followed. The surface of the star before her rippled and burst like a massive, singular plane of magma. The fact it covered nearly the entire viewscreen only added to her sense of awe.

“That’s Arcturus, by the way,” Kal said, steering the ship so the bow pointed toward the edge of the star rather than its center.

“We’re not landing on the star, are we?” Adora asked “That’s not a thing, right?”

Kal chuckled. “No, not quite.”

A small speck of darkness against the star-scape came into focus. Adora watched it grow larger and larger until she realized what they were approaching was actually a small, rocky planet.

“How has that thing not been pulled into its gravity?” Adora asked.

“That’s the least surprising thing about this place, believe it or not. Just wait until we get to the other side.”

Adora was about to ask what he meant by that when the ship’s computer blared at them. Two fighters off in the distance had locked onto them and were hailing to open a channel. Kal obliged, and a ragged looking fellow, a sheet of polished metal covering a portion of his face and an eye patch covering one of his six eyes, appeared on an opaqued section of the viewscreen.

“Attention unidentified craft,” he said. “You are entering a restricted Imperial no-fly zone. Provide identification immediately or turn away. Refusal will be met with deadly force.”

Adora tensed, but Kal reached out and pressed another button on the console without batting an eye.

“Sending identification codes now,” he said as he input another set of commands. The person on the other line glanced down.

“Identification checks out,” he said after a moment. “You can continue on.”

Kal smiled. “’Checks out’ isn’t standard Imperial comms language, you know.”

The man grumbled and cut the line.

“The outpost is built here specifically to deter people from stumbling across it by accident,” Kal said when Adora looked at him, confused. “Every now and then, the planet will still pop up on someone’s sensors and a curious explorer will come looking. They send out two or so fighters in unmarked warbirds to pretend this is an Imperial black-site.”

“It’s not?” Adora was a little ashamed to admit to herself that, for a brief moment, she imagined Kal having lied, her being right, and them being moments away from actually landing on a military outpost to meet Horde Prime as she had originally accused.

“No,” Kal said. “It’s the opposite actually.”

They shot past the planet. Jumping so close to a star might have startled Adora, but what she saw when Kal turned them around to face the sun side of the planet was jaw dropping.

A shimmering dome, made of what looked to Adora like a lattice of diamonds, covered the whole surface, protecting an enormous green landmass underneath. There was a glistening blue sea, what looked to be a beach, and the towering skyscrapers and winding highways of a megalopolis built nearby.

“Welcome to Eden,” Kal said to her. All Adora could do was gape.

The crackle of comms chatter opened up in the cockpit as they drew closer, and someone identifying themself as ‘Tower Control’ greeted them with a static-filled voice.

"Acknowledged Tower Control," Kal said, responding to them. "This is the starship Dzivia coming in on heading four-seven-nine. Requesting approach vectors for landing."

"Transmitting approach vectors for bay three now," the voice said. "Prepare to release manual controls to your autopilot on my mark."

"Negative Tower Control, my autopilot is malfunctioning." Kal shot Adora a look as if to say 'you broke it when you cut my ship,' and she had the good manners to at least look sheepish. "I'll take her in manually."

There was a pause, as if they had to double check to make sure they heard Kal correctly, before:

"Acknowledged, *Dzivia*. Approach vector transmission complete. Follow those coordinates as best you can—we'll keep an eye on you from here."

A set of multi-digit coordinates broken up by decimals and dashes appeared onscreen. Kal guided the ship gently through the barrier and to one of the open landing platforms below. A team of marshallers, each wearing a reflective orange vest and hardhat, stood atop the landing bay and guided them in with glowing batons and exaggerated motions. When Kal touched them down and powered off, he leapt from the pilot's seat and went to the workbench at the rear of the cockpit.

"They're going to scan us when we get off the ship," Kal said, taking the crystal still there and stuffing it into a small field bag. "You'll be fine, but they're going to spook when they get to me. Whatever you do, don't provoke them and don't get defensive. Just stay where you are and do whatever they tell you to do. You don't have any weapons on you, do you?"

"What?" Adora glanced out the view screen and saw a small troop of armed guards dressed in brown already marching up to the

craft in formation. “No, I don’t have anything on me. Why are they going to get aggressive?”

“It’s a long story,” he said, walking out the cockpit and through the halls to the back of the ship while she followed. “Whatever you do, just don’t give them any reason to shoot us.”

“That doesn’t make me feel any better at all,” Adora said. She suppressed a high-pitched whine of anxiety when she waited for more of an explanation and he didn’t give her one.

When they reached the cargo bay, Kal pulled a lever next to the exit ramp and it descended in a flurry of steam and pneumatic groans. When the metal of the ship’s ramp touched the floor of the landing bay, he strode down and out to the soldiers waiting there. Adora matched his pace on his right. A shiver ran through her body at the cold air that kissed her skin. Despite being on a planet so close to the sun, the air was cool?

“Nothing to declare,” Kal said stopping just shy of the soldiers. “No weapons.”

“We still need to scan you,” the nearest soldier said, holding up a portable device. “Imperial presence in the sector is heightened. The Beast is seeping through into the Kaloshi border, so we aren’t letting anyone go without one.”

Kal shrugged and the soldier gestured for Adora to step forward first. She did, spreading her arms and her legs when they asked her to as they ran the scanner across her

“Clean,” the soldier said, jerking his thumb in a ‘get going’ gesture over his shoulder when they finished with her. Adora didn’t know where he wanted her to go, so she stayed put.

Kal took the same pose as her when they moved on to him, albeit with a lazier posture and a bored look on his face. The machine screamed as soon as they started the scan, and every guard on the platform suddenly jumped and trained their weapons on the both of them.

“Who the fuck are you?” the soldier said, jumping back a fair distance from the both of them.

“I’m Kal,” he said, tone placid.

“Don’t give me that bullshit.” The soldier pulled a sidearm from his holster and trained its barrel on him. “These magazines are loaded with full ignominite rounds. You either tell me who you are and what you’re doing here, or I’m going to put a bullet between your eyes.”

Kal’s unassuming expression shifted into something steely and dangerous. Adora’s body urged her to move, but her mind reminded her of what he said moments before—to give them no reason to shoot them. She didn’t move a muscle.

“You will do no such thing,” Kal said in a low voice. “Because in about five seconds, someone is going to walk through the doors to this hangar and order you to stand down. And you are going to listen to them.”

The soldier furrowed his brow. “I’m not going to entertain anything an Abomination says to me. My job is to keep this landing port safe.” He nodded to the rest of the squad. “Shoot them. Both of them.”

Weapons primed to fire, and for the second time in recent memory, Adora could feel the imminent approach of death. Then, a baritone voice blared over the hangar’s intercom.

“Belay that order.”

The soldiers looked to each other and then their leader in confusion. The voice spoke again, thick with an accent Adora couldn’t place, not that she was surprised.

“Lower your weapons, damnit!”

The soldiers complied, albeit warily, and the doors to the ground floor of what Adora assumed was the hangar’s security office in

the far corner flew open. A burly man with a scarred face and a thick fur-collared jacket marched out and toward them. A smaller team of soldiers, dressed in sharp, blue uniforms that set them distinctly apart from the brown of the security soldiers before them, flanked him on either side.

"V-Vasher?" the first soldier said, turning to him and offering a shaky salute.

"Put that shit away, son," Vasher said, voice gruff and face equal parts irritated and weary. "My guys and I will take it from here. Go on to your next security check—I think a transport just pulled into the bay next door."

"But sir, this person tripped the scanner." The soldier pointed at Kal, who just smiled and gave a cheeky wave. "We can't let an Abo—"

"I've tried to be civil about this, Captain, but you don't seem to get the hint." Vasher's tone grew more divorced from a human voice and more akin to a feral growl with every syllable. "Get the *fuck* off my landing platform."

The captain saluted again, barked out orders to his men, and within a handful of seconds had them double-timing away. When the blast doors at the far end leading out of the hangar slid shut behind them, Vasher turned to regard Kal with a severe expression.

"Hey, man," Kal said with all the tact of someone who hadn't just been moments from death.

Vasher just blinked at him, incredulous. "I almost couldn't believe my ears when I heard that the Dzivia was transmitting a landing request to Tower Control," he said. "I was certain someone had somehow killed you and took your ship. Either that, or I was trapped in some nightmare where you actually thought it was a good idea to show up here again."

“So, you’re saying that you aren’t happy to see me?” Kal asked, sounding as if he were trying to solve an incredible challenge of a puzzle.

Vasher grunted. “Yeah, that has to be you. No one else I know could be nearly as cheeky after having half a dozen rifles shoved in their face.” He glanced in Adora’s direction, and she gave him a wave and a nervous smile. Vasher only rolled his eyes and harrumphed again before turning his attention back to Kal. Adora tried not let her disappointment at having been so thoroughly ignored show on her face.

“So?” Vasher asked. “Three years and no word, not even a goodbye. What brings you back?”

“I need to see Ly.”

Vasher choked out a laugh. “Oh, like hell you do.”

Kal crossed his arms and raised an eyebrow at him. “I’m serious. I wouldn’t be here if it weren’t for a good reason, just like I wouldn’t have left in the first place if it weren’t for a good reason either.”

“You ask for too much, Kal. Too much.” Vasher shook his head. “Do you realize how long it took me to calm her down after you left? She was disconsolate for months. I mean, hell, she doesn’t even know you’re here right now or else those warbirds would have blasted you to pieces without even hailing first.”

“That mad, huh?”

“Yes!” Vasher threw his arms up and waved them in aggressive, sweeping gestures. “You left, Kal. In the middle of a job. We were lucky to make it back here alive and doubly lucky that our employers didn’t mount our heads on spikes. How else are we supposed to feel?”

“You weren’t ever in any danger,” Kal said, frowning. “I wouldn’t have left if I thought either of you had the slightest chance of

getting caught, and the deal we negotiated with the Vestamid was airtight. They wouldn't have killed you."

Vasher's troops grew nervous at the mention of the Vestamid, and Vasher himself spoke with more restraint.

"We're still paying off the debt from losing all their product," he said.

"I know," Kal said. "I'm sorry. You have every right to be angry, I'm not trying to dismiss that. But, please…I wouldn't have done it if it weren't absolutely necessary." He held up the sling bag in one hand for Vasher to get a good look at, and his eyes nearly bugged out of his head.

"Is that…?"

Kal only nodded.

"Then does that mean—"

"No," Kal said, cutting him off. "Something went wrong with Pip and I need to talk to Ly, see if she can do anything about it. I haven't been able to make any progress on my end."

"You must be really desperate if you've come to ask her for that," Vasher said. "How do you even know she'd be able to fix her?"

"I *am* desperate," Kal said. "And I don't know that she'd be able to fix anything, but she's the best chance we have." He slung the bag around his shoulder again. "Will you help me? Or am I going to have to hunt her down myself?"

Vasher looked him in the eyes for several moments before deflating. "She's got a performance late tonight," he said. "You won't be able to get ahold of her before then, but I can put you both up in a room and get you a meeting after the show is done."

"Same place?"

“Same place,” Vasher said nodding.

“Alright, thank you.” Kal pushed past Vasher and his guards, glancing briefly in Adora’s direction for her to follow. Adora power-walked to catch up and stuck close as they made their way to the blast doors at the back of the hangar—the same doors the security team that had first greeted them had fled through.

“Kal,” Vasher said, calling after them from behind loud enough for his voice to echo. When Kal stopped and turned to look at him, he said, “it’s good to see you again. I’m glad you’re back safe.”

“Me too,” he said. “Me too. And thank you for your help. I mean it.”

No more words were exchanged, and Adora followed him out the hangar, her mind scrambling to make sense of the whole exchange.

Chapter End Notes

> My favorite part of this scene has to be when Adora gets so put out after meeting Vasher. The first friendly new face she's scene in years, finally off Etheria and exploring the wider galaxy, and the dude straight up ignores her and just, woosh. All the wind out of her sails T.T Even though she's not your typical egotistical person who thinks the world revolves around them because they are awesome, she still has a bit of that "I have to do everything and save everyone" in her, and it's always a fun time slapping her with a bit of a reality check. That's it. That's Adora's arc. (I'm kidding of course, but come on. I've gotten a few comments about people wanting to strangle Adora for being dumb and I'm sure there are more silent readers out there thinking the same. I get the same enjoyment writing her flailing like a fish out of water as I'm sure some of you get reading it)
>
> The Vestamid up until now were solely part of Catra's POV scenes (there was one mention in a Glimmer scene as a

background detail), but now they're here mentioned in some secret faraway during an Adora scene. Everyone seems to be talking about them. That conspiracy theory tag is there for a reason too!

We're at about the halfway mark for this fic, and have a Catra chapter coming up next. Been a while since we've seen her.

Another fun fact about this story is, before I started posting, I considered making the chapters just absolutely huge. Like, 10-12k word chapters each, and releasing one a month or so. The story would have concluded around the ~30ish chapter mark (around here), but I decided to break the chapters up into smaller, more "traditionally published sci-fi/fantasy novel length" chapters. It was easier for me to proofread in smaller chunks before posting, and after doing the math, I realized you would get more story (and we would get to the end) faster with weekly updates and smaller uploads than monthly updates and larger uploads. Plus, I wrote the whole thing with the current chapter breaks in mind, so trying to figure out a flow for larger chapters would have added onto the work.

Thank you as always for reading and following along!

# Pip

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra settled into the corner booth of the Tailchaser, a cozy pub situated deep in Phoenix Station's mid-wards. The leather of the overstuffed seats creaked and crackled as she maneuvered into a comfortable position. A seat at the bar would have been preferable, but seeing as how most of the booths that would have been used to seat patrons were instead crammed full of mountains of packaged food and supplies, she was lucky enough as it was to have been let in and given one of the only open tables to begin with.

Vadim, the owner, came by and held a menu up for her to take. "Gonna browse?" he asked. "Or wanna do your regular?"

"I'll do the regular, and a club soda or something if it's not too much trouble?"

He raised both eyebrows. "You want a nonalcoholic drink?"

Catra rolled her eyes, bantering with him as they had for years by now. "I have a job too, you know. Can't be under the influence on the clock."

"You're clocking in to the precinct *after* eating here?" he asked, confused. "But you typically come after your shifts are up. Is Dax giving you a hard time about accepting a promotion again?"

"I quit the force, actually," Catra said, shaking her head. "Have a new gig lined up and this is my first day, I guess you could say. I don't want to mess it up." Diallo had been overjoyed to hear she was onboard when she went to him, days ago now. Together they had planned their move for when Moriarty was due to give his rally. Today.

Vadim studied her for a moment, then shrugged and wandered off to fulfill her order. Catra liked the Tailchaser and she liked Vadim, precisely because he knew where her line was and never crossed it. Diving unexpectedly into a topic that Catra felt was 'too personal' was never an issue with him. Not to mention she also really liked his cheese fries.

Her meeting with Diallo was in an hour—they were going to infiltrate Moriarty's office together, and the fact she still hadn't gotten a good night's rest meant her nerves were frayed beyond belief; she needed every tool in her arsenal to keep calm, and wasn't above scarfing down junk food in her favorite dive bar right before if it gave her clarity.

*Just the fact I was able to get in here was a miracle in and of itself*, she thought, watching the waitress who tried to block her at the door careen through the establishment. She nearly crashed into the bar in her haste to get to it, scooped up as many packaged boxes of food as she could, and tumbled back out toward the line of people outside the front door without sparing Catra anything beyond an annoyed glance.

The Catra from a previous life might have shot back a smug face, but the Catra sitting there at the booth kept it classy. More refugees had flooded in during the preceding days. More than even the most pessimistic of doomsday experts could predict, and administration had commandeered all establishments—from the station's upper-wards down to the bowels—to provide emergency services for the influx. The line out the front door of the Tailchaser alone was massive, and Catra wasn't technically supposed to even get seated, since no shops were conducting regular business. Vadim had made a special exception for her and she was grateful.

A catchy theme song drew her attention to one of the TVs mounted above the bar. Catra watched the logo for the largest news network in their region of space play onscreen. An anchor duo, a man and woman both dressed in suits, introduced themselves and their topic for that afternoon's special: Moriarty and his upcoming rally, where he would outline his plan to keep

the region safe and prosperous despite the Beast continuing to spread against ever more populous Imperial territories. The idea was to offer commentary both before and after the live airing of his rally speech.

"I've heard some concerning rumors lately," Vadim said as he rounded the corner back to her, balancing a platter with one hand and carrying a folding stand in the other.

"What kind of rumors?" Catra asked, turning away from the broadcast.

He placed the platter on the tray stand. "I've heard that the ignominite munitions might be losing their efficacy. Bullets that once could put down a thrall like any other person aren't working as well as they did in the last war anymore."

"Really?" Catra asked. "I heard rumors that Moriarty will finally open up the Atrium for the refugees. Everyone thinks that's going to be part of the rally speech."

Vadim snorted. "I'm more concerned about whether he's going to let more people dock in the station. Sure, open up the Atrium. I don't mind seeing all those pompous rich assholes get the panties in a twist having to share space with the refugees like everyone else, but we can't just keep funneling people here with no end. Sooner or later the station will reach capacity, and life support will stop being able to 'support' all the life on the station, regardless of where we put them. I'm barely able to keep up with the new emergency orders they put in for us."

Catra sighed. "The universe is going to shit and I'm sitting alone in a dive bar to stress eat. Let's hope they find a way to curb this sooner rather than later, then." When she saw the mountain of cheese fries in the basket Vadim placed in front of her alongside the largest virgin Mai Tai she had ever seen, she squawked. "Vadim, that's too much!"

"Nonsense," he said with a scoff. "You're the first person I've heard of getting a new job in this kind of climate, but if today's your first day, then you need to be fueled up. Besides, how many times now have I told you that you're thin as a rod? I don't know how you made it three years as a cop looking like a string bean, but if your new gig is as physical as your old then you'll need to pack on some more meat."

"I'm *lean*, Vadim," Catra said. "And we both know this isn't what I'm supposed to eat if I want to bulk up. You're going to ruin me." Vadim only laughed.

"The extra is on me," he said, referring to the comical portion sizes. "As a thank you for always being a loyal customer, and as an apology for the server at the door. She's new-ish."

"Don't even worry about it," Catra said, meaning it sincerely. "We're all under a lot of weird stress right now, so I understand. Thanks for making an exception and letting me in."

Vadim nodded and wandered off to help his staff hand out food at the front. Catra could hear the sounds of the crowd nearby, could hear the anguished and anxiety-stricken voice of men and women and children worried about where they're going to shelter and where they'd get their next meal after this one. It intermixed with the measured, energetic voices of the anchors on the TV, who were entertaining a guest on their panel and drawing out his predictions for the kinds of announcements that were going to come out of Moriarty's mouth within the hour.

Catra reached inside the collar of her shirt and pulled at the leather cord there. The apeiron Taline gifted her popped out, hanging at the end of the cord, shining blood-red, held in place by an elaborate knot that wrapped the entirety of the crystal. It was beautiful—a reminder of Taline's trust in her as Sentinel—and Catra had made a habit of bringing it out and staring at it whenever she was alone.

She put it away, chastising herself for being so ready to expose something so valuable and irreplaceable in public, and instead busied herself with her PDA. She propped her left elbow on the table and flipped through the menus on the screen while she picked at individual fries in the basket and took small sips of the Mai Tai. She briefly considered reaching out to Taline, again, before quickly and vehemently rejecting that idea.

It was embarrassing, how many times she had hemmed and hawed about reaching out and telling her of her plans with Diallo. It was especially bad in the days after having approached him and agreeing to help, since it felt weird to be both officially and unofficially going behind Taline's back on some undercover mission. And when she finally mustered the courage to actually do it—managed to actually send a call request through and wait—Taline had picked up, answering her with a harried voice, deep in the middle of preparing for Moriarty's rally with twenty other very important-looking people.

And that hadn't even been the worst part. Even after interrupting Taline's meeting, even after hearing Taline's concerned voice prompt her through the line, all the courage Catra had pulled together to make the call in the first place fled all at once, and she hung up after making a number of halting excuses Catra still couldn't think back on without flushing in embarrassment. She had vowed, right then and there, to erase the term 'butt dial' from her vocabulary entirely.

Diallo had been right, again; if Taline had been asking Catra to read between the lines and commit espionage on her behalf when commissioning her as a Sentinel, what exactly was Catra expecting her to say when she called her in the middle of an administrative meeting to ask about it?

She felt another flush of embarrassment creep up her neck. To distract herself, she navigated to Glimmer's contact card on her PDA and tapped the 'resend' button on the message waiting there—the one she had drafted and tried to send days earlier already. She watched the little 'sending' animation with bated breath,

picking at another grouping of fries slathered with cheese from the basket and eating them.

The message failed to send, and Catra resisted the urge to rip the PDA off her arm and throw it at the wall. The PDA would be fine if she did, but then she'd have to apologize to Vadim for damaging his pub. Entrapta's gadgets were near-indestructible, even so many years on.

Reaching out to Glimmer again was a bad idea; she was looking for a distraction, not more worries. The fact she hadn't heard from her or couldn't get ahold of her still was bad. The chances she was still in hyperspace were slim, which meant that wherever she had been sent off to, it was dangerous and top secret. The last time something like that happened was when she was deployed to Rinne, and Catra feared for Glimmer's mental health as much as her physical safety if that's the situation she had been thrust into once more. It also didn't bode well for the conflict with the Beast as a whole, if yet another incident like that were to crop up.

When Catra dove back to her PDA a third time—desperate for a distraction from her original distraction—and came across Adora's name, she almost shut the device off altogether. Out of everything she could tempt herself with, *why* was she tempting herself with Adora of all people? Why did she even still have her contact info at all? It wasn't like she'd be able to send her a message. Writing anything to that contact of her's in the PDA would only forward it to Glimmer, who'd forward it to Salas, who'd get it to Adora maybe in a month. By that time, whatever insanity might have possessed Catra to write to her in the first place would long have worn off.

Memories and thoughts and emotions about her old friend flooded back to her, and she was too sleep deprived and tense to fight the tide. Catra wondered what Adora was doing, wondered whether she ever thought about Catra as Catra was thinking about her in that moment, and wondered about if she found a way to use She Ra again, even though it had barely been a week since Glimmer told her she still hadn't. All this while grabbing cheesy fries by the

fist-full and shoving them into her mouth as quickly as possible, not caring that the cheese got all over her hands and stained her fingers with grease.

She was pulled out of her spiraling thoughts when a spike of alarm lanced through her mind. Catra's ears perked up, and her fur stood on end. Her heart pounded and she knew her pupils were slits because of how laser-sharp her center of vision had grown when she snapped up and looked toward the front of the Tailchaser. It felt as if something were stalking her with the intent to kill, although she had no idea what. Even her claws were out.

Catra counted heartbeats.

…One...

…Two...

…Three...

Someone yelled out front. There was a crash, followed by the sound of shattering glass: someone—not the first person who yelled, but someone different—had fallen, dropping a half dozen glasses and shattering them on the floor by the sound of it. Catra almost got up from the booth to investigate, but she heard Vadim ask the person who fell if they were okay, heard the waitress she bumped into earlier respond saying she was fine, and heard the sounds of the refugees around them help her up. Another person offered to help clean up the shattered glass.

A moment passed, and the waitress came around the corner, the front of her serving uniform stained with drinks. She rushed into the women's bathroom at the rear. Vadim popped back for a second too, grabbing a broom and dustpan before disappearing once again.

*Weird*, Catra thought. It was like she had picked up on something bad happening long before it actually did, almost like she had a premonition. *That wasn't the only weird thing to have happened recently either,* she thought, as she reminisced about what

happened with Trayn's suspect and the Motherbrain back at the precinct. She really needed to get some sleep—pushing the gas this hard for this long couldn't be healthy.

When she reached for the fries again, she saw a translucent young woman, about as tall as her drink glass, standing next to the basket on the table and staring at it with big eyes.

"Fucking hell!" Catra yanked her arm away and scrabbled as far back into the cushions of the booth as she could.

"Well, that's rude," said the miniature woman, cocking a hip and giving her a sour look.

"Who the fuck are you?"

"I'm Pip!" The woman turned and faced Catra full-on, legs wide, both hands on her hips, and a giant smile on her face that reached to her eyes. She was the embodiment of sunshine happiness, and it especially creeped Catra out.

*I have to be going crazy*, she thought, pulling into herself. *All those sleepless nights, all those caffeine pills and coffee…they've all caught up to me. This is it. I'm nuts.* She took a closer look at the girl. *Why does she look strangely familiar?*

Pip wandered closer toward her on the table and stared straight up at her. "Oh, come on now," she said. "You aren't crazy. Well, maybe you are just a bit. I haven't seen much, but anyone would be a little crazy with all the nightmares you've been having."

"You…you're in my head?"

"Yes, of course I'm in your head, silly. I've been here for almost a week now. Don't you remember?"

Catra thought. What happened a week ago? The only thing was her talk with Taline after Glimmer left. The first one, where she showed her Evelyn's old lab and then…oh.

“You’re the big project Taline’s sister was working on before she died?” Catra asked, keeping her voice low. “You’re a program?”

“I prefer the term artificial intelligence, thank you very much. But yes, I was Evie’s last creation. Taline’s had me since she died, and now she’s passed me along to you.”

Catra narrowed her eyes at the girl. She had a pixie cut and wore a sun dress that twirled with her movements. Catra lowered herself so her face was level with the table, driven by instinct, and slowly extended a clawed finger to poke at Pip’s form. To her utter astonishment, she felt something when her finger passed through; Pip wasn’t corporeal, but she *was* there.

“Hey, stop, that tickles,” Pip said, avoiding a second prodding by disappearing and reappearing behind the drink glass.

“Why are you just showing up now?” Catra asked. “Taline gave you to me a while ago, didn’t she?”

“She injected the nanites that let me interact with you like this a week ago, but it still took some time for them to activate, and then more time for me to get familiar with your physiology and psyche.” Pip stepped out behind the glass and smoothed her dress. “I’m still not fully integrated, but I’m far enough along that I can finally manifest and talk to you like this.”

“Huh.” Catra sat back and considered that.

“I have to say though,” Pip said. “I think your concern for your friends is really sweet.”

“You think my what?”

“You keep worrying about Glimmer. And Adora. Especially Adora.”

Catra’s heart froze.

“She shows up in all your dreams,” Pip said. “And just now you were wondering whether you should try and reach out to her

again or not. It's sweet."

More images of Adora came flooding back, unbidden, and Catra panicked.

"See, you're thinking about her now, too. Also, I like your little arm device. It's old and really inefficient, but I could tell your other friends put a lot of effort into it. I mean, just look at all these messages."

Catra's PDA came to life on its own, and one of the first messages Entrapta and Scorpia recorded on it began to play on the screen.

"Hi Catra!" the both of them said, although Scorpia's voice and face were thick with tears. "So, we're kind of recording a lot of this one last minute since apparently you may be leaving tomorrow. We wanted to just—"

"Stop! Stop, stop, stop!" Catra mashed the exit icon. She had seen all the videos they had sent her over the years, including the ones Glimmer had transferred during their last meeting—she just hadn't seen *that* video. It brought back too many powerful memories she didn't know how to navigate.

The screen went dark and Catra rounded on Pip. "What the hell?" she said, practically exploding on her.

Pip shrank back with a fearful look on her face. "S-sorry," she said. "I just thought it was really cool and…I didn't know those were private. Sorry."

Catra massaged the pinch in her brow away and took a deep breath. Part of her wanted to ask how she could not know it was private when she apparently knew everything else in her head, but Pip had admitted she wasn't fully integrated yet either.

"It's fine," she said. "That video is…it comes with a lot of emotions attached to it. I still haven't watched it. I was just…surprised, seeing it pop up all of a sudden."

“I understand,” Pip said, with an apologetic look. “This is technically the first time we’re meeting so…I might have gotten a bit excited. Just, uh…just let me know if I start yanking up things I shouldn’t and I’ll back off.”

“It’s fine,” Catra said. “It just caught me off guard, like I said before. Warn me next time you do something like that.”

She had to admit, having Pip in her head felt a lot better than Shadow Weaver or the Emperor. Pip just felt like some overly happy buddy, eager for her company. That, along with the fact she was yet another example of the trust Taline had invested in her, was enough to make Catra actually feel happy about this development. Pip seemed to feel that emotion radiate off her too. The embarrassment wiped from her face, and the smile she had showed up with from the start reappeared.

Something else tugged at the corners of Catra’s awareness, again like a premonition, and she looked to the bathroom doors. The waitress who had rushed inside earlier had left, and was standing there, frozen mid-step on her way back to the front. She had a new shirt on, and was looking directly at Catra with a perturbed expression.

::She can’t see you, can she?:: Catra asked. To her surprise, the idea had formed in her mind, instead of as words on her lips.

“Nope, only you can see and hear me,” Pip said. “You’d better be careful what you say out loud or else people will think you’re just crazy talking to yourself. Good thing you’ve figured out how to communicate with me through your thoughts.”

::Noted,:: Catra said. The waitress shrugged her shoulders before stalking away, and Catra let out a breath of relief. She glanced back down at Pip, who was waving goodbye. ::Why are you waving to her if she can’t even see you?:: she asked, equal parts amused and exasperated.

“Well I don’t want to be rude!” Pip said.

Catra still wasn't convinced she wasn't actually having a conversation with a figment of her imagination, rather than a real AI. If later, she found out she had indeed been going nuts, then she honestly wouldn't be surprised.

"I heard that," Pip said, offended.

The television above the bar drew her attention again with its music, and the anchors returned.

"And now here comes Moriarty, walking up the stage to give his annual rally speech," the female anchor said. "What kind of policies will he lay out for the denizens of Phoenix Station and the region in general? You've heard hours of speculation, now let's tune in and find out from the man himself."

::Time to go,:: Catra said to Pip, grabbing the last portion of cheese fries with both hands and stuffing them in her mouth before chugging her drink. ::I promised to meet Diallo as soon as the speech started. Unless you already knew that from being in my head for a week?::

"You've only been agonizing about it all day every day since agreeing to help him," Pip said, all sarcasm.

::Yeah, yeah, okay I get it. Watch yourself you cheeky robot. You may be in my head and can read my thoughts, but that can be just as unpleasant for you as it is off-putting for me if you don't behave.::

She had become aware of a fuzzy, roughly formed, separate entity in her consciousness that she guessed was Pip. Catra sent an amalgam of vaguely threatening impressions and emotions across the bridge connecting their psyches and felt a twinge of satisfaction when Pip squeaked next to her.

"Okay okay, I get the hint," she said. "I'll be good, I promise."

Catra smirked. *Good*.

Vadim said everything was on the house, but she pulled out more than enough to cover what the charge would have been and left it on the table. Pip floated up and rested on her shoulder. Catra felt at the sidearm she had strapped to her hip and at the stun baton against her thigh, double checking that they were still there. Then left out the back to go find Diallo.

Chapter End Notes

> One reason why I have so many scenes with Catra talking to seemingly brand new people almost every one of her chapters is because I wanted to show, after three years off on her own, she really does have a whole life and group of friends that's completely separate of Adora and Etheria and the Horde. For as much as she feels down about herself or feels unworthy of things, she did alright for herself in the end :) It's not every day the proprietor of a restaurant will give you special treatment and seat you during an emergency lockdown, then give you massive portions of "your regular order" on the house.
>
> The "::" punctuation for Catra and Pip's mental dialogue is ripped straight from Ghost Brigades, by John Scalzi. It's what's used to denote how the Ghost Brigade soldiers speak to each other telepathically.

# A Pilot's Intuition

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A boulder stood behind one of the megaliths in the compound. Several stories tall, it had a good view of Tir in the distance and of the rocky steppe between. And because almost no one wandered in that corner area of the compound, it was Glimmer's favorite spot to hide out at when she needed a break from everything.

The panic attack back at the pavilion had long since abated; it had only taken a few moments of solitude for her to calm down, but that only made room for another issue altogether. She sat there at the top of the rock, hunched over, knees high, with one hand grasping a fistful of hair and the other staring at yet another unfinished draft to Bow on her PDA.

She huffed and deleted the whole thing. Nothing she had typed seemed right, no matter how many times she tried. A simple "Hey what's up?" sounded like she was playing ignorant to the tension between them still going strong after all these years. An "I miss you," came on too strong for her liking, and a "why didn't you send me anything last month?" was a sure way to guarantee he wouldn't respond at all.

She pictured him somewhere on Etheria—maybe at Entrapta's lab, maybe at Bright Moon with Adora, or, possibly, somewhere with Swift Wind and Sea Hawk. Then she imagined the irritation on his face at seeing a notification from her, bothering him with whatever she had sent, and gave up trying to draft a message altogether. Maybe it was too much to hope he'd forgive her for having left so soon after the emperor's invasion, on top of everything she had done before first activating the Heart. It was funny, how three years could feel like an eternity and a blink of an eye at the same time.

She groaned and she leaned back on her hands, staring out at the city and the mountains in the distance. Judging by how low in the sky the sun was, she had likely been sitting there alone for hours already. How time flew when she thought of him, good or bad.

A sound echoed up to her atop the rock then. It sounded like a pair of people walking by, likely having come from using the secluded bathroom nearby that no one knew about. She listened to their voices talking excitedly to one another, their footsteps growing closer, and sat as still as she could. The footsteps and voices started to recede, and she thought she had made it through unnoticed until…

"Glimmer, is that you?" said one of the voices from down below.

"I'm off for the rest of the day," she said, angling her voice down at them without turning to look. "I already cleared it with my shift leader and I'd rather be left alone right now. Please go away."

"Is everything okay? You're kind of high up there."

Did they not understand what wanting to be left alone meant? Glimmer turned to shout at them and regretted it the moment she peeked over the lip of the rock to look down. Kyle and Rogelio were standing at the base, staring up at her.

Lonnie had told her she wouldn't recognize Kyle if she saw him again and she was dead wrong. He had filled out somewhat and his face looked significantly less boyish and soft than it had when last she saw him, but she knew it was him the moment they locked eyes.

"I-I'm fine!" she said, suddenly wishing she could disappear. "Just not feeling well, so I took the rest of the day off." She had assumed they had all returned to the *Omen-Kador* in orbit when her PDA warned her they had gotten off duty. What the heck were they both doing down in the compound?

"You should be in the infirmary, or at least resting if you aren't feeling well," Kyle said. "What are you doing up there on that

rock?”

Glimmer slunk back to the center and hugged her knees closer. They couldn’t see her at all if she did that, and she hoped they’d eventually just leave her alone and be on their way. Instead, Glimmer heard Kyle say something else she couldn’t quite make out—likely to Rogelio—and then she heard a rhythmic clinking sound ring out from down below. When she peeked back over the edge, she saw Rogelio ambling off in some other direction, and saw Kyle scaling the boulder with an ice pick.

“What are you doing?” Glimmer asked, incredulous. “This rock is like, four stories tall. You’re going to hurt yourself!”

“Help me up then!” he said, slamming the pick into the rock again. “I’d rather not fall if I can help it.”

Glimmer threw her head back and groaned again before drawing a quick spell. It grabbed Kyle by the midsection and hoisted him up to the top to join her.

“Thanks,” he said when she let him down gently. “Way easier than doing that the other way.”

“Why do you even have an ice pick?”

“Would you believe me if I said it was standard pilot survival gear?”

Glimmer narrowed her eyes at him and Kyle laughed.

“It’s not standard,” he said, realizing she wasn’t in the mood for jokes. “But I always keep it on me. We crashed into the side of a cliff on one of my first missions and had to scale our way out. Didn’t want to be caught without something like this again after that.” He folded the pick into a compact form, rolled up his left pantleg, and clipped it to the innards of the prosthetic there. Glimmer’s eyes went from narrow to saucer-shaped when she saw.

“Is that…how did that happen?” she asked. “Did you lose your leg one of your deployments too?” When she realized she had been staring, she raised her eyes to look at Kyle instead. He was giving her a confused look with his head tilted to the side, and she feared she had asked something terribly insensitive. “Sorry,” she said, waving her hands. “I didn’t think when I asked that, I just—”

Kyle sat down cross-legged next to her. “It’s fine. I actually lost it way back on Bright Moon. The emperor’s first assault caught us completely off guard and I lost the leg in the attack. A ceiling beam fell on my leg and Adora and six more people had to lift it off me. The doctors couldn’t save it.”

“I’m so sorry,” Glimmer said. Kyle had lost it before they had even parted ways to begin with. How had she not noticed at all that someone was wandering around with either a whole leg missing or wobbling on a new prosthetic at the time?

“It’s fine, really.” Kyle chuckled and gave her an easy smile. “I’m more than used to it after so long. Besides, it lets me store the ice pick without having to really worry about putting it in a bag or something.”

Glimmer nodded and a beat passed between them. “You know, I’m a little surprised you wanted to come up here and talk to me.”

“Why would you say that?” Kyle asked. He seemed genuinely confused.

“Well, y’know…I kinda turned the three of you down from being your Battlemage leader.”

“Technically you turned down twelve of us,” Kyle said, and the words nailed Glimmer like a punch to the gut. “Me, Lonnie, Rogelio, and I think nine other non-Vanguard grunts?” When he saw how Glimmer shrank under each of his words, Kyle laughed again. “It’s fine, I’m not mad.”

“You aren’t? Why not?”

"Just aren't," Kyle said with a shrug. "Lonnie is a different story, but me? I was a little confused and worried when I found out. It just didn't seem like the 'you' I had known to turn down an opportunity like that, but I wasn't mad, really. Rogelio is fine too in case you were curious."

Glimmer breathed a sigh of relief and stretched her legs, splaying them out before her on the stone. "A lot has happened since I left home…since that day in the emperor's throne room and since…"

"Rinne?" Kyle finished for her what Glimmer couldn't say aloud.

She swallowed, with some effort. "I've come a long way, especially after Taline's mentorship, but leading and taking responsibility over someone else's lives in battle is just not something I'm prepared for yet."

"Yeah," Kyle said, mirroring Glimmer's posture. "You don't have to explain yourself to me. I might have heard a thing or two here and there about what happened."

Glimmer nodded. "So," she said, after another beat of silence. "Vanguard pilot huh? And one hell of a good one from what Lonnie told me."

"Last I checked, you have to be 'one hell of a good whatever it is you are' in order to be in the Vanguard," Kyle said. "But yeah, I guess I'm okay."

Glimmer snorted. Since when had Kyle developed such a fine balance between self-deprecation and a Catra-like smugness in his sense of humor? "How the heck did that happen? No offense, but I didn't peg you for a daredevil pilot back home when we were on opposite sides."

"You remember when we kidnapped you and Bow from Frosta's Princess Prom?"

The fact Kyle brought *that* up, and so casually too, surprised her. "Yeah, I remember," she said, carefully. "That wasn't very fun."

"No, it wasn't," Kyle said, shaking his head even though the nostalgia in his voice betrayed him. "And you probably don't remember this part since Catra tied you both to a chair and blindfolded you after taking off, but Scorpia was the one piloting the ship at the time."

Glimmer frowned, trying to remember what happened that night. It turned out she couldn't remember much, her strongest recollections being of what happened after, when she arrived at the Fright Zone. "I do remember a lot of screaming and yelling on the trip out," she said.

"She nearly crashed the ship. Three times. Catra and Lonnie were so pissed, and I was sick about four times during the journey and then another three times after we arrived. I promised myself that I'd never let her pilot a ship again if I could help it, so I started signing up for all the flight sims in the Fright Zone."

"And you just, what? Tapped into something you didn't know you had?"

It was Kyle's turn to snort. "No, I was terrible. For a long time. It took so much practice to not just crash on every landing approach, even the easy ones. Lonnie and Rogelio were so nervous the first few times I took them out on a real flight."

Kyle smiled as he reminisced, and the mood had relaxed enough between them Glimmer couldn't help but smile too. She had gone from fearing that this person hated her guts to being grateful he was there sitting next to her. She hadn't realized how lonely she had been, even after only a handful of days away from Phoenix Station.

"Sorry if you really didn't want to be bothered up here," Kyle said, breaking the silence that had stretched between them. "Like I said, I was more worried than upset hearing you wouldn't take us on, and seeing you up here by yourself only made me more worried."

“It’s okay,” Glimmer said, waving him off. “I just like to find quiet spots sometimes to get away. I found this place the first day we hit the surface.”

“Do you ever come here because you feel overwhelmed with everything, or is it really just a break spot?”

Glimmer gave him a sidelong glance. “Both,” she said. “Usually the former.” She didn’t tell him a panic attack was what brought her out there that day to begin with.

“I saw Catra do the same thing when she’d get overwhelmed,” Kyle said, nodding. “Heck, I do it too sometimes, when it all gets too much.” He tilted his head and gave her a thoughtful look. “How are you feeling right now, with everything?”

“Maybe I am feeling a bit overwhelmed,” Glimmer said, leaning back on her hands. She hadn’t planned on volunteering that information on her own, but after he had asked, and in such a relaxed way too, she found she actually wanted to answer. A question played at the back of her mind then, something she was desperate to know but wasn’t brave enough to ask outright. She decided to skirt around the topic instead. “What do you think of Catra?”

“What do I think?”

“Well, what do you and Rogelio and Lonnie think of her, I suppose.”

“Lonnie can’t stand her,” Kyle said. “I wouldn’t put either of those two in a room together—they’re both incredibly hot-headed and emotional people. Rogelio likes to pretend he’s indifferent about her but I know he misses Catra from time to time too. They actually got along somewhat before Adora left and Catra…well, yeah.”

“And you?”

Kyle sighed. “My feelings are a little more complicated, I guess. She used to scare the crap out of me when we were younger. I kinda got the feeling Shadow Weaver was doing some shady stuff to her behind closed doors too, but…“ He trailed off and shrugged, not able to find the words. Glimmer didn’t blame him.

“’Shady’ is an understatement if I’ve ever heard one,” Glimmer said, remembering the first time Catra fully opened up to her about her relationship to Shadow Weaver.

“I probably don’t know the half of it then,” Kyle said. “But to me, I guess I just didn’t know how to be or act around her. Catra was so swayed by her emotions, all the time. I still remember when I first tried to talk to her after she came back from a private meeting with Shadow Weaver. I wanted to do something to help because she seemed so on edge, but it was like I poked a sleeping bear. She snapped at me and”—he whistled and made an ‘exploding’ gesture with his hands—“it just didn’t end well.”

“That’s Catra for you,” Glimmer said, looking away with a sad smile. “Textbook definition of a ticking time bomb. Or at least, she was. She’s gotten better now. A lot better.”

“I believe it,” Kyle said. “She was terrifying, you know, but she also inspired me quite a bit. Especially after Adora left.”

Now that was surprising. “Catra went off the deep end after Adora left,” Glimmer said, raising both eyebrows at Kyle. “You do realize that, right?”

“Yeah, of course I do,” he said. “She opened a portal that nearly swallowed the world, she was so far gone. I remember.”

“Okay, then what about all that was inspiring to you?”

“Definitely not the portal opening part,” Kyle said with a chuckle. “Like I said, it’s complicated…but if I had to put words to it, I would say it was inspiring to me how she took such huge blows to her pride, to her plans, to her relationships, and instead of

crumbling under the stress, she doubled down on herself and worked harder the next time around."

Glimmer furrowed her brow and considered that.

"She was pretty lazy growing up you know," Kyle said. "She always showed up late to everything, always did the bare minimum, always gave everyone lip. I'm not saying it was justified, because it wasn't, but she didn't exactly make it hard for Shadow Weaver to find things to thrash her for. A lot of the other cadets started taking bets behind her back on how long it'd take her to crack when Adora defected."

"That's terrible," Glimmer said, fixing him with an acid glare.

Kyle frowned and nodded. "It was," he said, not looking her in the eye and instead staring out at the view. "That was one of the only times I stood up for someone before I became a pilot. I got my ass beat for it and felt good about it, strangely enough."

"You…stood up for her?"

"I was the *only* one who stood up for her at the time. I was the only one who said she wouldn't crack when everyone was taking those bets."

Glimmer tried to wrap her head around everything Kyle said. Adora had shared bits and pieces of what life in the Horde was like for her, but Glimmer had never thought too deeply into it. In fact, apart from that one conversation about Shadow Weaver, Catra hadn't delved too deep into her childhood either, and Glimmer hadn't pushed.

Kyle shifted next to her. "I guess what I'm trying to say is, when she felt at her lowest point, instead of giving in and giving up, Catra chose to work her ass off instead. She wanted to prove to everyone she was somebody worth paying attention to." He took a deep breath and Glimmer could tell he was working through some deep emotions to get his words out.

"I admired her for that…her drive to prove herself in the face of all those setbacks. I guess seeing her do that inspired me to do the same. Not that it excuses some of the crazy shit she did and the horrible things she put us through when she was second in command, but I know I wouldn't be half the pilot I am today if I didn't see her work so hard back then. Whenever I felt like giving up on my own training, I'd just think about what I saw her put herself through, and suddenly all my problems seemed trivial by comparison."

"I didn't consider it like that," Glimmer said. "Her and I didn't start getting close until we were stuck in a room together on the emperor's citadel."

"We've all had our different interactions with her," Kyle shrugged. "Like I said, if you ask Lonnie, you'd get a different response. Why did you want to know, anyway?"

"Why did I want to know what?"

"Why did you ask me what I thought about Catra?"

"Ah." Glimmer fidgeted, suddenly feeling exposed. "Well, as much as I love her, I know that she's a master at having burned her bridges in the past. She's changed and we have a good relationship now, but I guess I was just curious how you and the others saw her after everything."

"I haven't heard of you burning any bridges though," Kyle said. "If anything, I've heard some very interesting and inspiring things. All the refugees Rogelio and I passed out there in the compound were whispering about how they saw 'The Angel of Archanas' earlier."

"Ugh." Glimmer slapped her hand to her forehead and dragged it down her face.

"Not a fan of the nickname? I know you've never actually been to Archanas before."

“It’s not the nickname itself really,” Glimmer said. “Some marketing nerd thought it’d be poetic to call me that because of what Taline did. It’s just…complicated, I guess, if I’m allowed to steal your own words from earlier.”

“Totally allowed to steal,” Kyle said. “And it’s no biggie. I won’t ask if you don’t want to explain it. But my point was, if anyone has public image issues, it’s not you.”

“That’s not really what I was trying to get at,” Glimmer admitted.

“Then what are you trying to get at?”

Glimmer realized then that the conversation would die of its own accord if she’d just let it, and she wondered why she kept poking at it. Then, staring out at Tir in the distance, she got an idea: the sun in the sky had set low enough that it cast a peculiar light on the spires and towers of the cityscape, and that contrasted with the orange-grey and orange-white of the mountains behind. She pointed it out to Kyle as a way to segue into her point.

“Have you heard what the natives have said about how the city looks against the mountains like that?” she asked.

Kyle narrowed his eyes, studying the view. “Not really. Was I supposed to have heard something?”

“All the Enclave and Imperial soldiers I’ve heard talk about it say the city looks beautiful, especially when the sun hits the skyline like that. But the locals all look at that and think it’s ugly.”

“What?” Kyle looked closer. “How does that make any sense?”

“The Scavrians all revere the mountain range behind it,” she said. “It’s holy land to them, although they aren’t as fanatical about it as some members of the Vestamid are about their own beliefs. The city, though, is new, relatively speaking—only a few hundred years old, and it was built purposefully in front of the mountains as a tribute to their majesty. But the natives, especially the older, more conservative ones, think it’s the height of hubris and pride to

try and make the city just as magnificent as the mountains behind it."

"It's their capital city," Kyle said, frowning. "Why would they build it that way if they didn't like it?"

"It was a mandate from some Regional Governor to build a metropolis here and make it Scavria's capital," Glimmer said. "Or maybe even a mandate from the Heartlands itself, who knows. I guess whoever was in charge of the project thought naming it like that would help them build support from the locals, but it wasn't the locals themselves that did it. They just went along with what the Empire demanded."

"All the outsiders see a beautiful sprawling city with towers that reflect the sunlight and cast pretty colors," Kyle said, "but the natives look at it like someone just took a spray can and drew graffiti before their ancient mountain."

"Exactly."

"I'm still not seeing how this has anything to do with Catra and bridges," Kyle said.

"I'm the daughter of an immortal fairy queen and one of the most brilliant sorcerers in Etheria's history," Glimmer said. "And I left home to train under one of the Enclave's most accomplished Battlemages. I've made Battlemage myself in less time than it takes most people to become citizens of the Empire, and I've even made a name for myself, what with all that 'Angel of Archanas' crap."

Glimmer picked at a thread dangling from her uniform as she spoke. Taline had tried so hard to erase that nervous habit of hers, but it had stuck. "Despite all of that, I still can't even think of leading a team without descending into panic attacks. Taline has tried to talk me through it, and I know she's not ecstatic about me staying behind at the evacuation centers. I should be deep in the city, fighting with you guys. Bow is…okay, when he

remembers to talk to me. None of us have seen anyone back home face to face in years, but…"

"You're worried about whether the people who matter most to you see a beautiful city or some pale imitation when they think about you," Kyle said, voicing aloud what Glimmer couldn't.

Glimmer nodded, and Kyle took a deep breath.

"I see now," he said. Another long silence stretched between them, this one much less comfortable than the others, before he finally spoke again. "Lonnie is mad, but then again Lonnie gets mad at everything. She'll come around. I think once she calms enough to listen to your reasoning, she'll understand. Rogelio feels the same way as me."

"Which is?"

"That whatever you're going through, you need to make decisions that are best for you. Everyone has expectations, especially for prodigy Battlemages during a time when people are looking for miracles."

Glimmer smiled, and Kyle continued.

"As for Bow and everyone else? I have no idea what's going on back home. I'm not allowed to know. But I *know* they miss you, just like how I know you don't have anything to worry about with them. Bow misses you the hardest, which is probably why he's distant."

"You don't know that."

"I don't, but also, I do," Kyle said, grinning. "I have the gut instincts of a Vanguard pilot, and those instincts are telling me you have nothing to worry about. As for leading? Only you can say whether or not you are ready for it. It's in the best interest of the squad that their leader be someone who feels fully confident in their ability…so, thank you for not putting us out in the field with you prematurely if you don't feel ready."

Glimmer felt like a weight had been lifted from her. She even believed him about Bow, oddly enough, and that was wonderful. She released her knees and stretched them out again. "Thanks Kyle…I think I needed to hear that."

"No problem," he said, glancing over the edge of the rock toward the ground. "Happy to help."

"What do they have you and Lonnie and Rogelio doing since I turned down my original assignment?"

"Aratoth has taken us on and rotates us with some of his other soldiers," Kyle said. "We still get field experience, not that we lack that in the first place, mind you, but he's making sure we aren't just sitting on the benches while everyone else tries to retake Tir. It's risky, since he's technically overstretched when we do go out with his group, but it's worked out so far."

Glimmer nodded, but didn't say anything further. Things had worked out despite the fact she had refused to step up to the plate. So why did she still feel uneasy about everything?

Kyle nudged her gently with his shoulder, drawing her attention. "You don't think you can set me back down on the ground, do you? I've really enjoyed catching up, but I'm technically still supposed to be on duty and I don't think I can be missing for much longer before someone comes looking for me."

Glimmer nodded again and floated both of them back down.

"There's one thing I should say before I go, though," Kyle said, turning to her when their feet touched the ground.

"What's that?"

"I never had a moment where I felt ready to be a pilot," he said. "And I never stopped worrying about whether or not I'd be able carry my team through danger before doing my first real field assignment. Simulations are one thing, but I always worried I'd

just up and choke when the time came to perform with actual lives in my hands."

"Do you still worry about that now?"

"Sometimes," Kyle said. "But I mostly feel fine, aside from the typical adrenaline everyone gets."

Glimmer balked as despair started to claw at her. "What was it that changed you?"

"One day it just so happened that I was the person most prepared to handle a mission. I had to go through training in the 'real' Horde after leaving Etheria, on top of all the training I did in Etheria's Horde. About six months into my new training simulations, we were out on a campaign. They needed someone to fly out and extract a team that got pinned down, but all the other experienced pilots were tied up. Out of all the trainees there, I was the one with the best scores and most time in the simulator. It would have been irresponsible for me to let one of the younger guys fly in my place, even if I didn't feel confident in myself, so I stepped up."

Glimmer bit at her lip while she considered what he had said.

"I meant what I said before," Kyle said. "You should only take command when you feel ready. But in times like now, where war and death are coming in faster than our veterans can handle, you might not get the luxury to stick to doing only things you 'should' do. You might just have to step up one day when no one else can, and hope for the best."

Kyle's pocket vibrated. He pulled out a thin electronic device and glanced at the screen.

"I have to go," he said. "I asked Rogelio to warn me if Lonnie started going on the war path looking for me, and he just pinged me. I should get out of here before she finds us." He flashed her another quick smile and ran off.

Glimmer gave him a halfhearted wave goodbye and watched him go. Her mind was a mess—Kyle’s words somehow helped and hurt at the same time, and as much as she tried, she couldn’t figure out what she should do about it.

An explosion and a low moan sounded off in the distance, carried to her by the winds of a rapidly approaching Scavrian night. When she stilled and concentrated, Glimmer could hear the sounds of battle ringing out to her as well.

She stood there for a long moment, looking at Tir on the horizon. If one didn’t know any better, it almost looked as if the city weren’t besieged by a deadly spreading enemy.

Chapter End Notes

> And here's the final scene from the part 3 poster--we already got the Catra + Pip scene and the Adora + Kal scene(s)
>
> Lonnie tells Adora in chapter 7 of this fic about Kyle losing his leg, as an explanation for why he's not participating in the attack on Horde Prime's citadel. I've had that little tidbit of character development for him planted waaaay in advance :) Who'd have thought out of all the characters, I'd make wimpy Kyle from the canon series be the level-headed outreacher, finally comfortable in his own skin haha. Someone in a comment mentioned they found it interesting how Catra was the one coping the best out of our main three, relatively speaking, while it was Glimmer and Adora pushing people away. I guess if that's true, then maybe maturing Kyle like this isn't too surprising.
>
> From a story arc perspective, this is probably the "true middle" of World Eater. All three arcs are in full swing, now it's just waiting to see which domino topples first.
>
> Thank you as always for reading! Love you all.

# A Serpent on the Beach

Chapter Notes

> The comments last chapter were so, *so* nice T.T I fully expected it to be a slower week because, even though I did work hard on the chapter and put in some nice symbolism and dialogue I was proud of, I thought reception to it would boil down to "Kyle and Glimmer talking on a rock" haha
>
> You guys are so awesome. Thank you!! Please enjoy the next chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The first thing they did aboard Eden was look for a doctor. Adora had asked why Kal had set off the security scanners in the hangar, but all Kal said was that people “didn’t want to understand things that scared them,” and, instead of pointing out that answer only made her more confused, Adora decided to just follow him and enjoy her surroundings.

Together, they pushed through the massive superstructure of the spaceport terminal, weaving in and out of aliens of all shapes and sizes pushing carts and cargo, all while Kal continued to mutter darkly to himself; her question must have really set him off.

Adora, for her part, tried her best not to stare at those in the crowd, or fall too far behind when something new and exotic inevitably caught her eye. She was doing a good job, all things considered, until the moment they left the spaceport itself and stepped into the megabuilding adjacent it.

“Try and keep up,” Kal said as he made his way through the extra-wide central corridor of the main level. “And don’t lose your jaw on the floor.”

It was harder to do than Adora imagined. If the spaceport seemed exotic and interesting, the megabuilding was on a different plane

of existence, novelty-wise. It seemed like every third step, an especially enticing store would draw her interest, or a particularly bizarre looking alien would cross their path, twice as freaky as anything she'd glimpsed back at the landing port. She almost lost track of Kal completely when she saw one particularly chunky alien, holding two of what she assumed were insect skewers, feasting on one skewer before lowering the second to its belly, where another mouth that unexpectedly appeared from the fat rolls there opened up and gorged.

"Did…did that just happen?" Adora asked, stopping in the middle of the walkway and staring. "Is that thing two people or one?" Kal hadn't noticed her stop, and she ran to catch up to him when she came back to her senses enough to notice she was falling behind.

Eventually they found their way off the main path to a small clinic, built into a corner of a secluded alleyway. Adora would have protested being pulled away from what practically was a feast of novelty out in the main concourse, but as soon as they entered and she saw that nearly every member of the staff looked like a cross between a praying mantis and housefly, she let out a squeal that fell somewhere between delight and disgust. With all interest in exploring outside gone for the time being, she slammed her butt down in the nearest waiting room chair while Kal checked them in.

"Funny, I thought for sure you would freak out seeing all these Gorm in here," Kal said, taking the open seat next to her after speaking to the attendant at the front desk.

"Is that what they're called?" Adora asked, watching them buzz and hum at each other while they worked, their compound eyes never blinking. The aliens waiting in the lobby with them were of a comparable diversity to the mish mash of oddities she saw out on the concourse, but the Gorm were so intriguing she barely noticed the others.

"Why are we here anyways?" she asked. "We've been traveling for a while now, and even though I don't exactly feel completely

healed, I don’t feel half as bad as before.” She picked at the set of bandages wound around her chest to make her point. “If anything, I feel hungry, actually. Those instant sand pouches only do so much for you.”

“Okay first of all, the fact you can eat so many of them in one sitting and still be hungry is insane,” Kal said. “And second of all, we’re here to do a little more than just get your injuries checked out.”

Adora flushed. She was hungry a lot. So what? It took a lot to maintain her training and level of fitness. “What else are we here to do?” she asked, choosing not to address his first point. She had a feeling he’d tease her even worse if she tried to defend herself.

He didn’t answer, and she pulled her eyes away from the Gorm to look at him. He was watching someone discreetly, tracking them with his eyes without moving his head. When she followed his line of sight, she saw a tall, freakishly muscled man coming out of the examination rooms at the back, walking toward them. He must have stood about the same height as She Ra, and likely weighed the equivalent of three of her, by Adora’s estimations.

Kal stilled when he got close. Adora was about to look away and pretend she hadn’t been staring when he suddenly looked down at them and their gazes met. She averted her eyes anyways and held her breath.

Long seconds ticked by, but he eventually passed them. It took several seconds longer for her to calm down, for her heart to slow its frantic pounding in her chest.

“Who was that?” Adora asked. She had seen large, intimidating people before and hadn't blinked, so why was this time different? Maybe it was because she reacted off Kal. Seeing him turn stock still like he was tensing for a fight might have tipped her off that something wasn’t right.

“No idea,” Kal said. “Trouble.”

“How do you know?”

Kal shrugged. “Just do. You get a feel for these things after a while.” He relaxed and glanced sidelong at her. “We need to get you immunized.”

“Excuse me?”

Kal turned to face her fully and grinned. “You know, vaccines? The Enclave gave you all a battery of immunizations when they arrived, but places like Eden are even more of a melting pot than most places in the Empire. You’ll find all kinds of nasty strains of bacteria and viruses floating around you wouldn’t find elsewhere. Wouldn’t want you to get a case of Greyscale or Red Death while you’re out here, would we?”

Adora swallowed and Kal laughed. He really was getting a kick out of seeing her inexperience being off Etheria, although that was leagues better than fighting opposite him, she figured. Still, she folded her arms and pouted in the chair, sneaking glances at the Gorm and the other aliens in the waiting room until they were called into the back.

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“So, what exactly are we doing here?” Adora asked, spearing another hunk of meat from the communal platter with her fork and popping it into her mouth. They had gotten her immunized and the Gorm doctor (so cool) confirmed she’d be able to take off the chest bandages after another day or so. Most of her other wounds had closed up nicely, giving Adora a much needed boost of confidence that maybe her healing factor from She Ra wasn’t totally out of commission. Now they were deep inside some sit-down place closer to the main walkway, eating something that Adora couldn’t pronounce but tasted fantastic.

Kal placed his fork down on the table and looked at her. “Okay, I get you asking that about the clinic, but we’ve been eating here for an hour and you’re still not sure what we’re doing?”

"No, I mean—" Adora cut off and narrowed her eyes when Kal smirked at her. "You're just being annoying on purpose, aren't you? I mean what are we doing here on Eden? What is this place? Who is Ly and why are we going to see her?"

"Eden," Kal said, drumming his fingers on the table, "is a scoundrel's paradise. It's one of the few places people can go to keep clear of the emperor's prying eyes." He took a long pull from his flagon of bubbling whatever it was he was drinking and called for a refill. "Ly is an old friend of mine, same as Vasher. We all worked together during the waning years of the Beast war."

"It sure sounds like she's not going to be very happy to see you from the way Vasher put it," Adora said.

"No, I imagine I'll be lucky to survive that confrontation at all," Kal said with a wry smile. "Working for the Vestamid hadn't been very pleasant for either of them, and it's likely just grown worse with me gone. We need to see her though. She's the only one that can help us fix Pip."

"And then Pip will help you read whatever's on the crystal, and that should help with the current war effort?"

"If my hunch is correct."

"If your hunch is correct," Adora said, nodding. "So, who is she then? What kind of person can fix an AI that is way more complicated than anything even the Enclave has come across? I'm totally imagining her to be like Entrapta, but maybe ten times… y'know." She made a tangled, jerky gesture with her hands and Kal laughed. "Entrapta struggled with Light Hope, so I'm super curious about who you think can fix the AI that woke her up in the end."

"Actually, I think you'll be quite surprised when you meet her. She's not at all like how you expect, but she *is* brilliant. She was part of the original team that discovered ignominite and

researched the Barrier. Ly didn't build Pip, but she did put her in me, so I'm hoping she'll be able to work something out."

Adora almost choked on her food at hearing that. Kal caught the look in her eyes, and the question that was implicit in them.

"Yes," he said. "Ly was a member of Evelyn's science team." He glanced about calmly after he spoke and then lowered his voice even further. "Although I wouldn't get in the habit of saying her name still. As out of place as Eden is, it's still not safe."

A million questions flashed across Adora's mind, but she only asked one: "You knew her?"

Kal's eyes drifted to his flagon as he tapped a pensive beat on the table once more. He shook his head. "No one knew her. Corynth thought he knew her. Ly and Vasher like to think they did too, since they worked together for years. I don't even pretend to have known her."

Adora opened her mouth, but stopped short of saying the first thing that came to mind. Something about the way Kal spoke—about the tone of his voice and the slump in his body. It told her he was answering more than just her question on the surface.

He mentioned working with Ly and Vasher during the waning years of the war. He mentioned Corynth. Was Evelyn no longer around when Kal came along? But Evelyn and Corynth had died at the conclusion of the war—they *were* the conclusion of the war, as far as she knew. It was hard to not ask for clarity, but now that she was off Etheria, Salas' warning about keeping that woman's name out of her mouth came back to her. Even if this place was beyond the emperor's reach, Kal too had still warned her to be careful, so careful she would be.

"You mentioned something just now that came up back on the landing bay," Adora said instead. "The Vestamid. I've heard some things about them back home, but nothing much. Who are they?"

“An extremely dangerous and reclusive sect of cultists,” Kal said, “who also happen to hold a monopoly on production and distribution of ignominite throughout the empire.”

“You mean to tell me the very thing aside from the Barrier that’s helping hold the Beast back is entirely in the hands of a single group of fanatics? How does that even happen?”

“Do you know how we get the stuff in the first place?” Kal asked.

“I know we mine for it, but not much more than that.”

“It’s incredibly hard to mine,” he said after getting his refill from the waitress and thanking her. “That’s why it’s monopolized. It only comes from worlds the Beast had engulfed during the first war, since ignominite is technically the calcified remains of the Beast itself. The problem is, when you travel to one of those dead worlds to mine ignominite, you experience…side effects.”

“What kind of side effects are we talking about here? Doesn’t sound like just a stomach ache.”

Kal shook his head. “Some people have gone insane from just looking at planets like that from orbit, let alone landing on them for extended periods of time for a mining expedition. I’m talking about psychosis and permanent internments in a psyche ward. Some people succumb in a matter of hours, others take a few days, but no one will go mine for the stuff. It doesn’t matter how lucrative the contract, everyone steers clear.”

“Except the Vestamid,” Adora said. “How do they do it? Are all of them already crazy or something?”

“Essentially, yes.”

Adora blinked at him in surprise. She had meant it as a joke, but seriously?

“They’re religious zealots,” Kal said, seeing the disbelief on her face. “Extremely unorthodox theists who believe they are ‘vested’

so to speak with the authority of the late Daiamid Shapers. Hence the name 'Vestamid.' They worship the Beast as their God, and believe that the Shapers like Corynth were messiahs who communed with their deity." He rolled his eyes while he laughed through his nose. "They think they are 'doing God's work' so to speak by mining the Beast's remains. All of the issues a normal person might experience on a dead planet, they just see as a divine experience—them communing with their God as the Shapers once did."

"That's…all sorts of screwed up," Adora said, placing her fork down on the table too. Her appetite had suddenly vanished.

"Agreed," Kal said, spearing a vegetable before chewing on it. "You think the galaxy at large idolize Corynth? Wait until you find out how fanatical the Vestamid are about him. Or about Taline." He shuddered, and Adora frowned, thinking on that.

"One thing that doesn't make sense to me," Adora said, "is why would they help enable us to fight the Beast if they revere it as a god? They mine its remains, and the empire uses it in weapons to fight its thralls on a more equal footing. Wouldn't that be like, I don't know…heresy to them, or something?"

Kal shrugged. "Don't ask me to explain their motivations or rationale," he said. "I don't understand them. No one is privy to their dogma, since they're so protective about it, but there are some rumors floating around saying they view fighting against the Beast as a means of purging sin—that by giving their lives at the zenith of the last war to lock it away, the Shapers convinced it to let the people of the galaxy prove their sanctity in battle against it when it inevitably seeped out of its cage again."

"They really spun being saved from total annihilation at the last minute into an allegory for purgatory?"

Kal shrugged again and Adora fought to keep from gaping at him. She shouldn't be surprised, she reasoned; there were as many coping mechanisms for trauma as there were varieties of people,

and she more than most should understand that. Still though, it was…hard to wrap her head around it, the beliefs of a fringe group such as the Vestamid.

"Ly and Vasher are working for these people?" she asked. "And you did too, sometime in the past?"

"In a sense," he said.

"I don't understand," Adora forced herself to eat another bite of food. "Everyone back at the hangar except Vasher seemed uncomfortable when their name was brought up—like they were surprised and afraid to hear the name mentioned. I get that the Vestamid are weird, but why would they act as if they were surprised to hear the name if they're working for them?"

"They don't work for them directly, per se," Kal said. "Nobody here is, technically, and certainly nobody here shares in their beliefs. On the surface, this Eden is run much like any other planetary settlement. They even had those warbirds come out to us and pretend to be Imperial Navy." He took another swig from his drink. "But this place is far from normal, remember? It's a hideout for criminals, like I said, sitting on the sunward side of a tiny planet that should have fallen into the star's gravitational field long ago already. No one is supposed to know about it or find it unless they're supposed to. Do you think the Vestamid would openly flaunt the fact they have a presence on a place like this?"

"You're saying this is a front?" Adora asked. "They supply the empire and help the war in public, and then have connections to a hidden outlaw settlement in private?"

"Not just that," Kal said. "No singular entity aside from the empire could afford the technology and the upkeep on a place like this. It's being prevented from falling into the sun, for crying out loud. But the empire wouldn't fund a location the emperor wouldn't have eyes on. The Vestamid don't just have a presence here, they *own* this planetoid outright, and no one is allowed to acknowledge

it. Couple that with the fact this isn't the only 'Eden' that exists, and you have the makings of a grand conspiracy."

"How does Horde Prime not crack down on something like that?" Adora asked. "Isn't he paranoid a group as powerful as them will cause problems? I have a hard time believing he has no idea about these underground sites, but even if he didn't, why wouldn't he at least move to take their monopoly away from them?"

"That," Kal said, gesturing with his fork, "is a very good question. People on this station? They've already asked themselves all the questions you just did, and no one knows any answers for sure. Some suspect the emperor is actually working hand in hand with the Vestamid in secret. What the heck is the point to all these stations they maintain, aside from the fact its lucrative for them? What are they planning? Or is Horde Prime working with them behind the scenes for his own reasons? It's shady as hell, which is why everyone reacts the way they do when their name is brought up."

Adora paused before her mind ran away with the conspiracies, and thought back to what originally got them into that conversation to begin with.

"If they're as powerful as some people think they are," she said, "then it makes sense why Vasher and Ly would be hiding out here. I heard that Prime conscripted or killed everyone from that old science team."

Kal nodded. "There are some still hiding out, and no one knows about it. Well, aside from me, and now you." He grimaced all of a sudden and dropped his fork. It clattered to the table and he yanked his hand back, holding it in his other hand, close to his chest. He hissed in pain, and Adora could see his fingers shaking.

"Are you okay?" Adora asked. "What's wrong?"

“I’m fine.” Kal forced the words out between gritted teeth and pulled away when she reached forward to touch him. The look he gave her wasn’t friendly. It reminded Adora that this was someone who, up until recently, she had thought of as an enemy.

“I saw the same thing happen to you back on the ship,” she said, remembering how his fingers shook when she first accused him of being a spy. She thought him just enraged then, but now she suspected differently. “What’s going on?”

“I’m fine,” Kal said again, squeezing his eyes shut as he took deep breaths. The tremors ceased and the tension in his shoulders abated. When he next spoke, his voice sounded tired. “It’s just blowback from using magic. Even after all this time, what I did on top of your castle to save your life is still affecting me.”

“I’ve heard of people getting tired from using too much magic,” Adora said. “Glimmer could barely use her powers for a while after Shadow Weaver got her hands on her, but it’s been days for you, Kal.”

“Turns out, coming into contact with the Beast as often as I did in the past has detrimental effects on a person,” Kal said, forcing a smile. “Who knew?”

Adora didn’t laugh with him, but to her surprise, he actually gave her more of an explanation this time.

“By all rights I should be dead,” he said. “Instead, I have these spells of pain every time I use…well, my spells.” He gave a little chuckle at his joke and it only made Adora worry more. It was scary almost, how he could look so feral for one moment then perfectly at ease the next.

“That first war must have been awful,” she said. “I know that’s probably putting it lightly, but just hearing and learning about what happened…it’s tough to even think about. I can’t imagine living through it, and I especially can’t imagine what fighting through it like you did was like.”

Kal didn’t say anything back, immediately. He sat there, flexing the hand that had trembled earlier as if to exercise it, and Adora chanced another question.

“Does that have anything to do with why you tripped the alarm back at the hangar?”

“Yes,” Kal said. “Those things are designed specifically to pick up concentrations of the Beast inside a person.”

“You knew that was going to happen, didn’t you? You already contacted Vasher by the time we landed.”

“I did,” Kal said, nodding. “Things would have turned out ugly if he hadn’t come. I’m…grateful he did.”

“They called you an Abomination,” Adora said. “I’ve heard that term used before too. But you don’t look or act like one, at least not from what I’ve been told about them.”

“I’m not an Abomination,” Kal said, glancing about when he said the room as if he were making sure no one overheard them. He sighed and leaned back into the seat, making it creak. “Abominations are intelligent, yes, but they’re malicious, and their only goal is to spread another infection. Not only that, but they don’t retain the memories of their host from before they were turned. You’d certainly not find an Abomination hanging around people like Ly and Vasher for eight years, or sneaking around Etheria for three.”

“You’ve been exposed to the Beast enough times that it hurts you to do magic, but it hasn’t actually turned you? I didn’t know there was that distinction.”

“Neither does most anyone else,” Kal said. “That’s what I meant when I said people don’t understand and don’t *want* to understand. All those security officers in the hangar saw was a scanner beeping at them saying I was tainted. They don’t care enough to distinguish between someone exposed and someone turned, they were afraid.” He blinked, looking morose. “Can’t say I

blame them, though. It's rare for someone to survive exposure at all, let alone enough to trip a scanner and still look relatively put together."

A kindred feeling bloomed in Adora's chest upon hearing that, and it took her completely by surprise. That feeling of isolation, of being rare and misunderstood and not by choice, she understood that. "How much can someone take before they turn, then?" she asked.

"It depends," Kal said. "Remember how I said some people go crazy just looking at a planet covered by the dead remains of the Beast from space? The number of people with no tolerance is so high, it might as well be the be-all-end-all statistic. Some 'lucky' few actually have a tolerance." He sighed. "Even still, the Beast doesn't just leave you, given time. Your body can't filter it out like other toxins. Even if only a small amount touches you, it will have a degrading effect that accumulates over the years. For me, it's been over a decade of living with it, and every year gets harder to do magic without feeling the consequences."

They lapsed into silence after that, neither speaking for a long time while they ate. It wasn't lost on Adora how forthcoming Kal had been, and she appreciated it. "Thank you," she said after some time had passed. "Thank you for telling me."

Kal nodded.

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Adora made him pay for a new wardrobe after they finished eating, only answering him with a raised eyebrow and a cocked hip when he asked what was wrong with the clothes he had loaned her. When she picked out something that fit better and didn't have a ridiculous logo on the front of the top, they found an elevator and rode it down a few stories underground. Immediately, Adora felt how much cooler the air was. It was even cooler than the hangar, and she tried to stave off the chill as she followed Kal all the way to the hotel room Vasher had promised to set them up with.

To her pleasant surprise, it was spacious and well-kept. They had a separate bedroom each, connected by a shared living space and bathroom. Low ceilings, warm lights, and a beige and black color scheme made the whole place feel cozy. Adora tested out the padding on the couch before heading to one of the rooms, saying she felt tired and was going to take a nap. Kal said nothing, so she clicked the door shut behind her and went to sit on the bed.

Truthfully, she wasn't tired at all. What she wanted was a bit of privacy so she could finally do something she had wanted to since finding out she had left Etheria: contact Glimmer.

Out of habit, she ran her left hand along the embossed patterns on her gauntlet, fingering the runestone there before turning to her PDA on her other wrist, tapping it awake. It was cracked and busted from the fight atop the Crystal Castle, but still functional, so she navigated to Glimmer's contact card and tried to send her a quick message.

It failed when the device couldn't get a signal.

Adora grit her teeth and looked at all the connections the PDA could detect. Nothing showed up, which was weird because she knew there must be at least something on this rock.

*You're on a secret settlement that's supposed to be a way stop for thugs and mercenaries,* she thought to herself. *What did you expect?*

Still, the idea of not being able to contact anyone at all out there perturbed her. Despite their shaky alliance, Adora was under no impression that Kal was actually her friend. Even if she could admit she thought they were starting to warm up to each other, she had already learned first-hand what happened when you trusted people too easily.

Catra was her biggest lesson—someone she had grown up with and had considered her closest friend…maybe even something more than a friend. And despite that, Adora still got burned. No,

she trusted to easily, and couldn't make that mistake again, ever. She wouldn't. Kal was right when he said trust wasn't something to give out easily; she was just heeding his advice.

Adora tried again to find a connection and gave up in a huff when still nothing came.

"I'm gonna go out for a bit," she said, stepping back out into the living area and announcing her plans to the open room without looking first to see if anyone was there to receive them.

Kal glanced up at her from his perch on the couch; he was hunched over the coffee table, tinkering again at the sprawling, cascading symbols and designs of Pips source code on the portable computer he had set up there. "You okay?"

Adora averted her gaze and kicked her toe into the carpeted floor. "I need to get out and just…I don't know. Explore. For a bit."

Kal nodded. "You should take some money with you then." He fished around inside the bag next to him before pulling out the wad of cash Adora had seen him use to pay for everything so far. When he peeled off a few bills and placed them on the coffee table, he said, "just in case you see something you want to buy, y'know?" before turning back to focus on his work.

Adora stood there for a moment, dumbfounded. She had expected him to refuse her, or at least balk at the idea of her going out alone. Encouraging her and giving her spending change was literally the last reaction she was expecting to get. She padded over and grabbed the money, fingering it restlessly with both hands.

"Just like that?" she asked, finally pocketing the cash. "I can go?"

"Yeah?" He sounded confused, although he still didn't look up from his work. "You know how I asked you if you were carrying any weapons before we got off? Yeah, no one else except for security and people the Vestamid consider 'extra valuable' are allowed to carry weapons. It's still dangerous out there, of course,

but you won't get into any serious trouble unless you go looking, and I know you can take care of yourself if you do."

"It's really okay? You're not going to try and convince me to stay or something?"

Kal furrowed his brow and finally looked up at her. "Did you want me to? I was under the impression you'd probably not give a damn what I'd say and leave anyway if I tried to stop you."

Adora laughed at that. "You aren't wrong. I'm just…surprised is all."

Kal turned back to the code, and Adora couldn't help but feel slighted. Was her desire to go wandering around on a supposedly dangerous settlement, alone and without any weapons really that inconsequential of a topic? Nothing she had done or chosen not to do had been inconsequential before.

"This is the first time you've ever left Etheria," Kal said, filling the silence that had grown between them again. "And there's plenty of interesting things to do here. Go have fun."

Now Adora felt guilty for fighting the urge to trust him, although she pushed the thought aside as she headed for the exit. She turned back to look at him one more time before closing the door behind her. He was still leaned over, plugging away at the computer, not even sparing her a second look. She shut the door and heard the lock click, still feeling just as conflicted about what to think of him as ever.

As time went on and she wandered, that general feeling of unease and confusion still didn't leave, as had hoped. She explored every section of the surrounding floors she could get to, heading back up to the main concourse on the ground level and exploring the dozens upon dozens of the shops that had caught her attention earlier. Giant department stores with magnificent cuts of clothes and exotic perfumes were lined up on either side as if waiting to be explored, but it was the tiny outlets in secluded alleyways, with

their assortment of knick-knacks and baubles, that really piqued her interest.

One of them had a section selling figurines and paraphernalia about the Shaper, Corynth, and Adora suppressed a laugh and an eyeroll at seeing it. Glimmer had complained to her more than once in the past of how Catra would stop and scrutinize every one she'd come across when they went shopping together on their off time. Adora had no idea why Catra might have taken to him like most others in the galaxy had, and the notion seemed especially ridiculous after seeing how flippantly Kal had spoken of him back at the restaurant.

*He might have saved the galaxy, sure,* Adora thought, *but he's just a person at the end of the day. Is everyone going to make me look like a messiah if I save people this time?*

She frowned and leaned closer, studying the mask on the closest figurine, before shuddering and pointedly turning away when it reminded her a little too much of Shadow Weaver. Maybe that was what had pulled Catra's interest to begin with.

Before long, she found the food.

Stands and outlets bursting with snacks and sweets seemed to pop out at her on every third corner after she noticed the first one. Before long, she had to fight to stop buying every little thing just to get a taste, because she'd surely get sick otherwise. Most of the stuff she wasn't even sure she could digest.

There was an arcade she explored, loud and obnoxious and flashy with games. She passed by someone up on the third floor playing an instrument she didn't recognize. It sounded like a dying, wailing animal, and although a fair amount of people had gathered who seemed to actually like the music, she couldn't get away from it fast enough. Despite her best effort to actually enjoy herself as Kal insisted, that uneasy feeling from before still followed her, clinging like a shadow no matter what she did to try and shake it.

Adora wandered through a less busy part of the megabuilding, dragging her feet, when she rounded the corner and came across a sight that actually managed to pull her out of her slump: a massive LCD screen stretched from one end of the wall to the other, as tall as she was, showing a beautiful view of trees and beaches and an ocean that stretched to the horizon. *Come see Eden's beautiful beachfront,* read the caption at the top. *The only beachfront this secluded in the entire galaxy.*

She knew it was an advertisement, just like she knew there was no way that beach was natural, either. Likely, it was another artificial construction, maintained by the Vestamid, for the sole purpose of entertaining whichever guests had come to funnel money into their pockets and further their schemes. But still, despite how obvious the pandering was, it managed to lull Adora for a moment, pulling her somewhere full of water and beaches and forests and nature, despite being so far from home.

She sighed and stared at it a moment longer, letting herself pretend for a moment she was there instead of on some sterile compound. Then she checked her PDA, hoping that maybe being out of the hotel room would afford her a connection, or at least a way to pay to get one. There was still nothing—no  way to get in touch with Glimmer, or anyone else.

Adora sighed and tried to concentrate on the advertisement again, trying to squash that lonely feeling in her chest. If even a sliver of that positivity she had felt from the billboard moments earlier came back, she'd consider it a win. She was so lost in herself trying to relax that, when the voice behind her spoke, she startled.

"Well, well, well," came the voice, low and gravelly. "I thought I might have recognized you from earlier."

Adora yelped and spun around, putting easily ten feet of distance between her and whoever was there. She recognized him immediately, mostly because he was impossible to forget: it was the hulking mass of flesh and muscle she had locked eyes with

back at the clinic. She should have heard him coming long before he got this close…how had she not picked up on it?

"No need to be so jumpy," the man said. "It's just a friendly hello."

"Little close and sudden for a friendly hello if you ask me," she said, stepping back to put even more distance between them.

"And she's got a sense of humor too," he said, taking a step forward and smiling wide enough to show all his teeth.

"What is it you want?"

"Oh, nothing much," the man said. "I just couldn't help noticing that little number you have on your arm there."

Adora furrowed her brow and held up her PDA.

The man shook his head. "The other one."

A stone felt like it dropped in Adora's stomach at that. She had *hoped* he was talking about the PDA, even though she knew he wasn't. Without thinking about it, she grabbed her runestone bracer with her other hand and angled herself away in an effort to hide it.

"That's it," the man said, taking another step forward and smiling wider. "I can feel something coming from it. It's calling me. Hand it over and I'll let you go."

"This isn't yours," Adora said, tensing her body to run.

"Oh, but it will be soon," the man said. "I can just take the whole arm, if you'd prefer."

If Adora had ready and reliable access to She Ra, she might have challenged him, but the guy was a literal mountain and she couldn't risk it. Not out here, alone, with no backup or any way to contact someone.

Adora took another step back and felt something cold and hard press up against her back. She glanced quickly behind her and felt the floor in her stomach open up, dropping the stone  there even further: the man had somehow maneuvered her against the billboard. How could she be so stupid? She had trained for *years* to handle scenarios exactly like this, and still had somehow been cornered so easily? Had she really let her guard down so much?

She bunched her hands into fists, preparing to fight just long enough to get away, when a voice off to the side drew both of their attentions.

"That's enough."

Vasher rounded the corner, striding toward them with a calm expression. "This one's with me. I don't know who you are and frankly I don't care, but you better get out of here."

Adora flicked her eyes from Vasher to the stranger and back. For a moment, she feared a fight would break out, especially when Vasher calmly but firmly rested his hand on the sidearm at his hip.

*That's right!* she thought. *Vasher was part of security, so he'd be allowed to carry.*

Even if the stranger were twenty times stronger than either of them, he'd likely not survive a bullet. He seemed to think the same, because he harrumphed and stomped off and away without another word.

"Are you okay?" Vasher asked, turning to her. The thick accent Adora had heard back at the hangar somehow worked miracles to calm her nerves.

"I am now," she said. "Thank you for coming to help me. I was right about to try and deck him in the nose and make a break for it."

Vasher looked her up and down with one eyebrow quirked. "I know you can fight, but that man would have snapped you in

two.” He made a ‘breaking’ gesture with both hands. “Like a twig.”

Adora shrunk into herself watching him make the same gesture a second and then third time. “I don’t doubt it,” she said. “How did you even find me anyway?”

“Kal asked me to watch out for you as a favor,” Vasher said. “I said okay, but he asks for too many favors.”

Adora gave a nervous laugh and rubbed the back of her neck. She wasn’t sure whether to feel relieved or incensed about being essentially spied on. “Either way, thank you for scaring him off.”

“It’s no problem,” Vasher said, turning and beginning to stump off. When she didn’t follow him, he stopped and glanced at her over his shoulder. “We need to go now.”

“Go where?”

“The Garden.” He glanced quickly at his own PDA at his wrist. “It's almost time for Ly’s show. I’ll bring you”

It was time to see her already? Adora hadn’t even realized how much time had passed while she was exploring. Maybe she had been having a good time after all? Or maybe she was so lost in her thoughts she hadn’t realized how fast time was passing her by. The fact she couldn’t tell one from the other concerned her.

Uncertain of the correct answer, and uncertain about what and where exactly ‘The Garden’ was, Adora hurried to follow in Vasher’s wake, scanning her surroundings the entire time to make sure that massive stranger didn’t sneak up on them a second time.

Chapter End Notes

> I make no claims about being clever with my naming conventions xD. Eden? The Garden? The Daiamid->Vestamid connection?

Some might think it's clever, others might think its tacky and too 'on the nose.' I myself flip flop constantly...lol

"Kal asks for too many favors" is officially Vasher's catch phrase haha

# Business and Pleasure

Chapter Notes

> I'm betting some of you are pleasantly surprised to see an update today, since it's technically a major holiday if you're in the USA like I am. I was planning on giving myself the week off, but forgot I failed to mention it in my update last week xD So instead, I carved out some time to get this chapter ready for you guys and keep to my posting schedule :)
>
> This chapter in particular is what first earned the "suggestive themes" content warning all the way back in chapter 3. There have been one-off lines here and there about some of the adult situations the characters have partaken in off screen, but this chapter delves a bit.
>
> It's nothing crazy...if you made it through Catra's torture chapter then this is a walk in the park, I think. Still thought it fair to put a bit of a heads up here either way. Please enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora watched the display on the elevator panel count down with growing apprehension. Wherever ‘The Garden’ was that Vasher was taking her to, it apparently lay deep in the bowels of Eden—far deeper than even their hotel underground was.

The elevator car slowed to a stop. A ding sounded, the doors slid open, and Adora followed Vasher out onto the central concourse of the 15th basement floor.

It was dark like night, and cold enough to make Adora want to rub her shoulders for warmth. Vasher offered his coat to her, but it smelled of smoke and whiskey, and she turned it down after imagining how comical she would look wearing it, like she had a fur-lined leather blanket engulfing her.

The longer they walked and the more of this level's concourse she saw, the further Adora came to realize that the lower levels of Eden were meant to be like a completely different world compared to what was near the surface. The ceiling was painted in a way that made it seem like there was no ceiling at all—that they were instead walking under a vibrant night sky with stars twinkling in the black above their heads. The floor was made of cobblestone, and it gave off a muted clack with each of their steps, unlike the polished smooth flooring of the higher levels. Iron lampposts wrought in the style of old oil streetlamps lit the area in misty, muted tones.

The shops on either side of the main walkway beckoned to her with a different kind of energy than the shops above too. Each seemed to panhandle for attention with their bright neon signs and window coverings, all designed with advertisings and slogans that fueled a sense of mystique and primal curiosity inside her. Adora wondered what kinds of toys a shop named 'Sappho's Playthings' sold, and what child would come so far down in a seemingly seedy part of the station for them.

"Hey there, big man," said a voice off to the side. "Are you and your girlfriend looking for a fun time?"

Adora looked and saw a svelte man, wearing too much makeup and a fishnet outfit that showed off way more skin than she was prepared to see, standing off to the side with his hip cocked out and a coy expression on his face. Vasher turned just enough to give the man a dangerous look and he stopped short.

"Sorry Vasher, didn't recognize you there." The low light of the floor combined with his neon makeup and twisted the terrified expression on his face to a comical degree. "I saw the girl and thought…well, never mind. Please don't tell Lysithea I tried to solicit you. She'll have me by the balls come morning."

Vasher grunted and Adora couldn't tell whether that meant he'd agreed to keep silent or not, but it was enough for the man. He backed away slowly, nervous look still on his face, then turned

completely around and rushed off. When he did so, Adora saw that the fishnet outfit he wore—which was already precariously designed just looking at it from the front—covered absolutely nothing of him from behind, and she got an eye full of bare-naked butt cheeks, glaring in the light because of how pale they were.

*Oh…my…god.*

She averted her gaze, but the damage was already done. That exchange had flipped a kind of switch in her, and suddenly she was acutely aware that many of the people on the concourse she had up until then only paid less than a passing glance at were dressed in a similar fashion. Couples walked arm in arm, some of them pointing excitedly at shops with furtive smiles, others strolling along in a more secretive and tentative manner with flushed faces, all of them whispering to each other in intimate voices. Even the ones not dressed as scantily as that man still wore clothes Adora wouldn't describe as anything other than 'brave.' You certainly wouldn't have caught her wearing anything like that; in fact, her and Vasher seemed to be one of only a handful on the concourse dressed appropriately at all.

Someone wandered by in a form hugging dress Adora swore was see through. Six shops in a row on either side of them had men, women, and aliens she wasn't sure even had a gender to begin with all standing outside, soliciting those passing nearby for 'company.' Adora heard one of them outright ask a nearby couple if they wanted to 'take turns watching them ride their partner like a bicycle,' and Adora nearly choked.

"Where are we?" she asked, agitated and flushed. "Vasher. Where the hell are you taking me?"

She caught the small smile that flashed across his lips. He had been waiting to see this reaction from her.

"To the Garden," he said. "Like I told you earlier."

“I don’t know what that is,” she said. “If we were going to some sleezy part of the settlement of all places, a little heads up in advance would have been nice, you know.” She stopped walking. “I’m not taking another step until you tell me exactly what the Garden is. I don’t want more surprises.”

“Are you uncomfortable?” Vasher asked, looking at her.

“Yes, I’m uncomfortable! How could I not be uncomfortable?”

“I thought Kal would have already explained. I’m sorry.”

Adora was about to go off when she saw Kal himself approaching from a distance.

“Explain what?” he asked, walking up to them and adjusting the strap of the backpack he carried so it didn’t bunch up the fabric of a fresh shirt he had put on. Thankfully, he came dressed like a normal person as well.

Adora looked up at the sign above the building they had stopped in front of. The words ‘the Garden’ were anchored above the entrance in cursive neon pink, and Adora wondered if it were life’s way of tormenting her, negating all the grandstanding she had done moments earlier on account of them having already arrived.

A long line of patrons snaked from the entrance and curved around the far corner out of sight. A bulky alien with four arms stood in front of the one open door with a glare on his face, checking slips of paper one by one at the front of the line before letting people in. Punchy music thrummed from the inside, reverberating through the cobblestone and coming through the front doors heavily muted.

“You said we were going to watch Ly’s show so we could meet with her after,” Adora said to both Kal and Vasher. “Why are we down here in what I can only assume is Eden’s red-light district?”

“Because Ly performs here,” Kal said, flashing her a toothy grin that matched Vasher’s own. They both of them were like hyenas

eyeing prey they intended to play with. “I told you she wasn’t going to be what you expected.”

Adora grumbled but didn’t say anything more. She followed Kal and Vasher to the front door. They bypassed the line entirely, and the bouncer only nodded to Vasher before letting all three of them in. The music ratcheted louder the moment they walked through, the bass thumping hard enough Adora felt each pulse rattle her bones. When they got past the counter and to the main area, she finally recognized the Garden for what it truly was: a nightclub.

Whereas the outside concourse gave the impression of an artificial night out on the streets of an ancient city, the inside of the Garden was just dark. Neon lights rimmed the walls, giving her the general outline of a large room with a spacious center dance floor. A raised stage stood in the back with a floor-to-ceiling pole installed in its center, and a number of private booths lined the perimeter. The floor was packed, and a bar with six bartenders and a wall full of booze stood just far enough away to be separate but easily accessible.

“You have the booth closest to the stage,” Vasher said. “Let me take you.”

“You aren’t staying with us?” Kal asked, as both him and Adora followed him down the steps to skirt the far wall toward the stage.

“Not this time,” Vasher said. “I’m doing damage control. Ly is not happy.”

“You told her we were here?” Kal asked.

“I feared what leaving it a surprise would do.”

They reached the booth and Adora slid in after Kal. When she did, the music suddenly dampened.

“The booths all have noise suppressor fields installed under the seats,” Kal said, seeing her surprise. Despite speaking at a normal

volume, Adora heard him easily, and still could enjoy the music in the background too.

"Come here often?" she asked, tone conveying either disapproval or curiosity—she honestly couldn't tell which herself.

"It's been three years, remember? But even before then, I wouldn't come as often as you'd think. And not for the reasons you'd think either," Kal said in a level voice completely at odds with the smug look on his face. "Ly started performing here as a hobby before I left. I have a feeling it's her main gig now."

"What did she do before?" Adora asked, only half paying attention as she watched the dancers on the floor, the DJ in the back, and the waitresses and waiters carrying platters of alcohol and food to and from the bar to the other occupied booths.

"Smuggling."

That caught her attention. "She did what?"

"Smuggling," Kal said again. "We all did. Lots of ignominite crystals and munitions across Imperial regional borders."

"So, she went from smuggling contraband with you to working at a nightclub? How does that even happen?"

Their waitress came before Kal could answer, and all interest in hearing what that answer might have been vanished as soon as Adora saw her.

She was all smiles, holding a small tablet in one hand to take their order. An intricate dragon tattoo snaked from her exposed shoulder down the entire side-length of her body, peeking out from the deliberate rips in her top and skirt before coiling around her leg and terminating at her ankle. It glowed green against her skin from the blacklight in the club, and Adora could clearly see the chisel of muscle on the exposed parts of her body—the girl worked out. Adora couldn't get enough.

She left, shooting her a wink as she turned.

“Wha?” Adora said, her brain having jumpstarted at the loss of attention. “Why’d she leave? I didn’t even get to order or see a menu.”

“She asked you what you wanted, but I don’t think you realized it,” Kal said, barely suppressing his laughter. “You were too busy gawking at her, so I just ordered for the both of us. Did you really not notice her looking you in the face and talking to you?”

Adora was glad it was dark in the club because she felt herself flush so hard her face burned. Kal finally lost his restraint and burst out laughing in tears.

“Hey!” she said, wishing harder than she’d ever wished in her life for the floor to open up and swallow her whole. “I’ve been caught off guard more times than I can count in the past few days, okay? Don’t tease me.”

“I’m sorry,” Kal said, still trying to suppress laughter. “I’m not trying to be mean, I swear. It’s just, you’ve had such a sour face on this entire time, and to see your eyes almost pop out of their head like that because of some pretty waitress is just too funny.”

Adora was scandalized. “Sour face? I don’t have a sour face!”

“Yes, you do!” Kal said, leaning forward and gesturing over their shared table. “My *god*, yes you do. For three years I wandered around Etheria and saw you on broadcasts or on visits to kingdoms. I even saw you in person a few times before you recognized me. And every time I saw you, the only thing I could think of was how miserable you looked.”

“You’re one to talk,” Adora said. “I couldn’t tell if you were a person or a corpse when I first saw you, since you looked half-dead already.”

“Half dead and still kicked your ass up and down the room until your castle woke up.”

Adora scowled and he held up his hands in a peace offering, the ghost of a smile still on his lips. "You're right though," he said. "I'd been running myself ragged far, *far* too long by the time you realized I wasn't supposed to be around. I was probably halfway there before I even set foot on Etheria, truth be told. That's why I'm especially qualified to know what a sour face looks like. You need a vacation, and that's coming from me of all people."

Adora rolled her eyes but let the conversation die, trying instead to soak in the ambience of the club and actually maybe enjoy herself. As insufferable as Kal could be, he did have a point. Even wandering the station on her own earlier only left her more shaken after that man confronted her. He had wanted her runestone, and if he somehow got it away from her? So much for ever using She Ra or Heart…so much for defeating the Beast and saving the galaxy. Sacrificing her relationship with Catra…

She was spiraling again. It was so easy to get lost.

If she didn't take the time to at least *try* and unwind like Glimmer and Angella and, god, even Salas and Kal had and *were* urging her to, then she'd truly be hopeless. Adora let her eyes wander the dance floor again, subtly trying to spot their waitress and her shiny dragon tattoo among the crowd.

The music turned down and Adora saw the DJ in the corner pull the mic mounted on his setup closer to his mouth.

"Good evening, ladies and gentlemen," he said. "Are you all having a good time at tonight?"

The crowd gave a muted cheer and the DJ shook his head. "That doesn't sound like the shout of anyone really having a good time —let me try that again: are you all having a good time tonight  at the Garden?"

The crowd cheered even louder and the DJ flashed a wide grin. "Now that's more like it! We have a special guest here to perform for you today, and I have the great pleasure of introducing her to

the stage. So, ladies and gentlemen of all colors and races, please give a warm welcome to the Temptress herself: the one, the only, Lysithea of Tantrice!”

The crowd roared again and Adora turned her attention to the stage when it lit up. A woman in heels and a fur-lined dress that hugged her curves strutted out. She rested a hand up high on the pole in the center, and Adora felt the blood drain from her head; if she had found their waitress cute enough to gawk, she didn’t think she had the vocabulary to describe Lysithea or her own reaction at seeing her. She had never seen someone so intimidatingly attractive before.

The crowd’s cheering died down enough for Adora to hear that the DJ had put on a new track—something that started with only a simple drum pattern. Slowly, more layers added onto the track, countermelodies played by synthesized tenors and altos, contributing rhythms that turned the original melody into fleshed-out chords, and a low, thrumming, throaty bass that rounded out the sound.

Lysithea hadn’t moved from her pose—ratcheting up the tension in the room by standing firm against music that compelled others to dance—and the crowd only grew more excited. The music built, growing louder, its melody and counter melody weaving in and out of prominence with one another.

Finally—*finally*—in in the final four counts at the zenith of the buildup, Lysithia pulled her dress off and threw it to the floor in one smooth motion, revealing a stunning lace outfit. Adora thought her heart had stopped. Then Lysithea hoisted herself up on the pole just as the beat dropped, began her routine, and Adora reassessed: maybe it was a stroke she was in mortal peril of experiencing, and not a flatlining heart.

The crowd went nuts, and Adora could sense at the edge of her awareness that Kal was giving her a shit eating grin. She didn’t care that her mouth was wide open; she didn’t care how obvious it was she was entranced, and she didn’t care how blatantly she

stared. The stroke or heart attack could turn literal, instead of metaphorical, and she'd die happy in that moment. The only thing her two remaining, working brain cells could focus on was not taking her eyes off the performance.

And what a performance it was. Lysithea was as flexible as she was strong, spinning on the pole in time with the music, capping particular high points in the songs with crazy, show-stopping poses. Adora had no idea how she managed it, let alone how she made it seem like pole dancing was as easy as walking or breathing.

Lysithea's routine ended when, after having climbed near the top of the double-height ceiling, flipping upside down, and holding herself there by her thighs around the pole, she dropped straight down, stopping just shy of the floor in a dramatic pose in perfect time with the end of the final song.

The crowd roared their approval and Lysithia planted her feet back on solid ground. She grabbed her dress from the end of the stage, took a deep bow, and disappeared through the back with a wave and a smile.

"Told you she wasn't what you'd expect," Kal said, grin still plastered on his face.

"Holy shit," Adora said, earning a look of mock surprise from Kal at having heard her swear. "That was amazing!"

The waitress returned and placed two drinks on the table between them. She shot Adora a smile. Thankfully, Adora had recovered enough to properly smile back and say thank you, but her reaction to seeing her and her tattoo again was far less powerful after the high Lysithea's performance had given her.

Adora leaned forward to take one of the drinks from the table and sipped at it. It was bitter, and she probably wouldn't have liked it enough to finish if it weren't for the fact her throat had gone

extremely dry. She took another sip, and another, and then another until it was practically gone."

"Slow down," Kal said, laughing. "I'm not promising to carry you out of here if you can't walk on your own." He picked up his own drink and swirled it around in the glass before taking a sip.

Adora saw Vasher and Lysithea, who had changed into more comfortable clothes, come out a side door and head straight for them. Lysithea did not look pleased, and Adora considered warning Kal until she saw he was already tracking her approach. She marched straight into their booth and right up to his face before—

*SMACK*

—she slapped him clean across the face with an open palm, sending the drink he had in his hand spilling all over him and the leather seat.

"How dare you," she said.

The DJ had already moved on to another song, but the crack was loud enough to draw the attention of the closest club-goers. They looked their direction, glancing briefly at Vasher before pointedly turning away and back to their own partying. Vasher stepped into the booth and fiddled with something under the cushion. Suddenly, the music outside grew even dimmer, and Adora had a feeling that also meant it was harder for people outside the booth to hear.

"I deserved that," Kal said, placing his now empty glass back on the table and rubbing at his cheek.

"You deserve a hell of a lot more than a smack to the face," Lysithea said. Her anger seemed to boil over once more when she balled her hands into fists that shook at her side. "How fucking *dare* you show up here again after what you did. Do you realize I'm still paying off the debt from when you abandoned us on that job?"

“I had a feeling you might still be chipping away at it,” Kal said, not shying away from her anger but doing nothing to provoke it further.

“Thirteen thousand fucking pounds of raw ignominite in that package, and I find you just sitting here three years later, sipping a Sazerac in the Garden? Who the fuck do you think you are?”

“I had a good reason for it, Ly,” he said. “You know I did.”

“You don’t get to call me Ly. It’s Lysithea to you, if I ever even let you speak to me again at all after this conversation is over, Kalanthe.” She gave a scornful laugh. “I’m surprised you go by that name still. Thought you’d change it to something even more obvious this time around.”

She cocked an eyebrow at him, looking for a reaction, and huffed when she didn’t get one. Adora tried to sit as still as she could and make absolutely no noise, hoping she might be invisible and passed over if she were surreptitious enough.

Lysithea glanced to her before doubling down on Kal again, eyes flaming anew. “And who the fuck is she? You pick up a new traveling companion after abandoning us?”

Adora winced and pushed further back into her seat. So much for being surreptitious. She tried to open her mouth and say something—introduce herself, at least—but the dryness in her throat from earlier returned and she got nothing but a pathetic gurgle out past her lips before shutting them, promising herself she’d never speak again as long as she lived.

“That’s Adora,” Kal said, evenly. “She’s the current holder of She Ra’s power.”

Much of the aggression and bluster in Lysithea’s demeanor vanished. She blinked, fully turning to inspect Adora, tilting her head to get a better look at her. “You’re not joking?”

“Would I joke with you, Lysithea?” he asked, emphasizing her full name.

She growled an insult out at him, and finally addressed her directly. “Is he being serious? Are you She Ra?”

Adora cleared her throat and forced words to come. “Yeah,” she said, clearing her throat a second time and wincing when her voice came out too gravelly. She held up her right arm to show the runestone in the bracer. “I’ve been having some trouble actually using my powers, though. Don’t ask me to transform in front of you or anything, but I do have the magic connection to her.”

Lysithea raised both eyebrows. “Well, isn’t that something,” she said, more to herself than anything. When she turned back to Kal, he was already holding up the backpack he had come in with earlier.

“I told you I had a good reason,” he said. “Every day for three years I’ve wished I didn’t have to leave you behind like I did. But Evelyn’s prediction came through and I finally got my hands on it. Even the AI managing the vault named it as such.”

“So that means…in that bag…”

“Is the Eye of Shukra,” Kal said, nodding. “And if Evie’s predictions about it are as true as her others have been, then…the original algorithm the Eternians hand-crafted for their Barrier…”

Lysithea’s breath hitched. “The imperfections in the version of it we reverse engineered…?”

Kal nodded. “We can fix them. Ly, we can finally shut the Beast away for good. Permanently.”

A beat of silence passed between all of them. The music from just outside thumped softly in the background. All trace of Lysithea’s prior anger had vanished.

“God damn it, Kal,” she said, sighing and shaking her head. “Why is it never easy with you?”

Chapter End Notes

Lmao I was either going to make Lysithea sing opera a la that one scene in Fifth Element, or make her a pole dancer.

I think having her be genius-tier brilliant and also aware of her sexuality/aware of how to use it made her a more compelling character in my opinion. Also, it opened up the perfect opportunity for me to portray gay panic Adora. How could I pass that up? What do you guys think?

Happy Thanksgiving for all you Americans out there, and see you next week!

# The Eye of Shukra

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora adjusted herself on the couch in the Garden's back room, trying to find a comfortable position sandwiched between Vasher and Kal. It barely fit the three of them, and while there was a spot wide open on the couch across from them, Adora hadn't trusted herself to not faceplant to the floor the moment she tried to get up. Lysithea had grabbed a second drink for her when she first ushered them all into the back room.

The bass of the music outside pounded away, muted, and for the third time in the half hour they had been back there, Lysithea stopped pacing. She took one hand from her hip to grab the Eye of Shukra from the low coffee table in front of them, then held it up to the musty halogen lights above to inspect it.

"So, let me get this straight, *again*," she said, the light filtering through the crystal casting a spackled pattern across her face as she rotated it. "Pip tried to read this thing and she just…what? Broke?"

"More or less," Kal said. "I'm not sure what happened exactly, but her internals are a mess." He leaned forward, pulling out the same puck-shaped projector Adora looked at back on the ship and placed it on the coffee table. It powered on, displaying the three-dimensional hologram of Pip's source code for all of them to see.

"What the hell did you do to her?" Ly said, her eyes going wide she saw the display, saw the pockets and craters of missing data spread throughout.

"I didn't do anything! I told you, one moment she had the entire fortress under control including the AI connected to the place—"

“Light Hope,” Adora said. She felt more than heard the ends of her syllables beginning to slur.

“—and then the next thing you know, she starts glitching out, disappears completely, and then the whole castle attacks us.”

Lysithea squatted down eye-level with the hologram and used her free hand to pan the display. By the way she lingered on some areas and “hmmm’d” at others, Adora got the impression she was making several deep inferences far faster than Kal had, tinkering with it for the several days she had witnessed him doing so.

“Well, it looks like none of the bespoke programming got touched,” she said. “Whatever she came across in the Eye was enough to wreak havoc on her systems, but she had either enough time or enough sense to block off everything irreplaceable.”

“Which means what, exactly?” Kal asked.

“It means the thing that makes Pip distinctly her is still preserved,” Ly said, pointing to the islands of code still in-tact. “It’s only the scaffolding and boilerplate code that was either corrupted or deleted, at least from what I can tell from a first glance. It looks very deliberate…she must have felt whatever she came across start to affect her and made the decision to guide it to only the replaceable parts of her code.”

“Can you fix her?”

Lysithea shrugged. “I’m not sure. There are a few things I could try, maybe, if I had the right equipment—which I don’t. What I’m more curious about is what caused this in the first place.” She looked again at the Eye. “If this is supposed to hold whatever original calculations or mathematical foundations the Eternians intended to put in the Barrier in the first place…why would something like that corrupt her instead?”

“Do you think maybe it was too dense for her to churn through?” Vasher asked, drawing their attention. He looked Lysithea in the

eyes. “I remember how frustrated you and Evelyn and everyone else got trying to reverse engineer the current algorithm…the long nights you all spent running Pip through iterations of it to mature her. Maybe the original is just too complicated?”

“I really doubt that,” Kal said with a frown. “She was telling me how amazing everything looked when she started digging into it… said she really wished she could show me what she was experiencing, and only started to panic after about a minute or two in. It sounded like she was trying to warn me of something she found, not that it was overloading her from the start.” He frowned, casting a quick glance at Adora before fixating back on the Eye. “There’s no ignominite in that thing,” he said. “Adora and I have actually been able to reach in out and feel around. There’s something there, Ly, we both felt it. We just can’t tell what it is or why it may have corrupted her like that.”

Lysithea’s eyes got wider and shinier the more Kal spoke. “Interesting,” she said. “Able to contain some sort of entity inside without using ignominite? It’s far more complicated than anyone could have guessed if that’s true, but I also think Kal has a point. Complexity wouldn’t corrupt portions of Pip’s code like that. In fact, complexity would have barred her from being able to double back and protect her code once she felt something was wrong, or prevented her from feeling something was wrong to begin with.

“Can someone explain why this thing is so important?” Adora asked, drawing all eyes in the room to her. Suddenly feeling exposed, bashful, and maybe too tipsy for her own comfort, she lowered her voice. “I’m hearing things about Barriers and algorithms and crystals that I only sorta understand. I just think it would…y’know, be kinda nice to get the whole picture, maybe.”

“You understand how the Barrier works, right?” Ly asked. “How it seals the Beast?” Adora nodded. “Our team researched enough of the Barrier to bring it online. The only problem was, the math behind getting it to lock correctly wasn’t there. We…well, mostly Evelyn and Pip…they did the best they could to come up with a replacement, but we were on a time crunch. It’s imperfect.”

“Mostly just the two of them?” Adora asked, dumbstruck. The idea of one person and an AI building something that complex was baffling.

Ly nodded. “I don’t question it, really. Evelyn could see through time because of her exposure to the Beast, so who knows what wisdom and knowledge she got looking through the timestream like that. It was enough for her to create Pip in the first place. Nothing else like her exists yet, she’s so advanced.”

Adora’s eyes drifted to the hologram of Pip’s piecemeal code. Ly hadn’t made the AI either…that was all the work of Taline’s late sister. Suddenly it made sense why Kal and Vasher and even Ly herself were unsure if they could fix her.

“She warned us the Barrier would fail too,” Lysithea said, hefting the Eye in her hand. “Kal believes this contains the original formula—the original algorithm the Eternians made to interface with the Barrier.”

“Ignominite was a good discovery,” Kal said. “But it was a step in the right direction that happened far too late in the course of the last war. By the time it got built into munitions and deployed to the front lines, the Beast was already far too large to defeat by conventional means. Salas and everyone on Etheria are looking at the Heart project like a be-all-end-all ignominite weapon. They think that once they get the Heart working, it will be no problem to quell any Beast threat no matter how large it gets.” He gestured to the Eye. “If we get that thing deciphered, however, and replace Evelyn’s old code with it, even at just one of the nodes, it will make the prison trapping the Beast outside our reality ironclad.”

“There won’t be any Beast incursions anymore,” Adora said, everything finally clicking together as she turned her attention away from Kal and back to the crystal. “That’s what you meant by bypassing She Ra. We won’t need her to fight or power the Heart at all if the Beast can’t escape ever again to begin with. We could take care of the existing hot spots and be done with it forever.”

“We would also deprive the emperor of a new weapon,” Vasher said. “Evelyn spoke of the Heart of Etheria too, before she died. She worried that if the only weapon guaranteed to quell the enemy fell into the emperor’s hands, he might withhold it from worlds under threat of the Beast if they did not respect his rule.”

Adora hadn’t even thought of that at all, having been so consumed with her own role in stopping the conflict. The Eye of Shukra just seemed like a good thing to explore—after all, any method to stop the Beast was worth going after in her books, especially if she was having this much trouble reconnecting with her powers still. But after hearing Vasher’s logic, getting the Barrier working suddenly jumped forward in her mental order of priorities. She’d do whatever she could if it meant depriving Horde Prime of a resource. She had broken the sword to begin with after leveraging her conviction to never become someone else’s weapon of mass destruction.

“Can you look into the Eye for us?” Kal asked. “And Pip? This station might not have the equipment you’re used to using, but anything you can do is better than nothing. At the very least, I need your expertise to tell me if what’s inside the Eye is really what we need.”

Lysithea met Kal’s eyes and held them for a moment. Adora couldn’t tell what the hesitation was for; it seemed like a no brainer to agree, but…

“What do you think?” Lysithea asked, suddenly turning to look at Vasher.

He seemed surprised to have been asked, blinking several times trying to regain his equilibrium. “I think we should help,” he said. “For once, Kal is not asking for too much. It’s what Evie would have wanted.”

Lysithea frowned. She looked back at the Eye in her hand, seeming even more conflicted after Vasher’s words. Adora didn’t understand why was this such a hard decision.

“I can’t help you,” she said at last, putting the crystal back down on the table next to the hologram puck.

“What?” Adora said, sitting forward.

“Why not?” Kal asked at the same time, similarly sitting forward with a deep frown on his face.

“It’s complicated,” Lysithea said, obviously uncomfortable and unsure of her answer. “I know it seems like an obvious choice, but there’s more to it than me just agreeing to look into this for you.”

Kal shook his head. “You were the team’s expert on crystal technology. Evelyn’s right hand. You were the one that figured out how to shape ignominite into crystals to capture the Beast in the first place. You are the reason Imperial R&D was able to study the enemy safely and ultimately figure out how to imbue ignominite into munitions to fight back. Out of everyone alive in the galaxy today, you are the most qualified to understand what’s inside the Eye. How is it any more complicated than that?”

“The Vestamid have been keeping an extremely close eye on the both of us since you left, Kal.”

“They aren’t going to make you start working for them,” he said. “They’re insane, but they also condemn breaches of contract no matter how small. We negotiated when we all started smuggling for them, remember? That under no circumstances would you or any of us assist in their business outside of strictly transportation?”

“They will not make us go against the contract, no,” Vasher said, playing with his fingers instead of looking at them. “But if she were to start touching equipment and working on anything in their labs, even just once, they would take that as a breach of contract on her end.” He looked up and at Kal. “You and I both know this. It is why she has taken up performing and I have agreed to be an enforcer for them on this station—it is the only

way we could repay the debt after they barred us from smuggling for them."

Kal looked away. "Even if they said the contract no longer applied and pressed you into service, they wouldn't endanger you. At most they would stick you in a lab—this Eden's lab, probably—and ask you to research improvements in their mining process or advances in the crystals they sell." A beat of silence passed, then he squared his shoulders and looked Lysithea in the eye. "I have no right to ask this of you, I know, but it'd be a small price to pay for only a short amount of time to save the galaxy. Wouldn't it?"

Ly sighed and Adora could tell she was warring with herself.

"Normally I would agree with you," she said at last. "If doing lab work for the Vestamid here on the station or somewhere else were the only thing I'd get pushed into, then I'd gladly do it if it meant finding a way to shore up the Barrier for good."

"Then what's the problem?"

She rubbed at one arm and bit her lip. It was the first real sign of hesitation and fear Adora saw in her since meeting they met.

"They've been getting bold behind the scenes. I don't know how to describe it concretely, but the volume and contents of the rumors surrounding them have grown and shifted in the past few years. People whisper of experiments and abductions, politicians suddenly cut interviews short or pretend to suffer technical problems or feign indifference when pressed for answers. Not too long ago, there was a huge scandal about an energy system they installed at their primary mining facility."

"Archanas is light years away from here and shrouded in superstition," Kal said, shaking his head. "You and I both know you can't tell truth from fantasy whenever it comes to that place."

"These are specific accusations, Kal, not just idle talk. They somehow got a green light to implement their new project so quickly there's no way they could have gone through any of the

normal audits for that kind of thing. No one even knows what the project is, just that it got pushed through all the normal channels so fast there isn't a tangible trail, no checks or balances for what they're doing. People are certain they circumvented the processes entirely and have the Region's governor directly in their pocket. Having free reign to do what they will on a planet like that? Even if it's far away, one misstep could spell danger for the entire galaxy. Again."

Kal scoffed, but Lysithea didn't let it deter her.

"That's not all," she said. "I'm also fairly certain they've cultivated an Abomination here, on this very station."

The mood shifted the moment she finished her sentence, a heavy feeling that blanketed them as soon as the words left Lysithea's mouth. Adora watched Kal's demeanor shift from that of someone merely frustrated, to that of genuine shock and focused concern.

"What gives you that idea?" he asked, voice low.

"A number of things," she said. "Small things. Small enough that if I pointed to them individually, they wouldn't amount to anything at all. But trust me, Kal…if you'd have been here watching the same channels I've been keeping an eye on, you would see it too. It'd jump out at you."

"I'll vouch for what she's saying," Vasher said. "I know it's alarming to hear, but I've seen the same reports and the same clues she's seen. I have no doubt in my mind that's what they've been doing for a while now—trying to craft a reliable process for cultivating Abominations."

"Just one so far?" Kal asked, looking Ly in the eyes again.

"I think so," she said. "They definitely don't have a process in place yet for mass producing them. I think they're using this place as a test site, but I'm almost certain they've managed to successfully create at least one."

Adora heard Kal say something colorful under his breath. “Do you know who it is?”

“Of course not.” Ly shook her head. “Even a lab grown Abomination would still be nearly impossible to tell apart from any regular person. They’d still have to reveal themself to you, try and start an infection. There’s no way they’d be as strong as a natural-born one either, but even if they’re weak compared to the real thing, I imagine it’d still have enough power to tear this station in two within a matter of minutes.”

“Well, fuck me,” Kal said, grimacing and running a hand through his hair. Both Adora’s eyebrows shot up—she hadn’t ever seen such a raw reaction from him before.

“Now do you understand why I’m hesitant to get involved?” Ly asked. “If I so much as look at this thing”—she gestured to the Eye—“and the Vestamid take that as me breaking the contract we signed with them? If they press me into service, it wouldn’t be me looking into their mining practices or researching more efficient crystals. They’d put me to work on this secret project they’ve been using this station as a testing site for. It’s the only reason I can think of as to why they haven’t outed either of us to Prime yet. They want me to help create Abominations for them.”

“We’ve been looking at leaving this place altogether, truthfully speaking,” Vasher said.

“How soon were you thinking of jumping ship?” Kal asked.

“If you came next month, we likely would have been gone already.”

Kal grimaced. “I understand there’s a lot at stake for you…but the stakes are even higher if we don’t get the Eye figured out. Please, Lysithea. I need your help.”

“I can’t,” she said, refusing to meet his eyes. “I know how important this is, but…but the Vestamid cannot be allowed to use me in their schemes. It could do just as much damage as the

Beast or more if they ever figure out a way to manufacture and control Abominations. Going with the Heart may not be the best option, but it may be the safest in the end. Please don't ask me to do this."

"Ly, I wouldn't be here if there was any other way. The Heart is a pipe dream at best, and if we don't—"

"Enough, Kal!" Lysithea said, finally meeting his gaze with a glare of her own and gesturing with her whole body. Anger had replaced the fear and uncertainty in her demeanor, enough to make Adora flinch and press back into the couch. "I've already given you my answer and it isn't going to change. I expect you to respect my choice, unless you plan on forcing me?"

Static seemed ready to spark in the air it was so charged. Lysithea stared Kal down and, to Adora's great distress, Kal seemed to actually be mulling his options over. Then the tension fled. Kal set his jaw and nodded once. He grabbed the hologram puck and the Eye of Shukra from the table and stuffed them both back into the bag. Then he stood, slung it over his back, and headed for the exit without another word.

Adora looked to Lysithea and Vasher, who were both shooting barely-contained disturbed looks at one another. Adora then placed her unfinished drink on the table and thanked Ly for it before jumping up off the couch and rushing to follow Kal. Thankfully, she didn't wobble or fall as she feared she might.

Kal stopped when they both reached the door leading back out onto the main floor and glanced back. Music from the nightclub blared back at full force when he pushed the door open. Lysithea looked on the verge of stopping him from leaving. When another moment passed and she still hadn't, Kal stepped beyond the threshold, and Adora followed.

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"I think we should head back to Etheria as soon as possible," Adora said to Kal. They had arrived back at the hotel without a

single word having been spoken between the two of them, and Adora couldn't help but voice her opinion as soon as they were alone.

Kal stopped and turned to fix her with a confused expression before stripping the backpack off his shoulder and tossing it off into a corner. "Why?"

"What do you mean 'why'?" she asked. "Lysithea refused to help us. That means the only other people who'd have a shot at cracking this thing would be Salas and Entrapta and everyone back home. We should leave as soon as we can."

Kal chuckled, which unbalanced her because hadn't he just been in a sour mood *moments* earlier after having been turned away? "Salas and Entrapta wouldn't make a dent in this if you gave them a hundred lifetimes over to try, no offense to their intelligence. No, our only chance is for Ly to work on it. She has the expertise and the experience."

"She just turned you down," Adora said. "Are you seriously considering forcing her?"

Kal shot her a disgusted look. "Of course not. She's going to come around and help us on her own."

"I really don't think that's going to happen, Kal. She seemed pretty adamant about not helping."

That wasn't true, and Adora knew it. She saw how conflicted Lysithea and Vasher had both looked after turning Kal away. She even had an inkling as to why she refused to acknowledge it out loud: the look of anger and determination in Ly's eyes as she made her decision, before the regret and uncertainty came, reminded Adora of someone else—someone similarly close to Adora, who had also dug their feet in the ground and refused to join *her*, only to maybe regret it later.

When he didn't respond to her and instead started browsing through a nearby tablet that displayed options for room service,

she grumbled and marched up to him.

“Look,” she said, taking the tablet from his hands and tamping down the swell of satisfaction she got when he looked surprised. “The Beast has been slipping through more and more as time goes on, so we don’t have time to waste, right? On top of that there’s apparently an Abomination wandering the station. We should get out of here now and head back.”

“Ly will come around,” he said, resting both hands gently on her shoulders. “You’re right, it is dangerous with that thing on the station, but the only thing we’re going to accomplish going back to Etheria is distracting them from researching the Heart. That’s the last resort to winning this fight against the Beast, and we don’t want to pull them away from making progress on it with something I know they won’t be able to understand. We’ll wait here for her to agree to help us.”

A strange feeling worked its way through Adora’s chest. It wasn’t the words Kal spoke, but the gentle tone of his voice, the reassuring pressure of his hands on her shoulders, and the sympathetic look he gave her. Instead of feeling confident in her own position (it made sense! It was logical!), she felt like she was unraveling.

“The galaxy doesn’t have time to wait for someone to change their mind once they already made it up,” Adora said. “She’s not coming back to you.”

Both of Kal’s eyebrows shot up at that last statement, and Adora sucked in a sharp breath. She hadn’t meant to say that. She hadn’t even anticipated it coming out of her mouth—it just…did. Her heart started to hammer in her chest. Something had lodged itself in her throat, and her eyes burned, although tears hadn’t yet fallen. She hated the feeling.

“How do you know she will?” Adora asked, pushing through the hoarseness in her voice to pressure Kal before he could say anything else that would undo her. Kal let her go and edged

around her. Adora pivoted to follow as he did. “How can you be so certain she’ll change her mind?”

“She’s my friend.”

“She *was* your friend, and then you abandoned her to do the right thing. Abandoned her to spend three years of your life alone on Etheria, trying to get that crystal and save trillions of lives. It might make all the sense in the world to her, but you think she’s going to forgive you and come around? You’re going to stake the survival of the galaxy on that?”

Adora crossed her arms and huffed. She felt even more annoyed—her words weren’t doing anything to convince even herself. She didn’t want to think about how persuasive she was being toward Kal in the moment.

“She’s your ‘friend’…” Adora rolled her eyes and gave a dismissive shrug. “What the hell does that even mean?”

“It means I trust she’ll do the right thing,” Kal said. “You heard Vasher when she asked, he wants to help us because he knows it’s the right thing to do.” By this point, he was by the door to the outside hallway, turned fully toward her with a look on his face that told Adora he was fully aware she was only half talking about Lysithea still.

“Look, Adora…having faith isn’t the easiest thing in the world to practice. It took me a long time to learn it, learn that some things were out of my direct control and came with risk…learn that you could be seriously hurt if that risk doesn’t pan out. But sometimes, it’s all we have to go on, especially at the end of the world. It doesn’t always mean believing in a higher power, either. Sometimes it just means believing in your friends, even when things are strained between you.” He smiled and put his hand on the doorknob, and the tone from his next words informed Adora he was back to speaking of concrete matters. “The Heart is a viable backup, but taking the Eye to Etheria is a guaranteed dead

end. In the meantime, we stay put and have faith my friends will pull through, just as they did in the last conflict."

"W-where are you going?" Adora asked. She couldn't explain why, but she suddenly felt extraordinarily sad. Depressed, almost.

"I'm going take a page out of your book and go exploring," he said. "I need some air. I'll be back in a bit, so try not to get yourself into trouble until I do, okay?" He stepped out into the hallway and closed the door behind him without waiting for an answer.

The door clicked shut behind him and Adora was alone. She hugged herself, gritting her teeth, still not understanding why she felt so upset. She fought back the tears that continued to well in her eyes and searched her mind for a reason—any reason—for why she'd been struck with such strong emotion.

When she couldn't find one, she reached for her power in a fit of panic, wanting to prove that she had made some progress with She Ra—wanting to feel in control of *something* for once.

The power bubbled under the surface as it always had, and, as it always had, it refused to come to her when called.

Breath coming through faster and more ragged, Adora jabbed the PDA on her arm awake.

"Please work," she said, whispering prayers to herself as she navigated to Glimmer's contact card and typed out a test message. "Please. Please work."

The message failed, again, like it was taunting her now. In a fit of desperate fury, Adora screamed, grabbed the room service tablet Kal had played with earlier from the desk and hurled it across the room. It smacked into the far wall and she heard the screen shatter when it hit the floor.

Her mind swam with thoughts, none of them pleasant. She stood there, counting heartbeats until the onslaught died down and she

could hear herself think again. Out of instinct, she reached up to fix her braid, only to find that it wasn’t even done up to begin with. Adora hadn’t put her hair up since her conversation with Salas back on Etheria. She hadn’t felt the urge to do it up again until that very moment.

Unwilling to consider what that actually meant for her mental state, Adora instead looked at the bag sitting in the corner, letting her eyes wander across it as a thought entered her mind. Then, making her decision and refusing to think on it any further, she grabbed the bag and left the room.

Chapter End Notes

Ok, three Adora chapters in a row means something finally had to happen, right?

Every time Adora has exercised her agency in this story, it's bitten her in the ass and put her in a worse spot. She's figured out a big piece of the puzzle about Catra (finally, ugh), and then gone and done something potentially horribly stupid again lmao. If you're throwing your hands up as a reader and about to write her off as a lost cause, I promise she'll get it, and soon. Had to drive some hard cracks in that armor first though, and it's happening.

Catra next!

# Infiltrate

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra watched the people on the Atrium ground floor shrink as she rode the VIP elevator. She'd been to the Atrium enough times already that month to last her the rest of the year, but this trip was different. This time, Diallo was with her, and together they were riding to the Executive wing—higher than she'd ever been before—to commit espionage against the Empire.

The Atrium was far more crowded than she had ever seen it before, too, and it wasn't just because Administration had, only minutes earlier, opened it to refugees that were now starting to trickle in. No, it was also because Moriarty's rally speech had drawn an enormous crowd. Catra narrowed her eyes and kept them trained on the pop-up stage below, where he and the rest of his entourage, Taline included, were to stand. Pip flitted into view at the corner of her vision, three inches tall and floating above the elevator handrail, humming as if she hadn't a care in the world.

"You know, people used to meet gruesome ends f-falling to their deaths out there," Diallo said, standing just behind and to her left, looking out at the same view. "Well, pushed to their deaths might be a better word than f-falling. Moriarty would assassinate his political opponents with spectacle like that to s-send a message back in the day—back before he consolidated p-power in this region."

Catra angled her head and raised an eyebrow at him.

"They s-say he wears those white gloves of his as a symbol that his hands are clean." Diallo scoffed. "I s-say you'd see the blood on his hands there still, if he only didn't h-hide them like that."

There were plenty of strange rumors around Moriarty, those white gloves of his being among the least concerning. Catra never paid

it much attention before, but still…what a weird way to start a conversation.

Something about the casual, almost pedestrian way Diallo described people falling to their deaths flipped a switch in Catra's mind, then. She crossed her arms and studied him.

"You've got a pretty good disguise going for you," she said. "The stutter really drives it home."

Diallo raised his eyebrows at her. "What do you m-mean?"

"Taline told me about how you two met," Catra said, her tail flicking behind her. "She told me what you did to 'help' her with everything in a certain person's hidden lab. You don't succeed working with someone like Taline—or working under someone like Moriarty—by being weak. You're craftier than you look."

A smile grew across Diallo's face as she spoke.

"I appreciate the compliment," he said. "You're quite perceptive yourself, although I would disagree with you on my stutter being the thing that makes people overlook me."

"What else is there?" Catra asked, noting that he had just spoken a full phrase without stuttering once. Suddenly, she was doubting it was even a genuine tic. "You're pretty unassuming, no offense."

"The stutter draws attention," he said, "but it's these that make me successful." He made a show of adjusting his glasses. "I feel more focused because of these. Level headed."

"That usually goes with being able to see clearly." Catra tried to imagine what it'd be like to not have her razor-sharp eyesight.

"See, that's exactly what I'm talking about," Diallo said. "Most assume I just have bad eyes, but the glasses are much more than that. There's sentimental value to them as well, I suppose. Not many people can say they have glasses with frames wrought from ignominite."

Catra turned fully around to face him in surprise and leaned in closer to focus on his glasses. She stared, unblinking, for several moments until...there! It would have been impossible to see were she not trying so hard to notice, but she did see the tiniest hint of blood-read thread its way through the frames.

"How in Horde Prime's nasty flaccid tentacle hairs did you afford a pair of ignominite glasses?"

"I didn't have to afford them," Diallo said. "They were a gift from the Vestamid."

"What?" Catra sputtered. "Why would they give you anything?"

"Because I'm the Administrator in charge of one of their most important systems?" Diallo said, confused. "Their main production plant on Archanas is one of my major constituencies, even if their population is near nothing compared to many of the other surrounding systems."

Catra's jaw hinged open and she shut it with a *click* the moment she realized. "You're in charge of *that* system?"

Diallo frowned. "Yes. Forgive me, I thought you already knew this. Didn't Taline tell you?"

"No, she didn't," Catra said, crossing her arms and grumbling. "Not about that. Taline doesn't talk about Archanas. She's never told me or Glimmer anything about it, really." She huffed. "I don't even know what her 'Seraph of Archanas' title means or where it comes from."

"What *do* you know about it, then? The planet?"

Catra shrugged. "What everyone else does, I suppose. It's where the end of the last war happened, where the Beast got sealed away. Taline held a fleet above orbit and punched a hole in the planet's defenses for the Daiamid to get through to the surface. I always just figured it was traumatic and she didn't want to talk about it."

Diallo “hmm’d” and Catra didn’t like the look he gave her—it made her feel like, once again, she was out of the loop on some key piece of information.

“That’s not to say I didn’t try looking you up on my own, though,” she said. “It's just…there wasn’t much there when I did. Your file is about as unassuming as you look, and no mention of Archanas at all in there either. I didn’t know that you were in charge of its Administration, just like I didn’t know there was a Vestamid mining operation there.” She paused, then huffed when the full weight of that statement hit her. “What the fuck. I thought the Empire quarantined that whole planet, on pain of death.”

Catra finished her sentence only to realize she had been talking for far too long and revealed far too much of her own ignorance. Diallo was studying her, and she suddenly regretted opening herself so wide to someone she had just correctly guessed was far smarter and better at manipulating people than she had originally expected.

“The Empire did quarantine the planet,” he said. “But, seeing as the Vestamid are such an integral part not only to the defense of the Empire against the Beast, but also, oddly enough, vitally important to the health of its economy, they are allowed access to it. It’s not common knowledge, and as such, my file is classified at a level much higher than even a newly minted Sentinel’s security clearance would have given you access to.”

Catra’s ears wilted, although she tried her hardest to keep them from doing so. And here she had thought that new security clearance was near ironclad.

“As for Taline being reticent to speak of the place,” Diallo said. “I don’t blame her for that either. You’re right in saying that planet is traumatic. It’s like a waking nightmare for her.”

“I wouldn’t want to talk about it either if I lost someone important there,” Catra said.

Diallo shook his head. “That’s not it.”

“What do you mean?”

“She doesn’t avoid talking about it because she lost someone. She doesn’t just avoid talking about it, but actively dodges any opportunity to come visit or have anything to do with it at all. Any report I’ve sent her in the past about its status has gone ignored. Losing someone wouldn’t necessitate such a vicious aversion—Taline has always attended to her responsibilities, even if it pained her. This goes beyond that.”

When Catra only furrowed her brow and shot him a confused look, Diallo sighed and pointed at her neckline.

“I know about the aperion she gave you—the one she spent years working at? Did she tell you what thoughts and emotions she imbued it with?”

Catra’s hand darted to the crystal, tied to its lanyard and lying flush against her breastbone under her outfit. She remembered Taline explaining it to her in the hidden lab, remembered how she explained she’d meditate on it for hours about her sister. Diallo’s point jumped out at her the moment she made that connection: Taline didn’t keep from talking about Archanas because of Evelyn’s death; there was something else—possibly something worse—making her avoid the topic at all costs.

Catra didn’t say anything, but satisfaction bloomed on Diallo’s face all the same. She hated how her realization somehow made *him* feel accomplished. Archanas hadn’t ever really crossed her mind before, but now she couldn’t help it. Diallo had aroused a suspicion in her about Taline she couldn’t shake, and she hated it—hated how easily she took to the paranoia.

“If she were trying to avoid dredging up memories of this nameless, formless person that, according to Imperial doctrine doesn’t even exist in the first place, well…that would be one thing,” Diallo said. “But it’s not like she’s avoided that at all to

begin with. She sat with those thoughts, ruminating on them for a decade. She plunged head-first into them."

Dozens of thoughts crowded Catra's head then—guesses as to why Taline avoided any mention of the place before. Taline had told her once, back on Etheria, that she'd explain where her 'Seraph of Archanas' name came from, but any attempt on Catra's part over the years to ask about it had been shut down before she'd get three words out. Over time, Catra just stopped asking. Now, those interactions fed the flames of her uncertainty.

"Tell me what happened," Catra asked. "Why is it she avoids any mention of it if it's not because she lost her family there? What do you know?"

Diallo didn't respond. Catra got the feeling he was trying to decide whether or not he should talk and how much to say.

"Archanas is where the last war ended," he said at last. "That, at least, is true. I was in the landing party when we touched down and saw what was left of the Daiamid and of Taline's sister. And, yes, it's where she and I first met, before we left and ransacked the Daiamid base together afterwards. It was my first time ever visiting that planet, but it was *not* hers."

Catra waited for him to continue, and suppressed a growl when he didn't. "And?" she said. "What's that supposed to tell me?"

Diallo shrugged and looked away. "I've said all I can about that. I'm trying to give you an avenue for further conversation with her on the matter, not to spill secrets that are not mine to give."

"All I'm hearing is someone being suspiciously cagey." Frustration bloomed in Catra's chest and spread to her extremities. Her fur threatened to stand on end. Why did he bring this up in the first place if he wasn't going to be forthright with her? "Archanas is a different world compared to back then. People are there spending their days mining for ignominite now, and you're in charge of them."

Diallo glanced at her from the corner of his eye and Catra decided that if he wasn't going to come out and say what he was thinking, then she had no reason to beat around the bush.

"I'm about to bring you dirt on your own constituents," she said, patting her pants pocket where the encrypted drive lay. "This is from the Vestamid too, you said. You expect me to believe you aren't up to anything having me break into Moriarty's office trying to decrypt it? What's your angle?"

"I don't expect you to *believe* anything," he said. "And frankly, I don't care what you believe. But just to set the record straight—Taline and I worked well together because I helped her all those years ago, and I helped her because it was the right thing to do. Letting the Emperor take away the last remnants of her family's work and get his hands on all of the Daiamid's research? That would have been dangerous, let alone immoral.

"If you want the real reason Taline vouched for me in this position, it's because she knows I'll do the right thing when it counts. Exposing the Vestamid and their schemes is the right thing to do. They're too dangerous left unchecked, constituents of mine or not."

Catra held his gaze a moment and, when he didn't waver, she did.

"Sorry," she said, averting her eyes. "I shouldn't have implied…."

Diallo smiled. "It's f-fine," he said, his stutter returning as his demeanor backed off into something less severe. "I understand the h-hesitation. Caution is a g-good thing in your new line of work. Y-you haven't hurt my f-feelings."

Catra nodded and they both fell silent. Pip floated up from the handrail to Catra's left.

"I get bad vibe from this guy," she said, an uneasy expression on her face. "Something about this just doesn't feel right."

::He's a veteran of the last Beast war and a politician:: Catra said to her. ::Of course he's going to feel off. I feel it too, just look at how easily he can turn that stutter on and off.:: A thought came to her and she furrowed her brow. ::Have you never seen Diallo before?::

Pip shook her head. "Should I have?"

::Taline got this guy his job and he's come to visit her enough times to drive her nuts. They've apparently been friends for years. How has she stewarded you all this time and you don't remember seeing him before?::

She regretted the words the moment she thought them. Pip recoiled and wilted without a response, looking sullen. Catra was about to say something else to at least try and smooth over the comment, or maybe understand why it got that kind of reaction, but the view and ambient light coming through the elevator window suddenly disappeared as they shot through the Atrium's ceiling. Then the doors opened when the elevator slowed to a halt, and the three of them exited onto the lobby of Phoenix Station's Executive wing.

If Catra had been impressed and simultaneously intimidated by the Atrium when she first saw it, the splendor of the Executive level far outclassed it. Whereas the Atrium and its various shops and apartment stories and ceiling-level offices—the Enclave Embassies included—were wreathed in silver and marble, this level had a distinct motif of obsidian veined with leavened-gold.

Office workers and aids bustled about, infusing the triple-height lobby with a constant thrum of background noise and feeling of activity. Several dozen staffers hustled from one of the other half dozen elevator doors nearby and Catra caught a closer glimpse of their clothing. She noticed the cut and silhouettes of several of them. Each easily cost more than a year of her salary as security, from what she remembered when she saw the price tags, perusing the Atrium shops with Glimmer in the past.

Pip had grown uncharacteristically subdued, perched on her shoulder in a casual pose that looked forced. Catra swallowed and followed Diallo to the front desk. It housed easily two dozen receptionists behind its massive, semi-circular length. A waterfall mural with the Imperial Horde insignia emblazoned on the front petered out water behind them.

*There's no doubt whose influence owns the place*, Catra thought, looking at the statues and reliefs of Horde Prime and Moriarty. *He must head this level the same way Taline heads the Embassies on the floor below.*

"Governor Diallo, h-here to badge in a guest," Diallo said to the closest receptionist when they got to the front. He put his palm on the reader and the receptionist looked over to Catra, gesturing for her to do the same. When the scanner read her palm, the receptionist's eyebrows shot up.

"Sentinel?" she said. "It's been a while since the Seraph has had one of those. Stand still and look here."

She adjusted a small spheroid camera on a stand on the desk and pointed it in Catra's direction. Catra didn't know whether to smile or not, so she kept her face even. After a few moments, the receptionist had printed out a small sticker with her picture and pertinent identifying information, and handed it over.

"Go ahead to the security checkpoint," she said. "Make sure that guest badge is visible at all times."

After pasting the sticker to her front, Catra followed Diallo off to the side, where a handful of body scanners lined up in a row were installed. For each scanner, two Imperial soldiers stood watch on either side, guiding the small backlog of staffers through the checkpoint.

Catra brushed fingers along the grip of her sidearm, holstered at her hip, and felt along the length of the stun baton hugging her outer thigh. She wasn't station security anymore and technically

shouldn’t have had either pieces of their standard-issue equipment on her, but leaving on an assignment (even an ‘undercover’ assignment, granted) without them felt wrong. But Catra just didn’t know what was going to happen once they got to the checkpoint. Would she even be allowed through with them?

“Weapons off,” the soldier to her right said as they got to the front of the line. “We’ll hold them for you and you can have them back when you leave.”

Catra considered arguing to keep them, but ultimately nodded and went to unholster the weapons. Pissing off the guards was one of the few things she felt instinctively was a bad idea; it would do her no good if she were to cause a stir before getting within even a hundred paces of Moriarty’s office.

“She’ll keep her equipment w-with her, thank you very much.”

Diallo’s voice cut through, and the soldiers, Catra, and even Pip all turned to look at him.

“Weapons are strictly forbidden beyond this point without a valid authorization,” the soldier said. “You cannot pass without relinquishing them.”

“It’s fine,” Catra said. “I had a feeling this might happen, it’s not a big deal.”

“It is a big d-deal,” Diallo said. “I’m giving explicit authorization for her to c-carry arms inside. She’s my bodyguard for the d-day with security so concentrated elsewhere for Moriarty’s r-rally. I want her armed. Check her visitor pass.”

Catra didn’t feel comfortable with this—she really didn’t want to draw attention to herself. The soldier leaned in and she stood stock-still, resisting the urge to swallow or fidget as he narrowed his eyes at her visitor badge.

“Sentinel?” he said, echoing the receptionist from earlier. Catra shrugged and he seemed to think for a moment before saying,

“Alright. If Governor Diallo vouches for you and the front checked you out then you can go.”

The soldier jerked his thumb behind his shoulder to indicate she should head through the scanner. Catra walked through and the machine immediately beeped and screamed because of her weapons. She grimaced as it continued, drawing the attention of others in the lobby before finally going silent. Diallo went through next, and when it elicited no complaints from the scanner, the two of them continued to the back.

“That really wasn’t necessary,” Catra said in a low voice, moving to catch up to Diallo who was already ahead of her, setting a fast pace. “Isn’t the whole point of infiltrating to not draw attention in the first place? I won’t even need the weapons if no one catches me.”

“They headed through one of the large doors in the back and into a double-height room filled with cubicles. It was significantly quieter here than out in the lobby, and all noise died out almost entirely when the door shut behind them. It almost reminded Catra of a library, except for the fact it was obviously an office floor.

“True,” Diallo said. “You won’t n-need the weapons. Not until you d-do.”

“Is that you cryptically trying to imply that I’m going to get caught?” she hissed, keeping pace with him and glancing left and right at he staffers and corporate jockeys at their desks. Each of them either plugged away at holographic visuals or sat flush against the backs of their office chairs with VR headsets over their eyes. None seemed to notice them.

“It’s me s-saying that, when dealing with Moriarty in any way, you’d better be prepared. It’s b-better to have a weapon and not need it than need it and n-not have it.”

“Even if he’s sixty levels down on the Atrium floor?”

"He's most d-dangerous when you expect n-not to run into him. Remember all those people I mentioned f-fell to their deaths because of him? How many thought they were safe moments before they found themselves r-racing to meet the floor, you think?"

Catra grunted and conceded the point, choosing to focus on keeping her head down remain inconspicuous as she followed Diallo through the office floor.

They passed a corner meeting room partitioned off with glass. Catra could see several people huddled around the long desk, staring at a large holo-screen mounted to the far wall. They were watching the live coverage of Moriarty's rally speech. There he stood, up on the raised platform behind a podium, sweat dripping from his skin, smearing the pancake makeup covering his face and staining his white gloves a toxic shade of yellow.

He spoke and gestured with loud, expansive movements, and although she couldn't actually hear him through the glass from where she stood, she got the impression she was watching someone on the precipice of sanity. The look in his eyes…she'd seen it in her own, looking back at her across the mirrors of the Fright Zone not long after she'd pulled the lever to the portal.

The camera panned out and she caught sight of Taline standing among the other officials in the region behind him, clad in her typical Consular robes, wearing a stony face. The words *"Moriarty declares region on lockdown to future refugees. Phoenix station to 'scrupulously vet' all incoming traffic amid budgetary slashes"* scrolled across the ticker at the bottom of the feed.

"That can't be good," Catra said, tracking the screen as they walked past.

"Did you ever r-reach out to Taline like you said you would?" Diallo asked, barely sparing the holo-screen a glance himself.

"I did," Catra said, ignoring the knowing smirk she saw spread across Pip's face and the flush of embarrassment beginning to spread across her own. "I uh…got ahold of her in the middle of prepping for that rally. And all the news interviews before and after it."

"And? Did she confirm what I said about w-working with Narre and Miri? The occasional secret assignments they w-went on?"

"She didn't," Catra said, feeling her flush spread further. Pip started to cackle on her shoulder, all hint of melancholy from earlier having vanished, and Catra physically brushed her off with a huff. Her hand passed through the Pip's translucent form without phasing her in the slightest. "All of a sudden it didn't feel right to straight up ask if I'm supposed to do this. I mean, the mission is secretive in the first place, isn't it? Either we get something good and she benefits from it, or we find nothing and no one is any wiser, right?"

Diallo didn't speak for a while and she was afraid she'd made the wrong assumption.

"That's a good s-sign then," he said, finally. "The fact you were unsure and wanted to r-reach out means you have a healthy level of skepticism, but the fact you stopped short of divulging the whole operation is more promising. It s-shows you have some self-awareness for what you're about to do. If you had g-gone all the way and actually asked her, Taline m-may have reconsidered her choice to conscript you. Good show of restraint, Catra."

They took another turn within the cubicle farm and Catra knew she'd definitely have gotten lost if Diallo weren't leading her directly.

"Where exactly is his office?" she asked, feeling her flush creep further still. All these years later and she'd still have such a visceral reaction to even the slightest bit of praise. It was embarrassing. "I feel like we've been walking for ages and I don't see anything."

Diallo pointed ahead and she looked, seeing a large square structure cantilevered off the second-floor loft in the far back corner of the room. Covered windows stretched to the ceiling, giving whoever was inside a clear panoramic view of the entire cube farm. A half-turn staircase leading to the access loft started at the very end of the hallway they were walking along.

"We have to be quick," he said. "Moriarty should be gone for a while, but we have no idea if he's scheduled anyone to do security checks while he's away. He's known to be paranoid and it's only gotten worse in recent years."

He spoke again in that dangerous, low voice devoid of even a stutter. It clashed so strongly with his normal demeanor it got Catra wondering about him, instead of focusing on the mission.

"What did you do before?" she asked Diallo, eliciting a quick glance from Pip. She eyed her back and gave a shrug; she had no idea why she was asking either. The question just came naturally.

"Before wh-what?" Diallo asked, not breaking his stride.

"Before all this Beast stuff. Before you met Taline and became a politician."

They reached the foot of the stairs leading to the second floor and Diallo stopped with one foot on the first step. He turned and fixed her with a curious look.

"No one's ever asked m-me that before," he said with his brow furrowed. He thought a moment, then adjusted his glasses. "Hm. Truth be t-told, I don't remember very much of anything before m-meeting Taline. The war scrambled m-my brains a bit too much."

"You don't remember anything at all?" Catra asked. Diallo started to climb the stairs and she followed "No tidbits from before the war? Nothing from your childhood?"

"N-nothing striking, at least," he said. "Selective traumatic amnesia, the d-doctors tell me." When Catra looked to him with something akin to pity in her eyes, he said, "It's not the m-most pleasant thing, you know, not remembering. S-so I just like to pretend I had a pretty g-good childhood growing up."

"That's nice, I guess," she said, thinking back on her own. "Mine wasn't exactly pleasant."

"Overbearing p-parents?"

"You have no idea." Shadow Weaver flitted across her mind and Pip gave her a sympathetic look.

"What's w-worse, I wonder," Diallo said, musing out loud. "Not r-remembering anything of your childhood at all, or r-remembering for certain that it was terrible?"

The question was strikingly profound and made Catra delve deep into the recesses of her thoughts. So much so that, when they reached the top of the stairs and entered the lobby outside Moriarty's office, Catra didn't realize something was wrong until Diallo stopped in his tracks. She looked up and saw another receptionist sitting at her station, chatting with a man in a station security officer's uniform leaned over the top of her desk. Upon further inspection, she realized the man in the uniform was Dax.

"What the hell is he doing here?" Catra said to Diallo, her panic forcing her voice into a stage whisper.

"I don't know," he said. "But I w-was expecting only Moriarty's receptionist to be present. With him here as w-well, it makes this difficult."

They must have been speaking loud enough to be overheard, because both the receptionist and Dax turned and looked at them.

"Catra" Dax said, pulling away almost entirely from the receptionist's desk. He looked like he had just been caught doing something he wasn't supposed to. "What are you doing here?"

“Right back at you,” she said, following Diallo’s lead and actually walking in closer, pretending like they were supposed to be there rather than about to infiltrate the office. No use trying to slip away quietly now that they had been seen. “Aren’t you supposed to be overseeing security for the rally?”

“Hey, I have a legitimate reason to be here,” he said, shooting the receptionist a nervous smile before turning to Diallo. “Administrator Moriarty wanted someone up here to make sure nothing shady happened. He liked the job we did welcoming you onto the station, Governor Diallo, and asked that I personally see to it that nothing happened to his office.” The humor and joviality from his voice disappeared and he frowned. “And also, we’re so short staffed now that I have to step into the field without any backup just to cover everything that needs to be covered. Moriarty took all his Vanguard troops down to the Atrium with him, and almost all of my guys as auxiliary security.”

“I thought he l-looked familiar,” Diallo said, grumbling low enough so only Catra could hear.

The receptionist shot Dax a scandalized look. “You said you took this posting to come see me!”

“I did, sweetie, I did!” Dax said, turning to her and looking thoroughly panicked. “You know how it is, though. I can’t just come out and say I’ve taken the posting myself for that reason. I’m the supervisor, how would that look?”

Catra rolled her eyes. The truth was likely a mixture of both: they were short staffed enough that someone had to be up here alone to guard the office per Moriarty’s instructions, but Dax could have easily assigned any other officer to the task instead. Judging by how hard he was trying to appease the woman behind the desk, the reasons why he took the posting himself were obvious.

“F-forget about this,” Diallo said, still speaking in a low voice to only her while Dax and the receptionist bickered. “There are cameras around h-here too.”

Catra looked around where the ceiling met the walls and indeed saw small cameras installed at each juncture.

"If it were just the r-receptionist, I would have been able to d-distract her long enough to disable them so you could slip inside," Diallo said. "But with your old s-supervisor here, there's not a chance in hell. We'll j-just have to try this another time."

"Wait!" Pip said, zipping in front to grab Catra's attention. Diallo would have seen her plain as day if Pip wasn't invisible to everyone except her, and Catra was still getting used to that fact. She flinched, and then played it off when Diallo caught sight of it and gave her a look.

Pip squeezed her eyes shut, concentrating, as Diallo turned to leave.

All the lights in the lobby shut off, only to then turned back on again, dimmer than before. An alarm blared, and a recorded voice repeated to them over and over again to evacuate immediately.

"What did you do?" Catra asked out loud to Pip, whose eyes went wide in surprise as she made frantic shushing gestures back.

Chaos ensued. Someone grabbed her by the arm and, amidst the alarm blaring out the loudspeakers and the adrenaline pounding through her veins, Catra jumped and turned with claws extended to hiss. Diallo flinched, and Catra forced herself to calm.

"Sorry," she said. "You spooked me."

"I didn't trip the alarm if that's what you w-were asking before," he said. "But whatever it is, w-we need to evacuate immediately."

"My thoughts exactly," Dax said, ushering the receptionist past them in a hurry. "I have no idea what's going on, but I'll leave last and make sure everyone on the first floor below gets out safe."

Diallo turned and watched them hurry down the stairs, out of sight. When they disappeared, he slipped behind the receptionist's

desk and typed furiously at the computer there. In a moment, all the cameras around wilted and pointed down to the floor.

“I’ve killed the camera feed,” he said. “I have no idea what triggered that alarm, but we can’t let an opportunity like this go to waste. Get in there, decode the drive on his computer, and get out as quickly as you can, you hear?”

Catra nodded, registering the fact his stutter disappeared yet again, trying and failing to ignore Pip who was zipping around her head in a circle with a gleeful look on her face. “Got it,” she said.

Diallo turned and hurried out and down the stairs, hot on Dax and the receptionist’s heels. He’d have to leave too, so as to not draw suspicion on himself and to keep suspicion off Catra while she worked.

::Did you do that?:: she asked Pip as she headed straight for Moriarty’s office door, all obstacles now removed from her path. She tried the door. It was locked.

“Yep!” Pip said. “Been connected to the station mainframe for a while now and finally learned my way around a bit. Watch this.”

Catra heard the lock on the door click and she tried it again. The door swung wide open.

::Oh…that *is* useful.::

“Isn’t it though?” Pip said, wheeling around her head anew.

The alarm shut off and Catra wasted no time. She dashed inside the office and closed the door shut behind her.

Chapter End Notes

> Some of you expressed some ample anxiety about whatever Catra is getting herself into and I'm curious...has this chapter eased some of those worries or deepened them? xD

Fun fact about this chapter: my original outline just had "some obstacle" preventing Catra from getting in. Dax being somewhat of a hopeless romantic and a flirt was something that just came naturally as part of the writing way back at the beginning of part 2 when I introduced him. Then he just slotted himself here of his own accord when I was writing the scene. I'm a heavy outliner and architect/plotter by nature, but this was one of those unexpected pantsing/gardening moments for me that just worked nicely haha

Heads up for all of you that I might not make my weekly Thursday updates for the rest of this month--holidays are growing crazy busy for me, and I got to revising this chapter far later in the week than I usually do. I'm still aiming for my usual Thursday evening release, but it may become a Friday or Saturday release depending on how much free time I get. But some good news for you:

First, I've updated the fic description to put a final chapter count to Part 3: Chapter 46. That means there's 7 more updates until we finish out this part of the story and move onto part 4 of 5 (the poster art for part 4 is in the rough sketch phase, and it looks epic already. This is our favorite so far, both for me and the artist I'm collaborating with). I've looked ahead and decided I don't need to combine or split any of the future chapters for the rest of this part for pacing purposes, and have that definite number to share with you guys...

...and second, as you may or may not have guessed so far, there is no danger of this story remaining unfinished, even if the holidays knock me off track a bit with my schedule. This is because World Eater is 100% already fully written, up through its epilogue. I've never explicitly said that, but now I'm saying it. It's been done since before I posted chapter 1, I just wanted to get far enough that I built a cadence and habit of reviewing and revising the chapters. I *do* proof read and make minor adjustments as I post chapters, and I'm also considering a minor retcon for pacing and clarity

purposes thanks to something Amur pointed out last chapter, but World Eater as a story is fully written, and you guys don't have anything to fear about this story becoming abandoned :)

See you soon!

# An Omen Before the Storm

Chapter Notes

> Quick heads up that this is one of the darker chapters in the story. But again, if you made it through chapter 3 then you should be fine :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Angel stood just inside the ground-floor maw of a megalith stationed on a Lost World, the massive, swirling clouds in the sky seemingly trying to drown them with rain. Great wings of magic emanated from the Angel's back, stretching from one end of the opening to the other, wide enough to fit the hundred-odd refugees standing shoulder to shoulder behind her had they tried to walk past in one unbroken line. But they didn't try to walk past, because the Angel was protecting those already inside from what was out—an army of thralls several thousand strong, once their own friends and family, rushing at them from across the rain-soaked plains like a wave.

Thousands had coalesced into one hive-minded creature with a singular goal, and the Angel would have stood there and rained fire and brimstone down upon them all with her runes, would have fought tooth and nail to buy enough time for those calling frantically to them over a short-band radio wave.

*This is warbird Hermes-3 to megalith Tower of Liberation,* the pilot said, their voice blaring over the loudspeakers to all inside the last remaining megalith on-planet, already prepped for emergency takeoff. *We are less than a hundred clicks from your location and carrying a full load of refugees—the last survivors. You cannot leave, I repeat, you cannot leave. We are less than eighty clicks from your location now and burning fast to get to you. You cannot leave us. Do not depart. I repeat, do not depart!*

Yes, the Angel would have moved heaven and earth, would have run herself so hot with magic output she would burn straight through and never cast again, all to buy those several dozen souls in that last warbird enough time and space to make it in.

Then, among the thralls dashing like mad toward them across the plains, she saw it. A bolt of thunder cracked overhead, splitting the cloud cover and illuminating the Trooper among its cousins. All time slowed to a stop as the Angel remembered what had been said of them.

*Troopers are a sign of an awakening Abomination,* the Seraph, her mentor, had told her once. *The only reason we've been so successful in containing the outbreaks so far is because we haven't let an infection grow enough it awakens a natural Abomination, and the contingencies we've put in place for an Abomination accelerating into maturity because of a sorcerer being taken are effective.*

*But even one Trooper on the field of battle is proof the Abomination is nearly done gestating, if it hasn't fully awoken already. If you see one, you need to get out immediately, no matter the cost. The planet is already lost. Only Corynth and his Shapers knew how to handle an infestation at that stage with any permanence. I myself would be hard pressed to take even one singular Trooper down, and I'd need a partner to even attempt it.*

And so, with tears of starlight falling from her glowing eyes, the Angel shut the doors of salvation and ordered the megalith to take off. The vessel shook as its engines roared. The roar mixed with the sounds of the refugees behind her sobbing, and the sounds of those damned wailing over the loudspeaker.

*You cannot save them*, a voice echoed in her head then, as gravity increased and they finally lifted off the ground. *You will die if you go to them.*

The Angel recognized the voice then as one from her past—one of the Seraph's old protectors, a Sentinel who had similarly protected

her.

*There's nothing you can do. Live on and honor their memory.*

Narre's last words mixed with the sobs and the wails and the sound of the engine roar, all of it coalescing into a monstrous noise that sounded more like the fires of hell, beckoning like a siren's call.

Glimmer finally shot awake with a yell when the staff building shook, and for a moment she worried dream had become reality—the engine noise was still there, as loud as ever. She laid still and listened to the rattle of the building subside as the engine noise, having hit a peak, finally drew away.

*Just a nightmare*, she thought, checking in with herself and counting heartbeats. *Not real…just a nightmare. You're on Scavria, nowhere else...just Scavria.*

But what was with that engine roar? Transports were explicitly forbidden from flying directly into the compound, it was too much of a security risk. Unless…

She gasped and threw herself off the bunk, landing on both feet and pulling off her pajamas as quickly as possible to change. She ignored the other Enclave staffers who had also woken from the noise, rubbing at their eyes and wondering what was going on, and instead rushed out into the cool night air as soon as she was passably dressed.

Chaos and commotion. That was all her sleep-addled brain could latch onto when she saw the scene outside the barracks. A damaged warbird was kicking up a storm of dust as it landed in front of the compound's central hospital building, its front floodlight trained on the nurses and emergency responders garbed in white rushing out the building to meet them. A platoon of regular Horde infantry stood in formation nearby, already prepped to receive them, and Glimmer sprinted toward them. Whatever she was afraid of before, this seemed worse.

While basic transports were not supposed to fly directly into the compound, warbirds—sleek fighter-transports  able to descend onto a planet's surface from orbit and always carrying a full cadre of soldiers instead of evacuees—were never to approach so much as the landing pads outside the intake area. Seeing one fly past and all the way inside the compound proper was almost unthinkable. Whoever was piloting that ship was sure to be court martialed and possibly even dishonorably discharged, what with fears of military ships getting taken over by the Beast like in the previous war.

That only made Glimmer worry harder. The last time wartime operating procedure was violated so brazenly, she herself had been the one to do it on Rinne out of pure desperation for how far gone the rescue operation had deteriorated. They hadn't even punished her for it in the end, all lukewarm thoughts of a court martial having disappeared from the High Council's heads the minute 'Angel of Archanas' started appearing next to her name in the media. All on account of her 'heroics.'

The warbird's landing feet touched the ground and the engines revved down. Scavrian evacuees started gathering around the viewports and exposed balconies of their respective megaliths. Some of them had even come out of the wide, floor-level entrances to surround both the hospital and the warbird in curiosity. The soldiers there moved between the warbird and the gathering crowd, yelling strict commands to stay back. None raised weapons at the crowd, but each made it clear there were dire consequences waiting for anyone trying to get to close.

The doors to the warbird's main troop compartment depressurized and slid open. Some of the soldiers peeled away from the group to reach in and pull a stretcher out of the cabin, the struts holding the wheels folding out as they pulled the gurney free. Glimmer saw Lonnie, dressed in full Vanguard armor, hop out and jog alongside the stretcher as it was wheeled to the main hospital entrance. She stooped low as she went, letting whoever was atop it whisper into her ear. When they reached the nurses waiting just outside the doors, Glimmer saw them take the stretcher and stop

the two soldiers pushing it from coming inside. When they tried to stop Lonnie, she pushed passed them with a glare, and followed the stretcher inside.

“What’s going on?” Glimmer slid to a stop, gasping for breath, and choked the question out to no one in particular, hoping someone there knew what was going on and would fill her in.

“We were ambushed.”

Glimmer looked up and saw Kyle, sweat dripping down his face and oxygen mask dangling off his flight helmet instead of covering his mouth, climbing out of the open hatch of the cockpit to slide down the half-ladder hanging there.

“Ambushed? How do you get ambushed by Beast thralls? They’re supposed to be mindless.”

“Yeah, well tell that to all of them,” Kyle said, jumping off the last few rungs and gesturing to the rear cabin.

More stretchers came out of the warbird one by one, each with a white sheet that covered their occupant from head to toe and concealed their face. Glimmer heart sunk lower with each body that emerged. Soon a train of them leading into the hospital had formed. The refugees around them had thankfully taken the infantry’s warnings to heart and hadn’t approached any closer, but an audible whisper began to spread through the crowd, building.

“How did this happen?” she asked, near despondent.

“I don’t know,” Kyle said. He headed toward the hospital alongside the train of stretchers and Glimmer kept pace beside him. “We were supposed to have the city purged by the end of the month, damnit. I was only supposed to provide air support and surveillance. Aratoth and the team went into a building to clear it out and the next thing I know, I’m getting frantic calls for an emergency pickup.”

“Aratoth and the…” Glimmer couldn’t finish her sentence. She scanned the train of gurneys again and counted them: twelve bodies, which was already two more than a typical urban engagement squad was supposed to be, not counting Lonnie and whoever was in that first stretcher. She glanced behind her at the warbird. No one else emerged after them.

“He and Lonnie were the only ones to make it out,” Kyle said. “Although I don’t know if you’d call what happened to him ‘making it out.’ Rogelio thankfully wasn’t part of this one, but Lonnie had to take care of the rest of the team herself while I piloted us back.”

“What do you mean ‘take care of’?” Glimmer asked. They passed into the sterile, halogen-lighted hallways of the hospital interior. Glimmer thought for a moment that the guards on either side of the entrance would have stopped them like they had with the infantry bearing Aratoth’s stretcher, but they only glanced in her direction and pointedly didn’t interfere with her or Kyle entering.

“You know what I mean,” he said. “By the time I got them out of the city they were all already tainted beyond saving. She had to do what she had to before they fully turned.” Kyle formed a finger gun with one of his hands and made a shooting gesture with it pointed to his temple.

“Oh god,” Glimmer said, feeling like she was about to be sick.

A team of nurses in full protective gear sprinted past them. One of them was yelling into a transceiver about prepping for a massive influx of patients they needed to triage. The whole hospital seemed to be abuzz with frantic energy, and Glimmer was still adjusting to how juxtaposed that was with the relative calm of the barracks she had come from moments earlier.

“Looks like I got us back way before everyone else,” Kyle said. “There’s at least twenty other teams that got hit like us.”

"Aratoth wasn't oversaturated?" Glimmer asked, already dreading the answer. She fought the urge to check her PDA, knowing that if she were to look now, she'd only find a deluge of emergency communications that'd do nothing to help her keep a level head in the moment.

Kyle balked. "I really can't tell these things, especially since I was flying the warbird. Lonnie didn't get to him until last, but she's still really shaken up. I really can't say if she had her wits about her enough at the end there to make an objective call about it." He sighed. "I got us back here before any of the other teams, obviously, but I don't know…"

The train of gurneys took a turn up ahead as the infantry hurrying them along brought them to the hospital's incinerator room. The room was typically shut to keep the smell from spilling out into the rest of the building, but Glimmer had a feeling they wouldn't be able to close the door for a while now. Someone was already loading bodies onto the conveyor.

They pressed on, leaving the incinerator and train of gurneys behind. Glimmer couldn't trust herself to dwell there without throwing up. She realized with a startle that she didn't actually know where Aratoth and Lonnie had gone since they hadn't stopped at the front desk to ask. Fortunately, (or maybe unfortunately, depending on how she wanted to look at it) she and Kyle could both hear a voice echoing down the hall—Lonnie was throwing a monster of an outburst inside one of the open rooms up ahead.

"What do you mean he's terminal?" Lonnie said to a harried nurse, just as Kyle and Glimmer dashed into the room. "I just shot twelve of my team in the head because *they* were terminal. I've been on more assignments than you've seen tainted soldiers first-hand, lady. Don't tell me he's terminal when he was the only one I spared exactly because he wasn't!"

Rogelio stood there next to Lonnie. Glimmer wasn't sure how he had gotten there before them—maybe Kyle had given him an

advanced heads up—but he grunted at Lonnie with calming gestures while she was leaned forward, practically bellowing at the poor nurse. Someone had already unloaded Aratoth from the stretcher and onto a  bed. Glimmer could see him lying there with his eyes closed, blood and sweat caking his combat uniform and face, thin veins of poisonous black reaching from his collar up to his chin.

"Miss, please," the nurse said, tapping at a tablet in her arm. "You've done your part helping bring them back here, but now it's time to let me do my job. You've been through an ordeal yourself. You need to stop making a scene where the rest of the hospital patients can hear you and go back to the front desk so they can get you processed for a medical evaluation. You need to be checked out as well."

Glimmer heard Kyle whisper a knowing 'oh no' under his breath just as she saw Lonnie's face tinge purple in rage. Rogelio stepped in front of her then, and told her off with a stern face and a fusillade of clipped grunts. He looked over her shoulder, acknowledging Kyle and nodding at Glimmer. Lonnie turned to follow his gaze.

"What the fuck is she doing here?" Lonnie said, bellowing even louder than before. Kyle and Rogelio and the nurse all tried to step in and shush her but she wasn't having it. "Don't tell me to quiet down. Not when the fucking Battlemage who turned down her own assignment comes waltzing in to see the man who's dying because of it!"

Glimmer felt like she had been kicked in the gut, not because of how vehemently Lonnie spoke but because of the words themselves. She kept her eyes trained on Aratoth, realizing that she wouldn't have been able to tell if he was still alive or not if it weren't for the cardiac monitor beeping erratically next to his bedside.

"That's enough," the nurse said, stamping her foot and shooting all four of them a death glare. "I don't care who you are or what

you've been through, I will not allow you to make a scene in this hospital. There are people here who *can* recover, and you are making it impossible for them to do so. You will remove yourselves and go to the front desk for checkups of your own or I will have you removed and brought there forcibly."

Lonnie was fighting a war with herself if the expressions cycling on her face were any indicator. Glimmer, however, knew the nurse wasn't bluffing—the hospital was staffed to near-overflowing with security now that the building was servicing troops in an emergency rather than catering primarily to injured refugees. She absolutely could (and probably would) call them in to take care of things if Lonnie gave any pushback, Vanguard or not.

Kyle and Rogelio seemed to have the same idea. "We're so sorry," Kyle said, grabbing Lonnie by the shoulders with Rogelio and turning her toward the door. "We'll get out of your hair and let you do your job."

They pushed her out the door, and Glimmer spared one last glance in Aratoth's direction. A strange feeling of remorse and guilt tug at her, seeing him lie there on the edge of death like that. There was nothing she could do, though, so she turned and followed the others out the door shortly thereafter.

Lonnie had turned and was speaking in a low, choked-off voice to Rogelio and Kyle out in the hall. She froze when she saw Glimmer rejoin them, eyes wide in anger. Glimmer thought she'd say something or maybe even hit her, but Lonnie just turned and started power walking away toward the front.

Glimmer followed her, and Kyle and Rogelio followed after Glimmer, the three of them giving Lonnie plenty of space ahead of them as they trailed behind. When Lonnie reached the front desk, instead of stopping and asking to be processed for a post-op checkup like she was supposed to, she continued straight on toward the exit.

“Get the hell out of my way,” she said, when the infantry there tried to stop her. She shouldered past them and hung a hard right as soon as she stepped outside.

“Oh geeze,” Kyle said, watching her go. “We can’t just let her wander out there by herself.”

Rogelio grunted in agreement, and they tried to head out the front door to follow, but the infantry had recovered from Lonnie practically barreling through them and took a firmer stance with the two of them.

“Let us through,” Kyle said, trying to force his way past only to have one of the soldiers put his hand on his chest and hold him at arm’s length. “She shouldn’t be out there alone, she’s not okay right now.” A dangerous glint flashed in his eyes, and Rogelio pulled him back by the shoulder faster than even Glimmer could react.

“I’ll go after her,” Glimmer said, not sparing either of them a second glance as she passed. She went straight up to the infantry, daring them to stop her with a hard look of her own. Neither met her gaze, indicated they’d let her pass without argument.

*Of course they wouldn’t say anything*, Glimmer thought, shaking her head as she pushed past the doors and into the night. *No one is going to try and stop the Battlemage from going where she needs to go. What a joke.*

Five more warbirds had joined Kyle’s, idling outside, and Glimmer saw the silhouettes and engine trails of several more rocketing toward them against the stars in the sky. Most of the refugees that had gathered nearby earlier had dispersed, but that only meant they were instead wandering about the compound in small groups now, too shaken to return to their megaliths. Anxious whispers traded between them: something about Tir off in the distance had changed. It was hard to pinpoint exactly what, since visibility at night was low, but Glimmer could feel it just as much as the others could.

An ethereal wail traveled the distance from the city to the compound and everyone gasped in horror at hearing it. A child started to cry off to the left. Bright streaking comets flashed in the sky, their trajectory betraying them as fresh military reinforcement craft burning through the atmosphere from the main fleet orbiting high above on a direct intercept course for the city. The whispering grew more pronounced. A cat-like revving sounded off to the right and Glimmer caught sight of dozens of speeders shooting toward the city in formation, having just jetted off from the staging area right outside the compound fencing.

Glimmer forced herself to focus on her original goal and stalked off to find Lonnie. Eventually, she found her pacing a new circular footpath into the undergrowth nearby.

"Lonnie, what are you doing out here?" Glimmer said, coming up cautiously behind her. "You've just come out of a botched combat situation—you need to let the doctors check you out."

"Like you know anything about seeing combat," Lonnie said. She spun on her heel, growing vicious, and lunged, pushing Glimmer hard in the chest, faster than she could step out from.

Glimmer took the full brunt of it and took several steps back, trying keep her balance. Lonnie feigned a look of surprise. "Oh, silly me, what am I even saying? You *have* seen combat. Plenty of it!"

She lunged again for another push. Now that she was expecting it, Glimmer could have dodged, or even used Lonnie's momentum against her to lock her in an armbar on the ground—she was emotional enough it might have worked. But instead, she took the shove head on again.

"What is this about, Lonnie?" she asked, staggering backward again. "Is this about me not picking you and the others up and leading?"

"Of course it is!" Lonnie shoved Glimmer a third time with a roar. "Of course it's about that. Why the hell aren't you fighting back, damnit?"

She lunged a fourth time, but Glimmer turned her body so the majority of the force behind the push angled off her. She whirled all the way around Lonnie before she could react and pushed *her* from behind instead.

*She's really going off the deep end emotionally if she's this clumsy*, was all Glimmer could think when she saw Lonnie stumble forward and almost fall. A bitter pit of worry began to form inside her at seeing that.

"This has nothing to do with me taking command," Glimmer said, keeping a measured voice. "Kyle said you were ambushed in the city. He said there were plenty of others that were ambushed as well—at least 20 teams! It would have happened no matter who was in charge and no matter who went in to respond. You can't beat yourself up or get mad at me for it, this is just what happens sometimes."

Lonnie whirled back around to face her and Glimmer got a clear look at the anguish radiating off her; tears were threatening to fall freely from her wide, bloodshot eyes, and her whole body was tensed for a fight. "I'm not beating myself up about any of this," she said, voice quavering. "But I do think I want to beat the shit out of you right now."

She put up two fists high and tight to her face and assumed a boxer's stance, bouncing on her toes. Before Glimmer could respond, she closed the distance between them and threw a punch. It sailed just past Glimmer's head, slipping the blow thanks only to the muscle memory Taline had instilled in her from hours upon hours of close quarters combat drills. Glimmer never understood why a Battlemage who could move mountains with spells had to train in martial combat as extensively as Taline had forced her to, but now she was thankful for it.

“Are you crazy?” Glimmer asked, dodging another blow. “You’re going to get court-martialed for this. Stop!” A number of people, including Horde Infantry, had noticed them and were starting to gather.

“Not if you join in,” Lonnie said as she feinted a punch. “Come on and fight back already. And don’t use any of that magic bullshit on me, it’s cheating.”

Something in the way Lonnie spoke tipped her off. Whether it was how each of her words came out clipped like she was afraid she’d burst into tears if she let them lengthen too much, or the way she seemed to almost be begging for a fight instead of demanding it, Glimmer wasn’t sure, but she got the sense that Lonnie needed this. Needed an outlet. So, half-wary and half-intrigued, she curled both her hands into fists too and squared up.

“Why did you turn us down?” Lonnie asked, inching forward. “Why didn’t you take us on like you were supposed to?”

“I’ve been pretty upfront with everyone I’ve reported to that I’m not to lead a team,” Glimmer said, dodging a blow and throwing one of her own. “The High Council wanted to try and pull a fast one and assign you to me without any warning. I spoke to Aratoth and he agreed in the end that it’d be a bad idea to force it. That’s why he took you off my roster.”

Lonnie scoffed and sidestepped a round of successive blows Glimmer fired off at her. “Yeah, right.”

“It’s true. I tried to come tell you almost immediately after we landed, but you wouldn’t listen.” Glimmer stepped around a jab, then grabbed Lonnie by the front of her armor and threw her from the hip. “I don’t understand why you’re so fixated on me leading,” she said. “We probably all would have died if I was there in charge, instead of you and Kyle at least getting out.”

“None of that shit would have happened in the first place if you were there!” Lonnie said, rolling as soon as she struck the ground

and bouncing back up to her feet. “I don’t know why you have this idea you’re going to lock up the moment you wade into a battle. Is this because of what happened up on Prime’s citadel?”

“That’s part of it,” Glimmer said, darting backward to avoid another blow.

“That was years ago,” Lonnie said. “And if you ever doubted whether or not it still affected your ability to lead, what happened on Rinne should have more than proved that’s not the case.”

Glimmer reeled. Why did everyone bring that up? And why did she think Lonnie would have a different impression of what happened there compared to everyone else? “Rinne is different,” she said, forcing herself to say the words.

“Like hell it was different,” Lonnie said, setting upon her with a ferocious barrage of punches and kicks and sweeps at her legs, each of which Glimmer shied away from in turn. “Fighting is fighting. It doesn’t matter how you feel about it or what the circumstances are, it matters that you’ve done it and survived. And you’ve done way more than that, Glimmer.”

She threw one more blow that Glimmer dodged before stepping in and pushing her backward, hard.

“Rinne is the other part of it!”

To her credit, Lonnie looked stunned, although Glimmer didn’t push the advantage when her  guard dropped. “What do you mean?”

“I mean that Rinne is the other half of the reason why I know I can’t lead. I thought the same thing you did! I thought, `*well gee, the emperor’s Citadel was years ago, maybe it’s fine’*, but it wasn’t fine, Lonnie. Rinne…that whole situation was so fucked up. It’s not something to pull out and point to as an example of good leadership.”

"It isn't?" Lonnie said, stumbling. "Seemed like *great* leadership to me, but you don't have to take my word for it. The people all think so as well."

"No, they don't."

"They gave you your name after that, didn't they?" They call you an angel because you saved thousands of people when no one else could—"

Glimmer clapped her hands to her ears and shook her head. "Stop! You don't understand!"

"Then make me understand, Glimmer! All I know is the number of people you—you alone—saved. And it may not have happened on Archanas, but you reminded all of us enough of what your own mentor accomplished that they decided to celebrate you anyways. You broke almost every rule doing what you did once the chain of command deteriorated enough you became in charge, but the High Council didn't even put you in front of a tribunal for it. How can you point to that and use it as an example for why you *shouldn't* be in charge?"

That finally set Glimmer off. She charged and threw a savage blow that connected perfectly with the front of Lonnie's face. She heard a snap and felt no small satisfaction when Lonnie cried out and stumbled backwards with both hands cupped over her nose.

"I told you already," Glimmer said, voice as hard and sturdy as steel. "Stop. You have no idea what you're talking about."

Lonnie narrowed her eyes one moment, and the next, Glimmer got a split-second glance of her closing the distance between them again with a mighty lunge. The world lurched and she saw stars as pain ripped across her jaw: Lonnie had connected with a haymaker so powerful it had knocked all sense of balance out of her. Unable to keep upright, she fell backward to the ground and put both hands in the grass trying to steady herself.

Lonnie padded over and loomed above her as the world continued to spin. She held one hand at her nose which dripped blood down to her chin, and the other she held still raised in a fist near her chest plate. A wet cracking noise filled the air when she set her nose, and Lonnie winced from it.

"If you have the gall to tell me what happened today is 'just what happens' after I put a bullet between the eyes of almost my entire team," she said, "then you have no right tell me that what you did on that assignment wasn't leadership in a tight spot. Especially not after you managed to actually save people." She spat again and Glimmer saw more blood than spit  come out. Lonnie cursed under her breath.

"You might think you're too compromised to lead, but unless some pinhead doctor who knows what they're talking about discharges you for PTSD, what you *think* means jack shit when compared to what you can *do* on the battlefield, Glimmer.

"Aratoth took us on when he had no room to do so because he knew the statistics behind Vanguard teams without *someone* to lead them. I couldn't do it. We would have been dead in days on our own out there without him, and instead, he gets to die because he tried to lead a squad that was too large. He needed you to step up—we all needed you to step up. Now, all they'll get is a furnace and a gravestone. Their blood is on your hands."

Lonnie spat blood on the ground a second time and turned to walk away. The world began to right itself and Glimmer managed to push herself into a fully sitting position. Unfortunately, without the vertigo distracting her, she instead grew more aware of the horrible pain in her jaw and the headache beginning to throb at her temple.

She sat there for a long time with her thoughts, trying to beat away the feeling of dread emanating from Tir in the distance. After a while, she felt brave enough to push to her feet and slowly stumble back to the hospital, alone.

Chapter End Notes

I got the chapter out on time! yay me haha

What happened on Rinne will be fully explained, don't worry too much about that. There was already a glimpse in this chapter, but what exactly happened will come to light since that and the incident on Horde Prime's citadel in part 1 are major drivers of Glimmer's trauma right now lol.

Speaking of the first part of this chapter, at first I wasn't going to include it, but thought having the dream sequence there would be a good opportunity to try out a style I had seen another fic written in. It's supposed to feel otherworldly, and almost like a folktale retelling of something. How did you guys feel about that segment, if you're willing to share your thoughts?

No chapter next week--I already know I won't have time to proofread it, so just a heads up here. Thank you all for reading and commenting as always, have a wonderful holiday, and see you on December 30 (PST posting time). We get back to Catra and see what she finds after infiltrating Moriarty's office

# A Hydra of Mysteries

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra plunged into pitch black darkness the moment she shut the door to Moriarty's office behind her with a click. The coverings over the windows preventing anyone in the cube farm outside from looking in also blocked out any ambient light, so she stilled, noting the interplay between her breathing and her heartbeat, trying to keep them balanced against each other and prevent either from spooling faster. Her night vision was superb, it just took a moment to kick in—a moment that, the longer it stretched on, she wished was shorter. The longer she stayed in that office, the higher her chances of getting caught.

Just when she finished that thought, a light appeared at her right wrist, powerful enough she hissed and tried to shy away from it on instinct. A moment later, she caught her bearings and realized it was emanating from her PDA.

*It's a flashlight!* Entrapta had told her when she first gifted the thing to her. *It's super powerful. Be careful not to burn anyone's eyes out with it.* Catra mashed at the controls, scrambling to shut it off as quickly as possible.

"Oops," Pip said, floating up to her left. She didn't give off any light of her own, despite being clearly visible against the dark. "Did you not want me to do that?"

"No!" Catra hissed the words aloud now that they were alone. "My eyes will adjust on their own. I don't want anyone accidentally seeing me in here. If that light is strong enough to blind someone, then it might be powerful enough to shine through the blackout curtains."

"Sorry," Pip said. At least she looked sheepish. "I'm still getting used to you, I guess. I felt that you wanted to see, now, and

knew there was a light I could turn on for you." She pursed her lips and sighed. "It will probably take a little longer until I can anticipate you better."

Catra huffed but let it go, since the outlines and contours of the room were starting to come into focus for her. It was still dead silent inside. The blaring alarm from outside had turned off before she had fully gotten inside, but she also figured Moriarty was likely to have the same kind of sound dampening in his office that Taline had in hers. Letting silence draw her into a false sense of security was a sure way to get caught, so she pushed the worries clawing at her mind aside and focused on what she had come to do in the first place.

An executive-style desk sat in the middle of the office, carved out of one solid block of black wood. A computer terminal sat on top of it along with a number of documents and a tablet. A trophy case filled with awards and pictures and baubles stretched the entire length and width of the right side of the office, pushed against the wall. A small coat closet was tucked away in the opposite far corner, near a couch, coffee table, and aluminum planter.

"Pretty sparse office for the head of an entire region of space, aside from the trophies," Catra said, stalking over to the desk.

Pip seemed confused. "Looks like a normal office to me. Taline's got one too."

"That's exactly my point. Taline has a whole storage area filled with contraband lab equipment hidden away in hers. You'd think someone who reports directly to the emperor and answers to no one else would have an office that was less..."

"Unassuming?" Pip asked, finishing Catra's sentence when she couldn't find the word.

Catra smirked and winked at her. "Maybe you'll start better anticipating me quicker than you think."

Pip beamed at her in response and Catra, feeling satisfied, slid behind the desk, careful to avoid touching or displacing anything. When she tapped the console's keyboard, a holographic screen popped up in front of her and prompted her for a password.

"Damn, I should have seen this coming," Catra said, patting at the encrypted drive in her pocket. "You think if I just plug in the device, it will bypass the login?" Diallo had given her a list of passwords to try but she didn't know how much time they had before someone came back. That alarm Pip set off outside was a good distraction, but it likely cut whatever time they would have had undetected short.

"I have a better idea," Pip said, landing with gentle feet on the desk.

As Catra watched her pad over to the holo-screen with her bare feet, she wondered at the back of her mind if she could change her size at will. Pip was supposedly just a projection in her head. Catra had only seen her manifest roughly the size of a glass of water—was it possible for her to appear as tall as her? Or maybe even larger?

"There you go," Pip said. The lock screen asking for a password replaced with Moriarty's working desktop with all his applications and electronic documents ready for access. "And I *can* change my size by the way," she said, briefly growing a few inches before returning back to her smaller size. "But it doesn't really matter, since you're the only one who can see me anyways. Giant seven-foot-tall women may be your thing, but I see no need to get into that if this size suits me just fine."

Catra sputtered. "Giant seven foot—" She stared wide-eyed at Pip who raised an eyebrow at her and didn't break eye contact, both hands resting on her hips. "That's not my thing," she said after schooling her voice and expression back into one of calm. "In fact, I don't have a thing. At all."

"If you say so," Pip said with a shrug, finally breaking eye contact to stare with abject fascination at a Newton's cradle sitting next to her on the desk.

Catra rolled her eyes. There really was no use arguing with her. Pip had been in her head, apparently had seen at least some of her memories, and could actively read her thoughts. She turned her attention back to the now unlocked computer, pulled out the drive from her pocket, and plugged it into the computer. A dialog box popped up, cycling through a number of log messages that flashed on-screen almost too quickly for her to read, and then a progress bar popped up with the words 'deciphering' displayed above it.

She watched the bar tick up to one percent after a handful of seconds, then turned her attention back to Pip. "This has to be one of the most secure places on the entire station, but you're able to set off the general alarm and unlock not just Moriarty's office door but his computer as well. Do you think you'd do any better at reading the data on the storage device?" She glanced back at the computer terminal. It had ticked up to two percent, finally. "It's going to take forever this way."

"Already tried that, Pip said, shaking her head. " Didn't work. I sat with that deciphering program back at the precinct, you know? Oh man, that poor guy was so confused about what we were trying to get him to do, it was almost comical."

"That guy?"

"You know, your 'Mother Brain'?" Pip said. "Funny you call him 'mother' when he's a dude. He kept asking me what you wanted him to do since the disk looked empty to him. I kept trying to tell him there was this massive encryption around it…even borrowed your hands for a bit to try and force him to look at it after he pissed me off by implying *I* was the defective one for 'seeing something that wasn't there'."

“Wait, you and the AI at the precinct talked to each other?” Catra asked, surprised. She blinked. “And Mother Brain is a guy? AI’s can have genders?”

Pip’s mouth parted slightly and her eyes narrowed, her whole face expressing an *are you for real?* sentiment as she gestured with both hands at her own body, clad in its frilly sundress.

Catra cleared her throat, feeling a flush tinge at her. “Silly question, perhaps. That was you doing all that crazy coding too? By…borrowing my hands?”

“More or less” Pip said. “I wasn’t actually borrowing anything—I can’t take over your body, if that’s what you’re worried about. I don’t want to bore you with the specifics, so I’ll just say that I make…suggestions. Suggestions that your body is very good at following, if you want to.

“As for talking to other AIs, the answer there is yes, too. All of the above, yes. Just like you and Diallo or Taline or Dax can talk to each other, I can talk to other programs and AI too. Most of them are pretty boring, some of them are nice. Like Hilda.”

“You’ve talked to Hilda? What do you guys even talk about?”

Pip laughed through here nose, then started to shimmer, and her features began to shift. Her blue hue, pixie cut, and sun dress turned into a green avatar of a woman with long flowing hair and a military-styled service uniform with the Imperial Horde insignia emblazoned on the front.

“She’s pretty nice,” the Pip/Hilda hybrid said, “I just can’t speak too much about her intelligence without being mean.” Pip turned back to her original self, brushing off imaginary dust from her shoulders when she finished. “I’ve always wondered what it’d be like to appear to other people. Hilda can go anywhere in the station using her holo-projectors. I thought about giving them a try myself, but…”

“But what?” Catra asked, when Pip trailed off.

"I dunno. They're hers, I shouldn't take over them just because I'm bored or curious." She gave a low chuckle. "Besides, can you imagine someone calling for her at a terminal and I show up instead? Would probably give Taline a heart attack when auditors start digging into why a blue AI showed up out of nowhere. She was always very…careful. About not letting me get onto the main station network. Seems like a bad idea to go crazy now that I've finally gotten a chance to hook in, even if its hard to ignore all the freedom from time to time."

"Yeah, I guess I can understand that," Catra said, remembering how she had to coach herself the same way during her first few months off Etheria. *It's a big, wide galaxy, Catra*, she'd said to herself every now and again, when the urge to do something self-destructive felt far more interesting than putting on her uniform and clocking in for her shift. *Don't go crazy with all the freedom, you'll only make it harder to build a real life out here if you do.*

She checked the computer again, anxiety creeping up her spine again when the decryption bar still had so much more to go. "So, you can't take over my body, but just 'suggest'," Catra said. "But however you phrase it, we still did something to Mother Brain trying to force *him* to try and decrypt the drive."

"Yeah, but it didn't work, remember? You could probably tell, since everything shut off while he rebooted. I think we short-circuited his brain for a bit, and when he turned back on, he just kept pretending there wasn't a drive for him to look at to begin with." Pip flashed a smirk and gave a low chuckle. "Serves him right. Shouldn't have said I was defective for pointing out something he couldn't see."

"So, *you* could see the encryption, but the cutting-edge AI designed specifically to decrypt things couldn't even register it was encrypted at all?"

"Yep, pretty much," Pip said. "Although that's as far as I could get too. I saw everything was scrambled but had no idea what to do with any of it. I would have said something sooner if I could have

cracked it instead of, you know…letting you come all the way out here with that weird politician man. I don't think Evie fully finished some of my modules before she died. Why else can I see the encryption but not do anything with it?"

"I don't know," Catra said. "Maybe you aren't finished, but thank you for trying to help." For some reason, the fact Pip already tried to decrypt the drive for her was touching. "You're pretty amazing, you know that? Even if you might technically not be done, Evelyn must have been a real genius to have made you. I mean, I don't think I'd have even gotten in here if it weren't for you."

"Thanks," Pip said, flashing a quick smile. "And I'm sure she was great. I kinda wish I remembered her."

"You mean you don't remember anything about her?"

Pip shook her head, crossing one arm over her chest to rub the other. "Taline has asked me that question so many times I've lost count. I wish I remembered something about her, anything at all! But I can't, and it's frustrating."

As curious as she was, Catra decided not to push for more answers or explanation after seeing how uncomfortable the topic was for Pip. A gentle wave of appreciation lapped at her consciousness from the other side of their connection in response. The progress bar on the monitor had just crested the 50% mark.

"Do you think Taline would approve of what we're doing here?" Catra asked.

"What do you mean?"

"I mean, doing this crazy undercover infiltration mission with Diallo." Catra tapped her fingers on the desk. Thinking about this was making her more anxious than she had expected.

"You mean how he told you Sentinels are supposed to do undercover missions like this when their Battlemages can't get directly involved?" Pip asked. Catra nodded, and she said, "I'm

really not sure. She said to return the drive to Diallo, then this happened when you tried. I couldn't tell you if this was what Taline wanted to happen originally, if her original order was code to be deciphered between the lines or not."

Catra sighed. "Okay, don't take this the wrong way, but there's something that just doesn't add up to me," she said, choosing her words carefully. Pip gave her a hesitant look and she continued. "You don't remember ever seeing Diallo before, despite him apparently knowing Taline since the first war. You don't remember anything about Evie, either, despite the fact she built you to begin with. And now you can't tell me anything about Taline despite the fact she's stewarded you for years. I don't get it."

Pip deflated and wandered over to the edge of the desk, sitting down on the hardwood and dangling her feet off the edge. "The thing is," she said. "Taline always kept me on a very short leash and behind very high walls whenever it came to interacting with her. She didn't want me reading any of her memories, didn't want me reading any of her thoughts, especially didn't want me getting onto the station's network, like I said….She essentially kept me tied to a limited interface and almost exclusively had me comb through my memory banks or my own programming to see if I could remember anything about Evie."

"That's it?" Catra asked, surprised.

"Well, she'd also feed me files that she thought were encrypted with phantom algorithms, but I always cracked those because they weren't actually phantom algorithms. Whatever's on that drive Diallo handed off to her is way more complex than anything Taline gave me before." Pip gave a rueful laugh at that. "The point is, she barely let me integrate with her at all and let me see even less of her thoughts and memories and experiences. I've never seen Diallo before. Not until I integrated with you and you talked to him. Despite being in Taline's care for over eight years now, I know more about you—your thoughts, your intentions, your desires—after being connected with you for less than a week than I know about Taline." She let out a sad sigh. "So, I really can't say

one way or the other how she'd feel about all of this. All I know is how *you* feel about it. I'm sorry."

Catra grimaced and shook her head. "That's okay…*I'm* sorry. Not just for asking, but I'm sorry that happened to you." Truthfully, hearing the way Taline treated Pip surprised her and reminded her of some unpleasant associations with her past. "My guardian…she didn't exactly want anything to do with me either unless it served some sort of ulterior motive, so I understand what it's like to feel that way, and you have nothing to be sorry for about it."

She stopped, suddenly realizing what she was admitting out loud. Although she hadn't identified her by name, Catra had spoken about Shadow Weaver and her past to exactly zero people except Glimmer. The fact she felt so comfortable just airing out such emotionally charged thoughts to Pip was alarming. When she looked at her, Pip was looking back with a sympathetic expression and knowing eyes.

"You already know who I'm talking about, don't you?" Catra asked, feeling as though she already knew the answer. Pip nodded and Catra gave a small laugh. "How much of my memories have you actually seen already? Y'know, just so we're on the same page about it."

"How mad would you be if I told you I've pretty much seen all of it?" Pip asked, fidgeting in anticipation.

"Not mad at all, believe it or not," she said, giving a shrug. She had to admit, being laid bare was a lot less off-putting than she'd imagined, to the extent she surprised herself at how okay it all felt. Somewhere deep in her mind she rationalized that having someone, even an AI, see into her deepest thoughts and view her most private memories and *still* want to stick around and help despite it all made her feel strangely grateful (even if Pip *was* kind of a brat about things, although Catra considered it yet another thing they had in common).

"Well that's a relief," Pip said, letting out an exaggerated sigh. "I do have to say though, if there's one thing I've learned about Taline over the years, it's that she's not exactly what she appears to be on the surface."

"What?" Catra felt another hand of ice squeeze her chest at hearing that, another association with Shadow Weaver threatening to solidify in her mind.

"No, nothing like that," Pip said, standing up and waving her arms in front of her as if to chase away Catra's fears. "I meant if you asked me before she gave me to you, I might have said that she was very cold and distant. She never let me see very deep, but what little I could glean from our interactions, she seemed angry and vengeful and single-minded. Then she left for a while, right when Etheria was discovered, and came back with those three mangled scars on her face from the emperor and a completely new attitude."

"You're saying she changed?"

"Yes! That's exactly what I'm saying. All she could think about when she came back was training her new apprentice or worrying over you. She went from almost obsessively thinking about hunting a dead man down and mentally flagellating herself over Evie's death to asking me if now was the right time to let her go—asking for advice on how she might even do that. Catra, I heard her talk about you so often, I felt like I already half knew you before she handed me over. She told me that you were a special person to her and that I'd better do everything I can to take care of you."

"She said that?" Catra asked, feeling her mouth go dry.

"She not only said it—but she gave me a glimpse, a *true* glimpse—into her mind when she did. She exposed herself fully to me in then so I could see for myself the depth of her emotions in the moment…how much she meant it. I never would have expected

such a change in her given our history. That's what I meant when I said she's not what she seems on the surface."

Catra hadn't realized how fast her heart was beating and how dry her mouth had gone until that moment. She ran her hands through her hair several times, her sense of stability returning and the lump in her throat subsiding when she reaffirmed how short it was.

It felt so silly now, thinking Pip was about to share something negative about Taline. Truthfully, she felt slightly ashamed that was the conclusion she jumped to first. Taline deserved the benefit of the doubt, at the very least, but why did she have to try so hard in order to give it?

"Don't beat yourself up so much," Pip said, giving Catra's hand she rested on the desk a nudge with her foot that, to Catra's surprise, she felt.

"She tried so hard to connect with me," Catra said, feeling tears sting her eyes and hating it. "A letter of recommendation sent straight to Dax for each of my performance reviews, invitations to coffee or brunch I'd brush off or find some flimsy excuse for… She brought me off world, Pip. I wouldn't even be here if it weren't for her."

"And you deserved all of her love and affection. It was hers to give and she gave it to you, willingly. You grew up and learned such displays were a manipulation, and it does no good to wallow in guilt now that you've realized it can be genuine too. You and Taline are nearly on the same page now, you've lowered the walls between you enough you can now see one another. You're her Sentinel, Catra, and you're here to do a job that is supposed to help her, right? Hopefully expose some hidden treachery that will protect this station, this region of space, and its people that Taline is trying to protect?"

Catra found empathy and understanding in Pip's expression despite how scolding the words themselves were. It was enough

to push back the guilt and regret swirling around her and focus.

The progress bar on the computer ticked past eighty percent, and Catra's sentiments about how plain the office seemed came back to her. Taline had an entire hidden area full of equipment in her office, and Catra was almost certain Moriarty had even more to hide than her. She'd just have to find it.

She pulled the drawers and cabinets of Moriarty's desk open and started rummaging through them. Nothing immediately caught her eye, until she pulled a cylindrical object out of one of the drawers and all racing thoughts came to an immediate, grinding halt.

"What's that?" Pip asked, standing on her toes and trying to crane her head over top of Catra's hand to look at the thing.

"It's not good, is what it is," Catra said, turning the pill bottle to show her the label. "These are antirejection drugs. Black market."

"I haven't read through any Imperial law yet, seemed boring. How serious is it to have those?"

"Very serious. They're completely illegal, category one banned substance. Enough to get even Moriarty thrown in jail under a lengthy sentence if he were to be found with them. What the heck does he need to suppress his immune system this much for?"

She glanced down and a second bottle grabbed her attention. She picked that one up too and read the label.

"He's got sleep narcotics as well," she said, shaking the bottle. "Same deal—black market stuff."

"Black market because they're so powerful?"

Catra nodded. "I recognize these ones specifically, too. I was on a few task forces to tamp down on the supply coming into Phoenix last year. When the Beast took Rinne, people couldn't sleep out of fear and they turned towards these and similar drugs to make do.

It wasn't until the stuck Glimmer with that name that public sentiment calmed enough the demand dropped.

"I threw my OTC sleepers into the trash because I didn't want to end up using stronger versions. This here is also ridiculously illegal—probably ten times stronger than the strongest version you can get with an actual prescription. Either one of these will earn Moriarty ten years in prison, easy. What the heck is he doing with them?"

The progress bar jumped the last chunk of the way to completion and a flurry of characters and information cascaded down the screen, dragging her attention back to the terminal.

"Oh wow," Pip said, staring at the screen. "Oh…oh wow."

"Talk to me, Pip. I can read the screens but I don't understand it."

"I'm linked directly into the computer and…Catra, this is the real deal. I can see the encrypted data stream, and the unencrypted stuff right next to it, but I *still* can't understand how they managed to go from one to the other, even when I'm staring right at the decryption key on Moriarty's box."

"What does that mean? I have, like, the technical understanding of a brick, so you're going to have to spell it out for me." She hadn't taken her eyes off the screen, but the sheer number of windows opening up and messages displaying came so quickly it astonished her she could actually track the information. It shouldn't have been possible.

"It means that whatever algorithm the Vestamid used on this to encrypt it really isn't indexed in the Empire's forensics database. That's why the program you consulted at the precinct couldn't understand or even see this either. As far as the empire is concerned, this type of technology doesn't even exist yet."

"The only algorithm in use not currently catalogued by the empire is the one the Barrier uses to the Beast caged. So Diallo was right

again. This truly is a phantom algorithm. He found one, tying the Vestamid and Moriarty together."

Pip nodded and Catra cursed. She didn't realize until that moment that, although this scenario was the whole reason why she was infiltrating Moriarty's office to begin with, she had actually hoped to find nothing at all. Opening this can of worms only complicated things so much more. For now, she had to get the decryption key copied over for Taline, and bring it to her immediately.

The stream of popups on the screen stopped, displaying the last piece of decryption information: a letter.

*Moriarty —*

*Your assistance with the latest iteration of our storage silos is greatly appreciated and did not go unnoticed. Our mutual benefactor is impressed, and I assure you that we are indeed considering your request. Please understand, however, that touching God is not something to take or ask of lightly. We have made encouraging progress on our satellite settlement on Eden, but there is still much work to be done.*

*Remember, all ailments and ambitions are nothing in the face of God. There shall be nothing, only Him—so said the Prophet Corynth. Soon, all will come to know His grace, and you as one among many of the Emperor's chosen shall be first in line. I ask that you exercise patience.*

*Forever your humble servant,*

*Larian*

*Primate of the Vestamid, Archbishop of Archanas*

"What the hell?" Catra asked, staring wide-eyed at the letter. "Prophet Corynth? Archbishop of Archanas?" Some part of her had prepared for this outcome—prepared for Diallo to be proven right. But seeing a letter spell it out so plain it was impossible to deny?

Something instinctual sounded off a warning in her head and scattered her thoughts like smoke. She snapped her head up to stare at the far door and, although she could still hear nothing and all was still. Another warning came, much like the premonition she had experienced back at Vadim's Tailchaser pub, but far stronger.

"Hide!" Pip said. She floated up into Catra's field of vision and shot her a desperate look.

"What's going on?"

"They're coming! Everything is soundproof in here so you can't hear, but they're coming. You have to hide. Now!"

Catra yanked the drive out of the computer and shoved it back in her pocket. Then she put the computer back to sleep, shut the monitor off, and darted over to the corner coat closet. She succeeding in squeezing herself inside and pulling the slatted door shut in front of her just as the doors to Moriarty's office burst open.

"—telling you Diallo, this false alarm was nothing but a ploy from one of my political rivals," Moriarty said.

The lights flicked on and Catra watched through an opening between two slats in the closet door. Moriarty stumped across the office with Diallo hot on his heels, throwing open the blackout curtains and slamming his girth into the office chair behind the desk. The chair squealed in protest at having to hold up his weight and Diallo flinched on the other side of the desk."

"I'm s-sure it was just a system error, s-sir," Diallo said, pushing his glasses up the bridge of his nose. "You have n-no more political rivals. Not f-for years, now."

"Hah," Moriarty said, leaning forward and eliciting another squeal from his chair. "An emergency alarm in the middle of my rally? Where conspicuously all the security cameras are off? I think not. It seems I'll have to start throwing people off the balcony to the

Atrium floor again when I find out who instigated this. It was a very effective means of sending a message back in the day, remember?"

Diallo meshed his fingers together and retained a placid demeanor. Moriarty studied him a moment, then huffed.

"You disapprove," Moriarty said. It was a statement, not a question.

"I didn't s-say anything, sir. Although I admit I f-find throwing people off the top floor of the Atrium so they s-splatter on the ground isn't the most appealing thing to imagine."

"Not that, you idiot. I'm talking about my rally speech. You didn't show even though I invited you, but I know you watched it. You have the same sour look on your face right now that you had when I first told you about all the budget cuts."

Diallo sighed. "Sir, my opinion on that h-hasn't changed. I just don't see h-how we can defend our systems against a Beast incursion w-with so little funding. Granted, the incursions are n-not as serious as they were so many years ago, but still. Even Phoenix Station right now is s-suffering immensely with the sheer number of people trying to apply for r-refugee status."

"Which is exactly why I shut the station intake down," Moriarty said, scratching at his jowls. "Look, Diallo, we've known each other for a little while now. I know you got your position because that Seraph bitch put you up for it, but despite my initial misgivings, you are quite the conniving fellow."

"T-thank you sir?" Diallo said, looking around the room, probably looking for any traces of Catra having been there. Pip, on her shoulder, giggled when he looked toward the closet and didn't linger.

"You're very welcome," Diallo said. "That's the main reason I'm letting you in on a little secret right now. The Emperor has a few aces up his sleeve when it comes to dealing with the Beast. One

of them I'm sure you've heard of already if you pay any attention at all to the rumor mill. Does the 'Heart of Etheria' sound familiar to you?"

Catra held her breath.

"I admit I've h-heard its name bandied about sir, although I h-haven't paid much heed to rumors."

"It's the real deal. I won't bore you with the details, but it's a superweapon, and as soon as it's revealed the Beast will cease to be a concern. That's why I'm cutting the budgets. The money is going into the central Imperial coffers for the Vestamid."

"S-sir?"

"The Beast nearly destroyed life in the galaxy. It still threatens to do so, and even if the threat were neutralized, the psychological trauma inflicted on the galaxy as a whole will remain. Would you believe that your very own Vestamid are pioneering a solution? They are intimately familiar with incorporating the trauma of the Beast into a functioning self-identity, after all."

"M-my very own—Moriarty…sir, what are you s-saying, exactly?" Diallo was feigning surprise, Catra could tell. He already knew most of this. Maybe not the Heart of Etheria part—she wasn't quite sure about that—but she now fully believed his suspicions around the Vestamid were well-placed.

"What I'm saying is…what's this?" Moriarty cut off and Catra immediately felt ice flood her veins when he picking up the two pill bottles that were still resting on the top of his desk.

::Oh shit:: she said, sending as strong a sense of panic she could muster through her connection with Pip. She had forgotten to put those back where she found them!

Moriarty stood up from his chair. "Whoever is in here, you'd better reveal yourself now or so help me I will gut you and your whole extended family like a fish."

Catra held her breath, each heartbeat hammering in her chest ringing loud enough in her ears she feared Moriarty could hear all the way across the room.

“I don’t think there is anyone in h-here besides—“

“Quiet,” Moriarty said. Catra saw him press something on the underside of the desk. “This is a code twelve,” he said, standing and leaning over to speak into one of the baubles sitting on the desk. “Send backup immediately.”

“He just sent out an emergency call on a private line,” Pip said, whispering into her ear despite the fact only Catra would have heard her even if she shouted. “Whatever you’re going to do, do it now before even more people show up.”

::What the fuck am I supposed to do?!::

“I don’t know, but don’t just stand here!”

Catra took a deep breath and stepped out of the closet. A twisted grin spread across Moriarty’s face when he saw, while Diallo looked like he had just seen a ghost he went so pale.

“Administrator Moriarty,” Catra said, fighting to keep the waver out of her voice. “You are under arrest for possession of illicit category one narcotics. Turn around and place both of your hands behind your back.” She pulled the stun baton off her right thigh and activated it, sending a threatening crackle sound rippling through the air.

Moriarty laughed. “I know who you are. You’re that new Sentinel. Oh, I should have known Taline was playing dirty tricks behind my back while she was down there with me.” He turned to Diallo. “Did you have any hand in this? Is this why you weren’t at the rally? Because you were too busy helping her break into my office?”

Diallo backed away toward the trophy case with both palms up.

"I said turn around and put both hands behind your back," Catra said. "Do it now!"

Moriarty scoffed and took a step toward her, rolls of fat rippling across his body as he did. "Oh, girl, didn't you know that you can't make arrests? You aren't a cop anymore." He tutted and shook his head. "Sentinel or no, Dax would be so disappointed to hear you've sold out to Taline just to play secret agent."

Moriarty didn't broadcast a thing. One moment he was several steps away, and the next he was directly in front of her, having lunged forward so quickly Catra felt the warning in her head before she noticed him move. He backhanded the stun baton out of her hand and sent it skittering across the ground until it slammed into the far wall.

Two things happened in the next instant. First, after realizing what happened, Catra understood she had far underestimated Diallo's capabilities. Second, in the following split second after that realization, she felt another warning in her head and ducked, choosing to act on what the warning told her rather than wait to notice something with her eyes. And just as she ducked, a meaty fist that would have sent her flying across the room passed over her head, missing her entirely.

*What?* she thought. *How did I react to that if I didn't even—*

"Don't think!" Pip said. "Just move!"

Catra had no idea what she was reacting to—she still hadn't seen or registered anything. But some visceral instinct inside her that had only been a passing sensation before suddenly screamed at her to sidestep, and sidestep she did. Moriarty followed through his haymaker with a forward lunge, intending to have rammed Catra's entire body back against the closet with a thrust from his shoulder if she hadn't gotten out of the way.

Catra unholstered the sidearm at her hip and raised it. Moriarty flailed and knocked her aim off just as she fired. The bullet flew

wide and slammed into the window overlooking the cube farm below. The glass cracked and spider-webbed but didn't shatter.

Another warning flashed in her head, but this time Catra already knew her body couldn't physically move as quickly as the instinct urged her to. Still, she did her best, dashing to the side as Moriarty rounded on her again, grabbing her by the neck with one hand before she could fully step away.

Catra yelped as Moriarty picked her up off the floor and slammed her against the closet door as easily as one lifted a small animal. His hand engulfed her from jaw to clavicle, his fingers wrapping all the way around and meeting at her nape. Catra dropped the gun, hearing it clatter to the floor as she kicked and scratched and plied at his face with her claws. He reeled back and slammed her against the closet a second time, hard.

Catra saw stars. Her vision swam and the room spun. She tried to struggle—her whole body was on fire, burning with the urge to fight, to live. She kicked and scratched, trying in vain to reach his face. But no matter how hard she struggled she couldn't get free of the man's grip around her throat. He squeezed, cutting off the air to her lungs and the blood flow to her head, and the edges of her vision started to close in on her.

She raked her hands down his arm, tearing at the flesh there and revealing a hard metallic endoskeleton under the skin. Both of Moriarty's arms had been replaced with prosthetics.

*Well, that explains the antirejection drugs* she thought, almost comedically to herself, as she realized she was probably going to be strangled to death in a few moments. He must have felt some pretty harsh aftereffects from the augmentations if he needed such powerful narcotics to function. And, judging by how quickly he closed the distance between them the first time, his legs were probably augmented too.

The side effects of the drugs were there too, she just didn't see it until looking him directly in the eyes: Moriarty was batshit insane.

"Years!" Moriarty said, squeezing her throat harder and forcing a choked gasp from her. "For years I haven't been able to sleep because I couldn't stop the voices, couldn't stop seeing the shadows…couldn't stop hearing them talk of this moment. Assassination!

"I thought giving it my arms, my legs…I thought sacrificing these things would appease"—he punched the closet with his free hand, sending splinters everywhere and showering them both with a fine blanket of pulverized dust—"but that still wouldn't stop the voices. Everyone called me crazy. Crazy! Hah. At least them I could silence—a quick drop and a sudden stop…splat. But nothing would stop the voices, the shadows in the corners. I will stop you, and then they will stop. They have to stop."

Catra felt her grip on his hand start to slip, her eyes beginning to roll up inside her head. The last pinpricks of her vision were in danger of being smothered entirely when the pressure around her throat disappeared all on its own.

She dropped to the ground, hacking and sputtering and coughing and gasping for breath. When she looked, Moriarty was lying face down on the ground. Diallo stood above him, breathing hard, eyes wide in terror and glasses sitting crooked on his face. He held up one of the metal trophies from the case against the far wall for a second strike, a sizeable dent in its side.

"Are y-you okay?" Diallo asked, shaking.

Catra tried to respond and only succeeded in coughing more. She held a thumbs up to him and nodded her head.

A hard thump came from the door into the office and both of them snapped their attention to it. Another thump, then a third. On the fourth, the door exploded inward in a shower of splinters and a squad of armored Vanguard soldiers thundered in, shouting rapid commands to get down on the ground while gesturing with the barrels of their rifles. One of came in close and kicked Catra's pistol far out of reach.

She heard Diallo try and reason with them only to be grabbed and slammed against the desk while they cuffed him. Catra coughed and sputtered again, trying to catch her breath and say something, but another soldier approached and rammed the butt of his rifle into the side of her head.

Everything went black.

Chapter End Notes

> Welcome back! Hope you enjoyed the lengthy Catra chapter. It was harder than expected getting back into the groove of proofreading chapters after taking a week off for the holidays, but I went back and read over some of the really nice comments you guys have left over the previous chapters and I gotta say, it was really nice to reread a lot of them and helped motivate me a lot.
>
> We get back with Adora next chapter. Thank you for reading and commenting, and I hope you all have a wonderful new year's!

# Abomination

Chapter Notes

Hello from 2022!

Quick non-spoilery heads up: I made a small edit to a prior chapter based on some reader feedback (thanks Amur!). If you're following along week to week and notice a part of the chapter that sounds familiar from an earlier chapter, that's probably why. If you're binge reading this after the posting of this chapter, this heads up doesn't really apply :)

Please enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora hugged the wall as she hurried along the hangar terminal. She wasn't sneaking, not really, but she did her best to keep a low profile. A group of aliens, each a different race speaking a shared language she couldn't parse, walked by and she squeezed the backpack she carrying closer to her chest. Kal had told her to stay put in the hotel room and out of trouble. She had stolen the Eye of Shukra instead, and couldn't stop panicking.

…Bay 10…

…Bay 9….

…Bay 8…

The signposts for each hangar in the terminal passed her by at an agonizing pace, but she couldn't walk any faster without outright sprinting and thus drawing more attention. She'd be discovered any moment now, she just knew it. She had to hurry.

The signpost for bay 3 lay up ahead. That was where the Dzivia was docked, and she again stifled the urge to run toward it. Kal was nowhere to be seen. It was fine. And although she had no

idea where he went after telling her he was just going 'out,' a large part of her was paranoid he'd actually anticipated her plan to take the Eye back to Etheria without his consent—was paranoid he'd been following her.

Someone screamed behind her and Adora jumped, spinning around and holding the bag like a shield to ward off whatever was about to attack her. No attack came. Instead, a haggard old man with matted, thinning grey hair and dirt smudging his sallow cheekbones was rocking back and forth, squatted against the nearby wall. His eyes darted every direction, scanning the terminal and landing on Adora for the briefest of moments before moving on as if they hadn't just locked eyes at all. He yelled again—yelled inane, incomprehensible things, and Adora noticed how everyone around them *except* her were pointedly ignoring him as they walked by.

*Is that how I look right now?* Adora thought, turning back around to make her way toward bay 3 again. She had the strongest urge to fix her hair into a braid again and she ignored it.

Of course, she didn't actually believe she resembled someone quite possibly going through substance withdrawals and likely on their second or possibly third week without a proper shower, but the fact she saw some small part of her paranoia reflected in that man's wasn't lost on her.

*I have no reason to be this paranoid*, she thought. *None at all.*

Kal would be mad if he caught her, sure, but Adora was mad at *him*. Mad he was willing to put the lives of trillions at risk, and for what? Because he wanted to think a friend—one he abandoned three years ago, mind you—was going to change their mind and come around after giving the clearest 'no' that could possibly be given?

Adora rolled her eyes, shook her head, and walked faster. She was doing the right thing. She had spent years trying to convince Catra to defect with her and join the Rebellion and that never

worked. No, there was no reason to feel guilty. She was doing the right thing.

She paused, confused. How had her thoughts switched so automatically from Kal over to Catra? Catra had nothing to do with this…Adora had to get back to Etheria and take the Eye to Entrapta and Salas for study, that was all.

By the time she regained her bearings, she had reached her destination and took a hard left into bay 3 with another forceful shake of her head.

The bay's security control room was on her left—a modest two-story building looking out on the hangar below. Adora had watched Vasher and his team come out the ground floor entrance of that same control room when they landed and had almost gotten shot by security. Now, as Adora approached, she tried to keep as confident a look and stride as possible: whoever was inside watching over the ship would no doubt question why she had come back wanting to take it out without Kal there with her.

No one was inside.

Adora let out the breath she had been holding with an airy curse, pushed inside, and leaned against the door the moment she shut it behind her, trying slow her heartrate. What would cause an entire hangar—a sensitive location with supposedly ever-present security—to be abandoned? It wasn't until she stepped forward far enough to get a clear glimpse through the window she realized she wasn't alone after all: Ly was standing on the ground level alone, weight on one leg, arms folded, right in front of the *Dzivia*. All Adora could glean was that she seemed contemplative, like she was considering the ship as if it were some enigmatic sculpture at a gallery.

"I have to admit, I'm surprised to see you here," Ly said, once Adora left the security room and approached. She hadn't even turned to look at her. "My first guess was that I'd have maybe an hour here alone while you two argued about next steps, and my

second was that I'd meet both of you here already prepping to leave if you hadn't argued and both agreed to get out quick. I hadn't expected only you to show."

"Uhh…I don't know what you said to security to get them to let you in," Adora said, shuffling her feet. Her nerves were killing her all over again, could she just catch a break already? "But no one is up there in the security room anymore. It's empty."

"Who do you think told them to get lost in the first place?" Ly asked, finally turning around to face her. Her eyes immediately went to the bag. She frowned and Adora hugged it even closer on instinct. Would Ly know what she was there to do? Probably, given she was not only a book-smart scientist but also had the street smarts necessary to survive on a place like Eden for years. Ly wouldn't be easy to dupe, either, and Adora already knew she was shit at lying to begin with.

She realized something else the moment after: that if push came to shove, she could probably take Ly in a fight. She hoped it wouldn't come to that, of course, but if it did she'd win. All the street smarts in the world and muscle from pole dancing routines wouldn't hold against the years of military training and conditioning Adora had put herself through.

Ly burst out laughing instead, and Adora furrowed her brow in even deeper confusion. That reaction was far, far down the list of what she had expected to receive.

"Oh…wow," Lysithea said, wiping tears from her eyes and falling into a fresh fit of laughter all over again. "Poor guy. He always seems gets involved with some of the most bullheaded, most stubborn people to ever live. First Evie, then me—probably the worst out of the bunch, really…or maybe Taline takes that one?—then Pip, and now you. She Ra of Etheria." She chuckled again and shook her head as if she were forcing disdain for a terrible joke. "I'm surprised he hasn't thrown himself off a bridge yet, to be perfectly honest."

"What are you talking about?" Adora asked. "What's so funny?" She still couldn't tell what Ly was planning. This whole exchange was throwing her off.

"Let me guess," Ly said, crossing her arms. "You thought it'd be for the best if you took the Eye back to the Enclave so they could work on it since I said no. Kal refused to leave until I had come around, and you decided to take matters into your own hands and try and take both the Eye and the ship back yourself, with or without him. Did I get that about right?"

"No!" Adora said, copying Ly and crossing her arms in front of her chest. Ly's read on the situation was so accurate it scared her. "… Maybe! What are you doing here then, huh?" She jutted her chin out for effect, but only succeeded in feeling more foolish, especially when Ly just laughed at her yet again.

"I was coming to reminisce for a bit before I went to look for Kal and apologize. I'm ashamed to admit it took me a while to calm down and think straight, but I *have* come around."

Adora blinked at her. "What?"

"I mean that you don't have to worry about taking the Eye back to Etheria anymore. I've changed my mind—I'll look at the Eye myself, I'll see what I can do about fixing Pip too." She paused a moment and then peered past Adora and up to the security building in the distance. "You really did come here without him, huh? He's not trailing behind you or anything?" She shrugged. "Color me impressed, Adora. You have some nerve to actually try and steal the *Dzivia* from him. Didn't think you'd have the stomach."

Somehow, securing Ly's tacit approval after being proven willing to hijack a starship didn't make Adora feel very proud of herself. This especially in light of the fact her assumptions about Ly never changing her mind and agreeing to help were also dead wrong.

"Why the sudden change of heart?" she asked.

Ly shrugged. "Vasher waited until I had calmed down a bit to remind me that Kal and Evie were—are—our friends. And although choosing to jump ship and leave would be safer for us in the short term, it wouldn't be right." She gave a rueful sigh and turned to run her hand along Dzivia's hull. "We'd all be either dead or in some sort of Imperial gulag in the Heartlands if it weren't for Kal and Evie, and Kal would already be long dead if it weren't for Evie and I. The Heart might still be a safer bet, but I'd never forgive myself if I just turned a blind eye when I could help. I'm not about to spit on Evie's grave and turn my back on Kal like that…it's just not something a friend would do." She turned back around to look at Adora and frowned. "Are you okay?"

Adora was too late to stop the tears. "I'm fine," she said, sniffling and rubbing her eyes. Somewhere along Ly's explanation, a tidal wave of emotion had crashed into her along with a sudden realization: she had turned her back on Catra, all those years ago.

Maybe it was the safer bet, pushing her aside to focus on She Ra and the Heart—it certainly seemed that way at the time. But this was the first time Adora realized it could be both—that it could have been simultaneously the right choice and also an ultimate betrayal of someone she cherished for most of her life…that these things weren't mutually exclusive.

She'd lost faith in Catra, standing there in Bright Moon's hallway years ago, telling her she didn't want to see her again. Adora felt guilty, and she realized then that she had never stopped feeling guilty. Not for three whole years.

She felt sick. Somewhere amidst the mire, she noticed Ly ducking down in front of her, trying to meet gazes.

"Adora?"

Another wave of emotion came and Adora spun away so she didn't have to be seen when the shame and guilt finally toppled her.

Hadn't Catra, for years, undermined her and fought as her enemy? Hadn't Catra, for *years*, got in the way of every attempt she and the Princess Alliance had made to defeat the Horde? Yes. Yes, she had. She had not only refused every olive branch Adora had extended, but threw those olive branches back in her face and hurt her deeply.

And yet the only thing Adora could fixate on was how she had turned Catra away just as she had her own change of heart. Adora had wanted to prove that people—that Catra—wouldn't change. She wanted to prove that Kal was wrong and that Ly wouldn't come around either. She wanted to prove it so badly that, in a fit of emotion and paranoia, she took the Eye and fully intended to steal a ship in order to do so. But she was wrong. Wrong about Ly, and wrong about Catra.

*You are not the person I thought you were*. That was what She Ra had said to her back on Prime's citadel, and maybe she had a point. Maybe Kal, who apparently had an unwavering trust in his friends when they had every right to forsake him, would have made a better She Ra.

Two firm hands grabbed her shoulders and spun her around.

"Hey, what's going on with you?" Ly asked, shaking her. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine," Adora said again, taking deep, gasping breaths and forcing herself to look Ly in the face. "I just realized I owe someone an apology as well. And if you're embarrassed about it taking you an hour or two, guess how I feel after coming to the realization three years later."

"Pretty shitty, I'd imagine," Ly said. "Don't feel too bad. Kal left Vasher and I with our pants down on a gig, remember? That was three years ago, too, and I've been mad about it this whole time. Him and I will get through that too. Vasher and I saved his life and pulled him out of hell once, a long time ago."

“She saved my life too,” Adora said. “My person. On more than one occasion, I think.”

Ly clapped Adora on the shoulders, hard, and winked at her. “Then you have nothing to worry about. Takes more than some prolonged idiocy to kill a relationship like that, trust me.” She flashed a grin so wide Adora couldn’t help feeling lighter.

“Thank you. Really. I…I don’t know what to say.”

“Then don’t say anything. Can we get out of here now, though? I want to find Kal and take a look at the Eye as fast as I can. The sooner the better. It still boggles my mind he really didn’t follow you here, how did you slip away without—"

Ly’s eyes again wandered past Adora and toward the security building as she spoke, only to narrow, her expression turning into a scowl as she cut off. Adora turned see what she was looking at and saw six people coming out of the building and heading straight toward them. None were dressed in a security uniform, though she did recognize one of them.

“I’ve seen him before,” Adora said, pointing out the burliest member of the six, standing a full three heads taller than the rest. “Twice. He was in a clinic Kal and I went to when we first landed, and he was harassing me before your show until Vasher stepped in.”

“You said you still can’t use your powers, right?” Ly said, stepping forward and putting herself between them and her. “I’ll take care of it.”

Adora gawked at her in surprise. Even with her training, Adora didn’t feel confident fighting six people, especially without She Ra. Hell, taking on the brute by himself didn’tseem feasible back before Ly’s show. What the hell did she mean she’d take care of it? She was about to pull Ly back and suggest they just make a break for it when Ly called out to them.

“Who are you?” she asked, her voice projecting loud enough to echo around the hangar.

They didn’t answer, and instead fanned out in a broad semi-circle. They were flanking them, cutting off any avenue for escape. Adora reached for She Ra—she’d only answered the previous time because Adora was desperate, and the panic clawing at her anew at seeing all avenues for retreat blocked gave her a bewildering sense of hope as well: maybe She Ra would come now? The power certainly seemed more energetic, but would anything happen when she tried to grasp it?

“Whoever you are, I suggest you turn around and head back right where you came from,” Ly said, tracking those at the farthest ends with her eyes. “We don’t want trouble.”

“I’ve come for the stones,” the giant said. “The on that girl’s arm and the one in her bag…I want them both. You will give them to me, and we will become one.”

Adora grabbed her runestone bracer with her other hand on instinct. The giant’s eyes darted from Ly to her when she did, and a chill ran down her spine. He could sense the Eye, too? All the way across the hangar? Adora had to hold the thing and concentrate to feel whatever was inside. This was way worse than their confrontation earlier, and it wasn’t just because the extra bodies he brought along to intimidate them. The air itself seemed stale now.

“You’re not very bright, are you?” Ly asked. “Big as you are, your guys would turn on you if they knew who I was. I’ll give you one last chance to leave, and maybe the Vestamid won’t hang you to from meat hooks to dry for fucking with me. Take one more step, though, and you won’t have to worry about that—I’ll drop all six of you before any of you can lay a finger on us.”

Adora had no idea how she planned to do that, but she concentrated harder on her powers, straining and poised to

plunge in and grasp at a moment's notice. The giant nodded once to the others and all five stepped forward without hesitation.

Ly stilled a moment, like how air and sound still moments before lightning strikes. Then she moved, fast enough Adora almost didn't see it out the corner of her eye. One moment, five were advancing with predatory looks in their eyes, then all five were on the ground with singed holes in their heads, eyes staring without seeing up at the hangar ceiling.

Ly cursed under her breath, holding a sidearm with smoke trailing out the tip of its barrel still trained on the giant. "Vasher's a fucking liar," she said, quietly enough Adora reasoned she must be talking to herself. "It doesn't matter how many nightmare scenarios you've already lived through, offing actual people is never easy."

Blood began to pool under the corpses and Adora winced. *Did I really just think to myself that I could take her in a fight if push came to shove?* she thought.

Kal had mentioned that only security and people of special interest to the Vestamid got to carry weapons. Vasher had a weapon, of course, but if the Vestamid had hoped to recruit Ly then it also made sense for them to let her as well. She just didn't put that train of thought together until five people were already dead on the floor.

"Come on," Lysithea said to the giant as she reloaded. "Try me, I dare you. I've put down enough thralls in the last war to fill this hangar, and I wasn't even a soldier. You might weigh five of me combined, but that won't help you win a fight if a bullet puts you on the floor first."

The giant, who hadn't taken his eyes off Ly the entire exchange, chose then to look over the bodies of his men. He sniffed in disdain, as if merely acknowledging them was beneath him, before looking Ly directly in the eye again.

“You are arrogant,” he said. “You will learn.”

He took a step forward and Ly didn’t hesitate, firing off one bullet into each of his legs. He didn’t stop, didn’t even slow, and alarms started ringing in Adora’s head when she realized. Even Lysithea took a step back in surprise before firing off another two rounds into his kneecaps.

“What the fuck,” Ly said when that still didn’t so much as make him flinch.

She pulled her aim up and put two into his chest, then a third between his eyes. Adora glanced away, and heard rather than see him hit the ground.

“Emptying two full clips wasn’t exactly how I expected my night to go,” Ly said, taking a slow, deep breath. “He was being so nonchalant about his entire team dying before his eyes I wanted to humble him a bit with those rounds in his legs, but the fucker didn’t blink. I swear, the kinds of drugs seeping into the underworld nowadays are something else.”

Adora looked at her, feeling somewhat shocked at how easygoing she sounded after killing six people, even if they were moments away from likely killing them instead. It wasn’t until she saw the worry lines on Lysithea’s face and the way her hands shook as she struggled to eject the gun’s magazine slide that Adora realized she was likely just as shaken.

“Ly to Vasher, come in,” she said into her PDA her wrist. “Vasher, you there? This is Ly, answer me.” The worry lines on her face subsided and her features relaxed after a moment: Vasher had responded. “I’m fine, but maybe I should have let you come with me after all. Yes, I’m alright, I promise I just…some goons tried to mug us and I had to put them down.” Another pause. “Yeah, you heard right, I did say ‘us.’ She’s here with me. Let me guess, you’re with him?”

Adora, feeling strangely like she was intruding on a private conversation by the tone of Ly's voice, busied herself by trying to find something of interest to look at in the hangar other than the bodies. Unfortunately, the moment she inevitably glanced at them, she saw something that made her blood freeze: blood hadn't pooled out from underneath the giant's corpse like they had for his men. Instead, it looked like his shadow had come alive, and it was reaching for each of the other corpses, slow as molasses.

"Ly?" Adora said, edging shuffling closer to her with an edge to her voice.

"You're on your own with that one, unfortunately," Ly said, still speaking to Vasher and not paying attention. She laughed through her nose. "Yeah, well, I'm not the one that made a bet with him that she'd try and steal his ship, now am I? Maybe if you lean into the fact he ditched us on a job he might feel bad enough not to collect—"

"Ly! Something's wrong!"

Ly looked up just as the giant's shadow engulfed the five other bodies and they started to move, picking themselves up of the ground with unnaturally bent and tangled limbs.

"Oh, fuck." Ly rammed a fresh clip into the empty magazine well of her gun. "Vasher, I need you. Now!"

The body of the giant started to reconstitute as well, although it was taking considerably longer. Ly unloaded two rapid rounds into each thrall as the shambled toward them, slowing each one when the bullets struck center mass. Vasher's voice blared through the PDA speaker at Ly's wrist, loud enough Adora could parse out the overblown syllables in between them being drowned out by the gunfire.

"I found the Abomination," she said, ejecting yet another magazine and pulling another from inside her jacket. "Or rather, it

revealed itself to me. It's got five thralls as far as I can tell, and you have maybe three minutes max before it starts infecting the rest of the station and we all die." She released the slide and aimed. "I don't have Ignominite rounds so I can't stall it for long. You need to get here, *now.*"

Vasher's voice kept coming through—it was clear they were on their way, but Adora got the sense he didn't want to cut the call until they arrived. The stale feeling in the air from earlier returned then, stronger than ever, and Vasher's voice cut off on its own. The line had gone dead, just as the giant reconstituted himself and rose to his feet.

"Like I said earlier," the giant said, his voice sounding different than before, reverberating like a heavy metal slab being dragged across a cobblestone road might—all croaky consonants and clipped vowels. "You are arrogant. You will learn."

The thralls continued to advance and Ly took aim at the nearest one, still a three dozen paces away. She emptied her entire ten round clip into one of its legs, hitting the same spot repeatedly, stripping cloth and skin and muscle and sinew away until the bone broke in half and the thrall fell to the floor in an awkward heap. It didn't stop, just crawled slower than its siblings toward them on one knee and with two hands.

The giant threw its head back and laughed. "You are at an even greater disadvantage than I'd thought, without ignominite bullets. How many more clips do you have, one? Two?"

Ly's fingers shook so hard she almost dropped the next magazine she had pulled. By the somber look on her face, Adora got the sense it was her last reload.

"I'll try and reach for She Ra," she said, whispering under her breath so only Ly could hear. "I'm sure I can—"

"No, don't do anything," Ly said, cutting her off with a pointed glare.

“But what if—”

“I said don’t!” Ly sounded downright terrified. Pleading, almost. And that was enough to give Adora pause, even more so than seeing the dead rise. “Maybe you can call on her if you’re desperate, and maybe you could actually put up a fight against that thing, but if you’re wrong?” Ly shook her head. “Not yet. Our only is to buy time, and as much of it as possible. Wait to try until you can’t anymore.”

“Even a thrall missing its leg can rip your face from your head, choke the life from your body,’ the Abomination said. “And I have five. You can do nothing, dead girl. Come and join with me.”

The four thralls still remaining upright screeched an unholy chorus together and *rushed* toward them faster than they had any right to move. Adora actually took a step back in surprise, thinking surely they wouldn’t have been able to sprint as fast as they were had they still been alive.

Ly stood like she were a boulder against a river current. She didn’t move, didn’t flinch, didn’t blink.

“Dzivia, emergency override code Archanas, zero-five-one-five, The End, Lysithea.” The ship hummed awake behind them. “Bogies, thirty-yard enclosure. Activate containment protocol. Execute!”

A turret lowered from the belly of the ship, anchored right next to where the loading ramp would have descended. It swiveled as it unfurled, then railed each of the thralls with consecutive, rapid-fire rounds. Adora clapped both hands to her ears and ducked, watching the thralls explode one after the other in isolated fountains of viscera.

“Don’t need ignominite rounds if I have enough firepower to turn a body to dust!” Ly said, shouting at the Abomination loud enough Adora could hear through the ringing in her ears. “You’re next, motherfucker!”

The turret, having exploded the last thrall, finally swiveled to the Abomination, who threw its arm forward like it was going for a punch. Its arm to morphed into a thick, black tendril that shot forward, straight toward them. Ly and Adora both dove out of the way and it shot past, piercing the turret clean through. Electricity arced and sparks flew.

The turret guns powered off and pointed down with a depressing whine before the Abomination ripped the whole thing off its installation with enough force the entire *Dzivia* shifted. It swung for Adora then, using the newly mangled turret like a makeshift flail.

Ly crashed into her from the side, sending both of them sprawling on the floor but letting the turret pass overhead. Before Adora could get her bearings or even take a breath, Ly had rolled off her and into a crouched position, emptying her final round into the Abomination still halfway across the hangar bay.

As disadvantaged as Ly seemed without the right ammunition, it still seemed to have an effect. The Abomination flung the turret away with an annoyed grunt, eliciting a crash when it smashed into the far wall and then another when it hit the ground. Then it disappeared, seemingly morphing into the same material its black tentacle was made of, reforming itself near-instantaneously at the other terminus of that limb—right between Ly and Adora.

Ly rounded on him and it smacked the gun out of her hand with a mighty backhand. Then it lunged, grabbing her by the throat and lifting her off the ground with one hand. Her feet kicked freely, trying and failing to find purchase as she slammed one fist against its hand and tried to pry its fingers apart with the other.

Adora reacted on instinct, rising to her feet with one push, leaving the bag with the Eye where it lay on the ground. The Sword of Protection was already coalescing in her hand. It finished forming mid-swing, and she cut clean through the Abomination’s arm, leaving Ly free to land on her feet, gasping for air.

The Abomination roared in agony before quickly reforming its limb. It kicked Ly square in the chest before she had a chance to move, sending her careening backward, smacking into the side of the *Dzivia* with a sickening, tinny gong that reverberated out from its hull.

"No!"

Adora rounded on the Abomination again, furious anger thrumming through her like a wildfire. She still hadn't unleashed all of She Ra, she could just tell, but she was still powerful.

She and the Abomination sparred, it dodging strikes and stabs from her sword, parrying and riposting with alternating limbs that turned into sharpened black tendrils too. Adora found a pattern in its movements and exploited it, stabbing clean through its chest with a roar.

Their fighting ceased, and everything stilled. Adora thought she had won, until the Abomination threw its head back and cackled.

"The power!" it said. "I knew I could feel something coming from that little wristband of yours, girl, but to think it held enough to do that? I would have never guessed." It smiled, the width of its grin seeming to split its face in two. "I will very much enjoy taking it from you, and then making your corpse dance for the trouble."

Adora tried to pull the sword from its body, only for it to get sucked further inside. She tried again to no avail, and when she thought to let go and try commanding it to reform in her hand as she had done in the past, six new tendrils shot from the Abomination's back like a spider's legs and pierced her from behind.

The air grew thick enough Adora felt like it was drowning her. She opened her mouth to scream and all sounds around ceased except for that of her heartbeat, which now pounded in her ears louder than anything else she might have been able to hear moments earlier.

Her head hurt enough she thought it might explode and her vision swam. The Abomination, from what little she could clearly see of its features, seemed to morph and shift with the distortion. Hot coals felt like they were searing against her flesh at six points in her back, no doubt where the tendrils had pierced her to keep her rooted in place.

When the Abomination's features finished reforming into a new face, Adora recognized who it was immediately.

"Hey, Adora."

Catra stared back at her, each eye like a spotlight shining deep into Adora's psyche. Adora couldn't speak—she feared opening her mouth would only elicit screams. She did her best to project concepts like *'I'm sorry'* and *'help'* across, reasoning that if she just thought hard enough and wished fervently enough, Catra would understand.

"You said we'd always be together, Adora. You promised. Don't you remember?"

Adora tried to open her mouth and speak the words this time, but she couldn't.

"You won't be able to keep your promise if you let this be the end," Catra said. "Don't let this be the end, Adora. *Don't let this be the end…*"

Catra's voice trailed off and disappeared into the nothing, like a leaf carried away in the wind. The effect it had on Adora was exactly the opposite.

A fire sparked within her, an unceasing will to fight and claw her way to survival. This wouldn't be the end, and she repeated those words in her head over and over again like a ritual chant done on the eve of battle.

The world exploded back into clarity once more: the smell of burning flesh and death wafting all around, the taste of copper in

her mouth, the sound of someone—hopefully Ly, calling her name in the distance. Catra was gone, the Abomination having returned and taken her place. Adora could see every pore and follicle of hair and wrinkle set into its sallow skin. Cracked veins of red creeped the length of each black tendril that held her in place, similarly pulsing like a heartbeat itself.

Fresh power coursed through Adora's veins, far more than before. Far more even than what she had been able to draw on in the Crystal Castle.

"Interesting," the Abomination said. The playfulness had left its voice. Now it seemed begrudgingly impressed, almost respectful. "That much power running through you, it can't just be the stone." It cocked its head to the side, studying her. "You'd be wasted as a thrall. Shame. But we all have to start somewhere, don't we?"

The coals of fire still at Adora's back grew hotter, and she screamed in agony. The clarity and strength she had been building, the foothold she had been slowly digging out for herself, disappeared as quickly as it had come. Whereas her vision swam and changed before, it disappeared entirely now—the Abomination had reimposed its will upon her tenfold and plunged her into darkness right there in the hangar, into a world devoid of any stimulus except for the sound of her heart and the pain ripping across her body.

There was no Catra this time to call out to her. No one and nothing came, except for one hazy image she strained to make out against the darkness. It was a face, androgynous and anonymous, like the features of thousands of beings had normalized into one supremely average, blank slate of a canvas.

*ADORA*

It called to her, a disembodied voice in her mind that spoke without its lips moving, its eyes trained unceasingly on her without blinking.

*You Are Not She Ra*

*You Are Not Enough*

*Not Enough For Either Of Them*

Fear and remorse, dull and round and edgeless as everything else, whipped at her in the void with every syllable. She'd never get the chance to apologize to Catra for everything, never get the chance to reach out like she now realized she wanted to—like Glimmer had been urging her to for a while now. She realized with another muted blow of formless emotion that she'd never get to see Glimmer again either, or the other princesses. Or Micah, Bow… Swift Wind. She even miss Salas. Sadness and regret suffused her mindscape, and then even that too started to fade.

And then it didn't.

Someone off in the far distance yelled loud enough for it to register, and she had already half come back to the world by the time she noticed.

Something cold lay against her face, and she realized a moment after that it was actually her, laying against the cold floor of the hangar. The Abomination had released her and she had fallen limp to the ground. She no longer glowed, and the Sword of Protection somehow ejected itself from the Abomination's body and returned as a bracer on her arm.

With great effort, she craned her head up and saw why the she had been let go of in the first place.

The hangar was lit in small arms fire. Vasher and a team of twenty were fanned out in a similar formation to the goons from earlier, but in an obviously more controlled manner—they had drilled this.

They advanced steadily forward, firing automatic rifles rounds at the Abomination who had turned to face them with both arms up

to shield its face. It yelled and grunted and shied away as the bullets tore endless holes into its body. Bullet wounds appeared and, although they were closing, they did so slowly with the same black substance that made up its tentacles.

"Ignominite…it burns…" the Abomination said, its voice now sounding like a chorus of many disembodied voices instead of one. "You are all so *annoying*."

More tendrils lanced forward, spearing nearly half the men who couldn't get out of the way fast enough. Those remaining turned immediately toward them and riddled them with holes so the Abomination couldn't take them as thralls, which only seemed to agitate it even further. It swept its extended tendrils across the length of the hangar, cutting six more men clean in half. Vasher and the rest had dropped prone to the ground a split second earlier to avoid death, before rolling again to their feet and continuing to flank.

Someone peeled off from the group, although with Adora couldn't clearly make out who since her vision was still going in and out of focus; all she could tell was this person wasn't part of Vasher's crew, since they weren't wearing the dark blue uniform like everyone else. They moved faster than all the others, flanking almost completely to the side within moments. They weren't firing either, only cradling their rifle with one hand as they ran.

The Abomination tracked them, sending a tendril screaming toward them. Their eyes glowed and they gestured with one free hand, mid sprint. The tendril veered off course as if slapped by an invisible hand.

It was Kal.

No sooner did Adora realize this than Kal changed course again, no longer flanking but now beelining straight for the Abomination.

It growled, turning its full attention to him when Vasher and his men stopped firing. Kal jumped and flew through the air, dodging

a dozen new tendrils the Abomination shot forward to intercept him and redirecting a dozen more with invisible magic. He landed only a few feet away and dropped, using his momentum to slide along the hangar floor, ramming both his booted feet full force into the Abomination to come to a hard stop.

The Abomination grunted at the impact and dropped to both knees, its feet having been kicked out from under it. Only then did Adora realize why Kal hadn't been firing with the rest: he wasn't carrying a rifle, but a shotgun. One he already had aimed squarely at the Abomination's chest.

The Abomination's entire back exploded outward like two wings of black viscera when Kal pulled the trigger. It painted Adora. Howls of pain and wet, gurgling wretches echoed through the hangar, chasing the sound of the blast.

Already, the wound was beginning to stitch close, but Kal didn't give the Abomination time to recover. He tossed the shotgun aside and leaptto his feet before grabbing its head with both hands, holding like he were trying to squeeze a watermelon.

Then Kal exploded with light.

When Adora first saw him use magic back atop the Crystal Castle, she was under the impression he had runes imprinted directly on his skin that glowed when he cast. But now, being this close to him, she saw that they were not runes at all, but ley-lines—circuits of blue-hot magic that spread across the entire surface area of his body. She and the rest of the Princesses had this happen to them when the Heart of Etheria first activated. Adora hadn't even considered that a similar phenomenon could show up on someone else.

Kal's hair floated in whisps around his head, like he was submerged underwater. His eyes had turned pure white, like pinprick stars so powerful the physicality of his body was insufficient a vessel to contain it.  And when he spoke, blue smoke accompanied the same light bursting from his mouth.

“Revealing yourself was the last mistake you shall ever make. The people of this station, of this galaxy, they shall have lifetimes and generations. I will not allow you to take it from them.”

The Abomination screeched. Its tendrils went spastic, flailing without intention or reason before going rigid, bursting into flames, and finally dissolving into ash. It clapped its hands to Kal’s own at either side of its head, like it was trying to pry them free, or merely hold its own head in agony.

“What are you!?” It screamed, ten thousand voices as one.

Kal leaned in and the light from his body grew bright enough to wash out everything else around. “You know who I am,” he said. “You felt me at the clinic when we first crossed paths. I have come for you.”

“But…but they spoke of you as one does a myth! The Shapers are all gone…Corynth is dead. You are dead!”

“You’ll feel I’m very much alive.”

The Abomnation gave one final scream before its whole body burst into flames, like its tendrils before. Adora reeled from the heat, squinting against the light to catch any glimpse of shape or form within. She saw the two of them blaze for several moments before the flames extinguished and the light dissipated.

Kal—or Corynth, as Adora suddenly realized that’s who he really was—stood there, body tense, steam rising off him. In his hands, he held a charred, blackened skull missing its lower jaw. It had detached from its body which lay nearby, charred, also with steam rising from its calcified remains. The Abomination was dead.

Corynth dropped the skull then and it tumbled across the floor. It collapsed into dust just as Corynth stumbled forward, seeming to be on the verge of collapse himself. While the blinding light from earlier had subsided, his eyes still sparked, his hair still floated around him like a halo, and Adora noticed veins of black creeping like vines up his neck.

Vasher hurried over and rested a firm hand on his shoulder, those few others still alive bringing up the rear.

"Corynth?" Vasher said. "Hey, look at me."

The words didn't seem to register. It wasn't until Vasher gave him a slight shake that Corynth seemed to realize where he was.

"There you are," Vasher said when Corynth finally looked at him. The concern hadn't faded from his voice, though. "I need you to dissipate the magic now,  okay? Can you do that for me?"

"V-Vasher?"

He nodded. "Yeah, I'm here. The magic, Corynth. Or Kal? Shit, this feels so much like it before that I completely forgot…"

"Vasher…I…I—"

"The magic, Kal, *the magic*. You need to stop or you're going to burn yourself straight through."

"Vasher, w-where's Evie? I have to…have…"

He went white the moment Evie's name was spoken. "Shit," he said, muttering under his breath before turning and bellowing over his shoulder: "Ly, I need you!"

Ly came running toward them from inside the *Dzivia*, flying down the now open ramp and across the hangar. Her face was battered and she clutched her ribs with one arm, but she was alive, to Adora's great relief.

"I've got it," Ly said, sliding to a stop in front of them. She had the ignominite cuffs Corynth had once used on Adora and held them up for him to see. "Hey bud, Evie's in her lab working, you know how she always is. I need you to put these on."

Corynth shook his head, seeming more animated than moments earlier despite the look in his eyes suggesting he was even further

away than before. “Taline…coming. Have to…explain.”

“Shhh, no.” Ly shook her head, and Adora could see tears pricking the corners of her eyes. “Taline isn’t coming, you already kicked her ass and she still didn’t get it. Let me put these on, please.”

His eyes drifted down to the manacles and confusion bloomed on his face. “I—”

“Corynth, you just ate an entire juvenile Abomination. I know you had to do it, but there was a reason I made you fucking *promise* me to never exert yourself like this again after Archanas and this is why. If you can’t disengage on your own, I can help you but you have to meet me halfway. If I force it and you aren’t here with us…” She shook her head and the tears finally fell from her eyes. “*Please.* Evie is gone. Everyone is gone, it’s just us. I plunged through Taline’s stupid fleet blockade and a toxic atmosphere to get you because I couldn’t lose another person. I couldn’t do it then and I still can’t do it now. You left us alone for three fucking years already, don’t make it permanent! Kal!”

It was the desperate hoarseness in her voice or the use of his other name—Adora wasn’t sure which, but one or both seemed to ground him enough to understand. He nodded then slowly extended both hands forwards palm up.

Ly wasted no time in securing both manacles to his wrists. The moment she did so, the remaining magic flowing through him disappeared, his hair lay flat against his head again, and the black veins inching up his neck disappeared. The next moment, he collapsed unconscious against Vasher, who held him upright against one shoulder while he comforted Ly, who was shaking.

“I’ll get him to the infirmary,” Vasher said after a pause.

“No, I’ll go,” Ly said, swallowing and wiping her eyes before stepping out from his embrace. When Vasher gave her a strong loke, she said, “I was attacked too, and so was Adora. Pretty sure I have a few broken ribs at least, and Adora doesn’t look like she

can even stand without help. We need to make sure this gets cleaned up and that no one comes snooping around to see what happened. There's also a giant hole in the *Dzivia* that needs to get patched since the Abomination ripped a turret from its installation, and you're the only person either of us can trust to stay here and coordinate all of that right now."

Vasher hesitated and looked like he was about to argue, until Ly reached forward and laid a gentle hand on his knee.

"You got here in time," she said, her voice dipping back into the tone Adora had heard her speak to him with before the Abomination reanimated. "We're all alive. This didn't happen because you didn't come with me to this hangar, and nothing bad will happen because you don't come with me to the infirmary. I promise." She stood without waiting for an answer and turned to help hoist Adora to her feet. "Tell me if you need a break," she said to her. "Or if anything hurts more than it should."

Adora nodded, sweat already breaking out across her clammy skin. She didn't trust herself to speak. Someone brought the bag with the Eye inside and Ly took it with a grateful nod.

Vasher handed Corynth off to two of his men, who he ordered to follow Ly. Then he surveyed the rest of the hangar, looking over the charred Abomination's body, the bits and pieces of his men, the wrecked turret in the corner, and the countless pockets of blood and other bodily fluids smeared about.

Slowly, Ly stumped forward toward the security building in the distance and Adora kept pace, leaning as much of her weight as she dared against her for support. The two men carrying Corynth trailed them.

Logically, Adora knew the fact she had been traveling this whole time with Corynth of all people was a massive revelation, but after everything she had gone through, she didn't have her wits about her enough to feel the emotion that should have been there. All she knew was that she hoped to never face another Abomination

again in her life and that she hoped to reach back out and apologize to Catra as soon as humanly possible.

With Ly finally agreeing to look at the Eye and troubleshoot Pip, maybe both those things could actually happen.

Chapter End Notes

> Phew ok, this chapter was a Beast (lol, pun not intended). I tried to find a good spot to split it but everything felt like way too much of a cliffhanger, so I just kept the whole thing in one chunk :)
>
> Am I 100% satisfied with how I portrayed Adora realizing a certain big point in her arc? That's debateable--I have a hunch my feelings on that will change given time, but I do think it flows a little better than what I had going in her previous chapter. Splitting up the agitation with the understanding helped pace things better, in my opinion.
>
> And, full transparency here, Corynth and Kal being the same person was not intended to be some huge twist xD In the very early planning stages of this story (I'm talking draft 1, chapter 17) I considered making Kal's identity be a major twist element, but the story outline just felt forced trying to keep that in. So I dove deep with the hints and was really glad to see a majority of commenters pick up on and express their suspicions early on. The only thing I didn't account for was then how to respond to comments when people made their guesses known xD I didn't want to give anything away, but y'all know me, I respond to every comment T.T
>
> Also, at over 8k words, this is the longest chapter in the story, or second longest when compared to one other we haven't gotten to yet. Since it was such a large chapter, I have this gut feeling a larger than usual number of typos/grammatical mistakes bled through this time around. Hopefully nothing that yanks you guys out of the story, but please tell me if anything does!

Hope you enjoyed! Part 3 is wrapping up!

# When Death Comes Calling

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer stood inside her intake station and tried to catch her breath. A particularly large family of Scavrians had come through, and processing them had taken far more effort than she had to give at the moment. Things were dire, and trying to instill even a modicum of hope into those passing through to the Megaliths beyond felt like an impossible task. At least she had a few seconds' break in the monotony before those next in line reached her, so she glanced out at Tir in the distance and let her thoughts overtake her.

Aratoth had died a few hours after Kyle and Lonnie had gotten him to the field hospital. Only been a few days had passed since then and already Tir's cityscape on the horizon looked transformed. Many of the spires and skyscrapers had collapsed, tumbling in heaps of noise and smoke periodically across the hours, the sounds of explosions and of nightmarish screams in the distance dogging the refugees and Enclave staffers like specters. Warbirds flew at all times of the day and night, a constant fixture in the sky now as they patrolled the skies and near-space orbit between Tir, the Megalith compound, and the fleet high above. Moans and screams of thralls in the distance echoed out constantly, weirdly harmonized at times, and always accompanied by percussive gunfire.

The compound itself was abuzz in martial activity. Refugees whispered to friends and loved ones and any who would listen about their suspicions surrounding the Empire's ability to retake the city. If Tir fell, all of Scavria would likely fall with it within a matter of months. Would evacuations from other major cities and continents have time to complete? Would those in the countryside be saved, or were they essentially dead men and women walking if Tir wasn't resolved? This and many other questions came

hurling out of the mouths of the refugees at all times of the day and all through the night as they crowded the administrative centers of the compound scrabbling for answers, driven forward in a frenzy by fear and uncertainty.

Not even Glimmer had been able to avoid scrutiny. In fact, as the famed 'Angel of Archanas,' she probably had it worse, unable to count on both hands twice over how many times she'd been accosted by angry and scared refugees for answers. Yet she and everyone else with working knowledge of the Empire and Enclave's efforts couldn't say a word, and it had driven her nearly to despair over the past few days.

All knowledge of operations were classified, never to be disclosed to the refugees themselves in an effort to keep from setting false expectations or instigating further unrest. Glimmer's earlier stunt in the central square, sharing her personal thoughts about a successful incursion against the Beast, had spurred the operational heads to issue an ironclad gag order on everything. So much as speculating aloud when the Megaliths themselves might lift off was not allowed.

Not that it mattered, though. The situation was plainly evident no matter how silent Glimmer and the rest of the Enclave and Empire were in the face of ceaseless pressure: things were not looking good. They would likely lose the city within a matter of weeks, now.

The next set of refugees up for processing reached the side of her station and sighed, breathing deep in preparation to dive back into the work. When she turned to address the newcomers with the best smile she could muster, she instead found Lonnie standing there with a mildly disturbed expression on her face. Glimmer's smile dropped the moment she saw.

"What are you doing here?" she asked, feeling put out.

Lonnie leaned away from the station and made a show of craning her neck to the side to inspect the refugee staging area behind

her. A violent bruise had spread across the bridge of her nose, and Glimmer and could tell it had been broken and splinted.

“Doesn’t look like you have very many left to process,” Lonnie said, sweeping her eyes over the near-empty expanse. “And there’s at least twenty others like you lined up in the stalls to help process them. Stealing a few minutes from you specifically won’t be too big a deal.”

The ache in Glimmer’s jaw flared with her irritation. Lonnie’s blow to the side of her face wasn’t anything to scoff. The swelling had largely gone down, but ugly bruises that had throbbed constantly through the preceding days still marred the side of her own face and had only recently started to shrink.

“The point,” Glimmer said, putting ice into her words and leaning over the countertop to get into Lonnie’s space, ”is that you’re keeping me from doing my job. You’re lucky they decided not to charge you for fighting outside the hospital, in front of all the refugees. Are you *trying* to get in trouble?”

“You fought back, last I remember,” Lonnie said. “And even landed the first blow—“

“Yeah, after you goaded me.”

“—so you’re just as lucky as I am we didn’t get reamed.”

Glimmer hands crept toward Lonnie’s throat and she forced them to still. Instead, she closed her eyes, pinched the bridge of her nose, and took a breath, deep breath. “Did you just come to pick another fight? You won’t win a second time now that I know how fast you can move, you know.”

Lonnie put both hands up and shook her head. “I’m not here to fight, actually. I came to apologize.”

“What?” Glimmer wanted to tell her to lead with that next time, but held her tongue.

“I’m serious,” Lonnie said. “I’m sorry for what happened. It was my fault for starting it.”

“Well…you did goad me into fighting back.”

“I’m not just talking about that.” Lonnie blinked. “Although, yes, I did do that.”

Glimmer frowned. “What are you talking about, then?”

“I’m talking about how things between us have been tense ever since getting to this planet. That’s my fault and I’m sorry.”

“You were upset about me not taking the team on.”

Lonnie smirked. “Are you justifying my behavior? Now you’re just being nice, you don’t really think that.”

Glimmer frowned. Lonnie was right, she didn’t particularly feel forgiving and nice about the whole situation, but she was just trying to be polite. She forgot how forthcoming and blunt a person Lonnie was. “Well—”

“I punched you in the face and blamed you for Aratoth’s and everyone else’s deaths,” Lonnie said. “It wasn’t fair to you, and I’m sorry.”

“You lost your whole team,” Glimmer said. “You lost them after thinking I was going to be there because we were matched without me knowing. I’d feel resentful too, if that happened to me, even if I understood why things happened the way they did.” She leaned back and out of Lonnie’s space. “I appreciate the apology, and I don’t hold it against you.”

Lonnie shook her head. “It’s not just that.”

Glimmer raised both eyebrows, and Lonnie sighed, fidgeting under her gaze in an uncharacteristic show of discomfort.

"My expectations were too high before our paths even crossed again on the *Omen-Kador*," Lonnie said. "The first time we ever saw each other, years ago when we were still back home and not even out of Despondos yet, you were just another Princess in my mind—another enemy to fight. I wasn't exactly thrilled with what Shadow Weaver did to you after we grabbed you from the Princess Prom, but I admit, seeing you go through that and come out the other end still strong left an impression on me.

"And then we left home, and you…well, you know what you did. What you've been doing. How fast things spread in the galaxy." She laughed. "Time lag for non-ansible messages is a thing, and the outer rim is only a few days behind the core Heartlands in terms of news. I'd already heard too many stories about you by the time we met again on the *Omen-Kador*. I was expecting to reunite with some mythical being, and I didn't take it well when that didn't happen."

Glimmer bit her lip. She'd disliked how her name had spread through the galaxy before, how pressured she felt by it, but she had never considered how it impacted her personal relationships. She'd never seen it *have* an impact on her personal relationships. Now, she absolutely loathed the name 'Angel of Archanas,' both for how wildly inaccurate a portrait of her it painted in the minds of those who heard it, and especially for how it damaged potential friendships before they could even begin.

"Lonnie, I…" Glimmer didn't know what to say, and she trailed off.

"They almost deployed us there, you know," Lonnie said. "Kyle, Rogelio, and I. To Rinne. If it weren't for the fact the entire planet fell so fast, we very well might have been.

"I'm glad you weren't."

"Sometimes I wish we did make it there," Lonnie said, surprising Glimmer. "Everyone else only remembers how horrible it was, seeing how many 'lost souls' were reported scrolling across news tickers day after day. Me, though? The thing that stuck out to me

—the thing I remember the most—was hearing about the survivors. Sometimes I catch myself wondering how many more might have made it out if we were there with you, helping."

"I would have mourned at an empty grave for you three, or stared at your names on the monument they put up in the Heartland capital."

"Maybe," Lonnie said, before repeating the word again, quieter to herself. "I was amazed that anyone at all made it off that planet, though. It gave me hope. And when I saw you again on the *Omen*..."

"You thought your chance finally came to be part of that legacy—to be there the next time shit hits the fan so you can help, and maybe more people would be saved."

Lonnie swallowed and nodded.

"And when I turned around and said no," Glimmer said. "When I chose to stand here in this processing station instead of be out there, and then when people *still* died and, worst of all, you had to pull the trigger?" Glimmer bit her lip and looked away. "Yeah. I get why that would be upsetting to see."

"If you're thinking about apologizing to me now, then stop," Lonnie said. "I sacrificed seeing you as an actual person so I could live in my little fantasy world about serving with a Battlemage that can save people from certain death. I'm apologizing for how selfish that is and that's the only thing anyone should be apologizing for."

"But—"

"You saved hundreds of people, Glimmer. Don't apologize for all those you couldn't. I'm sorry I ever asked you to, even in an abstract way."

Glimmer pressed her lips together and thought. One moment she was loathing her nickname and the next, the very person that got

mislead by it was telling her how much hope it had given them? Maybe being the Angel to so many people was a curse, but maybe it was also a blessing. Maybe it could be both.

"They really should have called me the Angel of Rinne," she said, cracking a tentative smile to break the tension. "I've never even been to Archanas."

Lonnie grinned in response and, for the first time since reuniting, Glimmer felt they were on the same page. "I doubt you'd ever want to go, even if you could get special dispensation to visit it. Empire made it a protected site for a reason."

Glimmer laughed. "Yeah, it's just a joke Catra and I have whenever it's brought up—that I've never even been to the place they call me an Angel of."

Lonnie's eyes widened. "Catra's still around?"

"Yep, she came with me off Etheria. Taline sponsored both of us. She's a cop, now."

"Lord above is that the last job I'd ever think she'd be fit for."

Glimmer laughed. "You'd be surprised at how much she's changed. We all have." A beat passed between them, and she said, "Thanks for coming to see me. And apologizing. I'm glad we're on the same page again, I hated being mad at you, even if we saw very little of one another."

Lonnie's expression turned melancholy. "I wanted to come and say something before it was too late."

Glimmer froze. She hadn't known Lonnie well back on Etheria, and although she had hoped she was the type of person to naturally dig deep, understand the root of a disagreement, and make peace, this whole about face in their relationship felt surreal. Now it made sense: something was wrong. Something that had spurred her to face what was really bothering her and make amends.

“What’s going on?” she asked.

“We’re going on one last deployment into the city,” Lonnie said. “Fleet command doesn’t think we’ll be able to save it and wants to nuke it from space, but we’re to do one last incursion before that.”

“One last attack to try and get a foothold, huh?” Glimmer asked, trying to keep the knot of worry in her stomach from growing larger. “Sounds dangerous, but nothing you haven’t done a hundred times over already. Who are you serving under now that Aratoth has…?”

Lonnie’s expression turned cloudy, and that was all Glimmer needed to infer the answer.

“They’re sending you out there without a Battlemage commander?” she asked, the knot in her stomach quickly forming into a boulder. “They can’t do that. That’s practically suicide, you said so yourself. There are other commanders out there, why haven’t you been assigned under one of them for the assault?”

“Technically, we are,” she said. “We’ve been attached as an augment to one of the existing squads, but the Battlemage in charge has made it pretty clear they don’t intend on really overseeing us. At least, not how they should. I guess they heard what happened to Aratoth’s squad and assumed it happened because he spread himself too thin trying to command too large a group.”

“That’s bullshit!” Glimmer said. “He was stretched thin, sure, but I reviewed the action report. You guys were ambushed. It wouldn’t have made a difference if he had the right sized team or not, almost everyone would still be dead!”

“Yep,” Lonnie said, speaking in a defeated tone of voice that Glimmer absolutely hated hearing from her of all people. “But our orders are clear. Tag along, provide back up, stay out of the way and don’t expect further orders. That’s what Rogelio and I are working with.”

“And Kyle?”

Lonnie shrugged. “They split us up for this one. Our guy ‘in charge’ put us on a different warbird and Kyle is reinforcing another wing that lost a pilot recently.”

Glimmer cursed. She wanted to ask who the new commander was, but also knew that Lonnie likely wouldn’t say and it wouldn’t make a difference if she did. Battlemages were in charge of their own teams, and it would be supremely hypocritical for her to try and influence another person’s command after she turned down her own.

Lonnie looked down at the PDA on her wrist. “I have to get going,” she said. “It’s almost time.”

They locked eyes a moment. Glimmer wanted to say something. Maybe wish her luck, maybe tell her things were going to be okay—something. But in the end, she could only nod and watch Lonnie walk off back toward the compound.

The terrified faces of a fresh set of refugees took her place and she processed them in. Then another set came, and then another, and soon time passed in a blur once again, as it always had. At one point, a flurry of warbirds took off from the nearby staging area nearby and flew overhead toward Tir. Glimmer watched, having never felt more helpless before, standing on the ground inside her station, watching them go.

Not even Rinne, as hellish a landscape as that was, felt this foreboding.

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The liftoff call came several hours later, after Glimmer had already finished her shift and was in the middle of forcing herself to eat something despite her nerves.

No one seemed surprised when the alarm started blaring. Everyone in her immediate vicinity looked up and around at one

another, and all bodies jumped up to execute what they had drilled for: emergency evacuation.

Soon, a voice came over the compound's PA system, accompanying the siren.

It told the refugees that evacuation procedures were underway. Told them to immediately return to their assigned megaliths. Told them that the city had been lost and that orbital bombardment would commence immediately to buy as much time for the megaliths stationed around the rest of the planet to pull out too.

Abject panic broke out in the compound then, as was expected. The refugees hadn't drilled for anything, not like the staffers had, and it was their training that would salvage what they could from the botched operation.

Soldiers and general security rushed to their duty stations, yelling and commanding everyone into their assigned megaliths. Refugees abandoned whatever they were doing, leaving behind personal belongings to scoop up children and meet with loved ones, scrambling to follow orders. Within minutes, giant crowds had formed at the mouths of each of the great starships, and security worked diligently to funnel them inside as fast as they could.

More warbirds screamed overhead as they flew in formation toward Tir, likely to support whatever evacuation efforts that had been put into effect for those still fighting in the city. Additional soldiers scrambled out of nearby barracks, yelling and hollering as they ran toward speeder bikes idling outside the compound exit, waiting for whoever needed to use them.

The announcer rattled off a one hour timeline until liftoff and began folding that into their other instructions. One hour, and those inside were safe while those not yet on a ship would die.

A chime sounded at her wrist and Glimmer answered the notification on her PDA. Kyle's face appeared on the holo-screen

that projected in front of her.

“Glimmer!” he said. “Oh thank god, you answered.”

“One hour until liftoff,” she said. There was no time for idle talk.

“We were told ninety minutes until orbital bombardment.” From the feed, it looked like Kyle was still flying, the stars and ships of the fleet tumbling and twisting outside the canopy of his cockpit.

“I’m looking at the live feeds right now,” Glimmer said, scanning through the data while she kept a line open to him. “It looks like there are still tens of thousands of soldiers in Tir, fighting. Are they going to be able to get out in time?”

“We’re scrambling practically every available transport to get as many out as we can, but fleet command has made it explicitly clear the bombarding begins after the clock runs out, regardless of whoever is still down there. They can’t wait much longer than that or they’ll risk losing the whole planet faster than the other sites can get out.”

Glimmer cursed. “This is way more aggressive a timeline than what anyone’s trained to. It sounds like they set something off out there.” she said. “Did they stumble across the Abomination? Was it just hiding how far along it was from our mages?”

“I have no idea,” Kyle said. “They may have lost a Battlemage to it and now there’s two, who knows. I wouldn’t be surprised, given that Aratoth was nearly taken right then and there.” The background spun faster and Kyle paused as he hooked through the g-forces. “Listen, I can’t get ahold of Lonnie or Rogelio.”

Glimmer felt her blood go cold. She had been afraid of hearing those words, and yet there they were. “What do you mean you can’t get ahold of them?”

“Nearly everyone else is answering the evacuation calls and we can pick them up, but the team those two in particular were part

of went dark. None of them are answering their pings and I can't pinpoint their exact location."

*Shit*, Glimmer thought. If they didn't answer their pings then they won't get picked up for evacuation at all. She had left people behind before—left the people of Rinne behind. Left Taline's Battlemage Narre to die by the Emperor's hand aboard his citadel. Left Bow and Adora and the other princesses behind to activate the Heart despite them pleading with her not to, so many years ago now.

Those memories, those realizations, came back one after the other as Kyle's words echoed in her head. She was about to lose two more people, and there was one thought that came of that realization—the one thought that stood clear to her amid the panic:

Never again.

"Send me their last known location," Glimmer said racing the other soldiers to the speeders at the edge of the compound. "Whatever is recorded for their last valid ping, give it to me. I'm going."

"Are you sure about this?" Kyle asked. "We're already at tremendous risk considering how many Battlemages are still down there. You're going in without a team to take care of you if you get oversaturated. If we lose you...we could bombard the city with twice the armament from space and even the megaliths in *our* compound won't have time to get free then, let alone the ones around the rest of the planet."

"They'll have time," Glimmer said. "I know exactly how long it takes one to lift off. We pushed the absolute limit on Rinne. They'll make it, even if I don't."

"Fuck." Kyle breathed the word to himself, but Glimmer heard it come through clear as if he had shouted it at her.

She didn't tell him that, if the Beast took her, she'd likely eat the whole region and start bleeding past the Kaloshi border, she'd be

so powerful. They'd probably reinstate Taline just to put a stop to her. The thought made her laugh, privately, in a perverse, morbid sort of way.

"Keep an eye on my own tracker," she said instead. "I'll ping you when I've located them."

"You have a ride in?"

"Working on it."

Glimmer had reached the idling speeders outside the compound right as he asked and she mounted one, grabbing the helmet slung to its side putting it on while her PDA and its onboard systems integrated. The moment the speeder registered her rank, it roared to life. She pushed the throttle to max and shot off across the steppe, heading straight for Tir in the distance.

Chapter End Notes

> This is the last Glimmer scene for part 3. She gets a consecutive 4-part "mini-finale" to her arc at the start of part 4, before getting to the lead up to the fic's "full finale" (which is pretty much all of part 5, lol)
>
> Adora next, then Catra, then Adora again to close out part 3!

# Hey, Catra...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora leaned heavy into Ly as they stumped forward through one of the industrial service coridors adjacent the landing bays, following two of Vasher's blue-coated men and Corynth's limp body they supported between them. Adora could barely focus, and several times during their jaunt she would have slipped and fallen face-first to the floor if Ly, amid a string of curses and strained words of encouragement, hadn't been there to keep her upright.

At last they reached the end of the hall, where two sentries—clad in armor of a color and design Adora had only before seen in educational reels on Etheria—were guarding a pair of sliding, reinforced steel doors. The halted Vasher's men, only to blink in surprise when they saw Ly bring up the rear and then scramble to get the door open.

"What are the Vanguard doing here?" Adora asked, as the doors slid open and they pushed through to the pitch black room beyond. "I thought this whole outpost was hidden from the Empire?"

"Curious, isn't it?" Ly asked, eyeing them as they passed by. "Why *would* the Emperor send his elite here to oversee a Vestamid black site?"

From her tone, Adora got the sense Ly knew exactly what she was implying. Was Horde Prime coordinating Beast experimentation with the Vestamid without anyone knowing? Even the implication seemed earth shattering, although in her rattled state she couldn't articulate why.

The lights cut on with a clang the next moment, robbing Adora of her train of thought. The room was huge and filled with countless

tables and shelves filled with scientific equipment.

“It’s a spare lab,” Ly said, picking up on Adora’s curiosity. “No need to look so confused.”

“They just keep this stuff ready to go?”

“Correction, it’s *the* spare lab the Vestamid have been trying to bully me into occupying for a while now. Do they just keep this stuff ready to go normally? No, but do they keep it ready to go for *me* hoping I’d come around and use it?”

Ly inflected the end of her sentence in a way that answered it as she asked. Suddenly it made sense why the Vanguard just let them in.

“Can you believe I actually considered taking them up on their offer?” Ly asked. “That was before I suspected they were working on creating Abominations.” She scoffed. “I can only imagine what would have happened had I joined and finally realized what they were trying to do, but it doesn’t seem like my abstaining did anything. They still managed to create one.”

“That thing was terrifying…” Adora tried not to think back to her skirmish in the hangar, how it almost subsumed her entire consciousness inside itself even after powering up with a good chunk of She Ra’s power.

“You stood your ground against it.”

Adora shook her head. “I gave it a hard time, but that didn’t seem to phase it much. Kal…Corynth…” She nodded her head in his direction ahead of them as they wound through the lab. “How he managed to immolate it, I have no idea.”

“Yeah, and as you can clearly see, he’s not doing so hot right now.”

“Will he be okay?”

Ly pressed her lips together and knit her brow. “Don’t ask me that…”

“But—”

“I don’t know, Adora.” She huffed, and when her voice shook, Adora realized she was terrified and trying not to show it. “I really don’t know.”

They pushed on soundlessly until their group came to lab’s far back wall, where a floor to ceiling window looking into an operating room was installed. A team of doctors and nurses in full regalia were waiting for them, and they directed Vasher’s men to bring Corynth inside and deposit him on the central table. Adora couldn’t get a good look at him.

“Can you stand on your own for a bit?” Ly asked, pulling her attention away. When Adora nodded, Ly left her side and stopped the team before they could turn around and head inside after Corynth.

They spoke in hushed tones and Adora could hear almost nothing of their conversation, but judging by Ly’s harsh undertones and jerky body language, she was conveying a stern message.

“What was that about?” Adora asked, when Ly returned to her side and guided her away.

“Cat’s out of the bag, unfortunately,” Ly said, pursing her lips with a rueful expression. “Those are Vestamid doctors. I threatened them hoping they’ll keep their mouths shut about who they’re treating, but I doubt they will, even after they promised me.”

Adora remembered what little Corynth had told her of them, how they venerated him like a god, and she grimaced. “Well, at the very least I think they’ll have plenty of incentive to get him healthy again,” she said, forcing a tone she’d hoped would lighten the mood. “It’s not every day you get to meet one of your personal deities, is it?”

Ly laughed under her breath in a way that made it clear she was not helping, and Adora sighed.

"He'll be okay," she said, voice turning serious. Ly looked up at her and Adora held her gaze. "He lived through the end of the last war and just ate an Abomination. This won't put him down."

Ly didn't say anything, but Adora liked to think she helped put her mind at ease, even a little bit.

The situation still baffled her. The Vestamid, one of the most powerful secret powers in the galaxy, venerated that guy? The legend of Corynth struck such a discordant note with who Adora had known as Kal for the majority of their time together that she still couldn't wrap her head around it.

They went through another door in the side of the lab once they reached it, where another figure dressed in doctor's robes helped her onto the examination table. Ly left them alone after promising she'd be back soon since she had to get her own injuries looked at.

The doctor was thorough, poking and prodding Adora in places she didn't realize could be prodded, doing quick full body scans with a wand-shaped device that beeped and hummed as it passed over particularly painful parts of her body, writing down notes on the pad of paper held to their clipboard.

"Have you seen any shadows?" they asked, after wordlessly going through many tests already.

"Pardon?"

"Shadows. Ghosts. Hallucinations. Have you seen anything moving around in the shadows that wasn't really there? Anything out of the corners of your eyes that disappeared once you turned to focus on them?"

"No, I don't think so." That sounded terrifying.

The doctor nodded and stood from their stool. “Well, your body is stitching itself back together faster than it has any right to, and I’m seeing nothing abnormal on the scans. If you’re not experiencing any side effects either—”

“My whole body really hurts.”

The doctor narrowed their eyes at her, as if trying to judge whether or not she were an intelligent lifeform or not. “Yes, well, that’s to be expected given the fact you went up against subject seventeen. Let’s just say the fact you are alive at all is abnormality enough.” They checked their clipboard of notes, their eyes scanning the page. “Your enhanced healing factor is interesting as well, although given what biological abnormalities I attend to on a daily basis, it isn’t worth my time to keep you for any further tests.”

Adora knit her brow and scowled. The doctor was insulting her, although his tone of voice was nothing but clinical and offhand, like someone discussing the weather in an elevator. Still, she might have felt incensed if she weren’t so spent, already.

“My suggestion is bed rest.” The doctor gestured with his head to a door in the side of the room. “There’s bedding in there. Get some sleep. We’ll monitor you for any changes.”

And with that, the doctor got up and walked right out of the room. Adora thought he might have at least stayed to help her, but it seemed he was too busy for even that.

With great effort, she lugged herself off the examination chair and into the other room, where a bed was indeed waiting for her. She left a crack in the doorway, not wanting to shut herself inside completely for some reason she couldn’t grasp. Sleep took her the moment her head hit the pillow.

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Adora had no idea where she was when she woke. It was so dark that, for a terrifying moment, she feared she was deep in one of

her nightmares. Even when her memory of the preceding events finally returned, she had no idea for how long she had been asleep.

The only light source was a thin line that seeped through the crack in the doorway leading back to the examination room. It gave Adora's surroundings an eerie, liminal feel that set her on edge, so she rose from the bed and headed back out into the main lab as fast as she could, only feeling like she had fully returned to the world when she saw others there with her. She counted maybe a half-dozen of Vasher's crew milling about, but no sign of Ly.

She followed the far wall, letting her fingers trace the cracks and divots in the concrete. Sounds of machinery now on and working echoed around, mixing with the tones of Vasher's men and their various conversations, giving life to the lab where before there was none. Finally, she came to the emergency operating room where they had dropped Corynth off previously.

The window looking in was tinted dark and she couldn't see through. Adora took that to mean the Vestamid doctors were still hard at work inside, but she wanted to make sure. She approached one of the two guards nearby and asked how long they had been in there.

"About three hours now?" they said, glancing over to their partner to confirm.

"Three and a half, actually," they said.

*That explains why I feel like I just rose from the dead*, Adora thought. She hadn't just taken a quick nap.

"Vasher and Lysithea are inside as well," the first guard said. "Lysithea said she didn't want to wake you. I'm sure she'll be out soon enough. I'll let you know you came looking for her when she does."

Adora thanked them and wandered the lab, intent on finding a distraction from her mounting worries over Corynth's health. It surprised her how much she wanted him to pull through, how scary the thought of their last interaction with one another being him saving her from an eldritch, planet-eating monster was. When had he gone from an aggravating and barely trusted traveling partner to someone she'd imagine inviting to the Queen's Ball on Etheria?

Catra had taken an interest in him, that much she knew. She imagined a hypothetical situation far in the future, one with her sitting at the head table back on Etheria, with the other princesses and Catra there at her side. They'd have made up already, and become friends again, and Adora would be telling her these hilarious stories of her misadventures with Corynth when he was still "Kal" to her.

*"Oh yeah,"* she'd say, suppressing a giggle at Catra's bewildered expression upon learning Adora had caught him breaking into the Crystal Castle. *"I gave him no choice but to take me aboard his ship, and then he walked in on me trying to eat the unprepared food-sand in those instant meal packages, since I was starving and didn't know what you were supposed to do with those.*

Adora shook her head to clear the fantasy, returning to the hidden lab on a hidden station, deep somewhere in a likely hidden part of the galaxy, far from home. If Corynth didn't pull through, and if Catra ever allowed herself to come back into Adora's life (two very big ifs), then she'd likely be telling her of how he well and truly died in the end, saving her life. Or maybe she'd never bring it up and spare them both the pain. Maybe that was a better option…

She came across a large table pushed against a wall of computer servers. The Eye of Shukra was there, suspended in another gravity well maintained by a machine far larger than what Corynth used on the *Dzivia* to analyze it. Running diagnostics splayed across multiple screens surrounding the table, and another of Vasher's guards stood nearby watching over everything. He nodded at her as she came into view, and Adora only nodded

back before moving on. She rationalized that, whatever Ly was doing to the Eye, she'd best leave it be.

Eventually, she came to what looked like a conference room in the far corner, built against the corner with walls of glass cordoning it off from the lab. Adora pushed inside and, mind still wandering listless, she pulled out the closest chair at the end of the boardroom table and sat. A holo-screen was mounted to the concrete there. Seeing it made her think of her own cracked PDA screen still strapped to her forearm opposite her runestone bracer.

She tried to reach Glimmer again, not really expecting to succeed. Still, when the error message came through again, she sighed and slumped forward on the table, resting her head sideways on her arm. Of course she still couldn't send any messages to her. She couldn't send messages to anyone.

And then, on a whim, she pulled up something else on the PDA she rarely ever did: the collection of photographs she had imported onto it when the Enclave first gifted the thing to her. Maybe it was because now felt like the first time in years she actually had a moment to herself, or maybe it was out of guilt that she had never made the time to reminisce over the photographs in the past, despite how important they were to her. Maybe it was the fact she had nearly died in the hangar bay several hours ago. Either way, as she flipped through image after image of her and Bow and Glimmer getting up to all sorts of trouble, she felt a part of her she hadn't realized she'd lost in the first place begin to come back to her.

There were no recent photographs, all of them having been taken in that short period of time after the Enclave first arrived where reconstruction was going full swing and no one had had left yet. Heck, they hadn't even reforged Adora's runestone yet, so most of Adora's worries had been contained to hypotheticals.

Catra was even in a number of them. Granted, neither Adora nor Catra looked particularly happy in any of the shots they shared together.

*"Come on*," Glimmer would say, any time Adora expressed her displeasure. *"We're all on the same side. Catra did more for me up on Prime's citadel than I think I can even put into words. She's part of the Best Friend squad, and you'll thank me for including her later, Adora.*

Adora hadn't realized it at the time, but Glimmer was right. Looking at the pictures now, even though she looked less than enthused to be within a hundred yards of Catra and Catra looked like she'd rather crawl under a rock than have her picture taken, Adora felt grateful. She hadn't seen Catra in years. It had been too long.

"That's a nice picture."

Adora jumped up in her chair and spun around, shutting off the PDA screen in a hurry. Ly was standing behind her with an apologetic look on her face.

"Sorry," she said. "Didn't mean to scare you. I thought for sure you heard me come in and call your name." Ly moved to the chair facing Adora's opposite the boardroom table. "You look much better than you did when we first got here," she said after a moment. "Did you sleep well?"

Adora checked in with herself, realizing for the first time that she felt fine. Enhanced healing factor, or whatever the doctor had termed it, really wasn't a joke. It might have taken a normal person months to recover from how she felt, but here she was, several hours later, feeling almost as good as new.

"I think so," she said. "Was out for three straight hours and completely forgot where I was when I finally woke up. I feel brand new."

"Lucky you. I was told I have several ribs with hairline fractures, among a number of other things. I think Vasher almost cried when he saw how bruised up my chest was." She pulled the chair out and sat, wincing with the movement to emphasize her point.

“Saw you passed the fuck out though and figured it’d be better not to wake you.”

“I was told I’m lucky to even be alive,” Adora said, glancing back down at her cracked PDA screen a moment. Already she wished she were back staring at the pictures, tricking herself into reliving a point in time that was marginally better than her current situation. At least then she had her friends with her.

“You fought an Abomination directly trying to corrupt you,” Ly said, leaning back in the chair. “I can chop off three of my fingers and my thumb from my left hand and still count how many people have done that and lived, aside from you.”

Adora frowned at the imagery and Ly laughed. “How is Corynth?”

Ly smiled. “He’ll live. I wouldn’t be as chipper as I am with half my body turning black and blue otherwise.”

Adora breathed a sigh of relief and actually slumped back against her chair. Well, at least now she won’t have to struggle about bringing bad news to Catra. Now she just needed to get on speaking terms with her again, which arguably was the harder of the two issues.

“Be honest with me,” Adora said, dampening the smile on Ly’s face with the seriousness of her tone. “How close did we get to being completely obliterated?”

Ly’s half-smile turned into a frown. “All of Eden was probably seconds away from being overtaken, if I’m to be honest. That Abomination was just a juvenile, and unleashed upon a much smaller populace than a planet, but even still…if Corynth hadn’t stepped in and taken care of it, we would have become a new epicenter.”

“I’m sorry…maybe if I had better control over—“

“You have nothing to apologize for,” Ly said, cutting her off. “You bought us enough time for reinforcements to come. You might not

have taken it down, but Corynth wouldn't have gotten to us in time if it weren't for you. You are just as much at fault for us still being alive as he is." Ly winked at her after that last statement.

Adora laughed through her nose and lapsed back into silence. She didn't feel very good about herself, despite Ly's obvious attempt to cheer her up. She Ra was still a problem, despite whatever progress she'd made. Progress she still couldn't reliably reproduce at will.

Ly nudged her under the table with her foot. "What's wrong?"

"Why didn't Corynth tell me who he really was?" Adora surprised herself with that response. Ly's question had pierced through the silence, and it sounded so genuine and raw that she responded before she could think through it.

Another beat of silence passed between them before Ly let out a breath and leaned back against her own chair. "There are a few reasons I could think might be the case, just off the top of my head. You'll have to ask him though, once he comes out of that operating room."

"Tell me what you think the reasons might have been." Really, Adora thought nearly having died was the thing on her mind, or maybe even Catra, still. Feeling lied to, or feeling upset at being kept in the dark? Yeah, that stung, but she hadn't realized it until her body spoke before her mind had caught up.

"Well, for one thing, everyone thinks he's dead. People finding out he's actually alive would…upend a lot of things."

"He's a galactic hero," Adora said. "Glimmer has mentioned on more than one occasion how many statues of him she's seen around different worlds, and one of my other…someone else I know has apparently watched every documentary and drama about him that's come out, and read the countless books they've put out about him too. Even on Etheria, we learned about what he supposedly did, when most everything else about the galaxy was

kept secret trying to keep us ignorant. Nothing about him I've seen paints him in a remotely negative light. Hell, a whole religion apparently sprung up around him. Why would it be dangerous to reveal he's actually still alive?" She thought. "And how the hell is he still alive to begin with?"

"You forget that he inspired a revolt against Horde Prime's rule alongside Evelyn." Ly said. "One thing they definitely won't tell you is that he was firmly branded as terrorist threat number one for years until Archanas happened. It was only then, when Horde Prime thought he perished with everyone else, that he went back and declared Corynth a war hero. Prime shifted the collective opinion of the galaxy about him over the course of a few years. What do you think he'd do if he found out the very person who nearly toppled his regime was still alive?"

"The threat against his rule would be back and his control over the narrative would be lost…" Adora said, piecing things together. "Okay, maybe it makes sense not to reveal himself publicly, but why would he not tell *me* who he was? He saved my life…twice! I stopped being fully skeptical of him. I thought at the very least we were on friendly enough terms he'd be honest with me about his true identity."

Ly grimaced and looked away. Adora got the sense she had just stepped onto a mine.

"What is it?" she asked.

"Corynth chose a new name for himself after Archanas. Vasher and I broke through the fleet blockading the planet after the final battle because we were still picking up life signs from his tracker. When we got there ready to evacuate him, he didn't want to leave."

"What?"

"I'm serious. He was cradling Evie's head in her lap, saying he should have died with her and the other Shapers. That if the

Beast didn't take him like it did the others when they shut it away, then he was going to wait to join them shortly thereafter anyways.

"'*Then let Corynth die,'* I said to him. '*Let him die and we'll rescue someone else from this rock. Whoever you want to be, just get on the ship and lets leave, already.*'" Ly sighed again. "He placed his Shaper mask on Evie's body, got in the ship, and we just started calling him Kallanthe from that day on. It was supposed to help him cope. I didn't think it was going to be permanent."

Adora studied Ly's face, noticed the way she didn't meet her gaze as she spoke. "Why do I get the sense there's more to the story?"

Ly finally looked her in the eye, and Adora saw a great sadness in them. "Because I honestly don't think that's the answer, although that really did happen. I think he didn't tell you who he really was because the last time he revealed himself to someone he cared about, they accused him of tricking them and then tried to kill him. Then continued trying to hunt him down and kill him for years afterward."

"Why would…how does that even happen…?"

"The Daiamid were once the Emperor's secret police. Their reputation before the Beast war was that of a mythical organization of incredibly powerful sorcerers that could turn family and lovers into mortal enemies, could reshape reality around them to fit their will…could entrance even the strongest minds and literally explode bodies into a million pieces merely by looking their victims in the eyes.

"When Corynth revealed himself at Evie's trial…when he openly defied the Emperor and rallied his brothers and sisters to do the same…we were expecting Taline to follow suit. We thought if the rest of the Daiamid coalesced to back Corynth, then Taline, someone he had been seeing seriously for some time already, would almost without a doubt do the same."

"Wait…wait, wait wait." Adora's mind reeled. Ly had just dropped several successive metaphorical bombs on her in a row. "Taline and Corynth were together?"

Ly nodded. "For years. We thought she'd be on our side when Corynth made his move. Instead, she took the whole revelation about who he was…very poorly. She accused him of bewitching her, said their entire history was a lie…said that he was doing the same thing to Evie and that's why she refused to follow the Emperor's orders even in the face of death. Taline believed the mythos surrounding the Daiamid to the extent she believed Corynth actually had her under a spell and had been manipulating her and Evie the whole time they'd known him."

"That's horrible…I can't imagine how painful that must have been. For both of them." Truthfully, Adora could key into it just a little. The paranoia she felt surrounding Catra's final change of heart, the fear she felt wondering if she were just opening herself up to be duped yet again, seemed strangely similar to how Ly framed Taline's hesitations.

"You'll have to ask him, like I said, if you really want to know the truth. This is just what I could see the reason being from what I know."

"Thank you for telling me."

Ly nodded again, then gestured to Adora's PDA. "What were you looking at earlier?" Ly asked. "Those pictures…were those your friends?"

"Friends of mine from back home," she said, nodding and turning her PDA back on. She activated the setting that floating the screen as a holographic image above her wrist, and turned the transparency up so Lys could see it from across the table.

The picture she had left off on was one of the last ones they had taken before people started leaving: it showed her, Glimmer, Bow, and even Catra, who was pulled into the center with an

uncomfortable look on her face that matched the aggravated one on Adora's. What she wouldn't give to have the four of them together again like that.

"I guess I was starting to get homesick," Adora said, finding the lamest possible way to explain the image and why she had been looking it over.

"I recognize that one," she said, pointing to Glimmer reflected in the picture. "That's Taline's mentee. She even has a nickname similar to hers after a botched campaign not long after she debuted." When Adora gave her a questioning look, Ly said, "I've been keeping track of her over the years. Wanted to at least make sure she didn't catch onto our trail well enough to actually show up and try to obliterate Corynth again out of the blue."

"Her name is Glimmer," Adora said, nodding. "She's one of my closest friends. And that's Bow. He's still on Etheria."

"And what about her?"

Ly had pointed to Catra and Adora's whole body tensed as if readying for a fight. She didn't even know where to begin to explain who Catra was in a rational, calm way. She'd not even said her name out loud likely more than a handful of times since their last conversation back home, years ago.

"That's my Taline," Adora said, voice coming out thick. "Or maybe I'm Taline and she's Corynth in the scenario, judging by how I reacted the last time we spoke to one another." She shrugged. "We've switched the roles we've played you could say, over the years. She smiled, more to herself than anything. "At one point, I was hoping she'd be my Vasher, if I were to pull  you into the analogy."

Ly smiled. "You caught onto that, huh?"

"Believe me, I thought it was you and Corynth at first, judging by how strongly you slapped him back at the Garden."

Ly made a face. “He deserved that slap, no matter how you rationalize it. I love Corynth, and so does Vasher. We wouldn’t have punched through Taline’s fleet blockade on Archanas to get to him if we didn’t, but we aren’t together. Not like Vasher and I are.” She laughed again as she leaned back and put her feet up on the desk. She barely winced this time as she did. “It was Corynth that got Vasher and I together to begin with, actually. I hated his guts at the start.”

Adora’s eyes widened. “Really? How did that happen?”

Ly waved her off and shook her head. “Story for another time. This is about you, girl. So, Catra’s your special person, and I’m under the impression you two aren’t on speaking terms. It’s been, what, three years for you two, if I remember correctly from what you said back in the hangar?”

Adora frowned and slumped down in her chair.

“Do you want to talk to her again?” Ly asked.

“I really fucked up. And it’s been a really long time since then. I’d be surprised if she’d ever want to hear from me again.”

“But you do want to talk to her?”

“Yes. Of course I want to talk to her, I’m just…scared. She’s more than just a friend to me, Ly.”

Ly nodded, keeping a modest smile on her face as she did. “Then all the more reason to finally reach out. I meant what I said before the Abomination showed up, you know? Better late than never.”

Adora gave a rueful laugh. “Yeah, well, even if I got the courage to, I haven’t been able to contact anyone at all. Can’t get a connection, and all my outbound messages error out.”

“Yeah, that’s because any unauthorized device is automatically blocked from doing anything on the network. This is a secret

settlement. What, did you think they'd just let anyone connect and send outbound messages? You aren't even allowed to carry a gun around here unless the Vestamid say its okay."

Adora opened her mouth to respond, then shut it just as quickly. The fact she had never even considered that was embarrassing enough, she didn't want to say something that only made it worse.

Ly held her hand out and Adora passed her PDA over. As she fiddled with it, she said, "this should let you send anything you want for the next hour. It's the best I can do, since I'm technically not an admin on the network. Even getting the allowances to do that much from the Vestamid was a pain in the ass."

A knock came at the door then, and they both looked up just as Vasher poked his head in the doorway.

"He's coming around," he said. "Seems stable, but I know you wanted me to get you the moment he opened his eyes."

Ly took her feet off the desk but didn't stand yet. "I'll be right there, give me another moment or two with Adora."

Vasher nodded and left. When Ly handed back the PDA, Adora said, "I really don't know what to say to her. Do I just…come right out and apologize? Talk about how much I fucked up and want to make it right? How do I even start?"

"Well, I would definitely put that apology in as close to the start as you could manage," Ly said, finally standing and heading to the door. She rested her hand on the doorknob and turned to look at Adora again. "Corynth's advice to me, back when I was still under the impression I hated Vasher's guts, was to just be honest and forthcoming. Don't try to find the 'right' thing to say, just say what you intend, even if it doesn't come out as eloquently as you'd hope. In fact, it definitely won't, but if the other person still respects you enough and wants to give you another chance… wants to make things right…they'll get the message."

“And that worked?” Adora was already gearing up to make a fool out of herself again.

“Well, it helped me realize that my unquenchable desire to punch Vasher in the face actually stemmed from the fact I was so attracted to him it pissed me off.” Ly’s face went pink and she cleared her throat. “So, yeah, I’d say it worked. We’re still together.”

“Yeah, except your situation and my situation couldn’t be further apart from one another.”

“You know, there are some points I could argue there being similarity, but that’s beside the point. Adora, you’ll do fine. Everything will work out, just take the plunge. And if it doesn’t work out exactly how you hope, everything will still be fine, you’ll see.” She opened the door and said, “have some faith in yourself, for once,” then stepped through and clicked the door shut behind her.

Adora watched her go, watched her disappear around one of the racks of equipment in the lab, no doubt returning to the operating room to meet up with Corynth and Vasher. She then took a deep breath, tried to calm her frantic heart and flush her mind of all its frantic, panicking thoughts. Then she turned on her PDA’s record function, adjusted so her face was in the video frame, and began.

“Hey, Catra…”

Chapter End Notes

> Moment ya'll have been waiting for from Adora, I'm guessing? xD Keep in mind that non-ansible communications take time to reach their recipient (don't ask me how that makes sense). Catra is the next chapter, but I think she's got some more immediate things she needs to sort through first before dealing with anything from Adora.
>
> Also, pretty big reveals for Corynth, if keeping tabs on the OCs is part of the reason you enjoy fanfics like this. I like to

think it gives a whole new dimension to Taline's conflict with him ;)

See ya'll next week! Two more chapters to go for part 3.

# Glass Figures

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra initially suspected she wasn't truly awake when she first realized she was in space, standing in a room and staring through a triple-paned window at a debris field floating against a backdrop of stars, nebulae, and dust. When the doors in the far back of the room hissed open and Taline walked through, only to ignore her and sit at a table opposite a life-sized and fully corporeal Pip, she knew for certain she wasn't truly awake yet.

"Two visits in one day?" the real-Pip said, feigning surprise. "I'm touched."

Taline sighed and slumped forward, running her hands through her hair. "Not right now, Evie."

Catra gasped. It made sense now, why Pip had seemed so familiar when they first met. Catra had seen flashes of Evelyn way back on Prime's citadel, through his memories and a few of Taline's. She just hadn't made the connection years on, when Pip first appeared.

"You're the one stopping by my cell," Evelyn said. "If you needed a minute, why didn't you just take it before coming in?"

"First, it's not a cell, and second, because I *can't* take a minute out on my own. You don't personally commandeer a frigate and pull it from the front lines to respond to a distress signal without someone higher up the chain hearing about it and snooping for answers. Add to it the fact the captain has made such a big deal about it and any moment I don't look like I'm actively doing something I have half a dozen officers hounding me to file my official report of the incident with High Command."

Evelyn snorted. “Sounds like you need to get a Sentinel or two, then. You’d have no problem with people harassing you if you did. They’d put a stop to it.”

Taline made a non-committal expression. “Maybe. Rumor has it they’re going to be mandated for every Battlemage in a hot zone, given what they’ve just recently found out about Abominations. Getting one *now* won’t change the fact the captain is still pissed off and it’s my fault, though.”

“Oh, please.” Evelyn rolled her eyes. “Norognev will get over it, he’s a big boy.” She drummed her fingers on the table. “I know you, Tal. You wouldn’t just come here to hide. You’ve made progress.”

Taline nodded. “I’ve made more than just progress, I’ve gotten you what you wanted. There’s a station…Phoenix station. Small, but it’s got everything you told me you needed to finish this out. Was going to go to a new PhD from the Heartlands but I’m yanking it and giving it to you. That”—she reached into the breast of her Enclave uniform and withdrew a modest tablet, handing it over to Evelyn—“and I’ve started looking at staff. Here’s where I think you could start.”

Evelyn’s eyes darted across the pad. Catra edged around to try and read it, but she couldn’t make sense of the words no matter what she tried.

“Lysithea, surname redacted…quite a juvenile record. Currently in prison for…” Evelyn trailed off. “Rewiring the multistory PA holo-projectors in her home world’s major commerce district to play, on repeat, a recorded performance of the punk idol group Spiritina and the Loo-Keys instead of the hourly Exaltations of Prime programming.” She lowered the tablet and fixed Taline with a look of surprise.

“She’s wicked smart, doesn’t just suck up to authority, and is cheap, since she’s currently incarcerated on the Emperor’s prison planet on Theranis IV.” Taline leaned back in the chair far enough

her back popped and she grimaced. “There are others in there for you to look through too, but Lysithea is the only one that I think you wouldn’t be able to live without. Give me a list of six or seven more…might be able to swing eight, we’ll see. You’ll have enough funds for six months.”

Evelyn nodded. “More than enough time.”

“Are you sure you know what you’re doing?” Taline asked. “You started less than a year ago…you nearly *died*. The fact you didn’t is a miracle, and now you want to plunge right back in? And I’m helping you….Empire above, I can’t believe I’m helping. What would mom and dad have said?”

Evelyn reached forward and covered Taline’s hand with her own on the table. “I have to do this, Tal. My team and I were so close to a breakthrough, and I’m the only one that can finish it in such a short amount of time. Anyone else and it will take years to get them back up to speed, by which time it will be too late. Ignominite will change everything, I promise.”

A beat passed between them. When Taline nodded, Evelyn squeezed her hand, pulled back, and said, “I want Corynth on as my security again.”

Taline sighed once more and ran her hands through her hair a second time. “I’ll see what I can do about that, but my sway when it comes to the affairs of another Battlemage are nonexistent.”

“That’s fine, I already asked him to stay, and he said yes.”

Taline frowned. “Then why did you ask me to try and get him?”

Evelyn smirked. “Just wanted to see if you’d push back on it or not. You like him, don’t you.”

Both Catra’s eyebrows shot up as Taline pushed away from the table and stood so fast her chair nearly toppled backward.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about,” Taline said, scowling when Evelyn started laughing.

“It’s fine, it’s fine,” Evelyn said, waving her hands and stifling another giggle. “You don’t have to play cold and aloof with me, sister. I’m impressed, really. Not just anyone can catch the eye of one of the youngest Battlemages in the Enclave’s thousand-year history.”

Taline gritted her teeth as she spoke. “He is currently the only person to have stood up to a manifesting Beast infestation and live, on top of saving your life. Forgive me for looking at him and feeling moderately impressed.”

“Well, I just wanted you to know that you can continue looking at him, a lot, and I can continue forgiving you for it, *a lot*, as long as you also come visit me on Phoenix. A lot.” She tilted her head in such a perfect rendition of the way Pip did it nearly broke Catra’s brain when she saw it and said, in the sweetest, most innocent voice, “Did I also mention Corynth is going to be there as well?”

Taline huffed and rolled her eyes. “Just get me the list of people you want,” she said, before storming out of the room.

Everything felt still once more after Catra watched her disappear down the hall. The door slid closed with a hiss. Another beat of silence. Then…

“Catra?”

She spun on her heel back at Evelyn, who was looking directly at her—*seeing* her.

“Catra, wake up.”

“What?” A deep foreboding feeling invaded the area. Darkness started to creep in from the corners of her vision, sticking with her when she turned, panicking.

“Catra….Catra, you need to wake up.”

She shot up out of the bunk, gasping for breath. Her hand went straight to her breastbone, feeling at the apeiron crystal still tied there, warm to the touch. Pip floated into view, blue once more and the size of a glass of water.

"Are you okay?" she asked, concern radiating from her big eyes. She had lost the deeply ingrained yet subtle expression of trauma-induced age Catra had noticed on Evelyn in the dream. Or was it a vision, technically?

::I'm alive,:: Catra said to her. ::Feels like I'm hanging on by a thread, honestly.::

She sat up, catching a glimpse of Diallo on the far side of the cell, sitting cross legged on another bed built into the wall. The next moment, a roaring headache stampeded through her head. Catra groaned, and pressed the heels of her palms against her eyes to block out the light.

"Is there anything I can do?" Pip asked. "How do you feel? You look like you're in pain. Actually, dumb question, sorry, I *know* you're in pain."

Despite having closed her eyes, Catra could still hear her as clearly as if she were speaking directly into her ear. Each word grated on her consciousness.

::Please stop talking.:: She gritted her teeth. ::No offense, but I think you being in my head and saying things is making it worse. Just…sit still and stay quiet for a bit. Please?::

Pip sent an indescribable imprint of 'understanding' through their connection, and Catra finally managed to relax.

"How did we end up in here?" she asked, speaking aloud this time to Diallo.

"The Vanguard g-got in right after I bopped Moriarty on the h-head. Then they threw both of us in h-here after." His voice seemed muted, and when Catra looked up, she noticed a thick

sheet of glass stretched from floor to ceiling, separating their two cells. “They hit you pretty hard on the h-head. Do you not remember?”

Bits and pieces came back to her, and even if it hadn’t, the pain in her head would have been testament enough. She nodded, immediately regretting it when only pained her head worse.

“I remember,” she said. “You saved my life. He was either going to choke me out or crush my windpipe if you hadn’t stepped in, although I suppose that only made you look even more guilty to the Vanguard. Thank you anyways.”

“We were both dead if I didn’t stop h-him,” Diallo said. He took his glasses off and started cleaning it with his shirt, then replaced them on his face. “He began to s-suspect I was an insurgent too, near the end there.”

Catra nodded and smoothed her fingers through her hair before putting her throbbing head into her hands.

“How long have you had n-nightmares like that for?”

“What do you mean nightmares ‘like that’?” Catra asked. “Nightmares are nightmares.”

“Not like what you just w-woke from.” Diallo frowned. “I recognize it. The tossing, the s-screaming. You would not wake no matter h-how I called to you. I’ve only seen n-night terrors that bad from someone touched by the Beast.”

Catra glanced down to Pip sitting cross-legged on her knee. She nodded with a sad look on her face that seemed to say “he’s right, you know,” and Catra sighed.

“Three years now,” she said, reaching up and caressing the apeiron through her shirt. “That’s how long it’s been since I’ve been exposed to an imprint of its essence. Longer than that actually. The nightmares should have died down by now at least, but instead they’re getting worse. I don’t know what the deal is.”

Catra didn't feel comfortable disclosing what the nightmare was, how different it was from her usual fare. The best she could do was just say they were "getting worse."

"Beast terrors evolve w-with time," Diallo said. "They never remain s-static. Take it from someone who lived through the last w-war. It's quite common actually…even Taline gets them."

"I've never been directly exposed though. Just an imprint, like I said."

"Then consider yourself l-lucky, although judging by your reactions wh-while asleep, you could have f-fooled me."

That only made Catra more anxious. In truth, she worried over why her nightmares had not only failed to abate, but shifted entirely to now include moments that weren't hers. Why was she visiting Taline's memories in her dreams? Why had the apeiron crystal grown so hot when she woke up? Catra was already plenty fucked up to begin with having grown up in the Horde under Shadow Weaver's care. A part of her feared her exposure to the Beast, no matter how far removed from actually touching it she had been, had only fucked her up worse over time.

Pip crossed her arms and shot her a stern look, no doubt reading her sentiments. Catra ignored her.

"So what now?" Catra asked, pushing the conversation with Diallo forward before Pip got the wise idea to actually try and say something to her about her warped self-opinion. "I don't suppose we're going to come out of this one with a slap on the wrist, huh? Undercover operatives typically don't get out of jail. Look, they even took my tech away." She held up her right arm in front of her to show Diallo her PDA was missing.

"I will be released because of my political position. You will be released because Taline will come for you."

Catra perked up at that. "Really? What makes you so sure?

"Don't misunderstand me," Diallo said, his face darkening, stutter gone entirely. "She will not come for you out of any sense of altruism. She will come for you because you are her Sentinel, and Taline cannot sit by and let her new Sentinel rot in a hidden station prison cell."

Any feeling of relief Catra might have been feeling fled the moment Diallo finished his sentence. "What are you talking about?"

"I understand Taline has been a huge help to you since arriving on station, but you've seen only a carefully curated side of her."

Catra felt her fur stand on end and she scowled in time with Pip, sitting cross-legged on her knee. "Is this about Archanas again?"

"Among other things. She is not who she portrays herself to be, and I have a feeling you will discover that soon enough."

"If you know something then just *tell me*."

"I already told you it wasn't the first time she stepped foot on that planet when her and I first met. After the final confrontation with the Beast, and after her sister's passing. That period of time was filled with such atrocities that many who were lucky enough to live through it succumbed after the fact—from the nightmares that plagued them, from the horrors they couldn't forget. Not atrocities done by the Beast, but acts of evil and self-interest perpetrated by the people themselves."

"Yeah, it was a war," Catra said, frowning. "Bad shit happens. People suffer."

"Justify it however suits you," Diallo said. "Evil begets evil, and malice and cruelty expressed in some engender more of the same in others. Everyone has skeletons in their closet, and she has more than most. Far more than most. It would be foolish of you to operate under the assumption she cares in the way you hope. That is all I'm trying to impress upon you. She did not make you her Sentinel out of a sense of charity."

Catra growled and actually pushed away from the bed to stand, the shooting pain in her head be damned.

"I'm tired of this," she said. "Don't get *me* wrong. I'm grateful you saved my life but speaking in these twisted half-implications reminds me of someone I'd really rather forget." She stopped shy of the reinforced glass between them and slid all five claws down it. She couldn't even leave a mark. "What did Taline do? Tell me now or shut the fuck up about it, forever."

The sound of a heavy metal bolt sliding free echoed nearby, right outside in the hall. Catra, Diallo, and Pip all turned their attention toward the door. Two Vanguard soldiers dressed in full kit, rifle included, stepped into Diallo's cell and flanked the exit, while a third walked all the way in and loomed over him sitting on the ground.

"Get up," he said. "You're free to go."

Diallo looked unsurprised. He merely stood and headed for the exit, stopping just shy of it to turn and look at Catra, pushing his glasses up his nose again.

"That glass c-could withstand a direct hit f-from the guns of a fleet d-destroyer. I wouldn't exert yourself upon it out of f-frustration. You'll just b-break your hand."

He disappeared through the door and out the adjacent cell without another word. One of the three Vanguard, Catra couldn't tell who, muttered a phrase that contained the words 'special political privilege' and 'bastard' in the same sentence before they too followed him out. The door shut behind them with a clang. Catra listened to the sounds of their feet retreat down the hall. After a moment, she heard another door open, then shut, and she was alone with Pip, once more in near complete silence.

"I don't like that man," Pip said, whispering in case she flared Catra's headache again.

::I don’t like that he keeps implying things without explaining them,:: Catra said, returning to the bed and trying to keep her headache from spiraling further. ::Reminds me of a certain someone. She always used to imply in her tone of voice or choice of words that I was worthless and would never amount to much. And that was when she chose not to say it outright to my face, which also happened all the time, too.::

Pip flashed her a sympathetic look, then said, “You don’t seriously believe what he said, though, do you?” When Catra didn’t respond, she floated right up to her face and put both hands on her hips. “*I* don’t believe for a second anything that he said about Taline. She’s not perfect, but she isn’t a monster. She doesn’t have crazy secrets she’s hiding from you, she’s not playing some mind game, and she’s not just using you. Diallo doesn’t know what he’s talking about.”

“He’s worked with her, Pip. For years now, and Taline’s kept you on such a short leash you can barely tell me anything about her let alone yourself.” Pip moved to respond but Catra didn’t let her. “I don’t believe him, for the record, but I also don’t think he’s just making shit up out of thin air. People do fucked up things in war all the time. Hell, *I’ve* done fucked up shit just trying to get back at the Rebellion back home. As much as I look up to her, I’m under no impression that Taline is a saint. If she’s ashamed of something, she’d try to hide it just like anyone else.”

Catra had half a mind to ask about what she had seen in the dream. Did Pip know Evelyn had modeled her after herself? Pip couldn’t even recall being built by her.

“He’s playing with your emotions and your insecurities,” Pip said. “On purpose. Don’t listen to what he says.”

Catra heard the door at the far end of the hall outside her cell open up, heard another group of people approaching by the heaving thunking of their boots against the floor. The bolt to her own cell slid free and the door burst open, allowing Taline to stride through with two more Vanguard escorting her.

Taline locked eyes with her. “Wait outside,” she said to her escorts. She didn’t look happy, she didn’t sound happy, and she didn’t break eye contact with Catra waiting for the Vanguard to leave. They listened to their footsteps retreat down the hall. Again, the door in the distance opened and shut.

“What the hell did you do?”

Catra flinched. She’d already known Taline was frightening when upset. Never abusive like Shadow Weaver, but Glimmer had filled Catra in on just how scary her mentor could be on those rare times she’d slacked on her training or shown up late. Taline had just never directed that at her before, and no amount knowing beforehand that she was in store for a major ass chewing helped soften the blow when it finally arrived.

“Nothing to say for yourself?” Taline narrowed her eyes and crossed her arms. “Can you not explain to me why you broke into the office of one of the most powerful people in the empire next to Horde Prime himself? Can you not explain why, in the middle of one of the most important public appearances this person was to make in a long time, you’re up here setting off general alarms across *all of Phoenix Station*?”

“I had to—”

“What you *had* to do,” Taline said, interrupting her hard enough even Pip shied away, “what you were *supposed* to do, was return that drive I gave you to Diallo. Not play secret agent and paint a target on your back large enough even an anti-orbital canon could hit you with an indictment on charges of grand espionage!”

Dozens of responses came and went in Catra’s head. She tried to trap one of them, but they raced by too fast for her to corner. Her fur stood on end. Her heart somehow both beat so fast she feared it might stop, and simultaneously lodged itself in her throat, closing it up. This whole situation triggered images of Shadow Weaver, demons she thought she’d conquered long ago. Catra

was reduced to a huddled mass, pushing into the corner of the cell. It'd been so long since she'd felt this ashamed.

Then Taline said something that broke the spell. Something that Shadow Weaver would never have said.

"I don't understand, Catra. I may have a soft spot for you, but that doesn't mean you can take advantage of your relationship with me for things like this."

Catra stilled. The question, the change in demeanor…it was so different than anything Shadow Weaver would have ever done it actually stopped Catra in her tracks. "What did you say?"

"Did Diallo put you up to this? I know you were on rotation with Dax when he arrived. I know you were on his security detail. Did he talk to you before he came to see me? Is that why you stopped by at the same time? Did you accept being my Sentinel so you could do this? So he could try some new way to get me to go to that damned planet again?"

Tears welled in Taline's eyes as she spoke. Catra could count on one hand how many times she had accidentally made Adora cry when they were growing up, how terrible it had made her feel and how quickly and effusively she had worked to mend things between them the handful of times it had happened before Adora's defection. She couldn't handle tears, and the thought of having brought Taline to the brink of them shook her.

"That's ridiculous," Catra said. "Taline, do you even hear what you're saying? I sent a paper application in months before I'd ever met Diallo, how would I scheme with him for something like this? *Why* would I scheme with him? I wouldn't do that to you, you mean too much to me." As much as Catra wanted to make things right, Taline still looked moments away from ripping her head off despite the tears and she didn't dare so much as move from the bed.

The three scars on Taline's cheek, given to her by the Emperor when she defended them against his wrath and only visible if one were looking at her from a certain angle, seemed to shimmer in the low light of the cell. All at once, the light dimmed further. A suffocating feeling bloomed in the small space they shared, a strong sense that the walls were closing in on them.

The corners of her vision pulled in, darkness seeping around like an ever-marching creep of vines. From that darkness, shadows bloomed. Moving shadows, and voices in the air began to whisper. When Catra turned her head to look directly at whatever was lurking, she saw nothing except new shadows in the new corners of her vision. When she strained her ears to hear the whispers, the seemed to grow farther away and more vigorous at the same time, and she still couldn't understand them.

"What's going on?" Catra spoke the question out loud even though she intended it for Pip who, for her part, looked just as terrified as Catra felt.

"Lies!"

Catra jerked up and saw Taline, eyes ablaze and skin patterned with white-hot ley lines of magic, standing straight backed with her hands fisted and trembling at her sides. Her hair swirled about her, weightless amid her display of magic. Catra felt it buffet her in waves emanating from Taline, a miasma that seemed to incarnate the very concept of rage and betrayal.

*I wouldn't do that to you.* Catra's words from earlier echoed around the cell, incorporeal, and now spoken by a man whose voice she had never heard before. *You mean too much to me.*

"Lies, all of it lies! You lie!"

"Taline, what are you—"

Pip floated up between them before Catra could do anything. "She can't see you," she said. "She's somewhere else right now. Don't get up, it's dangerous."

The shadows grew more defined and pulled further toward Catra's center vision. It almost seemed like she was in a different space entirely—a vast open courtyard, hundreds of stories up, surrounded by skyscraper buildings on all sides.

Dozens of persistent shadowed forms ran by or grouped up and moved as a team. It looked like they were fighting, if Catra had to guess, phasing in and out of the small area of the cell as they moved about. Judging by the frantic whispers around them, it almost sounded like they were fighting, too. Taline was looking through her, of that Catra was certain. There was no recognition in her eyes.

A crack formed in the ballistic glass behind her. That crack spread from its one pinprick center outward, scintillating their reflection—Catra's looking at it and Taline facing away from it—into a thousand fractured splinters.

Catra nearly jumped out of her skin when she saw a new shadow reflected in those splinters. A tall, amorphous blob of a person stood there as if they were *inside* the reflection, and they had just one defining feature: two nearly perfect circular eyes like unblinking lamps of starlight, staring out at them from its mask of shadow.

*You know me, Taline.*

There was no logical reason to assume it was the figure in the glass speaking, but somehow, she knew.

*You mean too much to me, and you know I wouldn't lie to you about something like this. The Barrier is our only chance. We need you, now more than ever.*

Taline spun on her heel and roared. "You've lied the entire time!" She lunged and threw a hand out, where a bolt of lightning lashed out and struck. It shattered the partition into pieces, obliterating the man in the reflection as shards of glass exploded outward.

Catra dashed forward from the bed and grabbed Taline by the shoulder, intent on shaking her out of whatever headspace she had dragged the both of them into. The moment her hand touched Taline's skin, it burned, and Catra yanked back with a hiss and a curse.

Taline rounded on her, finally noticing she was there but clearly not registering where she was, what was going on, or even who Catra was. In fact, by the way her face contorted further in rage, it seemed like Taline mistook her for one of the shadowed figures still darting around about them—no doubt phantoms from her past.

A life-sized blur of blue materialized to Taline's left, just as Catra was certain Taline was about to call forth another bolt of lightning for her specifically.

"Stop!" Pip stood there, corporeal and glowing, much larger than she had ever appeared before. "Taline, you need to snap out of it. You're not in the Heartlands. Corynth and the Daiamid are gone, there are no insurrectionists. You're scaring Catra half to death!"

Taline gasped and recoiled, taking a full three steps back before shaking her head and blinking rapidly. Pip disappeared and reappeared, miniature and see through once more, perched on Catra's knee with a perturbed expression.

The shadows abated, and the grueling, suffocating feeling that had infused the cell retreated too, along with the voices. Taline's eyes returned to their normal color, the ley lines disappeared, and her hair fell, mussed, back to her shoulders.

Catra sprung from the bed the moment Taline's eyes shifted to the shattered glass and widened in horror, closing the distance between them in two wide steps and pulling her into a fierce hug. Taline tensed a moment, then embraced Catra back, squeezing hard enough there was no space between them. If those shadows and visions were a roaring sea storm threatening to put her under,

then Taline clung to Catra like she were the one anchor there capable of keeping her grounded.

“Catra, I’m—”

“No,” Catra shook her head and pulled Taline in tighter. “No, don’t apologize. You scared the shit out of me but you didn’t hurt me. You came out of it before anything bad happened, I promise.”

Taline and Corynth had history. Personal history. He had apparently rescued Evelyn early on, had stood up to the Emperor, and also saved everyone on the galaxy. He had also betrayed Taline in doing so. Catra had no idea if it was a true betrayal or not, and part of her wondered if that even mattered. Adora had betrayed Catra, even though it made sense why and even though it was the right thing to do. Even after Catra herself understood, it didn’t change the fact it *felt* like a betrayal and hurt like a betrayal and, from a certain standpoint, that’s all that mattered.

So, yeah. Catra understood now, why Taline thought the things she thought. She didn’t even need the full context, she just understood. So many things, little things that she didn’t understand or otherwise overlooked…they made so much more sense now.

“I saw her.” Taline’s voice came muffled against Catra’s shoulder. “Evelyn was there. She pulled me out. I was lost and she pulled me out.”

Catra angled her head to scrutinize Pip behind her. Pip set her jaw and didn’t meet her eyes.

::Does she know?::

“The one time I showed myself to her was the only other time in all the years I’ve been with her that she had an episode like that,” Pip said through their link. “Seeing me *triggered* that in her. It’s part of the reason I didn’t pry her away from meditating on that apeiron around your neck after so many years. Until she gave it to

you, I was afraid it was one of the few things still keeping her grounded."

::And seeing you pop up just now was what grounded her, this time.:: Catra concentrated on breathing deep and steady, trying to match Taline's pace and nonverbally lead her back to baseline. Idly at the back of her mind, she remembered how she had once gone to comfort Shadow Weaver when she was distraught only to be pushed away. What a difference this was.

::This has really been going on the whole time she's stewarded you?" she asked Pip. ::Eleven years now?::

"It's never been bad like this," Pip said. "It's been getting worse. Her nightmares have been getting worse with it. They've never gone away, Catra. It's why I'm so worried about yours, too."

Catra sighed and stepped back, holding Taline at shoulder length. "Diallo told me your other Sentinels used to run undercover jobs for you. Used to get things done for you without explicit orders, so they could push your goals forward without jeopardizing your public standing. When I tried to return the drive to him, he said this was one of those times—that by telling me my first 'assignment' was returning it to him, you were really telling me to infiltrate Moriarty's office and crack the algorithm protecting the drive's contents." She shook her head, emphatically. "I'd never betray you, Taline. The thought had never even crossed my mind."

Taline took a deep, shuddering breath. "You're supposed to put a bullet in my head if I'm on the verge of becoming an Abomination. You only ever take orders from two people."

Catra cocked her head. "Two?"

"Me, and yourself. Anyone else tries to get you to do something on my behalf, they're lying to your face."

Catra released her and stepped away, only just catching her jaw before it hinged open on its own accord. It was her turn to feel betrayed—Diallo had used her. "That fucking *bastard*."

“One of the Emperor’s direct Imperial Administrators is being held on charges of conspiracy, collusion, and severe narcotics procurement. On top of stepping in as the new head of the station and its immediate surrounding regions while he is indisposed, I am likely going to be the one to personally execute him in a number of days when his trial concludes. The Emperor himself will likely come down from the Heartlands on a personal errand because of this, and if I thought my ass was under a microscope before then this will take it to a whole new level.”

She took another shivering breath and ran shaky fingers through her hair. “And now, concrete proof of a phantom algorithm. One tying the upper echelons of Imperial governance directly with the Vestamid. Diallo tricked and used you, yes, and he’s successfully blown the door wide open on something I cannot ignore.”

Catra nodded and studied Taline for a moment. “Are we okay?”

To her surprise, that actually got a chuckle. “Aren’t I supposed to be asking you that?” Taline asked, wiping a tear from her eye.

Catra smirked and nudged Taline with her elbow. “Nah. I’m okay. I didn’t really think you were going to hurt me anyways, although I did get my hand singed when I touched you.” She held her hand up, seeing that it was already starting to blister, and Taline grimaced.

“Put some salve on it and I’ll see what I can do to heal it once it’s sat for a bit. I’m still shit at healing runes, though.”

Catra nodded again, and the tension between them seemed to have melted all on its own. For her part, Catra was relieved. She could count on one hand how many times she had successfully reconciled with a person after fighting with them. She wasn’t upset with Taline, and Taline no longer seemed to be under the impression Catra was deceiving her.

“What happens next?” she asked. “Do I get to leave the prison too or do I have to stay here longer?”

Taline laughed. “Empire above, no. I’m getting you out right now.”

“Are you sure you can swing that?” Catra asked, grinning now. “Don’t you think springing your Sentinel from prison after they went rogue and attacked a Regional Administrator might look a certain way to people?”

Taline shrugged and walked past Catra toward the exit, shattered glass crunching underfoot as she went. “My reputation can take the hit, not that I really care. I’m heading off station and I want you there with me. You’ll need to pack for a few nights, maybe longer.”

“Off planet? Didn’t you just say you were put in charge of a lot more things now that Moriarty is out?” Catra trailed behind her and Pip sat straight-backed and cross-legged on her shoulder. When Taline didn’t immediately respond, she furrowed her brow and said, “Where are we going?”

“The *Constable* is already prepped and we push off in an hour.” Taline stopped at the precipice to the door and glanced back at her over her shoulder. “We’re going to Archanas.”

Chapter End Notes

> We hit 400 kudos and, at this point, I think this fic is on the front page if you filter by length. The fact so many of you are still here and some are even actively engaging chapter by chapter with comments is so so nice, thank you T.T
>
> There's a draft 1 of an 80,000 word prequel novel centered around Corynth, Taline, and Evelyn that I wrote in between drafts of this story. It was mostly to flesh out the world and the character arcs I have playing in the background and sides, and will definitely never see the light of day because it's not edited xD but bits and pieces of that prequel have ended up in the mini-flashback scenes (both here and in earlier parts).

If any of you get even the slightest inkling or feeling that this world the characters operate in feels decently put together, it's because I did do a lot of heavy lifting and prewriting--tons of stuff that just don't make it into scenes at all, or never get explained but have their own internal worldbuilding "rules" they abide by.

I hope it makes for a more enjoyable reading experience :)

One more chapter to go in part 3! Adora finishes us out.

# Escape from Paradise

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora threaded her way through the lab, absently following the sound of voices talking in the distance, trying and failing to concentrate on where she was going. It'd take time for the message she had sent Catra to arrive, and more time for a response to come back, if one came back at all. That much she knew.

What concerned her now was how successful she'd be at concentrating on more pressing matters in the meantime. Ly had agreed to look at the Eye of Shukra, but that was no guarantee it contained the key to sealing the Barrier and trapping the Beast out of the galaxy for good like they hoped. If Ly couldn't decipher the Eye, or if it didn't contain what they needed, then what? The Beast would still be an ongoing threat, she still had an unreliable-at-best track record utilizing just a portion of She Ra's power, and she still had no idea what kind of shape Corynth was in after his stint with the Vestamid doctors.

Adora yelped when, in her distracted state, she crashed front-first into a block of wire-rack shelving full of lab equipment. Only her quick reflexes reaching out and suctioning her whole body to the shelving kept it from falling over, and she didn't dare let go of it until she was sure it was steady.

"I'd be careful if I were you."

It was a voice off to the side and Adora spun around, heart racing. Ly was eyeing her over the top of a set of computer monitors bolted to a desk, sitting in the center of an open space. What looked to be server racks that stood even taller than the labyrinth of shelves surrounded her. The Eye was floating in a gravity well generated by a bulky machine sitting on the same

desk as all the other computer equipment. Corynth and Vasher were there too, along with a cadre of Vasher's blue-clad soldiers milling about.

Adora had made it to the others and hadn't even realized it.

"The Vestamid will narrow their sights on you and hound you to the ends of the galaxy for repayment of their property if you break anything." Ly blinked, as if hearing and considering her own words. "Actually, that might distract them from Vasher and I when we leave, so go right ahead."

"I could just order them not to chase after you." Corynth was lounging on a bulky piece of equipment nearby, his one leg swinging freely a few inches off the ground, booted foot hitting the side of his perch with a rhythmic thump. "They'd listen to me."

Vasher, leaning against another piece of bulky equipment, crossed his arms and snorted into a laugh. "They've made dogma of passing comments you've made on the Beast, twisting it out of fanaticism. I'm sure they'll find some way to turn 'leave Lysithea and Vasher alone' into 'capture them for a blood sacrifice, the World Eater demands it.'"

The words themselves, mixed with Vasher's gruff tone and accent, seemed severe, but there was an undercurrent of playfulness in their exchange Adora caught onto the same moment she noticed some of Vasher's men cracking smiles of their own.

Corynth snickered. His snickering snowballed into a belly laugh, and then he started coughing, doubling over and wincing in pain. A cold streak of fear ran down Adora's spine, then Ly started laughing too.

"The great Corynth, last Shaper of the Daiamid," she said, effecting an official tone, "brought to death's doorstep because of some gentle ribbing between friends."

"Technically it was the proto-Abomination, but we can go with your thing too."

Ly rolled her eyes with a smile still on her face. She still hadn't turned away from the monitors. "Vasher, stop antagonizing him." He shot her a look, mouth agape, like she had just slapped him and Adora suppressed a giggle. "And Corynth, as much as I know you enjoy sniping back and forth with your butt buddy, you need to focus on getting better. Stop playing into this game between the two of you if it's just going to cause problems."

"I'll stop when he pays up," Corynth said. He crossed his arms and tilted his nose up at Vasher, hints of a smile twitching at the corners of his lips. "I won the bet."

A flash of metal at Corynth's wrists caught Adora's attention: he was still wearing the manacles Ly had put on him—the same ones he had first cuffed her with at the Crystal Castle—except the chain linking them together had been broken. Now they looked—and likely functioned—like simple forearm bracers.

"What did you guys bet on?" She wanted to ask about the cuffs, but was afraid she already knew the answer, so that question came out instead.

Corynth's attention snapped to her, and the laser-sharp acuity with which he had leveled at Vasher moments before melted into something more delicate. Something gentler. Even his voice came out softer.

"We were trying to guess what you'd do after I left you alone in the hotel," he said.

Vasher stood up a little taller, a proud look on his face. "I bet him a hundred imperial credits that you would stay put in the room, exactly like he asked you to."

Adora's jaw hinged open. Any and all concern she had over Corynth's wellbeing melted away, replaced with disbelief.

"And you bet that I'd steal the Eye and steal your ship?" she said to Corynth. "You anticipated me doing that?" Adora didn't know whether to feel mildly insulted they'd make a betting game over

something like that or feel completely see-through, like she were transparent and utterly devoid of cunning.

Corynth's gentle expression turned sheepish, as did his voice. "Well…I saw it as a good thing?" When that didn't seem to have the effect he was hoping for, he shrugged, a bit helplessly. "I mean, I told you to walk away back at your castle and you decided it was a better idea to try and punch me in the head. If you didn't listen to me back then, I seriously doubted you were going to just sit around the hotel room because I asked you to."

Adora put her hands on her hips and narrowed her eyes at him. She wasn't actually mad, but seeing Corynth fidget under her gaze was a refreshing change in the power dynamic. Seeing Ly and Vasher smirk out the corners of her vision told her she wasn't the only one enjoying it, either.

Corynth gestured with both hands at Ly. "She doesn't just suck up to authority either," he said. "It's a *good* thing in my books, Adora. I'm happy you thought trying to steal my ship was a better option than doing nothing." He paused. "That sounds kind of screwed up, all things considered."

He was likely going to keep talking, except by then Adora had closed the distance between them and engulfed him in such a strong and sudden embrace she nearly sent them both to the floor.

"I'm glad you're okay," she said, when he stiffened in her arms. "I'm really glad. Also, I'm so, *so* sorry for taking the Eye. And for trying to steal your ship. And also for trying to punch you in the head back on Etheria. Wow, that feels like forever ago, now."

She felt him relax after a moment, then return the hug. "It's okay. I'm glad you're okay, too."

Adora furrowed her brow at that. Why did he sound like he was suddenly in more pain? Then she remembered him coughing

earlier and broke away from him so fast she nearly tripped over her own two feet attempting to retreat.

“Sorry! Shit, I completely forgot. Sorry.”

Corynth winced but still smiled up at her. He flashed her a quick thumbs up, keeping his other hand pressed to his side like he was trying to keep some unseen stitches there from ripping. Adora was about to feel bad again when Vasher pointed a finger at Corynth and laughed.

“She apologized to you,” he said. “I won the second bet.” He looked at Adora. “He didn’t think you were going to say sorry or be his friend anymore.”

Now Adora was truly surprised, and the open-mouthed expression of shock she fixed Corynth was real. “Ok, I will fully admit and own the fact I am not an easy traveling companion, but I like to think that, deep down, I’m fundamentally a decent person.” She raised both her eyebrows and widened her eyes in disbelief. “You seriously thought I was going to try and get one over on you and not feel bad about it at all?”

To his credit, Corynth looked apologetic. “It’s something I’m very glad to have been proven wrong about,” he said to her, before turning to Vasher and saying, “and it’s a bet I’m very glad to have lost. How about we just say our respective wins cancel each other out?”

Vasher shrugged. “Sure. I’ll just have to win whatever we bet on next. We have a three-year hiatus we need to catch up on.”

“You two are insane,” Adora said, shaking her head.

Their dynamic, this obsession over betting on stupid things like this, it was so comical that Adora didn’t think she could be mad about it even if she wanted to. Just flabbergasted. Two grown adults, one of them a textbook definition of a literal living god, behaving like teenagers after facing down a proto-Abomination and nearly dying. It was crazy.

Ly snorted off to the side. “Don’t get too worked up about it,” she said. “You can’t reason them out of it, either. They bet on almost everything.” She finally turned away from the computer monitors to look at Adora directly. “Corynth bet Vasher on whether or not him and I would get together, years ago. And Vasher took the bet.”

“I got so much money,” Corynth said. He sounded so proud of himself.

“And I got a fantastic relationship that’s still going,” Vasher said. “Who’s the real winner?”

“Definitely not Corynth.” Ly said, before winking at Adora, who felt like she was finally rediscovering what ‘female camaraderie’ meant, years after Glimmer had left home.

The machine twirling the Eye in its gravity well beeped and Ly turned back to the monitors. She studied it a moment, then let out a long sigh and shook her head.

“Bad news?” Corynth asked. He sat forward, and any trace of humor or lightheartedness was gone.

“Lukewarm news,” Ly said. She tapped a cadence of commands on the keyboard and a holographic projection materialized in the space between them. It was a web of points and intersecting lines, creating a three-dimensional tangle of light so concentrated and complicated it hurt Adora’s eyes just to look at it.

“This is the best approximation I could generate of what information is inside the Eye,” Ly said. “What you see here is maybe five percent of the total data volume, and even still there are several levels missing from the model. It is simply too complex to display everything, even from just this one small slice.”

“You can’t analyze it for the barrier algorithm, then,” Corynth said.

Ly shook her head. “I can’t get it, no, but I can confirm it’s in there.” At Corynth’s look of confusion, Ly tapped a few more

commands  into the computer and a portion of the model broke away and highlighted. “There are bits and pieces that I know for certain are part of the original formula—they match up almost exactly to the bootlegged version of the algorithm Evelyn and I put in years ago. It’s just…”

“Too complex to get through,” Corynth said, completing her thought with a pensive expression.

“We thought what we had come up with back then was massive and complex at the time, but this?” Ly gestured to the model. “This is insane. The Eye has what the Barrier needs to seal fully, but Pip is the only thing that could extract the algorithm and apply it to the nodes directly. Cutting edge software is like “baby’s first plastic toolset” compared to this thing. We need Pip and whatever time-transcendent insanity Evelyn breathed into her when she made her in order to do it.”

Corynth hmm’d and leaned in closer. “What are those?” he asked as he pointed to subtle patches of red coloring inside the web Adora hadn’t noticed before.

“Those are traces of the Beast I found inside the Eye,” Ly said.

“You’re kidding me.”

“*That’s* what I sensed lurking there when I felt around inside?” Adora asked, surprised as well.

“I’m not kidding, and yes, that’s probably what you both felt,” Ly said. “The data in the Eye makes it so dense it’s able to contain a sample of the Beast without an ounce of ignominite to pacify it. It must be a fragment of the same infestation the Eternians were coming across when building out their countermeasures so many millennia ago, before the Emperor came.”

“Or it could be the sample they experimented on directly,” Corynth said, before turning to Adora. “It’s one of the first things Evie saw when she looked through the timestream—the Eternians discovering ignominite for the first time. She just replicated their

findings for us to use now on Phoenix, after Taline got her what she needed."

"If they already had ignominite when they were crafting their barrier," Adora said, "then why didn't they use the same technology to contain this sample here? Why is the Beast inside the Eye?"

"It could be because they needed an 'unpacified' sample for their tests," Ly said. "Or they might have lost control of the sample they had and part of it got stuck inside the Eye when it ate their researchers, I have no clue. The important thing is I got it out."

"You can't analyze the data, but you were able to get all of the Beast out?" Adora asked.

Ly nodded and turned to a sealed case she had sitting nearby on the desk. It hissed and steam rose out when she undid the latches and opened the top.

"Running a basic diagnosis is a lot simpler than deriving insights from this thing, so I just had it comb through the whole structure with a basic extraction protocol. Still took an ass-load of time, though." From the case, Ly pulled out a thin, metallic-red crystal that seemed to shift in shades and hues depending on which angle a surrounding light source struck it at. "I put it in here, fully pacified, and confirmed the rest of the Eye is now clean. When Pip looks at it this time, she'll be able to get through the whole thing without getting corrupted."

"I'll take that," Corynth said, holding his hand out. "It's dangerous in the wrong hands."

Ly looked from the tainted crystal to him, as did everyone else. For a moment, Adora wondered whether they would fight over it, before Ly set her lips in a thin line and nodded.

"It's even more dangerous in the right ones," she said, placing it in his upturned palm. "Still, you're probably the best person to safekeep this kind of thing."

He stowed the crystal away and Ly turned back to the table to tap out new commands on the keyboard. A new visualization replaced the old hologram between them. It was the same neural net pattern Adora had seen several times before: Pip's source code, including the still-corrupted and entirely missing pockets of data as well.

"As for our favorite spritely AI," Ly said. "No change from what I told you back at the Garden. She's the only one who can read the Eye, and I can do nothing repair her. Her code is too far gone for me to piece back together. The gulfs between what remains intact are too wide."

"So…Pip can't come back?" Adora asked. She had only met her once, very briefly, and already felt sad. "Why are we talking about getting her to read the Eye if she's just…gone?"

"*I* can't do anything to fix her," Ly said, "but that doesn't mean she's gone." She stepped away from the table and circled the still-intact portions of Pip's code with a finger, outlining them with a shimmering red highlight in the hologram. "The damage to her code is extensive but targeted—she was able to partition off the most important parts. Her personality, her memories, Evie's module for decoding the Eternian language…it's all still here and untouched. The missing parts are just the core framework and boilerplate that holds it together. The 'glue', so to speak."

"If we replace the framework then she'll still be her?" Adora asked.

"Yes." It was good news, Adora thought, but the way Ly spoke and the way her gaze slid from the visual to Corynth betrayed her. "A master copy of her programming needs to be pulled and merged to get her functioning again."

Silence draped over them at that, heavy with a feeling of forboding Adora couldn't pinpoint or make sense of. Ly and Vasher looked morose, and Corynth wore a face of stone, seeming to stare unblinking straight through the visual without actually seeing

it or anyone else. Vasher broke the silence with a small groan, putting his head in his hands.

Corynth finally blinked and made eye contact with Ly. Adora got the distinct feeling they exchanged a whole heated conversation between them with that one look than the entire exchange they all had since she almost knocked over that first piece of equipment.

"There's no other way," Ly said, quietly as if just to him. "I'm sorry."

Corynth grimaced and deflated with a deep sigh. He sat back, leaning into the equipment he was sitting on for support as he ran shaky fingers through his hair. It struck Adora as odd; even when weakened or upset he had never seemed out of his depth before, for lack of a better word. Now, though? He looked like he'd rather be anywhere but sitting there, having listened to what Ly just said.

"What's going on?" Adora asked. "This is good news, isn't it? We can go get Pip restored, have her read the Eye now that it's been scrubbed clean, and hopefully shore up the Barrier so the Beast can't seep through and attack any more worlds. Isn't that a good thing?"

"It would be a good thing, yeah," Ly said, rubbing at her temples, "if it weren't for where Pip's original backup copy is located."

Adora was about to ask where the backup was and why it was such a problem when all the lights in the lab shut off. Emergency lights snapped on a moment later, bathing them all in a blood-red hue. An alarm blared to life around them, screeching.

"What the hell is going on?" Adora asked, clapping both hands over her ears.

Vasher's men had already, on their own, surrounded them in a protective formation with weapons drawn and pointed outward. Ly typed furiously away at the console on the desk. The alarm

stopped blaring, but the red emergency lights remained. She read from one of the screens as it spit out a stream of new information at her.

"Shit," she said, pausing for a moment to scrutinize the display before diving right back into another round of furious typing. "Those fucking Vestamid scum."

"What happened?" Corynth had stood and shuffled over to her with Adora's help.

"I made sure this workstation was completely disconnected from the network while it churned through the Eye," she said. "And I triple extra checked before I started having it run diagnostics on Pip's code. They must have put in a backdoor connection. Some kind of subroutine that made sure if any of this equipment was ever used, they'd be able to track it and what I did with it. Unfortunately, since Pip's code got on the network anyways, it tried to automatically contact the server hosting her backup to try and rebuild her."

She slammed two fists down on the table, making the equipment rattle. "That…fucking server sent back a booby-trapped file. It's gotten into the guts of Eden's entire infrastructure and is causing all sorts of problems."

An explosion sounded off in the distance, rattling not just the equipment on the desk, but all the equipment on the racks spaced around the whole lab. Dust fell in sheets from the ceiling and Adora tried not to breath it in.

Everyone froze and looked at each other in surprise, then. Everyone except Ly who stared wide-eyed in shock at the monitor as she read off new information, mouthing rapid-fire syllables under her breath, eyes darting across the screen.

"Ly?" Corynth asked. "What was that?"

"They've definitely been experimenting with more than that one Abomination." There was a quaver in Ly's voice when she spoke,

now. “The emergency system is telling me there’s a massive infection spreading rapidly throughout the entire station.” She tapped another set of commands and another window popped up with a dense block of text scrolling down it. “An Imperial fleet within the system has been alerted to this as well. They must have picked up the infection on their scans. They’ll be here within minutes.”

“We have to leave,” Corynth said. “Now.”

Ly yanked the Eye from its gravity well and shoved it back in the same pack Adora and Corynth had it in previously, slinging it around her shoulder. Vasher barked a set of quick orders to his men and they pulled in closer, forming a tight, outward facing box around them. Adora anchored herself better under Corynth’s arm just like Ly had done for her when she couldn’t walk reliably on her own, and then all of them together moved as a cohesive group through the labyrinth of equipment racks and back toward the exit.

The blaring alarm siren wailed at them anew the moment the door leading out into the service corridor opened—Ly must have only shut off the thing inside the lab. Adora didn’t have any hands free to cover her ears. If they started bleeding before they got to their escape, she wouldn’t be surprised. At least Corynth kept up fine with her support. She was half afraid he’d be wholly unable to move.

When they hit the end of the service corridor that emptied back into the hangar terminals, Adora got a good sense of just how dire things had become.

People were in a panic, sprinting up and down the terminal, many crowding and pushing into and around the hangar bay entrances and trying to force their way through to their ships beyond. The Gorn doctors she had last seen in the clinic apparently had wings, since Adora saw more than a few of them buzzing around high above, trying to avoid the stampedes.

Adora only caught glimpses here and there of this—only the bits and pieces she could see through the tight gaps in the formation Vasher and his men maintained around them as they hurried down the terminal. With the alarms continuing to blare, the emergency lights, the shouting, the running, the creeping, snowballing feeling of existential dread that was slowly making itself know…it was overwhelming, all of it together. It was all Adora could to do focus on keeping Corynth supported and not tripping over herself in the process.

She ran straight into the back of one of the men when their whole group made a sudden stop. Their shouting commands to 'get out of the way' intensified, and two of them actually crouched down to grab at something.

A moment later, Adora realized what had happened: someone had tripped and fallen right in front of their group. She thought they might be leaning down to try and help. Then her blood ran cold in shock when she watched them grab the person in question and drag them out of the way. Two others filled in the gaps the first had left, and they continued forward as if nothing had stopped them in the first place.

She was about to say something when gunshots rang out somewhere off to the left. Every guard turned in unison to the sound, rifles already raised, and they fired back without waiting to see what had happened.

Adora screamed and turned away before she inadvertently caught sight of anything that'd feed her nightmares all over again. They hadn't even waited to look at who they were shooting at. They just turned and fired back, hurrying them along even faster after they were done. What if they killed a civilian? Just another person trying to escape, like them? What if it was a family?

Corynth nudged her to grab her attention. When she looked over, his eyes radiated sympathy.

“It will be okay,” he said. “One foot in front of the other, just focus on that.”

Adora sucked in a breath, blinked away the tears, and focused on that. One foot in front of the other.

They made it to bay thirteen again, and that was when Corynth stopped them all.

“You have to get out of here,” he said to Ly and Vasher.

“But—”

“There’s no time.” Corynth cut Ly off with a shake of his head. “You go. We’ll make it the rest of the way on our own.”

“Just come with us,” Adora said. “We’re all going on the same ship, aren’t we?”

“They’re two of the most wanted people in the galaxy,” Corynth said. “They can’t go where we are. They’ll light up every security checkpoint we try and cross.”

Ly shot Vasher a glance before cursing and shrugging out of the backpack carrying the Eye. She handed it over to Adora, and pressed something else into her palm. It was a data disk.

“For when you get to your destination,” she said. “The Dzivia is all fixed up, but you’ll still need this.”

They turned and hurried off, already beyond shouting distance before Adora could get her bearings enough to ask after what Ly had given her. Instead, she and Corynth continued through the bay doors.

Amid the chaos still raging and the sense of dread and doom that was so loud now it seemed to be trying to kick her in the head, metaphorically speaking, she wondered why no one was trying to push past them to take the ship. She had seen countless others

literally fighting to get into bays that certainly didn't belong to them. Why wasn't anyone trying the same with bay thirteen?

She got her answer when they reached the security tower.

Dozens of bodies littered the hangar floor. Pools, smears, and footprints of blood coated the whole stretch from the first floor door of the security room to the *Dzivia* itself. People *had* tried to take the ship. It's just the auto turrets had taken care of them, and everyone else learned to steer clear.

"One foot in front of the other," Corynth said, bringing Adora back. She whimpered and breathed through her mouth to avoid smelling the blood and corpses.

*One foot in front of the other. Just put one foot in front of the other.*

She chanted it like a mantra in her head as they made their way down the stairs and across the hangar floor.

*Ignore the bodies. It's not your fault. Just put one foot in front of the other.*

Finally, they reached the ship, and Corynth keyed in the passcode to lower the ramp. Adora let him go and he beelined inside, disappearing from view. For her part, Adora remained at the foot of the ramp, hoping to dissuade anyone from coming at them if the pile of bodies didn't do enough to make them turn back on their own. The last thing she wanted was those turrets coming down and turning someone else to paste right in front of her.

Instead of people trying to force their way in, she saw what she initially assumed to be a trick of the eyes: what little she could still see of the terminal beyond the hangar seemed to darken, like the air there was growing thicker. Those panicked settlement-goers still running around outside grew fainter, like they were disappearing into a fog. When she could no longer make them out and that same dark fog seemed to be seeping into the hangar proper, Adora knew it wasn't a trick of the eyes. It was the Beast.

The ship's engines revved to life, buffeting Adora with strong winds. Corynth called to her from deep inside loud enough it startled her to action. She darted up the ramp into the ship and ran through the cramped interior tunnels until she reached the cockpit.

"Strap in," Corynth said, already in the pilot's seat and working at the controls.

Adora threw herself into the copilot chair and fumbled with the harness straps as the engines revved higher.

They lifted off, rotating and pointing toward the energy barrier separating the hangar bay from the vacuum of space. Corynth guided them through as steadily as he could and accelerated *hard* the moment they broke free.

Adora's body sunk into the seat cushioning as they rocketed away from the settlement and toward the star nearby. If seeing it take up almost the entire viewscreen still made her uneasy, the fact they were rocketing toward it at speed terrified her.

A warship, massive and ponderous, popped out of hyperspace and into existence right in front of them. Suddenly, instead of the star, all Adora could see was the Imperial Horde insignia emblazoned on the side of a hull.

Adora yelled and Corynth banked, just missing the ship by a hair as they ducked underneath. Twenty more ships warped in around them, appearing one after the other in a popcorn cascade around the first. The *Dzivia's* computer screeched warning after warning at them: proximity alert, gravity well alert, dozens of scanning alerts all in a row as the incoming Horde naval vessels targeted and identified them.

Corynth reached up and began to tap furiously at the controls under a screen embedded in the overhead control panel between them.

*Course set*, the computer said to them, voice deceptively calm amid the chaos. *Please confirm.*

"Hey, they even fixed the autopilot and plotting assistant for us," Corynth said. Adora thought the calm in his voice was completely out of place considering their situation. "Remember when you broke that trying to stow away in the first place?"

"Can you *please* just concentrate on flying the ship and not—"

A flurry of energy beams shot forth from each Horde warship and Adora screamed, holding onto the armchairs with a death grip. Corynth banked again, left and right, up, down and around to avoid them. It took Adora a moment to calm enough to realize the warships weren't aiming for them in the first place.

Still, she screamed again as another beam shot past, far closer than the others. Corynth pitched them sideways, g-forces pushing her further into the chair as the ship carved a sharp 180-degree turn.

The warships and the star in the background pulled away, and they faced Eden once again, built onto the sun-facing surface of the planet in front of them. Except this time, instead of the lush settlement, beach, and body of water under the protective barrier, Adora saw the black mass of the Beast spreading slowly and steadily outward from the landing bays. Countless ships were pouring forth from the landing bays scattered around, each trying to escape. Adora hoped Ly and Vasher were among them.

The beams from the capital ships now behind them shot forward past the bow of the Dzivia and lasered into the planet, the barrier, the settlement. Consecutive explosions rippled across the surface. Dozens of escaping craft got caught in the crossfire.

Corynth reached for the throttle in the center console between him and Adora and slammed it forward. The viewscreen distorted into a psychedelic tunnel which, a moment later, swallowed them.

Adora screamed a third time, and the Dzivia rocketed forward into hyperspace.

They had escaped an Eden under siege, both from the Beast and from the Empire, and that tiny screen embedded in the center overhead console blinked the name of their new destination at them:

Phoenix Station.

**End of Part Three**

Chapter End Notes

Phew, part 3 is the longest part of the fic and it is d o n e.

Glimmer is heading into a rapidly decaying situation on a far off planet, Corynth and Adora are heading to Phoenix (and some of you have rightly guessed what's supposedly waiting for them there), and Catra + Taline are heading to Archanas. World Eater is careening toward its climax, and let me tell you: when these three storylines converge....? oh boy. I am SO excited to get to that moment.

That being said, I'm switching gears here momentarily. World Eater will be going on a brief hiatus. I anticipate it being roughly 6-8 weeks, no longer than 10 weeks at the maximum.

In the meantime, I will be releasing the first chapter of another novella-length multichapter starting sometime late next week (around the time World Eater usually gets posted). It's comparable in size to my other novella-length story (4-6 chapters), and this fic will continue after that one finishes out. I won't advertise it too much here but: it's Catra-centric, set in the canon timeline, takes place shortly after season 5 ends (maybe a few months after). If you'd like to get an alert for when that comes out, you can subscribe to me as an

author and it should email you. (Or just bookmark/obsessively check back on my profile, as I do with many of my own favorite authors...)

I've mentioned this story is fully written to completion and is not in any danger of being abandoned. That still is true :) Pivoting to something else for a handful of weeks will help me when I come back to proofreading and doing final passthroughs of the part 4 and 5 chapters here, but it will be about a month and a half or two before those chapters start coming out again. I'm also tentatively planning on releasing all of the part 5 chapters in one giant update for binge-reading purposes too, but we shall see. More info to come.

Love you guys, thank you all for being an awesome audience, and see you very soon!

ps: the poster art for part 4 and 5 are shaping up to be my favorites so far. I can't wait for y'all to see it.

# Part IV: Revelations, Chapter 47: Fugue

Chapter Notes

Whew, hiatus over! Thanks everyone for your patience. Part 4 is where the three separate strands of narrative across Catra, Adora, and Glimmer twine closer together—the individual POVs themselves are dense with plot and worldbuilding so you can imagine how challenging it gets interweaving them closer until they finally collide (especially for a part titled 'Revelations').

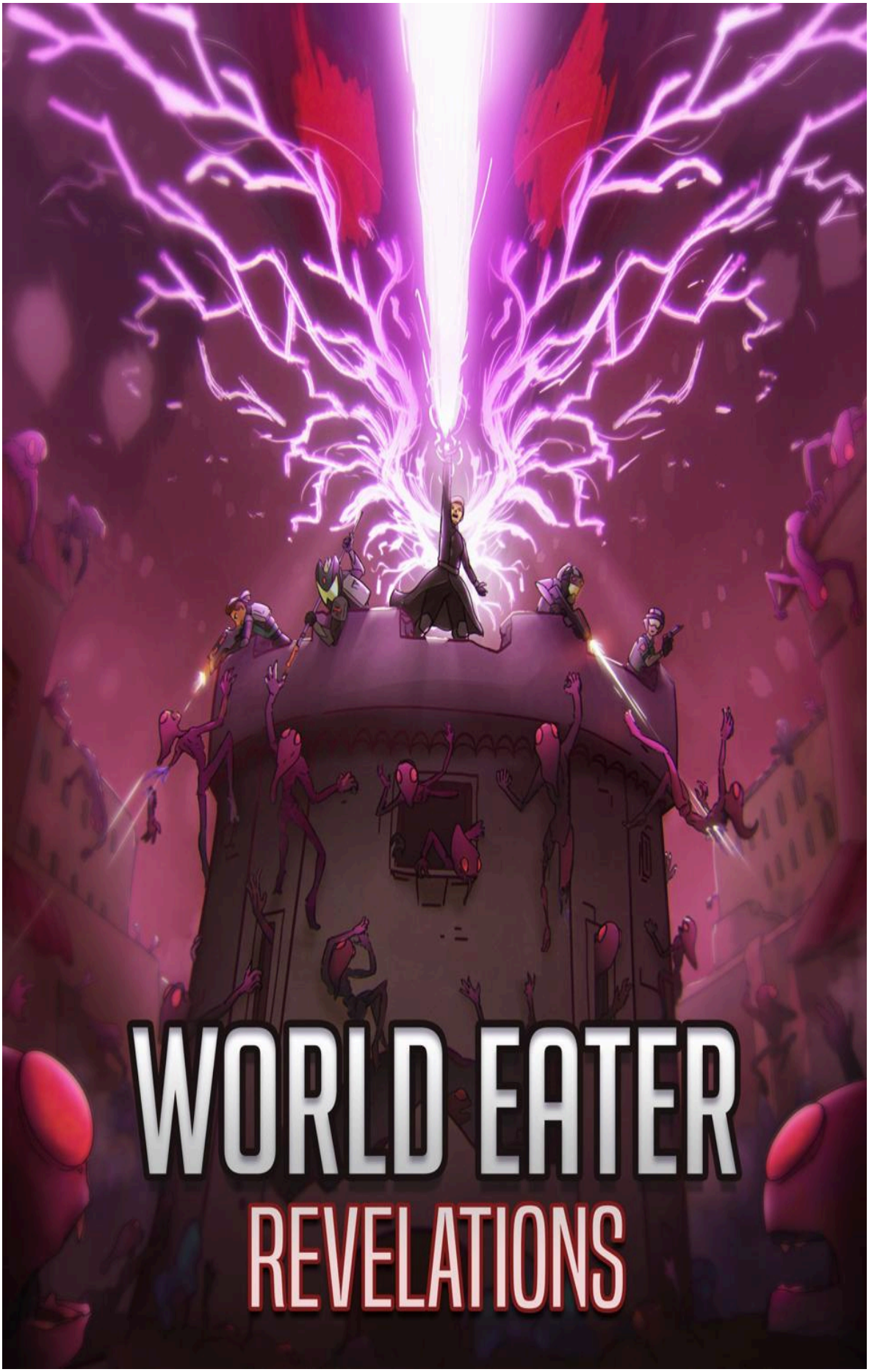
I took the time to do another 2 heavy revision drafts on these parts in particular over the preceding weeks; they were finished and in decent shape already when I posted the last chapter of part 3 back in February, but the extra work has really brought it to a new level and I'm super excited to start posting chapters for you guys again!

I will continue to aim for 1 chapter posted a week. The story is complete, but putting chapters up hinges on me doing final proofread passes in time. With me starting a new job soon, there might be times where the chapter comes out a day or two late.

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Quick recap for those who might need a refresher: Glimmer and Lonnie are at odds with one another, deployed on an alien planet trying to fight back the growing Beast infection. The last we saw them the planet took a turn for the worst and everyone was ordered to evacuate. Glimmer found out Lonnie and Rogelio did not evacuate and were missing, so she decided (albeit recklessly) to head into the succumbing city of Tir to rescue them. Kyle is their getaway pilot.

See the end of the chapter for more notes


WORLD EATER
REVELATIONS

Art commission done by SzethK. Linktree: Here

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## Chapter Forty-Seven: Fugue

Glimmer raced across the steppe toward Tir in the distance.

The speeder, her PDA, the helmet covering her head, she'd synced all of it together, and she could see her current velocity—soaring with no end in sight—next to Kyle on video stream in her heads-up display. Judging by the fuzzy-at-best connection and the stars tumbling and twisting behind him, he was in space among the fleet, flying in formation with other warbird squadrons. *All the better*, she thought. He'd have an easier time tracking her out there than inside the *Omen-Kador*.

The comm system in her helmet crackled at her ear with his voice, and the distance between them made his words come out a half second delayed.

"We're starting to lose any sort of instrumental visibility into the city," he said. "Even looking down from space it seems like something is already forming on the surface. What the hell is happening down there?"

"The city is succumbing. The Abomination—it's affecting the atmosphere. That's what you're starting to see."

Already, a fog blanketed part of the city on the horizon. The Beast's essence, its force of will manifesting like a physical force of nature, was eating the planet.

"Is this what Rinne was like?" Kyle asked.

Glimmer frowned and pushed the speeder harder. As experienced in the field as Kyle and Lonnie and Rogelio were, she was the only one out of the four of them that had seen a planet turn into a Lost World. She had forgotten that.

“Honestly, this seems more abrupt,” she said. “Rinne was tiny in comparison to this. We only had one megalith for the city. Tir has six.”

The Beast hadn’t taken any worlds this far in toward the galactic center since the war ended, so the fact they were moments away from losing Scavria was terrifying. She tried to focus on her one goal: getting Lonnie and Rogelio out.

The sound of several engines roaring like gatling thunder came from behind, drowning out her speeder and the howling wind. Glimmer looked and saw the six megaliths kicking up a cloud of dust as large as a mountain as they pushed off, lifting higher into the air. Dozens of warbirds circled them like escorting gnats, safeguarding the countless thousands of refugees inside.

The Scavrian race would turn into an endangered species within the next handful of hours. Glimmer turned her attention back to the city and tried not to think about it.

“Are you seeing what’s happening here?” she asked, when something unexpected caught her eye. “This isn’t just me, right?”

The tallest cluster of skyscrapers across the center of the skyline had disappeared fully, and the fog obscuring it had turned dark. An aura always hung around infected cities and planets—sometimes barely detectable and sometimes palpable enough to feel like a heavy dew coalescing around the body—but Glimmer hadn’t seen it grow this thick before. Obscured, yes, but completely blocked out like this?

“It’s not just you.” Kyle sounded shaken. “None of my sensors are picking up anything in that fog, either. Multiple channels of command are freaking the hell out right now.” He hesitated a beat. “How are you supposed to get in touch with me from in there if we can’t even get a topographical scan from up here? How am I supposed to know where you are?”

"You won't. Not from in there." Glimmer nudged the speeder enough to let her careen past a boulder without hitting it. "We just have to hope that thing doesn't expand any further. I'll pull Lonnie and Rogelio and anyone else out of the affected zone, then you'll be able to come get us."

"On a one-seated speeder?"

Another row of skyscrapers disappeared in the fog and Glimmer's heart sank. So much for hoping it wouldn't expand. It mushroomed out, blanketing more of Tir with each passing second like a tide rising on a sandy beach.

"Glimmer?"

"I see it." She set her jaw. "I'll figure something out. Just keep scanning for my PDA signal and be ready to move as soon as I come back online."

"You have an hour until they start the orbital bombardment. If you aren't out by then, none of you will—"

The fog exploded out far enough it engulfed Glimmer despite how she'd just reached the outer edges of the city suburbs. Kyle's voice and image on her HUD disappeared, and her visibility cut to zero.

"Kyle?" She slowed, carving the speeder to the side until it stopped. "Kyle, can you hear me?" Static came through, but nothing else.

Glimmer sat back against saddle's back and cursed. She couldn't panic, not now. But considering how the Beast was powerful enough to suffocate her vision, it was difficult.

*Stay calm*, she chanted to herself. *You've been through this before. Maybe not as drastically, but you've felt the Beast in the past. If you panic it just makes it that much easier to fall victim to it.*

A light inside her helmet blinked red at her; it was looking to reconnect with Kyle but couldn't get a signal. She listened to static in her ear for a heartbeat, then two, pretending it was just white noise to try and calm down. Once she'd ridden her anxiety to calmer waters, she removed the helmet and hung it on one of the speeder bike's handlebars. She was liable to feel claustrophobic again with it on, and she could get in touch with Kyle through her PDA once she found Lonnie and Rogelio and the others, anyway.

*If anyone was still alive at all, to begin with*.

She beat the thought off before it could send her spiraling again. Kyle had deliberately not brought up the fact everyone might already be dead—that there were no guarantees anyone was still themselves after disappearing in the fog in the first place.

Again, she spiraled. The Beast's aura already beginning to seep into her psyche despite her best attempts to not let it. Despair, gloom, hopelessness—it had just never struck as quickly or as strong before, and this was becoming a recurring theme despite having plunged into the fog only seconds ago.

She needed to focus on getting to Lonnie and Rogelio's last known location. Anything else was the Beast baiting her. Thankfully, Kyle had already briefed her, and the castle district deep in the heart of the city was an obvious place to travel to. Maybe it was the one lucky break she'd get: them broadcasting their location moments before going dark. But she wasn't going to make it there if the fog kept her from seeing more than two feet in front of her face.

Her nerves chafed when she realized what that meant she'd have to do. She counted out ten deep and slow breaths, trying to center herself. The near-suffocating presence of the Beast suffused every pore of her skin, trying to chip away at her sanity and sense of identity. She focused on feeling every beat of her heart, every wayward breeze against her skin—on every molecule of air filling her lungs, each breath seeming to barely keep that sense of looming oblivion at bay.

She dismounted from the speeder, the *tap tap tap* of her boots echoing as she stepped away. Maybe she couldn't see the buildings and roads around her, but if she could touch them with her power, she could navigate from there. She reached out with her mind…

And recoiled as if burned.

Taline had explained it, once. If reaching out with your mind was a near-equivalent to touching something with your hand, then probing the Beast's aura like this seemed on par with plunging an arm into a vat of molten lava. How did anyone the other Battlemages on the front lines deal with this?

The fact the Beast had won meant they didn't, but Glimmer couldn't think about that when she had a job to do.

Despite the initial shock, she found she could bear the exposure if she steeled herself. The more she groped around the more of her surroundings she could make out. Skyscrapers sprouted up around her like towering trees. She was closest to the right-hand side of the street and the sidewalk was only a few paces away. There was an intersection up ahead, and dozens upon dozens of abandoned vehicles littered the area.

"That's odd," she said, speaking aloud to ward off how isolated she felt. "I stopped at the outskirts of town, not here."

The last thing she remembered seeing was a scattering of small buildings, but what she felt now was indicative of being deep downtown. She pushed the thought away and continued exploring. She had to learn to navigate by feeling the buildings like this, then she'd be able to mount the speeder again and move.

Except there was one thing she *couldn't* feel. She spun on her heel and stared at the expanse of nothing in the direction she'd come and reached again.

Where did the speeder go?

She searched around, feeling blindly with her hands, now, as well as her mind, taking uncertain steps forward, hoping maybe she'd bump into it on accident. She heard something in the fog—voices, whispering indiscernible words as she fought another onslaught of panic. How long had she been wandering? She had only taken a few steps, only practiced feeling with her powers for a minute at most, right? She couldn't have gotten far. Right?

One of the voices played devil's advocate: she might have wandered far from the speeder and just didn't remember. After all, the last thing she remembered before the fog hit was approaching the suburbs, and she wasn't there, anymore. If she couldn't find that speeder, her chances of getting to the others were slim to none.

Her hand bumped into something hard, something she hadn't sensed at all, before. She yanked back, runes flaring at her fingertips. Her heart thrummed hard enough she felt it in her throat. Nothing happened, and when she'd reasoned nothing was about to kill her, she snuffed out the magic and reached a hand out again to touch it.

It was a chair. She could tell when she ran her hand along the fine-grain wood of the back and down to the cushion on the seat. She furrowed her brow, confused. What the hell was a chair doing out here in the middle of a suburb street?

"Who are you?"

A voice spoke from behind, and Glimmer yelped, whirling around with magic crackling in her hands again. A woman stood there, short hair framing a youthful face. A lab coat hung off her frame, and she stood only a little taller than Glimmer, herself.

"Who are *you*?" Glimmer asked, scowling at the woman and refusing to snuff her magic out again.

The scene around her had changed without her noticing. The fog was gone. Instead, she was standing inside a well-lit room, where

computer monitors and machines and lab equipment stood anchored to a grated floor, pushed against the walls. There was a long table in the room's center with chairs on each side. Glimmer was standing next to one of them.

"Ah, you're one of those," the woman said, beleaguered realization dawning on her face.

A knock came at the far door and Glimmer jumped.

"Come in," the woman said, projecting her voice before looking back at Glimmer and saying, in a more subdued tone, "Grab a seat, and don't distract me. No one else can see or hear you, but it still unnerves people when I pay attention to something that isn't there."

Glimmer scowled. 'Something that isn't there?' She was standing right in front of her! The door opened before she could respond, and a man with windswept hair and bags under his eyes stepped through, shutting the door behind him with a clang. He took a moment to survey the room.

"Everything okay?" he asked. "I heard you talking to someone."

The woman gave Glimmer a pointed look before slumping into one of the chairs at the table. "Everything is fine."

The man sounded exasperated as he joined her at the table. "Evie, if you're seeing things again you need to tell me."

Glimmer gasped. She could tell Evie had heard her and was trying not to show it.

"Seeing things when you're in touch with the Beast is one thing," the man said, reaching across the table to lay his hand over hers, "but to still see them when we're not touching it is something else."

Evie pulled her hand back and held it close to her chest. "They're just ghosts, Corynth."

“Holy shit,” Glimmer said.

This got a reaction out of Evie. She shot Glimmer a death glare from across the table, and Corynth followed her line of sight too, although he seemed to stare past Glimmer instead of at her.

“It’s getting worse, isn’t it?” Corynth asked, turning back to Evelyn. “Maybe we should cut back on the number of trips I orchestrate for you.”

Evie shook her head. “We can’t stop now, we’ve almost finished deciphering ignominite’s molecular structure. And I know where we need to dig next. There are some writings and artifacts I’ve seen that reference something, all of it written in ancient Eternian. Something about a wall or a barrier, I’m not sure yet.”

“Since when can you read dead languages?”

“I’ve been tinkering with a program that helps. It’s able to decipher enough of it to derive meaning. Whatever it’s finding, it’s important. We can’t stop.”

Corynth looked unconvinced and Evelyn huffed.

“It’s no worse than normal, I promise,” she said. “I’m just preoccupied with other things, obviously, and their presence is more irritating than usual.” She leaned forward, propping one elbow up on the table and putting her head in her hand. “Taline is alive.”

Corynth’s expression hardened. “She is.”

“I feel like I should be more relieved about it than I am. I don’t want to lose her, and if it’d taken her then Archanas would have fallen—”

“All of the mid rim would have fallen within days if she’d been taken, not just Archanas.”

Evelyn nodded. “Yeah. But it didn’t take her, and she’s alive, so why do I still feel apprehensive about it? Now there are two of you who can rebuff the Beast directly trying to corrupt you, but…”

“We have to deal with what comes next.” Corynth finished her sentence with just as much trepidation. Glimmer had never before been so invested in something she had no context for.

“What happens now?” Evie asked.

Corynth leaned back in his chair, staring up at the halogen lights in the ceiling. “The Daiamid will send someone to make contact,” he said. “She’s passed the ritual. The first in hundreds of generations to do so.”

“You passed it too,” Evie said, confused. She looked off to the side where a pedestal stood flush against the wall, holding up a pulsating red and black-veined crystal sealed inside a glass container. “You protected me against that thing when it took over the research station. *You* were the first.”

“Taline survived against a full-strength outbreak that was well on its way to taking an entire hub planet. It wasn’t just a singular space installation and a few dozen scientists and staff. News of this will fundamentally upend the Daiamid. Again.”

“Okay, fine. You were technically the first, then. She just did it better.”

Corynth chuckled and shook his head. “Another fully-fledged Shaper within a handful of years. The old guard wouldn’t even hold a candle to her, and she comes with far less baggage than I do.”

“You both have plenty of baggage,” Evie said, hints of a smile on her face, too. “Do you think they’ll send you to her?”

Corynth shook his head. “I’m not the pariah I was when I was working security for your old team,” he said. “But even with

everything that's happened, my standing is still poor. They'll send someone less controversial."

Evie chewed at her lip. "Maybe you should talk to her before they do. Tell her the truth."

"Why would I do that? That sounds like a terrible idea."

Evelyn rolled her eyes and shot him a '*seriously?*' look. "The Daiamid are pure folktale. Scary stories told to children to get them to behave, and she's already been through an ordeal. Some random person showing up to recruit her will go a lot smoother if someone she trusts eases her into the idea first."

Corynth shook his head. "We have procedure for a reason. I can't break it a second time."

"But if you—"

"You haven't forgotten what happened to the La Valettes." Corynth's eyes flared with indignation. "I know you haven't forgotten. I was sentenced to death because I revealed who I was to them. Because I didn't want to kill them, emperor's orders be damned. And they *still* died anyway."

A heavy silence came over them, interrupted by the ticking and whirring of the hardware surrounding them. Evie stood from her chair and made her way over to him. She knelt beside him and fished one of his hands out from his lap to hold in both of hers.

"They were dead the moment Horde Prime ordered your people to assassinate them," she said, voice gentle. "If they didn't send you, it would have been someone else and nothing would have changed. It was your empathy and refusal to eliminate an innocent family line that had them send you to me. Breaking protocol and revealing yourself to outsiders are just pretenses they used to justify it to the others." She tugged at his hand, trying to get him to look at her. "And it brought us together. All of us. What happened to them was terrible, and what happened to you was terrible, but there was still good that came of it."

Corynth refused to meet her eyes. His whole body was rigid with tension. Evie cupped the side of his face with one hand, startling him.

"If you're still apprehensive about it, then I understand. Just promise me you will tell her about yourself after the Daiamid made contact. If she hears from anyone other than you that you aren't really a Battlemage, she'll feel betrayed. You aren't breaking any rules by telling her if they've already reached out, right?"

Corynth relaxed and nodded. "I'll tell her after."

"It will still be a shock when they break the news to her, but at least she'll have you there when she has to process everything after."

"She'll have you, too," Corynth said. "You're her sister. She loves you."

Evie smiled wide. "She'll have us both."

The sound of shattering glass followed by shouting emanated from outside. Corynth and Evie both snapped their heads toward the door.

"Are Vasher and Ly fighting again?" Evie asked, letting go of Corynth and moving back when he stood from the chair.

"Have they ever stopped?" Corynth pressed his lips into a thin line. "One of these days I'm going to lock them both in a room until they figure it out."

"They'll either fuck, or one of them will be dead. Either way, it will be loud."

"I'll pick one of the sealed rooms we use with the Beast, then," Corynth said.

He opened the door and stepped through, the yelling and screaming amplifying until he shut the door behind him with a

clang. Corynth's voice joined theirs, shouting above them, and after a few moments, all three arguing voices ceased altogether.

A moment passed in silence, then Evie turned and looked at Glimmer.

"You're still here?" she asked.

"I—"

"You need to go back where you came from. And speak nothing of what you've seen here to anybody. If anyone finds you passed out in a barn or slumped over in a coffee shop or laying on the floor of your office, it will only get worse if you start talking about the Daiamid and these random people you saw in a lab on top of it."

"You're her." Glimmer was still trying to find her equilibrium. "How am I seeing this?"

Evie stepped over to her and shook her head. "No, you can't keep dwelling on this, it will just make it harder for you to reorient yourself back where you belong."

She placed both hands on Glimmer's shoulders. Her grip was strong and corporeal, and it shocked her.

"Think!" Evie said. "What was happening right before you found yourself here. What were you doing?"

Glimmer scrunched up her face and closed her eyes trying to remember. Bits and pieces came back. Being surrounded by fog, searching in the dark for her friends, blind. Voices began to echo around her, whispers from some collective anonymity that danced at the back of her consciousness, barely noticeable.

Then the rest of it came back in a rush, like freezing water drenching her. Scavria, Lonnie, and Rogelio, the emergency evacuation. Glimmer opened her eyes with a gasp and Evie, the lab, all of it was gone. She was in the fog once more.

The whispering grew louder, angrier, and there was no longer any doubt in Glimmer's mind that she was indeed succumbing slowly to the Beast. Was that what Evie had been trying to warn her about? Was that why she seemed to almost panic when Glimmer wanted to dive further into the vision rather than find her way out?

A new presence was there in the far corners of her mind. No, multiple presences—a small crowd. Glimmer's immediate thought was that she had been set upon by thralls, but that didn't make sense. If they had found her, they would have rushed her already, not milled about aimlessly nearby like this. She  also would have detected them long before they got this close, since she'd already been feeling about with her powers.

One of those in the crowd shambled toward her. Magic flared at the palms of Glimmer's hands, ready to strike. A bulky figure appeared, a dark, stained shadow against the fog. When it stepped into view, Glimmer recognized who it was.

"You have nothing to fear from me," Narre said, modulated voice coming through the front of his helmet's faceplate clear as crystal against the backdrop of whispers. His voice was just as she remembered it back on the emperor's citadel. The Beast had turned Scavria into a sea of ghosts.

"What are you doing here?" Glimmer took faltered backward as he advanced. "You can't be here. You're dead."

"Not a day goes by that you don't think about me, and you think I'm dead?" Narre cocked his head to the side.

Glimmer grimaced and decided to stand her ground, instead. She raised a hand bristling with magic at him as a warning. "Not another step," she said, pleased when Narre stopped. "What do you want?"

"We came to ask you something."

"We?"

More figures appeared beside him, still obscured by the fog.

“Why didn’t you save us?” It was a different voice that spoke this time, and it came from behind.

Glimmer spun around to see even more figures. There were easily a hundred, maybe two. When they too stepped out of the fog and into view, Glimmer realized with horror that she recognized them as well.

“Why did you leave us behind?” said a small girl no older than five at the front of the group, holding her mother’s hand.

The Rinnite’s, like the Scavrians, had discernable features, too. Their lithe bodies and elfin features haunted Glimmer’s sleep and slipped beneath her eyelids every time she blinked. Seeing them stand before her now was like a waking nightmare.

“We aren’t remembered.” Another spoke the words, although the voice coming from their mouth was frayed and full of static, like the pilot who had pleaded with her to wait had sounded, begging through the loudspeaker. “No one speaks of Rinne, of the billions of lives left there. Yet the call you the Angel of Archanas.”

“No one remembers us,” they all said in unison.

“I remember!” Glimmer said, voice hoarse. “I spoke of you when they first started calling me the Angel.”

“We are dead because of you!” The crowd—not just the Rinnites, but Narre and those with him—roared as one, blowing Glimmer back on her heels. “You are no Angel. You are the Demon of Rinne. You are a failure. A fraud. Coward!”

“I’m…” Glimmer shook her head. “No…I tried to save you. I wanted to save you, I just—“

“You just failed to act,” said a third voice.

Glimmer almost didn't turn around again. She didn't want to turn around.

Another person had stepped through the fog next to Narre, wearing the same fashion of armor but scorched nearly beyond recognition. Taline's second Sentinel looked as Glimmer imagined she might have after sacrificing her own life, immolated by her dad's portal when he brought the Rebellion to the emperor's throne room.

"How is failing to act any different than being a fraud and a coward?" Miri's voice dripped with  contempt. "I sacrificed myself to save you because Taline commanded it. But even with her mentorship, you still failed to act when Rinne needed you. Everyone here, their blood is on your hands."

"That's not what happened!" Glimmer clapped her hands to her ears. "No, that's not…I couldn't have…" There was no anchor for her to find, try as she might. No landmark for her to orient herself.

"I might still have been alive too if you had acted," Narre said.

Glimmer looked up. He held both hands over his chest. When he let go, they came away covered in blood, and Glimmer saw the gaping hole in his armor that Prime had made when he killed him.

"If you had grabbed that knife, if you had attacked Prime before he could do this to me, I might still be alive."

More figures stepped out of the fog, surrounding her. One by one, Angella, Micah, Catra, Adora, the other princesses revealed themselves. They looked unharmed and unchanged, save for the bottomless black holes where their eyes should have been. It looked as something had gouged them out, and only their sockets remained.

Glimmer clapped a hand to her mouth in horror. She had long ago extinguished her magic, no longer able to maintain it with the onslaught of emotions flooding. Finally, Bow pushed forward out of the group, stepping closer than any of the others.

“Are we next?” he asked. “Are we to fall and die because you don’t have what it takes to fight?”

“That’s not what happened!” Glimmer said. “Bow, please…”

She couldn’t let them drag her under like this. She had to keep fighting, had to say something, even if whatever she tried seemed no more effective than trying to keep her head above water in a tsunami by paddling.

“The Beast is coming,” everyone said, speaking together again, chanting. “Soon, we will all be as those of Rinne are now. At last, we shall be whole. At last, we shall be together.”

Adora stepped forward this time, her voice a solo. “Join with us, Glimmer. The fight is over.”

Something changed inside Glimmer at hearing that. There was insight and recognition where before there was none.

Her friends wouldn’t speak that way, least of all Bow and Adora. It reminded her of where she was and what was happening, and Glimmer at last put enough distance between herself and her fear to think clearly.

The Beast had was corrupting her, and fast. If she didn’t act now, she’d succumb and turn into an Abomination. There would be no hope for the planet then, and billions more would die as she ripped through the surrounding sectors.

Glimmer pushed power to her hands again. She drew no runes; they weren’t needed for what she was about to do, and although she had never attempted something like this before, Taline had taught her what to do. *Most can’t do this*, she had been told, early on in her training. *But you grew up with your connection to your runestone. You’re better prepared than most.* Taline had drilled her over and over again to prepare her for a moment like this. A moment where she really might fall to the Beast.

*You as an Abomination?* she'd said, early during Glimmer's mentorship. *It wouldn't just be a lost planet. You'd probably take a whole system with you, maybe a whole region before we stopped you. The emperor would likely reinstate me by special command to do it. Not as a punishment, but because the damage you'd cause and the power you'd wield would be so extensive, I'd be the only one who could excise you.*

Glimmer shuddered at the memory and swore she heard the voice actually echo around her, amplified by the Beast. It was a stupid decision to risk herself like this for Lonnie and Rogelio, but she refused to regret it.

Everyone around her took a step forward. "Come, Glimmer," they said, chanting again as one. "Don't postpone the inevitable, join us. Join us *now*." They took another step forward, and then another, growing closer, closing in.

Glimmer reached for than she had ever used at one time. The blue around her hands grew opaque, more defined. It writhed and oscillated, spinning faster and faster like a living thing stimulated and jolted by the sheer force of her will. Power raced up her arms and engulfed her body. She was on fire and still she did not stop reaching for more. She couldn't afford to mess this up; it had to work on the first try. She needed more.

"It is hopeless, Glimmer," the mob said. "Did you not hear us the first time? All will become one with us. We shall all be together again. You will no longer feel lonely and far away. You will never be far from your home because your home will be *us.* Do not prolong the inevitable."

Glimmer set her feet and looked at her parents' doppelgangers, staring into the endless voids where their eyes should have been.

"No!"

She released everything she'd gathered within at once. A shockwave of magic exploded out with her at its epicenter. The

fog cleared, and within moments, entire blocks of the surrounding cityscape with its towering skyscrapers became visible. Fatigue crept into her bones, and remaining upright was a struggle, but her head finally cleared. Anxiety and adrenaline and fear no longer plagued her, and she could finally think straight now that the whispering voices had gone.

The mob had changed, too. Narre, Miri, everyone from Rinne, her parents and her friends—even Bow and Adora—they were all gone. Thralls stood in their place, shambling corpses with missing limbs and wrinkled, grey, half-decomposed skin, their clothes torn and tattered from the elements. Glimmer both sensed and saw them when the fog cleared, looking off in random directions as if never having noticed her to begin with. They all turned together, fixing cloudy eyes and empty eye sockets on her, each finding her at the same time.

One of them roared at her and charged. A rune sparked to life at the end of Glimmer's palm, drawn instantly and with surgical precision won through years of grueling practice. A ball of magnificent purple shot forth from the rune and engulfed the thrall in white flame.

The others watched, and a steady thundering of anger grew and roiled among their ranks. The thrall on fire screeched and flailed before crumbling to ash. The mob roared together in fury, and Glimmer aimed her other hand with the first, bristling with magic, ready to fight.

The thralls stopped upon seeing it, and they didn't attack immediately either. Silence stretched between them, tense. Glimmer knew they'd attack anyway, so why not immediately? Why would they hesitate?

The answer came not long after as thousands of voices screeched back in answer to the first. The sound bounced off the walls of the skyscrapers and reverberated down the wide streetway corridors. Thousands of thralls materialized out of the buildings,

breaking through windows and crawling down the sides of the buildings like ants swarming. All of them rushed her.

Glimmer didn't think. If she thought, she'd surely be overcome by fear. So instead, she threw her arms out to the side, hands palm-down, and cast a different spell.

A ring formed around her, wide enough to accommodate a small fireteam had she been leading one. Bright purple marks appeared on the outside perimeter. Once the markings were complete, she threw her hands high into the air. A wall of white fire twice as tall as she was roared to life, encircling her.

The first group of thralls to slam into it screamed in pain as they tried to push through. Glimmer couldn't see them, since the fire immolated them to a crisp as soon as they touched it, but she could sense what was happening on the other side.

She could also sense the sheer number still approaching her, could see thousands more follow the thousands who came first, filing endlessly out from inside the surrounding skyscrapers. They were like a flood.

The fog began to encroach upon her once again, slowly blanketing the farthest street corners. She still couldn't sense the speeder despite having cleared the fog earlier; wherever she had wandered off to before coming to her senses, it was far.

An arm stuck through the flame before it too crumbled to dust. Then a second arm, a leg, part of a face—half a thrall then got through before the flames stopped it. The screeching and roaring from the army outside continued to build. They were moments away from breaking through and tearing her to shreds.

*I really wish I'd practiced this more*, Glimmer thought, moments after deciding how to proceed.

She centered herself and reached out with her mind again. After a moment, she found what she was looking for: the castle district and its location relative to her. It wasn't nearly as clear as she'd

have liked, given how far away it was and the fact the fog still permeated the majority of the city, but she could approximate its location.

More thralls (and more parts of each thrall) continued to penetrate the wall, clawing for her before evaporating. She knelt, placed the tips of her fingers to the ground, and concentrated. Blinding purple magic began to etch itself steadily into the road. It arced away from her, twisting and turning like the roots of a plant growing far faster than anything natural.

Glimmer went as fast as she dared, keeping in mind what Taline had told her the last time they spoke.

*Speed is important on the battlefield, sure, but so is drawing smooth, accurate ley lines*, she had said. *Teleporting only half your squad—and by that, I mean half of each member of your squad and not half the number of them—is just as undesirable as not teleporting out of a sticky situation in time at all.*

A thrall got through the fire as she finished. It charged at her with its body aflame. Glimmer looked into its eyes in shock and activated the spell just as it grabbed her.

A bright flash of light engulfed the both of them, then they were gone.

Chapter End Notes

> The "flashback" with Corynth and Evelyn overhearing Ly and Vasher fighting out in the hall corroborates Ly telling Adora in chapter 44 how she used to hate Vasher's guts.
>
> Many of the OCs have their own mini-arcs that play out behind the scenes, much of it non-sequential in time. Weaving that without ever leaving the POV of the main canon three (so as to not take away from the fact this is primarily a story about their arcs and reinforce the OCs as side characters only) feels like juggling 30 balls in the air at the same time.

Thanks as always for reading, and see you soon!

# Requiem for Forgotten Worlds

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer woke in a dark room.

It was night, judging by the moonlight coming through a row of high windows embedded in the brick wall to her left. Slatted blinds covering the top half of the windows blocked some of that moonlight and cast a pattern against the hardwood floor. She was dozens of stories off the ground, probably in the penthouse room of a skyscraper judging by the view.

A figure stood at the middle window, staring out. Thunder boomed overhead, making Glimmer jump, but she didn't see the flash of lightning outside and the figure at the window otherwise didn't respond.

"Hello?" Glimmer said. They didn't turn. "Do you know where we are? How did I get here?"

Still, they didn't turn and Glimmer couldn't tell who it was from where they were standing. Shadow obscured half their face. They were muttering under their breath, each hand wringing the opposing wrist.

The sound of a lock disengaging came from behind and the person spun around. It was Taline. She looked younger than Glimmer had ever seen her, possibly the same age as her. She even looked happy—relieved—which was an expression she'd never seen on Taline's face before either. *What the hell was the Beast trying to do?* Glimmer thought.

Taline's look dissolved into confusion, then apprehension and concern. "Who are you?" she asked.

A man passed through Glimmer as if she were a ghost. Some nameless, featureless person she didn't recognize. He wore a mask—one in a style similar to what Glimmer had seen sold as novelty items in shops and costume stores throughout the empire, although she had a feeling this mask in particular wasn't some dress-up accessory.

"Disappointed to see me?" The man's voice came warped. "Not who you were expecting?"

Taline frowned. "Is that mask supposed to do something for me? A simple robber or assassin might opt for something less ostentatious you'd think." She turned back to the window, treating the intruder as if they were nothing worth paying attention to. "How did you get in here? There's a biometric lock on the door and guards outside."

"Not much of an obstacle for me, I'm afraid." The man laughed and a phantom chill shot down Glimmer's spine from how it echoed around the room. "Don't worry. Your Corynth will be along shortly, but in the meantime you and I are due for a chat."

Taline turned full around to face him. The moonlight bathed her from behind, outlining her body in a halo of white, which made it feel all the more fantastical with what happened next.

Her eyes glowed and her body burst alight, veined with white-hot magic ley lines, and her hair floated about her head like a crown of sun rays. She rose off the ground, the tips of her toes floating a few inches from the floor. When she spoke, it was like a hundred-strong  chorus chanted her words as one.

"You are too cavalier for a man courting death," she said. "I have seen Death's face, touched it and come away reborn. Who are you to talk to me as one would a child ignorant of the ways of the world? Who are you to come to me uninvited and demand my attention?"

Glimmer shied away from her brilliance. The man, however, didn't step back, didn't shield his eyes with his hand, and didn't apologize.

Taline wavered, swaying in the air like she was suspended on wires and the person holding her on the other end was losing strength. Her hair dropped back to her shoulders and the ley lines disappeared from her body. Finally, when she lowered back to the ground and stumbled on her feet, her eyes returned to their normal color again, too.

"Impressive that you can call upon it again so soon," the man said. "Although, without proper training you will never learn how to control it long enough to do anything useful." He extended an arm and, after pushing up the sleeve of his robes to reveal the skin underneath, gestured with his hand.

New lines of magic erupted across his skin, more subdued and of a warmer color than Taline's. Two chairs pulled out from a table shoved against the far corner. They floated through the air before arranging themselves in the center of the room, facing one another.

"Come," he said, removing his mask with his other hand and revealing his face. Glimmer still didn't recognize him. "We must speak."

Thunder boomed again, rattling the room, then three more came one after the other. Taline and the man didn't react at all, and suddenly Glimmer didn't think the noise was thunder at all. Instead, it seemed like some unseen figure standing beyond was hammering at the invisible walls encasing this reality. When she next paid attention to her surroundings, Taline was standing in the center of the room with her arms folded, scowling at the man seated in one of the chairs.

"The Daiamid aren't real," she said, picking up midway through a conversation Glimmer had lost track of. "I'm not interested in children's tales or conspiracy theories." She turned to stalk back to

the window. A hovercar flew  by, lighting the room with its headlights until it passed. “Leave, now. Before I make you.”

“The La Valette family thought the same as you, when our agent decided reveal themself against our creed,” the man said. “That arrogance is what prevented their offshoots from disappearing along with them in the extermination. Had the La Valette family spread their discovery, backed it with their name and given legitimacy to it, then we would have had to cull hundreds of their cadet branches. Possibly more.”

Taline froze mid-step and looked back over her shoulder, eyes wide in surprise. Then she turned to fully face him again for a second time. Anger, shock, and confusion played across her face.

“They were killed in a fire,” she said. “An arsonist was implicated, some slighted former servant in their household that was then executed. The Daiamid playing a part was just some fringe rumor no one listened to.”

“And it will remain that way, in all our dealings, for as long as the emperor demands it to be so.” The man tilted his head. “You wouldn’t think Horde Prime would parade his secret police out in the open for anyone and everyone to gawk at, would you?” He smiled wide, the white of his teeth glinting in the moonlight. “Assassins work best in the dark, after all.”

Taline sucked in a sharp breath, and although her face remained stony and neutral, she was shaking.

“Is that why you’ve come, then?” she asked, voice a whisper. “Am I your next target? Because I lost Archanas? Because of what I’ve become?”

The man’s face soured, but he shook his head. “Archanas was a regrettable loss, but understandable given the alternative. Hope is not lost. The emperor is confident in your sister’s discovery. Evelyn bringing us ignominite changes everything.”

“Then what is it?” Taline asked. “Why are you here?”

“I am here to bring you into the fold,” the man said. “You have touched the World Eater, communed with it, received its gifts. You will become one of the Daiamid. Quite possibly one of the most powerful we’ve seen in generations. Already, more raw power flows through your veins than does mine. Once trained, you would be a Shaper like those of old.”

Taline narrowed her eyes at him. She didn’t look happy. “And if I refuse?”

The man furrowed his brow. He didn’t seem to have anticipated this line of questioning. “Then you will not leave this room alive.” He spread his arms wide and gestured to himself. “I have revealed who we are to you. I cannot allow you to live if you refuse to join. And your friends, your sister, they will ask questions. They would not let your death fade into obscurity without concrete answers.”

He grimaced. “Corynth especially would not leave it alone until he knew the truth, I know that much of him. He would disseminate that truth to all who would listen. Any who would discover us are a threat. They cannot live, we could not allow it.”

Taline’s eyes flared and she balled hands into fists at her sides. “Couldn’t allow it?”

The look of cautious skepticism on the man deepened. Just as Glimmer was certain things between them would tip, another trio of booms sounded off above her, rattling the room and throwing her off balance.

“What the hell is going on?” Glimmer asked, staring up at the ceiling as if waiting for whatever was making those sounds to crash through and scoop her up in its hands.

Another boom sent her tumbling backward to the floor. She caught herself with both palms flat on the ground and hissed with eyes closed when pain shot up to her elbows.

The banging subsided. When she opened her eyes, she was no longer in the penthouse room with Taline and the man. Instead,

she was in a dank cell, sitting on wet cobblestone, staring up at motes of dust swirling against the singular ray of light that broke through the window above her.

Her body ached. Fatigue permeated her bones and made her wonder if she shouldn't just shut her eyes again and go back to sleep. She blinked, trying to clear the blurriness away. The air felt still and stale—almost the opposite of the room she'd just come from.

Another bang—rumbling and rolling this time—shook the room. Two men opposite a set of metal bars separating her half of the room from theirs sat on chairs flanking a door. One looked asleep while the other stared up at the ceiling, at the sheets of dust cast down from the rafters.

Glimmer's head pounded. She tried to cradle it between her hands, only to realize those hands were chained to the ground behind her, in the exact position she'd caught herself when she fell backward out of the vision. She struggled against the restraints, but only succeeded in making the guard staring at the ceiling notice her.

"Hey," he said, nudging his partner. "H-hey! She's awake. Get up, you idiot!"

The other guard snorted and startled upright, clasping the rifle laying against his lap. He locked eyes with Glimmer and the sleep plaguing his eyes cleared, replaced with fear.

"Go get her," the first guard said. "I'll watch and make sure she doesn't try anything until you get back. Hurry."

The second guard hesitated, then gave a curt nod and scrambled off his chair and out the room.

"Where am I?" Glimmer asked after the door slammed, throwing down another sheet of dust from the ceiling. "How did I get here, and why am chained to the wall?"

“Don’t!” The guard stood and pointed his rifle at her. “Don’t you dare say another word!”

She saw it then, the fear in his eyes, same as the other guard if not more pronounced. There was no use reasoning with him, not when he was like that. She’d have to force her way out and subdue him. Make sure he couldn’t harm her or himself. It wasn’t what she wanted to do, but her hands were tied—literally—and she had no idea how long she had been out. It was the only way she was going to get answers, and she couldn’t waste any time with an orbital bombardment on the way.

No magic came when she reached. Glimmer narrowed her eyes and tried again. It wasn’t just that it refused to come to her—it wasn’t there at all. There was no reserve. She’d always felt a reserve, bubbling under the surface, and now it was gone. Panic mounted. A part of her was missing. They had restrained her in ignominite chains, and no amount of pulling and yanking and straining loosened them.

“Stop struggling!” The guard cocked his rifle, looking down the iron sights at her. “Just…just sit there until the commander gets here or I swear I’ll blow your head off right now!”

His finger slipped inside the trigger guard and trembled. Glimmer froze. If that finger slipped, that was the end. The Angel of Archanas, killed in action not by the Beast, but by a fellow soldier in the field. Time seemed to slow, and she felt lifetimes pass between the beats of her heart. A noise on the other side of the door bled through, subtle at first, then growing louder.

The door opened and Lonnie stepped inside. Glimmer almost called to her. The guard barely acknowledged her arrival and kept his gun trained on her.

“Leave us,” Lonnie said to him without taking her eyes of Glimmer, either. “I’ll handle this.”

“Are you sure that’s safe, ma’am?”

“No.” The guard glanced sidelong at her, confused, but she didn’t waver. “Stand guard on the other side of the door. If I don’t come out in ten minutes, pull the pin off a grenade, toss it in here, and go reinforce your squad at the back of the wall.”

The guard hesitated, then saluted and left.

“Thank god,” Glimmer said the moment the door clicked shut behind him. “I’m glad to see you’re alive, but what the hell is going on?”

Lonnie approached her with a measured look and measured steps, dragging one of the stools behind her without responding.

Glimmer pulled the chains. “How did I get here, and why am I chained to a wall? Why with ignominite cuffs?”

Lonnie pulled the stool around between them and the bars, scraping its legs on the stone floor, and sat. She pulled her sidearm from its shoulder holster and pointed it at Glimmer’s head.

Glimmer recoiled. “What the fu—“

“Stop talking.” Lonnie’s voice was low and cut like steel. That steel bled into the look in her eyes. They were cold, detached, like she was appraising Glimmer as farm stock for processing. The fingers on Lonnie’s other hand shook, propped on her leg. Sweat sheened her forehead, her breathing came ragged, but the hand holding her gun didn’t falter and her finger on the trigger didn’t shake.

“What’s going on?” Glimmer kept her voice as level as possible. Another rumble in the distance came, although it didn’t shake the building. “Why are you doing this?”

“We found you unconscious just outside the compound walls with the burned-out remains of a thrall lying on top of you. I lost three men from the team I sent to get you, and I refuse to risk any more of them. You have three seconds to start talking and prove to me you aren’t an Abomination before I pull this trigger.”

Oh. Oh shit.

Glimmer wracked her brain for the last thing she could remember before waking up. It wasn't the vision of Taline, that much she knew, but what came before?

There was the fog, and the Beast doing everything it could to corrupt her by conjuring apparitions of her friends and long dead victims, but she hadn't succumbed. She'd made it! She'd teleported herself near enough to the old castle district for Lonnie and her after all.

But what could she say to prove any of this? Lonnie's finger tightened over the trigger, and the one thing she'd hoped she'd never have to relive bubbled to the surface to save her life.

"Rinne!" She bit the words out as if they were painful to say. "I was at the battle of Rinne. It was such a disaster. The biggest disaster since the war first ended on Archanas. In fact, they're so closely related in the public mind people sometimes forget which parts Taline and I played, even though they happened years apart."

Lonnie's hand stilled, but she didn't lower the gun. *She'd want more,* Glimmer thought. Abominations with a little bit of cunning still left to them could mimic their original selves. Delve into intimate memories, however? Abominations had no recollection of their host's experiences before being turned, but recounting something as renowned as the Seraph and Angel of Archanas respectively wouldn't be enough.

"It was the first planet we lost entirely to the Beast since the war last ended." Glimmer shuddered as she remembered, feeling like she was unlatching a trunk she'd shoved a nightmare creature into years prior. "There was only one megalith stationed next to the main population center I was attached to. That was all we needed.

"I'm still not sure what started it. Reports and rumors are all over the place, still talked about today, but I was on the ground. I could feel what was happening and I couldn't tell you how it started. All I can say is we thought we had the planet rescued much like what's happened here. We even started sending people back to the city to start rebuilding. Then the Beast swelled. It overwhelmed each of our entrenched forward positions, one after the other. Our deployment was too small to handle the wave, and within hours the city was lost. The fleet commanders gave the order to evacuate. Everyone who hadn't returned to the city prepared to lift off."

Another rumble in the distance. Glimmer thought it was the same phenomenon as before, until a scream trailed after the sound like an echo and, suddenly, she wasn't sure. Now it sounded eerily similar to a megalith taking off—a sound that had chased her from more than one nightmare since Rinne.

"The ship malfunctioned and we couldn't take off. Our presence on the planet was small already, since it was a less populated system. We didn't have enough soldiers to defend the compound until the techs finished their repairs. I was the only Battlemage not stationed at the front lines. I led the defense.

"The amount of magic I forced through my body that day…" she shook her head trying to clear the feeling of static racing along her skin. "My wings"—another shake, more vigorous. Not the right thing to talk about if she wanted to avoid flashbacks—"It was stupid to push that hard, but I wasn't thinking. I was just fighting as hard as I could. Some managed to make it back to the megalith while the repairs were going on. Every single one of them felt like I'd won a war, but I could only delay for so long. I didn't want them to die. *I* didn't want to die."

By now, Lonnie had stopped pointing the weapon at her. Instead, she seemed to hang off her every word. Glimmer could stop there if she wanted. She'd more than proved she wasn't an Abomination, but now that she'd started the story, she couldn't stop. Swept away in the swell of emotions, it would have been

easier to break the chains holding her down than it would have been to stop telling her story.

"We were about to close up the access doors and leave when we got an emergency communication from halfway out to the city—a final group of transports carrying the last surviving evacuees were on their way. The full might of the Beast infection, not just the thralls but the Beast itself, was right behind it. They… radioed us. Said they were thirty seconds out and to hold the door. They begged and pleaded for us to wait, but…"

Glimmer hissed and pulled on the manacles. Suddenly it seemed like a much better idea to actually try and break free than continue. The shackles dug into her wrists. A cutting, searing pain radiated up her arms, and she used that pain to force herself to finish.

"That's when I snapped out of whatever daze I had been in. That's when I looked at the number of thralls rushing us. Th-there were troopers too. No one had seen them since the war ended. When those people on that transport needed me to fight for them, I let fear take over me. I thought about everyone already safe aboard the megalith. I thought about them turning into thralls if we stayed behind. I thought about my parents and my friends, about never being able to see them again. I thought about all of that and I just…I—"

*Why did you leave us behind?* said a voice from nowhere. *You are no Angel. You are a failure. A fraud. Coward!*

Lonnie was there, wrapping her in a hug which Glimmer returned. Belatedly, she realized this meant she was free from the shackles. The barred door separating them was open, the stool Lonnie had been sitting on lay tipped over. She didn't realize she'd been crying until Lonnie stroked the back of her head and the sensation pulled a sob out of her.

"Hey, hey it's okay." Lonnie said. "You're okay. Breathe. Just breathe and focus. That's it."

Glimmer beat away the ghosts of the dead until Lonnie pulled back and held her at arm's length. She looked scared and deeply concerned as she looked her over, as if searching for physical wounds she might patch up. It was a welcome change compared to the cold, detached look from earlier. Lonnie's tightened her grip on Glimmer's shoulders and she saw she was shaking. They both were.

"Don't ever do that to me again," Lonnie said, dropping her head onto Glimmer's shoulder like it were a leaden weight. "I thought for sure you were dead when I saw you out there, and when I found out you were still alive all I could think about was what I'd have to do if it turned out you'd been corrupted. I almost shot you, Glimmer." Lonnie pulled her into a hug and pressed her head into the crook of her neck. "Goddesses above, I almost shot you. Don't *ever* scare me like that again."

Parts of Lonnie's armor dug into Glimmer, but she didn't care. For as much as she expected to be taken aback at how uncharacteristic seeing Lonnie scared was, a bigger part of her was happy for the relief. Rinne had been a weight on her chest she'd never expected to share.

"I condemned all those people to die," Glimmer said between shaking breaths. "It was a decision made because I was afraid. And this time it wasn't a highly trained Sentinel half expecting death to come for them in combat anyways, but hundreds of civilians hoping to evacuate just like everyone else. I had one job, Lonnie…to help people evacuate, and I failed."

"This is why you refused to take command of our team, isn't it?" Lonnie's voice was muffled from her speaking into Glimmer's shoulder. "It's not just Rinne. That'd be traumatic for anyone, but its tied up in what happened on the emperor's citadel, isn't it?"

Glimmer nodded. There was a reason the Beast manifested Narre and Miri alongside the Rinnites. Both were symbols of her previous failures. Glimmer told Lonnie all of it, the story slipping

out in a rush, and Lonnie listened with rapt attention, sitting back on her heels as Glimmer detailed every facet of it.

"Those people didn't die because you were too afraid to act," Lonnie said once she'd finished. "You keep talking about how people died because you were too scared to act or acted rash because you were scared, but all I took from both stories was that you jumped into the fray anyways and aren't giving yourself credit for it. You defended everyone at the megalith on Rinne until the thing was repaired and could take off, and you ignored Taline's Sentinel telling you to stay back in favor of bum rushing the emperor with a dagger hoping to kill him and save the rest of us."

"I failed, Lonnie." Glimmer didn't get what was so hard to understand about that. What point was Lonnie trying to make when the results spoke for themselves?

"Sure, if you want to see it that way." Lonnie gave her an exasperated look. "I personally would disagree with you on calling the outcome of either of those situations a failure, but even still, you didn't fail to act. You just didn't save everyone." She held up a hand to forestall Glimmer and said, "Those are different things, aren't they? Maybe you froze and Narre died, but you didn't freeze on Rinne, and you saved thousands. It's not the same mistake, if you can even call it a mistake at all."

When Glimmer still only gave her a skeptical look, Lonnie sighed, tapping an anxious rhythm with her fingertips on her armored thighs. "I had a friend once. A medic. Well, they were Kyle's friend, because Kyle makes friends with everyone, but then they became my friend and Rogelio's friend. This was before we were scouted for the Vanguards." Lonnie's tapping on her thigh became erratic. "They had family on Rinne and had to be put on suicide watch when news broke about what happened. A week later and they were gone."

Glimmer covered her mouth with a hand. "Oh my god…I'm—I'm sorry."

Lonnie shook her head. “It’s another casualty of the war, not your fault.” Glimmer bit back the urge to argue with her. “They were the first ones to explain triage to me and how it works. Funny how I’d grown up in a militaristic environment but never heard of something like that until my twenties.” Lonnie laughed, although there was no humor behind it. “Are you familiar with the term?”

Glimmer nodded. “Generally speaking, yeah. Categorizing extent of injury and likelihood of recovery if treatment resources are expended. I know a medic’s judgement on it often becomes the deciding line between life and death out in the field, nowadays especially.”

Lonnie nodded, staring past her. “I don’t know if its because he explained it well or because it was one of the last things I’d learned from him before…Anyway. You know how it is. Rinne was triage. You made a decision on peoples’ lives. Some were saved, many weren’t. It’s okay to feel beat up about it, just like it’s okay to carry the scars—mental scars—of that decision with you.

“But using their sacrifice as a shield to hide behind? Pointing to the fact you couldn’t save *everyone* from a Lost World and letting the guilt of that eat you alive for years? Even if they held you responsible, what does continuing to cudgel yourself over losing them accomplish except to tarnish the memory of their deaths?”

Glimmer glared at Lonnie. As much as the logic made sense, she didn’t appreciate hearing the same words she’d told herself over and over again repeated back to her. Instead of looking apologetic and backing off, Lonnie surprised her by reaching forward and laying a firm hand on her shoulder.

“For example,” she said, unabashed and without a trace of humor. “I’ll be pretty mad if you have to sacrifice me. I’d sacrifice myself to save you or someone else in a heartbeat, but I’d only feel *proud* of doing so if you’d traded me to save a million.”

“A million?” Glimmer squinted at her. She couldn’t tell if Lonnie was joking or not—for as morbid a subject this was, her delivery

perfectly straddled the line between deadpan humor and complete seriousness.

Lonnie nodded. "One million. And you aren't allowed to beat yourself up about losing me, either. Otherwise, I will return from the grave and haunt your dreams. It will be never ending stories of our time as kids fighting each other back home and you will hate every moment of it."

Glimmer couldn't help it. She barked out a supremely unattractive laugh, covering her mouth immediately after, shoulders shaking with barely suppressed mirth. Lonnie smirked at her.

"You're annoying," Glimmer said, shoving Lonnie's shoulder and rolling her eyes. She never thought she'd be one for gallows humor, but then again, she'd never been on the front lines enough to really appreciate it. She saw the draw, especially with it coming from Lonnie. Something told her she only joked like that with people like Kyle and Rogelio—comrades deep in the shit with her.

"That's half my job description, you know," Lonnie said, standing and holding out a hand for Glimmer to take. "Put bullets in thralls and annoy the shit out of Battlemages so they're too agitated for the Beast to take them in." A bang sounded overhead, shaking the room. Lonnie looked up with a frown. "Speak of the devil."

"What is that?" Glimmer asked. "It's been going on since before I even woke up here."

Lonnie shot her a strange look and Glimmer realized that hadn't made much sense. Instead of letting her clarify, however, she walked back toward the exit with Glimmer in tow and said, "Our jailer."

Was Glimmer supposed to know what that meant? "I came here to rescue you and Rogelio and whoever else is here. I don't know how long I've been out, but the fleet is supposed to begin their orbital bombardment any minute now. We have to get out before that happens. Kyle is on standby for an extraction."

Lonnie stopped with her hand on the doorhandle. She regarded Glimmer with a careful expression over her shoulder. "You've been out for three hours since we found you. The bombardment's been long underway, already. What do you think that banging is you've been hearing?"

"What?" Another bang overhead made her jump and sent her heart racing. "*That's* the fleet bombarding us with dreadnought-class cannons from space? How in the hell are we still alive?"

Lonnie shot her another smirk, although it was clear this one was a mask for her anxiety. "It'd be easier to just show you." She pulled the door open, light flooding into the dime and dingey room as she stepped through. "I hope you had a plan to get us out of here before you came. We all could use a morale boost right about now."

Chapter End Notes

> Bonus points if you can follow the Corynth/Taline/Evelyn side-thread throughout the whole fic. I made a deliberate choice to not ease the learning curve on that arc at all.

# Under Siege

A rotting smell blanketed the air as they stepped out of the dungeon, a specter of death clinging to Glimmer's skin and clothes and hair like a pall. Three seconds walking outside with Lonnie and already it felt like the smell would never leave her. Even if they were fortunate enough to make it off Scavria alive and she took half a dozen showers, Glimmer wasn't sure she'd stop smelling like a dead body.

The overcast sky toned everything in a drab, muted light. The soldier standing guard outside the door to the dungeon they'd just vacated snapped off a sharp salute to Lonnie as they passed. When he caught sight of Glimmer coming up just behind her, his eyes widened in surprise.

"At ease," Lonnie said. She held her hand out and, after a moment of hesitation, the soldier handed over Glimmer's PDA which he'd been safekeeping. "She's clean. Go join your squad at the rear. We need everybody we can muster at the wall."

The soldier gave an over-compensating 'yes Ma'am!' and double-timed away. Lonnie handed over the PDA and Glimmer slid it back onto her arm as a second figure, taller and bulkier than the first, approached them. Glimmer recognized him immediately.

"What the hell are you doing up and about?" Lonnie said to Rogelio before Glimmer could squeal in happiness and hug him. "You're injured. I need you to be resting."

Rogelio grunted at her, barely an acknowledgement, and turned a concerned, questioning look on Glimmer. Large swathes of his body—anything not covered by the bits and pieces of his armor he could still wear—were covered in bandages. They were wrapped double thick and still blood had seeped through. His right arm was held close to his scratched-up breastplate in a sling, and upon closer inspection Glimmer saw it had been amputated just below the elbow.

“It’s me,” Glimmer said, voice gentle. “I’m not corrupted. How did this happen? Are you going to be okay?”

Rogelio grunted and nodded.

“My harness came loose in our transport,” Lonnie said, “and he undid his own to shield me. He took the brunt of the impact when we crashed not far from here.”

Rogelio turned his bad arm away and pulled Glimmer into a side hug with his good arm, strong enough to squeeze the breath out of her.

“Gave me one hell of a scare, but he’ll be okay. The arm will regrow.” To him, she said, “You’re too stubborn to let some surface wounds and a missing limb keep you down, aren’t you? Just like you’re too stubborn to do what I say and rest.”

Rogelio snorted and the corners of his lips pulled back in a smile. He released Glimmer and patted the grip of his blaster strapped to his side as if to say, ‘I’m well enough to fight, too.’ Lonnie rolled her eyes but didn’t argue further. Instead, she stalked off toward the fortified wall in the distance, beckoning for Glimmer and Rogelio to follow her.

The castle district was enormous. As a preserved historical site nestled inside an even larger garden complex at the heart of Tir, it was also sufficiently isolated from the rest of the surrounding city.

A stone tower keep stood the compound’s center clearing, and it loomed high over the surrounding buildings. Although it was shorter than the skyscrapers Glimmer felt on her way in, it dominated the district and imbued sense of ancient, regal power in the atmosphere that battled with the muted, drab suffocation the fog imposed.

“We were lucky we made it as close to our LZ as we did before we went down,” Lonnie said as they headed for the far wall. “Fleet command wanted us to secure this as a base of operations. They

were planning to launch the last effort to retake the city from here before the emergency evacuation orders hit."

"Why here?" Glimmer looked at the ancient buildings as they walked, but always returned to the tower. A pair of soldiers trucking a machine gun and reams of belted ammunition ran by and she shifted to avoid them. "Sure, these buildings were designed to protect against attack and fortify a position in the past, but that was thousands of years ago. How are stone and mortar going to protect against hordes of Beast thralls?"

"You'll see why soon enough," Lonnie said, nodding up ahead to the wall. Glimmer and Rogelio both followed her up a set of stairs jutting out the side of the wall. As they crested the top and they got a clear view of their surroundings from atop the wall, Glimmer finally understood why Lonnie and the few soldiers she'd seen since waking looked so grim.

"The fog…" Glimmer trailed off when words failed to describe what she saw.

"Yeah." Lonnie answered each of her unspoken questions with the defeated tone of her response.

The sky wasn't actually overcast, it was the Beast's fog surrounding them. The trees and lawns and artificial lakes of the gardens surrounding the compound disappeared abruptly behind what amounted to an unnaturally thick curtain. Glimmer couldn't even see the sun. No wonder Kyle had lost their tracking signal; the Beast had trapped them here, just like it had almost trapped Glimmer in the city.

The sky lit up. The soldiers standing watch by the nearby parapets jumped and spoke in quick, hushed tones to one another, each wearing nervous faces.

"Lightning?" Glimmer asked, still staring up at the sky.

The ground began to shake in another tremor, and Lonnie reached for the closest parapet to keep stable. "That's the fleet

bombarding the planet from orbit."

"How is that possible? There are at least ninety ships in orbit firing down on the city—we should have been space dust after the first silo. Is the Beast muting the salvos like that fog dome is some kind of shield?"

"I don't know. This is the first I've seen something like this, and you said yourself you experienced some crazy things in that fog. Who knows what it's capable of?" Her look hardened. "That's not the only strange thing going on around here, either."

"What do you mean?"

Lonnie gestured again for them to follow as she moved toward the soldiers standing guard together further along the wall. One of them noticed their approach and snapped off a salute.

"They've been quiet for some time, but I think they may be gearing up for another surge any minute now."

"Is that you going off a hunch or have you actually seen something that would indicate that?" Lonnie clapped the soldier on the shoulder when he hesitated and walked past him without waiting for an answer. "Don't make the mistake of guessing what they'd do like they were just any other group of thralls. That's a one-way ticket to an early death. They've already shown us they aren't like the others."

She said the last part quietly as if to herself, and Glimmer wouldn't have heard it had she not followed Lonnie closely to the very edge of the wall. When she looked over the parapets and down, she saw yet another unexpected sight.

"What are they doing?" she asked, staring down at a mob of thralls standing outside the wall, clumped together shoulder to shoulder and chest to back. "Why are they just standing there?" Thralls not only always attacked if they sensed you—typically rushing a position with mindless abandon and with no regard for their safety much like their namesake would imply—but they were

also always spread out from each other. She had never seen them gather that close together before when there was plenty of space to roam.

"Beats me," Lonnie shrugged, looking down at them as if studying an interesting bug. "They're a lot harder to kill too. Our ammunition is coated with purer ignominite than most of what the rest of the armed forces use. It's expensive as hell, but it usually means a thrall goes down in one shot. These guys? We've put enough holes in some of them to make until they're unrecognizable before they finally drop."

Glimmer frowned. "Are…are they developing some sort of immunity or something?" The implications behind that struck deep. Thralls resistant to ignominite would take away their one advantage in ground combat away. The empire had lost every conflict in the first war badly before Taline's sister first discovered the stuff. The idea of regressing to that state of conflict was terrifying.

"I sure as shit hope not," Lonnie said. "I'm just catching you up to speed with what we've experienced so far. We've walked the entire perimeter wall of the compound and there are no thralls anywhere except here, and you're right that they're acting super weird clumping together so tight like this. I don't know why, just like I don't know why they're suddenly harder to kill and I don't know why this damn fog is protecting us, either."

Glimmer 'hmmed' and narrowed her eyes in thought. A breeze blew past, playing at the short strands of her hair just as another ripple of lightning and subtle shake of the ground occurred.

"What is it?" Lonnie stared at her like she might transform into a literal angel in front of her. "You're thinking hard about something, that much I can tell."

"There's something off about this whole situation," Glimmer said. "And I'm not just talking about the thralls. The way everything suddenly shifted as we were taking the city. How no one could tell

what exactly happened that turned the tide against us. And then how quickly everything fell apart from there—it wasn't even a few hours before the infection had engulfed most of the city once we lost it."

Glimmer shook her head, not liking how any of this sounded now that she was speaking her thoughts aloud. "Taline warned me a long time ago about what would happen and what I'd experience if the Beast were ever to directly attempt to subvert me. I've experienced some of that, but…"

Lonnie raised an eyebrow at her. "But…?"

"But some of it seems so different, so far out of left field I can't help but feel there is something else. I've been seeing things. Things that aren't there."

Lonnie snorted. "Yeah, we all have been seeing things. Damn shadows lurking in the corners of your vision. One of them snuck up on one of my guys taking a piss out behind one of the buildings and scared the shit out of him, but they're pretty much harmless."

Glimmer shook her head. "They weren't shadows, Lonnie. I saw visions. Concrete ones, of things that I think have already happened, and of people who are long dead. One of them could see me as if I were there. Talk to me and ask me questions as if I were really there. They could *touch* me."

Now Lonnie looked concerned. She leaned forward and, in a low voice meant to keep her words between them, said, "Are you sure you aren't really an Abomination and just not telling me?"

Glimmer had been so ready to hear whatever secret bit of information Lonnie was about to share that having the rug yanked out from underneath her like that pulled a snort of laughter out of her in response.

"An Abomination would say no," she said, rolling her eyes. "They also wouldn't have told you about Rinne."

“Fair.” Lonnie smirked before growing serious again. “Whatever it is that’s happening, we can figure it out once we get off this planet and somewhere else. Do you have a plan for getting out of here?”

“I might.” Glimmer gestured over the parapet wall to the idling mass below. “Do you have any idea why they might have concentrated here in particular rather than a different part of the wall? You said they weren’t anywhere else.”

“It’s weakest here.” Lonnie pointed to a spot behind Glimmer. “The entrance to the compound is back there, barred shut by a pair of heavy metal doors, but this section of the wall here is weakened structurally. I don’t know how, but they’ve managed to find it and have been occasionally trying to ram through it ever since we holed up in here.”

“They’re trying to ram through a fortified stone wall?” Glimmer asked, feeling all the more incredulous when Lonnie only nodded at her with a serious expression on her face. “Even weakened, you wouldn’t be able to break an entrance without a battering ram of some sort. Why don’t they just climb it? Thralls can’t scale walls with their hands any better than you or I could, but I’ve seen them pile on bodies layer after layer and then climb the mound like a hill. Trying to break through a wall in the first place just doesn’t make sense.”

“Reach over and touch the outside of the wall,” Lonnie said, gesturing toward the edge.

Glimmer wasn’t why Lonnie changed the subject so abruptly. She reached over the edge, expecting one of the thralls to leap up and bite her arm off, and touched her hand to the cool stone.

“You’ve got to be kidding me,” she said, yanking her hand back. “The walls are infused with ignominite, too? These structures are supposed to be ancient. When did they make the additions?”

“This whole compound was converted sometime after the last war to be a fortified storage facility against the Beast in an emergency,” Lonnie said. “The Vestamid, shady as they are, must have put a lot of resources into this area. We never tapped into it before because the threat was honestly so small and our response was so large that fleet command didn’t think it was needed. When things changed—“

“That’s when they decided to use this site to mount a more effective offense,” Glimmer said, understanding where Lonnie was going. “Geez, the cost that must have gone into preparing this is staggering.” As Etherian royalty and a Battlemage with a pay grade that reflected the status of one of the Enclave’s highest-ranked and most valuable combatants, Glimmer was intimately familiar with large sums of money. But even she blanched when she first learned the cost of a pair of high-quality ignominite restraints. Thinking of the cost to infuse a fortified wall that wrapped the entire perimeter of a compound was overwhelming.

“I don’t think about the cost,” Lonnie said, amused at whatever shocked expression had found its way to Glimmer’s face. “I’m just glad it’s kept us from being overrun so far. We’d last ten minutes max once they got through. Maybe not even that.”

Glimmer looked at the soldiers who had been listening to their conversation. There were five of them, including the two who had guarded her when she woke up in the dungeon. All were young. Three had lacerations on their faces and through the plating of their infantry armor, but otherwise seemed battle-ready, if out of their depth and nervous.

“Is this all you have?” Glimmer asked, surprised. “Five?”

“Five plus the two who ran by you with the machine gun earlier,” Lonnie said. “Aside from Rogelio and I, they have the most combat experience so I put them on the heavy repeater in front of the tower. Everyone else either died on impact when we crashed or fell to the thralls before we got inside the compound. Plus the

three I sent outside to grab you when you just appeared. They didn't make it either."

Ah, right. She quashed the guilt roiling in her gut. Lonnie was giving her an appraisal of their situation, not blaming her for deaths that weren't her fault. She had to stay focused—use that information in a sterile, surgical manner. To feel and process guilt was a privilege that would come after they'd escaped, not before. She resolved to ask Lonnie their names once they were safe, at least.

"We have to get out of here," she said instead. "The Beast may be growing immune to the ignominite and its thralls may be growing smart enough to strategize, like a virus adapting after so many years. Kyle said he lost contact with you altogether as soon as the fog started expanding, but we're going to need to get some kind of message to the fleet in order to get out of here. What's going on with your communications?"

Explicit talk of escape caught the soldiers' attention. Hope bloomed on their faces. They looked at one another with subtle smiles, and Lonnie knew to capitalize on it.

"We certainly have better chances of survival now that you're here," she said. "As for communications, we managed to yank the orbital radio from the Warbird when we crashed but haven't gotten anything in or out. As far as we can tell, the fog is blocking all transmissions."

Glimmer eyed her PDA and the blinking icon on the screen; it was still searching for a signal, trying to reconnect her to Kyle. The beginnings of a plan were brewing there, although she still wasn't feeling confident about it. They'd have to do something about the fog dome. A dubious thing to contend with in the first place, but if they managed to disperse it, wouldn't that just expose them to the fleet bombarding the surface?

An ethereal wail drifted up from below, startling everyone as it crescendoed to a chorus of screeches.

“They’re surging again!” one of the soldiers said, staring over the edge of the wall while the others press checked their rifles.

Glimmer had never seen anything like it. The mob of tightly packed thralls weren’t mindlessly scrabbling over one another trying to push forward. Instead, they were rearing back to charge the wall together as if they were one body comprised of hundreds. Like a living battering ram, they slamming into the ignominite-plated bricks with enough force to splatter those at the front of the charge into flying chunks of meat and viscera, spraying the surrounding grass with body matter.

The wall shook hard enough that Glimmer tottered to keep her balance. She could have sworn she heard the sound of the stone itself fracturing. The soldiers aimed their rifles down range over the parapets and fired coordinating bursts into the mob as they reared back for another thrust.

Glimmer felt grateful that the ignominite in their bullets didn’t seem to lose all its efficacy. Sure, they took more than one or two bullets to go down, but they *did* go down. A single thralls was frighteningly strong, and with them acting in coordination? The wall would go down, and sooner rather than later.

Lonnie grabbed onto a parapet to keep from falling over when the thralls impacted a second time. Rogelio grunted and widened his stance, his sidearm already out and ready to fire.

“You said you might have a plan,” Lonnie said to Glimmer. “So that means you’re in charge. I’ll command the troops, but you’re in the driver’s seat. Tell me what you need us to do, and I’ll make it happen.”

Rifles continued to rattle off beside her as Glimmer looked to the tower in the center of the compound. The top looked like an open roof, again with parapets from which to defend.

“We need to get to the top of that tower,” Glimmer said, pointing. “And hold off the thralls long enough for Kyle to get us. I’ll take

care of the fog."

Lonnie nodded and turned to the soldiers. "Change of plans boys," she said, bellowing. "Those fish will jump out of the barrel and slap you dead, so we're leaving. Get your asses to the tower and up to the top floor. Standard defensive formation, three plus me in the back providing cover, the rest up front, and we all move with the Battlemage, clear?" A chorus of 'sir, yes sir!' rang out and Lonnie smirked with a strong gesture of her fist. "Let's go, move, move, move!"

The soldiers pulled off the wall one after the other like synchronized divers. Despite the fear plain on their faces, they moved with the automated professionalism of a team that had drilled scenarios like this enough to instill deep-rooted muscle memory. They encircled her and kept pace as she rushed down the wall, jumping the last four steps as she neared the bottom.

The wall burst as her boots hit dirt. Screeching, clambering thralls spilled into the interior courtyard like water through a crack in a dam.

"Keep going, don't stop!" Lonnie said, grabbing one of the soldiers by the back of their neck guard and pulling them with her when they'd slowed to stare. "Stop and you're dead. Are you trying to die? Remember the others?"

The automatic repeater stood mounted on its tripod before the entrance to the tower, one soldier behind it while the other held the belt of ignominite rounds feeding into it. As soon as Glimmer cleared past them, they opened fire, the sound of controlled automatic fire playing accompaniment to her pounding heart, wheezing gasps, and the sounds of thralls screeching louder as they fell.

"Get inside, all of you!" Lonnie said, throwing open the door and gesturing for everyone to hurry in. She and one other soldier remained as the two on the repeater dragged it back through the mud, continuing to hold off the flood as they eked to their escape.

As soon as Glimmer got in, she heard a scream and a gurgle out from outside. Thralls had caught up to them, piling on top of the gunner who was still firing into the mass as they tore into him.

"Get inside!" Lonnie bellowed, trying to pick them off before retreating with the other soldier inside. "Let it go and get in, both of you!"

The assistant, extra belt of ammo still hung across her shoulders, startled out of the paralysis that had gripped her. She turned, casting only one forlorn look back at her partner as they fell, and she sprinted toward them, thralls hot on her heels. She burst through the open doorway as one of them caught her arm. She screamed and her armor crimped in the thrall's grip, sending a sick cracking sound echoing inside the chamber. The thrall yanked and pulled her off her feet, and began dragging her back outside.

"Let me go!" she said, screaming and kicking at the thing. Rogelio and three others have already pushed the door nearly shut, keeping more thralls from flooding in but unable to fully shut it since it's caught on the arm of the first.

Another sickening crack and another cry as blood started running at the crevices of the soldier's armor, staining the rest of her. Despite two others holding her back, she was slowly getting dragged out.

"I'm sorry for this," Lonnie said, looking into the woman's tear-streaked eyes. She threw her arm out and a wicked, serrated blade extended from her gauntlet. She slashed up, cleaving the woman's arm off above the elbow.

They pulled apart, soldier and thrall, each yanked back from the sudden release. As the soldier tumbled to the ground inside, Rogelio and the others nearly got the door shut until another thrall took the place of the first, wedging itself inside the doorjamb.

“Fucking get *back*,” Lonnie said, voice growling low as she surged forward and stabbed through the opening with her serrated blade. Another screech from outside and now it was Lonnie getting pulled outside instead—her blade had gotten stuck.

Glimmer, healing rune twisting in her palm as she helped cauterize the soldier’s bleeding stump with magic, left here side and went to Lonnie’s with a new rune ready to activate.

“Damn it,” Lonnie said, fumbling for her sidearm and shoving it through the crack in the door, firing four, five, six rounds haphazardly outside. Glimmer was there the next moment, emitting a continuous stream of purple fire from her palm through the same opening. More screeching from the thralls outside, but still Lonnie was stuck.

“To hell with this,” she said, anchoring herself with both feet planted wide. With a jerk of her arm, she broke the blade off, ostensibly still embedded in whichever thrall she’d stabbed. She pulled her arm free, and the door slammed shut the moment it was clear. Glimmer was on it the next moment, casting a large sealing rune over it. The door bumped once, twice, three times as the thralls on the other side tried to break through, but the rune pulsed with light on each bump and held.

“That won’t last long,” Glimmer said, turning back to the group. “If they keep trying to barge in haphazardly it might hold, but as soon as they clump up and start working together again this door will fall. If they can break through the fortified outer wall, nothing here is going to hold them back forever.”

“Then we’d better climb,” Lonnie said. She looked to the wounded soldier. The others had used a belt as a tourniquet to stop the bleeding, and a thick patch of cloth ripped from one of their uniforms covered the stump.

“I can move, too,” they said, sweat pouring down their clammy face. “I can make it. Just…"

Lonnie nodded, holding a hand up to cut her off in a silent command to rest for a few moments.

The thralls continued to bang on the door and Glimmer inspected the ground floor as they got situated. It was bare and musty with a wet feel to the air. Despite it being an ancient structure, bare lightbulbs attached to open wires ran the length of the wall near a spiral staircase and provided their only source of light—all the windows had been boarded up with ignominite-veined metal. There was no furniture, but several black cases lined the floor, filled to the brim with sparkling crystals.

"Are those…those can't be apeirons can they?" Glimmer asked. On instinct, she reached with her mind to touch one and felt the surge of power living within. Taken together, a single case emanated a small star's worth of magical energy just sitting there waiting to be used. And there were dozens of cases sitting there around them.

"I told you this was supposed to be a storage facility," Lonnie said, holding the wounded soldier's head up and dabbing at her sweat-streaked forehead with another strip of cloth she'd ripped from somewhere underneath her armor. "Deep breaths," she said to them. "Come on, stay with me. We aren't out of this yet."

They groaned, skin pale and clammy, but had stopped bleeding all over the floor and all over Lonnie's lap thanks to the tourniquet and cauterization. The door banged again, hard enough the hinges rattled.

"They've already started working together," Glimmer said. "We have to go."

Lonnie and Rogelio helped guide the injured soldier to her feet. She looked ready to pass out one moment until she got her bearings, then Lonnie traded places with another soldier and took up a position with two others at the rear, between Glimmer and the door.

Glimmer took her cue, made for the stairs, and climbed. The others molded and moved with her like a cadre of static electrons. The incessant banging—and soon enough, splintering—sound against the door from behind urged them to hurry the fuck up, and Glimmer balanced that with the need to make sure they didn't push the injured soldier to the point of collapse. Rogelio didn't have a second arm with which to carry them comfortably, and throwing them over his shoulder like a sack of potatoes probably wasn't safe either.

Glimmer was on the same page with Lonnie about that one: they were all getting out alive if she could help it. The ones left still left breathing, at least.

They got to the second level—it too filled with chests brimming with apeirons—when the door burst. The sound of it rang up from the ground floor. Glimmer and Lonnie exchanged knowing looks while the grunts at the front whined in shock. The sound of thralls flooding the lower levels roared up at them like a fast-approaching torrential flood.

"Keep going!" Lonnie barked the orders to those at the front. "Don't stop and don't look back!"

Glimmer pushed magic to her hands. The thralls were close enough their screeching and scrambling was deafening. Lonnie and those with her at the back rattled off burst fire. Glimmer spun and held out both hands, eyes flaring neon as a large rune rotated before her palms. The rune pulsed and a stream of unbroken white-hot magic streaked past the back line and blasted the thralls surging up the stairs.

"The war engineers had the right idea fortifying this place," Lonnie said. Advancing backward up the stairs without missing a step, she put three rounds into one thrall then kicked another down the stairs when it got too close. It fell back, taking a handful of its peers with it as it tumbled down. "It's contained and the stairs are narrow, but that makes it easier to defend since we have the high ground."

That was probably the only reason they'd made it this far without getting caught, honestly. Glimmer used the confined space to better augment her magical attacks. She planted flame runes on the walls and ceiling overhead, stuck stasis runes on the stairsteps underneath, and blasted lightning at a clumped-up wall of thralls impossible to miss. They'd get caught in the stasis, too slow to get out of the way while the flame runes next to and above them burned them to a crisp.

All they were doing was buying time. Time to survive just a few more seconds. Time to get up to the top of the tower in a final bid for rescue. Time that was quickly running out.

The thralls had only one goal, and that was to get to them. Shoving disabled or debilitated brothers and sisters off the stairs, or even grabbing them and tossing them toward Glimmer and Lonnie in an attempt to strike them, all of it was fair game. They didn't fight like traditional, rational combatants. They didn't even care for their own safety.

It was almost a surprise when they got to the top level. As soon as they burst through, every soldier in the group threw grenades back through the doorway. They exploded as the last of Glimmer's stasis and fire runes went off. Competing against the shockwave looking to escape the interior was a challenge, and Glimmer twined six consecutive runes on the door to hold it for as long as possible, making sure to reinforce the hinges and stonework surrounding the opening, too.

Lonnie was back at the injured soldier's side, lowering her to the ground against a nearby parapet with Rogelio's assistance. She was still conscious, if not clammier and more soaked through with sweat than before. Glimmer guessed it wouldn't be long before she went into shock.

Everyone else took a defensive position while she got situated, holding lines of sight that would allow all of them to cover the door with overwhelming crossfire as soon as the first thralls burst through. The door slammed from the inside. It was only a matter

of time, and once the thralls got through again, there was nowhere else to go. Glimmer had to end this now.

Using so much magic earlier—the teleportation spell, the runes up the turret, clearing the fog the first time—drained her already. She couldn't let up. Not when they were so close. She stumbled to the center of the rooftop and stared up at the fog dome overhead.

She centered herself and stretched her mind. The surging mass of thralls was there past the door—she could feel them. They reached down the tower and surrounded the whole compound. She could also feel the chests upon chests of apeirons inside the tower, too. So many of them, it was like a constellation of stable suns ready and waiting for release, twined within the tower like a central core.

Using them would be crazy. Hell, feeling *around* the stockpile was risky enough, like feeling around a floor laden with shattered glass in the dark, barefoot. But then again, she rationalized that what she was about to attempt with the Beast was even riskier.

"Hold onto this," she said, yanking her PDA off her arm and handing it to Lonnie when she came over. "I might not have it in me to even speak once I've started, so you'll have to talk to Kyle or whoever is on the other end of that line once the signal connects."

Lonnie took it from her. She glanced at the screen and at the blinking icon still searching for a signal with a frown. Glimmer pulled some of the magic from the apeiron stockpiles, drawing it out like a nervous seamstress might unspool radioactive twine from a coil.

Someone had plunged a syringe of adrenaline into her. That was the only explanation for how lit on fire she felt the moment she took from the reserve—and so little of it, too. Cold electricity danced and arced in ribbons across her body, and every hair on her body stood on end.

*No*, she thought, stuffing the energy back inside when it pooled at two points inside her shoulder blades and started to spill out from there. *Not here*. *Not yet.* She had to use as much of it as she could. Channeling this much power without properly radiating the excess was mortally dangerous, but she'd only get one shot at this and it had to count.

Lonnie's eyes went wide at the display. Glimmer looked down at her hands and her body; she glowed with such concentrated magic the aura itself was almost fully opaque. When she felt as if holding the magic in even a moment longer made her liable to explode, Glimmer dug her heels into the stone underfoot and threw an open palm up as if to push away the sky.

Power exploded from her palm. A beam of energy wider than she was tall shot forth. It hit the dome with a heady impact that rattled her bones, pulled her mind from her body, and had her touching something impossibly large and violent.

Despite knowing what she was doing—despite anticipating what she'd meet—she recoiled in horror when the rest of her caught up to her rational mind and realized what she'd done:

The figure before her was massive and ponderous. Like a mountain that had taken notice of a singular ant crawling upon its surface, it turned to regard Glimmer, pushing the weight of its full attention onto her.

She had touched the Beast.

# Tower of Liberation

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Lonnie was still there next to her; Glimmer was certain of that much despite seeing nothing except the Beast in the blue. The pounding of the thralls against a reinforced door, countless thousands of individual threads of magic leading from each apeiron in its stash to her as she drew them in, and a gargantuan monster before her in her mental mindscape, but Lonnie was there. She called Glimmers name, and her voice came muffled from above water.

"Hey, can you hear me?" she asked, shouting to be heard against an alien damper. "What's going on?"

She tugged at Glimmer's shoulder and yanked her hand away with an expression of pain. Bristling with magic as Glimmer was, touching her was tantamount to touching an open flame—Lonnie had singed her hand.

Glimmer couldn't warn her not to touch her again. That *thing* in front of her was all encompassing and it was taking more than she had to give just to keep from losing herself in abject panic. Maintaining the gargantuan flow of magic through her body was the only thing keeping her whole at this point—a warning shot across the bow to the Abomination not to come any closer, or else. It loomed before her in her mind, massive and pondering, and Glimmer had no doubt in her mind if it called her bluff and advanced anyway, she'd crumble.

And in the midst of this, a memory came unbidden to her. A memory of her mother.

*A sailor rowed the seas in a tiny boat,* Angella said to her, voice reaching through time and space to once more tell a story she used read to Glimmer before bedtime. *He rowed to an island in*

*the distance. Only, as he drew closer, he realized it was not an island at all he was rowing to, but the back of an enormous creature, the rest of it floating hidden under the water's surface.*

Glimmer remembered how that story terrified her when she was young and how she loved it all the more because of it. Now, she was that sailor, having dived from that boat and into the water. There was nothing but deep blue surrounding her. No light from the sun broke through the surface to her, and the Beast was the island monster—fog dome the island visible above the surface, and the rest of it visible to her now only because she'd left her earthly vessel to look upon it.

Oh, what a mistake that decision was.

The Beast was large enough it could swallow her whole and not even realize it. She was a speck floating in a vast nothingness—an intruder in its realm. She could no better confront it than a finless swimmer could outmaneuver a shark hunting by the smell of blood.

*Have you had enough?* a voice in her mind—hers and not hers—asked. *Let go. Let go, and every problem in the world shall fade away.*

She'd thought herself nearly enthralled before when she was lost in the fog. Now that it appeared before her, its attempts to ensnare her again were both harder to fight off and easier to direct her efforts toward.

"Begone!" she said, angling her chin up as if to look down upon it from below. "Leave this world!"

Fuck, was she even doing this right? Taline had told her once, when Glimmer had asked, that the Shapers of the Daiamid could vanquish an awakened Abomination in a contest of wills, overpowering it with sheer determination to 'eat' them, as they would apparently describe it. They were the only ones capable, as far as Taline knew. Everyone else, including the most

accomplished of Enclave Battlemages, needed several dreadnoughts hammering the infected planet from space, and not even that was a guarantee of victory.

The Beast shifted in their shared mind-space, expanding like a great squid, posturing and encircling her. Glimmer, vaguely aware of fighting and yelling and the firing of ignominite bullets from rifles all about her on the physical plane, reached further into the stores of apeiron crystals littering the keep and held her ground as the Beast redoubled its efforts on her.

Their surroundings shifted. The Beast subsided, its presence diminishing to a thrum in the background as the endless blue of the 'ocean' fell away. To Glimmer's surprise, the tower and surrounding castle district came back into focus. Lonnie, Rogelio, the other soldiers, the thralls, all of them were missing—she'd been returned somehow to the physical plane without them.

There was no great dome of fog obstructing her view anymore either. Instead, Scavria itself and the surrounding city of Tir stretched around her in its glory. Great spires and skyscrapers circled her like trees of a great redwood forest. Vehicles soared through the air in neatly patterned lines at different elevations. The setting sun reflected off both the glass windows of many of the buildings and against the snow of the holy mountains acting as backdrop.

Voices carried up from below and Glimmer rushed to the parapet edge to peer down. Dozens of individuals of various races, including Scavrian, wandered about the compound. Some looked at maps held out at arms-length as they walked; others pushed children in strollers. Some walked backward talking to groups that followed in their wake: tour guides, expounding upon the history of the 'old castle district.'

One person in the crowd caught her attention immediately, and from there, everything fell apart.

Her dad walked among the others. His eyes sparkled as they cast every which direction, seemingly trying to take the entirety of the area in altogether. That alone would have been enough to shatter Glimmer, but then she noticed Adora walking next to him, grinning. She seemed so carefree, so light, and so unlike the Adora she'd seen only a handful of weeks earlier through the ansible, begging for any scraps of information on the Daiamid Glimmer had been unable to dig up for her to begin with.

"It's too bad Catra wanted to stay behind for this trip," she heard Adora say before turning to a burgundy cat-shaped being padding alongside her. "You'll have tons of bragging rights about this place when we get back, that's for sure."

Glimmer recognized the thing Adora was speaking to, especially by its ephemeral mane and stark blue eyes. Krytis had been taken over by the Beast early in the first war. Taline, emboldened by the trust the war council had placed in her, had elected not to save the planet. *A devastating sacrifice*, Taline had written in her official report on the matter, leaving no Krytians left in the galaxy. They were all extinct. The fact Glimmer was seeing one right in front of her…

"These are lies!"

She spun back around and planted her feet. The Beast was still there, slinking in the background and almost imperceptible behind the illusion. The illusion fell away at her declaration and she was back in the endless blue. She wouldn't allow the Beast to distract her, that's how you got lost. And so, she resolved to face it head on, never blinking, until one of them burned out entirely.

Glimmer pulled enough magic into her she felt she'd sooner explode and demolish the whole keep, defendants included, before her standoff with the Beast would conclude. It reared up like a tidal wave, growing larger, looming higher, *advancing on her.*

Moments before the Beast  struck, the scene shifted once again. She was in a room, now. The same room she'd witnessed before

waking up chained to the ground in a cell. Whereas back then, Taline was standing at the window bathed in moonlight and looking out at the night view, now rays from an alien sunrise flooded through the window blinds and illuminated the room.

Deep red was splattered across near every surface of the room. Glimmer had watched a live art show once, where an abstract painting came to life as a nameless artist threw gallons of paint on wall-sized canvases. The room looked much like those canvases had, except Glimmer had a feeling someone had been turned inside out to supply the paint.

The furniture lay in splintered pieces, most scattered across the floor but some embedded in the walls. A chunk of the granite dining table had broken off, likely ground to dust judging by the dust covering every surface that wasn't already covered with blood. Glimmer spotted  a body—the man who'd come to visit Taline in the earlier vision—bisected at mid-chest, laying in two opposite corners. Taline herself was slumped against the far corner, a cloth stained red in her grip-less fingers as she pulled in shallow raspy breaths.

"Gods above," a shaky voice cried out from behind. Evelyn ran past before Glimmer could react, sliding to a stop and dropping to her knees beside Taline. "What the fuck happened to you?"

Glimmer had no idea where the Beast had gone—she could no longer feel it in the background of this vision like she could in the other. Something told her this wasn't something the Beast was throwing up in front of her as a distraction. This was different, somehow.

"Get your ass in here!" Evelyn said, shouting over her shoulder at someone Glimmer hadn't yet seen. "She needs our help!"

Corynth swept through the door and strode to them with quick steps. Glimmer followed, keeping silent. Evelyn looked on the edge of hysteria as he knelt too, concern clear on his face despite the calm in his movements.

“There’s so much fucking blood, just…everywhere. Oh my god,” Evelyn said.

“It’s not all hers,” Corynth pressed two fingers to feel for Taline’s pulse at her neck. It was obvious she was still alive, judging from the breathing, so then why would he need to check? “Her pulse is weak,” he said after a moment.

“Even losing half this amount would be a death sentence. Can you heal her? Please tell me you can heal her.”

Corynth shook his head. “She already tried to heal herself. I can’t.”

“But she’s fucking horrible at healing runes! Why would she try and do this herself?”

Glimmer didn’t know why the statement surprised her. Maybe it was the gravity of the situation. It was common knowledge Taline was the worst at healing, but Glimmer had only reckoned with that fact in a humorous light, before. The great Seraph of Archanas being criminally bad at even simple healing spells did have its comedy, but now it seemed blasphemous considering Evelyn’s panic and Corynth’s hard-fought rationality.

“I don’t think she had a choice,” Corynth said. “She did what she had to.”

“And you’re here now, you you can do something. Help her.”

He shook his head. “It’s not that simple.”

“Yes, it is. Set bone wrong, you break and reset it so it heals right. This is no different.”

“It’s very different. She’s liable to slip into shock if I interfere—its worse than resetting a bone. Magic has its consequences, especially when it comes to me.”

“Then what the hell do we do? Should paramedics even move her if it’s that serious? Should healers, if they even get here in time?

You have to be able to do *something*."

Corynth reached out and placed a hand over Taline's bloody head, pressing his thumb to her forehead and two fingers to her temple. His eyes glowed and faint circuit lines of magic appeared, creeping up the stiff standing collar of his Enclave uniform. The tension in Taline's face relaxed, and her breathing came easier.

"She'll wake in a moment," he said. "It won't be pleasant for her, but it's the best I can do. We don't want her unconscious." He turned to Evelyn and said, "Did you know this was going to happen? The guards outside are gone too, I checked. Did you already see this coming?"

"I told you already, I only see what happened in the past, not the future. I've tried but…it's fuzzy. I didn't see this at all." She gripped the fabric of her pants. To Glimmer, she looked almost guiltys. "I didn't know this was going to happen."

Taline stirred, coughing hard enough she doubled over. Corynth had stopped glowing, stopped whatever he had been doing to help wake her up, and instead rubbed circles over her back to ease her through the spasms. Taline moaned when the coughing subsided, and Corynth and Evelyn both eased her back against the wall.

"You came," she said, eyes wandering lazy and unfocused between him and Evelyn. "How long have I been…?"

"Long enough the fight had already finished before we got within earshot," Corynth said. "We found you like this."

Taline hummed something noncommittal, blinking slow. "Tried to fix myself up. Don't think it helped any…" Her eyes slipped shut and she started to lean into Corynth, nodding off.

"Hey, hey, you can't do that." Corynth shook her back to consciousness, although it looked like it pained him to do so almost as much as it pained Taline to endure it. "I need you need

to stay awake long enough for the medics to get here." He glanced around the room, taking in the gore. "What happened?"

"He…he came for me"—a sharp intake of breath—"Was wearing a mask."

Taline's pupils dilated and constricted seemingly at random as she followed Corynth in taking in the room. Clarity and focus returned to her eyes, and with that clarity, rage and anguish came as well.

"He said he was a member of the Daiamid. That he'd come to welcome me into their ranks because of what happened on Archanas."

Corynth's and Evelyn exchanged a look. An understanding passed between them, Glimmer could tell, but Taline seemed to interpret it differently.

"I swear I'm telling the truth," she said to them both. "They're real, I swear  it. The Daiamid—"

Corynth squeezed her shoulders. "I'm not sure if—"

"He told me about what happened to the La Valettes. He…he could do what I can. He could cast magic without needing any runes. The ley lines…they w ere on his body. The Daiamid are real."

Desperation tinged her voice as tears ran ruddy streaks down her face. Corynth and Evelyn's expressions shifted from apprehension to concern.

"They're going to kill me," Taline said, voice breaking. It was the most scared Glimmer had ever heard her sound, and it broke something inside her at hearing it, too. "I refused their offer. And when he threatened to…I killed him when he…" She swallowed and shook her head. "They won't let this go. They will come for me. I'm next."

“Tal, no.” Corynth wiped her tears before guiding her into the crook of his neck. “They won’t come. And if they do, they aren’t going to get you.”

“You don’t know  that,” she said, voice muffled against his body. “I denied the Beast itself when it came for me, yet that man—that Shaper—nearly destroyed me. Are they all like this? No one stands a chance if they’re all like this. It’s no wonder the emperor has remained in power this long if they are yet another arm of his power.”

Corynth and Evelyn exchanged another look while Corynth worked his hands to smooth over Taline’s shaking shoulders. This time, Glimmer could almost read the message they passed between them.

*Are you going to tell her? About you?*

Corynth set his jaw, giving his answer. He peeled Taline off him as gently as one would replace a burn victim’s dressings and looked her in the eyes.

“Nothing will happen to you, I promise. As difficult as it was to endure, do you know how many other people are alive today after experiencing what you did on Archanas? How many people are still sane?”

Taline swallowed and said in a low, almost whispered voice, “Just you.”

Corynth laughed. “Well, the jury’s still out on my sanity, but I am still alive, I’ll give you that. But you’re right. Out of everyone the Beast  has ever touched, it’s just us that are still ourselves. The Daiamid may be real and they may be mad enough you killed one of their own to retaliate, but you *killed* them, Tal. In single combat. From one singular exposure to the Beast, you triumphed over folklore.”

“There will be others.”

"And how many times do you think I've opened myself up to the thing by now, guiding Evie in her research?"

"Too many to count." Taline still mumbled the words, but Glimmer could tell Corynth's logic was  having an effect.

"You're damn right." Corynth's smile looked more encouraging than proud. "They aren't going to get you because you aren't going to let them, and neither will I." He squeezed her shoulders again and wiped more tears away with his thumbs. "No harm will come to you. If I have to stand up and declare war upon the emperor himself and all his secret assassins in the shadows then I will, but no harm will come to you. I promise."

Evelyn looked uncertain and apprehensive. Glimmer could almost hear her wondering how this would play out in her head.

The vision froze. It wasn't obvious at first, especially since the room had been so still already, but Glimmer got the sense that whatever she'd been brought here to witness had fully played out. That's why it was an especially great shock when Evelyn then turned her head, looked straight at her with a fire in her eyes, and said, "Seen enough? Are you enjoying traipsing through my memories behind my back as I'm trying to work?"

Glimmer yelped and scrabbled backward, only succeeding in landing flat on her ass in her attempt to get away.

Evelyn pursed her lips. "I swear. Hundreds of trips all across the galaxy to all sorts of different people and I have no issues when I speak to them of the Beast and who will emerge to save them, but *you* somehow go digging into things all on your own when I'm not paying attention."

This Evelyn was different from the one kneeling stricken with Corynth at Taline's side. This Evelyn looked older and wiser, but it wasn't additional lines on her face or sag in her skin that gave that impression. No, it was her eyes. To Glimmer, those eyes gave the impression they had seen much, *much* more than the eyes of

the version of Evelyn she'd met in the other visions. Behind the fires of irritation  that sparkled in her irises, there was a serene, aloof, borderline cold nature to them in their gaze. Almost like she'd lost her empathy.

"Why am I seeing these things?" Glimmer asked, getting to her feet and trying to wrest enough confidence to at least sound authoritative in front of this ghost of a woman. "Why are you showing them to me?"

"I'm not showing you anything." Evelyn peeled her gaze away and looked over at Corynth and Taline, still embracing and frozen in the memory. "You've gone looking all on your own, like I said, and at things I'd truly do not wish to revisit at this current time. Or ever again."

She gave a sharp flick of her wrist and the vision dispersed. They were back in the blue ocean mind-space from before, and the Beast was gone.

"Is this you?" Glimmer asked, horror creeping up on her at the thought. "Are you the Abomination?"

Evie raised both eyebrows at her, like a detached empress looking upon a servant who had done something particularly stupid. "Really?" she asked.

Glimmer scrunched up her nose and reached with her mind again. False alarm. The Beast was still there after all, in recessed corners. Evelyn wasn't the Abomination, but then why she was here now in the foreground?

"The creature had grown powerful enough it made short work of the remaining forces in the city," Evelyn said. "They stood no chance."

"But that doesn't explain this," Glimmer said, gesturing to her and their shared surroundings. "How are you here? *Why* are you here?"

“Someone has to keep you and your friends from succumbing to its influence.” The Beast surged in the background, fighting against invisible restraints before quieting down again. Evelyn side eyed it. “Just like someone had to keep that fleet in orbit from turning you all into space dust.”

Keep from succumbing? Protect from the fleet? Was she implying *she* was the one maintaining the protective fog dome over them?

“Why?” Glimmer asked, when she could think of no way to broach the myriad of more complicated questions she had. “Why are you protecting us?”

Evelyn tilted her head to the side and looked at Glimmer like the question made no sense. “Because you are needed.”

As if that made any sense. “So, where are you right now, exactly? In the past? Taline said you couldn’t cast magic to save your life, and that you couldn’t see into the future, only the past.”

“I couldn’t see *well* into the future,” Evelyn said, holding up a finger to correct her. “At least, not when her and I were still able to speak to one another. I’d had enough prescience to warn of Etheria’s imminent coming, after all.” She shrugged. “As for how I can do this? Use the Beast to traverse time and space a few hundred times yourself and you’ll become a natural, too, although without the kind of chaperone I had it might take longer.”

Glimmer had no idea what she meant by a chaperone, but she got the hint: the Beast had changed Evelyn beyond what even Taline had recognized. “You travelled forward in time to protect my team and I because ‘we’re needed’? Is that really it?”

“Don’t flatter yourself too much, now,” Evelyn said, shooting Glimmer a smirk that made her flush with indignation. “There are many pieces on the board—pieces I’ve been moving since long before the endgame you’ve now crossed into. Compared to some whose strings I’ve pulled, you are largely untouched.”

“Strings?”

“The Vestamid call me their Goddess. For as much as I’ve influenced their inception and subsequent devotion to Corynth, I find I cannot fault them for the name. I just pray you don’t take it up yourself.”

Glimmer knew exactly what Evelyn was telling her. *She* was the creator of the Vestamid. Visions—vivid ones—came then. Visions of Evelyn, still alive over a decade in the past during the apex of the first Beast war, traversing forward and backwards in time, prophesizing to future bishops and cardinals and priests of the coming of a great evil, of Corynth, and of his ultimate triumph on Archanas. One of the most powerful organized religious cults in the history of the empire had sprung up near overnight because of her—their Goddess.

As awestruck by the revelation as she was, Glimmer held steadfast to her pride and pragmatism. She stuck her chin up a little higher and said, “Goddess is a bit much, and I have little patience for flattery, both given and received. Tell me how to kill the Abomination. You’re able to hold it back, you must know how to destroy it so I and my team can get off this planet.”

“You won’t be able to kill it,” Evelyn said. “Not even together do we have the strength to do that, but you have already broken its stranglehold over this area.”

“What?” Glimmer frowned. “I have?” She reached out with her mind again and found…nothing. There was nothing there in the blue except her and Evelyn. The Beast was gone—fled to less contested parts of Scavria it could corrupt without challenge.

“I could only hold it at bay for you, and even that took a toll,” Evelyn said. Only then did Glimmer notice she looked stretched thin. “You’ve been actively pushing it out since you first touched it, even pushing into my own memories. Taline did a wonderful job teaching you, but you are extraordinary in your own right. To lose you here would be…”

She trailed off and shook her head. Their surroundings started to pull away, as did she, and Glimmer got the feeling she was being returned to the physical plane. The contours and outlines of the keep top came back, as did the figures of Lonnie, Rogelio, and the other soldiers she'd been with.

"Be careful on your way out," Evelyn said. She seemed so far away all of a sudden. "The Abomination had fully awoken before you took care of it. That is still a dangerous thing, even with my blessing."

Glimmer didn't want to leave, not yet. She had so many questions. She didn't want to step back into a raging battlefield with the cards still stacked against them, rolling a pair of dice to see if they'd make it out alive or not.

Reality reasserted itself and Glimmer killed the firehose of magic she'd been funneling through her body and up her arm. The enormous beam of energy she'd aimed at the sky dissipated and she fell to the cobblestone underfoot. Lonnie was at her side the moment her knees hit the stone, hooking under her arms and hauling her back to her feet.

"Kyle!" Lonnie's voice rang loud, head craned as she shouted into the PDA embedded in her gauntlet as she kept Glimmer upright. "We need an immediate evac, now!"

Someone, probably Kyle, responded, though Glimmer couldn't make out the words through the buzzing in her ears. She shook her head to clear it and pulled away from Lonnie.

"You broke us through!" Glee and awe were mixed in equal measures on her face. "I think hearing from us so suddenly nearly gave him a heart attack, but he's on his way. He'll be here within minutes."

Glimmer looked up. She hadn't fully rid them of the Beast, of course, but she'd indeed broken its hold over the area like Evelyn had said: a hole in the fog dome overhead had appeared—large

enough she could see it was night, the stars overhead twinkling amongst the fleet bombarding the planet.

Good. Now they only had to hold out long enough for Kyle to arrive. Glimmer had no idea how long she'd been immersed in that separate mental plane, but judging from the fact they hadn't been overwhelmed and killed by a horde of thralls in the interim, they could probably make it. Surveying the top of the keep to gauge how the fighting so far had gone, however, had only sparked more questions.

Dozens of inert thralls lay strewn around them, the stone underfoot slick with their blood. At the opposite end of the keep, dozens more still-alive thralls stood idle, just inside the doorway to the turret chamber, staring out at them with glassy eyes.

"We barely kept the first few waves back," Lonnie said. "I was starting to get nervous, then they all just stopped. They've been like this for a little bit now."

Rogelio, still missing his arm, was squatting down nearby, helping tend to the soldier whose arm Lonnie cut off in their retreat. There was something poetic about it that Glimmer couldn't voice aloud even if she'd had the time and wherewithal to try. The looks of nervous agitation and full-blown terror on the other soldiers kept her grounded.

Their survival hinged on whether or not the thralls decided to surge for them once more. With no clear understanding of why they stopped in the first place, no one could say what would spur them to attack again, and it was the uncertainty of it all that was the worst. Was it because she had helped break the Abomination's hold over this place?

The thralls pulled back into the shadows, glassy eyes like muted fireflies against the dark. A rhythmic sound came from beyond the doorway. *Thump, thump, thumped*, it grew louder until it shook the foundations of the keep. Something was coming.

The stones framing the doorway exploded out, raining dust and debris around them. A hulking monstrosity, three heads taller than any of the thralls, stepped through.

“What the fuck is that thing?” Lonnie asked, aiming her rifle at it and yelling at her squad to do the same when they stood dumbstruck, slack-jawed, and frozen.

Glimmer had only seen them once before, on Rinne. It had been far away, one amongst many of its lesser thrall cousins, but it was enough for Glimmer to heed Taline’s advice and leave immediately. Now another one stood barely twenty feet away: an amorphous, constantly shifting mass of pure Beast matter, formed into the viscera and striated muscles of an eight-foot-tall killing machine.

“It’s a Beast Trooper,” Glimmer said.

Even with half a dozen rifles pointed at the thing, Glimmer wasn’t keen on their odds for survival. She almost preferred the thralls rushed them, instead. Magic flared to life at her fingertips.

“Stay in as tight of a formation as you can,” she said. “As soon I unbalance it, we need to keep it off balance. We won’t win, but if we can hold out long enough for Kyle to get here, we might stand a chance at escaping.”

The Trooper struck before any could respond. It lunged, throwing an arm out as if to grab them, and that arm elongated and twisted through the air as it lanced across the distance toward them like a missile.

Glimmer threw up both hands high and wide. A purple shield manifested wide enough to cover the whole team. The Trooper’s arm crashed into the shield, sending spiderweb cracks fracturing out from the impact like electricity through a block of wood. As soon as it struck, Glimmer condensed the shield into an unbreakable cuff wrapped around the arm that anchored it in place.

Lonnie shouted a set of sharp commands. Glimmer gritted her teeth, straining as the Trooper pulled against the cuff. The soldiers split into two groups, scrambling out from behind her, a clumsier imitation of the same maneuvering she saw Salas' own mages make when attending to him personally. Her soldiers flanked, pelting the Trooper it with a continuous stream of alternating burst-fire on either side.

As inspiring as it was to see them act, none of their attacks seemed to have any effect. A note of warning sounded off in Glimmer's head, a shot across the bow, then the Trooper destabilized. Instead of trying to pull its arm free, its body dissolved, tracing along the line its extended limb cut across the rooftop. It reformed directly in front of Glimmer and would have used its inertia to follow through and shoulder Glimmer hard enough she flew off the building, except she released her hold on its arm and reform a shield once more at the last moment.

The Trooper's body struck the shield with such force it shattered and sent Glimmer flying backward anway. Instead of flying off the building, she crashed into a parapet at the far end, landing in a slump on the ground next to the injured soldier, panicked and pale.

The world spun and Glimmer's couldn't make sense of her surroundings until she forced herself to her feet. The Trooper picked one of the flanking teams and advanced on them, cutting a soldier in half with an arm it had transformed into a scythe and spearing another through their chest plate with extrusions that shot forth from its abdomen like a spike trap.

The final soldier in the group had abandoned their weapon entirely and turned to flee. The Trooper's entire central body cavity opened up like a gaping sideways mouth, revealing dozens of flailing tentacles inside. The tendrils shot forward, ensnaring the soldier, wrapping around their arms and their legs, chest, and even their neck. They struggled, screaming as they were dragged them backward and swallowed whole.

The screaming ceased, and the Trooper turned to Lonnie, Rogelio, and the last remaining handful of soldiers still alive.

Evelyn had warned her not to let her guard down—that the Abomination and its forces were still dangerous despite having broken its hold and driven it from this place. This was what she must have meant. Beast Troopers had been so controversial and damaging to troop morale during the last war that once the war had ended, their mere existence had been heavily censored. That's how Taline had explained it to her, at least.

*I myself would be hard pressed to take even one singular Trooper down, and I'd need a partner to even attempt it*, she'd said in the past, trying to impress upon Glimmer just how impossible it was to face one. *There's a spot at their back where they have a weakness. A small spot that doesn't morph or change like they do. If you can get behind it long enough to hit it with a blow, you might be able to harm it. Either that or overwhelm it with enough continuous, concentrated firepower it can't act.*

Glimmer gestured with a hand crackling with fresh magic. A line of sequential runes along the ground formed, running in an arc along the ground from her current position, past the remaining survivors, terminating at a spot behind the Trooper. She sucked in a breath and released.

Ice flooded her veins. Her body felt as if someone had scooped water from a frozen lake and dumped it on her. At the same instant, she surged forward, carving along the line of runes as if propelled on skates. When she crested the final rune in the sequence, time resumed its normal flow, and she'd emerged at the Trooper's back with only a split second after drawing the path in the first place.

She pushed more magic to her hands again, tracing the pattern for a fire spell with quick fingers. The weak point at the Trooper's back was small, but it was there, she saw it. Just as the spell finished—and not even a full two seconds after she'd emerged behind it—the Trooper spun around and grabbed her. Its hand

was large enough the fingers wrapped around her torso and met at the small of her back. It lifted her off the ground with seemingly no effort before roaring at her, its shapeless head splitting open in six distinct flaps and revealing several rows of teeth deep in its new orifice.

The army of thralls that had receded from view before the Trooper's arrival surged through the demolished turret and onto the top of the keep. Even if Glimmer could somehow get free before the Trooper killed her, she wouldn't be able to make a second attempt at its weak spot with the hundreds of thralls now coming to its aid. The team wouldn't be able to hold out for very long against them either, even if Glimmer somehow monopolized the Trooper's full attention.

That only gave her one last option, according to Taline's advice long ago: overwhelm it with enough firepower it couldn't kill you.

Hundreds of munitions chests full to bursting with charged apeiron crystals still lay in the keep. What Glimmer had drawn out to bolster her in her confrontation with the Abomination had barely dented the store, at least according to her cursory feel of the stockpile with her mind.

She reached forth once more and overloaded every crystal she could feel, grabbing every chest and every apeiron within them in in the levels below, shattering all of them.

From there, Glimmer knew she had split seconds to act. She hadn't drawn the power into herself either; that would have taken too long what with how dire things were. She'd instead released their contents uncontrolled to the world, and if she didn't step in immediately to guide how that energy was released, the resulting discharge would blow up more than just the thralls and the Trooper.

Glimmer released her wings.

Again, just for a moment. It was so quick, Lonnie and Rogelio probably wouldn't have seen them even if they were staring right at her, but holy hellfire did they burn, especially since she didn't have the reserve that would have made it safe to do. Venting an enormous amount of magic from her body without having an enormous amount of magic to draw upon to begin with was a stupid thing to do, but she'd done more than enough stupid things coming here in the first place—what was one more?

The Trooper's limb encasing her minced into a hundred different pieces and the creature roared. Glimmer dropped to the floor with the chunks of rent flesh. The pieces destabilized and coalesced, pieces attempting to reform into the whole. Glimmer used the handful of seconds she was free of its grasp to reach for the magic she felt exploding in the keep, reaching for the uncontrolled maelstrom of power flowing the only direction it could: up to them.

Flames as hot as a sun barreled through the wrecked turret tower leading up to the top of the keep. Like a great serpentine dragon it slithered, shooting into the air and then crashing down to the stones underfoot, writhing along and swallowing every thrall in its path. Hellfire of an unimaginable power, and Glimmer was trying to influence its motion. She felt like a lone sentry trying to divert a river with nothing but her hands.

The Trooper had finished reforming its hand before Glimmer could get all of the thralls. It rounded on her, forming its other limb into a scythe again, poised to cut her in two.

Rogelio barreled into it from the side, knocking it off balance. It stumble to the side, then planted its foot and torqued to swing the same moment Glimmer ducked. It's blade arm missed her by a hair-length, and Glimmer somehow managed to maintain control of the energy.

Finally, with the last thrall burned to a crisp, she turned the giant fire snake on the Trooper. It shot up in the air once more and, just

as both she and Rogelio rolled free, crashed down, swallowing the Trooper in a continuous inferno.

Even though they had distanced themselves enough to not get caught in the flames, they were hot enough Glimmer was certain her skin would blister within the hour. Rogelio had a gash on his leg, probably sustained while they were fighting off the first wave of thralls. Glimmer helped support him back to where Lonnie, two other soldiers, and the one with the amputated arm were waiting for them.

"Did you just kill that thing?" Lonnie asked. She hadn't lowered her rifle, and it was still pointed at the flame-snake-turned-pillar-of-fire at the other end of the keep.

"At the very least I slowed it down," Glimmer said. "That should keep it busy for as long as the power in those apeirons last. And there were a fuck-ton in those crates so I'd imagine it will last until Kyle manages to—"

Another roar—one familiar enough now it sent a shiver down Glimmer's spine—came from the flames and the Trooper stepped out of it, nearly unscathed.

"Fuck me," Lonnie said. She was out of breath, but racked the slide of her rifle and aimed down the sights as if this were just another routine training exercise.

Glimmer had no more tricks up her sleeve. She'd unleashed an entire military compound's worth of stored magical energy on the creature and it barely stalled it for a few seconds. The thralls were gone, sure, but she was running on empty. That last attack had been their best shot.

The Trooper took another step toward them when a hole the size of Glimmer's head appeared in its chest, flinging it backward with the force of the impact. Glimmer, shocked, glanced over at Lonnie. Lonnie, who looked equally as shocked, looked at her rifle.

"I hadn't fired anything yet," she said.

The squeal of stellar engines roared overhead as a figure burst through the small hole in the fog dome. Kyle's Warbird screamed toward them, then banked hard and strafed, tracing a perfect circle in line with the perimeter of the rooftop as the gimbal gun on the nose of the craft fired endlessly at the Trooper.

Glimmer, Lonnie, and the others covered their ears. Rogelio and the injured soldier tried their best with their one arm. Within moments, the massive-caliber bullets from the warbird had loosed and kicked up enough rock and dust they couldn't even see the silhouette of the Trooper anymore, although Glimmer had no doubt it was getting cut down faster than it could regenerate. And then, when Kyle seemingly deemed his efforts effective enough, he strafed another lap around until he was hovering just off the edge of the parapets closest to them.

The bay doors to the troop hold slid open, and Kyle yelled at them to 'hurry the fuck inside' from the cockpit.

Glimmer helped Rogelio grab the injured soldier under the arms and haul them inside. Just as Lonnie cleared the threshold—the last inside. Just as the doors closed and they pulled away, Glimmer saw the Trooper once again emerge from the dust, piecing itself back together again. It was a nightmare given form.

"Get us out of here!" Glimmer said, yelling to Kyle from across the vessel. "Now!"

Kyle peeled them away from the keep at a rapid clip and the doors shut. Glimmer only just managed to slam herself into the nearest bucket seat and get her harness on when he angled them up and accelerated.

G-forces stronger than she'd experienced in a long time pushed her deep into the seat and threatened to drop her back into unconsciousness; Kyle was burning them up to space, hard. The engine screamed, but they could see nothing through the tiny viewport windows, only the fog and the small tunnel Glimmer had opened in it for them from earlier.

They burst through the fog dome and Scavria's curve appeared, monstrous and titanic against the backdrop of stars and starships. Blood rushed back to Glimmer's head and her peripheral vision came back, only for her breath to squeeze from her lungs once more as Kyle angled them to the side and carved. A beam of energy as wide as the plane-tside keep was careened past them, lighting up the interior of the warbirds in a brilliant orange through the viewports.

The beam traveled down to the planet's surface and struck the dome. Pockets of black pocked the surface under the fog as it finally started to clear. Kyle let off, only to bank again as dozens of beams from the other ships in the fleet streaked down to the surface, chasing the first. He pushed them further, dodging the bombardment, zig-zagging every which direction until they were safely out of the line of fire. From there, he slowed them to a safe cruising speed, and everyone breathed easier. At least, for a few more seconds they did.

"What is going on down there?" one of the soldiers said. They'd unstrapped from the seat and were pressing their face against the window.

Everyone followed and crowded one side of the Warbird—Glimmer's side—to look. More than half the planet had been covered in a black substance, the same that had comprised the Trooper's body from earlier. A collective gasp rang out from the group as a massive face, surrounded by tendrils in the black, appeared beneath the dissolving fog around Tir.

"That," Glimmer said, pulling her attention away, unable to look at it any longer, "is what happens when an Abomination wakens during an infection."

A heaviness descended upon the group then. Scavria was lost, just like Rinne had been lost and just like Archanas had been lost. Just like countless other worlds during the first conflict had been lost. Not even the elation they'd felt at escaping with their lives could offset that.

“All the refugee megaliths made it safely to the carriers,” Kyle said. The relief in his voice at having saved them was evident, the pall was still there. Billions of Scavrians, turned into thralls and burning to a crisp on the planet’s surface because of the bombardment. They’d become an endangered race.

Glimmer gripped the armrests of her seat until her knuckles turned white and her fingers hurt. Her body couldn’t decide whether to throw up, cry, or fall unconscious from the exertion. The pain in her wrists and joints from squeezing the chair so hard was the only thing keeping her grounded.

Kyle piloted the warbird back to the *Omen-Kador* in complete silence.

Chapter End Notes

> It took me a while moving chapters around for pacing purposes to finally settle on a 4 part "mini-finale" for the whole Scavria arc with Glimmer. She's not done, obviously, but her major piece of character development choosing to do something in the face of her survivor's guilt and fear is accomplished.
>
> I decided on having that play out uninterrupted (no switches to other POVS between chapters) to start off part 4 strong, but even after solidifying that, figuring out where to put and how to portray the other million-and-a-half tidbits of character development, backstory, revelation (lol), etc. was surprisingly difficult. It took another 2 rounds of extra revision (7 or 8 total, depending on what you count as a revision draft), but I'm really happy with how this and the rest of the part came out.
>
> That little bit about the Beast showing Glimmer a glimpse of Adora, Micah and Melog (yes, that was Melog) are an easter egg for my other fic, The Queen's Proxy. If you haven't read it, it shows, briefly, what they were up to while Catra was working back home. The "ghosts" Adora mentions to Catra in

that final chapter are pretty self-explanatory ;) I also strongly considered removing that passage to cut for wordcount on this monster of a chapter, but decided to keep it in because its fanfiction and I'm allowed to be self-indulgent.

Catra up next! I'll have another quick recap in the beginning author's note for that chapter once it's posted for those of you following along weekly. Until then!

(ps, we're already at 50 chapters? geeze. Maybe I should alter the summary to make it more inviting for potential new readers. A Legend of Zelda fic got me reading it recently with the way they addressed word count, I might emulate it.)

# Seeds of Uncertainty

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra dodged strikes she couldn't see. She marveled at the feeling of what felt akin to reading and reacting to the future on an instinctual level. Six enemies surrounded her, and she danced around their attacks like it was a game.

She struck at one's throat with claws extended while at the same time contorting her body sideways to avoid a blow from a second. The first enemy dissolved into a fizzle of holographic dust, and Catra's mental load evading (as well as the amount of fun she felt at this exercise) diminished by a sixth.

"You're getting cocky," Taline said to her from behind a console off to the side.

Irritation lanced through Catra. "Cocky? What are you talking about? I'm not—"

She didn't register a strike coming from behind until it was too late. An enemy kicked her hard enough in the butt to send her careening forward, and even though she managed to turn her stumbling into a forward handspring, the other four pounced on her. Electricity powerful enough to send her hair standing on end arced through her. She fell to the floor as her muscles seized. When the electricity stopped, she rolled away, flipped back onto her feet, and rounded on them, ready for whatever counterattack they no doubt were already pressing.

The enemies were gone.

Pip floated into view off to the side, hands on her hips and shaking her head, and Catra clicked her tongue and folded her arms. She had gone through countless combat exercises aboard the *Constable* over the past few days as it made its way through

hyperspace to Archanas, and this was the first time the simulation got the better of her so early. She'd only taken down one enemy.

"See?" Taline said without taking her eyes off the console. She tossed a bottled water to Catra and she caught it without needing to track it with her eyes.

"I wasn't getting cocky." Catra grumbled as she pressed the cold bottle to her forehead and stalked over to Taline.

"No, you weren't actually."

Catra sputtered. "Then why the hell—"

Taline looked Catra in the eyes with such a casually piercing gaze it derailed her. "You lost your focus as soon as I said something to throw you off."

Catra ignored Pip's quiet snickering on the side and grabbed a towel she had draped over one of the unused consoles nearby. "That's hardly fair," she said, dabbing her forehead.

"Battles aren't fair," Taline said. "Maybe you were going easy on the Rebellion when you fought them on Etheria. Maybe you thought it fun to play around with them at times, maybe not, but you were able to walk away from your defeats. When you fight alongside me, you don't 'play,' you keep your head in the fight. We fight as a team, so if either one of us loses focus then neither of us will make it past the first engagement." She returned her attention to the console and tapped a sequence of commands into it, an unusually somber expression on her face, even for her. "Engaging the Beast is never something to make a game of."

"You think we're going to get into it on Archanas?"

Taline shook her head. "Thankfully, the risk of being attacked there is close to zero, but I'm talking about future assignments. I'm not putting you in the field until I'm confident you understand the consequences of not staying one hundred percent focused at all times."

Catra averted her eyes, no longer able to deflect her nerves with snippy comments. Of course Taline was being serious—she had heard more than enough from Glimmer about how intense she was during training. Catra had just never experienced it herself, how huge a difference there was compared to how Taline normally treated her. It was unnerving.

For a few days now they'd been traveling to Archanas through hyperspace, carrying a full contingent of forensic analysts whose job it was to tear apart the Vestamid computer systems at their destination and look for the software they'd used to encrypt Moriarty's drive. However they'd applied the same uncrackable Barrier algorithm lock down the data on that drive, Taline needed to know. And luckily (or perhaps unluckily) for Catra, she'd used the spare time they'd had during their transit to begin training her directly.

"I-I understand," she said, unsure of what else to say.

"How are the nightmares?"

Catra hadn't had a good night's sleep since before Diallo had arrived at Phoenix. The anniversary of Adora's blitz aboard the emperor's citadel—and thus the anniversary of Taline having broken one of her apeirons and exposing them to a memory of the Beast—had long since passed. But every time she'd closed her eyes, it was yet another nightmare and a gamble on whether she'd wake up the next morning feeling rested or restless.

"They're still there," she said, rubbing at her temples absentmindedly. "They seem to be worse than ever. I don't understand why."

"A lot has happened this year," Taline said. "I wouldn't be surprised if that's contributing. It does for my nightmares at least." She tapped a rhythm with her fingers on the metal sides of the console and said, "At any rate, they don't seem to be affecting your ability to fight."

“I haven’t been able to take on all six yet, though.”

“Still, you’re integrating with Pip much faster than I expected.”

Catra blinked. “I am?”

“Take a look.” Taline pressed a button on the console and the screen mirrored onto a holographic display cast above. What looked like hundreds of colored tangles of string, clumped vaguely together in a loose three-dimensional representation of a brain, rotated before them both.

“Is that…mine?”

“This is the brain of an average Vanguard soldier, not yours,” Taline said. “It was recorded during a routine training session similar to this one. Watch how long it takes for them to respond to a blow from an opponent they see coming”—an area at the back of the model lit up—“with an adequate block and then counterpunch.” After a moment, Catra saw an area at the top section of the model light up just as the portion at the back dimmed.

“There’s a gap,” Catra said, repeating what she saw out loud and hoping Taline would explain.

“One hundred seventy-five millisecond response time,” Taline said. “That footage is slowed down so you can actually see it. It’s not bad for a soldier with cybernetics of their own and the training needed to fight on an elite level. But you?”

She tapped another button and a new brain model replaced the old one. The colors on the ‘strings’ comprising this one were far more vibrant, as if all the neural connections at once were constantly at some low-level activity. Catra watched some parts of her brain light brighter sequentially and other, discrete parts light up together. It seemed haphazard. The area she knew was her motor cortex didn’t seem to light up in any discernable pattern, either.

“Eighty-nine millisecond response time on average across two hundred and thirty-four separate stimulus activation events,” Taline said. “Your brain is processing stimuli not just from your eyes, but from your hearing, and from your skin and fur as it detects subtle shifts in the air pressure around you. And on top of that, you are responding to those stimuli far faster than even most elite Imperial soldiers. Most of those blows you dodged you hadn’t seen with your eyes.”

“So, I wasn’t reading the future then,” Catra said, cracking open the seal on the water bottle and taking several large gulps while she watched the light show replay.

“Nope, just reacting extremely fast to stimuli you aren’t even consciously aware of,” Taline said. “Like a reflex. Although it does feel like you are processing things one or two seconds before they happen when you’re in the moment, doesn’t it? You don’t become consciously aware of your actions until after you’ve performed them”

The question surprised Catra and she looked at Pip, floating in plain sight right under Taline’s nose. She too was watching the recording of Catra’s brain model play, but Taline didn’t seem to know she was there.

“She integrated with me years go,” Pip said. “Just enough to sharpen her reflexes. That’s why she understands what it feels like.”

“You let yourself get distracted when you heard me say you were getting cocky, though,” Taline said. “You listened to what I said and thought about it, and your response time slowed. If it were a real fight you would have died.”

“I know, I felt the electric shock,” Catra said, grimacing.

“No, you don’t understand.” Again, Taline spoke with such nonchalant gravity despite outright contradicting her. “I didn’t trick you into making a mistake purposefully to be an asshole. When

we get to Archanas, you're going to find it especially hard to concentrate."

Whenever Catra woke from a nightmare, there was  always the sharp taste of copper in her mouth. That taste started to bleed to the forefront of her senses now. "What do you mean?"

"Do you remember what happened in the cell?" Taline asked. "Those ghosts moving about in the dark? That oppressive feeling you said filled the air?"

How could Catra forget? She'd asked Taline about it and Taline had explained it to her, but Catra still didn't understand what had happened. It was all very metaphysical. What was "shades or imprints of people in the past" supposed to mean, and why would they manifest around Taline during what she could only assume was a psychotic break?

"Archanas will be like that," Taline said. "Except…more. I will be there to shield our group from the worst of it, but that's no guarantee nothing won't slip through. Your mind may seem to play tricks on you. There won't be any enemies for you to face, except for what you allow yourself to conjure."

Catra didn't like the sound of that. The draconian preparations the crew had been subjected to before and during their jump into hyperspace suffocated her the more she understood the context behind them.

"What happened on that planet?" she asked.

Taline's expression turned stony. "You already know what happened. You passed the empire's naturalization exams with flying colors since you took such a strident interest in its history. Especially thee parts concerning the prior Beast war." She turned an accusing look on Catra and said, "Why are we playing ignorant to that fact?"

Catra knew deflection when she saw it. Taline would never get one over on her in that regard. "Diallo told me you'd been to

Archanas. Before the final conflict with the Beast. He didn't elaborate, but I can only assume he meant before the planet became a Lost World, and that part definitely isn't in the history texts."

Taline narrowed her eyes and whispered something colorful under her breath. "Diallo doesn't know when to keep his mouth shut."

Catra couldn't bring herself to disagree, not even privately, but she kept silent. To her surprise, the ire in Taline's voice was gone by the time she spoke again.

"I know what you must be thinking," Taline said. "I'm not keeping you in the dark on purpose, it's just…"

Catra held her breath. She'd worried about this. What did it mean that Taline was purposefully hoping Catra hadn't learned of this? Why wouldn't she want her to know, and why would she be hesitant to say anything? Even if she didn't have malicious reasons for shutting her out, still…

"Archanas is complicated," Taline said at last. "I didn't know how to broach the subject, and now that it's out in the open I don't know how to explain it. I fear that no matter what, my explanation would just leave you confused and possibly with the wrong impression. I thought it might be better if you just saw for yourself once we got there."

She averted her eyes, and to Catra's surprise, it almost looked like she was worried Catra might get even more upset at her reasoning. "You'll still have questions, naturally," Taline said, "but it will be easier to explain once you've seen for yourself what it's like there."

It still surprised Catra whenever she remembered how she was essentially on equal footing in the power dynamic with someone as influential and storied as the Seraph of Archanas herself. It was easy to forget, and Catra rationalized that the only way she'd start

to feel like an equal peer to Taline instead of a subordinate was if she started acting like one.

“You’ll fill me in once we get to the surface, then,” Catra said, earning a look of relief from Taline. “I’m sure there will be downtime as the analyst comb through the Vestamid’s systems. Although, I have to admit I’m even more interested in what I’ll see than before. And I was plenty interested already.”

“You might not feel so enamored by it all once we get there. Remember the ghosts?”

“I’m trying not to.”

Taline laughed and shook her head. “Let’s go again, then.” She tapped more commands into the console and reset the training room. “Try and block out any distractions, and let's go with seven this time instead of six.”

Catra downed her water bottle and sent it flying into a wastebin in the corner with an overhand toss over the shoulder. She draped her towel back over one of the unused consoles and walked back onto the training floor.

“Ready,” she said, once she reached the center.

She stood there for several moments with her back to Taline, ready for seven enemies to materialize and rush her. Nothing came. She looked back and found Taline staring at the console with a tense expression.

“Taline?” Catra turned fully around, uncertain. Was this another test?

“Change of plans,” Taline said, exiting her session on the console. “I have to go.”

“Go?” Catra took several hesitant steps forward, wringing her hands. She really didn’t like the change in Taline’s voice. “Go where? What’s wrong?”

"I don't know yet," she said. "I just got an emergency communication coded for my eyes only. I have to take it privately in my quarters." Taline was already halfway to the exit at the other end of the training room. "We'll make it to Archanas within a few hours. Go get some rest. I'll come get you and fill you in as soon as I'm done."

Catra watched her leave. Seeing Taline's disappear through the door felt like something—a connection, a relationship starting to build firmer roots—was slipping away. Catra suppressed the urge to call out to her, and the door hissed shut amid silence.

*You're worrying about nothing*, Catra chanted to herself in her head. She fought back the sudden image of Adora slipping away from her, too—something that had not emerged from the depths of her mind now for a while. *She's not leaving you. Stop imagining things that aren't happening.*

Pip was looking at her from a short distance away.

::What?:: Catra asked.

"I didn't say anything."

::You don't need to say anything. You're in my head. I can tell when you have an opinion you aren't saying to my face.:: Truthfully, this was the first Catra realized she could do that, although the realization didn't help things.

"I think Taline had good advice. You should get some rest."

Catra rolled her eyes and huffed. What kind of message would force Taline to cut their training short and leave like that?

She grabbed her towel and another water bottle and headed for the exit, too. She had no idea how she was going to fall asleep when her thoughts were racing like this. Two bodies on either side of the doorway snapped to attention when the door slid open and Catra stepped through.

"Relax, it's just me," she said.

Trayn and Keren looked visibly relieved, and Catra nodded for them to follow as she hung left and padded down the ship's hallway toward her quarters near the rear of the *Constable*. They were surprised to learn of Catra's new role as Sentinel, but that surprise dropped to unconditional support the moment Catra had told them she'd vouched for their inclusion in the Archanas mission.

"How did it go?" Keren asked, falling into step at her right while Trayn mirrored to her left.

"I get distracted too easily, apparently," Catra said.

"Seems to me Taline's the one who was distracted," Trayn said. "She sure left in a hurry, and without you. I don't think she even noticed we were guarding the door."

"Something came up." Catra wasn't paying much attention. "Seemed important, I don't really know."

"I'm sure she has a lot going on," Keren said, her tone of voice implying she caught on to Catra's reluctance to speak on it and was trying to cap it off. "We're going to Archanas of all places and she has a new Sentinel to train. I don't blame her for being a bit all over the place. Especially after she went out of her way to commission us for this mission."

Catra grunted her agreement. Taline had the good sense to scoop up many of the officers from her old precinct as she could after Moriarty's cuts left them out of a job. Catra had heard many of the other precinct captains weren't easy to negotiate transfers with, even after lay-offs, but Dax had jumped at the chance to find his people new employment even if it was temporary. Catra had ensured Trayn and Keren were on the list, and they had been assigned to her for the duration of the trip. She was glad they were there—their presence helped temper some of her nerves.

“Even with the absolute gauntlet of tests we ran through before getting a contract it’s nice she kept us working,” Trayn said. “But she rushed off in such a hurry we didn’t get the chance to say thanks.” He earned a nasty look from Keren when it was clear he didn’t get the hint to let the topic drop.

“Mm.” Catra’s rumination grew worse the further they walked. She squeezed and relaxed the water bottle in her hand, hoping in vain that treating it like a stress toy might provide relief. Pip shot her worried glances from atop her perch on Trayn’s shoulder (with Trayn of course being none the wiser).

Evidence of their stiffer than usual preparations for Archanas were obvious. The cruiser’s singular observation deck was closed and nothing except Taline’s personal biometrics would open the door. Any viewports looking out were also shuttered, since just looking at their destination planet from orbit was enough to give people night terrors for a month.

Catra caught glimpses of the deck patrols making their circuits in pairs of three instead of the usual twos, a change Taline had ordered to better anticipate a situation where the typical two-buddy system ended with both on-duty staffers experiencing side effects at the same time. The contingency of medical personnel had been doubled, apparently, and Catra was surprised when she first came aboard to see even the viewports on the bridge had their blast shields down and permanently locked for the duration of the mission.

The ship was almost like a prison.

All the extra preparation had only made it harder for Catra to calm herself once she started spiraling. This, on top of whatever message had Taline practically running away from her. Even though this was the first time in years she’d be traveling off Phoenix Station, Catra already couldn’t wait for this assignment to finish so they could return. For all her interest in the previous war, she’d never thought she’d be landing on Archanas itself.

She wished Glimmer were here. She'd know how to help, even if 'helping' meant getting into a sniping match over something stupid.

Pip sucked in a sharp breath, Keren and Trayn both hesitate beside her, and both of these things happening at the same time was enough to pull Catra out of the fog and get her to look up. Diallo was there, walking the hall toward them. He was alone.

That was the other thing that had her on edge this entire time: despite the fact Diallo manipulated her, Archanas was his world, and Taline couldn't leave him behind even if she wanted to. Although Catra understood the politics behind it, she still hated how he'd used her.

"H-hello," he said, intercepting them in the hallway instead of letting them pass by each other in peace. "I h-heard Taline has been putting you through s-some rather intensive training recently. How is it?"

Catra squeezed the water bottle so hard her claws punctured holes in the plastic. Water spilled out onto the floor. "Really? After the shit you pulled, you think you can just walk up to me and strike up a conversation like nothing happened?"

Keren and Trayn gasped. Catra might have been surprised at her own reaction too, if Diallo had a predictable response to her violence. Instead, he smirked and spoke without his stutter.

"I did what was necessary to get Taline to act. For years I had been working to get her to even look into what was happening in my system and she refused. I don't blame her, not after what happened, and you should not blame me." He reached out a placed a heavy palm on her shoulder. "I was right, you know. Moriarty was corrupt, and the phantom algorithm his computer decrypted was all the evidence we needed to—"

Catra dropped the empty bottle and grabbed the hand he was touching her with She spun him and pushed his arm far enough

up and against his back to cause pain, then shoved him forward hard enough the thump from his face slamming against the polished wall resounded down the hallway. His glasses flew off and skittered across the ground. Several crewmen and officers who had been walking the halls stopped in their tracks and stared open mouthed and wide eyed.

"Catra," Keren said, hissing in apprehension. "What are you doing? You can't just attack a System Governor!"

"You lied to me," Catra said, ignoring her. "You used me and manipulated me knowing that I had no idea what I was doing. I don't give a rat's ass if you were right. If it weren't for the fact we have to bring you along and I have to play nice because it's your system we're going to, I wouldn't hesitate to give you two black eyes." She leaned in, pressing him harder against the bulkhead, and growled into his ear. "But let me be one hundred percent clear with you—if you ever touch me like that again, or if you ever jeopardize my standing with Taline again, I will give you a legitimate reason to have a genuine stutter for the rest of your life."

Diallo's shoulders started to shake and, for a moment, Catra thought she had pushed him so hard he started crying. Then his voice broke through, and she realized he was actually laughing instead. Hearing it sent shivers down her spine.

"You're still convinced she's a good person, aren't you?" he asked. "You're still under the impression she cares about you? I warned you about this before, didn't I? Did you not take me seriously?"

"I took you more seriously than I should have and you used that against me." Catra shoved him harder against the wall. She'd hoped it would have shut him up, but instead it only sent him into further hysterics, and the people around them were starting to whisper among themselves in concern.

"What has she told you about Archanas? Or were you under the misguided impression that she was avoiding coming here because

she really thought I had been chasing conspiracy theories?”

Catra didn’t want to give him the satisfaction of learning Taline hadn’t said anything yet, despite her having directly asked. She didn’t want him to see how conflicted it made her feel, and when she didn’t immediately say something, Diallo turned his head and looked at her while still pressed up against the wall. The gaze in his eyes made her feel like he was seeing straight through her, and Catra released him with a yelp and backed away.

“As I said before,” Diallo said, stooping to grab his glasses from the floor before slotting the back on his face with all the calm of someone who hadn’t just been attacked in the hallway. “Taline isn’t who she says she is. It would be wise of you to treat her with the same skepticism you now do with me because she wants something out of you, just like I did.”

He adjusted the glasses on the bridge of his nose and sent one last look in Catra’s direction. She recoiled.

“You will find out soon enough,” he said. “That, I promise.”

Diallo turned and continued down the hallway in the direction he was originally going, passing all the stunned bystanders with smiles and nods. Catra watched him go, a sudden restlessness attacking her.

She wanted to change course and go to Taline’s quarters. Instead, she quashed that urge and continued on to her own room, ignoring the concerned whispers of everyone around them.

“Hey, is everything okay?” Keren asked once they reached her door. Trayn, too, looked uncertain.

“It’s fine,” Catra said. She palmed the reader next to her door and it slid open with a beep. “Why don’t you guys take the rest of the time for yourself until we arrive? Go get some food and rest yourselves.”

They glanced at each other with skeptical looks.

"Are you sure?" Trayn asked. "Why not come with us to the cafeteria? We could eat together."

Catra did her best not to lash out. They were worried about her, as friends were likely to do. "I promise I'm fine. I just need to get some sleep and be alone for a bit. I'm more worried about you guys once we arrive. I know they briefed you on what people have experienced on Archanas before it was quarantined. It'd probably be best that we're all as well rested as we can be when we arrive."

Keren and Trayn exchanged another set of reluctant glances before agreeing and heading off, sending cautious glances back at her over their shoulders every few steps. They finally disappeared around a curve in the hall and Catra turned and stepped into her room, shutting the door behind her and encasing herself in near-complete darkness.

Pip floated into view, standing out against the pitch dark that surrounded Catra before her night vision fully kicked in.

"He and I meant it in different ways, you know," she said.

"Meant what in different ways?" Catra asked, speaking aloud.

"That Taline isn't who she says she is. I said the same thing in Moriarty's office, remember?"

"I remember." Catra had never forgotten in the first place. It had sent such a jolt of apprehension flooding through her at the time, there was no way she'd forget, even if Pip had later clarified it as a positive thing.

"Taline is distant and she can come off cold, trust me I understand," Pip said, hovering in front of Catra while she pressed herself flat against the inside of her door. "You haven't seen much if it because, well, *you* were the distant and cold one between the two of you for a while. But I've seen enough of her to know she isn't a bad person. She opened up to both of us back in the prison

cell. She's not manipulating or using you, Catra, I would have seen it if she was."

"I know." Catra's night vision was coming to her and she was starting to make out the shapes and subtle shadows of her quarter's cramped interior. "I've known too many people that pretend to be things they aren't, though. Shadow Weaver barely pretended to be a mother and I still hung on to any scraps of affection she would show. Hordak...well, that one I can't really say much against him since I wasn't exactly forthcoming with him either, but it still hurt when we finally fought."

"And Adora?"

Catra balled her hands into fists tight enough her claws pricked the palms of her hands. "I thought Adora was my friend. Well… she was. She was my friend, until I…"

She trailed off when she remembered that Pip likely already understood everything she was trying to say anyways. She was doing this on purpose, the sneaky program, drawing out her emotions like she was unspooling string, tricking her into processing them aloud.

"I'm not tricking you," Pip said, a hint of indignation in her voice.

"I just thought we were the kind of friends that'd find our way to each other again no matter what happened," Catra said after a deep breath. "And I was wrong. I don't blame her for cutting me off, I would have done it a long, long time ago if I were in her place. Sooner, even. But it still hurts to realize Adora wasn't as forgiving a person as I thought. It doesn't matter how well I rationalize it, either, it still hurts. All of it hurts."

"I see."

"I'm not writing off Taline," Catra said, suddenly feeling the urge to defend her. This, again, despite the fact Pip already knew everything she was feeling. "Really. I think Taline is who she says

she is, too. It’s just…it doesn’t take much to get me to start worrying again.”

“I know,” Pip said again, softer this time. “These things take time.”

Catra was about to ask how she—an AI locked in a server for the majority of her year—could speak so confidently about that when she saw a tiny flashing light out the corner of her eye. She hadn’t noticed it before, but here in the dark with her night vision fully kicked in, it stood out. She pulled up her arm and saw it was an indicator flashing on her PDA. With a furrowed brow she opened up the menu and her heart almost stopped when she saw what the alert was.

A message had come through for her. It was from Adora.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for the delay! But Catra (finally) got wind of Adora's message! And that's where I end the chapter, muahah ;)

The threads are slowly culminating.

# Wheels Within Wheels

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"—just so cool! I don't really know how to describe it, but he just slid right in and lit up like he was *made* of magic and burned the thing right out of its body. The spaceport would have been destroyed if he hadn't stopped it, maybe even all of Eden probably, it was just…wow."

Adora's image flickered in the video stream, and Catra sat hunched over on a chair in Taline's room, biting her nails and pumping her leg. This was her third time watching Adora's message, while Taline stood off to the side with arms crossed, watching for the first time.

"Ly told me who he really is," Adora said. "I always had a feeling his real name wasn't Kal, but to think *that's* who he really was? The same Corynth from the stories? Catra, this is the person Salas told me would be able to help me get in touch with She Ra again. He can train me." She went quiet all of a sudden, curling into herself. "I know I shouldn't be saying any of this to you but…I miss you. I made a mistake the last time we saw each other and it's been eating away at me ever since.

"I don't know if you'll ever forgive me enough to speak to me again. I don't know if you'll even get this message, or maybe you've moved on enough by now you wouldn't care to open this once you see who it's from." An anguished look passed across her face. "But I just had to reach out and say that I'm sorry. And I miss you. And I hope we can see each other again soon, and I hope…Well, I hope for a lot of things. I think I should just leave it there."

She cleared her throat and looked behind her shoulder. There was a lab behind her—people, soldiers maybe, in uniforms Catra didn't

recognize. When Adora turned back around, she said, “I have to go. Can you message me back something, even if it’s just to say you got this? I’d love to hear from you.” She looked like she wanted to say more, but instead reached for the camera, and the feed cut off.

Catra sat there, unable to process anything. The urge to replay the video a fourth time was near unstoppable. It wasn’t until she noticed Pip floating off to the side, glancing between her and Taline in concern, that she remembered why she’d come here in the first place.

“When did you get this message?” Taline asked, the calm in her voice at odds with how Catra felt.

“The timestamp says it came through about a half hour before our training session ended,” Catra said. “I just didn’t notice until I got back to my room. I watched it twice and then came straight here.”

Taline’s frown deepened. “Well, that settles it then,” she said, staring a hole into a point on the wall. “To think, everything I had been worrying about for years was actually true…that it wasn’t just paranoia. Corynth is alive, and Adora has been traveling with him.”

A memory came to mind for Catra, one of her looking up at Corynth’s statue in the Atrium. She remembered seeing his Shaper mask in the box Taline hid it in, deep inside the hidden room adjacent her office, and thinking whoever carved the statue got it looking just like the real thing.

“I’m not entirely convinced Adora knows what she’s talking about,” Catra said. “She’s been wrong before. Quite a lot actually, and she’s very impressionable. Super impressionable. It’s almost embarrassing. I’m sure she just thinks this person is Corynth...it can’t actually be him.”

“That emergency communication I took earlier informed me of Eden’s destruction.” Taline spoke with finality in her voice, and it

sent a stone plummeting in Catra's stomach.

Destroyed? Adora had just sent her a message from Eden, how could it be destroyed? Catra had to force herself to focus on Taline's words when she started to speak again.

"It was a smuggler haven, hidden on the sun side of a rocky planet so close to its star it was considered uninhabitable. All scans of the planet had marked it as such and no one ever investigated further. The Vestamid were apparently using it as some sort of makeshift research settlement, and the Imperial naval forces stationed nearby responded when their scanners picked up a brand-new Beast infection spreading across its surface. To say the commander of the garrison there was surprised when the scans tripped would be an understatement."

She stopped with a faraway look in her eyes. The ship creaked as it continued to rocket through hyperspace, the only sound alongside the humming of the life support system and thee rhythmic thumping of Catra's leg still pumping away.

"They picked up a handful of survivors, those who had escaped before the response fleet obliterated everything. Some of those survivors had been called in to clean up the aftermath of the fight Adora recounted in her message—the one against the Abomination.

"There's not a Battlemage alive that could have left behind what that cleanup crew said they had found. A burned-out husk missing a head? Calcified growths on the corpse that caused a severe mental reaction when touched? A whole *team* of Battlemages might kill an Abominations, as can an entire fleet bombarding the surface of a corrupted planet from orbit, but only the Shapers were powerful enough to do something that surgically precise to a fledgling Abomination."

"Are you sure? People misremember things under stress. Eyewitness testimony is not reliable, its like the first thing I learned as an officer."

Catra didn’t want to wrestle with the implications behind Corynth being alive and Adora having traveled with him, almost as much as she didn’t want to wrestle with the idea she might have died when the station supposedly broke apart.

Taline shook her head. “I’m certain. Those friends of hers Adora met along the way? Lysithea and Vasher? I recognize those names. Those are famous names, two of Evie’s original scientist faction, marked on official Imperial records as dead since no one could find any trace of them after the war ended. The fact Adora called them by name and said it was them who directly confirmed Corynth’s identity to her leave doubt in my mind. There’s too for this to be mere coincidence and faulty eyewitness testimony.”

“Are you saying Adora finally reached out to me wanting to, I don’t know, rekindle something after all these years and now she’s died before I’ve even got a chance to respond?” Catra’s breathing started to come in spurts. The corners of her vision were pulling in, signaling an oncoming panic attack.

Taline paused and looked at her—finally seemed to see her. She looked surprised, as if her mind were on a different topic and hadn’t expected to wander so far afield after assuming her and Catra had been on the same page.

“I’m not sure,” she said, sounding and looking far more sympathetic and comforting than moments earlier. It helped settle Catra’s nerves and she managed to get herself back under control.

“You said the station blew up.”

“I don’t know if she’s alive or not, Catra. I hope she is, but I’m operating on almost no information myself, either.” Taline ran a hand through her hair. “Corynth is still alive. If he survived what happened at Archanas the first time, then a station exploding wouldn’t be enough to take him down. And if he’s still alive, then Adora likely is too. Whatever his reasons, he wouldn’t have gone to all the trouble to take her from Etheria just to leave her to die. Not unless he was already done with her.”

Catra almost felt relieved until Taline got to the last part. "What do you mean 'not unless he was already done with her?' What's he trying to do?"

"Nothing good, that's for sure."

Catra scowled. Taline was in her head again already, ruminating on overdrive because her strange fixation and paranoia over Corynth had reignited. Catra understood, since now she was doing the same thing about either reuniting with Adora or learning of her sudden death. Still, these non-answers and cryptic comments about things that had happened in the past were starting to grate on her.

"What's your deal with him, anyways?" she asked.

Taline whirled on her, glaring this time, and Catra put both palms up to placate her.

"I just don't understand, is all. We talked about this before you made me your Sentinel, but you'd never explained what happened. You two used to be close. Now he's someone you've thought about killing for years. Believe me when I say I get it, but context would be nice."

Taline didn't speak, and Catra crossed her arms and scowled at her. Being cagey about Archanas was one thing, but Catra had her limits, especially after having to talk to Diallo again.

"He stood up for Evie when she refused to bow to the emperor's command," she said, unfurling fingers as she listed things off. "He rallied all the rest of the Daiamid and whisked her and her scientists away so she could study the Barrier away from his wrath. When the time came, he brought them all back to Archanas and then *you* helped them spear through your blockading fleet and onto the planet's surface so they could partially seal the Beast away."

Taline averted her eyes midway through Catra's words, and it was enough to convince her she was actually making some astute

points. She'd not wanted to throw cold logic in the face of Taline's emotions, however, so she gentled her voice.

"I'm missing something, obviously. You're convinced he manipulated not just your sister, but you too—that he'd tapped into the depths of some horrific power to persuade Evie to abandon reason and defy the emperor despite the threat of death. And even though it ended with them helping save the galaxy, you haven't forgiven him.

"What is it that I'm missing, then? I might have let it go before, but I'm your Sentinel now and I won't fumble around making guesses on my own, not after what happened with Diallo and Moriarty. Fill in the blanks for me, please. I just don't understand how someone who'd done all that so your sister had a shot at sealing the Beast away could earn such deep hatred from you."

Taline bit her lip, eyes still averted. She closed them, took a deep breath, then tilted her head up to the ceiling and uttered something under her breath. To Catra it sounded like it might be a prayer, or perhaps a curse. Taline then padded across the room and leaned on one hip against the table pushed against the wall of her private quarters. The image of her there, arms crossed and contemplative, struck a strange chord with Catra when she saw it.

"There was a prominent family in the empire, once," Taline said at last. "The La Valettes. They were old money…very old. 'Roots dating back to the first decades after the founding of the empire'-kind of old money." She gestured to herself and said, "They ran a scholarship that sponsored part of my education at the Enclave Academy when I was an initiate. That and endless shifts at the local tavern off campus helped pay for things."

"You were a bar maid?"

"The scholarship didn't cover living expenses, unfortunately," Taline said, maybe a little indignant. "I took to the service aspect of the job well enough, believe it or not."

"Is that why you're the only member of Phoenix's administration who could stomach personal office hours?"

"My secret is out." Taline gave her a tired smile that disappeared the next moment. "The La Valettes were also extremely powerful, and it was for that reason Horde Prime wanted them gone. There was a fire at their estate one day, during a major gathering. Every important member of the main family branch was there. The fire consumed everything and razed it to the ground before emergency services got it contained. No survivors."

Catra kept silent, nodding along with a somber expression.

"An 'internal investigation' found an arsonist." Taline's contempt for that investigation was clear in her tone of voice. "One of the family's servants was implicated, arrested, then executed. It was a big affair. Everybody talked about it, and for days every news agency large and small ran near constant updates and opinions and roundtable sessions about it. And then, about a week after the execution, there was nothing. Nobody talked about it any longer, the news moved on to other prospects. It was as if the whole family were wiped from the face of galactic consciousness overnight."

"Let me guess," Catra said. "Anyone remotely questioning the arson narrative were called crazy and dismissed?"

"Yes. I thought it strange at the time, too, but what could you do aside from speculate endlessly with no proof of anything? It wasn't until the Daiamid actually reached out directly to recruit me that I learned they had done it. It was an assassination, sanctioned by the emperor himself and then aggressively covered up. Those 'conspiracy theorists' calling foul on the arson narrative weren't just dismissed, they were disappeared. All of it was the Daiamid working in the shadows."

"Corynth told you?" Catra knew he'd practically begged Taline to come with them when they were escaping after Evelyn's trial. Whatever atrocities the Daiamid committed against imperial

citizens, they did a complete face-heel turn as soon as the verdict came down.

Catra watched Taline's features harden—she was clenching her jaw. "Corynth didn't tell me anything, he lied to my face. Someone else was sent to recruit me—not him. They told me what happened before the Daiamid ever went public."

That…wasn't what Catra had expected to hear. She was under the impression Corynth himself had tried to recruit her after they'd defected. This was the first she'd heard of Taline being a formal candidate to the Daiamid before they'd revealed their existence to anyone else.

"Their representative bragged about their accomplishment to me," Taline said, before Catra could get a word in. "He thought because of the things I'd done already in the war that I'd be impressed they'd successfully culled one of the oldest, most revered families in the empire's history without anyone discovering the truth. I was disgusted and I killed him, but not before he let slip that they'd almost failed the hit in the beginning. The La Valettes discovered the identity of the first agent the Daiamid had sent after them."

"Pretty big accomplishment, considering no one knew about them at the time," Catra said. "How'd they find out?"

"Corynth was the first agent."

Catra's jaw fell open. So many questions came to her at once, the only coherent thing she could get out was, "Him? How? *Why?*"

"He wasn't always their leader," Taline said. "Long before he became the 'Last Shaper of the Daiamid', he was sent to eliminate the family line, and he told them who he was. I don't know why he was sent and I don't know why he broke their most sacred rule to never reveal the nature of their existence, but he did. He told them who he was, but he didn't tell *me*. Not when he had every opportunity to, and not until it was too late."

Taline leaned further into the table and ran her fingers through her hair again, smoothing it back. Her fingers shook with her voice, although from anger or some other emotion, Catra couldn't tell.

"The fight against their envoy nearly killed me," she said. "My new powers weren't enough at the time, so I had to over-rely on my runes. I kept up. I'm still not entirely sure how I won that fight, actually. And when Evie and Corynth found me later, half dead in the corner of my apartment, I told them what happened. I knew the Daiamid would come for me after I killed one of them. I was half afraid Corynth himself would be the one to do it, right there in front of Evie. I knew what he was. He still thought I had no idea."

"But that didn't happen," Catra said, so invested in the story she forgot to breathe.

Taline shook her head. She was looking to some distant point off to the side, her sharp features standing in contrast against the light of the room. "No. He had no idea I knew what he was. He still thought I was in the dark. He could have told me. Do you want to know what he said to me instead of the truth?"

She looked at Catra with such a naked look of open pain and anger she froze. Then, realizing Taline was actually waiting on an answer, she swallowed and nodded. "Yeah."

"I'd told him I knew what happened with the La Valettes, but without explicitly saying I knew it was *him* who was sent to kill them to begin with. I wanted to see if he'd come clean. Instead, he said, to my face, that he wouldn't allow the Daiamid to retaliate. 'Nothing will happen to you, I promise,' he said." Taline effected a different tone of voice as she recited the words, each syllable dripping with contempt and hurt. "'If I have to stand up and declare war upon the emperor himself and all his secret assassins in the shadows then I will, but no harm will come to you. I promise.'" She scoffed then, crossing her arms.

"He didn't tell you something untrue," Catra said. "He just…wasn't fully honest with you." Catra understood how damaging even that much could be.

"He promised no harm would come to me without realizing that he'd caused me more pain and suffering than any blatant assassin ever could." Taline spoke with such force it felt to Catra like someone was driving a spike into her chest. "He was one of them, Catra. For *years*. For as long as him and I had known each other. For longer! The entire time, he was only pretending to be a Battlemage.

"These people served as the emperor's secret enforcers in the shadows. The La Valettes were just one instance, and if even a fraction of just the most believable stories I'd heard whispered about them up to that point were true, the atrocities they'd committed in the name of the empire would be enough to make even the most forgiving person sick with hatred."

She took a deep breath and smoothed her hair down, again. It was a nervous tick, one Catra hadn't ever seen her do before because she'd never thought Taline of all people could even have a nervous tick.

"I knew where his allegiance lay that day. If he'd come forward and told me who he was that day, I might have been inclined to believe him when he said he cared about me and cared about saving the galaxy. But he didn't." She shrugged, throwing her hands up and letting them fall back down to her sides like she were giving up on something and saying 'oh well.' "How was I supposed to believe anything he'd said or done after that if he couldn't even be forthright with me about who he *was*?"

Catra remembered wrestling with the same question when Adora first defected from the Horde—everything she'd come to believe about her growing up had been thrown into question. A betrayal like this wasn't something straightforward to come back from. And with Corynth having been believed to be dead up until only minutes earlier, it was clear Taline had no way of reconciling the

hurt. It had been festering for so long, she was certain it had turned into a knot of impossible to untangle emotions.

*At least with Adora, both of you are still alive, and there's the opportunity for your paths to cross again in the future.*

Taline had said that to comfort her back on Etheria, when Catra and Adora had their final falling out. Those words came back to her, this time laden with a newer, deeper, more painful meaning. Catra could finally, *finally* admit she was decidedly not over Adora and had not moved past their shared history at all. Merely entertaining the possibility she might really have died on that station when it exploded threatened to send her into new spirals of anxiety-stricken grief.

"So, he's alive," Catra said, pushing all other thoughts out of her head to focus on getting back to the original conversation. "Corynth. What now?"

Taline tapped a restless rhythm the table she was still leaning against. "Our mission to Archanas is too important to divert from," she said. "He had a hand in helping them crack the algorithm encrypting Moriarty's files, I'm just sure of it. We can't abandon that lead."

"Why do I get the feeling there's a 'but' coming in the next sentence?" Catra asked.

"But"—Taline smirked at Catra as she said it—"once we're done on Archanas, I'll need to set out again and hunt him down. He can't be allowed to live."

"But why, though?"

Taline shot her a genuinely puzzled look, and Catra sighed and shook her head in response.

"Why does he need to die? If he's alive now that means he's been alive for the past decade, too. It's not like he's been marauding around wreaking open havoc, and you two haven't actually talked

to each other in all this time either, just like Adora and I haven't. Why can't you just talk?"

"*Talk?*"

"Or start by talking, I don't know!" Catra flailed her arms in a vague gesture to try and get her point across. "You two haven't talked in all this time, just like Adora and I haven't, and unless I'm mistaken, he was trying to reason with you and ask you to come with them when they escaped with your sister, right? Why does step one have to be throwing lightning bolts?"

Taline scowled and that was all the proof Catra needed to know, yet again, she'd made a good point. Taline had never gotten the opportunity for her feelings of betrayal to be validated. Just like Catra's last conversation with Adora, they went their separate ways before reaching any sort of definite conclusion, each having to carry forward without any sense of closure good or bad. Adora had *just* reached out trying to mend things. Catra didn't want to see Taline kill any chance of possibly getting the same for herself.

"We didn't speak to one another after that day with the envoy," Taline said. "Not until the trial. I'd planned on confronting him after, thinking Evie would agree to research ignominite and comply with the emperor's wishes to avoid death. But she didn't. It never crossed my mind that she might refuse him, and before I knew it, they were trying to escape and *succeeding* at it. By then, the only thing I could think of was getting Evie away from Corynth. I still half believe he had her under some kind of spell and she hadn't made the decision to refuse Horde Prime of her own volition."

"Can he even do that?" The look on Taline's face when she asked was answer enough and Catra shook her head. "Never mind, I actually don't want to know if he can mind control people. What if he was telling you the truth then, though?"

"What do you mean?"

“What if he really did care about you? Lies and half truths aside, what if the relationship you had before everything fell apart was real? What if he believed Evelyn and that was why he backed her up to the extent he revealed the existence of the Daiamid to everyone? He already did that much with the La Valettes and he said he’d do as much again in order to protect you, didn’t he? What if he was sincere?”

“Catra—"

“He was part of a secretive group that committed countless atrocities, sure. He also kept that from you and broke any sense of trust you had for him, yes, but what if the only reason you or I or anyone else in this god’s forsaken galaxy is still alive is because he decided to step up and do the right thing when it really, *really* counted?”

Catra realized halfway through that she was repeating the same things she’d told herself when coming to terms with Adora’s betrayal, but this time to Taline on behalf of Corynth—someone she’d never actually met. Her breathing had turned labored, and she was gripping the leather of the chair she’d been sitting in so hard her claws were digging into the cushioning. Why was she pushing this so hard?

“What if one of you kills the other without either of you finding out the truth?” she asked.

Catra felt like Taline could see right through her the way she was looking at her. Much of her own feelings on redemption were getting tangled into this and she wasn’t doing a good job hiding it, she knew. She’d done horrible things as part of the Horde before Etheria came back into the wider universe and Taline had been the one to whisk her away from it all. Everything she’d built for herself was thanks in part to her.

A new, chilling thought came to her: was it fair to say she wasn’t deserving of those opportunities if Taline decided to dedicate her life once again to hunting down and executing someone else

who'd also supposedly committed atrocities as part of a belligerent group? Was all of her progress thus far just some casual fluke that the universe would invalidate soon enough? It didn't make any sense logically, of course, but it didn't have to. The feelings were real enough.

Taline must have read all of that too, because she shook her head, went to her, and put a firm hand on her shoulder to ground her.

"It's not like that," Taline said. "I have to kill him because he's too dangerous to be left alive, my personal feelings aside."

Catra looked up at her. "What do you mean?"

"He survived the final confrontation on Archanas. The Beast infestation there was so strong and concentrated, it turned the other few hundred Shapers there with him to ash before the Barrier sealed the thing away, remember? Corynth was powerful, immensely so, but even he has limits. Archanas still drives people mad years after its death. Do you really think anyone could survive having touched the thing when it was living? Do you think they have any chance of still being sane, still being themselves, if they had?"

Ah, now Catra understood. Whoever Adora was traveling with, even if it looked and talked and proclaimed itself to be Corynth, it likely wasn't the same person. Not really.

"You're to kill me if the Beast corrupts me," Taline said. "It's your duty as my Sentinel. It's my duty to kill Corynth, now that he's surely corrupted beyond saving. Abominations, especially powerful ones like he no doubt is, could easily blend in for a decade, even longer. I'm likely the only person alive strong enough to have a chance at destroying him. I'm probably not strong enough, truth be told, but the opportunity for us to have talked things out is… long in the past, I'm afraid."

Catra nodded. She couldn't point out why, but Taline's explanation just made her feel sad for her.

Taline gave Catra's should a squeeze. "There's something else."

Already that sounded bad. What else could there possibly be, after that? Catra tried to stamp down the knot of anxiety that was growing unchecked under her sternum.

"That message I took earlier also mentioned that we lost another planet to the Beast. Scavria."

"Scavria isn't that far from Archanas," Catra said, frowning. "They're both on the Kaloshi Border. How concerned is Imperial Command about the local Barrier node? It's within jumping distance, if I remember correctly"

"You are remembering correctly, and they're fairly concerned," Taline said with a sigh. "It also happens to be where Glimmer was deployed. An Abomination appeared in the capital city when they were on the verge of retaking it. The whole planet is lost."

That knot of anxiety turned into a dense stone that dropped into her stomach. "Don't tell me that Glimmer…"

"She's alive," Taline said quickly, shaking her head. "She's alive, but somehow escaped only after several hours of orbital bombardment. She's quarantined and receiving the best care aboard the *Omen-Kador,* the flagship. I happen to know the Admiral leading the detachment. He assured me she's in good health, but were being coy with the details."

Catra breathed a half sigh of relief. Glimmer was alright, thank god. But another planet lost? And this time to another confirmed Abomination? "Poor Glimmer," Catra said, biting her lip. "First Rinne and now this?"

"From what I've heard, it took them by surprise. They didn't want to say too much, but it seemed like the Beast was…different this time."

“Different how?”

“If I knew, I’d tell you,” Taline said. “We won’t be able to contact Glimmer yet until the mission is over. They blacked out all nonessential communications until the campaign officially concludes. But once they’ve bombarded the planet into submission, her assignment should be over and she’ll finally get her shore leave. Whatever happened there was likely traumatic—likely similar to Rinne, if not worse. She’ll need some time to adjust and it might be…rough at first when you see her again.”

“Whatever she needs,” Catra said, nodding. “And I’ll be there for her regardless.”

“I know you will.” Taline squeezed her shoulder a third time, and Catra used the gesture to drag herself out of spiraling thoughts and worries.

“Whatever it is that happened, both on Eden and on Scavria, we’ll find out,” Taline said. “If Adora is still alive, I promise you I won’t let anything else happen to her. Regardless of his motives, Corynth won’t have the chance to manipulating her anymore. Glimmer will come home, and if she needs something to help get her through her latest experiences, we’ll both be there to help her. It’s not all on you, I’m here as well. Ever since I took you from Etheria, I’ve been here and I will continue to be here. For you, for Glimmer, and soon for Adora.”

Pip floated into view and landed with dainty feet on top of Catra’s knee, looking up at her with a determined expression. Catra had forgotten she was there, but when Pip looked up at her with a determined expression and gave a single, firm nod as if to agree directly with Taline, she felt as if a weight had lifted from her shoulders.

“I know,” Catra reached up to lay her hand on top of Taline’s over her shoulder. “Thank you.”

Taline pulled away and, mentioning the need to check on the bridge as they make their arrival, left. Catra remained seated, watching her go. When the doors hissed shut and she was alone in Taline’s quarters, she slid over to the control console and played Adora’s message again from the beginning.

She and Pip watched the recording a fourth time and then a fifth. Neither said a word to one another.

Chapter End Notes

> Catra: *Doesn't admit how much she wanted to hear from Adora until she actually finally hears from Adora
> Taline: That station she was on blew up about 15 minutes after she sent that message.
> Catra: . . .!?
> Taline: Oh, don't worry, she's probably fine, unless Corynth got done with using her for whatever he's been up to. He's harmed too many people already and is incredibly dangerous. That's why I have to confront him when he shows. I will not let him harm Adora any further, if she's still alive.
> Catra: . . .!?!?
> Taline: . . . maybe I could have phrased all of this better, I'm sorry.
>
> We've gotten a "neutral" view of a bit of Taline and Corynth's history through Glimmer's chapters, and now some very biased recounting of their history from Taline. Of course, there's another major component to this we haven't heard from yet. I'll refrain from commenting on that any further, since we're right in the middle of revealing the pieces.
>
> One thing I will say though, is Taline is intentionally written to be kind of bad with people and relationships outside her job. She's a side OC, so all you get of her are glimpses from an outsider's (Catra's) pov. But she did mention being adopted and studying her ass off in school to become a Battlemage (part 1), there was a flashback with her and her sister where she couldn't even pretend to hold it together when her sister

started teasing her about a crush, and in this chapter she didn't quite catch onto the fact Catra was freaking out about Adora potentially having died because she was so focused on something else. By the time she realized what Catra was really worrying about, she'd already said a lot with very little tact.

Some of that can be attributed to mystique and audience distance since she has no POV chapters, but a lot of it is just because she's somewhat socially inept and clings *hard* to her identity as an aloof, powerful Battlemage who's somewhat of a mythical figure herself.

Anyways, enough about my OCs. Catra really is still pretty much in the middle of shock from actually hearing from Adora again and has had no time at all to process it. And if you think I'm going to give her ample breathing room with where she's going and what we're all careening toward in this part...hah :D

Adora chapter next! Thank you for reading!

# The Last Shaper of the Daiamid

Chapter Notes

> Last we saw Adora, she'd just discovered her unwitting travel partner Kallanthe was actually the famous Corynth, Last Shaper of the Daiamid and controversial war hero of the previous Beast War. Together, they escaped Eden shortly before its destruction. They are on their way to Phoenix Station to rebuild the version of Pip Corynth has been traveling with for the past 10+ years, and then use that reconstituted instance of Pip to seal the Beast away for good using ancient Eternain knowledge locked away in the Eye of Shukra.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora sat in the copilot's chair on the *Dzivia*, staring at the hyperspace tunnel bursting outside the view screens. The door at the back hissed open and she turned, already halfway out the seat to help Corynth. How had she not heard him wandering the ship, or noticed the empty infirmary bed on the security footage? She'd had it up on one of the forward screens specifically to keep an eye on him.

"I made it to the cockpit on my own," Corynth said, waving her off before she got to him. "I can make it to the chair on my own, too."

Adora settled back in, but didn't take his eyes off him as he made his way to the front. The fact he was up and about on his own without her constant help was a big improvement, but he still wasn't fully healed if the grimace on his face and subtle lines of exertion around his eyes as he lowered himself into the pilot's chair were any indication.

Adora let him settle in. With him having spent most of the previous days recuperating in the same medical bay she'd first

woken up in, it had fallen to her to learn how to make the sand-food concoctions in the kitchen for the both of them to eat. When she'd discovered boxes of ready-made snacks in one of the cupboards as well, she'd taken to carrying handfuls of them with her to eat whenever the mood struck.

A pile of such snack bars was sitting atop the dashboard, nearly depleted on account of her stress eating the previous hour. She grabbed one and held it out for him. Corynth took it with a muted 'thanks,' and Adora wordlessly tried to go back to what she'd been doing before he joined her: staring out at the hyperspace tunnel with a blank mind.

"What's up with you?" Corynth asked after an indeterminate amount of time had passed in silence.

Adora turned to him, her eyes trailing down at the unopened snack still sitting in his lap before flicking back to his face. He seemed to be looking straight through her, and she suddenly wished she could just disappear.

"Nothing's wrong," she said. "I'm fine."

"I didn't ask if anything was wrong," Corynth said. "I just asked what was up with you."

Adora frowned and tilted her head back until it lay flush against the headrest. Wasn't that the same thing? Playing semantics was the last thing she wanted to do, but then again, she'd always been a terrible liar anyways.

"I'm worried about them," she said. "Ly and Vasher. Eden looked like it blew apart seconds after we got free of it. I don't know if they got out in time."

"They're fine," Corynth said, adjusting himself in the pilot's chair the way someone did when their whole body still ached. "Trust me. They've escaped far worse situations, and have pulled me out of spots I didn't think I could get myself out of in the past as well. They'll have made it out."

Adora *hmm'd* but didn't say anything further. She hoped by not engaging and not even looking at him—by keeping her eyes trained on the tunnel in front of her—he'd stop probing her.

She wasn't being truthful with him. Sure, she'd been worried about Ly and Vasher—how could she not?—but she'd only told him that to hopefully keep him from finding out what was actually bothering her. As soon as it became apparent he'd recover from his injuries, or at least not die outright because of them after they'd escaped, something else had plagued her mind. And Corynth, with nothing but his silence, somehow was able to communicate to Adora that he knew all of this and was waiting for her to come clean.

"Do you think I'll get a response from Catra before we get to Phoenix Station?" she said instead, trying a second time to deflect.

Adora cringed the moment the words left her mouth. She'd already asked that question, and he had already answered it at least twice already. In the preceding days, Corynth had asked about her history with Catra, and she'd told him everything. And he'd helped get her anxiety over not hearing back—or worse, being actively rejected after so many years apart—to a manageable state, so the fact she was still deflecting again was even more obvious than the comment about Ly and Vasher.

"What is it really?" he asked. "You can ask me anything you'd like."

Adora closed her eyes and drew in a deep breath. "Why didn't you tell me who you really were?"

She felt like she was about to throw up. If she saw distrust—or worse, apathy—on his face after finally mustering the courage to confront him about this, she might just die. She didn't want to open her eyes, didn't want to look at him. Part of her knew she was being perhaps a little overdramatic, but she'd *just* come to admit she was grateful for having traveled off Etheria with him

despite how rough of a start they got. Finding out he didn't feel the same would be catastrophic.

"I don't distrust you, if that's what you're worried about," Corynth said, gentler than Adora would have expected. She still didn't look at him.

"I only attacked you the first time we met, chased after you, damaged your ship, then acted very distrusting of *you* when you patched me up afterward. But it's not because you distrust me." Adora gave a self-deprecating laugh. "Of course not."

Corynth chuckled wit her and that only put her more on guard. She whirled in the chair to face him, a sharp comment defending herself from his teasing already on the tip of her tongue. When she saw his smirk and the mirth sparkling in his eyes, though, she came up short.

"You stared me down when I was helping deliver Entrapta's equipment, but I got away before you could do anything," he said. "Technically we fought the second time we met, if you're counting by the number of times you saw me, too. More if not."

"We crossed paths before then?"

"Did you forget that I was wandering all around Etheria for three years before you realized I was there?"

Adora crossed her arms and pouted, and Corynth laughed again.

"I'd heard all about you and had seen you in person several times already before you ever noticed me," he said. "Even if we weren't on good terms, and even if you didn't trust me, I knew you wouldn't betray me if I'd told you my name wasn't really Kallanthe."

"Then why didn't you say anything?" she asked. "I probably wouldn't have found out at all if that Abomination showed up. You would have just continued to pretend to be Kal." The look on his

face told her she was right, and her stomach plummeted. "Why keep me in the dark if not because you don't trust me?"

Her eyes burned with unshed tears and she was convinced anything he said or didn't say would end with her crying. Corynth took a deep breath and leaned back in his chair to stare at the hyperspace tunnel. Suddenly, he looked older and much more tired.

"I just didn't know what to do and ended up saying nothing at all," he said at last. "You were already on edge and I worried telling you would make it worse. Not because I didn't trust you, but because I know *you* didn't trust *me*. Any way I thought to put it, I was convinced it would just make things worse, so I didn't say anything." He frowned and glanced sidelong at her. "Truthfully, it's never gone well in the past, either."

Surprisingly, this answer got Adora more curious than upset. Him not saying anything because he'd worried she didn't trust him instead of the other way around made sense, but…

"I would have been quicker to trust you if you told me who you were from the start," she said.

"Really?"

"Yes! Why does it sound like you don't believe me?"

"I have a hard time believing things people tell me."

He'd said it like he was telling her what he'd eaten for breakfast, and Adora narrowed her eyes at him in disbelief. "You've seen some of the most outlandish things to ever happen in the galaxy, things that probably break the laws of physics, and you say you have a hard time believing what people *say*?"

Corynth shrugged and Adora tilted her head up to the cockpit ceiling and groaned. This man was a frustrating enigma, but he'd assuaged her fears about being distrusted or disliked, at least. And if someone with his life experience and power could get hung

up on such trivial, pedestrian issues, then maybe her struggles with her powers weren't such a far-fetched thing, either.

"What did you mean when you said it's never gone well for you in the past?" Adora asked. "Are you talking about Taline? Salas had told me she was meant to join the Daiamid but fought against you after Evelyn was put on trial."

To her surprise and relief, Corynth seemed to already know Salas had fed her information. "That's an example of it working out poorly when I chose not to tell someone who I was. Before that, everything fell apart after I *did* tell someone who I was." Corynth pursed his lips and drummed his fingers on the armrest of the chair. "Damned if I do, damned if I don't. Me not saying anything to you wasn't personal, Adora."

"I know it wasn't," she said, "but what happened before, when you did tell someone? I've never heard that story before."

Corynth laughed. "You wouldn't have. It's not something most anyone would know, actually. Even when I was one of the most wanted people in the empire for a time, they couldn't propagandize that story to demonize me to the public either. I doubt anyone other than those who know me personally, know that story."

Adora shifted in her seat, timid. "What happened?"

"You actually want to know?"

Of course she wanted to know, but Adora didn't trust herself to speak. She nodded once, and the look on Corynth's face betrayed his surprise. Or was it skepticism? She hoped it was surprise and not actually a reluctance to tell a story he apparently only shared with friends. What would it mean if he refused her, then? Adora didn't want to think about it, so she instead forced herself to utter, "Please," to hopefully nudge him to speak.

Finally—*finally*—Corynth spoke and told her everything. He told her how he'd been born into the secretive Daiamid sect, knew

nothing about anything except what they groomed him for and, after initiating into their ranks as a full member, went on assassination mission after assassination mission as decreed by the emperor whom he served. Adora listened with rapt attention as he explained how, after a time, they'd sent him to exterminate a highly influential family—an aristocratic lineage called House La Valette with ties reaching back to the very founding of the empire.

"This was different from the other assignments," he said. "Those were quick kills. This time, though, Prime wanted the entire family line gone in one go and he wanted it to look like an accident. Politically speaking, they were very powerful, which was part of the reason why he wanted them gone to begin with. The job took planning. There was infiltration on my part over the course of months to earn their trust."

"You didn't want to kill them once you got to know them," Adora said. Strange that she could guess where the story was going before he'd explained, but something about the person she'd come to know—both over the course of their adventures and from how his friends spoke of him—told her that's what had happened.

Corynth gave a humorless laugh and when he spoke, Adora could hear the bitterness tingeing his voice. "Imagine growing up in a death cult only to finally grow a conscience as a teenager. It would have been easier if I'd just become a fully entrenched psychopath like I was supposed to."

"Something tells me everyone would have died long time ago if that was the case."

"Like I said, it would have been easier. Dead people don't have hardships. They're dead."

The morbidity in his words shook Adora. It sounded like something he'd joke about, but she couldn't hear any hint of a joke in his voice and that scared her. He didn't really believe that, did he?

“I told them who I was,” Corynth said, bringing her back. “The La Valettes. I told them what I was there to do, and I tried to help them escape their fate. The Daiamid just sent someone else to finish the contract. As for me…the penalty for revealing the Daiamid’s existence to any unsanctioned outsider was death. They sent me to one of the empire’s black-site research stations as ‘security.’” He made air quotes, and the disdain in his voice was plain as he continued.

“At the time, serving on one of those stations was a guaranteed death sentence because Evelyn still hadn’t invented a reliable way to contain the Beast with ignominite yet. The plan back then was to progress with research before an infection inevitably broke out and everyone was killed, then another team with another two-to-four-month window would carry that research forward until a breakthrough.” He laughed, and it was derisive, sneering, and cold. “They didn’t plan on me or anyone else surviving the outbreak. I met Evelyn on that station, actually. I protected her when the outbreak occurred. No one else had been able to do such a thing. Not even my brothers and sisters who had condemned me.”

Corynth kept his eyes forward, staring out at the hyperspace tunnel as if it were the one reciting the story and his body were merely a vessel to convey the words. Unshed tears made his eyes look glossy, and they reflected the brilliant kaleidoscope of colors from the tunnel.

Adora didn’t take her eyes off him. She didn’t think she could if she’d tried.  For all the information littering the empire about him, the sheer humanity on display before her was staggering. This wasn’t the version of Corynth she’d come to know from the empire’s propaganda.

“I told the La Valettes of my true identity hoping to spare them death, yet death came for them all the same. Evelyn found who I really was after the station succumbed, too,” he said. “How could she not? Death came for her, too, in the end. Although, it took a little longer.”

Adora's jaw hinged open, appalled. "You saved her!" she said. "You saved her, and she was able to research things that saved trillions more lives. We're on our way to shore up the Barrier *right now* and end the Beast threat forever, something she discovered only because you saved her in the first place!"

Corynth smile was forced. "She said the same thing, years ago. I didn't even bring the subject up, she just sensed I had a lot on my mind one day and said that to me."

Adora pressed her lips into a thin line and refrained from saying anything further. What more could she say if the truth didn't work? She'd been unable to reach Catra with it when she'd defected from the Horde, too. The only difference between her from then and now was now she was older and a little wiser. Now she understood that rational truth frequently did nothing productive in the face of emotion, and thus she could understand Corynth's pessimism.

"I promised myself to do it differently with Taline," he said. "Something had happened on Archanas, and the Daiamid reached out to recruit her. Evelyn wanted me to reveal my association with them before they did…she was worried Taline wouldn't take their visit well. I didn't want a repeat of what they had done to me the first time I broke their rules, especially with Evelyn and Taline's lives potentially on the line if it went bad. I promised I'd tell her after they made contact with her first.

"She killed our envoy." Corynth shook his head in disbelief with a smile and twinkling, reminiscing eyes. "I'd run every scenario in my head thinking up the best way to tell her who I was, thinking about how best to acclimate her to the idea of the Daiamid after they'd revealed themselves to her, but her outright *killing* the envoy had never once crossed my mind. I wasn't even mad, I was amazed. I remember still having a hard time believing she'd done it even as I stared at his body lying in two separate corners of the room. And even though I wanted to, I couldn't tell her who I was. Not after that."

“Why not?” Adora asked.

“Because they were going to come for her. She spurned the invitation. They’d told her about what they did the La Valettes without implicating me, and Taline had decided if they could do away with such a powerful family with impunity, then it was only a matter of time before she’d fall victim to them out of revenge. She’d almost died killing the first one they’d sent.”

“But she’s not dead,” Adora said. “She’s alive, and all of the Daiamid except for you are dead.”

“Funny how that works, isn’t it? She was in danger, but they couldn’t come after her so soon after what had happened.” A reader on the cockpit beeped, indicating they’d traveled another AU closer to their destination. “Taline’s name had taken off like wildfire through the galaxy because of what she’d reportedly done on a recently infected world. You couldn’t go twenty minutes on even a backwater imperial settlement without hearing one story or another of the newly minted Seraph of Archanas. Those who led the Daiamid, the Old Guard, they knew that killing her then would only bring unwanted scrutiny that not even they could avoid. So, they played the long game. They wanted the fervor around her exploits to die down first, then kill her and make it look like an accident out in the field.”

“No one would think twice about her dying on another world fighting off a Beast infection,” Adora said. “It’d still draw attention, but it wouldn’t seem strange and the narrative would stick.”

Corynth nodded.

“What changed, then?” Adora asked. “You showed your hand at Evelyn’s trial. When Horde Prime ordered her executed for choosing to pursue research on the Barrier instead of follow his orders, *you* were in charge of the Daiamid. You revealed the entire sect to everyone watching. Every one of your brothers and sisters in that room followed *your* lead to protect her, not anyone else’s.”

“What changed is I became their new leader.” Corynth finally looked at her, and the glint in his eyes sent a shiver down her spine. The expressiveness of his face had gone, replaced with a mask as hard and cold as steel. “The Old Guard led through merciless brutality and were insulated from outside contact. It took planning and subterfuge on my end in order to get close enough to assassinate them and take over. It took time.”

Adora swallowed. “H-how did you pull it off?”

“I went along with their plans to kill Taline. In fact, I made myself a key component of those plans. I was an outcast after having survived my death sentence, so I portrayed someone desperate to regain favor in the Old Guard’s eyes. Because Taline and I were… involved, I put myself forward as a direct line to her. Any and all information about her whereabouts, her standing in the public—everything—I gave it to them. And shortly before Evelyn’s trial, I’d succeeded. I had curried enough favor to gain a direct audience.

“I murdered the entire Old Guard. All of them and their sympathizers, all at once. The most powerful and accomplished members of the Daiamid together could not stand up to me. Brutality and mercilessness was their legacy, so I killed them in a manner befitting that legacy. Some of my brothers and sisters were kind. Some were driven to do horrible things out of fear and ignorance of a different way despite how they wished they didn’t have to.

“I’d tried to emulate that for myself once, but”—he broke eye contact and drew in a shaky breath—“I ended up getting crushed all the same. It wasn’t until I came back with a bigger stick, for lack of a better phrase, that things could change. I executed the Old Guard in a way that freed those with empathy from murdering, and demanded complete obedience, if not begrudging respect, from everyone else who valued their lives.”

“And with everyone in line, either through fear or true respect, Taline was no longer in danger,” Adora said.

"It came at great cost, but…yes. Telling her of my involvement and identity before taking over wasn't an option, since it would have only put her at further risk. My support for Evelyn, my decision to rebuke the emperor and reveal our existence to the public, it was a declaration of a new course I intended to take the Daiamid as an organization. It worked, since everyone either followed or fell in line and Evelyn's science team were able to complete their research on the Barrier, but…"

"You lost Taline."

Corynth nodded. "Among other things, but yes. The moment she found out who I was, I lost her." He paused, then, "I'm sorry I didn't tell you."

Adora's eyes stung with welling tears. She no longer blamed him for keeping secrets. Hell, she wasn't even upset at it having happened now that she had context. Instead, there was pain in his voice despite the look lingering in his eyes, and that had done enough to move her despite him turning his gaze back to the hyperspace tunnel.

"You know, Vasher and Ly would leave me in the cockpit for hours like this when we ran smuggling jobs," he said. "Ly was the pilot, but she often gave me the space during transit. I'd stare out the viewscreen the whole time."

"It is oddly therapeutic once you get used to it," Adora said, for lack of anything better.

"Sometimes, if I stare long enough, I can almost hear her voice again. Taline has a beautiful singing voice, believe it or not, but I'd rarely ever hear it since she'd get embarrassed letting anyone listen. Usually, she'd be distracted with some chore and start humming to herself, forgetting anyone was there for a moment.

"Sometimes, it'd be the only thing that would help me get to sleep, and then she'd get mad-but-not-actually-mad at me for falling asleep in the middle of the day. She'd never actually wake

me up once she realized I'd dozed off." He closed his eyes and leaned his head back against the headrest. "It's been so many years since I'd last heard her sing. And I'm so very, very tired."

The steel in his eyes had faded, leaving nothing left. Even the beautiful colors of the hyperspace tunnel barely reflected there anymore, leaving him lifeless and empty, and Adora finally turned fully away to wipe quickly at the tears that had fallen down her cheeks. It had been a long time since she'd cried in earnest, and despite how she hated the feeling, something deep inside her began to unravel. Something she hadn't realized was knotted there to begin with.

"I should thank you," Corynth said after a moment.

Adora started to speak, then cleared her throat when her words came out thick and raspy. "Thank me for what?"

"I'd run out of motivation after Pip failed to decode the Eye," he said. "When you first confronted me in your castle, that was supposed to be the end of my mission. Pip was to bring the Barrier up to full strength with what she'd pull from the Eye. When that failed and the castle attacked us, that was the last straw for me. I was discouraged, and I saw no way to come back from it."

He turned back to her and Adora nearly hid her face from him again, until she saw that the light in his eyes had come back, and he was smiling at her.

"Seeing you leap four stories in the air just to catch me got me going again, so, thank you for the inspiration."

"I put a hole in your ship, dude. Then I yelled at you while you made me food." Adora grinned when that pulled a laugh out of him. All the heaviness from earlier had evaporated. She felt light.

"Both of these are true," Corynth said, playing with the still unopened snack bar in his lap. "If seeing you reawaken your powers just to chase me helped kick me into high gear, then

putting up with you for the first leg of our journey kept me occupied enough not to slip back."

Adora pursed her lips. "Partially reawaken my powers," she said, correcting him as their shift in top jogged her memory. "Wait, you can help me with that! Salas told me."

Corynth paused. "Salas…told you what, exactly?"

"I was struggling so much I went to talk to him. He said my powers, the way I draw them from my runestone, it's not dissimilar to how you and the Daiamid shape your own magic. He said that Taline would have made a good teacher since she was supposed to join, but you're here now. You can help me."

She bounced in the chair from excitement, and wondered why Corynth didn't seem as enthused.

He grimaced and said, "Salas was making a lot of assumptions."

Adora's bouncing slowed, then stopped. "Is that not how your powers work, pulling it from a source?"

"It's an oversimplification. And even if it weren't, there isn't much I could do to help with your specific problem."

Salas was wrong? He couldn't be wrong; he was the only one who'd had anything helpful to say in the first place. Even Angella had vouched for him. "I don't understand," she said.

Corynth gave her what she thought was a sympathetic look. "How do you imagine the magic works in the first place, yours and mine?"

Adora chewed her lip and gave him the best rundown she could: that on Etheria, princesses like her and Glimmer drew it from their runestones to manipulate freely as they saw fit, while sorcerers like Micah would draw runes. Micah had explained it once, how Etherian and Enclave sorcerers used magic in similar. Admittedly,

she didn't know nearly as much as she thought she might have, given how little she could explain beyond that.

"The magic taught at Mystacor is a branch of Enclave magic, this is true," Corynth said. "It was interesting researching the similarities while I was there. There are variations and dialectical differences in the actual runes they use and the effects those spells engender, but they are indeed cousins of a sort. Even the pedagogy that drive the education of Enclave and Mystacor initiates are similar."

Adora had somehow forgotten Corynth was not only a mythically powerful magic user, but had also traveled for years to every kingdom on Etheria before having officially met. There was a reason he'd been able to successfully masquerade as a Battlemage to Taline in the decades prior, too. Seeing this expertise come out in explicit terms, however, was jarring compared to how he'd normally acted with her so far. It might have given her hope for maybe learning to unlock her powers from him, too, if he hadn't already cast doubt on it.

"Transmutation of energy is difficult," he said. "In all forms of teaching, it's something that takes normal mages years of dedicated study and practice with runes to pull off. You Etherian princesses can do the same without the need to draw complicated circuitry first, provided you have an adequate source of energy such as your runestones. Doing even that much is an incredible feat of magical skill."

"And the Daiamid?" Adora asked. "You said the similarities Salas told me about were an oversimplification."

"We were known for casting powerful spells without the need for runes or a store of magic energy. We 'shaped' reality as we saw fit, purely from the strength of our will."

"Okay…" Adora chewed her lip. "So, I get the link between Mystacor and the Enclave, but it still sounds like there is some sort of connection between the Daiamid and the princesses."

"I never said there isn't, I just said what Salas told you was an oversimplification. Once you access the magic in your runestones, the way you wield that magic is similar to how I shape mine."

It should have been good news, since it seemed to Adora like a good reason for Corynth to be able to help her. The expression on his face, however, still didn't give her hope.

"My people were once a dominant power in the galaxy thousands of years ago," he said. "Before Horde Prime, we warred with the Eternians—your ancestors. Etheria was one of their colonies before it disappeared, and it was rife with magic energy back then, even more than it is today.

"I'm not sure how exactly those runestones were first created. Looking back in time with Evelyn never did yield answers, but whether they were a byproduct of Eternian technology or a natural occurrence that they merely harnessed, I'm not sure. What I *am* sure of, however, is that the Eternians took inspiration from my people, from our Shaper Kings of Old, when forging connections to those runestones. Connections that are hereditary to each kingdom's princess and now underly the foundation of their power, generations later."

Adora still didn't understand what the problem was. "If we cast the same way, then why can't you help me?"

"Because we *don't* cast the same, Adora," he said, agitated. "It is similar but not the same, and if you think that is too pedantic a difference to matter then you haven't been paying attention to the lessons you received back home. The Eternians didn't copy us, especially after they found out how the old Shapers' magic worked, they only reverse engineered what they could to better arm themselves against us in a conflict. Their choice to tie the execution of their magic to runestones was deliberate."

Adora narrowed her eyes at him. "You killed an Abomination before it had the chance to infect an entire settlement. Why do I get the sense that's not even scratching the surface of what

you're capable of? I only held out against it for a handful of seconds." When he didn't respond, at first, she doubled down. "What exactly is the extent of your power?"

He laughed and said, "At this point, it'd probably be easier to categorize things I can't do, rather than the extent of things I can." Adora didn't laugh with him and he sobered. "Not everyone in the old Daiamid kingdoms were sorcerers. Much like the dichotomy between Enclave mages and their standing army, there were rank and file Daiamid soldiers who couldn't perform magic, led by those who could.

"And just as there is a distinction between an Enclave mage and an Enclave Battlemage—between those who assist Salas and Salas himself—among the old Daiamid Sorcerors, there were only a handful of Shaper Kings. Exceptionally powerful individuals that gained the power to shape reality itself after surviving an initiation ritual.

"In their hubris, they eventually fell. And once Horde Prime had conquered the known galaxy, he'd kept a small number of rank-and-file Daiamid sorcerers who swore fealty to him, exploiting their more-than-capable rune-less spellcasting for his own benefit, enshrouding them in mystery and employing them for clandestine assassinations and espionage assignments. He called them 'Shapers,' perhaps as a way to subtly mock the old rulers he'd toppled, but the true Shaper Kings would never have bowed to him and so all were exterminated. Those that remained in the emperor's faction were fake."

"And what about you?"

"I am genuine," he said, fixing her with a grave look. "I am the first in countless generations to wield the old magic in its purest form. I can bend the fabric of reality itself to my will. I can create fire from nothing and have it burn so hot it turns a person to ash within an instant. I can accelerate the flow of time and turn that same person to atoms instead of ash. If I so desire, I can reach back through time and enmesh it with our current reality."

He leaned toward Adora and she shied away from him, unsure of what else to do in the face of his sudden intensity. "The great hall of some decrepit ancient castle can manifest newly built once again if I so desire, as can the people inside who once walked its halls but now lay buried in the ground. I could make them appear as they were thousands of years ago, drinking and singing and reveling with their loved ones. Here and now, should I but desire it strongly enough."

Adora scowled at him. "Why don't you just 'wish' the Beast away, then? If your so powerful you could resurrect the dead, why are we doing this whole song and dance running around the galaxy trying to seal it away with some giant crystal?"

"Where do you think the knowledge of all the old magic comes from? The power to do all of that?"

"Your powers come from the Beast?"

He gave her a blank look and Adora slammed two fists down on her chair's armrests.

"Are you fucking kidding me? Is it here because of you? Did you bring it?"

Corynth shook his head. "No. I became this way because of it. I didn't bring it here."

Adora watched him again, looking for any sign of a lie. She found none, although she didn't trust her skill in reading faces enough to say for sure whether or not he was telling the truth. She sat back, crossing her arms and thought, trying to ignore how her heart raced.

"Your runestone is a receptacle for your powers," Corynth said. He reached into the folds of his shirt to extract the blood-red ignominite crystal Ly had given him on Eden, containing the pieces of the Beast she'd extracted from the Eye of Shukra. "If we were to use the same analogy, then this would be like a runestone for me."

“But you don’t need a runestone or apeiron or any other receptacle to use your powers,” Adora said. “You just told me. You were even able to cast back on Etheria before you had that.”

“Yes, well it was just an analogy to help explain,” he said, stowing the crystal away again. “Maybe a bad analogy. Anyway, when the Beast infected the Evie’s first research station—the same station I had been assigned to die on—I saved her from succumbing to the infection. And when I did that, I inadvertently completed the ancient ritual none of my people had been able to perform since Prime’s ascension. Because I somehow retained my sense of self, I became one of my people’s fabled Shaper Kings of old. The first in thousands of years.”

Adora considered that, the tension in her shoulders and adrenaline in her veins lessening the more she realized Corynth’s explanation of things made sense and was consistent. She was grateful they hadn’t devolved into another shouting match based on distrust for one another. “Now I understand how Salas’ explanation might have oversimplified things,” she said. “But I still think you can help me.”

She wasn’t about to let it go that easily. She’d run herself ragged for years trying for even the smallest of breakthroughs. She’d had several since leaving Etheria with him and was within grasping distance of another; she’d be damned if she let the opportunity just slip by.

“I know, I know,” she said when Corynth looked unconvinced. “Our powers work similarly but are fundamentally different. I get mine from a rock, and you get yours from some inter-dimensional eldritch horror that’s consuming our galaxy, fine. I might not know exactly how that works, but the point is, we both cast magic and the method through which you get it to work is the same as mine. You think of something, wish for something, ‘will’ it to happen, so to speak, and it happens. I used to be able to do the same with my runestone. I used to be able to call on She Ra and transform at will, and now I can’t.”

Adora felt as if the fate of the galaxy rested on how Corynth responded. The thought seemed dire, and for once she hoped she was just catastrophizing her feelings as per usual.

"How exactly do you imagine me helping?" he asked at last.

Adora scrunched up her nose like she'd smelled something repulsive. "I can't believe I'm actually going to say this and give her credit, but Shadow Weaver helped get me through a particularly nasty block when I was trying to heal her. She explained exactly what was going on with me up in here"—she pointed to her head—"and guided me through the emotions and how to respond to them in the moment until I figured it out. Maybe you could do the same for me?"

She'd expected him to think it over, or worse, expected to see a refusal plain on his face. Instead, he looked away again and started playing with the wrapper of the still-unopened snack she'd given him. Was he…uncomfortable?

"There's something else, isn't there?" she asked. "What haven't you told me?"

"The Eternian's decision to tie their most powerful rulers to Etheria's runestones was a deliberate choice, like I said, but they only came to that decision after too many failed attempts to recreate our method of casting magic in full, first."

Adora didn't like what that implied. "Explain."

"We are Masters of the Universe." Corynth effected an official tone that told Adora he was reciting something from memory. "We shape that which is. Reality persists at our sole discretion, and it is by our sole discretion that reality may change. To affect this power without the belief one is worthy of it—to put on the airs of a Shaper but hold not the substance of one within your heart of hearts—it is the height of hubris. It is anathema. It is Abomination."

A beat passed between them. "Sound familiar?" he asked.

Adora shook her head.

“That is the first stanza of the Daiamid initiation ritual,” he said. “It’s more of a warning, really, to those who would take it on. It involved calling forth a strain of the World Eater, as we’d called it. If you survived touching it, if you kept your sense of self after it attempted to subsume you, then you were proclaimed ‘Shaper,’ able to wield power beyond recognition through the old magic. If you failed and the Beast took you instead, you were an Abomination, and subsequently executed before you could spread your corruption to others.”

He pointed to himself and said, “The only difference between myself and any of the countless Abominations that sprung up during the last war is that I was strong enough, both magically and in my self-identity, to survive being touched by the Beast. They were not.”

“Alright...” Adora said. She wasn’t sure what significance she was supposed to have gleaned from that. Why would that make Corynth hesitate to help her?

“The forbidden archives on Mystacor have written instructions on how to perform what’s known as the Spell of Obtainment. That stanza prefaces those instructions too. It’s the same text, warning practitioners of the risks involved in invoking the spell.”

“No.” Adora pressed herself further into the chair and squeezed her eyes shut. Micah had told her the story of ‘Light Spinner’ and what the Spell of Obtainment had turned his mentor—her foster mother—into. “No, no, no.”

“I understand it might be a lot to take in,” he said in a gentle voice. “But it’s true. The ties between Mystacor, the Enclave, and the Daiamid are concrete. If there—"

“Shadow Weaver is a Shaper?” Adora fixated on him, searching even harder this time for any sign of a lie, this time hoping to find one.

"Technically she is," Corynth said. "While it did leave her malformed, from what I've heard, she retained her individuality. She is considered one of us." He reached up and tapped his forehead with his index finger. "She even made a mask for herself in our same style. Probably to hide her disfigurement, sure, but the design had all the ritual and symbolic markers."

Adora deflated, unsure of what to say, unsure of what to think. Maybe she'd never get up from that chair again. Shadow Weaver had been a sore subject even when she was still around, and the one silver lining to the pressures of the previous few years was that Adora had used it as excuse to pack everything 'Shadow Weaver' into a box in her head and shove it far, *far* down in her head. These revelations about her lust for power and its abstract ties to the man sitting next to her made her impossible to ignore anymore.

She'd used that magic to torture Catra. Torture Glimmer. Nearly wipe her own memory! The power to inflict that came from the same source Corynth had used to save everyone on Eden? Save her at the Crystal Castle? The very same source that had been eating away at the galaxy for years, planet by planet and system by system?

She was so in her head she startled when Corynth moved out the corner of her vision. He was holding out the snack bar she'd first offered him for her to take. It was such a random gesture she didn't know how to respond, at first. She stared at it and at the ignominite manacle still clasped over his wrist.

"That's for you," she said, once she'd found her voice.

"Yes, but I'm not hungry. And knowing you, you're probably moments away from starvation anyways, despite that mountain of opened wrappers on the dash."

Indignation flared in her chest. Adora looked up from the shackle to scowl at him, only for that indignation to sputter out when she saw the smile on his face. His eyes now sparkled with more color

and warmth than it possibly could have, were it merely reflecting the hyperspace tunnel. His eyes flicked past her, over her shoulder and ostensibly to the mountain of opened snack bar wrappers he'd mentioned before—remnants of her stress eating in the moments before he'd joined her in the cockpit.

Sheepish and embarrassed to the extent she could feel her flush on her cheeks, she reached for the snack bar only for him to hold fast to it when she tried to pull it from his grip.

"You know, in my culture, those masks were a symbol of your true self," he said, ignoring the confused look Adora gave him. "An enemy removing it in battle was symbolic of defeat. Removing it yourself for them to see your face was a sign you saw them as an equal. Leaving it behind was tantamount to death.

"Symbolically, of course, although we didn't see much difference between the symbolic and the literal. To us, a major setback could be just that, or it could be an analogy for something deep inside that needed tending to first. It all depended on how you looked at it."

"Are you going to give me the snack or not?" Adora tugged again and he still didn't let go.

"There's nothing wrong with your powers," he said, catching her eye and making her still before she gave up in a huff. "And there's nothing wrong with *you* for not being able to use them reliably. Remember the ritual? 'To affect the power without believing you are worthy' is wrong. You aren't in danger of becoming an Abomination, but it will still cause problems if your head and your heart aren't in the right place. It's not as easy as drawing a rune correctly or throwing a punch with the correct technique or passing some test, and that's the point. Your belief in yourself and your self-identity are much more complicated to resolve issues between."

"I've been trying for three years and have nothing to show for it!" She pulled at the snack bar again and growled at him, finally

throwing her hands up in exasperation and abandoning any pretense of taking it back when *still* he didn't let it go. He chuckled at her frustration which just made her bristle.

"You've spent those years exercising to the point of overtraining, getting next to no sleep, ruminating endlessly every day about the end of the world and how you don't have results, and you're surprised you haven't made as much progress as you'd hoped? Do you think Catra has all her issues resolved after all this time, either?"

Adora scoffed and folded her arms. "Catra has a mentor, a job, and friends. She's fine. Better off than she'd ever been with me in her life."

"I doubt that."

Again, his voice sounded so calm and patient and understanding, Adora had relaxed before she'd realized it. He offered her the snack bar again, and this time, he let her have it she tried to take it.

"You've made progress getting your powers back," he said. "That progress will continue, you just have to breathe. Give yourself the space to work through it on your own time, instead of rushing for some arbitrary end goal like being able to transform at will."

Adora was about to say she didn't have the luxury of taking her time when he held up a hand to head her off.

"And before you argue about needing your powers back quickly to fight the Beast, no, you don't. We'll arrive at Phoenix soon enough. Once the Barrier is shored up with the algorithm contained within the Eye, the Beast will never come through again. And if that of all things fails to work for whatever reason, then I am still here to help. I just can't help *you* with *your* powers —there's no secret technique or incantation."

He put his hand on her knee and squeezed. It was reassuring. Firm. Something stable she could anchor to amidst the turmoil still

roiling in her head.

"Thank you," she said, lowering her eyes and speaking quietly.

He nodded. "It's a journey you need to traverse for yourself and no one else, but that doesn't mean you're alone, Adora. We'll figure it out together, and I won't just abandon you. I'm not trying to lose any more friends."

Friends? Were they friends now?

Adora busied herself with opening the wrapper to the snack bar and tried not to show how much the words affected her. The rational part of her knew she had plenty of friends back home. Bow had even managed to break through her walls at intermittent periods and allow her to *feel* like she had friends, not just know she did.

She would have been happy moments earlier to walk away with someone she could refer to as a mentor. 'Friends' was not something that had crossed her mind to even hope for with Corynth given their short history, and yet, he'd been the one to label them as such.

Adora hummed to herself as she took her first bite, unable to wipe the small smile on her face away. She was friends with Corynth, the Last Shaper of the Daiamid.

Outstanding.

Chapter End Notes

> Whew, I feel like this entire part so far has either been whirlwind action, dense, *dense,* dialogue-heavy infodumps, or both at the same time.
>
> The concept for the Beast as an entity was pulled from an old videogame I was obsessed with as a kid, but the in-universe lore for what the Beast is and where it comes from--its ties to the actual show canon thru the Spell of Obtainment and its

role in disfiguring Shadow Weaver--were points I'd outlined very early on in the original drafting stages of this novel. I think it might have been the second or third thing I'd established originally as a headcannon when writing the first draft back in January/February-ish 2020.

Personally, I don't think Corynth is absolved of all guilt, but it sure complicates things. Maybe you can fault him for not trusting his girlfriend to be let in on the secret without further endangering her life, maybe you can see they already almost killed her, already succeeded in killing an extremely powerful family despite his intervention and he didn't want to take chances. Either way, if you're sitting there thinking "dang that's a hard call and I wouldn't want to be in his shoes" then I've achieved what I'd hoped to :)

Having him sit there being depressed he never hears her singing voice actually got me sad while I was writing it, and I could totally imagine Adora thinking a similar thing about Catra years in the future if they never make up.

# Security at the Hangar

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You did not. Tell me you didn't do that, Adora. *Tell me*."

Corynth stared slack-jawed at Adora from the pilot's seat, the hyperspace tunnel outside the cockpit reflecting against his face. Hours had passed since he'd first joined her there earlier, but they were hours that had passed quickly. Except for one break Adora had used to dispose of the mountain of snack wrappers she'd collected and make a trip to the kitchen to bring back more, they'd spent the entire time talking.

Adora snorted. "Every inch of my body burned, and I swear I thought my hair was going to fall out it was so caustic. I had never seen Mermista that angry before when she found out what he'd done. She looked ready to grab one of his ears and twist it off, like he was some unruly child and she was his extremely angry mother."

"Did it help, at least?"

"No! I couldn't even concentrate enough to tell if the tingling on my skin was because my powers might have been coming back, or if it was his salve I'd slathered on. My skin turned as red as Scorpias claws for a whole week after, too."

Corynth shook his head, incredulous. "I heard about that 'spiritual retreat' with Perfuma and what you did to that noble in her court —"

"I didn't do anything to them, it was totally a consensual thing."

"—And I'm pretty sure I was there when you tried to call She Ra by holding a wooden practice sword. But that? That is the craziest story by far. I heard everything else gossiped about back on

Etheria, but how am I just now finding out about your experiments with caustic salve?"

"I swore any witnesses to secrecy," Adora said. "Like, really swore. If Sea Hawk looked scared of Mermista after what she did to him, it didn't compare to the way he looked at me when I told him what would happen if anyone found out. Even Mermista looked shocked."

"Makes sense."

Corynth nodded, but didn't say anything further. Just as Adora relaxed in the chair and got comfortable with the silence, he spoke again as if a new thought jumpstarted him to life.

"How would that even work? I mean…Adora." He sounded appalled in such a comical way Adora couldn't help the smile that broke across her face. "What in the world went through that head of yours when you agreed to try *that*?"

"I don't know! I was really that desperate to get in touch with She Ra again. I tried literally *anything*." She shot him a scandalized look when his shoulders started to shake. "Don't make fun of me! You promised you wouldn't when I agreed to tell you the story."

They bickered with each other laughing until Adora's sides hurt. She called for truce moments before the *Dzivia* dropped out of hyperspace within range of Phoenix Station.

"That's definitely not good," Corynth said, sitting forward and suddenly serious. A parade of ships blockading the station filled up the viewscreen. Adora couldn't count the number. "I know they put the station on lockdown, but this is excessive."

"Will this help at all?" Adora pulled out the IFF chip Ly had given her shortly before they parted ways.

"That's our ticket in," Corynth said. "Lysithea, what would I do without you?" He paused as if realizing he'd said that out loud

without meaning to. “Don’t tell her I said that, okay? I’ll never hear the end of it.”

“No promises,” Adora slotted the device into the ship’s dash and fake credentials for a ‘Commodore Nerelay Hofstra’ appeared on the screen. The blockade canvassed more of the viewscreen as they got closer, and soon the volume of ships and bulk of the station was all Adora could see instead of stars. The *Dzivia*’s computers registered one of the ships locking onto them, and a request for communication chimed at them.

“You’re up,” Corynth said.

“What? Why me?”

“Nerelay is a feminine name, it won’t work if I’m the one that talks. Just take the hail and pretend to be an extremely pissed-off officer. Try to intimidate them and don’t take no for an answer. Steamroll them if you have to.”

The hail chimed again, seemingly more insistent than before. Pretend to be an Imperial Naval Officer? And not only that, but do it while trying to intimidate the person on the other line? She was already out of her depth and they hadn’t even docked yet.

The chime came again, and she pressed the button to accept the hail before it terrorized her any further. A gruff-looking man with heavy stubble and an undone uniform collar appeared on stream against the viewscreen.

“Station’s closed,” he said, speaking in a drawl that betrayed the fact he had likely said this a hundred times already during his shift and was irritated at having to say it once again. “No one allowed in, only out. Find somewhere else to dock, we can’t take you.”

Adora’s first instinct was toward diplomacy, to acknowledge what the other person said, and then present something compelling to persuade them to her side. As uncomfortable as it was to do and as foolish as she felt doing so, she disregarded that instinct.

“Say that again?” she said, putting on a glower that felt forced.

The man hesitated. “I said we’re closed. Regional Administrator’s orders, we can’t take people in. You’ll have to go somewhere else.”

“You’d think you’d be smart enough to at least ID who you’re talking to before you start running your mouth like that.” She primed the IFF and sent the credentials over the line. The man’s face blanched when he looked down and saw.

“My apologies for speaking so casually, Commodore,” he said. “Unfortunately, I’m still not able to grant you access to dock. This lockdown was put in place by the Regional Administrator himself and I can’t just—“

“You can’t just what?” Adora said, crossing her arms and praying that her nerves read as anger over the feed. “I am on a classified assignment to meet with someone on Phoenix. I don’t care if the Regional Administrator is standing behind you pointing a blaster at your head and telling you not to let people dock, it will take either an act of God or of the emperor himself to deter me. Now, you either find me a bay to dock in or you will find yourself removed from that seat. The person to next inherit your job will be letting me onboard in your place with no arguments, I guarantee it.”

The man gaped at her, his mouth opening and closing like a fish removed from water. “Yes ma’am,” he said, head tilted down and eyes scanning frantically as he looked for a place to direct her. “Bay six is open for you. You are clear to proceed, and we’ll have a team out to greet you on your arrival.”

“That’s more like it.”

“My sincerest apologies, Commodore. Please enjoy your stay.”

The line cut and Adora let out a breath she hadn’t realized she had been holding.

“You aren’t used to bluffing your way through things, are you?” Corynth asked. He was smiling as he guided them through the blockade.

“No, I’m used to punching my way through things. I’m the punching guy, not the acting guy.”

“That’s okay. He was more shocked by the title that came through and saw your nerves as you just getting more and more annoyed with him. The real test is coming up.”

“What? What real test?”

“Didn’t you hear? They’re sending a greeting party to meet us when we dock,” he said. “You’ll have to play the part a little longer.” Adora balked and Corynth laughed. “It’s just until we get through customs, then we’ll have a good excuse to tell them to buzz off. Your line about having a confidential meeting was good.”

Even though the station looked large enough already, it was still another twenty minutes of tense, anxiety-filled silence for Adora before she saw the guiding lights of their landing bay, blinking just beyond the atmospheric barrier. By then, Adora had already run through every memory she had of her previous failed attempts to bluff her way out of something—everything from her time trying to play the occasional pranks on Shadow Weaver before she’d learned better, to sneaking around Bright Moon castle before she had grown comfortable there and getting caught, to trying to play the ‘tough guy’ act in the Crimson Wastes before getting to know Huntara. Her anxiety had never been higher.

Like the maw of an ocean whale slowly hinging wider to swallow them, the hangar opening grew larger until it eclipsed everything else in the viewscreen. A worker in an orange vest and white hardhat was on the floor, gesturing in sweeping motions with lit batons as Corynth guided them in.

An industrial door at the back of the hangar slid open, making way for a cadre of station security to hustle in. They were dressed

in white with the Horde Empire logo emblazoned on the chest, and a terrible moment passed where Adora imagined Catra being among them—the last she'd heard from Glimmer, this was what Catra was doing, right?

She scanned their faces trying to find her, only calming once she double and triple-checked that, no, Catra was not among them.

"Relax," Corynth said after touching the ship down, flipping several switches on the overhead board to down-cycle the engine and power it off. "You'll do great."

"I don't know why I'm so nervous," Adora said, gathering her hair by the fistful and braiding it in a way she hadn't since on Etheria. "I've done this before. I've gone and tried to bluff my way through things in the past."

"Has it ever worked?"

"Not once."

Corynth laughed through his nose. "Then that's probably why you're nervous."

He left the pilot's seat and headed to the workstation at the back of the cockpit with Adora following close behind. He opened a metal box holding the Eye of Shukra and stuffed it back into the small shoulder pack he had used to carry it around on Eden. His hands shook as he did, and Adora didn't miss the look of strained concentration on his face as he worked.

"How much longer do you need to wear those?" she asked, indicating the ignominite manacles he still wore as bracelets. "Having some of that godly Shaper magic might be helpful, just in case I screw things up and blow our cover. If you can manage it, that is," she said, hastily tacking on the last part when she realized that may have been insensitive.

"For a while, still."

“Using my powers never made me sick,” she said. “Not even when I had full control over them. I don’t know how I’d feel if She Ra left me drained like that whenever I called her.”

“If only either of us had the luxury to never need our powers.” Corynth inspected the manacles, turning them palm up, then down, then caressing one with light fingers. “Once I take these off, it will be for the last time.”

His expression and voice changed, becoming graver than Adora had ever seen before. It was gone before she could commit it to memory and ask about it—Corynth turned a placid smile on her like he’d forgotten she was there and only just remembered.

“Here,” he said, holding the bag with the Eye out for her to take. “Wearing the manacles right come in handy, actually. They’ll want to scan us like they did on Eden and inspect the ship. Let them do both, but don’t let them touch the bag. They see a huge apeiron like that and are bound to ask more questions.”

“Scanning is okay, looking at the ship is okay, don’t let them touch the bag,” Adora said, committing the instructions to memory. “Alright. This is fine. Everything will be fine.”

“Also, you aren’t dressed at all like an Imperial Officer,” he said, slipping on a pair of dark gloves that covered the manacles and reached up underneath his sleeve cuffs. “You cannot, under any circumstances, waver, no matter how they scrutinize you. You’re on a classified mission and you won’t be deterred.”

She slung the bag over her shoulder and followed him out the cockpit to the cargo bay. The greeting party was already waiting for them when Corynth lowered the ramp. The agent at the front—the one with the most embellished patch on the sleeve of his uniform, denoting him as the senior-most official in charge—did a double take when he saw Adora.

“Greetings, Commodore Hofstra,” he said, looking her up and down and speaking as if he were questioning every word that

came out of his mouth. “Please stay aboard your craft until we have completed our inspection. We must at the very least follow standard lockdown procedure.”

Adora stepped back inside the bay and Corynth followed, indicating without saying a word that she’d acquiesce.

“We were not expecting your arrival,” the officer said. “In fact, there are no records of your transit manifest in the Imperial databases.”

“You wouldn’t find records were your pay grade tripled, dock officer,” Adora said, forcing a sneer. “Did that agent who spoke so flippantly to me on my approach explain nothing to you? The emperor would not send me on a classified mission out here and have my flight path from the Heartlands recorded. Get in here and conduct your inspections, already. I’m on a schedule and you are standing in the way of it.”

That seemed to do the trick. The officer paled, then turned and shouted at his men to get onboard. All but one of his team, including him, scrambled up the ramp to begin.

“I will oversee them personally, ma’am,” the officer said as he passed her. “We will be done before you know it.” He disappeared down the hallway and both Corynth and Adora watched him go. The sounds of the officer yelling at his men to move faster echoed from deep inside the *Dzivia* not long after.

“You’ve really never done this before?” Corynth asked, whispering from beside her. “Could have fooled me.”

“I feel like I’m going to be sick.”

Corynth laughed through his nose. “You’re doing great. Keep it together just a little longer.”

The last person from the group, the only one to not rush aboard the Dzivia to inspect it, carried a portable scanner—the same type the guards on Eden used on them to scan for the Beast.

“Begging your pardon, Commodore,” she said as she ascended the ramp. “But I’ll need to scan the both of you for infection before signing off for you.”

Adora couldn’t find it in her to actively try and be a jerk to this person. Judging by the fear in their eyes and sparse badging on their uniform, they were a bottom-rung enlistee. Adora figured they were probably close in age.

She crossed her arms and shrugged. “Do what you need to,” she said, hoping they wouldn’t pick up on her inward panic.

“It will only be a minute.” They tapped at the controls on the scanner to calibrated it, then held up the device in front of Adora. It gave three short, high-pitched beeps, paused, then gave a long tone—Adora was clear. No surprise there.

When they turned to Corynth, Adora’s heart was in her throat. The last time this happened, they were seconds away from getting shot. Corynth said it was fine to let them scan this time as long as they didn’t touch the bag around her shoulder, but Adora had no idea why it would be fine. She hated this so, *so* much.

“You’re both clear,” the enlistee said after the device beeped for Corynth in the same way it did for Adora. Corynth cut her off with a stern look before she could let the surprise show on her face, and she managed to keep it together when the enlistee said, “We just have to wait for my supervisor. We’ll authorize your boarding passes and be out of your hair as soon as he’s back.”

“I don’t like to be made to wait,” Adora said, leering at her and feeling horrible for it.

“I’m so sorry, Commodore. I promise we are almost done. Things on the station have been…challenging as of late. Your patience is greatly, greatly appreciated.”

The effusive way she looked between her and Corynth caught Adora’s attention. She considered ignoring her entirely for a moment, before sighing and giving in.

“Speak,” Adora said.

“P-pardon, Commodore?” The enlistee might have been sprayed with boiling water judging by how she recoiled in surprise.

“You want to say something, I can tell by the way you’re looking at me. So, speak.”

They swallowed. “I don’t mean to pry, Ma’am, but why are you not wearing a naval uniform?”

Damn it. She really should have just kept her mouth shut. How the heck was she supposed to answer that? Adora had pressed her lips into a thin line in panic, and the enlistee blanched, averting her eyes.

“S-sorry, Ma’am. I didn’t mean to speak out of line, it’s just…I’ve never seen an officer dress so casually before.”

“You were ordered to speak,” Corynth said, and Adora nearly deflated in obvious relief at him coming to rescue her. “But I wouldn’t make a habit of being so obvious with your curiosity if it entails asking after classified information. I don’t know how many senior officers you’ve dealt with, but most are not as willing to forgive a slip of the tongue as the commodore is.”

“Yes, of course.” The girl bowed low, first to Corynth and then again to Adora. “Truthfully, I haven’t dealt with any officers personally, just seen them from far away. You’re the first I’ve had the pleasure of speaking with like this.”

Adora didn’t know what to say to that, either. A commotion from those deep in the ship sounded from behind, but other than a narrowing of Corynth’s eyes that made the enlistee hold her breath, he didn’t react to it and neither did Adora.

“You said things have been challenging on the station,” Corynth said, once the commotion died down. “What did you mean?”

“Have you not heard of what happened to Administrator Moriarty, sir?”

Corynth tilted his head as if appraising a malformed being and Adora shuddered—it was no wonder he blended in for three years on Etheria by how convincing he could step into roles like this.

“He was arrested a few days ago almost immediately after a rally he gave,” the enlistee said, shifting her eyes back and forth between Adora and Corynth like she was grasping for anything she could glean from their reactions. Again, it made Adora sick. How were the junior military this afraid of their commanding officers, and what did that say about the Imperial Horde’s wider culture?

“And?” Corynth said. “Go on.”

“There is no official story out yet, although that doesn’t stop speculation and opinions from running rampant in the media. The rumors are breathtaking. It is whispered that Consular Taline has taken on a new Sentinel, and this person infiltrated the Administrator’s office on suspicion he’d been harboring dangerous narcotics and conspiring to commit treason against the emperor. Moriarty was arrested, alongside another System Governor that was with him. Consular Taline left almost immediately after on a mission of her own.”

Corynth and Adora exchanged glances. Adora didn’t know what to make of the news until she saw confusion mar Corynth’s face, and suddenly she was unsure whether they should be concerned or not.

“Do you know who this new Sentinel is? Or where the Consular has gone?” he asked.

“Nothing aside from speculation that differs depending on who you ask, I’m afraid. We all assumed the emperor would send someone to help settle the matter, but”—she fixed them both with

a look heavy with implication—"I must admit, you've arrived much sooner than anyone anticipated."

"Did I not just warn you?" Corynth's voice dipped so low it even startled Adora. "Our mission is confidential. You have no basis to assume our arrival stems from Moriarty and his transgressions."

"Truly sorry!" the woman said, casting her eyes away again and wringing her hands together. "I'm so sorry, I will not make assumptions again, I promise. It's just…there's been so much change recently, what with the influx of refugees, then the Angel suddenly leaving as soon after she'd returned, then this business with the Administrator, and now the Consular herself has gone and left the station for the first time since being assigned here."

She bowed low, even lower than before, and said, "Our station used to be so very quiet and now you are here, too. I forgot myself in my excitement. Please forgive me."

Adora exchanged more glances with Corynth. The Angel…? Was she talking about Glimmer? The last Adora had talked to her, she was on her way for weeks of downtime on Phoenix, and that wasn't even a month ago. Did Glimmer already leave? The enlistee admitted herself what was happening on the station was strange and sudden, and Adora hated feeling like she'd escaped one random grab-box of a situation only to land right in another.

A shuffle of feet stepping across metal grating came from behind.

"Sorry for keeping you waiting so long, Commodore," the supervisor said, returning with his crew from the innards of the *Dzivia*. "Our scans are complete and you should be clear to proceed, as long as you aren't hiding any contraband goods in some well-hidden compartment or the like?"

He cracked a grin, waggled his eyebrows, and Adora realized belatedly that he was trying to crack a joke. Corynth's warning about keeping the Eye away from them rang in her head, and the

best idea she could come up with to head them off from asking about it was also the riskiest.

"Just this right here," she said, arching a brow as she lifted the bag to show him. "But you and everyone on your team will lose their hands if you try and take this from me."

The man glanced at the pack. Corynth gave no indication of his thoughts and Adora held her breath. Deliberately drawing attention to the thing was risky. Even if she pretended to answer the supervisor's joke with one of her own that could reasonably be construed as a threat, there was always the possibility that he'd still probe—Adora just felt more confident if she was proactive rather than reactive, and she was banking on that confidence being what carried them through.

The man looked up from the bag and gave Adora a weak smile: her gamble had paid off.

"Very well," he said, clearing his throat and waving around a few sheets of paper folded together in his hand. "We have your paperwork and passes right here. You shouldn't have any issues getting to where you need to go on most areas of the station with these, despite the lockdown. Once we confirm your identification, our work will be done."

"I'm sorry, did you say you want to confirm my identity before you hand my papers over to me?" Adora asked, hoping she sounded pissed off instead of nervous.

"Yes, I'm afraid this is a new security measure that the Consular has put into effect, now that Administrator Moriarty is…more or less indisposed. She has jurisdiction now, and she's ordered the station shut down along with these heightened security requirements."

One of the workers  readied a bio reader for them. All the attention was on Adora instead of Corynth, but he gave her a

subtle “absolutely not” gesture when she looked to him for guidance.

“I’ve already identified myself on approach to this station and I’m not inclined to do so again,” Adora said, casting prayers in her head. “You’ve done your inspection and your subordinate has cleared us of any infection. I don’t feel the need to allow more intrusions on my itinerary just because some second-in-command Enclave bureaucrat demands it.”

“Ah, yes. Well…I wouldn’t exactly call the Seraph some second-in-command bureaucrat. Consular Taline would have my head if she found out I let someone through without following her explicit orders.”

“And I will have your head if you do not let us pass this instant.” Adora forced the words out through gritted teeth. “I am an officer of the Imperial Navy on special assignment from the emperor himself.”

“I wouldn’t dream of hindering you from enacting the emperor’s will,” the supervisor said, growing emboldened. “But I must insist. The Consular is…” He shook his head, and Adora thought he looked paler than before. “I will not take my chances on her bad side. I’m sorry to say this, commodore, but between the two of you, it is the Seraph I will not risk angering.” He took the scanner from his teammate and held it out for her. “I’m sorry. Please place your palm here.”

Adora looked at the palm reader, then back at the supervisor, panicking, moments away from openly hyperventilating. What could she do? What could she say to get out of this? She looked to Corynth, whose steadfast gaze told her nothing; she was in the driver’s seat.

Adora punched him in the face.

The supervisor reeled back, dropping the paperwork and the palm reader, both hands shooting up to cover his shattered nose. Adora

let loose a squeak of surprise and held both hands up as if she'd dropped an antique in a shop. Everyone froze and traded shocked glances with one another, likely asking one another with nothing but a look whether they'd all just witnessed the same thing.

Corynth grabbed one of the crewmembers from behind in a chokehold and lowered him to the ground, unconscious a moment later. A brawl broke out, and by the time both of them had gotten every member of the greeting party bound by their arms and legs and stuffed unconscious inside the Dzivia, Adora had several bruises over her body, and Corynth had a cut across the side of his face that was dripping blood onto the shoulder of his shirt.

"That could have gone better," he said, far too calm as he stooped down to pick up the paperwork strewn about the cargo hold. "Are you okay?"

"Never…better." Adora was leaning over with both hands on her knees and trying to catch her breath. Aside from a few ribs she'd know would bruise in a handful of hours and a split lip she'd just noticed, she'd live. Corynth, on the other hand, wasn't even out of breath.

"That busted lip will draw attention if you aren't careful," Corynth said. "Let's try not to draw any more attention. We'll have to move quickly as it is before their friends realize they're missing and go looking."

"I never want to do that again," Adora said. "I think getting to punch people in the end was the only thing that stopped me from throwing up all over the floor. And I feel really bad about having to knock out that girl."

"You put on an impressive show, but I think your right," Corynth said. "You don't have the stomach for espionage and infiltration."

"I think that's the first time I've ever felt perfectly okay with being called inadequate at something." Adora wiped the sweat from her forehead with her sleeve and bumped shoulders with him as they

walked to the exit at the far end of the hangar. “Thanks for having my back.”

Corynth gave some noncommittal response and organized the mess of papers he’d picked up earlier. Adora watched how the leaves trembled in his hands, and this caused her to look him over again, closer this time.

She’d been wrong about her initial assessment. While she was pretty sure they hadn’t managed to land a single blow on him during the fighting, he looked far from okay. Corynth’s skin looked sallow and his eyes looked like they had sunken into his head. It was subtle, but she could tell; he just didn’t look healthy. He caught her staring, and Adora quickly averted her eyes.

“That scanner didn’t out you like what happened on Eden,” she said.

“I still have the manacles on. The ignominite in them tamps down on the infection in my body, and it also prevents those scanners from picking up its presence, too.”

Adora cursed under her breath. Something told her the effect of those things touching him was much more than just ‘tamping down’ on the infection. Maybe she should have tried harder to avoid a fight. He was just barely getting back on his feet after exerting so much of his power on Eden. They had to be careful.

“Whatever it is you’re worrying about, stop it,” Corynth said. They’d reached the exit. “Come on, we have to get to the Atrium as fast as possible. Someone will notice those hangar workers are missing, or they’ll wake up on their own. they’ll sound the alarm as soon as they wake up and we’ll be in deep shit if we haven’t gotten Pip working before then.”

Adora followed him through the double-thick blast shield doors leading out the hangar, sparing only a single glance behind her back at the *Dzivia*.

Chapter End Notes

In my head, Adora tried a bunch of progressive and hilariously crazy stuff to get her powers back as she grew more desperate. In trope terminology, these would be called "noodle incidents."

**

I found my treasure trove of material from previous drafts. As in, all previous iterations of this story as I was working on it, all my statistics on words written day by day, the revision notes I had for myself between each draft on what to change or fix or clarify, etc. I'd always had those docs saved, I just hadn't looked at them again until recently. Funnily enough, when I started looking through an early pre-draft 1 outline of the story (so many things changed), I kept coming across this name I didn't recognize. "Who the heck is 'Tiraia?' Did I axe her from the story or something?" And then a realized that's who Taline was before I changed her name.

Anyways, long story short, I'm open to cleaning some of it up and structuring it for AO3. I know it helped me a ton with my own writing when Brandon Sanderson posted his prior drafts of one of his novels and I got to see the kinds of deep changes he mad and how rough the initial drafts could be. I certainly don't have his reach or platform, but I have fielded a handful of direct messages on another fanfic site about writing, so maybe it would be helpful. Let me know if that's something you guys would like to see.

# Apocrypha

Chapter Notes

> I put a good amount of effort into naming the chapters well (I think it's fun!) Here's the first wikipedia paragraph on what "Apocrypha" means (it's not just the name of a Fate/stay night spinoff):
>
> [Apocrypha are works, usually written, of unknown authorship or of doubtful origin. The word apocryphal was first applied to writings which were kept secret because they were the vehicles of esoteric knowledge considered too profound or too sacred to be disclosed to anyone other than the initiated. Apocrypha was later applied to writings that were hidden not because of their divinity but because of their questionable value to the church. In general use, the word apocrypha has come to mean "false, spurious, bad, or heretical".]
>
> I'll leave it up to you as the reader to decide how the title relates to the content in this chapter :)
>
> ps: this is one of the longest chapters in the entire story

See the end of the chapter for more notes

*What the hell is taking him so long?*

The thought poisoned Catra's mood. She sat in a passenger shuttle idling in the *Constable's* tiny hangar bay, arms folded and slouched down in her bucket seat. Diallo was late and Taline had told her they couldn't head planet-side without him when Catra had suggested it. Everyone else in the shuttle—Trayn, Keren, a handful of other guards, the analyst team that had been tapped specifically for this mission, and Taline herself—all chatted with one another or, in Taline's case, brooded. Catra seemed to be the only one royally pissed off about being made to wait on that asshole.

Finally, he showed.

“S-sorry I’m late, everyone,” Diallo said, ambling up the ramp into the shuttle with a genteel expression. “Had some l-last minute preparations t-to attend to.”

Taline stood and disappeared through the doors to the cockpit to give their pilot and co-pilot the go-ahead, and Catra side-eyed Diallo the entire way out the hangar. It was only when Pip started buzzing around his head making rude gestures at him that she stopped, fearing she might smile because he couldn’t see her.

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They were headed for a massive refinery embedded under Archanas’ surface. That much Catra knew, but they’d ridden for nearly an hour without seeing anything of the planet they were to land on: the windows of the shuttlecraft also had their blast doors sealed shut. The artificial lighting inside the passenger bay made Catra feel trapped.

She hadn’t even seen pictures of Archanas’ surface before. The Vestamid refused to photograph their holy site, and no one else had visitation rights to a still-quarantined world laden with imperial protection orders. Well, there was one person Catra had heard of. The one person purported to have successfully visited after forcibly crashing on the surface was still babbling, insane, and frothing at the mouth years after the Vestamid rescued them —a minor infamous celebrity made permanent resident at a major psychiatric hospital deep in the Heartlands.

The co-pilot stepped through the door separating the crew hold from the cockpit and leaned down to whisper something to Taline, seated again near the front. It was only Catra’s enhanced hearing that let her hear their exchange over the sound of the shuttle’s engine and the muted, nervous conversation from the other passengers: they’d burned through Archanas’ atmosphere and were minutes away from their destination.

Taline nodded and whispered something back Catra didn't catch. The co-pilot disappeared back into the cockpit and Taline stood. Conversation died as, one by one, everyone looked at her with anticipation.

"All of you have been chosen as participants in this landing party because of the exceptional mental fortitude scores you earned screening for this mission," she said, looking over each of them. "During transit, procedure has been to prevent anyone from gazing upon the planet we were traveling to. Once we land, however, that will no longer be feasible."

The blast shields covering each of the windows folded up. Sunlight bathed the interior, casting through the windows in great, blinding rays.

"Behold," Taline said. "The final Dead World of the last Beast War."

The vista pulled a gasp from everyone in the shuttle except Diallo. Catra felt rooted to the spot despite already having been strapped into her bucket chair for over an hour.

Archanas' surface looked like a living, roiling ocean had been flash frozen mid storm. Brittle black obsidian veined with red stretched beyond the horizon in every direction. Craggy stalagmite growths and enormous cornices formed from crashing waves stopped in time formed petrified mountain ranges. Their shuttle passed between these at speed as they raced forward.

It was violence, personified and hardened into karsts vast enough to blanket a whole planet's surface. Catra could only stomach looking out the window for a few moments before she had to avert her eyes.

The rest of the landing party had done the same; they were sitting timid, shifting in their seats, avoiding eye contact with everyone else. Only Diallo and Taline were still looking out the viewports: Taline with a cold, unreadable expression and Diallo with unrepentant, near-manic glee.

“Even with Taline here, she can’t offset all of the planet’s effects,” Pip said. “She can’t fully protect everyone. It’s nearly overpowering.”

Catra couldn’t disagree.

Just when she started to feel like she wasn’t on the verge of emptying everything she’d eaten earlier at the ship’s cafeteria out on the floor, the sunlight streaming through the windows disappeared and the lights inside the passenger hold turned on once more. Their pilots had taken them down, an enormous gorge splitting the surface of the planet swallowing them like some terrifying dragon. The canyon that enveloped them was so deep it had eclipsed the sun overhead.

A half dozen landing pads jutted out the side of the canyon wall and their shuttle approached the largest one. Catra could see a group of seven already waiting for them on approach.

The ship touched down. When the ramp leading outside lowered, cool air flooded the compartment, and Catra picked up on a subtle sweet aroma in the air, threaded with an even subtler scent of what she could only describe as bitter almonds. It was alien but not altogether unpleasant, and that wasn’t what she was expecting after having nearly had a crisis just looking out the window earlier.

Everyone filed out of the ship onto the landing pad in order, with Diallo, Catra, and finally Taline exiting last. Their greeting party met them a few steps from the ramp.

“Greetings, Taline,” the closest person to them said, stepping forward and bowing deep. He wore a dark suit fringed with deep scarlet, while the other six around him wore scarlet robes fringed with black. “I am Larian, a High Primate of the Vestamid and Archbishop of Archanas. Welcome to our holy compound.”

Catra looked around at the smooth metal of the compound embedded within jagged obsidian. “This is an industrial complex.”

Larian smiled. “What better way to foster a deep and powerful relationship with God than to mine for and refine His holy body?” His response sent something unpleasant shooting down Catra’s spine. She shuddered, and Larian regarded Diallo with a glassy-eyed expression. “Governor! It is so good of you to finally visit. I am sure you are happy to at last step foot on our holy place yourself, as well?”

“Ecstatic,” Diallo said, cracking a grin that showed all his teeth.

Trayn cocked his head, the fine bony plating on his face coming together to approximate his version of a furrowed brow. “This is your first time here?” he asked Diallo. “But you’ve been the Governor of this sector of space for years.”

“Diallo is our governor in imperial affairs, true,” Larian said, “but not even he is granted rights to step foot on our sacred ground for such business. We send delegations to another world within his jurisdiction for all official matters.” He turned to Taline, and his tone grew even more effusive. “But for the fabled Seraph of Archanas? Such a visit is an honor none of us had expected to receive.”

The more Larian spoke, the better Catra was able to place what about him unnerved her. It wasn’t just the glassy expression in his eyes. His face looked artificial, like a great deal of cosmetic surgery had rendered it ill-fitting and tight.

Taline scowled at him. “I’m not here for pleasantries. I’ve informed you already of my rationale for the sudden visit. I’m to assume you’ve read the message over already, ahead of my arrival?”

“Of course!” Larian said. “I pored over your message with my inner circle, and our senior-most team of preservationists will ensure your words are recorded for all of history.”

Taline winced. “It’s only an official notice,” she said. “A template letter with my signature is hardly something worth getting worked

up over."

"Nonsense. Any communication from the Seraph shall be preserved in our archives for prosperity, no matter how trivial. And I'd hardly say the matter is trivial at all. It's not every day one is under audit over suspicion of having forged a key to the house of God. I'm not sure whether to be offended or amused."

Catra stood bewildered by the whole exchange. She understood how someone like Taline might inspire awe in those with even just a superficial understanding of the previous Beast war. With how peculiar everyone knew the Vestamid to be, she'd even prepared for a certain level of eccentricity on this trip. But preserving Taline's warning to them and speaking of it as if it were a sacred edict? That was beyond weird, and judging by Trayn and Keren's reactions, they felt the same.

"Flattery will get you nowhere," Taline said with finality. "The activity laid out in the notice is serious, and I expect you to provide my team full access to your entire infrastructure. Whatever technology was used to encrypt that message to Administrator Moriarty, we need to perform a full analysis of. A full accounting of the contents of that message is in order as well," Taline said, narrowing her eyes at him. "Some of what was in that drive is…alarming, to put generously. I expect you to help clear up any ambiguity."

"It will be quite a lengthy audit then," Larian said, speaking as one did when they were confronted with an inconvenience they fully expected to run into anyways. "Let my priests conduct their scans, and I will ensure you have everything you need. We will cooperate fully, as we have nothing to hide."

Taline nodded and the robed priests who had accompanied Larian divided the members of Taline's entourage between them. One priest stopped in front of Catra and held up a scanner to her forehead. Pip floated up near it, bent over at the waist and staring at it as if she were examining a home appliance. Catra at first didn't understand why she seemed so intrigued until she

remembered Pip had never been off station and hadn't seen how the Beast was screened for at points of intake.

The scanner gave Catra the all clear, and the priest moved on to Diallo. Catra watched them hold the scanner to his forehead, and Diallo seemed amused she was watching him so intently. Catra didn't care. She probably wouldn't have been surprised if he set the scanner off, truth be told, but it beeped clear for him as well and Diallo shot her a smug look.

"Expected m-me to set off the alarm?" he asked, adjusting his glasses. "Sorry t-to disappoint."

Catra scoffed and rolled her eyes when an alarm from a different scanner screeched in warning nearby. She whirled to see who it was. One of the priests was holding their scanner up to Taline just a few paces away.

A commotion broke out. The priests stopped what they were doing, dropped their scanners to the ground, pressed their palms together, and started chanting rushed prayers under their breaths, bowing low to Taline. Catra could tell even amidst the chaos that the prayers were reverential—they weren't scared of her. While the *Constable's* landing party looked on the verge of panic, the priests were worshipping her right there on the landing pad.

Taline looked like she either wanted to hide under a rock or deck the nearest priest in the face, Larian looked enthusiastic, and Diallo, perhaps not so surprisingly, seemed just as elated.

"That is enough, my friends," Larian said to the priests. They ceased their prayers after another deep bow done in unison toward Taline, and picked the scanners from the ground. "Follow closely," he said to the rest of them. "I will bring you to the main sanctum."

Larian moved for the industrial doors at the back of the platform leading into the canyon wall and Diallo followed after. He looked

at Catra as he passed, and the expression on his face said, *I told you so*. Catra stuck her tongue out at him and he laughed it off.

The priests followed after, but not without another quick bow each toward Taline. She wasn't paying attention, and Catra instead caught her looking back at their landing party with an uncharacteristically forlorn look on her face. Their team whispered frantically amongst themselves, casting secretive glances back at Taline.

Her gaze hardened, and Catra wondered how many times she'd had to do that—remind herself to stay above the whispers and rumors about her, personal, human feelings aside. It seemed almost habitual. Taline turned to follow Larian, but not before locking eyes with her, freezing. The forlorn look returned, and Catra nearly went to her when a shadowy figure moved out of the corner of her vision.

Catra spun around to see who was suddenly trying to sneak up on her and saw…nothing. Just the other side of the gorge, miles away.

::Did you see that?::

Pip floated near her with an equally spooked expression. "You saw it, which means I saw it," she said. "And now I don't see it anymore. I don't like this place."

A large, heavy hand landed on Catra's shoulder, engulfing it, and she almost jumped out of her skin until she realized it was Trayn. The landing party was following Larian and the others, now, and he'd grabbed her attention before they left her behind.

"Did you know about this?" he asked as the group walked together. "Did you know about Taline?"

Catra shook her head. "I didn't."

One of the many analysts looked at her with suspicion. "I don't believe that for a second. You're her new Sentinel. Battlemages

don’t take Sentinels unless they know each other well.” They pursed their lips and narrowed their eyes at her, and Catra wondered if everyone *except* her knew how Sentinels were commissioned. “Aren’t you the one she took in years ago, too? Yeah, I think you’re full of shit. You knew Taline was an Abomination and chose not to say anything this whole time? For years?”

“That’s jumping to conclusions far too fast,” Keren said as the analyst stared wide-eyed at Taline far ahead of them, muttering under their breath about walking into a death trap. “Taline has been one of the most well-respected administrators on Phoenix for years, and she was a war hero that saved countless worlds in the Beast war before. It should come as no surprise she’s been saturated, to some extent, but that doesn’t make her an Abomination.”

“All of us would have been thralls by now if she were,” Trayn said.

The others in the group grumbled to themselves, but no one challenged Trayn and Keren. Catra nudged both of them with her shoulder, one after the other.

“Thank you.”

To Catra’s surprise, despite defending her, neither Trayn nor Keren looked particularly forgiving.

“You swear you didn’t know about this?” Keren asked. “You had no idea Taline was tainted enough to set off a routine scan?”

“I promise I didn’t,” Catra said. “Neither of us had left Phoenix. Not since we came, years ago. She wasn’t allowed to without a Sentinel to watch her.”

They finally passed through the doors leading into the compound —into the cliff face—and their footsteps echoed around the massive concrete sanctum foyer.

"You were with her when you first arrived," Trayn said. He'd lowered his voice so no one else could hear and Catra was grateful. "She brought the Angel, too. She didn't set anything off back then?"

Catra scrunched up her face in recollection. Taline hadn't brought them through customs or security at all back then. There was no formal security at their point of arrival, and they'd had preferential treatment all the way up through both of them earning imperial citizenship.

When Catra told them as much, Keren and Trayn's skepticism deepened.

"It's…it's not like that," Catra said. "An Abomination wouldn't stick around on Phoenix for three years holding office hours and becoming one of the most popular administrators on the station. You said it yourselves. Of course she'd have been exposed given what she lived through, but that doesn't make her an Abomination. And it's my job to prevent that from happening, now."

"Yeah, but that doesn't mean I'm not confused and pissed off after this, though." Trayn looked Catra in the eyes and said, "Being saturated enough you set off the alarms? Tell me you're not even a little bit concerned after seeing that."

Catra chewed her lip as they walked. It did bother her. Was she liable to set off alarms even three years ago when they first met? Or was the exposure she'd sustained getting worse? Taline had made it clear as day that Catra would have to be the one to end her if she'd slipped too far. How close were they to that moment, and why had Taline decided not to mention any of this before giving so many people a heart attack?

Diallo's warning echoed in her head. *She's not who you think.*

Pip floated into view as they continued to walk, no doubt sensing her distress. "Go and talk to her," she said.

::Did you know this was going to happen?::

Pip fidgeted. "I…might have suspected it could happen." When Catra scowled at her, she hurried to say, "I wasn't sure, okay?"

::Why didn't you say anything? Do you know what's happening to her?::

"It's not my place to say! It's personal, and it's not like I'd go around telling everyone about your problems, either. You wouldn't want me integrated so deeply in your head if I did that. You'd fight me." She crossed her arms and shot Catra a defiant look. "Besides, even if I wanted to tell you, how was I supposed to bring it up? 'Hey, here's a random and extremely personal tidbit about this person you've looked up to for years but only just figured out how to approach. Taline's liable to screen as an Abomination because she was—"

Pip's eyes blew wide and she shut her mouth with a click, undoubtedly realizing she was about to spill even more without realizing it.

"You didn't know how to bring up why you avoided her for three years because you thought it was a stupid and embarrassing reason," she said instead. "But you told her when she finally asked. Why can't she have the same kind of trouble figuring out what to say to you? She doesn't have anything to hide, but she's not going to dump her life's story in your lap unprompted. Just go talk to her."

Catra sighed through her nose when she realized Pip might be right. Taline had a bad habit of not saying things, but that didn't absolve Catra of the responsibility to try. She batted away the flashes of smug *of course I'm right* emotions Pip sent her before power walking to Taline and the others ahead.

She caught up to them just as Larian, Diallo, and the priests rounded a corner, and whatever question had been on the tip of Catra's tongue dissolved into thin air.

A pair of statues stood as the centerpiece to this part of the triple-height room, tall enough they nearly brushed the ceiling. One was another rendition of the Shaper Corynth, standing tall in his mask and robes, one hand outstretched toward the second statue as if to command them to halt.

Catra didn't recognize the second figure, though. Not immediately. It wasn't until the group threaded around the statues toward another pair of doors at the far wall that she got a clear look at the face carved into the stone.

It was Taline. Her expression was twisted in ghastly fury as she gestured to attack Corynth with magic. There had been no statues of Taline on Phoenix, and Catra was surprised to see this one. She didn't like it.

"The Dance of the Revenants."

Larian brought Catra's attention back to the present. The others had caught up, most standing transfixed, staring at the statues like Catra had until Larian had spoken.

"A beautiful work of art, if I do say so myself. It commemorates the Seraph's first fight against the Shaper Corynth, how it was a precipitating event to Armageddon." He turned and spoke to everyone but paid special attention to Taline. "It was only upon the Shaper's return here, to Archanas, that they parleyed with God and negotiated a period of peace. Purgatory. A chance to atone for sins before the World Eater Himself returns. It is this period we have been living through for over the past decade, now."

Someone in their group whispered about how the Vestamid must be insane. They clearly didn't intend for anyone to hear it, but Catra did thanks to her ears. Whether or not anyone else heard, however, she couldn't tell.

"What do you mean by first fight?" Catra asked. There only ever was one. "Saying it like that implies—"

“That there will be a second,” Larian said, nodding. “Astute observation. It is prophesized that, upon the eve of the second battle, the doors to God’s kingdom shall open once more, our Purgatory shall come to an end, and a new age of Armageddon shall usher forth.”

More whispering from the group, met with steely glares from the priests, as if being alarmed by such a statement was itself offensive. Behind her narrowed eyes and pursed lips, Taline was impossible to read, and that worried Catra even more. Was this news to her? Had she known these ‘prophesies,’ already and that was why she did everything she could to avoid coming here?

“Who says this?” Catra asked, earning Larian’s full attention. “Your doctrine? Your holy books?”

“Our patron goddess.” Larian spoke with a finality that brooked no argument, like he was reciting naked fact. “Long before God Himself deemed us worthy of hearing His words directly, we received visions from the goddess, instead. Visions of the coming conflict and its key players. Visions of God’s judgement, hanging in the balance.

“Many of us thought ourselves insane, naturally. After all, hearing a voice speak in your dreams sounds crazy, does it not? Visions of two great demigods fighting to prove to God Almighty that the living deserve a chance at salvation sounds the stuff of fantasy and fairytale.”

“It still sounds that way today,” Trayn said under his breath, earning a snicker from those around and a sharp elbow in the ribs from Keren.

“Nevertheless,” Larian said, continuing as if Trayn hadn’t said anything at all, “once His wrath visited us in earnest, events unfolded exactly as our goddess proclaimed. The Seraph rose to prominence, the emperor was rebuffed and the ancient order of Shapers revealed themselves under the leadership of a new mythic king. We realized our dreams were not a product of

insanity, but a divine vision from beyond. A vision from our patron goddess of the Vestamid. It is she who proclaimed the first battle between Seraph and Shaper, and it is she who proclaimed the second."

"Is this the same goddess that told you to create that test tube Abomination on Eden?" Taline had, at some point, pulled away to stare up at her statue with disgust. But when she spoke to Larian, her expression had returned to something unreadable. "Or taught you how to encrypt your message to Moriarty well enough imperial code-breaking software thinks it uncrackable? We know it's encoded the same way the Barrier is maintained."

"Our devotion to the faith and time on this holy site has opened new realms of enlightenment and transcendence," Larian said. "Goddess is gone. The World Eater Himself speaks to us, now." He turned to Taline and said, "It is His teachings that scrambled our message to Moriarty. No one else's"

Taline's eyes widened in surprise, as did Catra's.

::Did he just admit the Beast taught them the Barrier algorithm?::

"That sounds really, *really* bad," Pip said. "Even for the Vestamid. The Beast is long dead on this planet. Even if its effects are still strong, it wouldn't be able to *talk* to you, wouldn't it?"

Catra ignored her and went straight to Taline while Larian moved the group past the statues and beyond the next set of doors. He navigated them through a hallway, passing several other priests and Vestamid staffers along the way.

"I told you things would be confusing when we got here," Taline said under her breath to Catra when she got close enough. "Do you understand now why I wanted you to see some of this before answering questions?"

Catra nodded and asked her what Pip had asked about the Vestamid and the Beast.

“I don’t know,” Taline said. “Whatever it is, it certainly doesn’t bode well if they are talking directly to the Beast as Corynth and my sister had. Their goddess is an enigma as well.”

“You mean you don’t know anything about that?”

Taline shook her head. “I’d never gotten involved with the Vestamid and did everything I could to stay away from them. It’s probably not hard for you to intuit why, but that also meant I had no insight into their beliefs or their dogma. I don’t know what their goddess is.”

“Evie could see backward in time,” Catra said. “Maybe—”

“No.” Taline set her lips into a thin line and shook her head again. “Evie saw thousands of years into the past, but I’m not aware she could ever interact with anyone, only observe. And her ability to look forward in time was even weaker. She’d warned us of Etheria’s coming, but could tell us nothing aside from the fact it would show and that it was important. There’s no way she was able to influence enough people to generate a religion out of seemingly thin air.”

“They seem to be under no impression that Corynth is really dead, though,” Catra said. “They seem to believe it more than you did, and with less proof.”

Taline grimaced. “That scares me,” she said. “This talk of us confronting one another again as if it were written into some ancient book when I’ve only just confirmed he’s still alive. It’s unnerving.”

Catra nearly asked about her having set off the scanners earlier, but their group passed through yet another set of wide, sliding blast doors into the large, circular room. The Vestamid’s central command center on Archanas was laid out like a college lecture room. Rows of technicians sat at desks, plugging away at computer stations installed in concentric semicircles around an open main floor in the center.

A scaffold supporting dozens of screens dominated the far wall, each displaying different dashboards—different visualized data or heuristics. There was also surveillance footage taken from various other parts of the compound. Catra caught sight of dozens of barracks filled with soldiers, and several hangars full of fighters, ready for take-off at a moment's notice.

Windows ringed the outside edge of the room and gave a clear view of the planet's surface. That also surprised Catra; how had they gone from a landing platform dozens of stories underground inside a ravine back up to the surface of the planet so quickly? They hadn't boarded any elevators, and the short hallway they'd traversed wasn't even built at an incline. Along with the surveillance footage, the whole compound was beginning to feel like an impossibly dense and complicated termite's nest, rather than a well-organized facility.

"We scanned the planet from orbit before coming down here," Taline said to Larian as they pushed further into the command room, the staffers at their consoles watching them as they went. "The captain of my ship thought they'd picked up a surface to orbit canon near the compound but couldn't confirm. Archanas emits too much radiation for our instruments to function properly. But that," she said, pointing out the window, "is unmistakable."

Catra followed her line of sight and saw an enormous cannon jutting out at an angle against the horizon. Even miles away, the thing seemed to rival and even blend in with the mountain-sized karsts cutting across the horizon.

Larian whispered something to the nearest tech in the pit, who then gathered a few of her colleagues from their consoles and gestured for Taline's analysts to follow them to the front. Larian then indicated for Taline and Catra to follow him to the window at the back she'd pointed out of to give them privacy.

"Do you like it?" he asked, once they'd put enough distance between them and the others.

“You have no need for it,” Taline said. “No one comes here uninvited, and it’s not just because it’s a protected site. Why have one?”

“Because God demands it.” When both Taline and Catra gave him skeptical looks he laughed and folded his arms. “Oh, come now. You can never be too careful. You never know when the day may come that enough people look at what we’re doing here and deem it blasphemous, try to attack from the safety of space, protected designation or not. Merely having a weapon powerful enough to strike back is a strong deterrent.”

“The orbital cannons installed on Heartland worlds require generator farms stretching entire city blocks to power,” Taline said. “Even having *one* is cost-prohibitive to a world that has only the infrastructure to support a single installation, no matter how sophisticated. You don’t have enough energy to run your operation and keep that thing primed to fire, regardless of what your God demands.”

“Supplying power is no issue,” Larian said. “Administrator Moriarty expedited our energy project over a year ago now. I believe that was controversial enough it ended up headlining mainstream media for several cycles, no?”

It had. Catra remembered those news cycles well. Dax had even brought it up when they talkeda about half his precinct getting let go.

“I have no idea what you’ve concocted that lets you power that thing,” Taline said, frowning, “but I have serious doubts it works as intended. If the Beast—sorry, if your God is destined to return, as you proclaim it to be, and if that return is inevitable no matter what anyone does about it, why go to all the trouble? Why openly disregard procedure to power a space gun you have no need for other than as a hypothetical deterrent? Especially if it only tarnishes the public’s already dubious opinion of the Vestamid?”

"What a question," Larian said, grinning. "Oh, *what a question*. The 'Beast,' as you call it, may be inevitable, but it is fear and superstition held by nonbelievers that pose the greatest threat to us. Who would not wish to arm themselves against a threat? Despite what the general populace may believe of us, we are not so crazy as to forgo our own protection."

His grin turned predatory and full of manic glee. "Let us not pretend you haven't done far worse than pressure a politician to protect yourself and those institutions you identify with. The very people you served would have put their precious 'Seraph of Archanas' in front of a firing squad had you not spun such atrocities in the name of their self-preservation."

Pip, who had been sitting silently on Catra's shoulder the whole time, shot outraged to her feet and shouted obscenities at him that he couldn't hear. Catra's ears pulled back and she hissed, her claws extending from splayed fingers she held down at her sides.

"I'd be very careful about what you say next," she said.

Larian didn't so much as glance in her direction. Taline's expression remained stony and unreadable, and Catra wondered how she kept it together. They'd only been on this god forsaken planet for less than an hour and she was already about to lose it.

"You mentioned the method you used to encrypt your message to Moriarty was given to you by your God," Taline said. "Did Corynth have anything to do with that process? Is he the conduit?"

"Pardon, Seraph?" Larian seemed to not expect the question.

"He's the only one that might have had any knowledge about its creation. Last I checked, he was still dead, yet you made it very clear we were expected to face each other again in battle. Unless you're communing with the Beast in some other way, there's no other way you would have learned the encryption."

Catra looked at her in surprise. Taline was lying. They'd both seen Adora's message, she was just trying to catch Larian lying to *her.*

“We have not seen him.” Larian seemed confused by the question, which in turn confused Catra. “As far as I’m aware too, he has remained dead after perishing here, although something as trivial as death wouldn’t stop a Shaper. I believe that’s part of the reason why the statue outside was called ‘Duel of the Revenants’, yes?” He laughed and nudged Taline with his elbow, to her great annoyance. “Besides, your people will be tearing through our records any moment now. You will see for yourself we are innocent of any crime you believe us to have committed. We’ve merely been rewarded for our devotion in our faith. That is all.”

Larian bowed low and excused himself, saying he wanted to check up on his people and ensure they’d have no issues assisting Taline’s analysts. Catra watched him go, then watched Diallo catch him on the way to the front of the control room, likely to pester with questions. Only after she was certain they wouldn’t come back and bother them did she sheath her claws.

Taline’s stony mask had crumbled—she looked exhausted, facing out the window again, leaning against the windowsill, appearing as if she hadn’t slept in days.

Catra reached out a hand to lay on her shoulder by instinct, then forced herself to pull it back before Taline had caught on. “I—”

“You feel it already, don’t you?” Taline asked, casting her a sidelong glance. “The air here is toxic. It messes with your head. We can’t risk staying here any longer than absolutely necessary, and I don’t want anyone who’s accompanied us here to experience lasting effects. Even with my protection, this place can still take a toll.”

Catra thought to mention the shadow she’d glimpsed earlier out the corner of her eye, but seeing as it hadn’t come back and no one else seemed to have noticed it, she decided to go straight to the important questions.

“What happened back there on the landing pad?” she asked. “Why did you set off the alarm when they scanned you? And what

the hell was Larian talking about when he said you'd committed atrocities?"

Diallo had mentioned, back when she'd woken up in a cell on Phoenix, how people committed atrocities in the previous war. Hearing Larian praise her as a holy figure one moment then mention she specifically had committed some the next, however, was unnerving.

Taline didn't respond at first. When she stopped looking at Catra to gaze out the window again, Catra thought she might not respond at all.

"It's really a shame Glimmer got stuck with that nickname," Taline said, finally. "'Angel of Archanas' is just unfair, especially considering she's never set foot here. All those journalists that pushed the name saying it inspired hope the same way 'Seraph of Archanas' does…they did so without knowing how I earned that name in the first place. Where it came from. How much it cost."

She stood between two extremes: Her profile cutting sharp relief against the darkness from the control room behind them and the light seeping through the window in front. Catra saw tears welling in her eyes.

"This planet used to be beautiful," she said. "Did you know that? An economic hub. Tens of billions of people living in cities. Beautiful plains with grazing animals stretching for endless miles, only stopping when they sand and those sands hit oceans. Now no one can visit for more than a day without going mad, and the only permanent residents are maybe a few hundred insane zealots, mining the remains of the Beast."

Catra wondered why it sounded as if Taline was blaming herself for the change.

"My team named me Seraph because of what happened the first time I was here," Taline said.

“Your team?” Catra knew she had other Sentinels before. Narre and Miri were never far from her mind, just like they were never far from Glimmer’s, but this was the first time Catra had heard Taline talk of them explicitly.

“Before you. Before Narre and Miri, even, although by the time I met you they were the only ones still alive. She leaned forward and put white-knuckled fists on the windowsill to stabilize herself. “There used to be ten, back during the first war.”

“The Beast had started to spread here and we were deployed to defend it. Evie had discovered ignominite already so we had a fighting chance of pushing the infection back if we got in fast enough. My group was stationed at a forward base near the shoreline. We were overrun one day…completely overrun. Thralls and troopers everywhere. Then Beast came for me directly. One big tendril of concentrated biomatter out of nowhere. Slammed me against a wall when I was distracted and completely encased me.”

Pip was staring glassy-eyed at nothing. Catra couldn’t tell whether she was disassociating because she’d heard this story already or not, but she figured she already knew how this story went: Taline had wrestled with the Beast and somehow gotten away alive while it consumed the planet.

“I died here,” Taline said, blowing Catra’s carefully preconceived guesses to smoke. “Over a decade ago, on this very planet, the Beast killed me.”

“But…” Catra gestured at her with two open palms, trying to get her intention across while sputtering. “But you’re here. You’re alive.”

Taline looked down at herself and frowned. It was as if Catra’s words had been news to her—news she had to seriously consider as if it were new, revelatory, world-shattering information.

“I suppose I am,” she said, halting. “It sure looks that way, doesn’t it? But it doesn’t feel that way. Hasn’t felt that way in years.” She looked back up and out the window as Catra felt a beat of magic pulse, her eyes glowing and ley lines appearing on her skin before disappearing. “Never used to be able to do that, before. I keep looking out this window expecting to see a tombstone with my name on it, maybe next to Evelyn’s. I keep expecting to wake up.”

Catra opened and closed her mouth, trying to find the words. What could you even say to that? Taline mentioned this place fucked with your head, but was it getting to her, now?

“When I woke up, I was told I’d fought it off,” Taline said. “I’m not an Abomination, contrary to what our landing party must assume. I have a feeling it’s because I know what happened to me. Salas once put it into words. Like a lucid dreamer, he’d said. Someone who knows who they are and knows what reality is well enough to keep their wits about them.

“Suddenly, it was like the rules of magic no longer applied. I saw… too much. I could cast spells without runes, although I wasn’t as skilled with it. And when I emerged, I fought off the hundreds of thralls and troopers that had surrounded our position on the beach. Single-handedly. Those under my command pledged themselves to me as Sentinels. They called me Seraph—a high angel.” She scoffed, and the disdain on her face was unmistakable. “A savior.”

“You did the same thing Corynth did for your sister,” Catra said. “I thought he was the only one to ever actually defeat the Beast.”

“I was to be a Shaper too, just like him, remember? It was because of that moment they tagged me for reecruitment.”

Catra nodded, but something still didn’t add up. “You saved the base. Archanas didn’t fall.”

"I evacuated all the megaliths under my jurisdiction," she said. "Then we left. Myself, my remaining troops, and the few hundred thousand Archanan refugees that were processed onto the ships all left. Immediately. There were hundreds of other evacuation sites still on the planet, but I pulled my people out. They then shuttled me directly back to the Heartlands for a full examination amidst a quarantine. That's when the envoy came, and shortly after that, Evie's trial and my very public falling out with Corynth."

Catra swallowed. It was hard to imagine the whirlwind of change and confusion Taline must have endured from all that. To have survived—maybe in just the literal sense, from how she'd put it—a direct attempt on her sanity by the Beast? Then verifying the existence of a secret cabal of assassins, only to discover someone close had been part of them without saying anything from the start? And then losing her sister…

"I was redeployed to the front lines again after that," Taline said. "The Emperor wanted me out of his sight for failing to stop Corynth and his Daiamid from leaving. Probably expected me to die on the battlefield properly this time. Except now, I'd learned to anticipate the enemy. After rebuffing its attempt to take me, I could read the Beast almost like a well-seasoned commander could anticipate a terrestrial enemy. Before long, I'd gone from commanding ground squads to whole ground-side theaters. Within a year, I was commanding whole fleet operations, maneuvering in terms of systems and regions instead of planets and continents.

"Archanas remained deeply contested, but I'd managed to prevent the Beast from taking many of the other major population worlds, the ones that would have empowered it to win. For several years it never advanced beyond the Kaloshi border—beyond this very planet—because of the tactics and strategy I'd employed in neighboring sectors."

"You're a war hero," Catra said, somewhat breathless. She'd read of her exploits when researching the history of the war, of course, but hearing her speak them made it seem all the more real.

Taline languished under the comment in a way that surprised her. "You can't save everyone, and in a war where every dead ally multiplies the strength of the enemy…you have to make some drastic choices and shoulder some heartbreaking responsibility in turn."

Catra furrowed her brow, but kept silent.

"How many worlds do you think I lost, once I'd assumed command?" she asked. "Did you ever see a number? I know how thorough your interest goes in such history."

"Several hundred at least," Catra said, trying to remember what she'd read in the past. "But the number you'd managed to save was—"

"I only lost one, Catra," Taline said, gently, as if correcting someone for having gotten a minor detail wrong.

"I'm sorry?"

"I lost only one planet. *This* planet. All others the Beast occupied, I ensured there was nothing around for it to feed on. Those planets they say I saved are accurate—the infection was pushed out or enough were evacuated the media could avoid calling it a tragedy. The Lost Worlds, however, were only lost because we had limited resources and I deemed them not worth the expenditure. And even in that case, I still ensured the Beast had no living material to feed on when it eventually arrived."

Taline finally turned to look at Catra, and there was deep shame in her eyes. Enough Catra held her breath and felt her knees threaten to knock together or give out or both.

"Military leaders still order full-scale planetary bombardments of a planet when and if the Beast is fated to win," Taline said, continuing inexorably forward. "As many refugees as possible are funneled out beforehand, of course, but not everyone makes it. For those that don't, 'Operation Scorched Earth' is enacted to ensure the Beast has nothing to feed on, nothing to grow more

powerful from. Colloquially amongst the admirals, it is still called ‘Operation Seraph’s Wrath.’”

Catra couldn’t process what Taline had told her. All the pieces were there, but her brain couldn’t get any of them to fit. Almost like it didn’t want them to. Then, physically pulling into herself as if to become smaller, Taline, with the most pitiful whisper Catra had ever heard from her, said, “Sometimes I wonder if Salas was wrong. If I really am an Abomination even though I still feel like me, because that’s the kind of person—the kind of thing—I am deep down.”

Everything in Catra’s head screamed at her to say something, to reassure, to alleviate the pain Taline radiated. Even Pip, floating between them and casting frantic looks between them, told her to “say something to her already, please!”

But all the pieces had finally slotted together, all at once. Taline hadn’t lost those hundreds of worlds she’d read about. No, Taline had done what she could to save who she could, and turned the weapons of a Galactic Empire on those she couldn’t. All in the name of fighting the Beast, of self-preservation.

Taline pulled herself together, elongating herself vertebra by vertebra until she stood tall with an imperious look all on her own. Now it was no longer a question for Catra, how many times Taline had slotted her mask in place over the truth. Now, she knew the answer was too many times to count.

“We lasted for two years,” Taline said. “I bought us two years, won through endless battles, endless destruction, endless suffering. So many dead. But the Beast still grew stronger despite my efforts, and eventually it was clear we would lose Archanas, too.” She shook her head. “That realization felt like some kind of invisible, inaudible clarion call. Corynth’s Daiamid reappeared with Evelynn and her team in tow. And…and—”

She sucked in a strangled breath and a single tear broke free to trace a line down her face. It was the only indication she felt

anything at all because all Catra could glean from her otherwise was stone.

"—and I stayed. For once, I stayed, and I ordered everyone I could to stay, even when the Emperor ordered retreat. I stayed and commanded every gun I had to fire at a single spot on the planet." She spread her arms to gesture at the control room at their back and said, "This spot. So their small fleet could get through and end things. And years later…years after this planet turned my heart to glass, I can't help but think"—she swallowed, another crack  in the stone—"if I hadn't run away the first time…if I'd stayed behind when the Beast was much weaker and when I'd first fought it off, then—"

Catra finally reached out and grabbed one of Taline's hands gripping the windowsill. She squeezed and squeezed until Taline let go of the windowsill to turn her palm and squeeze back, finally revealing how badly in need of an anchor she was despite the mask.

Everyone else seemed too preoccupied with their jobs to have noticed, but Catra kept a surreptitious eye on them anyway. Keren, Trayn, and the others were guarding the analysts, the Vestamid techs were either working or helping instruct the analysts, and even Diallo was still hogging all of Larian and his priest's attention at the front.

"There's no way he's alive still," Taline said after a moment, her voice ragged and tinged with fear. "I don't want to believe it, I don't. If you'd seen what this planet had turned into that day, you'd understand. Sealing the Beast away turned the hundreds of other Shapers there with him to *ash*. I saw their outlines with my own eyes, after the battle was done and we touched down.

"Whatever is walking around in Corynth's skin is no longer him. And if that's the case, then he's been like that for years. It's no longer just some mindless creature looking to infect as many people as possible, it's been masquerading as him, concocting some plan no one is even aware of. It even subsumed *another*

Abomination it crossed paths with. That sort of thing, the merging of two centralized infection points like some sort of reverse mitosis…that hasn't happened since the last war, Catra.

"Larian said he hasn't seen him, but I'm certain Corynth's Abomination is still influencing this sect, somehow. The thing is a hive mind, and if it's become powerful enough to hide, then it's become powerful enough to exert its will through the dead parts of itself here on this very planet."

"They did say they'd started hearing it directly," Catra said. "The Beast. No more goddess."

Taline nodded, and was shaking visibly, now. She squeezed her eyes shut and fresh tears flowed down her cheeks. Pip had moved to float by her shoulder now instead of Catra's, and was hugging her despite her not being able to feel it.

"I don't want to fight him," Taline said, her voice breaking. "I wasn't angry the first time we came to blows like that statue might have had you believe. I was terrified. I threw everything I had at him trying to get him to stop, trying to get him to let Evie go, but none of it even phased him. He spoke to me the whole time trying to get me to join them and never once sounded so much as winded.

"Him as a true Abomination? After all these years? I've grown more into my powers after so  much time, but…even if I can do more now, I don't know if I could beat him. And if I could…"

She cut off in a way that piqued Catra's interest. There was more there she'd stopped herself from saying. "And if you could…?"

Taline looked away and, in another quiet voice close to a whisper, said, "I'm afraid I wouldn't want to once I saw his face again."

Catra breathed out long and slow, another piece of another puzzle slotting to completion. Taline had pushed such naked, vehement hatred for Corynth every time Catra had brought him up not just because of what he'd done, but because, after all this time, she

wasn't entirely sure she really did hate him. Catra herself once had a complete meltdown trying to keep her position in the Horde after Adora had left. Deleting entire world populations to fight an interdimensional enemy and then losing two very important people after years of struggling was almost unfathomable.

She squeezed Taline's hand again, rubbing soothing circles over her knuckles until her shoulders stopped shaking.

"You won't have to fight him alone," Catra said, turning back to Taline. "We'll finish here and get off this stupid planet, then we'll figure out what to do about Corynth and Adora. I'll be there with you."

There was disbelief in her eyes when Taline looked at her again, but it was far more preferable than stone and steel. Catra couldn't find it in herself to label Taline a bad person, deep down. As horrible as the acts she'd confessed to, someone in this much pain from having committed them couldn't be evil in Catra's eyes. In fact, she saw her as brave and strong for putting on such a brave face. She didn't think even Adora could do that for more than a few minutes, let alone over a decade.

"I see your new Sentinel is just as loyal as the old ones," came a voice.

They both spun around to see Larian standing before them. Catra had no idea when he'd left Diallo or how he'd snuck up on them.

"I'd heard about what happened to Narre and Miri," Larian said. "Loyal help is hard to find, so you have my belated condolences. I hope the same fate doesn't befall you." This last he said with a bow to Catra.

Taline turned away and hid her face, and Catra decided that was her cue to handle whatever bullshit he'd come to them with and spare her. "What do you want?" she asked.

"Your team has everything they need to conduct a full analysis of our systems," he said. "But it will take time for them to comb

through everything. Since the Seraph expressed such interest in how we power our orbital canon, I'd thought it prudent to offer a tour of our newest addition to the facility."

Catra glanced to Taline who only gave a small nod of assent as she rubbed at her eyes with the heel of her palms.

"Excellent," Larian said, turning on his heel and gesturing for them and the priests to follow him again. "This way, please."

Catra gently pulled Taline away from the window and guided her to follow Larian's wake, then gestured for Trayn and Keren to come as well, and that was when she glimpsed six shadowed figures, swaying idly nearby.

They weren't at the corners of her vision like the first one was, and they didn't disappear when she looked directly at them, either. They were a clear fixture of the control room, standing feet away. Each had unblinking eyes of white set into their featureless faces. Catra couldn't shake the feeling they were all looking right at her. Her apeiron tied to its lanyard was warm to the touch, pressing against her breastbone.

One look at Pip confirmed she could see it too. Taline had warned her this place would play on her mind. The shadows turned to watch as she walked past, and Catra ignored them, heart pounding in her chest. She tried not to think of them at all as she followed Taline and the others to wherever Larian was taking them.

Chapter End Notes

> Archanas was something talked about but never explicitly described or explained with any depth since I think part 1. It finally getting screentime was a huge deal, and this is absolutely one of the chapters that went through many of the heaviest structural edits throughout the various drafts. In the end, it still weighed in at almost 9k words, one of the lengthiest chapters, because there's just so much that needs

to get setup and shown, even after cutting all the fat and streamlining as much as possible. I also considered splitting up the chapters, but didn't like any of the breaks I tried out.

Anyways, big long chapter on a dead world, hurray! Hope Taline's existential guilt over whether she's technically responsible for multiple genocide or not doesn't get you down too bad :(

# Confessional

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora held tight to the handhold overhead as their tram rocketed through Phoenix's transit tunnels. Corynth had taken her past customs checkpoints, the paperwork they'd taken off security in the hangar ensuring they got through both the throng of refugees and officials at the control points without incident.

"The Beast," she said, keeping her voice low to prevent the others around them riding the tram from hearing, "was it…scary to talk to?"

Adora realized how stupid the question must have sounded when Corynth turned a look on her.

"You said you went through a ritual with it," she said by way of explanation. When that didn't connect any dots for him, she huffed, and her voice came out more timid than she'd have liked. "The nightmares I get…it's always the same thing. I'm hurtling through space, watching stars and planets snuff out as the Beast eats them. Then it notices me. Turns around and talks to me. It's terrifying."

Understanding dawned on his face and he nodded. "Yes and no," he said after a moment. "It was already malicious by my time. It had already escaped into our dimension and the first war was in full effect, remember? But the impression I got from Evie's jaunts through time seemed to paint the Beast as somewhat more… docile, so to speak, far in the past."

The train continued to speed along, the lamps illuminating the tunnel they raced along casting a rhythmic strobe of shadow and light inside the car. They took a sudden curve, and Adora leaned with the tram as it banked.

“I wish this never happened,” Adora said. “I wish the Beast never broke through in the first place…I wish everyone’s chances for survival didn’t depend on us shoring up the Barrier or on me becoming She Ra again—on using the Heart. I wish I didn’t wake up in a cold sweat in the middle of every third night hearing its voice in my head, telling me it’s coming for me.”

Corynth studied her before looking back out the window. “Me too,” he said at last. It was a blunt admission Adora wasn’t expecting to get from him. “A lot of my friends would still be alive, otherwise.”

Some of the tension left her shoulders, then. Tension she’d lived with so long she’d forgotten it was there. Maybe it was finally acknowledging, in words, how they were both in this clusterfuck (as Glimmer and Catra would no doubt put it) sinking ship of a situation together, but that lonely feeling she’d definitely been aware of carrying for years now had left with the tension, too. She had no idea what to make of it. For the second time since leaving Eden, she no longer felt as alone.

With that realization came a new emotion she hadn’t felt in a while and she acted on it, a predatory smile slithering onto her face. She nudged Corynth in the side until she got his attention again.

“I think you and Taline could work things out,” she said to him, and the look of blatant surprise that flashed across his face was perfect.

“What makes you think that?” He was humoring her.

“I just have a feeling.”

It was the truth—she really did have a strong feeling things could work out that she had no way of explaining. It was the same kind of gut feeling that had told her to defect in the first place, and then to smash the Sword of Protection, although that last one she admitted hadn’t exactly panned out. Either way, she was in a good mood all of a sudden, and she wasn’t going to complain if some of

that positivity rubbed off on him. She was pretty sure he wouldn't complain about it, either.

"You know, Evie said the same thing to me, too."

"Really? I must be right, then." She flipped her hair over her shoulder the way she'd seen Horde cadets do when feeling cocky, coming down off a high in the training simulators as kids. "That's not the first time her and I had the same advice for you. Funny how it's still relevant, all these years later."

"I'm pretty sure she was just reading the future, even though she never told me she could."

"Maybe she didn't want your behavior to change? Like, if she told you what the future held, then you'd act differently and then that future would change." When Corynth turned a questioning look on her, she gave an exaggerated shrug and, in an effort to explain herself, said, "Bow's parents have a big library. Lots of science fiction novels. Turns out books are a pretty good tool for escapism. Who knew?"

"Is that where you were when you used to disappear for days on end and people would start talking?"

Another shrug. "Maybe."

Corynth laughed, but in a way that told her he understood. "Evie wasn't trying to keep from influencing me. It was the opposite, actually."

"What do you mean?"

"At some point, she'd learned how to interact with people when looking through the timestream. She never mentioned that either, of course. I found out long after she'd died, when I'd realized the one unifying feature of the many different sects of the Vestamid religion was their goddess. One that sounded strikingly like her, in the flesh."

Adora knit her brows together. “She started the Vestamid? That crazy group of fanatics you told me ran Eden?”

“Allegedly ran Eden.”

Adora scowled at him. She’d seen them in the lab they’d dragged him to, half dead. Heck, she was pretty certain the physician who checked on her injuries was a member, himself.

“Evie had learned narrated the events of the war to those in the past,” Corynth said. “To everyone she’d visit, it just seemed like a crazy dream. But when the war actually hit…”

“All those people remembered her visits as visions. As actual prophecy.” Irritation spiked in Adora’s chest. “Yet another thing you conveniently forgot to mention back on Eden,” she said.

“It wouldn’t have made sense for Kallanthe to know that. I had to be cautious.”

Adora snorted, finding humor in how he could say something so ridiculous with such conviction. “I saw you bum rush an Abomination with a shotgun then eat it, uhm, hello? You aren’t cautious.” When he dropped his jaw at her for dismissing him outright, she rolled her eyes and shook her head in endearing exasperation. “I bet you a thousand imperial credits that you and Taline will work your differences out and be friends again.”

Corynth’s expression turned to shrewd disbelief. Adora turned an innocent look on him that felt overdone even to her.

“What?” she asked, after he didn’t say anything. “I thought you liked betting?”

“You don’t have a thousand credits.”

“I’m a princess on a really, *really* important planet. I have a castle. Made of crystals! I have enough money, don’t you trust me?”

Corynth stared at her and she stared back at him. He was waiting for her to break character and start laughing but she refused to, pressing her lips together into a thinner and thinner line as seconds passed and the tension between them grew.

At last, Corynth broke the spell. He started to chuckle, and that chuckle snowballed into a roiling belly laugh. Adora joined him when she couldn't hold it together anymore, doubling over with tears pricking her eyes. Everyone in the tram car stared at them, concerned.

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The tram exited the tunnel it was speeding through and a sweeping view of the Atrium sprawled out before them. Adora's jaw dropped.

Phoenix's "rich district" was magnificent. The flooring gleamed with the artificial light shining from a ceiling dozens of stories overhead, sliced with mezzanines and office-slash-condo balconies. It was the first time Adora had seen actual plants since leaving Etheria, too. Not even Eden had trees or growth that hadn't looked plastic and manicured; the whole area reminded her of Bright Moon, if it were transplanted inside a station floating through space.

Adora stared at the view as they sped along, the knowledge that she'd likely not get the chance to explore like she had on Eden already disappointing her.

"This place is feeling it bad," Corynth said, looking down at the masses of people spread through the levels below. It was just as crowded—if not more so—as the customs checkpoint from earlier. "The blockade outside the station was one thing, but the fact they're putting the refugee overflow up here of all places means they're way past capacity. No wonder they tried to turn us away."

"There are a lot of people, sure, but there's still plenty of space," Adora said, noting how, although it was crowded, it wasn't stifling. "They can fit plenty more as far as I can tell."

“Physically maybe, but that’s not it.” Corynth was frowning. “Never in a million years would I have imagined actually seeing refugees gathered in any well-off area of an Imperial settlement. The Empire’s rich are almost as militant about cordoning off their space from ‘unwelcomes’ as the actual military is about fighting off the Beast. Or quelling insurrections or rebellious colonies.

“The fact any refugees at all are being allowed up here means the station is pushed way past its limit and they have no choice but to allow it. Stuff too many people in a lower ward such that life support in that sector fails, it could have a domino effect on the rest of the station. That’s something not even they would risk.”

The opulence spread out before her out the window no longer seemed appealing. Bright Moon was always a welcoming place; Angella had even taken her in when she was nothing but a recently defected Horde soldier. The fact portions of the Empire’s citizenry—those least exposed to the difficulties and tragedies of the Beast conflict—held such little regard for refugees of all people put a sour taste in her mouth. She had to admit, though: she wasn’t at all surprised.

The tram made three stops before they got off at the fourth. Adora followed Corynth across the platform and down two flights of stairs to the ground floor. It wasn’t nearly as crowded with people this deep into the ward, and everyone looked well dressed and fed compared to those throngs she’d glimpsed further back. No one here looked like a refugee, and Adora wondered why until they rounded a corner and it suddenly made sense.

Trees and shrubs and green lawns had dotted the landscape before, but this area was on a new plane of beauty. Lavish gardens stretched as far as Adora could see, threaded with gilded walkways. Tiered mezzanines formed a web above them stretching to the artificial ceiling, dripping with displays of outlandish wealth. Adora stood mesmerized by it all, affected in a way nothing she’d seen since leaving Etheria had done.

Corynth didn't wait for her, and she rushed to catch up to him when she finally came back to herself.

"So how exactly does it work?" she asked, struggling to keep up with his brisk pace.

"How does what work?"

"The magic. Your magic."

They were halfway across a cobblestone bridge—one connecting two artificial islands in the middle of an artificial lake, Adora tracing fingers along the grooves in the wrought iron railing—when Corynth pulled up short and turned a look on her.

"I get where it comes from," she said, meek, trying to bolster herself underneath his scrutiny. "And believe me, that's terrifying enough as it is. But how does it *work*? Micah, the Enclave—they use runes. The princesses use their runestones." She flapped an arm at him, expecting him to work out the rest.

Corynth eyed a group strolling past them on the bridge. He started walking again, slower this time, easier for Adora to follow, and didn't answer until they were out of earshot..

"It's pure willpower," he said. "I can cast runes just like any other Mystacor mage or Enclave Battlemage, but shaping my magic is like…flexing your hands versus using those hands to write something down. Both require intention, but one is far more visceral than the other. The only difference being moving your arm typically doesn't come with dire consequences if you somehow fuck it up."

"What kind of consequences are we talking about, here?" The path away from the bridge led into a hedge maze, and Adora stuck even closer to Corynth as they traversed its halls, a strange fear of getting turned around and lost by herself on yet another alien station occupying a significant portion of her thoughts. Why was a hedge maze even on a space station to begin with?

"You mean aside from the ever-present danger of turning into an Abomination and threatening reality?"

"Ah, well…" Adora really should have guessed that.

"Even if you're strong enough to remain yourself, you are still unbinding and reforming the strictures of reality. With runic, you're merely combining raw materials already present with formulae, but Shaping allows for *creatio ex nihilo*—spontaneous generation."

"Geeze, that already sounds ominous."

"Even something small, like a modest fire, for example, can become incredibly dangerous when you try to bend reality to create it rather than just rely on a tried and tested runes. Screw that up and you might self-immolate, or maybe you'd burn your house down. Worse, maybe it will be a bystander next to you, or someone halfway across the galaxy. Maybe it will be someone you care about."

He stopped at a juncture in the maze and, after a moment of consideration, took the left path. His choice seemed far more arbitrary that Adora would have liked. "All that to say, for simple, routine utility, relying on runes and pre-verified formulae is preferable."

"What if the magic isn't small or simple, then?" Adora asked.

"Like what?"

"I don't know. Making fire out of nothing sounded pretty cool and not very simple."

"You sound like an initiate. More concerned with doing what's 'cool' than understanding that messing with the fabric of reality isn't something to ever take lightly. Shifting yourself to another physical location, bringing that physical location to you instead, warping spacetime around yourself …any sort of bodily metamorphosis whatsoever." Corynth counted off each example

on his fingers. “You’d better know what the hell you’re doing, because fucking up something like that engenders far worse than accidentally setting things on fire. How long did it take you to figure out how to teleport onto Horde Prime’s citadel to fight him?”

“Several hours, plus Micah and Shadow Weaver, who are two of the most powerful magic users I know exist even after finding out about the Enclave. Plus Entrapta.”

Right, and how long did it take Taline to open a portal and bring Angella back from the void?”

“Several continuous days and a team of mages that were leading experts on runic magic, from what I remember,” Adora said. “Plus Entrapta.”

Corynth nodded. “Translating magic like that into runic are amazing feats in and of themselves,” Corynth said. “I know Taline spent considerable time on both, and even used some of the methods Micah and Shadow Weaver devised for teleportation when she was working to retrieve Angella. However gruesome you imagine the effects of potentially messing up those spells might be, I promise the reality is worse. And those are just advancing applications of teleportation. Don’t get me started on trying to wipe minds, for example, or manifesting someone who’d died long ago.”

“Wait, you weren’t joking when you said you could resurrect people?” Adora asked, nearly walking into a lamppost and only then realizing the hedge maze had dumped them out onto a spacious pavilion.

Corynth shook his head. “Wasn’t kidding.”

Adora didn’t know where to begin wrapping her head around necromancy of all things.

“It’s not quite what you think,” Corynth said, speaking as if he’d read her mind and making Adora question whether he was

capable of that, too. “Resurrection is probably too dramatic a word for it. It’s not necromancy—that’s an entirely different school of practice, although the similarities are there. You aren’t raising anyone out of a grave, per se, and no one is sticking around any longer than your ability to enforce your will against nature pushing back on you.”

He grimaced. “In any case, it’s unnatural. And the Beast takes this already twisted thing and warps it further when it creates its thralls and Troopers.”

Adora pressed her lips into a thin line, unsure of what to make of that. What exactly was he talking about if not reviving a corpse from a grave? She could imagine creating a fireball or manifesting armor or shapeshifting, since she’d seen that kind of magic play out before. Glimmer’s poofing magic was easy to think about too, and she’d witnessed Enclave and Etherian sorcerer both draw and activate countless thousands of runes. But resurrection? Or, well…’not-quite -resurrection’? Manifesting a location around yourself? The way Corynth talked about some of this stuff made it very difficult for her to picture it in her head.

The pavilion eventually gave way to a spacious pseudo-outdoor bazaar, dotted with market-stall gazebos and black-marble statues striking dramatic poses. A few were of Horde Prime, but others, to Adora’s surprise, seemed to be statues of other famous people throughout the empire’s history.

“Do you still know where we’re going?” she asked, when Corynth picked a path winding through the market again seemingly at random.

“Maybe,” Corynth said. “Not convinced we’re lost, just yet.” He took a hard left at the first intersection, following a path that took them by a larger-than-life statue of Horde Prime with a waterfall flowing from outstretched hands. He stopped again, more suddenly than before, and Adora almost ran into him.

“Hey, what are you—”

“We need to split up,” he said, eyes darting every which direction.

“What? Why?”

Corynth locked onto a spot far in the distance. When Adora tried to follow his line of sight, he grabbed her by the arm and turned her in the opposite direction.

“Go pick one of the stalls and blend in,” he said. “Look like you’re perusing. Chat up some of the stall owners, just don’t draw attention to yourself.”

“But—”

“Go. I’ll be back.”

He was gone before she could turn and catch him, and nothing seemed out of the ordinary when she did. A chill shot down her spine, though, making her hair stand on end, and that was all it took for Adora to stifle a shudder and get to work. If he’d needed to act that quickly to separate them, he must have seen something serious.

She kept her head low as she walked to one of the stalls nearby. She looked at whatever was on the display, eyes roving vague forms her brain didn’t care to discern because she was hyper focused on everything around her, vigilant for danger. Still, she’d frozen her face into what she hoped was a contemplative expression, if only to fool anyone who might look at her.

“You have to actually buy a paper if you want to read it,” the stall owner said after a moment.

Adora startled and glanced up. The stall owner regarded her with a skeptical look, one eyebrow raised. His eyes flicked to her split lip and a deep frown appeared on his face. Adora cursed at herself in her head; two seconds in and she was drawing the wrong kind of attention.

"I said you have to buy a paper if you want to read any of the stories in it," the owner said again. "I don't care if the Beast ate your world and you just barely made it here looking for information. If you want a paper, you have to pay for it."

Adora furrowed her brow and looked down at the items on display again, finally seeing them. They were newspapers. Everything was a newspaper—the stall didn't sell anything else. She picked some random stall focused on just *pretending* to blend in, but she'd picked the one stall where perusing with a convincing expression just looked like she was trying to read the material for free. Stupid.

The front-page headline jumped out at her. Giant, bold letters mentioned another planet under siege, warring with the Beast.

*Scavria Under Attack!* it read. Adora followed the first paragraph: *One of the largest hub planets on the Kaloshi border has recently gone into total lockdown when the stirrings of a Beast infection were detected in the capital city of Tir. With the planet's proximity to a major Barrier node, and it being within jumping distance of Archanas—another symbolic site for the war against the enemy—tensions abound over whether or not the Imperial response can save the planet. Are we on the cusp of another tipping point in the war against the enemy?*

The only other story sharing space on the first page was that of the old Regional Administrator, recently incarcerated on narcotics charges. Adora got halfway through scanning that headline when the stall owner slammed both hands palm-down on the tabletop.

"Hey!" he said. "Stop reading my papers without paying for it! You refugees are nothing but a nuisance, I cannot believe the Administration let you up here." He turned and spat on the floor next to him with a sneer on his face. "Moriarty be damned. The man must have been huffing too many paint cans, it's the only way I could see him signing off on something like that, especially after getting caught with that stuff in his desk. And by the Seraph of all people."

Adora panicked. Whatever Corynth had in mind for her blending in, this wasn't it. "How much?" she asked for lack of anything better to say to try and placate him. The stall owner told her, but she had no context for the figure he quoted her. She didn't have any money! Not unless the handful of Etherian coins she'd managed to keep on her person all this time would suffice. Which they wouldn't since almost no one knew Etheria existed in the first place yet.

"Well? Are you going to pay for one or am I going to have to call the guards? They might give you a black eye to go with that bruised lip."

*Shit*. Adora really didn't know what to do. This was a thousand times worse than the scuffle in the hangar. Her first instinct was to just sprint as fast as she could in the opposite direction, but that would draw attention to her and make it harder for Corynth to find her again.

Something large and fluffy and purple appeared out the corner of her vision before she could land on anything, though.

"Leave her alone, Joris," said the mass of purple, who Adora realized the next moment was actually portly middle-aged woman covered in exotic alien furs holding a purse. She picked a paper up between her thumb and index finger, holding it like she'd plucked out a rat by its tail. "Heaven forbid someone actually reads your newspapers. You're business has boomed only because of the refugee crisis, you know."

"I run a stall, not a public library," Joris said. "Reading without paying is a crime."

The woman snorted and tossed a handful of coins onto the stall table. "Here, girl," she said, pushing the newspaper into Adora's chest.

The owner sputtered. "Coins?" he said. "What the fuck am I supposed to do with coins? Wire the funds!"

“No one reads physical newspapers anymore,” The woman said, rounding on Joris once Adora took the paper from her. “I paid for your archaic news with archaic money.”

Adora backed away from the both of them, sensing they were too distracted arguing to notice her leave. Even if she wasn’t in Joris’ sites any longer, being around two arguing people would still draw too much attention. She passed by a trash receptacle and dumped the paper in it, making sure neither saw her do so.

Someone grabbed her by the arm again and she whirled around, fist raised, ready to punch them in the face. Corynth didn’t flinch, and an apology was already on Adora’s tongue when he spoke first.

“Walk with me,” he said. “Keep your head down and don’t look anyone in the eyes. Security is crawling absolutely everywhere here.”

He didn’t wait for her, but Adora had been left behind enough times to have finally caught on. She kept pace with him, eyes scanning the feet of those around them instead of their faces. Together, they hurried far away from Joris and the squabbling woman. The last she heard of their argument before it faded into the din was of the woman making the case that any of the refugees arriving here might not have money to wire, just what they carried on them, and that Joris would do well to accept it if they came to him looking information.

“Hell, you might build some karma for yourself and offer it for free, or at least a discount,” she said. “You of all people probably need it.”

Adora smiled. Corynth had painted a bleak picture of the imperial upper crust, and Joris’ attitude only soured her further. But the woman was proof enough that there was compassion in the general populace as well, even those well-off enough to wear exotic furs across their shoulders.

Three pairs of white-booted feet crossed her line of sight and Adora glanced up at who was attached to them. Three Vanguard soldiers dressed in full kit, rifles included, patrolled in formation not far from them. Her heart rate sped up, and Corynth nudged her in the side.

"Don't stare at them," he said, practically hissing.

"What the hell are the Vanguard doing here?" she asked. "This isn't some front-line world, this is supposed to be a commerce station, isn't it?"

Adora had had plenty of time to study Corynth's star charts during their hyperspace transit from Eden and Glimmer had even pointed out Phoenix's location to her at one point. They weren't in the Heartlands, but the station was sufficiently close enough to it that none of the empire's elite frontier soldiers should have had any reason to show up. This was what keyed her in to things being not as they should be, more than the blockade and refugee crisis.

"I told you things were bad," Corynth said. "Moriarty was a Regional Admin, directly under Horde Prime himself. They were likely part of his personal guard. Him getting busted for narcotics and Taline taking over on top of the refugees flooding in is only making things more tense."

"I saw that another planet was under siege by the Beast, too," Adora said. "A big one, near a Barrier node."

Corynth nodded, a grimace on his face. "Scavria. I saw. All the more reason for us to hurry. I need you to focus, Adora, this isn't like Eden. Even though this is an imperial settlement, that only makes it more dangerous for us."

They'd passed the earlier patrol by now, but she caught sight of another Vanguard team confronting someone up ahead. This person stood out only because the clothes they wore pegged them as another refugee and not a resident. After a few

exchanged words and a brief scuffle, they lead the man away in handcuffs, a bruise beginning to swell his face.

Adora realized she and Corynth stuck out just as much, if not more than that man had. Corynth had the right idea, trying to avoid getting in their line of sight to begin with, and she remained hypervigilant as she trailed him, threading through countless people, taking turns along different paths seemingly at random.

At one point, she caught sight of a jumbotron high above them, displaying a never-ending stream of newsreel clips for all to see. A three-quarters portrait of Taline appeared. She was stony-faced with the scars across her cheek Horde Prime had given her on full display, but not much changed from when Adora had last seen her. The words: *Taline to assume temporary command of all Phoenix station amid Moriarty scandal* scrolled across the ticker on the bottom.

"Okay, I officially do not know where we are anymore," Corynth said, pulling Adora's attention back.

There was a bench near them, installed under a cherry blossom tree and yet another dark statue. He sat on the bench, tapping his foot and surveying their surroundings. It was clear he was trying to figure out where they were.

"I thought you said you knew where you were going," Adora said.

"I said *maybe*. This place is completely different from the last time I was here. It's like a city now. Just give me a minute, I know what I'm doing."

Adora snorted, but the statue behind the bench caught her attention before she could antagonize him further.

"It's you," Adora said, frowning up at it.

"What?"

She pointed up at the statue. "It's you."

Indeed, it was a statue of him, striking a dramatic pose with robes flaring out behind him, flapping and straining against a hurricane wind. The only different thing was the mask covering his features, barely visible inside the statue's deep hood.

He craned his body around to look, then glanced down at the plaque at the statue's base. *Corynth—Last Shaper of the Daiamid,* it read. *Savior of the Empire. Beast Slayer.*

Corynth—the actual, living one—turned back and faced forward with a snorted laugh and a shrug. "They got my nose wrong."

Adora refrained from saying the first thing that came to mind—that how could he know if the mask covered it—and was happy for it, first because she would have felt like an idiot reacting to something that was clearly a joke, and second because she got the sense Corynth still had more to say.

"I left that mask behind you know," he said after a moment, speaking barely loud enough for Adora to hear him. "I left it with Evie's body. That Corynth died with her."

A green person blinked into existence to Adora's immediate left, nearly stopping her heart cold. She yelped and swung at them out of reflex, only to watch her fist pass straight through their face.

"So sorry, I didn't mean to startle you!" the person—a transparent woman projected as a green hologram—said. "I'm Hilda, Phoenix Station's virtual artificial directory assistant."

"Took you long enough," Corynth said, still lounging on the bench. "I said I was lost a while ago now."

"My deepest apologies," Hilda said, bowing. "The recent influx of refugees has taxed my central processor to its limit. I am experiencing severe delays in responding to requests." She looked at them both in turn. "How may I be of assistance?"

"We need directions to the Enclave Embassies," Corynth said.

"I'm afraid the Embassies are inaccessible. Levels eight and above are sealed except for residents of those floors or by special permission of an authorized imperial official."

"Great," Corynth said. "I'm guessing the elevators are shut down and the Vanguard soldiers here would shoot anyone trying to tamper with them?"

Hilda nodded, and Corynth frowned.

"Maybe Catra would help us," Adora said, bringing her up like she hadn't already been thinking of her nonstop since escaping Eden. "She works security here. Or, at least, she's supposed to be working security here. Maybe if get in touch she'd be able to help us? If she doesn't hate me, that is…"

It was a long shot, truthfully, but Adora would do anything to see her face to face again. And while it was true they needed to address the Eye first, if they could do that *and* she could see Catra sooner, all the better, right? She hadn't seen or talked to her in three years, but the fact she was *right here* suddenly made the urge to reconnect so much stronger.

"Accessing public records," Hilda said as her eyes took on a faraway look. She blinked and focused back on Adora. "Station officer 'Catra' is no longer employed by any of Phoenix Station's security precincts. She is no longer present aboard this facility. Reason cited for termination: trespassing, espionage, and battery of a duly appointed Imperial Administrator."

"Damn," Corynth said, standing. "She's the one who busted Moriarty?"

"What do you mean she was terminated?" Adora asked on top of him. "Why is she no longer on the station? Where is she?"

"Can't be anywhere good," Corynth said. "It sounds like whatever she did wasn't exactly sanctioned."

Adora shook her head and took a step back, processing. “They didn’t…they didn’t kill her or something, did they? They couldn’t have.” Why else wouldn’t an AI plugged into all facets of the station be able to find her?

“They didn’t,” a voice from behind said.

Corynth and Adora spun around, ready for a fight. A man wearing a security chief’s uniform stood before them. Adora wondered how he snuck up on them without either of them noticing.

“Who are you?” Corynth said, not even looking at Hilda when she phased out of existence.

“My name is Dax,” the man said. “I was Catra’s supervisor until she went—until she got another job. She’s not dead, just not here.” He turned his attention to Adora. “Why are you asking about her?”

Adora caught sight of Corynth out of the corner of her eye trying to discretely warn her off saying anything. It probably would have been a smart idea not to reveal who she was, but she ignored him: Dax knew more about Catra’s whereabouts than anyone else at that point and that was enough for her.

“Adora,” she said, hoping she wasn’t making a mistake. “My name is Adora.”

Dax’s eyes widened. “The Adora?” he said, voice and expression decidedly not aggressive. “She’s mentioned you before. Wherever Taline took her, she’ll probably be really upset to find out you came here looking for her and she wasn’t around.”

Adora’s heart soared. Catra had talked about her! And not just that, Dax thought she’d be upset at them having missed one another.

“Where did Taline take her?” Corynth asked and, oh yeah, that was a good question, too.

Dax explained everything as best he could. They heard about how Catra supposedly snuck into Moriarty's office and uncovered the narcotics in his possession. They heard about how he was still being held in custody for it, despite being such a high-ranking official. He told them about how Catra and a local System Governor, who was somehow also involved, had been thrown in jail, only for Taline to release them and take the both of them off station to God-knows where.

"Much of this is just hearsay," Dax said as he finished up the story. "But everyone who knows Taline and knows Catra understands that this is a huge deal. The Consular hasn't been off station for three years. I don't think she was able to until she took Catra on as her Sentinel." He leaned close, eyes darting around as if to check for eavesdroppers before saying, in a whisper, "Some are even calling her 'Seraph' again."

That seemed to get a reaction out of Corynth, although he didn't say anything or ask further questions.

"Thank you for you telling us," Adora said.

"Yes, well…" Dax looked over his shoulder like he was checking for anyone listening in on them. "I know you're her friend, and I'm concerned about her. I'm glad she found a new job before Moriarty slashed our budget and forced me to lay off half the precinct, but even though she was one of my best officers, Sentinel is not what I imagined her getting herself into. Proud as I am she qualified for it, it's dangerous business. Anything at all to do with Taline and the Enclave is dangerous business."

"We need to get to their Embassies," Corynth said. "I didn't know the station was locked down to this effect until we arrived, and we don't have the proper authorization to work the elevators."

"You did hear me when I said the Consular is not on station, right? It's not really going to matter much how urgent whatever appointment you have is if she's not even here to take it. Why not

get some time on an ansible and reach out to her from there if it's really important?"

"She'll come when she realizes I'm here," Corynth said, shaking his head. "Few hundred thousand light years of space isn't going to stop her."

Dax raised both his eyebrows in surprise and Adora could see him connecting dots. "You know her personally, don't you?" When Corynth nodded, once, Dax sighed. "I'm guessing that appointment is really important?"

"Yes."

Dax sighed again and spoke to himself. "Of course it is. This day keeps getting stranger and stranger." He looked around yet again, searching again for eavesdroppers. "Okay, I'll help you."

"Really?" Adora asked, not entirely believing their luck.

"Really." Dax shot her a weary smile. "It's almost impossible for anyone to get up there, but I have the authorization to make it happen. And if it's to help Catra and Taline in whatever they ran off to do, then I will help. Follow me."

Dax stalked off, away from the bench and the statue and the cherry blossoms, walking down a different path than the one they had come from. Corynth and Adora looked at one another, then Adora hefted the pack holding the Eye more securely over her shoulder and they both followed Dax deeper into the gardens.

Chapter End Notes

> Adora co-opting Corynth and Vasher's long-standing betting habit with each other was what got this chapter to click for me when first writing it. Her flipping the script on Corynth and surprising him for once was cathartic to write :) It was also nice getting her to slowly (finally) gain some of her confidence back when she's been shoved on her ass and essentially pinned there for most of this fic. She dropped it

way back in part 1 when her mission to Horde Prime's citadel blew up in her face, so it's been a long time.

Her making a mistake with the newspaper vendor but not immediately beating herself up over it was another subtle shift in her personality. The fact she was able to listen in on and feel hopeful when one of the rich people trying to stick up for her was a big one too, since many of her chapters in part 2 were her getting down on herself, and many of her chapters in part 3 were her just trying to tread water after stepping into Narnia lol.

Anybody have guesses on how long it will last?

ps: the bench with the statue and the cherry blossom tree was the exact place Catra talked to Hilda at back in part 2, just in case the description sounds familiar :) +1 for reusing set pieces. This is the part where, if this were a tv show I was watching, I'd point to the screen and be like "hey they're at that place!" :D

# Convergence

Chapter Notes

> I apologize in advance for the monstrosity of the author's note I left at the end of this chapter. Everything under the asterisks is just me nerding out about plotting and story structure lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After several days of ceaseless tests and monitoring, the three rotating shifts of doctors and nurses that were overseeing Glimmer's quarantine aboard the *Omen-Kador* had managed to heal almost all the damage her body had sustained touching the Beast. Only a circular burn scar on her palm remained to remind her she'd shoved far too much magic through her body all at one time.

Then they finally discharged her.

Release had come just in time, really. She'd been on the verge of forcefully discharging herself she was so keyed up, sitting around doing nothing, being stared at and poked at all day and night. Several times, she'd wondered if talking to Bow might have made things easier. Even with their relationship still strained, she could imagine him being a solid anchor for her, to beat back the worries and the nightmares about Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio, and the rest of the few remaining Scavrians.

Part of her was unsure whether to be grateful she wasn't allowed her PDA during the quarantine. She surely would have agonized over even more drafts she'd never send to him. Maybe it was a good thing she didn't have the temptation.

The moment she got free Glimmer hurried down one of the supercarrier's main hallways to the hangars. Halfway to the service elevators, the ship rumbled and she braced herself against the wall to keep her footing; they were still bombarding Scavria's

surface after all this time. None of the other crew seemed to even notice the jostle, but the doctors had warned Glimmer she'd be unsteady on her feet still. Leave it to her to not take them seriously until a small jostle almost threw her into a bulkhead.

She carried herself into the nearest piston lifts with more care and rode it down.

Despite having served on countless vessels over the years, Glimmer couldn't help the awe she felt when the lift doors opened and the enormous hangar stretched out before her. As the flagship for the Scavria campaign's 90-ship response fleet, the *Omen-Kador* was one of the largest in the entire Imperial Navy, fitting four of the six refugee megaliths from Tir in its central cavern.

A passenger cart carrying ten Scavrians zoomed past her and maneuvered its way through the throng of even more Scavrians scurrying about the hangar on foot. Glimmer was grateful she didn't have to flag one down: Lonnie had messaged her to meet near the megalith closest to the access lift she stepped off of. It was close enough to walk.

The Scavrians had transformed the first few levels of the hangar into a new refugee compound, and the sight filled Glimmer with more hope and gratitude than she'd ever have expected. The Scavrians had practically nothing. They couldn't even say they escaped with their lives—not for a majority of few fractured, splintered families that had made it off world—and yet everything she saw as she walked the hundred-some yards looking for Lonnie told they had come together.

Glimmer knew from previous deployments and from commiserating with Taline over the years that the refugees were always like raw, open wounds: everyone avoided them so soon after escape, even their fellow refugees. But from what she could tell here, the Scavrians had somehow put their diverse skills to use, scrounged for supplies from who knows where, and somehow set up tenements lively enough to draw crowds of not

just other fellow refugees, but even enlisted and commissioned officers serving aboard the flagship.

She hadn't realized how industrious a people they were until she passed a stall selling shredded ice with flavoring, then another with hand-whittled wooden figurines. The Beast had robbed them of everything, yet their determination to rebuild—to smile—touched Glimmer in a way she'd never expected. Sidelining herself as a Battlemage, working the evacuation centers for years, risking her life to save her friends, losing the planet anyway. And now, finally, the forest instead of the trees at last stood out to her.

Losing Rinne, losing Scavria…losing *anyone* would always be a tragedy. But there was beauty in what she'd saved. Beauty she'd done disservice to in the past because she'd never acknowledged it. There was strength and resilience here, in the Scavrian people. Strength and resilience she'd dare not let herself tarnish now that she'd finally noticed it.

A child was hocking handmade necklaces standing near her mother. She smiled and waved. Glimmer smiled and waved back like a reflex, and any concern she might have had about the Scavrian peoples' ability to bounce back disappeared in a cloud of smoke.

At last, she found Lonnie, standing with Kyle and Rogelio, separate from the stalls. They were speaking to a pair of Scavrians, and Kyle held a third, smaller one one in his arms. It wasn't until she got close enough to overhear their conversation that Glimmer realized they refugees seemed familiar.

"—keeps waiting for his parents to show up," one said. "They're not on the intake records for any of the megaliths, so it's likely they didn't make it…I just don't know what to say to him. And I hate feeling like I'm lying to him whenever I change the subject."

"He'll understand if you tell him the truth," Lonnie said while Kyle bounced the child on his shoulders, distracting him with laughter. "He probably already has a feeling. It won't be easy but, kids are

smart. And it’s obvious you care about him. As hard as it will be, he will come out okay. Especially with you both there for him, too.”

“We’re not letting him out of our sight,” the third said, combing fingers through her long hair. “We worked for his family for years and took him in when the Crechemaster’s office was full. If all of Scavria falling to the Beast wasn’t enough to separate us, then—”

“Then nothing will,” Lonnie said with a smile. “Good.”

“Ennis?” Glimmer said, finally reaching them. “Marcie? Newt?”

Newt was off Kyle’s shoulders and barreling into her for a hug before she could finish. She hadn't seen the three of them since processing them into the compound. The relief Glimmer felt at seeing the three of them alive and still together was palpable, and judging by how Marcie and Ennis wrapped her in an embrace right after Newt, they felt the same.

“Look who finally decided to show up,” Lonnie said, smile even wider once they’d let her go. She wandered over and punching her in the shoulder. Rogelio came with her sporting a toothy smile and handed her a candy bar, which she took gratefully, letting out a moan of satisfaction when she unwrapped it and bit into it.

“I couldn’t help it,” Glimmer said, rubbing her arm and chewing. “The doctors—oh my god, this is so good. Thanks, Rogelio, I haven't eaten since this morning." She swallowed. “The doctors were paranoid about me being exposed to the Beast, so they were extra careful about quarantining and testing me. I thought I’d go mad from boredom.”

“It was the same with us,” Kyle said. “They locked us in a room together and ran way more tests than usual. You should have seen their reaction when Lonnie finally snapped at them. I swear I thought I saw all the color drain out of that one nurse’s face when she started talking about what she’d do if they didn’t discharge us immediately.”

“Hey!” Lonnie scowled when Rogelio started laughing, prompting Kyle to burst into peals of laughter, too. “They have accurate readings for this stuff. It makes no sense for them to keep you for days and test you a hundred times in a row just to ‘confirm one more time’ over and over again. It’s ridiculous.”

“I was on the verge of walking out myself too, whether they liked it or not,” Glimmer said. “Why did they keep me so much longer than you guys, though?”

“Maybe because you’re way more dangerous than any us if you’re corrupted?” Kyle said.

"Yeah, but I'm still right about the instruments having accurate readings," Lonnie said before turning a look on Glimmer. "Did you tell them about the visions? You'd mentioned seeing them planet-side—that they weren’t the typical moving shadows and ghosts everyone else usually sees whenever a Beast infestation gets going. "

Glimmer shook her head. “Nothing out of the ordinary happened after we’d left, so I didn’t say anything.” Truthfully, she didn’t want to scare the doctors into keeping her even longer, and something about her conversation with Evelynn told her it wasn’t something anyone would be able to speak to, anyway.

Lonnie just smirked. “Maybe they just enjoyed your sunny personality enough they wanted to keep you longer. At least they were able to patch us all up.” She flexed her hand down at her side. “Even took care of that burn I got on my hand touching you on top of the tower. Should have known not to grab you in the middle of doing something like that.”

“Lucky you,” Glimmer said, showing her scarred palm to all of them. “I came away with this.”

Lonnie whistled low and everyone else wince—everyone except Rogelio, who made some grunted comment about not

understanding how non-reptilian races coped with being unable to regenerate entire limbs as he could.

Glimmer rolled her eyes with a smile on her face and turned to the Scavrians, instead. "I'm glad to see you all again," she said to them. "I was thinking about you, although I'm surprised you guys found each other." She said this last part gesturing between them and Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio.

"We were worrying about you, too," Ennis said, taking Newt back from Kyle and handing him to Glimmer when he started making a fuss for her. "We heard you went back to rescue some stranded troopers after we lifted off instead of evacuating with us. When people started talking about how you actually managed to get your team rescued from the middle of the city during a bombardment, we kept an eye on them and reached out as soon as they were discharged."

"My team?"

Ennis looked between them, a confused. "Aren't they under your command? Sorry, I just assumed…"

"We aren't, technically," Lonnie said, shooting Glimmer a sheepish smile along with Kyle and Rogelio. "Just old friends."

"You know, during the countless hours I spent staring at a bare wall, I couldn't help but admit we did actually make a pretty good team," Glimmer said, watching a grin break out on the faces of all her friends. "I don't think it'd be such a bad idea to make things official. That is, if you're open to the idea…?"

"Really?" Lonnie asked. "You aren't shitting us?"

"I am not shitting you." Glimmer appreciated the smiles on their faces, but she didn't want to take anything for granted. Especially after getting into a huge fight with Lonnie over refusing her command the first time.

“Well…” Kyle said, drawing out the word such that Glimmer could just tell he was being annoying. “After you refused, High Command started putting names of new commanding officers in front of us to see if we’d bite. We’ve been pushing it off so far, saying we need more time to recover before thinking of a new assignment. But there is this one Battlemage. Pretty young but highly decorated, already. If her name were to suddenly pop up on our list of options, I don’t see why we wouldn’t agree to the assignment.”

The fact her friends were sought after enough there were other Battlemages jockeying for partnership and relying on High Command to mediate was amazing. “I’ll put in the request immediately.” Relief washed through her the moment she said so, and even Marcie and Ennis broke out in wide grins.

“Took you long enough,” Lonnie said, punching her in the arm again and earning a scowl from Newt in the process. “And here I thought you’d never come around, especially after I decked you out in front of the hospital.”

“I only accept command over people who can kick my ass in a fight,” Glimmer said.

That earned a laugh from everyone, and they lapsed into a comfortable silence with one another.

“There’s one thing that’s been bothering me, though,” Lonnie said. “What was that thing that attacked us at the end? It didn’t look anything like any of the thralls we’ve faced in the past. It didn’t die, either, even though it clearly should have after what Glimmer did to it.”

“I’m almost certain that was a Beast trooper,” Glimmer said. “Taline used to tell me how dozens of them would show on a battlefield sometimes during the first war. It was one of the few things she was legitimately afraid of seeing because, to her, it meant they were done. Plan of attack became plan of immediate

retreat. Any tactics they'd attempt were only to help curb the scale of casualties."

"So, what you're saying is, we were extraordinarily lucky to have lasted the thirty-something seconds we did before Kyle got to us?" Lonnie asked, pursing her lips when Glimmer just nodded.

"I riddled it with enough firepower it nearly overheated my forward gatling guns," Kyle said.

"A few popped up on Rinne at the end," Glimmer said. "They were the reason the whole report on its fall was classified so high, and why the name itself got suppressed. I wouldn't be surprised if someone spotted one on Scavria and that's what prompted the retreat. There's supposedly a way to kill them, or at least immobilize them. I tried, but"—she shook her head—"it was too fast for me."

Lonnie's shoulders dropped and she took a deep breath. "Let's just count our blessings, then."

The hangar lunched, and a ringing sound, like that of a microphone kicking up feedback, echoed around the hangar, drowning out the din.

"Attention, this is Fleet Admiral Norognev speaking," said a voice laden with static over the intercom. "Scavria's bombardment is reaching its conclusion. A portion of the fleet has been called away on an emergency assignment, and the *Omen-Kador* is one of the ships on that list. We will be entering hyperspace shortly, after I have formally transferred command to the battle group that will remain here. All active-duty personnel are required to return to their posts and await instructions. Refugees, please return to your megaliths. ETA to our destination is twelve minutes."

Everyone traded alarmed glances with one another. Newt started to fuss in Ennis' arms and he and Marcie both cooed at him under their breaths to calm him.

“Battlemage Glimmer, please report to the bridge, “Norognev said. “I repeat, Battlemage Glimmer, Angel of Archanas, you are to report immediately to the command bridge, over.” The intercom cut, leaving ample space for the worried murmurs of everyone in the hangar to take its place.

“What the heck is going on?” Lonnie said, furrowing her brow and looking around as the murmuring built to a fervor.

“I have no idea,” Glimmer said. “But I have a feeling I’m about to find out.” She promised to message her new team as soon as she had more information and promised to see Marcie, Newt, and Ennis again soon. Then she made her way as quickly as she could back through the crowds to the lifts.

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“This is as far as I can take you,” Dax said when the elevator pulled to a stop and the doors opened with a ding. “This whole level is the Enclave Embassy.”

“You can’t come with us the rest of the way?” Adora asked, stepping out with Corynth.

"I can't." Dax shook his head. "I don’t have nearly the officers I need for patrol. It’s fine, though. I don't think anyone is stationed up here, so you shouldn’t run into anyone that might try to stop you. I have to return to my post, make sure the tension doesn’t snap and riots start spilling out. You know how it is.”

He waved as the doors shut, Adora waved back, then wrestled a foreboding feeling to the back of her mind as she followed Corynth through a ghost town of a lavish, open lobby. Every footstep of hers clacked on the marble floor and echoed around the room no matter how hard Adora tried to keep quiet. Dax had said no one would be up here to stop them, so being silent wasn’t a necessity, but Adora couldn’t help but cringe with every step she took. If anything, the lack of people only made the whole space feel larger, and only made her feel more exposed.

"You never did give me an answer about that bet," she said, keeping her voice low despite herself.

"You mean the one about Taline and I becoming friends again?" Corynth spoke in a normal tone, and his oddly cavalier attitude about sneaking around up here helped put Adora at ease.

"Yes."

Corynth laughed. "It's a bad bet, Adora. Evelyn is dead. Taline is not going to change her mind."

"But all of it is just a huge misunderstanding!" Adora threw out her arms. "It was traumatizing to find out you were part of some crazy assassin death cult your whole life, fine, but it's not like you chose to be born into that. And maybe you kept it a secret from her, but you did it to try and save her life—to keep her safe. And it worked!

"If anything, she should have realized you broke free of all of that!" It shocked Adora how strong she felt about this, how quick she'd riled herself up this much mere seconds after getting into this topic. It felt personal in the way Catra made her feel still, sometimes. "You transformed the Daiamid, turned them into folk heroes with you. You pulled Evelyn through death on more than one occasion. You upended *everything* to protect her from Horde Prime."

Adora raced ahead to cut Corynth off, and seeing the unexpected raw expression on his face pushed the flame that had lit under her to knew extremes. "I get that she was hurt. I get that you hurt her, and I can tell that you get that too, but you can be hurt and still make the right choice. You can make bad choices too! But then you can figure it out and then you come around."

"She's not looking to understand, Adora." Corynth spoke slowly to her, like he was explaining something so obvious he was confused why she didn't see it. "She's angry."

Adora crossed her arms and said, in a low voice, “It’s been over ten years.”

“Yes. Ten years. If nothing has changed after ten whole years then it won’t change.”

“You’ve been hiding out with an assumed identity this whole time. How would you even know if she’d come around and changed her mind or not?”

Corynth rolled his eyes—actually rolled his eyes!—and walked past her, setting a brutal clip she struggled to keep pace with without jogging. “Why are you obsessing about this?” he asked.

Adora frowned. She wasn’t obsessing, she was being reasonably assertive, but the acerbic tone in his voice caught her off guard.

“You can’t fix your relationship with Catra by trying to repair my relationship with Taline,” he said when she didn’t respond.

Oh, that did it. It had been a long time since Adora had felt physically slapped by words, but there it was. She grabbed him by the shoulder and whirled him to face her, making him stop again, meeting the pointed anger in his gaze with fire and brimstone in hers.

“This isn’t about me and it sure as hell is not about Catra,” she said. “And now I know I’m getting at something because you’re deflecting by trying to piss me off.”

“And you’ve picked the perfect time to get really, really observant about things.”

Adora jutted her chin out, daring him to try and walk away from her. “You haven’t seen each other in all this time,” she said, enunciating each word to make her point as plain as possible. “You can literally change *reality itself* based off what you’ve told me about your powers. Why, of all possible things, are you so convinced there’s no chance whatsoever Taline has changed her

mind even a little after a whole decade? How is *that* the thing you are so convinced cannot change?"

Silence. Tension that ratcheted ever higher with every thundering beat of Adora's heart. She was half convinced her ribs would crack under the pounding when the tension finally broke, and the stone in Corynth's face crumbled. He cast his eyes away, suddenly looking twice as old and three times as weary.

"We will come to blows again," he said at last. "It is foretold. The next time we meet will be in conflict. Prophecy."

Adora frowned, more confused than she was seconds earlier. "Prophecy isn't all it's cracked up to be. You can fight it," she said, not knowing what else to say. She pointed to herself. "I fought. I broke the sword. Granted, I realized that wasn't the smartest thing to do after I got all the facts, but…I still did it." She smothered the thought questioning whether or not she'd really fought against prophecy at all if she was still, after everything, trying to get She Ra back specifically to use as a weapon against the Beast.

"This isn't the kind of prophecy you want to fight."

Adora felt like she had a thousand pieces to a puzzle she had no idea how to start putting together. She'd expected him to come up with some irrational, emotional, human reason for not believing Taline could come around. "I don't understand."

"I chaperoned Evelyn through hundreds of sessions with the Beast sample we were experimenting with. Hundreds of sessions peering through time, living in the timestream, stretching seconds into decades. Lifetimes. Until we both felt less like people and more like…I don't know. Ghosts. Souls stretched thin over corporeal bodies.

"I didn't get the kind of insight she did, but I did feel the effects of our efforts all the same. Out of those hundreds of trips, those thousands of potential futures she was exploring behind my back,

how many do you think Evelyn found where we succeeded? Where we defeated the Beast for good before it devoured so much of the galaxy nothing could be rebuilt?"

Adora swallowed. Her throat had gone dry as those puzzle pieces started coming together, building an image she knew just from the tone of Corynth's voice she wouldn't want to see.

"How many futures were there?" she asked, voice rasping. "Where we won—how many were there?"

He tilted his head, watching her, and the prickly, crawling feeling that snaked up her back got the better of her. "Corynth," she said. "How many?"

"It's been over ten years since Taline and I last saw each other," he said in lieu of giving her a straight answer. "Ten years she's been *trapped*, and I have since not spent one day alive without thinking about it—about her. It's a sickness, that kind of obsession, but"—he smiled, all the tension flooding out of him, leaving him looking suddenly ten years younger—"it's the one sickness I feel proud of having carried for so long."

He took both his gloves off and dropped them to the floor. The ignominite manacles around his wrists caught the halogen lights overhead and reminded Adora of another sickness he probably wasn't as proud to have carried.

Corynth spoke his next words with a deadly, funeral-serious voice. "Knowing how trapped and in pain she was—how much of it I caused…knowing that, do you think I would have forgone the chance to go to her, to make things right, for any reason short of the *one and only* future Evelyn found where Taline even had a reality to live in once free? Where anyone had that reality?"

Adora let out a slow, shaking breath. One future. One future out of countless thousands.

"The Vestamid were a calculated piece Evelyn placed on the board," Corynth said. "When I'd realized what she was really

capable of seeing during our jaunts…" He shook his head. "Free will is an illusion. One that she thoroughly disavowed me of the moment I realized the extent of the bread crumbs she'd left me through her proclamations."

Corynth pushed forward again, deeper into the embassy, and Adora followed. "Over ten years, but it ends today. The Eye will reveal its secrets, the Barrier will close, the galaxy will be free of the Beast, and Taline will, at last, be free of me. Prophecy fulfilled."

The lobby funneled into a tangle of hallways. Corynth seemed much more confident about where he was going compared to before. He looked every bit a man on a mission, and Adora had no idea how to come back from the enormity of what he'd just told her. Corynth had been walking this path since before she'd even found the sword, and she was about to witness the last couple of steps.

"We're here," he said as they pulled up to a smaller, ensuite lobby for a corner office.

The front desk was unmanned, and half a dozen chairs lined the inside wall, also empty. A decorative waterfall fixture hung against the inside wall, bone-dry.

Adora followed Corynth through the far door. Except for a military-grade repeater rifle displayed in a case high up on a shelf behind the desk, it was a nice, normal corner office. There entire far wall was a reinforced window with a beautiful view of the Atrium, below. She'd never really thought about where they might find Pip's backup copy, but Taline storing it somewhere deep in her personal workspace made sense, in a strangely pedestrian sort of way.

Then Corynth pressed his hand against a palm reader and the whole wall it was set into pulled away, revealing an entire laboratory storage room hidden away. The irony of being immediately proven wrong the second she thought anything

normal or pedestrian might happen during this adventure made Adora laugh. Corynth paused on the precipice—half hidden in shadow—and looked back at her with a questioning face.

"I still want you to try and talk to her," she said.

"Adora, I—"

"Promise me."

Corynth frowned, a wrinkle forming between his eyebrows when they pinched together. "What? Why?"

She was smiling as she pushed past him into the lab. The lights inside shot on the moment she was all the way through, and his footsteps followed her from behind as she threaded down a walkway straddling the space between two wire-rack shelves.

"Because I don't think it'd be such a legit prophecy if you could break the whole thing just trying to talk to someone you love. Besides," she said, catching his eyes over her shoulder and shooting him a beaming smile, "as your friend, I'm asking you to. So, please?"

Corynth gave her such an incredulous look she had to turn back around and watch where she was going before she burst out laughing. Quiet—so quiet, she almost didn't hear—she heard him mutter under his breath, "I am sorely regretting admitting we were friends, right now."

Adora threw her head back and cackled, knowing she'd already won him over. "No takebacks! Absolutely. No. Takebacks."

She let Corynth take the lead again, since she had no idea where they were going, but each step now felt lighter. After so many years and so much trauma, it didn't surprise her he could forget you could 'come to blows' and 'meet in conflict' just as much flinging insults and screamed words at one another as you could actually trying to kill with magic and fists.

He would at least try, she knew he would, and she didn't care very much to examine too closely why that was so important to her.

"This was Evie's lab," Corynth said. Adora watch him trace his fingers along the dozens of pieces of paraphernalia crammed into every inch of open shelving on either side of them. "The first one. This and the Embassy outside were all part of what Taline gave her to finish her research on ignominite."

"This place?" Adora asked. "But Phoenix is huge. It's got apartments and shopping malls and office buildings and everything. At least, from what I could tell so far."

"It was much smaller back then," Corynth said. "Just a few levels. The Empire repurposed it into a service station after we all defected. It grew over the years as more wards were added on."

"I assumed it was destroyed or something after that, not repurposed," Adora said. "Prime sent Taline here as some kind of sick joke, didn't he? He knew this place must have reminded her every day of her sister…that's why he agreed to leave if she returned here." She remembered the kind of rampant speculation they'd all fallen into the weeks after he'd just up and left after thoroughly beating her last-ditch attempt to end his invasion.

"It tells you how petty he is that he'd agree to leave you all alone in exchange for putting her here," Corynth said. "It also tells you just how much he hates and fears her influence. Keeping her tied down to this place made certain he always knew where she was. Knew that she wouldn't put a stop to any other schemes he'd think up later."

The walkway opened up to a spacious area of the lab and Adora stopped to stare at the floor. An enormous rune, far more intricate than she'd ever seen before, lay burned into the tiles.

"Look familiar?" Corynth asked. He took the bag holding the Eye from Adora before skirting the edge to a refrigerator-sized black

box and a desk.

“No?”

“It’s that spell you guys used to teleport onto Horde Prime’s citadel. Except, she’s inverted it to serve as an anchor and added her own flair to it. Added a *lot* of her own flair to it.” Corynth’s eyes shone with strange pride as he explained. “All these years later and it still takes my breath away the kinds of things she can do with her runes. She can be anywhere in the galaxy and beam back here in an instant.”

"This is insane," Adora said, tracing the patterns with her eyes. Salas had shown her some of the more complex runes, the ones even he'd spent months and sometimes years studying before being able to use well. This was far more complicated.

“We likely tripped the sensors the moment my biometrics opened this room,” Corynth said. He pulled out the Eye of Shukra, a scanner, and the portable computer he’d packed from inside the bag, laying them on the desk. “She might already know we’re here, depending on how far away she is. We don’t have much time.”

Adora watched him hook everything up and start the computer after placing the Eye in the scanner. He kicked open the bottom-most compartment of the refrigerator-box, revealing it to be crammed full of wire and electrical hardware and circuit boards.

"What do you need me to do?" she asked as he began hooking up the computer.

“Keep an eye on the rune,” he said, rolling up a sleeve and preparing a syringe and canister he had also pulled from the bag. “Pip will start to rebuild herself as soon as the server recognizes the nanites in my blood. And once she’s rebuilt, she will go straight for the Eye and seal the Barrier. Warn me as soon as you notice the rune begin to spark.”

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“This is the energy project you bribed Moriarty to approve?” Taline asked.

Larian had taken them deep, deep underground. They’d even needed to use an elevator this time, and the ride down had been frustrating not just because it seemed to take forever, but because Diallo had also decided to tag along with them.

“It’s a major breakthrough in energy storage, yes," Larian said. “And we didn’t bribe the Administrator, we merely demonstrated why having a means of storing such vast amounts of ignominite might earn a relaxing of protocol. I believe classifying this as research instead of infrastructure helped, too.”

“And yet it *is* infrastructure,” Taline said, frowning.

They were all standing in another massive sanctum carved out of granite and obsidian, staring down rows and columns of dozens of enormous black silos that stretched three stories high to the ceiling. Catra wondered if all of the Vestamid structures here were monolithic by design, or if that was done mostly out of vanity.

Taline stepped forward and put her palm up against the first silo. She yanked that hand back with a hiss as if it burned her the next instant.

“You’ve made siloes entirely out of ignominite? To store even more ignominite?”

“Yes,” Larian said. “To store more of it, in a far more concentrated form. Only the flesh of God is a worthy enough vessel to hold His blood.”

Catra heard Trayn whisper to Keren, quieter than anyone except her could hear, “I was wondering what would eat up so much of the region’s entire budget it forced Dax to cull half the precinct. For as much as this doesn’t make sense at all—”

“—it makes a shocking amount of sense,” Keren said, finishing the thought.

"Contrary to the rest of the empire, we operate with a surplus of the material here," Larian said, to Taline and all of them together. He turned to Diallo, who'd been staring wide-eyed and silent in awe at the things since they'd arrived, and said, "What do you think? While few are ever allowed to step foot on this planet or into our compound, even fewer are allowed in here. Even among the Vestamid, only those among my inner circle are allowed to see this holy place."

"It is b-beautiful," Diallo said, similarly stepping forward to run his hand along the surface of another silo. "The concentration of B-Beast matter in here must be orders of magnitude d-denser than what is currently possible to f-fit in conventional ignominite crystals."

Larian smiled. "Forget about powering an orbital cannon. Place only a handful of filled silo farms like these and you'll have enough to power all the Heartland worlds for generations."

"And the chances of those Heartland worlds being overrun skyrockets as well." Taline looked on the verge of exploding in anger.

Keren and Trayn looked at one another with worry. Catra, however, was preoccupied with something else. The shadowed figures from earlier had multiplied. Two now stood beside each silo, staring at her, and although their faces lacked mouths or any discernable features, an unbroken undercurrent of low voices filled her ears.

::Can you make out what they're saying?::

Pip shook her head, bobbing in the air next to her. "It's just garbled whispers," she said. "I really think you should talk to Taline about this. I don't think the others are being affected as heavily as you are. They don't seem to notice anything is wrong."

::Taline is busy,:: Catra concentrated on apeiron pressed against her skin under her clothes, feeling its warmth. Somehow she

knew it was protecting her, but what did it say if she was still experiencing side effects and others weren't? Was she not cut out to be here? ::She warned me about this. It will be fine, I can handle it. We'll finish up quickly and we'll leave. It will only take longer if I distract her, and I don't want to stay here longer, do you?::

Catra couldn't tell if the look Pip gave her meant she agreed with not wanting to stay longer or disagreed with Catra's assessment she could handle it.

"The fact this is on Archanas already is a travesty," Taline said to Larian. "What happens if these fail? Ignominite crystals were created specifically with a lower density in mind to keep them stable." She threw her arm out at the closest silo. "This is not stable."

Larian spread his hands in a conciliatory gesture. "I'd mentioned earlier that God has begun to speak to us directly, yes? It was at His direction we built these, and He would not lead us astray. Not after so many ceaseless years proving our devotion to his chosen Goddess. It is as I told Governor Diallo: only His body can perfectly contain His blood. His lifeforce. Building these receptacles is not just a leap forward for galactic civilization, it is an evolution on the intersection between science and theology. The siloes cannot fail."

"Those regulations you bypassed are there for a reason," Taline said. "They were lessons won at the cost of trillions of lives and hundreds of worlds in the last war. To shirk them now is beyond irresponsible."

Larian frowned. It was the first time Catra had seen his mood sour since meeting him. "His return is inevitable. No amount of bureaucratic red tape, no amount of palliative care and the emergency triage you loath to ever spearhead again will prevent that. If the time of our purgatory has passed, and if it is at last time for the doors to the kingdom of heaven to open once more so that judgment may continue, then so be it."

He spoke with the same measured calm one used when explaining basic facts of the world to an infant. It might have infuriated Catra beyond restraint had the number of ghosts standing around her in the room not multiplied along with the volume of their muttering voices. He looked to the siloes again, face mellowing and eyes shining with pride.

“I have done what God commands, and I will have aided my fellow brothers and sisters of the galaxy with scientific advancement. I am content.”

"Does the Emperor share the same outlook as you?" Taline asked. "My understanding is he's tolerated your outsized presence because you provide one of the few tools we may use against the Beast, religious beliefs or not. I don't think he'd continue to tolerate your operations continuing unfettered should he learn of this."

Larian laughed. “Dear Seraph,” he said, shaking his head. “The Emperor greenlit the project himself. Who do you think listened to Moriarty’s plea on our behalf? He has not cracked down on us because he *cannot* crack down on us.”

“He *knows*?” Taline asked, aghast.

“We all have different coping mechanisms for reconciling with that which is out of our control,” Larian said. “It seems our dear Emperor has decided, in the face of God Almighty, to push his head in the sand and pretend he still wields absolute authority. Better to affix his stamp of approval and cling jealously to the idea he sanctioned our work than to watch it happen in spite of his objections.”

Diallo didn’t seem to notice their arguing, but Taline, Keren, and Trayn all looked on the verge of outrage. Catra was certain things were about to boil over. And just as she was about to step in and say something hopefully disarming, another figure materialized in shadow next to her. A figure whose silhouette she recognized.

“Hey, Catra.”

Adora’s ghost peered into her with lifeless searchlight eyes, black smoke evaporating off her form, and it took all of Catra’s faculties to not shriek in alarm—to not visibly react at all.

“I regret reaching out to you,” Shadow Adora said. “No need to respond to my message. Let’s just pretend like it never happened.”

Those words felt like a gut punch. Catra knew it wasn’t real. It was whatever twisted vignettes the long-dead Beast was putting in her head on this planet, but that didn’t stop her from reacting on a visceral level to an imprint of Adora telling her to, yet again, get lost to her face. The shadow disappeared, dissolving like sand in a non-existent wind.

“You okay?” Keren said. She was at Catra’s side with Trayn, whispering. Catra hadn’t notice them come. She hadn’t noticed she was hyperventilating, either—not until Trayn shook her shoulder.

The voices were worse. There were more figures in the room with her now, their voices combining, trying to drown her. Suffocating. How did Trayn and Keren see none of this, only its very real effect on her?

“Catra please,” Pip said, zipping up right in front of her, refusing to leave her alone when Catra tried to avert her eyes. “I tried getting ahold of the *Constable* to have them send someone for you—”

::You *what?*::

“Something’s wrong, I can feel it and I’m worried about you. Taline ordered radio silence, but they still should have answered me. We need to get you off this planet. No one else is experiencing symptoms like this.”

Anger roiled in Catra’s gut, nearly drowning out everything else that was trying to force her underwater. Giving up and leaving,

going back to the *Constable* because the Beast was scary? Admitting defeat over a panic attack when people like Glimmer were out there, battling the thing on the front lines day after day? That's not something the Sentinel to the freaking Seraph of Archanas herself did.

"Please," Pip said. "Why don't you head back to the command room and ask them to patch you through directly so we can call a shuttle?"

::Would you stop trying to mother me so hard?::

Catra tamped down on the urge to visibly snarl, knowing it'd just freak Keren and Trayn out and definitely garner Taline's attention. The fact they'd explicitly chosen not to plug Pip into the Vestamid systems in leiu of using flesh-and-blood analysts meant she didn't have any kind of direct override to the *Constable.* Their radio silence in the middle of all of this only made things worse. Catra knew she was being unfair, but all of it was too much for her to handle with any kind of poise and she was *not* leaving Taline here because of a panic attack.

::I'm fine, I don't need to—::

Another set of whispered voices assaulted her, words still indiscernible. She was aware, in a faraway sense, of both Trayn and now Keren shaking her gently, trying to be subtle so as to not tip anyone else off that something might be happening.

"At least go talk to Taline," Pip said. She seemed oddly fuzzy and incorporeal, whereas Catra had always been able to see her clearly as if she were a physical being. "*Please.* I think something is affecting me, too. I don't—I don't know what it is. Not the Beast, but it's getting harder for me to concentrate. It's feels like something is calling me back—"

::I told you to quit it!:: Catra finally did snarl at Pip and she, along with Keren and Trayn, recoiled. ::I can't focus with you butting in over and over and over again like this! Unless someone is dying or

the building lights on fire, I don't want to hear another word from you until we're done here. Got it?::

"But—"

::I swear to god if you don't lay off I'll have Taline pull you out of my head as soon as this mission is over. Just—disappear for a bit, will you?::

Pip shrank away from her, hurt. She seemed almost on the verge of saying something else, then set her lips in a thin line and fizzled out of sight after a single, jerky nod.

Catra regretted the words the moment they'd left her mouth, but the damage was done, and everything was still overwhelming. That image of Adora—that fresh rejection that haymakered her out of the blue—had unleashed feelings she'd been bottling up inside for years. Feelings of frustration and anger and hurt that Pip had stood directly in line-of-fire sight of.

She would give Pip an enormous apology once this was mission done. She'd grovel, even, and wouldn't feel weird about doing so after being such a colossal bitch. But with her gone, Catra resolved to push through and see the mission to completion. Taline needed her coherent.

She wondered why Keren and Trayn weren't saying anything to her after she'd essentially snarled at them, too, without explanation. Then she noticed Diallo looking at her with a peculiar expression over his glasses, and realized Keren and Trayn had frozen solid on either side of her, likely in a bid to pretend nothing strange had happened while under his scrutiny. What more, the ghosts had gone as well, and there was no longer this incessant whispering of their voices attacking her.

Catra apologized to Trayn and Keren, promising that she was alright, and that was when she noticed Taline.

She was staring down at her wrist PDA next to Larian. They hadn't moved from the silo they had been arguing beside earlier,

but Taline had gone pale and clammy, and Catra could see it from the dozen paces away she was standing. She looked up, searching for Catra, and when they locked eyes from across the room, Catra went to her.

"He's there." Taline's voice quavered. "He's on Phoenix. My office has been breached."

*Oh no,* was Catra's first though, followed by, *Oh shit.* She felt like someone had dumped ice water over her head when she realized what was about to happen. *Please, no*.

"I have to go," Taline said. "I have to go right now."

She'd wanted to spend more time plying her, pushing for them to at least try and talk rather than opening straight away with a fight to the death. Taline was about to leave, and Catra realized with a sickening, plummeting feeling in her stomach, that there was no guarantee Taline would ever come back.

She thought they had more time.

"Take me with you," she said, desperate. "I have to be there with you. You can't face him on your own, you can't."

Taline gave an emphatic shake of her head. "No one can stay here long without my protection, you know this." She took both Catra's hands in hers, like she was pleading with her. "I need you here. Get in contact with the *Constable.* Round up all the analysts and all the guards and get out of here. I don't care that they won't be done, everyone needs to get away from this place as fast as possible. I need you to handle this."

She let Catra's hands go and walked backward, putting distance between her and everyone else. Catra took a step toward her and she held up a hand; a clear order to stay back.

"Meet me on Phoenix," she said. "I'll be there with Adora, and you two can finally say hello again after all these years."

“And if you aren’t there?” Catra didn’t want to give voice to the real possibility Taline wouldn’t survive, but she couldn’t not ask.

“Then Phoenix itself will likely be nothing but a derelict when you arrive,” Taline said. “Sync up with Glimmer, and take everyone to the Heartlands instead. Get in touch with Salas as soon as you can. Etheria needs to be made aware of the situation, as does the rest of the Enclave. The Heart will be needed sooner than we’d thought, especially if Corynth claims me.”

Taline smiled at her, but that clashed with the haunted, fearful look in her eyes. It gave no credence to her next words when she said, "It will be okay, Catra, I promise. Whatever happens, it will be okay."

She threw her hands up, reaching for the ceiling, palms open. White-hot magic appeared on the ground, slithering like several multi-headed snakes, carving out a rune underneath her boots. The circle completed, and a flash of light engulfed her. Catra shielded her eyes to keep from being blinded.

When she looked again, blinking away the afterimage, Taline was gone. Diallo, Larian, his priests, Keren, and Trayn all looked on with varying emotions, manic glee being the most evident on Larian’s face and outright surprise on Diallo’s.

Hundreds of ghostly shadows were in the room where before there was once none, all standing shoulder to shoulder, all staring at her with lifeless, searchlight eyes.

They spoke, and this time, Catra could understand what they were saying. Hundreds of voices of all timbres and tones filled the room, chanting over and over and over again:

*…Abandoned…She Abandoned You Here…With Us…*

The apeiron against her chest was burning.

*…With Me!*

“This doesn’t make any sense,” Corynth said. The refrigerator-box had been beeping and whirring for several minutes now after he’d slotted a vial of his blood into one of its ports. He reached inside and pulled out a container the size of a shoebox.

“What’s wrong?” Adora asked. The rune thus far showed no signs of activating. She’d not taken her eyes off it.

“I know what we left behind for Taline’s crews to find,” he said. “Lots of stuff from the second lab. Everything that wasn’t transported directly to Horde Prime’s private storage units should be here. Even this thing is here.” He’d lifted the lid off the box and was staring at whatever was inside. “But our original sample of the Beast isn’t.”

“Wait, really?” That sounded bad.

Corynth nodded. “The sample we experimented on from the start—the one I helped Evelyn commune with. It’s not here, and it definitely wasn’t transferred to Prime’s storage units. Taline wouldn’t have been able to destroy it, so I assumed she just kept it. But it’s not here.”

The gaps in her knowledge were just enough Adora couldn’t fully follow him, but before she could clarify anything with him, the rune powered on.

“Corynth,” she said, still not taking her eyes off it and reaching inside for her power the same way a soldier might reach for their firearm. “I think this is it.”

When he didn’t respond, she looked up, and that’s when she saw him at the desk with the box he’d pulled out moments earlier.

“I’m so sorry, Adora,” he said, pulling out a mask—his mask—from inside. “It would have been nice to have had more time together.” He looked up and met her eyes from across the sparking rune, something proud and something regretful shimmering there. “Thank you for helping me feel like a person again, one last time.”

He brought the mask up with both hands and slotted it over his face. Adora’s blood curdled in her veins with the feeling she’d just watched him lock himself behind a prison door and throw the key away. He undid the ignominite cuffs on his wrists, letting them clatter to the floor.

It was Corynth. Not the goofy, harried, somewhat teasing friend she’d come to appreciate since their first fight on Etheria, but the figure of impossible renown she’d heard people whisper of as if he were a fairytale character. He was there, in front of her, made flesh once more.

The rune exploded with light and Adora stepped back, turning her head and shielding her eyes. When the light dimmed enough for her to look, Taline was standing there, another figure from the legends. Smoke curled around her from the burned markings on the floor. Her eyes glinted with untethered rage, glowing with magic, and power crackled at her fingertips.

Corynth and Taline stared at each other, two beings pulled from collective imagination, and Adora stood rooted to the spot. Her mind screamed at her to move, to step between them and break their stare down. Her body didn't listen. The silence stretched between the three of them for what felt like an eternity.

“Taline,” Corynth said, his voice emanating from the mask in a heavily modulated, alien pitch. “Adora seemed upset at the idea of us fighting again. Instead of—”

Taline let loose a banshee scream. Time slowed to a crawl as Adora watched her fling a hand forward, every plane of her body spring-loaded and tight.

As Adora scrambled backward to put more distance between them, a circlet of runes appeared spinning around Taline’s outstretched wrist, sparks of electricity arcing to life at her fingertips. Adora remembered what Micah had said about his experience fighting her, years before.

*It was one of the scariest moments of my life, taking that woman's lightning,* he'd said one day, while they were surveying the damage Horde Prime's invasion had done to Bright Moon. *Aside from watching your Catra put a knife to my daughter's throat, I don't think I'd ever felt that helpless, before. Something about putting everything I had into keep up a shield up while she ripped it down like cheap wallpaper made me feel…so small.*

A dense sphere of lightning coalesced in Taline's palm. It lashed out at Corynth in thick, branching bolts just as Adora screamed at him to watch out.

Chapter End Notes

She left Catra behind???

Surpriseeee (maybe?). I'm willing to bet some of you thought she'd come along and this is where the big reunion conflict was going to happen, but nope--Taline couldn't wait another second with Corynth finally showing up at the most inopportune time, but she also wasn't going to abandon everyone she dragged to Archanas like that, either. Unfortunately that means Catra is paddling the boat with a major complication she slept on sharing (how convenient).

I think this is the first time in the story where all three POVs are present in a single chapter, hence the chapter title. They're usually one to a chapter, or two on occasion.

I also liked writing Corynth and Adora arguing. Real friends argue (within reason), and to me this was another piece proving they could actually have a healthy friendship.

**

The escalation of power was an interesting thing to balance throughout this story. I knew way back first drafting this that I wanted some epic moments and big set pieces for battles, but also knew I couldn't just throw all that there at the beginning or end without ramping up to it. You, the readers,

have to become familiar with the characters and the "laws" of the worldbuilding I've done, even with a soft magic system like I portray here--if you just throw all this cool stuff on the page without having explained how things work (or better, let the readers intuit how things work), it ceases to be cool and instead becomes tedious.

Part 1 shows a decently hefty set-piece on Horde Prime's citadel with all three POVs participating to some extent. Truthfully, while it was important to the story, I also used it as a sort of soft pilot for the rest of the story, since there's familiar plus new characters, original sci fi conventions, character arcs with a denouement, and the execution of a large climactic battle I tease as I'm leading up to it (ie, a micro-example of how the rest of the larger story is, lol).

You also get introduced to the power levels in the world I've introduced (Taline wipes the floor with Shadow Weaver and Micah without trying too hard, and also toys with a powerless and exhausted Adora for like 0.3 seconds before dealing with her. You see Taline's first Sentinel put up a good fight against Horde Prime but ultimately lose spectacularly. Then you see Taline's subservience to him and *his* outright fear of something as of yet unnamed [The Beast]), thus lending a subtle credence to the gravity of the threat once its finally introduced.

It's one thing to show the Beast eating a bunch of planets and wow, yeah that's pretty terrible. But show how powerful Horde Prime is both with his physicality and with the subservience he commands of others, *then* show him throw all plans to the wind merely because "it's to fight the Beast?" Yeah, that gasses the Beast up before you even learn what it is, and I continued that theme all the way up through finally introducing it on screen at the beginning of this part.

The big fight scene in part 2 is between Adora and Corynth (Kallanthe at the time), where he still 1. wipes the floor with

her despite her heightened physical fitness, and 2. deals with all the bots attacking them like they're a nuisance.

Then in part 3 you see Adora actually put up a good fight against a mini Abomination, then Corynth--who's revealed to be severely weakened--manages to defeat it at great cost to himself.

Beginning of Part 4 you discover what a near fully-fledged Abomination and its singular Trooper is capable of, to the extent Glimmer needed a lot of help to just escape with her and her team's lives. You also hear a little about what Taline and Corynth are supposedly capable of even though you haven't quite seen it yet, when Taline mentioned fending off an entire swarm of Beast Thralls in her past, the extent she went to fight the Beast with any level of success, and the amount of success she had fighting Corynth at his prime.

All this to say: I put a lot of thought into how power levels are portrayed when planning out the major conflicts that happen on screen. If you have a good memory, you might remember an early author's note where I mentioned never dipping into my OCs POVs because they're supposed to supplement and support the main canon three, not overshadow them. And although we are nearing the end of part 4, there's still one last part in the story....

To put it another way, if the structure of part 1 were to be extrapolated to the whole story, then we've just hit the point right before Adora teleports onto the citadel to attack Horde Prime directly, perhaps while Glimmer is antagonizing Prime and Taline's prior two Sentinels demonstrate they are literally willing to fight their Emperor because Taline ordered them to keep some random (to them) person safe.

It's where I planned the rising action to get so heated you're sitting there wondering what snaps first.

:)

# Dance of the Revenants

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Corynth threw both hands up, and a barrier of writhing blackish-blue erupted in a semicircle around him.

Taline's lightning struck, then dispersed, the fabric of Corynth's clothing whipping violently about his body in the resulting shockwave. Whatever lay beyond his protection got caught in the blast. Adora planted her feet, ducked down, and covered her head to avoid getting hit by any of the wire racks and science equipment it held up.

The room settled. Adora waved away the dust and coughed, trying to pop her ears and listen through the ringing in her eardrums. Corynth was in the middle of another sweeping gesture. The barrier of magic was gone, replaced with a condensed black ball the size of a fist he held suspended between both hands. Several lengths of ventilation ductwork and industrial tubing had ripped free of their installations and were spinning around him like electrons circling a nucleus.

With another gesture, they shot in a straight line at Taline. She cut downward with both hands and sliced the full arsenal clean in half with another blast of magic. By then, the only part of the room that remained unmolested was the refrigerated server Corynth had been working at earlier and the equipment handling the Eye.

Corynth dissolved before Taline could follow up. Adora might have mistaken the sight for her brain misfiring had she not received a crash course in what a Shaper was actually capable of less than an hour previous Like sand in the wind, his essence swirled about the room like some mystical phantasm. He shot past them and

back out the door to Taline's office. As he brushed past Adora, he also imparted a message—something she felt, rather than heard.

*Everything will be alright. I need to draw her out.*

Taline gave an angry, cat-like screech and spun on her heel to storm after him. Adora watched her go, knowing she had to chase after them but unable to get her body to do anything other than listen to the crunch of Taline's boots stepping on the broken glass littering the floor. They'd just unleashed enough power to likely turn anyone who might have been standing between them to dust, and all in fewer seconds than Adora had fingers on one hand with which to count.

Before Taline had showed, she'd briefly entertained the idea of stepping between them to keep them from fighting. Maybe this time her body was onto something, freezing her to the spot out of instinct rather than letting her act on a whim.

Eventually, her brain kicked into gear. If Catra was Taline's Sentinel, then it was strange for one to show up without the other, but Adora didn't have time to worry about that. She ran after them both, hurdling past tipped-over boxes and shelving. She made it back through the hidden doorway just in time to see the nice conference table that had been sitting in the middle of the office fly across the room.

The table split in half down the middle and the two sides flew past Taline, magic rune still twisting in her thrust-out hand, before embedding into the wall behind her.

Corynth shifted his stance and the still in-tact computer desk launched to her, the paper and computer terminal atop it exploding in every which direction. This time, when she blocked, the desk exploded in a shower of debris that obscured her from view.

"Get to safety!" Corynth said to Adora.

Even with the modulation in his voice, she could tell he wasn't playing around. The realization sent a shiver down her spine—he was still recovering from how hard he'd pushed on Eden, and Adora hadn't forgotten how Taline had steamrolled her when they last faced off.

The rifle on display above the cabinets shot past Corynth, shattering the display glass it was encased in. It shot into the dust cloud Taline had created, and a stream of bullets pelted out, fired in bursts—Taline had kept the rifle loaded, of all things.

Corynth dashed to the side and threw an arm up as if to block a haymaker. A mass of pulsating black viscera exploded out of his forearm and coalesced into a hardened shield large enough to cover most of his body. It absorbed the bullets, and he waited for a pause in her firing pattern before lunging forward and throwing his other hand out. It morphed into intertwined, black tendrils, and they twisted in the air, twining to a sharp point like the head of a spear, screaming straight for the dust cloud which had now persisted for too long to be natural.

Taline dove sideways into a roll before the tendril dispersed the cloud and slammed into the back wall between the two halves of the table. Using that as a new anchor point, Corynth pulled himself forward. He careened toward Taline just as she came out of the roll and raised the barrel of the rifle at him. Corynth pulled up inches in front of her, both limbs already reformed, and grabbed the barrel, pushing it out of the way.

Bullets sprayed in a wild arc around the room and punched holes into the surrounding furniture, walls, and glass windows looking out at the Atrium. Adora ducked down with a yell, covering her head with her hands, searching for cover to avoid being hit while Corynth and Taline wrestled over control the weapon.

Corynth looked away from Taline to find her, and Taline used the distraction to her advantage. Instead of releasing the rifle or trying to yank it out of his grasp, she shot forward and rammed

her shoulder into him, forcing him to stumble backward and release the rifle instead.

With superhuman speed, she dropped to a knee and snapped the rifle up to her cheek again, aiming down the sights with the thing pointed straight at Corynth's center of mass. He threw both arms out, fingers tensed, and the rifle disassembled in Taline's hands. Bolts, springs, screws, pins, and the framing of the rifle circled the two of them just like the innards of the secret room had earlier.

Adora had skirted the perimeter of the room and successfully shoved herself behind a sectional sofa in the far corner of the room for cover. Heading back inside the destroyed lab might have been safer, but she'd already decided to remain nearby in case she could help, risks be damned. And despite knowing Corynth wanted her to stay out of it, if the opportunity presented itself, she *would* help him.

Unfortunately, both Corynth and Taline had tried to use pieces of the rifle as projectiles against each other. When they tried this at the same time, the pieces swirling about them instead repelled like same polarity magnets and exploded out. The shrapnel pierced more holes into the walls and the windows, which were already veined with thousands of spiderweb cracks.

Adora yelped and curled up into a smaller protective ball behind the couch when half a dozen chunks of sharp metal pierced the upholstery and sliced. One particular piece—the firing pin—had struck her shoulder and passed all the way through. She cried out, and her vision swam with the pain.

It took a moment for the adrenaline that had already been coursing through her body to do its job, but she quickly regained enough of her senses to realize Corynth and Taline had taken to trading rapid-fire, physical blows with one another. Magic power accented each of Taline's swipes and kicks and jabs. Corynth dodged each. He seemed more like he was trying to lead her around by the nose and tire her out than actually trying to strike her.

Adora reached deep. She'd latched onto some of her power twice now since leaving home, and found, when she called upon the power this time, some of it actually came. Not enough she felt confident she could materialize her sword at will if she tried, but enough that each breath felt frigid with power, and the bleeding from her wounds ceased.

"You're slower than I remember!" Taline screamed the words at Corynth after putting some distance between them. "All these years and, as much as I'd wished it were so, I never believed you'd really died. But at the very least I'd thought living infected for so long would have made you faster."

Adora remembered Pip said the same thing when she first fought Corynth. *Have you gotten slower?* she'd asked him at the time, moments before Adora learned he'd really just been toying with her. Suddenly, the tension in Taline's body as she circled the room —breathing heavy and trying to size him up—made sense.

Instead of pulling some inhumane feat of superhuman speed to subdue her, however, Corynth instead stretched his hand out to the side and splayed his fingers.

"You're going to need to do a lot better than this to put an end to me," he said.

The lidless eyes of his mask flashed and his hair swirled about him, suspended and weightless. An incessant screeching filled the air as if thousands of birds were chirping and chirping and chirping without end.

A rod of undulating, refracted light formed in his outstretched palm. The screeching ceased the moment after, plunging the room into a silence that was deafening, before a spear of condensed, self-contained lightning burst into existence in Corynth's hand and the screeching returned tenfold.

"You're going to have to do much, *much* more." Corynth raised the energy spear high overhead, as if to flaunt such a powerful

display of pure magic manipulation.

Taline took a step back. Adora saw fear flash across her face. Fear that transmuted into rage.

Ley lines of white-hot magic etched in her skin and her feet lifted off the ground, floating. Her hair hung weightless in the air like the rest of her, a tangled halo that framed her head. Like the eyes of Corynth's mask, Taline's own eye blazed an even brighter hue, bursting with power. Adora jumped in surprise when shadowy forms appeared and began to prowl around her.

Taline screamed, a thousand voices from the same mouth, drowning out the screeching of Corynth's birds. She shot a blast of magic at him so fast, to Adora it seemed like she blinked and it was already there, gunning for Corynth. And this time, there wasn't a rune in sight.

Adora expected Corynth to have dodged, or perhaps blocked or redirected the beam. Instead, she watched him take the blast head on and fly backward with the impact. He crashed through the cracked window glass and disappeared from sight to fall dozens of stories to the Atrium floor.

"No!"

Adora scrambled out from behind cover. Taline was already sticking her head out the person-sized hole in the window, staring down. The station's life support system created a breeze that, as high up as they were in the Atrium, was strong enough to tangle with Taline's hair and uniform along with her powers.

"A fall like that wouldn't be enough to put you down," she said. Adora couldn't tell if she was speaking to Corynth far down below, or to herself. "Bastard."

"You don't have to fight him," Adora said, pushing her voice to be heard over the howling wind. "Neither of you have to fight each other!"

Taline whipped around and looked at her. The magic saturating her eyes turned them to floodlights and made Adora feel like some suspect under interrogation.

“Stay here,” Taline said to her. “It’s not safe. I will come back for you once he’s dealt with. I won’t let him hurt you any longer.”

Taline’s voice was still that of dozens speaking as one, but to Adora’s surprise, each of them sounded scared. Did Taline think Corynth was a danger to her? She’d thought they merely needed to defuse her anger long enough for them to talk, but what was she to do if Taline was under the impression Corynth had, what, taken her hostage when that couldn’t be further from the truth?

Taline turned back to face out the broken window and stepped over the edge herself, plummeting out of sight. Adora sprinted after her and skidded to a stop before she inadvertently flung herself off, too.

Bolts of fire and lightning traced Taline’s path down dozens of stories, each of them shot with sharpshooter precision at Corynth, still alive on the Atrium ground floor. A crowd of onlookers had encircled him, held several yards back by a meager team of security—Dax’s people, if Adora had to guess. White-clad Vanguard troops had engaged Corynth directly, taking cover behind the flora and benches and concrete trash receptacles inside the makeshift arena. They moved like well-trained squads, flanking him with coordinated weapons fire.

The thought of jumping down crossed Adora's mind, then. As She Ra, she'd survive that drop easily, and she'd just proved she could finally call on a small sliver of the power at will, now. Maybe the mortal danger would help push her the rest of the way there? Any progress she'd made reasserting control over her powers had only come during life-threatening situations, as far as she could tell. It was a worrying pattern, but…

“Nope!” she said aloud, more to chastise herself and consciously pump the brakes on that line of thinking. “No. No, no, no—not

even going to think about that anymore."

Instead, Adora spun around and sprinted out of the office, hanging such a hard right as she burst out into the hallway that she slid across the floor and nearly slammed into the wall. Her footsteps *slap, slap, slapped* the tiles underfoot as she pumped her legs, chest heaving and lungs burning, pushing to just move faster, damn it. She flew down the hall, through the lobby, and back to the elevator.

The elevator door opened with a ding and Adora must have punched the button for the ground level a hundred times over before the doors shut again behind her. Then she pressed the button another hundred times over again, even more frantically this time, when the thing still didn't move.

Adora screeched with one hand fisted in her hair. "Why aren't you moving!?"

A figure bathed in green fizzled into existed to her right and Adora swung at it, again, out of instinct. Her fist, again, passed through Hilda's fuzzy outline projected inside the elevator.

"The Atrium ground floor is currently experiencing an emergency situation," Hilda said, calm and collected. "Please remain where you are."

Adora threw her head back and cursed at the halogen light built into the elevator's ceiling. "I need to get down there," she said, after a deep breath. The calm in Hilda's voice made her blood pressure skyrocket.

"The Atrium ground floor is currently experiencing an emergency situation. Please remain—"

"Oh, screw you! What do you know?"

Hilda flickered, turning blue for a moment before disappearing. The elevator hummed to life and started descending, and Adora might have wondered what just happened if the panorama of the

whole Atrium expanse—and thus Corynth and Taline's duel—hadn't opened up for her to see as she descended.

Thunder and lightning, fire and brimstone, whatever the hell Corynth was doing with his body that turned it into slimy viscera—that was all Adora could make out of their fighting. They danced around the open area, much of the surrounding trees, shrubs, installations, and paved walkways of the garden paths around them already flattened, ripped up, and blasted out from collateral damage. They were so intertwined as they zipped around even the Vanguard seemed hesitant to keep firing at them, probably for fear of accidentally hitting Taline.

One thing was different, however: the crowds of bystanders she'd glimpsed earlier were gone, although it didn't take much looking for her to figure out what had happened to them.

A fog had started to seep into the ground level. It was subtle, but the longer Adora watched Corynth and Taline fight, the more she noticed it growing thicker, little by little. And as that fog continued to spread, so too did the shadowed figures that had first appeared in Taline's office moments before she'd thrown Corynth out the window.

The civilians had noticed them too, since most had fled and the few remaining were huddled even further away than before, pressed up against the walls and inside the storefronts lining the perimeter. Even Dax's security had gone from trying to keep them back to hiding from the shadows, too.

Adora watched Corynth score a brutal, magic-powered kick to Taline's chest that sent her flying backward. With him isolated, the Vanguard that had been flanking the both of them had a clear line of fire.

Dozens of rifles pointed at him, and Corynth smacked an open palm to the ground. A wave of magic rippled out, knocking some Vanguard off their feet while blasting others several lengths back.

Only a handful appeared to anticipate him, planting their feet and pushing into the blast to stay upright.

The blast continued to the outer edges of the Atrium, where it blew out every window of the shops and department stores facing the concourse. Screams from those cowering in fear inside accompanied the sound of shattering glass, and those screams were drowned out immediately after when the shockwave traveled *up* the Atrium's levels, shattering the hundreds of apartment and office windows lining each mezzanine level. The glass wall of Adora's elevator shattered too, knocking her off her feet with a yelp of surprise, arms up and over her head for protection.

Those shards of glass rained down from the highest level of the Atrium, a hellish downpour of lethal-sharp blades cutting to shreds even the massive Horde Empire flags draped around the sanctum. Corynth moved with sweeping gestures, and the hail of glass coalesced into thick tendrils of dancing ribbons in the air. Despite being literally knocked on her ass in surprise moments earlier, the view enamored Adora. It looked like great schools of fish pushing through the water, or maybe an enormous, coordinated flock of birds looking to disorient an enemy.

The tendrils turned aggressive. They swirled tighter and faster above Corynth before engulfing him in a cyclone swirl, just as those Vanguard soldiers who'd remained on their feet through the earlier shockwave got their rifles aimed at him again. They fired, their bullets ricocheting, then one by one they fell as spears of glass shot out from the cyclone, piercing their armor and killing them with pools of blood staining the ground.

Taline appeared again and Corynth turned the entire cyclone into a missile the size of an industrial oil rig's drill bit. He hurled it at her, and Taline gestured with her hands. A sheer force field materialized in front of her that turned the glass to sand the moment it struck, and that sand sprayed behind her in an arc as it passed around her, like she was a stone sitting in a stream.

“Can’t this thing go any faster?” Adora wasn’t even a quarter of the way to the bottom. The fight would be long over by the time she reached the ground, judging by how slow the elevator seemed determined to move.

It ground to a sudden halt the moment she said that and something *clunked* deep inside the mechanism. Then the elevator dropped at a complete freefall. Adora screamed as she held onto the side railing and pressed her back into the wall, trying to find any purchase to keep from getting pancaked into the ceiling.

The ground floor raced up to meet her and she shut her eyes, anticipating turning into a puddle of organs splattered about within moments. The elevator gave another lurch and started squealing as the emergency brakes kicked in. The change in g-forces nearly ripped Adora’s shoulder from its socket with her still gripping the handrail, but the elevator slowed to a surprisingly gentle stop, dinged to signal it had reached its destination, and the doors opened to the ground level.

Corynth and Taline were ahead, locked in a battle neither seemed to have a clear upper hand in. A gash ran down the side of Taline’s face, bloodying her uniform. Several more Vanguard troops than Adora had seen Corynth kill lay dead around them.

Adora rushed out the elevator toward them, although the sudden wobble in her knees made that difficult. She stumbled forward, fighting to regain a semblance of stability and coordination, and the nearest Vanguard soldier still alive turned and stopped her when she got too close.

"Are you insane?" he asked, voice coming muffled through the helmet. "Stay back. It’s too dangerous."

“Let me through,” she said, trying to push past. “Let me through!”

The soldier shoved her back and raised his rifle at her. Adora flinched. Instead of being riddled with bullet holes, however, she felt as if she’d been doused with warm liquid, instead. It took her

a moment blinking in confusion to realize she'd been splattered with blood. Not hers.

The soldier lay before her in two halves, split down the middle: Corynth had cut him down to save her.

Taline took advantage of the opening Adora had given her. She clapped her hands together and strained to pull them apart, like they were held together with a thick, viscous glue that she had to fight against. A thousand-strand web of eldritch energy crackled and sizzled between her palms, and every light in the Atrium concourse began to snuff out one after the other.

Taline blazed more brilliant with each light source lost, plunging their surroundings into more profound darkness until only she stood visible—a supernova of light. Adora had to shield her eyes for she had become like the stars.

All at once, Taline loosed the energy she had collected. A great serpent of electricity snapped out, larger than anything she'd generated before. It illuminating Corynth a split second before all became dark again. Adora's ears rang with a thunderclap she was certain would have shattered all the windows around them had they not already been broken—she was half convinced it had shattered her eardrums.

Backup generators kicked on the moment after and the lights switched on again. Corynth stood where Taline had blasted him. Both his hands were outstretched, smoke lifting off them. Thick scorch marks reached feet behind him, almost touching the far wall which a handful of the station's denizens and refugees were huddling in fear behind amidst still moving shadows.

Taline wobbled on stilted legs and the magic lighting her eyes flickered and dimmed. The ley lines on her body also seemed to have shifted, twisting and darkening like poisoned vines withering on a wall. She fell to her hands and knees, heaving.

“You can drain as much power from the station as you want, backup generators and all,” Corynth said to her, sounding like dispersing that much energy was nothing to him. “Archanas didn’t kill me, Taline. I am That Which Eats the World Eater. You could siphon all the energy on this plane of existence to use and it would hardly slow me. If you can’t generate it yourself—if you lack the conviction to bend reality itself to your will, then I shall not acknowledge you.”

Taline leaned forward, pressed her head to the floor, and screamed into ash-streaked tile. The fog that had hung around their battle coalesced turned fully opaque, forming a swirling, thunder-riddled dome wide enough to isolate the three of them and the handful of fallen Vanguard soldiers in a now impenetrable arena of smoke and storm clouds.

More shadowed figures appeared. These were solid enough Adora could almost make out individual features on their bodies as they moved. As she observed them, Adora realized they were reenacting some scene independent of her or Taline or Corynth. In fact, none seemed to even notice their existence.

Teams of shadows moved as groups carrying rifles, taking cover behind invisible barriers and peeking out to return fire at some unseen enemy beyond. Others gestured in sweeping movements like Corynth and Taline were, orchestrating magic Adora could neither see nor feel. More than a few passed straight through ruined fixtures in the Atrium, and a chill shot down Adora’s spine when one inadvertently passed through her, too.

None of the surprise Adora felt at seeing these drastic changes occur in their surroundings compared, however, to the surprise she felt when she saw the bodies of the dead Vanguard soldiers around them begin to stir and pick themselves up, arranging themselves into lopsided, upright postures. Like the Abomination on Eden, Taline had reached forth, an unnatural shadow stretching from her body like the fingers of some unholy ventriloquist to resuscitate corpses and remake them into thralls.

She didn’t seem to be as competent at it, however.

Three of the thralls collapsed to the floor and stopped moving after their first shambling step forward. Another merely twitched on the ground without rising at all. Several others hadn’t moved to begin with.

Corynth cut those remaining down with a lazy swipe of his hand, and for a moment, Adora thought this was the end. He stood still unphased by this titanic demonstration of power while Taline heaved and gasped, clutching at her chest on the floor. But then he didn’t do anything, and Adora could tell just looking at him—looking at the way he stood despite not being able to see his face: something was wrong.

She was at his side within moments.

“I have her backed into a corner,” he said, “but she’s held out far longer and under much more stress than I anticipated.”

There was what Adora could only describe as a death rattle rasp accompanying his heavily modulated voice. Hearing it shot a bolt of cold fear through her.

When she put both hands on his shoulders to physically stop him in case he tried to push past her, he instead collapsed fully against her, pulling a surprised curse from under her breath. She barely had time to hook her arms around him and lower him gently to the ground.

“You’re in no condition to keep going,” she said, panic tingeing her voice. “You barely recovered enough to move around your own ship. You’re going to get yourself killed if you don’t stop.”

“Step away from her!” Taline bellowed the words from behind. Adora expected to argue with Corynth, but Taline was already on her feet with fresh magic swirling about her.

“She’s going to get herself and a lot more people killed if I don’t keep going,” Corynth said, speaking rapidly to Adora as if afraid

Taline might force them apart before he could finish. “She never trained…was never truly pushed. I have to make sure she can shape her magic without it shaping her in return. If she can’t, and I’m not there to help her, this could be a huge mistake. I will not lose her to that *thing.*”

“Adora, you need to get away from him,” Taline said. “Don’t listen to him. He’s dangerous. Whatever he’s telling you, don’t believe him. It’s a lie.”

The words flipped a switch for Adora. The irony behind Taline telling her not to listen to him spew lies as he articulated his concern for her would have been amusing were she not so upset about this whole situation. Her concern over Corynth’s wellbeing gave way to righteous fury. Fury on his behalf.

She squeezed his shoulder. “Let me help, then,” she said, before standing and turning to face Taline with narrowed eyes and a hardened look full of steel. It must have gotten her intentions across because Taline faltered.

“Stand aside,” Taline said.

“You’re wrong about him, you know. Semantics aside, I don’t think he’s said one straight lie to my face since I’ve met him.”

“He’s dangerous. You have no idea just how dangerous. The Daiamid orchestrated countless clandestine killings and high-profile assassinations. They were the emperor’s personal secret police, Adora. He was their ringleader!”

“He took over because of you.”

Taline didn’t seem to know how to respond to that, brow furrowing in deep confusion.

"I know they wanted you to join,” Adora said, pressing. “I know that you killed the person they sent to recruit you. Corynth told me." She tilted her head in what she hoped was an infuriating

gesture of defiance and said, "Or, what? Is that also a lie that I shouldn't believe or listen to?"

Again, Taline seemed at a loss for words, so Adora didn't give her the chance to reorient herself.

"One of the most powerful groups of secret assassins in the galaxy was hell-bent on killing you, and then they forgot all about you and instead revealed themselves to save your sister. From Horde Prime. At Corynth's command!

"*He* asked you to join them in the middle of escaping." Adora jabbed a finger repeatedly against her forehead as if to shout '*think, would you?*' with her body language. "Not some envoy, but Corynth. He gutted the entire organization and took charge to save you."

Saying it aloud made it that much harder for her to understand why Taline seemed to have trouble reconciling things. Maybe it was because she'd heard his take on things already, or maybe it was because she, too, had done incredibly foolish things like executing a suicide mission infiltrating Horde Prime's citadel to rescue people she cared about, but it felt like the truth should have been staring Taline in the face.

Adora turned her head skyward and sighed in frustration. "Taline, he cared about you. Ten years on and he still cares about you."

Taline took a step back, blinking rapidly and shaking her head like she was trying to dislodge intrusive thoughts.

The dome enshrouding them swirled, the shadowed figures moving about surged, and a voice—Corynth's voice—boomed out: an echo from a different time, and from unreachable depths.

*The Barrier is our only chance. We need you, now more than ever. Come with us! Please, come with us.*

Taline whipped around and threw a haphazard bolt of electricity in some random direction into the dome. The voice ceased, but the

tension in her shoulders didn’t relax. She turned back to Adora, face contorted with emotion.

“You have no idea what you’re talking about,” she said. “You weren’t there. You don’t understand.”

Adora didn't really know how this whole reality-shaping magic was supposed to work, even after Corynth had explained it. Heck, she barely understood how her own powers worked (or didn't work), but she had the distinct feeling that one of two things might happen if Taline pushed harder: either those shadowed figures might somehow turn corporeal, or Taline herself would break.

“You’re right,” Adora said pushing her voice to be heard above the howling of a ghastly wind beyond the fog. “I wasn’t there. But I was there when he was infiltrating each of the kingdoms on Etheria. He told me he’d helped each of them. I watched him deliver supplies to Entrapta’s lab. He saved my life three times over after he’d warned me about staying out of trouble.”

Adora laughed, amazed at how much he’d put up with her in the short time they’d been together.

“Take it from someone who’s very, very stubborn—someone who’s a pro at sticking their head in the sand instead of listening: you’re wrong about him. He’s not a liar and he’s not manipulative. He’s the one person who’s never stopped fighting the Beast even after everyone thought he was long dead.”

Taline bared her teeth. “This conversation is over,” she said. “Stand aside, Adora. I won’t ask you again.”

“I can’t do that,” she said, shaking her head.

Taline gestured with a quick flip of her hand. Circlets of magic appeared around Adora’s wrists and ankles—it was the same thing Taline had done to her years earlier. “Last warning,” she said. “If you don’t stand aside, I will make you.”

Adora sighed. Her track record with Catra being a prime testament, she'd never been much good at talking people down. Still, she'd hoped she might have been able to do it with Taline, especially since she thought she'd made a solid argument.

Oh well.

She reached for her power, feeling none of the apprehension she'd had up to this point over whether or not it would come.

Adora glowed. The remaining wounds she'd sustained from the earlier shrapnel closed up, the blood spattering her skin and clothes evaporated off her, and the circlets Taline had fastened to her wrists and ankles shattered.  It still wasn't a full transformation, but Adora hadn't been trying for one. She'd just needed enough to stall Taline until Corynth got back on his feet.

She stretched forth her hand. The Sword of Protection formed in her grasp, and she pointed it at Taline.

"Make me stand aside, then."

If Adora thought Taline might have started running out of juice, she'd certainly lost that impression the moment she outright challenged her. Taline's magic flickered and dampened, replaced with an insidious darkness that crept across her skin like a poisonous rot in her body. And for some reason, the aura she emitted felt more powerful because of it.

Taline lunged, throwing her whole arm forward as if reaching for Adora's throat across the distance. A larger-than-life statue of Horde Prime had shattered earlier during her fight with Corynth, and the pieces shot toward Adora. She cut each projectile clean in half with the sword, then danced out of the way of a new onslaught of a dozen more chunks of rubble and debris Taline had aimed at her with the same gesture.

Adora flung the sword out on a tangent. It carved through the air like a boomerang, ballooning away and then turning inward to

strike Taline from the side. Taline smacked the sword with a magic-infused arm and it went careening away, singing.

Adora thrust her arm out. The sword stopped midair and sped back to her, landing with a solid *smack* against her palm as Taline straightened and pointed two fingers at her like a precision shooter with a pistol in their hand.

A pinpoint ball of spinning energy materialized at the end of those fingers, then a laser-thin bolt shot to Adora. She braced her stance and intercepted it with the point of the sword. The blow pushed her back, feet sliding across the dusty floor a foot, then two, the whole sword glowing brighter as it absorbed Taline's magic. Adora spun out and away from the line of attack and aimed a swipe downrange at Taline. Magic flared out from the blade, casting a wide arc Taline wouldn't be able to sidestep.

Adora didn't wait to see if the attack landed. She sprinted forward on supernaturally strong legs and closed the distance between her and Taline in a handful of strides. Taline dissipated her return blast with a firm hand and a strong stance, only to get tackled to the ground the moment after: Adora wasn't going to win in a magic duel and wasn't certain she'd even prevail in a melee after seeing how proficiently she'd fought Corynth. So, she'd opted to take them both to the floor and hope pure strength bolstered with She Ra's power might help her triumph in a grappling match.

Taline struggled as Adora latched onto her like a python wrapping a tree, yelling and bucking and trying to roll. But Adora had years of grappling experience reaching all the way back to her adolescence. That, and the countless impromptu wrestling matches she'd had with people like Rogelio, Lonnie, and especially Catra meant, even though she couldn't quite submit Taline with an arm bar, it was a near thing. Eventually, Taline lost momentum.

"Are you…ready…to calm down, now?" Adora asked, gasping as Taline stilled.

Taline responded by throwing her head back into Adora’s nose. The moment Adora released her, shouting in surprise and pain, Taline reaching up and behind to palm Adora's head between both hands like a ball.

Pain rocked her body, shooting down her spine and extending to the ends of her hands and feet, a cold fire that would have made her scream were she able to breath. Her vision swam, and in the blurred forms of her sight floated impressions of history.

She saw Corynth as he was years ago when Taline first met him. Felt her existential anxiety marred with confusion at seeing her sister alive after the Beast had destroyed the research station she’d been on. Felt her curiosity, directed at the Battlemage who’d saved that sister.

She caught glimpses of the aftermath. A cleanup and emergency quarantine. Endless tests and examinations culminating in a coverup: the public couldn’t know someone had repelled a Beast infection. Not yet.

Later, there was a gift. A bottle of wine and a warm hug as thank you for pulling enough strings to get a lab and enough funds to finish research on ignominite.

*I’d still be a lab specimen,* he’d said to her by way of explanation. *Poked and prodded all day if you hadn’t gotten Evie her new station and an excuse to retain me.*

There was a second bottle of wine, later on, after initial research had concluded and ignominite was a ready commodity for the war effort. This time, Corynth’s thank you came with dinner, and she’d invited him to stay the night.

Adora saw pain. Pain and confusion and oblivion. After the Beast had taken her on Archanas, after the truths the envoy had shared with her and Corynth had withheld, after the Emperor had sentenced her sister to death and Corynth chose to share his

secrets with the public instead, all Adora saw was pain and confusion and oblivion.

She watched it fester for years until it grew to unbearable heights. And as she watched it drag her further into despair with every planet she turned to glass, watched her will to live dance on the edge of a knife after discovering her sister's remains on Archanas at the end of the war, Adora noticed something.

None of the emotions themselves ever changed.

Where over the course of a decade-plus, she'd have expected the pain of betrayal and loss to shift—to solidify, scar over, dull, or perhaps take on new facets with age. But Taline's pain remained static. Ever present. She saw it begin to shift at points, only to inevitably return.

Even the hurt Adora had unwittingly nurtured these years over her rupture with Catra had taken on new forms. This, however, felt very much like the nightmares Adora had experienced every year on the anniversary of her defeat on Horde Prime's citadel: driven by some underlying force. Something 'other.'

The strange trip through Taline's memories ended, pulling Adora back to the present like breaking to the surface from under an icy body of water. Taline had extricated herself fully from Adora's hold and was standing beside her, hands outstretched and fingers splayed like she was maintaining a spell. Adora watched Corynth rise to his feet in the distance, disappear in a swirl of gossamer, and reappear between her and Taline.

"Leave her alone," he said, pushing Taline away from her. "I'm your opponent."

His back was to Adora, but she wouldn't have been able to see him clearly had he been facing her, either. Her vision pulled in and out of focus. She didn't have full control over her body. She couldn't move. If Taline went for her again, there would be nothing Adora could do to defend herself.

Thankfully, she caught the look in her eyes when Corynth stepped between them. Taline had forgotten about her altogether. The fact she seemed to no longer exist in Taline's mind, and so quick, drove home the feeling there was definitely something wrong. There was no sign of the calm, collected version of Taline she'd fought years ago.

The ley lines on her skin had finished changing, too. Now all that remained was something twisted and blackened stretching across her skin like an enormous tattoo, and the sclera of her eyes had gone black in direct contrast to the starlight seeping out of them before. She looked almost like the thralls she'd tried to raise earlier.

"You won't acknowledge me if I can't shape reality to my will, you say?" Taline spat the words at him, the rot flaring on her body like a viper rearing back to strike. "I don't need your acknowledgment. I don't want it."

The fog dome around them shifted again, swirling faster and more violently like they had whipped into violent hurricane storm clouds. Soundless lightning flashed in their depths, and dozens more shadowed figures appeared around them. These were clearer than the others. Adora could almost make out their features.

Another bolt of lightning struck in the clouds, and this time, illuminated the silhouettes of several enormous skyscrapers towering about them in the fog. Adora had enough of her wits about her to know that should have been impossible. They were still on a space station, how could there be skyscrapers? With another flash of lightning, the facades of hundreds of them became just as clear and pronounced against the dome as the ghostly figures running about and between them, locked in their eternal play.

"I don't need your acknowledgment," Taline said, repeating herself. "I don't want it. I want you dead. Everyone I ever saved, I want it so you may never threaten their safety ever again." She

dropped her voice to a deadly whisper and said, “I want you to stop torturing me with his face. His body is not yours to do with what you will. It’s not your plaything!”

She threw her hand out to the side and, amazingly, the rot on her body began to recede, replaced with those ribbons and circuits of light that had emblazoned her skin from the beginning. The clouded darkness in her eyes gave way to starlight once more, and, most surprising of all, Corynth’s body language implied he was surprised by all of it.

"I am Taline, Consular of Phoenix, Sister to Evelynn Farseer, Seraph of Archanas. And if reality itself must bend for me to put an end to you, then it—”

A set of chains erupted from the ground, snaking up to latch onto Corynth’s wrists, pulling him down and forcing him to kneel.

“—Shall—”

Taline reached up high and grasped a spear of purified lightning she materialized out of thin air, screeching and chirping like another chorus of thousands of birds.

“—BEND.”

Taline exploded with light, vanquishing all the blackened vines that had crept across her body. The cloud dome exploded out like a shockwave, revealing a vista Adora had never visited once in her life.

The Atrium was gone. Instead, they were on an outdoor terrace dozens of stories off the ground on an alien world. The shadows were still there, still incorporeal, but the hundreds of skyscrapers in the fog had become real.

Taline had altered their very surroundings with nothing but her power.

“Look familiar?” Taline asked, looking down her nose at Corynth with an imperious gaze as she stood over him. Gone was the strained warping of her voice. The voices that comprised her speech sounded, once more, every bit the dominating force Adora had known her to be the last they’d seen each other. “The courtyard outside the Imperial Judiciary. I failed to stop him the last we saw one another. I thought it fitting to end things here, since you felt brave enough to inhabit his body.”

Something indistinct came from Corynth—something Adora couldn’t quite hear with him still facing away from her—and Taline leaned forward. “What was that?” Taline made a subtle gesture with magic infused fingers, and Corynth’s mask flew off his face, landing somewhere in the distance with an indistinct clatter. “I couldn’t quite hear what you—”

Taline paused. Looking at his face drained all the color from hers, something Adora could tell even though she was still bristling with magic.

“I knew you could do it.” Corynth’s voice was thick with emotion. It was obvious from his tone he was grinning. “My god, you’re amazing. I’m so proud of you.”

The words might as well have been a devastating punch to the stomach judging by how Taline reacted, folding in on herself.

“You’re…But… It’s not—” She shook her head and spoke to herself under her breath. “No. I’ve prepared for this.” Stepping into her resolve, teeth clenched so tight Adora could see the muscles working her jaw, she raised the screaming spear high, aiming at his chest, determination radiating from every inch of her.

*Taline will, at last, be free of me.* Corynth’s words rang in Adora’s head. *Prophecy fulfilled.*

Adora tried to scream out, tried to move, tried to stop her. Her body betrayed her. She was about to watch her execute Corynth on the floor of this alien world pulled from history.

Taline hefted the spear, her whole body, tense. Just before she plunged it down into Corynth, a figure of translucent, brilliant blue appeared next to them among the shadows on the terrace.

“That’s enough,” they said.

Amid the shock and sluggishness still plaguing her head, it took Adora a moment to place her. And when she did, she realized it was the same fluorescent woman she'd seen all the way back at the Crystal Castle—the same AI that had helped Corynth break in. The same one they’d come here to resuscitate.

Except now, she no longer looked the carefree, happy, and somewhat goofy character Adora had first met. Now she looked stern, with sharper cheekbones and thinner lips that were pulled into a frown. She had hardened eyes that seemed to state proudly how they’d witnessed lifetimes.

Taline’s eyes whipped to her and the spear shattered into a million crystalline pieces that dissolved in the air. Their surroundings melted like the tent of a circus collapsing while one was still inside. The skyscrapers gave way to the Atrium and its cowering residents, the near-hundreds of shadowed figures that had built up over the battle had faded, and all the starlight thrumming through Taline snuffed out.

“There’s no way,” Taline said. Her hair had fallen back to her shoulders in messy, sweat-streaked ribbons. She stared at the glowing woman with wide eyes. “It can’t—it *can’t* be you.”

Evelyn gave her a sad smile. “Hello, sister,” she said. “It’s been a long time.”

Chapter End Notes

> The symbolism behind Corynth and Taline being compared to revenants--animated corpses revived from the dead--is intentional. Originally I just wrote their characters and their arcs, but stumbled across a definition of revenants in folklore where they're portrayed specifically as vengeful spirits

brought back to take revenge on those that have harmed them in a previous life. From there I tweaked several things throughout the story during subsequent revisions to reinforce the comparison in my OCs.

With that in mind, Taline's "person to take revenge on" seems to be Corynth. But when you think about who Corynth would be trying to take revenge on, that theory for Taline doesn't seem so solid.

I also originally wrote Adora jumping out the window leap of faith style (similar to how she jumps after Catra in S5). She was going to awaken more of her power right before impacting the ground, similar to how Bruce Banner mentions in one of the Marvel films that the Hulk comes out when he'd otherwise suffer a mortal injury. Instead, I had her deliberately tell herself it was a bad idea, like she was an idiot for even considering it, and had that scene of her freaking out in the elevator instead.

I think it turned out much better. It definitely gave the nearly 8k word fight scene a much needed breather in the middle and injected a little bit of humor. Plus that blink-and-you'll-miss-it line about Hilda turning blue was definitely a telegraph for who shows up at the end.

Two more chapters in this part. Thank you as always for reading! Comments are always welcome and appreciated.

# Nightmares Waking

Chapter Notes

> This chapter gets pretty dark; It's not a big spoiler to mention Catra is in a pretty tough spot and, judging by the chapter title, it's liable to get worse. I've only done one, maybe two content warnings so far and I think this one warrants it too.
>
> If you made it past the chapter where Catra gets literally tortured in part 1, and then continued to read for nearly 60 more chapters after the fact, you'll be fine, but as a courtesy...
>
> Content warning for brief suicidal ideation (it's only a couple of lines and relatively tame, but its there) and suggestive themes.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The rune Taline left behind smoldered, burned into the floor of the silo room. Catra stared at it and tried to block out the chorus of voices from the countless shadowed figures standing around her.

*…Abandoned…She Abandoned You…Left You Here…*

Catra grit her teeth. Her vision swam with tears of unshed frustration.

*…Alone With Us…They All Leave…They Always Leave YOU…*

She knew this was an overreaction, something triggered by deep emotional scars instead of logic, but that didn’t help her stop panicking.

She slammed her eyes shut. Breathed deep. When the voices still didn’t go away, she breathed again, and again, and again. She resolved to keep going until they disappeared even if it meant

she'd be standing in the middle of all these ignominite silos with Diallo and Larian and everyone else for minutes on end.

Glimmer had showed her this long ago, saying it was a technique she'd originally learned from Perfuma and subsequently backed by the Enclave for calming her mind and focusing her magic. Catra had scoffed at first, wondering how doing nothing but breathing could solve anyone's problems, only to promptly shut up and adopt it herself when it had started to help her work through a panic attack she'd experienced not long after leaving Etheria.

Eventually, she managed to focus more on the apeiron searing her breastbone than the voices. Even with Taline gone, it still felt like a part of her was there, helping. When Catra opened her eyes again, the shadows were gone, as were their voices.

"What happened?" Keren asked. She and Trayn were still beside her, worried. "Are you okay?"

Catra took a moment to survey the room, afraid the shadows might return the moment she let her guard down. Larian and his priests were speaking quietly with one another, casting quick, excited glances to the burning rune Taline had just disappeared from. Diallo was there, watching Catra with a quizzical expression over his glasses. She wondered if the ignominite in them would protect him from Archanas' effects without Taline there. She wondered how much time the others had before they were affected the way she was.

"We have to leave," she said to Trayn and Keren. "The mission is over. We need to go back to Phoenix, immediately."

They looked at one another with surprise.

"But we just got here," Trayn said.

"Where did Taline go?" Keren asked. "Do you know why she left so suddenly?"

Catra didn’t have time to argue with them, but to her surprise, Diallo spoke up for her.

“W-without Taline’s protection, w-we are at far higher r-risk of falling under this p-planet’s spell,” he said, walking over to them with Larian and the priests close behind. He gave Catra an astute look and said, “I believe it has affected s-some of us, already.”

Maybe he was being genuine, or maybe he was just being a politician again and trying to get on her good side. Either way, Catra wasn’t about to pass up an opportunity to galvanize people and get away from here. “We need to get back to the main control room and hail the *Constable*,” she said, speaking to everyone. “They need to send the shuttle back and all of us have to be on it as quickly as possible.”

Her PDA chirped on her wrist, and Catra jerked her arm up to answer the call being funneled to her.

“Oh, thank god someone answered,” came a voice over the comm line. It was one of the analysts they left behind in the control room, Catra recognized them. "We've pinged Taline half a dozen times now and she hasn't answered."

“Taline is gone.”

“Gone? What do you mean gone?”

“I mean gone as in she left. Went away. Magically disappeared.” Catra sighed and pinched the bridge of her nose before taking a deep breath. “It’s Catra, her Sentinel. I’m in charge now.”

“Okay, well, she picked a hell of a time to hand off command over the mission. The *Constable* was supposed to check in with us twenty minutes ago, but they haven’t been responding to any of our hails. And the ship definitely didn’t magic itself away like the Seraph did, either. It’s still sitting up there in orbit, we can see it.”

Catra frowned. “We’re on our way,” she said.

Larian agreed to take them back to the control room the moment Catra cut the line. They left the silo room and piled into the elevator that would take them back. Pip had told her she'd already tried to reach the *Constable* earlier to get a shuttle sent to pick Catra up, and Catra had gotten mad at her for it. Even back then, the *Constable* wasn't responding to anyone.

::Pip?:: she said. ::Are you there?::

No answer. Catra tried not to panic.

::If you're mad at me for what I said then you have every right to be. I…I owe you a huge apology, and I'm so, so sorry. And I wasn't going to actually have you ripped out of my head if you didn't stop talking. Those were empty threats, and I feel really, really bad for saying them.::

She did panic a little when Pip still didn't answer, and Catra tried to focus on her breathing and the warmth of the apeiron again. If any new shadow ghosts decided to appear just then, Catra was certain she'd have a meltdown.

::Listen, I get it. You can still be mad even if I apologize. You don't have to forgive me, either, I'll keep apologizing until I'm blue in the face But I really, *really* don't want to be alone in my head right now and I could really use your help. Please don't ignore me. Even if all you do is yell at me for being a terrible friend, I don't care, just…please.::

Pip didn't answer her. Catra couldn't even feel her presence—that ephemeral bond she'd sense between them from time to time wasn't there. She wondered if Pip might have removed herself from Catra's head all on her own. Was she even able to do that?

As she traveled back to the central control room with the others, the voices started to come back. They chanted their chorus to her once again.

*…Abandoned…They All Leave…They All Abandon You…*

Catra's steady, concentrated breathing turned strained as she struggled not to hyperventilate.

---

The lift doors opened and Glimmer stepped out onto the bridge of the *Omen-Kador*. It was breathtaking, as far as bridges went. She'd only ever seen the bridge of Taline's *Constable* once before, and that ship was only a small cruiser in comparison to the supercarrier flagship of the Scavrian response fleet.

Standing and sitting consoles for the bridge officers dotted two levels, and a collaborative, board-room-style holoprojector sat in the open center, emanating a projection of the surrounding sector of space in crisp LIDAR detail that stood the full two stories tall. Augmented reality lasers projected the view immediately outside the supercarrier onto the blast shielding lining the perimeter of both levels. The kaleidoscope colors of the hyperspace tunnel they were shooting down paired with the sea of diagnostics interfaces on the occupied consoles, the sight mesmerizing Glimmer the moment she saw.

The officers—each dressed in crisp uniforms, calling out system-critical diagnostics and statuses to one another from their consoles and injecting the whole bridge with a sense of frenetic tension—noticed her. One by one they stopped what they were doing, plunging the bridge into deepening silence with each ticking second.

None of them looked as happy as the Scavrians had been to see her. None of them looked happy at all. Glimmer resisted the urge to tug at her uniform collar out of nervousness.

"Battlemage Glimmer, reporting to the bridge," she said, announcing herself with a salute.

Only one person within view hadn't turned to look at her. He was leaned forward over the shoulder of another officer still at their console, still in the dead-silence of the bridge.

"I know who you are." He sounded like they'd been fighting a pack-a-day cigarette habit for years. "And I think the rest of my bridge knows who you are, too, judging by the effect you're having on their focus."

He spoke the words like a warning, and one by one the crew turned away from her and back to their duties. The officer straightened and turned around, revealing the medals on his uniform breast and the scrambled eggs embellishing the visor of his service cap.

"Admiral Norognev, sir, I didn't—"

"At ease," he said returning her salute with a lazy one of his own and finally letting her rest. "Do you care to explain your actions to me?"

"Sir?"

"Your actions, Battlemage. On Scavria. Am I to understand you disobeyed orders to evacuate?"

Glimmer furrowed her brow. "My team was trapped, sir. I had to get them out."

"Your team?" The wide-eyed look he gave her said he was not amused. "There was no team. You opted to stay at the evacuation center and rejected command of your 'team' when it was first given. You ventured, alone, into an active infestation zone to rescue soldiers that were not even within your operating vertical, let alone under your command. You put not just this operation, but potentially the entire mid-rim at risk."

"Sir, I—"

"I don't recall asking for your input after the first time." Norognev's tone brooked no room for argument. He waited for Glimmer to argue back, and although the interruption got her hackles up, she bit her tongue. "You can expect a court martial when this is over. Putting yourself at risk of becoming an

Abomination is not something any branch of the military takes lightly. I don't expect you to come out of it with your commission intact."

Glimmer cringed and looked around the bridge again when it had gone suspiciously quiet. Norognev's officers were clearly trying to eavesdrop and only look busy. Some were even side-eying her. And in their eyes, Glimmer saw the resentment for what it truly meant: she'd risked all of their lives and all of the Scavrians' lives to get Lonnie, Rogelio, and the handful of soldiers still alive with them.

And she couldn't bring herself to regret it, even while she was folding in on herself under his gaze, wishing the floor would open up and swallow her. Her friends were alive because of her actions and because of Evelyn's help, although she still didn't know how or why that help had come.

"I understand," she said, putting on a brave face and meeting Norognev's eyes again. "If the military sees no merit in retaining me, then I understand. I'm sure the Enclave will happily think of some alternative for me."

Maybe she could help with the refugees, since there was always a crisis brewing about where to put them. Or perhaps she could get leave to return to Etheria, maybe with Salas' help lobbying on her behalf? Would Lonnie and Kyle and Rogelio still want to go with her if that was the case?

"You are just like her, you know?" Norognev said, pulling Glimmer out of her thoughts. "The Seraph."

Everyone knew who Taline was, but the way he spoke sounded almost like…

"You know her personally?"

He nodded. "Since before she'd ever earned her moniker. She was the one who commandeered my very first ship command. Forced my crew and I to respond to a research station the Beast had

infected long before we ever had effective tools with which to defend ourselves. She put us all in jeopardy, and later justified her actions by saying it resulted in the creation of the ignominite we now use to fight the creature."

"Doesn't sound like she was wrong." Glimmer tried not to sound petulant.

"She wasn't wrong, but she wasn't kind, either. She displayed no concern for my life or the lives of my crew. Not before taking command, and not after. In fact, she's never been known to show any remorse whatsoever for any of the lives she sacrificed throughout the war, justified or not."

Glimmer frowned at that, feeling an unexpected punch to her gut. She knew every planet Taline had saved was purchased at great cost. And she knew that although Taline had built a strong reputation with the common citizens on Phoenix Station, she'd also stepped on more than a few toes to achieve her objectives in the past. But as demanding and rigorous a mentor as she was, Glimmer had never known Taline to be cold or heartless. Quite the opposite, actually.

Norognev gestured for her to follow. She kept close as they proceeded between consoles down the main walkway, curious as to why she'd been called up to the bridge in the first place. Merely getting dressed down by the ranking officer of the fleet wouldn't have necessitated the trip.

"Speaking of the Seraph," he said, "we received an emergency SOS from the *Constable* and are on our way to respond with roughly half the fleet under my command. It's currently orbiting Archanas."

Glimmer looked at him in surprise. "The *Constable*? What is Taline doing off Phoenix? What is she doing back at *Archanas?*"

"I was hoping you could tell me. She's not supposed to go anywhere unless she takes a Sentinel or contracts with the

Vanguard, and last I heard, the Emperor refuses to give her troops."

Had Taline made Catra her Sentinel after all? Is that what had happened since they'd last spoken to one another? Glimmer stewed in thought. Even if Taline could leave, she still had no idea why she might have gone to Archanas.

"Are you sure it's safe to bring the megaliths within even a hundred light years of that place?" she asked.

"We're to keep to strictest protocol. No direct line of sight to the planet for anyone except the bridge crews. We're likely the only ones that could handle the exposure, anyways. Do you have any insight into why she might have gone to Archanas? Anything at all?"

Glimmer shook her head, earnest. "I don't."

Norognev sighed. They'd reached the front of the bridge and the view of the warp tunnel took up nearly all of Glimmer's vision. It was like standing a foot away from an enormous movie theater screen.

"The distress call was sent with a tight-beam signal directly to our coordinates above Scavria, spread across only a handful of astronomical units at the reception point. No one except us would be able to pick up on the signal. Did she know you were deployed with us?"

Glimmer bit her lip, knowing even that small gesture gave her away. "We called each other during our resupply stop at Kaloshi's Barrier Node. She knew where I was heading."

"Then the SOS was for you, but you have no idea what might be going on."

"As terrifying as it is to admit, that sounds about right, sir."

Norognev nodded and folded his hands behind his back. “I brought you here to help us respond when we arrive. This whole situation seems fishy from the start and I don’t like it. We’ll make contact with her vessel when we exit hyperspace, and I’d like you to be here in case we need your input. She’s your mentor.”

Glimmer leaned forward and gripped the railing cordoning them off from the viewscreen. She agreed with the admiral: this whole situation seemed peculiar just from his description and she didn’t like it, either. The fact this was happening over Archanas of all places only made it more frightening.

"Terminus lock acquired." One of the nearby officers behind them spoke loud enough everyone on the bridge glanced to them. "Exiting hyperspace in three…two…one…"

The hyperspace tunnel fell away, and the enormous curve of Archanas’ black and red-veined surface appeared before them, titanic amongst a backdrop of stars. Glimmer immediately felt it call to her, felt it whisper tainted words in her head.

Everyone on the bridge tensed with her. The *Constable* was visible, idling below them, off to the left.

“Comms?” Norognev asked the question without taking his eyes off the planet.

“No answer, sir,” came the officer’s reply. “The distress signal seems to have ceased as well.”

“Try and get them again.”

When still no reply came, Norognev looked to Glimmer for input and she shrugged at him.

“Scan the ship,” he said to his crew. “Full depth sweep. If there’s so much as a faulty wire aboard that ship, I want to know about it.”

When the elevator opened up to the central control room and everyone shuffled out, Keren stopped Catra by the shoulder and kept her back.

“Hey, what happened back there?” she asked after waiting for the others to drift out of earshot. “Governor Diallo said the planet was already affecting some people. Was he talking about you?”

Catra wilted and thought carefully about what to say. She could lie, but…

“I saw shadows moving in the corners,” she said. “At first it was just one or two but…when Taline left there were dozens of them.”

“Shadows? Catra, why didn’t you say anything before?”

“Would it be worse if I said the reason was stupid or if I said I didn’t have a reason?”

“Catra.”

"I didn't want to distract from the mission, okay? Do you realize how significant it is we're here? On Archanas? That Taline herself came?"

“Girl, yes I do, especially for you, but I also know none of that shit matters if you’re hallucinating for crying out loud. I can't count how many times they'd warned us about the potential side effects visiting this place when we were going through the initial screening. Seeing shadows was the number one thing they said we must absolutely tell someone about the moment it happens.”

Catra gazed up at her. Keren sounded upset, but not at her. It felt almost like she was upset *for* her, and that sentiment confused her.

“How do you think Taline will feel learning she left you behind in the middle of something like that? I know whatever it is was important, but that’s not going to stop her from ripping you in half when she see’s you again.”

Catra had to consciously hold herself back from voicing her very real fear they might not ever see her again. It would do no good for morale if she dropped that bomb before they'd even safely escaped Archanas.

Keren rubbed an unseen tear away with the heel of her hand, her voice coming through thick. "This is why you stayed a rookie for three whole years, you know. You need to do a better job speaking up for yourself. How else is anyone supposed to know what's going on with you if you don't say anything?"

The emotion in Keren's voice pushed Catra back on her heels. She had no idea what to say to that. For all the strides she'd made since leaving Etheria, opening up to people and showing any kind of weakness or vulnerable honesty was still hard. Hearing yet another person worry over her like this was hard to reconcile. And feeling like a shitty friend was not something she'd expected to experience here, of all places.

"I'm sorry," Catra said. "I should have said something."

"Tell us what you need," Keren said. "Trayn and I will help you."

At hearing his name, Catra noticed Trayn nearby. He'd stopped only a few feet ahead of them. Whereas Diallo, Larian, and the priests had continued all the way to the back of the room to talk with the analysts, Trayn had stayed further back to make sure no one came to bother Catra and Keren while they spoke.

She didn't deserve them. Their stubborn looking out for her reminded Catra of her friendship with Adora when they were kids, before everything fell apart.

"I need help coordinating our departure," she said at last. "If I concentrate the shadows stay away, but that's no guarantee they won't come back. We need to reach the *Constable,* figure out why the hell they aren't answering us, and get them to send a shuttle back down to pick us up so we can leave. I also need your help corralling the analysts. Everything needs to be packed up—we

can’t leave anything behind. Get the other security personnel we brought to help if you need it, but the sooner we're all off this rock and headed back to Phoenix, the better.”

"Well get it done." Keren pushed passed her, giving Catra's shoulder a squeeze as she went and prompting Trayn to follow with a nudge to the bony plate on his arm. Catra trailed them from behind, touched that they would rally for her like that with nothing but a request.

Catra stopped just short of the steps leading down into the mass of consoles in the room’s lowered center. Keren and Trayn continued all the way to the back where they got Diallo’s attention. She watched them exchange words, watched Diallo nod his understanding, then averted her eyes when he turned to head toward her.

Keren and Trayn taking over freed him from whatever he’d been doing, but that didn’t mean Catra wanted him to come over and talk to her. Especially not after it seemed like he’d figured out the planet was affecting her more than the others. Which, what the hell? She was wearing Taline’s crystal. It was still painfully warm under her clothes against her chest. Wasn’t it supposed to afford her *more* protection than the others?

“See anything interesting lately?” Diallo asked once he’d reached her.

Catra bristled. She could hear the cheekiness despite how innocent the question was. Of course he was still going to be an asshole, even after backing her up in the silo room. He didn’t even pretend to stutter anymore, and she was more convinced than ever it was just an act he’d put on and now felt comfortable dropping around her.

“Plenty of interesting things to see on Archanas,” she said with a cool tone. “I would say that I’m sorry we have to leave so soon, especially after all the work you put in trying to get Taline to bring you here, but—”

“But you would be lying if you did, I know.”

Diallo didn’t sound all that put out by it. Catra scowled at him, and he laughed in the same way he did back on the ship, deranged and maniacal. It sent the same shiver of fear down Catra’s spine as it did back then, too.

“Did I ever tell you how much you remind me of Taline when she was younger?” Diallo asked. Catra watched him pull his extraordinarily expensive ignominite glasses off his face and toss them aside like they were a cheap bauble. “Brash and headstrong and seemingly uncaring of what others thought or said about her, but all of it a mask to hide great, *great* insecurity.”

Someone—one of the analysts—called out saying they’d nearly hacked into the *Constable’s* onboard camera system, but Catra paid them no mind. She turned on Diallo, extremely angry at what he was insinuating with his words and his tone.

“Listen, I don’t know if you realize how—"

She cut off mid-word when a near-corporeal silhouette of Shadow Weaver appeared beside her, hair flying about her head like a halo of agitated snakes. She backed away until she nearly fell off the raised section of the control room, spun around, and found Diallo again. His eyes  had gone pitch black.

“She used to be so innocent, you know. So naïve. So pure of spirit and full of love before her accident. Before me.” Diallo’s lips pulled back in a wicked, aquiline grin, all teeth, reminding Catra of a predator moments before it struck out for prey. “And although I’m disappointed she won’t be around to witness this first hand, my little game with her has gone on long enough. I think it’s time to end it here, where it all began.”

A feeling of impending doom permeated the room as the shadows Catra had strived to banish returned in droves. Countless dozens reappeared, crowding the room, filling it with chorused whispering proclaiming death. And when Catra tried to get away, she found

she couldn't move. Her body remained rooted to the spot, and everyone else around her, from Trayn and Keren to the analysts and even Larian and his priests, they all seemed similarly locked in place.

*What the hell is going on?* Catra thought.

“It’s almost unfair how easy this is with her gone,” Diallo said. “She’d always been too strong to influence directly, but even after all these years, I hadn’t thought I’d affected her enough to actually send her back to Phoenix in a panic. To think she’d become so paranoid she invented a reason to run away? That she wanted so strongly to confront him again she tricked herself into seeing what was not there, without even needing my help?”

Diallo threw his head back and cackled. “I’d never have guessed that timing my move on the ship would have been the biggest challenge.” He slid a sidelong glance at Catra, smirking. “After all, I couldn’t have anyone, least of all you, growing suspicious until everything was in place down here.”

"W-what…are you…?" It felt like someone was sitting on Catra’s chest. She had to force the words to come, and even then couldn’t finish her sentence.

“Look for yourself,” Diallo said, strolling over to one of the engineers standing frozen in horror at his console. “All of you can look.”

He held a hand up, palm flat, only for it to morph into a slender, black tendril which he rammed into the back of the nearest engineer. They tensed and convulsed, frothing at the mouth, their eyes rolling into the back of their head. Their skin turned mottled and pale, and the whites of their eyes turned as black as Diallo’s.

Catra short circuited as she realized, finally, what was going on. Diallo was an Abomination. One who’d remained hidden for years. How he’d evaded detection in full view of Taline, Catra had no

idea, but the fact he chose to reveal himself here and now spelled certain doom.

She fought to move, and her body still refused to listen. She was certain if she were able to turn around, she'd see the twisted silhouette of Shadow Weaver he'd put there, still standing among the others. The voices cut off, plunging them into an ear-ringing silence. Catra could only assume it was because Diallo wanted her to hear with perfect clarity what he would say to her.

Slowly, ever so slowly, she forced her body to take a step forward. Hope bloomed in her chest. If she could get to one of the similarly immobilized security guards nearby, she could grab their sidearm from its holster while Diallo was distracted and put an ignominite bullet through him. She wasn't sure that'd even stop him, but it was something, at least. Something to focus her efforts on and stave off despair.

"Nuh-uh," Diallo said, chastising her with a wag of his finger while his other arm was still in the engineer. "Behave, please, will you?"

The room grew another order of magnitude more stifling, and Catra was right back where she started. Now it not only physically pained her fighting to move, but it was even harder to breathe.

Diallo pulled his arm out of his new thrall. Suddenly free of its independent fears and fully under Diallo's control, it typed away at its console, its movements jerky and clumsy like a toddler playing at the keys. The viewscreen covering the front of the control room shifted into a half-dozen partitions, each displaying various closed circuit television feeds. Catra recognized the places it was displaying a moment later: they were the hallways and rooms and engineering floors of the *Constable,* still up in orbit.

The crew weren't acting like themselves. Each stood about in lopsided postures or shuffled around aimlessly with awkward gaits. They, like the engineer Diallo had touched, were reduced to hollowed-out husks of their former selves: thralls, all of them. A subtle refraction effect rippled across the footage, like the air

aboard the ship was thick with an alien aura. A fog, much like Catra had heard Taline and even Glimmer describe on occasion.

Diallo had taken control of the ship, Catra realized with fresh horror. That's why no one had responded.

A ping appeared and the viewscreen shifted to accommodate the new information. A fleet—dozens of ships headed by a supercarrier—blinked into existence in orbit near the *Constable.* Catra's blood froze solid in her veins at the sight. *Why* were they here? Every soldier and naval officer up there was in grave danger, more people arriving and exposing themselves to an Abomination on Archanas of all freaking places was the last thing anyone needed.

"Perfect timing. Oh, Lariannnn," Diallo sing-songed with a rictus grin spread across his face. "Come here, would you? We may need your security overrides in a moment."

Larian shuffled forward, looking equal parts terrified and gleeful. "T-to be in the presence of a vessel of God…I am humbled. Had I known before that you—"

"Yes, yes." Diallo waved him off. "I need you to be a good supplicant and assign full administrative control of the compound to me."

"You can't help him, are you crazy?" Catra said, as Larian switched places with the thrall and started typing away at the console. "What the fuck are you doing?!"

"Don't blame the man, he can't help it," Diallo said as Larian continued to work. "He has as much control over his actions as you or anyone else in this room does right now. The only difference is he feels *happy* about it. Happy to serve me. Fanatics are interesting like that, don't you think?"

The visiting fleet fired upon the *Constable*, reducing it to rubble splitting apart amidst the stars. The camera feeds giving them a

look inside cut to static, and Catra cried out, seething between teeth gritted so hard her jaw ached.

“Administration is ready for handoff,” Larian said. “Press your holy palm to the console, and our compound shall heed your will, like its people have already done.”

Diallo stepped forward and pressed his hand to the console. It beeped at him and the display at the front indicated root administrator privileges had been revoked from everyone else and assigned solely to him. Diallo then grabbed a handgun from the holster of a nearby security guard and shot Larian in the gut with it.

Larian looked down at the wound and the wetness spreading across his suit jacket. He collapsed to the floor with a smile still on his face. Diallo and Catra watched him bleed out for several long moments, Diallo with a smile on his face and Catra with horror. When he stopped twitching, another tendril reached from Diallo’s back to stab him in the chest, too. A moment later, he’d risen again as a thrall, the same, effusive smile on his now clammy and cloudy-eyed face.

“The gunshot wound was unnecessary,” Diallo said. “I just felt like it.”

The intercom in the control room crackled to life and a voice spoke to all of them.

“Vestamid mining facility, this is Admiral Norognev of the Imperial Orbital and Surface Combined Arms Force, Scavrian Response Fleet. The light cruiser in orbit above this planet directed an SOS at our position. A full scan revealed it to be thoroughly infected by the Beast, beyond saving. Please respond immediately with your current status.”

Scavrian response fleet? A stone sank to the bottom of Catra’s gut at hearing that. Glimmer had been sent to Scavria. Was she up

there, too? If she was, she was likely aboard the same enormous flagship that admiral was transmitter to them from.

“Oh, we will be responding,” Diallo said to himself and those in the room. He glanced sidelong at Larian’s thrall. “This surface cannon you’ve built doesn’t work *quite* the way you thought it would, I’m afraid. I embellished some of those ‘brilliant epiphanies’ your engineers experienced to make it support a slightly…expanded functionality.”

“Leave them alone!” Catra said, voice hoarse from the effort she put into holding back tears.

Diallo turned to her with a look of evil mischief. “Why, Catra," he said. "You sound like you've never caught a big haul fishing before.”

He didn’t wait for Catra to respond, and instead threw his head back and his arms out. Dozens of tendrils erupted out his back and pierced every engineer in the room at the same time, making them convulse as if he’d run a thousand volts through their bodies.

One by one they stilled, then they, too, began typing away at their terminals. Dozens of pill-shaped icons appeared on the forward viewscreen alongside a new visual of the responding fleet in orbit.

“I repeat, this is Admiral Norognev with OSCAF Scavria. Please respond or we will be forced to assume your operation has been compromised.”

“You should have assumed quicker.” Diallo splayed his fingers over his terminal and dragged them down the touch screen. All the pill-shaped icons on the forward screen lit green.

“Target their flagship,” he said to his thralls.

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“Sir, the surface compound isn’t responding to us either.”

Norognev drummed his fingers on the railing before the bridge's forward screen, staring narrow-eyed at the real-time diagnostics of their fleet capabilities and situational intelligence overlaying the view of the planet.

"Scanning the surface won't do anything for us," Norognev said. "The calcified remains of the Beast will just mess with our readings. Targeting and Munitions, prepare a formation plan for another surface bombardment. Comms, draft a message to the remainder of the fleet at Scavria and to the Heartlands informing them of our current findings. Wait to execute both on my command."

A round of 'Aye, Sir's echoed around the bridge and the officers spurred to action. Some spoke rapid jargon into their comm-sets, ordering adjustments to the supercarrier or relaying the Admiral's orders to the bridges of other ships in the fleet. The shuffling of feet joined the din as assistants scurried between workstations with urgency. Glimmer stood tense beside Norognev at the front and held onto the railing as if it were the only thing keeping her grounded.

She'd just watched them blow up Taline's ship with no idea if Taline was aboard or not. Catra might have been too, since making her a Sentinel and taking her along was the only logical way Glimmer could make sense of Taline having left Phoenix to begin with.

Protocol was clear and it made sense, even in this situation: an infected Beast ship was to be destroyed. Period. But…how could they have let their guard down so bad? Had she really lost both her mentor and her friend right before her eyes? Just like that?

"Sir, I'm reading a new energy surge from the planet's surface," said another officer. "It's got a similar energy signature to what we detected aboard the *Constable,* but…"

"What is it?" Norognev turned to them when they trailed off. "Spit it out. What is it?"

The officer was you and inexperienced. They stared at their console, fear written plain in their wide eyes. “Th-the infection readings are off the charts. Our instruments…they can’t quantify it.”

Norognev frowned. “All stations to high alert. I want the rest of our ships primed to—”

An alarm sounded off on the bridge. Emergency lights replaced those used during normal operation, casting everything red.

“Sir, I’m reading a system lock on our location,” said yet another officer—one that had taken over for the previous after they proved unfit for their post. “The compound has targeted us.”

“They’ve *what*?”

A concentrated beam, red and as thick as a corvette streaked toward them from the surface. One of their destroyers had just arrived at its bombardment position, slotted between them and the surface. The beam, which was surely meant for them, instead struck the bow of the destroyer. It started to drift and turn on its side like a listless whale.

“The *Carpathian* is reporting systemwide control failures,” the bridge exploded with a flurry of voices, the loudest among them coming from the head intelligence officer. “Stabilizers are offline. Infection readings are spiking!” They looked up and made eye contact with the Admiral, their voice whisper-quiet and filled with disbelief. “The Beast has infected the ship, sir.”

The *Carpathian’s* hull bristled with red static when suddenly another beam jumped from it, forking to two others of their fleet in formation nearby. Those two ships buckled before the energy jumped to four more. Before the Admiral could bark out new orders, half the task force had been hit along with the *Omen-Kador* itself.

“Life support is offline. Emergency power is barely holding on!”

The flagship lurched and began to drift.

“Stabilizers are gone…decks S through AF are reporting Beast infections spreading rapidly through the halls. Decks AG and AH are now reporting the same.”

Norognev cursed. “Launch the megaliths. Get all of them out before the ship is taken, then initiate emergency scuttle protocols.”

Another alarm, more urgent and higher-pitched, replaced the previous one as activity on the bridged kicked up to new levels. More orders went out ship-wide about the evacuation and scuttle orders coming down. Officers got in touch with the other vital areas of the ship, engineering, life support, and weapons, to coordinate. Soon, a giant timer counting down from three minutes appeared on the forward viewscreen, and an automated voice fought with the alarm to signal the start of the self-destruct sequence.

"Everyone here needs to get to the escape pods and evacuate, too," Norognev said. “I will remain with the ship.” When he took in his crew looking at him like they wanted to argue he barked out, “That’s an order. Now *move.*”

Glimmer spared him a shocked look, herself, which he responded to with a stony gaze that brooked no argument. She nodded her respect, then turned and rushed out with the rest of the crew to the emergency lifts at the back. She didn’t look back at him as she went.

“Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio, are you all there?” she asked, speaking into her PDA as she crammed into one of the lifts with a dozen others.

“We’re here.” Lonnie’s voice came through clear. Glimmer could make out the sounds of the emergency alarm blaring in the background from her feed, too. “Where are you?”

"I'm on my way down from the bridge. Everyone is rushing to the escape pods. You three better be on your way out as well."

"We're taking Kyle's Warbird as part of the defense. Whatever hit us from the surface isn't just going to let the megaliths idle defenseless out in space."

Glimmer made a split-second change to her plans. Lonnie told her which bay the Warbird was docked at. When the emergency lifts opened on the bridge crew's escape floor, she stayed behind, punching a new floor into the elevator console when it emptied out. Moments later and it let her out on the correct hangar level, close to the *Omen-Kador's* underbelly.

A different Warbird screamed overhead as it shot out into space, blowing out Glimmer's ears, escorting the last megalith to undock. She hunkered down out of reflex and six more Warbirds joined the first, buffeting her in the hurricane of their exhaust flow.

Compared to before, the hangar was almost empty. All the refugees had boarded their megaliths and left already, already out in space. The few dozen remaining pilots and support engineers were rushing to their stations to launch, escorted by small teams of security firing at numerous ex-crew that had already turned into thralls.

She saw Kyle's ship downrange. Lonnie stood with one foot already inside the troop hold, waving at her with large, frantic movements. Kyle was in the cockpit, revving the engines to take off, and Rogelio was already strapped in next to about a half dozen others. They were waiting for her.

She had no idea how much time was left before the ship blew, but she guessed not much. Ninety seconds could fly by faster than anyone expected, and not getting into one of the escape pods with the rest of the bridge crew had cost her precious time.

Glimmer pumped her legs hard, running as fast as she could to her team in the distance. She was almost there!

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Catra watched the flagship explode on the viewscreen.

“You bastard!” Catra railed against her body’s refusal to cooperate. She fought so hard to storm over to Diallo and strangle him with her bare hands, but couldn’t so much as twitch a single finger. “You fucking bastard!”

“Now, now,” Diallo said, still at the console. “Let’s try and be civil, shall we? There’s no need for name calling.”

Several ships remained in space, most tilting on their sides and bursting with static red electricity, but a handful still upright and untainted. Several megaliths were with them, as were a modest swarm of Warbird squads in defensive formations.

A new set of live footage superimposed itself over the carnage. Catra watched dozens of remote hangar bays around the compound—bays she hadn’t even known existed on the surface—launch hundreds of fighters already tainted with the black-red ooze of the Beast. They arced up, burning through the atmosphere to meet with the few, uncorrupted vessels remaining in orbit.

Tears streamed down Catra’s face. Glimmer was likely dead, Adora was likely dead, Taline was likely dead. And Catra was here, alone, caught in a monster’s web, defenseless to his whims.

The voices in her head wouldn’t stop screaming, the shadows surrounding her seemed to grow more solid and corporeal with each passing second. Pip was gone, Larian and dozens of others had been turned to thralls, and Keren and Trayn were likely to be next. And then Catra after.

Taking her own life was preferable to that, and Catra didn’t even have the agency for that.

“I know what you must be thinking,” Diallo said, turning to face her with a look that sent a new shiver of fear shooting down her

back. “You must be thinking that things couldn’t possibly get worse for you.”

Catra tried to open her mouth and say something, anything, but even that ability had been taken from her. Instead, she watched Diallo take a step toward her, then another, and then yet another, more black tendrils unfurling from his back like decomposed wings unfolding.

He stopped an arm-length away and the tendrils encircled her, slithering from her legs up her torso like snakes until they wrapped her neck and squeezed. As he slowly, agonizingly restricted her airway and the blood flowing to her head, Catra discovered her body’s instinct to struggle was at least still partially there.

He’d lifted her off the ground such that her toes barely scraped the floor, her legs giving pathetic kicks trying to break free. She listened to herself gurgle, body fighting and rasping for any oxygen at all he’d deign to give her.

“I’m pleased to tell you that it can very much get worse,” he said. “Much, *much* worse.”

His shadow elongated in an unnatural way behind him, blanketing the floor and reaching out to everyone still untouched and frozen in the room. They convulsed frothing at the mouth as soon as the darkness touched them.

One by one, the pill-shaped icons on the front viewscreen turned blinking red and a warning flashed repeatedly across the screen in bold letters: the silos were open and spilling their contents—spilling pure, refined ignominite—all over the compound. Diallo was reawakening Archanas in full, and by the urgent reports piling onto the viewscreen all of a sudden, the planet was coming alive fast.

Catra’s eyes felt like they’d sooner pop out her head, but she managed to spot Keren and Trayn at the far end of the room.

They stopped convulsing, turned, and headed toward them with stiff, jerky movements, different from how the thralls moved.

“All of this is thanks to you,” Diallo said, one tendril reaching forth and hooking under her chin to turn her head and force her to look him in the eyes. “Without your help, Taline would never have gotten me inside this compound. How does it feel knowing that you are about to bring the greatest change the galaxy has seen since the end of the previous war?”

He’d stopped short of squeezing Catra until she passed out, and she knew that was on purpose. He wanted her to feel her fear and dread deepen with each passing second. He’d engulfed her with his presence—infused her. Saturated her.

He was taking her as a thrall, too, she realized all at once. Much slower than the others.

Diallo jerked her toward him until he could lean forward and whisper directly in her ear. “I will not turn you.” His voice was a sensual purr. Catra felt her fur stand on end in visceral response. “Not yet. Your friends will succumb first, one by one. I will make you watch.

“Or perhaps I will start with you. Make them watch as I do many horrible things to you. Things no sentient being in this galaxy or any other can articulate with words. And then, when you can do nothing but beg pitifully for death, maybe then will I turn you into one of mine.”

Images flashed in Catra’s head, then. Images of what he planned to do. Catra had once been horrified at the thought of having to kill Taline should she ever be in danger of becoming like Diallo, but after what he showed her, she understood. It finally made sense why so many unlucky enough to survive an encounter with the Beast without becoming a thrall still ended up a broken, hollowed out husk of their former selves anyway.

Catra already wanted to beg for death. Plead for enough control over her body she could unsheathe her claws and tear her throat out herself.

Diallo hadn’t restrained her arms, probably because he knew she had no chance of moving them no matter how hard she tried. That knowledge threatened to push her off the edge into madness before he’d even gotten started with her.

Chapter End Notes

Norognev actually gets a super brief mention in a flashback! Evelyn and Taline talk about him.

The Beast is strongly hinted to prey on individual insecurities. Who'd a thunk Shadow Weaver would be among Catra's insecurities? (Plus Adora telling her to forget about her)

I'm curious to hear what you guys think about the Diallo reveal. I know most of you probably didn't like him and were side-eying him the whole time, but how many of you guessed his true nature before the reveal? Let me know in the comments so I can bestow super kudos to you ;)

One more chapter to go in part 4!

# Séance

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“What’s wrong?” Evelyn stepped toward Taline. Her mouth was turned up in a smirk but her eyes were sad and apprehensive. “You look like you’ve seen a ghost.”

She reached forth as if to caress her sister’s cheek with the back of her hand. Taline watched that hand, looking torn between meeting her halfway and shying back. It passed through her, proving she was nothing but a hologram, and Taline tripped over her own feet as she stepped back, crashing to the floor with a thud.

Evelyn’s smirk widened and the sadness in her eyes deepened. “I guess, technically, you have seen a ghost,” she said.

Adora, still prone on the floor, managed to roll onto her side and immediately regretted doing so; the ruined Atrium spun around her and she nearly threw up from the vertigo. She stared at a scorch mark on the floor, trying to anchor herself. Out the corner of her eye she watched Taline, legs splayed, gaping up at the image of her sister. The expression and how it contrasted her typical look might have been funny had Adora not realized how tragic this reunion was, already.

“Careful now,” Evelyn said. “That public image you so carefully manicure is liable to break if you keep staring at me like that.”

That pulled a sharp bark of laughter out of Taline. She tried to suppress how the corners of her lips turned up in a smile, then shook her head like she was disappointed at some tasteless joke when she couldn’t.

“Manicure?” Her tone implied she didn’t care to so much as manicure her nails let alone her image. “Even in death you still

tease me."

"What are sisters for?"

"It really is you, isn't it?" Taline said after a beat of silence between them. "I'm not dreaming this."

Evelyn's expression hardened again and she shook her head.

"How are you here?" Taline glanced to Corynth, unsure, then back. "Did I…?"

"No. Buildings and locations are one thing, but you aren't yet strong enough for me to have come through as well." Evelyn gestured down at herself, at her holographic blue body. "I had to procure another means of reaching out."

"It's a recording," Corynth said, speaking for the first time. His voice still held that death rattle even without the mask, and he was still facing away from Adora. Now it started to seem deliberate, to her.

Evelyn turned to him, even deeper regret and apprehension staining her features than when she'd looked at Taline. "You're so fast at figuring me out, now."

"You left a lot of yourself behind." He didn't sound happy to see her. "Your riddles. I imagine deciphering so many of them over the years, alone, would do that."

Evelyn reared back as if slapped, the first hint of humanity Adora had seen in her since appearing because even the sadness she'd shown them had seemed divine and aloof. Taline's attention snapped to something in the distance and the rest of them followed suit.

The crowd from earlier was reforming. Brave but terrified Phoenix denizens and refugees emerged from the lingering smoke and dust, held back from getting too close by Dax and his station security. A few remaining Vanguard troops were there, too, and by

the way they hefted their rifles at the four of them in the center of the floor, their intentions were clear.

“I’ll take care of them, order them to back off,” Taline said, making to rise from the ground. Evelyn stopped her with a shake of her head.

“There is no need. They will not interfere in our conversation.”

“The Vanguard engaged us mid battle,” Taline said. “They won’t hold themselves back now that we’ve stopped.”

“I wasn’t the only one feverishly deciphering cryptic messages dressed up as prophecy and holy edict,” Corynth said. “The Daiamid are more prevalent than anyone reasonably expects.”

Even Adora didn’t know what he was trying to get at, and, frankly, she was getting tired of constantly feeling out of the loop. As much as Corynth derided those ‘cryptic messages’ Evelyn had supposedly left behind for him, he was speaking in an equally cryptic way, too. No wonder it irritated him. It irritated her, too.

She had half a mind to try and say as much when she noticed several of the refugees and denizens rush forward to intercept the Vanguard on their way to them. A handful of Dax’s security aimed weapons at them, too, ordering them to halt. Some Vanguard even turned the barrel of their guns on their teammates, and judging by the look on Taline’s face, Adora wasn’t the only one surprised by this.

“The Goddess has revealed herself!” One of the turncoat Vanguard soldiers said.

“She prophesizes again,” said a refugee. “None shall interrupt her words, for they are sacred beyond sacred!”

Taline turned an expectant look on Corynth and, apparently finding no answers there, looked to her sister instead. Evelyn had drawn up to full height, regal imperiousness icing her features once more.

“With this, the Barrier is complete and at last the Beast is sealed,” she said. “That which has already passed through is the last of its kind, and for as long as the Nodes remain operational, the World Eater will hunt no longer. Thus, I decree it.”

An outsized portion of the faraway crowd chanted back, “Thus, it is,” making the hairs on Adora’s body stand on end.

Evelyn smiled at them, then at her and Taline. It wasn’t until she looked at Corynth that her smile disappeared, replaced with…was that discouragement? Corynth was still turned away from Adora, and never was there a time she wished she had the strength to even crawl close enough to see what his expression held.

“Pip has fully reconstituted,” Evelyn said, quietly for just the three of them to hear and specifically to Corynth. Adora got the strange sense she was trying to placate him, somehow. “She’s getting her bearings straight between the two of you, but once that’s done, she will be there with you again. There to make fun of you, even when I cannot, remember?”

Corynth didn’t say anything, and the helpless, despairing look on Evelyn’s face deepened. Taline glanced between the two of them, looking exactly how Adora felt: like she wanted to say whatever magic words would make things better but at a complete loss for what those words might be. It was an expression at odds with the one she wore moments earlier, trying to rip Corynth’s head from his body.

The irony wasn’t lost on Adora.

“You shouldn’t look so surprised,” Corynth said at long last. “You knew this is how I’d react. You knew the day you recorded this and just never said anything, didn’t you?”

“It doesn’t make the experience any less painful.” Evelyn spoke in a whisper that suppressed tears. “It might actually make it hurt worse.”

A knock came from somewhere far removed from them. Evelyn shut her eyes, sucking in a deep, shuddering breath like the knocking were a death knell. "Enter," she said, and it was then Adora realized that knocking had come from her end of the transmission.

The sound of a door hissing open came, and Evelyn looked off to the side at something no one except her could see.

"Hey," she said, forcing a smile and a light voice. "Was Ly able to help you with what I'd asked?"

"Yeah," said another voice. "I sat in that chair for hours and she wouldn't let me even stretch my legs. Vasher bet I'd lose my patience, but Pip is in my head now, too."

Corynth—a younger but no less weary-looking version of him—appeared in the hologram projection beside Evelyn, who stepped to the side to make room for him. He didn't look at Adora, Taline, or his older self. Just at Evelyn, like he wasn't aware anyone else was there watching.

"Again, I don't really need a research assistant, so why did you insist I have her?" he asked, running his fingers through his hair. "Also, why does she look like you?"

Evelyn smiled up at him, although even Adora could tell it was pained. "So that I will always be there making fun of you, even when I'm not."

"And here I thought it was because of your vanity. That runs in your family, you know?"

Evelyn punched his shoulder with a laugh—a genuine one. "Not that it's ever mattered before, but Taline's adopted, remember? That's not the second-hand insult to her you think it is."

"I remember." He tilted his head, watching her close. It amazed Adora how expressive his face was back then. "What's wrong?"

Evelyn shook her head. “Nothing, I just…I was thinking.”

That excuse sounded flimsy even by Adora’s standards.

“We leave for Archanas in a handful of hours. Not getting cold feet now, are you?” the younger Corynth asked, causing Evelyn to roll her eyes and laugh through her nose.

“You know that’s not it.” She gestured with a tilt of her head to the three of them in the Atrium. “I’m recording a message.”

The younger Corynth followed Evelyn’s gaze, his eyes looking over Adora, Taline, and his older self without really seeing them. “For who?”

“For Taline, speak of the devil. And others. For posterity’s sake, you could say.”

“Ah.”

“Why don’t you say something, too? It would be cathartic.” Evelyn looked right at the older one on the other side of the recording, her eyes conveying far more than her words. “And I’m sure it would mean a lot to her to hear what you have to say now that you two aren’t in the middle of a pitched battle.”

Young Corynth seemed to consider this for a moment, then looked directly at them—directly at Taline, even though Adora already knew he couldn’t see them. She swore Taline was holding her breath by the way she sat unmoving, unblinking, staring up at him with shimmering eyes.

She startled when both Corynth’s spoke at the same time.

“I should have told you the truth,” they said together. “That day we found you bleeding out in the corner of your apartment after fighting off the Daiamid’s envoy…I should have told you who I was.

"I got too caught up in wanting to protect you. I got too caught up in fearing how you'd react learning I'd kept the truth from you for years already, and after they attacked you…all I could think about was making sure they never laid their hands on you again.

"I didn't think about how it would damage the trust you had given me. I didn't think about what it would cost. How I was trading your dignity just so I could protect you alone. How much it would hurt you. I don't regret that I succeeded keeping them away from you, but I'm sorry for what I did to you making that choice."

The younger one breathed deep and looked up at the ceiling, blinking fast. "I'd told you, once, that despite how terrible the circumstances of us meeting had been and despite how bleak the future looked, I wouldn't have changed a thing. Because I got to meet you.

"I think, just this once, were I able to, that would be the one thing I *would* change. I would have told you the truth, that night. And I would have told you how sorry I was for not telling you sooner."

Both Corynths lapsed into silence while Taline sat near them on the floor looking like all the fight had drained out of her. Evelyn broke the moment, nudging the younger Corynth in the ribs with her elbow.

"You're a real sap, you know that?"

He gave her a look. "Thanks."

"I'm sure she'll appreciate it, though. Really." Evelyn's expression gentled. "You've given a lot of thought to what you wanted to say, haven't you? I mean, that just came right out of you."

"Months twiddling my thumbs and working with the remains of the Daiamid while you and your scientists study the Barrier? Where would I have found the time?"

“Alright, smartass, get out of here,” Evelyn said, pushing Corynth out of view and, ostensibly, toward the exit.

“Wait, what about you? You get to stand there and listen to me pour my heart out but I don’t get to listen to your message?”

“If you’re that curious you can listen to it after Archanas. How does that sound?”

There was a pause. Adora imagined him giving her a serious appraising look, judging by how Evelyn was staring back.

“Is that a promise? Because if you’ve seen something, anything at all about what we’re about to go up against, now is the time to tell me.”

“It’s a promise,” was all Evelyn said. “Now go. You have to prepare.”

There was a stare down, of which they got to see only her side of, then the sound of a door hissing open and shut once again. He’d left.

Evelyn deflated, looking even wearier than before, and a tense silence followed.

“It really is a recording,” Taline said, sounding like all the life had been sucked out of her voice. “How are you able to talk to us like this? You’re responding as if you’re right here with us holding a conversation.”

“Because her future vision was far more precise than she’d ever admitted to any of us,” Corynth said. “She doesn’t get ‘fuzzy imprints of possible futures,’ like she’d told us when first warning us about Etheria. She sees the whole damn thing play out as if she was there living it herself. And by the end, she’d grown adept enough at it to use that power without even needing to commune with the Beast at all, isn’t that right?”

Evelyn swallowed. “Yes.”

"That was our last conversation with one another before the end," Corynth said, voice going tight. "I'd taken your words to mean you *had* glimpsed what was to come despite swearing to me time and time again you hadn't. When you said 'I promise,' I'd took it to mean that we'd come out alright together, because how else would you keep that promise if you'd died?"

He gestured to Taline beside him and the ruins of the Atrium around them, at the alternating scared and worshipful faces in the crowd, and said, "This is what you meant? Me waking up, surrounded by the burned out remains of my last living brothers and sisters and your corpse, listening to this message after years wandering the galaxy, following your words scattered throughout the various sects of the Vestamid? Alone?

"You knew I'd guessed you could see more. I even gave you the chance to come clean and you still didn't."

Evelyn shied back the more bitter Corynth's voice got. "I—"

"And don't tell me that I technically did get to listen to your message after Archanas, Evelyn. Don't you dare tell me that, because that would be a supremely shitty thing to say to me right now."

Taline looked like she was so dazed she barely comprehended what Corynth was saying. Adora struggled to move. Her toes wiggled and her arms twitched. The room had stopped spinning and she'd stopped feeling sick, but wasn't able to so much as pull herself toward them, yet. Taline had reset her hard with whatever mind blast she'd done during their fight.

"Corynth, I have no excuses," Evelyn said. Her voice came out more confident than she looked. "I could make them. I could try and tell you it was all necessary to at last fight the Beast on an even footing, or I could tell you that I *had* tried telling you. Tried countless times, countless different wordings, different permutations, only to witness those timelines I'd experimented with lead to annihilation all the same.

"I could say all of that and more, and it would be true, but it wouldn't change the fact I know I've hurt you. I've used a lot of people through the decades…placed a lot of pawns on the board in this long, endless game, and I've used you more extensively and far longer than anyone else.

"All the excuses in the world won't change that. I am so sorry for what I've done to you—both of you," she said, turning to address Taline, too. "You have every right to be upset with me. You have every right to never forgive me, to hate me. But I just want you to know that I tried everything, and I'm sorry that it had to be this way."

Adora was starting to feel her strength come back, again. Soon, she'd be able to go to both of them and do…well, something helpful, she was sure. Soon.

Corynth was deadly still, but Taline must have seen something wrong because she reached a hand out to him in concern. She got halfway there before remembering herself and pulling back, surprise at her own actions crossing her face.

"I'm not upset with you," Corynth said at last. "Not anymore. I'm just…tired, Evelyn. Your prophecies ended with this. The Barrier is finally sealed and Taline is free of my influence. Or, the Beast capitalizing on some very old feelings about me to ensnare her, at least. There is nothing left for me. Nothing left of me. I want to join the others."

Hurt, followed by confusion at the hurt, flashed across Taline's face. Adora felt rage mix with her own sadness at hearing Corynth talk like that. Rage and sadness both at the thought of him wanting to die and at the tragedy behind him being run so ragged that was all he felt he had left to do.

Evelyn's face twisted into anguish. "Corynth…there's something else," she said, knocking Adora back on metaphorical heels the moment she realized whatever Evelyn was going to say next would fracture her heart.

He gripped the fabric of his ripped and dusty pants tight, his shoulders rising to his ears and shaking while he bowed his head. “Something else? What else could you possibly ask me to do? What else is there?”

Adora called to him, her voice coming out like a gravelly rasp as she forced herself onto her knees and crawled over to them. Taline had, again, been mid-reach for him when she startled, like she’d just remembered Adora had been there the whole time. She glanced in horror at Corynth, who was still turned away, and shot an arm out.

His mask barreled forward from off in the distance, and she fixed it to his face with two reverent, gentle hands.

Adora reached them the moment after, but the tension in Corynth’s body had subsided, and with his mask on again she couldn’t get a good read on him, either. He nodded to her, but all she could focus on was how that damned death rattle still accompanied every breath he took.

“Hello, Adora,” Evelyn said, finally addressing her. “It is nice to finally meet you after all this time waiting.”

“Nice to meet you, too,” she said, unsure of what else to say. She wondered how long, exactly, Evelyn had expected this meeting, especially given how Adora had almost never thought of her until Corynth had explained her significance. “At risk of sounding a bit rude, it would have been nicer if you’d showed up, you know, earlier. Like, years earlier.”

“It would have been, yes,” Evelyn said. They were the words a goddess might have spoken to their devotees, but Evelyn sounded like an exhausted, mortal girl when she said it. “I would have liked to have been able to do that, too, but then you wouldn’t have been here.”

“Me?”

Evelyn nodded. “Yes. You. You have a place in all of this, too, even if it sometimes doesn’t feel that way.”

Adora didn’t know how to respond, feeling strangely intimidated by that answer.

“Sorry I mind blasted you like that,” Taline said, sounding genuinely apologetic. She looked almost worried that Adora wouldn’t forgive her. “That was my bad.”

It was still difficult to talk, but Adora gave her the best smile she could manage and mimed rapping herself on the head with her knuckles. “It’s fine, I’ve got a pretty thick skull. Catra’s said so on more than one occasion.”

Taline gave her a pained look, something between a hesitant smile and an embarrassed grimace.

“You didn’t answer my question,” Corynth said to Evelyn, voice modulated once more. “I scoured all of the Vestamid’s holy writings, all the differences between the sects. It was supposed to end here. What else am I needed for?”

Evelyn looked at him for but a second before blatant sorrow and shame overcame her. She kept that shame on full display, refusing to look away from him as she said, “The Vestamid were there to preserve my instructions for you, true, but that wasn’t the only reason I created them.”

“For what other reason would you need to make an entire order of fanatics for, then?” Adora asked.

Evelyn looked to her, shame still in her eyes. After a moment, Adora got the impression that shame wasn’t only because she was still stringing Corynth along.

“They’re bait.”

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“Closing your eyes will only make it worse,” Diallo sing-songed.

It was the only thing Catra had any control over, closing her eyes. She squeezed them shut harder, defying Diallo in any way she could. Why hadn't he killed her already? He'd won. Why was he keeping her alive to wallow in this misery? Why torture her further?

"It's your reward," he said. "For being such a big help getting me here."

"Get. Out. Of. My. Head." Catra could force the words out with effort. She had a sneaking suspicion that, on top of reading her every thought, she was only able to speak because he let her. Hell, he could probably prevent her lungs from working altogether if he wanted to do afford her a particularly pitiful end.

Diallo laughed. "Now why would I do that when pulling your strings is such an easy and inviting thing to do?" He two-stepped away from her with a flourish of his arms, looking every much a kid dancing in a candy store with glee. "Poor s-s-stuttering Diallo needs your help d-decoding a secret data drive. Only y-you can help, Catra. Don't you want to make Taline p-p-proud of you?"

Catra bared her teeth. "Fuck. You."

"Can you believe I almost dropped my guard on more than one occasion because I was having so much fun with you?" He sounded like he was recounting some old, comraderie-building story with a friend the way he spoke. "I must admit, part of my dragging things out with you is because I felt robbed. Taline was always an especially tough case. I was about ready to write her off completely, certain I'd get nowhere if the years I spent in her presence had no tangible consequences aside from nightmares. It was a surprise when the pressure finally got to her and she ran off.

"You, on the other hand? I'm shocked you never realized it sooner. All the sleepless nights? All the dreaming terrors that grew worse every time we spoke instead of going away like they normally did? Not once did you think maybe there was something else at play?"

He shrugged. “Well, maybe that’s expecting too much of you. After all, Taline complained of the same thing and never put two and two together. And she had years over you.”

"She's not going to let you get away with this," Catra said. "Once she finds out what you are, she will come for you. She'll put an end to you as she did to the countless other infestations she culled in the past."

“Once she finds out what I am? Oh, poor baby. It’s far too late.” He folded his arms. “Archanas is reawakening, and once it is done, the Barrier shall fall. There is a node not too far from here, you know? Short work for my new fleet in space. When I destroy it, I will flood into this reality untethered once more. With the Shapers gone and the galaxy far more complacent than it was years ago, no one—not even Taline—will have the strength to stop me.”

“She’s going to turn you inside out and burned you to atoms, that’s what will happen.”

“You look up to her. It’s endearing and pathetic because it blinds you.” He scoffed. “And, of all people, she cherishes you, someone so easily swayed by their emotions and their baggage and their trauma. Someone holding you in high regard isn’t deserving of half the idolization she receives.”

He pulled back, blinking in feigned surprise. “Oh, you didn’t know? You are her weakness, after all. Years of plying at her defenses trying to break her down and it’s *you* that did her in, exposing enough of herself she succumbed to paranoia. Pathetic.”

Catra decided to keep her mouth shut. Nothing she could say would make a difference anyway, and she was just playing into his desire to toy with her. Maybe if she shut up and deprived him of the satisfaction, he'd end this agony sooner.

“You don’t believe me, do you?” Diallo asked. “Oh, how I wish she were still here. Seeing the look on her face as I used you against

her, watching that steadfast, self-righteous look she'd always have crumble as I break you—that would have been pure ecstasy. Shame she left you here all alone, but no matter."

Keren and Trayn, who'd been jerkily making their way to them from the front of the room for the duration of Diallo's occupation, stopped before them. Fear was written plain on their faces; he hadn't enthralled them, yet.

"The mind is a brittle thing, it's will, easy to fracture," Diallo said. "I will show you."

He stepped between them and threw his arms across both their shoulders, like one greeted friends they hadn't seen in a while. At once, both of them jolted like they were stricken with a thousand volts of electricity. It seemed he'd chosen to work on them before her. Catra couldn't with full honesty say that was preferable.

"Leave them alone!" she said.

Catra seethed as anger. She met both their eyes trying to instill a sense of confidence in them, or at least reassurance they wouldn't endure whatever Diallo was about to do alone.

Within moments, their fear had taken hold of hers and ratcheted it to new heights. What could she even do? They were an arm span away and she couldn't so much as reach out and touch them. She was useless.

"Ah, there it is," Diallo said, although he seemed irritated rather than accomplished. "One little push is all it takes. How quick that fire of yours snuffs out. Almost too quick. Perhaps I will maintain you like this until I have Taline successfully cornered this time. That will at least allow me to draw this out to a satisfying length."

As Keren and Trayn began to seize and their eyes rolled into the backs of their heads, a floor opened up beneath Catra, plunging her into despair and hopelessness. Diallo's threats against Taline and his threats to prolong her suffering rang hollow. She wasn't

even afraid anymore, just empty and ready to be filled with whatever made his thralls.

*"Catra!"*

Pip's voice rang in her head, and Catra almost laughed through her nose because of it. Was this what her last moments were to be? Hallucinating Pip's voice telling her…telling her what, exactly?

*"Hallucinating? Oh, I'll show you hallucinating when this is over and I get my hands on you. I'm gone for five minutes and this is what you get yourself into?"*

She was…angry with her? No, there was real fear in her voice, too. It was shaking. Pip had never been angry like this at her, before, and she'd never sounded outright scared before either. Both at the same time was an odd thing for Diallo to put into her head to torment her.

Pip materialized in front of her. A handful of inches tall, but none of the innocent naivety in her face Catra had gotten used to seeing. This Pip seemed older in the way she carried herself—no less fun-loving and impish than usual but twice as dangerous because of it. And right now, hands on her hips and a severe frown on her face, she looked ready to burn the planet to ash with the fire in her eyes.

::Pip…you're—::

"We do not have time for question and answer," Pip said. "I did not reconstitute myself and then painstakingly patch up the holes in the Barrier just to watch all of you die the moment I'd finished. I need you to focus."

Focus? Focus on what? Diallo was mouthing off, still monologuing in the background even though Pip now filled all her senses. It was too late.

::You were gone,:: she said, swallowing the thick lump in her throat as regret came. ::I'm sorry for what I said to you earlier. I…

I shouldn’t have…::

Pip rolled her eyes, although instead of annoyance there was panicked urgency in her expression when she focused on Catra again. “You’re not the only one that needs to apologize” she said. “I had to take care of some things, but it doesn’t change how I left you here to deal with this. Apologies can come later. Right now, we need to act. It’s not too late.”

::I can’t even move.:: Catra tried again. Her index finger down at her side twitched, but that was all, and the rest of her was still wrapped in Diallo’s tendrils while he droned on and her friends continued to convulse.

“You aren’t even trying!”

Pip gave a derisive gesture, implying with her tone that Catra was like some lazy teenager who didn’t want to clean their room. But rather than lighting an indignant fire under her like she suspected Pip was going for, it only confused her. She was in the clutches of an Abomination—one that was about to reawaken the very planet that nearly cost the empire the war a decade prior. What could she do other than shrug?

Actually, she couldn’t even do that…

Diallo’s arm phased through her when he gestured, still speaking, and Pip groaned at the ceiling.

“I swear I am going to give you so much shit when this is all over, so you aren’t allowed to die,” Pip said. “This better force your ass into gear.”

Catra was about to ask what she meant by that, but she fizzled out of sight, only for floating, two-inch tall hallucinations of Scorpia and Entrapta to replace her.

“Hi!” the both of them said together.

Catra realized right away what she was looking at: it was their first recording to her since leaving home, still on the ancient PDA still strapped to Catra's forearm—the same recording she'd never mustered the courage to watch out of fear of growing too emotional over it.

Entrapta gestured with her hair tendrils. "So, we're kind of recording a lot of this one last minute since apparently, you may be leaving tomorrow."

Scorpia wiped at teary eyes with a claw. "We just wanted to say that we're going to miss you and you can bet your bottom dollar we're going to be sending you tons of messages every chance we get. You'd better do the same."

Entrapta nodded, a strange shimmer in her eyes that complimented her manic smile differently than Scorpia's.

"You'd better not forget about your pals back on Etheria," Scorpia said. "What with all the awesome adventures we know you'll have out in space, all the places you'll see, and—"

"And all the cool tech you'll run into," Entrapta said, bouncing in place. "Agh, I'm so jealous! You *have* to tell us about everything."

"Especially the tech, right?" Scorpia asked.

"*Especially* the tech."

Scorpia laughed and slung her arm around Entrapta the same way Diallo had with Keren and Trayn, except she pulled Entrapta in for a cozy side hug. "Whatever you do out there, Wildcat, be safe. We'll be rooting for you."

They both waved and fizzled out. The oversaturated control room came back into focus along with Diallo, who was looking at her with a peculiar expression, head cocked.

"I'm sorry, was I boring you?" he asked, not sounding sorry at all. He gestured to the room, at the listless thralls and still-ensnared

staffers and analysts they'd brought, and to Keren and Trayn who were new frothing at the mouth. "You didn't forget how this is all thanks to you, did you?

An odd feeling welled up in Catra. Diallo was one of the most powerful, malicious beings in the galaxy, and when she looked upon him, she still felt terror. But now there was something else. Elation. Warmth blossoming in her chest. The apeiron crystal burned against her skin once more and Catra wondered when she'd stopped noticing its effect to begin with.

"My original plan was quite different, you see," Diallo said. "The various Edens scattered about have made decent progress with their research thanks to my influence. Breaking their goddess' hold on them as I did here was a pain, but it still would have taken years more work before they were reliably producing more of me at scale.

"Those Abominations they create now are nothing but pale imitations, unable to connect to me. Even that natural-born on Scavria was nothing but a fledgling."

It hit her a moment after: she wasn't struck useless with fear any longer. The entire time she'd spoken to Pip and watched Entrapta and Scorpia's message to her, she'd been unaware of Diallo. As deep in mortal danger as she still was—as scared as she still was—Catra's mind was her own once more.

The realization was liberating, and a burst of encouragement came from Pip deep inside her psyche.

Diallo gripped her under the chin with rough fingers and forced her to look at him. He stared down his nose at her, scrutinizing and unforgiving. Catra guessed he could sense his hold over her having slipped, and when he spoke, she confirmed her suspicions.

"There is no escape for you," he said. "Wresting back control of your emotions while your body is still subordinate to my whims? All it would take is pain and your mind would succumb to me once

again. You do realize this, don't you? Although, I shall not complain about a challenge."

He grinned, showing rows of pointed teeth that Catra had never seen him wear before.

"Do you think Taline would fare as well as you once caught in my web? On first thought I'd assume she would, judging by how she shrugged off the majority of my influence over the years. It might be fun to…break her over a long, *long* period of time. Break you both, together.

"But part of me wonders if she'd just crumble immediately, like a dam suddenly bursting open once the tiniest of cracks manifests in its wall. It was truly pathetic how she ran off thinking she was about to finally face her demons."

Diallo pursed his lips like he was considering something. "What do you think ran through her head when she arrived at Phoenix and found no sight of her precious Corynth anywhere at all? Do you think she despaired when she realized she ran off and left you all alone because her mind was playing tricks on her again? Do you think she felt embarrassed thinking about seeing you again having to apologize?" He scoffed. "Perhaps the shock of learning what transpired here might break her spirit before I ever get to her."

Catra found another foothold to grab onto. Diallo wasn't omniscient or omnipotent. An incredibly powerful eldritch horror that had managed to evade even Taline for years right under her nose, sure, but he thought Corynth didn't exist—that Taline ran off because he'd gotten the better of her at last.

He didn't know Adora sent her a private message outright confirming he was still alive. He could be wrong! And with that realization, Catra no longer viewed him as some all-powerful being that was impossible to escape from. If he was fallible, then he could be fought. He could be defeated.

Slowly, agonizingly, Catra brought her arm up and gripped Diallo's wrist where he still held her chin in his hands. Both his eyebrows shot up.

"Well, well," he said. "Color me impressed. It seems you do have a strong enough will to resist after all. It makes no difference." He made no move to extricate her hand or punish her for her defiance. "How many times must I say it? You are *mine.*"

"You're wrong."

Catra had friends that loved her and sent her messages every month for years ever since the first. She had friends she made after leaving home—friends that would follow her here of all places and help when she was struggling.

Catra had a mentor who had believed in her and left her in charge of an incredibly sensitive assignment on a historical dead world. Taline hadn't abandoned her, she'd raced to confront a nightmare that had plagued her for more than a decade.

And Catra had Adora. After all these years, she'd finally heard from her again, and she'd be damned if she succumbed without a fight to some world eating parasite without finding out if she was still alive or not.

Diallo leaned closer, his face right next to Entrapta's ancient PDA still strapped to Catra's arm as she gripped his wrist. "What was that?"

"I said you're *wrong*. Taline isn't standing on Phoenix looking for someone who doesn't exist, she's found him. And if you can be wrong about that, then you can be wrong about other things."

She swallowed and tried to adjust in his grip, tried to hold onto his wrist tighter. "I might be easily swayed by my emotions and my baggage and my trauma like you say, but if you think you're going to have an easy time exploiting me because of it then you have another thing coming."

Catra forced her other arm up, fighting through Diallo's near-indomitable will with Pip's phantom help. With clumsy fingers, she smacked the touchscreen of her PDA twice in a row, activating a shortcut for a function she'd never had to use nor expected to since first programming it in.

Entrapta's flashlight ticked on, set to its highest setting. Diallo released her and reared back, screaming when it blinded him, and even Catra had to stagger back blinking away stars the way the entire room whited out.

"The door!" Pip screamed in her head the moment Catra got free and shut the light off. "They're on the other side waiting. The door, Catra! You must open the door!"

The apeiron seared her it was so hot against her body. Catra reeled from it. Diallo cursed and thrashed about steps away from her—his hold over her was completely broken.

*I can feel the presence of this crystal should I concentrate on it. And were it to break, I'd be able to lock onto its position in an instant*.

Taline's words echoed in her head.

*If you are to become my Sentinel, I want you to have this. I want to know at all times that I can come to your aid should you ever need it.*

"I told you back on the ship," Catra said, heaving while Diallo clawed at his face, black ooze dripping down where his nails broke alien flesh. "I told you if you'd ever touched me again, I'd give you a legitimate reason to have a stutter for the rest of your life."

She yanked the cord around her neck until the apeiron popped out from under her shirt, then palmed it in a closed fist, ignoring how it set her whole arm aflame with pain.

"I intend to keep that promise."

She squeezed until the crystal shattered in her grip. The room whited out again as light even brighter than Entrapta's flashlight exploded from her hand. Catra squinted and shaded her eyes, feeling oddly weightless and floaty. The burning heat from the apeiron had snuffed out the moment she shattered it, but a new one blossomed, strong and steady and growing like a furnace in front of her.

Catra had wondered before what shattering the apeiron would do. The one Taline broke years ago had saved them from Horde Prime's wrath while condemning her and Glimmer and Adora to years of off-again on-again nightmares. Judging by how hot that new heat source was growing, the only inkling she got for this one was that it unleashed some sort of miniature star.

Slowly, the white of the room gave way to shapes and colors once more, and what she saw was far from where even the wildest reaches of her imagination had taken her.

Two great serpents of fire snaked and twined their way around the room, curling about Catra and Keren and Trayn and engulfing many of the thralls Diallo had turned, devouring them in single gulps. Two Pips—one she recognized and another wearing a different style of dress—stood each at the height of a full person, holding both hands out as if controlling the serpents directly.

A third figure stood between the two, eerily similar to both, and yet, different. Their eyes made them seem older. All knowing.

*I've spent hours upon hours meditating on this apeiron.* Taline's words to her from before now seemed to echo from everywhere and from nowhere at once. *Both to pay penance and to honor her memory. All that remains of her now are the memories, thoughts, and emotions of an older sister who didn't deserve her.*

Evelyn stepped forward and took both her hands in her own. Catra marveled at the sensation—she was real. Tangible. And when Evelyn brought Catra's hands up to kiss her fingertips, eyes

flashing and ley lines igniting over her skin, it was like immersing them in cold fire.

"I bestow this gift upon you," Evelyn said, smiling in a way that reminded Catra of the benevolent looks many of the statues on Phoenix had when they portrayed their subjects as near-divine. "With this, the final die is cast. May it give you the power to protect those you love."

Evelyn released her and faded to nothing. The two Pips on either side of her combined into one before similarly disappearing. Catra expected the fire serpents to go with them, but they remained. Instead, the rest of the room came into focus as the lingering brightness from the apeiron dimmed, and she saw who the serpents' true puppeteers were.

Taline and Corynth—*the* Corynth, mask and all—stood in the center of a smoldering rune burned into the floor, so enormous its outer flanges reached the far walls of the control room. They worked in tandem, moving with large, sweeping gestures and wide, planted feet, mirroring one another.

Between them stood Adora, sword in hand, eyes of saturated starlight, concentrated magic curling off her silhouette like smoke. She looked nothing like the preoccupied, stressed individual Catra had last seen. It wasn't She Ra, not a full transformation. It was Adora, her Adora, looking more in control and sure of herself than the picture Glimmer had painted of her weeks ago.

Catra sank to her knees, exhausted as Taline and Corynth turned to face Diallo, staring at them with unadulterated hatred between the fingers of a hand he still held clasped to his face.

Help had come. And not a moment too soon.

**End of Part Four**

Chapter End Notes

Whew, I've held onto some of those plot devices for a while. The apeiron Taline gave Catra was an obvious one, but Entrapta and Scorpia's recording to Catra had been sitting there for a while, and Entrapta's flashlight was brought out all the way back in part 1 (and reused periodically throughout part 2 and 3). I'm a sucker for my Chekhov's guns :) Also, those fire serpents have appeared before as well. I've made a big effort to have everything the characters do in the final part already be introduced from a worldbuilding perspective in a previous chapter.

That's a wrap for part 4! Over 300k words and 60 chapters, thank you to everyone still reading and enjoying (and especially people commenting this deep in the story, too). Writing and editing this has been great, and getting to share it for others to enjoy is wonderful.

Chapters for the final part will go up starting in November--I need a handful of weeks to rebuild my proofreading buffer. In the meantime, I plan on releasing the first draft iterations of parts 1-4 in the coming weeks with author's commentary. If that's something you're interested in seeing--how drastically a story can shift over the course of 6-7 drafts and what thought processes went into certain editing decision--then be on the lookout for it. Otherwise, I shall see you soon for the finale to World Eater!

# Part V: New Unity, Chapter 61: Diamond Shoals

Chapter Notes

Wow, looks like I was premature saying this would come out within a month back in October of last year! As I've discovered twice now with the editing process, you might think you're done even after 6 drafts, but let a manuscript settle for some time and you will surely find plenty of room for improvement once you revisit. This final part of the story has gone through another deep revision since I posted the final chapter of part 4. Along with the final proofread pass, that means this story is up to 8 revisions.

Sorry for the wait. I think the extra time I took to really hone the finale to this behemoth story was well worth it, though, and my hope is that translates into an epic reading experience for you! I'm super excited to finally be posting these chapters, so I'll stop here, put a quick synopsis catch-up below, and let y'all get to the story!

***

After infiltrating Phoenix station, rebuilding Corynth's version of Pip, and at last fully sealing the Barrier keeping the Beast back, Corynth and Adora fought Taline. With an intervention from her sister beyond the grave, they set aside their differences (for now?) to tackle a bigger looming threat.

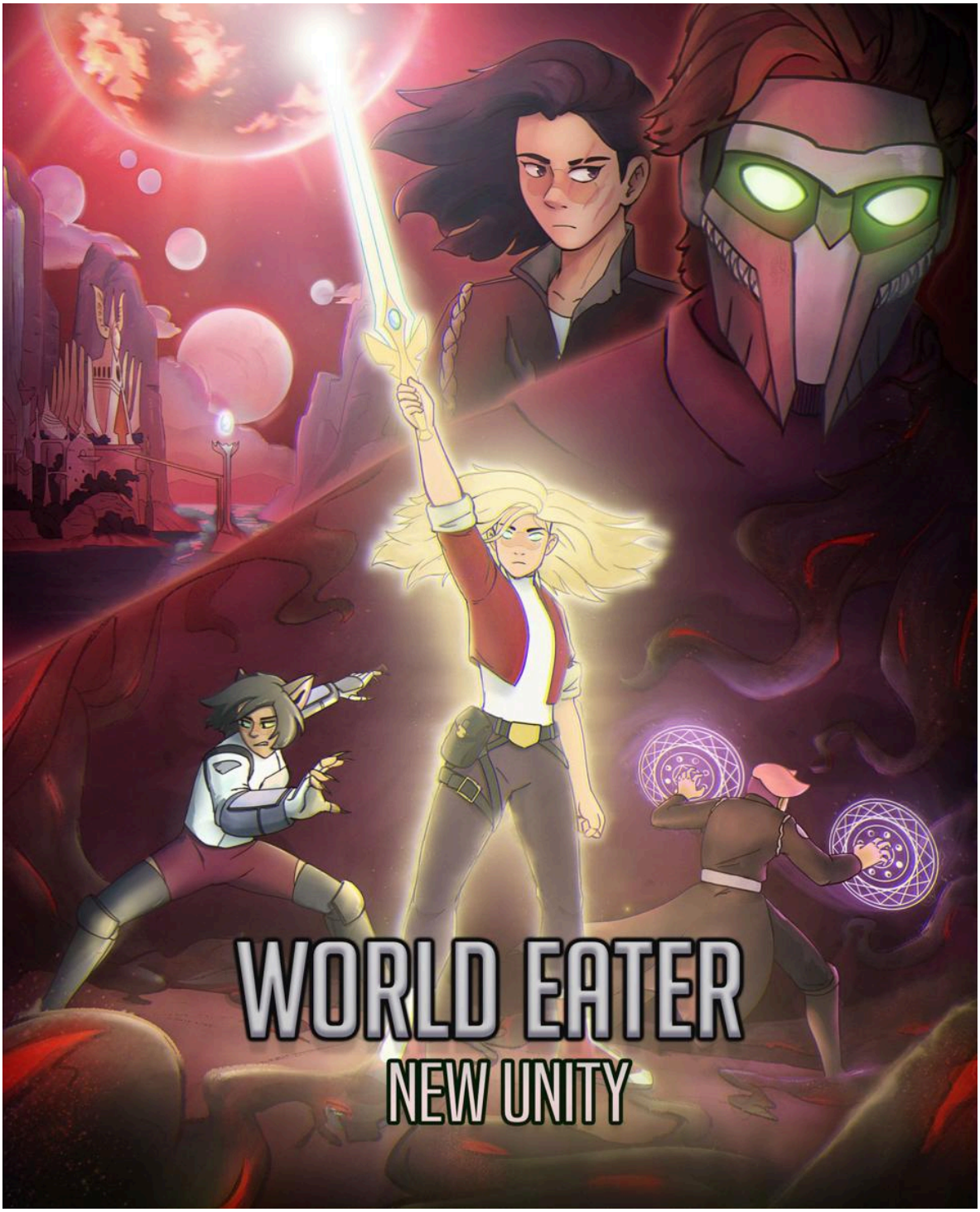
Catra--having travelled with Taline to a Vestamid mining compound on the dead world Archanas, site of the final battle in the previous Beast war--stumbled into a trap the moment she left to confront Corynth. Diallo, the shifty stuttering System Governor revealed himself to be an Abomination disguised as Taline's friend for the past 10 years. With him finally given access to the quarantined planet, he revealed himself as a Beat Abomination and began to reawaken

Archanas itself, to continue the war from its stopping point years earlier and finish devouring the galaxy.

Glimmer, after successfully rescuing Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle from certain death on Scavria, responded with half of the Scavrian fleet to an emergency SOS broadcast from Taline's ship, the Constable, over orbit on Archanas. When they arrived, they found the Constable overrun with Beast thralls, only to get hit with an infection beam themselves from Archanas' surface. The last we saw from her, she was moments away from evacuating the flagship with her team before it exploded.

Now, after Catra successfully fought off the Archanan Abomination's hold long enough to call for help, Taline, Corynth, and Adora appeared via teleportation rune to come to her rescue.

See the end of the chapter for more notes




Art commission done by SzethK. Linktree: [Here]

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## Chapter Sixty-One: Diamond Shoals

Smoke lifted from the teleportation rune under Adora's feet. Sword of Protection in hand, she shielded her face from an inferno

swirling around the room: the twin fire snakes ate whatever thralls they came across as they danced, and Adora thought her face would melt from the heat.

Corynth and Taline moved together, controlling them.

"Smoother motions," Corynth said over the roar. "You're guiding the flames but they have a mind of their own. Force them to go where they don't want to and they'll turn on you, next."

Taline grunted and her movements smoothed to match his. Sweat poured down her face, soaking her undershirt where it peeked through her unbuttoned, ruined uniform jacket.

Catra kneeled a dozen paces away, glassy-eyed, next to two unmoving bodies.

"Go to her," Taline said, just as Adora was starting to wonder if she was a heat mirage. "Keep her safe."

Corynth gave a sharp twist of his wrist and one of the snakes turned, doubling back on itself to swallow more thralls. "We'll take care of the Abomination," he said, as Adora noticed the one figure both snakes seemed to avoid: a tall, rail-thin man with blackened sclera, gazing at them through the heat waves with malice.

"Go!"

Adora didn't need to be told a third time. She bolted as the Abomination rushed in to engage Corynth and Taline, black arachnoid tendrils sprouting from its back. She called to Catra, sliding to a stop on her knees in front of her, the sword clattering to the ground beside them. She grabbed Catra's shoulders and shook her. Something had wrung her neck, hard, judging by the noose-like imprint around her throat. "Can you hear me?" she said. "It's me! It's Adora!"

The serpents coiled around again before snuffing out together, the last dredges of their fire casting a choreographed interplay of light and shadow across the room before that too disappeared. Adora

hooked a hand under Catra's chin and turned her head toward her, but Catra's eyes were still glazed over and unseeing. For a moment, she feared they had come too late—feared the Abomination already worked her to the point she wasn't herself anymore.

Then, Catra's eyes focused. Not on Adora, but past her. Before she could see what caught her attention, Catra grabbed the sword forgotten next to them on the floor and vaulted over her shoulder, a feral roar tearing from her.

Adora scrambled to her feet in time to see Catra launch the sword overhead with two hands. It sailed through the air spinning, until lodging itself into another thrall and sticking into the ground, hoisting the thrall chest up and limbs dangling in the air like it had been impaled as a warning to others. Adora winced at the brutality, then wondered how Corynth and Taline's snakes had missed eating the thrall in the first place.

And when she took another look, there were a great many thralls the snakes had missed. The room was crawling fresh with them—seemingly more than there were when they first teleported into the room. Where the hell had they all come from? Corynth had told both her and Taline before they teleported in the snakes wouldn't disappear until every single one was ash.

She got her answer the next moment: several of the far doors leading into the control room had opened, letting fresh thralls pour through. Worse still, Corynth and Taline seemed unaware of it, locked in pitched battle as they were grappling with the Abomination. Luminous magic and dark rotting tendrils clashed, devastating the surrounding installments.

"What the hell are you doing?" Catra said, sparing Adora a glance over her shoulder as she raced to intercept the thralls. "Don't gawk, you idiot, protect them! We're all dead if they don't take the Abomination down."

Adora watched mouth agape as Catra leapt, twisted midair into a barrel roll, hooked her arms and legs around the necks of four thralls, then jerked. A *snap* drowned everything else out, their necks broken, and each thralls collapsed to the floor before Catra landed, graceful on all fours.

She kept her momentum, transitioning into a forward handspring, leaping and dodging between bodies until reaching the head of them, where she refused to give ground or let any pass her by. She fought so swiftly Adora couldn't see Catra herself so much as the light her claws reflected as she mowed countless bodies down.

Corynth and Taline were still facing the Abomination, struggling to keep it pinned to a wall and avoid its attacks. It was only Catra standing between them and the flood threatening to take them by surprise.

Adora scrambled forward on both hands and knees, yanking the sword free from the chest of the thrall Catra had embedded it in. With a feral scream of her own, she raced to Catra's aid, swinging and cleaving through bodies. The floor and surrounding consoles were coated with blood and viscera.

Together, they held back the thralls. It helped that they fought like mindless husks; all instinct and no strategy meant they were easy to cut down and only dangerous because of their numbers. A voice in the back of Adora's mind warned her she was being overconfident, however—that she could cut down a hundred, a thousand, or even more, but eventually she'd tire, and the Beast would have countless millions more to throw at her and Catra.

One thrall slipped past Adora, and that thrall was one too many for Catra, who was already juggling eight together. It didn't stop her from trying to catch Adora's slack, though, and when Catra tried to handle a ninth, everything fell apart. Within moments dozens had made it past their guard, scrambling over one another to reach Corynth and Taline.

“Oh!” Catra said, jumping out of the way before she got bowled over. “Oh, *shit.* Watch out!”

Taline struggled to bind the dozens of tendrils sprouted from the Abomination’s back while Corynth, lit through with magic, wrestled the rest of him into submission with ephemeral chains of white fire. It looked like he was trying to eat this one the same way he ate the Abomination on Eden, and was having a much harder time of it.

The thralls reached them, with Taline leaning back far enough the closest thrall swiped at her and slashed the side of her uniform instead. She released the Abomination, ducking another blow as she reached forth fast as a striking snake, grabbing that thrall by their head with splayed fingers like she was palming a ball. Her eyes flashed. A jolt of energy coursed from her shoulder down her arm. That thrall and all the others that had rushed with it exploded, spraying blood like popped water balloons.

When she turned to reengage the Abomination, Corynth broke off instead. He ducked and weaved the tendrils Taline had released, each of them trying to impale him.

“We’re done!” he said, as he parried another blow. He wrapped an arm around Taline’s waist to physically pull her away from touching the Abomination again. “Our window is gone.”

Something knocked into Adora from the side hard enough it punched all the air out her lungs and sent her to the floor. She had her wits about her enough to recover from the shock, rolling to a crouch the moment she realized what had happened, but that meant she came too close to comfort nearly slicing Catra open—it was her who had knocked her sideways.

“What the hell are you doing?” Catra said, resting all her weight on Adora’s chest and meeting her look of shock with anger. “Twice I’ve had to ask you that, now. We’re in the middle of a fight and you’re just staring? Are you *trying* to get killed?”

Catra heaved both their bodies to the side before Adora had a chance to respond, rolling them across the floor. The rotted, clawed hand of another thrall struck where they'd been laying, splintering the tile.

Adora had gotten distracted. She'd let her thoughts carry her away, let the enemy exploit the crack in their defense, then practically spaced out, after. If Catra hadn't literally tackled her out of the way just then…

A dozen more thralls set upon them both, still sprawled out together on the floor. Catra tried to springboard up, but couldn't manage it. Instead, she evaded their attacks, but couldn't find her footing fast enough before they pushed her back down on top of Adora. And despite Adora doing everything she could parrying blows from the ground and slicing more ankles than she could count, they were slowly suffocating. For every one thrall Adora felled, three more piled onto them, like a hydra.

Flashes of being overrun by security bots in her castle came back to her. And judging by the shouting and screeching of magic clashing in the distance, she didn't think Corynth had the freedom to come to her aid like last time. Not while it was likely he and Taline were doing all they could as it was to keep the Abomination contained.

One thrall came into view above them, then flew violently out of sight as if a wrecking ball smashed into it. The sound of a shotgun blast accompanied it, blowing Adora's ears out.

An arm—as thick as a tree trunk and covered in striated, bony plate—pushed through the bodies that had piled up on Adora and Catra. It reached down to grab for them, and Adora nearly chopped it off with the sword until she saw Catra turn from her perch on top of her chest to grab the arm. It lifted them both out of the muck and set them on their feet. Adora had to concentrate to keep the world from spinning.

"—believe you're still alive!" Adora heard Catra say, once the ringing in her hears began to subside. "Both of you?"

Catra's gaze turned downrange, where a large alien-looking woman wielding a shotgun blasted one of the few thralls still standing. It seemed like most had piled onto Adora and Catra on the floor and were already dead.

"I thought he turned you," Catra said.

The armor-plated giant shook his head. "He said he was going to make us watch him turn you, first. It still wasn't pleasant." He turned to Adora with a questioning look.

"Adora," she said. "I'm Adora."

Surprise flashed across his features. Adora was surprised she could read them. "I'm Trayn," he said, then gestured to the woman with the shotgun, who was now pummeling one final thrall in the head with it like a bat. "That's Keren."

"Do I still get an IOU if we aren't in the same department anymore?" Keren asked, shouting over her shoulder as if having her name called had summoned a response.

"You can have ten for all I care," Catra said, shouting back at her. "We'll do another eating contest at that waffle joint next to the precinct, and I'll pay. We just need to make it out of here alive, first."

That pulled a laugh out of Keren and Trayn, and sent a heavy feeling dropping like a stone into Adora's stomach. Feelings she refused to name or examine. How quickly Catra could go from rightfully raking her over the coals for making a mistake to…what, exactly? Bantering with two friends she was happy to see alive? Good friends, by how comfortable they sounded talking to each other during a pitched battle.

Why had Keren mentioned IOU's like they were an inside joke? And how many eating contests had they done together for Catra

to bring it up as incentive like that?

Adora hadn't realized she'd yet again stopped paying attention to her surroundings until a shrill laugh cut through the air. Goosebumps erupted across her body, and she turned in time to see Corynth throw a magic-infused punch hard enough into the Abomination's side he pierced his abdomen.

Something didn't seem right. He pushed Taline clear out of the way just as the Abomination exploded into millions of swirling, glittering pieces—like a precious stone atomized and caught in a vortex.

"Shaper, risen from the dead," it said, its voice howling in the artificial wind ripping through the room. "You have failed to do away with me twice, now. You shall not get a third such opportunity."

The pieces traced a wide arc in the air, its mass growing as the countless thrall corpses littering the control room similarly turned to sparkling ash and joined with it.

"You have made a mockery of my plans, returning here. I shall finish what you started, and welcome you into my collective like I did your brothers and sisters. Join the World Eater, and together we shall devour the galaxy."

Its voice echoed, a final, ringing warning as it thinned until disappearing into the atmosphere like smoke. Everything stilled, tension keeping everyone in the room on alert, listening for any abnormal sound in case it telegraphed the Abomination's return. Corynth broke the spell, lowering his arms and nearly toppling to the floor from exhaustion.

Taline darted forward to catch him, only for him to instead turn and catch her when her legs gave out. Catra was there with her the next moment, having left Adora's side. When Taline regained her footing, she pulled Catra into a fierce embrace which she

returned, gripping hard at the back of Taline's ruined uniform jacket.

Adora stopped short a few steps away, having been hot on Catra's heels. That heavy feeling in her stomach deepened until she couldn't ignore it anymore. She hated how this of all things was what demanded her attention and muddied her judgement.

Catra had never let anyone but Adora hug her before. And even then, when they were kids, it was always an uphill battle getting even that. Seeing Catra so openly hug another person like that? A lot could change in three years, but still. This felt like a lot of change.

Adora looked away when she heard they started whispering to one another, Taline in a trembling voice and Catra with stalwart reassurance. It would be a gross overstep to overhear their conversation even accidentally, and Adora didn't want to spend another second looking at them hold each other like that, either. She felt like a coward.

Was there even room for her anymore? She'd reached out, intent on trying to patch things up if Catra would let her, but…was there even room for her? Did it even make sense to reconnect after all this time? Maybe they'd drifted too far apart, already.

Keren and Trayn were stalking the ruins of the control room, hunting for ammunition and more weapons. Trying to distract herself watching them proved fruitless.

The screens at the front of the room blinked on. Most of them were damaged, displaying only static or a warped rainbow of colors, but Adora didn't care: she was glad for something new to focus on.

Numerous copies of Pip appeared on the handful of still functioning screens. It was surprising how recognizably different this version of her was compared to the recording of Evie back on Phoenix.

"Sorry the doors took so long," Pip said to everyone. "Took me a second to isolate this room and kick Diallo out so I could have full control of it. You did a good job with the extra thralls he brought in in the meantime, though."

No wonder they'd stopped flooding in all of a sudden. Pip had sealed them out.

"Better late than never," Corynth said. There was anger simmering in his tone through the mask, although Adora didn't think it was directed at Pip. "I need a full situation report. Anything and everything you can tell me. We need to plan our next move."

Pip scrunched her face in concentration. "Give me a minute to comb through everything, there's a lot here. Diallo is still blocking me out of most things in the compound outside this room as it stands."

She glanced at Catra, and Adora swore something unspoken passed between them with that look—like a complex conversation exchanging hands in the blink of an eye. Her suspicions only grew when Catra looked between Taline and Corynth with knit brows, shrugged, then stalked off toward Keren and Trayn in the back, muttering under her breathe. Her steps slowed when, by accident, she caught Adora watching her, only to shrug her off and speed away as if she hadn't noticed in the first place.

Adora hated to admit it even to herself, but seeing that drove the stake of jealousy and envy deeper in her chest. She had been unable to read Catra as well as she used to, and even now after locking eyes with her, she had no idea what was going through her head. Where would she even begin to start bridging the enormous gulf between them?

She decided to bother Corynth, instead. Pester him about a plan, find something she could give her whole attention to. It was agonizing and stupid how jealous she was, and Adora was disappointed in herself with how strongly the feeling had grabbed

her when they had more important things to worry about. Like not dying.

Corynth was standing with Taline before one of the last functioning control consoles. Taline's chest heaved with every breath she took, while Corynth, for contrast, seemed perfectly fine. The fact he could appear this way despite Adora knowing he was still recovering scared her. She couldn't anticipate his needs or be there for him the way Catra could be there for Taline if she couldn't tell when and how bad he was struggling.

Adora faltered when she realized Corynth and Taline were having a private conversation, too. One that they wanted to exclude her from, judging by how Taline paused long enough to glance at her approach, then pick up the conversation again at a faster clip and more urgent whisper.

This time, Adora didn't feel generous enough to give them privacy, but Taline cut off all the same, giving her a forced smile when she got close enough. It reminded Adora of someone getting caught doing something they weren't supposed to.

"I'll just let you two, uhm…" Taline looked away, downrange. "Yeah." She gave Corynth one more meaningful look, then shuffled off, her foot scraping the floor with every third step, shoulders bowed in exhaustion.

Adora watched her go, skeptical, before turning back to Corynth with her eyebrows raised. "So, you two are all chummy now? Just like that?"

She regretted those words the moment she said them. Corynth paused what he was doing for only a moment, but it wasn't hard to imagine what kind of expression he gave her even if it was hidden behind his mask.

"Sorry," she said. "I don't know why I said it like that. It's just…" She looked back and saw Taline talking with Catra and Keren while Trayn continued to pick through the debris nearby. Catra's

ears flicked and swiveled as they talked. She looked elated despite the ordeal they'd just gone through. Were still going through.

Taline said something that made Catra laugh. She covered her mouth, tip of her tail crooked to the side, and bumped hips with Taline in response. It seemed *too* familiar, and it made Adora bristle.

"The Abomination is growing stronger by the second," Corynth said under his breath, drawing her attention back. It was only when Adora looked at him she realized he wasn't talking to her. He was leaned over the console, studying the display. He shook his head. "This was your plan? Luring it here and springing me on it once it showed its hand early? What the hell, Evie?"

This was awkward. Adora didn't have enough history with Taline's sister to feel comfortable saying much about her. She shuffled her feet and cleared her throat. "That Abomination sure sounded angry when it escaped."

"It wasn't expecting me," Corynth said. "As powerful as it is, it isn't really omniscient. Seeing me again probably gave it a scare, since it likely thought me long dead the same as everyone else."

Imagining the Beast or any of its offshoots feeling fear just didn't seem right, for some reason. "This one won't go down as smoothly as the one on Eden, huh?" she asked. "It seemed to be giving you and Taline both a hard time back there."

"It's been incubating for over a decade, Adora. Whoever's body it possessed died long ago, it having been biding its time in their skin instead. And it's just unleashed itself on the most potent dead world in the galaxy. The fact we sealed the Barrier might not even matter anymore."

Corynth had nearly died after eating the Eden Abomination, and the fact he choked on the verge of beating Taline proved what little rest they'd taken on the way to Phoenix meant no matter how put together he seemed now, it was only an act. And if this

Abomination on Archanas was older and stronger as Adora figured it was, what did that say for their chances at prevailing here?

"How are you doing?" she asked him in a low voice. "I know you're just pretending for the others. Even if we get a plan, how much longer can you keep going like this?"

Corynth paused over the console and looked at her. Adora held her breath anticipating his response, but Pip interrupted, reappearing on several of the damaged screens at the front of the room before he could answer.  Adora scowled at her, deflating.

"Alright," Pip said, drawing out the middle vowel in much too cavalier of an attitude. "I have control over most of the compound now. Still working on getting a full picture of things, but here's a start."

She disappeared from a cluster of screens, making room for them to instead display what looked like the remains of a decimated fleet in low orbit. Debris from several scuttled capital ships drifted like space dust, while half a dozen or more intact vessels floated listless and off-axis among them, veins of black and red threading through their hulls. Beast-turned ships.

Among the debris and converted warships, however, floated several more unblemished craft: Megaliths, defenseless gargantuan refugee ships, all burning away from the infected at speed. Dozens upon dozens of fighters were dogfighting among them.

"Standard reinforcements won't arrive in time to help." Corynth turned back to the console and started typing. A widget appeared on the forward screen and locked onto an empty sector of space. "Send a message through a secure ansible connection directly to Salas. Relay these coordinates to him."

Realization dawned on Adora. "Salas was your mole," she said, scarcely able to believe it. "He pretended to take Entrapta's investigation seriously, but he knew. It was him? The whole time?"

“The whole time,” Corynth said, nodding. “How else do you think I got away with it for so long?”

Adora could hear his smile in his voice through the mask. It was almost enough to defray some of her apprehension knowing he was just pretending he wasn’t pushing past his limits.

“Entrapta really did impress him,” he said. “When she found out what I was doing and presented evidence to him, he had to skip the Induction Ceremony that night because he was trying to come up with a convincing excuse to not blow our cover.”

“Hey, Boss,” Pip said, cutting in. “It’s really a mess up there. All the ships that weren’t destroyed have been taken over. The Megaliths look stable, but there’s only a handful of Warbirds defending them from an onslaught of Beast Interceptors that launched from this compound. I don’t know how much longer they can hold out.”

“Can you relay them the same coordinates you sent Salas? If the Warbirds can guard the Megaliths long enough for them to make it there, they’ll have a chance.”

Pip’s eyes glazed over a moment, then she came back.

“I’ll do you one better. One of the Warbirds is responding to my hail. And lucky for you, I think it’s the one leading the defense.” She gave him a grin and said, “Maybe you can turn on your classic Corynth charm and convince them yourself.”

Pip disappeared and another face replaced hers. One Adora wasn’t expecting to see given their current predicament.

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“Everyone, brace!”

Glimmer held tight to an overhead handrail inside the Warbird. She stood with feet planted wide, straddling the partition between the cockpit and the troop hold and straining against too many g-forces as Kyle fishtailed their craft through space. Several of the

soldiers behind Glimmer sitting in their bucket seats passed out just as Kyle pulled them out of the maneuver. Even Rogelio looked to be struggling.

They'd barely made it off the *Omen-Kador* before it scuttled. That was lucky, but Glimmer was anticipating that luck would soon run out given how few other Warbirds made it off the capital ships, and how many enemy vessels they were up against: Archanas had spit out hundreds of infected Interceptors from the surface. Glimmer, being the senior-most officer left among the survivors, had taken command of their dogfighting response.

They had already lost a handful of their forces burning out to meet the enemy, pushing their line of engagement closer to the planet and farther from the Megaliths. She'd split their dogfighting force into two groups, using one as bait while theirs carved around to take them from behind.

"The enemy fighters are still on Group A," Lonnie said from the copilot's seat. "Six of ours fell out of formation with that last turn and burn, twenty-three still tight with us."

"Don't wait for the six," Glimmer said, watching the red and green blips on Kyle's radar. "We need to push now before they get to the Megaliths."

"B Group, on my mark, paint your targets and engage," Kyle said into the mic attached to his headset. He calibrated the targeting computer. "A Group, call out those that fail to break off from your pursuit and we'll prioritize those in the next go around to get them off your back. All else, swing around and reinforce us, acknowledge."

Kyle gave the command and jerked the controls to one side, sending the Warbird through another maneuver Glimmer had to strain against to avoid blacking out. The blips on the radar indicating their two separate squadrons shifted in relation to the enemy. B Group kept close with them while A Group scattered far ahead.

Chatter exploded over the tactical radio keyed into all their headsets as both groups called out targets. A rough two-thirds of the enemy mob broke off their pursuit of A Group Warbirds to engage or evade the new attackers.

By the end of the maneuver, Kyle alone had taken out twelve, they'd lost nine, but routed the enemy—they were successful beyond even Lonnie's most optimistic prediction. The soldiers strapped into their Warbird's troop hold whooped and shouted, and Glimmer had to physically pull her headset off her ears to avoid going deaf with the celebrating happening over the radio.

They cut short as, one by one, the local area radar scans showed a change.

A sea of red encroached on their position, seeping toward them from the planet like the tide of an ocean racing up a beach. They weren't backed into any corners yet, but with no way to defeat an enemy that numerous and no hyperspace capabilities on either the Megaliths or the Warbirds, it was only a matter of time.

Where the hell did that many Interceptors come from? The planet was supposed to be desolate.

"The squad leaders are asking us for orders," Kyle said, tilting his head back to look at Glimmer over his seat's head rest. "What do you want to do?"

What could they do? Even stalling for as much time as possible seemed bleak; it would take at least an hour for the SOS she dispatched to reach the nearest garrison she knew of, and at least another hour over again for any sort of relief to transit through hyperspace and reach them. They wouldn't make it.

Lonnie, likely sensing that Glimmer was working through this in silence, gave sensible orders on her behalf. Within moments, their two fighter squads pulled back and regrouped among the Megaliths in something marginally more defensive to them than earlier.

“Are they…carving out a perimeter?” Kyle asked, staring at the sensor readings, watching the sea of red spread out as if trying to encircle them. “Don’t tell me they’re actually going to try and take the Megaliths instead of destroy them.”

“I have no idea what they’re trying to do,” Glimmer said. This was a completely new scenario to her. The Beast wasn’t supposed to have tactics. Hell, it wasn’t even supposed to have ships. The last time it had subverted a vessel was the war. “Whatever they’re trying, we can’t let them take the Megaliths. Scuttling the refugees would be preferable to letting the Beast convert hundreds of thousands of new bodies in space.” She swallowed. “It would be kinder, too.”

Lonnie sat forward when the screen drew her attention again. “There’s a hail for us. Coming from”—she squinted at the notification—“the planet’s surface? A mining compound near where that ion beam that struck the fleet originated.” She paused. “Why the hell is there a mining compound here?”

“Ignore it,” Glimmer said, similarly ignoring Lonnie’s question, since she had no answers. “Last thing we need is the Beast taunting us directly over the comms. The radiation emanating from the planet does that enough already.”

Lonnie tapped the reject button, then frowned when nothing happened. She tapped it again, then jammed her finger hard on the button a third time when the hail still wouldn’t go away. “It’s not letting me reject the request.”

A young woman with a pixie cut and freckles appeared on the overhead screen splitting the center of the cockpit. The fact she could override their rejection of her hail wasn’t the weirdest thing about her, however. The fact she glowed blue was way weirder.

“That hail was a courtesy, not a request,” they said.

Glimmer scowled at her. If the Beast was trying to play mental games with them, it sure was picking a strange way to do it.

“Identify yourself,” she said. “You are broadcasting directly from an active infection zone and I will—“

“Hello?” The woman stuck her face so close to the screen there was a clear view up her nostrils. “Hello, can you hear me?”

Glimmer huffed and straightened her back. “I can hear you. I am Glimmer, Battlemage of the Enclave and current commanding officer of the defending forces in orbit above this planet.” She was, what, a hundred people down the line of succession from Admiral Norognev after he perished with the *Omen-Kador*? That’s how bad their fleet had been gutted. “I have no idea who you are or how you are transmitting from the surface when it’s currently an active infection zone, but if you do not identify yourself immediately, I will terminate this connection.”

The woman pulled away from the camera and gave her such an exasperated look, Glimmer almost cut the call right there out of irritation.

“Alright Miss ‘Commanding Officer,’” she said. “How do you plan to cut our call if you couldn’t even decline it in the first place? I get that things are rough for you up there,” the woman said, “but if you’ve got nothing on what I just helped pull Catra out of.”

Glimmer frowned. She had a point, but it was hearing Catra’s name that stopped her from arguing. “Wait, what did you just say? What did you just pull who out of?”

“And let’s not forget about me,” the he woman said, ignoring Glimmer’s question and instead gesticulating with her hands as if she were gossiping with friends over a drink. “Corynth is being shifty, keeping distant. He thinks I don’t know what he’s doing—”

“Wait, can you just—”

“—but I *do*, and it’s not fun having to deal with it on top of everything else. So, yes, I understand why you’re a bit short on patience right now, but—”

"Can we just focus on what's going on, please? Did you say Catra was down there with you?"

"—should appreciate that we're all just trying to deal with this shit sandwich together, right now."

Glimmer wished she could through the screen to throttle her. It took all her self-restraint to stand there with a clenched jaw and thin-pressed lips instead of explode on this mystery person for ignoring her in lieu of a tangent while they were moments away from being overrun and killed, again.

"Would you please, *please* tell me, what the hell it is you're talking about?" she said. "Please."

The woman smiled so wide it reached her eyes. "It might be easier if I just patch you through and let you all figure it out amongst yourselves. I've got enough on my plate already."

"Wait, patch me through where?"

"My name is Pip by the way. Okay, bye!"

"Hold on, where are you—*damnit*!"

Pip disappeared and Glimmer clenched hard enough she thought her teeth might crack. Replacing her on the screen was a sorry group of harried individuals, and an even more choice set of curse words flew out her mouth at the sight of them.

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Hearing Glimmer let loose a long string of swear words the moment she appeared on screen lightened the anxiety weighing Adora down. It was almost reassuring, like the Glimmer on screen before her was the real thing and her mind wasn't playing tricks on her down on this haunted planet. Kyle and Lonnie were on either side of her, much older than she remembered seeing them last, and along with Catra, the they all were so much closer physically than they'd been in years. With a deep sigh, she

dismissed the sword, changing it back into a gauntlet that wrapped her forearm.

"What the hell is going on?" Glimmer half shouted after she'd apparently run out of curses. "Catra? *Adora*?"

Adora had no idea what to say. Catra beat her to the punch.

"Hey, Sparkles," she said with a grin. "Coulda sworn you'd blew up on that giant flagship earlier, but"—she made a show of looking around at the destruction surrounding them in the control—"can't say I'm unhappy to see you alive and well, all things considered."

Adora could see she was feigning nonchalance, although being able to read at least this much didn't make her feel much better. Even a stranger wouldn't be surprised to see Catra feel relieved at Glimmer's survival.

"All things considered?" Glimmer asked. "*All things considered?"* Her eyes flicked to Taline. "I thought you were dead! What in Prime's name was the *Constable* doing here? Do you have any idea how seeing it blow up in front of my eyes made me feel?" She looked over each of them again, growing visibly more irritated. "What are you doing down there?"

Taline looked wholly unprepared to respond, too, which was something Adora oddly sympathized with her over. It was Corynth laughing under his breath that drew everyone's attention, instead. "She's definitely your apprentice," he said.

"And what is that supposed to mean?" Taline asked.

"You attract difficult people into your life."

"I do *not.*" Taline stood taller as if trying to peer down at him, even though she was halfway across the room and would barely reach his shoulder were she to stand next to him. "Although you're a big enough outlier you alone would be enough to earn me that reputation."

"No argument here. I would never want to be accused of…what was it you said? Making you feel like the universe was tricking you if you didn't have to suffer and earn every good thing that came into your life?"

Taline's jaw dropped and her eyes glinted with something that seemed to straddle the line between incensed and challenging. Adora looked between them with mounting panic and confusion. Were those real barbs they were trading, or was this some perverse kind of flirting? The latter felt doubly distressing considering how they'd been at each other's throats not even an hour prior. And judging by the looks on Catra, Trayn, and Keren's faces, they were all just as lost and perturbed as her.

"Alright, *alright*, enough!" Glimmer said, cutting in before Taline could bite back. "I have no idea how to react to seeing you argue like children, let alone how to even begin processing that you"—she gestured to Corynth before coming up short of words. "…Are you really…?"

"What are you doing here?" Taline said to her instead, not giving him a chance to respond. "The Scavrian fleet wasn't supposed to pull out for several more days."

Glimmer caught them up to speed. She told them how they picked up the *Constable's* tight-band SOS, how the Admiral pulled half the fleet away to respond, and how the subsequent attack from the surface eliminated most of that fleet, including the flagship she barely escaped from.

Taline muttered a curse. "That's why he was late to the shuttle," she said, eyes narrowed in anger. "Diallo was preparing."

"Then we should do some preparing of our own," Corynth said, turning back to the console. "Pip?"

Multiple mirrored copies of Pip appeared on the screens next to Glimmer's feed. "They've confirmed receipt of ansible transmission," she said. "Fifteen minutes."

“And how much time do we have until Archanas is fully awake?”

“Also roughly fifteen minutes. And that’s a generous estimation.”

“Fifteen minutes and then what?” Glimmer asked. “Anyone know what its first move will be?”

“It mouthed off about taking its new fleet and blowing up the nearest Barrier node,” Catra said. “And with that orbital canon, it shouldn’t have any issues reinforcing that fleet, either. All the empire has to do is send more ships here to investigate.”

“We’re coming to get you,” Glimmer said, eliciting nods from both Lonnie and Kyle in the frame beside her.

“Absolutely not."

“No chance in hell, Sparkles, that’s a terrible idea!”

“You can’t come here, what?”

Catra, Taline, and Adora spoke over one another. And, as if anyone could expect anything different, Glimmer doubled down.

“Do you realize what will happen when any of you succumb down there?” she asked. “Not if you succumb, *when* you succumb. You, especially?” This last, she directed to Taline.

“It’s too dangerous,” was all Taline said.

Glimmer to rolled her eyes and turn her attention to Corynth. “Then do you have any other plans for getting out of there in less than fifteen minutes? Because even a single node going down is disastrous. The clock’s ticking, and you’re the only one who hasn’t objected yet.”

“I don’t object.”

Glimmer grinned the same moment that Adora groaned, Catra cursed under her breath, and Taline shot him a death glare.

“It’s settled then,” Glimmer said. “The other Warbirds under my command will escort the Megaliths to those coordinates you provided, under the assumption that’s where reinforcements are supposed to arrive. It won’t be an easy thing to pull off, but I think they can hold out. Especially since I don’t think the Beast is trying to destroy them.

“But, more importantly, where are you, exactly? The radiation emanating from the surface has only grown worse, and our onboard sensors can’t see. We’ll be flying in essentially blind once we plunge through the atmosphere.”

“That’s where I think I can help,” Pip said, jumping in before either Catra or Taline could argue with Glimmer again about coming to their rescue.

A three-dimensional layout of the compound projected into the center of the room. Filled with interwoven, web-like tangles of corridors, it sent Adora’s head spinning it was so complicated. Some of the layout didn’t even make logical or physical sense. The longer she stared at the map, the more muddled her brain got.

“That’s going to take some effort to navigate,” Taline said, stalking up to the display next to Corynth.

“So, my brain actually wasn’t leaking out my ears,” Catra said, marching up to the display with Keren and Trayn at her sides. “I swore we followed Larian up here above the surface from the landing platform without taking stairs or an elevator.”

"The best bet for an extraction is the orbital cannon," Pip said, bypassing their commentary.

A yellow highlight appeared in the projection, tracing a convoluted path from their location at the center of the compound to what looked like a service elevator far away. There were too many turns and double-backs for Adora to count.

"That giant gun that shot you guys up in space?” Pip said. “Yeah, it’s sitting on a raised platform about five miles out, and is the one

part of the planet where the infection seems to be growing the slowest. Maybe because it shoots a fair amount of infected matter when it fires and needs time re-accumulate, who knows, but that's likely where a rescue attempt would have the highest chance of success."

"It probably helps it's a visible landmark on the surface too," Lonnie said, speaking for the first time. "Lack of instrumentation is going to be a real bitch."

"There's a direct underground railway connection from this compound to the gun platform," Pip said. "But as you can clearly see, it's not a straight shot to get to the service elevator feeding into the caverns. There are also quite a few, how should I say… obstacles…between that elevator and all of you."

"Those obstacles don't happen to be thralls, do they?" Trayn asked in a deadpan. "Lots and lots of thralls?"

"That's a great guess, because yes it is!" Pip said, snapping her fingers with a smile Trayn didn't return. "You're smart, I like you."

"How many thralls?" Taline asked.

"A lot."

She pinched the bridge of her nose. "Numbers, please. We need numbers."

Everyone except Corynth and Taline acted like they had the air sucked out their lungs when Pip listed off a number that continued for far too many syllables.

"Diallo is scrambling my access to things microsecond by microsecond," she said, "so that's more of a quick estimation rather than a truly accurate read. Look for yourselves."

One copy of her image disappeared from the front screen, replaced with a rotating carousel of security footage showing the various hallways making up their planned path to the service

elevator. Thralls packed every inch of space on every video feed as it came through. Adora wouldn't be surprised if there were over a thousand of them—far too many to brute force their way through. Judging by the scowl on Glimmer and Lonnie's faces as well as the whistle of surprise Kyle let out, Pip had sent them the same feeds to review, too.

"Let me take care of the route," Corynth said. "It won't be easy, but I can make our path to the elevator a straight shot."

Taline faced him, hands on her hips. "After all that, the last thing you should be doing is pushing yourself harder right now."

"You want to fight through an endless winding tunnel, instead?" Corynth asked, gesturing to the feed and the countless thralls.

"It's not about what I want, it's about what what's feasible. We just tore the Atrium apart trying to get at one another and then tried and failed to kill the Abomination before it escaped. Now you want to wrestle with the Beast itself? To do what, shorten a hallway? Not a good idea. We can manage the long way."

Adora locked eyes with Catra, who she was surprised to see already looking at her. Both averted their eyes when they realized, but Adora had already understood the expression Catra gave her in that split second: she didn't know what to do about the situation, either.

"It's a great idea, and for exactly all the reasons you just laid out," Corynth said. "You can barely stand, your Sentinel is not in much better shape—"

"I can fight," Catra said.

"—we have two more who only have however much ammunition they picked up in this room to fight with, and even Adora will tire if she has to fight through that many thralls. You and I might survive the long way, but it's not just us two that will be making this trip. Not to mention we're on a time crunch."

Taline's expression shifted as the logic sunk into her head. "Fine. But I will shorten the path, not you."

"You just figured out spatial transference."

"And I can do it again. If you—"

"The entire planet will be fighting every step of the way to impose its reality, Taline. That resuscitated Archanan Abomination we just failed to stop? It won't be like fighting me. I wasn't actively trying to stop you."

Taline made a face that Adora had trouble describing. Not because it was a hard expression to decipher, but because seeing it on Taline's face just felt alien.

"Are…are you *pouting* at him?" Glimmer said, looking completely taken aback on the screen.

"No." Taline's face turned into a scowl in an instant.

"You totally were," Catra said, similarly in awe. "Archanas is coming alive again, and Taline is making weird faces. I don't know how to process this. Hell must be freezing over."

"Fourteen minutes, y'all," Pip said.

Corynth moved past them to the exit indicated in the projection, and everyone followed. When he reached the door, he turned back to Taline. "If you say you can do it then I won't argue and you can take the lead. But if you're wrong, everyone in this room dies within two steps of you losing control."

A muscle in Taline's jaw twitched as she gritted her teeth. "It's so unfair for you to put it that way." She said it under her breath in a way that sounded to Adora like she wouldn't argue. To Corynth, it seemed he interpreted it that way, too.

"You two at the back," he said, indicating Keren and Trayn. "Shoot anything that tries to catch us from behind. When you run dry and

need to reload, switch with Catra and Adora in the middle. Taline will clear our path forward while I keep the Abomination from trapping us and concentrate on giving us a straight shot to the exit. Glimmer—”

“Will be burning as fast as possible down to you,” Glimmer said. “Fourteen minutes, you said?”

“Thirteen twenty-eight,” Pip said. “Twenty-seven.”

“We’ll be there.”

Glimmer’s feed cut off, then all the copies of Pip disappeared as the screens blanked out. The six of them assumed their places, and everything suddenly seemed real and immediate to Adora. She summoned the sword again in her hand. Her heart beat in her chest like it wanted to break it open, and she could feel the pulse of blood all they way in her fingertips, could hear it rushing in her ears.

“Everyone ready?” Taline asked. Keren, Trayn, Catra, and Adora all answered in the affirmative.

“Stick as close behind Taline and I as you can,” Corynth said. “As soon as Pip opens the door we’ll be moving, and fast.”

“Bit of a problem with the door, actually,” Pip said over the sound system. “You see, I kinda did a hard override when first closing them so Diallo couldn’t get any of them open again. Unfortunately, that also means I can’t get them open either, and forcing your way through eighteen feet of triple reinforced steel might be—”

Adora looked over at Catra beside her while Pip went on. “Good luck,” she said, leaning over to whisper.

Catra met her eyes for a moment before giving an exaggerated shrug and extending her claws. “Try not to zone out again. I’d honestly rather get ripped apart by the thralls than feel that kind of second hand embarrassment a third time if you do.”

A large rune appeared out of thin air in front of Taline. She plunged her arm into it all the way to the elbow, like she was preparing to rip the guts out of an animal. A burst of magic energy pulsed from her strong enough it almost knocked Adora off her feet, distracting her from whatever incensed feelings she had over Catra's comment.

The door cracked and buckled like it was flimsy aluminum crumpling inside her grip. It splintered then exploded out, disappearing behind a dense, impenetrable fog that began to fill the control room the moment an opening was there for it to seep in from the outside.

Adora fought back the urge to choke when it washed over them, until Corynth dissipated Taline's rune and, glowing with faint magic of his own, allowed some kind of barrier to wash over them. It insulated their group of six, giving them just enough room to maneuver between each other.

The sound of hundreds of screeching creatures erupted from beyond the doorway, and dozens of figures appeared in the fog directly ahead of them. Taline made a circular gesture with one hand extended forward. A tight beam of energy exploded from her palm, immolating those figures and carving their path forward.

"Move, now!" she said.

Not one of them hesitated. Together, they plunged ahead into the abyss.

Chapter End Notes

> The next two chapters will be released every other week rather than weekly. These first three chapters are enormous, since they are actually six chapters combined down (I didn't want to leave you guys on 6 continuous weeks of cliffhangers, so I made the chapters longer for better pacing).

We'll resume weekly uploads starting with the fourth chapter (Ch 64).

This last part of the story, although not the longest by chapter count, is the longest by word count. You'd think Part 3 would be longest, since its also the part with the most chapters and is waist deep in the three main characters' separate storylines, but no--part 3 is ~95k words, and part 5 is over 100k in word length. This is doubly cool (or daunting, depending on how you look at it) considering that this is the part of the story where all 3 main characters are in the same geographical location. I don't have to spend words setting up context for their viewpoints as we jump between them, because they're all in the same place dealing with the same issue. It's their respective character growth smashing into one another on top of the world ending threat that is this Beast infestation threatening to get out of control.

We're in the home stretch now! And it's one hell of a dense, action packed home stretch ;) Till next time, and thank you as always for reading and commenting!

# Bridge of Tears

Chapter Notes

> I'm super glad to see so many longtime readers jump right back into the story months after the last update. Your guys' support is amazing, thank you :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It had been years since Adora felt this in her element.

Sword of Protection in hand, she kept pace with the others, sprinting down a narrow corridor in tight formation, beset on all sides by an impenetrable fog that was like a curtain to some unknown plane of existence. Great shadows of what seemed like alien creatures or perhaps twisted, angular buildings moved and shifted on the other side of this curtain, held back thanks only to what she knew was Corynth's astounding use of Shaper magic.

The rattling of automatic rifle fire and the percussive blasts of a shotgun rang at her back, while Taline's throaty electricity and fire spells cried ahead of her, tearing through countless shrieking thralls. It was the perfect mix of frenetic fighting and a straightforward objective that finally let her settle into her own skin for once. And with Catra at her side running down the hallway with her, it was hard to imagine any other place she'd rather be, despite the circumstances.

"I'm out!" Keren said.

"Me too." Trayn ejected the magazine of his rifle. "Switch!"

Catra and Adora leaped to the back at the same time they pulled to the relative safety of the middle to reload, allowing Adora to thrust head-first into battle.

She swung, first left with the sword, then right, cutting down six. The thralls had no combat instincts, it was just their sheer number

that made engaging them a challenge. Soon, she could only fend off the onslaught instead of thin them: extending too far forward exposed her to too many counterattacks, while keeping pace backward with the others put her at risk of tripping over her own feet.

Catra complimented her movements. Every parry, she was there to push the thrall back; every thrust of the sword and she played defense, ensuring none of their other countless opponents took advantage of the opening. It was nostalgic in a way Adora hadn't expected to experience again.

Then she twisted, reaching between four thralls to swipe at a fifth with her claws and retreat back to safety before the others could pounce on her for being so exposed. The maneuver threatened to break Adora's brain. Catra had always been a good fighter, but her movements now seemed almost superhuman.

"Where did you learn to fight like that?" Adora asked. "You've always been fast, but this seems different."

Catra wasn't even winded. She glanced sidelong at her. Adora got the sense she was trying to decide how to respond. "It's a long story."

"Cybernetic enhancements?"

Catra kicked the legs out from underneath a thrall Adora had distracted, sending it to the ground and toppling the others that came up from behind. "Not quite?"

The fact she posed her answer as a question made Adora frown.

"Switch!"

They twirled back to the middle at Trayn's command, while he and Keren reassumed their position at the rear. Automatic rifle fire and shotgun blasts rang out again as Corynth and Taline lead their group under the silhouette of an enormous archway in the fog.

When a portion of the fog wall lit up with brilliant, silent lightning, countless silhouetted figures with eyes of starlight appeared, and dozens of hands reached through to grab at them. Adora yelped and swung, batting the hands away.

"They're coming through!" Catra said, fighting off her own set of hands, too. One grabbed her arm and started to pull her through. "Help!"

Adora pressed her back to Catra's body and used it as a pivot to spin around her, putting that inertia into her arms as she swung the sword up to cut the arm holding Catra clean off.

Corynth leaped into the air and flew over them, the eyes in his mask shining bright as he gestured for a spell, contrails of magic tracing the arc of his hands.

The fog walls exploded back, revealing something that was arguably more terrifying. The tight hallway was gone, replaced with a bridge narrow enough Adora nearly panicked. Instead of the impression of thick walls boxing them in on either side, there was a steep drop into an abyss with no visible bottom—she could fall right off if she wasn't careful running.

In fact, that's what happened to the countless dozens of thralls that had been hiding. Corynth had changed their surroundings, sending them plummeting down the very chasm Adora struggled not to think about too hard.

Their screeches echoed up, timed to hit Adora's ears the same moment another bolt of soundless lightning cracked overhead. The fog Corynth pushed back had instead coalesced into a dome high overhead, in which even more silhouettes of towering building facades loomed over them. It felt like Adora was in a nightmare. This wasn't a hallway in a mining compound they were fleeing down, this was like some third dimension the Beast had pulled them into. A dimension only one person was capable of protecting them from.

Corynth gestured again and the chasm filled. Barren dirt and rocks flooded in from the abyss over top of them, packing the empty space until they were surrounded by a flat plain of earth a hundred meters across that terminated at the bounds of the fog. Adora could run without fear of falling off, and soon, they reached the end of the hallway, everyone crowding together at the elevator.

"We're here," Taline said, mashing the open button. "Pip, open the doors."

A speakerphone overhead crackled to life. "I've almost got it," Pip said, voice coming through riddled with static. "The Abomination has been fighting me every step of the way, but I'm close. Hold on just a little longer."

The fog dome began to close in on them. Lightning struck again, and this time, Adora saw new silhouettes beyond the veil. Hundreds of figures among facades of even more alien skyscrapers. Whatever lay beyond looked like an entirely alien world.

"What the hell is that?" Trayn asked, gripping his rifle tighter.

"Narsis." Everyone glanced to Taline when she spoke, surveying the skyline through narrow eyes. "Another lost world from the previous war. One that I doomed personally. There were just…too many thralls. Last we heard from the ground forces before everything went dark, there were enough to overrun even heavily entrenched positions."

"And Diallo is now almost powerful enough to manifest a portion of it here, around us," Catra said, grimacing.

The implication behind that statement struck Adora steadied herself. The thing could manifest dead worlds around them? She'd read stories about the ground forces in the last war, heard tell of unimaginable horrors the Vanguard would plunge into on

contested worlds. Is that what was about to happen the moment Corynth could no longer hold it back?

She looked at him and wondered how much longer he could. She took another step back, then a third when something grabbed her by the wrist—Catra was there, digging into her with a sharp look. Of course Catra would still read her like a book even after all these years. Even when Adora herself felt like she could no longer do the same for her.

Another screech came from the silhouettes beyond the fog, the curtain now so close Adora could count their starlight eyes individually.

Keren swore and pumped her shotgun. “Any chance you can do what you did earlier?” She shouting up at Corynth who still floated above them, glowing. “Open up a chasm and drop those sons of bitches before they rush us?”

“Not a good idea,” Taline said, answering instead of him. “Diallo will just negate it as soon as his fog covers the area. Our only chance is to get off this planet. He will have much less control over things once we get out of his direct sphere of influence.”

“It will still be another minute or two before I can get this door open,” Pip said. “I’m almost done clearing the tunnels, but the Abomination is really pushing to keep you all here.”

“I’ll take care of them, then” Taline said, stepping forward with blue electricity screeching at her fingertips.

“Wait!” Catra, who was still holding Adora’s wrist, squeezed at the same time she shouted. “Something’s happening.”

Adora wondered what tipped her off until she too felt something in the air shift. The air went still. Even the screeching from the thralls lined up just on the other side of the fog ceased. Then all at once they disappeared as if swooped up by some invisible force.

There was shouting—not just the shrill screeching of mindless thralls, but the voices of conscious people in a struggle. The telltale buzzing and zinging of magic came after, along with a gurgling sound that made Adora's stomach turn over. Catra's fur stood on end by the time things went still again.

"Thralls aren't the only thing hiding in the depths of time," Corynth said, floating down until he landed among them. "And the Beast isn't the only one that can call them forth."

Taline exchanged looks with him. The doors to the elevator behind them shunted open, and Pip shouted at them to get in.

Corynth was the last inside. When he stepped past the threshold, he took a breath, the faint aura of magic infusing him disappeared, and the fog raced forward. The doors to the lift closed just before it reached them.

Corynth sagged, and Taline and Catra were there on either side to prop him up. Catra looked behind her at Keren and Trayn, and they intercepted Adora before she could go to Corynth, too.

Before she could figure out what why, they'd assaulted her with a barrage of questions—questions about her relationship to Catra, how they knew one another, where she'd been for the past three years. Adora felt they had no reason to ask and she had no obligation to tell them, but she got lost trying to come up with answers all the same.

It wasn't until Catra at them again while Taline was supporting Corynth, a look of contentment passing across her face, that Adora finally realized what was going on: Keren and Trayn's interference was not coincidence.

Dejected and feeling more like an outsider than ever before, Adora gave up on going to Corynth and let Catra and Taline tend to him instead. She did her best to answer Keren and Trayn's questions as the elevator pulled them down, but her heart wasn't

in it. And when she saw Catra’s tail reach up and brush the back of Taline’s hand, she frowned.

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Kyle guided the Warbird through Archanas’ atmosphere practically blind. With the ion storm raging outside, he had to rely on his ship’s frazzled navigational computer to make sure he didn’t hit anything.

“This is insane,” he said, yanking the controls to avoid a massive obstacle that appeared on the nav computer without warning. If he wasn’t such an ace pilot, Glimmer was certain they’d already have crashed and died with how suddenly these things popped up.

“How are we thousands of feet up in the air and the computer is telling us there are things the size of buildings flailing all around us?" Lonnie chewed her lip as she stared at the glitched-out readings on their shared radar. "It'd help if we could at least tell what they are. I can’t see shit through this damn storm.”

“I prefer it this way,” Kyle said.

“Really? How does that make any sense?”

“You’re aware of what’s happening here. Scavria was no walk in the park, but this is the most active of an infestation we’ve ever confronted, by far. I think it’s a blessing in disguise we can’t see what’s really out there with us.”

That seemed to change Lonnie’s mind. She pressed her lips together in silence.

Glimmer stood behind them, concentrating on protecting the Warbird with her magic. Rogelio and the team of soldiers with them were sealed in the transport cabin at the back, but Glimmer wasn’t taking any chances letting the Beast mess with their heads. Enforcing a protective bubble around their craft was starting to feel suffocating.

“How much longer until we reach the LZ?” she asked.

Lonnie snorted. “Is it really an LZ if we end up not being able to land?”

Kyle ignored her, staring at the faded blip on his screen. “I really can’t tell. Not from this. It’s too fuzzy and intermittent.”

Pip—who by now Glimmer had realized was apparently some super AI—was transmitting an ansible ping to their onboard computers. But even that apparently wasn’t enough to get them an accurate read through the storm: the signal was weak, and would sometimes disappear entirely before coming back.

“We’ve been burning through the atmosphere for a while, now.” She patted the headrest of Kyle’s seat. “You got to us from orbit over Scavria in, like, a minute. Can we go any faster?”

“We’ll run the risk of overshooting if I do,” he said, guiding them around another enormous, moving obstacle the computer warned them about. “Or worse, we’ll hit one of those things, whatever they are.”

Glimmer was worried about whether they’d make it on time at all, something seeming less likely the longer they spent traveling this slow.

“Hey.” Lonnie grabbed her attention looking her in the eyes, leaned back in her chair. “We’ll make it. Even with a shitty signal, Kyle will get us there in time.”

Glimmer watched Pip’s blip drift steadily closer to the center of the radar. “I know,” she said. “I know. I’ll feel better once we’re there, though.”

Lonnie reached over and squeezed her arm. “Me too.”

The signal disappeared from the radar, and Lonnie turned around to stare at it when Glimmer’s eyes darted to the screen. Together, all three of them in the cockpit held her breath.

The signal didn’t come back.

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By the time the elevator slowed to a halt and released them to the rail system deep underground, Corynth was good to walk on his own. That hadn’t stopped Taline from imploring him the whole ride down to let off the gas, though.

*Stop using so much magic*, she’d said to him under her breath, quiet enough only Catra could hear, helping support him from his other side. *Let me pick up some of the slack. You need to recuperate at least a little. Please.*

He’d agreed, but Taline still asked Trayn and Keren to accompany him when he stepped out of the elevator. They’d stopped badgering Adora with questions immediately, the excited smiles on their faces disappearing the moment she couldn’t see, and followed him out instead. Catra felt bad for sicking them on her earlier, but figuring out how to juggle Adora on top of everything else was not in the cards for her, right now.

“You’re avoiding her,” Pip said in her head as everyone else filed out the elevator.

::I don't know what you're talking about,:: Catra said as she followed Taline onto the platform.

“Seriously? You’ve been pining after her and wondering if she’s doing okay all these years, but the second she shows up you give her the cold shoulder and won’t even acknowledge you’re doing it?”

Catra bristled. She hadn’t been ‘pining.’ Catra didn’t pine. She almost said as much, too, until catching sight of the tunnel before them.

It carved directly through the obsidian beast matter deep underground, which made sense on second thought since this entire compound was for mining the stuff, but what didn't make sense was how the whole tunnel glowed a subtle orange hue as if

recently superheated. The air was stuffy and hot as well. Even the concrete under Catra's feet was warm to the touch.

::What happened down here?:: she asked as she walked with the group to the two linked railcars waiting for them.

Pip sighed loud enough Catra rolled her eyes at how dramatic she sounded. "It was crawling with thralls down here, too, so I flooded it with plasma."

::Really?::

"Yeah. It turns out the Vestamid consider keeping this tunnel clear for transport extremely important and have some, uh…'interesting' emergency cleaning protocols you can flip on if you have the right administration privileges. Why do you think it took me so long to get you all down here?"

::I thought Diallo was making it hard for you to open the elevator doors.::

"He was, but I also didn't want to roast you guys alive in the elevator. Or let you walk into yet another army of thralls."

::That's very magnanimous of you.::

Pip snorted and finally appeared again in front of Catra. She looked different since the last time Catra saw her—the sundress on her frame was of a different cut with a different pattern emblazoned on the translucent fabric, and her demeanor seemed more reserved, although Catra could still easily see the devilish playfulness underneath.

::What happened to you?::

Pip narrowed her eyes at her. "Reintegrating with years of additional memories can change a person. Stop trying to change the subject. I already know you're avoiding Adora and I already know you feel bad about it, so stop playing dumb. What's going on with you?"

::Shouldn’t you already know the answer to that, since you’re in my head and know everything else, already?::

Pip grabbed at her hair by the fistful and groaned. “I swear, you’re more aggravating to deal with than Corynth. Both of you together? If I had a lifespan, I’d probably be losing years of it right now.”

Something nudged Catra's arm. Adora was at her side, staring right at her with wide, probing eyes. All of them had been standing in front of the railcars for longer than she'd realized, Taline and Corynth holding another conversation while Trayn and Keren watched.

“Are you okay?” Adora asked. “You looked spaced out there for a bit.”

The doors to both railcars opened, and when Pip next spoke, her voice rang out for all to hear from the platform’s PA system.

“The Abomination is a serious pain in the ass,” she said. “It will take me a little longer to actually get this thing moving, so sit tight.” She turned to Catra and said, privately, “Maybe you can use this time to finally talk to her.”

Corynth entered front car with Keren and Trayn escorting him. Catra watched him go with a frown before turning to Adora. She had no idea what to say to her, but was determined to try.

“Stay a moment, please,” Taline said, tapping Catra on the shoulder before she could start. “Adora, can you wait in the second car?”

“Oh, come on!” Pip said, throwing her hands up before disappearing from Catra’s view.

Adora deflated and glanced between Catra and Taline with a heavy look. It was amazing how expressive her face was. Had Adora always been like this?

“That canon is pretty far, so the ride will be long,” Catra said to her. “Plenty of time for us to talk. Soon, yeah?”

Adora nodded, and a small, hesitant smile appeared on her lips. With one last, furtive glance at Taline, she turned and headed into the second car. Catra watched her take a seat facing them on a bench inside.

“She can only control a small portion of her powers,” Taline said, drawing Catra’s attention once Adora couldn’t hear. “And Corynth made it abundantly clear to me she’s got one hell of a mental block to get past before the rest of it will come.”

Somehow, that didn’t surprise Catra to hear. For as head strong and action oriented as Adora had always been, she also tended to get too into her head and fall flat on her face. The only question was, what was it this time that had her so locked up for the past three-plus years? Worrying over the Beast was an obvious culprit, but Catra thought that was too simple.

…And she’d officially been ruminating over Adora for too long, again. “I’m more concerned about you,” she said to Taline.

“Do I really look that bad?”

She looked stretched thin. A bruise was flowering over the clammy, pale skin of her left cheek. She’d left the front of her jacket open, and what hadn’t been soaked through with blood, sweat, soot, and dirt was ripped and frayed, leaving most of her soiled undershirt open for display.

“You really do. ‘Bad’ might be an understatement.”

Taline averted her eyes and wrung her hands together. “I imagine you’re right. Certainly wouldn’t look as put together as usual with everything that’s happened.”

Catra didn’t like how she sounded almost like she was apologizing when she said that. She frowned and took both of Taline’s hands

into her own, then started massaging them with her thumbs until Taline stopped shaking.

"What happened after you jumped back to Phoenix?" she asked. "I was fifty-fifty on ever seeing you again, even after breaking the apeiron you gave me. Seeing him come through too wasn't even a consideration." She gestured with her head to the first car, where Keren and Trayn stood fidgeting near Corynth, who sat precariously on one of the benches.

Catra caught Taline's eye when she didn't say anything, and saw more than she was expecting. "It happened, didn't it? What you said you were afraid of back on the ship? You saw his face and couldn't kill him."

"No, actually." Taline perked up, almost looking proud. "I was about to do it when my sister stopped me."

"…Evie?" Catra thought back to the figures she saw after crushing the apeiron—the two Pips forming into one, preceded by the third who had kissed her fingertips. Catra's claws tingled, and that phantom's last words echoed in her head. *With this, the final die is cast. May it give you the power to protect those you love.*

::I had nothing to do with it this time, I swear,:: Pip said in her ear. ::Completely out of my control.::

Taline caught her up to speed. She learned about Taline's duel with Corynth, Evelyn's appearance, and the way she persuaded them to work together instead of fight.

When she was done, Catra didn't know how to respond. Hearing it implied that Corynth was acting more as an agent of Evelyn's posthumous will clashed with the wider galaxy's interpretation of him as some near-mythical figure. Hell, it clashed with her own mental fantasy of him. And she didn't know whether to feel relieved that Taline no longer seemed to harbor an irrational hatred of him, or sympathize with how she'd been led around

blind by emotions the Beast had used to manipulate her in secret for over a decade.

Taline herself seemed to be struggling with how to feel over it.

"I just…don't know what to think anymore," she said, deflating. "For years, everything seemed so clear. I didn't have to agonize over any kind of gray area. Now, it's like I'm angry with myself for not sensing what was going on sooner. Then I tell myself to cut me some slack, then end up feeling angry at him"—she gestured to Corynth in the front car with a tilt of her head—"for not coming to settle things sooner. And then I cut him some slack, only to end up being angry at myself again for thinking so poorly of him."

Taline's jaw clenched. She pulled out of Catra's grip, gesturing at their surroundings and working herself up. "Then I get angry at Evelyn for orchestrating everything and putting us in this situation. And *then* I realize, as dire as this is, we're in the *best*-case scenario right now because she concocted this whole plan years before her death and Corynth has been the one to carry it forward.'

She frowned. "That's when I loop back to thinking I'm a piece of shit for having sat on my ass on Phoenix all this time, ignorant to all of it. Maybe if I'd managed to get my head on straight without his help, then he wouldn't have had to do everything alone this whole time. Maybe then he wouldn't have to push himself so hard he can barely keep it together anymore."

Competing emotions warred on her face. And Catra had thought she had it tough trying to figure out how to feel seeing Adora again.

"Be honest with me," she said to Taline. "How fucked are we right now? I mean, Archanas is rejuvenating itself for crying out loud. There's no getting around how bad that sounds. And it didn't even seem like Diallo was expecting this to happen, either. He had a different plan until I came along and he saw us interact."

“Oh, it’s pretty bad,” Taline said.

Catra made a face. “Maybe I’m just utterly failing at reading you right now, but it almost seems like you’re more concerned about several other things except for the fact we’re still stuck on this planet and things are going to shit, fast.”

To her surprise, Taline broke into a wide grin. She looked either manic or elated, Catra couldn’t decide.

“Things are so bad, I can’t even pretend to look like I’m in control anymore,” she said. “It’s strangely freeing. With so many much happening at once, it’s enough to just focus on the immediate next thing and not worry about anything else.” She looked Catra in the eyes, sincere. “I’ve never felt like this, before.”

Catra took a step back, swallowing. “Geeze, are you trying to scare me? Because it’s working.”

“I don’t mean to scare you,” Taline said, shaking her head. “This is still Evelyn’s desired endgame, after all. Things are dire, but I don’t think they’re hopeless.”

“Will it help at all if Adora gets the rest of the way with her powers?”

“Probably. But I wouldn’t get my hopes up for it happening right now. Maybe in a year or two?”

Catra wrinkled her nose. “We don’t have a year or two, Archanas is live *now*. And I know you’re thinking it will be fine since Corynth is here too, but he can barely even stand. We both had to help him in the elevator.”

Taline, devoid of any sarcasm, said, “I’ve been telling him not to push himself, though.”

Catra smacked her hand against her forehead and dragged it down her face with a groan. “You’re still in love with him.”

“I never said that.” Taline spoke in a harsh whisper, eyes darting left and right like she was checking that no one overheard them deep underground on a near-desolate planet.

“Please, you’re practically shouting it at me,” Catra said, rolling her eyes.

“Just because I’m not trying to rip his head off doesn’t mean I’ve forgiven him. It’s not water under the bridge.”

“Sure, whatever you say.” Catra spoke in such a flippant way Taline scowled at her. “Look, I get it. He’s a living legend and you guys have history, but right now he looks like he’s barely holding it together. I’m just concerned you’re not seeing that through those mile-thick rose-colored glasses you’re wearing.”

It was frustrating seeing Taline throw caution to the wind while Catra herself was doing an admirable job keeping from losing it on Adora. She almost said as much, until Taline placed a heavy hand on her shoulder.

“It’s not like that,” she said, really looking at her now. “The optimism you’re picking up from me is perhaps uncharacteristic, I admit, but it isn’t misplaced or misinformed.”

She pulled Catra into a hug, and despite having already done this back in the control room, Catra hadn’t realize how she had been on the verge of yet another panic attack until she was fighting tears with her head pushed into the crook of Taline’s neck.

“It’s okay,” Taline said, threading her fingers through Catra’s short hair and rubbing circles into her back with her other hand. “I know he doesn’t look like much right now, slumped over on the bench like that, but I reached deep into my soul and threw everything I had at him and more when we fought, and I didn’t stand a chance. He struggled more with the effects of long-term exposure than he did with me.” She paused, then in a quieter voice, said, “I don’t know if that’s sad on my part, or impressive on his.”

“Impressive on his,” Catra said, without missing a beat. She couldn’t imagine any scenario she’d classify Taline as ‘sad.’ She sniffled into the collar of Taline’s ruined jacket. The stench of blood and sweat might have been off-putting were she not in such need of something strong and solid to ground her. “What do you mean by long-term exposure, though?”

“I was right when I said the no one could survive Archanas at the height of the war. He was exposed to so much of the Beast when he and the others first sealed it away with my sister. It’s just he’s just been managing it without succumbing for far longer than I’d ever realized was possible.” Taline pulled back. “Corynth is dying.”

Catra was numb to it all by this point, but she did feel a pang across her chest seeing the devastated look on Taline’s face. “For real this time?”

Taline heaved a tired sigh and tried to fix her hair with one hand. “Yes, ‘for real this time.’ It’s been a long time coming already. It’s just tragic it’s happening now after we’ve crossed paths again, instead of before.”

It was obvious she was trying (and failing) to put on a brave face. Catra didn’t know what to say, or if she should say anything at all. “Taline, I’m so—”

“Don’t be sorry,” she said, shaking her head and pressing a finger to Catra’s lips. “Don’t, or else I’m going to start crying. Besides, there *is* a silver lining to all of this.”

“And that is…?”

“He and I managed to hash out a semblance of a plan when Adora wasn’t within earshot. I don’t particularly like the plan, but the fact things are coming to a head pretty quickly has put a lot of things into very stark clarity for the both of us.”

Catra furrowed her brow, unsure of why Taline had said ‘the plan’ with that odd lilt of disapproval. “That doesn’t sound nearly as

optimistic as I was hoping it would. Why make sure Adora wasn't around to hear?"

"Because she would definitely hate the plan, too."

"If you hate the plan and Adora would hate the plan, then don't you think maybe, I don't know, it's a bad plan?" This wasn't helping Catra's mental state. She could already feel the panic beginning to mount again. "What exactly is 'the plan', then?"

"Corynth is going to kill the Abomination."

Catra made a face. She was being just as intentionally obtuse as Pip sometimes acted. At the back of her consciousness, Pip gave her the mental approximation of a flick to the forehead. "Ok, we both know that sounds fine, and the only way it wouldn't be is if the details were suspicious. What are the details?"

Taline pulled fully away and huffed, as if Catra was the one pushing her buttons instead of it being the other way around. "Ugh, no. If I tell you, then you're going to hate the plan too. And if you and I start arguing over it, then I'm not going to have enough pent-up frustration for this trolley ride."

That literally made no sense. It was all she could do to not grab Taline by the shoulders and shake her. "Okay, fine! But if all three of us would hate the plan, then why is it even an option? It must be the worst plan in the history of all plans if all three of us could actually see fully eye to eye and collectively think it's bad."

"It's not a bad plan. It's really good." Taline must have sensed she wasn't saying anything sensible seeing Catra on the verge of ripping her own hair out. Her expression hardened, and she held a hand up to forestall whatever was on the tip of Catra's tongue. "Let me clarify. I said all three of us would hate it, not that it was a bad plan. This is very much what the first Beast War was like, Catra. We're standing here talking to one another in a mostly-populated galaxy today in part because I've had to sign off on

dozens of orders that felt terrible, but were objectively the best option."

Her eyes glazed over in a way that tipped Catra off she was reliving some nasty memories. "It's easy to hate a contingency plan that entails bombarding three billion citizens because you can't evacuate them. But when you stack that against letting the Beast get them in exchange for keeping your hands and your conscience clean, then it's pretty clear cut which option out of a litany of shitty ones is the 'good' one."

Catra was hating everything the more she wrapped her head around what Taline was saying. She nearly jumped out of her skin when Taline reached forward and tucked a stray lock of hair out of her face.

"You have enough to worry about," she said. "Allow me to be the one to bear the weight of existential questions once more. All I ask is you trust Corynth and I know what we're doing."

Catra was getting a glimpse of the true Seraph of Archanas. It was like she had reawakened after a long slumber the same way Archanas was coming alive once again, too. Was this what birthed those rumors and stories people would whisper about her when she wasn't around?

All she could do was nod and ponder how her Battlemage's face could look so cold and calculating, but feel so reassuring at the same time.

"Good," Taline said, patting her shoulder with a more reserved smile than before. "How are we doing on our transportation?"

This last question wasn't aimed at Catra, but Pip, who came back over the platform's loudspeaker.

"We're good to go," she said. "I'll start you off as soon as you're both inside."

Taline nodded. “I’m going to ride in the forward car and give Corynth a piece of my mind,” she said, turning back to Catra. “A lot of pieces, actually. There are things I’ve been wanting to say to him for years, and I’m not passing up the chance to finally say them.” She gestured to the second car. “You should ride with Adora and do the same. I know you two have a lot to work through. Better get started, yeah?”

Catra knew this was coming, but suddenly being moments away from having an uninterrupted conversation with Adora sent her deeper into worry. What was she going to say? How did you even start a conversation knowing there was so much they needed to say to each other?

“Stop overthinking it,” Taline said. “I can see it on your face. You don’t have to solve everything in one go right now. It’s enough to take the first step or two. And besides, if we win, then you’ll have plenty more time to figure it out together.”

Catra glanced into the first car again, and cleared her throat. “Are you sure you want those two in there with you?” she said, indicating Keren and Trayn, who both looked far out of their depths keeping tabs on Corynth.

“They can stay. I don’t mind an audience, and it’s not like they’ll have any context for what I plan on saying, anyways.”

Catra pressed her lips into a thin line. That meant it really would just be her and Adora alone together for the duration of the ride. Before she could come to terms with that, Taline clapped her on the shoulders and turned. “Let’s get going,” she said, heading into the front car. “Last thing we want is Glimmer getting to the pickup spot first and us getting an earful about being late.”

And within seconds, Catra was alone on the platform. She blinked, then glanced into the window of the second car. Adora was looking at her with a crease between her eyebrows. Even Pip chimed in when she still didn’t move.

“She’s not going to turn into a thrall and lunge at you, if that’s what you’re afraid of, you know.”

::I know that.:: Catra forced herself to step into the car. ::That’s not what I was worried about.::

Pip shut the doors behind her instead of responding and set the railcars moving. To Catra, it felt like Pip’s way of saying ‘yeah, right,’ with a snarky tone, and she fought to keep her hackles down as she took a seat on the bench.

“Everything okay?” Adora asked, facing her on the bench across the aisle.

“Yep, all good.” Catra shrank into herself, feeling scrutinized with Adora looking at her like that. “Had some things to go over with Taline first, that’s all.”

“Anything I should know about, too?”

Only then did it strike Catra why Corynth and Taline worked out their plan while Adora was out of earshot. It even made sense now why Taline had made her sit their earlier conversation out.

*Corynth is dying.*

The words rang in her head like a funeral bell tolling, binding Catra now to the same unspoken mandate: under no circumstance could Adora find out. Not when a large reason she still couldn’t access her powers was because of some undefined ‘mental block,’ or however Taline had put it.

::How come you didn’t say anything earlier?:: Catra asked Pip. ::You knew, and you didn’t say anything?::

“I suspected, but I didn’t know for certain, either. Not until Taline figured it out and he didn’t deny it.”

::What do you mean?:: Catra asked. ::Aren’t you in his head same as me? How can you not have known?::

“Because he’s been shutting me out, and I don’t know why!”

Pip voice was raw with emotion, and it threw her off. She had no idea it was possible to unilaterally block her out. Even to Catra, it was hard to imagine that kind of rejection considering how, to the best of her knowledge, Pip’s entire existence was defined by their mutual interplay in her (and Corynth’s) head.

::How am I supposed to play this off without making Adora suspicious, then?:: she said, instead. ::She’s going to know something is up. Hell, she probably suspects something, already...::

As if on cue, Adora leaned forward to Catra closer, like she could tell she was having a side conversation in the split-second she wasn’t paying attention. “Corynth didn’t look like he was doing so good,” she said. “Especially on the elevator ride. And I haven’t seen his face since he put that mask on, either. Everything just feels…off. Do you know what’s going on?”

::See?:: Catra’s began to panic. ::What the hell do I say to her?::

“I have no idea,” Pip said. “You’re crafty, I’m sure you’ll think of something. I have to go. Diallo’s been trying to turn the plasma flow back on in the tunnels. I need to concentrate if I’m going to keep you all from getting roasted alive down here, so excuse me if I’m not responsive for a bit.”

Before Catra could respond, Pip’s presence faded from their shared mindscape. She grit her teeth in frustration and sympathy for her friend, then realized Adora was still watching, waiting patiently for an answer with her hands clasped in her lap.

“I don’t know anything, Adora,” she said at last. So much for being crafty.

Adora didn’t seem to mind. She tilted her head. “How about you? Is everything is okay? I’ve noticed you kind of space out here and there. I wasn’t even sure you heard me earlier.”

"I'm fine, just tired."

Adora narrowed her eyes, and for some reason, it only made Catra angrier.

"What, don't believe me?" she asked, tossing her hands up in the air. "I just got my neck wrung nearly getting turned by an Abomination, *and* we were nearly overrun back in that hallway by an army of thralls appearing out of nowhere. Not to mention we are still stuck on this planet fighting for our lives. Sorry if I'm not perky enough to jump at the chance to answer your questions with a big smile on my face."

Adora reared back looking like she'd been slapped, and a stone dropped into the pit of Catra's stomach. She crossed her legs sitting back and pinched the bridge of her nose, forcing herself to pump the brakes.

"Sorry," Adora said after a moment composing herself. "I didn't mean to make you upset." Both her hands were in her lap—she was the very picture of repentance, the profile of her face cutting a stark silhouette against the lights of the tunnel speeding past them out the massive window behind her. Catra stared at the crease in her forehead and the downturn at the corner of her mouth with mixed emotions.

What if that was it? What if Adora didn't have anything else to say? What if everything was in that recorded message she'd already sent, and Catra had inadvertently snubbed her by not responding in time? She didn't know how to feel about that. If Adora didn't care enough about their history to push for a candid, vulnerable conversation…well, that would suck. They'd probably be nothing more than acquaintances ever again if that was the case, and that thought alone nearly brought tears to her eyes.

Catra could do it. All she had to do was calm down and talk to Adora normally. Broach the subject in a calm and respectful way. She could definitely do that much. She was about to sit up and try when Adora's demeanor changed.

“What the hell is going on over there?” she asked, perking up and looking to the side.

Catra followed her gaze to see through a window into the first car. Taline was facing them, tears streaming down her anguished face she screamed herself hoarse at Corynth, whose back was to them. She had his mask in one hand, gesturing with pointed movements while her other hand was in her hair.

Corynth reached up and cupped her cheek, wiping a tear away with his thumb. Keren stood at the far end of the car looking as stunned as Catra felt. She didn’t realize she’d been holding her breath, frozen, until they locked eyes and both of them got unstuck at the same time.

Keren gestured, saying something Catra couldn’t hear, and Trayn’s head suddenly popped into view. He’d been standing at the other end of the car, closer to them and out of view. When he repositioned himself to stand in front of the window and block the view in, Adora stood up.

“Something’s wrong,” she said.

Any composure Catra had gathered for herself disappeared into smoke. Knowing Adora, she would latch onto this and not let go. She’d find out everything. “They’re fine, Adora. Sit back down.”

“I don’t like this.” Adora didn’t seem to even hear her. She stood there staring at the window, passing her weight from one foot to the other. “Why’d he stand in the way like that? What are they doing in there? What are they hiding?”

What they were doing was having a long-overdue conversation, and Adora was on the verge of ruining that if she went barging through in a panic. Adora took two steps to the door and Catra jumped from the bench to head her off.

“I just want to make sure they’re okay,” Adora said.

“I said they’re *fine*, Adora.”

“She was crying! You had to have seen that. And Corynth can’t be doing much better if Taline of all people is losing it. Unless you know her so well it’s not a surprising thing to see?”

In truth, it was. Catra had seen tears before, but nothing as raw as what she glimpsed through that window—not from Taline. She wasn’t going to let Adora know that, though. “They haven’t seen each other in years. There’s bad blood between them, of course it’s going to be tense. You’re just going to make it worse if you interrupt.”

Adora shook her head and stepped around her, reaching for the doorhandle. “I can’t just leave him alone in there. Not after what she tried to do to him back—”

Catra caught her by the wrist and shoved her away from the door. She knew the moment she clocked the surprise on Adora’s face that she was being too aggressive, but Catra’s panic was overflowing and she had to channel it somewhere.

“Taline isn’t going to do anything to him,” she said. “Nothing he doesn’t deserve, at least, and he’s a big boy who can handle it. They don’t need your help to sort things out.”

The sound of the railcars screaming down the tracks cut through the silence between them. Adora stared at Catra with wide, surprised eyes and Catra stared back with her jaw set. Adora’s expression turned back to scrutinizing.

“Do you two have a thing?” she asked.

It was Catra’s turn to blink, dumbfounded. “What?”

Suddenly, Adora looked unsure. She averted her eyes. “You and Taline. Do you two have something going on together, too?”

Catra’s jaw dropped. *This* was what Adora was worried about right now? It didn’t even make sense! Well, she did have a thing with Taline—Sentinels were important to their Battlemages—but not in the way she knew Adora was imagining. Catra couldn’t believe her

ears. She no longer felt ashamed for regressing into an aggressive bitch when stressed. Now, she relished how easy a thing it was for her to do.

“Three years apart and absolutely nothing has changed, has it?” Catra pushed the snarl on her face into her voice as she shoved Adora with both hands.

Adora stumbled back, shock plain on her face.

“You really can’t help yourself, can you?” Catra didn’t let her get a word in. “Always sticking your nose into other peoples' business. Always thinking you're better than everyone else and that's why you need to get involved in their shit. You haven't changed at all!"

“Catra, I—”

“Did you ever stop to think maybe you’re sitting in this car with me because they didn’t want you around while they talked? That they were just too polite to say so to your face?” Technically it was true, and sure, Catra didn’t have to phrase it like that. But she was still seething, and she also knew nothing short of a metaphorical bombshell would derail Adora from her quest to break into that front car. She had to do everything she could to prevent that.

Adora’s confrontational demeanor crumbled. Now, she was hurt and trying but failing to hide it. “You haven’t changed much, either,” she said, voice shaking. “All these years and you still know exactly where to stick your claws to make them hurt the most.”

“Kinda have to if I’m going to protect someone as powerful and important as Taline.” Catra crossed her arm and tilted her head, the tip of her tail flicking behind her. “Maybe her and I are a thing. It would be none of your business if we were. How about you, huh? Are you and Corynth fucking? Is that why you’re so concerned about what Taline might be saying to him without you there?”

Adora's face twisted and, ah, there was that anger. Good. See how she liked it when Catra asked stupid, insulting things.

"I told you I just wanted to make sure they were okay!" Adora said. "You weren't there when they were fighting one another, Catra. He was trying to help her and she nearly killed him!"

Catra scoffed. According to Taline, she was the one out of her depth, but Adora took that scoff to mean Catra was blowing her off shoved her back in return. Catra gave just as good as she got, and when she pushed Adora yet again, she stumbled further back than before, halfway down the car.

"How did you even find him?" Catra asked. "Hero of the galaxy who's been dead for ten-plus years and, what, you just happen to bump into him back home? Figures. And let me guess, you stuck your nose into his business just like you do with everyone else. That's why you've been traveling with him, isn't it? Perfect, helpful Adora can't ever just take a hint and butt out for once in her life."

"Hah! Hahah!" Adora's eyes bulged with laughter that bordered on manic. "You have me all figured out, don't you? We've barely spoken to and you already know all there is to know." She stepped up until she was within arm's reach of Catra again. "Question. Do you think I was just 'butting in' to your life again when I reached out? You must have gotten my message."

"Yeah. You sure had a lot to brag about. Was that supposed to surprise me? Impress me?" Why was Catra doing this. They'd gone so far off the rails, but she couldn't reign in her anger or her hurt. All the resentment she'd bottled up over the years was just pouring out of her, poisoning everything.

"You wish I'd never reached out to you, don't you?" Adora puffed up until she loomed over Catra. "Admit it! You would have been perfectly happy to have never seen me again for the rest of your life."

Catra was tired of listening to Adora put words in her mouth. She screamed and pushed her with all her might. Adora launched backward, slamming hard against one of the side-facing benches in the trolley and collapsing on top of it in a jumbled, slouched heap.

"You're the one that told me you never wanted to see me again," Catra said in a low, dangerous voice after stalking up to her. She was heaving. "You're the one, Adora. What do you think I've been doing out here this whole time?" She sniffled and put everything she had into keeping a sob stuck at the back of her throat from escaping. Adora stared up at her, stunned and motionless. "I never wanted to leave Etheria. I came here because I had no other options.

"And I made it work! I busted my ass to have *something* to show for myself out here. And for you to just come back into it all 'la-di-da, I'm Adora, great to see you again. By the way, I know Taline was the one to give you *everything* after I kicked you to the curb. Are you two sleeping together'? Fuck you."

She'd intended the last part to be scathing and final, but it instead came out like pitiful, broken whining. She turned away and wiped a tear before it slid too far down her face. Adora continued to sit dumbstruck and silent on the bench like a sack of bricks.

"I don't want to be a spiteful person," Catra said in a whisper. "I scares me how easy it was to flip my shit at you the moment we hit even the smallest bump in the road, but I guess that's just how fast three years of hard work improving yourself can disappear down the drain."

She sighed and stood a little straighter. "You don't get to just come back into my life and pretend like we're buddy-buddy again. And I especially don't want to hear any opinions you might have on who I'm close to. Not now. Not after you made it especially clear where we stood three years ago."

Maybe that last part was giving away too much—opening herself up enough one might easily see the reason that comment set her off so bad, but Adora hadn't seemed to noticed.

"I was afraid something like this might happen," Adora said after a pause, just as a shrill screeching filled the air. At first, Catra was afraid it was another group of thralls, but then she realized Pip had engaged the brakes to the cars.

Adora's voice barely carried over the sound. "Glimmer kept telling me to reach out to you. Maybe I should have sooner, but I was afraid."

Catra whirled back on her, her voice cracking. "*Glimmer* was trying to get you to talk to me, again? Is that the only reason you reached out in the first place?"

Glimmer had tried to get her to do the same, of course, but Catra had gotten it in her head that Adora had reached out because she and she alone missed Catra enough to break the ice. Finding out it was only because Glimmer nagged her into doing it? Catra didn't know if she could take the disappointment on top of everything else.

The railcar eased to a stop and the doors to both cars hinged open, allowing them access to another underground platform similar to the first.

Adora must have seen something in Catra's expression, because she sat up with a resolute look on her face and reached forward to grab at Catra's wrist. "It's not like that," she said. "Whatever it is you're thinking in your head right now, it's wrong. Let me—"

Catra yanked out of her grip and stepped back. "Don't tell me how and what to think," she said. "You don't know me as well as you used to."

Taline, Corynth, Keren, and Trayn had already left the forward car and were waiting for the elevator on the platform outside. Catra

turned on her heel and marched out to meet them, leaving Adora reeling behind her.

She didn’t look back, and Adora finally picked herself up off the bench, dragging her feet over to wait with them in silence.

Chapter End Notes

> Never underestimate Adora's propensity to find the absolute worst thing to say at the worst possible moment xD Her asking Catra if she and Taline were a thing was a late draft change, but when the idea struck me to put it in I couldn't resist. It just made everything so much *worse* after that question dropped.
>
> Lot of dialogue this chapter to baseline us after all the action in the last chapter. I bet many of y'all weren't expecting Catra and Adora to make up soon (I got a comment or two expressing they hope they won't), but how many were thinking they'd actually go backward? To be fair, Catra's also contributing to the dysfunctionality. She's regressing into bad habits and catastrophizing herself, thinking that means all the progress she's made since leaving Etheria didn't count. The fact she actually gets sad over the imagined prospect of her and Adora not fully making up ever also adds another shade of grey to the whole thing.
>
> Next chapter in 2 weeks!

# Flight of the Angels

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

If Catra hadn't had her fill all those years riding elevators on Phoenix to get between the various wards, then this ride up to the orbital cannon control room on Archanas was enough to have think of taking the stairs everywhere for the foreseeable future.

She couldn't pretend even to herself that she was doing anything except avoiding Adora, who was standing in the corner of the elevator looking at the grated floor with an expression reminiscent of the single time Shadow Weaver had ever expressed explicit disappointment in her when they were kids. It almost broke Catra's heart all over again. She was trying to distract herself before she did something stupid, like try and talk to her again.

"It doesn't look like things went very well between the two of you," Taline said to her, under her breath.

"We fought," Catra said. "It wasn't pretty. I'm pretty sure we went backwards."

Taline didn't look much better, herself. Her eyes were red and puffy and a flush colored her cheeks. Corynth stood apart from them just like Adora in the far-too-spacious service elevator. Keren and Trayn fidgeted near him, clearly uncomfortable.

"I could say the same for you, actually," Catra said.

Taline gave a wry laugh. "I gave myself too much credit, it turns out. I wasn't expecting to lose my composure like that. It was one thing to fantasize over the years about what I'd say to him once I got the chance, but…it went downhill. Fast"

"We caught a glimpse through the window."

“I kissed him.”

“What?” Catra stopped side eying Taline and looked fully at her, mouth agape. Corynth was back with Adora, so he probably didn’t hear their conversation. Catra was at a loss. “O-oh. That’s…good? Good for you. Congratulations.”

Taline deflated, and Catra rushed to smooth things over.

“Sorry. Looks like we both struck out. I panicked and lashed out bad at Adora.” Catra made a face. “She asked if you and I were together.”

Taline’s eyebrows shot up. “Really? If only I had an award to hand her for being so good at putting her foot in her mouth.”

“No kidding. As soon as she said that?” Catra imitated an explosion with her hands. "It was like she’d flipped a switch in me. Everything that had built up over the years came rushing out. I couldn’t stop.”

“It’s good that happened on the train, at least. If ugly emotions like that are going to come out no matter what, you want it to happen on a quiet train ride underground than literally anywhere else. Especially not during a battle.”

Catra hummed her agreement and the elevator fell silent save for the sound of the mechanism shuttling them up. She looked at Taline out the corner of her eye, tracing the contour of her face.

Despite her puffy eyes and ruddy cheeks making her look wrung-out, Taline was beautiful. If Catra hadn’t come to view her as an authority figure, maybe she instead would have thought of her in the way Adora assumed. But the truth was Adora had nothing to worry about, and her worries were so outlandish they bordered on insulting. She just had no idea how to tell her everything she wanted to say—no idea how to start. And the fact they were running for their lives currently didn’t help spur her creativity, either.

“Are you ready for your first official assignment as my Sentinel?” Taline asked, making Catra jolt.

“I thought coming with you to Archanas was the first assignment. Or was it when you asked me to return that encrypted drive to Diallo?”

“Fine. Are you ready for the first set of orders you are probably going to disagree with, then?”

Catra furrowed her brow. She leaned in close and whispered, like they were conspiring. “Are…are you trying to tell a joke right now?” At the back of the elevator, Keren and Trayn were trying to engage with Adora, maybe cheer her up.

Taline set her lips in a thin line and sighed through her nose. “I need you to prioritize Corynth’s safety over mine.”

“Oh, hell the fuck no.”

“Catra—”

“I’m your Sentinel. Yours. I’m supposed to protect *you*, not him. Are you so smitten you’d ask me to abandon you?” Taline scowled, and another piece of understanding slotted into place for Catra. “No, this is part of ‘the plan,’ isn’t it? I take it back, you don’t need to tell me it is, I already know it’s stupid.”

“If he dies then we’ve lost. It’s that simple.”

“Okay, and? Why would he need my help in the first place? You said yourself you threw everything at him and still couldn’t match up. If anything, that’d be good cause for me to continue protecting you instead of him, don’t you think?”

“I glimpsed on the train just how strong a front he’s been putting up. I was doing a good job keeping everything together until I saw that—until he let me in, just for a moment.” Taline took a breath. “He might need help. Please, Catra. You’re the only one

who'd be able to keep up with him if all of us got cornered into a fight."

Yet another curveball. Catra didn't know where to begin with that last statement, and she didn't have time to begin either, because the elevator doors slid open. So instead, she scoffed and escaped out to the enormous, circular control room for the orbital gun without another word.

The others followed, and she heard Taline mutter under her breath about adults who act like difficult teenagers. Catra held her tongue.

"She's right, you know." Pip said in her head. "You'd be a better match to fight at his side than Adora."

::Can you not?:: Catra said. ::How about we focus on getting out of here first before we start arguing the merits of abandoning my own Battlemage.::

Pip sent a mental shrug across their bond, but didn't say anything else. It seemed to Catra like she was still preoccupied with something else which—fair. She was likely still juggling dozens of tasks helping them progress through the compound unmolested.

The orbital canon's control room was nothing like the centralized one they'd come from. Although this one too was a circular room, lined with massive server racks and screens, there was more open space, since this place controlled only one enormous gun anchored outside rather than an entire mining compound.

They stopped near the center of the room. Taline stood ramrod straight, staring out the clerestory windows lining the walls just under the ceiling.

"I've never seen the storm get that bad," she said, breaking the silence their echoing footsteps had filled. "No planet ever looked like this, not even during the war."

Catra followed her line of sight. At first it looked like there was nothing to see, the windows coated in a strange, mixed-brown tint that would have left the room dark were it not for the halogen lights and computer screen luminescence. Then lightning flashed outside and she realized what she thought was a dense window coating was actually a raging, swirling storm.

The canon itself should have been enormous and clearly visible, but not even an outline of it bled through. Her ears picked up on the sound of rushing, screeching wind: what she'd initially assumed was the life support and instrumentation forming white noise in the background was actually the storm. It was powerful enough it imposed itself through the concrete walls.

"Imagine standing out there in it, frantically trying to set up equipment," Corynth said.

Adora, Keren, and Trayn all had their guard up, each of their heads twisting like they were on a swivel to survey the room. She didn't blame them for their caution: something didn't feel right.

"Well, Glimmer didn't beat us here, which probably saves us from hearing her gloat," she said, "but I don't like the idea of waiting around for too long, either. Where is she?"

The speakers in the room popped and came alive. "She's close," Pip said through them. "Yet another issue, though. When do they end, am I right? The storm has grown too strong. The signal I've been streaming to their Warbird to guide them here can't reach."

Taline cursed. "She's flying blind? In this?" She traded places with Catra to stand in the direct center of the room. "Will a physical beacon work? Is she close enough to see us through the storm if I project something up?"

"The last coordinates I could pull from her craft placed them roughly three hundred clicks out. With the kind of low visibility outside, fifteen thousand lumens could do the trick, maybe twenty just to be safe. Can you swing that?"

“I can certainly try.”

“That will blind everyone in the room,” Catra said. She knew how strong Entrapta’s flashlight on her PDA was, and it wasn’t even half that.

“I’ll cast it as a self-contained beam. You won’t be able to look directly at me, but it won’t blind you otherwise.”

“You’ll need to keep it up enough for her to arrive,” Corynth said, drawing her and Catra’s attention. “The Abomination will take advantage of you leaving yourself wide open like that.”

Taline looked insulted. “You think me so unskilled I can’t do anything to defend myself if I’m standing there trying to project a light in the sky? I can defend myself, at least.”

“Of course I don’t think you’re unskilled.” Corynth stared at her and Taline stared back. Catra could tell they were having a full nonverbal argument with each other despite no one actually being able to see Corynth’s expression. It might have been amusing had they not been where they were.

“Guys?”

All heads snapped to Adora, who had the Sword of Protection already manifested and held ready in both hands. Keren and Trayn had pulled close to her, weapons hugged to chests.

Living smoke and shadow were above them, twisting and coalescing into amorphous forms with an invisible wind. When Adora took a swipe at one of them, her sword cleaved straight through, and the two separate bodies of roiling shadow grew again. The control room lights flickered, the storm outside surged¸ and Corynth and Taline jumped into action.

“Keren, Trayn, with me,” Taline said, twisting her hands as an intricate, multi-layered rune bloomed under her feet against the floor. “Adora, you too. Move!”

On instinct, Catra stepped within an arm's reach of Taline even though she didn't call for her. Keren and Trayn obeyed the orders without question, sprinting inside the ring she'd drawn into the ground, facing their backs to her and aiming their weapons downrange, tracking the forms still dancing in the air.

Adora hesitated. Her and Corynth were maybe twenty steps away, and instead of closing that distance she turned to Corynth and said something with a furrowed brow—something that Catra missed on account of all the blood rushing through her ears and adrenaline coursing through her body.

"Get in here!" Taline said, finishing the rune with a final flourish. She sounded frantic. "We can't be caught separated when they manifest!"

Adora didn't pay her any attention; it was only Corynth she looked to. When he gestured with a tilt of his head, the defiant resolve on Adora's face give way. She nodded to him, then took a step toward their group, away from Corynth.

A shiver ran down Catra's spine—a sudden warning she understood meant danger but not from where—but it was Corynth who acted before she could. He grabbed Adora by the shoulder and yanked her to him just as one of the shadowed forms dove. It hit the ground where Adora stood moments before, and in the mass of swirling, amorphous darkness, Catra saw a form: a spindled leg that emerged, then pivoted.

After the leg, a blackened scythe appeared from the shadow at neck-level. Corynth maneuvered Adora around by the shoulder like she was a marionette, guiding her out of the way as the scythe swung and missed. Keren and Trayn trained their weapons on the thing and Taline raised a palm with a rune already spinning on it. Catra felt useless so far away with nothing but her claws.

The two other shadows still dancing in the air dove like the first, leaping again for Adora. The lights in the room shut off, plunging

the whole room into darkness, but not before Catra watched Corynth and Adora get overrun.

"No!"

A fireball the size of Trayn's head appeared on Catra's left. It streaked across the room, tracing a line from Taline's palm—the only light source keeping the dark at bay. Even Catra with her keen senses couldn't see anything except for what the flames illuminated. The fireball collided with the shadows that had surrounded Corynth and Adora, intermixed with them, creating a firestorm vortex.

It mesmerized Catra until she noticed a fourth figure lurking near them in the stark shadows the fire vortex cast. When it moved, so did she, claws extended, and she parried a blow meant to take Taline's head off moments before it connected.

Alarm bells rioted in Catra's head when she saw the Trooper, outlined against the dark, turn its attention to her. This was worse than when realized too late in Moriarty's office that he could move faster than she'd anticipated. This time, instinct warned her death was imminent. Even Pip seemed to freak out beyond the ability to verbalize.

Catra dropped to the floor and rolled, narrowly missing getting impaled in the gut as the Trooper stabbed down at her. And when she sprung up to her feet, claws primed and swiping straight for the head, it had already anticipated her. As the creature lunged for her midair, she grabbed its forearm and vaulted over, landing in a crouch low to the ground behind it, heart hammering in her chest. Only her prior training aboard the *Constable* saved her from getting caught.

Taline capitalized on the opening, following up with a palm to its chest before it had the chance to attack again. A flash of light burst at the point of contact, and the Trooper flew back, out of reach, vanishing into the dark. A residual afterimage of Taline's

rune flashed against Catra's retinas, the only proof she had they'd narrowly escaped death yet again.

"I hate this!" Taline sounded like she'd given up any pretense for even appearing in control. She gestured again with her hands as the Trooper emerged from the darkness once more. The circle of runes Taline had drawn on the floor earlier came to life. "I hate this so fucking much."

A wall of blue flames encircled them, so intense Catra could barely through to the other side. It bathed the room in blue, and the Trooper reared back shrieking in pain when it slammed into it.

Keren and Trayn were with her, heads swiveling, waiting for that Trooper to reappear. The fire and shadow vortex still swirled across the room.

A snapping sound pulled Catra's attention back just in time for her to see the vortex burst through the flame wall, the swirling shadows blooming into a rain of cinders that lit the far end of the room. Three Troopers stalked Corynth and Adora. A gash ran down Adora's cheek, her eyes lit with magic and a snarl on her face as she brandished the sword.

Catra looked back and saw Taline hunched in on herself, breathing heavy. Her body was wreathed in light that grew steadily brighter, her face contorting in either pain and concentration, maybe both.

With a burst of movement, she punched an open palm into the air as if she were trying to touch the triple-height ceiling above them. Catra averted her eyes as a blinding beam of light engulfed Taline's form and shot skyward. The beam punched through the ceiling, letting the screeching and screaming of the ion storm bleed into the very room.

It was Glimmer's signal—a light bright enough to see even through the storm. She *had* to see it. And as Corynth and Adora continued to fend off the Troopers together, Catra knew they had no choice but to hold out until she arrived.

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“Another anomaly. Geeze, how many of these are we going to run up against?”

Kyle maneuvered them around the hundredth obstacle lighting up the radar tracking their surroundings. His hands shook as he fought the controls, and the Warbird rattled as it cut through the storm.

“I’m still not picking up even a hint of the signal,” Lonnie said. She glanced up at Glimmer from the co-pilot’s seat. “Please tell me you’re having better luck than I am.”

Glimmer made a face. On top of protecting their craft with magic, she’d also been probing at the vast, planet-covering storm surrounding them, poking and prodding and searching for something coherent to grasp onto that might lead them to the others. So far, no luck. “All I feel is pain and confusion.”

A stroke of exhaustion fell over her like a pall when she thought about it, and Lonnie’s expression turned concerned.

“How are you holding up?” she asked. “You look like you’re running out of gas.”

“I’ve still got some left in me.” Glimmer made her eyes pulse with magic to make her point.

“I’m surprised you’re still on your feet after everything that happened on Rinne, honestly. Tell me if you start to run low, okay?”

Glimmer chuckled. “Why? Do you have a second Battlemage hidden up your sleeve to swap out with me when I do?”

Lonnie smirked, and even Kyle laughed through his nose. “Please. You magic types are rare enough as it is, to say nothing of someone with your pedigree. Etherian Princesses don’t grow on trees out here, you know?”

“Ah, so it’s my heritage you’re after? Why does that make me feel no better than a highly prized dog?” The banter helped Glimmer concentrate better. She welcomed it.

“You’re the team leader and I’m your second in command,” Lonnie said. “I need to know if you’re starting to fatigue, just like a commander needs to know when their soldiers are running low on ammunition or food rations. If your magic we rely on to achieve our objectives is in danger of petering out, I need to know in order to have our contingency plan ready.”

Glimmer furrowed her brow. Her Battlemage hidden up the sleeve comment had been a joke, of course, but not whatever contingency plan Lonnie was talking about. She was about to ask for clarification when a blinding pillar of light cut through the storm, shooting high into the sky in the distance.

“That’s her!” Glimmer said, sensing Taline’s power emanating like the buffeting winds of a hurricane. “Kyle, get us to the epicenter of that light as quick as you can. Scan the surrounding area, find us a safe place to land.”

“Copy.” Kyle nudged the Warbird’s nose toward the light and pushed the throttle.

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After Taline had saturated herself with light, Catra had looked back at her exactly once, and that half second glance was enough to convince her not to do it a second time.

“She warned you, didn’t she?” Pip said in her head.

Catra instead concentrated on scanning the room for that fourth Trooper that had engaged them earlier. Taline had lessened the intensity of the flame wall surrounding them, but that combined with the light emanating off her personal beacon lit the room better than the actual halogen ceiling lights had when they first arrived.

And despite that, Catra couldn’t locate that fourth Trooper, enhanced senses or no.

::Can you sense it?:: Catra took a wider stance and crouched lower to the ground in preparation to springboard away should it succeed in ambushing them unaware a second time.

“Of course I can.”

Catra frowned. Why was she having such a hard time detecting it if Pip wasn’t? They were intertwined. Shouldn’t she have been able to see it, too?

::A little help would be nice. I can’t find it.::

Pip scoffed, although Catra got the sense she was more harried than annoyed with her—like Catra was barely a secondary concern among other things. Something flashed out the corner of her eye. Keren and Trayn must have seen it too because they startled and fired, hitting nothing except the flame wall.

“You’d think you could at the very least fend one off since I’m helping juggle three.” Pip said. “A better question would be why are you standing around courting it when *you* could be helping, too.”

::Courting it?:: Another flash of darkness amidst the dancing light and they all turned, once again to see nothing. ::What do you mean by courting it? I’m trying to protect Taline.::

A split-second feeling came over her and she dashed for Taline, claws extended, keeping her in her peripheral vision so as to not be fully blinded. The Trooper appeared once more, looming, a black inkblot against the light and poised to strike. Catra parried again before it could cleave her in two, and Taline, while maintaining the beacon projected into the sky, followed up with another magic-infused strike.

This time, instead of throwing the creature back, Taline immobilized it midair. Keren and Trayn swiveled and emptied their

clips into it. Their weapons seemed to have no effect, even though Catra knew they were firing near pure ignominite bullets. Each hole they opened in the Trooper closed up as quickly as they appeared.

Taline splayed her fingers and threw the Trooper back. When it hit the wall of flame, it screeched in pain before punching through to the other side. The flames stoked higher and flared louder than before, as if warning the thing not to come back or risk a more painful burn.

"There's no easy way to kill those things," Taline said through a chorus of a thousand voices. "I'm not certain we could incapacitate it, either. Not while I'm concentrating on the light."

So, the plan was to scrabble and stay alive until Glimmer came? That's what the Beast had reduced them to, already?

The Trooper stalked them from the other side of the wall. Catra could track its silhouette bleeding through the opaqueness of the flames. As it paced, she caught another set of moving figures: Corynth and Adora, still engaged with the other three Troopers on the far side of the control room. And for some reason, even though she could barely make them out with her eyes, Catra could still sense exactly how they were fighting as if nothing was obstructing her vision. Like her other senses were honed in enough to paint the full picture for her anyways.

Corynth was leading the three around by the nose, one hand on Adora's shoulder as he pivoted her about, helping her dodge strikes that came too fast for her to register like she was a marionette puppet and he was her puppeteer. As she continued to monitor them, Catra realized a couple things: first, that Adora was far, *far* out of her element fighting these things. Even powered up such that her magic was now evaporating off her skin and saturating her eyes, every swing of her sword met nothing but air —the Troopers were just too fast.

And second, that Catra herself could track these Troopers' movements. They moved faster than Moriarty and the training holograms Catra faced aboard the *Constable*, and maybe it was because they were far enough away Catra hadn't lost them like the fourth Trooper gunning for Taline, but she could read their intentions. It felt like they were openly telegraphing them.

Corynth pivoted around one of the Troopers. There was a weak point at the juncture at the back where their shoulders met their neck, and he had a clear opening to attack there. How Catra knew that was the weak point she had  no idea—she just did. What she didn't know, however, was why Corynth didn't take the opening.

Adora swiped at one with the sword. The Trooper twisted out of the way and carried its momentum through its arm, fashioning it into a spear. Corynth pivoted again and maneuvered her away in a smooth motion. When the Trooper lunged with its spear arm, Corynth redirected it with his free hand, already coated with brackish magic energy, and drove the spear into the ground.

This repeated several times over the span of a handful of seconds. An opening in the Troopers' combined front would reveal itself, and Corynth would refrain from pursuing it in lieu of sticking close and protecting Adora.

::She's holding him back,:: Catra said. ::But I still don't know why he isn't taking those openings He's more than fast enough to exploit one and get back to her in time.::

She'd seen how he moved enough to know it was the truth. Hell, if it was Catra, she'd give it a try, especially since fighting two Troopers would be easier than juggling three if they succeeded in incapacitating one.

Pip didn't respond and it made Catra jittery. She wasn't ignoring her, but that just meant whatever she was focusing on took up enough attention she *couldn't* answer. And for someone that had as much juice as Pip to struggle this much keeping the compound under her control, that was a scary thought.

It took Corynth three more telegraphed openings before he finally took one. The second he reached for the back of the Trooper's neck, magic arcing across his fingertips the other two turned on Adora so fast, the way they canceled out their body's inertia to make the moved looked downright uncanny.

With sudden horror, Catra all at once realized why Corynth hadn't taken any of the earlier openings. The Troopers had been deliberately leaving themselves open. It was a trap.

Adora saw the attack coming, her eyes blowing wide in surprise realizing she couldn't get out of the way in time. Catra realized it, too, just as she realized that by taking the opening Corynth wouldn't be able to bail her out, either.

*You're the only one who'd be able to keep up with him,* Taline had said. Now it made sense. Suddenly, Taline's surprise at how quickly Catra had taken to Pip's enhancements had proper context, as did all those comments Pip had been making about 'reintegrating' after coming back.

Corynth had a version of Pip in him, too. They'd likely been with each other for years ever since his supposed death. And with Pip fully reconstituted between the two of them…

"Tal!" Catra said, tensing her body in anticipation. "Get me out there, now!"

Taline's magic hooked Catra under her breastbone and yanked her forward. It was the very same sensation from when Taline teleported the two of them aboard Horde Prime's citadel. In less than a moment, Catra rocketed forward through the flame wall, past the fourth Trooper still stalking them, and toward the Trooper moments away from cutting Adora in half.

She hooked her arm around its neck, yanking it off center and forcing it miss Adora. She twisted around it like it was a pole, driving her knee into the head of a second Trooper. The movement startled the third, and Corynth finally realized a true

opening to strike at its exposed neck with a bolt of magic. That third Trooper jerked and squealed before exploding.

*Ah*, Catra realized, vaulting to the ground in a low crouch as viscous black goo fell like rain and coated the room. *It's not so much overwhelming their durability with firepower as it is reaching a near impossible spot to strike.*

"Took her long enough," Pip said at last. Her voice rang in Catra's head, but she didn't sound like she was talking to her.

::She's right on time.::

Catra almost tripped when Corynth's reply also echoed in her head. He shot her a meaningful glance behind the mask as they rounded on the first Trooper together, bringing it down before the second could gather its bearings.

"Well, she wouldn't have been cutting it so close if you had just let me tell her to stick with you." Pip said. "Even Taline was trying to tell her but she wouldn't listen."

::Hey, I didn't think this is what she meant,:: Catra said. New data was streaming directly into Catra's head from the link. It was like Pip had released the floodgates, unlocking an entirely new aspect of their bond she hadn't known existed moments before. ::I thought she was getting on with some stupid sacrificial bullshit.::

Admittedly, she was maybe, *maybe* projecting a little bit of her experience with Adora onto Taline. Still, Pip shot a strangely smug feeling—not to her, but to Corynth—across their intertwined connection. The fact Catra could now feel and decipher *him* as an endpoint among their modest web was more surprising than anything.

::She wouldn't have been half as proficient at this if we just told her,:: Corynth said, ignoring Pip's gloating in a way Catra could feel made her steam. ::Why do you think there's so little I can do for Adora? You know how much impact self-discovery has on something as innate as this.::

Together, they took down the last Trooper that wasn't preoccupied with getting through Taline's defenses.

"Do I?" Pip's voice dripped with sarcasm. Catra wondered why until more information came across the connection. Years of small moments flashed in her head—moments of Pip similarly withholding information from Corynth in previous adventures. She'd even said the same thing about self-discovery to him as they'd integrated over the years.

"Holy shit. Catra? How did you get here so quickly?"

Catra spun and looked a surprised Adora square in the face. The entire exchange, including Catra arriving to help Corynth take down all but one of the Troopers, had happened in less than a few second. So fast Adora had only just realized what had happened.

When Catra noticed the shadow of the fourth and final Trooper looming behind Adora its blade arm already wound back to strike, her heart almost stopped. It must have given up on Taline and the others the moment Catra left to reinforce Corynth.

A Warbird crashed through the ceiling before anything else could happen. Rocks and debris rained from above, rocking the room hard enough Adora lost her footing. She fell to the floor, and the Trooper, similarly off balance, missed its swing.

The Warbird strafed the inside perimeter of the room, its afterburners melting the electronic consoles and screens lining the wall. Catra pounced, landing atop Adora, grabbing her shoulders, and rolling the two of them together across the floor before the Trooper could regain its balance and attack again.

The doors to the Warbird's crew compartment slid open as it continued to fishtail feet above the ground. A familiar set of dreadlocks dressed in the armor of a Vanguard Commander appeared, flanked on both sides by a half-dozen soldiers. All of them were looking down the sights of their repeater rifles aimed inside the room.

“Call your target and burst fire in pairs!” Lonnie said as the craft touched down inside the room. “You know the drill. Don’t make the Angel have to come out and do your job for you.”

The soldiers opened fire and the single standing Trooper turned into a near imperceptible blur as it dodged a hail of ignominite bullets. Taline’s wall of fire came down, and she no longer glowed. Instead, she, Keren, and Trayn ran at a dead sprint for the Warbird.

Catra released Adora and pulled her up off the ground, shoving her toward the craft. “Go!” she said. “I’ll be right behind you. Get moving!”

Adora looked like she was about to argue, or maybe reach for Catra to pull her along and make sure they didn’t get separated. Corynth, thank the Empire for him, grabbed Adora by the wrist instead and spurred her forward with him as he sprinted for the Warbird, too.

The three puddles the Trooper had dissolved into begin to stir at the corners of Catra’s vision as they began to reconstitute themselves. Once Corynth and Adora had gotten a head start, she followed. Sprinting for the Warbird from behind allowed Catra to act as a buffer between the Troopers and Adora should any of them make any last ditch effort to attack.

Everything was to ensure her and Corynth’s safety. Taline, Keren, and Trayn were far enough ahead they likely didn’t need help.

One by one, their team made it aboard. When Corynth threw Adora into the hold and scrambled in himself, the Warbird revved its engines and began to lift off the ground. Catra had ample time to leap up and inside herself.

“Hurry!” Adora said, kneeling on the precipice inside as the craft pulled further off the ground. Her voice was nearly lost among the sound of the engines and the ion storm whistling through the holes in the ceiling.

Catra could sense all four Troopers pursuing her now. It was a persistent, ominous feeling of death she couldn't shake at the back of her head. They were gaining on her despite the soldiers riddling them with bullets. Corynth and Taline stood on either side of the open doorway, eyes crackling with magic. One of the soldiers pulled inside, and Glimmer appeared in the spot they vacated, eyes glowing purple as Catra pumped her legs.

All three mages raised their hands forth, two with runes spinning on the ends of their palm while Corynth's seemed to be driven by pure willpower. Three beams of magic exploded forward, streaking past Catra. Troopers screeched and yelled with the sound of the impact. Catra she could practically smell the energy searing their flesh as she leapt, the Warbird having pulled up high enough she just caught the lip of the crew hold with both hands.

Two soldiers abandoned their rifles to grab her arms and try to haul her up. Just as they grabbed hold, one Trooper latched onto her leg and weighed her down.

Alarms sounded from inside the cockpit. The Warbird lurched to the side, throwing most of the soldiers off their feet. Corynth, Glimmer, and Taline all rounded on it, shooting three continuous streams of fire past Catra, close enough she felt it singe her fur through her sweat soaked uniform.

The Trooper did not let go of her. Despite even more yelling and screeching and the smell of charred meat, it did not let go.

"It's going to pull the whole damn Warbird down with it!" someone yelled.

Searing pain lanced through Catra's whole body with the effort she put into holding on. Her arms were liable to tear off before they crashed. Just as she was certain the Trooper would sooner rip her in half than release her, Adora appeared above, face contorted in rage, smoky white magic trailing out her eyes and her mouth.

She lifted the Sword of Protection in both hands and swung. Catra flinched, only for the weight holding her down by her ankles disappear. So much was happening, she didn't recognize Rogelio was there, too, until he'd reached over the edge of the craft, grabbed her by the scruff of her neck with one hand, and pulled her in.

The Warbird rocketed skyward, punching through the hole in the ceiling Taline had made earlier with her magic. And with a lot of screaming and cursing, the soldiers managed to get the sliding door shut and locked just as they plunged into the storm outside.

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"Strap in!"

Adora might have wondered why the pilot's voice sounded so familiar echoing from the cockpit if the force of their ascent wasn't pushing her into the grated floor hard enough to mark her skin. She'd swung the sword too hard freeing Catra from the Trooper's grasp and accidentally fallen on her back.

Lonnie—what a surprise it was to see her—hoisted her up like she was a suitcase, one arm fisting her shirt in a vice grip, before shoving her into one of the open bucket seats bolted to the side of the crew compartment. Adora landed with an oomph, and by the time she realized someone had strapped her in, the rest of the seats were already occupied. Lonnie had crab walked back to the cockpit fighting against another swell of g-forces.

Rogelio was across from her, slotted between other soldiers, strapping himself in one-armed. Keren and Trayn had occupied adjacent seats nearby and were leaned toward one another, holding some clandestine conversation in hushed, rapid whispers. Corynth, Taline, and Glimmer remained standing in the center aisle, subtle magic banding at their feet revealing how they could stand as if inertia held no power over them.

And Catra stood with them, although by the way she gripped the overhead rail, body swaying with the movements of the craft and

muscles rippling with effort, she was at the full mercy of the laws of physics. If only there was just one more open seat for her to take, although something about the way Catra set her jaw told Adora she'd have chosen to remain standing even if there was.

Adora thought she'd feel incensed or at least annoyed watching her stand there among practical demi-gods while the everyone else relied on the seats—even Lonnie had strapped into the copilot chair at the craft's front. Instead, it was dejection that iced her veins. She was She Ra, damnit. If anything, she should have been the one standing strong and freeing her seat for Catra, but…

*There won't be much we can do against them until Catra realizes she can step in.* Corynth's words to her as they fought within the vortex of Troopers came back to her *Not with you so exposed and Taline gunning for my head the moment she thinks I'm pushing myself.*

Even he didn't want her. All this time traveling together, all the progress she'd made with her powers after years of nothing, and still she'd been reduced to little more than a puppet on strings as he led her around by the shoulder. She'd been nothing but dead weight.

Guilt and self-loathing beat at her. She hunkered down in the chair, wondering if she might just disappear altogether if she pushed into the seating enough.

"I did not expect to see Troopers at the rendezvous." Glimmer said, looking at Taline with a furrow in her brow. "And four of them at that."

Taline frowned. "I don't think we should be surprised, given where we are. You showed up just in time."

"In retrospect, I think he had the right idea vouching for me to come." Glimmer tilted her head toward Corynth, whose back was toward them as he faced the cockpit. He didn't speak, but Adora didn't get the sense he was ignoring them, either. "Anyways,

you're welcome. I was worried breaking through the roof like that wouldn't work, but we couldn't find anywhere to land."

"Kyle made it work." Lonnie reached over and thumped the pilot on the shoulder. "Kyle can make anything work."

The pilot leaned out of their seat and flashed everyone in the troop hold a thumbs up and a smile, until Lonnie smacked the back of his head, telling him to pay attention to what he was doing.

Adora's jaw dropped when she realized the 'Kyle' they were talking about was the same Kyle she'd known in the Horde growing up. He was older, with chiseled features, but it was him. He, Lonnie, and Rogelio had stuck together this whole time, through everything they must have experienced together after leaving Etheria.

"I for one am glad you decided to ram the whole ship through the ceiling like that," Catra said. "Those things are smart. They were trying to bait Corynth and Adora with openings before I stepped in. And the fact all four were moments away from catching me?" A visible shudder traveled down her body.

"You know I'm going to gloat about saving your skin once we get out of this," Glimmer said, smiling in a way that contradicted her teasing. She was overjoyed to see Catra again. Adora averted her eyes.

Kyle took the craft through another sharp turn, the harness keeping Adora in the bucket seat pressing divots into her skin through her clothes. "These obstacles are cropping up everywhere, now," he said, voice strained as he fought against the controls. "The flight computer can barely differentiate them anymore."

"This is the first time any of us has been planet-side as a world fully succumbs." Lonnie was leaned out over the armrest of the copilot chair, looking back at Taline with thinly veiled worry. "At

least we were insulated somewhat on Scavria. What the hell is going on out there?"

"How long has it been since you called offering to pick us up?" Corynth spoke for the first time since boarding. Every soldier sitting down turned to stare at him. Even Lonnie looked out of her depth when she realized he'd asked her the question, and she'd have to answer.

"I don't know," she said, before glancing at a screen on her dashboard. "Twelve minutes, roughly."

"And how long did we say it would take the planet to finish actualizing?"

Lonnie's face turned pale. "Fifteen… *Shit.*"

"The Abomination does not want us to leave. Now that it knows we escaped its Troopers, I anticipate it will step in, personally. And with the planet on the cusp of fully reawakening..." He paused and his words seemed to sink in not just for Lonnie, but everyone in the Warbird. He turned and spoke to Glimmer. "Do you still have those coordinates I had you forward to the rest of the survivors in orbit?"

"There's no way we'll make it there in the next two minutes," she said. "We haven't even broken out of the atmosphere."

"We don't need to. Just point the ship toward those coordinates and burn at full speed. Let me worry about the rest."

By the look Taline shot him, she didn't like the sound of that. It was Corynth and Glimmer that didn't take their eyes off one another, however. Almost like Glimmer was trying to size him up, or find some hint at subterfuge.

Finally, she looked past him at Lonnie. "Follow the heading."

Lonnie returned an uncertain, "Aye, ma'am," and the next moment, Kyle cursed aloud, throwing them into another vicious

turn.

“Hold on!” he said.

The straps creaked, straining to keep Adora in secured in her chair. Keren and Trayn held hands, squeezing each other so tight Keren’s knuckles turned white. The Warbird lurched again when Kyle pushed them into a falling roll. Inertia tore Catra from the handhold and slammed her into Adora’s lap.

Adora snaked her arms around her by instinct and held tight. Another sharp turn pushed Catra harder against her. Adora almost passed out from blood pooling in places other than her head until Kyle pulled them out of a third turn, and her senses came back into focus.

“Sorry,” Catra said, already trying to extricate herself from Adora’s lap while mumbling more words she couldn’t pick up. Adora squeezed tighter. Catra stilled, then squirmed in her grip until she could look over her shoulder at her. “Adora, I’m fine now. You can let go.”

Adora shook her head. If she let go, Catra would fly off and injure herself. “I don’t want to let you go.”

“Come on.” Catra pushed hard and Adora held tighter. “Stop playing around, Adora.”

“I’m not playing around.” Adora buried her face in the crook of Catra’s neck and tried to ground herself with a shuddering breath. “I’m not playing around,” she said again. “I don’t want to let you go. I never wanted to let you go to begin with.”

By the way Catra stilled in her arms, she must have realized Adora hadn’t just meant now. Her ears swiveled the way they always did when she started to listen extra hard. Seeing that released something deep inside Adora, opening the floodgates.

"I think about that day we last saw each other a lot. Bright Moon that day seems so long ago. I think about what I said to you, how

if it hurt me as much as it did to say it then it must have hurt you even worse to hear it. The last I saw of you, you were running away from me in tears. I did that to you."

The Warbird flipped into another steep, corkscrew maneuver. Adora squeezed her eyes shut, blocking out the screams of the others.

"I lied when I said that I didn't want to see you again!" she said, yelling to be heard above the noise. "I thought I was doing the right thing, telling you that I couldn't afford distractions, that I had to focus on strengthening my connection to She Ra. I thought it was the right choice to make for the sake of everyone's lives in the galaxy. But…I was lying. I was lying when I said I didn't want to see you again. I lied to you, I lied to myself…and that was the last thing I'd ever said to you. I thought it was the last thing I was ever *going* to say to you."

The tension in Catra's body didn't ease even as the Warbird stabled out again.

"But it was wrong," Adora said. "And I should have reached out to you soon as I realized. I should have done it before you'd even left home. I should have come out and told you not to leave with Taline. I should have told you that I wanted you to stay and that I was just being stupid because I was afraid of what would happen if I couldn't figure my powers out."

Every 'should have' rose with urgency until Adora couldn't ignore the desperate hoarseness in her voice. A long silence stretched between them, punctuated only by the roaring of the storm outside, the muted sounds of worry from those in the passenger hold with them, and the alarms and curses coming from the cockpit.

"So why didn't you?" Catra asked at last.

"I was afraid." The answer came as if by reflex, and Adora cringed. It wasn't an acceptable excuse despite it being the truth.

“I agonized over what to say to you, I swear I did, but every time I thought to reach out, it just terrified me. And with everything going on, I’d let myself get swept up in some other pressing matter. Some new emergency or project on Etheria to enhance our battle preparedness, or some new scheme to get back in touch with my powers. I…I took the cowards way out, every time.”

Catra didn’t speak, and she didn’t move. The longer this went on, the harder of a time Adora had trying to drown out the panicked sounds of everyone else in the Warbird with them. Soon, she thought she heard the creaking, crunching sounds of the craft’s frame warping as Kyle continued to push it through the storm.

“I didn’t just reach out to you again because of Glimmer,” Adora said. “Maybe that’s what it sounded like back on the train, but I swear that’s not what it was. I just—I missed you, Catra. So much I couldn’t distract myself from it anymore even if I tried. I know I should have talked to you sooner, and I know you’d probably be too upset with me…that it’d be too late for us to fix anything, but”—she swallowed—"I just needed you to know the truth. You deserved to know the truth.”

Catra still didn’t speak. She seemed to be sitting even stiller than before. Adora’s had screwed it up, she absolutely had. The anxiety weighing on her these past years was finally gone after confessing, but in its place now was this aching nexus of pain, and every moment Catra didn’t respond, Adora’s spirits sank.

A new alarm blared from the cockpit.

“I can’t evade it!” Kyle said, struggling with the controls. He yanked the yoke as far to the side as it would go and everyone got thrown against the side wall of their chairs. Lonnie braced with both hands against the frame of the dashboard, and Adora held onto Catra with a death grip.

“I can’t evade it!” Kyle said a second time. “Brace! Everyone, br—”

The Warbird jerked again, sending everyone slamming into the opposite side of their seat harnesses. Adora almost lost Catra. A sickening wrenching, crunching sound tore through the compartment, sending shivers cascading down her back.

The top of the troop compartment ripped free and disappeared into the vortex clouds. The sound of the storm raging free inside the enclosure swallowed everyone's screams. It was so loud Adora couldn't parse her own thoughts.

The Warbird tipped onto its side, and Adora could tell by the way Kyle and Lonnie were panicking in the cockpit they were fighting to regain control. A lightning bolt split the sky, illuminating the silhouettes of dozens of skyscrapers. They were thousands of feet into the atmosphere, but those shadows loomed over them all the same. Like curved pillars buttressing a crystalline dome.

Glimmer planted her feet wide, still standing in the middle aisle. Her eyes and body saturated with crackling magic. With a burst that pummeled Adora like a wave, she infused the Warbird with her essence, steadying it, allowing Kyle to get the it wobbling on the right heading again.

"Grace of the Empire, that is way too many of them!" he said, staring up through the opening in the ceiling.

Adora followed his gaze. With a naked-eye view of the storm, she saw the skyscrapers begin to move. That was when she realized they weren't buildings at all, but planet-sized tendrils akin to what had sprouted from the Eden Abomination's back when she'd faced it. Six of them swayed then dove, tearing through the clouds on a direct collision-course trajectory for them.

"Holy shit." Catra pressed deeper into her lap. "On second thought, hold on to me tighter."

Taline and Glimmer moved as mirror images of one another, thrusting their palms up to the sky as if to physically hold it back. A shield dense enough to see radiated inches from their palms

and blocked the tendrils moments before they were about to cut the ship in half.

The Warbird strained to keep altitude. Even against the storm Adora could hear the engine pushing past its redzone, and one look at Taline and Glimmer's faces told her they wouldn't be able to keep the shield up for long. Mortal fear wracked her body when their shield, built by the combined might of their respective magic, began to split and crack.

Corynth watched them struggle. Adora wondered why he wasn't helping, then Taline shot him a look—a clear demand he not involve himself. Adora couldn't understand why.

The tendrils pulled away and Taline and Glimmer let the shield lapse. Both were gasping, sweat pouring down their faces as they looked to each other for what seemed like mutual reassurance that the other was okay. When the tendrils geared up to slam into them again, they blanched.

"Kyle?" Glimmer asked.

"There's no way we're evading that," he said. "We've lost thirty percent of our maneuverability. Not to mention with the craft no longer sealed, the air will be too thin if I push us much higher."

Corynth cocked his head and Taline shook hers. "Don't you dare," she said. "We'll take care of it."

"We will?" Glimmer shot Taline a skeptical look. "It doesn't look like either of us have enough to shield against a mild wind, let alone another tendril onslaught."

Taline didn't have an immediate rebuttal, but Glimmer's words seemed to flip a switch in Lonnie. She vaulted out of the copilot chair and kneeled next to an access hatch built into the floor. Rogelio, without any prompting, unstrapped himself and wobbled over with careful, well-braced steps. Together, they threw open the hatch and pulled out a large, sealed crate.

“What kind of miracle can you two work with that?” Lonnie asked, kicking the crate over to Glimmer and Taline.

A blinding light burst from the box when they opened it, and Glimmer’s eyebrows shot up. “You took one of the munitions boxes from Scavria?” she asked, staring in awe at a mountain of gleaming apeiron crystals inside.

“Told you I had something up my sleeve,” Lonnie said, before glancing up at tendrils with apprehension. They were even closer. “Now answer my question. Is that enough to do something about that?”

Glimmer and Taline shot each other tired, mischievous smirks. “More than enough,” Glimmer said.

They each took a step away from the box, then faced one another.

“If there’s one silver lining from all of this,” Taline said, spreading her arms, her eyes flickering once more, “it’s that you can finally say you’ve visited Archanas.”

“This isn’t what I had in mind whenever I complained about the moniker.” Glimmer mirrored Taline’s posture and rolled her eyes, although her smile didn’t leave.

The soldiers in the troop hold flinched as the tendrils drew close enough to obscure the sky. Lonnie—who had scrambled to strap herself back into the copilot seat—cringed, and even Catra shied away.

Glimmer and Taline clapped their hands together in front of them at the same time. The light from the apeirons raced in equal halves to them both, staining them with magic until no power remained in the crate.

At once, a larger, even more opaque shield encompassed the whole Warbird instead of just a single face. The ship righted itself as if there was no longer any outside force acting upon it—as if it

were perfect once again perfectly insulated from the elements. And when the tendrils slammed into the shield this time, no cracks appeared.

Gritting her teeth in concentration, Glimmer threw her arms out, and a second swell of suffocating magic pulsed out and slammed into Adora. Great wings of plasmic energy burst from her back, stretching several spans past the wings of the Warbird itself. They rebuffed the tendrils, making them recoil as if struck.

"Keep the ship on heading!" she said, voice now a chorus of thousands. "Push us higher, Kyle. We will not suffocate."

"Here they come again!" Kyle said once the tendrils regained their sense of direction and rounded on them once more. "I still won't be able to avoid them!" Taline, palms still together, tracked them with eyes of bleeding starlight as their craft rocketed higher into the atmosphere.

The tendrils reoriented themselves on approach, pointing such that they would pierce the ship rather than slam into it with the flat of their bodies. Taline gestured with an efficient movement, and a second wave of magic slammed into Adora, pounding the inside of her ribcage like the bass at the nightclub on Eden had done.

Six lithe tendrils of her own unfolded from Taline's back. Too bright to look at directly, all Adora could tell about them as she peeked out the corner of her eyes was how they undulated with what seemed like raw, unshackled magic, just like Glimmer's wings.

Taline lunged like she was throwing a spear, her hand thrust high. All six of her "wings" lanced forward, intercepting Archanas' tendrils at the point they would have pierced Glimmer's shield. Instead, Taline pierced *them*, snaking through the center of their bodis. Light permeated the darkness, expanding inside it, sending cracks rippling throughout their surface.

The tendrils exploded, sending the remaining blown-out stumps flailing in the air like they were writhing in agony. The storm raged harder as if the planet itself was screaming in pain, and all the soldiers in the troop hold cheered, Catra and Adora included.

Then the clouds shifted, and the cheering stopped. It took a moment for Adora to realize why, since she'd been fixated on Taline who'd expended all her magic surplus, and Glimmer, who's wings had disappeared despite her continuing to insulate them inside her bubble with great effort.

Lightning cracked overhead, and panicked murmurs grew among the soldiers as the clouds parted.

"What the hell is that?" Keren said, looking up.

"We're too late." Taline stumbled and Rogelio, still out of his seat, darted forward to catch her before she fell. "Archanas is awake."

The clouds were now moving at an unnatural rate even for a storm. They stitched together, planes and angles chiseling out an enraged face in the sky. It stared down at them, its features made all the more prominent by the fact their ship still had no cover, and they were speeding toward it as Kyle forced the Warbird to climb.

Its lips parted. When it spoke, its voice was all-consuming, the cosmic background radiation of creation itself projected into Adora's head—a million voices to Taline and Glimmer's chorus of thousands.

*You Shall Not Escape Me.*

It was the Beast itself, naked and unvarnished before them, no longer acting through thralls or Abominations or the reality-warping fog of its essence. This was the same entity that had spoken to Adora in her vision aboard Horde Prime's citadel years ago, and the same one she'd seen countless times since in her nightmares.

She gasped, letting out a single choked sob. Catra twisted to face her again, snaking her arms around her when Adora no longer had the strength of will to do so herself, pressing her head into the crook of Adora's neck. It was little comfort.

*You Shall Not Leave,* it said*. This Place Is Your Grave.*

The soldiers in the Warbird clapped their hands to their ears, straining against their seat harnesses as they writhed in agony. Glimmer blanched, Catra was shaking in Adora's lap. Even Taline stared in open horror as now hundreds of enormous tendrils appeared where there was once only six. Still the size of skyscraper buildings, they looked insignificant next to the face.

Death was upon them, and all felt its effects.

Corynth stepped forward, separating himself from Glimmer and Taline. Like a single stone standing defiant against a river and splitting its waters, he confronted the face, extending a hand forth like he intended to caress the very sky itself. And for a third time in a short span, another pulse of magic rippled out, slamming into Adora.

This one flattened her outright, making her retch and gag with an aura so toxic, for a moment it made her fear him more than the Beast. She had to fight to keep from shoving Catra off her lap in anticipation of throwing up, and then watched through watery eyes as a ball of reddish black, wreathed in lightning, spun just beyond the palm of his outstretched hand.

Adora screamed when Corynth unleashed that magic. It exploded from his palm forming a beam that streaked through the storm, continuing until it pierced the face of the Beast between its cheekbone and the ridge of its nose. The clouds making up its features seemed to swallow the magic. A beat passed, then an explosion deep within dispersed the Beast altogether and cleared the sky, and the existential dread that had grabbed everyone by the throat disappeared.

Stars and nebulae appeared where there was once nothing but storm clouds. Specks darted across the heavens—fighters dogfighting amidst larger forms in low orbit: the Megaliths still making their desperate escape. And just as Adora made the connection, a supernova flash forced her to squint.

A pillar of light appeared in front of the stars, splitting the sky like a tear through spacetime itself. And as Adora watched a gargantuan blue-green arc push through that light above them, she realized that wasn't far off from the truth.

Etheria had portal-ed right on top of them. It was almost too good to believe true until the few working speakers still lining the interior of the Warbird crackled to life.

"Attention all local vessels," came a voice blaring at them just as Adora noticed the dozens of capital ships pulling through the portal, too. "This is Admiral Hordak, Commander of the Etherian Orbital Defense Fleet. We are answering your emergency SOS. I repeat, we are answering your emergency SOS."

Another round of cheering rang out inside the cabin and the broadcast continued.

"Begin broadcasting your call signs and locations. Prepare—… receive new opera—…battle orders—"

The storm clouds began to reform and Hordak's voice cut out.

Catra spun around, sitting forward with such gusto it caught Adora off guard. "Glimmer, it's now or never," she said. "Get us home!"

Glimmer squeezed her eyes shut, the muscles in her jaw and her neck straining with effort as she concentrated. Adora's whole body tingled. Everything stilled, frozen in time for a moment that stretched forever.

All at once the view through the Warbird's mangled top shifted. Gone were the raging storm clouds and oppressive, suffocating

atmosphere. Etheria's majestic curve wasn't visible any longer, either. Everything just suddenly became…blue. Blue with streaks of fluffy white.

They tipped down into a pitched dived, the sound of the air rushing past them sounding not even a fraction as menacing as the earlier storm was. It was strange how Adora heard no alarms ringing despite the fact they were essentially free falling. A moment later, she realized it was because they'd lost all power to the Warbird, entirely.

Kyle strained trying to pull the controls up, but they continued to lose altitude, fast. Mountains in the distance came into view, then a great plain that stretched out below them, reaching for it. Adora, finally coming back to her senses, wrapped her arms around Catra again tight. She saw Rogelio similarly brace Taline in his one arm.

The Warbird hit the ground with a such a terrible crunching sound, Adora's couldn't help being reminded of just how fragile her body was really was, despite her recently-reacquired healing factor. Everyone jostled in their harnesses, and even Corynth, Taline, and Glimmer buckled despite using the last of their magic to keep them propped up without a seat.

They slid for countless long moments—likely hundreds of feet—kicking up mud and dirt and grass all like a boat splitting the ocean waters. They slid to a slow, agonizing halt, and no one spoke for several moments after, like they were all afraid they'd flash somewhere else and free fall a second time if anyone so much as breathed wrong. The Warbird's superheated chassis crackled as it singed the earth underneath.

Something in the distance caught Adora's eyes. A caravan of hovercars was speeding across the land toward them, and when she squinted, she swore the person sitting in the forwardmost car looked just like Salas.

Behind the caravan, Bright Moon castle shimmered in the distance. And when she realized where they were, she broke the spell of silence binding everyone in the wreck, letting out a whoop and a cry that snowballed as the others joined in.

They had made it. Glimmer had brought them home.

Chapter End Notes

I believe we just passed the 2 year mark of this fic! I posted the first chapter back in March of 2021. What a crazy 2+ years it's been :)

Only 10 more chapters to go. Thank you all for reading and commenting! Feedback on the last chapter was amazing and really made my week(s)

# Homecoming

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer came to, not having realized she'd fallen unconscious in the first place.

Even though she kept her eyes shut, it felt like she was spinning in the dark. The last she thing she remembered was latching onto the Moonstone while deep inside Archanas' atmosphere countless thousands of miles away, poofing an entire Warbird full of passengers back home.

"Hey," said a voice in front of her. "I think she's waking up, Hurry!"

Glimmer felt like she was going to be sick.

"I'm right here, you don't need to yell," a different voice said.

"I'm not talking to you, I'm—Hey, there he is!"

Glimmer couldn't take it anymore; the voices were grating and her head was pounding. She snapped her eyes open to glare at whoever was talking so loud right in her ear.

She was still in the Warbird's ruined troop compartment. Lonnie, wearing a shit-eating grin on her face lounged in a warped bucket across from her, while a nurse wearing Bright Moon colors and an annoyed expression stood next to Glimmer and adjusted a saline bag fed into her arm. Before Glimmer could say anything, however, she noticed a third figure.

Bow hovered at the threshold of an enormous rent in the side of the hull, one foot through the opening and the other still planted on the overturned grass outside. The look on his face had stopped her from yelling at Lonnie and the nurse for being so loud.

"You're awake," he said. The relief in his voice was palpable, but he didn’t come any closer.

The nurse rolled her eyes. “I told you she’d be fine,” she said. “We just didn’t want to move her.”

If Bow heard her, he gave no indication he did. Instead, he held onto the jagged paneling like it was the only thing keeping him grounded, and his reasons for keeping distant suddenly became apparent: he didn’t know if he was welcome.

“Come here,” Glimmer said. Her mouth felt like it had been stuffed with cotton.

Bow went to her, kneeling, pressing his head into her lap. She wrapped her arms around him, and realized he was holding back tears when she felt him trembling.

“I’ve been so stupid,” he said, voice muffled and vibrating against her. “So, so stupid. Adora tried to warn me, and”—a sharp inhale —"and I didn’t listen because I was being stupid, and didn’t really think about how you’re out there, and how it’s dangerous, and how anything could happen at any moment.” Another sharp breath. “And then I rushed out here with the others when I heard what happened, and then I saw you passed out and—”

“Bow, I think—”

He snapped his head up to look at her. His eyes were shimmering. “And of *course* it’s dangerous. You’ve been fighting on the front lines. God, how could I be so…*ugh*. I didn’t listen when she told me and I thought, ‘well she’ll be fine because she’s Glimmer,’” he said, effecting a high voice as he imitated her in his thought process. “But that was so stupid of me to think because even if you’re amazing, you aren’t invincible. And when I heard the ship crashed and saw you just laying here, you wouldn’t wake up, and the nurse got mad at me and told me to leave and walk around until I cleared my head, and—”

Glimmer rolled her eyes and cut him off with a kiss, pressed slow and deliberate to his mouth. He froze, and Glimmer fought back the urge to roll her eyes a second time while they were closed. Then he kissed her back, slow and deliberate, and that was when, finally, she *felt* like she was home.

The broke apart, and she stifled a giggle when he just blinked at her, lost.

"Wow," he said. "What was that?"

“Payback for not sending me a message this month.”

Bow turned sheepish, but that only made Glimmer’s feelings soar. Whenever she thought of him on past deployments, she’d always imagined him with an apathetic—or worse, disgusted—look on his face. But seeing him shatter under some gentle ribbing only confirmed what she’d already known from the kiss: he wasn’t repulsed at the thought of her, and he still felt the same way about her that she felt about him.

He missed her.

It was probably a good sign she could still read him like a book after all this time, too.

The sound of someone clearing their throat nearby cut through the silence. Bow jumped away and Glimmer leaned back with a sigh, pressing her back against the cold metal of her seat. The nurse was still there, looking down at her with an unamused expression.

“Nothing like a bit of adrenaline to get color back to one’s face,” they said in a deadpan.

Right, there were other people here.

“Yes!” Lonnie said, slapping her knee and cackling. “Rogelio owes me money.”

Glimmer looked down and scowled, noticing the wires and diodes attached to her. They were hooked up to a screen that monitored her vitals, likely casting the results to the tablet in the nurse held in her hand.

The subtle beep of her heartrate filled the room and brought everything rushing back to her. The *Omen-Kador* scuttling, diving through Archanas' stormy atmosphere, picking up Taline, Catra, Adora, and the others. Barely making it out alive.

Glimmer started ripping diodes off. "Where is everyone else?"

The nurse's unamused look turned alarmed. "Miss? What are you doing?" There are several tests I must run before you—"

Glimmer had left the intravenous drip for last and she grimaced as she pulled it out of her arm. "I was quarantined for days already after Scavria. I'm not sitting around on my ass again for who knows how long when while everyone else deals with the crisis on our doorstep."

Bow and Lonnie were at her side before she had the chance to call for them, supporting her as she stood.

"Nothing will keep her sitting here if she wants to go," Bow said, drawing Glimmer's arm across his shoulder. "Believe me."

The nurse scoffed, but Lonnie spoke before she could.

"You weren't around for this, but you should know she defied direct orders from a Fleet Admiral to push into a succumbing city, alone. All to—"

"You did what?" Bow's tone of voice echoed the surprise on the nurse's face.

"—save our skins instead of leaving on a Megalith like she was supposed to."

Lonnie shifted to better support Glimmer's weight, ignoring Bow, and the three of them hobbled past the nurse, similarly paying her no attention. When they got down the aisle to the rent in the Warbird's hull, Lonnie shot Glimmer an exaggerated look of forgetfulness.

"Hey, what was it you told me you said to the Admiral when he threatened to court martial you?" she asked, in a way that immediately made Glimmer suspicious. "'Eat my entire ass,' was it?"

Glimmer snorted. "That's *not* what I said." She paused, suddenly horrified, and said, "Oh my god, you didn't tell other people I said that while I was out, did you? He died going down the ship, Lonnie, don't tell people I said that!"

The view of home Glimmer finally took in once squeezing outside kept her from paying attention to Lonnie's response.

Archanas' storm-ravaged curve dominated Etheria's sky. Beneath it, a field hospital had been set up around their point of impact. Military trucks filled with equipment idled on the grass nearby, and teams of doctors and nurses rushed between several tents, tending to those wounded in the crash. Glimmer caught sight of Kyle and Rogelio sitting together under one such tent, a large bruise forming on Kyle's exposed chest while Rogelio's stump of an arm was wrapped in fresh bandages outside of its sling.

Catra was nowhere to be found, and Glimmer only realized this after catching Adora rushing linens and gauze between stations. That came as no surprise, seeing as how Adora had always distracted herself by trying to be helpful. It was like some itch she couldn't help but scratch, especially during times of heightened stress. And by the look on her face, this was one of those times.

Not that Glimmer could blame her.

She almost flagged her down, until nearby voices drew her attention.

"—not for at least another year or two on our projections."

Salas stood a dozen paces away under another tent, flanked by three of his robed Sentinels, deep crevasses of worry set into his face. He spoke to Taline, who sat on a stool while a trio of nurses wrapped her arm with gauze, and a third adjusted a hanging saline drip fed into her arm.

"He called us far too soon," Salas said. "I don't know if we're ready."

"The fact he is alive to call you in the first place is surprising in and of itself." Taline scowled at him and tried to cross her arms until the nurses bandaging them chastised her. "The last time we saw each other, we sat at the head of Bright Moon's table of honor as celebrated guests. You didn't tell me he was already here—that *you* had smuggled him in."

"What's this?" Glimmer asked, stopping short of them. Bow and Lonnie released her, and thankfully, she stood well on her own without them. "Arguing already? I was under the impression you two held each other in high esteem as colleagues."

Salas and his Sentinels looked surprised to see her for a moment, then schooled their expressions. Taline's scowl gave way to elation, and Glimmer stifled a laugh when all three nurses tending to her gripped her by the shoulders, urging her to keep on the stool instead of go in for a hug.

"My 'esteemed colleague' didn't see fit to inform me Corynth was alive and on Etheria the night your parents hosted my farewell banquet," Taline said. After a moment, she added, "It's good to see you up."

"I told you she'd be fine," Salas said, earning another withering look. "And while I understand and sympathize with why my withholding of information might make you upset, I stand by my earlier assertion. It wasn't personal, I just could not risk telling you."

So, it really was him in the Warbird with them, then? Glimmer had thought maybe he was some kind of imposter in a fake mask, but…maybe it should have been clear from the start he was real. Who else except some mythical figure resurrected from the dead could have dispersed what had appeared to them over Archanas? It was troubling enough for Glimmer, scaring off the Scavrian manifestation, and even then she had help.

It was then she noticed then that, like Catra, Corynth was nowhere to be seen, either.

Taline clenched her jaw tight enough it worked the muscle in her temple. "You don't think it would have been the tiniest bit helpful for me to have known the Last Shaper of the Daiamid was alive and on Etheria three years ago?" she asked.

"No," Salas said. "I know for a fact it would have been disastrous had I told you."

Glimmer had a hard time wrapping her head around the context for the conversation she'd walked into, but this she could at least understand. Despite how Glimmer felt for her mentor's frustration, Taline's irrational streak had always showed any time Corynth's name had come up.

"He's right," she said, pulling surprised looks from everyone, most of all Taline. Glimmer softened her voice and let her sympathy show in her expression, hoping it would keep the hurt on Taline's face from solidifying.

"You spent nearly two weeks negotiating with the Emperor," she said. "Two full weeks pulling every concession you could out of him so he would leave us alone and let the Enclave could work with us on the Heart. So we would have a viable weapon to fight the Beast with, because you knew it was only a matter of time before it put the whole galaxy in danger again.

"Horde Prime's condition for all this was that you leave. You wouldn't have left had Salas told you. All your hard work would

have been for nothing the very second learned someone even vaguely the same height and build as Corynth had appeared. He would have had all the justification he needed to come back, imprison if not execute you, and take direct control of us again." Glimmer frowned, suddenly unsure of how to interpret the fact she'd *just* seen Corynth and Taline working together. "As ill prepared as I'm sure we are right now, that would have been worse."

To her surprise, rather than getting angry, Taline broke down. Glimmer floundered without a clue what to do staring at the guilt on Taline's face. She'd never looked like that before. Glimmer almost hugged Salas when he stepped in to offer words where she couldn't.

"You cannot blame yourself," he said. "This is not your fault."

"How can it not be?" Taline turned on him with enough raw emotion it made Glimmer flinch.

The nurses averted their eyes, and one busied herself with replacing the now empty saline bag with a fresh one, muttering something about severe dehydration.

"That thing only got to me because I rolled over like some meek, chastised child and gave Prime what he wanted, letting him chain me to Phoenix," she said. "I never even realized Diallo was never himself after the war. And it wasn't just myself I left exposed, either. It got to Catra. It got to Archanas again, too. Everyone is putting themselves at great risk here trying to keep that thing from launching a fresh assault on the galaxy because—"

"Because you were tormented by an extremely powerful Abomination for years." The way Salas spoke brooked no argument, his three Sentinels casting each other a shared look. His face softened the next moment, as did his voice when he said, "It is not your fault, Taline. The real Diallo died long ago, true, but no one can blame you for not having noticed."

“But—"

“Not even yourself,” he said, firm again. “And if the thing wearing his skin hadn’t ensnared you, it would have just found a different way to bring us to this exact moment anyways. You submitting to the Emperor and being sent to Phoenix did not cause this.”

A pause followed, the distant screaming of warships fighting in orbit mixed with the breeze and the sounds of those still getting treated in the field.

“Abominations are no joke, ma’am,” Lonnie said, gently, as if dipping her toes into a pool of potentially contaminated water. “I know that goes without saying, especially to someone with your experience, but no one ever understands unless they’ve experienced meeting one first-hand. And as terrifying as Scavria was”—she looked up at Archanas looming over them—“I get the feeling whatever thing you were dealing with that woke *that* up is much, much worse.”

“I have to agree,” Glimmer said when she noticed the look of confusion Taline gave Lonnie. She raised her hand palm out, exposing the shimmering white scar there she received saving her team. “Scavria is peanuts compared to what I felt back there. I don’t think you should blame yourself for falling victim to it on Phoenix.”

Taline’s eyes blew wide. “You touched the Abomination there? Directly?”

“It really wasn’t pleasant,” Glimmer said, lowering her hand and hiding her palm again in a fist at her side.

The nurses looked like they were trying harder than ever to seem inconspicuous. Bow muttered something about risks and hardheadedness, and the Sentinels looked taken aback. Even Salas himself looked impressed if not somewhat horrified.

“I can’t imagine any of the senior officers attached to your deployment were thrilled to hear you did that,” he said.

“Lonnie said something about the Admiral of the Fleet threatening to court martial her,” Bow said, putting an enormous grin back on Lonnie’s face before Glimmer could elbow him to keep his mouth shut.

Salas burst out laughing and turned to Taline. “She certainly is your protégé, there’s no doubt about that.”

Taline blanched and put her head in her hand while the nurses fretting over a sudden uptick in her vitals. “Your mother is going to kill me.”

Seeing the look on Taline’s face was so comical, all the tension flooded out of Glimmer’s body as she laughed. Taline shrunk on the stool, embarrassed, and that only made Glimmer laugh harder. The fact she was so worried about her *mom* of all things was beyond hilarious. And, sure, Glimmer could admit her mother was scary when she wanted to be, but not when compared to a literal Beast planet threatening them from less than a single astronomical unit away.

Still. Her worrying about how her mom might take things meant she wasn’t flagellating herself over something that wasn’t her fault, and that was good enough for her. Catra might have made fun of her if she was there with them, but Glimmer was content enough to let it lie.

“Speaking of Angella,” Bow said, similarly looking up at the sky the way Lonnie did earlier. “We should probably get back.”

“We should,” Salas said. “Her Majesty has already called the war council to session. Our commanders and the other princesses are waiting.” The nurses began packing their equipment when Salas nodded with his head toward a pair of military support trucks idling on the nearby grass.

Glimmer followed Bow’s previous gaze, and finally met Archanas’ stare head on. It stood with the sun in the sky, close enough it seemed to be threatening to eat it, and this far out, she could see

how red-veined obsidian marked its surface where the dark swirling clouds didn’t obscure it.

Between them raged a battle. Remnants of her old fleet, reinforced with the Orbital Defense forces of her home world, locked horns with enemy Interceptors: interstellar extensions of the Beast virus itself. And amid the pinprick explosions and capital ships cutting sharp reliefs in the sky, the remaining Megaliths were there, burning toward them. The remains of the Scavrian refugees, seeking shelter.

Salas’ robed Sentinels got under Taline’s arms to support her from the stool. Glimmer refused the same from Lonnie and Bow when they offered. Instead, she called out to Adora, who sprinted over and pulled the three of them into a bone-crushing group hug.

Together, the four of them piled into in the back of the second truck, while Salas joined Taline and his Sentinels in the first. As soon as he got in, he tapped the side of the truck twice with the flat of his palm. Both trucks took off, racing across the plains toward Bright Moon in the distance.

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The plains weren’t as bare as Glimmer remembered them to be last she was home. On the way, they passed a fortified encampment fed by a miles-long supply train that stretched all the way back to the town. It was one of several such encampments dotting the surrounding area, Bow told her. One for each princess and her respective war group, and this setup was apparently mirrored for every kingdom across Etheria.

Eventually they passed through the enormous gate into Bright Moon proper. As they wound through the streets, Glimmer grew more divorced of the nostalgia for her hometown she’d held onto for these last three years.

Bright Moon had turned into a war fortress, castle town and all.

She'd read all the reports and heard from her parents and her friends during ansible calls over the years, of course, so Bright Moon's transformation wasn't an unexpected thing. But there was a difference between knowing this and seeing it firsthand. Despite having witnessed several other Beast-fortified planets on her deployments, something inside Glimmer splintered seeing how changed her home had become since she'd left.

Guilt ate at her, even though she knew her leaving wasn't the cause of this. Out the window, she watched a family sprinted toward the castle, an infant in the arms of the mother while the father led their young daughter along by the wrist. Countless other Etherians were doing the same. And in the opposite direction ran soldiers—officers spurring teams under their command rucking supplies, equipment, and the like.

Warbirds shot by in formation above them, saturating the air with squealing engine noise. When they faded, Glimmer realized the inside of the truck had grown quiet, and she pulled her attention away from the window.

Adora was watching her from across the cabin with a curious tilt of her head. Glimmer had no idea how long she'd been doing that; her, Lonnie, and Bow had been neck deep in conversation catching up with one another when she'd first let her attention wander outside.

"Sorry," she said. "Did you ask me something? I was…distracted."

"It's a little jarring, isn't it?" Adora gestured out the window, at truck even larger than theirs shuttling a platoon of kitted-out soldiers the opposite direction in its flatbed. "Bow and I have seen the changes play out gradually over years, but this must be like landing on an alien world for you."

"I'm glad to be back home, even if it's premature because of an emergency."

Calling it an ‘emergency’ might have been underselling their current predicament, outrageously enough, similar to calling Glimmer’s feelings at seeing Bright Moon again ‘a little jarring.’ Still, she put on a smile for her. And judging by deepening skepticism on Adora’s face, it wasn’t convincing.

“Do you mind if I ask how you happened to be above Archanas in the first place?” Adora asked. “Or what you, Salas, and Taline were all talking about earlier? Last I heard you were supposed to get shore leave on Phoenix, which is several systems away, at least.” She narrowed her eyes, scrutinizing her. “You look even less rested than that last time we called each other.”

That’s right. They’d spoken not too long ago, back when she was anticipating a vacation. But that felt like ages ago. She’d been deployed to Scavria since then. She’d touched the Beast. Glimmer pressed her lips into a thin line and shrugged, making it clear she didn’t have much to say. She felt bad, since Adora had an especially vulnerable look of curiosity in her eye, but Glimmer was in no mood to recount that gauntlet of horrors.

Glimmer balled her hand into a fist so there was no chance Adora might see the scar on her palm. “How about you?” she asked instead, trying to redirect the conversation. She pretended not to notice how the shimmer in Adora’s eyes faded when she did. “I was under the impression you were still here on Etheria until I saw you pop up on that video screen with everyone else, needing rescue. How did *you* end up on Archanas?” She paused, thinking. “And do you know how Corynth of all people was there with you guys? That is him, right? I still have a hard time believing…”

Adora frowned. Glimmer thought she was going to press her for answers until Bow cleared his throat.

“Yes, Adora,” he said, crossing his arms and tapping his foot. “Why don’t you tell them what you told me the second I cornered you out in that field hospital?”

Adora met his gaze with steel in her eyes, muttering something stern under her breath that made Lonnie laugh through her nose. When Lonnie said she too was curious, Adora lost her bluster and sat back in the chair.

"I didn't know who he was until we were already traveling for a while together," she said after a moment, fidgeting.

If Adora had hoped they'd leave it at that, she was wrong, because both Glimmer and Lonnie leaned forward, intrigued.

"Traveling?" Glimmer asked, the same time as Lonnie said, "Together?" They looked at one another, consensus passing between them in an instant before Lonnie looked Adora dead in the eyes.

"You need to fill us in," she said. "Tell us everything."

Adora did. Halting at first, then picking up speed as she wound them through the story. She spoke about catching the intruder Entrapta had alerted them to while he was in her castle, and about how she'd inadvertently left Etheria chasing after him as he was making his escape. Bow confirmed by way of his facial expressions this was his second time hearing the story.

Glimmer and Lonnie sat riveted in silence together. When Adora recounted facing down the Eden Abomination, buying enough time for Corynth to come annihilate it, Lonnie tapped Glimmer's knee in astonishment. When she told of how she'd squared off against Taline of all people in a bid to defend Corynth, Glimmer sat open-mouthed, listening. And she and Lonnie were both lost for words once Adora described Evelyn's appearance.

"I'll be frank with you," Lonnie said, after Adora finished explaining how they teleported back to Archanas to save Catra. "Everyone in the Vanguard knows the history those two have. Taline hating Corynth's legacy is like knowing the Gorm make terrible doctors."

"Wait, they do?" Adora asked, looking far more interested in a run of the mill fact than was normal.

"I'd been wondering ever since seeing them pop up on screen how they were standing together in the same room, not fighting each other. My first thought was that wasn't really him…" She shrugged. "I suppose running into some long dead hero of the last war shouldn't surprise me as much anymore, at this point."

"So that's it then," Glimmer said, drawing their attention. "You got your powers back."

Adora averted her eyes again. "Well…"

"Three times, Adora. If it was just the one time you were trying to prevent Corynth from leaving then maybe that could be chalked up to luck or a fluke, but you've called forth some measure of it at least three times, now. That last one when you faced Taline sounded like you did it on purpose, too."

"And you can summon that sword at will, too," Lonnie said. "Or at least, it seems that way. You had it when we got to you guys."

"Sure, but it's only a little bit." Adora sounded stricken. She wrung her hands together in her lap and shook her head. "I still can't fully transform."

"It's a hell of a lot more than what you could do before. Or couldn't do, I should say." Glimmer was trying to be encouraging, but she wasn't sure she was pulling it off.

Bow, who had gotten distracted by something outside his window halfway through Adora's story, turned in his seat fast enough it drew Glimmer's attention. He knocked three times on the partition separating them from the driver's cabin, throwing open when the truck slowed to a stop.

"Wait, are you leaving?" Glimmer asked, confused.

"Sea Hawk and your dad are coordinating these emergency preparations in the city," he said, already halfway out the door. "I'll rejoin you guys as soon as I can, but I have to help."

Glimmer lunged for his hand like a viper before he could run off. Instead of surprise, however, a strange look pulled over his face. Glimmer only realized what that look meant when he closed the distance, cupped her face in his other hand, and leaned in to kiss her.

This kiss was different from the one she'd initiated earlier. This one felt like a pledge. A promise to keep safe—that this wasn't the same kind of goodbye he'd inflicted on her before.

She pushed him away when he broke the kiss. "Go," she said. "Go help."

He nodded, holding eye contact with her while taking a step back, then another, before whirling around and sprinting off. She watched until he disappeared into a group of Enclave and Etherian soldiers double-timing past them in formation, then shut the door with a tired sigh, and banged on the partition to the driver's cabin.

They were off again, weaving through the streets at speed to the castle.

"Wow," Adora said. The dumbstruck look on her face was enough to temporarily shake Glimmer out of the melancholy that had come over her. "When did that happen?"

Lonnie jumped in before Glimmer could respond. "About thirty seconds after she woke up in the Warbird."

A tinge of affection worked its way through Glimmer's body seeing Lonnie get so energetic. "I realized the second I saw him that everything I was worrying about  on deployments, thinking he hated me, was wrong," she said, trying to play off how full her heart felt with a shrug. "The relief was so strong I just…" she gave a vague gesture with her hands to explain the rest.

"I'd been telling him for *ages* to talk to you." Adora sounded equal parts annoyed and relieved. "I'm so glad he finally grew a brain again. Good for you two."

She was smiling and Glimmer could tell her friend really was happy for her, but the tears swimming in her eyes told a deeper story. When she looked over at Lonnie and saw how she similarly watched Adora with concern, she knew there was something else.

"How are you and Catra?" Glimmer asked, not giving herself the chance to reconsider her words. "You guys must have talked to one another while you were up there, right?"

Adora's face shattered and tears spilled down her face, taking both Glimmer and Lonnie by surprise. She didn't go to wipe them as she said, in a broken whisper, "Catra hates me."

Lonnie snorted and rolled her eyes—a response anyone would think callous except Glimmer, who knew it was only a knee-jerk reaction born of panic. "Catra doesn't hate you. Not the way I hate *her*, at least. She's wanted to jump your bones for forever, from even before you defected, and just gets more and more bitter every year about it not happening."

Glimmer pinched the bridge of her nose. Even considering the fact she was the one who'd been in touch with Catra over the previous three years and not Lonnie, she wasn't wrong. But did Lonnie really have to say it like that?

"I wish that were true," Adora said, giving a bitter laugh between hiccups as she wiped her face with alternating hands. "We did talk, and…well…"

"And, what?" Glimmer took Bow's old seat next to her instead of across and rubbed her back. "What happened?"

"And, I don't *know*." Adora devolving into a desperate whine took Glimmer by surprise, and she redoubled her efforts soothing her back. "It was super awkward at first, which I understand. I tried to tell her how I felt, twice. Three times if you count the message I first sent before we'd actually met face to face again. Her reaction was…lukewarm at best. Terrible if you count the fight we had.

"I wanted to try again after we crashed, thinking all those doctors would tend to us and I'd get another shot, but she ran off following Corynth to the castle as soon as they arrived." Her shoulders were so tense, it felt like Glimmer was massaging a stone. "I shouldn't even be fixated on this right now. There's a freaking Beast planet right above us and I just can't stop thinking about stupid relationship stuff and I *hate* it."

Glimmer made a face, finally pulling her hands back into her lap. Maybe it would help Adora feel less alone in this if she knew how many times she herself had agonized over Bow while on deployments. But honestly, she didn't feel like that had a good chance at succeeding. She'd always felt Adora and Catra's relationship would take some yelling—or perhaps a lot of yelling—before anything got better, so none of this surprised her. It was just this couldn't have been timed worse. Adora was right, they were in the middle of something else they needed to address, first.

"Catra doesn't hate you," she said, shooting Lonnie a look that earned her an eye roll. "I mean that. I mean, I'm not exactly planning on letting Bow off the hook all that easily after three years of hot and cold between us, and you and Catra have a lot more to work through than we do."

A quiet "You can say that again," came from Lonnie, prompting Glimmer to kick her in the shin. It wouldn't have hurt her on account of the armor plating she still wore, but it got her message across: Lonnie clamped her mouth shut, and Glimmer continued.

"And with everything else going on right now, neither of you are in the right mind to solve anything rationally. Just…" She really had no idea how to explain it better. "She absolutely doesn't hate you."

"You don't know that," Adora said.

"I know *you*, Adora. This is going to eat away at you until it gets resolved and it's definitely not getting resolved before shit hits the

fan with Archanas.” Glimmer sighed and pressed her head back into the headrest. “Catra really hasn’t written you off. It’s actually been a total mess. She asked about you every single month for the entire three years we were away. Often more.”

That piqued Adora’s interest. “Really?”

Catra really should have been the one telling Adora this, not Glimmer, but fuck it. Things were desperate all around, so she pressed her lips into a thin line and resolved to give her friend as honest and firm an answer as she could.

“Really,” she said, as the truck ferried them over the long bridge leading into Bright Moon Castle. “Every time I called home on the ansible, she would pester me for details after. I'd give her updates on Etheria and the Heart, I'd give her the messages Scorpia and Entrapta passed along, and then I'd catch her up with what was going on with you. And if I happened to leave you out of the conversation, she’d fall into this insane funk. Empire above she was insufferable, acting all passive aggressive until I gave her something on you. And she refused to just ask outright, like it was some weird sticking point to her pride. Every single month.”

Adora seemed to take that in. Glimmer couldn’t read her as well as she’d hoped—that telltale shine of excitement no longer showed in her eyes like it used to when they were younger—but she could at least tell with reasonable certainty that Adora wasn’t on the verge of a panic attack any longer.

“That’s…I mean…” Adora took a breath and her features settled. “I don’t know what to think about that right now.”

“As long as it helps put your mind at ease, then great. You can’t be fixating on Catra right now when we’re on the cusp of an all-out battle. I just hope my mom and the others have a plan for dealing with this.”

Adora nodded, all business, and Glimmer was satisfied. If Catra wanted to give her shit for spilling things that weren’t hers to spill,

she could do it to her heart's content later, after the threat of imminent death was gone.

Their truck arrived at the main castle entrance and the three of them filed out. The other truck, the one that took Salas and Taline, was parked to the side and already empty. Glimmer ignored the way the guards on either side of the high double doors snapped to attention and saluted her. Instead, she stood on the landing, taking in the enormous towers and parapets of her estate, laden with more defensive military equipment than she'd seen in her life.

A flash of light exploded in the sky between two towers, and it took Glimmer a moment to realize it wasn't an explosion above them in the sky, but in orbit. One of the Megalith broke apart, debris turning into fiery comets as it entered high atmosphere. Adora blanched and Lonnie cursed.

"There were tens of thousands of people on there!" Glimmer said, rage thrumming through her veins.

So many dead while she was riding safe, gossiping, and playing catch up. Glimmer squeezed both hands into fists to prevent electricity from arcing between her fingertips. The Moonstone was so close, she felt dangerously close to catching fire same as the comets. If things like this were an everyday occurrence during Taline's time, then it was no wonder she'd built such high walls around herself. It seemed the only conceivable way of staying sane.

"Let's get inside," she said, marching up to doors and pushing her way into the castle.

Chapter End Notes

> I always imagined Bow and Glimmer to have a tender yet relatively tame reunion and reconciliation. That doesn't mean everything is forgiven, of course, but them drawing out getting on the same page with one another and rebuilding

bridges seemed unnecessary. Catra and Adora's relationship is that, already, and I thought it'd be somewhat refreshing to just have two characters "get it" with one another relatively painlessly, given all the crazy shit that's happening around them.

Low-key, getting to write Taline progressively lose her Ice Queen persona in front of people the deeper into part 5 we get was a guilty pleasure. Something about the potential end of the world just makes her not care to hold up appearances anymore, and the liberation from that, is part of her side-character arc.

Lonnie shit-talking Catra when she's not even there to defend herself is true to form. Despite all that's changed with these characters in this AU, their rivalry/borderline outright animosity toward one another hasn't.

And poor Adora just finally losing it the second she gets the smallest chance to vent to her friends in a semi-private space? Yeah, I had a ton of fun writing this chapter. Hope you all enjoyed reading it!

# The War Council

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer's boots thumped on the shiny tile, the sound mixing with that of countless staffers rushing stacks of data pads and carts of equipment every which direction through the castle foyer. To her pleasant surprise, there were plenty of Bright Moon citizens there, too, hunkering down for protection. That likely implied there were countless more hidden in various rooms and threaded through various levels of the fortification.

Good. She'd have hated to find out they kept their own people out the same way refugees coming to Phoenix were barred from the Atrium.

Lonnie and Adora were close behind, and those citizens watched them beeline down the foyer to the end of the room.

Two guards standing watch at the end of the room saluted, same as the ones outside. Glimmer ignored them and, with Lonnie and Adora close behind, pushed through the high archway leading into the castle's central sanctum.

Over a dozen people were there, crowded around a large circular table at the room's center. The tension was palpable. Glimmer could even hear it in Salas' voice, catching onto the thread of his words in the middle of a sentence.

"—in place before the eclipse makes it strong enough to—"

He cut off when he noticed her. Tangled masses of electrical cording snaked between stockpiles of electric equipment—a hallmark of the short, purple-haired scientist standing beside him. Entrapta, tablet in hand, looked up at him. The others—the princesses, her mom, various officers, Bright Moon Royal Guards, and Enclave soldiers—lined the table, from which a hologram of

Bright Moon's surrounding areas marked with its deployed military assets sprouted. One by one, they looked away from it, curious as to why Salas stopped, until they laid eyes on Glimmer.

The room exploded with fervor. The princesses surrounded them, talking over one another.

"You're here!"

"Is that Lonnie?"

"Holy shit, Adora's really back."

Mermista smacked the back of Frosta's head. "Watch your language."

Glimmer almost couldn't believe how many of her friends she was seeing again in person after all these years. It was almost overwhelming, until her mom parted the crowd and pulled her into a fierce hug, grounding her.

"I'm okay, mom," she said, voice muffled and tears hidden, pressing her face into her shoulder. "I'm home. I'm okay."

Angella stroked her short hair, murmuring something. Her eyes swam when Glimmer pulled back to take her in at arm's length. She looked Glimmer up and down, as if trying to commit this moment to memory. The princesses had pulled back to give them some space, and an opening appeared in their midst to let Taline through. She paused at Angella's shoulder.

"Three years and several deployments," she said in a gentle, almost timid voice. "It haunted me that I couldn't guarantee her safety to you when you first asked, but…"

Her tone flipped a switch in Angella. Her gaze turned urgent. It seemed like a kind of preternatural instinct only a mother could have, the way she grabbed Glimmer's hands and turned them up. Her face blanched when she saw the scar on Glimmer's palm, and the others gasped when they saw.

Taline shifted. Swallowed. “She’s tough,” she said, continuing from where she trailed off. “Not even an Abomination was enough to take her from you.”

Touching the Scavrian Abomination was, without a doubt, a near-fatal mistake, but Glimmer bit her tongue and suppressed the impulse to come clean to her mom. Besides, knowing her, she probably already knew.

Angella let go of her and, to everyone’s surprise, turned to Taline, pulling her off balance into just as fierce of an embrace she’d given her daughter, too.

“Thank you,” she said. “She’s alive, and I know that you…just—thank you.”

Taline looked like she’d stood up from a raft moored to the dock only to find the tethering had come undone and she’d drifted a dozen yards out to sea. And after a long moment spent regaining her bearings, she wrapped her arms around Angella. It was the most halting, tentative display of acceptance Glimmer had ever seen, and cast those initial years off Etheria—those long hours her mentor spent dragging her through draconian, unforgiving training regimens—in a new light.

Having her friends witness this moment seemed important, and they had their own varied reactions. There was a mix of elation and anticipation on Scorpia, Entrapta, Mermista, Perfuma, and Frosta’s faces, an unblinking anticipation in Adora’s, and steadfast satisfaction in Lonnie’s. Glimmer’s scar gleamed in the light when she cast her eyes down to her palm, and an inscrutable feeling of power and responsibility washed over her.

Aside from Taline and possibly Salas, she was the only one from home who’d seen the horrors of the Beast first hand. She was definitely the only Etherian to hold that distinction, the ones among her friends and family. For her friends and family, this would be their first true engagement with the creature, while for her it was, what, her third? Fourth? She’d lost count.

Salas was still by the table, apart from them. The other Enclave officers were with him, and all were watching their little reunion huddle.

"We interrupted you in the middle of speaking," Glimmer said, pushing past her mom, Taline, and her friends to stand across the table from him. She flashed Entrapta a quick smile, ignored the hologram spanning the table's surface, and met Salas' gaze. "I apologize. What were you saying, before?"

Half the officers gave her skeptical looks, while the others watched him, waiting to see how he'd respond. He didn't, and instead waited for the others to take their place back at the table, like a good leader with a good control of the meeting might.

It was Angella who picked back up before he did, however. She spoke as if this were a routine thing, him de facto leading the meetings but delegating to her as ruler of the kingdom.

"The ground forces are still mobilizing in and around the city," she said, gesturing to the holo-table. "I'm sure you saw them on your way in."

A myriad of icons denoting Etherian and Enclave soldiers, mechanized units, and fortifications dotted the map. The display confirmed what Glimmer had suspected on her way in: that there were more fortifications here than she'd seen on any of her previous deployments, including Scavria.

"I have," Glimmer said. "As have I seen the size of our fleet. As needed as these reinforcements are, we've given the Beast plenty of food to feast on in orbit, if we aren't careful."

"Currently, that is the most immediate threat," Salas said, finally speaking. "I'm sure you of all people do not need a refresher on our war doctrines concerning fleet battles."

He spoke the words like he was acknowledging to everyone in the room she was a veteran when it came to fighting the Beast and thus was competent, but Glimmer could read between the lines.

The doctrine called for lowering their fighting vessels' exposure to the Beast and reducing the 'conversion rate,' as it was called. It was a euphemism for turning their guns on their own soldiers the moment they were infected—a doctrine put in place by Taline herself, responding to the brutality of the first war.

And Salas was feeling out her potential to push back on its continued implementation here, now, among her friends and family.

"It doesn't matter how perfect we are following procedure in this fight," Taline said."The longer it draws out, the more attrition we suffer. Fighting defensively will only buy us so much. Add to that the fact the Beast's next goal would be to destroy the nearest Barrier node, and the fact that there is one within jumping distance of this sector—"

"We have no room for retreat," Glimmer said for her, the graveness she felt seeping into her voice as she let these facts sink in. "Etheria is the only thing standing in its way, and additional reinforcements will not arrive fast enough on conventional FTL drives. The fight must end fast, before we inevitably get peeled down."

It was a tough premise to accept, but that was the reality of battle. Hopefully that was enough to show Salas she wasn't naïve enough to believe otherwise. Glimmer tapped her chin and considered the map again.

"What kind of ground forces are we expected to come up against?" she asked. "I was under the impression Archanas had only a tiny population of Vestamid miners and clerics. Not enough to enthrall and pose a real ground threat, even if the Beast could break through our fleet screen and land its bodies here."

"The thralls on Archanas do not worry us," Salas said. "You are right. There aren't enough of them there to pose a threat, and it's unlikely to find a way to land them here. Our larger concern is we

just don’t know what kind of effect being so close to the planet like this will have.”

Mental fortitude tests and training, lockdown, quarantine, limiting exposure of the senses wherever magical intervention was not possible—by now, Glimmer was more than familiar with the strict protocols in place whenever a force engaged with the Beast. But that applied to fleets in orbit, not…planets.

“What is the concern, exactly?” she asked. “It’s a Lost World, sure, but Etheria is rich in magical energy and the Enclave has been pumping enormous resources here. I thought we had countermeasures?”

“We do,” Salas said. “Enough to protect every mind on here from direct corruption despite our proximity to Archanas, even our noncombat citizens. It won’t make thralls of any of *us*, but that only makes us more worried we’ll end up facing a land assault in due time.”

Glimmer frowned. There were pages upon pages of literature concerning the Beast’s mechanism for enthralling its subjects. It was a relief hearing Salas admit they weren’t concerned about it, but judging by the apprehension still on everyone’s faces, she’d missed out on an important part of the briefing.

“How exactly would that happen?” she asked. “With so few bodies on its own surface and no feasible way to ferry them here, how exactly would it land an invasion force? And what would it be comprised of?”

Every eye in the room turned to Taline when she cleared her throat to speak. Glimmer knew she commanded great respect, even among those who resented her, but seeing Salas and her mom—even Mermista—latch onto her so quickly made an impression.

“Toward the end of the war, the Beast had eaten planets with large enough populations, the magnitude and reach of ambit

had…evolved," she said. "When Archanas first fell, efforts to reclaim it were disastrous. By that point, the infection had grown powerful enough it affected more than just the minds of those caught in its sphere. Suddenly, it could reach beyond. Shift reality itself."

"Which means what, exactly?"

"It would materialize bodies directly onto the decks of orbiting ships. Like the Beast was telling us it didn't matter if we protected the minds of our crew, because it could finally cast a shadow powerful enough to reach beyond its atmosphere." Taline looked like she was reliving those moments the way her eyes glossed over. "It's what prompted Horde Prime to order that general retreat I ignored.

"When I ordered my flagship to stay and support Corynth's Shapers that day, my crew obeyed with the understanding it would be the last thing anyone ever did. Several hundred thralls had appeared across various decks, yet no one had been turned. They just materialized out of nowhere. And by the time Evelyn and Corynth set off the Barrier, most of my crew was gone, including half my bridge staff."

Silence trailed Taline when she finished. One of the Enclave commanders coughed, the sound echoing in the room. Salas and her mom had ordered a full mobilization because they were under the assumption the Beast would just spawn an army on their doorstep once it got strong enough, Glimmer realized at last.

"Is it enough?" she asked. She remembered seeing Salinean, Snow Kingdom, Plumerian, and Scorpion Kingdom colors on the way in, but suddenly all of it seemed inadequate. "Even if we deploy everything we have, is it enough?"

"Half our contingency of Battlemages are already casting protective wards around the city," Salas said. "Which means no matter what, the Beast will have a hard time materializing

anything on the streets. The civilians, you've seen, area already barricading safe areas for the time being, including the castle."

He glanced to Entrapta, who tapped at her tablet and zoomed the table hologram past the battlement walls and long bridge insulating the castle town to the plains.

"We're scrambling as fast as we can, concentrating everything else on reinforcing a solid defense of the surrounding plains" he said, indicating the series of long arrows webbing out across the map denoting the supply lines Glimmer saw. "We're about halfway there. It will be another hour before every soldier is equipped and deployed. Even then, we'll be heavily reliant on individual princesses to hold any advancing thrall army away from the city."

"That's okay, right?" Adora said, reaching over to point out multiple spots on the map where major fortifications were set up. Glimmer recognized the one they drove past on the way in. "Unless things have changed since the last time I attended the strategy meetings, the princesses are the anchor points at the main junctions here, here, here, and here anyways. Even if the entire force can't mobilize in time, half a dozen rune-stone powered princesses and their personal guard should be able to hold back a sizeable force for a good amount of time."

"That all depends on what the Beast manages to put on our soil," Salas said. "No matter what, it will have a hard time getting anything on the surface here, but if it succeeds, we might get unlucky."

"Unlucky how? You'd think we'd already have struck out if it gets to that point."

"If it's a few hundred thralls like what showed up on Taline's ship last time, then we can hold our own, of course. But something tells me if the fight is protracted enough it grows strong enough to break through our wards, I'm not sure that's what it will send us. Taline already filled me in on what you all faced during your escape."

“You don’t think it’s just going to send thralls, do you?” Glimmer’s heart raced. Salas’ mentioning of what they saw up there was hint enough already, but she felt like she had to ask. Even if she thought she already knew the answer. “Do you?” she asked again, more urgent.

Adora made the connection out loud.

“We fought Troopers at the end,” she said, speaking with a hollow voice, looking through the hologram instead of at it. “We almost didn’t make it out….We…”

Commotion broke out in the room again as Adora trailed off, losing steam with her hands limp in her lap. Hushed whispers between staffers, murmurs of how nightmarish the planet of all planets had reawaken—how crazy it was a Lost World *could* reawaken in the first place. More than a few faces had turned with scrutiny and resentment to Salas. It seemed he hadn’t informed them of the details of his conversation with Taline before Glimmer, Adora, and Lonnie joined them.

“It is possible,” Salas said, raising his voice to speak above the din, “that Troopers will come, yes.” One by one, conversation died down again as people paid attention. “But despite the fact we plan worst, as we always do, Troopers are not something I expect us to contend with in the end. This, despite what has been confirmed during the Seraph and Angel’s escapes.”

He traced the room with his eyes, studying everyone’s reactions. “Remember, it takes the Beast a great amount of energy to produce even one Trooper at ground zero. We know this. Projecting mere thralls beyond the planet itself was a drastic escalation of Archanas’ influence over ten years ago. Projecting Troopers? Not even at the zenith of its power over a decade ago was it capable of that.” He turned to Taline. “How many did you see up there?”

“Four,” Taline said, earning a fresh round of curses and panicked mutters from the war council.

"It is a miracle any of you are alive, then," Salas said. "But I stand by what I said. Four Troopers on the surface is one thing, but projecting them across space to another planet's soil is another. We will face thralls on the battlefield, if any at all. And if for some god-awful reason this incarnation of Archanas can project Troopers to us after all?" He cracked a lazy smile and laughed through his nose. "Well, then we've already lost, and then there's no use in worrying about things any longer to begin with."

Adora blinked, her eyes coming back into focus. She seemed confused. "Corynth took them down," she said. "And Catra."

"That is because Corynth can do anything," he said, turning on her with such fervor it surprised Glimmer and made Adora flinch. "That man faced down the nexus of the whole damn infection and not only lived, but *won*, sealing it away at the height of its power. You could partner him with a junior magus two weeks into their academy training and he probably wouldn't blink were there half a *dozen* Troopers bearing down on him."

A crease formed in Adora's forehead and she averted her eyes from Salas, her gaze returning to its glossy, spaced-out look. There was something going on with both of them, but Glimmer didn't have the first clue what.

An alert sounded off in the room, diverting her and everyone else's attention. Entrapta swiped at her PDA screen. "Another pulse beam from the planet," she said. "It hit a destroyer and chained between a handful of ships, but we scuttled them fast enough we didn't lose too much." She made a face. "Still not good. Too many of those and our losses are starting to pile up. Also, the other Megaliths are about to enter our planetary defense grid."

Relief flooded through Glimmer's body. "Are there teams ready to take them in? It might not make sense to have a bunch of temporary hospitals out on the same field we're expecting to face a Beast invasion, but it might also be difficult to get countless tens

or hundreds of thousands off the ships and inside one of the fortified zones in time."

Salas and the Enclave commanders looked at her like she'd grown a second head, while her mom and the other princesses looked stricken.

"What is it?" she asked.

"We haven't been able to identify any of the Megaliths," Entrapta said, as if that would explain everything. She wouldn't meet her eyes.

The beginnings of a shiver ran down Glimmer's spine, but she did everything she could to avoid jumping to conclusions. "What do you mean? Are they not transmitting the right IFF codes or something?"

"They aren't transmitting any IFF codes at all." Her mom frowned, placing her hands gently on the desk as if trying to hold onto it. Her tone already implied something more dire than a simple miscommunication. "We've pinged them continuously since arriving, confirming their SOS and asking for a return of identification codes so that we may safely offer them asylum. We've only ever received back the same automated distress we respond to in the first place. Like a recorded message."

"Well that shouldn't surprise anyone," Glimmer said. "They barely undocked from the *Omen-Kador* before it blew up, and had only a few dozen Warbird squadrons as escort before you all arrived. Is it that hard to believe their communication systems might be damaged?"

Angella looked to Salas, who huffed.

"Fleet doctrine mandates that an IFF *must* be provided and cleared before aid is rendered," he said. "If they enter our sovereign space without it, they are considered an enemy. You know this."

Glimmer did know, and despite understanding why it was put in place, the thought of what it meant horrified her. She almost argued, until Adora connected the dots, too, and beat her to it.

"Even if the'yre a friendly vessel? Even if they legitimately cannot transmit any communications at all?"

"That's the point," Salas said. "Given the nature of the enemy, we have no way of confirming they are a friendly vessel in the first place if they cannot communicate."

Adora's mouth dropped open and she stared at him. When it was obvious he wouldn't budge nor say anything else, she looked at everyone else in the room with wide, unbelieving eyes. Suddenly, it made perfect sense to Glimmer why no one might have pointed this out to her at any point during the last three years. She remembered her own reaction after learning as much.

"So, we treat all ships as deadly unless proven otherwise?" she asked. "Whose brilliant idea was that?"

All eyes shifted to Taline, Glimmer's included.

"Really?" Adora asked, her voice breaking. "You?"

Unlike the tender moment with her mom or the frantic one out in the field hospital, Taline made a true return to form. She met Adora's eyes with that unmistakable gaze of solemnity that Glimmer had come to associate with her—that look of exhaustion and dignified acceptance born of years shouldering burdens that would break lesser people. She didn't say anything, and it pained Glimmer that she could read what was going through both their heads so well.

"Why?" Adora asked, her desperation for answers pushing her voice into a whisper.

"Unchecked, exponential growth of the Beast's fleets was what nearly drove us to extinction in the first place," Taline said in a measured voice. "It would use distress beacons as a lure, then

infect and subsume whoever responded. And just to be unpredictable, it would also leave some ships alone instead of infect them, just disabling communication modules and allow for their crew to be rescued. It reasoned correctly that if only one out of every ten suspicious distress calls resulted in a trap, we were less likely to wise up to its tactics.

"By the time I took over as Grand Marshal, it had abused our natural tendency to want to rescue our fellow soldier, and had taken enough ships rival those our combined fleets." It was here that Taline's voice turned hard, rather than measured. It was a subtle change, but Glimmer caught it. "I instituted a zero-tolerance policy. Without a valid IFF, all ships were to be considered a Beast decoy and destroyed. We stopped losing ships to the Beast after that. Losing men no longer meant strengthening the enemy, and as horrid as it might sound to turn your guns on your own comrades, it was easier for the families to come to terms with than try to process how their loved ones had become thralls, instead."

Taline shrugged when that answer brought only more silence from Adora, but the gesture gave off more a sense of helplessness than indifference. Glimmer remembered how quick Norognev was to fire upon the *Constable* the moment it failed to respond to their hails. She'd thought she'd watched her mentor die to the same doctrine she herself had imposed during a time of pitched war, and every officer aboard the *Omen-Kador* had treated it almost like a mercy.

She swallowed, finally finding her courage to ask. "We shot down that first Megalith, didn't we?"

"We followed doctrine." Salas said, catching her attention by leaning toward her over the table. "Doctrine that was put in place for a good reason. Doctrine whose efficacy was tested and proven for years in the field." He sighed, his face looking even older. "The Megaliths pose no threat to our fleets since they have no weapons, so the fleet does not fire upon them. But they will become a threat were they to land here, on the doorstep of your

home, carrying an army of thralls. It did not provide the correct identification, and we had to make a decision after it breached the atmosphere."

Despite understanding the justification, something about hearing the finality in Salas' explanation and seeing how it made Adora wilt with disillusionment made Glimmer irrationally angry. She couldn't pinpoint why, exactly. Taline's doctrine did make sense from a self-preservation standpoint and it did prove crucial during the course of the war, but she couldn't shake the feeling Salas was still copping out here—taking the easy way out by refusing to look at the greater context.

"We cannot afford to lose any more of them," Glimmer said to him, channeling her rage into single-minded focus to get what she wanted, no matter the cost. "We cannot allow the Beast to wipe out what remains of the Scavrian people. Not when they are, like you said, on our doorstep, running to us for protection."

"Did you not just hear what we explained?" Salas asked. "It's simply a risk we cannot take."

"So, what?" Glimmer mirrored his posture, both hands on the desk as she leaned over it. "Ten years later and our best option is *still* to blow up five more defenseless refugee ships because we cannot be certain they aren't infected? Because we are afraid?"

Salas shook his head, exasperated. "That is not what this is."

"It's not?" Glimmer laughed, and even she couldn't deny that it sounded a little hysterical. "Since we're following old doctrine, why don't we use the same old figures, too." She turned to Taline. "You said it was a one in ten chance of this being a lure. Put another way, it's a nine in ten chance there are countless thousands of Scavrians aboard those ships that think we are their last hope for salvation. And right as they believe they are on the verge of reaching us, we are going to blow them up? Because they can't transmit the right codes?" She laughed again, looking over

everyone in the room. "*Sure*, why not? We already did one, what's five more?"

At least the princesses and her mom looked more uncomfortable than before. She took comfort in know if Bow and her dad were in here too rather than out coordinate things, they'd look the same. It was the Enclave commanders who stared at her with thinly veiled animosity for scraping off the paint finish on a plan none of them wanted to examine closely.

To her pleasant surprise, she did find a few looking at her with understanding and agreement—mostly younger commanders. The ones who likely hadn't had to contend with the kind of horrors Salas and Taline saw that made them implement the doctrine in the first place.

"Etheria is the galaxy's last hope against the Beast right now considering the enormous escalation that has just happened," Salas said. "This is not the time to be arguing against established practice."

Glimmer slammed both hands on the table, making many in the room jump. She was no longer able to contain her frustration. "Now is the perfect time for it!"

The Enclave Commanders and Princesses exchanged looks of shock, while her mom and Lonnie looked both wore looks of concern she could only imagine were for her mental state. Taline still had her trademark mask of an unreadable expression on, and Salas narrowed his eyes at her.

"It's the perfect time," Glimmer said again, calmer. "Even if it's Archanas we are facing again, things are different now than they were back then."

She gestured to the table, at the layout of her kingdom saddled with wartime fortifications. "You have princesses that can harness the magic of this planet at a level unseen since the Daiamid were alive. Considering that the last time they showed up on the field

of battle, the war ended, we have more leeway than your typical standoff with the Beast."

Salas' eyebrows knit together in consideration, and Glimmer capitalized on the moment.

"You also have a planet that can portal anywhere in the galaxy in a fraction of the time it takes a conventional fleet to respond. You have the Heart." She looked at Entrapta. "Last I heard, you were close."

"It's…technically ready to fire," Entrapta said, sliding her eyes to Adora, who stiffened. "Light Hope getting unexpectedly brought online allowed us to clear the final hurdles rather quickly, but—"

"Then we have a weapon now, too," Glimmer said, interrupting her. "One that makes the circumstances of this encounter fundamentally different from before. Back then, you all fought for survival from a place of tactical inferiority. Today, we are fighting it from a position of strength. Is that not what you believed we would give you when you—all of you," she gestured to Taline and Salas and all the Enclave commanders, "pushed back against the Emperor himself to have us?"

Taline's eyes took on a faraway look as she brought her hand up to touch at the scarring on her cheek Horde Prime had inflicted on her. The silence in the room broke when Salas began to drum his fingers on the desk.

"If you are wrong, then you will be dumping those countless thousands on our front doorstep as thralls," he said. "I am barely optimistic about our chances should Archanas build up the strength to manifest an army of them from scratch, given another hour to prepare. What happens if letting them through leads to that army showing up right now, instead? We aren't fully deployed."

A great sigh cut through the room before Glimmer could answer, and Salas turned his attention to Mermista with a deep scowl.

"As much as I love hearing the two of you go at it endlessly like this," she said. "And believe me when I say I really love it—this is very entertaining…I think it's fair to remind everyone that I'm a princess of Etheria, too. And I have been training for the past three years knowing a day like this was coming."

The moment held for a beat, then her expression returned to the bored countenance she'd worn all her life.

"I'd much rather risk my life fighting thousands of thralls on the field early if there was a chance to save people having risked it," she said. "That sounds a hell of a lot better than delaying a fight against thousands of thralls anyways for a few hours by blowing up refugee transports just because we weren't sure they were safe." She looked to the others in the room. To Perfuma, Scorpia, Frosta, and finally Adora. "And I'm willing to bet I'm not the only one who thinks that, either."

By the looks on all her friend's faces, they agreed with her, too. Angella looked equal parts impressed and relieved, and even Adora looked marginally less frazzled than when Entrapta had spoken about the Heart while looking at her.

Glimmer couldn't help the broad grin that broke out on her face, and beside her, she noticed Lonnie making the same expression. Mermista rolled her eyes when she noticed, but Glimmer didn't miss the way her cheeks tinged red, either.

Salas' frown deepened. He pinched the bridge of his nose before rubbing the crease between his forehead out. "I am at my wits end," he said, before turning to Taline. "Would you please talk some sense into them? You know better than anyone here the dangers of this kind of idealistic optimism."

Even after all that, Glimmer couldn't get a read on Taline. She was beginning to think the near-hysterical version of her she'd caught sight of outside the crashed Warbird—the one who'd been freaking out over her mom raking her over the coals for having touched an Abomination—had actually been a hallucination.

Then the corners of her mouth turned up. Again, it was subtle, but to Glimmer, she might as well have been glowing.

"It's refreshing to see, actually," she said. "It's been a very, very long time since anyone has held any optimism at all when it comes to fighting the Beast, idealistic or no."

"Taline, this is madness," Salas said, the pinch in his brow coming back full force. Disbelief saturated his voice. "This goes against every hard-earned lesson from the war. Lessons we paid for in blood. Do you not realize it spits on the graves of the countless billions who died before your own precautions came into widespread adoption. How it dismisses all those who yet live because they elected to carry the burden of having potentially killed their fellow brothers and sisters in arms?"

His words didn't dampen the pride Taline held in her eyes as she looked not at the Enclave representatives with her, but at the Etherian Princesses, at the Queen, and finally, at her student.

"As colleagues, we'll have to agree to disagree," she said. "To see leaders advocate for putting themselves at greater risk for only a chance to save civilians? That kind of thinking snuffed out very early on in the war." She looked back at Salas, face expressing a gravity that reached deeper than the surface of her words. "Besides, it is not a battle in the surrounding fields that will determine the outcome of this fight. We have other things that require our focus."

Salas breathed deep through his nose and cast his eyes to the ceiling. After a moment, he muttered something about "madness" under his breath before looking at Angella. "Empire save us. The surface batteries shall not target the remaining the Megaliths. They will be allowed to land, but we need to expedite our deployment schedule. Just in case."

Angella nodded. "Just in case." She stood, prompting the commanders and princesses to stand with her. "With me," she said, casting Glimmer one last gentle look before turning and

striding out the room back to the foyer. Except for Adora and Glimmer, the princesses and commanders paired, then followed Angella as she swept out of the war room.

"Should I…?" Adora craned around in her seat to watch them go. She made as if to go with them. "Maybe I should—"

"Sit down," Salas said. He no longer sounded angry or irritated like Glimmer assumed he might. Now, he just sounded tired. He rubbed at his face again. "Please. You're needed for this next discussion, both of you." This last he directed at Glimmer, too.

Adora nodded slow as she lowered herself back to her seat, looking lost. The sounds of the war council's receding footsteps grew quieter, until the high doors at the back closed with an echoing thud. Entrapta whispered into a portable transceiver she held to her mouth, relaying Salas' orders to not fire on the Megaliths, plunging the room into a tense silence once more once she finished.

"The truth is, we will not win a battle against the Beast here," Salas said. "Not a fleet battle in orbit, and not a ground battle with soldiers, even if the Megaliths are clean like Glimmer hopes and the Beast can do nothing but manifest thralls like I predict. Not even if we hold out long enough for reinforcements from other systems. Archanas is simply too powerful to defeat by conventional means, now."

To Glimmer, this was a remarkable shift in tone and demeanor compared to the strong front he'd put on with everyone else present. Why such a radical change? And why were only her, Adora, Entrapta, and Taline privy to it?

"I had hoped once the Barrier had been fully sealed, we could eradicate the Beast without the need to rely on this," he said. "But at this time…with Archanas of all places having reawakened, our only chance against it is to use the Heart. It's why Corynth chose to call for us in the first place."

The Barrier being sealed was news to Glimmer, but the significance of that revelation was lost when she noticed how Adora reacted to the news. She clammed up, breath hitching as she nodded once, then twice, like she was a puppet forced to do so on marionette strings.

"I understand," she said, clearing her throat. "I've got roughly half of She Ra I can call forth on command. Maybe a bit more? It should be enough…"

"I'm afraid it isn't." Instead of angry, like Glimmer might have expected, he just sounded sad.

Like Salas before her, it was now Adora's turn to inflict whiplash on Glimmer for how fast her emotions flipped. She whipped her attention to him fast enough her hair flared out behind her. Anger twisted her features. "It *has* to be enough," she said, in a tone that made it obvious the anger was only a flimsy mask for fear and desperation. "It's all I have."

Salas didn't speak, but his and Taline's expressions each turned sympathetic and resigned, as if they were both preparing to tell a young child their cherished pet had just died.

Adora picked up on the shift. Her voice turned pleading.

"I-if it isn't, then…then I'll push for more. I can do it. I *swear* to you I can do it."

Glimmer could hear the unvoiced '*I am enough, why can you not see that*?' in Adora's words. Her heart ached for her friend, but no matter how hard she worked her jaw, no words of support or reassurance came. She could only watch.

Next to Salas, Entrapta wiped at her face with the palms of her hands and, again, wouldn't meet anyone's gaze.

"It's not enough," Salas said, repeating himself. "And that's okay. Do you remember what I told you the last time we saw each

other? When you finally came to me seeking advice for the very first time?”

“I don’t want to hear it.” Adora’s voice had gone small and high-pitched. Tears swam in her eyes. “Please don’t."

“I said you cannot force it to come. That you would come into your powers again on your own time and to not worry.” Salas looked to Taline, who nodded, before turning back. “I meant what I said, Adora. There was always the possibility it would just take longer than was convenient for those powers to return to you, but it would never be your fault for that in the first place. That’s why we have a backup.”

“There is no backup, Salas,” Adora said. “She Ra is the only one powerful enough to survive using the Heart.”

Salas took in a long breath. The moment seemed to stretch forever, before: “We don’t need someone who can survive it. Just someone who can use it correctly, once.”

‘They will die!” The tears finally spilled free down Adora’s face. Neither Salas nor Taline looked away. “You can’t sacrifice someone else just because you don’t think I’m ready. It *has* to be me. You can’t send someone else to die in my place!”

Salas stood up fast enough his chair clattered backward to the ground, making Entrapta startle next to him. “We can and we will,” he said. “*You* will die if you try this before you are ready, and we will not sacrifice the future She Ra of Etheria when we have another option. *Any* other option.” He looked to Glimmer with the same stone eyes she’d seen Taline wear during war anniversaries and said, “This is different from arguing over unidentified Megaliths. The decision is made and I will not move from it.”

Every muscle in Adora’s body was tense. She breathed hard as she stared, unblinking, at both her hands clenched into fists, resting atop the table. Glimmer finally found her volition and went

to her, taking the chair beside hers and rubbing her back. It didn't seem to help.

"How can you do that?" Adora asked, closing her eyes, letting more tears fall. "How could you think to even ask that sacrifice of someone else? If I'm not ready, I should be the one to face the consequences for it. How can you force that responsibility onto someone else?"

"No one is forcing anyone to do anything," Taline said, finally speaking up. Her voice was so devoid of emotion, it gave Glimmer pause, and her face betrayed her as well. Because despite her features remaining stone, her eyes were not: Glimmer saw the conflict there, like she really had traded them with Salas the moment prior.

This was the final missing piece to a puzzle Glimmer had been putting together ever since Salas first broke character during the meeting. And once it slotted into place, the epiphany it granted her slipped from her mouth before she could stop it.

"Corynth can do anything," she said, recounting Salas's words out loud.

Realization dawned on Adora's face upon hearing her. She shook her head, eyes blown wide. "No. No, he can't do that. He—"

"Corynth traveled here ahead of even Salas and I," Taline said, looking on the verge of tears herself. "The way Angella tells it, he didn't so much ask as demand to be the catalyst in your stead. He had already convinced me, as shameful as it is to admit, and Salas didn't need convincing. He made the decision, Adora. For you."

"But *why*?" Adora slammed two fists down on the table harder than when Glimmer had hit it, sending cracks through its surface and disrupting the holograms. "Why would he do that? He might be able to 'do anything,' but he can't survive the Heart. Not in his condition."

Taline's expression broke, and she finally broke eye contact, looking away with a clenched jaw and trembling lips. After seeing this, Salas spoke up.

"Because he is already dying," he said, voice saturated with grief. "He has been since before you even met him. I am sorry, Adora."

That came as a shock to Glimmer, who had watched him effortlessly blow apart the Beast's own manifestation in the clouds above Archanas—something she knew from experience was incredibly difficult. Hearing that he was dying, especially after seeing proof that everyone had been wrong about his death for years already?

She was expecting to see that same shock play out on Adora's face, too. For a moment, it did, then her expression crumpled worse than Taline's. She started sobbing, her tears dousing the splintered wood of the table.

Her friend had already known, she just hadn't wanted to believe it. And realizing this struck Glimmer deeper than watching Adora slowly unravel from Salas and Taline's earlier words had.

"How long does he have?" Glimmer asked, when it was clear Adora was in no condition to speak.

"Another hour," Taline said. "Perhaps two, if he's lucky."

She continued to rub circles into Adora's back, clinging to the motion more out of comfort for herself rather than any true hope Adora could even feel it. Taline tried to be inconspicuous as she wiped a tear away. Glimmer was too numb to register this was the first time she'd ever seen her cry.

It wasn't until later, after sitting in silence for several moments, that she realized something: despite all this commotion around him—despite it being mentioned he'd come earlier than anyone else—Corynth hadn't been there for the meeting. In fact, neither had Catra.

Chapter End Notes

Poor Adora :( she's really been ground down hard for endless pages now, and I'm pretty sure this is where she finally just loses it entirely and finally drops all the plates she's been juggling this entire time. It kinda reinforces her perfectionism to be told what you've achieved for yourself isn't good enough to save people if she can't use *all* of She Ra, doesn't it? You'd think someone saying "hey, great job getting some of your powers back, finally. I think that will work" would help, but alas, shit has hit the fan, and no one can afford to lie to her :(

As I was writing this, I was surprised and honestly proud of her character for holding out so long. It took a lot for me to feel a natural breaking point for her at this moment.

This means she can only go up from here, right?

Thanks as always for reading and for your comments!

# Words to Inspire

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra stormed down a hallway dozens of stories up in Bright Moon Castle, unsure if she was panicking or just extremely irritated. It was likely both.

She'd lost Corynth. One second, he was speaking privately with Angella in the war room while Catra caught up with Entrapta and Scorpia, and the next he was gone. Angella had no idea where he'd gone, either. He'd left when her back was turned.

::This is really beginning to piss me off,:: she said. ::We've been through how many rooms now and still can't find him? Where the hell did he go?::

"I don't know," Pip sounded unlike herself, and she was definitely acting unlike herself, too: Despite having escaped Archanas, and thus freeing up her processing power already, she hadn't reappeared to Catra again, yet. "I have a bad feeling about this. He's not speaking to me at all. I can't feel him. I can't even tell where he is in the castle."

The hallway was packed with Bright Moon citizens taking refuge, who watched as she stormed past them. After turning a corner, she picked the first door she saw, throwing it open and sticking her head through. The room was jammed with even more citizens sitting pressed chest to back. All of them looked up at her. A child's cry rang out from somewhere in the back, their parents turning in an instant trying to soothe them.

"Have any of you seen a shady looking guy skulk by here?" Catra asked aloud. "He'd be wearing a mask? Would still seem half dead even though you couldn't tell from looking at his face?"

She got a full room of blank stares and heads shaking ‘no.’ Catra threw her head back and groaned, then continued on down the hall.

::I thought you already said he wasn’t speaking to you already back at the railway,:: she said to Pip.

“I told you he was blocking me out, not ignoring me. Those are different things.”

::Are you *really* hitting me with semantics right now? Anyone with a functioning brain cell would say those are the same thing in a passing conversation.::

"They are not the same thing," Pip said. "Let me put it this way. You weren't ignoring Adora when you guys were talking during that train ride, but you were definitely blocking her out with all that deflecting you were doing.::

Catra scoffed and checked another room, coming up short. ::Don’t start that with me,:: she said. ::If I blocked her out, it was because she said some stupid shit like she always does. ‘*Are you and Taline together?*’:: She rolled her eyes. ::Give me a break.::

“See? That’s exactly what I mean. Sentinels traditionally share an intimacy with their Battlemages. You know this and you know that Adora *saw* this, yet you willingly misinterpreted her question so you could get offended over it, yell at her, and not have to risk talking about any of the actual important shit you two *should* have been talking about to begin with. But what do I know? Blocking someone out and ignoring them are apparently the same thing.”

Catra stopped in the hallway, stunned. She couldn’t even pretend Pip was wrong, since she was tied so close to her psyche. She shook her head to clear it—now was not the time for splitting hairs over semantics. She needed to keep moving.

::What happened to that cheery, innocent, naïve version of you?::

“They’re buried under years of reintegrated memories and current mounting panic. Catra, I’m really worried.”

She understood. ::Let’s just focus on finding him.::

Neither Pip nor Catra spoke again as Catra searched. It wasn’t until after the tenth or so room (she’d stopped counting somewhere around five) that someone mentioned seeing Corynth. One of the guards in the hallway had heard her asking and pointed her to an out-of-the-way corner of the castle.

When she burst out onto a secluded balcony overlooking the divide between the Whispering Woods and the fortified plains surrounding Bright Moon, Catra found him there, sitting on the ground, back pressed up against the wall. A fierce battle raged in orbit above. Several hulking Megaliths were burning through the atmosphere toward them, and Archanas’ curve looked wicked and imposing behind it all, but Catra could focus on nothing but him, limp against the stone.

“Shit,” she said under her breath. “Shit, shit, shit.”

Catra squatted in front of him. Her stomach did loops. She couldn’t tell if he was breathing.

The lenses in his mask were retracted. That might have reassured her he wasn’t dead, except it just showed her his eyes were shut. The fact the mask reminded her too well of Shadow Weaver also probably contributed to the anxiety, infuriatingly enough. Apparently, all the time Catra had spent staring at statues of him or reading about his feats in the war hadn’t done anything to quell that visceral response from childhood.

Taline had told her to prioritize his life, for Empire’s sake. How would Catra face her, admit she lost track of him, then say she found him dead on a balcony?

“I’m still alive.” Corynth synthesized rasp came as he opened his eyes. Rather than looking at her though, he looked at the vista past her. “You can stop panicking now.”

"Oh, thank fuck." Catra heaved such a big sigh of relief she grew light headed.

She leaned back until her butt touched the floor, then pulled her knees up and pressed her forehead against them. This was the first moment since first arriving in orbit above Archanas that she felt she was far enough from imminent danger to relax.

“You can take it off if you want, you know,” he said after she’d caught her breath. “The mask. Although I wouldn’t recommend it.”

“I already know you’re alive, why would I want to do that?”

“I’ve been told you have more than a passing interest in seeing what my face looks like.” He tilted his head. “Is it true you collect figurines of me?”

Catra burned with embarrassment. “*Seriously?*”, she said. “It’s *one* statue, not a figurine. A small one. And I don’t collect them, it was included in the boxed set of this really well done documentary about—”

She cut off and scowled before inadvertently saying something even more embarrassing. What that something might be she didn’t know, but Catra wasn’t going to chance it. Glimmer would always smirk and tease her for ‘nerding out’ like that, as she’d put it, but she was the one who bought her that special documentary collector’s edition to begin with.

“Is this what you and Taline were talking about up there?” she asked instead, pointing to Archanas in the sky. “You two were gossiping?”

Something whisp-like and raspy came from Corynth then, like air getting choked out of an old tire. It wasn’t until Catra saw his shoulders shaking she realized he was laughing.

“Taline had nothing but positive things to say,” he said. “I see why she likes you.”

Catra didn't know what to say to that. She almost asked what it was he saw, since she still didn't really see it three years on—only a greater recognition of how her upbringing informed her low self-esteem stopped her. That didn't mean Taline's affection for her wasn't real, mind you, just that Catra herself didn't get it.

"We made a pretty good team back there," Corynth said, after she kept silent. "Back in the control room."

Again, Catra was at a loss. "I wasn't going to let Adora die to those things. Even with you helping her, she wasn't going to last much longer."

"Adora is a masterful fighter, but she can't bridge consciousnesses with me like you can." Corynth tapped the temple of his mask, his fingers eliciting a hollow sound against the material. "Truthfully, I think I might have learned more about you in those few minutes fighting together than I'd learned about Adora over the years spent here." He paused. "I can also see why you might not yet know how to feel about her, while she's had plenty of time to figure out how to feel about you."

That last bit of information definitely hadn't come from Taline. And having just spoken about bridging consciousnesses made Catra remember something she'd forgotten in all the adrenaline from fighting for her life.

::What the hell have you been talking to him about?:: she said to Pip, who was the only one other than Catra who would have known what Corynth had just shared.

"Nothing! I told you he was blocking me out and then straight up ignoring me." Pip's disembodied voice filled her head, but she still didn't show herself. "I told you all the way back at Moriarty's office I'm great at keeping secrets!"

::Clearly that's not true. You were *both* talking in my head back at the control room.::

“She’s telling you the truth,” Corynth said, interjecting aloud into a conversation Catra had been having in the privacy of her head. “She hasn’t told me anything private.”

::But—::

“Your thoughts are loud,” he said. “Very loud. It’s like hearing someone stand in the same room as you and yell. As nice as it was to be connected to someone again, I didn’t think it was right to listen in on some of your most private thoughts. I had to block you out. Both of you.”

So this was what had Pip freaking out, earlier: his concern for Catra’s privacy. That made sense, and brought a kind of relief to her for Pip’s sake. But it was the other thing he said that caught Catra’s attention.

“Who were you connected to before?” she asked aloud. Continuing to speak nonverbally at this point seemed rude.

“Evelyn, for a short amount of time before we sealed the Beast away. I felt her last moments.”

Corynth had left out the part about expecting it to be his last moments, too. Catra had picked up on it like they were her own recollection.

“So how much did you hear, then?” she asked instead.

“Excuse me?”

“My thoughts and feelings. You said it was like I was yelling them out loud. How much did you learn before you blocked me out?”

“Ah. Well. You dumped a lot out on me rather fast as soon as the connection took,” he said. “I’ll admit I probably should have anticipated that in hindsight and blocked you off early, but curiosity got the better of me.”

Catra tilted her head. “What in the world could you possibly be curious about?”

“About you, obviously.” When Catra gave him a look, he said, “What? You’re allowed to take an interest in me but I’m not allowed to take one in you?”

It felt surreal hearing someone she’d studied like a historical figure say this to her. “I’m not some living legend brought back from the dead.”

“No, but you are the first Sentinel Taline has taken on in over a decade, and are the person She Ra of Etheria herself has spent the past three years pining over without consciously realizing it.” A beat. “Well, she eventually realized it.”

That stumped Catra. She had to admit he had a point, and hearing him mirror the same sentiment Adora herself had expressed during their escape made her heart flip a second time, just like it had back then, too.

“I want to know more about you, then,” she said, and then immediately cringed. She’d meant to derail the conversation and get them onto something else, but ended up blurting up something far more forward than she’d intended. She cleared her throat, forcing what little poise and pride she could. “I mean, it’s only fair, since you’ve been in my head. How come I can’t feel your thoughts even though we’re connected? I can feel Pip if I concentrate, but that’s it.”

“Not much for you to feel for in the first place,” he said. “My head is typically empty. No thoughts.”

It took Catra far too long to realize he’d made a joke.

Another note of exasperation came from Pip in the formless void bridging their consciousnesses. “There are several moments I could point to where that statement could be taken literally,” she said.

“Once we deal with Archanas, you can ask me any questions you’d like,” Corynth said, ignoring her.

Catra narrowed her eyes at him. “Why do I get the feeling you’re just humoring me?” she asked. “You don’t plan on living past this confrontation to begin with, do you?”

He didn’t respond.

“I know you and Taline have a plan to deal with that Abomination. She told me to protect you over herself if it came down to it, which means you’re crucial to that plan. She already told me that you’re dying.” She paused as several pieces slotted into place. “You’re going to sacrifice yourself activating the Heart, aren’t you? That’s why you were in such a hurry to rush ahead to warn Angella. You needed her to buy in on the plan just in case, so Adora wouldn’t have even a foothold to challenge it.”

“Tal said you were smart, too.” It sounded like he’d been timing how long it took her to reach that conclusion, rather than surprised she made it in the first place. “No wonder she offered to bring you with her when she left.”

“Don’t try to change the subject. That is what you’re planning to do, isn’t it?”

Corynth’s gaze was piercing, but she looked right back at him, refusing to back down.

“The Heart is our last chance,” he said. “I’m supposed to hold the Abomination still long enough for the Heart to get a direct hit.”

Catra made a face. “That’s bullshit. There has to be another way.”

“There isn’t. I can’t burn it out, we tried already tried that. It’s too powerful and I’m running on fumes as it is.”

“Adora is supposed to channel that thing.”

“Do you think she’s ready?”

Catra grimaced and sidestepped the question. “She’s gotten some of her powers back. She’s got the sword again, too, and she’s nearly as fast as she was when she’d fight me fully transformed in the past.”

“But do you think she’s ready?”

Catra looked away. “I don’t know,” she said in a low voice. Even admitting that much killed her.

“That’s what I told Angella when she asked me the same thing. And that’s why she agreed when I insisted that I be the conduit instead of her.”

“But you’ll die.” Catra’s words came out thick despite her best attempt to tamp down her emotions.

“Everyone dies,” Corynth said, and it made sense to Catra how a person could admire someone and be exasperated with them at the same time. “And I’m going to die soon even if I don’t use the Heart.”

Catra opened her mouth, and then closed it. She tried again, thinking this time she had something to say, only to close it again. After the third failed attempt, she deflated.

Pip materialized at last, floating in the space between them. By the way Corynth’s eyes flicked to her, she had to both of them, together.

Rage from her end of the link blasted Catra full force. Her face was twisted in anguish, tears streaming down her cheeks, and Catra froze. She’d never realized when she first stopped considering her an AI and started seeing her as a flesh and blood person, but seeing this brought a new realization into stark contrast at the front of her mind: Catra had never seen an AI cry before.

“You can’t seriously be giving up this easily,” Pip said, voice trembling.

It took Catra a moment to unstick herself and realize Pip wasn't talking to Corynth, she was talking to her. "I…I don't…" She made a helpless gesture. "What do you want me to say?"

"Taline gave me to you because she knew you were smart! You figure things out, put two and two together, come up with a plan. You're persuasive, and she trusted you. You can't just give up. Say something to him!"

Catra was again at a loss for words. This sudden shift, the immediate jump from worried to frothing rage, it didn't make sense. But as Pip's anger continued to stream across their link, she slowly realized it was only acting as a mask for anxiety. A poor mask, at that, now that she noticed.

"I don't know what to say," Catra said after a moment. She spoke gently, but firm. "You know I don't." Maybe there wasn't anything to say at all, and it was the acceptance of that fact that was giving Pip such a hard time.

Pip's anger shattered, and Catra saw how it wasn't just anxiety she was masking, but fear. Deep, existential fear.

"I don't want him to die," she said in a tiny voice that complemented her tiny, hunched-in posture. "I remember what it was like with Evelyn. I…I didn't know how to handle it. I almost lost myself the first time…I *would* have lost myself if it wasn't for…"

Catra's eyes trailed over to Corynth, and a new horror dawned on her when she realized what Pip was talking about. Corynth wasn't the only person linked with Evelyn when the Beast ate her: Pip was there, too. She was the bridge. And while Catra could already imagine how deeply traumatizing it would be to feel someone's death like that—something she was preparing to deal with herself now that she knew she was connected to Corynth—she had no idea how to describe in words how that might feel to an AI with so little context for emotions and trauma and healing.

Hell, trauma had made a mess of Catra in more ways than one, and she wasn't a fraction as optimistic or naïve as Pip had been when they were first introduced.

"It's going to happen again," Pip said, devolving into hiccups that derailed her every word. "And I don't know what to do. I thought maybe if you…if I…"

A warm feeling flooded in from beyond Pip's presence in Catra's head. It was all-encompassing, soothing in the way a warm bath loosened tight muscles. Pip calmed, her panic-broken sentences dissolving into muted sniffling and hiccups as her body relaxed and she wiped at her tears.

::Come here.::

Corynth's voice stained Catra's own mind like ink muddying water, speaking from every direction. And unlike before, where she was surprised to realize Pip was talking to her, she know right from the start Corynth's words weren't directed at her.

Pip drifted to him like she was hung limp from a wire. She didn't meet his eyes, not even after she settled on his knee, morose.

::You know, when I first got you, I thought Evie was playing a practical joke on me,:: he said. ::I was under the impression you were just some helper program she built to decipher those ancient documents she was relying on to research the Barrier.::

Pip gave a wet laugh and scrubbed at her eyes again. "Yeah, and how many times did I tell you stop referring to me as a program because it was insulting?"

::Every time I mentioned it until you started to think it was funny.:: He paused. ::Do you remember when you stopped getting mad over it?::

"I don't really, no," Pip said, giving an exaggerated shrug that told Catra she was lying to be difficult and, in fact, likely knew exactly when. "I think eventually it hit me how funny it was you thought

someone that helped decipher a long-dead language and resurrect an ancient interdimensional prison was”—she brought her hands up and made air quotes—“‘just a helper program.’”

Corynth laughed, casting Catra a quick look. ::Like I said before: my head is usually empty. No thoughts.::

“You were doing it on purpose, weren’t you?” Pip sounded like she genuinely hit upon that realization for the first time, and Catra wondered how he learned to hide things from her in the first place. “Why? To get a reaction out of me?”

::Because Evie insisted I have you.:: When that didn’t seem to make things clearer, he continued. ::I didn’t understand why, at first, but after everything that happened? Grief, denial, anger, these aren't things that a program or even an AI would really experience. Not like you did when she died. Evie didn't pair us just because she knew I'd need someone around when everything fell apart. She knew you'd need someone, too.

::’*If I could just make her laugh*’ was what I thought. ‘*If I could just get her to laugh, then that would be enough*’. You were so despondent those first few days, I didn’t have enough time to feel sorry for myself because I was so worried over you. I thought Evie was crazy for sticking you with me since I’m terrible emotional support, but…::

“You eventually got there,” Pip said. “None of that matters if you die, though. How am I supposed to make sense of any of it if you aren’t even around anymore?  What’s the point?”

::Evie’s dead,:: he said. ::She’s been dead for a long time. So what was the point back then?::

Catra was holding her breath. Pip bristled, as if the mere implication Evelyn’s death could be pointless made her angry. She glared up at him, seemed to catch something in his eyes, and deflated again. “I see your point.”

::I died on that planet up there, already,:: Corynth said, gesturing to Archanas above them. ::Years ago. Every moment we had together beyond that day was something precious that should not have been—you know this. Nothing can take away the time we spent together, but it's time reality caught up. And just like Evie gave you the hellish task of watching my back, it's now my turn to give you another.::

Corynth looked over at Catra again—long enough Pip followed his gaze—and a mix of pride and apprehension welled up inside her.

::I'm here to watch your back, too:: Catra said, the words coming out of her without hesitation. ::We're here for each other, just like it's been since we first met.::

Nothing could have stopped Catra from doing everything she could to be a comfort to Pip. Whenever the time came, she'd do what she could to help, and more. That sentiment must have made its way over to her, because she smiled and patted Corynth on the knee.

"Ten-plus years together and you're still full of surprises, aren't you?" she said to him in a watery voice. "When did you learn to say such touching things? I sure as hell don't know, and I should since I've been in your head the whole time. Unless you learned how to be good with words while I was out of commission?"

::I'll admit Adora made an impact on me. My first few times trying to talk her down didn't go as I'd hoped so,::he shrugged, ::I had to learn some new tricks.::

The mention of Adora's name made a whole host of conflicting emotions rear up again for Catra. She'd only been so confident telling Pip she had nothing persuasive to say to Corynth because of how poorly she was treading that same water trying to figure what to do for Adora.

She had no idea what to say her, still. Even back at the feast before ever leaving Etheria she'd had no idea what to say to her.

Not after Adora had dropped bombshell after bombshell on her that night. It had been much easier to run away to a different part of the galaxy entirely than face her again and say something coherent. And now, three years later, she was still no closer to having an answer.

“Do you want to talk about it?”

Catra’s eyes snapped up from where they had been boring a hole in the floor. Corynth was looking at her with an intensity behind the mask that made her shiver. Even Pip, for all the range of emotions she’d shown earlier, seemed attentive.

“I don’t think I need you to take the mask off after all,” Catra said, finding her voice after clearing her throat. “It’s fine.”

“What do you mean?”

“You offered, before.” She pressed her lips together and shook her head. “I don’t think I need to see your face. I already know you aren’t anything like her.”

Surprise showed in Corynth’s eyes. “Well that’s a relief. The little I know about her isn’t very flattering—"

“Trust me, you’d be better off not learning the rest.”

“—but I was talking about Adora.”

Catra laughed through her nose. Corynth hadn’t even called her out for deflecting like she thought he would have. She would have called herself out, were she instead to have the same conversation in front of a mirror.

Her amusement fell away and she squeezed her eyes shut, forced a long, slow breath to work from the depths of her lungs all way through her body to the tips of her fingers and toes. Her heart was hammering in her chest, her palms sweaty and clammy. Her thoughts were a jumble. If she was having this much trouble just

getting started, then she'd need all the help she could get when it came to Adora.

"I don't know what to say to her," Catra said at last.

"Why do you think you need to say anything to her at all?"

"Because…!" Catra perked up with a swell of emotion, only to lose it the next moment. Saying nothing at all just felt wrong. Like a betrayal. "Because I feel partially at fault for the issues she's having with her powers. And before you say anything—because I can just see it on your face…mask. Eyes. Whatever. Before you say anything, I *know* how fucked up that sounds. Why would I have anything to do with Adora not getting her powers back? Well, you said yourself she's been thinking about me all this time. Newsflash, she isn't the only one."

Catra put her head in her hands and ran her fingers through her hair.

"If her never being in my thoughts has had me doing questionable things to cope these past three years, I can only imagine what effect it's had on her, trying to get in touch with a part of herself, thinking the galaxy lived or died by her success or failure." She shook her head. "Adora's always been hard on herself. She's always expected perfection, and that's always been a problem."

"You think you're at fault because she thinks about you a lot?" Corynth asked.

"I'm at fault because I ran away from her," Catra said, with more force than she intended. "She had so much to share that day we last spoke to each other. She laid it all out, said everything that was on her mind and told me where her priorities were. She wanted to focus on her powers even back then, and even after all the shit we put each other through—all the shit *I put her* through—she cared enough to and tell me the truth to my face and say what she needed from me.

“And I just…” she shrugged. “I just ran away. All the way off the planet and to a different part of space. And I can’t help but wonder what if I’d figured my shit out sooner? What if I came back or got in touch with her and we talked before all this happened?” She gestured to the battle raging above them. “Would she have figured things out, then, if she instead had my support? God’s above, even Glimmer was trying to get me to talk to her for the longest time, but I never did.”

“You’re here now,” Corynth said, eliciting a nod from Pip. “You can talk to her now.”

“But that’s the thing,” Catra said, balling her hands into fists. “I still don’t know what to say to her. I’ve been wracking my brain this whole time trying to think, but I just…” She huffed. Even finding the right words for this conversation was difficult. “Even after all this ‘progress’ I’ve made, I’m still fucking useless.”

Corynth only watched her. So did Pip, except she had her head tilted in a way that reminded Catra of a worried dog.

“You’re worried about her,” he said at last. It was such an obvious statement, it irritated Catra he felt the need to say it.

“Of course I’m worried about her,” she said. “How can I not? That girl placed the weight of the world on her shoulders back when the worst thing we had to worry about was getting enough food in the cafeteria and doing a good enough job during drills Shadow Weaver didn’t come down hard on us. Her not being able to perform when the fate of the whole galaxy is actually at stake?” She made a frustrated gesture with her hands. “I just wish I knew what to say to make it better. To help.”

“Why don’t you tell her that?” Corynth asked.

“What? Tell her that I wish I knew what to say but I don’t?”

Corynth closed his eyes and sighed. “Tell her the truth. That you’re worried about her because you care about her still even after all this time apart.”

Catra snorted and rolled her eyes. “You can’t be serious.” When Corynth didn’t back down, she said, “Is your answer seriously for me to believe in the power of love and friendship or whatever the fuck else? Just tell her the truth. That’s your advice?”

“It’s not cryptic sage advice,” Corynth said. “Telling her the truth is the only thing you *can* do. It only feels annoying to hear because it’s so simple. You’ve been thinking about her this entire time just like she’s been. Surely you must have *something* heartfelt to say?”

Gods, of course Catra had thought of the words. She had countless lines and openings about what she’d want to say to Adora; she’d practiced them near constantly since leaving, turning the phrases and thoughts around in her head, ruminating near-endlessly about them whenever things got too quiet.

"Just because I've thought about it doesn't mean I know what to say," she said. "Being up in my head is easy. Actually talking to Adora is hard."

It didn't always use to be that way, but Corynth didn’t have to know that. Although, he probably already knew since they were apparently connected to each other’s brains or whatever. Damn it.

“None of it feels good enough,” she said. “No amount of words can turn around the kind of shit I put her through for so long. What she told me at that banquet…that”—Catra sucked in a breath, fighting a sudden surge of tears—“that…came from somewhere deep. Some place that I pushed her to, betraying her and being horrible to her because I was in pain. I could hear it in her voice.”

Catra squeezed her eyes shut. Tears ran down her face, leaving hot streaks on her cheeks. So many emotions pent up tight for so long meant letting even a little out risked opening the floodgates.

“I had a job to do after Archanas,” Corynth said, after a moment Catra spent getting her breathing under control. “Evie had left me behind to ensure the final steps of her master plan played out

accordingly. Taline was a loose end through all of that. Ten years. I don't know what you'd call it…prophecy, maybe, although some would laugh at the term….but Evie left The Dance of the Revenants coded into Vestamid holy scripture as a warning to me."

"That the next time you and her met you would fight?" Catra asked.

Corynth nodded. "It was an easy enough thing to point to whenever I started thinking about reaching out to her. Ten years is a long time to go without addressing dangling threads, and even though I could have seen her any time I wanted, especially since she was looking for me the whole time, I didn't. And part of it was because of that prophecy."

Truthfully, with how full of hatred Taline had spoken of him to Catra during their time on Phoenix, she didn't blame him for wanting to avoid her. But the way he spoke about that prophecy implied there was more to it than just that.

"The other part was because I was telling myself the same thing you're telling yourself now: that you've caused too much pain to someone you cared about, and you could never even begin to make it up for it. So why try? What could you possibly do by looking at them and opening your mouth? What would you even say? You're sorry?" He laughed, shaking his head. "Would you believe my surprise when I found out that was exactly what she wanted to hear from me all along?"

"Really?"

"That's simplifying things, of course, but yes. Whereas I thought it'd just reopen old wounds, apologizing did a lot for her."

Catra was invested. Pip sat cross-legged and still on his knee, humming to herself while Catra sat forward. "Is that what she said on the train ride?"

“In more words, with a lot more volume, but yes,” he said, and Catra could tell he was smiling. “Not telling her who I was, keeping her in the dark about the Shapers and my involvement with them—in effect, not telling her the truth—was the thing that hurt her the most and continued to hurt her all those years. It’s the very pain the Abomination exploited to remain hidden under her nose for so long, too.”

He met her eyes. There was a gravity behind them that wasn’t there before. “Looking her in the eyes as I’m doing with you now and telling her I was sorry for what I’d done? Expressing true remorse? Opening up and telling her she was someone I admired and wanted the best for? Someone I’d never, ever wanted to hurt?

“Words like that aren’t going to suddenly make everything magically better, but if they break the ice and unstick something that has gotten in the way of healing? That’s all you have to do, Catra. You don’t have to find the perfect thing. You just have to be honest.”

Catra gave a wet laugh, already wiping away tears again. “That’s still a lot of pressure.”

“Not as much pressure as Adora typically puts on herself, though,” he said. “I swear, it’s like she expects herself to solve everyone’s problems and single-handedly defeat the Beast, and anything short of absolute performance is a catastrophic failure.” He pointed to himself and said, “She watched me annihilate a different Abomination in person. You’d think if she’d ever let herself lean on someone at some point, it’d be me, right now, while we’re in the middle of all this.”

Catra gave another laugh, this one more reminiscent and commiserating than anything. “She’s always been like that. Even when we were kids, she had to be the one to do everything, and she had to be perfect. I can’t believe I liked her so much I regularly lost sleep over her.”

Pip and Corynth both smiled at her, Corynth with his eyes. No one teased Catra for obviously still liking Adora now, despite how she said that last sentence.

"I can believe it," Corynth said. "She's really something special. Did you know the only reason I got Pip back and sealed the Barrier at all was because of her?"

For some reason, that didn't surprise Catra. "Adora being a big fat hero? Nah, couldn't be. What'd she do, give you a pep talk or something, after she figured out who you were?"

"No, actually. I watched her flounder about for three years while I was sneaking around Etheria."

"So, not heroic after all, wow," Catra said, leaning forward, putting her chin on her hands and her elbows on her knees. "That actually sounds kinda sad."

"It was very sad."

"Then you've lost me. What about that was inspiring?"

"The fact she never stopped trying." When Catra only looked at him with one eyebrow raised, he said, "She wasn't even the one to notice me at first, Entrapta was. She was talking to Adora and some others about how she found an intruder after combing the Enclave personnel files.

"I happened to be there, helping a crew deliver a shipment of tech to her lab, and I walked right in front of Adora as she was trying, for the thousandth time that month most likely, to summon her powers. I watched her hold a wooden sword over her head, and then watched the disappointment on her face seeing it not work. It was something I'd seen play out countless dozens of times already. And you know what my first thought was?"

"What?"

"'I wonder what she'll do next.' That was the very first thing to cross my mind. I'd watched her pick herself back up so many times I hadn't even considered the possibility of her giving up."

Catra had to admit, that did sound like Adora.

"A few weeks later and she caught me at what I was supposed to be the end of my journey. I'd finally gotten what Pip needed to seal the Barrier. She walked in on me and we fought."

"Oh?" Catra had heard precious little about how he and Adora had met and what they'd gotten up to. Them fighting first thing wasn't what she'd pictured. "Did she put up a good fight?"

"Put up way better of a fight than I was expecting, yeah. She broke my nose."

Catra pumped a fist, only to push it back into her lap as soon as she realized.

Corynth told her what had happened next, with Pip sprinkling in her own commentary. They told her how a sliver of the Beast remaining in the crystal he'd recovered had corrupted Pip; How he'd ensured Adora had survived the following onslaught from the castle's automated security system once it flagged them as intruders.

"I'd thought that was the end of it," he said. "Years waiting for Etheria to show again, years spent traveling her kingdoms, only to get nothing from the Eye and lose Pip. I made sure Adora was safe, but when I got back into my ship, I thought that was it. I was ready to give up."

Hearing Corynth, alive and breathing, say those words nearly broke Catra's brain. Any sane person would have reached the end of their rope far sooner than he had, but the idea of *him* giving up felt so foreign. Seeing the living person behind the legend like this was taking some getting used to.

“How did Adora change your mind, then?” she asked. “What did she do?”

“She chased me,” he said with pride. “She saw me getting away and wanted to catch me so badly she actually reawakened some of her powers. Made that sword of hers finally appear after years with no progress, then leapt four or five stories into the air and slammed it into the fuselage of my ship.”

Catra whistled, Corynth’s enthusiasm painting a clear picture in her head that was getting her excited. “So that’s what did it, huh? Her being pissed off at you?”

Corynth shrugged. "Only lasted a few seconds and I had to catch her with a tractor beam after to keep her from falling to her death, but by then I was already second-guessing myself about giving up. Then she woke up and hounded me until I got angry enough that I actually argued back. When she accused me of being some spy for Horde prime, I got so mad I came up with a plan to get things back on track.”

“She annoyed you into submission,” Catra said, a big grin on her face. Classic Adora. She’d sooner pester you to death than let you give up, even if she had no idea you were on her side and close to giving up to begin with.

“I think it’s working,” Pip said to Corynth, out loud. “She has that dopey look on her face Taline always had for you.”

Catra realized after a moment that they were talking about her. “Hey!” she said, crossing her arms.

“How about it?” Pip asked. “Feeling better?”

She should have known after all those pointed looks she’d given Keren and Trayn to help her that she wasn’t fooling anyone when it came to how freaked out she was over Adora being right in front of her again.

“A little better, yeah,” she said, truthfully. “I still have no idea what I’m going to say, but that doesn’t feel like this vice gripping me by the throat anymore.”

“Baby steps,” Corynth said. “I’m sure it will come to you, just don’t overthink it. As long as you don’t jump twelve steps forward and go straight for the kiss before saying anything first, you should be fine.”

“Okay, I’m definitely not going to do that,” Catra said, unamused. She hadn’t thought about kissing Adora once since she showed up again. Well, not until Corynth brought it up…

Pip pressed her lips into a thin line and gave her an unconvinced look. “I’m not so sure about that.”

“Oh, screw y—”

The earth shook so hard it threw Catra back against the balcony railing. A chorus of shrieks rang out from below, and Corynth was on his feet faster than Catra could scramble to hers. Together, they looked out at the surrounding lands. Everyone in the castle town, who had before been hustling, preparing for battle before, were now stopped, staring up, and pointing at the sky.

Three Megaliths were there, one of them tipping over. Catra cringed as it plummeted and impacted the ground, tossing up a mushroom cloud of smoke in the open plains beyond the walls of the town. The quake hit a moment later, the shockwave threatening to dump Catra to the ground again while she held onto the railing.

Corynth, Pip, and Catra all looked at each other, eyes wide. the Megaliths were crashing.

“We need to go, ”Corynth said, just as the third hit. “Something is wrong.”

The lenses in his mask slid over his eyes with a click. He turned and sprinted back into the room without waiting, the shouts of

surprise from everyone cowering inside punctuating his disappearance through the door. The shockwave from the third impact hit as Catra went after him. She fell to the floor inside the room and scrabbled desperately to her feet, trying not to trip over those inside as she raced behind him.

She had a feeling whatever time they were depending on to set up an effective counterattack with the Heart had just been cut short.

Chapter End Notes

> This is like "don't meet your heroes" but flipped on its head--Catra has an arguably positive experience from it. We also finally got to see how she's taking this whole reunion with Adora after getting a moment to breath. Instead of hating her, feeling indifferent, or even focusing 100% on the threat like she tells Adora to do, she's very worried about what to even say.
>
> Catra doesn't *have* to say anything to Adora. It's not her responsibility to "lift the hero up" so to speak. Yet the fact she puts that on her shoulders all the same shows she, 1. cares way, *way* more about Adora than she'd ever let on, and 2. struggles with the same perfomance/am I even good enough to succeed-type mental blocks Adora is currently struggling with shouldering the fate of the galaxy, herself. Catra's is just on a smaller, more intimate scale.
>
> Pip having the emotional reaction she did this chapter was entirely unplanned. It just hit me right in the face during writing this chapter that she'd not only be just as traumatized as Corynth or Catra or anyone else at a death, but even more so because she was both the bridge last time someone she was connected to died, and since she's an AI and not a flesh and blood person, would have far less personal context for how to process or cope with that.

Thanks for reading and commenting, as always! Eye of the storm is now past with this chapter. Here to the end, we earn the "big battle set piece" tag I've had since posting chapter 1 of this fic :)

# Bloody But Unbowed

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra avoided the looks the hunkered-down citizens of Bright Moon gave her as she and Corynth sprinted down flights of stairs and hallways. Before long, Corynth had pulled ahead far enough she didn't want to risk falling behind—impressive for someone on death's doorstep—and she cleared the last flight of stairs to the castle's ground floor with a leap and a roll, nearly barreling into Glimmer and Adora when she hit the marble.

Taline, Salas, Entrapta, and Lonnie were there, too. "It got to the Megaliths," Taline said to Corynth, who was already matching pace with the group by the time Catra scrambled to her feet and caught up. "None of us were expecting it."

"Which is the whole reason we had your IFF doctrine to begin with," Salas said with a grimace. The muscles in Glimmer's jaw worked. She was clenching her teeth, but whatever words Catra could tell were fighting to come out, didn't.

"I really didn't think they'd be affected, even with the lack of communications," Lonnie said, on Glimmer's other side. "The Megaliths were transiting inside a supercarrier specifically for their protection. They should have been insulated from direct corruption even if the planet had hit the *Omen-Kador* with that surface cannon."

"They didn't have the same protections we on the surface and our naval forces have. I was hoping the same thing, but it looks like the planet has already woken to the point it can enthrall far away from its surface." She shot Glimmer a sympathetic look. "I threw my support behind your plan because I believed it couldn't do that, yet. I underestimated it, I'm sorry."

That didn’t seem to make Glimmer feel any better. “Maybe I should have taken the hint when you and Salas were talking about it spawning thralls out of thin air. If it was strong enough to do that during your time, it shouldn’t be a surprise it could bend minds off planet, too.”

Angella was there, waiting for them alone. All the other princesses and Enclave commanders must have went ahead, already. Catra could tell by the worried looks on her faces, she was full of questions, but Taline didn’t give her a chance. She shook her head and continued speaking to Glimmer.

“We weren’t expecting it to be able to do that for a little longer, yet,” she said. “Archanas is coming alive faster than I ever thought possible, even given the fact it’s merely resuscitating, not falling for the first time. I wonder how it’s growing this fast.”

“It recognizes me.”

Corynth’s voice traveled above the din. Entrapta was whispering rapid, unbroken intel to someone on the other end of her PDA, footsteps from their group marching out the castle echoed in the foyer, and the citizens lining the walls held hushed conversations as they tracked all of them through the room, but Corynth’s voice traveled.

“There was no record of the aperion Evelyn, Ly, and I experimented with,” he said to Taline. “I didn’t find it in any of the manifests you when you sent lab equipment back to the Heartlands, and I didn’t see it noted anywhere in the secret stash you kept at Phoenix. I didn’t put together what had happened until I touched the Abomination during our escape.”

Taline blanched, and Salas looked like he couldn’t believe what he had just heard.

“Diallo—the real one—must have found it helping you catalogue Evie’s lab after we sealed the Beast away. It must have subsumed

him in private. That's why no one even knew it existed, let alone that it was missing."

"You're kidding me," Taline said. "The same strain you saved Evie from in the beginning? The very one she kept and used in all her experiments?" She blinked in disbelief. "I thought you destroyed it before vacating the lab and that's why I couldn't find it."

"It was already unfathomable how dangerous this was knowing it had masqueraded as a person for over a decade," Salas said. "Add onto it the years it spent as your ticket to marauding through the timestream?"

They reached the main castle entrance. Two guards in full royal armor moved to pull the doors open for them, but Angella ordered them back. With a gesture, magic sprouted from her fingertips and the doors flung open on their own. The soldiers rushed back to their posts and stood tall, saluting the group as they marched through the doorway to the courtyard outside.

The sky had gone hazy with smoke from the Megaliths burning out on the nearby plains, but Archanas' suffocating black and red curve still dominated. Pinprick flashes of light dotted the view, each one a Warbird or Beast-infected fighter from the Vestamid mining compound breaking apart while dogfighting in orbit. Debris from derelict ships burning up on their descent through the atmosphere traced comet lines through the air.

Something flashed bright enough to white out the sky. Catra squinted and shied away. When her eye's eyes adjusted, a deep red beam had cut across the sky Archanas' surface like a gash. In the next moment, four successive bursts of light followed the first, and Entrapta registered three destroyers and a dreadnought as confirmed losses after following their scuttling protocol.

"Fleet is at sixty-seven percent strength," she said, not taking her eyes off her PDA. "At this rate, we'll be down to a patchwork defensive grid within the hour."

“Our timeline has become immediate, then,” Angella said, leading their group down a steep flight of steps to a side bridge Catra knew served as a shortcut to the Whispering Woods adjacent to their kingdom.

“Our ability to mobilize has been cut off at the head,” Salas said. “All the gates leading out of the castle have been closed, and we will close this bridge once you are across. Whatever forces we managed to deploy before those Megaliths crashed, that is all the reinforcement we will have to deal with the thralls.”

This finally got a direct response from Glimmer.

“The princesses were in agreement with me,” she said. “We said we’d rather take the risk fighting more thralls sooner than fire on refugee ships without knowing they were clean. I was wrong and we will fight, but I will not apologize for wanting to avoid potentially killing innocents en masse out of fear.”

Catra saw Salas ready with a rebuttal, but Angella spoke up before he made it.

“There’s no use arguing,” she said, casting a stern look back at both him and her daughter while they continued to walk. “Our situation will not change, and every second we spend sniping back and forth at one another halves our chances of success. We execute the plan, and we do it now.

Angella’s mention of a plan reminded Catra there was a whole other nuance to defeating the Beast she’d forgotten about as soon as those Megaliths hit the earth. She looked over their group, only to find Adora trailing alone at the back, eyes cast down, a sort of immeasurable tension in her shoulders. She hadn’t said a word the entire trip out, and it surprised Catra she hadn’t thought to look for her sooner: Adora had never been one to just blend into a crowd before.

“She doesn’t look too happy,” Pip said in her head, and if Catra was having a crisis over how to lift her spirits before, it just

snowballed into something bigger.

A thousand screaming voices came to them, then, carried on the wind, pulling her attention. “That sounds a lot closer than the fields,” she said.

They reached the side bridge as a group, where four speeder bikes were hovering off the ground at the bridge’s mouth, their engines already warmed. The Whispering Woods dominated the panorama beyond, where a plume of smoke as large as Bright Moon castle itself was pushing into the sky.

“I was wondering where that last one crashed,” Entrapta said, mashing her fingers on the screen of her PDA, her eyes inches from its surface. “We’d only fired on one in the atmosphere, after all.”

“You four need to leave, now,” Salas said, looking to Catra, Adora, Corynth, and Taline. “Get to the crystal castle, activate the Heart. We will blow the bridge as soon as you’re across, like I said.”

Catra, with her enhanced eyesight, saw thralls shambling between the tree trunks in the distance. And if the staggering number of them she could see from across the bridge was any indication of the number that survived the crash, then their chances of making it to their destination seemed slim.

Corynth and Taline would probably be fine, and she at least had Pip to help her zip between tree and thrall alike on those speeders. But Adora? She looked back and saw her still standing with the group but not present, eyes staring through everything.

“There’s no way we’re going to be able to get there in one piece,” she said to Salas. “Not with an army waiting to ambush us in the trees.” She turned to Glimmer. “Maybe you could…?”

Glimmer grimaced, looking especially guilty. “Maybe if it were just me and one other person, but poofing four others? After that stunt I pulled getting us here, I don’t think I can swing it.”

“Maybe we can get them a ship?” Lonnie said. “Kyle and Rogelio just got back with everyone else from the field hospital. I’m sure there’s at least one Warbird we can spare and he could take them?”

“There’s no time.” Entrapta surprised everyone stepping up, eyes still glued to her PDA. “I’ve got a better idea.”

Angella, Salas, Corynth, and Taline exchanged looks, and Catra had to stifle how humorous she found it how everyone, her included, knew enough to be concerned whenever Entrapta grew excited enough about something to push her own agenda forward. Even Adora had perked up to see.

“Surface Command to Orbital Defence Command Carrier *Veer-Rak*,” Entrapta said, shouting at her PDA with unrestrained glee on her face. “Hordak? Come in!”

Adora made a face, Taline looked at Corynth with a quirked brow, Angella put her head in her hand, and Salas let out a weak “Oh, no” under his breath.

A moment later, Hordak’s irritated gravel voice cut through a static backdrop. “What is it, Entrapta?” he asked. “My hands are full enough already juggling our rapidly dwindling forces against this hell-spawn planet.”

Entrapta extended her arm like she was offering someone a fist bump, pointing the PDA across the bridge. “I’m painting a target for you,” she said. “There’s a bit of an obstacle we could use your help in clearing. Let me know as soon as you get the data.”

“Are you certain this is a good idea?” Taline asked, looking between Entrapta and Glimmer’s mom.

“*Now* you wish to think things through?” Salas asked. “This would not have been an issue at all had we followed your own procedure in the first place.”

Glimmer and Taline both glared at him, but Hordak came back online, and the crackling of Entrapta's shaky connection with him cut between them before either could say anything.

"This target is miles in diameter and far too close to your current position for me to feel comfortable with what you are suggesting," he said.

"That's why I painted the target in the first place, smart one. No use having you eyeball it all the way up there, even if the forest is enormous."

"Yes, but…Entrapta, are you sure this is wise?"

"See? Even Hordak thinks this is a bonkers idea," Catra said, eliciting a tight-lipped nod from Lonnie. They'd barely said a word to each other since this odd reunification, but there was no doubt in Catra's mind they were both remembering the same authoritarian upbringing they'd experienced under his leadership. Even if he'd changed in the intervening years, it was a shock to hear him express such naked caution and care.

Entrapta groaned. "There's no time to argue. You're losing ships by the minute, and we have a thrall problem down here that will only get more complicated the moment Beast fighters penetrate your defensive screen. Just triple check the coordinates and have your men fire, I promise we'll be fine."

A heavy sigh came through the line, followed by, "Target lock confirmed. Firing in three…two…"

A flash of green light burst overhead. The sound of the wind, the chirping of Etheria's birds, the rattle of fighting high above them, all of it ceased for a moment as if swallowed by an auditory black hole. Then it all came roaring back with an earth shattering sound, and everyone shied away, throwing their hands up to shield their eyes when the Whispering Woods lit up like a sun.

An enormous pillar of energy drilled into the ground, kicking up a new cloud of dust that pooled into a mushroom cloud as larger

than the plumes from the crashed Megaliths. Heat washed over them, only to disappear the next moment and leave them feeling colder than before. They struggled to keep their footing when the shockwave hit. Catra opted to hold onto Adora to keep her upright rather than cover her ears and prevent them from getting blown out over the sound of the Whispering Woods being turned into a hellscape.

"Status?" Hordak asked after some of the dust settled. Catra's ears were still ringing, she could make out enough to hear syllables once again.

Entrapta pumped her fist in the air, shouting. "That was perfect! Spot on targeting, pat your bridge officer on the back, whoever it was that calibrated the lock on."

"That would be me," Hordak said, a tinge of relief in his voice reaching Catra's ears. "I didn't trust anyone else to calculate the beam's trajectory, or its launch."

The line cut without any further comment, and in the silence fell upon them in Hordak's wake. Gone were the screeches from the thralls not even a hundred meters from them. It finally hit Catra that they'd traded plunging into a forest full of enemies with plunging into a bombed-out forest on fire.

Glimmer turned to Salas, working her jaw like she was trying to get her ear to pop. "Give us a minute?" she asked. "I can barely hear, and if they're the same then they're liable to run into a tree if they leave right away."

"Be quick," Salas said, dusting off his uniform and walking back toward the castle without sparing her a glance. "We'll be waiting for you at the central spire."

Catra hadn't realized she was still holding onto Adora until she slipped her hand out of her grasp, offering a timid smile before skirting off to go talk to Corynth and Taline by the speeders.

Before Catra could think of anything to say to call her back, Entrapta had come up and poked her in the arm.

"You're still wearing the PDA I gave you," she said, staring at Catra's wrist instead of looking her in the eyes. "Wow, that thing is so old."

Catra laughed despite herself. She brought her arm up, turning it this way and that to inspect the device. "You have no idea how many times I've heard that," she said. "Everyone at one point or another comments about how much of an exotic antique I'm wearing."

"Why didn't you just get a new one? There must have been better options once you got settled in."

"Nah, none of them would have come from you."

Entrapta finally looked at her, giving Catra full view of the impact of her words. If only talking to Adora could come this effortlessly.

"I watched every video you and Scorpia sent me," Catra said. "That stupidly powerful flashlight you put in here was strong enough to blind an Abomination. It saved my life. You both did."

Entrapta pulled her into a hug, and after a moment of stunned surprise, Catra wrapped her arms around her in return.

"I'm glad you're okay," Entrapta said.

Catra nodded and patted her back. When Entrapta released her, she said, "Scorpia is already at her outpost with her troops, but I'll tell her what you said. We didn't get enough time with each other before you had to go chasing after the scary mask man over there." Entrapta nodded to Corynth still standing with Taline and now Adora in the distance. "Salas really pulled a fast one on me getting him in. Although I guess he had to, considering what would have happened if I found out he was there while Taline was still around."

Catra gave her a confused look.

“You know about that?” Catra asked, earning a scoff.

“Oh, please,” Entrapta said. “I figured it out in the first place. And after I did, Salas started venting to me about all sorts of drama between them over the years. Probably because he felt confident that I was too engrossed in my work to retain anything he said.”

“But you remembered everything, didn’t you?”

Entrapta smiled. “Of course! A scientist never forgets.” A beat passed, and she pulled Catra into another quick hug, muttering, “Don’t you die out there.” She released her before she could respond and ran off, yelling something about them still having a lot of catching up to do when this was all over with.

Catra watched her go until she rounded the same corner their group came barreling around earlier. Glimmer was talking with Lonnie and her mom a handful of paces away, the sound of the Whispering Woods burning preventing her from overhearing what they were saying.

Angella wrapped her daughter in a hug, squeezing her tight with a few whispered words in her ear before letting her go and power walking the same path Entrapta took. After a few words exchanged with terse gestures, Lonnie sprinted after the Queen, too, and Glimmer turned her attention to Catra.

“Here,” Glimmer said, pushing something into Catra’s hand after closing the distance between them. “You weren’t at the meeting to get these, but you’ll still need it. Taline likely gave Corynth his, already.”

Catra opened her hand to see a sleek earpiece sitting on her palm. She pressed it into her ear, then interrupted whatever Glimmer had started explaining by snatching her wrist and pulling it back toward her. She’d noticed something when Glimmer handed over the earpiece. She pried open her fingers, revealing a large scar on the palm of her hand.

“That last deployment got a little harrier than the others,” Glimmer said in a low voice when Catra just stared at it, unable to breath. “Taline had a fit when she saw it, and I’m pretty sure my mom turned away and hugged her when she saw so I wouldn’t notice her crying.” She paused. “You’re handling it a lot better than either of them, I th—”

Catra yanked Glimmer forward off her feet, wrapping her in such a strong hug she let out a groan as Catra squeezed her. Pip made an offhand comment in the back of her head about how everyone was giving hugs, and how nice it must be to have a flesh and blood body to experience such a thing. Catra ignored her.

“H-hey,” Glimmer said, voice strained. “Wow. Since when do you voluntarily give hugs? I thought that was something you only ever did unconsciously in your sleep.”

“Shut up,” Catra said. “I heard what happened to Scavria. Did you really touch that thing?” When she didn’t get a response, Catra shuddered. “You should have *died*.”

Glimmer wriggled out of Catra’s grasp and held her out at arm’s length. “I could say the same thing about you!” she said, gesturing to Adora, Taline, and Corynth in the distance. “I know what brought them to Archanas and I know what was happening to you before we came to your rescue. Taline and Adora filled me in during the meeting.”

Catra averted her eyes, but Glimmer didn’t let her get away, stooping and leaning to keep in her line of sight. “I also know what it means that you and Taline were off Phoenix together in the first place, before this all happened. Is it too soon for me to say I told you so about the whole Sentinel thing?”

Leave it to Glimmer to give Catra shit during the least appropriate moments. Somehow, her keeping up their ridiculous dynamic now of all times was enough to somewhat lift Catra’s mood.

"I *was* being a bit dramatic, looking back on it," she said, laughing through her nose. "The actual process for becoming a Sentinel was much less…complicated than I thought it'd be."

"What was it?" Glimmer asked. "Tell me."

"Oh, hell no." Catra couldn't help a small smile. "You're never going to let me live it down."

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "You know I'm just going to find out from someone else. But fine, keep your secrets." She pulled her into another hug, finally returning the one Catra first gave her, and said, quietly against her ear, "I'm so proud of you."

"Proud of me?" Catra pressed her face into Glimmer's shoulder so her ruined uniform would soak up any tears. "I'm not the one who went and touched an Abomination and lived. Don't tell me that has something to do with how you and Lonnie and the others linked up?"

"It's a long story."

"I bet. I see how you two are around each other. It's like you have your own Sentinel now, with her trailing you like that."

"Don't go giving her ideas. She's already got an insubordinate streak getting scouted for the Vanguard."

"Sounds like you two are perfect for each other, then. Beats me how that makes any sense, though."

The way Glimmer sighed put a clear picture in Catra's head of her rolling her eyes. "You two have always had a prickly relationship."

"Next time you see her, tell her she can suck my—"

"Catra!"

Glimmer broke their hug and punched Catra's shoulder, making her snort with laughter, and her look of stricken disbelief melted a

moment later when she descended into laughter, too. A moment later, they both jumped in surprise when they realized Taline was standing with them.

"I'm glad circumstances haven't put a damper on your habit of antagonizing one another," she said. "I always looked forward to when you both visited me together."

Corynth was still standing by the speeders at the mouth of the bridge with Adora. She looked like she was pleading with him, but again, Catra couldn't overhear. Taline started to walk back to them, indicating for Catra and Glimmer to follow. After a few steps, Adora wilted, and the hollow, defeated look she had on earlier returned. Corynth must have said something to put her out—that was the only explanation Catra had.

"He told me the plan," Catra said to Taline, before they got close enough for Corynth or Adora to hear. "Now I know why you said I needed to keep him alive."

"It's not ideal," Taline said, 'but it's our only shot at victory right now." She looked over her shoulder at Glimmer. "Thank you for not pushing back when we laid it out."

Glimmer gave a single, terse nod, lips pressed together. Catra could read she wanted to say something, likely an apology or acknowledgement of the immense pain Taline was no doubt holding back from expressing, but she didn't.

"Whose that fourth speeder for?" Catra asked, her eyes roving over each one before landing on Glimmer. "Yours?"

Glimmer shook her head. "I'm with central command. We…didn't think it was right to tell Adora to stay behind, on top of everything else we dropped on her back at the meeting."

Catra pressed her lips into a thin line. They were right. Adora's mental state was likely in such disarray, it was more kindness than anything else they let her go along with them despite not being the Heart's catalyst, yet.

They reached the bridge, and Corynth wasted no time once they arrived. “We need to go,” he said, and Catra heard none of the weak rasp or death-rattle breathing he’d wrestled with when they were alone. “The sooner we get to the Crystal Castle, the better.” He tapped the side of his mask that covered where his ear was. “Archanas has already broken through the fleet screen as of seconds ago, and it’s only a matter of time before it grows powerful enough it’s influence can start to impact us directly.”

Glimmer nodded. “You should have a clear path after that craziness Entrapta pulled, so our focus will be keeping the thralls and whatever else the Beast throws at us away from Bright Moon and the civilians. We’re connected to one another through the earpieces, though, so if the situation in the Whispering Woods shifts, you can reach us and we’ll do what we can to help.”

Catra mounted the nearest speeder, with Adora taking the one next to her.

“We’ll let you know as soon as we arrive,” Taline said, throwing her leg over the last open speeder after Corynth claimed his.

Glimmer nodded again. “Watch out for each other out there, okay?”, she said, before poofing away.

Corynth and Taline spooled their engines faster, and in a fit of heightened panic (because everything was suddenly real and immediate), Catra turned to Adora and said the first thing that came to mind.

“No Swift Wind?” she asked, forcing a smile while she screamed internally. Even Pip winced in her head at how that came out.

Adora somehow slumped even further in the saddle. “No Swift Wind,” she said, morose. “Probably for the best. Flying above the tree line would make me an easier target, and Pip just said there are already a handful of Beast interceptors that broke through and are challenging our air superiority.”

Catra wondered how Adora could get any information from Pip if she wasn't integrated with her, until her earpiece went live and Pip's voice came through for all four of them to hear.

"There's way more than a handful, now," she said. "The fleet has been reduced to half, and Interceptors are streaming to the surface. It's like watching schools of fish escaping through a broken net."

Catra cursed, revving the bike. "Stick as close behind me as you can, then," she said to Adora, refusing to let the fear she felt show on her face. If she couldn't think of something to say to get through to her, then the least she could do was put on a brave face for her sake. "With how fast we'll be dodging between those trees, it will be easier for you to focus on following me than try to do it by yourself."

Adora nodded, listless, and that response was alarming. Adora had always been able to flip a switch and turn 'on,' so to speak, when push came to shove. Seeing none of that happen now scared her. She had to say *something* to get through to her, but all her brain could supply her with at the moment was some variation of panicking nonsense.

Corynth pulled the trigger before she could torture herself any further over it. He shot off across the bridge, Taline right there with him. Catra rocketed forward behind her, and she glanced over her shoulder to make sure Adora followed as instructed.

As soon as the four of them cleared the bridge, Catra heard an explosion, and another glance back confirmed her suspicions: the Enclave had blown the bridge like they said they would. The only path open to them now was forward, through the Whispering Woods, burning.

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The Moonstone was humming at the center of the castle's highest tower when Glimmer reappeared next to it. Lonnie rounded on her right away.

“Did you seriously just poof up here?” she asked. Her eyes flared, and she looked vexed enough it gave Glimmer pause in the middle of thinking how nice it was she could do that so easily, again.

“Yes?” she said.

Lonnie propped her rifle against a nearby battlement and crossed her arms over her chest plate armor. “You poofed us from one planet to another across *space* and then blacked out. Why in the name of Horde Prime’s third eye are you doing it again when you haven’t rested properly yet? You told the others you weren’t well enough to take them directly to the Crystal Castle, that’s why we gave them speeders in the first place.”

“I said taking all four would be too much. I can poof myself just fine, thank you very much.” She smirked. It was like arguing against her mom as a teenager all over again, although that idea felt more nostalgic than it ever had in this moment.

“I’m sure you can,” Lonnie said. “But at least save the teleportation for when you really need it, will you? There’s a battle going on. If we find ourselves in a sticky situation, I want you well enough to poof right out. It’d be shitty if you were too exhausted to do it when you needed to because you’d decided to save a few minutes getting to the spire instead of taking the stairs.”

She had a point, but Glimmer wasn’t in a conciliatory mood.

Rogelio appeared then, clearing the last few steps leading to the spire-top, carrying a bulky trunk over his shoulder. By the look on his face, he’d heard Lonnie arguing and thought it was funny, the traitor. Lonnie caught it and her face soured. Glimmer thought to say something smart just to make everything worse for no reason, until Entrapta, Salas, and all his Sentinels came into view following Rogelio from behind.

“Ladies, can we please focus?” Salas said, before Glimmer could speak.

Lonnie seemed ready to punch him in the face for calling her a lady, and Glimmer nearly rounded on him for the same, but he walked past without sparing either of them a glance. He stopped before the Moonstone, and his dozen robed Sentinels moving to encircle him.

"We have a limited window of time before the thralls from those Megaliths hit our forward position," he said. "If we don't hold them there, we'll have to fall all the way back to the city."

Rogelio put the trunk down nearby with a *thunk,* and Entrapta threw it open, humming. A group of techs had come up the stairs in the meantime. They began pulling equipment out of the box, setting up a mobile command center next to the Moonstone.

"Forward tower three is going to get hit first," Entrapta said, turning to her PDA while her assistants worked. "Frosta's tower. And she's the furthest behind her deployment schedule. If the thralls break through, the others will get flanked pretty quick."

"We'll buy her as much time as we can, then," Salas said.

A holographic map of the nearby plains burst over the first piece of tech Entrapta's assistants had turned on. Icons for the guard towers were spaced miles apart and carved a jagged bulwark before Bright Moon castle and its walled castle town. Beyond the line were three amorphous blobs of red—the crashed Megaliths and their pooled troops beginning to spread out.

The intensity of the colors made Glimmer shudder. Most of their forces were still inside the city walls—there was no way to deploy them all in time thanks to her decision to let those Megaliths through—and everyone out on the plains was grossly outnumbered. Thankfully, their technological and magical advantage was significant, but looking at the disparity, Glimmer still wasn't sure they'd come out the other side of it.

"Where are we aiming for?" Salas asked, as he spread his arms wide. Geometric rune lines etched into the smooth stone

underfoot. His Sentinels followed his example as Entrapta rattled off an unbroken string of coordinates. When she was done, Salas threw his head back, face pointed to the sky, then threw his palm up as if to grasp something in the clouds.

The rune completed, and heat burst from its enclosure, forcing Glimmer back with her arms shielding her face.

A fireball as large as Glimmer's bedroom appeared above Salas' outstretched palm, spinning in place, screeching. It launched, carving a long parabola through the sky, heat dimming the further it got. Lonnie and Rogelio's tracked its path with awe, and Glimmer was certain she wore the same expression—even with a team supporting him, Salas' magic was impressive, even for a Battlemage. There was no doubt in her mind he outclassed most of his peers, except for maybe Taline.

Glimmer didn't so much see as hear the fireball impact in the distance, just like she didn't see so much as hear the thralls it hit. The sound of thousands of their screeching voices echoed with the breeze, and the intensity of one of those blobs of enemies on Entrapta's holo-map dimmed.

Glimmer shuddered, hoping one day she'd forget that sound. "Shouldn't I be down there, too?" she asked. "I could lead one of the interstitial teams between the towers." For all their discussion of 'the plan' earlier, Glimmer had neglected to clarify her own role in it.

Lonnie looked like she'd kiss Catra on the mouth than let Glimmer fight a thrall army, but then again, Lonnie's primary concern was keeping her safe and uninfected. Glimmer didn't want to consider the consequences of her or any other princesses getting overwhelmed on the field. There were countless magic-wielding beings here; if the Beast took any of them, there would be countless new Abominations, and Etheria would join Scavria and Rinne as the new lost worlds of the second war.

There was a reason why the princesses had been shoved into heavily fortified compounds despite being on the front lines, after all.

“Your parents are filling that role already,” Salas said, striding up to her while his assistants caught their breath.

“Then I can help Frosta. If she’s not got a full roster of troopers, I can—"

“I need your help up here.”

Glimmer frowned and looked around. Aside from the Moonstone and Salas’ Sentinels, it was just Entrapta with her assistants manning an intelligence tower. “With what?” she asked.

“Energy spike from the Archanas!” Entrapta said, before Salas could answer her. “This one is worse than the others. It blew out our sensor readings!”

A star-bright pinprick flashed against Archanas’ curve, and an overwhelming feeling of fast-approaching death washed over Glimmer.

Salas threw his hands up and she did the same, pulling as much extra magic as she could from the Moonstone, treating it like a living apeiron and pushing the everything it gave her to her palms. A bubble shield large enough to cover the castle and the city bloomed above them, moments before a concentrated beam of red, Beast-infused energy as wide as one of the castle’s turrets struck.

The force of the impact pushed Glimmer down to her knees. She yelped and strained with Salas to keep the barrier intact. It felt like she was holding all of Archanas on her shoulders as it tried to grind her into the floor.

When she started to think the two of them might crack was when the pressure evaporated and the beam dissolved. Glimmer fell forward on her hands and knees, gasping, and Lonnie and Rogelio

were helping her upright within moments. Even Salas looked winded. His assistants were on him in a moment, and he brushed them off to go to her.

“That’s why I wanted you up here,” he said, pulling her to her feet. “Even with my team, I don’t think I would have been able to fend that off without your help. Already the Beast is fogging up our sensors enough Entrapta needs to be exposed out here rather than inside the war room. At least now, if our intel is correct, we have some time before that beam is ready to fire again.”

“How did you know it was going to aim for the surface?” Glimmer asked, gasping for breath.

“Experience,” Salas said. He offered her a hand and hoisted Glimmer to her feet when she took it. “It doesn’t need to keep punching holes in our fleet any longer, so the surface would be its next target. And aiming for the tallest tower with the Moonstone atop it was a safe bet.”

Glimmer nodded, leaning into Lonnie and Rogelio to help keep her upright after Salas released her. Lonnie was right: she hadn’t had enough time to rest since Scavria.

“For the record,” Salas said, giving her a serious look. “I didn’t enjoy being the voice of reason against you, earlier. To have come out alive after touching an Abomination and still retain such an optimism against the Beast?” He looked away. “Some might call that naiveite, but I would not.”

“What would you call it, then?”

“Faith in yourself, perhaps. Or maybe vision. Both of which I’d believed all of us had lost long ago fighting this creature.”

Had Salas just admitted a begrudging respect for her?

Entrapta, who had since moved from her PDA to the fully set up computer system, stopped tapping at the console and looked over at them. “More news,” she said.

Glimmer lolled her head back and groaned. To her surprise, though, it wasn't Entrapta that spoke next. The crackling sound of a precarious comms connection rang out from the speakers, and Kyle's voice spoke over the channel.

"Another wave of Beast Interceptors has broken through the Orbital Fleet's screen," he said. "We're changing course to engage, but there's an anomaly. A squadron of five has deviated from the main arrangement. Do you guys see it on sensors?"

It clear that, just like how Rogelio had found his way to them at the top of the spire, at some point since leaving the field hospital, Kyle had gotten in another Warbird to take the fight to the Beast, directly.

Glimmer shrugged off Lonnie and Rogelio's help, finally feeling well enough to support herself. She made her way to the holographic map, where the thralls had spread out to cover most of the plains in front of their defensive tower line. A flood of fighters was descending from above, chased by several groups of tightly organized blue dots: their own Warbirds in pursuit.

"I see them," Glimmer said, watching a five-group of red dots that had broken off. "Looks like they're coming for us."

"Can you handle it, or should we chase them down?"

"We should be able to handle it on our own," Entrapta said glancing up at Salas and Glimmer. "Not sure why they're sending any at us directly, and only five, but we have plenty of firepower to use against a handful of airborn—"

"Wait!" Glimmer said, leaning in to get a better look. "They've changed course." She waited several tense heartbeats to watch their new trajectory. A stone dropped in the pit of her stomach when it confirmed her suspicions.

Lonnie cursed under her breath. "They're heading straight for the Whispering Woods." Her and Glimmer locked eyes. "You don't think…?"

“Kyle,” Glimmer said to the console in lieu of responding to Lonnie. “Take a wingman and get to those Interceptors. Now.”

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Burning trees and stumps whipped past Catra as she sped through the Whispering Woods.

Despite keeping her head low and pulling shallow breaths, her lungs burned from the smoke. It blanketed the landscape, searing her throat and making her eyes water. And despite having ripped up part of her uniform and tying the cloth over her nose and mouth, every draw of breath felt like the pricking of a thousand needles deep inside her chest.

Corynth and Taline were ahead of her, weaving between the trees. Corynth seemed even more adept at it than Catra.

::How is he riding one of these things without falling over right now?:: she asked. ::Are you helping him?::

“No more than I’m helping you,” Pip said.

::I don’t get it.:: Catra pulled the handlebars and the speeder cleared a burning trunk that had fallen over. She checked over her shoulder to make sure Adora was still with her. ::I was half convinced I’d have to fireman carry him away from that balcony earlier, but he ended up beating me back to the ground level. Is he able to, what…just seem like he’s not on the verge of death if he wants?::

“It’s called a final push for a reason, Catra: you push. And Corynth can push pretty damn hard when he needs to. Being a few steps from death’s door isn’t going to slow him down.”

::Is he *trying* to sprint past the finish line, though?::

“He’s already done that.” Pip sounded equal parts proud and agonized to admit it. “I think his plan is to do another lap, at least.”

“Guys?” Adora’s voice came through Catra’s earpiece. “I think I just saw a thrall wandering around out here. I’m not sure Hordak’s orbital blast took them all out.”

“Shit, seriously?” Catra scanned the trees speeding past them for signs of movement. It didn’t take her long before she found them —blurry imprints of vaguely humanoid shapes moving in and out of the smog.

‘They’ve been tracking us,” Taline said, also through the earpiece. “Normally, they wouldn’t have even noticed us moving as fast as we are, but these are following. Just make sure you don’t fall off your speeder or crash. They won’t be able to catch you as long as you keep up the pace.”

That went without saying, of course. Knowing her and Adora’s luck, though, Taline having said as much out loud only made it more likely one of them was going to get thrown.

A hellish screeching tore through the air. Catra jerked her bike to the side, thinking the sound was a group of thralls about to ambush at her from the trees. A moment later, the air above them opened up as a group of fighters surged past in formation, clearing the haze like a ship cutting through ocean water.

“Are those ours?” Catra asked over the group channel. “Please tell me those are ours.”

The ships doubled back far ahead, screaming straight for them. Catra got her answer when they started firing, their energy beams throwing up ash and soil like exploding mines when they impacted the dirt.

“Break!” Taline said.

“Adora, stick with me!” Catra yanked the controls to the side, veering left while Corynth and Taline went right. Adora was still close behind when she checked, and overhead, she saw above the tree line that two of the five enemy fighters changed course to pursue them.

The earbud crackled in Catra's ear, and a new voice came over the line. "Hey, uh, we might have a bit of a problem," Glimmer said through the static.

"I think you might be right," Catra said, weaving through a pair of close-growing tree stumps. "If you're talking about a bunch of Interceptors trying to shoot us from the sky, then they're already here."

"Wait, really? I don't have trackers for you all… you're further ahead than I thought. How are they already on you?"

"They're Beast Interceptors," Taline said, joining their conversation. "From the Archanan mining compound. The Beast has taken directly controlling it like the thralls. no need for pilots and no need to adhere to g-force or speed limitations."

"There are still actual thralls here, too," Catra said to Glimmer, weaving to avoid another run of blaster fire and watching the Interceptors bank around for yet another run. "Taline said they've been tracking us."

Glimmer said something colorful. "Then I wouldn't be surprised if the Interceptors had been doing the same, if they're similar enough. Hold on. Kyle and Bow are on their way with a squadron to take them out. They're almost—"

The two gearing up for another blaster run exploded as another vessel overtook them, moving so fast it appeared only as a black smudge even to Catra's enhanced senses: there one moment and gone the next.

"Wait," Glimmer said. "Sensors just lost two of them." A trio of explosions in the distance reached Catra's ears a moment later. "Now all five are gone from the sensors."

"Looks like Kyle got to us already," Catra said. "That boy burned *fast* to get to us."

Another pause. Then: "That wasn't them."

A moment later a Warbird and Bow atop a winged horse shot past them. Catra frowned.

"Well, *something* came and blew those Interceptors out of the sky. Any idea what?" Catra hadn't realized Pip had faded into the back of her consciousness until she reasserted herself at the forefront of it, urging her to stop.

"I'm trying to figure that out now," Entrapta said, her voice joining the channel and intermixing with Pip's presence in an irritating way. "I picked up an energy signature the split second before and after each of those Interceptors exploded, but it disappeared right after and I haven't been able to pick it up again. You didn't happen to get a good look at it, did you?"

Catra shook her head, only then realizing Entrapta had no way of seeing. "No," she said. "It was moving too fast." When Pip's urging became impossible to ignore, she growled. ::What?::

"Adora!"

The urgency in her voice sent a bolt of ice streaking down Catra's spine. She checked behind, and saw no Adora in sight.

::Where the hell is she?:: Catra skidded to a halt. Already, she could hear the thralls closing in on her.

"I don't see any wreckage or a body."

::You mean you didn't see what happened to her?::

"I was preoccupied. This seems to be a recurring theme with you, that you forget I'm an AI, not omniscient. I can't reach her through the comms, either. She must have fallen off her speeder."

Thralls were starting to come out from between the trees. A good number of them were even on fire, but that didn't seem to slow them. Catra was panicking.

“Keep your head on straight, damn it,” Pip said. “She’s back there somewhere. Go find her!”

Glimmer and Entrapta were still talking over the comms. One of them—she wasn’t sure who, since she hadn’t been paying attention—was trying to prompt her. Instead, Catra cut her link to them, revved the speeder, and shot off back in the direction she’d come.

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Glimmer thought something was wrong with her connection at first when her PDA told her Catra had dropped. When she tried reconnecting with her and got an immediate error, however, she knew something else was at play.

“Catra cut her connection,” she said, concerned. When she looked up at the holographic map, panned to the Whispering Woods, it had glitched and gone fuzzy enough she couldn’t discern any intel from it.

“Archanas’ ion storm is growing powerful enough it’s affecting my instrumentation even up here, now,” Entrapta said. She pressed a few commands into her console and slid a digital lever on another screen up. Most of the map including the Whispering Woods fell away, but the remaining view of the battlefield plains clarified. “So much for nailing down that ghost ship. I’ve redirected everything to give us a clear view of the battlefield, instead.”

“We’ll just have to trust those four can get the job done, then,” Glimmer said.

Another fireball exploded out from Salas’ outstretched hand. The rune he was standing on dissipated, and his Sentinels lowered their arms. Glimmer couldn’t help remembering how, when she’d first seen them group-cast like this, it had been aboard Horde Prime’s citadel, them linking her mind to Catra’s while Salas invaded it. That memory seemed like ancient history now.

“The front line is getting hit hard,” Entrapta said, drawing Glimmer’s attention again. “Especially Frosta’s tower, despite Salas’ assistance. I don’t think she’ll be able to hold.”

The map of the plains showed the red markers of countless thousands of Scavrian thralls throwing themselves against a thin, flexing line of Etherian and Enclave forces, anchored to the princess’ tower compounds. The forwardmost one—Frosta’s, no doubt—had the heaviest concentration of red around it.

Catra had said the surviving thralls in the woods were intelligent enough to track them. Did that mean the ones on the plains were also smart enough to pick up on and try to exploit a weakness? Just like those on Rinne had?

“Any chance one of the interstitial teams can clear a retreat corridor for her?” Lonnie asked, scrutinizing the map. “Or maybe one of the other tower bases? Perfuma is closest, and it looks like she has a handle on things. Scorpia’s team, too. Maybe if they both break off what they can spare, then…?”

“Not a smart choice,” Salas said, narrowing his eyes at the display. “The line is thin enough already. If we strip any resources away from them, everything will fall apart.”

“We can’t just hang them out to dry, though!” Lonnie said. “We’re screwed if the line collapses, and it will collapse if that tower falls without a tactical retreat.”

“Bow, I need you back here,” Glimmer said into the comms. “Bring your own wingmen, I need you to protect the castle and the spire.”

She’d hatched a plan, but with so many interceptors breaking through the atmosphere, the castle would need dedicated air support. When Bow confirmed her orders, she said, “Kyle, load a contingent of soldiers in your hold. Leave space for three, then come to us, too. We need a pick up.”

“Roger,” Kyle said.

Lonnie and Rogelio knew what she was thinking, that much Glimmer could tell when she looked at them, but Salas was harder to read.

“Don’t tell me you’re going to play devil’s advocate again?” she asked.

She expected him to frown at her and offer compelling reasons to stay behind. She imagined potentially even taking that advice, depending on what it was; even in peril, Frosta was not helpless, and just a scant few moments earlier she’d ignored his advice to great detriment, so maybe this time she’d listen.

Instead, Salas smiled and clapped her on the shoulders, the grip of his hands, firm. “Who better to boost morale and reinforce our most vulnerable outpost than the Angel of Archanas herself? Take your Vanguard and go.”

Chapter End Notes

> I can't decide if this is the start to a second battle, or a continuation of the same battle that started at the beginning of this part. If anything, it feels like the start of "The Battle--Part 2."
>
> Anyways, I remember thinking that choreographing the 3-way switching POV fight aboard Horde Prime's citadel in part 1 was tough. This sequence is like that earlier sequence's older brother. The goal with this was to tie everything the characters and you as the reader went through in the preceding parts. Everything culminates here.
>
> ...It definitely stretched me as a writer. In so many new directions :)

# Hero's Lament

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Traveling to Frosta's watchtower was a nervous affair.

When Glimmer boarded Kyle's new Warbird with Lonnie and Rogelio, she was greeted by a sea of new faces, all of them eager to serve alongside the famed Angel of Archanas. They were heading into the hottest part of the battlefield with the Angel herself, and despite every bit of confidence Glimmer had gained over the years, she still didn't feel good about marshalling all these soldiers in such a hectic battle zone.

"Where the hell are we supposed to land?" Lonnie asked. They'd left the hold doors open, and she was looking down at the armies on the plains, shouting to be heard over the wind. "*Can* we even land in this mess?"

Halfway to their destination, news came of their forces holding a line between Frosta's tower and her neighbors getting overrun. Neither were headed by her parents, thankfully, but that meant the compound was now surrounded, and there was no front for them to safely land behind.

"Salas will enforce a twenty-meter perimeter around the tower for us once we get close," Glimmer said, shouting as well. Doubt in her voice was evident even to her own ears: the thralls were enough like a tempest sea below them, she could barely see the grass of the plains they stood upon. "Frosta and her personal guard are barricaded in the tower, so our job once we land is to clear all the thralls we find inside and get everyone to the top for an extract." She gauged her troops' reactions. "Any questions?"

No questions came, but everyone Etherian and Enclave soldier in the hold continued to look at her with a mix of awe and trepidation. Two individuals in particular, she noticed, were a

different uniform, and both were looking at her with a peculiar kind of recognition, different than the others.

“You look like you have something to ask,” she said to the taller of the two, a husky alien with bony armor plating across their body. “We’re heading straight to the front line. If you have anything to say, now is the time.”

They shook their head, but it was the one next to them—a large, purple individual only a head shorter than them—that spoke. “No questions, Ma’am, we’ve just heard a lot about you.” She nudged her friend. “Sorry for staring.”

Lonnie and Rogelio snickered behind her, and it dawned on Glimmer why their uniforms looked so familiar despite being different from the others. They were Security Officer uniforms from Phoenix.

“You’re Catra’s friends, aren’t you?” she asked, making both light up.

“We were with her on Archanas when you rescued us,” the purple one said. “I’m Keren, and this is Trayn.”

“It’s a pleasure meeting you in person,” Trayn said, as Glimmer shook both their hands. “We just wish it was under better circumstances.”

One of Salas’ fireballs shot past them, flying ahead faster than they and their wingmen. A crescendo of screeches echoed up from the plains after the impact, and then the Warbird jerked forward as if running nose-first into a wall. Only Kyle’s masterful piloting prevented them from flipping fully upside down.

Alarms rang from the cockpit, punctuated by Kyle cursing at the controls. “When did they start flinging themselves like projectiles?” he said, shouting into his headset. He maneuvered them around one of their wingmen who’d panicked and nearly veered into them. “Everyone, evasive maneuvers. Drive high!”

Several unsecured soldiers fell out the open troop hold doors, screaming. Glimmer held tight to the overhead railing to avoid the same fate. Despite Kyle's best efforts, they fishtailed out of control. Sounds of 'mayday' came across all radio channels. Glimmer only had a few seconds to get a protective shield around the craft before they impacted the dirt.

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The thralls were on fire.

Granted, so was everything else, but something about being rushed by a dozen-and-a-half bodies more concerned with ripping her face off than extinguishing the flames eating them made Adora break out in a cold sweat despite the heat.

She was in the middle of a clearing. Her speeder lay in a crumpled heap nearby. She'd lost her earpiece, too, tumbling off the speeder, and her only option left was to fight.

She swung at one thrall as it got close, the Sword of Protection cleaving it in half when it did nothing to avoid her. She swung at more as they came, continuing through a combination of swings, slashes, and thrusts until several dozen thrall bodies lay around her in heaps.

*Please don't beat yourself up over this,* Corynth had said earlier, his words to her at the mouth of the bridge echoing in her head each time her blade sung through the air. *This isn't your fault. It's okay to need more time.*

"But there *is* no more time!" Adora was so lost in her frustration she repeated her words aloud on the back of another swing. She didn't realize she'd overextended until she'd dropped four more thralls and stumbled to keep upright.

Corynth didn't believe in her, despite her best attempts convincing him to let her handle the Heart with the half of She Ra she'd recaptured. She really shouldn't have been surprised, she

rationalized. He'd made it clear since she'd first woken up on his ship that she was someone he was merely putting up with.

But…still. After what they'd gone through together—after what he'd said to her moments before Taline confronted him—she'd thought he might at least have grown to appreciate her in a new light, like she had with him.

Instead, he'd chosen to rely on Catra once he met her, and give Adora nothing but vague answers and excuses. Another thrall ran into her sword, and she scoffed, still deep in her thoughts. It wasn't like she blamed him, either! Catra had Taline's personal confidence, and surely that held far more weight than a failed vessel for She Ra.

These thoughts continued to plague her as she caught her breath, doubled over. Her vision was blurring, and the ash in the air made her lungs feel like they were on fire just as much as the trees. It was surprising she hadn't succumbed to smoke inhalation, already.

More thralls came, and the Sword felt heavier in her hands when she raised it in challenge to them. One managed to get inside her defense with a lunge, forcing her to spin away with a counterstrike in exchange for the thrall's arm. That didn't slow it down—why would it when being on literal fire hadn't slowed any of them down to begin with?—but Adora was flagging, hard.

When that armless thrall rounded on her with yet three others, fatigue got the better of Adora. She stumbled back, and watched even more thralls appear from between the trees and among the smog. A voice in her head—small and insignificant, but growing fast enough to eclipse the earlier voice of self-pity—told her it was only a matter of time before they overran her.

Another thrall lunged, getting closer than the other before Adora spilled its guts across the forest floor. Her foot caught on a something: a rock or a root, or perhaps nothing at all. She fell against a burned-out tree trunk, gasping for breath, sweat and

ash and grime coating her face and her chest and making her clothes stick to her.

A quick tally had her counting over three dozen thralls surrounding her, closing in. Many of them stepped over their fallen brothers and sisters in their advance, like some mindless, unstoppable force of nature rather than a once proud, sentient race of people.

The voice in her head now screamed Death. Despite her powers, despite how much progress she'd made, she was tiring and wouldn't be able to keep up much longer. She couldn't even draw a full breath anymore without coughing.

Out of desperation, she reached for more magic, and a voice she'd heard for years now every time she closed her eyes spoke to her from the crackling, roaring flames eating the Whispering Woods whole.

*You have forsaken me, Adora,* She Ra said, repeating the words she'd first said after Adora lost her confrontation with Horde Prime. *You are not the person I thought you were.*

No more power came. It might as well have been She Ra herself shutting the door in Adora's face for good. The Princess of Power was done with her. Wanted to wash its hands of her and focus on whoever the next chosen hero of a future age would be.

And there would still be a future age, despite Adora's lack of utility in confronting the present threat. Corynth and Taline were far ahead, and Catra would arrive at the Crystal Castle with them. Together, they would activate the Heart, and Corynth would sacrifice himself to clear Archanas' influence above.

Yes, she could picture it clearly.

With the thralls closing in and her body already pushing its limits, Adora closed her eyes, the point of the sword dipping with her loosening grip. She hoped whoever came after her would be a worthier vessel for She Ra's divine self than she was.

A squeal sounded in the distance. No, not distant, Adora realized the next moment. It was much closer than that, and it certainly didn't sound like another group of thralls, either. It almost sounded like a speeder engine…pushed to its breaking point.

She opened her eyes to see Catra clear a jump, bursting through the flames engulfing a toppled tree, and landing into the clearing with her. When the speeder touched down, she carved a sharp semicircle before the thralls, kicking up dirt and rocks in their faces and forcing them back.

"Get on!" she said, stopping the bike next to Adora while the thralls were off balance. Her expression was difficult to read because of the cloth tied over her nose and mouth.

Adora blinked, then blinked again, only realizing that she wasn't in fact hallucinating when Catra's demeanor shifted, turning incredulous.

"Are you nuts?" Catra asked, looking at Adora from under furrowed brows as the thralls regained their bearings. She revved the speeder. "Get on the bike!"

The urgency in her voice made something warm bloom in Adora's chest. She clambered on, wrapping adrenaline-shaken fingers around Catra from behind before the bike spurred forward at speed.

"Hold on," Catra said as she threaded them between two close growing trees, pushing the speeder at a far faster clip than they'd gone when Adora was following her.

Adora wrapped her arms around her tighter. Neither of them had seen each other for years, and now was the second time in less than a day Adora had held Catra from behind like this. And both in life threatening situations, too.

It wasn't lost on Adora, how Catra's words had compelled her where her own survival instinct couldn't. Because here Catra was, saving her yet again after she'd let her guard down—on purpose

this time. This was the first time she came face to face with such a naked desire to feel needed. This  was something Catra wrestled with, never Adora. Hers was always some related but tangential issue of self-esteem. She'd felt pressured to be perfect, of course, but never completely unneeded or redundant.

As they sped further through the smokey woods, past scattered pockets of gathered thralls and swathes of burning woodland, Adora came to understand how demoralizing feeling so unneeded was, and how stupid it made her feel to get so hung up on such a thing.

She didn't *require* Catra to need her, absolutely not! But the fact it was so crystal clear Catra was fine without her made Adora doubt even more that she was worth keeping around anymore to begin with. She Ra wanted nothing to do with her, Corynth saw no need to so much as pretend to humor her any longer, Glimmer hadn't thought it necessary to call her over after she'd woken up and held an important meeting with Taline and Salas at the crash site, and everyone in the War Room wouldn't have left with Angella if they weren't also united in keeping her from fulfilling the one and only thing she was destined for in the first place: activating the Heart. So, what was the point to her?

"How do you do it?" Adora asked, when the despair of it all was too much to contain any longer.

"What was that?" Catra shouted over her shoulder to be heard over the sound of the air whipping past them.

"I made the biggest mistake of my life giving you up so I could focus on saving the universe," Adora said. " I haven't been able to do anything helpful. You, Corynth, and Taline are all so amazing, and…here I am."

"Here you are, what?" Catra asked. "What does that mean?"

"I'm just holding you all back." Adora caught the look of surprise and disbelief looking at Catra's profile, but she wasn't going to

give her any openings to argue. “I can’t even use She Ra fully, but that’s not even really an excuse because I had years to figure her out. You don’t have any powers, but you ended up having to cover for me back on Archanas. How do you do it?”

“Adora, you can’t be serious.” Catra looked appalled, and that only made Adora want to throw herself off the bike and crawl under a rock. Instead, she buried her face into Catra’s shoulder so she wouldn’t have to look at her.

They rode without speaking for a moment. Adora thought perhaps that was the end of the conversation, then Catra said, “You aren’t holding any of us back. It’s dangerous out here, we’re all just trying to survive. Besides, how do you know I don’t have powers? We haven’t seen each other in a while. I move a heck of a lot faster than I did before, in case you haven’t noticed.” A beat. “Are you just embarrassed because I’m the one that pulled your ass out of the hot water this time?”

“That’s not it,” Adora said. “I just think maybe She Ra should have picked one of you instead of me.”

“One of us?”

“Corynth, Taline, maybe Glimmer—”

“Adora, we weren’t even out of Despondos yet when you found the sword, and Glimmer would *not* make a good She Ra, are you kidding me?”

Adora gritted her teeth together. “You, then! You especially wouldn’t have the problems I’m having trying to figure this out. She wouldn’t be half as disappointed with you as she is with me if you’d inherited her powers, and no one would need to die to stop all of this, either!”

Catra went stiff in Adora’s arms, her shoulders rising to her ears. They were fighting again, and this time there was yet again no doubt about who started it. Could Adora seriously not go more

than a handful of seconds without making Catra upset over some comment she was too stupid to think out beforehand?

"What's going on, Adora?" Catra asked. Surprisingly, she sounded stricken instead of angry. "This isn't you."

*…you are not the person I thought you were…*

She Ra's words echoed in her head. She bit her lip, willing her tears not to fall and despairing when they did anyway. She was tired of pushing so hard for so long and not measuring up.

"Hey, are you there?" Catra tried to twist her upper body in the seat to look at her, but Adora held her tight enough to keep her facing forward. "Talk to me. Tell me what's going on. Please?"

Strange. Adora was certain Catra would be mad at her, but the way she was asking her to open up, it sounded almost…pleading? Again, words came flooding out of her before she could think them through.

"Do you remember when Taline pulled out that crystal and shattered it on Horde Prime's citadel?" she asked.

Catra took them through a harrowing turn between two boulders, then underneath an overturned tree with just enough room Adora avoided smacking her head on it.

"How could I forget?" she asked. "Worst nightmares of my life, even to today. Did you ever tell anyone what you saw?"

"Angella knows. I told her maybe a few weeks ago. It feels longer than that."

"Anyone else?" Adora shook her head against Catra's back, and Catra made a sound halfway between surprise and incredulity. "Seriously? You held on all this time without telling anyone else? Why?"

"I just…I couldn't."

She couldn’t talk about all the worlds she’d seen destroyed in those nightmares; couldn’t talk about how more would be lost the longer she went unable to step into her powers again. Couldn’t talk about how all of it hinged on a mistake she’d made in a moment of desperation.

“I saw her,” Adora said. “I saw She Ra.”

“Like, you saw *her*? Separate from you?” Catra again tried to shift around to look at her, and again, Adora didn’t let her. “This isn’t the first time you’ve talked about her like that, you know. Like she’s a separate entity from you. I thought that she *was* you, just… transformed with that sword magic?”

“Yeah.” Adora gave a decrepit laugh through her nose. “I thought so too, until…”

“Until?”

“She told me…” Adora took a breath and forced herself to speak. “She told me she was disappointed in me, Catra. She said that I wasn’t the person she thought I was. She thought she made the wrong choice, picking me.”

“She said *what?*”

The tension in Catra’s body had made its way into her voice, and Adora winced. There it was. Catra had a right to be upset. She understood. Adora had pretty much just admitted she’d been spinning her wheels for three years—that she’d given up their friendship for something that was never meant to be. She Ra had made her judgement of her years ago, already, and it was Adora’s hubris that mistakenly thought she could change it this whole time.

Seconds ticked by without a word between them, just the sound of the speeder screaming and the wind whipping at them as they rocketed through the woods. It seemed more and more likely that Catra had nothing left to say to her after that admission. Adora didn't blame her for that, either. She squeezed herself against

Catra's back tighter and tried to forget about how she'd just confessed her greatest failure to someone she'd lost all right to call a friend.

They rode together like that until the Crystal Castle appeared in the distance. Catra didn't try to turn around and look at her again.

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Glimmer's ankle throbbed. There was no doubt she'd sprained it in the crash, or maybe worse, but she pushed through the pain and continued throwing bolts of Moonstone-infused magic at the thralls closing in around their wreck. The adrenaline coursing through her veins was almost enough to dull the ache.

All of them had taken cover behind the upturned wreck of the Warbird. At Lonnie's command, the handful of soldiers who survived the crash provided cover fire, while Rogelio worked to tear open the mangled hinges locking the cockpit's canopy in place. Their two remaining wingmen were still in the air, dancing around the airspace above them like leaves in a tornado wind, strafing around, looking for an opening to provide air support cover fire. Whenever they got low enough to try anything, however, nearby thralls would leap into the air like canon fire at them, nearly scraping their undersides with sharpened claws until the Warbirds pulled away.

"When the hell did they learn to jump like that?" Keren asked, reloading next to Trayn and Lonnie.

Glimmer ignored her, instead focusing on helping enforce their perimeter, pushing back the advancing flood as best she could. She wasted no time opening a direct line to Salas over the comms as soon as a moment presented itself.

"We're down about thirty clicks south, south-east of target," she said, peeking over the wreckage to see Frosta's tower compound in the nearby distance. "Can you read our position?"

“I see you,” Salas said over the line. “I can clear an area roughly twenty square clicks surrounding the crash zone. Large enough your airwing extract you. Fifteen second ETA, stand by.”

“Negative.” Glimmer shoved back a few dozen more thralls with a barrier, then cut them down when they started to hammer at it. “Can you create a corridor from us to Frosta’s compound?”

“You’re still  planning on going after her?” he asked. “You can’t be serious.”

“And you can’t be serious talking to me about evacuating when she’s still trapped there,” Glimmer said. “We aren’t leaving her behind.”

“You have two wingmen circling your position who are unable to land, and however few infantry on the ground with you who survived the crash. You don’t have the manpower.”

Rogelio had abandoned trying to pry the canopy off in favor of smashing it with his fist. Trayn abandoned his firing position to help him. Cracks spiderwebbed across the canopy as the both pounded the reinforced glass, the sound of their fists thumping out a steady rhythm alongside the spitfire crackle of Glimmer’s soldiers continuing to fire in bursts at the thralls.

“Then enforce a safe landing perimeter around us first,” Glimmer said, shouting into the comms. “You can clear the corridor after the rest of my men have landed.”

“That won’t work.” A swell of static swept Salas’ voice away for a moment, before it came back. “—enormous volume of thralls around your position right now. Most are ignoring you in favor of the compound, but their intelligence levels have shifted, objectively. The moment I intervene on your behalf, you will be the new priority. We either extract you now, or you are on your own once I make the corridor. Extracting your team and whoever survived from Frosta’s group will be entirely your responsibility.”

He paused, and when he spoke again, his voice was much less stern. “We lost contact with them fifteen minutes ago, already.”

Rogelio broke through the canopy and hauled a limp Kyle from the cockpit. For a moment, Glimmer feared he hadn’t made it, but Rogelio placed him on wobbly feet, dusting his shoulders before Lonnie shoved a spare rifle into his arms.

No one hauled out his copilot.

“Get me the corridor,” she said.

“Are you *sure* you can get out again after I do this?” Salas asked.

“I did it on Scavria, I can do it here,” she said. “Focus on reinforcing the rest of the line after this.”

“I was planning on it. They’ll need as much support as possible, now.”

It was the closest they both had gotten to admitting out loud how desperate the battle had turned. With Frosta’s forward position compromised, the rest of the front line was already untenable. The other princesses, her parents included, were likely preparing to execute a carefully rehearsed, steady retreat to Bright Moon, continuing to keep the thrall army held away as long as possible and limit casualties all the way.

All at once, the world lit up in flames, and countless tightly packed thralls burst into ash with it. From there, a corridor of land about twice as wide as their Warbird was long opened up, stretching from their location to Frosta’s embattled compound in the distance. On either side of the corridor, a wall of flame reaching to the skies kept any thralls outside it from flooding back in.

“Everyone, move!” Glimmer said, urging her people forward. “Into the corridor!”

Together, their group sprinted down the opening Salas had made for them, hundreds more thralls chasing after them, spilling

through the same opening like a raging river rapid. Salas was right: his intervention had galvanized them. These thralls were far smarter than the usual lot.

They reached the compound, where heaps of mangled and bloody corpses lay—not thralls, but Frosta's Snow Kingdom guards and their Enclave partners lay. Glimmer swallowed at the sight, the compound's central tower looming over them like an obelisk guardian.

Their group switched formations. Lonnie shoved Glimmer to the back—toward the reinforced blast doors leading into the tower's main room—while the others lined up and pointed their weapons down range of the corridor. Already, Salas' magic spell was weakening: the walls of fire were dimming, and the thralls on the other side began pushing all the way through the plasma before they fell to the ground, too burned to move.

They needed to get inside. It would be easier to hold position inside the building rather than out in the open like this, but they also needed the rest of their soldiers still in their wingmen's Warbirds to mount a feasible assault. Those two wingmen continued to circle above, pelting the thralls with additional fire where they could but keeping far enough away from the ground to avoid them leaping up, again. Glimmer still needed to clear enough space for them to land.

She worked her hands in wide sweeps, drawing a large rune under her feet while her soldiers continued firing down the corridor to buy her as much time as possible. A trio of Beast Interceptors cut through the sky, blasting. One of their wingmen spun out after getting hit, impacting the ground somewhere in the distance.

Glimmer didn't let it break her concentration. They could still save Frosta with only one contingent of reinforcements. It would be cramped shoving so many people into one Warbird to escape, but they could do it.

The rune circuit completed and Glimmer activated the spell. An opaque bubble of energy burst from the center, engulfing their battle group and extending far enough to push the thralls encroaching upon them back dozens of feet down the corridor of fire.

"Talon-2 you are clear to land," Kyle said into the headset he still wore over his ears. "You have plenty of room, get down here and reinforce us."

Already, Glimmer was feeling the effects of maintaining this large an area of safety. Every thrall that came in contact with her shield was pounding at it trying to break through. She felt each of their fists as if she were barricading herself alone up against a door that a thousand people were trying to ram through.

Their last wingman swung around, the Warbird's landing feet already extended and the doors to the personnel carriage already open. Something moved out the corner of Glimmer's vision as they lowered to the ground, kicking up dirt and dust. When she looked, a dozen thralls flung themselves from the top of Frosta's tower inside her bubble.

A few impacted the ground with wet smacks that made her spine tingle, while the rest slammed into the top of the Warbird. The force of their impact sent the craft's tail plunging into the ground, and the pilot nearly flipped the whole thing upside down overcorrecting.

Several soldiers fell out the open doors, scrambling to their feet and rushing to join Glimmer and her crew at the compound door. The rest, no one knew what happened to them, because the craft spun out of control after the pilot panicked. In their attempts to stabilize their overcorrection, they instead made the Warbird fly out of Glimmer's protective bubble and crash beyond the flame wall corridor just like their other wingman.

Everyone froze. It was as if everyone all at once realized what losing their last wingman meant, and none had come to terms

with it, yet.

Lonnie was the first to come back to her senses. “You need to get out of here,” she said to Glimmer. “Remember what I said about not poofing until it’s absolutely necessary? Now is the time.”

Glimmer ignored her, choosing instead to push more of herself into the shield. It felt like someone was pressing needles into her head with the countless thralls hammering on it at once from outside.

“Salas,” she said prompting him through the comms. “Please tell me there are reserve Warbirds you can scramble to our position.”

Entrapta came on the line instead of him. “He’s a bit tied up at the moment,” she said, sounding equally tied up herself. “We’re stretched pretty thin, I’m afraid to say. Two more Warbirds went down just moments ago.”

“Those were ours. Entrapta, we’re pinned here right outside Frosta’s compound with no backup.” They didn’t have enough people to storm the building, and Glimmer already knew Lonnie would kill her herself if she suggested storming the compound as is.

Entrapta hummed on the other end. “Have you had any luck reaching Frosta directly? She went dark when her front line fell, but I’m almost certain she’s still alive holed up in there. All my data points to it. If you can get in touch with her, both of your forces together might be able to pull off a pincer maneuver and clear the compound. Her from the inside, you from the outside?”

Glimmer looked to Lonnie, who had already been intermittently trying to reach Frosta ever since they left the Moonstone tower. She shook her head, and Glimmer said as much to Entrapta over the comms.

“It will be tough, but I can redirect two more Warbirds to your location,” Entrapta finally said after a tense pause. “ETA is five minutes.”

Glimmer set her jaw. Already, she was starting to flag, and her shield was flickering. Lonnie gave her a look when she saw. She didn't know if she could hold out that long.

"Five minutes," Glimmer said, gasping. "Five minutes, and not a second longer."

Another concentrated surge from the thralls against her shield sent Glimmer reeling. She stumbled back several steps until she was pressed up against the locked compound doors, then made the decision to shrink the bubble by a several feet.

Lonnie said something to Kyle and Keren she couldn't hear, both of them nodding before engaging the other soldiers with them in conversation. Each wore confident, energetic expressions as they spoke, like they were trying to boost morale. Even Rogelio seemed less stern than usual, although his expression seemed practiced. A moment later, Glimmer found out why.

"You're flagging," Lonnie said to her, under her breath.

"I can make the five minutes," Glimmer said. "Four minutes, now." Despite shrinking the shield's range, there was still just enough room for the Warbirds to land one at a time, and as long as there were no more thralls jumping from the tower this time, they would make it.

Salas' flame corridor finally sputtered out with a gust of wind, like the magic he'd put in place had taken one final gasp. With no more walls of plasma to enforce a bottleneck, the entirety of the host sieging the tower set upon Glimmer's modest bubble shield. What before felt like needles in her skin now felt like battering rams against her skull. She fell to her knees, clutching her head, doing everything possible to drown out the pain and continue protecting the landing zone until reinforcements came.

"It's time to go."

Lonnie's voice was right in front of her, gentler than she'd ever heard it. When Glimmer looked up, she was kneeling before her,

looking her in the eyes, apologetic but stern. The protective bubble had shrunk again without her realizing, now covering only an area barely large enough to cover their team. The thralls were within arm's length—countless Scavrian corpses raving and frothing at the mouth, surrounding them, reaching far back to the horizon.

"Come on, Glim," Lonnie said. Glimmer's eyes trailed to the pistol at Lonnie's hip, and she knew what the alternative was if she didn't decide to poof away. "Everyone knew this might have happened when we backed you up on letting those Megaliths through. I certainly don't regret that decision, but…we have to deal with the consequences, now."

A crack shot up the side of the bubble with a particularly vicious thrall rammed their head against the magic. Glimmer's senses were ridden raw, all of them were blown out, but even she could tell they were moments away from getting overrun.

She'd failed.

Who better to boost morale than the Angel of Archanas, Salas had said? Glimmer would have laughed if she weren't so disillusioned with the state of things. The Angel had tapped out long ago already. Scavria was her crowning moment, and what she'd pulled to rescue everyone from Archanas' atmosphere was a miracle performed on fumes. She had nothing left.

What would it have felt like if she'd instead held her tongue and let Salas and the others blow up those Megaliths instead? Would living beyond this moment with the guilt of potentially having condemned countless innocents to death have weighed on her? Would it have been preferable for her to never be able to look herself again in the mirror again, instead of knowing she'd led everyone here only to get ripped apart by thralls?

Now, seeing Lonnie's hand move to her pistol, seeing the brave face she was putting on and the looks of naked terror on all the others, she couldn't dredge up any of those righteous, incensed

emotions any longer—that burning idealism that let the Megaliths through in the first place. All that came now was recognition of how cold reality could be.

Despite the horrors she'd witnessed on several deployments already, she couldn't force Lonnie to put a bullet in her. She couldn't do that to her—force her to kill her commander and friend to prevent the birth of a second Abomination. They'd lose Frosta, too.

This was what the Beast War was like, Glimmer finally realized. It was more than losing refugees on a desolate planet. Even if they won, Glimmer would forever live with the knowledge her decisions lead to the deaths of many of her friends. It would change her, forever. No wonder so many thought Taline was cold. They had known her before Glimmer ever met her…when she had made these same kinds of decisions.

Another thrall lunged at her shield hard enough it made the earlier crack larger.

"I'm so sorry," Glimmer said, straining to look at Lonnie through the tears blurring her vision. Her body tingled as she pooled what small amount of magic she could inward, preparing to teleport away. "I'm…"

Something impacted the ground nearby with a weighty thud, smashing a thrall, throwing dirt up in the air, showering the surrounding area with viscera and debris. A small tremor rumbled under Glimmer's feet. Everyone turned, rifles pointed at an object that stuck out at an angle in a modest crater. It was unmoving, person-sized, and metallic.

A moment later and it activated, appendages folding out from its metal carapace, reaching up before splaying out like the unfurling of a compacted lily pad. A deep thrumming came from the device, rattling Glimmer's bones, before an enormous shield sprouted from the splayed arms, blasting out like an explosion and covering

an area even wider than Glimmer had initially carved out at full power.

"Guys?" Entrapta's voice came through Glimmer's earpiece, cutting through the adrenaline threatening to wash away all of her senses. "I just read an enormous energy spike coming from your position. What the heck is going on over there?"

Again, the world erupted in fire as a series of explosions rocked their surroundings inside the new shield. The sound of thralls screaming as they vaporized gave way to yet another hellfire screech overhead when a gunship soared through the filament. This one was not one of Entrapta's reinforcements, however. Sleek and dark and half again as large as a standard Warbird, whoever this new pilot was had heavily modified their ship.

"Sorry to interrupt," said a voice Glimmer didn't recognize over their closed comms. "We couldn't help but notice you might be in need of some help."

"And who the hell is 'we'?" Glimmer asked.

The gunship cut around, carving through the air at a sharper angle than any Warbird was capable of, even in Kyle's hands. It kicked up a smokescreen of dust as it hovered a foot off the ground.

"Friends of a friend," the woman—ostensibly the pilot—said. "The next time you see Corynth, you tell him Ly and Vasher came through for him. Again."

The dust cleared and the cargo doors slid open. A dozen blue-clad soldiers hopped out, forming two groups with drilled efficiency. Rifles out and aimed, they burst fired in pairs as fast as any Vanguard commando squad, shooting down any thralls still standing after the carpet-bombing they'd been subjected to.

It hit Glimmer a moment later what was happening: this new arrival had dropped some sort of area of denial technology on top of them, mimicking her Battlemage magic except in missile

payload form. This kind of technology wasn't even supposed to exist, and yet whoever had deployed it just single-handedly saved her operation.

The gunship pulled away, twisting close to the surface inside the shield to angle its rear thrusters at the ground. A moment later, it rocketed away, shrinking into the sky. "Holy shit," Kyle said, his words a breathless whisper next to Glimmer. "She's good."

Once all the nearby thralls were taken care of, a burly man with thick scarring on his face emerged from the ranks of the blue-clad soldiers. He stood a head and a half taller than the others, and strode up to Glimmer, his visage twisting and warping with the scintillating magic she continued to protect her men with. Rogelio positioned himself between the man and Glimmer, while Lonnie and Kyle pointed their rifles at him. The others, Keren and Trayn included, followed suit.

"That device has five minutes of power remaining before it dies," the man said. He nodded to the edges of the new barrier, where the rest of the thrall army was still scratching and clawing away at without making any progress. "Ly will come back for us before then. If you want to save your friend and come with us, I suggest mutual cooperation."

Glimmer was pushed so far beyond her limits that, even though there were no longer thralls hammering her down trying to break through, she wasn't thinking straight. As far as she was concerned, there were still a dozen strangers before her and her team. It was a miracle she could still keep her own shield going.

"Wait," Keren said, lowering her weapon and turning to Lonnie. "Ly and Vasher. Catra has mentioned those names before."

Trayn nodded. "I remember. Figures from major battles and events in the Beast War. They came up more than once."

"I've heard the names too," Lonnie said, eyeing them both. She turned back to the man. "You're Vasher? Does the Siege of

Katratzi sound familiar to you?”

Vasher pointed to his scarred face. “I left with a souvenir.”

Lonnie lowered her rifle and all the others followed suit. “We can trust him,” she said to Glimmer, who was too exhausted to do anything except drop the shield. Vasher gave a grunt as he pushed past them to the compound doors behind.

“Can you get this open?” he asked her, tapping the reinforced door with the butt of his rifle.

Glimmer shook her head. “It’s been locked down since Frosta’s front line fell. Beyond anyone’s ability to open manually, from the inside or out. Short of brute forcing our way through, central command would be the only ones with the clearance to open it.” She tapped at the transceiver in her ear. “Entrapta? You there?”

“Ly scrambled the connection,” Vasher said. “Apparently, this Entrapta person wouldn’t stop asking questions about how we broke through the atmosphere without her knowing.” He sounded like he was describing the weather rather than talking about hacking one of the greatest technical minds Glimmer had ever known. “Seems like you’re going to have to force it open for us.”

“Or you could just have her unscramble the connection for us.” Lonnie interjected on her behalf with a fierceness that made Glimmer want to give her a hug. When Vasher looked at her, she took a moment before clearing her throat and gesturing at Glimmer. “She’s barely standing on her own two feet, *sir*.”

Hearing Lonnie call someone ‘sir’ was enough of a shock it threatened to derail Glimmer entirely. “I’ll get it open,” Glimmer said, if only to get both herself and everyone back on track. “I can still do that much.”

Vasher looked pleased enough. “My boys and I will take point,” he said, before acknowledging Lonnie. “You protect our rear.” He turned back to Glimmer and said, “When I give the signal, I need you to shove that door so hard it goes flying. Ly’s scans showed a

small army of thralls just sitting in there, so we'll need you to give us as strong an opportunity as possible to penetrate fast. See if you can't get the door embedded all the way into the opposite wall."

Glimmer's head still swam, but she slotted herself into position before the door, sidling up next to Lonnie. "Sir?" she asked, tilting of her head toward her. "You don't even call me sir."

Lonnie shrugged and refused to meet her eye. "Vasher is ex-Vanguard," she said. "Katratzi was a shit show, and his team was apparently one of the few to survive it. They're legends within the corps." She hefted her rifle in her arms while Glimmer got the spell ready, tracing thick magic patterns. "You'd think I'd have recognized the name, but…he dropped off the radar long ago. Everyone figured he'd died at some point. Although, if he were still alive, him showing up quoting a friendship with Corynth of all people wouldn't be the most surprising thing."

"Sounds like a pretty impressive guy if he has you all star struck like this." Glimmer was unable to keep the teasing out of her voice, though she made a mental note to check into Vasher's history herself once this was all over. "Looks like we're getting Frosta after all."

She completed the spell pushed, sending the reinforced blast door everyone was standing in front of rocketing back until, like Vasher suggested, it embedded itself sideways in the far wall at the end of the room. Blood and guts and viscera painted the inside from the thralls it had taken out on its way.

"Four minutes!" Vasher said as his troops stormed in. "We find the Snow Princess and extract, no detours."

Their reinforcements were efficient. Scarily so. Glimmer had thought the Vanguard impressive with how fast they could cut through thralls with their practiced tactics, but Vasher's men seemed to take that to a new level. "Protecting the rear" didn't so much mean mopping up any thralls they missed as much as it

meant just not slipping on the floor with how coated in blood and viscera it was.

Together, they drove through the first floor like a railgun punching through sheet metal, cutting through thralls and stepping past the eviscerated corpses of even more Snow Kingdom guards and Enclave soldiers. The second through fourth tower floors were no different, Vasher's team moving so quickly Glimmer's own soldiers struggled at points to keep up.

They made it to the door the survivors had barricaded behind with more than half the original allotted time to spare.

"Frosta!" Glimmer pounded on door, which was bent inward and scratched raw. The rest of the thralls that were trying to break in lay in heaps around them. "Frosta it's Glimmer, open the door."

There was no answer.

"We've cleared the room," she said, pounding on the door again. "You're safe now, but the tower is lost. We need to get you out of here." When still no answer came, she turned to Lonnie. "Are you sure she's still alive?"

Lonnie frowned. "Door seems intact."

"She was communicative before we set off," Kyle said. "She was blowing up my radio and everything before the line cut out."

"We wouldn't be standing out here knocking on this dented up door if they'd gotten to her, would we?" Trayn asked.

Glimmer thought on that.

"We would be in a hell of a lot more trouble if the Beast had succeeded in taking her," Vasher said. "It would have been obvious. An Abomination planet-side would have already shifted things irrevocably on the battlefield."

Before Glimmer's mind could dive into darker depths to explain Frosta's lack of response, the entire doorway and part of the wall it was built into them froze solid.

"Frosta!" she said, pounding the ice now. "I know you're in there. I know you can hear me." She looked to Vasher with a clear question on her face, and he held up a pair of fingers to answer her: two minutes before the barrier Ly had erected fizzled out.

"Go away!" Frosta's muffled voice came from beyond the door. "I'm not falling for any of your tricks. You can't have me. Get the hell away!"

Glimmer knew what she was afraid of. She squashed her instinct to poof inside and confront Frosta in person—prove beyond all doubt that she was real and not some trick the Beast was playing on her. If she was half as scared and delirious as Glimmer herself was on Rinne or Scavria, she'd end up fighting a Frosta acting on knee-jerk instinct, without backup.

Instead, she stepped closer and pressed a hand to the ice, as if she were trying to touch Frosta directly through it. The Beast retained none of its host's memories from prior to their assimilation. If she was going to prove to Frosta she wasn't some auditory hallucination, she'd have to come up with something to tell her the same way she did for Lonnie.

"Hey," she said in a softer, gentler voice. "Remember when you hosted Princess Prom? The one where Adora ran around freaking out about Catra and Scorpia? You were so, *so* mad about that. You thought they were going to ruin everything."

Frosta didn't say anything, but suddenly the ice over the door didn't feel as piercing cold.

"Here's a thought," Glimmer said, taking that as an encouraging sign. "Why don't we host a new one, once this is all over? Empire knows it's been forever since the last one, and from what I've heard, those Induction Ceremonies aren't exactly a fun affair." She

bit back a laugh and said, "I guess you could say they 'don't hold a candle' to what you would plan."

Glimmer nearly rolled her eyes at the play on words. If Adora were here, maybe she'd have laughed.

There was silence for a moment. And then the door slid open, revealing an irritated looking Frosta, hands fisted at her sides, eyes bloodshot red. "Did you just make a pun?" she asked, voice quavering with her effort not to cry. "We're in the middle of a battle and the best you can do is make a *pun*? I used to think you were cool."

Glimmer lunged forward and pulled her into a fierce embrace. "You still think I'm cool," she said. Instead of answering, Frosta embraced her back, her shoulders shaking from fear.

"Nu-uh," Frosta said in such a pitiful way it pulled a laugh out of Glimmer. "How is it you left to become an interstellar Battlemage and somehow got lame?"

Glimmer scanned the room Frosta had barricaded herself behind. Boxes of ammunition and supplies were stacked before the open door like cover for a firing team, but only one other figure was in there. The body of a Snow Kingdom Royal Guard was propped up against an inside wall, sitting in a pool of dried blood. A mound of stained-through gauze was packed into a gaping wound in the soldier's chest. They'd likely pulled Frosta inside while still alive, only to succumb to their wounds shortly thereafter, and Glimmer imagined Frosta frantically packing that wound thinking they could save them, the tears streaming down her face staining her eyes red.

A sixteen-year-old going through that was hard for Glimmer to swallow. A shiver ran down her body when she realized how close Frosta had come to being taken.

"We need to go," Vasher said, once Glimmer and Frosta pulled apart. "We have seconds, maybe, until the shield falls."

They rushed to the top of the tower without wasting any more time. When they crested the final set of stairs and exited to the top of the building, Glimmer got a sweeping panoramic view of the plains and the battle.

Thralls surrounded them for miles, terminating where the Enclave and Etherian front line had fallen back to roughly a mile away. They'd already abandoned the other towers, but if she squinted, she thought she could make out the other princesses holding that line with their soldiers. Perhaps she'd even glimpse her mom or dad.

Was this how her endless weeks on Scavria had paid off? Instead of shore leave, she got countless long shifts processing an endless army of refugees, only for the Beast to enthrall them and set them upon her home and friends? Her family?

"Ly, come in," Vasher said, speaking into his own comms unit. "Need immediate pickup, topside, over."

His men had already set up at the single chokepoint leading back inside, ready to beat any thralls that came hurdling up the stairs at them. Kyle, Rogelio, Trayn and most of Glimmer's team were with them, while Keren and Lonnie comforted Frosta.

The shield Ly had dropped down below finally caved in on itself, accompanied by a chorus of frenzied screeches as the thralls surrounding them now had free reign to assault the tower once more. Her soldiers at the mouth of the stairway tensed, some of them hefting their rifles. Glimmer went to join them, until the sky suddenly dimmed. She looked up, expecting some enormous cloud to have floated over them, but what she saw made her freeze.

The sun was disappearing.

Archanas had grown strong enough to begin obscuring the nearby star, the shadow of the Beast itself reaching forth like spindled fingers to touch Etheria directly across an expanse of space.

Glimmer felt its power, its presence steadily growing. It made her chest ache, as if the Beast could similarly reach directly into her body to grip at her heart.

Priority alerts pinged one after the other on her PDA. Another screech rang out from inside the compound tower, much closer this time. The thralls sounded even more ravenous now, as if the enlarged presence of their master had whipped them into a mouth-frothing frenzy.

Amorphous figures coalesced in the corners of Glimmer's vision. At first she thought they were just a trick of the mind, but when she turned to look at them and they didn't disappear, the fine hairs on her skin stood on end, and all attempts at remaining calm dissipated.

"Ly, ETA?" Vasher said, and even he sounded nervous.

Static flooded Glimmer's own earpiece and everyone else's, judging by their reaction. "Thirty seconds out," came Ly's warbled voice.

Her gunship was on the horizon, screaming toward them with an entire wing of Interceptors pursuing at her back. When she cut a hard corner to evade, two ran into one another trying to follow. She pulled out of her maneuver behind a third who couldn't keep up, and the shadows surrounding them grew denser.

Glimmer turned to her PDA. "Attention all ground forces, this is Battlemage Glimmer. Archanas is preparing to manifest its forces on our soil directly. All forces, full emergency retreat immediately to the castle walls. I repeat, all forces, full emergency retreat immediately to the castle walls."

"What's going on?" Frosta asked, coming up on Glimmer's side with Lonnie and Keren. "I thought the others were doing a good job holding the thralls back a strategic retreat?" She watched with cautious trepidation as the amorphous shadows around them began to multiply. "What are these things?"

The last Interceptor dogging Ly's gunship broke apart under fire, and she pulled up to them, cargo doors already open and ready for boarding.

"Nothing good," Glimmer said, letting Lonnie herd them toward the ship with Keren's help. The others were already piling in. "It won't matter how well everyone else was holding that line. The Beast has reached critical mass even faster than Salas predicted. Even if we had a thousand princesses with elemental runestones, in a few minutes, it won't matter."

"But—"

"She's right, kid." Vasher's gruff voice brooked no opportunity for argument, and Frosta gave up all efforts at stalling as soon as he looked at her, ducking her head inside the idling ship instead. "Another army of thralls on top of what landed with the Megaliths would be formidable, but that's not the scenario we're facing anymore."

With an unsure face, Frosta strapped into the chair opposite Glimmer inside the gunship. The doors slid shut the moment the last soldier got in, g-forces already pressuring them the moment Ly peeled them away from the tower.

"Those shadows were too large to be simple thralls," Glimmer said, her voice nearly covered by the sound of the engines screaming. None of the other soldiers seemed to hear her, but Frosta paled with understanding, and Lonnie's frown deepened. "Our only recourse is to run. As fast as we can. And pray Corynth, Adora, and the others aren't far from the Crystal Castle."

Chapter End Notes

More and more action!

Remember when I said Adora hit rock bottom a few chapters back? Yeah, looking back on it, that wasn't the case. Even though I've drafted these chapters so many times, when I get to final proofreads before posting, parts of the story I didn't

keep in long term memory re-surprise me when I read (its actually kinda cool), and Adora's rock bottom was one of them.

This is her rock bottom. She blew past the grief in that prior chapter and made it to acceptance, but Catra isn't gonna let her accept her own death lmao.

Also to note: I considered making the title "Heroes' Lament," because Adora and Glimmer both have their moments where they lose faith in themselves. But I thought the singular "Hero's Lament" just felt better, and Glimmer and Adora could both be the individual Hero I'm referring to :) No, I don't think that makes logical sense.

The entire sequence with Frosta's tower was rewritten from scratch somewhere around draft 6, I think. And the previous iteration was redone from the previous-previous version around draft 4. All 3 versions had Ly and Vasher show up as extra help, because it just made poetic sense for Corynth's ride or die friends to continue riding or dying lol. I like this version where they go rescue Frosta the best--it's got its own sort of mini-narrative structure to it, whereas the previous versions were both flavors of "Glimmer and co getting stuck out in the middle of the field with the rest of the army."

# A Sentinel’s Watch

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Corynth and Taline were waiting for them at the entrance to the Crystal Castle. Surrounded by more thralls, Taline had her feet spread wide, her arms working in wide, fluid motions, spinning a hurricane of fire and lightning to keep them away. As soon as Catra locked eyes with her from across the distance, she opened a corridor through the thralls with her magic, and Catra shot straight down it as she blasted out the Whispering Woods.

“Hurry,” Taline said, as soon as she pulled up alongside them, killing the speeder’s engine. Taline rushed her and Adora through the open doors, continuing to fend off the thralls. “We don’t have much time.”

Corynth whirled after they all pushed inside, reaching for the door with magic at his fingertips.

Taline swatted his hand away with a glare, drawing a rune of her own in his stead. The door shut, and three layers of spells adhered themselves one after the other to the metal, reinforcing the door against the thralls pursuing them.

Catra leaned close to Adora and nudged her in the side. “She’s really on him about not using magic, huh?” She’d whispered, hoped to lighten the mood and maybe get one of those awkward smiles she’d not seen in so long, but testing the waters like that only got Adora to nod, eyes staring through everything.

Catra fought not to visibly deflate. ::This is way worse than I thought.::

“Corynth’s pep talk only lasted this long, huh? Pip said. “Are you surprised she’s given up? Powers aside, you essentially left her out

to dry after she spilled her heart out to you. Three times, I might add."

::This isn't just some hang up she has over our fight, or some minor frustration. She's been hearing from some voice in her head telling her, from the very start, that she was the wrong choice to wield the sword. Adora is doubting her entire existence. What the hell do you even say to that? 'Oh, this voice you're convinced is She Ra herself is wrong and you're actually awesome?'::

She huffed, keeping pace with their group as they ascended a spiral staircase two steps at a time.

::I know what it's like to feel beaten down enough you start to question if you're even worth the space you take up,:: she said. ::I know what it's like trying to prove to everyone, yourself most of all, that those voices in your head are wrong. *You know* that I know this.:: She scowled at some nondescript space in front of her where she imagined Pip would appear. ::Corynth is wrong. Maybe I can say something that will help her start to heal, but we're moments away from the end. When he dies, she's going to blame herself, and I don't know if she'll ever come back from that.::

Pip did appear then, exactly where Catra had imagined she'd be. She didn't look impressed. "You'd think I'd be used to this, now, considering how many countless times I've watched it happen."

Catra frowned. ::Watched what happen?::

"Your lack of faith in your friend, now, at the most important of times." Irritation flared in Catra's chest, but Pip pressed on. "Elevated heart rate, falling back on the worst-case scenario you could dream up. Tension that makes brilliant people regress into a state of instinct. I've seen it happen with Taline, with Corynth, with the whole god's forsaken galaxy. Even Evelyn, in her final moments. Now you and Adora both."

Pip crossed her arms. “You sacrifice your vision. You say it’s pragmatism, but it’s really just a flimsy excuse you all tell yourself because you’re afraid.”

Catra’s anger boiled over. This was a terrible time for Pip to undergo whatever philosophical awakening was making her say these things. ::What the hell is all that supposed to mean?::

“I didn’t understand it myself, until we were on the balcony.” This, Pip said more to herself, before refocusing on Catra. “You are literally the only person who could say *anything* right now that would get Adora to reexamine things.”

::Like hell I am! You don’t think I don’t know that?:: Pip really wasn’t making it easier. Catra already placed enough of a weight on her back alone with this. Why was she stepping on the scale, too?

A tug came at the back of her consciousness—something pulling her away from the physical world, drawing her into her own headspace. Catra jerked back on instinct, bringing her surroundings back into crystal clarity, all of her senses blowing out like they’d been dialed to eleven.

They had just rounded a corner into a large sanctum after clearing several flights of ruined stairs in the castle. Countless spider bots lay strewn about the room, deactivated, many of them missing limbs and chunks of their central carapaces. The walls and ceiling of the room itself were damaged, too.

Reams of wires were strewn across the room, threaded between more thick vacuum tubes that were hooked into various machines sitting on carts. Adora stepped over an entangled clump of tubing with concentration written on her face, while Catra vaulted over chunk of overturned debris. They both trailed Corynth and Taline as they pushed toward a raised dais at the center of the room.

“So what are you going to do, then?” Pip asked. She was still floating in Catra’s vision, lips pressed into a thin line. “Keep

ruminating about this in your head until you break under the stress?”

Catra clenched her jaw. ::I’m working on it, okay? You’re seriously being no help.::

Pip rolled her eyes, disappearing just as another swell of her mind’s ocean threatened to drag her away from the present moment. Again, Catra forced herself back to reality, and again that reality grated on her senses, blown past their normal levels.

They’d made it to the central dais which rose to roughly Catra’s hip in height. A circular mainframe computer set into the floor surrounded them.

“This place has seen better days, hasn’t it?” Taline asked, gesturing to the ruins. “What happened here?”

Corynth and Adora glanced at each other, before Adora looked away, playing with her fingers.

“Adora and I formally introduced ourselves here,” Corynth said. “It was fun.”

That pulled the barest hint of a smirk from Adora. It disappeared so fast, Catra thought she might have imagined it.

“That door I sealed isn’t going to keep those thralls out forever,” Taline said, standing at a console plugged into the dais and waking it up. “Pip?”

“I’m on it.”

Dozens more lights flickered on as Pip’s voice reverberated around the room. The consoles and computers scattered about surrounding them powered up, as did the mainframe surrounding them. It was like the heart of an ancient starship taking its first deep breath after millennia asleep.

Pip herself appeared above the centra dais, casting an effervescent blue hue on the four of them. Dozens of holographic consoles encircled her, swirling, and she got to work on them.

"Light Hope deteriorated after we left," she said to Cornyth. "I'll need time to plug into her neural sockets." She looked to Taline. "You're right about those thralls, by the way. They've just broken through the door."

A shrill screaming echoed up to them from beyond the sanctum, carried on the wind in a way that sent the fine hairs on Catra's body standing on end. It was like an alarm telling her she was quickly running out of time.

"We'll buy you as much time as you need," Taline said, igniting with magic. "Not you," she said to Corynth. "You stay back."

Corynth didn't argue, and that was the moment Catra knew this was it. Pip was about to turn on the Heart while the Beast's thralls were flooding in trying to stop them. Once they arrived, she'd have even less opportunity to talk to Adora.

Win or lose, this was her last chance.

Adora adopted a wide stance next to her. The Sword of Protection materialized in her hands, but there was no fight left in her eyes. As far as Catra was concerned, she was operating on autopilot.

Panic scratched at her, driven higher when yet again she started to pull into her headspace. This time, when she yanked herself out of it, wondering why now of all times something like this was happening, Pip drew her attention.

"I don't understand why you are fighting me on this," she said, voice echoing in Catra's head despite her mouth not moving from her place atop the dais. She hadn't taken her eyes off the screens surrounding her, either, and Catra realized Pip was talking to her privately. "We don't have any more time."

::I…wait, is that you trying to pull me out?::

“Yes.”

::*Why*?:: The last thing Catra needed right now was to lose her presence of mind.

Pip finally turned to her with an even deeper unimpressed look than before. It gave Catra the impression she was missing something obvious.

“Because you lack vision,” Pip said, mouth still not moving. This time, Catra heard more exasperation than judgment in her voice, like she was merely stating fact, and Catra wondered if she’d just misheard her the first time. “Because you can’t see the forest for the trees. I’ve told you before I can’t directly influence you unless you allow it, but you’ve let me in for far less pressing things than this.”

Catra remembered all those times her body just moved on its own, even before learning Pip was there. Both those times at the precinct, taking down a near-escaped suspect and hacking the precinct AI’s interface, her battle with Moriarty. That sixth sense she’d had at Vadim’s diner before a waitress dropped a bunch of plates. The speed with which she was able to move while training under Taline on the *Constable*. Every time the urge came to act, she had.

“I think we might finally be *just* integrated enough for this to work,” Pip said. “But we must do it now.”

::Do what now?:: Catra asked, this time letting the ocean current of her mind drag her away from the shore. ::What are you going to do?::

“Show you the forest.”

By now, Catra’s awareness had pulled so far away from her surroundings even Pip’s voice sounded distant. She caught that Adora was looking at her, asking her a question she couldn’t make out. And was that concern on her face?

Everything was so blurry, Catra just closed her eyes and shook her head. She reached, trying to grasp the console she knew was still right there in front of her. Her hand touched metal and she held fast to it, letting it ground her. But when she opened her eyes again, she wasn't in the Crystal Castle any longer.

An ocean stretched out before her in its place, and the light of Etheria's setting sun glinted in the water, casting beautiful colors that danced against the clouds in the sky. A breeze caressed her fur.

She was in Salineas, standing high up on a bridge that led to the Castle, the Sea Gate far in the distance at her back. And instead of the computer consoles she thought she'd grabbed onto, she was gripping the salt-rusted railing keeping people from falling off the bridge.

One guard dressed in full gear stood at attention across from her on the walkway. Corynth, Taline, and Pip were nowhere in sight. Catra thought she'd lost Adora, too, until she saw her walking toward them, Mermista at her side, both flanked by more Salinean Royal Guards.

"—just…I don't know," Adora was saying. If Catra hadn't seen the bags under her eyes and the sallowness of her skin, she would have heard the exhaustion in her voice. "It's been six months. I still haven't made any progress."

"You shattered the sword," Mermista said, stretching her arms high until Catra heard a pop. "The Enclave might have rebuilt it for you with Entrapta's, er…help?" She shrugged. "But that doesn't mean you're going to step into your powers right away like nothing happened. Most people take a while to walk again after breaking a leg, you know."

Adora cringed. "Oh, thanks for that. I lost my healing factor, too, by the way. Thinking about broken bones is just…" she shivered. "I seriously didn't need yet another thing to worry about on top of everything else."

“Keep overtraining and it will become a reality, not just a worry. It’s really not healthy what you’re doing to yourself, Adora.” Mermista tapped her chin with her index finger. “Now that I think about it, if you break something, then at least you will finally be forced to slow down and rest.”

Catra noticed something strange as they got closer: Adora wasn't taller than her anymore. In fact, Catra seemed taller than her, now. She looked down at herself and saw she was dressed the same as the guards. Her tail was gone, too.

When Adora and Mermista passed them, Catra and the guard opposite her fell into step with their entourage. She kept pace two steps behind Adora, maintaining distance in a way that helped her realize two things at once: that she was playing a role in a memory that wasn’t her own, and that this memory holder wasn’t actually a Salinean guard, themself.

She had disguised herself to better infiltrate a nearby First One dig site.

“I’m not breaking my leg, Mermista,” Adora said, making a face. “Can we please talk about something else? How’s it been going, working with the Enclave, anyways?”

“Believe it or not, surprisingly smooth. They’ve helped rebuild almost all the damage Horde Prime did when he invaded. I thought it’d take way longer than it has.”

Adora scoffed. “Almost like they have experience with cleaning up after invasions. Extensive experience.”

If Mermista caught her sarcasm, she didn’t show it. "Sure, probably. Their Battlemages are also kick-ass magic teachers. I thought Glimmer was exaggerating the way she talked about her training until we started our own regimen. Now, I’m almost glad Taline didn’t get to stay here. She sounds like a harsh mistress."

Adora snorted. “Micah tells me he still has nightmares about the handful of seconds they dueled with one another. All I remember

is how she treated fighting me like it was a game." She sighed after a beat of silence. "I think talking with you helped. I have, like, a dozen more things I think I could try to get back in touch with my powers again."

"Really?" Mermista seemed taken aback. "I didn't really do anything, though."

"You invited me here."

"And you took the invitation. I'm surprised you did."

Adora smiled at her, but didn't say anything else.

Mermista didn't understand, Catra could just tell. She didn't understand how talking about everyone else's progress was what did it for Adora. Hearing how hard everyone else was pushing to rebuild and prepare for the Beast was what reinvigorated Adora's flagging spirit. She would never let herself fall behind while others carried on the fight. Catra saw all of that reflected in the hyper-focused, determined expression on her face.

Adora suddenly craned her neck to look over her shoulder, her eyes sliding over Catra for a moment. She panicked thinking she might have been caught staring. Then Adora looked past her at something far in the distance.

Brow furrowed, Catra looked over her shoulder too, hoping to see what had caught Adora's attention, and the scene shifted all over again.

Salas was now before her, standing only a couple inches shorter. They both were in a small, messy office in what Catra guessed by the architecture was deep in Bright Moon castle. Salas' eyes were chastising.

"She could really use your guidance," he said.

"I am not the right person to help her." Catra spoke words that weren't her own. "That's not how this works."

“Why not?”

Catra narrowed her eyes at him. “You already know why. And just in case you’ve forgotten, then let me remind you: the Daiamid are not inclined toward teaching and mentorship. They aren’t even all that inclined toward forgiveness, either, if you remember what they did to me after I broke their rules.”

“The Daiamid are gone, Corynth,” he said, finally confirming for Catra who’s memories she was really living. “You are all that is left of them. *You* are the Daiamid now. It doesn’t have to be the same for her as it was for you. It can be different under your leadership.”

Catra laughed. “You sound as if I will rebuild them, perhaps with her as my first student? I’m telling you that won’t happen. The Daiamid, their legacy…all of it ends with my death. I want to make sure of it.”

“You don’t hate them,” Salas said, weary. “You make it sound as if you do, but I know you don’t. They’re some of the only family you’ve ever had. You miss them.”

Catra gave him a blank look.

Salas’ look of exasperation deepened. “Taline—”

“Is not dangerous,” she said with force, gritting her teeth. Figures that’s what got her to react. Bringing Taline up was a dirty trick, even for Salas. “Years have passed with no incident. If her lack of training were an issue, it would have become apparent already.”

She crossed her arms and looked away. “Besides, she’d sooner turn me into paste across the floor than anything. You’re not senile enough to have forgotten what happened the last time we saw one other. You were there. Or do you need me to remind you what happened that day outside the judiciary, too? After Evie’s trial?”

Salas sighed again. He chewed his lip a moment, thinking, before: "I can set you and Adora up for weekly training sessions. The sparring rooms the Enclave have in the city will be more than adequate. I'll make a recurring reservation—"

Catra grunted, turning around entirely to head for the door and leave. Salas' voice grew stronger.

"—and it will not be at all difficult to synthesize an identity for you like I've done the other times. I know I'm not as deft with it as Lysithea was when you ran smuggling jobs with her, but as long as you don't deliberately show your face to Adora in another kingdom after being introduced as her private tutor, you should be fine."

Catra's hand was on the doorknob, ready to yank it open when his next words stopped her.

"Adora needs help."

It was the way he said it, not just the words themselves. There was an urgency in his voice that had rooted Catra—rooted Corynth—to the spot.

"She's become obsessed with searching for any information at all about the Daiamid," Salas said. "She thinks it will give her answers. She barely eats, she barely sleeps. She doesn't do anything except show up to strategy meetings and train." He sighed, displaying a vulnerability Catra knew through Corynth was rare to see from him. "She needs help," he said again, "and nothing any of her friends have tried has worked. Will you at least consider talking to her?"

She did consider. For several long moments, she stood there, considering.

"No."

She opened the door without waiting to see Salas' reaction, and, yet again, the scene changed when she stepped through. Bright

Moon Castle was gone, replaced with the cramped cockpit of a ship, and Catra sitting in the pilot's seat.

Futility and despair weighed heavy on her shoulders. She'd failed her mission and had no idea where to go from here. She mashed the buttons on the dash under the misguided hope it would make the *Dzivia's* engines warm faster. Allow her to leave Etheria behind sooner.

Her fight with Adora had been exhilarating. Not in the sense she'd been at risk of losing, but in the sense that it had been a long, *long* time since she'd had to use her magic to even the playing field. Not since Taline, before the war had even ended.

Catra had saved her life, twice now, but for Adora to have fought so fiercely without any of her powers was impressive. She'd even broken Catra's nose! And now Catra couldn't help but wonder how Adora would have fared had she trained her like Salas asked.

The engines finished spooling to full power when Catra paused, something from the camera feeds outside her ship catching her eye.

Adora, sword in hand, had leaped four full stories after her from the top of the Crystal Castle. Catra cringed when she embedded the sword to its hilt in the fuselage of her ship. Alarms blared inside the cockpit, but she couldn't look away from Adora, at the ferocious look on her face. She was staring into one of the cameras, directly at Catra through the screen, sending a shiver down her spine.

The fury and sheer, implacable determination burning in Adora's eyes seared her, too.

Then that fire snuffed out as Adora's eyes took on a glassy look. The sword disappeared, changing back into a gauntlet clasped on her forearm. She tumbled off the ship, free falling hundreds of feet to Etheria's surface. Catra lunged for a different set of controls than the throttle.

Just as she engaged the tractor beam, the scene shifted again.

Now, an Abomination had revealed itself on Eden. Ly had sounded positively stricken in a way she'd not heard in years—not since she'd punched through Archanas' atmosphere to rescue her after everyone else had died sealing the Beast away. With a shotgun in hand, Catra ran, the sounds of Vasher and his men pounding the floor with their boots close behind.

Adora was there in the hangar when they rounded the corner, whisps of power emanating from her body. She was staring down a monstrosity that could annihilate the entire station in seconds with nothing but that magic sword in her hands. That determination was burning in her eyes , again. Adora had stalled the thing long enough for backup to arrive.

Another sudden shift in scenery and now Catra watched Adora stare Taline down on Phoenix Station with that same look in her eyes. Their surroundings were damaged beyond recognition. Catra would have fared better—would have brought the fight to a close sooner—but her exposure to the Beast was finally taking its toll after all these years.

And despite having warned Adora in no uncertain terms to stay out of the way, she'd stepped up to Taline, burning her with her gaze, determined to protect Catra now that exhaustion and weakness had overwhelmed her.

"Stand aside," Taline said. "Or I will make you."

Taline was a raging storm, arguably more fearsome as any Abomination. She stood amidst the carnage on Phoenix with a shimmering nexus of blinding energy swirling about her, a display likely to inspire a fresh onslaught of new legends to compliment the litany of others she'd already collected as Seraph of Archanas.

Adora merely pointed the sword at her, feet planted wide. "Make me stand aside, then."

A sense of orientation finally came back to Catra—a separation of herself and the memories she'd been viewing. Corynth had witnessed the end of the world, escaped death, seen and experienced and done things an ordinary person might not even be capable of imagining. And despite this—despite all this—at his lowest moment, Adora had inspired him. It was just as he'd said on the balcony.

And seeing this astronomical shift in her? Seeing her go from this frustrated, obsessive gremlin of a person to the driven, righteous force Catra had always known her to be? Seeing this shift with her own eyes lit a spark of inspiration in her, too.

She finally knew what to do.

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Glimmer hadn't ever thrown up riding in a Warbird, before. Not even when Kyle had spirited them away from Scavria, or when they'd plunged into and then halfway back out of Archanas.

Subject to Lysithia's piloting skills as a passenger in her gunship, however? Twice now in the span of a few minutes she'd now come dangerously close, nearly emptying the contents of her stomach out where she stood, magically anchored, behind the pilot and copilot seat in the cockpit.

Lysithea had dodged, evaded, and shot down countless Beast Interceptors since extracting them from Frosta's tower. The two Warbirds Entrapta had sent earlier as backup had caught up to them too, halfway back to Bright Moon, and were also having serious trouble keeping up.

"Ares Two, switch places with me on my mark," Lysithea said, watching the radar as crimson seeped in from the edge. "Mark."

She pulled back on the yoke, making room for the wingman on their right to take their place at the front of their formation. On the horizon, an entire squadron of Beast Interceptors burned toward them.

“You’re making them take the lead?” Kyle asked from the copilot’s chair. “They’re good, but not *that* good. You’d do a better job guiding everyone through that airwing.”

At first, Lysithea had argued when Glimmer insisted he take the copilot spot. She’d only relented after finding out Kyle was an ace Vanguard pilot, himself.

“Even I wouldn’t be able to evade all of that for long” she said, fingers flying over a control panel at her right. “If we’re going to make it past them, we need a change of tactics.” Over the comms, she said, “Ares One and Two, break left on engagement. Repeat, break left.”

Both acknowledged, and a holographic representation of both their modified gunship and Ares Two appeared side by side in the heads-up display projected onto the forward viewscreen. After a moment working the controls, Ly switched the data differentiating both their vessels. Weight, callsign, radar signature, IFF frequency —they had subsumed all of Ares Two’s data, and Ares Two had taken theirs. To any ships scanning their formation, it still looked like they were the ones leading even though they had switched.

“You’re going to use them as bait?” Glimmer asked, disbelieving. “*That’s* your change in tactics?”

“Ares Two is the better wingman,” Lysithea said, sounding as if she were explaining something inconsequential while flipping a set of overhead switches. “They’ll guide Ares One as best they can.” She soured under Glimmer’s continued scrutiny and finally looked sidelong at her. “I burned through Taline’s blockade over Archanas at the end of the last war to rescue Corynth, and I did it in that shitty tub of a craft he stole from me. I know what I’m doing. If you want reassurance, then ask your copilot his opinion, but I have no interest in debating with you.”

Glimmer was used to being treated with occasional skepticism and even hostility. She found it easier to handle than the reverence most would show. But outright open and shut indifference? That

was new. Even as the swarm of Interceptors on the horizon grew closer—even as the comms chatter from their wingmen grew nervous—she didn't know what to say back. Instead, she looked to Kyle, who was already watching her with a helpless expression of his own.

"She did pick the better of the two pilots to switch with us," he said, for lack of anything better.

"Contact, contact!" came Ares Two's frantic call over the line as the radar pulsed with enemy fire. "Evasive maneuvers, breaking left, breaking left!"

Their wingmen cut across the viewscreen while Lysithea pulled the yoke tight to her body. They climbed, hard, pushing enough g's even Glimmer strained to keep the corners of her vision from pulling in too far.

"Holy shit," Kyle said as Lysithea pulled them out of a maneuver that put them behind most of their attackers, all of whom had followed their wingmen.

Lysithea fired, thinning them with only a few perfectly aimed blaster shots each, turning them into fireballs careening for Etheria's surface. Glimmer was pretty sure she hadn't missed a single shot.

Once they realized the trap they'd fallen into, the Interceptors broke off pursuit of the wingmen, scissoring in the air, preparing to cut back and chase after them instead.

"You good, kid?" Lysithea asked Kyle without taking her eyes off the forward viewscreen.

"Two seconds," Kyle said, working furiously at his own controls with an obvious strain in his voice. "Targets painted!" he said, once he'd turned the last blip on the radar from red to orange.

Lysithea flipped open a plastic cover on the dash and smashed the red button laying underneath. The gunship rattled, and countless

smoke trails shot off from either side of them out the forward screen. A glance at the radar told Glimmer they were missiles—fifteen of them to be exact, launched at once. She and Kyle watched as they chased the remaining Interceptors. One by one they impacted, despite those Interceptors doing their best to evade. When the last found its mark, they let out a whoop.

Lysithea was already two steps ahead, working on the next thing.

"Nice work you two," she said into her headset to their wingmen—miraculously still alive—as she worked another cadence of commands at her control panel. "Form up back on me. It's a straight shot to the castle, but that doesn't mean something else can't surprise us once we get there."

A mixture of relief and resentful grumbling came from them both through the comms, and they doubled back toward them to resume an ordered formation. Lysithea continued to work at the controls, and Glimmer wonder what she was doing until the cockpit holo-projector spun up, and a miniature, full-body rendition of the blue AI that first connected her to Corynth, Catra, Adora, and Taline stuck on Archanas reappeared.

"What is it you want?" the woman—Pip, was it?—said. She didn't look at them, but kept her focus off screen, like she was working with rapt concentration on a computer screen there. "I'm busy."

"Status?" Lysithea asked, earning a look from Pip.

"In progress," she said. "Is that all you wanted to ask? Because the Heart is only going to get turned on slower if that's what you interrupted me for."

The muscle at Lysithea's temple flexed. "Do you need backup?" she asked. When a chorus of otherworldly screeches rang out from over their connection, she narrowed her eyes. Wherever Pip and the others were, they were surrounded by thralls. "Taline's protégé and the Snow Princess are with me. The eclipse has started and we're running out of time. We can reinforce you."

Glimmer nearly took offense to being referred to like some nepotism-child of Taline, since that used to happen constantly during her time as an Enclave Cadet, but her concern over where Lysithea seemed to be pushing the conversation took precedent. Taking them to the Crystal Castle instead of Bright Moon wasn't part of the plan. She was supposed to help slow down the advancing army with the  other princesses.

"Taline has it handled," Pip said, letting Glimmer breathe a sigh of relief. When Lysithea didn't look convinced, she said, "And if she suddenly no longer has it handled, then Corynth will handle it."

"Put him on," Lysithea said, to which Pip shook her head.

"I can't."

"I'm not doing this with you, Pip. Put him on, or—"

Pip finally turned away from whatever she was working on to look at them. There was a hardness to her expression that surprised Glimmer. "Do you want to talk to him, or do you want him to stop this infection?" she asked. "Because he's on the verge of losing it altogether, and needs to keep it together long enough for me to activate this damn weapon."

Her expression softened, seeing the effect it was having on Lysithea. Vasher stepped into the cockpit to stand next to Glimmer, his eyes shimmering. Pip acknowledged him, and, gentler, she said, "His last words to you both were to ask you to come here. He didn't want to exclude you from the fight. He knew you'd resent him if he had."

"Where else can we help, then?" Lysithea asked. Her voice was thick, and when Vasher placed a hand on her shoulder, she leaned into his touch.

"I'm too preoccupied with this clusterfuck of ancient Eternian code, I can't monitor anything outside this castle. What did that girl say? The one acting as central command?"

"I blocked her," Lysithea said in a deadpan. "She wouldn't stop talking at me."

Glimmer stifled a giggle, and when she saw Pip trying to do the same, she almost lost it.

"Corynth at one point had considered betting with Vasher over that happening," Pip said.

"I don't know if I would have accepted that bet," Vasher said, looking down at Lysithea stewing in the chair. "But for old time's sake, let's just say we did wager, and he won."

Pip nodded, then blinked out of existence after an ominous, "Till next time."

Lysithea punched yet another set of commands into her control console as they continued flying—this time with tighter, jerkier movements, like she was trying to hold herself back. Entrapta's visage filled the area Pip vacated.

"*There* you are!" Entrapta said, the overexcitement in her voice clashing with the somber mood in the cockpit. Glimmer noticed Lysithea's grip tighten on the controls as Entrapta continued on, an unending spiel flowing from her mouth, asking everything from how they'd managed to evade her cybersecurity, to how she'd successfully blocked her when *she* was the admin for the network, to how they even found their location in the first place, and whether or not they friendly or enemies.

Glimmer managed to interject at that last question just as Lysithea seemed on the verge of ripping the gunship's yoke from the dashboard. Even Kyle looked nervous, until Glimmer successfully persuaded Entrapta to give them intel on the state of the battle raging below them on the field.

"It's not looking good," she said, the corners of her lips tugging into a frown. "Most of our forces that were out there have made it back through the castle town and to the bridge. Salas will order

the doors to the castle courtyard opened once they can cross safely, but...”

“How far behind are the thralls?” Glimmer couldn’t get a good read of the battlefield from where they were flying, and the radar was only tuned to pick up on their immediate surroundings in the air.

“They broke through the line as soon as they hit the castle town. Close quarters combat, the entire combined army broken into discrete units. It’s bad.”

“How bad?”

“The Princesses managed to enforce a new front line about fifty meters from the mouth of the bridge,” Entrapta said. “But unless they do something to keep the thralls line from pushing at the same time as they retreat, they’re stuck there.”

Kyle cursed under his breath, and Glimmer couldn’t help agreeing with him. That bridge into the castle was wide enough for ten soldiers to cross shoulder to shoulder, but even that amount of space left them too exposed. And with the thralls still so close, they couldn’t all get across and inside the fortifications without guaranteeing those thralls would make it in with them.

“How is that line holding out right now?”

“They’re more or less okay for now,” Entrapta said. “But you saw the influence Archanas is beginning to exert here.”

Glimmer nodded. “Even if they hold, it won’t matter soon. We need to get everyone back before the eclipse is complete.”

“Sounds like that’s where we need to put you, then,” Lysithea said, looking up at Glimmer from her seat.

Glimmer looked her right back in the eyes. “We’d stand a better chance if we had you and your boys in blue, too,” she said.

Lysithea grinned—the first she'd received from her—and called out a new heading into her headset for their wingmen to follow.

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Adora's face was inches from Catra's when the visions fell away. But unlike the look of boundless determination she'd worn when Catra watched her through Corynth's eyes, now there was deep concern.

"What happened?" Catra asked, and Adora's expression melted into relief as she helped her sit up. Catra was happy to see the shift—happy to watch Adora's spirits lift even if she was still trying to get her bearings and didn't fully understand the context for her worry in the first place. That happiness disappeared the instant her she registered what had become of the ruined, barren sanctum they'd traversed earlier.

There was a dense aura blanketing the room, making everything look hazy. At first, Catra chalked it up to delirium or her eyes still having trouble focusing, but then she saw the countless thralls filling the room and her blood turned to ice in her veins. Many already lay in unmoving heaps on the floor, badly burned or missing significant chunks of their bodies. Those still standing were pressed nearly shoulder to shoulder and front to back, surrounding them.

Taline was enforcing an oscillating bubble shield, insulating them at great apparent effort. This, Catra realized, was why none of those thralls were attacking. They'd already fought a harrowing battle to a standstill while Catra had been diving through the visions.

"How long was I out for?" she asked, trying to stand, grasping the dais behind her Pip was working at for stability.

"Only a handful of minutes," Pip said out loud, those dozen holographic terminals swirling about her, still.

“A handful of minutes that very nearly killed us.” Taline said. She was making an effort to sound nonchalant, but Catra could hear the strain in her voice. Keeping up that shield was agony for her after  fighting Corynth on Phoenix and then fighting alongside him out of Archanas.

All of them were running on fumes.

Catra noticed a hole had been punched through the sanctum’s ceiling, where even more thralls were spilling through, crawling along the walls like spiderling zombies out of a nightmare, replacing those who had died. Through it, she could see Archanas’ black and blood red surface, staring at them like a great eye in the heavens. It was eclipsing the sun.

“You just…knocked out,” Adora said, voice shaking. “What happened?”

“Got some inspiration?” Catra didn’t know why she’d said it as a question. The look of confusion that flickered across Adora’s face might have made Catra laugh, but she’d just woken up to even more imminent danger than when she’d drifted off, and was still wrapping her head around the visions. She’d had some kind of epiphany when coming out of them, but that had disappeared the moment she’d opened her eyes again. Like a dream she remembered only bits and pieces of after waking.

Taline cried out in pain and both Catra and Adora’s attention went to her. She’d taken a knee, both arms up and shaking like she was barely succeeding in trying to keep an enormous boulder from crushing her. Watching her struggle so much to enforce the shield made her realize it wasn’t just to keep the thralls out, but to keep the haze obscuring the rest of the sanctum away from them, too.

It was the same hazy fog Corynth had protected them from on Archanas, the kind that would birth horrors from beyond its curtain. But they weren’t on Archanas any longer, they were on Etheria. That meant the Beast’s very essence could not just touch

them a world away, but was powerful enough to tear at Taline's magic. Push her to the ground.

Catra and Adora went to her, crouching at her side, hands hovering over her shivering, lit-through form with neither unsure how to help. Catra didn't want to get burned again like she had the first time with her running so hot, and it seemed Adora had the same idea.

Corynth, on the other hand, stepped away from them, stopping just short of the shield's boundary. "Some of this pressure needs to come off you," he said.

"No!" Taline tried to push to her feet. Her legs shook under the effort, and she only managed to get halfway up before they gave way and both knees slammed to the floor this time. "Please, no. The Heart isn't ready yet, it's too much of a risk. I can hold on. I can…I can—"

The haze beyond swirled and coalesced, several tendrils materializing among its depths and then striking at the shield. Hairline fractures appeared across its surface. Taline crumpled under the blow with another cry, forcing her down onto her palms. Catra fought the urge to touch her, again.

"How much longer?" Corynth asked, turning his head enough to look at Pip over his shoulder.

She shot him a pained look before resuming her work. "Minutes."

"You won't last," Corynth said, looking at the damage to the shield and assessing the thralls.

Taline whined in pain, and Corynth strode through the shield unhindered. The haze covering the room pulled back like he was a torch in a dark room, as if the very aura around Corynth's person was anathema to it. Taline stopped shaking so hard the moment the haze retreated, her breathing coming in smoother.

It looked like a thousand mirror lenses shifted when every thrall in the room locked eyes on Corynth instead of them. Catra had heard the Beast's subjects referred to as a hive mind on more than one occasion, even experienced it first-hand fighting its Troopers, but this was the first instance she'd seen so many individual bodies act as if inhabited by one mind.

Corynth took another step forward, pushing the inky murkiness further back, and every thrall took a hesitant step away at the same time to stay inside its depths. The Beast itself was afraid of him, Catra realized with a shock. Everything she'd ever read and everything anyone had ever said about it painted the Beast as apathetic and ruthless, afraid of nothing. More like a force of nature than anything else.

Corynth took another step, and this time, after pushing the thralls back yet again, they started screeching and posturing at him.

Adora spoke next to Catra, her words, breathless and quiet like a prayer, unreeled from her mouth like an unbroken string. She was still on her hands and knees with her and Taline, eyes glassy and unblinking as she stared at Corynth's back. "Please," she said, and Catra knew she wasn't talking to anyone but herself. "Please, please, *please*. You have to come. You have to do this, *now.*"

Seeing that slotted the final pieces of the visions in Catra's head for her, letting an odd sort of calm lay over her like a blanket. She felt buoyant. Happy, even, seeing that, no, Adora *hadn't* given up entirely, yet. And Catra still had her plan.

She stood, placed a reassuring hand on Adora's shoulder, then extended that hand for Adora to take when she looked up at her with watery, desperate eyes. "Come on," she said, hauling Adora to her feet. She gestured with a tilt of her head to Corynth, still staring down twelve troopers. "We should help him."

There. For the split second, she saw it in Adora's eyes before she looked away: the fear and uncertainty were still there, but hope

was there, too. And hope was a good start, but it wasn't what Catra was looking for. That would take some work.

"I…I can't," Adora said, averting her eyes. "She won't come."

Catra, still holding one of Adora's hands, reached for her other one. Adora jumped at the sensation of their fingers interlocking, eyes darting back to Catra's, and electricity from three years of mutual longing dancing between them. A warm shiver ran down Catra's spine as she trailed her fingers from Adora's hands up her forearms, feeling her tremble and shudder with the sensation.

This was why she had such an aggressive reaction on the tram ride before. Without some immediate, outside emergency to attend to, she'd straddled this line between electrifying intimacy and pent-up aggression, both borne of the same repressed longing. Before, Catra hadn't wanted to wrestle with intimacy, so she'd pushed Adora hard enough she fell back onto the benches, then lambasted her with enough verbal abuse to escape Adora's gravity.

This time, she didn't want to run away. This time, she wanted more than just a vague hope mixing with the fear and uncertainty in Adora's eyes.

Catra's fingers continued their journey, fingers tracing up the rest of Adora's arms and across her shoulders to cup her face in both hands. Adora held her breath, a flush staining her cheeks and spreading down her neck, her gaze so full of open vulnerability that Catra almost got lost in it. A tear fell, running down Adora's cheek until Catra brushed it away with her thumb.

Catra's eyes drifted to her lips. Adora's breath hitched before she held it, the look in her eyes deepening, the first sparks catching into embers. She had to stoke that fire. Encourage it to grow.

"You always did turn into a puddle of tears when you had too many thoughts running through that thick head of yours," she said, running the fingers of one hand to the back of Adora's head

and through her hair. "Good thing you have me here to set you straight."

Catra closed her eyes, leaned in, and kissed Adora on the mouth.

The electricity from earlier exploded into an unstoppable current. Shooting from her head down to her toes, it filled every inch in between with boundless energy. If someone had asked Catra to draw a rune and cast a spell powerful enough to end the Beast right then and there, she had no doubt she'd pull it off despite having had no magical inclination her entire life. And when she finally broke the kiss, when she looked upon Adora's face and saw the transformation that had taken place there, she knew that same feeling of invincibility and soaring self-confidence had infected her as well.

There was her Adora. Her eyes blazed like they had in Corynth's memories. In her own, too, if she reached back far enough.

"Now," Catra said, unable to stifle her smile when she saw galaxies reflected in the blue of Adora's eyes. "Those thralls will attack any second. Grab that big-ass sword of yours, and help Corynth and I fight these things off."

Doubt creeped back into the corners of Adora's expression, and Catra squeezed her fingers for good measure. "We don't need to beat them, just keep them from overwhelming Taline until Pip gets the Heart up. Don't overextend yourself and don't do anything risky. I'll be right there with you, forcing some openings. You just exploit them."

Adora bit her lip, but Catra could see the determination start to win over the doubt. Adora looked to the side and Catra followed her line of sight. Corynth, standing alone against the flood of thralls like a rock parting a river, watched their exchange over his shoulder.

The thralls screeched again and reared back. They were seconds away from overcoming whatever doubts had plagued their alien

hive mind, Catra could tell. Corynth turned away from her and Adora to face them again, then lit up in a brilliant, blinding hue.

It was as clear a sign as any, both of his open challenged to the thralls and his open invitation for Catra and Adora to join him. A grin broke out on Adora’s face, an elation that spread through the rest of her body language as quickly as the flames that consumed the Whispering Woods.

The Sword of Protection materialized in her open hand again, her eyes glowing with starlight and her hair lifting off her shoulders like gravity itself exerted less influence on her person.

There still was no full She Ra, but Catra’s plan was working.

The thralls surged forward like a tsunami wave. Catra and Adora both leapt through Taline’s shield, Adora with a fierce battle cry, determined to meet the onslaught of thralls alongside Corynth with just as much force.

Chapter End Notes

> This isn't the first time we've had current-timeline characters reliving memories of another character. It's a recurring thing in this fic, actually, since it's a device I lean on to have flashbacks without actual flashbacks.
>
> Last time this happened to Catra, it was the residual side effects she was experiencing after Horde Prime interrogated her, and they were his memories she was revisiting. This time, we finally got some snippets from Corynth's POV. There are wider, philosophical implications behind her and Corynth sharing Pip to the extent they can relive each others' memories (which gives a lot of clarity around why Corynth so strongly shut both her and Pip out earlier in this part). But for me, the most important thing about this is how those memories relate to Adora's arc.
>
> I've stayed more or less true to the promise I made all the way back in part 1 that we never leave the big canon 3

characters' POVs, but the issue with that was, for all of Adora's adventures, we only experienced them through her eyes. We only saw and felt how much she failed because that's all she could see for herself. At least two readers have commented about how sad and sorry for Adora they feel, how they think she's achieved nothing at all. And this is both true and not true, because we've only seen Adora's scenes through Adora's eyes. Catra wasn't there with her for those past 3 years, either, so she couldn't provide context, either. This whole time we've only ever gotten a very biased, one-sided view of her adventure.

But Corynth has been there this whole time. He's even explicitly stated to Catra that Adora is amazing, he *witnessed* her being amazing several times, and has outright stated she is the only reason they've come as far as they have. Because she inspired him. And its through these memories of his Catra gets to see all of Adora's adventures--all of her crowning moments of epic--from outside herself. Adora herself thinks she failed, and now Catra has the context she needs to be able to show her that's not necessarily the case.

All this in a giant author's note to say: as much as it may seem like I was just pummeling Adora into the ground for endless chapters, I really haven't. We both (as character and author) have just been in the extremely unfortunate position of not being able to see/show with a realistic lens how much Adora has actually achieved.

"If only you could see yourself through my eyes" is such a powerful theme, as is narrative therapy and the ability to re-contextualize traumatic events and problems. And that really is the key to Adora's arc :)

Also: Haha, I made them kiss!

# Chapel Perilous

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Magic crackled at Adora's back as she fought, the sound punctuated with Taline's strained cries as she pushed to the point of injury to keep the power flowing into her magic shield. She was doing everything she could to protect Pip and the equipment she was working on to jumpstart the Heart. But as concerning as those cries were, Adora couldn't stop thinking about the kiss. How Catra's lips seared her. How the thought of it continued to drive the inferno raging in her chest to new heights.

She might have felt silly thinking of a kiss when they were mere ticking seconds away from determining the fate of the galaxy, but Corynth was making it surprisingly easy to be effective without paying full attention. Despite the legion of thralls filling the enclosed space, no more than a dozen or so at a time could get past him to Catra and Adora.

"Does he even need us?" Catra asked, dancing between several thralls, pushing them off balance as they rushed forward.

Adora was so fixated on watching her move, she didn't realize what she was referring to until Catra vaulted over another thrall and gestured midair to Corynth. There he stood, electrifying, immolating, and sometimes even physically hurling back countless thralls with his magic. Unlike the intricate, sweeping gestures of the Enclave Battlemages, Taline included, Corynth's movements were all in his unique, harsh, economical style.

"I think he does," Adora said. To make her point, she cut down another set of thralls that had made it past him—ones Catra had just pushed her way before they got to Taline, still struggling to maintain her shield just behind them.

“Yeah, but he’s kind of stealing my thunder.” Catra bent far enough backward the top of her head nearly touched the ground as a thrall’s clawed hand soared past her nose. “After I gave such a convincing speech to get you out here, this feels sort of anticlimactic.”

That pulled a laugh out of Adora as she ducked a blow sliding forward on her knees. She let her sword do the work slicing another thrall in half on the way. “You get used to it,” she said, surprised to discover she meant it.

Whereas before, her need for control and lack of it in the preceding years had driven her insane, at some point, she’d stopped feeling ‘less than’ for handing that control over to Corynth during their adventures. Speaking as much aloud shifted something in her mentality. Something that brought her the freedom to finally just enjoy the present moment, for once.

And what a moment it was. Her and Catra, fighting side by side. After the kiss, even the threat of impending doom seemed inconsequential. It made no sense but Adora didn’t care. She reached a hand out, smiling, and Catra, after only a moment’s pause to decipher, smiled back at her and took that hand, allowing Adora to pull her out of harm’s way before another thrall pounced on her.

The feeling she got as the two of them tore through another dozen bodies in short order was indescribable. Nothing could stop them.

And then all the thralls stopped fighting, suddenly pulling back the furthest recesses of the sanctum with the fog without explanation. Even Corynth stopped engaging with them, hands still bristling with energy, poised. Catra and Adora looked to one another in confusion, before the room darkened and took on a blood-red hue.

Amorphous shadowy figures appeared around the room among the thralls. Just like those that had appeared in Archanas’ control

room, they were like the mirages that played at the corners of one's vision when coming out of a deep sleep. And just like those in the control room, these didn't disappear when looked at directly, either. Catra's ears pinned down, pupils thinning to slits as she hissed. Goosebumps erupted across Adora's skin. A palpable feeling of dread blanketed the room, and Adora could only latch onto one thought in her head as she looked up through the hole in the ceiling and saw Archanas had nearly covered the sun:

Death. Death was here.

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Lightning, firebolts, missiles, and anti-air repeater rounds zipped past the gunship as Lysithea drove them down a nearly ninety-degree dive to the bridge leading into Bright Moon Castle. Glimmer clung to the overhead railing, each projectile whizzing past her making her grip tighter until her knuckles were white. She stared out the slid-open doors at their destination, the front line of the Etherian and Enclave forces holding a tenuous position barricaded just a hundred meters from the mouth of the bridge.

From her vantage point, Glimmer saw a divot in the front line the barricade was broken through and the soldiers were struggling to reinforce. If it grew any deeper, the entire force might be routed. And with their backs pushed up against the bridge, that would be disastrous.

The sharp sound of blaster fire tearing through metal cut through the sound of rushing air blowing out Glimmer's ears. The radio exploded with activity at the same time Ly called out from the cockpit, "Ares One reports mayday, Ares One is down!"

The rearguard of Battlemages and anti-air technicians were grouped both on the surface and inside the castle grounds, beyond the bridge straddling its river-cut gorge. They did everything they could to provide covering fire, but the Beast held enough air superiority to make this dive a gamble even accounting for this.

Glimmer narrowed her eyes, remaining focused as the ground race to meet them. Any moment, now. Any moment now, and they'd be down there, she just had to wait. The front line was flagging and the eclipse was continuing, but she just had to wait.

Another explosion and another callout from the cockpit signaled the destruction of their second wingmen. They were so close. Each moment felt like agonizing centuries, but they were so close. Glimmer counted the seconds.

"Rearguard! Shields, now!" she said into the comms the instant she judged they were close enough.

The numerous Battlemages helping them on the ground cast together, and a partial shield, shaped like an umbrella instead of a dome, burst from the rough center of their location. It grew until it engulfed their gunship, larger than any Glimmer had created alone, leaving the countless Interceptors chasing them to crash into its surface. A rippling thunder of rolling explosions chased them from behind like the roar of a vicious mountain-sized predator.

Lysithea pulled the gunship out of its dive still dozens of feet off the ground. She stopped so fast, their soldiers would have turned into past on the floor had Glimmer not magically anchored everyone's to the craft as a precaution. Everyone inside checked the harnesses wrapping their chests, preparing to rappel down. Glimmer and Frosta were the only one without rappel harnesses.

They all jumped.

Glimmer heard Lonnie and Kyle curse behind her, heard Rogelio grunt in surprise, heard all three of their tethers squealing as friction against their lines and its feeders slowed their descent. She ignored them. Instead, she used her magic to push her mid-fall away from their landing zone at the rear of the formation and toward the front of the line—to the divot where that line was sagging.

High above and behind, the Moonstone pulsed. Like the stockpiles she pulled from on Scavria and Archanas, Glimmer drew magic from it, feeling like she'd plunged into an ice bath the way its energy suffused every inch of skin, every pore. The aches and pains and exhaustions of her body disappeared as she turned into an incandescent comet, shuttling through the sky.

And just like an actual comet, Glimmer slammed into the ground on impact, releasing the energy she'd gathered. The ground beneath her shattered under the weight of her feet, and the earth itself opened to swallow the countless thralls threatening the integrity of the line.

"Holy hell," Mermista said among her troops. They were the ones struggling to hold position behind the barricades. Not because they were poorer quality than the others, but because she was the one covering the most for Frosta's losses.

Glimmer ignored her, too, and focused on doing as much damage to the rest of the thralls around them as possible. With Mermista's help, she pushed them back and held them there, waiting until her reinforcements still at the back of the group could reach them.

*I beat my own Vanguard here*, Glimmer thought with a touch of humor as she quick-cast with both hands. Lightning as thick as her forearms sprang from her fingertips, immobilizing another swathe of thralls in crushing static.

The squeal of engines from behind drew her attention. The gunship, having divested itself of its payload, broke away, abruptly strafing left from idle at such a harsh angle it looked like Lysithea had cheated inertia. They'd let Kyle remain her copilot in exchange for Vasher and his team accompanying them surface-side, again. *One of yours for one of mine*, Lysithea had said. Glimmer was certain Kyle would learn several new pilot tricks from her if they made it through this.

Bow, clad in a Bright Moon officer's uniform, chased close behind riding Swift Wind as the gunship fled out from underneath the

protective umbrella, exposing them both to a hail of blaster fire from even more Interceptors. Glimmer watched him nock three arrows and pull his weapon taught before firing. His arrows streaked through the air before turning, carving an unnatural angle through the air, homing in on a few of the missiles dogging the gunship until it intercepted them. Him and Swift Wind through the resulting explosion and gave chase.

He was Lysithea's new wingman now, it seemed, following Glimmer's last orders to protect the airspace around the castle.

She forced her attention away from him just as Vasher and his men pushed through the formation at her back. Frosta was with him, and at his order, his men they filled out Mermista's line, integrating seamlessly with her troops. Frosta rebuilt new barricades out of solid ice just as Lonnie appeared and grabbed Glimmer, dragging her away from the front to relative safety.

Rogelio was waiting for them as expected, ready to take his place at her side again as part of her inner circle team. What wasn't expected, however, was how Keren and Trayn were there waiting with him. A surreal kind of pride for Catra seeped into the back of Glimmer's mind when she realized that meant her friends had passed muster under Lonnie's scrutiny. She wouldn't have let them come along unless she'd approved of their performance so far, and in a pitched warzone, no less. Glimmer thought to ask her about it until she saw the look on her face.

Lonnie was livid. With her. The expression was so clear, several explanations and even a few excuses danced by reflex on the tip of Glimmer's tongue the moment she saw.

"You were supposed to wait for me," Lonnie said in a gruff, put out voice before Glimmer could speak. But just as she expected her to lay into her more, Lonnie waved her hand in an irritated gesture that gave the impression she was resigned to Glimmer's worst impulses no matter how much she detested it. "What's our next move?"

Relief flooded through Glimmer. She wasn't about to dwell on her good luck not getting chewed out by her second in command, and looked up to gauge how much of the sun Archanas had eaten. It was nearly gone, and the sky had begun to bleed with red.

"Everyone needs to get across the bridge and inside the castle walls," she said, eyeing the still-formless shadows standing among them as she opened a shared channel to Salas.

"I don't think that's going to be an easy sell." Lonnie looked across the bridge at the closed siege doors. "The thralls won't wait around while our front line retreats inside. And judging by the fact you felt it necessary to save that front line at the cost of nearly giving me a heart attack, I don't think we could afford letting anyone retreat in the first place."

Glimmer smirked, but Salas answered the connection before she could explain.

"Good job reinforcing the line," he said. He sounded genuinely relieved, even through the static. "But I fear the time it bought us won't be enough. Are you certain you want to move ahead with this plan?"

"I wouldn't have called it in if I wasn't certain. They're going to manifest here on our doorstep, and they're certainly not going to be mere thralls given how large they are. Your worst nightmare is about to come true."

Salas cursed, the exact wording lost in another swell of static. Glimmer looked past Lonnie's perplexed expression at the shadowed figures once more. They remained there like obelisks, waiting.

"We're running out of time. Either we do this now or it will be too late."

Entrapta's voice came on the line, replacing Salas' with a, "He's busy again, sorry." She sounded like she was striving to keep pace

with a frantic amount of information. “Hold please. I’m opening up the channel to bridge the others.”

“What is happening?” Lonnie asked. She’d looked to Keren, Rogelio, and Trayn after Glimmer ignored the clear request for context in her earlier expression. After getting nothing but shrugs, had turned back on Glimmer.

“Code Black,” she said, before gesturing to one of the nearby shadows. “I didn’t call it explicitly, but the others knew what was coming when I got on the general comms line and ordered a full retreat. With the eclipse starting those shadows starting to appear, I wanted to give everyone plenty of time to maneuver.”

Lonnie frowned. “I thought I’d memorized all the in-use field codes. I’ve certainly drilled most of them, but I’m not familiar with that one.” A commotion broke out at the front and everyone startled, Lonnie, Keren, and Trayn gripping their rifles and Rogelio his sidearm. The thralls seemed to have made another concerted push, and Glimmer waited until it was confirmed their defenses still held.

“It’s not an Imperial or Enclave code,” she said. “It’s Etherian and needs at least five princesses to pull off. That’s why they’ve been holding a line at the bridge. With Frosta and I here now, we’ve met our quota.”

Keren and Trayn seemed openly curious at her description, and even the notoriously indifferent Rogelio paid close attention. Lonnie quirked an eyebrow. “A field tactic I haven’t heard of, huh? You confident it’s going to work?”

“I guess we’ll find out.”

That seemed to make Lonnie more nervous. Glimmer didn’t blame her. They could do everything right and still get shafted if those shadows materialized too soon. The Moonstone was likely the only thing left that would buy them enough room to get inside the castle walls.

A series of sharp static noises cut in, like someone was plugging several sound cables into a dusty amplifier and making it pop. "Alright, everyone should be here," Entrapta said. "Call in for Code Black readiness."

"Perfuma calling in," came her voice over the line. "We're dug in tight but holding. Green."

"Scorpia here and ready to go. Green across the board. The sooner I can let my guys pull back the better."

"Frosta, checking in." She sounded nervous. Vasher's voice came through muddy in the background, yelling something about cover. "Green?"

"Hey, when did you get new uniforms for your people?" Scorpia asked. "I didn't realize you'd switched them to an even deeper color blue than—"

"Guys, *focus,*" Glimmer said, rolling her eyes at Rogelio, who gave her a knowing side eye in response. "Mermista? How's it looking?"

"Uh, was red for a bit there until…hold on."

The sound of soldiers yelling and violent water crashing against bodies sounded off in the distance and over the comms. Glimmer looked over, unable to see much through the mass of reserve soldiers surrounding position. That was until about a dozen thralls flew through the air as if they were tossed, soaking wet.

"Sorry," Mermista said, coming back on. "Was red for a bit until you came along. Thanks. For the help and the reinforcements. And Frosta, I guess. Green."

Glimmer wasted no time. "That was five greens including mine," she said. "Mom, Dad, pull back to the castle. We'll need extra cover."

They both acknowledged, though Glimmer could hear the concern staining their voices. Nevertheless, her parents soared above,

escaping the mass of bodies ebbing and flowing in pitched battle before the bridge. Her mom's ethereal wings carried her through the sky while her dad stood tall on a saucer of purple magic. Both sped past the bridge, over the castle walls, and up toward the Moonstone spire towering in the distance.

"How are we feeling, guys?" Glimmer asked, forcing herself to look away from them. "Still green?"

Their responses trickled in, each of them sounding more unsure, more pressed, more exerted than earlier, but all still green. Their successful execution of this strategy could shift moment to moment.

"How is this supposed to go?" Lonnie asked, watching as Glimmer widened her stance and straightened her arms over her head, stretching until her joints popped. "I don't know how we're supposed to help if you don't let me in on how this is supposed to play out."

"You don't have to do anything," Glimmer said. "None of you do." To the comms, she said, "Entrapta, make sure the gate opens as soon as we get started."

"What do you mean we don't have to do anything?" Lonnie asked. "We're on your team, Glimmer. Use us."

Glimmer shook her head. "Code Black is simple. The soldiers don't do anything. You all retreat."

"That doesn't make any sense. There won't be any front line, then, and the thralls are *right*—"

She cut off when Glimmer met her eyes with a pointed look, refusing to elaborate further. A moment later, and realization dawned on her face.

"You're going to hold the entire thrall host back," she said, voice quiet and forced low out of disbelief. "The five of you? Just the five of you?" She gaped, then looked back at the army shoving

against the front line about thirty feet away. The combined might of their forces barricaded behind solid cover still struggled to keep the dizzying number of thralls at bay. “Are you insane?”

Glimmer laughed. “This close to the moonstone? Yes. I think maybe I am.”

She lunged, punching out with both arms, making a “tearing-apart” motion like she’d dug her fingers into the doors of a closed elevator and was trying to rip them apart.

Magic ripped through her body, suffusing her such that her hair stood on end, the overflow spilling from her back again like great wings. She glowed so bright her squad had to take several steps away from her, shielding their eyes. Salas had given her plenty of reports over the years. Ones detailing her friends’ experiences training with the Enclave, pushing themselves further than they thought possible through their respective runestones. She’d read what that felt like.

No amount of reading prepared her to feel it herself.

This more than she’d ever tapped into on Scavria and Archanas. Even those full stockpiles hadn’t gotten her close to this, because this was pure Etherian magic—power from her native Moonstone. Power she could more easily metabolize and use.

It felt like switching to her dominant hand after years forced using her other one.

An enormous pink and purple wall bloomed at front line. Taller than any magic barrier she’d ever attempted before, it separated Etherian and Enclave soldiers from the thrall host, wrapping all the way around until it hit the cliff behind them that the bridge crossed. Like the shield she’d held outside Frosta’s tower, Glimmer felt every scrape and scrabble and impact the thralls made against it. This time, however, none of it phased her. Now it felt like small animals pawing at her ankles instead of an army trying to break her apart.

At the front, obscured by their army, Mermista pulled a typhoon's sum of water from the river carving the gorge at their back. She sent it forward, tendrils flowing through the air like dozens of river estuaries. The water formed around Glimmer's magic wall, insulating it like a second skin.

Perfuma, far left at the front, worked her arms in wide circles. The earth rumbled and cracked as great vines sprung forth. They intermixed with Mermista's water, swimming through and around it like fantastic sea eels. Frosta gestured and turned that water to solid ice, pushing spear-tipped icicles out to face the thralls for good measure. That was when Scorpia directed currents of Black Garnet-infused electricity across the ice-and-vine-and-Moonstone wall's expanse, and at that point, the thralls throwing themselves against its surface failed to register for Glimmer at all.

Lonnie and the others gave a muted sound of awe.

"Castle walls opening," Salas said, coming back on over the comms. A prolonged creaking sound of the reinforced doors across the bridge opening followed.

"Send everyone across, now!" Glimmer said to the others. "We will hold them."

A beat passed while the princesses relayed the orders to their men. Then, all at once, countless Enclave and Etherian soldiers from across all the kingdoms turned and rushed for the bridge. Fear and concern were etched on many of their faces. Glimmer and her team stood at the mouth of the bridge, parting the masses like a rock parting a stream.

Vasher and his people were some of the last to pull back. "Do you need us?" he asked, once they reached them.

"No," Glimmer said, sweat beading on her forehead. "I need everyone inside the castle, you included."

He made some comment or other about not feeling right leaving Frosta alone up there, but otherwise didn't put up a fuss as him

and his men pulled back with the others. Glimmer's own team, however, wasn't moving.

"We'll pull back with you and the other princesses," Lonnie said when Glimmer turned her attention on her.

"Not this time," Glimmer forced herself not to wince at the look Lonnie gave her as even more soldiers rushed past. "I know you hate it, but you need to go with the others."

"It's not because I hate it, our mandate is that we *cannot* leave you alone." A note of disbelief rang in Lonnie's voice, like she couldn't believe Glimmer had distilled this clash of orders down to a simple 'like versus dislike'. "Why can't we just wait until all you princesses pull back?" Her words slowed the more she spoke, her face taking on deeper skepticism with each syllable. Realization—a second one—dawned on her face. "You aren't going to pull back, are you? None of you are."

Glimmer sighed. "Lonnie—"

"Hell fucking no. This is a *terrible* idea." Lonnie had never bristled like this before—at least, not as far as Glimmer had seen. Keren and Trayn looked concerned, and even Rogelio looked unsure of what to do. "There are five of you here holding that entire army back, and you all did that knowing what would happen if even one of you falls victim to the Beast. There is not a chance in hell I'm going to—"

"Lonnie!" Glimmer yelled with enough frustration, born mainly out of her own fear and exhaustion since Archanas, it got her to listen. "We *can't* pull back. Not yet. As soon as we do, that wall goes down and the thralls will flood across the bridge and into the castle. Everyone will die, not just you and your soldiers, and not just us princesses. All of Bright Moon's citizenry hunkered down inside, too."

Soldiers continued to stream through the open gates, but a quarter of the army was still pushing onto the bridge. A low,

throaty sound burst from the top of the Moonstone spire, where another bubble of magic sprang, encapsulating the grounds of the castle all the way to its walls. Seeing that invigorated Glimmer. Whoever made it inside the was now beyond even the reach of whatever the Beast would do in the coming moments. Not even those obelisk shadows could materialize inside, and she only had to hold out until the last of the army made it to safety.

"Listen to me," she said before Lonnie could stall her. "Remember what you told me on Scavria? When you thought I'd already turned into an Abomination and was trying to trick you? You told me never to do that to you again. Never put you in a position where you thought you'd have to pull the trigger for the greater good of the galaxy.

"I very nearly did back at Frosta's tower, and believe me when I say I'm not putting you through that a third time. We can't pull away until everyone is across and that includes you." She huffed. "If you're adamant about waiting for us, then pull back to the halfway point and wait there if you must, but any extra body on this side of the gorge is too much of a risk."

That extra clarification helped connect the dots for Lonnie that this wasn't a suicide tactic, and she calmed. Keren and Trayn both looked relieved, too.

"You think you can pull it off?" Lonnie asked. "After everything that happened, all the exertion, you think you can make it work with just five?"

Thinking had nothing to do with it. This close to home, she *would* get all of them out of there even if she had to crack the Moonstone and flay her very body to get it done. "I need you to trust me," she said, looking Lonnie straight in the eyes. "Go."

The look of incredulous resolve crumbled into resignation on Lonnie's face while Rogelio looked relieved he wouldn't have to manhandle her to follow orders. Lonnie looked skyward, shouted an exasperated, "Fuck!" then gestured at the bridge to the rest of

the team. “Keren and Trayn at the front, Rogelio and I will cover the rear. She jabbed a finger at Glimmer. “We stop at the halfway point, and you’d better fucking meet us there.”

Glimmer watched them double time away. To her credit, Lonnie didn’t look back. Most of the remaining troops had piled onto the bridge by now, and it would only be a handful of seconds now until the princesses could pull back, too. She took a breath, feeling the Moonstone’s aura fill her lungs.

“Are you guys ready?” she asked the other princesses over the comms, still dozens of feet ahead of her and pumping their own magic into the monstrous barrier they’d erected. “That wall isn’t going to last long once I pull out.”

They chorused various forms of “Ready as I’ll ever be” at her, each of them sounding beyond exhausted. Glimmer pulled even more magic to her. She felt like her body was tearing apart at the seams, and yet she continued to pull. She pulled until her body finally did rip apart at the seams, as did the rest of the princesses, scattering them all into sparkling dust where they stood.

They rematerialized about a hundred yards back, halfway across the bridge. Glimmer’s legs gave out the moment she appeared, dumping her to the cold cobblestone underfoot.

“Holy shit, you really did it,” Lonnie said, already pulling Glimmer’s arm across her shoulder to help haul her to her feet. Glimmer scanned around for the others, relief flooding her foggy, near-delusional brain when she saw Scorpia, Perfuma, Mermista, and Frosta there too. To her surprise, Vasher and his men had stayed at the halfway point, too. They must have waited with Lonnie and the others once they caught sight of them.

“We’re away,” Glimmer said into the comms, voice scratchy and hoarse. “Salas, do it now!”

The far half of the bridge exploded. The munitions rigged underneath its support structures disintegrating in a controlled

detonation, sending stonework raining into the river far below. The obelisk shadows were here, too, but at least now there was no way for the thralls to get to them, even if they got past the wall. A cheer rang out from those still with them, rushing toward the castle. Glimmer was exhausted enough she was steps away from shutting down.

She nudged Lonnie when her team took a little too long staring across the gorge. “It’s still not safe out here,” she said. “We still need to cross. We need to get inside the castle.”

Lonnie glanced at Trayn, and before Glimmer could decipher what the look on her face meant, he’d scooped her up in his arms, bridal-style. She was too tired to react, and together them and all the princesses rushed with the others across the back half of the bridge. Micah and Angella’s barrier scintillated with magic ahead, terminated just inside the walls of the castle. Salvation and respite.

The darkness that had overshadowed them since the start of the eclipse grew suddenly deeper and all encompassing. With a chill shooting down her spine, Glimmer know what had just happened without having to look up: Archanas had fully eclipsed the sun, plunging all of Etheria into shadow lit only by the ambient red emanating from their newest moon.

What before was just an ever-present feeling—an undercurrent of impending doom—pushed to the forefront, becoming a screaming, tearing sensation. It clawed at the inside of Glimmer’s skull, and judging by how everybody else on the bridge reacted, it was affecting them, too. They had all stopped to grasp at their heads, their hands palming their ears like they thought the sound of the Beast speaking directly to their minds was something they could block off.

Trayn managed to let Glimmer stumble to her feet before he succumbed. Even Lonnie fell victim, her breath coming in shallow and rapid. Glimmer herself lasted only a few moments longer before she too covered her ears, trying to block out the Beast. Her

panic only reached new depths when she realized that didn't do anything to quell the sensation.

"Acro…across," Glimmer said to the others, her sanity hanging on by a thread. "Keep going…Get across…the bridge. We have to… get inside!"

A crunching sound echoed out to them from behind, like the jaws of a gargantuan monster snapping the bones of countless animals in its mouth. With great effort, Glimmer looked back over her shoulder

The thralls had punched holes in the princess' magic wall, large enough they could start to squeeze through. Their bodies wriggled and writhed halfway through the wall, like person-sized worms struggling through shoddy perforations. Cracks formed branching pathways between those holes, until the entire wall apart.

Not just that, but a dense fog was descending upon the landscape, obscuring everything beyond. It was like a tidal wave as tall as the castle itself, and Glimmer had at first thought it was just the mountain range surrounding the plains until she realized it was growing. Getting closer.

The thralls had fully broken past their wall. When they hit the edge of the gorge with no way to pass, fog reached them. It muddied the contours of the ruined half of the bridge, the shape twisting and moving until, to Glimmer, it seemed to elongate.

"No," she said, her blood running cold as the thralls took tentative steps on that murky bridge form before rushing across en masse. The Beast was altering physical reality on Etheria. It had rebuilt the bridge they'd just blown apart.

Something rattled in Glimmer's ear—a voice she recognized but couldn't place, saying words she could parse syllables but not meaning from. The doors to the castle, now just feet away, started to close, the shimmer of magic promising safety beyond thinning into a smaller and smaller sliver.

At last, as the thrall host closed the distance between them and the even smaller group of soldiers and princesses still trapped on the bridge. That was when the amorphous, obelisk shadows that had been standing like mute statues all around took shape.

A leg formed, then another, followed by an arm anchoring to the edges of the void as if trying to pull itself through. What passed for a featureless head poked through, followed by the rest of the creature.

“Form up!” a voice to Glimmer’s left said. It was Vasher, spurring his men in hazy dark blue to converge around Glimmer and the other princesses.

Over a dozen Troopers pulled themselves from their respective pockets of shadow, each of them turning as one to the bridge. And at the back of Glimmer’s mind, one thought made itself clear above the ocean current of panic sweeping everything else away:

They’d run out of time.

---

“These things again?” Adora asked, pointing her sword at eight Troopers that had just manifested in the sanctum with them. Admittedly, this was the first thing she figured would happen as soon as the thralls pulled back, but she hoped it wouldn’t.

“Remember what I told you before?” Catra said, taking slow, deliberate steps closer to her.

“Don’t overextend myself and don’t do anything risky?” Adora readied a defensive stance with the sword in both hands.

“Exactly that.” Catra sounded confident, but there was a waver in her voice Adora couldn’t miss. “I’ll back you up and create openings. We don’t have to go on the offensive, our only job is to keep them away from Taline. Her shield goes down and the Beast has full reign to destroy all the tech Pip’s using to open the Heart.”

This was different than Archanas, where Catra had told her to seek Taline's protection instead of fight. It still baffled Adora how Catra seemed so in control and in the loop about what was happening, especially considering she'd fallen unconscious after entering the sanctum. But that didn't matter very much, honestly speaking, because Catra wasn't telling her to back down. She was asking her to fight, and against even more of these things than before.

Catra believed in her, and it had been literal years since she'd felt her confidence soar so much.

The thralls lining the far walls gnashed their teeth and retched at them while the Troopers closed in, strafing, taking slow, deliberate steps, each one inching them closer like a noose tightening around them strand by agonizing strand. Adora pivoted equally as slow, angling so she could keep her back to Taline and as many Troopers as she could within her line of sight. Catra, on all fours low to the ground, moved with her.

The tension was maddening.

And then, Catra's ear twitched—a tell Adora assumed meant she'd either strike or was reacting to something else. Before she could tell which, Corynth struck first, closing the distance between him and one of the Troopers in a blink-and-you'll-miss-it lunge. His arm shot forward like a striking viper, hand closing around its throat before lifting the creature off the ground like it weighed nothing and then driving it into the ground so hard it cratered.

"Oh hell—" Catra stepped back until she bumped into Adora. "He didn't do that when I was helping him before."

Corynth sent a pulse of magic through his arm and the Trooper exploded. Coated in the viscous matter of its sibling, the others hesitated. Corynth spun around to face a second Trooper, grabbing it at the back of the neck and sending another pulse of magic into it that made it explode, too.

The rest advanced on him then, just as fast. Two had surrounded him before Adora or Catra could help to react, their arms already lengthened into blades and poised to strike.

They swung.

"No!"

Adora rushed to help just as a third Trooper appeared in front of her, moving fast enough it appeared as a blur, already poised to cut her in half, too. Someone yelled—a hand at her shoulder tried to stop her, tried to pull her back, but it was too late. She anticipated her death the same moment she watched Corynth block both Trooper's bladed limbs with his bare forearms. Even Adora's instinct to help him had been unnecessary.

Except, the Trooper attacked much slower than it had moved confronting her in the first place. It was like some phantom power had slowed its hand, held it back just long enough for Catra to yet again pull her out of the way in time.

At first, Adora didn't know what happened. That was, until the Trooper looked past them, uttering a sound of contempt at Taline. One of her hands was pointed out at them while the other maintained the shield she continued to take refuge behind with Pip.

She gestured again with that hand, and an incandescent ball of energy shot forth. The Trooper dodged it like it was merely an annoyance, then rushed for her, prompting the remaining three of its siblings not already engaged with Corynth to join.

"Oh, *shit*," Catra said, bounding after one of them, trying to peel its attention away while Adora chased the second.

Corynth turned another of the Troopers occupying him into a cloud of viscera, then shoved the other to put distance between them. He threw a hand out, and two of the four Troopers rushing for Taline lifted into the air, their feet kicking, trying to find

purchase. They flew away from her and back to him, no longer an immediate threat.

That left three for him, and while he'd already taken out three others to begin with, Adora wasn't so certain she and Catra would fare half as well against the remaining two, even with what little help Taline might afford them. The Troopers had already so thoroughly outclassed her on Archanas. She resolved to do her best against them, still, but their presence on Etheria coupled with the dark red hue permeating the air wasn't a good sign.

*So much for not overextending myself.* The thought lasted just a moment before Adora swung, the Sword of Protection singing through the air for one of the Troopers already hammering away at Taline's shield.

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The situation on the bridge was an absolute shitshow. The fog had completely overtaken them, and Glimmer couldn't tell left from right, reality from a construct the Beast made through its essence permeating the air. She couldn't even see the castle anymore, and doubted they were still feet from its walls. Not until Salas and his Mage Sentinels appeared on the bridge with them, heralded by a swirling firestorm that masked his own brand of teleportation magic.

"Get up!" he said, yanking Glimmer to her feet.

A moment later and the fog pall over Glimmer's brain receded, as did the actual fog around their immediate surroundings. Salas created his own sphere of influence, extending that of her parents' to cover the remaining forces on the bridge that hadn't made it inside the castle walls before the doors shut.

All the princesses and perhaps a quarter of their respective forces were there pressed up against the wall and doors, trapped. Lonnie, Rogelio, Keren, and Trayn were there too, as were Vasher and his men. Everyone was firing weapons and shooting bolts of magic down range of the bridge, but not even that vast

concentration of firepower seemed to slow the flood of thralls and Troopers rushing across the artificial, Beast-made half of the bridge.

The Sentinels gestured together, the sharp, cutting motions of their arms making the fabric of their robes flap in the air. A glowing yellow-orange rune appeared beneath their feet, Salas positioning his own soles where two lines in the pattern intersected. He made a punching movement with both hands and a miniature sun appeared, held in the collapsing gravity field his Sentinels maintained. After another sharp gesture, Salas sent it rocketing down the length of the bridge.

It impacted the front row of thralls, making them disappear. There was no screech of pain, no burnt silhouette hewed into the rough shape of a Scavrian by million-degree plasma. They just disappeared—obliterated into nothing in an instant. The spell continued for several rows before snuffing out, only for even more thralls to take the place of those who had gone.

It was as if the extreme power of even Salas' spells had no effect on their enemy.

"What do we do now?" Glimmer asked, shouting to be heard over the sounds of battle. Salas turned a look on her that made her feel like she'd gotten punched in the stomach. He didn't have an answer.

"We hold here," he said at last, and Glimmer had to give him credit for sounding confident. "Thanks to your parents, the Beast still cannot directly manifest anything inside the castle walls. As long as they enforce the Moonstone's protection the citizenry will be safe. But that won't prevent thralls and Troopers from taking it by force. They can still break down the walls and enter physically. We must hold them here. For as long as we can."

The thralls were maybe thirty feet away and slowly but steadily pushing forward through overwhelming firepower.

A monster-sized vine—one of Perfuma's—reached up from under the bridge, slamming into as many thralls as it could reach and pushing countless others off the sides. Mermista swept dozens off the side the same way Perfuma did, except with a torrent of water, while Frosta impaled countless numbers of them with icicles the size of Glimmer's forearm. Scorpia's brand of Black Garnet lightning kept many paralyzed in place long enough for their soldiers to gun them down with ignominite rounds. The spent shells coated the bridge and formed small mounds around them.

The Troopers, however, weren't advancing. They were interspersed among the flood of thralls still at far side of the gorge, towering above their cousins like watchtower commanders overseeing their performance. But they did not advance, remaining in the same place they pulled themselves out of from the obelisk shadows.

"We never stood a chance to begin with, didn't we?" Glimmer asked. "Even if I'd stepped aside and allowed our forces to destroy the Megaliths before they landed, it wouldn't have mattered. Not when the Beast can put Troopers on the field like this."

Echoes of Taline's warnings about the creatures played in her head, as did her experience failing to so much as phase the one who'd confronted her on Scavria. Dry lightning struck above them where the dense fog still obscured the sky, illuminating the silhouettes of countless alien structures. Despite this, Salas shook his head at her, a rare smile on his face.

"We are not the main attraction," he said. "Did you forget?"

A screeling sound came from above, betraying a Warbird that had combusted into a flaming comet inside the fog. It impacted somewhere in the distance, although Glimmer couldn't see where. Another surge from the thralls. They were close enough their screeches hurt her ears.

“Corynth and the others are in the Crystal Castle,” Salas said, speaking with urgency. “It’s a matter of minutes. And while those Troopers could cut through us in mere seconds, they don’t out of hubris.”

“I don’t understand,” Glimmer said.

“The intelligence the Beast has at last imbued them with is a double-edged sword. They think we are beneath them. They do not engage us directly because the thralls are here. They mean to let them overwhelm us instead of stepping in personally. ” Salas’ eyes flicked across the bridge to them, then back to Glimmer. “Your insistence on letting the Megaliths through may have given us our opportunity to hold out in the first place.”

“They’re getting closer!” Keren said after emptying her rifle, reaching for another clip.

Enough thralls had fallen by now that those still alive had to clamber over mounds of their fallen kin. It had slowed their progress but not stopped it. Thankfully, Salas explaining away the mystery behind the Troopers not engaging helped lift the hopeless feeling that had until then refused to let Glimmer go. In its place, was volition.

Reckless volition, one might say, although that was nothing new to Glimmer.

Again, her hands lit with purple magic. And despite how it now burned her skin because her body was so pushed past its limits as a conduit, she pointed downrange, loosed another bolt of pure energy at a clump of thralls, and rejoined the others in fighting back.

And just as she did, a flash high overhead plunged Glimmer into another ice bath of fear, stretching the moment for an eternity. The thralls—those that had pushed through the mountain of inert bodies that had finally been put down for good—were now so close Glimmer couldn’t ignore their faces any longer. They looked

so unmistakably Scavrian despite the animalistic ferocity in their faces. All these people she'd tried to save, and this was what it had amounted to.

The static of the comms in her ear brought her back out. Entrapta's voice came on the line.

"Another energy surge!" she said, voice fuzzing out from interference. "That canon is firing again!"

Above, through even the dense fog obscuring everything else, a deep red beam of pure Beast essence cut a straight line across the sky. It wasn't aiming for them, but away.

Toward the Crystal Castle.

Chapter End Notes

> The progressive degradation of Glimmer's whole situation at Bright Moon was a huge challenge to write. Despite all the "big-battle" (tm) chaos going on in the background in previous chapters, her rescuing Frosta from her tower was a more or less focused and self-contained scene, which was straightforward to write.
>
> For this chapter, I needed to show they were losing the battle and things were getting especially desperate, show Glimmer still having a plan and enacting it, and that plan bringing together all the princesses to demonstrate the kind of thing they can do in this desperate situation after 3+ years training off screen on Etheria. I did repeatedly mention how the Enclave was helping them improve and how that had a direct, negative impact on Adora (who wasn't improving alongside them)
>
> Add to that the fact I needed the chapter to end with things getting *even worse* despite achieving a tiny victory with Glimmer's plan, and the outline->rough-draft->several edits pipeline of this chapter over the years has been a lot.

I'm really proud of it, at the end of the day :) When I came back to proofread this, I didn't need to make nearly as many tweaks as I thought I would, and actually got to just read and enjoy some of the sequences, myself.

(Don't ask about Netossa and Spinnerella...In my head, they're helping somewhere probably deep in the city. From a candid author perspective, I just didn't feel right about any of my attempts explicitly incorporating them, and the scene always read stronger when I took them out. We're already dangerously close and arguably over the line already with character oversaturation, but I did try to find a place for them, promise)

Also, Lonnie and Glimmer's dynamic (one being by the books and taking their role seriously while the other is a maverick that does whatever the fuck she feels like, causing the other a lot of stress) appeared very organically. I didn't go into writing them this way, it just sorta happened. It's grown on me over time :D

Last chapter was most impactful for Catra, this chapter is obviously more geared toward Glimmer--I'll leave who gets the lion's share of next week's chapter up for guessing ;)

# Rise, She Ra!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora's healing factor struggled to keep up. Despite every effort, she hadn't landed a single blow on her Trooper, every attempt ending with her forced to parry or pull away. She'd been lucky so far, coming away with nothing worse than minor gashes she could address through magical means when amputation or worse were far more likely outcomes.

Could she regrow a limb? Or a body, should her head come away? She preferred not to test the limits of her healing.

And despite her efforts, she'd barely distracted the Trooper either. Taline's shield was falling apart under its onslaught, Pip still working frantically inside. She was on her hands and knees in pain, but somehow still maintaining a barrier so textured with cracks and fractures it was a wonder it still held up at all.

Corynth worked circles around them, felling all but one, but not even Catra could come away unscathed. She danced and flipped around her Trooper, nicking it here and there, slashing her claws against exposed parts that quickly healed. She'd repeatedly tried to get above and behind to attack the back of its neck, but couldn't ever quite manage it. And after a while, she started to flag.

Adora's growing concern about how much longer either of them would be able to hold out came to a screeching halt when a beam of thick, red energy punched a second hole through the ceiling. It traced a line from a point on Archanas' massive leering curve above and ended inches from Corynth's outstretched palm. Writhing and reaching like a living creature, it strained against some inconceivable force he'd thrown up to trap it midair.

The thralls surrounding them dropped to the floor, convulsing, and the three remaining Troopers—Catra's, Adora's and the one Corynth hadn't yet subdued—grasped their heads with bladed limbs. They thrashed, the pain born from Corynth's defiance of their master driving them mad as the full weight of the Beast pushed down on him, trying to drive him into the floor. The metal tiling crimped under his boots when he refused to give.

Pip shouted his name from her perch atop the dais. She'd stopped working away at the consoles surrounding her, frozen in fear for him.

The beam reacted again, and Adora started to get the sense it really was a living creature. It pushed on Corynth harder, and this time he pushed back, sending a shockwave rippling out from where they stood in deadlock. Adora planted her feet and braced, while Catra dug all four sets of her claws into the floor, cracking the tiling to hold tight. The remaining Troopers pulled themselves out of their reeling and turned on him, their movements still jerky and erratic. They were fighting their pain.

When they attacked, Corynth gave a lazy wave of his hand. Another sickening burst of magic washed over Adora, threatening to make her double over with nausea, and all three Troopers exploded into viscera that painted the floor.

He turned his attention to Adora. Still holding back the beam, Corynth reached with his free hand—the one that he'd just taken three Troopers out with—as if to grab for her. Adora flinched, before her feet lifted off the ground and she sped halfway across the room to him, stopping within reaching distance. She couldn't see his face through the mask, couldn't read his eyes through its opaque lenses, but she knew what he was telling her, anyways.

Catra called out to her, but she couldn't register it. Her spirits had already plummeted to such depths, she couldn't focus on anything except Corynth in front of her. On anything except her failure, thrust once more in her face.

Of course this would happen. She'd felt so empowered moments ago, fighting alongside Catra, but…why did she think for even a second that would change how things played out? How could she have thought any different, after what she'd been told at the war room? After what she'd failed to achieve all these years training?

Corynth reached for the sword and Adora pulled it away. "No," she said, holding it close to her chest. She was still suspended in the air, and would have no real leverage to stop him if he tried again. Her voice had gone thin and pleading, the tears welling in her eyes making everything go blurry. "Don't. Please don't."

"I'm sorry, Adora." Corynth's voice sounded mournful despite the mask's modulation. His fingers curled next to Adora's around the hilt of the sword, ignoring her pitiful kicks in the air trying to get away from him as he pried it from her hands.

He was too strong—and she, too weak—to stop him.

"Please, just—just let me try!" she said. Her fingers refused to hold fast to the sword no matter how she tried. Little by little, she lost her grip. Tears streamed relentlessly down her cheeks. Where had all her confidence from earlier gone? Moments ago, she'd been on top of the world. "Stop. Stop! I can do it. I *swear* I can do it, just—"

The lenses in Corynth's mask retracted, and Adora's words died in her mouth when she met his eyes. They were clouded, stained black and threaded with red. Despite the apparent sickness, it was the first time Adora both saw and felt seen by him since he put on the mask. Not even a handful of hours had passed, but Phoenix Station seemed like ages ago, already.

She didn't realize she'd let go of the sword until he was already far away, and Catra was wrapping her arms around her from behind, both of them safe behind Taline's shield. He'd sent her away and she hadn't noticed.

“Protect them,” Corynth said, holding her sword in his free hand. His voice was somehow clear despite his distance—despite the noise of the energy beam he was still holding back and the screeching of the thralls still frothing at the mouth and seizing on the ground. Adora wasn’t sure who he was talking to until Taline, eyes lit and starlight tears cutting pathways through the dirt on her cheeks, spoke.

“I will,” she said, pushing for more magic until she glowed an even more brilliant shade than be fore, and the cracks and holes in her shield started to patch together. “Nothing will get through me.”

Corynth gave her a stiff, single nod, then turned all the way around to face up at the hole in the ceiling—at Archanas and the source of the energy beam he was still (still!) holding at bay. With an aggressive sweep of his hand, he hurled the beam off to the side, deflecting it at a sharp angle against his palm where it impacted the far side of the sanctum.

As soon as it struck stone, the beam snuffed out, leaving nothing but stillness and silence behind. Then the entire room—the walls, the ceiling, everything except the floor upon which Adora, Catra, and Taline stood upon behind the shield—exploded out. The rubble disappeared behind the dense fog that had still lingered at the edges of the room. And with that room’s disappearance, all that surrounded them now was that fog.

It engulfed them. Catra held tighter to Adora like she was an anchor, her nails inadvertently digging into her body. Goosebumps erupted across Adora’s skin. She felt even more exposed to the Beast this high up in the Crystal Castle with no walls.

It was like they were deep in an endless blue ocean, unable to see neither the ocean floor nor the sparkling light of the sun hitting the surface above them.

A presence made itself known within the depths—a malicious entity that filled nostrils and flooded ears. It invaded and touched,

lathing and sliding across every plane of Adora's body like the ocean water itself. It was familiar, somehow. Like she'd glimpsed it in a dream. Or a nightmare.

*It showed me all the worlds it had taken, all the suns it had devoured.* Adora recalled the words she'd used not too long ago to describe that nightmare to Angella. She could scarcely breath now, just like back then. *There were so many of them…so many dead people I couldn't save, just…just looking at me!*

A thousand eyes watched her from the foggy, shadowy depths. There was no Etheria anymore. One moment there was the ocean, and the next she'd be between galaxies in the uncharted reaches of space. After that, she'd find herself standing on a platform that stretched endlessly in every direction. A never ended flatland with no horizon.

No matter where she was and no matter what her surroundings changed to, Archanas was always there in the sky. It was even closer than when it had eclipsed Etheria's sun. A great eye wreathed in a corona of inky black tendrils, staring at her.

Staring into her.

Seeing.

*Rudimentary Creatures. Microscopic Pests, Scuttling Across Your Cold Rocks, Spinning Mindless And Ignorant Among The Stars*

Reality quivered as the Beast spoke. Its voice was everything—the chorus of a trillion dead souls with sutured mouths, the grinding of mountains and glaciers across tectonic plate given vowel and syllable and fricative. The decay of empires given voice.

"This ends here." Corynth's voice stood as a lone counterpoint. Adora couldn't see him, but just like the Beast, he too was everywhere. "It's been a long road for the both of us. Let's stop for a rest, shall we?"

His voice brought other things back into focus for Adora. She became aware of Catra once more, standing with her, holding her. Taline was there too, every muscle taught as she protected them from the impenetrable fog outside her shield. And Pip was still behind them, staring imperiously at the Beast among her projected work screens.

Some semblance of 'reality' came back to her, then. She could see all four of them in the swirling eye of the Beast's reality-bending aura. Could finally move her own body, again. Flex her own fingers.

*The Years We Endured Your Primitive, Fumbling Experiments Are But A Flicker-Flame Atop Our Candle Of Living Memory.* The fog around Taline's barrier shifted, giving a vague, whispy outline of a gargantuan creature. It shifted, circling Corynth like it was playing with him, standing out there beyond Taline's magic.

It was at once both a planet hundreds of thousands of miles away, somewhere above Etheria's surface, and also some interdimensional, eldritch *thing,* floating beside and between them.

*You Are One Shaper, At The End Of Your Individuality And On The Brink Of Our Joining. Those You Once Had By Your Side Are Gone. Those With You Now Pose No Help.*

The thousand eyes in the fog looked to Adora. Pressure built in her head, growing until unbearable depths of pain forced her to her knees. Catra was saying something she couldn't hear through the white-noise in her head. The Beast had singled her out, invading her mind, scraping through every layer of her until she laid bare before it.

*Not Even This Failed Deity Of Power Can Help You Stop What Is To Come. Just As She Begged And Pleaded Only To Fail, So Too Shall You.*

Corynth, still holding the sword, twirled it in his hands and stabbed it into the ground. It shimmered, morphing into a staff two heads taller than he was. The Beast seemed to take it as a provocation. Some of the eyes from its thousand-eye stare shifted from Adora back to him, lifting some of the pressure squeezing her and allowing her to breathe again. The fog shifted again; a hideous maw opened across the center of its gargantuan form.

It lunged, intent on swallowing him.

A soft-edged bubble of magic erupted from the tip of the staff. The Beast slammed into it, then reeled back screeching, and allowing Adora to get a glimpse of its true form. Wispy, plasmic tendrils wreathed its body, wrapping all around them like some bio-organic cage. All of them turning spastic like a gigawatt current had been run through it. And in their indiscriminate flailing-about, several struck Taline's shield sending fresh cracks through the filament where she'd previously restored them.

"I told you back on Eden that the people of this galaxy shall have generations," Corynth said. His voice was like a chorus, echoing hundreds strong against the void now closing in on them in the Beast's agitated state. "I told you I would not allow you to take that from them. He pulled the staff out of the ground and twirled it in his hand. "I intend to keep that promise."

He thrust the staff high in the air The bubble of magic spinning on the staff's edge burst out, pushing the Beast and its encroaching tendrils back as dozens of runes began to etch themselves in the air around him and spin.

---

Glimmer thought she'd already learned why official Enclave and Imperial doctrine demanded full retreat once Beast Troopers were spotted on the battlefield. Taline had originally warned her of this. She'd thought facing down that lone one on Scavria trying to rescue her team had been lesson enough.

She was wrong.

After that red beam traced across the sky and disappeared, the thralls pushing their position dropped to the ground, convulsing and frothing at the mouth next to those the alliance had put down by force, already laying still. And from there, the Troopers stepped up to engage. Except, these weren't like the sterile, impossible to read killing machine Glimmer had faced before. These seemed feral. Just as mindless as all the thralls she'd faced, before Scavria and now Archanas had branded them with its strange mutation of intelligence, but easily a hundred times more potent.

And even more had pulled themselves from shadowed obelisks. Now, twenty-some-odd feral Beast Troopers had rendered every kingdom soldier, every Etherian sorcerer and Enclave Battlemage, and every princess impotent. Vasher's team had downed one, somehow, partnering with Frosta and Mermista. But that wasn't much considering the hundreds already the other Troopers had culled from the Alliance's own roster.

They couldn't even get a foothold strong enough to push some of them back, let alone go on the offensive.

"On your left!" someone shouted in between Glimmer firing a bolt. She flinched to the side, thinking the words were a warning to her, only to watch some poor Enclave mage get ripped in half by a Trooper that had jumped through his own team's protective formation.

Their defensive line had fallen within moments, everyone left scattered around the bridge under Salas' protective spell keeping the Beast's essence from corrupting them. Glimmer had no idea how he kept it going.

Perfuma and Scorpia were to her distnt left, shooting overloaded magic attacks without break alongside their soldiers. More sorcerers flanked them, and those sorcerers were guarded by still dozens more—a mix of Plumerian soldiers, Scorpion Kingdom attack bots, and Enclave commandos. Thankfully, Perfuma had managed to encase her and Scorpia's battle group in a weave of

vines dense enough the roughly six Troopers confronting them were still hacking away to get through.

"Watch out!"

This one was for Glimmer, she realized, as Lonnie tackled her sideways. A swipe from another Trooper passed overhead inches from her nose—a strike that would have cleaved her in two had she not been taken to the ground. Lonnie rolled to a crouch, unloading an entire clip from her rifle into the Trooper's throat while it whaled at the shield Glimmer had thrown up the instant she'd gotten to her own feet.

"It heals too fast!" Lonnie said, ejecting her clip. "Even this close, I can't shoot through to the back of its neck."

Glimmer flagged under the nonstop blows the Trooper was inflicting on her shield. Even pulling directly from the Moonstone wasn't helping, seeing as her body unconsciously fought her from taking more to avoid doing irrevocable damage.

The Trooper continued hacking away, brutal, single-minded, and vocalizing something on the cusp between ecstasy and suffering. It was like something had driven the thing insane.

Cracks threaded through the shield, and Glimmer whimpered, shying away from the blows.

"*Shit*," Lonnie said, fumbling with shaking fingers as she jammed another magazine—her last—into the well of her rifle. "Hold on. I'll try and distract it long enough for you to—"

The Trooper flew sideways as Rogelio crashed into it like he was ramming a door with his shoulder. At the moment of impact, he dug the claws of his one good arm into the viscous matter that made up the Trooper's body, trying to knock it off balance. Instead, it remained upright, both its talon-ed feed digging trenches into the cobblestone of the bridge as it slid a handful of feet. It dug into the ground, then raised one of its bladed arms, poised to cut him down.

Images of Rogelio being diced to ribbons flashed in Glimmer's head. She gasped, trying to look away. She didn't want to watch him die like she had that other Enclave Mage, the one who had gotten ripped apart, earlier.

Another figure appeared next to Rogelio, thrusting a bony plated arm up to protect both their heads. Trayn grunted in pain as the Trooper swung down and embedded its blade in his arm. Purple blood ran free down to his shoulder, dripping to the cobblestone before he lunged forward, hugging the Trooper with his other arm, same as Rogelio. And in the split second they both held it still, Keren darted behind, severing the Trooper's head from its body with a well-placed blast from her shotgun, the barrel of which she'd pressed against the back of its neck.

Glimmer let the shield fall. She collapsed sideways to the ground, her chest heaving, rasps tearing from her throat with every breath. The world was spinning as the others joined Lonnie at her side. All of them went in and out of focus as they shouted something at her she couldn't make out.

Her friends were dying. Despite her delirium, she could tell that much. Frosta and Mermista had gotten separated from Vasher and their auxiliary troops. Both of them were cornered. Perfuma's defenses were beginning to fall as the Troopers cut through her vines faster than she could replace them. Vasher and his men couldn't regroup with either of them help, and even Salas had lost half his Sentinels within a matter of minutes, already.

Glimmer didn't have the strength to stand again, no matter what her team did to try and make it happen. She pulled her legs to her chest in a feeble fetal position and looked up to the sky, wanting to see something other than their complete failure on the battlefield.

Archanas was there, a red eye staring back at her through the fog.

She couldn’t even see the fleet in space, or whatever Warbirds remained fighting the Beast’s interceptors. Perhaps there were none left. Maybe Hordak had fallen, already. Maybe even Lysithea and Kyle. Maybe even Bow.

Even the sun was gone. All that was left was Archanas.

New shapes began to form in the fog. Large and monolithic and curving up as if to wrap the globe of the sky, they were obelisks that towered over and everyone on the surface. They reminded her of the skyscrapers on core Heartland worlds, twisted in on themselves like gnarled tree branches.

And among those obelisks shot countless bright white whisps of… something. Something Glimmer couldn’t describe except to say, by instinct, that it was something antithetical to the Beast, like a rebuttal of the malice staining her mind. They shot into the sky like reverse comets, tracing a rough arc toward the same direction the Beast’s earlier beam had shot.

And when Glimmer turned her head to trace where those whisps originated from, what she saw only made her more confused.

The thralls that had fallen earlier, convulsing, had stilled as the whisps lifted from their bodies. And their faces…those grotesque, twisted caricatures of the Scavrians she’d helped save? They looked almost peaceful

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Adora had seen countless Enclave mages teach dozens of new runes to the sorcerers of Mystacor. She’d even watched Micah and Salas swap diagrams between one another with smiles and kind words, each containing a rune far more complex than even the advanced spells the princesses would practice.

She’d never seen any as complicated as what Corynth had drawn.

Dozens of runes so complex they looked like solid blocks of neon spun around him in a loose, multi-pointed, geometric dome. Even Micah and Salas had drawn runes one at a time, but these swirling

Corynth appeared all at once. The faster they spun, the angrier the Beast seemed to grow, the more the multitude of eyes turned from her to him, and the more the pressure in Adora's head lessened.

The Beast's screeched and warbled, its tendrils slamming again on Taline's shield in protest of whatever Corynth was doing to it. The shield held, but the sound Taline made fighting to keep it up made Adora think of someone slowly having the life squeezed out of them, crushed under a boulder. On instinct, she reached for her again.

"Don't touch her," Catra said, concern making her voice shake as she grabbed both Adora's hands held them away. "You'll burn yourself. She's running way too hot."

New forms appeared in the fog. Tall, dark, building-sized things that solidified into featureless, monoliths leaning over them. At first, Adora feared they were a new evolution of the Beast pushing on them. She didn't think Taline or even Corynth could take much more.

Then those forms clarified, resolving into solid skyscrapers, their appearance exploding the Beast's fog all the way out until it was city blocks away. Rays of golden sunlight pierced from the clouds of a new, heavenly sky, threading between the skyscrapers and revealing this new scene in full.

"Wha--?" Catra took a step back, a stunned expression on her face. "Where the hell are we?"

Adora, however, recognized it.

*Look familiar?* she remembered Taline asking, after having manifested the same scene to Corynth on Phoenix. *The courtyard outside the Imperial Judiciary.*

They were back on that skyscraper terrace, somewhere far away in the Imperial Heartlands, deep in a core world at the administrative center of the galaxy.

Adora marveled at the change, just like she had the first time. Taline had pushed herself beyond her limits to embody this place, nearly succumbing to the strain of the Beast infecting her in the process, but Corynth? He made it look easy. And something about this difference told Adora this time was different than when Taline had tried it. This time, something was missing.

Catra took another step back, nearly stepping out of Adora's grasp altogether. "They're back," she said eyes darting around the room with a flinty edge to her voice. Adora followed her gaze, and in the next moment, realized what was missing from the scene.

Ghostly figures began to appear, some manifesting among the plants and trees and benches of the terrace, others standing vigil atop balconies and inside skyscraper windows. This had happened before when it was Taline orchestrating the shift. And at first, Adora thought it was those same ghosts, running around, replaying the moments of Corynth and Taline's first battle before the end of the war like marionette puppets repeating history.

But these figures weren't pantomiming a fight. They were standing stock still in a way that made Adora feel watched and sent a shiver of unease down her spine. And after a moment scrutinizing them, she thought she figured out why: Despite the lack of clear features on their forms, they seemed as if they could see them through whatever thin veil separated them in the past from her and the others in the present.

The Beast was about to deploy more thralls and Troopers, Adora realized with horror. There was no other explanation for this difference—the Beast really did have more tricks up its sleeve for them. Taline was barely holding on as it was. At this rate, they wouldn't last.

Except, those figures didn't solidify into thralls or Troopers. After a moment of abject terror where Adora waited for the worst, they instead solidified into people.

Hundreds surrounded them now, none of which had any of the typical markings of a thrall or the obvious mutation of a Trooper. In fact, their only discernable characteristic helped Adora identify them immediately. Each wore a mask, similar to Corynth's own but with their own unique designs. Suddenly, all of Corynth's pedantic musings on Phoenix about necromancy and…how did he put it? That what he did was an entirely different school of practice, although the similarities were there?

Adora shook her head. Part of her still believed he'd only been exaggerating, or pulling her leg to get a reaction. But his? She'd never expected to see this. There was no other way to look at it.

Corynth had resurrected the Daiamid.

"Thralls aren't the only thing," Catra said, her voice a murmur full of awe. She turned to Adora, fixing her with wide, elated eyes. "Back on Archanas before we hit the elevator down. He said thralls weren't the only thing hiding in the depths of time. That the Beast wasn't the only thing that could call them forth."

"My people helped stop you once already," Corynth said his voices booming against the inconsolable tantrum the Beast was now throwing. "And if they are needed once more to finish what we started, they would gladly traverse all the realms of undeath to stand by my side once more."

The Beast roared and thrashed in fresh protest. A terrifying sound, it seemed to echo down from the cloudy, golden sky itself, reverberating between the skyscrapers. This time, Adora thought she might have heard a tinge of fear in its wailings, too.

Its tendrils renewed their attack on Taline's barrier. Cracks deepened and spread across its surface, multiplying faster than she could patch them. Catra watched her with naked concern, and Adora wished desperately she could do something to help. Despite Corynth's display, she had no misgivings about what would happen should Taline's shield fail them.

One of the tendrils finally pierced a hole in the shield. Taline, face pressed into the floor hard enough it would leave a mark, couldn't get it closed again, and the fog of the Beast's essence slid around Corynth and his projection like river water around a stone, seeping in. He wasn't just shifting their surroundings in his face off against the enemy, Adora realized, as every shallow breath she took singed her lungs. The very air outside was so concentrated with their warring spirits, it was mortally toxic.

Catra and Adora screamed, fingers tearing at their skin and hair as the Beast tore at their psyche. And just as quickly as the torture had come, it receded, relief riding on the back a new person speaking.

"Need some help?" said a voice, speaking as clear as running creek water.

Delirious from frayed nerves, Adora thought Taline had found the strength to repair the shield herself, at first. But that wasn't the case. The shield was still broken, and the Beast's essence was still seeping in. It just…wasn't affecting them anymore. Adora had no idea how that was possible until she looked over.

Evelyn was kneeling with them, whole and corporeal and glowing with magic. She wore a radiant smile that put not just Adora at ease, but Catra, too, judging by how the tension in her shoulders relaxed.

Taline looked at her in utter shock, any hint of pain from her exertion long gone. "How…how are you…?" She couldn't get the words out, and Evelyn merely laughed as she continued to mouth at her like a fish.

"It is a jarring change, isn't it?" she asked. "Considering I couldn't even draw working runes the last we saw one another, this must come as a surprise."

Adora had a hunch it was the fact Evelyn was there in person and not as a hologram that was more of a surprise to Taline. It was

certainly a great surprise to her.

Evelyn reached a dainty hand out, and the moment her fingertips touched the barrier, it doubled in size. The hole in the shield disappeared with it, the cracks spiderwebbing around the rest of the filament sealing and growing twice as vibrant.

"My experiments did more than just postpone the galaxy's destruction," Evelyn said, speaking as though this was common knowledge. "Make direct contact with the Beast a few hundred times like I did, and even a snail would learn how to cast magic."

Taline gaped at her, still unable to find words, and Evelyn rose to her feet.

"Alright, boys!" she said, enunciating her voice enough it reached even those Shapers standing on distant balconies. "Are you ready to finish what we started?"

"Sir, yes sir!" Every Shaper chorused together, shouting in perfect unison. If Corynth's voice sounded like a hundreds-strong chorus, then the hundreds of Shapers sounded like an army of thousands speaking as one. Their voices rattled Adora's bones, making something deep in her chest thrum with hope.

*Gods and Goddesses above*, Adora thought, as they clapped their hands together and pulled them apart, magic flaring between their palms. *Salas' assistants! All of the work he does to coordinate with them…he was inspired by this!*

The Daiamid threw their hands forward like they were each lassoing a feral beast. Brilliant orange-hued ropes of magic flew forward, latching onto the Beast still hidden in the depths of the fog spread between the skyscrapers. Those ropes pierced rather than wrapped its twisting form, lighting it up and dispelling the last of its aura it was using to mask itself.

With nothing left to hide behind, the Beast's true form—its avatar in this semi-corporeal reality anchored to Etheria—lay naked and bare for all to see. It was gargantuan. A titanic creature easily the

size of Hordak's flagship in orbit. Fins and multi-articulated appendages sprouted at odd angles from its mish-mash, slug-like body, like it had been grafted there at random by someone with poor hand eye coordination. A great mouth split its bulk down the middle just as Adora imagined while it was still obscured by the fog, and its thousand eyes dotted its bulk in similarly random spots, all of them swirling in terror at the hundreds of shapers tying it down.

"Your Troopers are gone," Corynth said, twirling the staff above his head. "Your thralls, I take them!" He slammed the staff down into the ground again, and another rune sprouted, this time at the point where the staff touched the ground.

It appeared fully formed and enormous from the outset, stretching past where Adora, Catra, Evelyn, Taline, and Pip were hunkering down, its ley lines as thick as Adora was tall. If Glimmer suddenly poofed there to tell them it stretched all the way to Bright Moon, she wouldn't have been surprised.

With the rune came a shower of comets streaking across the sky. At least, Adora thought they would streak across. Instead, they changed course at the zenith of their arcs, shooting at a ninety-degree angle toward them on the surface. And when they impacted, they didn't leave behind rumbling craters that destroyed their surroundings.

They left behind more figures. Thousands of new ghosts, white and wispy in form, appeared with the Daiamid Shapers. Some stood on the rune inlaid into the terrace, others stood on the surrounding balconies. More still floated as if on invisible platforms in the air. The open terrace was suddenly so density with people, Adora could barely make out the Beast Corynth continued to face down ahead of her.

Pulled from their corporeal bodies and enthralled no longer, Adora saw what these Scavrians Glimmer had fought to protect finally looked like. They simply joined the Daiamid in thrusting their palm

out, and countless magic spears shot from their hands to pierce the Beast and help better hold it in place.

The Beast seemed to sense it had been lured into a trap and cornered. It yanked and pulled with more urgency, but didn't win any purchase for itself. Scavrian and Shaper alike gave no quarter.

An entire religion had sprung up around Corynth, she mused. A hero cult. The Vestamid had regarded him as a deity, and Adora remembered thinking it silly after learning his identity. The rumpled, disheveled, irritating vagabond she'd traveled with, revered like a god?

Seeing this much power on display, however, made her wonder how she could have been so naïve as to ever have doubted it. There was enough magic coursing here to anchor that which consumed planets—enough to hold even the World Eater captive. All of it orchestrated by someone more than willing to die by the Heart's hand to at last kill Beast in her stead.

So many emotions flooded her at once. On top of the varying levels of existential dread that had been a constant all these years and especially ramped up since teleporting to Archanas, it was overwhelming. And then, when Catra peeled her eyes away from the spectacle to look at her—her!—none of it mattered anymore. Not with the look Catra was giving her. It was like the floor giving foundation to all of those worries fell away, plunging her into something deeper, something more visceral and impactful than fear and shame.

Catra's eyes reflected all of the awe and wonder she felt looking at such a brazenly amazing display of magic. Except Catra was looking at her like that—at Adora. And through that look Adora felt like she could almost feel that same sense of awe for herself.

"Doesn't this remind you of Thaymor all over again?" Catra asked her.

Adora's mouth had gone dry trying to figure out why she was looking at her like that. "What?" she asked. "How?"

Catra gave her a smile that looked almost shy. "Seeing you transform the first time felt kind of like this. As much as I hated it, it also felt…I don't know. Magical. Awe-inspiring. And despite how much I wished it hadn't, it continued to feel like that every time you transformed, too." She laughed, and despite everything happening, the sound of it made Adora feel like she'd come home. "You know, that probably fed into my frustration with the whole thing. I hated how I couldn't take my eyes off you, even though every time you transformed you also always wrecked my shit."

Adora would have laughed if the timing wasn't so horrendous. Catra finally admitting she liked her transformations, but only after it was too late? She averted her eyes, chewing her bottom lip as she fought the doubt creeping in. "You know I can't transform anymore."

To her surprise, Catra seemed wholly unphased by the admission. "Do I?" she asked. "Why not? Because you had some stupid vision where she told you she was wrong about you?"

That didn't make any sense. Because, yeah? Why was Catra saying that as if Adora was the crazy one for doubting herself? Anyone would after something like that.

Catra must have caught the look on her face because she shook her head, cutting her off before she could speak. "You stood up to Corynth himself when you thought he was an enemy and you had no idea what he was capable of. You faced down that Abomination on Eden to save that Lysithea woman and everyone else on that station. You even stood up to Taline! Why did you do that?"

Adora frowned, first out of confusion—because how did she know these things?—and then out of a real inability to answer the question. She opened her mouth to try, only to shut it again with a click.

"Because you thought it was wrong she and Corynth were fighting!" Catra said, before she could try again.

Despite Adora's knee-jerk reaction to argue, she couldn't. Catra wasn't wrong about what she did while adventuring with Corynth and she wasn't wrong about why she took the arguably stupid route of standing up to Taline mid-fight. Part of her wanted to argue none of that made any difference, but the look Catra was giving her—that look of pure confidence in her opinion—stopped her.

If Catra was arguing this hard for her, there must be some merit to it, right?

Catra gave another sharp bark of a laugh and said, "Hell, you gave up a girl you were in love with just because you thought it was the right thing to do." She placed a hand on Adora's shoulder and turned her so she could again look at their surroundings. Corynth, his Daiamid, and the Scavrians continued to pin the Beast down ahead of them.

"If I'm reading this right," Catra said as Adora took in the sight with fresh eyes, "then all these people pushed literally across the threshold of death to answer Corynth's call, solely to help him fight the Beast. Stepping up simply because they *could.* Just like you have countless, *countless* times, already.

"And if you were in their position? If you'd died and had the opportunity to come back to put that thing in its place? You'd be standing right there with them, fighting, just like you always have."

Catra looked Adora in the face again, her eyes so full of conviction in what she was saying it made Adora's heart race.

"She Ra didn't tell you that you aren't worthy, and she wasn't the one saying she thought you were the wrong choice. *You* told yourself that, Adora. You've probably been telling yourself that for years, ever since you failed to take Horde Prime."

“Catra—”

“You *are* She Ra,” Catra said, speaking over her and holding her by the shoulders with strong, grounding hands. It was almost like she was trying to squeeze sense into her by force. “You always have been, even back when I wished and prayed and screamed and did everything I possibly could to prove that you weren’t. That you were just Adora.” A pause and another squeeze. “My Adora.”

The words themselves were serious, but Catra spoke them with a widening smile and a progressively shimmering look of conviction, like she’d said a fact so true the mere sharing of it released any fear of possible impending death.

She was beautiful. Adora had always known that, had always thought that, but now it was all she could think of. And with that thought, came release. Release from pain, release from shame. Release for her, too, from the fear of impending death.

The battle continued around them, magic popping and bursting like fireworks that reflected in Catra’s eyes, Evelyn coaxing Taline through increasingly complex defenses as the Beast’s untethered tendrils continued to assault their combined shield, trying to get at Pip still working away at awakening the Heart. At that moment, nothing mattered to Adora. Nothing except her. Nothing except how strong Catra believed wholeheartedly in her.

The trance broke when Corynth turned around to face them again. Adora’s stomach plummeted when she realized what was coming.

Catra’s own look of serenity faded seeing this. “What’s he doing?” she asked, when Corynth reached inside his robes and pulled out something obscured in his fist.

The Beast continued to struggle, pinned down. It seemed no longer capable of speaking. Where had all of its boasting gone? Now it looked more like some pathetic, amorphous animal than an

all-powerful world eating hive mind that brought the galaxy to its knees a decade before and threatened to do so again.

"Tal." Corynth's voice traveled across the terrace to them. No longer a chorus, it was just one—just his voice. He opened his hand to reveal a thin, blood-red crystal, sitting on his palm. "It's time."

Like the terrace, that apeiron looked familiar to Adora, too. And she remembered where she'd last seen it. Ly had found a fragment of the Beast trapped inside the Eye of Shukra and pulled it into its own, separate container to help purify the Eye. *You're probably the best person to safekeep this sort of thing*, she'd said at the time, handing it over to Corynth before escaping Eden.

Taline—looking significantly better than she had earlier thanks to her sister's help—shied away at the sight of it. "No," she said, swallowing past an obvious lump in her throat. "Don't ask this of me. I…I can't."

Corynth shook his head, voice coming through more urgent. "We don't have *time*. Not even all of us together can contain it long enough to matter, and I don't have enough in me to subjugate it without this." He held up the crystal so it glinted in the red of the moon.

As if to herald the truth of his words, the Beast gave a mighty lurch against its restraints, shattering several of the magic beams piercing it. A guttural screaming echoed around down the hallway of skyscrapers.

Corynth released the staff, leaving it to stand on its own again as he turned. With his back fully to the Beast and, instead, facing them, he pulled his mask off. Adora gasped when she saw the markings of the Beast's poison spread across his face, damaging his features in a way that echoed Shadow Weaver's own disfigurement. Even Catra next to her sucked in a sharp breath.

Taline's expression was more nuanced. She seemed at a loss for words, but not because of his face. If Adora had to guess, she seemed intimidated by the very gesture of his removing his mask.

This compounded when the other Shapers followed suit. One by one, they too removed their masks, revealing determined, respectful faces. None of them bore Corynth's scars. Some were even smiling.

*You know, in my culture, those masks were a symbol of your true self*, he'd said to Adora before. *An enemy removing it in battle was a symbol of defeat. Removing it yourself was a sign you saw them as an equal.*

He and all the other Shapers, the very people Taline had once rejected and fought against, were acknowledging her as a peer.

"We talked about this," Corynth said to Taline. Then, softer: "It's time to let me go. I need to know you will be okay, before I go. Please."

Evelyn squeezed her sister's shoulder. Taline squeezed her eyes shut, her entire body tensing before denial sloughed from her features. Resigned, she pressed her lips into a thin line, then pointed at the apeiron with the one hand she'd released from the shield.

A spark jumped from the tip of that finger across the room. Cracks warped the apeiron when it struck home before a glob of black viscera exploded from it, flooding the room. It attached like a millipede encircling its young to both Corynth and the Beast, binding them together before beginning to swallow.

All at once, the terrace, the Shapers, the Scavrians, all of it blinked out of existence. They were again back on Etheria, high up in the Crystal Castle's ruined inner sanctum, the Whispering Woods smoldering for miles around.

Corynth's mask clattered to the ground, forgotten as his body took on this overwhelming new infection. It encased both him and the

thrashing, squealing Beast until one couldn’t be told apart from the other. And in the moments before all trace of Corynth the individual succumbed, he looked Adora in the eyes, brought his hand up in a comically flippant salute, and smiled.

Then he was gone, the infection having subsumed them both. And although this new, merged form of the Beast was free of the chains that had bound it after those Corynth had summoned returned to where they came, it now had to contend with this new threat—an Abomination born from Corynth himself, fighting its other, Archanan half for control. And that other half seemed to be losing.

Taline snuffed out her shield, only to weave a new one. Her arms worked in quick, striking patterns, and another cage sprang up, this time around the Corynth/Archanan hybrid. The convulsing mass of tendrils and viscera and gore expanded to fill its enclosure, and Taline struggled, pushing herself once more to keep the thing contained.

To her surprise, Evelyn was still there, mirroring her movements. Helping.

“You’re still here?” Taline asked, uncertainty accompanying the strain in her voice. “The spell is finished. How can you remain while everyone else has gone?”

Evelyn smirked, but the rest of her face was marked by hard lines of concentration. "After how long it's been since I'd last seen you in person? There's no way I'm leaving my older sister behind before I see this through to the end.”

Evelyn’s eyes flared with starlight as if to demonstrate her resolve, and the shield trapping the warring Beast factions pulsed with added luminescence. Wasting no time, she regarded Pip over her shoulder, still surrounded by holographic terminals near the dais at the center of the room.

"Expose the Heart," she said. "Corynth is not the true catalyst, so wait until he has fully subjugated his other half before firing it at him. We don't want the Archanan strain to be in control of the pairing when it hits."

Pip nodded wordlessly. Her tapping at the surrounding consoles stopped all of a sudden, and the dais opened, revealing a bright core of energy swirled within. The Heart of Etheria, finally awake.

"Shit," Catra said, muttering the words under her breath. She faced Adora again. "This is it, isn't it? The end of the Beast for good? The final end of the war?"

They'd only been out of Despondos for little more than three years, but the war against the Beast had ravaged the wider galaxy for over a decade, now.

Adora looked to the Beast—this final incarnation of it—across the room, still contained. She glanced to Taline and Evelyn, sisters reunited once more for however brief a period to finally end this terrible period of galactic history. Pip, herself a mirror image of Evelyn but without any of the determined concentration on her face, seemed at a loss for what to do now that her job was done. She shifted on hologram feet, wringing her hands. Nervous.

Everyone, even those long dead, had come here to make this happen. And Adora herself? She…she…

*He acknowledged you, too, you know.*

Another new voice in her head interrupted her thoughts. This one sounded eerily like the She Ra of her nightmares, speaking to her from the reservoir of power bubbling deep inside.

*You are She Ra*. Catra's words, spoken with Catra's voice. And in that moment, that clarifying moment where everything seemed to stand still and finally connect, Adora realized Catra was right. The voice wasn't some separate entity judging her every thought and action.

It was her. *Just* her.

More came, then. A deluge of realizations that flooded her mind the moment the first crack formed. Catra hadn't just been right about her powers. She was also right about Adora's place in this conflict, too.

Corynth wasn't humoring her during their time together. Back when they fought, when she fell…he could have left her. She could have woken up safe on Etheria's surface with him having already long escaped. There wouldn't have been anything she could have done about it.

Instead, he'd brought her along. Opened up about his true identity when he could no longer hide it. He could have shut her out, but…he hadn't.

He'd saluted her before he'd gone just now, too. And even if he'd done it in his typical, goofy, flippant way, his acknowledgement of her was done in the same breath as removing his mask to request one last kindness, as equals, from Taline.

*He acknowledged you, too,* said the voice in her head, again. Her voice.

For the love of Etheria, how had she missed all of this?

"Pip," she said, whirling on her with new, ironclad resolve. "Give me the Heart."

Pip startled. Something in the way she looked at her told Adora she wanted to say yes. Instead, she shook her head. "I can't."

Adora snarled, more out of frustration over the delay rather than out of any true anger over the refusal. She shot her hand out past a smiling Catra, and the staff, still standing upright on its own before the Beast, zoomed across the room to her. By the time it hit her hand, it had transformed back into a sword. Adora stood, giving it a flourish, testing its weight.

“I refuse to let anyone take my place, not when this is my duty to fulfill. It was my mistake, thinking any plan anyone else pushed was even an option.”

She reached for her power then, more as an afterthought to make her point rather than out of any need to prove to herself what small amount she’d reclaimed would come when called. She let it flare to the surface, only about half of what she was owed. Still not a full transformation, but for the first time since shattering the sword, she didn’t let it bother her.

She already knew how to burn the last of her doubts away. How to free the rest.

“Give me the Heart!” she said again, her eyes flaring with magic, her voice fraying at its edges.

Pip’s eyes widened in surprise just as Catra’s grin widened in excitement. Taline didn’t dare take her eyes off the shield she continued to maintain around the Beast. Adora was ready to march right up to the exposed dais and plunge her whole arm into the magic when Pip still seemed to hesitate, but one last idea stopped her.

She looked to Evelyn and was surprised to see her already looking back, a calculating, intrigued expression on her face that clashed with the others.

“I know what the plan is,” Adora said. “Everyone else’s plan. But it is not their place to tell me when and where I can use *my* own power.” She gestured to the Beast, thrashing against Taline’s cage again strong enough fresh cracks started to form in the façade. “It’s my responsibility to confront this, not anyone else’s.

“I’m done waiting for permission. I’m done watching others step in to cover for me when I never asked them to. I’m done sitting on the sidelines waiting for my powers to come back so that I can finally, *finally* play my part.”

Evelyn’s eyebrows had creeped higher up her forehead with each word Adora spoke. It was hard to gauge what she was thinking, but that didn’t faze Adora either. She was done caring. Instead, she looked to Catra, and saw all she needed to reaffirm she was on the right path.

Catra was beaming.

“*I* am She Ra of Etheria, Princess of Power,” Adora said, returning to Evelyn with twice as much fervor and resolve as ever. “Step aside or don’t, but it is my turn to finally step up.”

A beat passed between them. Still, Adora couldn’t read Evelyn’s expression, and still, she didn’t care. She really would plunge her arm into the dais if anyone tried to fight her on wielding the Heart. Throw her whole body in, even, see if she cared.

But Evelyn’s calculating look at last gave way to a smirk. “Took you long enough,” she said, before turning to Pip. “Give it to her.”

It was Pip’s turn to send her eyebrows shooting up in surprise. “But—"

“Pip,” Evelyn said, the look in her eyes and her tone of voice conveying more than Adora could decipher.

Pip hesitated a moment longer, then sighed. Another console appeared at her waist, and she tapped a new cadence of commands into it. She looked up, caught Adora's eye once more, then pressed one last sequence on the panel.

A beam of swirling white magic erupted out the dais and shot straight for Adora, engulfing her. Pain—burning, searing pain—rippled across her body. She felt like she’d really plunged into a volcano. Stars burst in her vision like smoldering fireworks as her vision began to pull and white out at the periphery.

The very heart of a planet pumped in her chest, infinite magic flowing through every vein of her body, suffusing every pore. It was indescribable, feeling the breath of every creature stepping

on her surface—for them to share in her own, in and out countless pairs of lungs, wind rustling the trees.

How could she ever hope to describe to another what it felt like to *be* a planet? To walk among stars, trace her elliptical orbit around the nearby sun? To step in tandem with her cancer-riddled sibling like they were acting out one final, frail dance?

As she regarded this...parasite, this thing that consumed, she couldn't help but wonder: by what hilarious work of fate and hubris did the World Eater think to look upon her, too, as conquest?

Adora's body—her actual body—refused to obey her, preoccupied as she was with incarnating all of Etheria itself. But she'd already decided Corynth wasn't going to die for her. No. Not just Corynth—no one else. No one else would die for her.

Salas had warned her she'd die if she used the Heart without all of She Ra, and everyone else had gone along with it. But she *was* She Ra, and she'd be damned if anyone, least of all herself, made her believe otherwise ever again.

Despite its refusal, she forced her real body to obey her. Not even her own pain and fatigue would stand in her way, not today.

She lifted the Sword of Protection and pointed it at the churning, roiling figure of the two Beasts fighting itself, trapped across the room, still under Taline and Evelyn's magic cage. Evelyn had warned to wait for Corynth's half to wrestle control of the whole. Adora wondered, briefly, if she, too, should hold out long enough to differentiate between them.

But no. She was the true catalyst for the weapon, after all. It no longer mattered which side of the Beast was in control of itself because she was in control of the Heart.

Adora channeled the power across her arm, to the tip of the sword, and with a warrior's cry that reverberated across the stars,

she released it. A spiraling shaft of magic streaked forth, the recoil from the blow making her feet slide back across the floor.

The Heart struck, and the overwhelming white that had been pulling at the corners of her vision obscured everything at last.

Chapter End Notes

I played with the idea of making She Ra's long-awaited appearance longer. I also played with making it more concrete--there was one draft where she finally emerges fully transformed and surprises the ever loving hell out of Taline. I think that version had merits, but ultimately I went with this. The lead up was longer, letting me focus more on the emotional transformation Adora walked herself through and lean on a more abstract, alien-like rendition of her experience taking on the Heart. As it stands, I don't think there's even a solid description of her /change/ in physical appearance. It's just heavily implied from how she /feels/ wielding all that power.

I think her getting to a point where she finally has her moment of clarity, stands up for herself, and then finally looks at the almighty Beast itself only to see what amounts to an egotistical parasite that makes her *laugh* of all things was much more powerful than more explicit action. I spent tons of words building Corynth to be this near superman-esque figure, and then have Adora absolutely tower over him in power and prestige in just a few paragraphs. Also, this second half of the Beast fight is already 42k words long--making She Ra's appearance more emotional than concrete just made more sense :) Plus, I think it makes what happens immediately in the next chapter more impactful, too

Next chapter is the denouement, and then we have an epilogue. Which is confirmed the longest chapter in this story, because I just let myself indulge at the end :D

# Eventide

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When the whiteout subsided and Adora could see again, her surroundings had changed. Drastically.

She was standing atop a hill. A breeze caressed her cheek, ran through her hair, and made the leaves and branches in trees far away rustle and dance against the horizon. Large, four-legged animals lumbered in the distance, their spotted hides catching the sunlight.

All of this felt familiar somehow. Not just familiar—like straight-up déjà vu. And if Adora's gut was correct, someone would call for her right about…now.

"Hello?" said a voice behind her.

Adora spun around and nearly fell over backward in surprise. *She* was there. She being an exact duplicate of herself—a clone perhaps. Her doppelganger, back to her, faced away at the sprawling hills beyond. The real Adora looked down at herself and gasped.

She'd transformed. All the way this time, wearing a white military-adjacent outfit lined with red, enhanced with gold armor. She Ra, now, instead of just Adora. The fact she towered over her copy to the extent she could see the top of her head should have tipped her off, but…this was amazing.

She'd finally done it.

"Anyone there?" said her copy, her back still toward her, scanning the hills as she projected her voice.

This was her vision, the real Adora realized with a start. Back on Horde Prime's citadel, this was what she'd seen, except from the other's point of view. This was why it seemed so familiar: this was when, in that vision, She Ra had first expressed her disappointment and doubt to her. And if she'd switched places with the other 'her' of three years ago in this strange, lush, vision world, then…

"Hello, Adora," she said to The Other, who spun around and backed away with wide, surprised eyes. "Do you recognize me?"

"She Ra? Of course I recognize you. How could I not?" The Other frowned and glanced about. "Am I dead?"

Adora laughed and shook her head. "You're not dead," she said, kneeling to look herself in the eyes. "You're very not dead. But you *are* something else. Do you want to know what?"

The Other furrowed her brow and tilted her head in an obvious question. This was not at all how Adora's vision of She Ra had treated her in the past, but that was the point, wasn't it? She reached forward and pulled herself into a tight hug, resting her chin against her shoulder. She closed her eyes, and breathed deep.

"You're amazing," she said to her former self. "So, so amazing, and I'm so incredibly proud of you."

Something released in her chest, like the unlocking of time frozen by a curse, and her double vanished when she pulled away like she'd never been there to begin with. When Adora looked down at herself again, she'd returned to her regular appearance, having taken The Other's place. Feeling lighter than she had in years, Adora stood, stretched, breathed in the fresh outside air. Someone else was there with her, someone new, and she smiled when that person grabbed her hand.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said, threading their fingers together and flashing her a smile. "I knew you could do it, dummy."

“This isn’t a dream, is it?” Adora asked, facing her.

Catra seemed to think it over. “Nah,” she said after a moment, shrugging her shoulders and tapping some nonsensical rhythm against the back of Adora’s hand with her index finger. “At least, I really hope it isn’t.”

Adora really hoped not, too. Everything that happened prior to her waking up here was clear in her mind, including her demanding the Heart to fight the Beast. But this place? Meeting a doppelganger of herself just for it to disappear? Seeing Catra here? It was too surreal and too reminiscent of the actual nightmare she’d witnessed aboard Horde Prime’s citadel that it made her uneasy.

Catra tugged at her hand, pulling Adora out of her thoughts only to find her looking past instead of at her. And when Adora followed her gaze, she was even less sure this place was real.

Where a moment before there was no one, now an enormous crowd surrounded them. Countless thousands of people that stretched to and covered the hills in the distance, standing in groups, socializing with smiles on their faces and animated gestures. A low hum of pleasant conversation intermixed with the sound of the breeze.

And just when Adora was going to ask what was going on—not that she expected Catra to know, but still—she saw Glimmer standing at the bottom of their hill. She seemed confused and lost, checking herself all over and brushing dirt off her ruined Battlemage uniform like she’d been yanked straight from the battlefield. Apprehension spread across her face when she took in her surroundings, and that apprehension that only deepened when both Catra and Adora ran down the hill calling after her.

“Ah shit,” Glimmer said upon seeing them. “Am I dead? I’m dead, aren’t I?”

Adora didn’t know how to answer that, because now she was worrying, too. And she’d just told her copy she wasn’t dead.

Catra, however, frowned. “Geeze, really? At least Adora’s first thought was she was dreaming. Was it that bad defending Bright Moon?” When Glimmer only blanched and her eyes unfocused, Catra cut back in. “Okay, don’t answer that. And here *I* thought I was supposed to be the pessimistic one. I think we’re fine, guys. We aren’t dead.”

“Well then where the hell are we?” Glimmer asked, gesturing at their surroundings. “Who are all these people and what is this place?”

Another voice spoke up from right next to Adora and she jumped. “Archanas,” they said making the three of them spin. Evelyn was there, hands clasped behind her back. “And Catra is right. You three aren’t dead.”

A range of emotions flashed across Catra’s face, but she was the first to recover. “This is definitely not what Archanas looked like when Taline and I flew in. And that was before the Abomination reinvigorated the planet.”

Rather than answer right away, Evelyn only nodded. She walked away from them, indicating they follow as she headed for the crowd. After a glance at the others, Adora shrugged and went after her, and they fell in step with her.

"The planet was turned to glass during the first war," Evelyn said, passing through the start of the crowd with a nod as they made way for them. "The Beast ruined it long before you stepped foot on it, but it used to be a beautiful world."

“Sure,” Catra said, “But if Adora succeeded in killing the thing, that wouldn’t have changed the fact the planet was already dead. It wouldn’t have gone back to this,” she gestured at their surroundings. “Not unless this is really some otherworldly Shaper magic at play or whatever?”

“No Shaper magic,” Evelyn said, shaking her head, “but look close and you might get a better idea of what’s going on.” She shot a look at Glimmer over her shoulder as they continued to walk. “Anything seem familiar?”

Glimmer seemed to realize what she was talking about within moments. “There are Scavrians here,” she said, and Adora was surprised to see some of the crowd notice her when she did. They waved and Glimmer waved back, a somber expression on her face. “You just said we aren’t dead.”

“I said you three aren’t dead. Just you three.” Evelyn stopped and scanned her surroundings, her head a swivel. What landmarks she could see among the endless sea of people they were standing among, however, Adora had no clue. “Well, that’s not quite right, but”—Evelyn gave a dismissive wave with her hand —“technicalities. The point is, I’m dead, as is everyone else you see around us. But you three are not.”

Her eyes locked onto something in the distance and she started down a completely different trajectory than before. “There is a threshold here. A phenomenon where, because of what has been done to this place, that which must be separate can touch. For now, at least.”

“Is everyone here?” A note of dread threaded through Glimmer’s voice as she raked her eyes over the crowd. “There are so many of them. Everyone we evacuated from Scavria…are they…?”

“No. They aren’t all dead.” Evelyn must have taken pity on her, because it was the most straightforward answer she’d given yet. “There are plenty here, true, but not nearly everyone you evacuated. You asked me before why I appeared to you at Scavria. Why I intervened with the Abomination there on your behalf, remember?”

“You said I was needed,” Glimmer said. She’d stopped looking at the Scavrians, instead turning her eyes down at her feet shuffling the ground and casting only surreptitious glances up at them.

“Can’t imagine why. So I could come back to Etheria, ignore Salas’ hard-won advice, and order everyone to let fully corrupted Megaliths crash into the planet and threaten people I love?”

She counted on fingers for each item she listed off and a pang of empathy harpooned Adora through the chest. Is this what she sounded like the past three years?

Evelyn stopped again and turned around to look at Glimmer. She wasn’t trying to be intimidating or make a point, that much was obvious. Instead, she looked like she was waiting for Glimmer to realize something. It took a moment for Adora herself to piece together what it was, and by then, Glimmer’s eyes had gone wide with realization, too.

“You wanted me to do all of that,” she said. “Why?”

“Because Adora did more than just kill the Beast,” Catra said, finally speaking up. She had a furrow in her brow as she looked at Adora, which made it seem like she was both deep in thought and trying to uncover more answers there imbued in Adora’s own facial structure.

“I did?” Adora looking between the three of them. Truth be told, she hadn’t even caught onto the fact she might have done that much, but Catra had said it like it was a common-sense fact, she didn’t want to be the one to backtrack all four of them because she hadn’t kept pace.

Except, Catra’s expression deepened after reading what she could from Adora’s face. “No,” she said, turning to Evelyn and parroting her words. “This isn’t Shaper magic, and we’re in the middle of this threshold or whatever you called it because of ‘what has been done’ here? Adora didn’t just kill the Beast, she reversed its effects entirely.”

Evelyn regarded Catra like she was inspecting a lab specimen, head tilted to the side, while Catra let those words sit out in the open. “After ironing out some early kinks, my first hundred or two

forays into the timestream consisted of me working primarily through you," she said at last to Catra. "You were the fastest to piece together what threads I left, no matter how tenuous, and after all this time I still don't understand fully why it is the path where I dealt with you the least that you all succeed beyond my wildest hopes."

It was clear by the look on her face Catra had no idea what Evelyn was talking about or how to respond to it. To Adora, Evelyn's talk with Corynth and Taline on Phoenix—their cryptic exchange about experiments with the Beast and seeing through time—had been confusing, too, but it made her wonder. What was it like living a whole life, piecing together a plan to defeat the Beast only to fail, then jump right in a try again hundreds and hundreds of times? It certainly put her own failures incarnating She Ra into better perspective.

"The Beast is gone," Evelyn said. "And while being touched by its essence used to be an inescapable death sentence, this is no longer the case. Thanks to your power," she said to Adora, before turning to Catra, "and your help freeing her to use that power, the Archanan strain is not only dead, but the very effects it had on the planet and all those within its grasp has been undone."

She turned to Glimmer. "But reversing those effects alone would not have been enough. It is only thanks to your actions that Etheria will not just be welcomed into the wider galactic community, but that it shall stand preeminent—at the forefront of that community."

At the looks of confusion Catra, Adora, and Glimmer sent each other, Evelyn laughed through her nose. "Oh, silly me," she said, eyebrows raised. "Did everything else going on make you forget Horde Prime was still a figure with powerful agency across the stars? Did you think he'd become a non-issue once the Beast was out of the way?"

Truthfully, yeah. For as blatant he was about using about seeing Etheria as nothing more than a glorified canon against the Beast,

he'd largely left them alone the previous three years, true to his agreement with the Enclave. In the face of everything else going on, it had been easy to forget about him, more or less.

Although, with the Beast out of the way, that was liable to change.

"Frankly, many of my earliest timeline experiments had been cut short because, after the end of the first war, Horde Prime found the freedom to act with even more impunity than he had before the Beast had shown up in the first place. Without the ever-looming threat of destruction, he was once again the sole major power in the galaxy."

"That's another part to why you created the Vestamid, isn't it?" Adora asked, proud to finally latch onto something she was reasonably sure neither Catra nor Glimmer had as much context for. "Not just to guide Corynth and to bait the Beast, but to chain Horde Prime to the conflict in the Beast's relative absence after you first sealed it away."

Realization dawned on Catra's face. "And with the Beast and Vestamid no longer an issue…"

"Horde Prime would become emboldened once again, yes," Evelyn said, choosing yet another seemingly random direction and ploughing forward through the crowd without waiting for them to catch up. "Thankfully, it is not merely your word against his in the upcoming power struggle. You have the extant survivors of the Scavrian race to vouch for you. Thanks to Glimmer, their testimony of the events that transpired on Etheria shall ignite the imaginations of the galactic populace."

"Horde Prime doesn't have 'saved the Scavrians from the Beast twice in a row' on his resume," Catra said, making a fist and punching the palm of her opposite hand. "Sounds to me like we've got a strong hand to play when he shows up trying to throw his weight around again. That is going to be *so* satisfying considering what he did to us the first time."

“Horde Prime may still be the emperor,” Evelyn said, nodding with a smile to a group of Scavrians conversing together, “but the galaxy will have a better source of hope from which to rebuild. And it’s a particular kind of hope only Etheria could give them.”

Catra and Glimmer fell into contemplative silences at that, the sounds of their footsteps brushing the grass replacing their voices. Perhaps Horde Prime would not remain the emperor for long. Perhaps son there wouldn’t be an emperor at all, but that wasn’t the only thing on Adora’s mind. Arguably, it wasn’t even the most important or pressing, either.

She’d demanded the Heart not just to fulfil her duty, but to keep someone else from fulfilling it in her stead.

“Where is Corynth?” she asked.

“Funny, he asked the same thing of you when we first got here,” Evelyn said. “He was about to go looking until I told him to stay put and that I’d bring you all back for him.” She made a face. “If they haven’t moved from where I left them, then he should be riiiight about—”

Evelyn threaded them through one more clump of Scavrians until a clearing opened in the ocean of people. At the center were a different group of people, laughing and joking and slapping each other on the back as they celebrated. These weren’t Scavrians, but individuals from seemingly several different races. Adora didn’t recognize anyone, but they all seemed to recognize them, or at least Evelyn.

In fact, she almost didn’t recognize Corynth when she finally saw him, either. He was talking with one of the strangers and hadn’t noticed them yet, giving Adora ample opportunity to look him over as they approached. The scarring she’d seen wrecking his face in his final moments had disappeared, and even the sickly pallor and bags under his eyes he’d had since they first met wasn’t there, anymore.

All these people were his fellow Daiamid Shapers, she'd realized after slotting the pieces together. The very same ones that had come back to help him subdue the Beast moments ago.

Someone else in the crowd called out to Evelyn as they drew close. Corynth snapped his attention to them, and an enormous smile exploded onto his face, striking Adora dumb enough she stopped dead in her tracks.

She'd seen him smile a few times after they broke the ice with one another, but never like that.

"Damn, is that really what he looks like under the mask?" Glimmer asked, sounding just as struck as Adora felt. "No wonder Taline had a thing for him."

Adora gasped and smacked her on the arm. "Glimmer! Really?"

"What? I'm just saying…"

"I'm going to tell Bow."

"He'll agree with me."

Catra, who had similarly been staring at Corynth as they made their way over to him, turned on her with saucer-plate eyes. "Wait, did you and Bow make up?"

"They kissed," Adora said, unable to suppress her smile when Catra's jaw dropped.

"How was I not there for that!?" she asked, punching Glimmer in the shoulder. "Three freaking years of watching you mope around and I didn't even get to see the payoff?"

Catra and Glimmer bickered while Adora tried to stay out of it. Evelyn seemed at a crossroads between amused and exasperated, and all four of them only drew more attention the deeper they walked into the nest of Shapers. The bickering didn't stop until

they were within arm's reach of Corynth, and by then whole group had stopped their celebrating to stare.

Adora couldn't hold back any longer. She lunged for Corynth and pulled him into a crushing embrace, only for all the air to get squeezed from her lungs when he returned it. The nearby Shapers smiled and nudged one another, whispering under their breath.

"You were incredible!" she said, once they'd released one another.

"Me? *You* were the incredible one." Impossibly, his grin widened even further, threatening to split his face. He gestured around. "Look at what you did."

Adora scoffed and waved him off. "Please. It was way past time I figured my powers out."

"Are you trying to be modest? Now?" The teasing in his voice was so heavy Adora couldn't help but scowl at him. "Really though. It's been a long time since I've been surprised at what was possible to accomplish with magic, but this place and all of these people are here through your doing. I certainly couldn't have done this."

Adora fought down a bittersweet swell of emotion. She didn't want to dwell on Corynth being here among the other dead. As happy as he was for her, she'd been too late in the end.

"I guess you were right," she said, forcing levity into her tone. "I just needed to believe in myself, or whatever it was that you were trying to tell me before." She glanced at Catra, who stared wide-eyed at Corynth like she was trying to memorize every feature of his face, her arm still wrapped in a loose headlock around Glimmer's neck—a holdover from their bickering having devolved into physical play fighting. "I got a pretty good pep talk, too."

Corynth followed Adora's gaze to Catra, who released Glimmer with a jump, smoothing out the front of her pants. He laughed, then turned to Evelyn. "Thank you for bringing them."

“I told you I would,” she said. “Didn’t want you wandering around looking. I know how easily you get lost.”

“That was one time,” Corynth said. “I get lost *once time* looking for the lab—the very first time I might add—and I’m forever branded as someone terrible with directions.”

“Because you are. It wasn’t one time. Why do you think Vasher started following you everywhere?” Evelyn frowned. “It wasn’t out of the blue. One day you bet him money you knew how to get somewhere without directions, and he bet you’d get lost.”

Adora’s jaw dropped, and she shut it again before anyone could notice. *That* was how the whole thing got started? “Come to think of it, you got lost on Phoenix with me, too. You had to ask the station AI for directions.”

Corynth shoved her shoulder, making her laugh. “You’re supposed to be on my side.”

Adora’s face hurt from grinning so hard. She shoved him back, only to drop that grin the moment after when another swell of emotion burst the bubble of warmth welling in her chest. Suddenly, she was turned away from him, blinking back tears.

The thought of saying goodbye was agonizing.

Catra watched her, and Adora already knew she was being read like a book. She was thrust back to a time when they were still kids, and Catra had the uncanny ability to know exactly what was going through her head with only a glance. Maybe she’d never lost the ability to do that the previous years, just the opportunity.

“How long do we have?” Catra asked Evelyn, shuffling over enough her side touched Adora. “This threshold thing can’t last forever, right?”

“No, it can’t,” Evelyn said. “We should have enough time for the last person we’re waiting on to find her way, though.”

“Who?” Catra asked. The crowd had gone back to conversing amongst themselves, casting a low murmur of voices underling the wind as the three of them scanned faces. Adora was the first to spot Taline, threading between a group of Scavrians and Shapers at the far end of the clearing. Her steps were tentative, her eyes darting this way and that, searching.

“You said the three of us were the only ones here that were alive,” Glimmer said to Evelyn after Adora pointed her out.

“With my sister, that makes four,” she said. “And potentially a fifth. We’ll see.”

This last, she said after a glance at Corynth. and Adora’s heart leapt into her throat at the implication. She nearly turned and shook her for clarification, but Taline found Corynth from across the distance, and time froze. Or seemed to, with the way even the breeze died. The world itself was holding its breath.

Adora expected Taline to pivot and march straight up to them. She’d only ever known her to be headstrong and straightforward, after all. A maverick. And just as she was about to take a page out of Corynth’s book and start a betting pool with Catra and Glimmer beside her, uncertainty flickered across Taline’s face instead, and she took a wide-eyed step backward, like she was trying to blend back into the crowd.

“Huh,” Adora said, suddenly grateful she didn’t place any money down. Catra and Glimmer both seemed equally as confused. “That’s…not what I was expecting.”

A shit eating grin broke out on Evelyn’s face when Corynth went to her instead, his long strides making him appear to float across the grass. Many of the Shapers whispered under the breath, casting him surreptitious glances as he passed, hiding their own smiles and nudging each other as they made a path for him. Taline’s face erupted in panic when she noticed, and it deepened to a comical level when those around her pulled away, singling her out.

“What the hell is up with her?” Glimmer muttered, brows pinched.

Taline fidgeted when Corynth reached her, but to her credit, looked him in the eyes. They spoke. About what, Adora couldn’t hear, but Taline’s apprehension gradually faded the longer they did. And then Corynth said something that made Taline laugh, and despite how alien this all seemed—watching Corynth joke with someone else and then seeing Taline of all people receptive—Adora couldn’t stop the tender feeling that welled up inside seeing it. It was hard to believe they’d ever been enemies at all, let alone for years.

Then Taline’s face fell, the shift so sudden it was like she’d exploited her happy high to redline herself right off an emotional cliff. Evelyn nudged Adora, Glimmer, and Catra, and they followed her again. They drew close until Adora could hear what they were saying, stopping just far enough away to be polite.

“—just said your injuries weren’t life threatening,” Taline said, voice cracking, hands clenched at her sides. “That’s a miracle. Adora pulled a miracle for everyone, you included. What do you mean you aren’t coming back?”

It was a wonder Adora didn’t earn a concussion from the whiplash she experienced hearing that. So, she *did* make it in time to save him, but he was still choosing to die? Somewhere deep inside, her rational brain tried convincing her there was a silver lining there—a measure of dignity to his being able to choose. She couldn’t help feeling crushed all the same.

To his credit, Corynth looked pained, too

Taline made a face. “The Beast may finally be dealt with for good…I hesitate to say even that much, but if it is, that doesn’t mean we are done.” She cast her eyes about as if searching for solid justification standing among the crowd. “You think the emperor won’t capitalize on this? Even if Etheria gains the advantage with the public because Adora can reverse an infection, that doesn’t make him any less dangerous.”

“Tal—"

She shook her head, zeroing back on him with laser focus. This arguing, to Adora, seemed like them stepping into a longstanding push-and-pull dance. Something whose familiarity hadn’t faded after years of hiatus. “Don’t start that with me,” she said. “You went from galactic enemy number one to a war hero with a cult following overnight because of how good he was at manipulating public sentiment. He will be a major challenge, still. There's a lot you could do to help if you stayed."

Corynth placed both hands on Taline’s shoulders, a move that startled her, breaking the routine of the dance and revealed how brittle the mask she was putting on was. Her whole expression shattered, and suddenly her eyes swam with tears.

“I’ve been apart from everyone for a long, long time,” he said, indicating the other Shapers around them with a tilt of his head. “You didn’t think I was supposed to survive Archanas the first time, did you? Not when everyone else including your sister perished.”

“But you did.” Taline brought her hands up to grasp at his wrists. Adora thought she was going to pry him off her, but instead, she held him there like she was holding onto the cords of a parachute. “You’re alive. You’re here.”

Corynth thought on that. “I don’t know if ‘alive’ is the right term for what I was or am, but sure. I carried the torch and fulfilled my duty. It’s over now.” A tear ran down Taline’s cheek. He wiped it away with his thumb, and if Adora thought she saw Taline lean into his touch, she had enough respect for their moment not to say anything about it. “You’re right that there will be new challenges. Horde Prime will become a pain in the ass again, but that’s a new challenge for someone else.

“Adora? Catra? Glimmer?” he said without taking his eyes off her. “You? Etheria will do a fine job ushering in a new golden age, and with your help, they’ll drag the emperor along kicking and

screaming if they have to. Now is as good a time as ever for me to get out of the way."

Catra and Glimmer were appropriately stone faced and somber. Adora was fighting back her own tears. This was quickly building up to a far harder farewell than the one she'd anticipated a few moments ago. She didn't understand why Taline only seemed to grow more defiant in the face of what Adora considered was an open and shut door.

Evelyn's reaction, however, was the most surprising of all. She rolled her eyes and booed at them. Several nearby Shapers laughed while several others put their faces in their hands and shook their heads. Corynth looked equal parts amused and exasperated, but Taline yanked her hands away from him like she'd been burned, her eyes darted to the four of them standing feet away. Had she not realized they'd been standing here the whole time? She looked horrified.

"You aren't going to let him steamroll you with reason and sensible arguments, are you?" Evelyn asked, with astoundingly little subtlety. "Say what you really want to say to him. This is your last chance."

Corynth turned back to Taline, confused. "What is she talking about?"

Taline's brought her hands together over her stomach and played with her fingers. A deep, deep flush spread across her face to her ears and down her neck. Where before she'd looked Corynth in the eye even while arguing with him near tears, now she refused to look at him at all.

"Oh, damn." Glimmer's voice was breathless. She leaned over and whispered to Catra, "Now I'm serious. What the hell is up with her? She looks sick."

"She's never been able to keep it together in front of him," Evelyn said. "All that angst and hatred you saw from her whenever he

came up was more of an unhealthy mutation of that behavior than a one-eighty reversal. Taline used to face down entire bridge crews of hardened naval officers without batting an eye, but as soon as he walked in, she'd trip over herself like some sunburned mooncalf." She grinned. "It's never not been hilarious."

"Never in my wildest dreams would I ever have thought she blushes as hard as Catra does," Glimmer said.

Catra opened her mouth to agree—Adora could just tell—then snapped it closed with a click of her jaw. She was bristling. "I do not blush! Adora, tell her!"

"You do turn pretty red, actually," Adora said, leaning into her space to look at her with scrutinizing curiosity rather than teasing. "Doesn't your fur mask some of that? Wouldn't that mean you turn really, *really* red underneath for it to show through?"

Catra, a hard flush of her own already growing, pushed Adora's face away and leaned back to put even more space between them. "W-what kind of question is that? Have you been spending so much time with Entrapta she's started rubbing off on you or something?" When that didn't deter her, Glimmer started laughing, and Catra groaned. "Ugh! I hate you both!"

"That's definitely not what you said to me before," Adora said with a smirk, making Catra turn even redder.

"Oooh, did you guys make up, too?" Glimmer pressed her palms together and rocked back and forth on the balls of her feet. "Tell me everything."

"Adora…" Catra said, drawing the last syllable of her name out in warning. "Don't—"

"She kissed me stupid, then offered me some very, *very* touching words of encouragement in the middle of the fight."

Glimmer squealed, clapping her hands together in delight. Catra groaned again. Instead of pulling away, this time she pressed her

forehead into the crook of Adora's neck trying to hide her embarrassment. Adora soothed her back with small circles, unable to wipe the smile from her face.

Half of her had worried Catra had only done those things in the heat of the moment, but her reaction helped settle those fears. They had a lot to work through together. A lot catch up on still and a lot to forgive each other for. The road was long, but with this, Adora knew they were both on the same page about walking it together.

Taline had been watching them alongside Corynth. Their display seemed to take some of the edge off her own apprehension: a small, guarded smile had worked its way onto her face. She dropped it when they noticed, pressing her lips again into a thin line of determination.

"I wouldn't dream of depriving you of a good death," she said, catching Corynth's eye again. "Empire above, you've earned it, but that wouldn't stop me from…from missing you, if you went." She cleared her throat, and her eyes took on this strained, widened, glazed look. Like she trying not to blink, worried that tears would fall if she did. "I let you go already, back there. Just like you asked me to, I did it. But…well…" She swallowed, her mouth opening and closing several times as she tried and failed to find the words. Her brow became more pinched with every attempt, until low, ragged sounds of frustration started coming out her mouth instead of words.

Corynth had let go of her at some point, his hands back at his sides. Taline's eyes dropped to them like she was adrift on the ocean and they were life vests. She reached to grab them, threading their fingers together with the same kind of reverence Adora had seen at the Induction Ceremony when people laid their candles next to the graves of their loved ones. "Given everything that's happened, I realize how selfish it is to ask this of you, but…"

Corynth gave her hands a squeeze when she seemed to lose steam again. Taline closed her eyes, the tears she had fought so

hard to keep from blinking free sliding down her high cheekbones.

"I don't want to say goodbye." Her voice was suddenly thick. "I know I already did back at the sanctum, but…so much time was taken away from us because I let myself be—" she cut off, shaking her head before trying again. "There are so many things I've done that I wished I could take back—so many things that I never *can* take back. People I've watched die that I can never bring back no matter how much I wish I could."

She swallowed. "But this? You? I'll never get another chance. So, if you'll forgive me for as…*selfish* as I know I will sound by saying this, but…"

Corynth didn't do anything except wait when she trailed off again. The tension between them was so high, Adora had to remind herself to breath. And judging by how still everyone else was, they likely thought the same.

"In the exceedingly rare chance you are even the least bit unsure of leaving," Taline said, her words halting and tentative, "would you reconsider staying? With me? Please?" She blinked another few tears but didn't look away. In a voice so quiet and pitched so desperate it was like a deathbed prayer, she said, "I don't want you to go."

Taline's entire demeanor—her stunningly sincere way of asking him to merely *consider* staying with her—made it feel infinitely more pleading than if she'd gotten on her knees, grasping at him as she outright begged for him to stay. Adora wasn't sure whether she'd melt into a puddle out of sympathy or snap in half from the tension waiting for Corynth's answer. She was rooting for Taline. Unless he was in danger of becoming an actual revenant, stuck in perpetual, torturous limbo unable to pass on, she didn't want him to go, either.

Finally, Cornyth unlinked one of their hands to cup her face a second time, and this time, Taline was much more obvious about

how she leaned into his touch. It felt like an agreement between them.

And then, with the beginnings of a smile tugging at his lips, he said—

"I suppose I could stay, then."

Radiant joy exploded across Taline's face, bright as the sun, and Adora released an enormous sigh of relief alongside everyone else.

"Really?" Taline asked.

"Really," Corynth said, smiling in full, now. "Does this mean I'm in the clear, though?"

Confusion erased some of her excitement. "What do you mean?"

"Dying a horrible, gruesome death by your hand now that the Beast is no longer a threat. Is your quest to separate my head from my body still in effect considering you weren't the one to bring me here to meet the others? I mean, you got really, really close on Phoenix, mostly because I just sort of stood still at tail end of our fight, but still—"

Taline let loose a wholly unbecoming bark of a laugh as she smacked his chest with the back of her hand. She seemed to gather herself for a moment, a fleeting glimpse of her usually flinty regality coming over her face again like a veil, only for her to snort and devolve into a fit. She giggled—*giggled!*—as more tears rolled down her face. Adora was floored, and when she looked, Catra and Glimmer seemed to share in her disbelief. Taline could *giggle*?

Corynth turned to Evelyn and the others, some of Taline's elation having rubbed off on him. "Are you all okay with waiting a little longer for me to catch up with you?" There was a hint of sarcasm under his words. "I know it's not fair to have gotten your hopes up just to dash them like this, but…"

Some anonymous Shaper from within the crowd said, "If you make her wait instead of us, we're all going to stop being friends with you." Even the Scavrians joined, voicing their support. Evelyn stayed silent, watching with a smile and shimmering eyes until she caught Taline's eye.

"Proud of you, sis," she said. "Took you forever to come around, but I suppose I won't hold it against you, all things considered."

A look passed between them, one that Adora didn't think she could decipher if she got a recording of it she spent years studying. But she didn't need to decipher it. Perhaps it was because she'd had that same ability to read Catra's mind once upon a time (and perhaps still), but she knew it must have communicated something tender and meaningful. Something that brought long-awaited closure for them both.

"Well? Get going, then," Evelyn said, ushering Catra, Adora, and Glimmer forward. "Hate to be the bearer of bad news, but the galaxy isn't going to lead itself toward new horizons."

They shuffled forward to join Corynth and Taline until all five were grouped tight together at the center of the crowd. When they turned looked, Evelyn, the Shapers, and the Scavrians were watching them, waving with radiant smiles on their faces. The white that had heralded Adora's awakening at this place reasserted itself, pulling in at the edges of her vision.

"One last thing!" Evelyn said before they disappeared completely. "I have no idea what happens next. My future vision ended the moment you all teleported to Etheria together. No matter how hard or how often I tried, I could never look beyond that moment."

Adora's jaw dropped. "You had no idea if we were going to win or not?"

Evelyn only shrugged, and while that was big enough of a revelation Adora struggled to wrap her head around it, Corynth

and Taline’s seemed to think that was a good thing. They both grinned even wider than before, and it was only then Adora realized the significance of what Evelyn had told them.

Their futures were their own to make once more. No more prophecies working in the background, nothing else muddying the borders of free will. Everything faded to white at last, and one last thought rang in Adora’s head as it did.

They had won.

Chapter End Notes

> "Fuck your death flags," says Adora.
> Corynth nods. "Fuck my death flags."
>
> Rando's repeated references to Corynth's death flags stuck in my head. I couldn't not have him respond lol.
>
> If the beginning of this chapter sounds at all familiar, it's because it is almost an exact copy of the beginning of Adora's nightmare in chapter 11, except flipped on its head. That chapter came out almost 2 years ago to the date. And whereas there she was touched by the Beast and saw a horrendous hellscape where She Ra berated her and Catra was her demonic portal-touched self, this chapter, after she does the touching, she pushes through to the purged, clean version. The one where she is She Ra on the other side, where she gets to say what she needed to hear to herself at last. And the Catra she meets is the real one, this time.
>
> And yes, Archanas was that ruined planet from the original vision. Y'all got a direct glimpse of it before it was even named in the story

# Epilogue: Turn Again to Life

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A gentle humming filled the air as Taline pushed Corynth outside in a wheelchair. She traced them along a curving concrete path dividing a lawn, and he fought to keep the humming from lulling him to sleep.

It was the first fight in a while he was happy to lose. With the sun warming him like a blanket and the breeze running like fingers through his hair, he closed his eyes, tipped his head back into the wheelchair's cushioned headrest, and let the sound of her voice chase him into blissful, half-consciousness.

The humming ceased, and he sighed, cracking one eye open to look up at Taline. She returned his gaze with pursed lips. "Why'd you stop?"

"I didn't sneak around all those nurses and break you out of the infirmary just so you could fall asleep right before we get there." She looked away, a dusting of color on her cheeks. "Besides, I didn't realize I was doing it."

Corynth smiled at her, even though she refused to look at him again. Once, in confidence, he'd told Adora how beautiful Taline's singing voice was, but that no one knew about it because she was too shy and too private a person to let anyone hear. It was only when she felt comfortable enough in someone's presence to relax—to not feel embarrassed or self-conscious or on constant high alert—that the voice came out.

It had only been a few months since Archanas' reconstitution. Since they'd started reconciling. Corynth wouldn't have found it strange had he waited years for that voice again, yet there it was.

“I can’t help it,” he said. “You’d think I’d be just as wired during the day given how much trouble my brain gives me falling asleep at night, but your voice just does something that lets the sleep debtor in me pay up.” He tilted his head, a playful gesture. “Do you think the nurses would play a recording of it in my room at night if I asked nicely?”

The issue was a non-starter. Taline would never consent to recording herself in the first place, but Corynth got what he was aiming for, anyway. Taline muttered something dark under her breath, a flush creeping up her neck.

“Flatterer,” she said.

The chair rattled as she pushed it away from the pavement and through the lawn, toward a hill in the distance where an enormous Etherian oak tree stood. Two thin lines from the wheels trailed behind them in the grass like the wake of a ship. Beyond that, Bright Moon and its castle town, and the even larger temporary encampment set up to house de-thralled Scavrians attached to it like an oversized barnacle.

“You’ve been having trouble sleeping?” Taline asked after a moment pushing in silence. “Still?”

Corynth nodded. “The doctors didn’t appreciate it when I told them it was fine, though—that I’ve been used to it for years, now. Apparently, lack of proper rest makes recovery harder. Who knew?” Despite the doctors projecting a full recovery, months later and he still needed the wheelchair. His injuries hadn’t been life threatening—he hadn’t lied about that—but he hadn’t come out unscathed, either. His body was wrecked.

The sharp planes of Taline’s face pinched in worry and Corynth gave her an exasperated look. His attempt at levity hadn’t worked.

"Does that really come as a surprise to you?” he asked. “Don't you have trouble sleeping, too?"

“I do,” she said, quickly. “Of course I do, but…”

“But?”

“The doctors didn’t say anything about your situation me.” Taline seemed both embarrassed and frustrated. “They told me you were fine. That you were recovering as expected. No concerns.”

Ah, that would make sense. Because he wasn’t well enough to be discharged yet, the nurses and infirmary staff had tolerated the little bit of rule bending Taline committed whenever she came to visit him. Her schedule was forever crammed, so administration looked the other way when she showed up outside visitation hours, when she snuck in unsanctioned food for them to share when his diet was supposed to be monitored, and even when she pressed and pressed his doctors for details about his recovery.

What they hadn’t forgiven, however, was her suggestion she speed that recovery along with healing runes. She hadn’t even attempted it, just considered the idea out loud within earshot of a physician’s assistant. And since her reputation preceded her for utter failure when it came to all things healing, the mere suggestion she try it earned her a two-week total suspension of all visitation privileges. The Dean of Medicine had signed and sealed the letter himself.

“I’m fine,” he said, trying to catch her eye again when she stared resolutely at the oak in the distance. “I promise. A nightmare here or there never killed anyone, and I am not behind schedule on recovery. The staff probably doesn’t want you worrying over something you don’t need to worry about, that’s all.”

Taline scowled. “You don’t have to spare my feelings. They don’t want to give me any reason to bring up healing runes again.”

“More like they want to avoid suspending you again and having Catra, Adora, and Glimmer all show up to enforce that suspension like last time,” Corynth said, laughing. Everyone except Taline had

found that stare down hilarious and overblown. Even now, weeks after the ban had lifted, she'd still grumble about on occasion.

"It was just a suggestion!" she said. "I know I'm no good at them, but if they helped you get well even a little faster…"

They'd reached the base of the hill. Corynth's body pressed against the back of the chair as Taline pushed him up it.

"Adora did what she could for me already," he said. "She's the reason I get to make a full recovery in the first place, but full powers or no, even she has her limits. Curing the Scavrian people of the Beast didn't do away with their need to heal the damage it had already caused. And I arguably have a lot more to heal from." He glanced up at her again, watching her purse her lips in begrudging acceptance. "I know you worry, but I will be okay, I promise. You have other things that require your attention."

There was something else bothering her. Something deeper she was trying and failing to mask from him. Something outright asking about wouldn't yield answers to. He'd expected her to argue, too. In the past, any attempt to redirect her focus had usually failed, especially when she was worried.

To his surprise, she seemed to think it over, and he decided to try for subterfuge. Distract her so she couldn't deflect when he finally dug in.

"Speaking of the other things," he said. "How are we doing out there?"

Taline smiled soft. "We're accomplishing plenty. There were several planets that were fighting against their own smaller infections when you and Pip strengthened the Barrier. Nothing close to how bad Archanas was, but showing up to help quell those outbreaks has been going well, regardless."

"How well? Any casualties?"

Taline laughed. “Surprisingly, no. The last we recorded was someone who broke their leg during a humanitarian deployment. They tripped tandem carrying a stretcher. Zero deaths so far.”

Corynth was honestly surprised.

“It’s not totally out of the realm of possibility we’d lose people,” Taline continued. “We do deploy troops and not just humanitarian aid. But Adora’s just has to transform and point her sword at the most densely concentrated part of the infection—the one most likely to form into an infant Abomination if it were to be left unchecked—and that takes care of it, for the most part.”

“Sounds deceptively straightforward.”

“Glimmer has had to teleport her and Catra into and out of a few tight spots, and they’ve had the occasional engagement, but nothing they couldn’t handle. Especially with that commando team Glimmer put together. After that, the local forces are usually more than equipped to handle clean up, and we portal to the next spot.”

“That simple, huh?”

A conspiratorial grin spread across Taline’s face. “I’ve heard through my own channels that the last four places the Emperor has shown up to looking for us have declined reinforcements from him, since we’d already solved the problem.”

Smug satisfaction thrummed in Corynth’s chest. “Oh, that must piss him off.”

“It does. Especially when the ground commanders tell him he missed our departure by just a couple of days in his quest to corner us.”

Corynth was pleased. He’d heard precious little of what everyone had been doing ever since Adora had come back from one particular mission, spilling everything to him in a thrilled deluge. It

didn’t take long for the nurses to kick her out, saying all this excitement was distracting him from meaningful rest.

He’d disagreed, of course, so Taline indulging him like this was welcome. Especially the part about them collectively pissing off the Emperor. He'd catch up to them eventually, but already his power was weakening in the eyes of the public. And hopefully, by the time he was able to threaten them directly, Corynth would be more or less healed.

“How is Adora coping with the Heart?” he asked. “She’s all smiles whenever she visits, but I know she’d try to play it off still if all this was taking a toll on her.”

Taline rolled her eyes in tacit agreement with him. “She would try, but she’s a terrible liar. Even you would be able to tell right away if something was wrong.”

Corynth frowned. “What do you mean ‘even me’?”

She ignored the question. “Besides, if she *was* pushing too hard, Catra would be the first to ask that you beat some sense into her, if she didn’t already succeed in doing so herself.”

“I’m not sure you noticed, but I’m under strict orders to stay in bed most hours of the day. I’m not in any condition to beat sense into anyone.”

There came her pursed lips again. Corynth loved pushing her buttons. So much so, he had a sneaking suspicion he might recover faster were he given more opportunity to do it.

“I was speaking metaphorically, genius.” She paused. “Adora is doing fine. Really. Funneling the full power of a planet through one, singular body is strenuous even for her, but she’s keeping up. It helps that she doesn’t have to do it more than once or twice a week, despite how fast we jump between hot spots. And Catra is on her hard about proper rest and nutrition and what have you.” A wayward smile had made its way onto her face. “Makes my job

easier, at least. Can you imagine if I had to wrestle her into submission for things like that?”

She’d be more irritable, that was for sure. And imagining Taline being more irritable than usual was hard. Corynth was lucky no matter how stressed Taline got, she was never irritable with him. Only others. “Do you think you could do it?” he asked. “She gave you a run for your money on Phoenix. That was before she could transform fully, too.”

“I’d rather not so much as entertain the idea,” she said, scowling. “And I don’t want you encouraging the others with that line of thinking, either. I’ve had to quash more than a handful of ‘who would win in a fight?’ conversations already.”

Corynth turned nearly all the way around in his seat to look at her with interest. “Really?” The thought of an illicit, underground fight club springing up on the very world ridding the galaxy of the last remnants of the Beast—the same world hoping to usher in a newer, brighter balance of power in that galaxy—was too ironic even for him.

They’d finally reached the top of the hill. Instead of dignifying his imagination with a response, Taline rolled her eyes and pushed at his cheek with three fingers, forcing him to stop giving her that look and face forward.

“We’re here,” she said, stating the obvious to drive home how little she wanted to talk about fight club, no matter how hypothetical. Then, with a voice small enough to fit in a child’s hand, she asked him, “What do you think?”

A gravestone stood upright under the tree. Evelyn’s gravestone. Up on the hill, Bright Moon castle cast a sharp relief in the distance, as did the castle town and Scavrian tent city, sprawling around it like fallen leaves.

Instead of relaxed and open, Taline had latched onto a different worry. If he wanted the words she needed to hear to hit home,

he'd have to continue steering her through choppy waters without tipping her off he was watching too closely.

"You picked a good spot for her," he said. "The view is beautiful."

"Angella was happy to let me reserve this plot when I asked. I'm… grateful." There was relief in her voice: she was glad he approved. As if she had anything to worry about in the first place. "I'm thinking of asking to have Narre and Miri brought over here, too. So she's not by herself all the time."

"That's a good idea. Evelyn often said she missed them, after we exiled ourselves."

Taline stared through the slab with hollow eyes before letting them drift down. At the foot of the gravestone lay a patterned picnic blanket, laden with baskets. "Glimmer told me she'd made preparations for the food. She's fast. I wasn't expecting this to be here, already."

Taline wheeled him over, and Corynth decided to play off her tactic of stating the obvious, if only to keep momentum. Prevent her from spiraling.

"Picnic on a hill?" he asked. "This is nice."

She started talking again, a good sign, saying something about wanting "all of them to do something nice together," only to squawk and crowd him the moment he tried to get out of the wheelchair. Corynth waved her off, forcing her to instead hover nearby, ready to snap forward and catch him should he fall.

He made it to the blanket with tentative steps, then accepted her hand when she offered, leaning into her as he lowered himself into a sitting position. "See? Progress. I'm recovering just fine."

Taline was still tense as she mumbled something noncommittal under her breath. That tension crumbled and gave way to another barely-there smile when, after sitting on the blanket next to him, she tried to pull her hand back and he held firm.

“When are the others supposed to get here?” he asked.

Her eyes were locked onto their hands still clasped together. “Not for a while, yet. I got you early.”

"So, you’re saying have some time to ourselves?" He pulled her gently toward him, and after putting up only token resistance, she scooted closer. "That totally wasn't on purpose, was it?"

“No, not on purpose.” She said it dutifully, an obvious lie. Despite the fact they were close enough for their sides to touch, she held herself just enough apart they didn’t, and still didn’t let go of his hand.

Corynth sighed, tracing her knuckles with a thumb. It still wasn’t easy to tell what she was thinking, not like before. But it wasn’t unlike reading a book for a second time, either, after all memory of the first reading had muddied with time. He wasn’t certain she’d be receptive to hearing him, but at this point, this was likely the closest he’d come to having a clear shot.

“I don’t regret coming back with you,” he said, with no preamble. “And I don’t think I ever will.”

Taline stopped breathing next to him, and that was all Corynth needed to know he’d finally ferreted out the root cause of the manic behavior driving the infirmary staff up a wall since his admission.

“Tal…” he said, and she tensed. He’d been unable to keep the appalment from his voice.

They had a lot to rebuild between them, still. Taline’s distrust of him had shifted—instead of fighting to put him six feed underground, she now merely distrusted his willingness to stay. That, and she distrusted herself being a strong enough incentive to keep him, but that wasn’t anything new.

This was just another stone in the thousands they’d need to build this bridge between them. And with the same, stoic resolve he’d

employed when approaching anything else he'd already long ago decided upon in life, he slotted that stone in place.

"I'm not going anywhere," he said, releasing her hand to wrap an arm around her waist. He pulled them even closer against one another so they had no choice but to touch from hip to shoulder. And when he reached for her hand again to pull into his lap, she didn't fight him. "Handful of months bored out of my skull in the infirmary? Not a problem. Prolonged recovery that doesn't go exactly smooth? Fine. I'm not going to get restless or frustrated and change my opinion about not dying."

Taline gave the barest of nods, just one. It was her going through the motions of agreeing with him, not her truly believing it.

"Vasher came once and tried to bet that you'd get sick of me being around before I ever started second guessing my choice to return. I told him no deal, and that I wasn't stupid. That I liked fleecing him for cash, not the other way around."

A strange, wheezing sound came from her next to him. Corynth thought with a muted frustration that he had made her cry, but it wasn't until Taline's shoulders started to shake that he realized she was also laughing. Her free hand scrubbed at her face and came away wet. Corynth pretended not to notice.

After a moment, she let out a deep, content sigh—like something rooted inside her had come unknotted, spooling loose. She finally relaxed fully against him, and he pressed a kiss to the top of her head when she nuzzled into his shoulder.

They sat together like that for a while, two perfectly slotted puzzle pieces, nothing but the sound of birds singing and the rustling of wind through leaves keeping them company with each other.

---

"Who would win in an all-out fight, you or Taline?"

Adora had done well ignoring Catra so far. This especially considering how she'd decided to balance sideways across an

overhead bar in the gym, laying there like she was posing for a photoshoot while Adora did pullups on that bar. That question, though? She couldn't ignore that question.

"Pretty sure I would win," she said.

Catra's smirked and Adora got the sense she'd just fallen into a trap. "Are you sure about that, princess? From what I'd heard, she laid you out after mind blasting you on Phoenix."

Adora grunted and dropped to the floor, dusting her hands against her shorts. "That was when I only had, like, half my powers figured out. And she had a hard enough time with me at that, so I doubt she'd be able to win now I can transform all the way."

Truthfully, Adora wasn't actually sure. Being an embodying avatar for a planet that acted as eldritch-panacea-cure for the Beast was one thing, and fighting in her super-powered body was another. Taline hadn't been in the right frame of mind when they fought, either, and had still 'mopped the floor with her,' as Pip had so kindly phrased it one day.

Regardless, she was glad they were on the same side, and that Catra's question was entirely hypothetical.

"Okay, well what about you against Corynth, then?" Catra asked, standing up on the bar before dismounting with a backflip.

"He's stuck in the hospital and confined to a wheelchair," Adora said, grabbing her towel from where she left it draped over an incline bench and wiping herself down. "I think trying to fight him might be considered a form of abuse."

"No, I don't mean if you were to fight him now, I mean once he'd gotten better. You've been channeling the Heart two or three times a week for a while now and the only side effect is that you need to eat an entire buffet and crash for twelve hours straight after. How would that stack up against someone who summons the dead and shapes reality?"

Adora stared at her, taking her in. Catra smirked, crossing her arms and popping her hip out to one side. Adora could hear the cheeky *"what?"* from her body language, like she had said it with her mouth. The ridiculousness of her line of questioning wasn't lost on either of them, and that, Adora supposed, was what made it so funny.

"Don't laugh!" Catra said, when Adora lost her composure. "I'm actually curious here!"

"Didn't Taline tell you to stop asking people that? What were her words again, exactly? That it doesn't matter who would win against who else in a fight since we're all on the same side, and speculating"—she pitched her voice to effect Taline's exasperated deadpan—"just encourages childish behavior?"

"Yeah, sure." Catra sounded like she took pride in letting Taline's opinion on the matter go in one ear and out the other. She grabbed a water bottle from a nearby side table and tossed it underhand at her. "I mean, even if she has a point, you can't tell me you aren't at least a little bit curious. If we let the three of you duke it out, what would happen?"

Adora caught the water bottle with a satisfying *THWAP* against her palm, and made Catra wait until she'd taken several deep pulls, wiping her mouth with the back of her sleeve before replying. "You could include yourself on that list of fighters, too, you know."

"Me?"

Adora flashed her a devious look. She'd sprung a trap of her own. "On second thought, maybe not. Didn't you get taken completely by surprise by a fat guy with robot arms?"

Catra sputtered. "That's *not* what happened! I knew he was coming and just couldn't get out of the way in time. Moriarty didn't just have robot arms, he had robot legs, too! How the hell was I supposed to know he could move as fast as he did?"

Again, Adora held it together for about two seconds before devolving into peals of laughter. She'd doubled over, cackling with her hands on her stomach. When she tried to calm down, imagining the miffed look she knew without looking was on Catra's face made her laugh harder.

"I'll have you know Pip and I are even more in tune now than we were back then," Catra said with a scowl, once Adora had come up for air. "You know what? I bet you I *could* move fast enough to put up a good fight against you and Taline and even Corynth. Maybe I *should* put my name up on that list."

Learning Taline had put in Catra's head what amounted to an intelligence thousands of years more advanced than Light Hope had been interesting, to say the least. It explained not just the increase in her already formidable fighting skills, but also how Catra had seemed to just know things she otherwise would have had little to no context for. Fortunately for Adora, however, as useful as Pip was, she was more prone to making fun of Catra on Adora's behalf than help Catra think up witty comebacks when they sniped at one another like this.

"There is no list, Catra," Adora said, still trying to catch her breath. "This is your hypothetical we were talking about. But sure, whatever you say. You can be on the hypothetical list."

Catra recovered faster than Adora expected, a new glint shining in her eyes that said Adora was in trouble. "I bet if I was you'd actually be the first to lose. I also heard about your reaction to a certain someone when you watched their dance performance on Eden." She tapped her chin in mocking thought. "What was that club called, again? The Garden?"

Adora went pink and she grumbled, making a mental note to talk to Corynth about showing more restraint with the embarrassing stories he'd share of her. There was no way to swear him to complete silence, since Catra had proven several times in the previous months she'd latch on and wheedle it out of him by force anyways during her infirmary visits, but did he *really* have to tell

her how she'd devolved into a blushing, wide-eyed mess seeing Ly strip on stage? Gods, how embarrassing.

"See, I know your biggest weakness." Catra, who'd never not capitalized on an opening in her life, stepped into Adora's space, tracing her fingers along the fabric of Adora's sweaty workout clothes, her tail sliding up the back of Adora's leg as she circled her. "All anyone has to do is put a pretty face in front of you and you turn into a puddle. You wouldn't stand a chance against me."

True to Catra's prediction, Adora's brain stalled so hard she couldn't put together a coherent response. Because of the countless long, emotional conversations late into the night, the two of them getting on the same page about their commitment to honesty and better communication with one another, Adora refused to lie to Catra's face and deny Ly had utterly mesmerized her at the time. And maybe it was a positive sign Catra found it funny enough to tease her rather than get upset or jealous, but that wasn't the point.

The point was, it was total bullshit that Catra rode her ass about this, because Adora wasn't the only one Ly had that effect on.

You see, after they recouped, mourned the dead, and recovered enough from the hell Archanas had put them through, their first stop after the dust cleared was returning to Scavria. The planet was in ruins after days of orbital bombardment, but with the Beast infection finally quelled, they'd offloaded those refugees who wanted to begin reconstructing their home world. And that was when they threw their enormous party. The one where Enclave and Etherian and Scavrian citizen alike finally got to acknowledge and celebrate that the worst of the Beast threat was finally behind them.

That party lasted all day and much of the night in Bright Moon. All had taken part—from the front-line soldiers and mages to the civilian population and even children. And when the celebrations eventually dwindled to a smaller, private gathering between most of the core Etherian defense, all of whom happened to be adults

who had perhaps too much to drink, someone (not Adora) had started egging Ly on, chanting until everyone joined in, begging her to do a routine.

It had only taken Entrapta three seconds to install a sturdy pole once she'd agreed. Then, about thirty seconds into a dance that had even staunch zen-master Perfuma blushing to her roots, they'd caught Frosta—who hours ago Mermista had been carried fast asleep to a distant guest room—trying to sneak back in.

Back in the present, Adora almost lost it all over again, remembering. Especially the part where, despite Frosta protesting that she was 'totally old enough to watch,' Keren and Trayn had no choice but to bounce her from the premises. Hordak and Sea Hawk of all people had to promise her an in-depth tour of the shipyards repairing their damaged carriers as consolation.

For whatever reason, remembering the look on Frosta's face when she'd walked in and caught Ly hanging upside down with her bare legs wrapped around a pole reminded Adora of the look on Catra's face at the sight, too And it gave her an idea.

Catra was already in her space, but Adora downed the rest of her water, crumpled the bottle, and tossed it overhand into a bin at the corner of the room. Then she stepped even closer.

"What are you doing?" Catra asked. Now she was the one tingeing pink, walking backward to enforce at least some distance between them. "You trying to pick a fight or something?"

"Not that kind of fight." Adora let her voice drop a register and smirked when Catra's fur stood a taller higher in response. She backed Catra up against a wall, making her breath hitch, pressing so close she swore she could feel the heat of Catra's blush radiating from her body. Then she grabbed hold of her powers, letting it flow through her, and transformed. When she looked down, Catra was staring up at her with eyes blown wide and mouth hanging loose.

Adora leaned down to whisper into Catra's ear. "I'm not the only one weak to pretty faces." When she pulled back, Catra's flush had traveled all the way down, plunging under the neckline of her shirt. And just to drive her point further than it ever needed to go, Adora cupped Catra's entire face gentle with one hand, making doubly sure Catra caught her staring at her lips, then leaned forward again, slow.

The fact she didn't question anything Adora was doing spoke to how entranced Catra was. Only a brief look of panicked indecision flitted across her face before she stretched up on tiptoes and closed her eyes, ready and open and eager for the kiss she no doubt expected Adora to give her.

Adora didn't kiss her. She pulled back, and when Catra opened her eyes, confused, she winked, then transformed back to her normal self. "I need a shower, I feel gross," she said with the same energy she used to describe a particularly uneventful meeting.

Catra deflated with a pitiable whine, and it took everything in Adora to not laugh yet again. Instead, she stepped away, spun on her heels, and stalked out the gym. The tapping of Catra's soft padding steps followed close behind.

"Since you brought up Pip, earlier," Adora said, still keeping her voice devoid of mirth as they threaded down the connecting hallway, "what's she up to? Is she still pretty much in your head, all the time?"

"No, actually." Catra's voice was raspy and dry, like she was in desperate need of a drink, probably from the same bottle Adora had just downed earlier. She cleared her throat. "Her, Entrapta, and Ly have been holing themselves up recently in the Crystal Castle, working. They're pretty close to bringing Light Hope back, from what they tell me."

"Like, actually bring her back this time? Permanently?" Adora was surprised and cautiously excited. Light Hope hadn't come back

after getting corrupted the last time. Adora was under the impression she'd never see her again.

Catra didn't say anything, and when Adora peeked at her over her shoulder, she had a faraway, listless look in her eyes. A moment passed and she came to, blinking several times in a row. "Yeah, permanently. When that tainted apeiron fucked up Pip's systems, she also inadvertently messed up Light Hope's. They've been untangling her."

"Is Pip with you right now?"

Catra shrugged. "She pops in and out. Corynth still needs to show me how to tune her out if I want to enforce some privacy in my head."

Adora considered that. For most people, Catra's moments of diverted attention were too quick to notice, but Adora herself was starting to catch on. She pushed through a door at the end of a hallway and into her bedroom, then went for her dresser, pulling open drawers and gathering a fresh change of clothes into her hands.

"Do you know how much longer until she's back?" she asked. "Light Hope, I mean."

Another brief pause. "A few more weeks. Entrapta had already made some good progress before Pip came along. Add Ly to that mix, and I guess you have a pretty potent mix of genius nerds. Although to be honest with you, Ly doesn't strike me as the brainy nerd type at first glance."

*She could say that again*, Adora thought, but cautious optimism bled suddenly into genuine excitement. It would be good to get Light Hope back again. She missed her.

Adora stopped at the threshold to her ensuite bathroom before turning back to look at Catra. She found her exactly how she'd expected: standing a few steps back, firmly in the bedroom, not meeting her eyes as she shuffled in place. That furious blush from

earlier seemed like it might have spread further down her chest. It certainly had grown darker.

There were still a lot of rough edges between them to sand down, but that was okay. Trying to find a new normal with one another, finding new depths of intimacy they could share…it was hard, strenuous, and ultimately rewarding work. And even though most of those long nights of conversation ended (and sometimes even started) with one of them pressing the other into the mattress (or against a wall, or over a table), Catra still had the occasional hang-up—hit the occasional bump in the road where guilt and self-loathing over the portal incident, or the way she lashed out when they saw each other again after years apart, or any of the myriad other things became overwhelming.

Adora was more than happy to offer a little needed reassurance. Sometimes it was nice to have the shoe on the other foot.

"Hey," she said, offering a genuine, open smile instead of a teasing one when Catra's gaze snapped to her. Adora gestured with a tilt of her head to the shower, an invitation without words, and that was enough to nudge Catra out of the spiral. A smile erupted on her face and a glint of playfulness simmered in her eyes.

"I'm gonna borrow some of your clothes, then," Catra said as she pushed past Adora into the bathroom.

"Heck no!" Adora said, following her in. "You can wrap yourself in a towel and go get your own clothes. You've stolen enough of mine already."

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Glimmer meandered one of the many gardens lining a wall inside the castle town outside Bright Moon castle. A large, floppy straw hat and large, round shades protected her from the sun, while the giant frosted mug of frozen margarita slushy in her hand kept her cool and loose. She had only one scheduled meeting before lunch,

and the fact even that one visit was in an unofficial capacity made it official: Glimmer was finally on shore leave.

"You drain that thing and it's going to be *me* dealing with the aftermath," Lonnie said, walking with her. She scowled when Glimmer took another drink. "You're going to be hungover tomorrow. That's your second mug and it isn't even noon, yet."

Instead of sniping back, Glimmer offered her the mug and said, "Come on, Lonnie. You're my second in command, not some adjutant who's supposed to hound me about work."

Lonnie looked at the mug before begrudgingly refusing it. "Is there really a difference? You have meetings early tomorrow, and at least one of us needs to be coherent enough to contribute."

"You're no fun," Glimmer said, pouting before she took another pull. They continued past the gardens, Glimmer setting them on a path past the last buildings at the castle town's outskirts and toward the plains beyond. "You're the one that suggested I take today off in the first place."

"Because you need it," Lonnie said. "Between cleansing the last active infections and figuring out what to do with the Scavrians who decided to stay with us, it's been weeks of nonstop work. And aside from that party, I don't think I've seen you sleep for more than a few hours at a time."

"And now I'm relaxing. So what's the issue?"

"I just didn't expect you to drain enough alcohol to poison a Beast Island snake monster, is all." Their eyes met, an inside joke passing between them. The first time Beast Island had come up in conversation since they'd returned home, Glimmer and Lonnie had paused, looking at one another as if to reassure the 'Beast' in Beast Island had nothing to do with the Beast of the World Eater variety.

"Getting drunk off my ass is not my idea of a relaxing time is all," Lonnie said, before a chime from her PDA pulled her attention.

She continued talking and taking care of whatever alert had popped up. “What would your mom and dad say? Hell, what would Bow say? Aren’t you guys supposed to see each other tonight?”

Glimmer already had a pleasant buzz going, and Lonnie’s concerns seemed distant and amusing. “We’re having dinner tonight, yes. I’ll be fine, I promise. I’m not going to risk drinking so much I turn sloppy on date night, c’mon.” She had a quip about Lonnie’s own dating prospects ready to fire back just to keep her off kilter, but frowned when Lonnie dismissed the notification on her PDA with a grimace.

“Them again?” Glimmer asked, all urge to tease forgotten. Vanguard Operations Command had been trying to reach her, Kyle, and Rogelio ever since Archanas, but no one had taken their calls or answered their messages. “You know, they’re going to dishonorably discharge all of you for desertion if you don’t talk to them, right? “

“Oh, they’ve already done that. Rogelio and I received the official notices a few days ago, and Kyle is waiting on his to come any moment now. They’re a little slower to cut their pilots loose, I guess.”

“And you’re fine with that?” Glimmer was surprised. “You guys will always be part of my team no matter what, but losing your Vanguard commission? Isn’t that a big deal?”

“It might have been, yeah,” Lonnie said. “But knowing what they’re trying to do makes the decision easier. They want to pull the three of us away from you, since this whole ‘travel the galaxy and cleanse the remaining infected worlds’ thing we have going on is not an imperially sanctioned operation.”

Glimmer laughed and took another drink. Saying what they were doing “wasn’t sanctioned” was putting it lightly. They were outright defying the emperor, running around like this.

They lapsed into silence as they walked, the grass crunched underfoot with their steps, the sound mixing with the growing noise of the Scavrians going about their business the closer they drew to the tent encampment. The unspoken part of their conversation hadn't escaped her: Lonnie and the others would rather desert the Empire than get reassigned.

Lonnie broke the silence, saying, "Besides, we have a pretty good role model, I think. Vasher renounced the Empire to join up with Corynth, Ly, and Taline's sister. And he turned out pretty good. The way I see it, sticking with you is the same choice. Can't go wrong."

Glimmer smiled at that. And not just because Lonnie was displaying a rare sentimentality, but because her, Kyle, and Rogelio had been spending a lot of time with Vasher, trading stories and bonding almost as much as Catra spent time trading stories and bonding with Corynth. And speaking of Corynth, after learning bits and pieces of what he'd been through with the others at the Crystal Castle, Glimmer was amazed he'd made it out alive. The things Adora could accomplish channeling the Heart were no joke.

The noise of civilization overshadowed that of nature when they turned down what amounted to the encampment's main street. Bustling voices, laughter, saws cutting through wood and through tile, someone hammering something in the distance—despite the temporary nature of this tent town attached to Bright Moon, the Scavrians were just as industrious as they were on the *Omen-Kador*, if not more so.

"I can't believe we got most of them back," Lonnie said, her head swiveling left and right to take in the shops on either side of them.

Glimmer couldn't believe it either, but she said, "I can't believe we got all this built up so fast. Good thing, too, since with how long it will take to rebuild Scavria properly. This might turn into a permanent addition of the castle town rather than a bunch of

tents.” Even with those that had decided not to stay on Etheria, there were still too many refugee Scavrians for one kingdom to take in. Similar tent cities had sprung up near the others to spread out their numbers.

Glimmer waved to the handful of refugees and Etherians that saw them pass. Her sun hat and sunglasses obscured more than half her face, but that didn’t stop people from recognizing her. In all fairness, with Lonnie walking in full gear beside her, it wasn’t that difficult to tell who they were.

In the distance, Swift Wind gave rides to some giggling children, their parents clapping and smiling and celebrating nearby. Glimmer considered getting his attention until Lonnie nudged her shoulder.

“I know you’re on vacation, but if we don’t keep going, you’re going to be late for the one thing you do have on your schedule,” she said.

“Do you know where their tent is?” Glimmer asked, following Lonnie as she led them away from the main road and down a less busy pathway.

“Yeah. You mean you don’t?” When Glimmer shrugged helplessly and took another drink, Lonnie asked, “Was your plan to just wander the whole encampment until you found them, or…?” Glimmer answered with another pull of her mug, not looking her in the eye. The sigh Lonnie gave was more resigned than frustrated. “I’m pretty much your adjutant at this point.”

“Hey, when you said to relax, I took it to heart. I literally had no other plans except to day drink and wander.”

A voice in the distance called to them, and before Lonnie could react, Newt was there, the tiny Scavrian child making a mad dash to them from dozens of tents away.

Glimmer smiled. “Oh! Hey y—”

Lonnie snatched the mug from Glimmer’s hands moments before Newt leaped for her, and she barely caught him in time with a hearty *oof*. He could run way faster than she’d expected.

“Dang, kid," Glimmer said, a wheeze underpinning her voice as she hefted him in her arms. “You’re getting heavy. What is Marcie feeding you?”

The last she'd seen him, the *Omen-Kador* hadn’t yet made its transit from Scavria to Archanas. He'd still been scared and out of his element, taken from his home planet and missing his parents. Glimmer took pride how he seemed happy here, on Etheria, even if all he and his guardian had to live in right now were thick-canvassed tents out on the plains. A large part of her was still glad she hadn’t stumbled across him as a thrall on the battlefield.

Newt proceeded to talk Glimmer’s ear off. As the three of them continued along the row of tents, Glimmer holding Newt and Lonnie holding the margarita mug, he regaled her about all the delicious food he was allowed to eat, how their ‘new planet’ was so pretty, and how nice everyone was. He asked whether Glimmer ‘really was a princess or not,’ since he apparently had a friend named Anais who swore she was, while he had another friend named Morgan who said Glimmer was just a high-ranking soldier. Newt didn’t seem to know what to say when Glimmer told him she was both, and it was in that momentary pause, his face shifting between several emotions trying to make sense of things, she realized this was the first time she’d seen him take a breath.

When he asked about the “pretty pony with wings” walking around giving all the other children rides, Glimmer privately decided to tease Swift Wind later about being called a pony. She stifled a laugh, and the second person she was hoping to run into appeared from out a nearby tent.

Well, more like sprinted out that tent.

Marcie skidded to a halt in the middle of the path after nearly crashing into a passing social worker. Her head was on a swivel,

darting frantically up and down the road. Unlike Newt, she looked even more stressed compared to the last time Glimmer had seen her. That was, until she caught sight of them further up the road and the tension flooded out of her, replaced with a simmering anger.

"Newton Faraday Durange," she said, hands clenched in tiny fists at her sides as she marched up to them. "How many times have I told you not to go running out of sight of the tent without telling me? I swear, one of these days you're going to—"

She paused when she got close enough to finally recognize, despite the hat and glasses, who was holding him. Glimmer flashed her a smile. "We're not interrupting anything, are we?" she asked. "I know we planned a visit, but we can come back some other time if now is no longer convenient."

Marcie waved them off with a grateful look. "No, no, absolutely not," she said, brushing back Newt's hair to inspect his face, then cleaning a smudge on his face with her thumb, making him squirm. "I'm glad you're here, it just worries me when I saw him run off. It's not the first time he's done that."

For some reason, Glimmer both wasn't surprised and she also understood Marcie's overprotectiveness. They hadn't gotten all of the Scavrians back, just most of them. And despite Etheria being probably one of the safest places Marcie and Newt could find themselves at, Glimmer didn't blame her for worrying when he disappeared on her.

They followed Marcie back to her and Newt's shared tent. "How is everything?" Glimmer asked after Marcie ushered them inside. She put Newt back on his feet so he could toddle off and play with a set of toys piled in the corner. Lonnie stood a respectable distance back, hovering by the exit. The mug sat in her hand like a precious keepsake she was ordered to hold.

"It's really not bad," Marcie smiling as she also watched Newt play. "Etheria is beautiful, and this is the safest I think I've felt in a long

time. It beats street life, and especially beats trying to survive a Beast infection."

She'd left out the part where they, in fact, did not survive that infection—at least, not at first—and Glimmer understood her reason for that, too. Some things were too traumatic to be worth mentioning offhand. "It's just you taking care of Newt now, right?" she said, opting for a different topic. "He seems fine, but how is he coping with…things?"

'Things' being Ennis' death. Sadness flickered across Marcie's face, there one moment then gone the next. She'd had sent Glimmer a message three days after Scavria's final liberation to tell her they had buried Ennis. Glimmer had felt guilty for not being there, but she dared not express that to Marcie, since she'd only swear up and down over and over again that Glimmer had nothing to feel guilty for. So, she did them both a favor and didn't elaborate.

"He's doing alright," Marcie said after a while. "Or, as alright as a kid his age uprooted from everything can be. He's old enough to know what…happened. I think he's processing it better than when you first found him, at least."

Newt had been terrified when Glimmer first found him on Scavria, wandering the refugee lines at the intake station. He was absolutely doing better than that. It was a low bar to clear, but again, it was as if Glimmer could hear the parts Marcie had left unspoken. Maybe he was handling it fine, or maybe he was just putting on a brave face.

Without at least semi-professional intervention, the several traumas in a row he'd lived through were a hotbed for developing problematic coping mechanisms. And as personal a connection as Glimmer felt to these two, they were only emblematic of a wider situation that affected all Scavrians that Etheria was providing refuge to. Providing reliable counselling was high on the list of projects the Alliance had yet to tackle.

Incidentally, that was also what her early morning meeting the next day was about, the same one Lonnie wanted her coherent for. Glimmer was grateful for that pragmatism. It was hard enough getting them all shelter on such short notice, let alone scalable psychotherapy services.

“Is he sleeping well, at least?” Glimmer asked. “Are you?”

“We are,” Marcie said. “Most everyone is, I think. And whatever nightmares any of us inevitably report are more about what we experienced on Scavria, not…”

She trailed off, but Glimmer knew what she had tried to say. For whatever reason, the Scavrians, thankfully, had no recollection of their time as thralls. Whenever someone explained it to them, many reacted with shock and horror, but in a detached way, like they were listening to some gruesome tragedy that afflicted someone else. They seemed unable to wrap their head around it having happened to them, and this collective amnesia was a phenomenon their best doctors had expressed great interest in studying further.

Glimmer imagined she had a similar look of shocked disbelief on her face, too, when Taline had explained why they’d all dropped motionless near the end of the battle. Hearing that Corynth had broken the Beast’s hold over them, enthralling them under his own will instead? Learning that push and pull between two indomitable psyches was also what spurred the Troopers to feral madness? It would have been hard to believe had Adora not blown away everyone’s preconceived notions about the Beast by literally curing entire worlds and their populations of it with the Heart.

“The nightmares ar getting fewer and farther between for him, though,” Marcie said, breaking Glimmer out of her thoughts. She gestured to Newt, still playing in the corner. “He has the occasional bad day, still, but there’s plenty going on to keep him from getting stuck in a rut too long. He’s resilient like that” She smiled. “He also keeps talking about wanting to visit the castle.”

“Oh, we can absolutely give him a tour,” Glimmer said, already imagining the look on his face as she took him and his friends around a ‘real Princess’ castle.” She remembered him mentioning the 'pony' outside and she grinned when an idea came to her. "Better yet, do you think he'd like a guided tour while riding that winged horse playing with all those kids outside? I bet Swift Wind would be more than happy to participate."

Marcie seemed a little breathless at her words. "Uhm, yes. I think he'd like that a lot. But only if it's not too much trouble. I know how busy you all are, we jump to new worlds pretty much every other week, now."

Lonnie, who with an impassive expression was now holding the margarita mug high out of reach after Newt abandoned his toys to pester her about wanting to try the ‘juice,’ said, “I’ll get it on the schedule sometime soon.” Marcie raked her eyes down Lonnie’s armor, the look of confusion in her eyes deepening. Lonnie returned a pinched smile. “It seems I’ve inadvertently turn into Glimmer’s personal assistant, as well as her second in command.”

“You are not my assistant.”

“Not officially, since you don’t actually pay me any extra.”

“I don't pay you at all. It’s not my payroll you’re on.”

“Actually, yeah, we should probably talk about that. I’m technically on no one’s payroll anymore since the Vanguard let me go, so…” She put on the least convincing pout Glimmer had ever seen and said, “How am I supposed to eat when you won’t pay me?”

“I said I *don’t* pay you not that I *won’t*. Why are you deliberately making it sound like I’m taking advantage of—” Glimmer cut herself off and scowled when she realized far too late that Lonnie was teasing her.

She would have had some choice words for her until the sound of Marcie giggling reminded her they weren’t alone. It was a close call, too, because what she was about to say would have

shattered Newt's impression of her that she was a true and proper princess, whatever that was.

"What about the encampment?" Glimmer asked instead, clearing her throat and fighting to affect some amount of seriousness in her voice. "We already get regular reports from the adjutants and social workers, and anyone is welcome into the castle and the nearby town any time they'd like, but that doesn't mean we're doing everything we could be. Is there anything that comes to mind we could be doing to help? Anything we haven't already done or talked about doing?"

Marcie shook her head, and something fond and grateful underpinned her voice when she said, "Glimmer, we're doing great, I promise. You and your people…they're doing more than any of us could ever repay after what happened. I'm not going to lie to you and say it isn't hard, but we're only able to hobble along the way we are because of Bright Moon."

She gestured out the tent. "If anything, it's brought all of us together. Everyone in this little tent village feels like family. It works so well sometimes I forget Newt and many of his friends are technically orphans, now. It just never feels that way, and that's…that's a blessing, truly."

Glimmer had to blink away tears, but she managed a nod and it was clear that was communication enough for Marcie. Lonnie gave her a moment, then leaned over and whispered in her ear that it was almost noon. Marcie was gracious about them needing to go, held the flap open for them as they exited the tent, and came out with them after telling Newt to stay inside.

"I'll try and make more frequent visits," Glimmer said to her once she'd found her voice and they'd gotten some distance from the tent. "We'll do the castle tour for all the children to start. You're welcome to come, too. And even though there's, like, a million and one projects we have planned to help your people integrate with the kingdom, if there's anything more we can be doing, please tell me."

Glimmer channeled all the frustration with the empire's bureaucracy she'd experienced to find the right words. "I know things can sometimes get lost in translation. How grievances don't make it through official channels because someone thinks they're too small or they worry about seeming ungrateful. But I don't want any of that to stop us from being partners in this rebuilding effort. Piecing the galaxy back together is going to be a team effort, especially with the emperor still around. We need to get this right, and it starts with the Scavrians."

Marcie hugged her with a profuse thank you and a promise of transparency. Then she disappeared back inside, but not before one last look back and a wave when she got to her and Newt's tent.

Glimmer felt as if a weight had lifted off her. She'd worried over that visit for days. Part of her had worried Newt or Marcie might have been upset with her for some reason or another. That they weren't was relieving, though it didn't fully alleviate the guilt she felt, earned or not, over pitting her friends and allies against them as unwilling enemies on the battlefield.

"You okay?" Lonnie asked, nudging her.

"Yeah," Glimmer forced herself to look at her instead of Marcie's tent. "Were you able to get everything set up, by the way? I completely forgot to ask."

"Of course," Lonnie's voice stepped out of that sincere caution and back to its usual smugness, as if Glimmer was somehow remiss in asking in the first place. "What kind of assistant would I be if I couldn't take care of something that simple for you? Keren and Trayn pinged me about ten minutes ago saying they delivered all the food."

Glimmer grumbled 'not an assistant' under her breath, but Lonnie just laughed and held the margarita mug out for her to take.

"Here," Lonnie said. "Don't forget your juice."

“Thank you for not letting Newt get anywhere near that,” Glimmer said. “I saw him bugging you for it.” A thought crossed her mind, and she shook her head. “You keep it. And take the rest of the day off. That’s an order.”

Lonnie blinked, surprised. “The rest of the day? Are you sure?”

Glimmer smile something devious as an incredibly petty plan to get one last jab at her for the teasing earlier slotted into place. “Yop.”

“Well, okay,” Lonnie said. “But are you sure you don’t want your __”

Glimmer poofed away before she could finish her sentence, leaving Lonnie standing there in the middle of the Scavrian refugee compound, still holding the mug and at a loss for how to react. She sighed, unable to keep from smirking and rolling her eyes. She took a sip.

“Damn,” she said, starting down the path again. “This is really good.”

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Catra had never skipped or frolicked in her life. She hadn’t planned to start up any time soon, either, but, as she pulled Adora along past the encampment outside Bright Moon and toward a great tree sitting on a hill in the distance, she felt the sun on her face and the lightness in her chest, and might have, maybe, for a few seconds, considered it.

More realistically, she was probably still coming down from the high of the mind-blowing sex they just had in the shower about a half hour earlier.

“I don’t think I’m going to be able to sit down for a week,” Adora said, voice hoarse as she adjusted the high neck of her shirt even higher. “And it’s too hot to wear this thing, but someone got a little too carried away.”

“Oh, quit complaining,” Catra tugged Adora’s arm, urging her to walk faster. “You’ll transform again tomorrow when we jump to the next planet fighting off an infection, then all the careful reminders of how much I appreciate you will disappear, too.”

“Yeah, and then you’ll just use my healing factor as an excuse to reapply that appreciation right away.”

“Don’t pretend you don’t like it. You could have just taken a regular old boring shower by yourself if you really wanted, but you just *had* to invite me in.”

“Touche,” Adora laughed as she squeezed her hand, and even though she wasn’t looking back at her, Catra knew she was shaking her head in that fond, exasperated way. Birds chirped and tweeted overhead, and Adora’s laughter harmonized with their song.

*Literally a princess.* The thought came to her on the back of such a strong fairytale feeling she almost turned to kiss her again right then and there, their destination be damned. Catra wasn't a sappy romantic, deep down inside. She really wasn't.

“Yes, you are,” Pip said, her disembodied voice echoing in Catra’s head like she was physically there walking beside her.

::Shut up. Don’t you have a cousin to finish rebuilding or something?::

There was no heat behind her words, but Pip never missed a chance to harass her and then pretend to be offended when Catra defended herself.

“Are you implying that Light Hope and I are related just because we’re both artificial intelligences?” she asked. “Not every neural network in a system is—”

::Ugh. *Go away*. Adora and I have a picnic to get to.::

“Oooh, how romantic. Isn’t the picnic supposed to come before you feel each other up in the shower, though? Or does that only apply to dinners?”

::Pip!::

Catra was beet red. Her face burned as Pip cackled and her presence disappeared from their shared mindscape.

“Her again?” Adora asked, stepping up to walk beside her and swinging their linked hands together. “Was she bothering you?”

“Yeah, she was being a little shit.” Catra willed herself forward. After a handful of steps, she looked over her shoulder back at Adora, hand still clasped in hand. “How do you always seem to know when her and I talk? This is the second time today.”

“Your face goes all spaced out whenever it happens,” Adora said, waving her free hand in front of her face with a blank expression. “It’s so different compared to how expressive you usually are, it’s not hard for me to miss.”

“Really?” Catra didn’t like the idea of having such an obvious tell. Did everyone else notice, too, or was it just Adora? “Do you ever catch Corynth doing that?”

“Oh, no.” Adora shook her head. “As expressive as he is when he wants to be, he’s impossible to read when he doesn’t. I’ve never been able to tell when Pip talks to him.”

Catra grimaced. She was going to pester him harder about teaching her to take better control of their bond. The sooner the better.

Adora squeezed her hand again, her voice taking on a placating note. “I like it when your face gets all expressive,” she said. “It’s cute.”

“I’m not cute.”

“Awww.” Adora’s voice was two steps removed from nausea-inducing sugar overload. “You’ll always be cute to me, no matter what you or anyone else says. Even your grumpy side is cute.”

When Adora raised her arm to kiss the back of her hand, Catra’s indignation gave way to yet another overheating flush. One that further down her neck than before. Privately, once they reached the base of the hill and started up it, she thanked the heavens it was such a nice day outside, even if Adora had complained about it earlier. Without the clouds and the breeze, she might have gotten heat stroke.

For Catra, it was both a great relief and a miracle she and Adora managed to get this far together. Part of her had been afraid they'd grown too apart since their reunion to build anything lasting, that the closeness they’d felt to one another moments before Adora fully transformed had only been a product of the literal end of the world happening. Every day since, she was thankful those fears were unfounded.

That wasn’t to say this was an easy thing between them, either, and even that, they were on the same page about. Glimmer and Bow were working through their own roadblocks, and Corynth and Taline likely had them both beat in terms of the sheer volume of shit to wade through together. But Catra? Catra was optimistic, for once in her life. Working through issues, assuaging old hurts, apologizing for past wrongs, it was hard but worth it, and they were on the same page.

Eventually, they’d get to a point where they could consolidate into one bedroom. They hadn’t gotten there yet, but week after week they spent more nights with one another than without. If that wasn’t a sign then Catra didn’t know what was.

They crested the hill, and Catra found three people waiting for them already. Glimmer, Corynth, and Taline—eyes slightly puffy and red—were sitting under the enormous Etherian oak, on a picnic blanket laden with several lidded baskets. Next to them was a headstone.

"Oh, damn!" Catra said to Taline after letting her eyes lock briefly with Corynth's. "You actually pulled it off? How did you sneak him out of the infirmary without any of the nurses noticing?"

"Very carefully," Taline said. She almost sounded proud of herself.

"They are going to be so mad at you when they find out. Maybe we'll get to see who wins in a fight between you and Adora after all, eh?" Catra sat at an open spot on the blanket and caught Adora rolling her eyes as she tugged her down next to her. "I don't think it will go half as smooth as before when they hand down a whole month-long ban this time."

"Actually, they'd already agreed to discharge him for the day," Glimmer said. "Salas approved it yesterday after my mom suggested it, and she suggested it after I pestered her to in the first place."

Catra knew Glimmer had cut in like that to head off a bickering war before it started, but she'd inadvertently stepped on a landmine doing so. The look of horror that crossed her face when she realized what she'd said out loud nearly sent Catra into cackling fits.

Taline turned to Glimmer with an expression like of a child whose ice cream fell to the floor. She said, "What?" and the toll of a funeral bell might have rung in the distance.

"Uh, wait." Glimmer panicked. "I mean, you sure showed them! Nothing stops you when you put your mind to it, right? Not even a pack of scary doctors and nurses who take patient safety and care very seriously?"

When that didn't seem to convince Taline the nurses hadn't, in fact, been humoring whatever crazy plan she'd concocted to steal Corynth away, Glimmer reached for the closest basket, threw open the lid, and started arranging the contents out on the blanket for everyone else to get to.

“Wow,” she said, turning a pointed look that said *play along* at Catra and Adora “You guys sure took your sweet-ass time getting here. We’ve been waiting for at least ten minutes. What took you so long?” and Catra wondered how she thought throwing them under the bus was adequate incentive to cover for her.

Adora glared at Catra, conveying the words *don’t you dare tell them what we were doing or so help me you will regret it* with a look. Catra bit back a laugh.

“Hey, we got here as fast as we could,” she said instead, jumping to interrupt Glimmer when she started to say something crass about Adora needing to find *just the right high-necked shirt for the occasion.* “Unlike the ‘Angel of Archanas’—who can freakin’ teleport, I might add—us plebeians have to make do with our own two feet to get anywhere.”

“Plebians?” Adora said, more to herself.

Glimmer, successfully bucked from her previous train of thought, threw her head back and groaned. “Can we *please* stop with that nickname? I’ve heard it nonstop from everyone for weeks now. I thought coming home would spare me all the celebrity.”

“No can do, princess,” Catra said. “After seeing your wings, I doubt any other nickname would even stick.”

“Plus, you technically have been to Archanas, now, since you came to pick us up,” Taline said. “That excuse you used to make about never having visited no longer holds up.”

Glimmer looked appalled. “You’re taking her side?”

“I might not have, but then someone decided not to tell me they’d secured a temporary discharge from the hospital and let me go through all the effort of sneaking a person out, instead.”

Catra and Adora's jaws both dropped. Catra always had a feeling deep down Taline could be an incredibly petty person in the most

comical of ways if she wanted to. She just hadn't seen any proof of it before.

Glimmer turned to Adora. “If there *was* a fight club, I think you’d win.”

“Hell. Yes.” Adora fist bumped her. “I think I’d win, too.”

“There is no fight club!” Taline said, throwing her arms up. “And no, you would not win!”

The sound of a quiet, stifled laughter stopped them mid argument. One by one, they looked to Corynth, hand over mouth, shoulders shaking. They watched him until he sucked in a deep gasp and started laughing outright.

The tension finally broke, and the rest joined him in laughing hard they had to wipe away tears. Adora and Glimmer had even toppled over from the effort to rein themselves in.

"Whose idea was it to have a picnic, anyway?" Catra asked, flipping open the lid to another basket once she’d finally calmed enough to speak.

“Mine, believe it or not,” Taline said. “A few weeks ago, I got Angella to agree to delay the jump we were supposed to make today and give everyone a break. And Prime is so far behind, there’s still no chance of him catching up.”

“I think this is a great idea,” Adora said, helping Catra unpack the baskets.

“You think anything with food is a great idea,” Glimmer said.

Catra snorted. The bickering was never going to stop until people started eating. Trying to curb it beforehand was a pointless endeavor, and she decided to use this opening against the person she knew would be the most fun to tease.

She said to Taline, “I’m more impressed about the fact you wanted to take a break at all. I didn’t realize you had the capacity to request days off.”

“I am plenty capable of recognizing the downsides of burning out from lack of rest, thank you,” Taline said. Her look of confusion not recognizing Catra’s teasing for what it was, deepened when Corynth started laughing again. His eyes twinkled with humor, and he smirked at Catra from across the blanket.

“Really?” Glimmer asked, sarcasm dripping from her voice. “That’s news to me. Did you perhaps forget to instill the benefits of this ‘rest and relaxation’ while you were training me?”

"I have to admit, I always got a very by-the-books impression of you." Adora said, piling on.

Taline hmphed. “I am not nearly as by the books as you all like to assume.”

“Could have fooled me,” Catra said, the same time Glimmer said, “Again, news to me.” They snapped their attention to each other and shouted ‘*jinx!*’, also at the same time, before falling into another fit of uncontrolled laughter.

Taline’s eye twitched. “There are plenty of examples of me bending or even breaking the rules. I snuck Corynth out of the infirmary.”

Corynth said, “Technically, you didn’t have to sneak me out,” in the same breath Catra said, “That doesn’t count, since he was already discharged.” Catra held a hand up for an air high five, and Taline looked on the verge of having a stroke when he gave her one.

Glimmer was holding her stomach, tears in her eyes. “Okay, wait,” she said, voice tight and shoulders shaking. “Before we end up at each other’s throats and I lose the opportunity, I do have something I’m really curious about.”

“If this is about fight club again, I swear—" Taline said, but Glimmer assured her it wasn’t before continuing.

“I thought this would have been the first thing out of Catra’s mouth the minute we were allowed to visit you,” she said, looking at Corynth, “but since it's apparently a much bigger bombshell for me than it is for anyone else at this point, will you *please* tell me how you not only survived what happened on Archanas the first time, but also managed to get on friendly enough terms again with Taline? I thought I was hallucinating when I saw the two of you stranded there, together.”

Taline and Corynth exchanged glances. Y*eah, that’s a good question actually,* those glances seemed to say.

“I mean, even just seeing the two of you sitting there next to one another all calm is astonishing to me,” Glimmer said. “Aside from how you were a near-mythical figure in the first war, my sole impression of you for years was that Taline had a deeply vested interest in ripping your head off if she ever saw you again.”

Feeling now was a good time to keep her mouth shut, since she'd heard much of this story already through Pip linking them together, Catra reached for a sandwich, a plate with disposable utensils, and a tub of potato salad. She passed Adora the plate and tub, keeping the sandwich for herself.

“She did try to rip my head off immediately after seeing me again, actually,” Corynth said, taking another sandwich Taline handed to him with a muted thanks. “Gave Adora and everyone on Phoenix quite a fright, too. Evie had to be the one to step in and calm things down before it went too far.”

“Dax still seems nervous whenever we get on an ansible for him to brief me,” Taline said, a little sullen. “I had hoped getting Dax promoted as my proxy on Phoenix would help smooth things over.”

Glimmer’s eyes slid over to Evie’s tombstone nearby. “Is she able to just…show up whenever she wants? Or was that more of a one-time thing?”

“Maybe you should start from the beginning,” Catra said to Corynth. “I don’t think half the things that’ve led to your guys’ explosive little reunion would make any sense without the full context.”

“Wait, you’ve already heard this story?” Glimmer asked, whirling on her.

“Oops.” Catra focused on her sandwich. “I said nothing.”

Glimmer turned back to Corynth with an expectant look, and Adora, who moments earlier had been piling a mountain of potato salad onto her plate after struggling with the lid, did the same. Even Taline watched him with interest.

“Alright, alright,” Corynth said, leaving his sandwich in his lap and holding up both palms to placate them. “Horde Prime is bound to stick his nose into our business the moment he catches up with us anyway, right? Might as well start working on what our official story will be once he storms in demanding answers at gunpoint.”

He leaned back on his hands, studying the oak like it would tell him the best place to start the story. Catra imagined him sorting through a catalog of memories, and that triggered a sudden lucidity in her about their surroundings—about the present moment.

For a passing second, she heard, felt, saw, and smelled with absolute clarity: the feeling of the blanket underneath them; how the grass pillowed and poked up from under it; the warmth of Adora's thigh as it pressed against hers; the taste of the food the castle kitchens had prepared especially for them; the breeze caressing her instilling a sense that Etheria herself had sprouted diaphanous hands with which to touch.

None of this would remain forever, she realized. Corynth was right: the emperor would get to them at some point. And while they wouldn't face him unprepared, that would herald a change all over again. Shadow Weaver had left with him the same way Catra and Glimmer had left with Taline, and her reappearance in their lives seemed just as inevitable as the emperor's.

They were in the middle of another transition. The calm before the storm, one might say. But, for that brief second of blissful clarity, time stood still, and Catra let herself believe the moment *could* last forever.

Corynth broke the spell. "I suppose the best place to start would be when Taline and I first met," he said, resuming time in a way she felt could have been his eldritch Shaper magic at work. "I'll vouch for her this time, too. About not always being so by the books."

Glimmer hummed, equal parts skeptical and intrigued. "It will take a lot for me to believe that."

"Well, she commandeered a whole carrier battle group from the front lines to respond to a distress signal from the research station Evelyn and I were serving on."

The equivalent would have been Glimmer superseding the Admiral of the *Omen-Kador* and relocating every ship over Scavria to respond to the *Constable*'s distress signal, rather than the Admiral having made that call himself. Catra had never seen Taline preen before, but she really had no other way to describe the look of absolute smugness she radiated when Glimmer's eyes almost bulged out of their sockets.

Corynth continued as if he politely hadn't noticed. "Why would she do that, you might ask? Well, it just so happened Evelyn never told her she was there as a junior member, helping research possible countermeasures against the Beast. She didn't find out until the sample they were using for experimentation got loose."

He smiled, clearly reminiscing, and reached over to take Taline's hand, giving it a gentle squeeze.

"I'd thought I'd experienced the most harrowing, magical thing I'd ever get to experience in my life after protecting Evie from that thing. But what I didn't realize—not until a while after, at least—was that someone very important was about to walk into my life and pull both of us from the wreckage."

Taking sudden inspiration from him, Catra reached over and grabbed Adora's free hand again, the one she wasn't using to shovel potato salad into her mouth. Adora smiled at her, then scooted closer so they were touching from thigh to hip to shoulder.

Together, with Taline and Glimmer, they listened to Corynth weaving his story. And to Catra, any lingering worry of what the future held drifted to the back of her mind, all her attention instead on hearing what it had cost to get here. To this moment, beyond the threat of the World Eater.

## The End

Chapter End Notes

> First thing first: Thank you all for reading this enormous beast of a story I spent 3 and a half years writing and editing and 2 years posting. World Eater evolved from a 240k word first draft I wrote in a 3-month fugue state at the beginning of "that terrible thing that happened starting in 2020" to something I am proud of having written and rewritten and rewritten. I feel immensely grateful to have shared it with all of you. So, truly: Thank you all for reading, commenting, enjoying, all of it.
>
> I played a lot with how I wanted the end to go. I decided to break two cardinal rules, one universal and one personal to this story: don't talk about fight club, and no OC pov chapters

(I think the Corynth pov its justified at the end, at least). As for tone, I couldn't shake the impact reading the Imperial Radch series by Ann Leckie left on me. She ended that series in a clear way: the conflict of *this* story is over, but the characters all live their lives beyond the page. That is how I wanted this epilogue to feel. Horde Prime is out there, our characters are still ravaged by trauma, they have plenty of rough edges that don't fit alongside one another comfortably. The galaxy itself is much the same. In the paraphrased words of an actual professional author I admire: it's like you've been on fire for the past fifteen minutes and someone just put out that fire. You have a lot (seriously, a lot) to heal from physically, mentally, what have you. But you aren't on fire anymore. You aren't going to die.

"Turn Again to Life" is a funeral poem by Mary Lee Hall. In my head, it's Evelyn's message to Corynth that convinced him to carry the torch after he was the only one to survive Archanas the first time. And off the page, I imagine him turning that poem over in his head and seeing a different meaning in it now, much like the turning of light in various facets of a diamond, or how that one optical illusion switches all at once in your brain from an image of an old lady facing forward to a young woman facing away. Instead of forging on to earn his death, he forges on to live.

And that's the kind of sincere, burdened optimism that Etheria will herald to the galaxy in opposition to Horde Prime.

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